DEADICATION

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DEADICATION

by Doodlejoops

Summary

Zombies. Fucking zombies.

Eighteen months ago, the dead started walking and overnight the world as Izuku knew it became more violent, much bloodier, and a hell of a lot smellier.

After losing his group, and almost his life in the process, he finds himself face to face with a set of wild red eyes that were far more dangerous, and far more likely to eat him whole than any zombie he'd come across.

Notes

If you've not yet checked the tags, it's oh so important you do! But, if you have then...

Enjoy, fellow disaster lovers.

Chapter 1: ZomBODY Once Told Me ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was supposed to be a simple run.

In and out, just as they had done dozens of times before, though always with varying levels of success. There had been many occasions where they had come back from a supply run with absolutely nothing to show for it. Except, perhaps, a tube of toothpaste handed to their brave leader as he blushed and cupped his hand in front of his mouth. There were days, however, when they would find enough supplies to last them the next one or two weeks, though as the months went by, those days came less and less.

Still, no matter whether the run was successful or not, they always managed to return unharmed and, most importantly of all… *alive.*

No Unnecessary Risks. It was a mantra they repeated before every run, and they had done well by it up until now. If there were too many of those soulless bags of rotting jowls and bowels – living dead nightmares that now owned the city – then they would move on. It didn't matter what kind of valuable treasures lay in wait inside the building, or if they passed over every store that week; so be it. Better alive and hungry, they figured, than dead and feeding something else.

If the weather was unfavourable and offered their trusted scout, Todoroki Shouto, poor visuals, then they would wait for a clearer day. If there was a heatwave, then they would consider whether the exertion was worth the cost to their water supplies. It made for slow going, and in the eighteen months since things had *Turned to Shit*, they had only made it so far as Shinagawa. It was a far cry from their eventual goal, deep in the prefecture of Shizuoka, and there had certainly been plenty of near misses over the months, but they had yet to suffer a single casualty. That, in itself, was something to be proud of, especially with so many things stalking the streets hoping to make an easy meal out of weary travellers. Still, a good track record was only impressive for as long as it lasted, and there was no guarantee that they could keep fate at bay indefinitely. One day their luck would run dry, much like everything else in their new godforsaken world.

Midoriya Izuku. Perhaps not the leader of their small band of survivors, but the problem solver and the glue keeping them together. He had a certain, sunny optimism that kept all of them going even through the darkest of days; a comforting and confident smile on his sun-kissed, freckled face, and gentleness lacing his fingertips as he wiped away tears and squeezed shaking shoulders. He was just as often the humour as the heart of the family, in a world that was growing devoid of both.

Despite his small size, Izuku was also their fastest runner, his feet every bit as quick as his wit, so when it came to supply runs, it was usually he and his closest friend, Uraraka Ochako, who the group put their faith in. They were fast and efficient, with a good understanding of the value of the resources they sought. They knew what to grab, what was worth digging for, and what to leave behind. They knew what food would still be good and what was likely to be spoilt, pretty essential knowledge when a single turned tin of beans could put the whole group on its arse for days. That was a lesson hard-learnt more than once.

Their current run was going about as well as they could have hoped; they realised early on just how difficult and dangerous the malls of Shinagawa were, and spotting hostiles from the ground became impossible after a point. They needed Shouto on the rooftops, binoculars in hand, with the other group members, Tsuyu Asai and Tenya Iida on the exits. It was a solid, practised formation, one they had done well by over the months, but that didn't mean that it was foolproof. And there wasn't anywhere that put their skills to the test more than the tight, claustrophobic streets and malls of Shinagawa.

Though there'd been many theories about the mindless, flesh-lusting monsters that now owned the streets, no one had any real answers for what these creatures were thinking, if thought was something they were even capable of. Months of experience with what by all accounts appeared to be the walking corpses that took over Japan had taught Izuku and his friends that they were still, unbelievably, creatures of habit. The undead had been seen milling around areas that had once been just as populated by the living, wandering around shopping districts, bus stations, and even outside of fast food outlets. Although it wasn't sushi and fried chicken that attracted them these days, perhaps hoping for an all-you-can-eat buffet of human brains and intestines instead. They were drawn to the malls and shopping centres like moths to a flame, and that made these places dangerous, particularly when spotting the undead was far harder than it seemed it ought to be.

Izuku had watched more than his fair share of zombie horrors in his lifetime. He'd played all of the video games, read the comics and manga… if his friends were to name a piece of media, it was likely that Izuku had devoured it like the typical teen he'd once been. He was, perhaps ironically, a big fan of the genre; it was ludicrous, after all. Grizzly, violent, and the addiction lay in the question… *what if it were me?* He would have eagerly explained his plan for the apocalypse were anyone to ask, believing that he was prepared. The truth was, when the news about cannibal corpses broke Izuku had been sat on the toilet, flicking through a manga and mindlessly whistling a tune. He had been entirely unprepared for Ockako to start yelling at him through the door. The zombie apocalypse had arrived, and it had, in perhaps all ways, scared the shit out of him.

Still, his zombie knowledge was vast. Mentally he knew the stats of the types he'd encountered in his years of consuming media, be they shamblers or groaners. Floaters or growlers. He knew the lot. What he hadn't been prepared for was the fact that these sly bags of guts hardly made a single, damn sound. They had no breath with which to groan and growl, and their slowly rotting bodies dampened the sound of their footfalls as they dragged themselves toward you. More often than not, the first warning you had of a zombie approaching you was the smell, and *fuck,* was it a smell. There was nothing that could prepare a person for the stench of exposed, rotting human flesh, and that was often the only warning they would get before the gnashing, filthy maw descended onto them.

This was why they relied so heavily on Shouto and Tsu. It was often entirely on them to keep an eye on the area around them, warning Izuku and Ochako of any hordes approaching and guiding them to the safest route out. But, when inside of the mall, they were mostly all on their own, knowing that each step could be their last.

On this particular run, they decided not to wander deep into the mall. It had taken them days to find somewhere that seemed zombie-free, but by the time they came across this place, it was already starting to get dark, making the rotting creatures all the harder to spot. They only needed a few basics. Underwear was the kind of commodity no one put a whole lot of consideration to until they'd been forced to wear the same pair for an entire week, and Ochako was quick to shove several packs of boxers and briefs into her backpack when she came across them. She flashed Izuku

a wink as she grabbed one pair with the much-loved superhero, All Might, printed across both sides.

“Does Iida know you go in for that sort of thing?” Izuku asked, lips twisting into a teasing smirk, and Ochako’s already pink cheeks flushed.

“You bumhole, I was getting them for you!”

“Children, please. Iida won’t stand for that sort of language,” came Shouto’s voice through the walkie-talkie on Izuku’s hip. Ochako rolled her eyes.

“*Do I know you go in for what sort of thing?*” asked Iida. At that, Izuku laughed, pressing him hand to his mouth to muffle the sound as Ochako blushed harder.

“Nothing, sweetie,” she said quickly before pushing past Izuku, and the two of them made their way to the next corridor.

In Izuku’s opinion, there wasn’t a place in the world that made the absence of civilisation so evident as a mall. The overhead speakers still played the same easy listening it had been playing the day the malls were abandoned, except now it was tinny and crackling. A bucket and mop lay abandoned in the middle of the aisle with a wet floor sign collapsed not too far from it. A rock-hard but remarkably robust cheeseburger sat on one of the benches, a bite mark revealing what could honestly have been either blood or ketchup, darkened and congealed inside. The mall was a place that had once been so full of life, and now it stood empty; the only sound the tinny speakers and their footsteps across the dusty, waxy floor.

“These places freak me out,” Ochako sighed, her voice low and quiet as she glanced back at Izuku. He nodded in solidarity. She wasn’t wrong; it was pretty creepy here, though honestly a small part of Izuku kind of liked it. The silence, the boundless opportunity for adventure. He might have even enjoyed it if it hadn’t come at the cost of most of the human race.

“Hmm, at least the music is good,” he said, bobbing his head, green hair waving in time with the mall-time special. “Oh wait, here’s my favourite bit! *You make me feel awooodeeeedooweeedooo-*”

“*Will you quit messing around? No Unnecessary Risks!*” Iida demanded over the walkie-talkie.

“Sorry, Iida,” Izuku said as he hurried after Ochako, a grin on his face. *Hey, the world had ended but that didn’t mean they couldn’t have a little fun, right?* Ochako threw him a sly grin, rolling her eyes as they turned the next corner, slowing down so that they could peer down the aisle.

It was quiet and empty, and ahead of them lay arguably one of the most beautiful sights either of them had seen in some time… The store was painted bubblegum pink, with yellow dripping like icing down the upper half of the window, through which rows upon rows of equally brightly coloured parcels and packets could be seen. Ochako squealed for joy at the sight, her brown eyes widening.

“Ok, so it’s not groceries,” she said, holding her walkie to her mouth. “But we’ve found the next best thing.”

“*Is it toilet paper?*” Tsu asked.

“Ok, so not quite as good as toilet paper either, sorry,” Ochako admitted. “But trust me, you guys are going to love it.”

The two of them hurried to the store, Izuku keeping an eye out behind them as Ochako checked the inside before they finally looked around. Their eyes widened, mouths practically drooling at the wide array of sweets and candies lining the shelves. The very best thing about sugar, Izuku had come to realise, was its ridiculously long shelf life. And where once upon a time Izuku would have questioned that, now he couldn’t wait to make himself sick on as many bonbons as he could get his greedy mitts on.

Between them they began to load their backpacks with as many treats as they could carry, Izuku launching himself at the bumper packs of marshmallows and Oreos, holding them to his chest in nostalgic happiness.

“Now all we need is some orange soda, and we’ve got a three-course meal,” he said.

“Hey, have you ever tried taking the top off the Oreos and putting-”

“The marshmallow in? Ochako, back in my hometown we called that the *Midoriya Mallow Special*.”

“You’re making that up.”

“I’m not! And not like there’s anyone who can prove me wrong,” Izuku said with a shrug, thrusting the bags of goodies into his pack.

“Ooh, that’s cold.”

“Hey, how are things looking out there, Shouto?” Izuku asked with another smirk.

“*Front is still clear,*” Shouto replied. “*Nothing obstructing your way. I did see some movement a couple blocks east, but even if it is zombies you have a good ten-minute head start on them*.”

“That’s good! Tsu?”

“*Back entrance clear. I can see the side door, looks like access to the west if you guys get stuck.*”

“What do you think, Izuku? Call it quits here?”

Izuku looked over at Ochako to confirm, and she nodded.

“Yeh, I think we’ve pushed it enough. We’re gonna head to the front entrance.”

“*I can’t wait for a Midoriya Mallow Special,*” Shouto said, entirely deadpan. Ochako snorted.

“*Enough flirting,*” came Tsu, and Izuku buried his blush with a laugh of his own, securing his pack before they started to walk back to the entrance of the mall. He threw Ochako a good-natured grin at the success of their trip. Sure, they hadn’t found any of the essentials, but what was life if you couldn’t enjoy some novelty candy necklaces every once in a while?

Izuku knew something was wrong the second the smell hit him. They were somewhat used to it; an entire city full of corpses meant there wasn't anywhere left that didn't carry the sweet, pungent scent of decay. But they did grow accustomed to the passive stink and more aware of the rising aroma that suggested that something was coming their way. He froze, reaching out to grab Ochako's wrist and pulling her against the wall. Her wide eyes told him that she smelt it too.

"Radio silence," Izuku hissed, as quietly as he could through the walkie. It was a routine they had practised, and as desperately as Shouto, Iida and Tsu might want to know what was going on and if they were ok, they knew better than to say a single word until either Izuku or Ochako gave the all-clear. Walkie-talkie-related deaths were at an all-time high.

He carefully inched forward toward the corner of the aisle, back pressed flush against the wall of the store as he poked his head out. A group of zombies, probably about a dozen or so, were grouped outside of a media store; their faces blank and eye sockets empty, mouths opening and shutting silently as their rotting hands mindlessly slapped against the window. He pulled his head back, looking at Ochako.

"Twelve, maybe thirteen," he whispered. "They seem distracted; we should go another way."

Ochako nodded, and together they began to inch their way back to the sweet store before Ochako's sharp intake of breath grabbed his attention. He froze, looking up wildly in the direction she was facing, and his heart stopped. A single zombie had managed to creep its way behind them and now stood on the opposite side of the aisle.

There were so many things wrong with these bastards it was hard to know where to start. But, perhaps the most disturbing thing about them was a moment, just before each attack, where they seemed to stop and *consider*. The zombies, upon sensing prey, would usually freeze, bodies entirely still, hunkering down low like a cat as their sightless heads rotated in the direction of their target. This was how they found this zombie: shoulders hunched, legs almost buckling and with its face looking straight at them. There was no doubt they had been spotted; the only movement from the thing was the minute tilt of its head, right then left. Izuku had long suspected that they hunted by sense of smell and taste from the way they waved their heads around like they were trying to find the scent in the air, and this zombie sure as shit could smell them.

"Back, back," Izuku hissed, keeping his hand wrapped tightly around Ochako's wrist, body in front of hers as they started to back away, hoping to put more distance between them and the zombie before it decided to attack. They weren't able to get far before the zombie chose to strike, its broken, rotting body stumbling forward with a speed that would always scare the shit out of Izuku. It threw itself over the benches between them with the kind of grace that seemed only possible in a creature that couldn't care less whether or not it broke its neck in the process.

"Shit!" Izuku hissed before he grabbed the wakizashi hanging from his hip.

One of the ways they had survived so long was by avoiding the zombies as much as possible, but that didn't mean that they hadn't needed to fight them. The group had built up a pretty impressive death count over the last eighteen months, and though Izuku wasn't as strong as Iida or Shouto, what he lacked in strength he made up for with speed. He was able to slip out of situations that others might have had trouble in, and he quickly darted to the right, throwing Ochako behind him again as the zombie launched. He thrust outwards, his sword connecting sharply with the zombie's

jaw. It wasn't enough to keep it down permanently, but it threw it to the ground with a thud, and he reached out to shove the point of his blade deep into its ear canal, teeth gritted and grimacing against the crunch and crack of brittle bones. With his foot pressed on the thing's neck, he pulled his weapon free and turned to look for Ochako. It was a good kill, a quiet kill. Unfortunately, there was no way to kill these fuckers silently. There was no way to prevent the scent of freshly spilt brains and innards from attracting the attention of the zombies looming by the media store. Sure enough, he could already see the group rounding the corner, a dozen frighteningly intent yet sightless faces staring directly at them.

"Time to go!" Izuku yelled, and Ochako didn't need telling twice, grabbing his hand as they broke into a sprint.

"How are those exits looking, Tsu?" Ochako panted into her walkie as they skidded down the aisles.

"*Still clear!*" Tsu said, clearly trying to contain her panic. "*What's happening in there?*"

"Zombies must have already been in the mall," Izuku replied. "Twelve on our tail!"

They spotted the signs directing them to the exit, and Ochako let out a cry of relief. Izuku spared a glance behind him; the zombies were still on their tails. Whilst they couldn't usually run as fast as Izuku could, it was still a gut-wrenching and horrifying sight watching these things come after them, using their hands and legs to go as fast as they could, intent on catching their prey. It was going to be tight, but hopefully, they could lose them out on the streets with both Shouto and Tsu guiding them. They had done it before; they could handle it again. But luck wasn't to be on their side this time, and Izuku let out a cry as yet another group stumbled out of a clothing store, attracted by the commotion and cutting off their escape.

"Shit!" Ochako swore, dragging Izuku to a halt.

Izuku's eyes darted about, assessing the situation they had found themselves in. The zombies following would be on them in a matter of moments, and those in front had spotted them, hunkering and stumbling forward. They could risk it and run forward, hoping that they could get past without any of the zombies snatching them. But he knew how unlikely that was… not without a distraction.

"Ochako, go for the back exit," he said, and she swung around.

"What the *fuck*, Izuku!"

"Go! I'll distract them-"

"Absolutely not, you lunatic!" she screeched. But Izuku shook his head, taking off his backpack and thrusting it into her arms.

"No time to argue! I'm faster; I'll go for the front. Go!"

He didn't wait for an answer before jumping forward, climbing onto the benches in the middle of the aisle and waving his hands in the air.

“Hey! Hey, shit for brains! Over here!”

It was enough. The zombies coming out of the store immediately shifted their focus onto him and began to rush forward. Izuku saw Ochako slip past, racing towards the back of the mall with a backwards glance, and breathed a sigh of relief. She was safe, for the moment at least. Izuku’s situation was a whole other thing entirely, however, and his mind began racing as he tried to work out his next move now that he had the attention of at least twenty bloodthirsty zombies.

Glancing down at his feet, he realised his best hope was to slow the zombies down, and after taking a deep breath, he lifted his arms and began to yell, encouraging the zombies to come at him as they clumsily changed course. There was no room for error as they came at him with every violent intent, and he readied himself to jump.

“One, two… three!”

He jumped backwards, hands reaching out as he vaulted over the bench, feeling a grabbing hand brush against the leg of his jeans. His feet skid on the waxed floor as he ran, leaping over the snapping jaws of one zombie as it found itself crushed beneath the weight of those behind it.

“Ochako!” he yelled into his walkie.

“*I’m out!*”

“*Ochako the way is still clear; get out of there!*” Izuku heard Tsu yell.

“*Izuku, are you out? Where are you?*” Ochako all but sobbed, her voice desperate.

“I’m past them!” he panted, heels skidding. “They’re still after me, about twenty, but I can outrun them!”

“*Izuku, there’s been a change in the situation*,” Shouto said suddenly, his voice calm, yet Izuku knew him well enough to catch the hint of panic.

“It better be an ice cream truck or something because this situation is already bad enough!”

“*There’s a group headed your way. They’ve passed the west crossing. You should be able to outrun them, but you are going to need to go east.*”

Izuku’s stomach dropped. East was uncharted territory… the tightly packed alleyways leading to a residential area that they had been avoiding at all costs.

“*East?*” said Iida. “*But… we don’t know what’s over there!*”

Izuku panted hard, checking over his shoulder. Some of the zombies were faster than the others, and he knew that if he slowed his pace even a little, they would catch up with him. He couldn’t go back, but he couldn’t head west towards safety. Up north was a horde, and a goddamn fucking massive one at that, and south was blocked by debris and a car pile-up that would be almost impossible to negotiate with zombies on his tail.

“Shouto,” he said. “How much can you see? Can you guide me back around?”

Shouto was quiet for a moment, and Izuku braced himself.

"*I will do my best,*" he replied.

"That's all I ask for, baby!" Izuku replied with a horse laugh, and he heard Ochako whine down the walkie.

"*Seriously? Quit joking around, Izuku, this is serious!*"

"Best time for jokes," Izuku panted as the entrance came into view, the street now visible. He could do this; he would make it.

He leapt free, slamming the doors open and skidding onto the street, putting faith in Shouto's skills and not wasting a second to appraise the area before he veered left, thundering down the road.

"*I see you,*" Shouto said, and Izuku had never been more grateful for how calm his friend was in these sorts of situations. "*Keep running straight. There's a T-junction ahead. Turn left.*"

"Got it!"

Izuku ran, his red sneakers pounding on the pavement, his breath coming out in harsh pants and sweat dripping down his temples and neck. He slowed his pace just a little as he saw the junction ahead of him, readying to turn left.

"*Shit! Wait!*"

Izuku stumbled to a halt, mouth wide as he panted hard, looking back over his shoulder. He knew Shouto wouldn't have stopped him if he thought the horde could catch up quickly, and from the looks of things he might have a good thirty second on them now.

"What is it?"

"*There's another group of zombies,*" Shouto hissed. "*Dammit! They must have been drawn to the rest of them. They've just come from an alley due east; you can't go left without running into them*."

"Ok, then I go right."

"*It looks clear, but, Izuku, the street narrows about twenty metres in. I'm- I'm not going to be able to see you.*"

Izuku swallowed, watching the mall zombies behind him. He could see the other group now, too, crawling out of the alleyway and heading in his direction. He groaned.

"Well, looks like I'll have to risk it."

"*Izuku-*"

"Yeh, yeh I know. *No Unnecessary Risks*, right? Not sure I can avoid it this time."

"*Izuku, keep talking to us!*" Ochako pleaded. "*Find somewhere safe, ok? We'll come and get you*

when it's clear!"

"Sounds good," Izuku breathed.

"*I don't wanna make things worse, guys,*" came Tsu, "*but if we wait here any longer, then Iida and Ochako are going to get caught by that horde coming from the west.*"

"*Damn! Tsu, how close are they to us?*" asked Iida.

"*You've still got about five minutes… uh, well, maybe more like four. You should be able to slip past and get back to the safe house.*"

"It's ok," Izuku said. "I'll keep on the road and find somewhere I can hold up. I'll be fine, ok? We'll work this out once these groups have moved on."

"*Izuku, I don't like this,*" Ochako breathed.

"Me neither," Izuku replied with a nervous laugh. "Ok, I'm heading right now. Still clear as far as you can see, Shouto?"

"*As far as I can see.*"

Izuku could hear how tense Shouto was, but there were no options left. The group behind were hot on his heels, the zombies to the left churning forward, and he had to go now or get caught by both of them. He took a deep breath before racing off, watching with dread as the narrowed street grew closer and closer, splitting off into a fork. He took the right and hoped that it would eventually lead him back to their safe house and his friends, his breath coming out in painful gasps.

"*Izuku, I can't see you anymore.*"

"Noted," Izuku replied. "Keep talking; tell me what's happening back there."

"*B-both groups have combined; they're still following you.*" The smallest stammer in Shouto's voice betrayed how afraid his friend was, and Izuku felt his stomach twist and churn. Making his friends worry about him felt almost as bad as realising he was now running blind.

"It seems clear ahead," Izuku said, slowing his gait just a fraction so that he could keep a keen eye on what was going on around him. The smaller residential streets were still wide enough for him to hopefully dodge past any zombies he might come across. It was possible that, should he get stuck, he could still duck into one of the houses and find some safety there, but he still felt far from confident of that.

"*Izuku?*" It was Ochako now, sounding terrified.

"I'm good," he replied. "What about you guys? You and Iida back with Tsu yet?"

"*She's almost here,*" Iida replied.

"*Izuku*," Ochako repeated, her voice breaking. "*I'm so sorry, I shouldn't have left you! I shouldn't-*"

"Hey, don't do that," Izuku replied, lowering his voice as he watched the streets, now lined with

young trees. “The only reason we both got away was that we split up. It was the right call, Ochako.”

“*B-but I’m s-safe and you’re-*”

“I’m going to be fine,” he responded, firmly. “I’m going to try and get into one of these houses until the groups go by, ok?”

“*O-Ok…*”

“*I can’t see the group anymore,*” said Shouto. “*But I’m pretty sure they’re still following you.*”

“Ugh, don’t they have anything better to be doing?”

Izuku slowed to a jog, looking back over his shoulder. He couldn’t see the zombies anymore, and that was a good sign.

“Fuck!”

He cried out as something collided heavily with his left side and threw him onto the pavement. The weight and the stink of the mass landing on top of him made him gag. He hadn’t even seen it… the zombie must have been behind one of the cars or fucking something because it had sure spotted him.

“*Izuku!*”

He grunted, unable to reach the wakizashi at his hips and forced to push the body back as his vision was filled with rotting flesh and empty eye sockets, teeth like tombstones gnashing and snapping an inch from his nose.

“*Izuku!*”

He heaved, crying out as he pushed until he was finally able to throw the zombie off him, rolling quickly to his side and grabbing his weapon. He swung the moment he grabbed the handle, the blade colliding with the zombie's temple just as it threw itself at him again. With a grunt he landed hard, the stinking body falling back on top of him, his walkie falling from his belt and being kicked across the pavement in the chaos. He gasped, breathing heavily, pushing the body off of him.

“*Izuku! Dammit, answer us!*”

He reached out blindly, grasping for the walkie-talkie with one hand, and wiping the blood and brains away from his mouth before his fingers froze. He had wasted too much time, and the large group from before were mere seconds from crushing him, mouths wide and snarling silently. There was no time to reach the walkie-talkie, and he scrambled to his feet trying real fucking hard not to panic. There were at least twenty sets of gnashing jaws and swiping claws at his heels, all desperate to pull his body apart and devour it. He almost slipped, trying to keep his grip on his blood-coated weapon. One zombie launched, and he dodged to the right before pain exploded in his side and he screamed, swiping out blindly in response and slicing the jaw of the zombie closest to him. In the brief reprieve, he looked down to see the branch of a tree pierced just below his ribcage, blood pooling from the wound and sending the zombies into a frenzy. He knew in any other situation, pulling the branch free was the last thing he should do. But, between taking his chances with the

zombies or bleeding to death, he'd rather the latter. He screamed again as he pulled his body free.

"*Izuku!*"

He heard Ochako's desperate cries from the walkie, now beneath the feet of the horde, before he turned tail and began to run, one hand pressed to his right side, hot blood making his finger tacky. His breath came out in sharp, painful gasps, adrenaline the only thing keeping him on his feet at this stage as he ran until, to his complete horrified dismay, yet another pair of zombies stepped out in front of him.

"Are you kidding me?" he cried. There was an alleyway to his left, and making a split-second decision, he took it, panting as he ran down the narrow pathway. His body hit the walls, and he ran, smearing blood against them, but it wasn't enough. Fate had caught up with him, and his luck had finally run dry.

The alley came to a dead end ahead of him, a high wall at the very end of it. There were bins knocked over beside it, but Izuku knew there'd be no time for him to stack them and use them to climb up onto the wall. This was it.

"Shit!"

He swung around, the zombies filling the alley as they followed him, mouths stretched wide in anticipation. If this was how he was going to go out, he sure as shit was going to do it standing. He held his wakizashi in front of him, taking a shaky hand from the wound at his side and gripping his wrist to keep his arm steady. His lips tore back into a very un-Izuku-like snarl.

"Do your fucking worst!"

But then, two things happened. In such quick succession that Izuku was almost left with whiplash. He tracked movement in the corner of his vision, something bright soaring high over his head, flickering and flashing. He hadn't a chance to make sense of what it was before it landed amongst the zombies and exploded in front of him, throwing him backwards.

"*What the-*"

He gasped as he saw the horde go up in flames, their bodies thrashing and twisting, some of them even trying to get back down the alley as if to escape the flames, a moment that quietly lodged its way in Izuku's brain.

"*Eat my fucking flames, cocksuckers!*"

"What the f-"

Izuku twisted on the spot, wincing in pain as he looked behind him to where the loud, harsh voice had come from, eyes settling on a sight that, were it not for the heat from the flames, could have been a hallucination brought about by blood loss.

Behind him, standing on top of the wall, was a man dressed in a black tank top, bottles crisscrossed across his hips and onto the thighs of his bright orange combats. His hair was a shock of spiked-up blond, his eyes a deep fiery red that glowed in the low evening light, alive with a certain madness that Izuku had only seen in damn comic books and never in real life. And his smile… lips drawn

back in a wide manic snarl of a grin that matched the flames ahead of him in their burning ferocity.

"*What the fuck?*" Izuku choked.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 2: Take a Braincheck

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He came to with a shrill whistling in his ears. The heat pressing on his chest and face made it impossible for him to take a solid breath, and he gasped and spluttered as he watched the flames grow in front of him, torching the crumbling bodies. The smell could only be described as *hellish*; a stinking miasma, putrid and sweet all in one, the impossible possibility that his brain could make up something so vile was the only assurance he had that he was even alive right now. But despite the stink and the heat, his body was starting to crash fast, only just beginning to acknowledge the shock and blood loss and beginning to shake and tremor in response.

“You alive?”

His ears didn’t register the voice behind him at first. It was just something else for him to file away for later as his focus fell on the scene in front of him. His eyes were wide, chest still heaving as his brain tried to catch up with all that was going on around him. *Was he dead?* Had he died back there and found himself in hell? He watched as the body of the zombie closest to him began to crackle and pop, the sizzles and whistles just sickening enough to break through the ringing in his ears.

“Oi! Nerd, can you fucking hear me?”

Izuku started, awareness coming back to him as the weight of his surroundings and his current situation kicked him in the gut. He gasped, the weapon in his hand dropping to the concrete with a clatter as he placed his palm over the gaping, bleeding wound in his side. He gritted his teeth, fighting the pain coursing through his body to look behind him.

So, it *hadn’t* been a dream, after all? There was a man on the wall, just as he thought, standing with his head cocked to one side. The features of his face were hard for him to make out from this distance and through the smoke, but he didn’t miss the narrowing of his eyes and the flash of white as his lips pulled back into a grimace.

“Oi,” the man repeated, dropping to his haunches. The bottles on his belt clinked together loudly. “Smell is gonna attract more of those fuckers soon. You gonna move or did you actually want to be zombie bait?”

“B-bait…” Izuku muttered, blinking dumbly, looking towards the melting zombies and realising all at once that, *no*, he didn’t wanna be fucking zombie bait. He shook his head weakly, and with a pained gasp, he started to clamber to his feet. He could feel his knees shaking and threatening to buckle beneath him, and a whine left his lips before he could stop it. The stranger's eyes narrowed more before he held out a hand, waving it impatiently.

“Any time you like.”

Izuku grimaced, his palm still pressed to his side as he approached the wall, tentatively stepping up onto the metal bin thrown on its side. He reached out for the hand, impatiently snapping fingers hovering just above him and urging him to hurry. For a moment, he was sure that there was no way

the man could pull him up onto the wall; there were no handholds, nothing for Izuku to grab onto. But, when the strong and rough hand grabbed him, the fingers tightened around his wrist, and he was pulled upwards. Izuku's eyes widened, almost certainly in a way that he would have been embarrassed about if his head wasn't so foggy, as he looked up to see the biggest set of shoulders he'd ever seen in his damn life. The muscles in the stranger's arms bulged with the effort, and before Izuku could do a single thing to help, he was pulled up and onto the wall with a grunt.

Izuku fell to his knees, his legs no longer able to support him. The whole situation was far too surreal; he had been saved from certain death by fire raining down from above, and frankly, he was having a hard time processing it. But he was *alive* . And it was thanks to this stranger, whose hand he was still gripping with all the strength he had remaining, now crouching and staring right back at him.

"Th-thank you," Izuku breathed, letting the rough hand extract itself from his own.

"Yeh, yeh," the stranger said shortly, his expression scrutinising. "Just what the hell do you think you were doing?"

Up close the man was no less… *well*, he was fucking terrifying. His eyes blazed, fixing him with an aggressive stare that would have once spurred Izuku to offer up his wallet or something. His spiky blond hair was heavily undercut, revealing three large scars that resembled scratch marks starting at his left temple and high up into his hairline. His mouth seemed fixed into a sneer, lips parted to reveal his canines as if he were readying to tear Izuku's throat out. But, where he was terrifying, in his state of shock, Izuku also found that the stranger was somewhat captivating. His eyes were frightening, cruel even, but they glowed such a rich red that Izuku was put in mind of strawberry sauce and cherries. That sneer was sure dangerous, but it was set on golden skin dusted with the faintest trace of freckles over his nose. And those shoulders, hunched over and primed like a battering ram, were somewhat difficult to ignore, and Izuku found himself shivering, the hair on his arms standing up.

"Hah? You say something?" the stranger demanded, leaning closer, and Izuku was partially aware that he might have also been mumbling. "Oi, anyone in there?"

The stranger reached out with his fist as if to knock on Izuku's head, but as exhausted as he was, his instincts were still sharp. Months of sleeping with one eye open, always on the lookout for danger, had given him the reflexes of a cat, and his body screamed *danger!* at him. His hand shot out, grabbing the stranger around the wrist and yanking outwards, thrusting forward with the flat of his palm to their chest. He saw the surprise register briefly on the man's face before he was quickly and easily overpowered, tough fingers snatching at his hair and tugging backwards with enough force that Izuku was thrown onto his back with a pained cry. The stranger loomed over him, entirely unfriendly and deadly.

"You better think twice about attacking the guy who just saved your worthless ass," he growled, face much too close. Izuku struggled beneath him before the pain on his side caused him to cry out again, his eyes flinching shut.

"Sh-shit," he whimpered breathlessly.

The weight lifted off him, and the stranger grabbed his shoulders and heaved him forward into a sitting position once more.

“Were you bit?”

Izuku blinked, feeling light-headed. Blackness had started to invade the edges of his vision, everything growing steadily foggier.

“Shit. Oi, don’t fucking pass out on me, asshole! *Were you bit?”*

But Izuku couldn’t say anything more, his mouth gaping soundlessly before everything went entirely black…

“I still can’t believe you brought this guy back.”

“Fuck you. You think I’m a complete bastard?”

“I know you’re a complete bastard.”

“Fucking bite me, Dunce Face.”

“Little bit on the nose for this day and age, don’t you think?”

“Fine. Suck my dick.”

“It’s been eighteen months since I last got laid, Blasty, so you wanna get a room?”

“I swear to fuck-”

Izuku jolted, his head dropping to the side before his world exploded in pain. The burn radiating from the wound in his side twisted up to his shoulders and down to his hips, and he began to panic. He didn’t recognise any of the voices and when his eyes snapped open he was looking up at an unfamiliar, swirling ceiling, the scent of peroxide in the air overwhelming. He shot up, hands sliding uselessly beneath him and feeling the rough texture of towels before his side exploded in pain again, yelling out and buckling forward. He felt hands press firmly against his chest and shoulder.

“Hey! Take it easy, guy, we just stitched you up!”

Izuku blinked, eyes darting to the figure closest to him. He had dark hair, wide and earnest eyes, and most definitely not a face that he recognised. In his shock, he hardly registered what the man had said to him, and his only concern now was to protect himself. His hands dropped to his sides, reaching for the belt loop from which his weapon usually hung.

“Looking for this, dickwad?”

His eyes darted left, settling on the aggressive-looking stranger that had attacked the zombies in the street with a fucking Molotov. He watched him with narrowed eyes, Izuku’s wakizashi held by the point of the blade between two fingers.

“Katsuki, don’t be an ass.”

Another voice grabbed his attention, and he swung his head back to see a woman with bubblegum-pink hair leaning in closer, her hazel eyes looking at him in concern.

“I told you to stop telling me what to do.”

“Katty-chan getting mad again.”

“Don’t think I won’t fucking murder you!”

Izuku swallowed, feeling no more at ease despite the gentle look on the woman’s face.

“W-where am I?”

“Somewhere safe,” the woman assured him. “We’re not going to hurt you, I promise. We’re not that sort of people.”

“Not unless you are,” the blond by the door growled.

“I-uh,” Izuku’s voice trailed off, feeling decidedly faint. His hand reached back to his side, realising then that he wasn’t wearing a shirt, and it had been replaced with a thick white bandage wrapped snugly around his midriff, stained with blood. A rush of memories came back to him then… being separated from Ochako in the mall… running from the zombies… the tree branch piercing his side, a dead end… and then a crash, flames, and a wild manic grin. He shut his eyes tight, taking a deep breath as he tried to steady his nerves.

“You feeling ok, sugar?”

He looked up. The woman with the kind face was still watching him, leaning in and cocking her head to the side in concern. He took a deep shuddering breath and nodded.

“I-yes. Thank you.”

“It’s a good job we found you,” said someone else, and Izuku took a moment to fully appraise the room that he was in and those that he was in it with. It was some kind of open-plan living room-cum-kitchenette, with gear and weaponry across almost every available surface. And there was a lot of it. Beside him sat the pink-haired woman and black-haired man, and sitting on a couch was another man with an open, friendly face, his bright red hair spiked up. Leaning on the back of the couch like he was attempting to look carefree and nonchalant was a man with yellow-blond hair pulled back from his face with several colourful clips. To his left, sitting at the island between the kitchen and the living area, was the man still staring daggers at him, twirling Izuku’s knife between his fingers with one hand and nursing a bottle of vodka in the other. Izuku swallowed, dragging his eyes away from the man two steps away from murdering him where he sat and towards the rest of the group.

“Thanks for, uh, patching me up,” he said. At that, the pink-haired woman beamed, looking pleased with herself.

“Oh, don’t mention it! You’re not out of the woods just yet; it could still get infected if you’re not careful. You’ll probably need to rest up for a few days.”

A few days?! Izuku's mind raced as his hand gingerly pressed over his wound again. As much as he appreciated the help of these complete strangers, his thoughts lingered on his friends. He needed to know if they were ok. He needed to get back to them as soon as he could!

"I- I have friends," he said urgently. "Did anyone-"

"Sorry, guy," the red-haired man said. "Were they, ah, out there with you?"

Izuku frowned, trying to recollect what they had said about their location before he had dropped his walkie-talkie. Ochako and Tenya had seemed safe from what Tsu had said, and he could only hope that they had the sense to go back to their safe house instead of coming to look for him…

"Hopefully not," he said. "Look, I really appreciate your help but I need to get back out there. My friends are going to be looking for me."

He went to get back to his feet before two sets of hands grabbed him and pushed him back onto the couch.

"Are you suicidal or something?" the man with black hair yelped.

"Yeh, man! It's night for starters," said the electric blond. "And you wouldn't make it five steps without collapsing!"

"Great, he's a fucking moron," the angry blond scoffed. "Fuck it, let him go. Got enough dead weight around here already."

"Dude!"

"Kaminari is right," the pink-haired woman said. "There's no way you'll be able to outrun any zombies in the state you're in."

Izuku swallowed, his throat so damn dry before he nodded shakily. He didn't make it this far by making reckless decisions… *No Unnecessary Risks.* Those words had kept him alive this long. It had been Tenya who started their group moto, and it was Tenya who he would be putting his faith in now to keep his friends safe. *They would be ok.* He could go back to them in a day or two when he could walk.

"Right," he said. "Sorry, I'm still a bit… uh, thank you. Again."

"It's really ok!" the red-haired man insisted. "Seriously, dude. We need to look out for each other now, right?"

Izuku glanced up, surprised at this. He heard the angry blond let out a derisive puff of air. It all seemed a little strange to Izuku, not least of all because he had been the one who had saved his life.

"Still, you didn't have to help me," he replied. "There are a lot of people out there who wouldn't have done."

"Yeh, well," the red-haired man sighed, "we ain't them."

Izuku laughed weakly, rubbing the back of his head. “Lucky for me, huh? My name’s Izuku, by the way. Midoriya Izuku.”

“Kirishima Eijirou,” the red-haired man replied, getting to his feet with a wide grin, revealing pointed teeth.

“Nice to meet you.” Izuku took Kirishima’s outstretched hand, shaking it.

“And this is Ashido Mina. Just call her Mina.”

“Pleased to meet you!” the pink-haired woman said, grabbing his hand with a whole lot of enthusiasm.

“And the man who stitched you up is Sero Hanta.”

“Just don’t look at them too closely; I’m still practising,” the black-haired man replied with a somewhat nervous laugh.

“And this is Kaminari Denki.”

“‘Sup my dude!” the electric blond said with a wave. Izuku smiled at him before a loud sound made him jump, the angry blond standing up and dragging his stool over the lino.

“This is fucking stupid,” he growled, glaring at each of his companions in turn. “You really wanna make the same fucking mistake again?”

Izuku’s brow furrowed, glancing back at the others in the room, hoping that their faces would offer some kind of explanation.

“Ka-”

“Nah,” the man snapped, shaking his head and snatching the bottle of vodka and Izuku’s wakizashi from the table. “Don’t get fucking comfortable, asshole,” he said, now squaring Izuku with a look that would have made a far larger man than Izuku quail. “And I’m keeping hold of this.” He raised the wakizashi before slipping it into his back pocket and storming from the room, kicking debris across the floor and slamming the door loudly behind him. Izuku winced; an uncomfortable silence was left in the stranger’s wake.

“Don’t mind him,” Kirishima said after a tense moment. “He just… well it’s been a long time since we last had anyone new around. He doesn’t trust easily.”

“No, I get it,” Izuku replied, still looking at the door. “We’ve not had anyone new join our group since it started. It’s hard to trust anyone, and it sounds like you’ve already had a pretty bad experience.”

“It was a while ago,” Kirishima replied, looking a little uncomfortable and glancing over at Kaminari. Izuku took that as his cue not to ask anything about it. “And he’ll come around, so don’t worry about it.”

Izuku hummed, doubtful. “That man… Kacchan? What I don’t get is he’s the one who saved me.”

To his surprise, Kaminari burst into laughter, the sound so loud that it made Izuku jump.

“Do not let him hear you calling him that!” Sero said, a nervous grin on his face.

“Oh, sorry! I thought what I heard you call him!” Izuku yelped. “I didn’t mean any disrespect-”

“Oh damn, *Kacchan*,” Kaminari continued to snigger. “That’s fucking gold, Midoriya.”

“Not if it’s gonna get him murdered, it’s not,” Kirishima hissed, eyes glancing nervously towards the door.

“What Kaminari is trying to say is, the angry one is Bakugou,” Mina explained. “We just like to mess with him, is all.”

“Oh, right.” It wasn’t really an answer to his question, but if there was one thing that he had gathered from this, it was that discussions related to *Bakugou* weren’t ideal right now. Regardless, he was still curious. The man had saved his life, after all. He had to assume he was the one who had dragged him off that wall and to safety.

“You should try and get some more rest,” Mina said, offering him another smile. “We’ve got some painkillers if you want them; otherwise, we’ll talk more in a few hours.”

Izuku nodded, bowing his head. “Thank you, Mina,” he said honestly. “Again. Thank you for everything. Let me know how I can repay you all.”

“For now, just take it easy,” Mina replied, getting to her feet. “I’ll wake you up when it’s time to eat.”

Izuku wasn’t entirely sure how he could possibly get any sleep at this stage, no matter how exhausted he felt and how much his body still hurt. As nice as everyone seemed, he hadn’t made it this far by blindly trusting people he had just met. And yet, they had taken him in. They had patched him up and offered him valuable medication and food, and he couldn’t think of why they would do anything like that if they were planning on hurting him. He was sure that the angry blond, *Bakugou*, would have already killed him if the group had even considered that as an option, and that in itself was more comforting than it ought to have been.

In the end, it didn’t matter what he thought, because the moment he laid his head on the couch, the fatigue hit him like a truck, and he passed out to dreams haunted by flames and teeth.

When Izuku next woke, it was to the sound of fat sizzling and the salty scent of what could only be meat wafting through the air, his stomach growling in response. They were almost always hungry these days; the easier places like the grocery store had been looted right back at the start, and with his group being on the move most of the time, they couldn't store food, let alone grow anything. Their best option? Cans, wherever they could find them. Dried goods, anything that could be heated over an open flame. With five of them to feed, it was slim pickings. But these guys? Shit, they had *pork,* and his stomach continued to growl embarrassingly loud.

There was activity from the kitchenette, and despite the kindness already offered to him, he was still feeling on edge. He was vulnerable right now; his side hurt, and he was weak from blood loss

and hunger. His odds of fighting anyone off right now were pretty slim, and in this new world of zombies and bandits, that made him incredibly vulnerable. Someone had already noticed he was awake, however, and he saw a head perk up and turn in his direction over the island separating him from them.

“Oh! Hey, you’re awake!

It was Kaminari who spoke, his electric blond hair standing up in all directions as if he had just woken up from a fitful sleep. At this, the other person in the kitchen also looked around.

“Morning Midoriya,” Sero said. “You fancy some breakfast?”

Izuku blinked, sitting up and rubbing his eyes. It was taking a long time for him to get accustomed to the fact that the people here were treating him so kindly.

“Sure, thanks,” he replied. His side still hurt, but the pain lacked the searing intensity it had the night before. He threw his feet over the edge of the couch with a small hiss. He was sweaty like he had spent the night tossing and turning, and he could really go for a shower. But the smell of cooking meat was far too enticing, and after testing the pain with each step, he made his way to the kitchen. Kaminari watched him, arms half out as if to grab him if he fell.

“Is that pork?” Izuku asked, stopping beside the island so he could lean his elbow on it. “*Real pork?* ”

“Sure is,” Sero replied with a broad grin as he pushed the pieces of meat across the pan on what looked like a portable gas burner. “We’ve been rationing this since the start.”

Izuku’s eyebrows rose, his jaw dropping in surprise. “How on earth have you been doing that?”

“Portable propane freezer,” came a response from the doorway, and Izuku looked back to see Mina and Kirishima entering the kitchen. “That baby has been a lifesaver!”

“That’s smart!” Izuku replied, impressed, before he then noticed the black unit pushed back against a dusty old washing machine. The nerd inside of him screamed for him to investigate, and he limped over to open the door. It only really occurred to him after that it might not have been the most polite thing to do in the home of complete strangers who had saved his life, but they never said curiosity killed the cat without reason. A rush of chilled air met his face as the door opened, and he looked at the selection of frozen meat packed inside.

“Where did you even find this?” he asked excitedly, reaching a hand out to brush over the dusting of ice on the shelves. He heard a snort of amusement behind him.

“RV,” Sero replied.

“Shut up,” Izuku said instantly, eyes widening in delight and looking up from the freezer. “Where did you find *that?”*

“Actually it belonged to my folks,” Kaminari said, looking smug. “We used to travel a lot. Kinda made sense to commandeer it when we could, you know?”

“Yeh, no damn,” Izuku laughed, shutting the freezer door with the smallest amount of regret. It

wasn't like it was particularly warm this time of year, but the allure of the fresh freezing air was hard to ignore. "Do you still have it?"

"Of course we do!" Kirishima said as he placed a kettle onto the gas burner. "As if we'd let something like tha-"

"Oi! Shut the hell up!" came an angry snarl, and immediately the cheerful atmosphere was gone. Izuku quickly got to his feet, wincing at the pain in his side as he did so, the room falling silent at the sight of Bakugou standing in the doorway, eyes blazing. "You wanna fucking tell this asshole where the keys are whilst you're at it?"

"Oh come on, Katsuki," Kaminari said, turning his back and tending to the bacon, lifting the pan off the stove. "You really think he's here to steal from us?"

Izuku stiffened, eyes widening at this. Sure enough, Bakugou was all but growling at him again, and though the molly bottles that had been crisscrossed over his hips were absent, he didn't miss the knife strapped to his calf. Nor did he miss the way his fingers inched towards what he swiftly realised was a bat covered in nails lying on the table by the doorway. Kaminari seemed to notice the silence, glancing over his shoulder and laughing.

"Go on, Midoriya my man. Tell him you're not here to steal from us."

Izuku swallowed, eyes darting from the aggressive, muscled man in a tank top to his hosts.

"I'm not quite sure that's gonna cut it somehow," he muttered. Bakugou scoffed before his hand clutched the cartoonish display of violence on the counter and thrust it at him, nail end first.

"Whoa, Bakugou!" Kirishima yelped, taking half a step forward.

"Your fucking group," Bakugou snarled, advancing on Izuku. "How many of you are there?"

Izuku held up his hands, but something about the way this man glared at him made him certain it would make very little difference how harmless he tried to look. The people here had been kind to him so far, sure, but here was the thing… up until now, *his* friends hadn't been involved. Their safety hadn't been compromised, and it had only been his to consider. The rest of this group seemed ok, but this guy Bakugou with the hairpin trigger and penchant for violence was a whole other thing entirely.

"Katsuki," said Mina as she stepped forward with her hands out in a placating gesture. "Don't you think this is a little excessive?"

Bakugou shot her a cold glare.

"Not in the fucking slightest," he growled. "You got until the count of three, fucker. How many are in your group? And you better not lie to me."

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek, looking back at the eyes staring him down, thinking fast. If he told him how many, that didn't mean he would be leading them to his group… they'd need his cooperation for that, and Izuku had no intention of giving it to them.

“Five,” he replied eventually, keeping his eyes fixed upon Bakugou and the bat. “Including me.”

Bakugou’s eyes narrowed more, lips raising into a snarl. “How many men and women?” he demanded. Izuku blinked.

“Huh?”

“How many you fucking deku!” Bakugou yelled, advancing another step.

“I don’t see why you’d need to know-”

“Just answer him, Midoriya,” Mina said. And for the first time, he could see wariness in her eyes too, watching him closely. He glanced at the others, and sure enough, the carefree attitude in the room was gone, and he became painfully aware of how many weapons there were about.

“Three guys,” he replied, looking at Bakugou. “Two women.”

Bakugou took a huge step forward, and suddenly the nail-bitten bat was thrust beneath his chin, forcing Izuku to back up against the wall, hands out in submission.

“You better be telling the fucking truth, or I’ll break both your legs and leave you out there.”

He wasn’t joking.

“I’m telling the truth,” he replied through gritted teeth, heart pounding in his chest as his mind and body raced over the various fight-or-flight scenarios in his head. He’d got this far, and he wasn’t about to let some Mad Max reject-looking asshole take him down. “Why would I even lie about something like that?”

Bakugou’s face was uncomfortably close to his, and he could make out every furious crease of his brow. His fiery eye darted between each of his before he mercifully stepped back, chucking the bat onto the table. Izuku let out a breath of relief, but it was short-lived when Bakugou rounded on him again.

“What do you know about other groups in this area?”

Izuku blinked, surprised. “Other groups?”

“Are you fucking stupid? Yeh, that’s what I damn well said.”

“Nothing!” Izuku replied. “We make a point of *avoiding* other groups. We had a feeling there was someone else here; some places had been freshly looted since we came across them, but we’d never seen anyone.”

Bakugou scowled at him for a heartbeat before looking back at his group.

“When was the last time you saw another group?” Kirishima asked. Izuku’s stomach churned at this.

“B-border of Minato,” he replied, his mind taking him back to the events of that day, bile rising to his stomach when he thought about how close that group had come to finding them. Bakugou

didn't miss the tremor in his voice, glaring at him once more, eyes staring with such an intensity that was enough to make Izuku shiver. For a moment he thought he was going to ask more about it, but he took a step away and focused on his group again.

"Those fuckers are back," he said. Izuku looked quickly between the group as he saw them tense up. Kaminari's breath caught, his hands curling into fists.

"Who's back?"

But Bakugou was ignoring him now. "Spotted all four of them this morning coming from the west. Fucking had to be them; it's that damn shitty-ass station wagon."

"Did they see you?" Sero asked, the pork now abandoned and starting to burn.

"Who the fuck do you take me for?" Bakugou scoffed. "Of course, they didn't."

But Izuku's brain had come to a complete halt the second he heard the words *'coming from the west'.* This group, whoever they were, were enough to make a person like Bakugou nervous. They had to be bad news. Bad news that had come from the direction of his group and their safe house.

"I say we stay quiet," Mina said, her tone serious. Bakugou immediately growled at that, turning on her with an expression of disbelief. She raised her hands in frustration. "I get it, Bakugou, I know how badly you wanna go after them! But what's the point?"

"What's the *point?"* Bakugou snarled. "You better be joking."

"I'm with Bakugou," Kaminari said, sounding decidedly more vicious than Izuku had heard him so far. "There's four of 'em. Five of us-"

"No," Kirishima interrupted. "Sorry, but Mina's right. We go after these guys and one of us is gonna end up dead."

"One of us already did," Bakugou hissed. Izuku's heart jolted, but before he could say anything, Bakugou had turned on his heel and stormed out of the room, slamming the door hard behind him.

"Denki, you ok?" It was Sero now, looking at his friend who now wore a pained expression on his face. Kaminari bit his lower lip before flashing Sero a wide and forced smile.

"Fine. Nah, you guys are right. Stupid idea. Let's just eat breakfast, yeh?"

"I-" Izuku paused as the group looked back at him, almost as if they had forgotten he was there for a moment. "Sorry," he said, realising that he was likely digging into something that wasn't his business. But he couldn't ignore the panic he was feeling. "This group… they're dangerous?"

Kirishima shifted uncomfortably, looking at Kaminari again, whose fake smiling was swiftly fading.

"I don't want to bring up old stuff," Izuku said hurriedly. "It's just… my friends, our safe house, is back west from here."

Kirishima rubbed the back of his head, his hair ruffled. "Midoriya, I dunno what to tell you," he

said. “They’re not good news. They’re not known for leaving folks in peace, you know?”

Izuku swallowed, his mind racing.

“Your group’s safe house – is it hard to find?” Mina asked.

It was. They knew it would take them a while to build up enough supplies before they could even think about moving to the next district between here and Musutafu, so they had been very particular about where they decided to lay their heads. Access to their safe house was via a heavy metal door around the back of a building and down an unobtrusive-looking alleyway. They were careful to keep windows covered whenever they had lights on, and there was no reason for anyone to assume there was anyone living there from the outside. It was about as hard to find as they could manage. He nodded.

“Then I’m sure your friends are fine,” Mina replied with a soft smile. “They were probably just passing through. No reason to believe they even stopped anywhere along the way where they could have run into your friends.”

Izuku nodded, but he felt no more at ease. His hand ghosted upon his side, the pain getting worse the longer he stood there. He wanted to go out, to head back to the safe house and check that his friends were ok, but it wasn’t likely he’d make it very far before running into zombies. And a person who couldn’t run in the Apocalypse was as good as dead.

“Give it a couple of days,” Mina said as if she could read his mind. “And you’ll feel well enough to go and find them. Don’t worry.”

But Izuku could do little else but worry.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 3: Silent as the Grave

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aside from when Bakugou came storming into a room, his attitude every bit as loud and explosive in his downtime as it was the very first time they had met, the two days that Izuku spent with this new group were pleasant. It had been so long since he spent time around anyone other than his own group that he had forgotten what making friends felt like. The group were friendly, and though he would never be so foolish as to think that each of them couldn't be vicious if they wanted to, as they likely had needed to survive, they were just as eager to get to know him as he was them.

He quickly learnt that the group had been together since the start, just like his, though the details of that first year were belligerently kept from him. He didn't need to ask why; he knew that Bakugou was being deliberately secretive, and it wasn't as though he could blame him for that. What he did know was that each of them had some sort of background in physics and engineering, making sense of how resourceful this group was compared to Izuku's own and why their safe house was littered with treasures.

To his credit, he was also careful of what he shared with them. Two groups of people in the same town didn't often make for a comfortable arrangement, no matter how friendly they appeared. This group would be competing with his own for resources, and they were strangers to one another in a world where strangers were often something to be feared. He needed to protect his friends as much as his new ones needed to protect theirs, and there was an unspoken agreement between each of them not to pry too much. For Izuku, the fact they had fed him, treated him and offered him a place to rest his head was more than he could ask for, and he wasn't about to ruin that arrangement by asking too many questions.

So, in those two days, he offered to help with whatever he could. Mostly he would prepare food and clean, the sort of things that made it easier for the group to carry out their tasks. There were generally two or three of them near him at all times, watching him but not being dicks about it, which he appreciated. The rest were out on patrols or on watch, sometimes coming back with supplies. It wasn't all that different from how Izuku was already used to living. The exception, of course, being the explosive man who thundered in like a hurricane.

For what it was worth, Bakugou spent very little time in the safe house. It was something that Izuku had mixed feelings about. Sure, it meant that he wasn't trapped inside with him, but it also meant that Bakugou was out there on the damn streets, where he could run into his friends at any moment. He was like a cartoon character; lips pulled back in a snarl whenever their eyes met, red eyes so haughty they could melt ice given long enough, and always covered in some sort of grime or, Izuku was sure, *blood.* It was as though he spent each day going toe-to-toe with the zombies themselves. While the rest of the group tried their best to live some semblance of a normal life, Bakugou was out there like some deranged cowboy of the apocalypse, bombs and knives crisscrossed over his hips, nail-encrusted bat in hand. And Izuku hated to admit he found him kinda cool.

On the third day, Izuku woke feeling strong enough to try and get back to his friends. He changed into clothes that Kirishima had put aside for him after his own had been thrown out, satisfied with the fit. He removed the bandage from his waist, Sero hovering nervously through, but both of them

were pleasantly surprised by just how tidy his wound looked. It was still sore, with redness around the site, but there was no heat and no swelling and Izuku was relieved to see that he had managed to avoid an infection. Sero had done a good job, and he had no idea how to thank him for that.

“I’m leaving today,” he announced as he sipped coffee from the mug Mina had offered him. “I think I’ve worried my friends enough.”

“You sure you feel up to it, hun?” Mina asked. He nodded, throwing her a smile.

“The pain’s almost gone, and I can walk fine! Honestly, I think I’ve leached off you guys for long enough now.”

“Don’t mention it,” Kaminari said from his place on the sofa, and Izuku knew that he meant it. “It feels good to be able to help someone for once, you know?”

“Yeh,” Izuku replied. “Yeh, I guess it does.”

“Speaking of which…” Kirishima stood up and took a couple of steps towards Izuku. “We’ve been talking. And, if you’re ok with it, we’d like to go back with you to your group.”

Izuku’s eyes widened at this, lowering his mug. “What?”

“Look, we’ve got you this far,” Kaminari said, nodding empathetically. “None of us in good conscience are happy to let you just go out there on your own. There’s that other group out there, for starts-”

“And there’s been a lot of movement from the zombies, too,” Mina added. “There usually is after a run-in with them. Like they still know we’re here or something? And Bakugou setting fire to a bunch seems to have put them on high alert. Even if you’re feeling stronger, it’s not safe out there on your own.”

Izuku swallowed, looking between them. He *wanted* to say yes, that was the first thought that came to mind. Because, even if he was feeling better, it was still undeniably frightening to be outside alone these days. But was it right for him to potentially put all of them at risk for his sake? Was he ready to trust them enough to lead them back to his group?

“I get it,” Kirishima said, “it’s risky. But, ah, well…” He rubbed the back of his head, and Izuku cocked his head to the side.

“What?”

“Look, we’ve done well so far,” Sero offered. “Really well. But that other group Bakugou talked about? They’re a big problem.”

“Right,” Kirishima nodded. “We’re kinda wondering if… maybe…”

“We should join our groups,” Mina finished.

“Oh.” Izuku placed his coffee mug on the table.

“Obviously you gotta discuss it with your group first,” Kirishima continued. “And it’s your decision, entirely! But you have to admit there are benefits.”

Izuku scratched his head, thinking. Perhaps it would be good to have their groups join forces. After all, this group succeeded in areas where his own were still struggling; they had a large safe house, the means to store food, and they could cook without needing an open flame telling everyone where they were. And his group were fast and sharp, they were survivors and good fighters. Together they could do well for themselves.

“And Bakugou?” he asked, looking between them. Kirishima and Kaminari exchanged a glance.

“He’s not happy about it,” Kirishima admitted. “But he understands the benefits, and I get he’s difficult, but there ain’t no one better at killing zombies.”

“I’ll need to talk to them,” Izuku replied. “They probably have no idea I’m still alive, so it’s a lot for me to come back to them with.”

“That’s fine, Midorya,” Mina said with a smile. “This is only going to work if we’re all on the same page, after all!”

Izuku took another moment to look between each of them, seeing the earnest expressions on their faces, and nodded.

“Ok. Ok, let’s try it.”

And that was how Izuku found himself back on the street for the first time in three days, surrounded by five heavily armed people, all of them alert for trouble, and with his prized wakizashi back in his hand, despite how bitter Bakugou had been about giving it back to him. He wished he had been able to keep hold of his walkie-talkie so that he could have told his friends that he was alive. More than anything, he wished there was a way he could warn them that he was on his way back with a convoy of twenty-somethings with guns and knives and bombs about their person. But life was never so kind these days, and that was made only more obvious when they came across their first group of zombies just twenty minutes into their journey.

Izuku was ready to deal with them as he always did: by being faster and smarter. He never engaged the zombies unless he had no other choice, and that was how he and his group had survived for as long as they had without much prior fighting experience. He assumed that Bakugou’s group would do the same, especially with six fresh-looking zombies standing stock still, staring at them with sightless eyes, mouths wide and heads tilting as though trying to taste them on the air.

“Left or right?” Izuku asked. But Bakugou laughed dryly from his side, making him jump.

“Fuck you, asshole, I don’t need your damn help with any of them.”

Izuku blinked, realising that Bakugou had *completely* misunderstood him, watching in complete disbelief as Bakugou pulled his nail-encrusted bat from where it hung on his belt, swinging it gleefully between his fingers. A wide grin spread over his sharp features as he marched towards the six stinking and walking corpses now making their approach, silent mouths screaming.

“What is he doing?” Izuku yelped, instinct jumping in as he lifted his weapon, stepping forward to help. He felt a firm hand on his shoulder, looking back to see Kirishima sighing heavily.

“Let him have this,” he said, shaking his head.

“Hah?!”

But he didn’t need to wait long for an answer as Bakugou stomped forward, shoulders loose and confident, swinging his bat at the first of the zombies approaching. The end collided with its head, sending the damn thing flying with a horrible *crunch* . Izuku watched in mingled admiration and horror as Bakugou swung again, twisting his body in place to avoid the zombie launching itself teeth-first at his hip, before bringing the bat down onto the back of its head. His hand dropped to his thigh, pulling out a knife, movements fluid as he stepped forward and thrust the blade into the underside of a zombie's jaw. Izuku wanted to shout out, to do *something*, but he was frozen to the spot as he watched the man swing and dart, lips spread back into a maniacal grin as he crashed his way through them, expertly taking out each zombie as if he were born to do it.

It was only when Bakugou turned back to them, swinging his bat sharply and sending a spray of blood across the wall of the nearest building, that Izuku realised his mouth was hanging open and he was staring. He heard laughter from his left before Bakugou’s expression turned sour again, holding the bat out towards him with his lip curled.

“The fuck you staring at!”

“You- *we could have just gone past them!”* Izuku finally managed, his voice breaking.

“What, and have them creep up and eat us later? The hell is wrong with you?” Bakugou’s good, murderous mood faded as soon as it had appeared. Izuku just gaped as Bakugou stormed off, swinging his bat over his shoulder and marching forward. He felt a nudge in his side and looked over to see Kaminari smirking at him.

“We told you he was good.”

“Y-yeh,” Izuku breathed, before shutting his mouth sharply. *He was a fucking madman!* “Guess the apocalypse suits some people, huh?”

“Don’t let him hear you say that,” Kirishima muttered in his ear as he passed. Izuku didn’t feel all that more confident that his friends would like Bakugou, but there was no denying that it would be good to have someone like that on their side.

Bakugou and the others took out several more zombies before they found themselves outside of the mall where Izuku had been separated from Ochako. Relieved, Izuku realised that they were maybe only another twenty minutes away from his safe house.

“That’s where I was separated,” Izuku said, pointing towards the mall.

“What happened?” Sero asked, and Izuku shrugged awkwardly.

“Same thing that usually happens, I guess. There were zombies inside and we didn’t realise. I had to lure them away so my friend could escape.”

“Really?” Mina asked, skipping to his side. “They escaped, right?”

“Oh yeh, she got out round the back and joined up with another member of our group,” Izuku replied, stomach churning at the memory. “It would have all been fine if a group hadn’t blocked my way back to them and forced me to run in your direction.”

“Manly, dude,” Kirishima said. “Taking one for your team.”

“So, what’s she like?” Mina asked, and he looked back at her quizzically.

“Huh?”

“The girl you played zombie bait for.”

“Oh! Ochako? Yeh, she’s amazing!”

“Pretty?”

“Sure. Why?”

Mina grinned at him. “Oh, no reason.”

“Fucking shut up with that shit, will ya?” Bakugou growled from the front of the group, and Izuku blushed.

They mercifully found no more of the rotting, roving bastards as they inched closer to Izuku’s safe house, and he was starting to feel decidedly positive about the whole thing. He liked these guys, and maybe it really would be good to have more people around. A larger group made it easier to protect themselves, and he wouldn’t mind having Mina, Kirishima and the others by his side. Ochako would love Mina. He could see Tenya and Shouto taking some time to adjust, but there was no way they wouldn’t like Kirishima and the other guys once they got to know them. Bakugou was a problem, a big one, but so far he had yet to harm a hair on Izuku’s head, and having someone that scary on their team could be a good thing. He found his eyes fixed on the back of Bakugou more often than not, lost in thought over his attitude and mannerisms, and maybe just enjoying the view a little. He had eighteen dry months in the apocalypse to thank for that, he was sure.

But, Izuku should have known by now, should have learned, that nothing followed the perception of hope more often and more heavily than goddamn reality. He knew, the second he stood at the end of that alleyway leading to their safe house, that something was wrong.

“This it?” Kirishima asked, looking up at the tall building in front of them.

“Hey, this looks pretty good!” Kaminari praised, looking appreciatively around. “Big, secure. Maybe we should drop our dump for this one?”

“Something’s not right,” Izuku muttered. The rest of them paused, and even Bakugou looked back at him, brow furrowed.

“What do you mean?” Sero asked.

Izuku raised a hand and pointed down the alleyway, his blood running cold and thin. It was nothing, really, not unless you knew what it should look like. There were a couple of bins that had been

knocked over, bins that had remained upright the entire time his group had hidden here. And the heavy metal door, the one they had needed to cut open with bolt cutters, was wide open.

Bakugou seemed to catch on quickly, holding his bat forward.

“The door shouldn’t be open,” Izuku all but whispered. His hands shook as he tightened his fist around his person. “Stay back. Lemme go in first.”

“Are you sure?” Mina asked.

“I-it could be nothing,” Izuku forced with a gulp before he stepped forward, making his way down the alleyway and to the steep set of stairs that led to their safehouse, ready to hack at anything non-human that might launch itself from the doorway.

It was dark inside, which wasn’t unusual. They made a habit of keeping the entrance dark even during the day, hopeful that anyone who might stumble on the place would figure it wasn’t worth trying to loot. But the darkness had never felt so… cold. Heavy. So thick with tension that Izuku felt like he might choke on it. He raised his hand and knocked sharply against the door. *Two knocks, one, three knocks, another one*… their secret code. He waited, not breathing, the dread growing as no response came.

“What?” Bakugou demanded, having now stormed up to stand beside him. Izuku glanced over before pushing past, his heart hammering fast and hard in his chest, his grip on his weapon tightening. He ignored the indignant growl of Bakugou behind him as he started climbing the stairs, two at a time, feeling more panicked with each step. If they were in here they would have heard him by now. There would be some retaliation, especially if they weren’t expecting him. The silence was deafening, *terrible* , as he reached the top of the stairs and saw that this door, too, was wide open. His stomach dropped.

Stepping into the room he’d briefly called home, Izuku’s world fell apart. He was no stranger to loss; no one was in the apocalypse. But the scene before him was far more painful than anything he had yet to endure, and his legs threatened to buckle beneath him. The place had been turned upside down; supplies, clothing, equipment… it was all trashed or shredded and tossed across the floor like someone had gone through every inch looking for valuables. But that wasn’t the worst thing, not even close.

He was aware of Bakugou standing beside him and the others coming up the stairs, but it was just a dim collection of sound as his brain struggled to comprehend the sight in front of him. A rust-red substance was dotted on the floor, splashed up against the walls as if someone had been hit and hit hard. The remains of a meal were spilt over the ground, and lying in a dark puddle of blood was the grotesquely surreal sight of *All Might* underwear, the character’s face entirely obscured by the blood it had soaked up. Izuku felt faint, taking a single shaky step forward before his hand reached out and grabbed the door handle, preventing his legs from completely giving way beneath him.

“Oh, shit…”

He heard Kaminari, but he couldn’t reply, only blinking and aching over the scene laid out in front of him. His friends were gone… something had happened, had come for them. It had fought them, injured them, probably even killed them and he hadn’t been there. He hadn’t been there to help… to stop… they were gone.

“Hey, Midoriya buddy, let’s go back outside-”

But Izuku ignored Kirishima, taking a shaky step into the room, his feet kicking aside the shredded remains of what had been Shouto’s coat. He dimply registered Bakugou stalking past him, his bat held between both hands as he took off to the hallway that lead to the bedroom, but Izuku hadn’t the will to follow him. He didn’t need to. If his friends were alive they wouldn’t hide from him. And if they were dead…? Well, they wouldn’t hide either.

“Hey, Izuku?” He felt a hand on his shoulder and looked around to see Mina standing beside him, her wide golden eyes looking into his face. “We shouldn’t stay here, ok? I know it’s hard but we need to get you back outside, ok?”

Izuku couldn’t understand why they wanted to drag him away, not with the blood of his friends smeared all over their things. Not when they weren’t here when they hadn’t even found them yet...

“Nothing back here,” came the gruff voice of Bakugou as he walked back into the room. Izuku vaguely noted him slipping something into his pocket, but the fog and confusion prevented him from making any sense of it.

“No, uh, *you know*,” Sero muttered, but Bakugou only threw him a glare and said nothing more.

“Let’s get the hell out of here,” he grunted.

“Izuku, sweetie?” Mina pressed, her hands tightening comfortingly on his shoulders. “You ok?”

He didn’t know how to answer such a stupid question. *Of course he wasn’t ok!* There was blood all over the place and he didn’t know who it belonged to! What if they had escaped? What if only one of them was… fuck, *who?* Who would have died for all of them if they hadn’t all died together? Whose blood was it on the floor? Would he find them out there? Their corpses walking around like all the others…

“For fuck’s sake.”

Fingers suddenly clicked in front of him, and he blinked, pulled from his reverie to look up at the pair of narrow red eyes, daring across his face.

“Nerd, let’s get out of here, yeh?”

For a second he wanted to say no. Shit, he wanted to *punch* the man in front of him just so his body could do something with the anxiety and misery tearing up inside him. But his shoulders sagged, and his eyes roved across the room again until suddenly it was suffocating. His breath caught, and he turned on his heel, pushing his way past Kaminari and Sero, slipping his weapon back to his hip as he tried to stop his hands from shaking, to stop his mind from racing, to stop the tight sensation in his chest. Once outside the air became a little easier to breathe, but the sight of the kicked-over bins only made things difficult again, and he was forced to push past them all but running into the empty street.

“Midoriya! Slow down!”

He stopped, panting, eyes darting up and down the street almost as if he expected to see them there, their broken and dead bodies freezing and staring at him in that disturbing way. But the road was

empty, the gum-littered sidewalk quiet, and he shut his eyes, trying to push the image of Ochako's face, sightless and mouth agape, looming in front of him.

"Are you alright?"

He felt a hand on his shoulder again, making him flinch and withdraw, fingers curling into fists until he realised it was Kaminari. He nodded and shook his head, raising his hands and running them through his knots and tangles.

"I'm sorry, man-"

"It's fine," Izuku spat. "Fine. You go. It'll be dark soon."

"We're not leaving you here!" Kirishima cried, and now the group were standing awkwardly around him.

Izuku didn't know what to say, his mouth dry, his brain thrumming, his hands drumming with the desire to hit something, his throat to *scream*, so he just nodded. Nodded and kept his mouth shut, his eyes not meeting any of theirs. Even through the pain, he knew not to break down here. Not on the street, not as it got dark, not when there were others his cries would put in danger.

"Come on, let's go, ok?" It was Mina again, her voice calm and comforting. He nodded, his feet shuffling on the ground as he began back the way they had come.

He couldn't break. *He wouldn't*. He couldn't cry. *He wouldn't*. He couldn't scream. *He wouldn't*. He could only walk, only follow, the group of half-strangers making their sombre way back to their safe house in an uneasy silence. No one knew what to say to him. After all, what could they say? Even Bakugou was subdued, his eyes darting back to him far more often and in a far less aggressive way than Izuku was used to, and it was enough to leave his blood boiling. He felt sick at the tentative way they handled him as if he would break down at any moment. He wanted to get away; he wanted to run from this city and everyone in it. But the hard-honed survivor instincts inside of him forced him to place one foot in front of the other, even as his heart was breaking.

It wasn't until they came across another group of zombies that Izuku finally let his walls down, stopping dead as the group of five rotters grabbed their attention.

"Stay back," Kirishima said. *To him. As if he were made of fucking glass or something!* He saw Bakugou hook his bat from his belt, and his feet decided for him, thundering against the asphalt, indifferent to the cries behind him. He reached out, grabbing the bat from Bakugou's hand before he could stop him, his focus entirely on the five monstrosities starting their approach, everything silent around him.

He swung hard, catching the first of them across the jaw and sending it flying, his teeth gritted and eyes flashing. The second and third were on him in a moment, snatching at his clothes, but he kicked the closest in the stomach, pushing it back as he swung the bat. Blood and brain matter splattered against his chest. Another zombie was on him, mouth wide and teeth snapping, and with a yell Izuku hit again, smashing this one around the shoulder and sending it spinning. The zombie he had knocked down was launching itself at his heel, and he kicked hard, his foot crashing through the already heavily fractured skull. The only remaining intact zombie, with its half-severed arm, threw itself at him with some sort of renewed fury, as if the smell of its fallen brethren was enough to send it into a frenzy. Izuku held the bat in front of him with both hands and charged forward,

barrelling into the zombie until it fell to the ground. He lost control after that point, certain he was crying and screaming as he brought the bat down once, twice, three times; he kept swinging until his throat was torn ragged, his hands aching from the force of the impact, and the zombie was just a puddle of blood and gristle at his feet. He was left panting, shoulders heaving, his face and arms splattered with the mess.

There was silence as he stood straight, raising his arm so he could wipe the grime dangerously close to his mouth away with the clear underside of his jacket. He looked back, the group watching him with wide eyes. He avoided their gazes, shuffling back and thrusting the handle of the bat against Bakugou's chest.

"Thanks," he muttered. The man, speechless for once, took it from him. He didn't wait for any acknowledgement before starting back in the direction of the group's safe house.

He made himself scarce the moment they got back to the house, not ready to hear what any of them had to say or see the pity on their faces. He knew that there was access to the roof; it was where they went to keep watch, and even with his body still covered in grime, he immediately made for the flight of stairs that would take him to the attic.

It was almost dark, the wind biting and freezing at this height, but Izuku hardly felt it as he stepped out of the attic window and onto the roof. Without streetlights and people it was so quiet and still up here, and with the setting sun he could see down past the overgrown front lawns of the houses on the street, just as empty as they had been when they left that morning, and he felt the urge to open his mouth and scream. He had yet to shed a single tear, his heart still so consumed with anger that he had little room for anything else. They were gone. They were *gone,* and someone had taken them from him. He hadn't been there to help, to *die with them*. They'd been together since the start. His mother had been the only blood family he had ever known, and his school years were lonely. It wasn't until he met Ochako that everything had fallen into place for him. He loved her. He loved all of them. They were his family, and now they were gone.

He wasn't sure how long he sat there. It had grown so dark that he could hardly make out the street any more, and he was sure he'd be half-frozen before long, considering curling up and sleeping there when he heard movement behind him. Someone was climbing out of the window, their feet sliding slightly against the tiles. It wasn't until he felt their presence at his side that he looked around, vaguely surprised to see heavy black combat boots and faded orange pants before something was thrust in front of his face, the hand waving somewhat impatiently.

"Thought you might want this," Bakugou grunted, still standing as Izuku blinked back at the object in his hand. It was only when Bakugou irritably grunted again, almost hitting him in the face with the damn thing, that Izuku finally reached out. The dried blood on his hand was visible in the warm light coming from the open loft window.

His breath caught in his throat when he turned it over, realising only then what Bakugou must have grabbed back at the safe house. It was a photograph taken the first time he, Ochako, Shouto, Tsu and Tenya had met face-to-face, standing outside of an ice cream parlour in Koto. Each of them held up a peace sign. It was one of his favourite memories. He had been so anxious about meeting them that he had been sick on the train ride there, but the moment all five were finally together, he quickly realised he had nothing to worry about. Ochako, his first and best real friend, had both arms around his neck, the peace sign peeking out over his head as she kissed his cheek, he with one eye closed and laughing. Tsu stood in front of them, both her hands held out, and Tenya dutifully took the entire thing as seriously as he always did, though the grin on his face betrayed how happy he

was. Shouto looked uncomfortable as ever, perplexed with an ice cream in one hand and two fingers spread in the other, but it was still one of his favourite photos of him. His hands gripped the frame, thumbs brushing against the photograph as he felt the rage in his chest subside. What was left was a terrible grief that yanked at his heart and tried to pull it straight out of his throat. He choked back a sob, not wanting to break down in front of Bakugou, one hand reaching up to wipe away the tears as he averted his face.

“Th-thanks,” he managed, voice thick with emotion.

“Whatever, don’t mention it,” Bakugou replied bluntly, already turning to leave. Izuku felt a rush of something in his chest and realised he didn’t want to be left alone again.

“Wait.”

From the corner of his eye, he saw the boots stop, and he dared to look up. Bakugou seemed calmer, the lack of a snarl and grimace making him appear almost soft. But there was an air about him of someone entirely out of their comfort zone.

“I don’t get it,” Izuku said, sniffing and wiping his wrist across his nose, his spare hand holding the photograph to his chest. “Y-you saved me. And then you acted like you didn’t want me here. You threatened me and… and then you do this.”

“What’s your point?” Bakugou snarled, his scowl returning. His face turned in his direction, red eyes shimmering in the low light, and Izuku could have sworn his head grew lighter, his grief the only thing keeping him grounded.

“N-nothing,” he replied. “Just… thank you for, well, saving me from being eaten by zombies, is all.”

“Yeh, well, turns out you might not be completely useless after that stunt back there,” Bakugou replied with a shrug. “I’ll keep saving your ass for as long as you’re useful.”

Izuku surprised himself with a short laugh.

“I don’t usually need saving,” he said. Bakugou scoffed at that.

“Yeh, the idiots downstairs keep saying the same damn thing.”

Izuku laughed again, the sound sharp and alien in the silent frosty air. He looked back at the photograph in his hand, finger brushing over the frame. He thought that Bakugou would leave, but instead, he heard a sigh, a rustle and a creak of boots, and he sat down beside him, lips pouting almost nonchalantly as he looked down at the photo.

“Tell me ‘bout ‘em,” he grunted. Izuku looked over in surprise. “You know if you want.”

“I, uh-” he hesitated. *Did he want to?* He had no idea if he was ready for that. But something about Bakugou’s rough presence at his side was strangely calming, and he breathed out. “We met only first. Um, you heard of No Coal Japan?”

“Who hadn’t?” Bakugou replied with a shrug. Izuku couldn’t help but note his use of past tense. He’d never known anyone so completely accepting of the apocalypse before meeting Bakugou.

“Well, I met Ochako-” he pointed her out in the photo, “-at the first protest I went to. She introduced me to a forum she was in. T-Tenya ran it, that’s him there. I guess he’s pretty much been the leader of our group since the start, you know? Tsu was Ochako’s friend since middle school. She always seemed to have such a level head, you know? And Shouto he-” Izuku froze, his throat closing up again. Ochako was his best friend; she was everything to him, and yet Shouto was… *he could have been… might have been…* “We had a lot in common,” he finished, voice hushed.

Bakugou remained silent, just looking down at the photograph, nodding his head as if in agreement.

“They were family,” Izuku continued in barely a whisper, as his eyes started to burn.

“Yeh,” Bakugou replied in a voice equally as quiet.

Family. He had lost *family.*

“Do you think… that other group. You think it was them?”

Bakugou glanced sharply at him, his face twisting into the same malicious grimace he was so used to seeing before he seemed to catch himself. His lips twitched, eyes hardening.

“And what would you do if it was?” he demanded, tone cold. Izuku was taken aback by the question, but he did not miss the challenge in Bakugou’s stare, the daring for him to say how he really felt.

“I don’t know,” Izuku replied honestly. “I-I’ve never wanted to hurt another person before. I swore to myself that the end of the world wouldn’t change that. I- I don’t think I could ever harm someone.”

Bakgou scoffed and got to his feet. “Yeh, well. We’ll fucking see about that.”

And then he was gone, boots scuffing across the riled roof, leaving Izuku alone with his thoughts and his grief and his confusion once more.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 4: Crash Corpse

Chapter Summary

Izuku starts to come to terms with the lose of his group, just in time to find his own life on the line again during his first run with Bakugou...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was perhaps a testament to how deeply they understood Izuku's grief that none of them, not even Bakugou, asked anything of him in the two days that followed the loss of his friends.

Izuku knew the deal; there wasn't room in the world any more for someone who didn't pull their weight. And yet this group (he supposed now *his* group) was established enough that he was offered the rare chance to grieve. He spent much of the next two days up on the roof, keeping watch so that he could at least contribute in some small part even as he sought space. His body and soul ached so badly, though his body at least would eventually heal. His soul? Well, that was another thing entirely.

The downside of having so much time to himself to just think was that he hadn't a single outlet for the anger that was growing inside of him, becoming almost suffocating since the conversation with Bakugou on the rooftop that first night. He didn't know for sure that this rogue group Bakugou had such strong feelings about were responsible for the death of his friends. But he knew that his new group certainly felt they were. Izuku hadn't asked for the details; he supposed at some point they would offer them to him, but he still suspected that they'd lost one of their friends to these people before. They had a history, and he didn't know what to even do with that. He didn't know what to think other than a cold and all-encompassing rage that, given enough time to infect him entirely, would only lead him to one solid conclusion. He wanted revenge.

Izuku had never wished ill on another person in his entire life. Not even when he had been badly bullied in his younger years. Not even towards the boy holding his head down the toilet as other kids flushed. Not even the girl that had set fire to the contents of his locker or the kids that jumped him and kicked him to the ground as he tried to walk home from school. He had hated them, but he never would have wanted something awful to actually happen to them. He had never felt the urge to retaliate and throttle them as he let loose with his fists. But this wasn't just about him. This was the cold-blooded murder of four people that he had loved more than anything else in this entire fucked-up world, and that changed a person. He wanted to see this other group cornered by zombies and for them to know he was the one to lead them there. He wanted to watch them be torn apart, and maybe he'd even take one of Bakugou's bombs and set fire to them himself. But imagining these things didn't make him feel any better; it made him feel sick, broken and twisted and vulgar, even if he couldn't stop thinking them.

Regardless of the rage he felt, Izuku knew that he couldn't stay secluded for long. As angry as he felt, the will to survive after a year and a half of clawing his way through starvation, grief, and fear was the kind of habit that was hard to shake, and it never occurred to him once to do anything other

than keep going. He had a hell of a debt to repay Bakugou and his group; they'd taken him in, shared their supplies, and been only kind to him considering he was a complete stranger and had very little to offer in return. And the only way to repay that debt would be to be as helpful as possible. So, on the third morning he made his way down to the kitchen, clearing his throat awkwardly as they all looked up at him.

"How can I help?"

"You don't have to-" Mina started, but Bakugou spoke over her, pointing the tip of the knife in his hand towards him.

"How much can you lift?"

Izuku blinked. "Oh, uh ... we talking deadlift or— "

"Fucking idiot," Bakugou snarled, his thin lips curling up to reveal those freakishly sharp canines. "No, I'm not talking about *deadlifting!* How many five-gallon bottles can you fucking carry?"

"Oh, uh-"

"*Oh, uh,*" Bakugou cruelly imitated in a high-pitched whine, his eyes rolling. "Just answer the fucking question, damn Deku!"

"Dude," Kirishima admonished, before he threw Izuku an apologetic look. Izuku rubbed his arms.

"A couple, I guess?"

"That'll have to fucking do." Bakugou got to his feet, pocketing the knife.

"You really think it's a good idea, going out so soon?" Sero asked, looking doubtfully between Bakugou and Izuku. "I can always go with you later?"

"No," Izuku said hurriedly. "I'm fine. I'm good. This is good. I can't stay inside all the time, right?"

Sero looked unsure, and Izuku couldn't help but notice how uncomfortable Kirishima and Mina seemed to be too, sharing a look that left Izuku bristling, his hands itching to prove to them that he was capable of carrying his own weight.

"I got this," he said firmly. "I survived this far, right? Gimme a chance to prove I can be useful to you."

"Quit fucking stalling," Bakugou growled. "We got a ways to walk to reach the river and I got other shit to do."

"You don't want me to come with you, too?" Kirishima asked, and Izuku felt the very fine thread of frustration inside of him threaten to snap. He knew they were just worried about him; he supposed he should be thankful that there was anyone left in the world that would be. But his group had always trusted him, and they had never doubted him. There'd been no pressure to prove himself to them like he was having to now, and he hated that growing realisation that he was a burden to these people. That he was a person they felt needed babysitting. So he stepped forward, grabbing his wakizashi and slipping it into his belt.

"I said I've got this," he repeated. "Me and Och-" his voice caught, embarrassingly so, before he pushed forward. "We did runs all the time."

"There you fucking have it," Bakugou said. And next thing Izuku knew, the dangerous-looking blond had grabbed the collar of his shirt and tugged, dragging him backwards towards the door. "Come the fuck on, nerd."

He caught the passing look of mingled doubt and concern on the faces of the rest of them crowding the kitchen before he was damn near yanked straight into the doorframe, turning on his heel as Bakugou let go. He gestured with a finger at the long sticks and five-gallon bottles in the hall

"Don't fucking show off," Bakugou snarled before he shoved Izuku's chest for good measure, making sure that he had all of his attention. "Only take what you know you can fucking carry. If we lose any water because you're too damn slow and get eaten by zombies, I'll shove a stick up your reanimated ass and leave you for the fucking buzzards, you got that?"

Izuku scowled, rubbing his sore chest. He briefly considered saying something back, but the intensity with which this man glared at him left him feeling pretty certain that none of his colourful threats were empty ones. Instead, he nodded, walking past him to grab one of the long sticks and two of the empty bottles. Bakugou cocked an eyebrow at him before pushing past and snatching his own supplies, hooking four of the bottles onto the stick with practised ease. Izuku tried not to feel too put out by this. He wasn't exactly the strongest person in the damn world ... he'd built up some muscles over the last year and half – hell, you kinda had to lugging supplies and running for your damn life most of the time – but the lingering sensation of inadequacy he felt standing beside Bakugou was a little hard to ignore.

"You done fucking standing around?" Bakugou snapped. Izuku started and nodded again, following Bakugou out of the house and onto the street.

There was definitely a difference between the way that Bakugou stepped confidently onto the street and how Izuku had long ago learnt to stay alive. Bakugou was already halfway across the road before Izuku had even taken two steps out of the front porch, his head swinging left and right as he walked, stick and bottles over one shoulder, and his nail-encrusted bat swinging to his right. Izuku had never, not once, not in the entire eighteen months of the actual apocalypse, left a building with the easy confidence that Bakugou had done, and had the man not survived as long as he had done, he'd have been quick to label him a goddamn maniac. And were it not for his desire to prove his worth to the explosive blond, he probably wouldn't have hurried after him, shoes pattering across the pavement. Bakugou glanced over his shoulder at him, that trademarked sneer and a scowl gracing his features.

"Hurry the fuck up, won't you?"

Izuku swallowed, looking up and down the street himself as he quickened his pace.

"Shouldn't we be a little more careful?" he hissed, catching up with the man who shot him an irritated glare.

"Fuck you, Deku. You really gonna lecture me? After I saved your ass?"

Izuku's mouth snapped shut at that, falling in step with the angry-looking asshole beside him, trying hard not to sigh too loudly.

They walked in silence for much of the way, and despite how seemingly blasé Bakugou had seemed at first, Izuku soon realised that there was nothing careless about him. Bakugou was very particular about the routes that he took; he'd picked out large open roads and sidewalks, with enough space on either side that it would be hard for anything to sneak up on them. But walking such open roads left them vulnerable too, especially considering that they might not be so alone out here. The group that had ki- that had *taken* his friends from him could still very well be about. And so Bakugou kept them to the sides, closer to the edges of the streets and verges, with Izuku trailing just behind him the entire way, eyes darting between the wide set of shoulders in front and the potential dangers to the side.

Because it was ridiculous, really. Here he was, still with a bandage around his middle, the threat of death by devouring hanging over him with every step, and he still couldn't keep his eyes from staring at the man in front of him. He might still be a little shell-shocked by the events that had unfolded over the last few days, and sure maybe it had been a while since he had been able to indulge certain ... interests, but he wasn't blind. Bakugou was pretty. Well, if you looked past the ugly faces he pulled, the massive gashes across the side of his face, and the seemingly constant coating of grime and sweat that clung to him. *He really must have been out here too long to find any of that appealing.* He'd always had a type. The studious, neat type. With kind eyes and soft hair, a gentle voice, the kind of guy he could laugh with. Bakugou definitely was not that type ... he was gruff and rugged, his eyes narrow and distrustful, his hair looked like it would cut you if you tried to touch it, and his voice? Well, he was sure the rough grating of his yelling could be heard into the next life. Bakugou was the complete opposite of his type, but damn if he could not stop staring at him anyway.

Of course, it was at that moment, when Izuku's helpless eyes roved down to those arms again, that Bakugou looked back, half a glance to check that their new nerd was still following him. It was all Izuku could do not to yelp out loud as those red eyes suddenly pinned him down, narrowing slightly as he took him in.

"The fuck you staring at?" he snapped.

"Nothing!" Izuku yelped, perhaps a little too loudly considering their situation.

Bakugou eyed him for a moment longer, a scowl on his face, before looking away, and Izuku let out an uneasy breath. He had no idea if he had been caught out or not, but he didn’t have long to worry about that when his well-honed survival instincts kicked in. He smelt them before he saw them, the sickening sweet scent stinging his nostrils. He was so accustomed to it by now, the smell of rotting corpses, that he'd long ago stopped gagging or feeling nauseous, and the smell instead heightened his senses. He froze, eyes darting to his left and taking in the road laid out before them, before he spotted them. Two zombies crouched between two cars, their pitted and grey faces twisting back and forth, blank eyes wide like they were trapped in some kind of horror story. They hadn't spotted them yet. His stomach twisted as it always did, the months of experience never erasing the fear.

"Heads up," he said.

Bakugou stopped, looking in the direction that Izuku was pointing, before he scoffed.

"Yeh yeh, I fuckin' saw 'em."

Izuku wanted to say that sounded like bullshit, but Bakugou was still armed and a hell of a lot bigger than him, and he wasn't entirely convinced he hadn't brought him out here to ditch him someplace. Instead, he fell silent, gripping his wakizashi tight. The flesh bags hadn't spotted them

yet, and there were two sets of cars and a road between them, so they could probably sneak past quite easily. Bakugou, however, wasted precisely zero time swinging his bat out in front of him, dropping the gallon tanks to the ground.

"Wh-what are you- *we could just sneak past them,"* Izuku hissed.

"What, and have them fuck us in the ass on the way back?" Bakugou snarled. "Better to take 'em out now."

Before Izuku could say anything else, Bakugou let out a single shrill whistle, and Izuku felt the rush of panic run through him the second the two zombies across the way took notice, their faces twisting repulsively towards them, jaws gnashing.

"Line on up, you ugly fucks," he heard Bakugou say, before the zombies were all but sprinting towards them, hands scrabbling on the pavement, bumping into one another in their eagerness to get to them. Izuku swore. These two were faster than many of the others he'd seen in a long while, and if experience had taught him anything, then it meant that they were probably fresher. But Bakugou hardly seemed bothered; in fact, his lips drew back into a wild grin, letting out a loud laugh.

"Hah! Maybe I'll get a decent fucking fight outta you two."

"Wait!"

The zombies were on him before Izuku could get any closer, and he watched in horror as Bakugou swung, side-stepping the first attack, his bat connecting with a loud wet thud with the side of the first corpse's head, blood and brain matter splattering across the pavement. The second, however, was hunkered low to the ground, limbs unbroken and deceptively agile in its state of recent decomposition, and it swiped out and grabbed Bakugou's ankle, jaw open with every intent to bite down. Izuku started to run, knife up and ready to strike, but Bakugou held his bat by the handle and stabbed down, the nails flattening the skull of the zombie about to tear out his heel.

Izuku skidded to a halt, panting, eyes wide as the blond-haired man spat on the ground at his feet.

"Fuckin' pussy assholes," Bakugou snarled, genuine disappointment on his face as he swung his bat, throwing blood across the pavement.

"Are you *crazy*?"

Izuku wasn't aware that the words had spewed from his lips until Bakugou turned on him, lips pulled back.

"The fuck you say, Deku?"

"I said, *are you crazy*? That last one almost got you!"

"Fuck you, I had it under control."

"No, you got lucky!"

And then, he was aware of heat, a hard mass against his chest, and the smell of sweat as a hand grabbed the front of his t-shirt and threw him against the side of a car.

"The hell you know, hah?" Bakugou hissed, his face pressed so close to Izuku's that he could feel his breath against his throat. "Your sorry ass has been here two fucking minutes, and you think you can tell me how to do things?"

Izuku winced as a large forearm was lodged beneath his throat, pushing his head back.

"N-no-"

"Well, it damn sure sounds like it!"

Izuku gritted his teeth, staring back at the vivid red eyes, pupils like pinpricks in a sea of blood.

"That's not- that's not what I meant," he gasped. Bakugou pressed harder, the tip of his nose touching Izuku's as he growled, his breath holding the distinctive tang of vodka, before he finally stepped back, letting Izuku slip down the side of the car, reaching up to cradle his aching throat.

"Good," Bakugou snarled. "Let's keep it that way, yeh?"

Izuku nodded, swallowing hard as Bakugou turned away, muttering a rough '*fucking disgusting'* as he kicked the corpse lying smashed on the ground out of the way. For a moment, Izuku didn't move, just staring after the man, hand lowering to grip the fabric over his chest, before he realised that Bakugou would probably just leave him here given the opportunity.

The guy was hard to work out ... he'd saved his life. He'd killed those zombies, then he could only presume that he had carried him back to his camp after he had passed out. The guy had gone above and beyond to keep him alive. Then he'd grabbed the photograph and had brought it to him on the rooftop. But otherwise he'd been entirely hostile and threatening towards him... And then, there was *something*. Something small and fleeting in his eyes that made Izuku wonder whether Bakugou was really in as much control as he thought he was. It seemed like he realised how close he had cut it with that last zombie, and he was furious that Izuku had noticed.

With that in mind, he started to follow Bakugou down the road again, keeping a respectable distance and not saying another word.

Eventually, they made it to a section of river that cut under a bridge, a low railing to one side allowing access. Whilst this was once a lovely picturesque spot, no doubt popular with amateur photographers once upon a time, with blossom trees no longer in season dripping over the bank, it wasn't the ideal place for any survivor of the apocalypse to be standing. It offered very little in the way of vantage points, the narrow alleys to each side like a bottleneck directly to their location. If a crowd of zombies wandered across them now, they'd have little other option other than to jump into the river itself to escape.

"Start filling the bottles," Bakugou ordered, chucking his four onto the ground beside the railing before he pulled a length of thick rope from his utility belt. "I'll keep watch."

Izuku didn't argue, catching the rope as it was thrust at his chest and tying it to the handle of one of the bottles. He chanced another glance at Bakugou, the man taking his place at the centre of the bridge, watching both exits, and as much as he knew Bakugou was good at what he did, his little reckless display from earlier still left him feeling decidedly uncomfortable.

He wasn't used to not trusting his wingman completely. Ordinarily, he would have had Iida or Shouto watching his back, and his own prickled as he leaned right over the side of the railing,

easing the gallon bottle down.

"Make sure you angle it against the fucking flow, Deku, or it won't fill," he heard Bakugou say, and he grunted.

"I know how to fill a bottle," he grumbled, before glancing back behind him. He saw Bakugou's face suddenly dart to the side, a scowl dropping quickly to his brow, almost as if he hadn't wanted to be caught so much as looking in his direction. Izuku sighed and focused on what he was doing.

Neither he nor Bakugou said another word as Izuku filled each of the bottles, heaving them up beside him, not entirely trusting in Bakugou to keep watch and glancing either side of him the entire time. But it was quiet; aside from the usual stench of a city gone to hell, it didn't smell like there were any biters crawling up ready to eat them, and it was with a certain relief that Izuku stood straight again, dusting his hands down his pants.

"All done."

"Took you long enough."

Izuku shot him a choice glare that Bakugou pointedly ignored and began lifting the bottles back onto his shoulders.

"You see anything, drop the tanks, no hesitation," Bakugou snapped.

Izuku hated to admit that, even with just two full bottles, it was heavy, and he stumbled slightly as he balanced his pole over both his shoulders. Bakugou scoffed at him.

It was slow going, and Izuku sure as hell resented how weak he felt compared to Bakugou, who confidently stalked ahead of him with all four bottles balanced, his wrists casually hooked over the poles. He feared that he might genuinely hate the man in that moment.

They made it almost the entire way back before trouble found them, and Izuku had to wonder just how strategic Bakugou and his group actually were. If it had been up to him, he would have had people on lookout, shadowing them the entire way. But no, he and Bakugou had struck out on their own, with little more than a handful of weapons and their damn good intentions, so ultimately he wasn't surprised to see the path they had taken blocked.

What was alarming was how the zombies were crowded around the point where Bakugou had dropped the two from earlier. It was not the first time Izuku had seen something like this. They'd killed enough of them over the months to know that if they didn't get out of Dodge quickly, they'd find themselves meeting more of their fiends. He had theories; perhaps they were drawn to the smell, or maybe they released a pheromone of sorts when they were in danger, like wasps and ants. Either way, killing a zombie, more often than not, seemed to attract more of them. And now, thanks to Bakugou's little stunt from earlier, their way was barred by no less than fifteen of them, circling aimlessly around one another as if they couldn't quite work out what it was that brought them to the place.

"Back up," Bakugou hissed, and they crouched beside a large blue van, letting their gallon bottles drop silently to the pavement.

"Shouldn't have killed those biters," Izuku muttered, peering through the windows of the van at the group.

"Don't think I won't throw you at them," Bakugou growled back, grabbing Izuku's hair and tugging harshly. "We'd have had to kill 'em on the fucking way back."

Izuku knew full damn well that would have been the better option, but he chose not to respond to that, rubbing the back of his head.

"So, do we just go around? There'll be another route."

"Yeh, but it'll add another twenty fucking minutes," Bakugou replied, scowling as he peered around the vehicle. "There ain't that many of them."

Izuku's mouth gaped.

"Are you kidding me?" he hissed, and those red eyes fixed upon him again, hot and angry. "You only just took out two of them earlier!"

"Fuck you, De-"

"Just go around them!" Izuku interrupted, too taken aback to hold his tongue. "Why are you even thinking about taking them on?"

Bakugou turned on him again, his hand lashing out and grabbing the front of his shirt.

"Because, moron, we're ten fucking minutes from our hideout, and there's a damn herd forming right on our fucking doorstep. If we don't do something about them now, then we're gonna have a whole lot more to deal with later."

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, then shut it again. Bakugou wasn't wrong, exactly. He'd seen herds form out of nowhere, and hell he'd almost been killed by one. His group were usually on the move so much that they'd never had to worry about them forming outside of their hideouts, particularly as they were careful to avoid killing them to begin with, unless they had no other choice. This smallish group of fifteen could become a big problem for them later if they left them unchecked.

"Ok, ok," he breathed. "So, what do we do about them? We kill them that's just gonna bring more of them. That's even if we could take them all out."

"You fucking forgetting when I took out all those crusty motherfuckers that were after you?" Bakugou said, raising an eyebrow pointedly.

"Right, with a freaking Molotov cocktail," Izuku hissed back. "We can't do that here."

"Then we draw them away," Bakugou replied, rolling his eyes as if it were obvious. "Fucking moron."

He dropped Izuku's shirt, peering back at the herd again.

"They don't look so fresh, blood's black, limbs look pretty rotten."

Izuku bit back a groan of frustration, and peered through the windows of the truck. Sure, he'd seen zombies in worse state, but these certainly weren't fresh and it would be easier to outrun them.

"Where do we lead them to?" Izuku replied. "We can't have them chase us back to the river, we need that route clear. And any other direction, we don't know what we'll run into."

"Then stay here with the water, and I'll fucking do it."

Bakugou got to his feet, and Izuku felt a rush of panic, unwisely grabbing Bakugou's wrist.

"Wait! A you sure we have to do this? They could just move on-"

Bakugou wrenched his arm free, scowling down at him. "Nah, we take care of this now. I ain't leaving these fuckers here so they can eat my damn friends later. Stay here with the water."

He quickly stepped out of his reach, hooking his bat up through a belt loop before walking out from behind the van, edging his way across towards one of the side roads winding out from the main route.

"Shit," Izuku hissed, before he grabbed the jugs that Bakugou had left behind and started heaving them towards him and pushing them underneath the van. It didn't matter that the guy was a huge fucking jerk ... he couldn't leave him, and he couldn't carry the water by himself.

"It's safer if we do this together," he said, skipping out from behind the van and towards Bakugou. "In case we get stuck and have to take any down."

Bakugou rolled his eyes, lifting his forefinger and thumb to his lips and letting out a long, shrill whistle. The zombies, previously meandering unawares of the two potential meals just a stone's throw away from them, changed their demeanour immediately, all of them freezing, fifteen sets of sunken eyes or blank sockets turning in their direction at once. Izuku's breath caught in his throat. It didn't matter how many fucking times he saw that; it never stopped being terrifying.

"Oi, fuckbrains!"

"Hell, this is happening," Izuku muttered, running his hands through his hair as the herd started to clamber towards them, reminded very suddenly of the last time that he had been forced to run away from a group this size ... it hadn't gone well for him then and he wasn't entirely convinced it would go well for him today, either.

"Better move it or get eaten, moron," Bakugou snarled, slapping him around the back of the head. "Oi, come on, come and get it, assholes!"

And then the zombies really started to move, hurtling after them with a speed that never failed to take Izuku by surprise, and they began to run, Izuku following Bakugou's lead as he thundered down the road, his rough voice calling to the fleshbags falling over one another in their eagerness to get to them.

This was stupid. *This was so fucking stupid.* They had no idea what was around each corner, and moving at the speed they were, it would be real hard to do much about it if the next turning they took they ran straight into a second group of biters. But Bakugou seemed determined, and as much as he knew his new group seemed to like him, he didn't think going back to them without Bakugou would go down so well, so he kept running, the zombies close on their heels.

God, this was so freaking stupid.

"Shut the fuck up, will you?" Bakugou yelled, and Izuku winced when he realised that he had been thinking out loud again.

"Then, what's the plan?" he panted back. "How well do you even know this area?"

"Well enough, shit stain," Bakugou snapped. "We lead 'em up the next three streets, and we'll hit a gutted-out supermarket."

"And then what?"

"We get in, lose 'em, take Hosta Street back to where we left the water. Piece of fucking piss."

Overstatement of the century.

By some miracle, they didn't run into any other issues as they led the zombies towards the point that Bakugou had in mind. The old supermarket, seemingly more of an old-style cash and carry warehouse than anything else, from the looks of things, came into view ahead of them, with a large parking lot out front.

"We ain't gonna lose them 'til we break line of sight," Bakugou said, as they began to wind their way through the abandoned cars. "We cleared out this place weeks ago, left it unlocked. We get in, bar the entrance, get out round the back."

"Easy as that, huh?"

"Fuck, do you ever shut up?"

Bakugou paused, looking back over his shoulder, Izuku following suit, checking that the group was still following them, and sure enough, they weren't far behind, their way slowed by the cars that they weren't quite agile enough to clear as easily as the living could, giving them the edge and the time they needed as they all but slammed against the double glass doors of the store.

"I thought you said you left it unlocked!" Izuku said, as Bakugou slammed his palms against the doors again.

"Fuck!"

"They're almost on us."

"Shut up!"

"Bakugou!"

A loud smash filled the air, and Izuku swung round to see that Bakugou had swung his baseball bat into the glass of the door.

"Come on!"

"This is stupid!" Izuku found himself repeating, even as he followed Bakugou into the shop, stepping over the frame of broken glass.

It was dark inside; any emergency lighting the place might have once had was entirely used up, and Izuku found himself reminded of some of the many runs that he and Ochako had done in the past ...

the darkness, the uncertainty of what could be hiding behind each stack of shelves... Except this time he didn't have the benefit of a partner he trusted. There weren't friends on the outside who had his back. He missed them. He missed them now more than ever.

"The glass isn't going to stop them getting in," he said, his voice low now, knowing that staying quiet was their best chance of getting out of there unnoticed. "How well do you remember the layout of this place?"

"Warehouse at the goddamn back, asshole," Bakugou growled. "Past the fucking shit wipes if you really need specifics!"

God, this asshole really never lets up.

The sound of smashing glass, and something heavy being knocked over, made it clear that the zombies had found their way in.

But Bakugou hadn't been mistaken, and the large blue staff-only door at the back of the store came into view. It was on a push release, and Izuku cursed under his breath. As far as he had been able to work out over the last eighteen months, the zombies weren't intelligent, not in any significant sense. They worked on a pure animal instinct, a drive to hunt, and with that came a certain cunning, but any degree of problem-solving seemed to be beyond them. He'd never seen one turn a doorknob or pick up a weapon. But if they saw which door he and Bakugou escaped through, and they pushed their weights against it long enough, a push release wasn't going to hold. He opened his mouth to say as much, but Bakugou cut him off, his red eyes darting towards him for a moment.

"Yeh, yeh, I fucking see it, nerd."

With a hefty shove, Bakugou was pushing his way through the door, grabbing Izuku by the collar of his shirt again and yanking him through before slamming it hard, his back pressing against the door for a moment as he panted heavily. It was dark in the warehouse, so dark that Izuku could barely make out anything a few inches in front of him, but the smell of the place hit him immediately. He pulled his wakizashi out from it's place about his hip, squinting through the darkness.

"It stinks in here," he hissed.

"Yeh, I fuckin' smell it."

That kind of smell only came with one thing. He heard banging and clattering on the other side of the door.

"Out of the way," Izuku said.

"The *fuck* you say?"

But Izuku ignored him, and he grabbed one of the metal shelving units against the wall and pulled it towards him and then over, Bakugou swearing as he stepped out of the way, the shelving unit coming down heavily by the door and blocking it just as the group of zombies crashed into it. The door shook.

"There could be some in here," Izuku said, pushing against the shelving again to be sure that it was as far against the wall as possible. "Smells like there's some in here."

"Yeh, and I don't fancy bumping around in the damn dark until they find us," Bakugou growled back at his side. "Hold back, if they're in here then they heard us. They'll be coming."

"I can't see," Izuku hissed. "And I can't hear anything coming over the racket from our friends out there."

"No shit, Deku! Can you stop stating the goddamn fucking obvious all the time?"

"Can you stop being such an asshole?"

"Oh, well fuck me, I'm sorry, princess. You wanna hold each other's dicks and sing Kumbaya too?"

"Wha-"

But Izuku was interrupted by the sound of frantic scrabbling somewhere in front of them, and his attention immediately snapped forward, gripping his weapon tight and out in front of him.

"Heads up."

The zombie launched itself at them out of the darkness, but Bakugou was ready with his bat, taking a wide swing, connecting with its jaw with a wet thud, blood splattering across both of them.

"That ain't all of 'em."

Izuku swore when he realised that Bakugou was right, and there was the sound of more scrabbling, bare feet thundering across the floor, and bodies hitting metal shelves and glass shattering.

"Time to test if you got the minerals," Bakugou said, and even in the darkness Izuku could see the wild mad grin splitting his face in two.

The next two zombies were on them in a second, Bakugou taking one and he the other, his hand thrusting out to press across its chest, that gnashing, voiceless mouth stopping just an inch short of his nose before he stabbed into its temple with his wakizashi, and he threw it aside. Another came right off the bat, pushing back backwards as his calves hit the metal shelving, and he was forced to grab this one by the shoulders, grunting as he pushed it away from him with all the strength he had. Another swipe and his knife stabbed into a long rotted-away eye socket. He looked to his left, seeing Bakugou kicking out the knee of the zombie before swinging down with the bat, all that noise and commotion blinding the man for an instant, Izuku seeing the biter coming at him before Bakugou did.

"Your left!"

Bakugou looked around just in time to catch it, his arm thrusting, forearm pressed against its throat as it came at him, snapping furiously towards his face. Izuku jumped forward, teeth gritted as he stabbed into the zombie's head, the dead weight falling immediately to the ground. He saw Bakugou glare at him, a flash of red in the darkness, before another snarl came and he swung out, his knife slicing across its chest. It didn't stop it, and he felt weight on him again, swearing as he was forced back. It was with a sickening crunch and a whole lot of panic that his hands went straight into its chest, the body so rotted and decayed that it hardly held up against the pressure. Its head came down; he could feel the teeth snapping at his hair before it was pulled away from him, Bakugou yanking it to the ground and lifting a heavy boot to stomp on its face, a ragged yell breaking his lips.

Izuku panted, eyes wide, his hands covered in rotting flesh and old browning blood, his wakizashi stained yet held forward as he waited for the next attack. He and Bakugou stood side by side, watching and waiting, the only sound their heavy breathing and the slam of bodies against the door behind them. A minute passed, each of them having gained their breath, before either of them felt safe enough to lower their weapons, looking around.

"Think that's all the fuckers," Bakugou growled before looking at Izuku's hands. "That's fucking disgusting."

Izuku took a deep, shaking breath before a light laugh broke from his lips. He'd never quite gotten over the fact that he spent so much time fighting for his life. He was getting better at it, the killing, if you could even call it that when their targets were already dead, but each time it was over and the adrenaline rush faded, he always felt some weird kind of euphoria. It wasn't even happiness, not strictly, but the knowledge that he was still alive, that he had beaten the odds yet again, expressed itself with involuntary laughter. Bakugou blinked at him, upper lip curling.

"Thanks," Izuku said, shaking his hands and rubbing them across his pants. "For saving me again."

"Shut up," Bakugou snapped. "Just ... you know, returning the fuckin' favour."

Izuku's eyebrows rose, surprised. He sure as hell had expected Bakugou to be furious at him for having the damn gall to save his life or at least refuse to acknowledge it had happened. But here Bakugou was, looking for the very first time humble as he stared back at him. Those thin lips thinned even more, and he looked away, glaring forward into the gloom.

"Come on."

Izuku swallowed and followed Bakugou through the warehouse, sticking close, stepping over broken jars and boxes, and winding their way back through the shelves until they hit the very back, a thin line of light visible around the cracks of a door frame.

"Noise might have attracted more," Izuku warned, and Bakugou threw him another glare. "Alright, alright just... voicing my thoughts."

"Yeh, well stop it."

Izuku sighed, Bakugou pulling at the handle, bat at the ready, before he kicked it outwards, the two of them ready and waiting for more zombies to attack. To Izuku's relief the coast seemed clear. Izuku saw Bakugou hesitate for the first time their entire trip, not so confidently stepping out, but he was still the first to recover, and Izuku followed him.

They cut back to where they had abandoned the water tanks, mercifully still hidden beneath the van where Izuku had pushed them, and started the last half mile of their trek towards home, Izuku trying to ignore the vague shaking of his hands as they hooked over his pole.

"Oh my god, what happened!"

Izuku and Bakugou were met by a frantic voice as they walked up their street some fifteen minutes later, Sero standing on the roof, his mouth wide as he took in the sight of the two of them, both covered in blood, and Izuku's arms brown and grey up to the damn elbows, smelling like he'd killed a couple zombies and decided to roll around on them afterwards.

"Shut the hell up and grab the fucking door!"

Kaminari was opening it a moment later, his face green at the sight and smell of the both of them, pressing himself as far back against the wall as possible so as to avoid touching either of them.

"The hell happened to you two? You were gone for ages, we were starting to wonder if we should send someone out to look for you."

"Just ran into some of those brainless fuckers, is all," Bakugou said. "Nothin' we couldn't handle."

"Yeh, well, Midoriya looks like he *literally* ran into them," Kaminari said, his upper lip curling as he eyed his arms. "Dude, what on earth?"

"I, uh, tried to push one of them back," Izuku replied, dropping the gallon bottles to the ground as they walked into the kitchen. "Hands just went straight through it."

"Gnarly," came a new voice, and Izuku glanced up to see Kirishima and Sero coming down the stairs and into the room, matching expressions of disgust on their faces. Izuku frowned, looking down at his hands.

"Alright, alright, guess I'll go wash up then. You'd think you'd all be used to a bit of zombie gunk by now."

Bakugou snorted, taking Izuku and, seemingly, the others by surprise. He paused when he registered their silence and scowled.

"What? He's got a damn point. You know what? Fuck you, bitch nuts. Go do something useful instead of staring at me like damn morons."

Kaminari rolled his eyes.

"Yeh, keep fucking rolling 'em asshole, you might finally find a fucking brain back there."

"Dude! I didn't even say anything!"

Izuku laughed. It was far from the kind of dynamic that he was used to ... a bit more violent, a lot more insults, but whatever relationship this group had was every bit as strong as what he was used to with his own, and he couldn't deny how warm it made him feel to have been welcomed into that as eagerly as he had been. Bakugou and Kaminari continued to bicker, as Kirishima threw him a smirk and a shrug.

"Oi, where the hell's Pinky?" Bakugou said suddenly.

"Oh, she just took over watch for me," Sero replied. "She said something about the smell bothering her-"

"Right, well that's the last hint I need," Izuku replied, throwing his blood-soaked hands in the air.

"Sorry, dude," Kirishima laughed, and Izuku shrugged as he walked by, leaving the kitchen and turning left down the hallway.

He paused for a moment, realising that his hands were still shaking. It had been a lot ... *a whole lot*. Sure, technically it was nothing more than what he wasn't already used to. He'd fought for his life,

slashed and stabbed at zombies and been on the run a whole lot over the last eighteen months, but it wasn't often that he found himself trapped. He'd survived this far by being quick, clever, and careful. And sure, it meant that they hadn't always gotten the supplies they needed, and they'd gone hungry a lot in that time, but they'd survived. But Bakugou, despite definitely being skilled and clever, was far more reckless than he was used to dealing with, and though they hadn't been killed this time, he wasn't sure how long his nerves could handle any more runs with the damn guy. He breathed out, leaning against the wall.

"So, how'd it go?"

"Fine, asshole. We just had to lead a bunch of zombies away from this place is all."

"That's not what I meant, dude, how'd it go with Midoriya?"

Izuku felt his heart rate quicken, eyes widening as he held his breath.

"The little shit's annoying as fuck," Bakugou replied, his voice full of disdain. And, like that, Izuku's mood plummeted again, a scowl coming back to his otherwise soft face.

"But when he's not stating the goddamn obvious... he's got pretty good instincts."

Izuku's eyebrows rose.

"So, you gonna be nice to him?"

"The hell do you think? Just be glad I ain't killed the bastard as punishment for assaulting my fucking eardrums with his constant whining."

Well, it was something. Izuku rest his head against the wall, shaking it slightly, before walking towards the bathroom to wash off the zombie gunk from his hands.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 5: Dead Beat

Chapter Summary

In which Bakugou goes full asshole.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After their moderately successful first venture out together, Izuku found himself following Bakugou more and more often as the weeks went by.

He told himself it was because, as it so turned out, yeh he was actually pretty good at taking care of himself out there. Did it annoy him that Bakugou and the others hadn't felt that from the start? Sure. But he'd made it perfectly clear that, not only was he fast, but he also had pretty good instincts when it came to negotiating the new world of the dead. In fact, he'd argue that he probably did a better job of that than his new companions.

And that wasn't to say that his new friends weren't hard as nails and twice as sharp. They were smart cookies; that much was evident in the lengths they had gone to to provide both power and even a small amount of hot water each day to their hideout. They'd even fashioned a way to make ice by storing water in some kind of evaporation chamber on the roof of the house that night, and Izuku would never forget the look Bakugou gave him when Kirishima offered him a beer, and he proceeded to fill half a glass with ice before topping it off with the beer. It didn't matter that it would be *'weak as ant piss'*. What did matter was that it had been a lifetime since he had last enjoyed a cold beer, and he wanted this damn thing subzero.

No, they were survivors; that much was clear. But it was obvious that they hadn't moved around nearly as much as Izuku and his group had done, as out there on the street they seemed to lack his sharply honed survival instincts. Balls to the wall, if it came down to it, he could outrun all of them if he ever needed to. Not that he *would,* of course, but the thought offered him the smallest amount of comfort. Hell, not even Bakugou, despite being built like the fucking *Terminator*, could keep up with him if he really sprinted. He had also developed such a keen sense of smell that it was pretty hard for the zombies to sneak up on him much of the time, earning him the nickname 'Bloodhound' from Kaminari and Sero. If it wasn't for the fact that Bakugou was constantly on the lookout for them, he was sure that his companions might have found themselves in a tight spot more than once. He found himself pondering over the series of scars, almost like deep scratch marks, across Bakugou's temple and wondered if maybe something of the sort had already happened.

But, if there was one thing that he clearly wasn't as good at, it was killing zombies. This group did things very differently, almost as if they had a single-minded mission to clear the entire damn prefecture of them one by one and despite the mess on their first mission together, Bakugou still couldn't hold back from killing them in the most elaborate and barbaric way possible. Izuku's favourite, if you could call it that, had been when he, Bakugou, and Kirishima had been headed out looking for fuel, and Izuku had spotted the zombies first, as he often did. For once, Bakugou had seemed inclined to leave it, the man being grouchier than usual that morning, but any hopes they

had of making their way past unnoticed were ruined when a cat had shot out from underneath a nearby car, causing Kirishima to swear out loud. The zombie was at them in a heartbeat, fingers clambering and nails scraping audibly on the asphalt. Bakugou had thrown his head back in frustration, uttering a tired *'fuck me'*, before pulling open the door of the car he was standing in front of. Izuku had noticed more than once that the zombies really seemed to have a fucking thing for Bakugou, and it inevitably charged towards him. He sidestepped at the last moment, grabbing the rotten thing by its old moldy jacket so that it launched straight into the seat of the car. In a swirling of limbs and teeth, it tried to scrabble out before Bakugou slammed the door shut, smashing the thing's head in the process.

"Jesus *fuck*, Shitty Hair," he had snarled. "Now I fucking got brains all over me." He stormed off, leaving Kirishima looking decidedly sheepish, and Izuku mentally taking notes.

Combined with Bakugou's surprisingly useful talent for zombie murder and Izuku's level head and quick thinking, the two of them made a pretty good team out there on the street. That didn't mean that Bakugou liked him any more than when they'd first met. In fact, he spent just as much time insulting and criticising him as he did just staring at him with that stony disdain that made Izuku's skin crawl. But Izuku still found that more often than not, it had started becoming just the two of them whenever they needed supplies. Still, the more time Izuku spent with the man, the more worrisome things he began to notice.

Izuku hadn't been top of his classes for no reason. He was good at observation; at school he'd take notes on everything, and naturally that habit just carried over into the apocalypse. Taking mental notes on his companions, including Bakugou, was second nature to him. The first thing to note, as if it wasn't already completely obvious, is that Bakugou was hot. Like, *spit-in-my-mouth and I'd still thank you for it* kind of hot, which not only grossed Izuku the hell out but was starting to become a problem. A *big* one. Izuku was still willing to blame it all on the fact that he hadn't been laid in close to two entire fucking years, because before *Shit Went South* he would have *never* found himself wondering what the sweat leaving tracks down the blood-covered shoulders of his hotheaded companion would taste like. Or, when Bakugou was in a bad mood and Izuku happened to be in the wrong place at the wrong time, he had to physically bite his tongue to stop himself from whimpering as Bakugou backed him against a wall. And he had no idea what Bakugou would do to him if that happened. Probably murder. Izuku had never been the horny kind. Sure, he'd got his, but he'd never felt so desperate before, wanting to tear his damn hair out. Of course, being in a smallish house where they all had to share a room with at least one other person meant that finding any kind of private time to relieve some of that desperation was next to impossible. Izuku was only glad that it wasn't Bakugou that he shared his room with, or he'd probably never sleep again.

Bakugou, despite having an attitude that would have ordinarily left him ugly as hell, was distracting to the point of insanity. But there was something else about the man that Izuku couldn't help but notice.

His observations started with the mood swings. He'd done some arguably very kind things for Izuku in the short two months that he had already been a part of their group. The first being saving his life, the second being that photograph that Izuku kept beneath his pillow. He'd done other things since that point, mostly saving his life again or coming up to the roof during one of Izuku's shifts to ask if he needed anything. Perhaps they were pretty basic things, particularly if you were a member of a group surviving the apocalypse, but Izuku appreciated them none-the-less, and each kind moment left his heart practically sweating in his chest. Then, without any warning at all, he'd find himself on the receiving end of Bakugou's wrath, the man laying into him as if he'd personally started the apocalypse over something as ridiculous as drinking from a new water gallon before the

previous was completely empty. Sometimes, Kirishima or the others would try and ease the situation, but it seemed as though they had to deal with his rage as much as he did, and each time it would be laughed off by one of them as Bakugou stormed away.

Perhaps most alarming, however, was how quickly he could shift from an insane mania, usually when he was killing zombies, to a black hole of broodiness that matched even Shouto on a bad day. Izuku had watched the man laughing as he launched flaming bottles of vodka into a crowd of zombies, pure joy on his face in one instant, to standing still as one of them launched itself towards him, Izuku certain he was going to get caught. In each instance, Bakugou had killed the zombie, but the look on his face afterwards was enough to leave Izuku feeling concerned for him.

The alcohol was probably his next clue that Bakugou needed the kind of help that couldn't be found in the apocalypse. He'd never go so far as to say that he acted inebriated... his motor functions were never a problem; in fact, he'd never looked drunk the entire time that Izuku had known him, but he knew for certain that the man drank. If he ever got close enough, he could smell the sour scent on his breath, and he always seemed to find at least one bottle of something or other to bring back to their hideout. After six weeks, Izuku finally felt brave enough to ask Kirishima about it. Of all of them, the box-dyed redhead seemed to be the closest to him and usually the only one capable of calming him down. Though Izuku knew deep down it wasn't his business to pry, he was worried. But Kirishima had only smiled all too broadly at him, the grin not quite meeting his eyes, as he flippantly said that it was for all the explosives Bakugou made. But Izuku wasn't stupid... They only needed so many molly's.

Whatever was going on with Bakugou, none of the group talked about it. And, granted, he did fully appreciate that no one was going to have made it this far without some kind of baggage... hell, he was plagued nightly by visions of his friends being torn apart by zombies, watching as Ochako's throat was bitten out and Shouto's insides were strewn across the sidewalk. He definitely had his own demons, and if he wasn't so vehemently fighting against it, he was sure he'd be inclined to drink each day to cope with it, too. He supposed the rest of them were all coping with something. They had lost a member of their group at one point, though no one spoke about it, and he had seen how big of an impact that had had on them.

So, Izuku simply continued to watch Bakugou and said nothing more of it. He figured, so long as someone had his back, and he was sure that Kirishima did, then he didn't need to know the full story. Because, even if they did clash, if there was one thing that he realised he could rely on, it was that Bakugou cared deeply about his group and would do anything to protect them.

But eventually Izuku wished he had said something. He wished that he had confronted Bakugou about the drinking and hadn't just assumed that Bakugou knew how to handle it. He wished he had known that he wasn't the only one concerned about Bakugou.

It all started during one of Izuku's night shifts on the roof. Honestly, it wasn't a job he minded. He was growing to care a lot for his new friends, especially now that he'd had a chance to get to know them better. Sure, they were a bit louder and much more crass than what he was used to, but they all had hearts of gold, and watching Kaminari and Bakugou face off so often was entertainment in itself. But that didn't mean that Izuku didn't want space every now and then. It was an important ritual that he had adopted since the very start, where he would offer to watch all night long for his previous group, under the guise of letting everyone else catch up on some sleep. He enjoyed those nights. Just him and the stars, the world silent, and he found he appreciated them even more these days. Because it still hurt. It still hurt a whole lot, and if he sat on the rooftop some nights just so he could let the tears fall unnoticed, then at least he was doing something valuable at the same time.

That night, Izuku sat on the fold-up chair they had installed on the roof, underneath the umbrella, nursing a mug of cooling tea in his hands as he looked out at the quiet street around them. Occasionally he would spot the odd roving zombie, shambling by seemingly aimless, but never had he seen anything that had him worried. Tonight, however, he heard voices, and he scowled, leaning forward in his chair and putting the mug down on the tiles at his side.

"Come on, man. Don't be this way."

"Fuck off."

Izuku sighed, dropping back into his seat. It was only Kirishima and Bakugou, though what they were doing out on the street was another matter entirely.

"You know I can't do that, Katsuki," Kirishima was saying. His voice was quiet, like he was deliberately trying not to draw any attention. "Let's just go back inside and-"

"Don't tell me whatta fackin' do," Bakugou responded with a snarl. Izuku felt his stomach twist. Bakugou sounded different. Slurred, out of control – hell, he sounded drunk for the first time since he'd met him.

Not really knowing what to do, and certainly not sure he really wanted to get involved, Izuku hesitantly got to his feet and walked to the edge of the roof, looking down just in time to see Bakugou start storming off, a walking cliché with a half-empty bottle of alcohol in his hand, his bare feet causing Izuku to wince at the sight of them on the hard pavement.

"Bakugou!" Kirishima hissed, hurrying after him.

"Kirishima," Izuku called, grabbing his attention. "Are you, uh... do you need-"

"I got it, Midoriya, don't worry," Kirishima said, raising his hands before turning on his heel and after Bakugou, who was halfway down the street.

"Are you sure?" Izuku hissed, but Kirishima was going at a jog now to catch up with his obviously drunk friend. Izuku didn't like this, not one bit. Sure, he could see pretty far from up here, but it was clear that drunk or not, Bakugou had no intention of being watched, and he cut through an alley just a bit further up that Izuku knew led to an old playground. He bit his lip. He hadn't seen any zombies all night, but that didn't mean they weren't out there. He knew both Kirishima and Bakugou were capable, but with one inebriated and angry and the other trying to calm him down, they'd hardly be on top form. He hesitated for just a moment longer before swearing under his breath and sliding down the roof to the open window.

Inside, it seemed like everyone else was still asleep, and he was certain to grab the spare set of keys and lock the door as he left. He knew he probably shouldn't be leaving them alone and unguarded like this, but between them and Bakugou, he knew who was most likely to get themselves into trouble at this stage. He checked his knife was still hanging from his hip and started a light jog down the street towards the playground.

He could hear Bakugou before he could see him, and he could only run his hands down his face in frustration. What the hell was wrong with him? How could someone who was proving to be as big a pain in the ass as Bakugou still be alive in this damn world when he was stupid enough to wander drunkenly through the streets at night, hollering and shouting the entire time? It wasn't until he got

close, however, that the drunken slurring started to make any sense, and he paused at the end of the alley.

"Come on, Bakugou, you can't keep doing this!" Kirishima was saying, his voice a loud whisper, and Izuku peered around the corner. The redhead was standing with his palms forward, trying to placate the man standing barefoot and fuming in front of him. Bakugou looked awful, swaying on the spot, his lips pulled back into a snarl as he waved the bottle around in front of him, defensive.

"The hell I can't!" Bakugou yelled back, shaking the bottle so fiercely it threatened to launch out of his hand and hit Kirishima in the face. Kirishima held his palms up further.

"Be quiet!"

"Stop tellin' me whatta do!"

"Well, someone has to!" Kirishima hissed back. "I thought we were over all this. I mean, I knew you were still drinking but the binging? The sneaking out at night... You're going to get yourself killed!"

"Ain't none of ya damn business," Bakugou growled, taking a large step forward so that his face was in Kirishima's.

"Of course it is!" Kirishima cried, so exasperated now his voice rose, throwing his hands in the air. "Come on, man, I care about you. But you've got to stop punishing yourself for something that wasn't even your fault-"

"Who says it's got anything to do with that?" Bakugou took a step back now, swaying on the spot.

"Katsuki," Kirishima sighed. "We were all there, ok? No one blames you-"

"Don't you say another fucking word," Bakugou growled, his voice low and threatening.

"You want me to just pretend this isn't happening? I can't do that! I can't watch you destroy yourself all over again. I can't keep any more secrets!"

Bakugou laughed at this, his head thrown back, the sound loud and maniacal, echoing through the empty park. "Oh that's fackin' *rich*," he said, his grin wide and terrifying in the moonlight. "You think I dun know you and Pinky been screwin'? Newsflash, asshole, you ain't that quiet!"

Kirishima spluttered, and if Izuku could see his face he was sure it would be as red as his hair. Izuku did have to give that one to Bakugou; until now Izuku had no idea that Kirishima and Mina were even supposed to be a secret.

"W-we're not- that isn't-"

"*We're not that isn't*," Bakugou imitated crudely, before giving Kirishima the finger. "Fuck you, Shitty Hair. You think I'm the only one takin' risks, hah? You think you're so much better than me, hah?"

"At least I'm not the one trying to get myself killed!" Kirishima yelled.

A ringing silence followed Kirishima's statement. Bakugou looked as though the man had struck him, his snarl falling and his eyes widening, looking for the first time entirely vulnerable. Izuku's

stomach twisted, his fingertips gripping the hilt of his knife just for something to hold onto as he saw the emotions flash across Bakugou's face. He shouldn't be here... this wasn't something he was supposed to overhear, and the guilt and concern twisted up inside him until his hands shook.

"The hell do you know?" Bakugou replied, his voice shaking. "Nothing! You think you fuckin' know what I'm thinking? Fuck you!" His voice rose again, and this time he threw the bottle, and it smashed on the pavement loud enough to make Izuku flinch. There was no way they hadn't been heard, and sure enough, he smelt it. The scent of rot. Bakugou too seemed to sense the arrival of their guest, and he swung round as the shambling beast, clearly with two broken ankles going by the way that it fell over itself in its anticipation to get to him, scrabbled over.

"Shit," Kirishima said, reaching down to his hips for a weapon that wasn't there. "Come on, let's get out of here."

"No."

Bakugou said it so firmly, so coldly, that the hairs on the back of Izuku's head stuck up. He stood there, looking at the zombie struggling to move towards him yet gaining speed, then back at Kirishima, before the humourless grin graced his already crazed features.

"I can't die if I try," he said, before he held up his forearm to the side of him.

"Katsuki, what are you doing?" Kirishima hissed, panicked.

"Come on, asshole, come getta taste!" Bakugou yelled, shaking his arm slightly, no longer swaying where he stood, looking over his shoulder at the rotting mass of meat hurrying his way. Izuku couldn't believe what he was seeing, his mouth dropping, his heart thudding.

"Katsuki, this isn't funny!" Kirishima cried.

"Bitch, *fuck you*," Bakugou snarled, before he raised a hand to his temple, tapping the scars on his head. "I. Can't. Die. I'm doomed to live in this hellhole for the rest of eternity, right? Well, only one fucking way to find out."

"Katsuki, stop!"

Izuku was halfway across the playground before he was even aware that he had started moving, pulling out his wakizashi as he ran forward. The zombie was close, sightless eyes wide, teeth bared as she was just inches from sinking them into the flesh of Bakugou's arm, he doing nothing to stop it, and it was frankly a fucking miracle that Izuku got there in time, throwing himself forward and tackling the thing. He heard someone swearing and felt the rotting corpse beneath him crunch and crumble before he was stabbing down into its face, panting heavily.

For a moment, there was silence. No one said a damn word; Izuku was just breathing heavily, staring down at the zombie beneath him and the brown goo up his arms. His mind was strangely blank in that moment, just looking at her, her rotting face, her once no doubt lovely-looking dress torn and tattered, before the rage began to bubble. He got to his feet, hands shaking as he wiped his knife against his jeans and put it back into its holster, turning to face Bakugou.

"What the *fuck* do you think you're doing?" he hissed. He didn't sound like himself at all in that moment. Hell, he sounded more like *Bakugou*, his voice cold and deadly, his green eyes fierce as they stared back at the blond. But Bakugou, far from intimidated, just bared his teeth.

"What are you doing here, Deku?" he growled, taking a huge step forward.

"What do you think?" Izuku yelled, throwing his hands in the air. "Are you both fucking *stupid*, hah?"

"And who's guarding the fucking house, *Deku?*" Bakugou asked, his voice low, eyes flashing. He hesitated.

"You were the ones yelling in the damn street! You think I was gonna let you go out here all on your own?"

"So you left them unprotected?"

"Bakugou, let's chill out-"

"No. Fuck no." Bakugou cocked his head to one side, and a cold, steely tint came to them. "I'm fucking done. I'm killing this bastard."

"Whoa!"

Something in the way Bakugou glared at him left him certain that he wasn't joking. And when Bakugou started to advance on him, fingers flexing, he realised just how much fucking trouble he was in. Instinct told him to grab his knife, but a part of him still couldn't quite comprehend his situation, and before he knew what was going on, Bakugou was on him.

"Bakugou!"

Izuku cried out as he felt the full weight of the considerably large man collide with his chest and was knocked back onto the ground with a hard thump.

"Wait-"

There were hands already around his throat, and he gasped, eyes wide.

"Stop it! Get off him!" There was a yelp, a hand momentarily letting go of Izuku's throat before it found its place around his jaw, holding his head upwards, and he choked. He couldn't breathe; the hand around his neck was gripping so tightly. He could smell sweat and alcohol and decay, his eyes staring up at the starry sky. *So, this was it?* All this time he'd fought to survive, and this was how he was going out? Choked to death by the world's most fragile asshole after saving his goddamn life? No. Fuck that. *Fuck that noise*. Izuku's fingers inched their way down, gripping hold of his knife, and before Bakugou could do a thing, he pulled it out and stabbed downwards, Bakugou letting out a yell as the knife sank into the flesh of his thigh. The hands released his throat, and as Izuku gasped and choked, he saw thick arms wrap around Bakugou's chest and haul him backwards.

Another silence followed, the three of them panting heavily, one of Izuku's hands gripping the grass to ground him, the other rubbing his burning throat. Bakugou hadn't moved, just hanging in Kirishima's grip, chest heaving as he stared back at Izuku in shock, the knife sticking out of his leg slowly oozing blood onto the ground.

"Sh-shit."

Izuku winced, pushing himself back on the ground a fraction when Bakugou spoke, really wishing he still had his knife, and that only seemed to make Bakugou panic more.

"F-fuck I- I-"

"Alright, enough of this," Kirishima said. "We can't be out here any longer."

"M-Midoriya," Bakugou said, his voice shaking. "I- I didn't- I'm sorry, I-"

"You're just making it worse, man," Kirishima sighed. Izuku sat stock still, adrenaline still rushing from almost being strangled to goddamn death, and entirely confused by the reaction that he was getting from Bakugou as a result. Kirishima seemed to think it safe to let Bakugou go, the man just slumping on the ground, his face haunted.

"Midoriya, are you ok?" Kirishima asked, walking up to him.

Of course I'm not ok!

"I'm fine," he breathed, coughing slightly. "It's fine."

"M-Midoriya-" Bakugou stammered.

"Forget it," Izuku said forcibly, getting to his feet, and looking down at Bakugou. "You're drunk. Obviously there's some shit I don't know. But right now we need to get out of here before we get eaten."

Bakugou didn't say anything else, just slapping Kirishima's hand away when he tried to help him to his feet, eyes averted from the both of them. Kirishima swallowed before he shot Izuku a look both thankful and apologetic, mouthing, *'later'*, before Izuku shrugged tiredly. He just wanted to get back. Right in this moment he didn't have it in him to think any more about what had happened, what it meant, or whether he could even stay here any longer than tonight. Bakugou turned away, starting to walk back towards the house without another word. He knew that wasn't the end of it, he *knew*, but he still walked with them anyway.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 6: Their Pound of Flesh

Chapter Summary

In which the rival group make their grand entrance.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

No Unnecessary Risks.

The words ran through his mind over and over as he paced across the rooftop. *No Unnecessary Risks*. They were words he'd lived by for so long that he wondered if they had been there long before the apocalypse. This mantra had kept him alive and right now his brain was screaming them at him; every instinct was telling him to get away, that staying under the same roof as Bakugou was about the riskiest thing he would do.

In the moment, Bakugou had seemed genuinely shocked by his reaction, even sorry, but what the hell did that mean? He'd already known the man wasn't stable, and frankly, there likely wasn't a survivor out there who wasn't, but Bakugou had tried to murder him. It hadn't been a threat or a warning – if Izuku hadn't had his knife on him, there was every possibility that Bakugou would have choked him out right there in the park, and everything he'd survived until now would have been for naught. As sorry as he had seemed, Izuku couldn't be certain that it would happen again. The next time Bakugou drank too much, maybe he didn't try and kill Izuku again, but instead did something so stupid and so reckless that it would get someone else killed instead. He thought about what Kirishima had said to him and the painful history the group was still keeping from him and began if it hadn't already happened.

Still, it wasn't so simple as just packing a bag and leaving. He had to consider how risky it was to be out there on his own. Without other people, there'd be no one to keep watch whilst he slept, to cover him when he searched for supplies, or to assist him if he got injured. Most people couldn't survive the apocalypse alone. Whether they died from starvation or exposure, or zombies got hold of them, the life expectancy of anyone out there alone was short.

Even if Izuku was confident that he had the skills to survive on his own, he certainly wasn't smart or fast enough to avoid getting impaled on a tree or chased into a dead end. He certainly hadn't been smart or fast enough to avoid a drunken maniac. If he left now, if he went at it alone, realistically what were his chances of lasting even the week?

He dropped into his chair, rubbing his hands over his face. Bakugou hadn't said another word after his stammered and shocked apology, not sparing Izuku or Kirishima so much as a glance as he stumbled his way through the kitchen, grabbing a bottle of beer en route as he stormed up the stairs. He wasn't so sorry for his actions that he'd stop drinking for the night… Izuku had excused himself after that, leaving Kirishima alone in the kitchen.

It had been an hour since then. He wasn’t sure what he was expecting, but he was glad that he at least had someone quiet to think, alone on the rooftop. That was until he heard the heavy footsteps on the riles behind him, his shoulders sagging comically.

"Not yet, Kirishima," he sighed, letting his head fall back against the chair. "Can we talk about it tomorrow?"

When there was no response, he turned in his chair and his breath caught in his throat when he saw Bakugou standing there. He shot to his feet, hands reaching for his knife, staring down the particularly sour-looking man in front of him. He immediately spotted the bottle of beer in his hand and his pale and clammy face. He was dressed only in black boxers and a tank top, with a poorly wrapped, blood-stained bandage around his thigh, and Izuku cursed under his breath. *Because, why the hell not?* Why wouldn’t he find himself alone, backed against the edge of the roof, by the man who had tried to murder him only an hour ago?

"Relax," Bakugou grunted, his voice so low that Izuku hardly heard it, before the blond sat down clumsily on the tiles, his feet dangling precariously over the edge of the rooftop.

"That's easy for you to say," Izuku replied, through gritted teeth, still holding his knife tightly in his fist and watching Bakugou carefully. The man looked worse than he had done in the park, and push came to shove, quite literally; he could just throw the man over the side of the rooftop if he got too close...

"I ain't gonna try an' kill you 'gain," Bakugou scoffed, his tone derisive, and Izuku felt his stomach coil in anger and disbelief.

"Well, thanks for fucking clearing that up!" he snapped. "You know, I didn't think you were going to the first time!" He pulled his knife out now, Bakugou's eyes following the action. "What are you even doing here?"

Bakugou huffed and shrugged, leaning onto his hand and taking a swig of beer.

"And why are you still drinking?" he cried, incredulously.

"Coz I dun wanna be sober, moron," Bakugou shot back, with very little malice.

Izuku sighed.

"I don't want to deal with this, Bakugou," he breathed, his voice suddenly sounding quite as tired as he felt. "You're drunk and I've got a lot on my mi-"

"You dun have t'leave."

Izuku froze, blinking back at him. "Huh?"

"Tha's what you're thinkin', righ'? 'Bout leaving?"

"The thought had crossed my mind, yeh," Izuku said back sourly. "It's kinda hard to feel comfortable around someone who tried to murder me an hour ago."

"Holy *fuck*, I said I was sorry!"

"Well, now I feel all better! Cheers, asshole!"

"God, do you have'ta be such a whiny bitch about it!" Bakugou turned to him now, pivoting dangerously on the tiles, and Izuku immediately tightened his grip on his knife, holding it point forwards to Bakugou's chest. His eyes narrowed.

"How exactly did you think I would be?" Izuku hissed, lowering his voice when he realised just how loud they had gotten. "Goddammit, Bakugou! You walk off on your own, drunk and out of your mind, then offer yourself up as zombie bait before trying to *kill me* after I saved your life!"

Bakugou looked away, his ears visibly reddening even in the low light. "I didn't need your fucking help, Deku," he grunted, so quiet Izuku almost didn't hear him. Izuku let out a bark of laughter, running his free hand through his hair.

"You know, when I was with my old group, we had a saying," he continued. "*No Unnecessary Risks*. Sure, it meant we went hungry more often than we didn't, and we never stayed anywhere long enough to build up the kind of thing that you guys have going on, but it kept us alive. You are a risk, Bakugou. You're loud and violent and clearly fucking unstable. And maybe everyone else is ok to just pretend that isn't a problem, but I haven't survived this long by being reckless!"

"First of all, *fuck you,"* Bakugou replied fiercely, and Izuku threw his hands in the air in frustration. "I've kept this fucking group alive!"

"You sure they haven't kept *you* alive?" Izuku shot back, and Bakugou was on his feet, deceptively agile despite his state of inebriation.

"Second of all, you conceited piece of shit, that can't have worked so well for you, can it? Coz your group is fucking dead, and mine is still alive!"

A ringing silence followed his words, hitting Izuku like a slap to the face. He could see that Bakugou regretted it the moment he said it, a sort of fog lifting from his face, but whether he meant it or not didn’t matter. Bakugou was right; his group was dead. And if he had come back to them sooner instead of lying around being coddled by these strangers, would he have been able to save them? Were they only caught out by their enemies because they had been waiting and hoping for Izuku to come home?

He turned his back to Bakugou, no longer caring much about the position that put him in, and slumped into his chair.

“Look,” Bakugou started, hesitantly. “I didn’t-” he huffed, a strange choked sound coming from his throat before he suddenly launched the bottle of beer over the roof, making Izuku wince at the sound. Just like that, angry Bakugou was back, his presence persistent and intimidating as he loomed over him. “Stay or don’t, fucking Deku,” he snarled. “See if I even give a shit.”

Izuku didn’t say a word, just staring at the reddening sky. Bakugou scoffed, the roof creaking as he climbed back through the window and left Izuku alone on the rooftop once more.

In the end, it didn’t matter how dangerous Bakugou was; Izuku knew he couldn’t leave. He was trapped between certain death out there and a slightly less certain one here.

Kirishima tried to speak with him the following morning – all comforting smiles and a concerned presence – but Izuku shrugged him off, telling him that there wasn't a problem. Kirishima didn't believe him, but Izuku found he didn't care very much. After all, what else was there to say? They both knew the score; both knew that Izuku wasn't going anywhere and that Bakugou was a force entirely unto himself. To Izuku's relief, Bakugou ignored him after that, dismissing Kaminari's questions about his new limp and dragging Sero off with him on his supply run. Izuku was more than ok with that.

Izuku opted to stay on watch most nights after that. Mina, Sero and Kaminari were definitely curious as to why Izuku and Bakugou were no longer speaking to one another, but it seemed they knew better than to ask and instead let Izuku stay up on the rooftop for as long as he wanted to. Until, just three nights later, when their awkward little arrangement came to a sudden end.

At first, Izuku couldn't for the life of him work out what he was hearing. It was so frustratingly and mundanely familiar to him that when he finally recognised it as the sound of a car engine, he felt embarrassed. His following thought was less *'I can't believe I've forgotten what cars sound like'* and more *'why the hell is there a car here?'* and he flattened his body to the roof immediately, peering out over the edge. There were no headlights that he could see, and with their own 'lights out' policy, the street remained dark, but that didn't make it impossible for their hideout to be spotted. He bit his lip, squinting into the dark.

When the rusted station waggon appeared on the street, Izuku felt his stomach drop down to his ass. Bakugou had mentioned something about a car like this when talking about the group that had likely killed his friends, and his palms began to sweat. This had to be them. After all, it was a strange car to see driving down the streets of post-apocalyptic Japan.

The vehicle slowed to a crawl and pulled up four houses down. Izuku waited, hardly daring to breathe as a car door creaked, and a man stepped out into the pavement.

Even from afar, Izuku could make out the dark scars across his arms and face. He looked as though he had been badly burned, and Izuku wondered how anyone could even survive a fire that would leave such extensive scarring. The man pushed his dark hair out of his face, looking up and down the street. Izuku flattened himself as much as he could, staring intently as another door opened and this time a man with white hair slouching out, expression haughty and bored.

"You sure this is where you heard it?" came a low voice. The back doors of the car opened and a woman with blonde hair joined them, a smile on her face and a knife twirled between her fingers.

"There was definitely some yelling going on a few nights back," she said. "Pretty sure I recognised Bakugou's voice."

"What a moron," the white-haired man sighed. "Jin, stay by the car."

"I don't want to! You got it!" came a fourth voice from a man Izuku could barely make out in the dark.

Izuku held his breath as three of them began to walk closer to their hideout, the woman confidently leading them down the street.

"Here," she said, pointing to the ground. Izuku's stomach dropped when he saw the beer bottle that Bakugou had thrown a few nights back lying smashed on the ground. The white-haired man

scratched his neck.

“What am I even looking at?”

“That wasn’t here last time,” the woman replied.

The man with the burnt face took a step back and looked up in Izuku’s direction. Izuku pulled back, praying that it was far too dark for the man to have spotted him, feeling sick as he watching him appraise the other houses on the street.

“What do you think, Tomura?” the burnt man asked.

The white-haired man sighed heavily. “I think I don’t care about a broken bottle and some yelling Toga heard three nights ago,” he said, sounding irritated. “Let’s go.”

“But-”

“I said let’s go, Toga,” the white-haired man snapped, making his way back to the car. Izuku watched the burnt man and Toga shrug at one another before heading back to the car. He didn’t move, staying frozen to the spot right up until all four strangers got back into the car and drove away. He waited until he could no longer hear the engine before scrabbling to his feet and throwing himself through the window.

He hammered his hands on the doors as he ran past, heading for the kitchen, ignoring the tired groans and irritated swearing from the room’s occupants. He almost flattened himself against the kitchen window in his eagerly to snatch back the heavy cloth covering it, peering out onto the street.

“The fuck are you doing?”

Izuku jumped, looking back over his shoulder to see Bakugou sat at the counter, staring at him with genuine resentment. Izuku didn’t have a chance to reply before the rest of the group filed into the kitchen. Kaminari yawned loudly, scratching his belly.

"Wha'happened?" he asked.

“A group was just out there,” Izuku replied. “Four. Three men, one woman, just as you said, in a station waggon.”

There was a loud screech as Bakguou immediately got to his feet, knocking the bar stool to the floor. He pushed past Izuku to get to the window, looking out onto the street as the rest stared at Izuku in shock.

“Are you sure?” Kaminari whispered with wide eyes. He saw Sero place a comforting hand on his shoulder.

“Yeh, I’m sure,” Izuku replied, trying not to let his exasperation show. “They stopped, got out the car, and checked the place out. They, uh… they said they heard some yelling a few nights ago.”

He felt rather than saw Bakugou tense behind him. He wasn’t sure why he didn’t mention that Toga had recognised Bakugou’s voice.

“It sounded like this was the first time the girl had been here.”

“What?” Sero yelped. “But *when?* We would have seen them!”

“I fucking did!” Bakugou snapped. “I told you I saw them, didn’t I?”

“Are they still out there?” Mina whispered. Izuku shook his head.

“No. One of them, Tomura, I think they called him, said he wasn’t interested, and they left.”

“They’ll be back,” Bakugou said. Kirishima flinched.

“C’mon man, we don’t know that for sure.”

“It did seem like Tomura was annoyed that they’d wasted his time.”

“I’m telling you that don’t mean shit,” Bakugou retorted. “He probably knew someone was listening; that was all for fucking show.”

“So does that mean… we’re leaving?” Mina asked.

“After we worked so hard to get all this?” Bakugou growled. “No fucking way. We do what we should’a done months ago and take these assholes out.”

“No,” Kirishima said firmly. “Are you crazy? *No.* It’s just stuff, Katsuki. I say we get in the RV and get the hell out of here. You really wanna risk all our lives just to get even?”

“It isn’t about getting even,” Kaminari cried. “Are you kidding? They’ve taken so much from us! We can’t just let them take *more.”*

“Sweetie, I know you’re still hurting,” Mina said, placing a hand on Kaminar’s forearm. “But think about what you’re saying. You think Kyouka would have wanted this?”

At that, Bakugou seemed to snap. A loud smash came from their left as he swiped his hand over the table, throwing things aside.

“Oh, Pinky, tell me you did not just say that.”

Kirishima placed himself between Bakugou and Mina then, his face suddenly more serious than Izuku had ever seen it.

“Back off, man,” he said firmly. “Mina’s right. If we fight these guys, chances are one of us is gonna die. And I’m not willing to take that risk!”

Bakugou scoffed and rounded on Izuku, as if he suddenly had stock in this particular argument.

“And what about you?” Bakugou hissed. “They killed your group.”

Izuku saw the challenge in Bakugou’s eyes, the only indication that he remembered what he had

said to Izuku on the rooftop that first time. Izuku looked away.

“I don’t know that,” he replied. Bakugou let out a derisive snort.

“No Unnecessary Risks, right?” he mocked. “Fucking pathetic.”

“Bakugou, I just don’t think this is a good idea,” Sero said.

“Maybe they’re right for now, Katsuki,” Kaminari said, his face scrunched up like every word caused him pain. “I don’t want anyone else to get hurt if we’re not ready.”

That seemed to sober Bakugou up a little, and his shoulders sagged.

“Fine,” he snapped, before starting to walk away.

"Where are you going?" Kirishima asked.

"To fucking pack."

The group spent the rest of the day packing and taking stock of their supplies, calculating how much fuel they had left and how long their food would carry them before they’d need to find more. The atmosphere was tense, none of them speaking much as they worked, and that night Bakugou had insisted on being the one to keep watch. The idea was for them to leave in the early hours of the morning, before dawn, in the hopes that it would take Tomura’s group a day or so to get their own affairs in order before coming for them.

Although he wasn’t needed on watch, Izuku still found it impossible to sleep that night, lying on his back in his sleeping bag and staring up at the ceiling. Sero and Kaminari snored lightly beside him, though Kaminari had only drifted off in the last hour or so. Izuku knew that leaving was the right call; they outnumbered Tomura’s group, but right now their group was hardly performing at its best, with Bakugou hardly speaking to any of them. Still, part of Izuku wondered if he ought to be making a stand here anyway. He didn’t have proof that these bastards were the ones who had killed his friends, but if they were… Right now, Izuku had no idea what he might be capable of.

He could understand why Bakugou and Kaminari didn’t want to leave, though, and it was not lost on Izuku that this city was the last place that he and his friends had been together. Leaving felt like leaving them behind, like he was really accepting that they were gone. He shut his eyes and rolled onto his side. The whole thing was such a mess.

At first, he thought he could hear someone playing music in the house, and his face scrunched up at the feeling of bass pounding and reverberating through his eardrums. *Who thought it was a good idea to play music when they were supposed to be lying low?* But the longer he lay there, the more he started to realise that it probably wasn’t coming from them, and he sat up with a gasp.

He was on his feet and yanking open the door in a heartbeat, thundering up the stairs towards the roof, taking them three at a time. The bass was from outside of the house, getting stronger and stronger with each passing moment. He almost ran straight into Bakugou on his way up, the man swearing as he grabbed hold of the handrails to stop himself tripping right over him.

“What is it?” Izuku asked, panting. “Is it them?”

“We gotta go.”

Bakugou pushed past him, all but flying down the stairs as he started hammering on the doors. Izuku kept climbing, all but throwing himself through the loft window so that he could see out over the rooftop, and his jaw dropped.

The station waggon was back, along with it a roaring drumbeat, screaming vocals filling the air as heavy metal blasted out of the sound system. But it was what was following the car that demanded all of Izuku’s attention: a horde, perhaps a hundred strong, of zombies. All drawn by the sound, snatching at the vehicle, and headed straight towards them.

"Midoriya!" he heard Kirishima yell and he swore, tearing back into the house and down the stairs, into the kitchen where the rest of them were standing, gaping out of the window.

"Fucking assholes," Bakugou was snarling, as he tightened the leather braces around his thighs, tearing through cupboards and grabbing weapons to strap to them. "Motherfucking *fuckers* I'm gonna kill them!"

"That's a lot of zombies," Kaminari whispered. "Guys, that's a lot of zombies!"

"Yeh, we can see them, Kaminari!" Mina shot back, she too grabbing weapons and shoving them into her backpack. They’d at least the foresight to pack essentials already in case they’d needed to make a fast exit.

"Do we just let them go past us?" Sero asked, but Izuku shook his head, answering before Bakugou had a chance to scream at the man.

"No, even if they don't know which house we're in, if we don't move now, they can just knock down the doors one by one until they find us," he said. He pulled on his own backpack, grabbing his wakizashi.

"Where do we go?"

"The RV," Kirishima replied. "It's a straight shoot from here; we can make it, right?"

"You bet your fucking ass we're going to make it," Bakugou snarled. "Just fucking stay behind me, you hear?"

Kirishima nodded, looking over at Mina before he reached out and took her hand.

"Alright, Deku, you're up."

Izuku blinked, looking away from the window.

"Huh?"

"You're the fast one, right? You fucking got this place mapped out, so let's go!"

"R-right."

Izuku trembled slightly as he looked back out of the window. If they were going to stand any hope of getting out of here alive, they'd need to go now.

"Right," he said, as firmly as he could. "Let's go."

Together they ran towards the front door, Izuku taking a second to check that everyone was with him before he pulled it open.

The smell was overwhelming. He'd seen large herds before, but he'd never been this close to them, and it was enough to have him gagging as the putrid scent of hundreds of rotting bodies pushed in on him. And it wasn't just the smell, either. The decomposition of so many bodies at once produced a lot of heat, and Izuku felt his eyes watering. In all, it was perhaps the single most nauseating thing he'd ever experienced.

They acted fast, perhaps quicker than Tomura's group had expected, but it wasn't fast enough to completely outrun their notice. Izuku looked up, watching as the station waggon slowed down, and through the window he saw him, the white-haired man with eyes red as blood, watching him with cold, deadly intent.

"Motherfucker," he heard Bakugou growl, having seen him too. He took a step forward, raising his bat as if the zombies around them no longer mattered, and without thinking, Izuku grabbed him by the wrist.

"Don't be stupid!"

The zombies finally took notice of them, a freezing terror running over him as he saw a hundred empty faces, all in varying states of decay, turn to them, heads raising, soundless mouths gaping.

"Come on!"

He started to run, Bakugou wrenching his wrist free but following. The group were hot on their heels as they ran down the street toward the alleyway to the abandoned park. They hadn't left the RV too close to their hideout, worried it would make it far too obvious if anyone stumbled across it, but they had still picked a location with a clear route from the hideout. The problem they had now wasn't just the horde behind them but other zombies nearby that would be drawn towards the commotion, potentially crawling out from behind the houses. Izuku skidded around a corner, looking for signs of any other zombies that might be coming their way. Bakugou hadn't been wrong; he'd had this area mapped out almost as soon as he'd been able to walk, and despite how panicked he felt, he knew he would be able to lead them out of here. He took a deep breath as he ran, forcing himself to remain focused.

"Shit!" he heard Sero yell. "They're right on our tail!"

"This way!" Izuku called back, pushing open the metal gate to the park. "Come on, come on!"

They ran through, and Izuku slammed it shut behind them. It wasn't much, but it would hopefully slow some of them down, and he raced back to the front of the group, where they began to clamber over the back railing. It was just a narrow verge and a gentle decline, before they would be on the road that ran parallel to their hideout. And from there, just two more alleys before they would be at the garage where the RV was parked. They could make it. *They would make it.*

"Deku!"

He heard Bakugou yelling as they skidded down onto the road, turning to his right to see another group, twelve or thirteen strong, coming around to flank them, blocking their route. He growled.

"Left!"

The group followed, panting and holding their weapons as Izuku adjusted their course. The way was clear, Izuku leading them down an alley that would cut through to the next road, where they would need to cross through a parking lot to reach the back of the garages. It wasn't ideal – there was a slight bottleneck ahead – but the next quickest route would take them dangerously close to where the horde a hundred strong would appear at any moment. They tore down the alley, Izuku just hoping that they weren't about to get jumped on, before spilling out into the parking lot.

"Through the cars!"

They could hear the dragging and thundering of hundreds of rotting limbs from behind them.

"That's so creepy!" Kaminari whined.

"Just fucking focus, idiot!" Bakugou yelled.

But it seemed like nothing was working in their favour that night. As Izuku led them towards the shortcut between the back of the garages, their way was immediately blocked by more zombies, pushing and shoving one another in their effort to race through the narrow alley.

"Shit!”

Izuku skidded to a halt, looking back over his shoulder. The rest of the zombies were already at the edge of the carpark.

"Where now?" Mina yelled, and Izuku swore under his breath, thinking fast.

"Cut back through to the houses," he said, pointing to his right, but as they started to adjust their course, he let out a cry of frustration as yet more zombies filed out of the treeline.

"Why are there so many of them!" Kaminari yelped. But Bakugou was stepping forward, towards the garages, pulling out his bat.

"This way," he snarled. "We can take these fuckers."

"Hell," Kirishima breathed, pulling out his own weapon. Izuku watched as Bakugou confidently stepped forward, swinging his bat, the end connecting with the first of the zombies to throw itself at him. It was the right call; there were far fewer between them and the garages than any other direction they might run, but it was still a lot more than he'd had to take out in one go before. He swore and ran up beside Bakugou, stabbing into the temple of the next zombie.

They hacked and slashed their way through the herd, working with a frankly frightful accuracy, particularly Bakugou, who seemed to never waste a single swing of his bat, knocking corpses left and right, blood splattering across the cobbled rough walls of the garages. Izuku took a chance to look behind them, and his stomach wrenched. They were close, so fucking close ...

"Alright, go!" Bakugou was roaring, and he looked back to see the way forward clear, and the group ran. He could see the RV, arguably the most perfect beautiful thing he'd ever fucking seen in his life, sitting and waiting for them across the road.

"Baby, come to Papa!" he heard Kaminari say beside him. They were almost there, almost in the clear.

"Fuck!"

Izuku's eyes widened, his head darting towards where Sero had been running, just behind him, before the yell of pain filled the air.

"Sero!"

There had been one left. One zombie, just around the corner of the garages, just out of their reach. One zombie that threw itself forward, fingers gripping hold of Sero's forearm before sinking its teeth in deep.

Bakugou was moving before any of them, pulling a knife from his utility belt and shoving it deep into the temple of the zombie gnawing down on Sero's arm. It dropped to the ground, Sero swearing and holding his arm to his chest, feet stumbling beneath him.

"Come on!"

Bakugou threw his arm around Sero’s shoulder, casting another glare behind them as the zombies began to file down the alley. Izuku grabbed Sero's other side, the two of them hauling the shocked man towards the RV, the door flung open wide for them.

"Fucking drive!" Bakugou was yelling, and Kaminari was jumping into the front seat, shoving the key into the ignition. Izuku panted, helping Bakugou move Sero towards the orange checkered sofa in the back of the RV. There was a bang, and another, the RV rocking as zombies collided with the side of it, rotting and bloodied palms slapping against the windows, sightless eyes staring hungrily in at them.

"Any time you like, man!" Kirishima called, and Kaminari let out a frustrated yell as he turned the key a second time before the RV finally sprang into life, the blonde hitting the gas with another yell, driving forwards. The sound of palms squeaking and scratching across the windows, the sound of cracks as bodies inevitably got caught under the wheels, the sound of the group panicking and Sero crying out in pain ... Izuku wished he couldn't hear any of it.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 7: Skin of Our Teeth

Chapter Summary

In which Sero is in danger and Bakugou reveals a secret ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"It's ok, Sero, it'll be ok!"

Izuku perched on the sofa beside Sero, his back pressed against his chest as he supported him, feeling his body shaking in shock.

"Is he ok? What's going on?"

"Just focus on where you're going!"

"Hey, Hanta, stay with me, man. Come on."

Izuku's breath came out in sharp pants and it was all he could do to support the man beside him. It was bad; there was no arguing that. The bite, far from a neat mark in the skin, was brutal, the zombie having bitten in and torn a large grisly chunk of flesh and muscle away. Mina was busy with towels and blankets, trying to stem the flow of blood, whilst Kirishima held Sero’s face, slapping his cheeks as his eyes started to sag and flutter, his head dropping down.

"Hanta! C’mon, Hanta, look at me. Please-"

"Out of the way."

"What are you going to do?" Mina cried as Bakugou pushed past her, reaching out to grab Sero's arm for himself.

"Only thing I can think of," he replied, his voice oddly calm amongst the panicked cries of his companions. He reached down, undoing his belt and pulling it free, and in that moment Izuku understood, his breath catching in his throat.

"Wh- the problem isn't just the bleeding, Bakugou!" Mina practically cried. "The bite ... he's going to ... he can't-"

Bakugou ignored her, tightening the belt around Sero's bicep.

"Deku, gimme your knife," he demanded, holding his hand out. Izuku handed it to him, and Kirishima followed the action, eyes wide.

"Whoa! What are you going to do with that?"

"Oi, Sero," Bakugou said, leaning forward and placing a palm against the man's cheek. Sero blinked, his hazy eyes looking at Bakugou, then down at the knife, before giving a small nod.

"Hold him," Bakugou instructed, and Izuku wrapped his hands around Sero's shoulders, pinning him to his chest. "Kirishima, grab his hand."

"You can't be serious," Kirishima whined.

"What's happening back there?" Kaminari yelled from the driver's seat.

"Do it or he dies!" Bakugou yelled now, and after another moment's hesitation, Kirishima moved around him, holding Sero's hand taut between his arms.

There was a cold, frightening moment where Bakugou's eyes seemed to grow dark, focusing on Sero's arm, before he swung down, hacking into the flesh just below his elbow. Sero screamed, his body taut and thrashing as Izuku and Kirishima held him between them. Bakugou pulled the knife out, and he swung again. The arm cracked, and Izuku felt Sero sag against him, passing out. Bakugou swung again and again until Kirishima was left holding Sero’s destroyed arm, choking back a sob as it bled out of the roughly edged stump.

"Oh my god," Kirishima breathed. "Oh my god... holy shit, oh my god-"

"Shut the hell up, Shitty Hair," Bakugou growled, his face decidedly grey at the sight of flesh and bone and the blood caking his hands. Izuku, still high on adrenaline, felt faint, and it was only Sero's heavy, hot weight against his chest that kept him grounded.

"Bandages, gauze, what the hell we got?"

But it was clear that Kirishima and Mina were panicking. Izuku leaned forward.

"Kirishima, take Sero," he said. Kirishima nodded numbly, placing Sero's amputated arm down on the sofa like it was made of glass. He got up and took Izuku's place, who then ran towards the first aid box underneath the sink.

"We've got both," he said, dropping the box open on the seat beside Sero. "Maybe not enough..."

"It'll have to do," Bakugou grunted. "Get round here, elevate his arm."

Izuku climbed onto the sofa around Bakugou, sitting on the back of it as he raised Sero's arm up over shoulder height, grabbing one of the towels and holding it against the stump, hot sticky blood coating his fingers. Bakugou busied himself with unwrapping the bandages and grabbing gauze before he got to his feet.

"Gotta stop the bleeding," he muttered, almost to himself. His hand wrapped around the back of Izuku's to pull the towel away, Izuku feeling the rough, calloused palm on the back of his fingers, making him only that much more anxious and nauseous at the contact, his hand almost as hot as Sero's blood. He glanced up, their eyes meeting for just a moment before Bakugou let go, inspecting the wound.

"How do we stop it?" Mina asked, her voice firmer, if not still shaky. But Bakugou ignored her as he started to pack the stump with gauze. "Bakugou?"

"Just lemme fucking work!" Bakugou yelled, scowling, his tongue sticking out between his teeth as he continued to push more gauze in. "Bandage," he snapped, clicking his fingers as Mina reached forward to pick it up from the sofa and hand it to him. He started to wrap the bandage around the stump. There wasn't much, not enough, and Izuku knew that they would need to change the bandage sooner rather than later, but it covered the wound. Izuku cast another look around the room of the RV.

"You got any duct tape? Anything like that?" he asked Mina, and she nodded, hurrying off to the sink before coming back with the tape. Izuku grabbed the towel again, looking back up at Bakugou who just nodded, moving his hands so that Izuku could press the towel back around Sero's arm, tearing the tape with his teeth as he secured it around his elbow.

"We're going to need more bandages," Izuku said. "Did we have any in the bags?"

"Y-yeh," Kirishima said, voice quiet. "I got some."

Izuku looked up in time to see Bakugou take a large step back, almost stumbling as he pressed himself against the opposite side of the RV. The man was breathing hard, raising both hands in front of his face, and Izuku could see how badly they were shaking.

"Kaminari, are we clear?" Izuku called.

"Yeh, I'm on the motorway."

"Ok, pull over."

"Huh?"

"If it's safe, pull over!"

The RV slowed, and before they had even come to a complete stop, Bakugou was pushing the door to the RV open, stumbling out onto the road outside.

"Take Sero," Izuku said to Mina, before following Bakugou out. Sure, the guy had tried to kill him, but that didn't mean he was going to let him stand out in fucking zombie country without someone watching his back. He was out of the door quick enough to see Bakugou gripping hold of the bonnet of a car, bent double as he emptied his stomach out onto the asphalt.

"Are you ok?" Izuku asked, taking a step towards him.

For a moment, Bakugou didn't respond, just holding onto the car and breathing heavily, before he straightened up, wrist reaching up to wipe his mouth.

"Fine." Bakugou didn't meet his eyes as he stalked back past him and into the RV, but Izuku didn't miss the way his hands were still shaking.

Back in the RV, Kaminari had joined the rest of them, his face white as a sheet as he looked at the bloodbath in the back. Sero was still passed out, with his head on Mina's lap as she stroked the hair back from his pale forehead.

"Is he going to be ok?" Kaminari whispered. Izuku swallowed, his eyes darting towards Bakugou again, as the man clenched his jaw.

"Don't ask stupid questions," he muttered.

"But... you cut his arm off so the infection wouldn't spread, right?" Kaminari continued. "That's... it's gonna work?"

Izuku let out a choked huff of air, his hand coming up into his long locks, and Bakugou shot him a sideways glare. Izuku had seen people go out this way. He supposed everyone had, at some point. It was always the same: you got bit, you died, you came back. Izuku knew enough about zombie lore to realise that even after cutting his arm off, the chances of Sero recovering were likely slim to none. But the hope in Kaminari's voice, the way Mina stroked Sero's hair, the way Kirishima could tear his eyes away from his friend's face, Izuku didn't have the heart to say it, to say anything. He could let them hope. At least for now.

"We need to keep moving," Bakugou said. "It's not safe out in the open like this."

No one said a word as Bakugou walked to the front of the vehicle, still blood-soaked, as he dropped into the driver's seat and put his foot on the gas.

They drove for another couple of hours, Bakugou refusing to take a break as they sped down the motorway, his eyes darting to the side mirrors and insisting that he wasn't stopping until there was a *'fuck load'* of miles between them and the city. The rest of them tended to the man, taking it in shifts to support his head and wrapping blankets around him to keep him warm, his body shivering even in the summer heat. He still hadn't woken up, both a blessing and a curse the way that Izuku saw it. All they had was ibuprofen; there was nothing in their arsenal that would be strong enough to help Sero cope with the pain if he woke up again. *When* he woke up again, Izuku tried to remind himself. Izuku wasn't a medical professional, though he did have a fairly good understanding of these sorts of things, and he knew enough to know that the fact that Sero hadn't woken up yet wasn't good news. Not when his stump was still weakly seeping through the fresh layer of bandaging and towel, and they still had no way of performing a transfusion. Sero had lost a lot of blood, too much blood, and when the infection finally started to set in... hell, it was a lot for anyone to tolerate. For now, all they could do was wait. Wait and keep him warm.

Finally, Bakugou called back to them, pulling them off of the motorway and down a side road to a service station. Frankly, it was a miracle they had managed to make it that far; the roads were close to blocked with abandoned vehicles, evidence of the desperate attempts people had made to find somewhere safe when this had all gone down. The road to the station was even tighter, and Bakugou had been forced to take them off-road on several occasions before they pulled up beside the gas pumps.

"How is he?" Bakugou asked, joining them in the back of the RV. Kirishima, whose turn it was now to support Sero, looked up at him, his face sullen and broken.

"He still hasn't woken up," he said. "And, uh... he's got a fever."

Bakugou's face twisted up, the rest of them looking towards Sero. They knew what that meant. Izuku had been watching how Sero's breathing was becoming more laboured; the already pale man was now so white that his skin seemed translucent, glowing eerily in the darkened RV.

"He's lost too much blood," he said softly. He was sat on the sofa beside Sero, gently resting the back of his hand against Sero's forehead before picking up his wrist and checking his pulse. "His heart rate is rapid, fevered and clammy; he's probably gone into hypovolaemic shock."

"Hypo-*what*-shock?" Kaminari asked.

"His body is going into shock from blood loss," Izuku explained. "His organs will start to shut down without a transfusion, and even at this stage it... *look*," he sighed, bringing his hand up to his face. "Even without the blood loss, that fever is going to be bad. If we don't do something soon-"

"Yeh, yeh we get how fucking urgent it is," Bakugou snapped. He grabbed his bat. "Right, let's go find what we need. Who's coming with me?"

Izuku got to his feet, and Bakugou's eyes narrowed.

"Not you," he snapped.

"I'm the fastest, and I know exactly what we can make use of," Izuku replied, tiredly. "Or do you want to keep wasting time?"

Bakugou growled before he clicked his tongue against his teeth, kicking the door of the RV open. "Fine, but don't fucking slow me down."

Izuku had to resist the urge to roll his eyes before he made to grab his weapon. He froze, his breath catching in his throat. His knife had been moved to the sink after Bakugou had finished with it, and now that was all he could see... *Bakugou hacking down, Sero's screams, blood and muscle*... He hissed, snatching his hand back.

"Take mine."

He glanced sideways to see Mina holding her axe out to him. He swallowed.

"Thanks."

He stepped out of the RV, seeing Bakugou already several feet ahead of him between the pumps and the small petrol station, swinging his bat to and fro as he walked, and Izuku experimentally swung the axe in his hand. It wasn't a weapon he was strictly familiar with using, but he supposed the principle was the same: hit them with the sharp end. He sighed and jogged to catch up with Bakugou.

"We need a narrow plastic hose, cocodamol if they have it-"

"I know what we fucking need, Deku," Bakugou interrupted. "Just watch out for the fucking biters."

Izuku bit his tongue in favour of staying quiet, not really wanting to deal with another horde of zombies any time soon. They stopped at the door, Bakugou glancing across at him to check he was in position, before he kicked the door open with his boots, the sound far too damn loud and echoing around the entire station. They paused, waiting, listening, before Bakugou was satisfied enough to take a step into the station.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" he snarled, kicking an empty box away from him in frustration.

The station had already been ransacked. If Izuku had hoped that maybe the station would be relatively untouched due to its location, then he really hadn't fully considered just how many people would have abandoned their vehicles back on the motorway and gone searching for somewhere safe. Any food had long been taken, the shelves all but bare, with half of them having been

knocked over. Even the shelves behind the counter were empty; the only thing left was old, fading magazines.

"I know it's unlikely, but see if you can find any pain relief," Izuku sighed, looking dejectedly around the store. "I'll look for the rubber tubing."

Bakugou grunted, kicking aside more clutter as he climbed over the shelves and towards the counter, Izuku heading to where the hardware section could be found. It wasn't a big store; in truth, he wasn't sure if it was the kind of thing that he would find there, but much to his relief, as he dug about through the shelves where anything that could have been used as a weapon had been taken, he found it. A five-metre-long length of rubber tubing. He breathed out a sigh of relief, immediately placing it into his pockets before looking to see what else he could salvage.

"No painkillers," Bakugou said, as he climbed back to him, before he paused. "What the hell are you doing?"

Izuku looked up from where he was digging through the discarded pile of sanitary products, shoving as many packs of sanitary towels into his backpack as would fit.

"Surely Mina needs them?" he said, quipping Bakugou an eyebrow. "Eighteen months with Ochako and Tsu, I just got into the habit of grabbing them when I saw them. Plus, they're absorbent," he shrugged. "They'd be better for Sero than those thin bandages we've got, and we'll eventually run out of towels."

Bakugou frowned down at him before he grunted again. It was then that Izuku looked down at what Bakugou had curled up in his hand. "Uh ..?"

Bakugou glanced down, then sighed. "Sero likes to pretend he only wants these things because of the crosswords in the back," he said, waving the curled-up mag, upon the front of which was just visible the unmistakable image of a woman in her underwear. Izuku hummed, unable to stop his lips twisting into a cruel smile.

"Right, and you pretend you only want them because Sero likes them?" he said. Bakugou gave him a weird look before he launched out, hitting Izuku around the back of the head with the magazine. Izuku yelped and covered his face.

"I'm fucking gay, you judgemental shit stain," he snapped.

That shut Izuku up, his breath catching in his throat, daring to peek up over his arms at Bakugou's face, but the man had already stalked past. For a moment, Izuku couldn't move. Bakugou was gay. That gruff, angry, sweaty, yet agonisingly beautiful man was gay. *He also tried to kill you*. Izuku winced. *Ok, enough of that*. He was not so fucking weak and horny that he would so quickly go back to fantasising about biting his way down those huge shoulders and biceps so soon after he'd tried to goddamn strangle him to death. He still had some fucking self-respect. Right?

He got to his feet, keeping his back turned from where Bakugou had stalked off, knowing that his face was probably far redder than it needed to be. He zipped up his backpack and hooked it over his shoulders, pausing to take a final glance around the store before walking back to the RV.

"Did you get everything?" Kirishima asked the second they stepped back into the vehicle, and Izuku pulled the tubing from his pocket.

"Got what we needed for the transfusion," he said. "But the place was cleared out. No medication at all."

"Crap," Kaminari muttered.

"Someone grab the needles," Izuku instructed, and Mina immediately set to work digging through their medical supplies. "Some duct tape. And, I guess the biggest question is, does anyone know Sero's blood type?"

"No, but I'm O negative," Bakugou replied, and then, for some reason, everyone in the RV seemed to freeze.

"Katsuki, are you sure that's a good idea?" Mina asked, turning from her place by the sink, holding the syringe packages in her hand. Izuku looked around, confused.

"What? Why? Why wouldn't it be?" he asked.

"Unless anyone else is a universal donor or knows his blood type, then what else we supposed to do?" Bakugou replied firmly, ignoring Izuku as he took his place beside Sero, holding his wrist forward. Izuku's mind raced.

"Look, if you've got ... Hell, if you've got HIV or-"

"What, I'm gay, so I must have fucking AIDS?" Bakugou yelled, his face flushing furiously.

"No!" Izuku yelled back, angry and incredulous. "Of course not, but if there's something wrong with your blood then I need to fucking know about it before I give it to Sero! If something goes wrong I need to know what to do!"

The RV fell silent, Bakugou just glaring back at him, before he let out a long heavy breath. He got back to his feet before he was wrenching his khaki vest up past his midriff and twisting to the side.

Izuku's mouth dropped. There, upon Bakugou's side, was probably the ugliest-looking scar he'd ever seen, deep indents in the skin that looked way too much like teeth marks to be anything but. It was wide, like whatever had bitten him had really intended to wrench his kidney out, the skin surrounding it a deep purple, it having healed unlike any wound he had seen before.

"Wh-what the *fuck?*" Izuku yelped, and his damn insatiable curiosity and desire for answers seemed to overtake any self-preservation and common sense he might have had remaining. He stepped forward, his hand reaching out to touch the purple skin.

"Oi!" Bakugou snapped, jerking his body away. "I didn't say you could fucking touch you creepy little perv-"

"How long ago were you bit?" Izuku interrupted. "Are the scars on your head from the same zombie? How long after you were bit did you start running a fever? Wait, did you even get a fever? Wha-"

"Holy shit, shut up!" Bakugou yelled, shoving his tank back down, his face looking oddly flushed. "Fuck, you have no idea when to stop talking, do you?"

Izuku hesitated, his face heating up when he realised that not only had he just charged on over and put his hands on Bakugou's waist without permission, but he was also muttering out loud again, a

habit that he had tried hard to kick when the ability to stay quiet was often the difference between getting lunch and being lunch. He coughed awkwardly, rubbing his hands against his khaki jeans.

"Uh, sorry," he muttered, knowing that he was blushing. "Just, uh, you know, *kind* of a big deal! But, wait... I don't know what that means for Sero! I mean, you're not a zombie, at least not as far as we know-"

"I think we'd fucking know," Bakugou snapped.

"Not necessarily; maybe you're only partially infected? Like, you're a carrier or something. I mean, it could explain why the zombies always seem so much more interested in you over us, and maybe that's why you're so aggressive all the time? Like-"

"Uh, Midoriya?" It was Kirishima now, his eyes darting warily between him and Bakugou, who was looking at Izuku like he wanted to murder him again, the man's jaw clenched and his teeth grinding together audibly.

"Sorry," Izuku repeated. "Maybe you're not a carrier; maybe you're just... immune? It's the infection that kills most people, unless they have mortal wounds from the attack, and I've seen some people turn seconds after their heart seemed to stop beating, making me wonder if some of the infected turn before death. So, if you have an immunity to the virus, whatever it is, then that could explain why you survived the bite-"

"Get to the fucking point!" Bakugou roared, his hands visibly clenching and unclenching as he obviously tried to hold himself back from attacking Izuku again.

"I'm just saying this could either be really good for Sero or really bad," Izuku replied, rubbing the back of his head. "I need you all to understand that before I do this. And I need to do it now."

"Just get on with it," Bakugou said, dropping back onto the chair and thrusting his wrist forward again. Izuku glanced at the others, who each nodded, Kaminari looking down at Sero's pale face, his breathing audibly rough.

"Ok," Izuku said, before he took the syringes from Mina. "I need a clean knife, or scissors or something."

Bakugou huffed in irritation before pulling one of the knives from his many holsters. Izuku looked down at it doubtfully.

"I clean my weapons every fucking day," Bakugou snapped, waving the knife impatiently. "And I haven't used this one."

Izuku took it from him before he started to unravel the tubing and cut it down to a more manageable length.

"Antiseptic wipes," he requested, holding a hand out, and Mina passed them to him. He set about cleaning a patch of Sero's inner elbow with the wipe before he pulled off his own belt and wrapped it tightly around his bicep. He then moved across to Bakugou, hesitating only a heartbeat as he felt rather than saw the way the man's lips curled, and he cleaned his wrist. He then threaded the needle of the syringe into the tubing, pressing hard against Bakugou's forearm as he felt for a vein.

"Sharp scratch," he said, and Bakugou snorted before Izuku was pressing the needle in. "Can you hold it?"

Bakugou pressed a thumb down on where the needle had sunk into his skin, Izuku tearing away some duct tape before taping the needle and tubing down. Then, moved onto Sero, grabbing the other side of the tubing, watching as Bakugou's blood began to flow through it, and waiting until it dripped from the end before slipping the next needle in. Sero's veins were faded and hard to find, and he grunted in frustration as he felt along the inside of his elbow, searching. Eventually he found one, and he stuck his tongue through his lips as he pressed the needle in, hoping that the damn thing wouldn't collapse on him. But finally the needle was in, and Izuku taped it down before letting out a huge shaky breath, falling back into his rear, finally letting his hands shake as violently as they had been threatening to the entire time.

"That was impressive, Midoriya," Kirishima said, smiling at him. Izuku nodded faintly.

"Let's just hope it isn't too late and that we got the arm before the infection had a chance to spread," he said. He looked over at Bakugou. The man was oddly quiet again, just watching the blood pass from his wrist and into Sero's arm almost as if he was watching a zombie get closer, the doubt and apprehension clear on his face, and Izuku was full of so many questions. How long ago was it that the man had gotten bitten? Had he fought the fever like everyone else, or had he simply not gotten sick? What did that mean for Sero, and... *Had he just made a terrible mistake?*

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 8: Dead Last

Chapter Summary

In which Sero wakes up and everything changes ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They decided to stay put for the rest of the day after that. Bakugou wasn't keen on the idea, but with Sero being in the state he was and Bakugou still needing to give blood, they decided that it probably wasn't a good idea to be driving into the unknown just yet.

To the relief of the entire group, Sero had begun to get some colour back to his pallid skin. No one knew if he would survive just yet, and his breathing was no less harsh than it had been, but Izuku considered it a promising sign. He wasn't a doctor, but he'd still had advanced first aid training, and it was clear he knew more about the human body than the rest of them; as such, Izuku had found himself Sero's unofficial doctor. He kept an eye on his temperature and heart rate throughout the day, pleased with how easy the blood transfusion was going. But Bakugou couldn't give all his blood away, and despite his protests, Izuku had needed to unhook Bakugou's needle partway through the day. They didn't have a huge amount of supplies, having needed to leave far too much of it behind, but Mina had still insisted that Bakugou eat more than his usual share to get his strength back.

After that, all they could do was wait.

Night fell before anyone broached the subject of moving. So far they hadn't been bothered, but an RV parked up outside of a petrol station could be far too tempting a target for anyone who might pass by, so it was decided that they would take it off-road. That in itself was risky; outside of Kaminari fretting that they would get stuck, they also lost quite a bit of visibility of the road around them. Kaminari had taken to sitting on the roof of the RV to keep watch, whilst Izuku tended to Sero. The others watched Bakugou stubbornly fight off sleep despite how exhausted he clearly was before he finally dropped off with his head against the front seat, still scowling. Mina fell asleep not long later, Sero's head in her lap and her mouth open as she snored lightly, leaving Izuku and Kirishima alone.

Kirishima had hardly taken his eyes away from Sero the entire day. He sat watching Sero's face and the way his chest laboured, each breath bringing relief before plunging them back into anxiety with each ragged exhale. Izuku leaned against a cupboard, exhausted but no more able to sleep than Kirishima could.

"I dunno why we're doing this."

At first, Izuku wasn't entirely sure that Kirishima had spoken, his voice so quiet and fragile that it could have just been the breeze, but the single tear leaking down Kirishima's cheek was enough to confirm the contrary. Izuku sat forward, focusing on the man.

"What do you mean?" he asked, his voice just as quiet, just as soft.

For a long moment, Kirishima didn't reply. Just watching Sero breathe, before his lips parted with an audible gasp.

"I just... *is this cruel?"* he asked. His red eyes looked over at Izuku, and he could see the pain in them, the agony. "Letting him carry on like this when-"

"He's looking better," Izuku offered, as Kirishima trailed off. "People survive amputations all the time."

"It's not losing his arm that's worrying me," Kirishima replied, and Izuku sighed.

"I know."

There was silence for a while longer, the two of them watching Sero breathe in and out, before Izuku finally found the courage to speak.

"Bakugou survived it," he said, hardly daring to talk louder than a whisper, with the man in question asleep not twenty feet away on the front seat.

"Yeh," Kirishima replied, glancing across to where the man was sleeping. "But he's... hell, you know how he is. The Grim Reaper turned up at his door, and he just told him where to go, you know?"

"What happened?" Izuku asked, before he could stop himself. Kirishima glanced up, chewing on his bottom lip.

"I... it's not really my place to say," he replied apologetically. "I think some of us just try and forget it. But he got sick, like everyone who gets bitten, and we thought he was going to die. But he didn't, and I don't know what that means, but he hasn't been the same since."

"You mean he wasn't always like... uh, *this?"* Izuku asked, and to his surprise, Kirishima laughed.

"Oh no, he's always been a hothead," he said, smiling honestly for the first time in days. "But the drinking? The mood swings and stuff, that's all new."

Izuku fell silent. He supposed having a zombie try and bite a chunk out of you and almost dying would probably have some impact, but it didn't seem to explain the severity of Bakugou's issues.

"That doesn't mean Sero will have the same problems," Izuku offered. He got to his feet, padding over to the man, placing the back of his hand on his forehead. "In fact ... I think the fever's starting to break."

"What?"

Kirishima was on his feet in a heartbeat, reaching past Izuku so he could feel for himself.

"Holy shit. Holy shit, you're right!"

Izuku smiled, placing a hand on his shoulder.

The following morning, Sero finally woke up.

It was with indistinct mumbles at first, his head tossing and turning before his black eyes opened, confused and hazy, and Mina immediately placed her hands on his cheeks, stroking gently.

"Hey, it's ok," she said. "You're ok."

Sero squinted up at her before he grimaced, breathing in sharply and looking down at his arm. Izuku was at his side, checking his heart rate and temperature.

"Hi Sero," he said. "How you feeling?"

"Like someone cut my arm off," Sero replied hoarsely, before he managed a weak laugh, dropping his head back into Mina's lap. "Thirsty. Where are we?"

"Somewhere safe," Kaminari replied, as Izuku hurried to get Sero some water. "Bakugou's on the case."

"Hey, Hanta, how are you feeling? Really?" Kirishima asked, his face a picture of concern.

"Tired," Sero replied honestly. "My arm hurts." Izuku offered him the glass, supporting it as Sero drank, swallowing the water gratefully. "Ahh, that's the stuff."

"Do you feel hot?" Izuku asked. At that, Sero hesitated. He looked down at his arm for a long moment before sighing.

"Yeh."

Izuku reached up to his forehead again. It wasn't as bad, no question about that, but the man still had a temperature.

"So, I'm infected, right?"

"We don't know that," Mina replied immediately. "Katsuki acted quickly, and we don't know how quickly this thing spreads."

"And your fever has improved," Izuku offered. "Nothing is set in stone yet."

Sero nodded, but the set of his jaw and the faraway look in his eyes were telling enough.

"If I get worse you gotta take care of it," he said, his voice shaky yet firm.

"Hanta-"

"I mean it," Sero interrupted, looking over at Kirishima. "I'm not turning into one of those things."

"We don't have to think about that right now," Mina said firmly. "You're ok. You'll be ok. Just keep focusing on getting better. Ok, sweetie?"

Sero looked unconvinced, but he gave in, letting out a sigh.

"I'm going to go let Bakugou know you're awake," Kaminari said, getting to his feet. Izuku dug around for some of the ibuprofen they had remaining, holding it out in offering before Sero nodded stiffly.

"Are you in much pain?" Mina asked, and Sero managed a shrug.

"I guess. It's fine, probably not as bad as you'd think."

"That's good," Izuku muttered, placing the pills into Sero's mouth and holding up a glass to drink from. There was the sound of heavy boots on metal from outside of the RV before the door opened, Izuku glancing up to see Bakugou walking in, his expression tight and hard to read as he looked at Sero.

"Man, I ain't mad at you for cutting my arm off."

"Better not be," Katsuki grunted, but Izuku could see the tension ease from the man's shoulders before he stepped closer. "How you feeling?"

"Fine," Sero sighed, rolling his eyes. "Be better when you all stop asking me that."

"Ooh, grumpy Sero," Mina laughed, before reaching around and flicking the end of his nose.

"Just keep taking things easy," Izuku said. "All we need you to do now is rest."

Sero continued to improve throughout the day, his colour returning and his energy levels improving. Izuku wasn't naïve enough to believe Sero was out of the woods just yet; after all, there was still the question of his fever, which lingered despite him otherwise feeling better. There was also the fact that none of them had any idea what Bakugou's blood might do to him.

Izuku had been almost entirely focused on Sero, but he still couldn't help but linger on the elephant in the room: Bakugou. Specifically, Bakugou's bite. How and why he survived it was a question that ran laps around his head. Izuku was curious by nature; he craved answers like a starving man craved food, and the apocalypse turned out to be quite the tantalising, if not traumatising, mystery that he was desperate to solve. He'd passively studied the zombies at any opportunity he got over the better part of two years, and he had come up with a few theories of his own in that time. But Bakugou was the first person he had heard of that had survived a zombie bite.

There was always that hope it was possible. After all, who wouldn't be holding out hope that somewhere out there there would be an immunity growing to the virus that had killed off most of the population of Japan, if not the entire world? With any other virus, you would expect to see some that fought it off better than others, but the zombie virus wasn't like anything Izuku had studied before. It seemed as though it could not be stopped.

There wasn't a lot known about it, but Izuku had observed that a person needed to fit the following criteria to become a zombie: first, they needed to be infected prior to death. In the early days of the outbreak, Izuku had sat huddled in Iida's room with his friends, watching the news in horror as panicked people took to desecrating shrines and burning graveyards. They set fire to mortuaries and protested outside of hospitals, calling for all bodies to be cremated regardless of religion. Most people were so caught up in popular zombie lore that they didn't consider much else. As it turned out, it was only those that were infected prior to death who turned into zombies, and the dead were not rising from their graves.

The second criterion was that the person needed to have their brain mostly intact. Izuku had landed more than his fair share of bad blows to realise that it wasn't enough to just damage the brain; a concussion did nothing to a zombie. Instead, it needed to be pierced or crushed entirely, or the

zombie would just get right back up again. How a person became infected was another matter heavily debated. It was clearly bloodborne, and if you managed to get an infected person's blood in your mouth and ingested it, then you would become infected too. If you were bitten, and their saliva entered your bloodstream, that was a guaranteed route of infection, and it was discovered that it could also be transmitted sexually, at an alarming rate.

How the first person became infected wasn't known, at least publicly. But before long the undead were walking, and they were hungry.

From the little that Izuku knew, he had a few theories about Bakugou. Kirishima told him that he had gotten sick, just like anyone else who was infected, which meant that he almost certainly had the virus at some point. Bakugou had perhaps been infected by a mutated version of the virus, or maybe he had the antibodies to fight it off, which meant that he was either still infected or he was immune. If he was immune, that would suddenly make Bakugou the most valuable goddamn person on the planet, *but if he was still infected?* Then he became just about the most dangerous.

As much as it pained him, Sero had become the perfect guinea pig to test these theories. If Sero continued to get better, then it would be a fucking miracle, and absolutely everything could change. But if he got worse, then it would mean that Bakugou still carried the virus and that perhaps it was still killing him. Izuku could only pray for the former.

It was hard not to be hopeful when, by the third day, Sero was sitting up and walking, eating his meals with the rest of them. His wound looked nasty; it was nasty enough that Sero had trouble looking at what was left of his arm. But it was healing, and from what Izuku could see, it wasn't becoming infected either. Sero did still have a low-grade fever, but nothing to stop the group from feeling optimistic, and the relief was palpable. They had decided to keep driving, running low on supplies and hoping that they would be able to find more of the many abandoned vehicles along the motorway, and Kaminari had been all too eager to get going. He hopped into the front of the RV, grinning broadly as he reached into the glove compartment.

"You want someone to hear us?" Bakugou snarled immediately, but Kaminari just poked his tongue out at him before selecting a CD and sliding it into the player.

"Let him have his fun," Sero laughed, and Bakugou softened a touch, scoffing and throwing himself onto the seat beside him without fighting him on the matter. Izuku took the passenger seat beside Kaminari, who winked at him before turning the key in the ignition, the speakers blasting out immediately. Bakugou groaned in irritation as the RV rolled forwards over the undergrowth, the building beats of *Guns N' Roses* sounding out as Kaminari drummed his hands on the steering wheel.

"It's too fucking loud!" Bakugou yelled, and Kaminari turned in his seat, staring Bakugou dead in the eyes as he turned the stereo up another notch and doing a frighteningly good impersonation of Axl Rose as the lyrics started up.

"*Welcome to the jungle; we got fun and games!*"

"Fuck me."

"*We got everything you want, honey; we know the names!*"

"Fucking asshole."

Izuku couldn't help it. Bakugou's face was a picture; Sero himself was holding his stomach with his one good arm as he bent double in laughter. Kaminari was singing his damn heart out and Izuku was laughing along with them. Ten minutes down the motorway, Izuku found himself belting out *Paradise City* alongside Kaminari, drumming on the dashboard, feeling like himself for the first time in months, with the slightest twinge in his heart as he thought about how much Uraraka would have loved this and how much Tenya wouldn't. He heard Sero joining in from the back and glanced backwards just in time to see the smallest smile tug on Bakugou's lips, only for his face to flush and his arms to childishly cross over his chest in the brief moment they made eye contact.

They didn't meet a single person on the road, something that Bakugou was quick to note was a fucking relief considering what *'noisy fucks'* they had been, and as night began to fall, they pulled into a second service station, intent on searching out some more supplies. The condensed traffic and abandoned vehicles were getting less dense the further away they drove from Shinagawa, making their progress a little less stunted. But they were closing in on Shizuoka, a trip that in normal circumstances should have only taken a couple of hours, and predictably the traffic was starting to build up again. It also didn't escape Izuku that they were driving towards his own hometown, something that he brought up when they eventually stopped.

"Do you have somewhere you're planning to go to?" Izuku asked as he climbed to the back of the RV, taking Mina's axe as she offered it to him. Kirishima half shrugged as he selected his own weapon of choice.

"We didn't really have a plan as such," he said. "Other than surviving, you know? Truthfully we didn't plan on staying in Tokyo as long as we did, but it was dangerous on the roads. The house we were in was Mina's grandparents', and it was empty after they went on holiday before it all started... it just made sense to stay where we were until we were ready to move again."

"But I think we had the same thing in mind as a lot of people," Kaminari offered, leaning over the front seat so he could look back at them. "We heard rumours that UA was a safe place, what with all the walls around the damn thing."

"Yeh, that's where we were headed too, my group, I mean," Izuku replied, trying to ignore that pit in his stomach whenever he thought about them. "It's where I studied."

"You went to UA?" Kaminari yelped. "But that place is almost impossible to get into! You must be a freaking genius!"

"O-oh," Izuku said, blushing and noticing the new intensity with which Bakugou was now glaring at him, the grinding of his teeth audible even from across the RV. "I'm not- I wouldn't say *that-"*

"What did you study?" Sero asked.

For some reason, Izuku felt very embarrassed by that question. It wasn't that he was ashamed or anything, but he'd always struggled with the attention that studying at UA got him.

"Uh, I'd just started my masters in forensic pathology," he replied, in little more than a mumble, and sure enough Kaminari's eyes almost bugged out, and Kirishima playfully shoved his shoulder.

"Masters? Nice one, dude, did you fast-track your degree or something?"

"I got a sponsorship in middle school," Izuku replied, rubbing the back of his head. "It's not that great, really!"

Bakugou scoffed.

"Tch, knew you were a nerd."

"Oh, give over, Bakugou, you were studying your masters too."

Izuku looked up, forgetting yet again that it was Bakugou that he was talking to, the man who tried to murder him not three days ago.

"What? No way! What are you studying?"

"Ain't studying anything now, moron," Bakugou spat back. "The hell does it even matter anyway? Let's just get on with this."

He grabbed his bat and pushed past him, Kirishima just sighing and clapping Izuku on the back, before the two of them followed him out.

They were fortunate enough to have a bit more luck this time, grabbing some cans and bags of food that hadn't already been pilfered. It wasn't a lot, but it was enough at least for Sero to have a decent-sized meal that night, setting up the propane cooker outside of the RV so they could heat up the tins of vegetables they had found. Kaminari lit candles around the place, quipping that it made things more romantic, much to Bakugou's irritation and the amusement of everyone else. Sero was still suffering a temperature, something that Izuku continued to be concerned about, though the man was feeling stronger and more than capable of sitting with them on the picnic benches outside the station, the group laughing and joking like there wasn't a care in the world.

Eventually, Sero grew tired, and Izuku helped the man to his feet to take him inside and check on his wounds one last time. In truth, Izuku was starting to lag; it had been so long since he'd had such a positive day, and he was surprised at just how much it took out of him. He thought back to the days before all this. He'd been an introvert; he'd struggled to make friends for various reasons, and he always needed some downtime to recover after any social event. He supposed it had been so long since he'd felt the luxury of that, and as tired as he was, there was a certain contentment in that. A relief that he'd not felt for some time, not realising there was a smile on his face until Sero jabbed him in the cheek.

"What?" Izuku asked, reaching up to touch his face in case there was something on it. Sero laughed.

"Just good to see you looking happy, Midoriya," he replied, before flinching.

"You ok?" Izuku asked, leaning forwards and reaching for his stump, but Sero just shook his head.

"No, it's my other arm," Sero said, sounding confused. Izuku frowned, reaching over and pulling the sleeve back, before his breath caught in his throat. Sero's arm, around the transfusion site, was swollen and angry-looking, as though he was having some sort of reaction.

"Does that mean what I think it means?" Sero asked, his voice quiet. Izuku glanced back up and shook his head.

"No," he said firmly. "It's just as likely an infection from the transfusion. We couldn't fully disinfect everything."

"Right."

"We'll find you some antibiotics," Izuku said, getting to his feet. "Don't worry about it, ok?"

"Midoriya."

"It doesn't mean anything," Izuku interrupted. His heart was racing, but he wasn't going to let Sero panic. It didn't mean Sero was infected. It didn't mean *anything*. Sero was going to be ok.

"Don't tell Katsuki," Sero said, his voice soft. "If it ... don't tell him it's because of the transfusion."

"Sero, I-" He stopped at the expression on Sero's face, and his shoulders sagged. "Ok."

Sero offered him the smallest smile, an action that obviously took effort, before he lay out on the sofa, Izuku passing him the blanket.

"Just get some rest," Izuku said. "We'll figure this all out and find some medicine in the morning."

"Sure," Sero replied, before shutting his eyes. Izuku felt faint and nauseous, his eyes lingering on Sero's arm before he sank down onto the floor, propping himself up with a pillow, the candlelight flickering in an effort to comfort him as he, too, fell asleep.

He was woken by an odd pressure on his chest, like something was hitting his rib cage, left then right, in an attempt to wake him. He groaned and scowled, reaching out to try and bat whatever it was away, before his hand was pressed to his chest with the same movement. He shook his head, forcing his tired and heavy eyes to open to the most curious sight of Sero half on top of him, like he had crawled off of the sofa and fallen, his remaining hand hitting his chest and gripping his hoody.

"Sero?" he muttered. "What is it?"

Sero opened his mouth in some kind of soundless scream before gripping his sleeve and pulling Izuku's arm towards him. Izuku watched in complete confusion, letting his arm be taken before he finally realised that something wasn't right... Sero was opening his mouth further, bloodshot eyes unfocused as Izuku's hand was dragged closer and closer to his teeth.

"Sero?" Izuku cried again before he roughly pulled his hand back, and Sero lurched forwards, falling entirely on his chest and gripping Izuku's hoody so tight it pinched the skin. His mouth snapped shut just centimetres from his chin.

"Shit! *Sero!"*

His yelling finally seemed to wake the others, and Izuku heard Kirishima yelling Sero's name, Izuku gritting his teeth as he fought back the decidedly heavy man currently trying to bite his goddamn face off. His teeth snapped shut right in front of him, the weight of Sero's body forcing Izuku down onto the ground, pinning him in place.

"What the fuck!" Kaminari was screaming. "Sero! What are you doing?"

"Get out!" Another voice was yelling. "Get the fuck out!"

Sero started thrashing harder before a pair of large hands wrapped around his shoulders and wrenched him backwards. Izuku gasped with relief as the weight lifted from his chest before he pushed himself quickly to his feet, scrabbling upwards.

"Sero," Mina was sobbing. "No... he can't be... *no-"*

"Get out of here, Mina!" Bakugou yelled, his face contorted with the effort of holding Sero back, the man twisting viciously in his grip, head twisting in an effort to clamp his jaws down on Bakugou's hands.

"Sero," Mina cried, and Izuku looked over to see Kirishima wrapping his arms around her, tears running down his cheeks as he pulled her away.

"Come on, Mina," he said. "You don't need to see this. We gotta go, ok?"

Mina wept openly but didn't fight as Kirishima and Kaminari both ushered her from the RV, Kaminari shooting Bakugou another look, the man shaking his head.

"I've got it," he grunted. "Just fucking go!"

Izuku didn't know what to do; his heart felt as though it was being torn up into shreds right in front of him as he watched Bakugou wrestling with the body that had once been Sero, now just a thrashing, hungry beast with lifeless, sightless eyes and a mouth wide and hollow and cold.

"The fuck are you still doing here?" Bakugou yelled, but Izuku stood his ground, shaking his head.

"You don't have to do this on your own," he said firmly. He wasn't even entirely sure why he was saying it, why he was standing by the man who had tried to kill him, who clearly didn't even fucking *like* him, but he knew that he couldn't leave him alone to take care of his friend. Bakugou, for once, didn't argue with him as he was forced to throw Sero away from him as he twisted in such a way that his teeth shut just inches from Bakugou's face. Sero stumbled, landing face forward against the sink, feet slipping as the fresh blood seeped freely from the ragged and beat-up stump of his arm. Bakugou, panting heavily, backed up beside Izuku, pulling his last remaining knife from his utility belt.

"I can do it," Izuku offered, but Bakugou just shook his head, keeping his gaze fixed on Sero as he climbed back to his feet, head angled up as if sniffing the air, remaining arm lashing about and reaching for purchase. The action caused his sleeve to catch, ripping it and revealing the large series of purple and black bruising that spread out from the inside of his elbow, and Izuku felt like he was going to vomit.

"I can do it," he repeated, firmer, knowing that there was no way that Bakugou had missed it. Bakugou didn't answer, and Sero started to advance again, fingers scrabbling and feet slipping on the blood.

"Bakugou!" Izuku said urgently, looking over at him. But Bakugou wasn't moving. His hands had dropped to his sides, the knife clattering onto the floor, his face blank. Izuku swore, and even as he made to grab for the knife, he realised there would be no time; Sero had thrown himself forward again, purple arm reaching out, and the only thing Izuku had time for was to get Bakugou out of the way, grabbing the man by the back of his top as he threw both of them to the door of the RV. There was a crash, the sound of metal banging, and Izuku looked back, watching in horror as Sero kicked a canister of propane forwards, watching almost in slow motion as one of the candles fell.

"Go!" he was yelling, pushing Bakugou forward, but they weren't fast enough; they were too close. Sero's foot came down on the canister, and Izuku threw himself over Bakugou to shield him as the world exploded, pain shooting up his body as they were thrown through the air.

Chapter End Notes

I hope this chapter helps to answer a few questions related to Bakugou's 'immunity' to the virus... he isn't immune to it at all, rather he is a carrier who hasn't turned. Mystery time.

Also... I am sorry about Sero. But how can it be a true zombie flick without losing characters we love? I debated a lot about who it would be, but ultimately Sero's loss would impact the group the most and push the story in the direction I wanted... I am limited on what I can say without spoiling anything, but his close friendship with Kaminari is important, and aside from Izuku he was the only one in the group with any real medical background, losing him is going to be rough.

(To clarify that last point, Bakugou had no idea what he was doing when he cut Sero's arm off. Now that's a scary thought).

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Chapter 9: Undead of Night

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Bakugou face the aftermath ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku couldn't hear a damn thing over the ringing in his ears. Couldn't see over the bright spots obscuring his vision, couldn't smell over the scent of gas in the air, couldn't speak over the ragged coughs that broke from his chest. He wasn't aware of a goddamn thing except confusion and pain, his lungs burning, and his right arm feeling as though it was on fire. Hell, it well could be, for all that he knew, and he only coughed harder, his fingers scrabbling into the grass beneath him in a desperate effort to ground himself.

"-ku!"

He shook his head, blinking back the stars in his eyes. He tried to speak, but his throat stung, and he started to cough again, bent double as the air was expelled from his lungs.

"-ku!"

He grimaced and shook his head, waving with his good arm to try and indicate that he couldn't hear anything the person was saying to him. He then felt a weight on his shoulders, his body lifted from the ground, and he blinked furiously, squinting until he could just make out the colour red.

"-et out of here!" the voice said loudly. He didn't know what else to do, so he just nodded.

“-you walk?"

He shook his head this time.

"Can't h-" he started to choke; his lungs burned so damn badly. He only slightly resisted as he was bodily pulled up from the grass before he felt lightheaded for a moment, as if he was in the air, and he felt a firmness against his chest, something wrapping beneath his legs.

"-old on!"

He caught enough to grip tight, his arms wrapping around the shoulders of the person carrying him, legs hooked around their waist, before they started to move. But the pressure, the movement, was too much, and hell did his arm fucking hurt, and he yelled out. What the hell? *What the hell?*

"You gotta shut the fuck up, Deku!"

The ringing was starting to fade, enough for him to finally recognise the man yelling at him and which firm chest was beneath his shaking hands, only having the smallest moment to wonder at

how *strong* Bakugou was before his thoughts were replaced only with hot-faced embarrassment at being carried. He blinked, turning his head, squinting back behind them where a huge plume of smoke was rising into the air, fire billowing as the RV burned, shrapnel littering the entire area. It was such a shocking sight that he almost completely missed the bodies surrounding it, and he understood Bakugou's urgency.

"Z-zombies?" he spluttered.

"We must have been out of it for a while," Bakugou growled back, adjusting Izuku on his back. “The fire attracted them."

"S-stop," Izuku gasped, wriggling in place. Bakugou swore before dropping Izuku unceremoniously on the ground.

"What the hell?" he snapped, rounding on him, but Izuku was grabbing his right bicep, grimacing against the pain. There was no way he was going to be able to keep hold of Bakugou for long.

"I can walk," he said, shaking his head as Bakugou reached out to grab him again. He looked back over his shoulder; the zombies at least seemed not to have noticed them, so preoccupied by the flames, but there were more of them coming, and if they didn't get out of here quick, it wouldn't be long before they had a whole horde of them to outrun.

"Wh-where's everyone else?" Izuku asked.

"I don't know," Bakugou shot back, and before Izuku could stop him, he had hold of his left arm, yanking him forwards. "We'll worry about that when we get some distance between us and the fire."

Izuku nodded weakly before allowing Bakugou to lead him forward, the two of them stumbling somewhat in the dark as they were pushed deeper into the woodland surrounding the station. Izuku didn't know the area well, but he was familiar enough to know that it wasn't going to be hard to get lost here, with mountain ranges just to their right... *or was it their left?* He had no idea, but running blindly into the undergrowth wasn't the soundest idea, if they had any other option to consider. He panted heavily, his lungs still burning from the smoke from the explosion. He desperately wanted to stop and look at his arm, but they weren't nearly far enough away for it to be safe to do so; that very fact was confirmed when Bakugou skidded to a halt, his fingers tightening around Izuku's wrist.

"Shit."

Izuku looked forward, and ahead of them were three or four zombies; it was so hard to tell with them swaying like that, their teeth glinting in the yellow light from behind him. Izuku's hand dropped to his waist before he realised that he didn't have any of his weapons on him. A quick glance at Bakugou confirmed that he, too, was unarmed.

The zombies had spotted them.

“Climb,” Bakugou hissed, pushing Izuku towards the nearest tree, and Izuku could only gawk at him in disbelief. But the zombies were coming closer, and though their progress was slowed by the tangled, tough layer of bramble underfoot, if they didn’t move soon, they would be on them. Bakugou didn’t wait for Izuku to start climbing, and he lifted him and practically pushed him into the tree, Izuku’s hands grasping at the branches. He couldn’t stop the cry of pain when he put his weight on his burned arm, and the zombies began to move with more fervour, their teeth gnashing

and snapping at them. Izuku hooked one leg over a lower branch, still relying on Bakugou pushing him from below, and he gripped onto the trunk with his good arm before reaching out to Bakugou with the other.

Bakugou grabbed it, and Izuku screamed as he pulled with all that he had, his arm on fire and feeling as though it was going to snap under the staring. He knew there were tears leaking down his cheeks, but the zombies were only feet away from Bakugou now, and he heaved. He heaved until he felt his arm cramp and spasm. Bakugou climbing up beside him and his foot slipping just out of reach of the zombies in the last second.

"Fuck!" Izuku yelled, before he started to feel lightheaded, his body swaying dangerously. Bakugou immediately pressed his body against him, pinning Izuku to the trunk of the tree.

"Hold on, moron!"

Izuku panted, peering over Bakugou's arm to where the zombies were crowding, their hands trying to gain purchase on the trunk of the tree, one of them even jumping in its efforts to reach them.

"We- we have to-" Izuku tried, but his words slurred. "Oh... Oh, I don't-"

"Deku?"

"Don't feel so... so..."

"Don't you dare fucking pass out on me, Midoriya!"

"Ok," Izuku mumbled back, not entirely sure what he was even saying, his head so light that he could barely see a damn thing, vision blurring. Bakugou was using his weight to keep them pinned against the trunk of the tree, the bark digging painfully into his back, and he tried hard to focus on that. Focus on the pain, a real tangible thing. His eyes drifted shut, and he shook his head furiously. He couldn't pass out. If he did, he would fall, and he would be eaten. But his arm hurt so much, and his lungs felt like they were on fire, and it was so... *hot*, and he couldn't think straight. Was he hyperventilating? He was gasping, his breath coming out in short pants. Was he panicking? Were his lungs actually on fire?

"I- can't... breathe."

"Then don't say anything," Bakugou hissed. "Stay awake, I fucking mean it!"

Focus on the pain, focus on breathing. Deep breath in, and out... in, and out... he was going to be ok. They were going to be ok.

Bakugou shifted in front of him as Izuku alarmingly swayed again, pushing back harder against him. His body was hard and *hot*; god, it wasn't helping. It was already just too damn hot. Then Bakugou looked down below them, and Izuku felt his breath against his neck, could smell the slight tang of the soup they had eaten earlier. *Focus on the smell.* It wasn't entirely pleasant. No one smelled good any more. Soup, and sweat, and smoke... he leaned his head forward, his forehead connecting with Bakugou's shoulder as he continued to breathe. *Pain and sweat.* His fingers reached out, gripping hold of the fabric of Bakugou's vest, the texture surprisingly soft. *Pain, and sweat, and softness. Breathe in. Breathe out.*

"How you doing there, Deku?" Bakugou asked, his voice rough.

"You stink," Izuku mumbled, still not entirely in control of his thoughts or the things that came out of his mouth. Bakugou tensed before a strangled noise left the man's throat, his chest rumbling beneath him, and Izuku realised it might have been some kind of laugh.

"You don't smell so good either, shit stain."

They stood there for a while longer. The pain in his arm wasn't easing, but he was finding it easier to breathe, his mind finally starting to clear, before he felt strong enough to hold his head up again, looking up. Bakugou was close, still watching the ground and the zombies that hadn't given up on their desperate attempts to reach them, and it felt so *weird*. Up close, Bakugou had the faintest of caramel-coloured freckles dusting his nose and cheeks and fine pale hairs over his chin. There was even a small pimple under the line of his eyebrow; these details were so damn mundane and regular and entirely *un-Bakugou-like*. He looked away before risking a glance below them... there were five of them now; he could already see one of them trying to use the other to gain more height. They couldn't stay here forever.

"I'm ok now," Izuku said, and Bakugou looked back at him, his red eyes narrowed and intense as he assessed him, before he seemed to decide Izuku wasn't talking out of his arse and leaned back. Izuku noted that he still kept him caged in, with strong arms either side of his face, and he hadn't taken all of his weight off of him, but it was enough to relieve some of the heat and give him a little room to breathe.

"What do we do?" Izuku asked. "We'll get tired before they do."

"Lucky for you I wasn't so out of it," Bakugou said. "We're going to have to take them down, no way around it. I thought maybe I could lead them away, but given the fucking state you're in you'll only get picked up by the next lot to walk by us."

Maybe Izuku was going crazy, because that almost sounded like Bakugou was worried about him...

"And we'd be fucked if zombies started munching on our only fucking *forensic pathologist*," Bakugou continued with a derisive snort.

Oh. Never mind then.

"So, how do we take them with no weapons?" Izuku asked dryly. Bakugou shot him an exasperated look before he reached up with one arm, and Izuku was gifted with a fresh whiff of sweat from the man's goddamn armpits, and he had to wonder how he was still attracted to the guy. With a grunt, Bakugou pulled and broke a long stick from the tree and handed it to him.

"We improvise," he explained, before reaching out and snapping his own stick from the branch above them. Izuku looked down at the stick in his hand ... ok, so it was fairly sturdy, and the end had a decent enough point, but it was still a fucking stick, and there were five bodies down there with teeth and nails and desperate to eat him.

"If you're gonna be such a bitch about it, stay up here," Bakugou snapped.

"I'm not being a bitch about it!"

"You fucking are."

"I fucking *ain't*."

"The hell do you call all that fucking backchat then, bitch?"

"Oh, what, you gonna try and choke me to death again?"

Bakugou froze, glaring at him, and Izuku had to wonder how easily it had slipped from his lips, how fucked up everything had to be that he would say something like that almost as if it was a damn joke, like attempted murder suddenly wasn't all that big a deal any more. He smirked at Bakugou's expression, and the blond averted his gaze.

"Bitch," he muttered again, under his breath. "Just stick 'em with the pointy end, genius."

Izuku opened his mouth to hit back with something smart, but he was cut short by the thud at his feet, and he looked down to see that they had worked out how to climb on top of one another, one of the zombie hands now reaching the branch they were standing on. Bakugou responded by crouching down and thrusting down sharply with his stick, the wood piercing the zombie through its not-quite-empty eye socket, the squealch audible even over the thudding and heavy breathing, before it collapsed on top of the pile. Bakugou, the goddamn *warrior* that he apparently was, wasted not a single moment before he swung himself down onto the ground with a light thud, taking several steps back as he raised the stick in front of him. The remaining four zombies turned on him, and Izuku swung down behind them before stabbing into the back of the neck of one of them, yanking it backwards. Bakugou took advantage of this to stab this one through the eye as Izuku grabbed the next.

They worked in a tidy unison, the kind of partnership that could only come from months out in zombie land together, until all five zombies were dispatched, and Izuku and Bakugou were left standing beside the pile of bodies, panting heavily. The smoke still billowed behind them, but the light was dying, leading Izuku to believe that the fire was at least starting to die down. It meant a whole lot of zombies between them and their friends, however, and Izuku knew that they were going to have to wait this one out, at least for a bit.

"We need to find somewhere safe to hold up for a while," he said. "And I really need to get a good look at my arm."

Bakugou looked back towards the RV, and Izuku could see just how conflicted the man was, torn between protecting his friends and avoiding being eaten, but eventually sense seemed to win out, and his shoulders sagged.

"Fuck."

He sighed, then stomped back to Izuku. "I'm pretty sure there's a public toilet or something around here somewhere," he said. "Not much, but it's got a fucking door, so-"

"How do you know there's a restroom nearby?" Izuku asked, trying not to think too much on the idea of hiding out in a toilet.

"My family used to go hiking round here all the time," Bakugou replied. "Come on, we have to swing near the station to get to it, but they should be distracted enough for us to slip past."

Armed with only their bloody sticks and wit, the two of them crawled back towards the RV, Izuku being careful not to catch his burnt arm on any of the foliage as they pushed their way through it. The smell of burning was strong in the air, and Izuku knew it would only make it that much harder to smell any of the dead getting close to them, and with the light levels so low and unsteady, it

made it one hell of a challenge. But walking about in the dark up a mountain was hardly any better an idea, so Izuku stuck close to Bakugou, stick in hand. It didn't take them long to get close to the RV, visible through the treeline. The thing was mostly just smoking now, flames still flickering on the more flammable parts of the vehicle, enough for there to be dozens of zombies, if not more, still milling around and trying to discern whether there was anything alive for them to munch on. Thankfully, as Bakugou had hoped, they were far too distracted to notice them slipping by. Sure enough, down the road a ways, there was an outhouse. The paint on the door had long since started to chip away over the rust; the place looked like it hadn't been cared for for years even before shit went bad, and Izuku tried hard not to feel too disgusted by that. As Bakugou said... '*it's got a fucking door.*'

There was a bolt on the front of it, but the building was in such a state of decay that Bakugou was able to force it open with a well-placed twist of the stick, though it did render his remaining weapon useless afterwards. With an irritated grunt, he threw the stick away from him before yanking on the lock and pulling it free, the squeak of metal loud in the dark of the night. They both froze, looking around them intently, though fortunately no zombies had heard.

"Wait here," Bakugou ordered, as he opened the door. It squeaked again, and Bakugou stepped back, body poised.

"I think we're safe from bog monsters," Izuku muttered, his voice tensing up as a fresh wave of pain spread across his skin. Bakugou threw him a sour look before he stepped in, waving his arm for Izuku to follow.

It wasn't big, but it was more than just a single stall, so there was that. It was hard to see exactly what was there in the dark, but he could make out two stalls, the walls of which were covered in graffiti, and the smell of old stale urine was something that apparently even two years of the apocalypse couldn't wear away. There was a sink area and two large mirrors towards the front, but even with the frosted window above filtering in light from the still smouldering wreck, it was almost impossible for him to make out anything in much detail, and he groaned in frustration.

"Oi."

He looked up to see Bakugou pulling something from his back pocket before striking up a single match.

"You're lucky your ass didn't catch fire," Izuku said seriously, but he still stepped forward in front of the mirror, Bakugou leaning on the countertop and holding the match out for him.

His jacket was pretty much ruined, the denim and the fabric of his hoody beneath singed and torn, the angry-looking pink flesh beneath looking only angrier and redder in the firelight. Grimacing, he pulled his jacket off, folding it perhaps somewhat needlessly as he placed it on the counter, before he attempted to get his hoody over his head, grunting at the pain as he stretched his arm up over his head.

"Oh, for fuck's sake."

Bakugou placed the match on the table, already close to burning out, before he grabbed the hoody and pulled it over Izuku's head, then eased it over his damaged arm. Izuku hoped it was dark enough for the furious blush that spread across his cheeks as a result not to be noticed.

"Thanks," he muttered, taking the hoody as Bakugou thrust it back into his hands, and reached for a second match.

He pulled the singed sleeve of his t-shirt up, leaning in close to the mirror so that he could get a decent look, and his stomach sank. It was a pretty severe-looking burn; the skin bubbled and blistered in areas, his bicep was red raw, and no wonder it fucking hurt. Hell, even the softest heat from the match was enough to aggravate it, and he hissed. He needed painkillers for starters; he was already starting to feel lightheaded again just looking at how badly he had been burnt. But with a wound like that, he was also going to need burn ointment, antibiotics... He didn't know enough about burns to say whether this was third degree or not, but he did know the sepsis risk that came with an open wound like this. And right now, he didn't have anything to clean it with or anything sterile he could cover it with, and every passing minute in a goddamn toilet was putting him at more risk.

"Well?" Bakugou asked, his tone unnecessarily short and irritated given the situation and that Izuku was the one injured, and from saving Bakugou no less. "How is it?"

Izuku couldn't even bring himself to look at the man, just staring at his burn, before rolling the sleeve of his t-shirt up so that it would touch it.

"It'll be fine," he grunted. He was lying, and he was pretty sure Bakugou knew that as well, but right now there was nothing more to be done. They were trapped here, at least until the fire stopped and the zombies outside moved on. He sighed before stepping away from the mirror and dropping down onto the floor against the wall. Right now, he just needed some rest, maybe even some sleep. Tomorrow they could worry about finding their friends. At that thought, however, his heart skipped a beat, and this time he did look over at Bakugou. The blond was staring at him, his brow furrowed like there was something that he wanted to say. He had seen it, seen it as clearly as Izuku had: the marks on Sero's arm. The infection leading from the transfusion site. He knew as well as Izuku did that it hadn't been the bite that had turned him, and with that came all sorts of implications.

"Bakugou," he started, hesitant, but the man cut him off immediately, stepping away from the sink.

"Don't," he said.

Izuku was tempted to push the matter more, but the honest truth was that he simply didn't have the energy for him. He sighed, averting his gaze again before letting his head drop back against the wall, and gradually sleep took him...

"Deku. Oi, fuckface, wake up."

Izuku was less than ceremoniously shaken from a deep, if not fitful, sleep, hell knows how many hours later, starting so suddenly that he lashed out with his good arm. He would have punched Bakugou in the face had the man not been so quick to react, snatching his wrist and glaring at him.

"Calm the fuck down," he snarled.

"What time is it?" Izuku asked, his voice still thick with sleep.

"Early morning," Bakugou replied. "Dunno."

Izuku groaned, his head falling back against the wall again, biting his lip against the wave of pain that spread from his arm to his chest. He was pretty sure that wasn't normal, and he looked down at

the shiny raw burn on his arm, the area blistering and wet.

"You ok?"

Izuku glanced up, and it was hard for him not to feel angry at the look that Bakugou was giving him, almost like he was fucking disgusted with Izuku's display of weakness or that he dared to be injured to begin with.

"Fine," Izuku spat out, before getting to his feet. "Zombies still out there?"

Bakugou's eyes lingered on him for a moment longer before he climbed up onto the sink, peering out of the high frosted window he had cracked open.

"Looks like it. I haven't seen movement out there in about an hour."

"No sign of anyone else?" Izuku asked.

Bakugou didn't answer, just dropping back down to the floor and snatching Izuku's stick from the sink before crossing the room to the heavy metal door. Winching, Izuku stepped closer, feeling decidedly apprehensive as Bakugou slid back the lock, as if he was expecting a crowd of zombies to suddenly push their way through the doorframe, teeth sinking into his flesh like he was butter. Instead they were just met with a disturbing silence. The smell was revolting – burnt rubber and fuel that clung to the air like it would never fade, so thick that Izuku could taste it on his tongue – and he grimaced as he followed Bakugou out of the restroom, thankful at least for the morning sun sitting low in the sky.

"Let's go," Bakugou said, and Izuku followed after him as they walked the gentle incline up to where they had parked the RV the previous night, the smell getting stronger and stronger the closer they got.

The RV was a wreck. The amount of propane still stored in the vehicle had left it a metal-framed shell of what it had been, rubber melted into the ground, nothing familiar about what was left, and Izuku held his good arm in front of his mouth as he tried not to breathe in too much of the fumes. Needless to say, the RV was gone, along with their supplies, their weapons, their fuel... Everything they had was inside that RV, and now they were left standing with just the clothes on their back and the blood-covered stick in Bakugou's hands. Izuku’s heart ached when he thought of the only photograph he had of his friends, now burned up with everything else.

Izuku stepped closer, his feet kicking a few things aside, perhaps hoping that something remained. He heard a noise to his side, looking over to see Bakugou bending down to pull out a charred mass, only the nails sticking out at one end of it giving any hint as to what it had once been.

"I don't see them," Izuku said, looking around for any sign of Kirishima, Kaminari and Mina.

"They'll know to come back here," Bakugou grunted back, shoving his hands into his pockets as his eyes swept the scene. "We'll fucking wait, De-"

Izuku looked over when Bakugou's voice cut off, hand immediately dropping to his waist for a weapon that was no longer there and cursing himself at the action. He swung to where Bakugou was standing, the man staring off away from them, his expression tight and fearful, like something that he had never seen on the man's face before. His eyes followed to where Bakugou was looking before his heart all but stopped in his chest.

About twenty feet away from them, barely distinguishable at first from where it lay beneath some of the rubble from the fire, was a body dressed in a dark sweatshirt, face down in the dirt. Izuku didn't need to be close to know who it was; the dark hair was unmistakable, the body long and tall.

"Wait," Izuku said, instinctually, but Bakugou was already moving, taking large strides towards the body. He hurried after him, his heart hammering hard in his chest, his good arm reaching out to grab at Bakugou's shoulder, not sure why but knowing that he needed to hold the man back, hissing in frustration as his hand was immediately thrown off.

It was Sero. He knew it would be. There was metal piercing through his abdomen, both legs clearly and painfully broken, the explosion having thrown him from the RV as it had done Izuku and Bakugou both.

"They haven't come back," Bakugou said. "They wouldn't have left him like this if they had."

Izuku didn't know what to say, just frozen in place as he looked down at the body of his friend, so mangled and so unreal, yet so clearly him. Then, to his eternal horror, there was a sound, like something scraping over the dirt, and he looked down to see Sero's remaining arm start to shift. *He was still alive... he was still...*

"He hasn't... his brain-" Izuku choked, but before he could do so much as move to reach for something he could use to give Sero's body mercy, Bakugou struck, the stick coming down hard into Sero's temple as his head had started to turn, and the movement stopped. Izuku breathed heavily, eyes flashing up to look at the blond, who had already turned on his heel, walking away so quickly he might as well have been jogging.

They stayed there for the remainder of the day, Izuku sitting on the ground against a tree as he tried to focus on staying conscious. His arm hurt, more than anything had ever hurt before, and he had nothing to help him. He'd elected to give Bakugou space. The man had started digging the grave not long after he had buried the stick into Sero's skull, using nothing but his hands and whatever bars of metal he could find. Izuku had offered to help him, but he'd only been met with a filthy glare and a sneer of contempt as he told him how *'fucking useless'* he would be with his arm busted up like that, and Izuku had stepped back, instead intending to keep watch.

Eventually, it started to get dark. The grave was dug, but Sero still lay where he had been left in the dirt, Bakugou sitting silently half the park away from him, covered in mud, his red eyes vivid in the dwindling light. Izuku didn't need to ask why he hadn't moved Sero yet; he knew that they were both still holding onto the hope that Kirishima and the others would turn up at any moment, and they needed to be there when their friend was buried. But night was getting close, and there was no way that they could stay here much longer, not with Izuku feeling as weak as he did.

Eventually, when Izuku could hardly see Bakugou through the gloom, he was forced to speak.

"We need to get back inside," he said. His voice was so quiet, so hoarse, that he wasn't entirely sure if Bakugou would be able to hear him from where he was sitting, especially as the man didn't respond for almost an entire minute. Then, just as Izuku was gearing himself up to speak again, Bakugou got to his feet, and with effort, Izuku got up and followed. It was in complete silence that Izuku dropped back against the wall, and he was asleep not long after he let his eyes slide shut.

When Izuku woke again, it was with some difficulty, his head heavy and hazy, mouth dry and arm aching so badly he couldn't move it. It was still dark, and it was with his stomach heavy with dread that he looked back down at his arm. The weeping plasma was only getting worse, and it was hard

to tell in the dark, but there was something on his arm that looked suspiciously like pus. If he didn't get help soon, his arm was going to get infected. And if he went into septic shock, he was certain there would be nothing and no one that could save him. He looked around the small outhouse, and his anxiety grew as he realised he was alone.

Would Bakugou leave him? He knew the man wasn't keen on him and had tried to kill him in a drunken rage, but somehow he'd never considered the possibility that Bakugou would just abandon him... Had he simply decided that Izuku would only slow him down? Had he looked at his injuries and realised that there was every chance that he would be dead soon... dead in a world where being dead only made a person *more* dangerous? He swallowed, unable to summon the courage to stand, to call out, or to look out of the door to find that he really truly was alone. After everything he'd been through and all he'd done to survive, was he really going to die all alone in a rusting building smelling of piss? Was this how it was going to end?

After a while longer of sitting there, Izuku finally found the strength to stand, his legs wobbling beneath him as he grunted with the effort of reaching the metal door. It was unlocked, the only way of locking the door being on the inside, and after several deep breaths, he pulled the door.

Hell, he knew it was fucking *heavy* and he was weak, but it was weird how the door just didn't move. He frowned before pulling at it again. No, he really wasn't going crazy; the door was locked. Barred. He heaved, his heart hammering in his chest. No... *no no no*... He'd left. Bakugou had left. And he'd locked him in. He'd abandoned him and locked him in, and he was going to die in here. He was going to die in here because he couldn't breathe; he couldn't–

"B-Bakugou!" he yelled, his voice cracking in panic, his fist slamming weakly against the metal door. "Hey! Ba- Baku-" He was hyperventilating, his body giving out on him as he crumpled back onto the floor, fist slapping against the metal. *"He- hel-"*

There was a loud scream, metal against metal, before a cold breeze flooded into the small space, Izuku gasping it down gratefully, his body shaking.

"What?" came a panicked, frantic voice. "What is it? What happened?"

The relief flooded Izuku's system, so much so that he only felt more lightheaded as he saw Bakugou standing in the doorway, red pinpricks in the dark staring at him.

"I- I thought..."

"Hah?"

"I thought you'd left me," Izuku managed. "I thought you'd left me and locked me in here."

The silence that followed was deafening. The blood rushed past Deku's ears, capable of nothing more in that moment than sitting and breathing, the cold night air so welcome yet so sour with the lingering scent of rubber fumes.

"You think I'd fucking leave you like that?" Bakugou managed, his voice tight, shaking with rage or maybe even fear or something that Izuku couldn't understand in that moment, because his brain was fogging over again, his eyes growing heavy.

"Oi."

"Y-you'd kill me if you had to leave, right?" Izuku managed.

"Hah? Holy *fuck*, Deku, what the *hell*-"

"Don't- don't lemme... don't lemme die like... like this..."

"You ain't gonna die at all!" Bakugou hissed loudly, dropping to his haunches in front of him, and Izuku could hardly make out the details of his face by now, just the red of his eyes, the shock of hair, teeth... snarling teeth…

"Hey, Deku! Fucking look at me."

There was a rough palm against his cheek, angling his face up.

"You aren't going to die, alright?" Bakugou said firmly, but Izuku had nothing left in him, his head dropping to his chest as a blackness swallowed him whole.

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 10: Brainstorm

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku fights for his life ... but there are marshmallows.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Time existed in a custard thick vacuum for Izuku after that. He wasn't even truly aware of who he was, forget where and why he kept drifting between periods of wakeful delerium, flashes of colour, images, sounds and smells all melting into one disorientating moment, his brain feeling like gum bubbling on a hot side walk.

Sometimes he was alone. He thought he yelled out in those moments, thought the hoarse sound could have been his voice but he'd frankly forgotten what he sounded like. The times he woke up and he felt so cold, so alone, he knew that he wanted to beg, to plead. He didn't want to be alone here, he'd rather be dead. He'd rather die than be left here all alone with nothing but the sound of his hoarse screams to keep him company.

Other times, he wasn't. He wasn't alone because he could smell it; the rot, the rubber, the sour scent of death, why was it so close? There were teeth filling his vision, gnashing and snapping, but he couldn't do anything about it. He could only watch, watch before he faded away again ...

There were times when he felt a heat on his body, something pressing against his face, his arms, his chest, and those times his vision was obscured with the colour red, his ears assaulted by screams and whispers. Pleading and cursing. Someone wanted him to live, someone wanted him to die ...

"Why?" the voice would ask. Sounding angry, or afraid, but always broken. *"You stupid fucking Deku, why did you do it? Why would you fucking do that for me? Goddamnit, why?"*

Someone wanted him to live.

That redness was so bright, so burning. It was paired with a hand around his throat, a noise like dying animal, howling it's pain and it's grief.

"Just fucking die then! You asked me to do it but I can't ... I can't ... just die. Just fucking die!"

Someone wanted him to die.

The red was familiar, comforting and intoxicating even when he felt the fingers scrabbling against his throat and a hot wetness falling on his cheeks. It was so familiar, yet why did it feel so alien?

"Take this." There was pressure against his lips, his cheeks squeezed tightly, something small and bitter against his tongue. *"It'll help, Deku. Take it."*

"Kacchan."

Sometimes he wanted to live.

Mostly he just wanted to die.

Time didn't mean a damn thing. Because he was trapped in this vacuum and there was no escape. He was trapped in this hell, this heat. So hot he could hardly breathe, waking up soaking wet yet shivering, his body shaking so violently that he cried out at the way it forced the pain to spread. But the worst of it was the white hot heat where his arm was ... *used to be?* He couldn't tell. But it burned, it burned so badly all he could do was tense against it, his body so contorted and tight each breath was agony.

There it was, the smell again. Thick, putrid rot, he could taste it on his tongue, his mouth inexplicably open, a sharp snapping filling the air as he opened his heavy eyes.

"Fuck!"

The smell grew stronger, he'd vomit if there was anything left inside of him to come back out, and then he saw red again. Soft, glowing.

"Kacchan ..."

He could almost make sense of it this time. He was still so hot, so weak, the pain so great it was cruel ... cruel that he should feel this kind of pain and not be dead. Why wasn't he dead?

"I found some fucking marshmallows. They're shit. Fuck ... preservatives are bad for you, you know? The hell does that even matter? Just eat them."

There was a softness pressing against his lips. He didn't want to eat. It hurt too much. It was always going to hurt. He didn't want to eat, he wanted to die, didn't he? He wanted this to end didn't he?

"Just eat it!"

He relented, lips opening, before his mouth seemed to explode, the sweetness against his tongue leaving him dizzy. It was familiar ... it was strange, but it was familiar, just like the wetness against his cheeks, the prickling in the corners of his eyes.

"Shouto ..."

That was the last of the sweetness, whispered apologies in his ear ...

"Open up, nerd."

It felt real this time. It felt real, and he didn't need the pressure against his cheeks to open his mouth this time, the bitter capsule touching his tongue and he swallowing in reflex.

"M'not dead," he muttered.

"This is the first time you've actually sounded pleased about that."

He blinked, there were thorns in his eyes because hell did they sting, his eyelids tearing back like velcro. But he could see, he could see more than just red at least, a golden hue filling his vision becoming more and more solid with each painful blink.

"Bakugou?"

"About fucking time, nerd," the man said.

Izuku swallowed again, a groan breaking from his lips before he could stop it. He felt like he'd been run over by a goddamn RV, his body so heavy, his limbs so achy, his skin itching with the layers of dried sweat and blood that clung to it, and he'd never felt like he needed a bath so much in his life. But he could move his arms now, and it was with mixed relief and confusion that his finger tips touched his right arm, so convinced that it wouldn't be there ... he tore his gaze away from red and gold and looked down.

"Shit."

His arm was a state. He'd clearly been fighting one hell of an infection, areas of the skin next to black in colour, peeling, dead looking, his arm pitted in places where the flesh had presumably already dropped away.

"Wha ... how-" Izuku croaked. He didn't know what he was asking, not really, but Bakugou seemed to make sense of it regardless.

"I found antibiotics," he said. "I had to leave you here for pretty much an entire day to find them."

Izuku looked up at Bakugou now. He'd been so certain at one point ... so sure that he had left him.

"How long?" he asked.

"Ten days," Bakugou replied without hesitation, and there was a haunted look to his features.

"I'm sorry."

For a moment, he hadn't even realised what he'd said, the apology falling out of his lips so easily, habitually, and Bakugou pulled a face, his brow scrunched up, before his lips curled up into a snarl.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" he snapped. And then there was a rough hand on his chest, gripping the dirty fabric of his sweat stained t-shirt. "*I'm* sorry, alright? I'm fucking sorry that I brought all this down on us! I'm sorry that I tried to kill you, that they only found us because of me, that you almost died saving my ass again, that I killed Sero!"

Bakugou's voice broke, and fear filled those red eyes at the sudden realisation of his outburst, and Izuku was stunned. Not least of all because his head was still thick with fever fog, his body still aching from infection, but mostly because of the tears filling Bakugou's eyes, spilling out and down his cheeks. Stunned because of the way the hand still gripped his t-shirt even has it shook, and despite how weak he felt he wanted to reach out. But even as his own palm reached up, Bakugou seemed to sense what he was doing, pulling away from him with an exaggerated wince, like even the thought of their hands meeting burned him.

"Bakugou-"

"Why'd you do it?" Bakugou interrupted.

"Do what?"

"Fucking save me!" Bakugou cried in a strangled yell, looking manic in that moment. "Why?"

Izuku's breath hitched, his mouth gaping in confusion as he stared back at him, wondering if this was some kind of trick question. *Why?*

"Why wouldn't I?" he replied.

Disbelief etched Bakugou's features, dropping back against the wall, looking at him like he had suddenly grown a second head. "You saw it," he said. "I turned Sero. Me. I'm a fucking monster, I should be dead!"

"But you're not." Every word brought him pain, his body so fatigued, but he forced them out regardless. And he didn't know why he was doing it ... he didn't know why, in his heart he wanted, no needed, for the man in front of him to hear him, *to understand*.

"You're an asshole," he said instead, and it was entirely telling how those words seemed to bring Bakugou some comfort, like he was shifting into something more familiar. "But you're not a monster. I did the transfusion knowing the risks ... I made that decision. You're no more a monster than I am."

"You're fucking stupid if you believe that," Bakugou snarled, getting to his feet, the anger returning to his face, the tears dripping down his face an startling contrast to the rage twisting on the cheeks beneath them. "Eat," he spat, grabbing a bag of something and throwing it in Izuku's direction. "I got shit to do."

Izuku didn't know what to say, his heart hammering in his chest as Bakugou turned on his heel and stormed from the outhouse, swinging the heavy metal door shut behind him. He knew Bakugou was hurting, that he clearly blamed himself for everything that had happened, but it still took everything he had not to call out for him, a cold sweat already breaking out over his skin at finding himself alone again. He was no stranger to anxiety, but the deep rooted fear he felt, staring at that metal door, his mind racing and chanting the words *'please don't leave me here please don't leave me'* were something else entirely, and he pulled his knees up to his chest as best he could. He didn't want to die in here ... he didn't ... *he didn't want to* ...

"Why haven't you eaten anything?"

He started. He must have fallen asleep again, lying on his side on the dirty floor, face pressed against a ratty old blanket he hadn't noticed the first time. Bakugou was standing over him again, frown on his face, and tiredly Izuku realised he didn't have the energy to be shouted at any more, just huffing out of breath and staying where he was on the floor.

"'Coz I'm too fucking tired, Bakugou," he muttered, shutting his eyes and hoping that would be the end of it. Instead, he felt hands around his arms, lifting him into a sitting position without breaking a single goddamn sweat.

"If you ate you wouldn't be so fucking tired, Deku," the man snarled. "I may not be a UA genius, but even I know if you don't eat you ain't going to last much longer."

Izuku shot him a cold glare, far too exhausted to say anything else, when a bag of what looked like crackling was thrown at his face.

"I'm not going to have wasted the last ten days keeping you alive only for you to pop your clogs because you aren't eating, so fucking eat."

"Would it kill you to try not being a complete jerk for just five minutes?" Izuku grumbled, tearing the bag open when his teeth after realising he had next to no strength in his bad arm.

"Maybe," Bakugou replied smartly. "Maybe being a jerk is all that's keeping me alive. So, just in case, *fuck you*."

Izuku sighed, his stomach churning in definite distaste as he looked down at the bag of salty pork crackling, the smell of it making him feel decidedly queasy.

"I found plenty of water, don't worry about the salt."

Izuku wanted to say it wasn't the salt that was bothering him, but he couldn't face more back and forth with the guy, just putting a hand into the bag and picking out a piece. It made his tongue burn, but despite the taste and saltiness of it, his mouth immediately kicked into gear, salivating at the realisation that it was food and he probably hadn't eaten much more than what Bakugou had been able to force down him in ten days. He swallowed, Bakugou making a self-satisfied sound, before letting himself sit down, back against the wall.

They didn't speak as Izuku ate, Bakugou just sitting with his eyes shut, one foot out stretched so that it pressed against the metal door in a manner that made Izuku think that those filthy mirages of snapping teeth might not have been part of his delirium after all. Izuku couldn't manage much more than about a third of the packet, his stomach growling threateningly, he hoping that Bakugou would leave that well alone as he dropped it down beside him, but the man didn't even seem to stir at the sound, and Izuku felt as though he could finally ask the question that he had been wondering since he had woken up.

"Where are the others?"

Bakugou didn't respond at first, the minute furrow of his brow the only indication that he had even heard him, before he finally let out a heavy sigh.

"I don't know."

"They didn't come back?" Izuku asked, his voice hushed. Bakugou kept his eyes closed, and shook his head.

"No. I left a sign in case they turned up when I wasn't by the RV," he replied. "Not that it did any fucking good."

"But ..." Izuku swallowed, as Bakugou's eyes opened, fixing on him. "You said they'd know to come back ..."

"They would," Bakugou replied shortly. "The only reason they haven't come back, is because they *can't* come back."

Izuku felt cold despite his lingering fever ... it was unthinkable, it was cruel, it was ... was it not enough that he had lost one group? Had the Apocalypse really taken more from him?

"There are all sorts of reasons why they couldn't come back here," Bakugou said, as if he could read his mind. "I don't know which direction the horde went, but if they couldn't get back here, then they'd carry on with the plan. They'll be heading to Musutafu, so that's where we're going."

"To UA?"

"Yeh, to UA."

Izuku didn't know if it was optimism, as such, but Bakugou at least seemed to be of the mind that their friends were still alive, and sure it was possible. The horde drawn by the fire had seemed big, from the little that Izuku could actually remember from that night, and if Kirishima and the others had been caught on the wrong side of them, then they would have just been driven further and further away from the RV. Not to mention, if something had happened to them ... wouldn't Bakugou have ... wouldn't he have found them? And, speaking of which ...

"What about Sero?" he asked.

Bakugou's eyes darted over to him, a sudden sharp look that held more emotions than Izuku really knew how to make sense of in that moment.

"I buried him."

That explained why Bakugou had left him that night. He knew it probably must have taken a while, must have been hard to move Sero's body in the state that it had been in ... must have been hard to stand there all alone by his grave.

"I'm sorry," Izuku said. "That you had to."

"His death's on me," Bakugou muttered, echoing his broken words from earlier. "I at least owed him that."

For a moment, Izuku didn't respond, watching Bakugou as those red eyes trailed back to the metal door, their light dwindling, and perhaps it was the way the moonlight from outside cast upon his face, but the man looked paler than usual, his eyes lined purple, his brow creased from the effort of maintaining his scowl, and from that angle he didn't look like Bakugou any more. The hollow shadows and the darkness of his eyes making him look like something very different ...

"We need to talk about it," Izuku said. "I know you don't want to, but we can't pretend like nothing has changed."

"I'm not pretending shit," Bakugou shot back immediately. "I know what happened, and I know what it fucking means. Sero turned because of my blood, which means I'm still infected."

"But not dead," Izuku cut in, leaning forward in spite of the pain in his body. Bakugou glared at him again.

"Yet," he said, and when Izuku's brow rose in alarm, he continued. "So, I'm some kind of fucking carrier for this virus, right? If I infected Sero, it means the virus is still active inside me, yeh?"

"Well, yes sort of-"

"Which means it could still be killing me. Just real fucking slowly. It sure as hell don't mean I'm immune to it."

Izuku shook his head. "I don't think so. You'd have symptoms, mild perhaps but you'd have them. Have you felt any different since you were bitten?"

"Of course I've felt different, Deku," Bakugou snapped. "But I've not had a fucking fever since it happened, and I didn't have all those ... marks, that Sero did."

"Different in what way?" Izuku pressed, before he realised that he was *definitely* encroaching upon something personal here, particularly with the way that Bakugou tensed up, his lips shifting into that familiar snarl me made whenever the man felt on edge.

"I don't need to tell you my whole life's story, fucking nosy bastard," he snarled. "Whatever. I get ... headaches. A lot. Never really got 'em before all this happened."

"Interesting," Izuku muttered, before he could stop himself and earning another glare from Bakugou. "I don't think it's killing you, slowly or otherwise, but you're definitely a carrier for the virus. It was theorised at the start that there could be people out there carrying it without even knowing about it, after all it spread so quickly for it to have been by biting alone."

"You can't fucking account transfusions for that either," Bakugou snapped, and Izuku chewed on his thumbnail, lost in thought.

"No, no ... well, it could be transmitted sexually as well-"

"*Hah?*"

"-So that would probably be the most likely way a carrier could spread it if they didn't even know they had it. I mean, how often do you go around biting someone?"

"The fu- go back to that last part!"

"Thing is, being bitten comes with it's own risks, especially if it's by a zombie," Izuku continued, brow scrunching up. "Necrotizing fasciitis alongside the virus is probably going to kill most people-"

"Necrotizing *what*?"

"So really it's incredible that you survived your bite at all! There hadn't been a single case of someone surviving after being bitten, so even if we forget the possibility that there were people infected sexually or via transfusions and not showing symptoms, your case is still entirely unique! I mean, maybe it could go a way into understanding more about the virus and ... UA could help with that! Kacchan, if we get you to UA maybe they can cure you! If it's as safe as Kaminari said then maybe my professor has survived and he can-"

"STOP!"

Bakugou had gotten to his feet now, towering over Izuku and breathing heavily.

"Goddamnit! You really fucking get lost in thought, don't you? Shame you can't be fucking quiet about it."

"Uh ... oh, sorry, I hadn't even realised that-"

"No, *no*," Bakugou interrupted again, leaning down and actually shoving his hand over Izuku's mouth. "Stop. Fucking. Talking. For like, one hot second."

Izuku swallowed, looking up at him, before he nodded, and Bakugou drew his hand back.

"First of all, I'm not a fucking lab rat! I ain't going to UA so I can be ... experimented on, or whatever."

"Experi- oh no, no!" Izuku protested immediately, waving his hands out in front of him. "Professior Toshinori would never-"

"*Second of all*," Bakugou hissed pointedly. "Since when has zombie been a damn STD? Who the hell says it can be transmitted that way?"

"Oh, I guess you must have cut away from the news before we did," Izuku replied. "Yeh, I mean it's transferred via DNA. So blood, or-" he froze, eyes wide. "Oh, oh my god, you haven't- since you got bit have you-"

"No!" Bakugou yelled, his face flushed. "Fuck are you annoying, asking personal shit all the fucking time."

"Oh," Izuku repeated, for what felt like the hundredth time in the last few minutes, and now his own face felt warm. "Uh, well, good."

"Yeh, good to know I can't have sex without *killing* the other person," Bakugou mumbled, walking away from Izuku now and dropping back onto his place opposite the door. Izuku nibbled at his lower lip, feeling entirely uncomfortable because he actually hadn't really considered that either, not until now. I mean, surely that fact alone should be enough to stop his heart racing each and every time Bakugou got close to him with his stinking, sweaty, hard muscled body, as if the insults and murder attempts weren't already enough.

"I, uh, I guess just use protection? You know, double up-"

"Shut up, Deku," Bakugou sighed, raising a hand and twisting his fingertips against his temple.

"Ok," Izuku replied, for once not inclined to argue. They didn't speak again for a moment, Bakugou just massaging his head, Izuku's brain still running a mile a minute, before Bakugou shot him a tired looking glare.

"Thirdly, who the fuck is Kacchan?"

Izuku blinked. "Huh?"

"You kept calling me that when you were fucking out of it with the fever," Bakugou replied. "And you just called me it again just now. I swear to god if that's some stupid nickname you gave to your ex or something-"

"It's not!" Izuku yelped, his face now burning bright red. "It's ... ah, it's what I thought your name was. When we first met, before Kami told me it was Katsuki."

Bakugou blinked, lip curled and eyebrow quipped in confusion. "Hah? You thought my name was fucking *Kacchan*?"

"It could have been a nickname!" Izuku protested, his face still burning. "I- sorry, I hadn't realised I had used it! I'll be super careful not to use it again."

"Good," Bakugou said curtly, crossing his arms over his chest.

"Does that mean you're going to stop calling me Deku?" Izuku asked, testing. Bakugou scoffed.

"No chance. It fucking suits you."

"Well, then I take back what I said. *Kacchan*."

"Don't you fucking test me, Deku!" Bakugou yelled, rounding on him. But loud and intimidating though he might be, the truth was Bakugou was nothing compared to everything else he'd already been through these last ten days and, frankly, he thought he'd earned the right to tease the guy. At least a little.

"Ok, Kacchan," he replied, resting his head back against the wall with a self satisfied smirk as Bakugou audibly raged, his teeth grinding together.

"I could still fucking leave you here, you know."

Izuku just hummed, feeling the weight of his body taking it's toll on him once again. He may be lucid again, but it was clear that it was going to take a little while longer before he would have the strength to start travelling again. And whilst time was rarely on their sides these days.

"Whatever," he heard Bakugou sigh. "Get some more sleep, nerd. I'll wake you up for your next dose of the antibiotics and see if we can give that wound of yours a decent clean."

"Sure, Kacchan," Izuku muttered, smiling at the sound of Bakugou gnashing his teeth at him again before he fell back to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 11: Dead Tired

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku has gotta deal with some burns.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wasn't entirely sure how many more days he spent in that outhouse, drifting between hazy periods of consciousness, and seemingly endless hours of darkness, his fever spiking and dropping in an entirely unpredictable manner, even on his very best of days, but he was getting better. He could feel himself getting better, and the antibiotics that Bakugou brought him were only helping him grow from unsteady strength to unsteady strength.

He was entirely lucid, however, when the time came for them to thoroughly clean Izuku's wound. Bakugou had done his best, keeping it dirt free and applying a solution of pink liquid that he had found inside of an old veterinary surgery, in one of the small villages that lined this part of the country. It had taken Bakugou almost two days to return, or so he said, leaving Izuku to fend for himself for the most part, and it was fortunate that Bakugou came back when he did after Izuku slept all the way through an entire day, forgoing his mediation by mistake. Bakugou had lay into him then, his face burning red with rage as he yelled, and as affronted as Izuku was to feel the spittle land on his cheek, a part of him only felt warmed by the sight ... Bakugou cared. He was shit at showing it, but he knew that he cared deep down. And he was busy reminding himself of that very fact as his back arched and the sweat dripped down his forehead, screaming over the shirt thrust into his mouth.

It became apparent very quickly that they were going to need to remove the necrotic tissue still clinging to the surface of Izuku's burn. He had miraculously been able to avoid going into septic shock until this point, but the more his flesh rotted and died, the greater his risk of developing yet another severe infection. Izuku had a basic knowledge when it came to medical practice, after all he had needed a medical degree in order to begin his masters, and compared to Bakugou he may as well have been a goddamn surgeon; so he knew that the tissue would need to be cut back to healthy flesh. He also knew, pain killers or no, it was going to fucking hurt. His arm was already so tender, it screamed at him whenever Bakugou's fingers had touched raw flesh as he applied the hibiscrub with a cotton pad, and cutting into it would only prove even more painful. Bakugou hadn't once protested when Izuku explained what needed to be done ... how quickly he took action after Sero's bite made it perfectly clear that he was far from squeamish, and somehow he didn't think the man would be so worked up about the idea of hurting Izuku ... hell, a dark part of him wondered whether Bakugou would *enjoy* it. And, though he was inexperienced, the man wasn't stupid. In fact, he was probably the most adaptable person Izuku had ever met, and he listened to Izuku's instructions carefully, red eyes fixed resolutely on his face, or on his arm, as he spoke.

An hour later, they had disinfected their tools ... tweezers, a blade, and surgical scissors that Bakugou had taken from the veterinary surgery, and prepared as clean a surface as possible on the ground beside of Izuku, resting everything in the pot of solution. They'd had to wait for the

brightest part of the day, but even then the lighting wasn't great, and Izuku was angled so that his arm rest in the beam of sunlight coming from the narrow window above the sinks. None of this was ideal, but it was about the best they were going to get whilst Izuku was far too weak to make it anywhere else.

"You sure you're ok with this?" Izuku asked, for probably the hundredth time since he had asked for Bakugou's help with it, and the man shot him a glare.

"Yes, for the last fucking time, I got it," he snarled, reaching out for the packet of gloves before he hesitated. "Shit, you got anything you can bite down on?"

"Huh?"

"For the pain, moron. This is going to hurt like a bitch, and biting your tongue or breaking your teeth ain't exactly gonna help matters."

"O-oh." Izuku looked around, thinking at first of the sticks that Bakugou had started hoarding as weapons, before remembering they were all covered in zombie goop. Bakugou huffed, before he started to yank his tank top out from where it was tucked into his, by now, mostly rust and brown coloured combats and up over his head. Izuku squeaked, he knew he did, the embarrassing sound leaving his lips when he was blessed, *cursed*, with an unhindered view of Bakugou's sizeable torso. It was insane, how could anyone maintain that kind of muscles mass when they hardly ate a single decent meal a day? However he did it, Izuku's eyes were immediately drawn to the dips of the man's stomach as he stretched up, rising up to his pecs as his arms criss-crossed up over his head, pulling the top lose. As if the heat on his cheeks weren't embarrassing enough, he also felt that familiar tug in his stomach, and he was entirely thankful that he had already pulled the dirty blanket over his lap.

"Here," Bakugou said, rolling his tank up before holding it out to him. Izuku swallowed, knowing that the intense way he stared at it to avoid looking anywhere else probably made him look utterly insane, before he realised something.

"Uh ... but ..."

"What?" Bakugou snapped impatiently. "I ain't got fucking cooties."

"No, but you have been wearing that same top for, like, weeks," Izuku said, and his nose creased in distaste because, boy, as hot as Bakugou was he sweat like no one he had ever known before and he dread to think what his damn top would even taste like. Bakugou actually flushed at this.

"You fucking ... shut up! Take it or don't! Ain't my fucking teeth you're gonna be breaking."

Izuku hesitated, before finally reaching out and taking the tank.

"We should probably add more clothes to our list of things we need to scavenge," Izuku said.

"Suck a dick, Deku."

Izuku shot him another look, before putting the shirt into his mouth, grimacing slightly at the taste.

"You know, I think I prefer you gagged," Bakugou said, and Izuku practically screeched over the tank, his mind immediately going places he really rather it wouldn't, but Bakugou paid him no

heed, instead pulling on the latex gloves at his side and grabbing a cotton pad, shuffling forward on his knees so that he could lean over Izuku's arm.

"Gonna sting," he said, before he started to clean Izuku's wound, and sure enough Izuku tensed up against the heated pain that spread over his arm. When Bakugou was finished, he chucked the pad over his shoulder, looking down at his selection of tools before picking up the tweezers and scalpel.

"You ready?" he asked, their eyes meeting again. He wasn't. He could surely never be ready for something like this, but what else could he do? He nodded, watching as Bakugou leaned forward again, picking at a piece of the blackened tissue with the tweezers, the gentle tug of it sending more pain coursing through him, Izuku moaning over the gag in his mouth. Bakugou paused, looking up at him for confirmation, and after three deep breaths, Izuku nodded.

The pain was incredible. It was far more than agonising ... his body already so hyper sensitive to the pain that it really felt as though Bakugou was cutting him open right the way to his bone, and he was very thankful for his sweaty gag as Bakugou cut into the healthier looking pink flesh closer up to his shoulder. The skin was deceptively thick, Bakugou having to make several slices on the same area before finally cutting through the flesh, gradually making his way around the edge of the area of necrotic tissue pumping poison into Izuku's body, and despite the pain Izuku found he couldn't look away, tears streaming down his eyes.

"You doing alright there, Deks?" Bakugou said, still focused on what he was doing, and Izuku managed a soft whimper in response, not daring to move. "Right, cutting from below."

If he thought the pain already was a lot, then it was nothing compared to what hit him next, this time Bakugou cutting into the already damaged flesh beneath the surface, and Izuku screamed, his back arching even as he tried to stay still. Bakugou, give him his due, didn't stop, just angling his body in such a way that he could press his shoulder against Izuku's chest, keeping him as still as possible as he continued to work, cutting through the flesh. Izuku cried and whimpered, in too much pain to feel embarrassed until finally Bakugou moved away, pulling the dead tissue with him, leaving a freshly bleeding raw hole in the surface of Izuku's arm. He acted quickly, packing the wound with cotton padding to stop the bleeding as Izuku's chest heaved, his body slumped against the wall and his head swimming.

"You ok?" Bakugou asked. Izuku nodded weakly, pulling the gag from his mouth.

"F-fine," he stuttered. "Just ... just need a moment ..."

Bakugou leaned back, sitting in front of him, Izuku could feel his eyes on him even as he tried to regain his breath, fighting back the urge to simply pass out after the experience.

"I'm ok," he managed finally. "Thank you for doing that."

"It's fine," Bakugou replied. "I gotta bandage it up, ok?"

Izuku nodded, wondering for a moment at how gentle Bakugou had suddenly become as he reached out to lift Izuku's arm, concentrating on wrapping the bandaging around his wound to keep the pads in place, before the man grunted in self-satisfaction, and dusted his hands together.

"Eat your fucking heart out, Deku," he said, grinning proudly down at his work. "Bet even you couldn't have done a better job." Izuku laughed weakly.

"Let's hope I never have to."

He let his head rest back against the wall as Bakugou got to work tidying up, picking up the discarded dead tissue and inverting his gloves around. He seemed to hesitate for a moment, before holding out to Izuku.

"Souvenir?"

"Are you crazy?" Izuku choked, and Bakugou just shrugged, throwing him the smallest smirk before he started shoving all of the bloody pads and gauze into a plastic shopping bag.

It was hopeless, really. The second Bakugou turned his back Izuku's eyes were drawn to the man again, eyeing the angle of his shoulders, the vest shaped tan lines, the two little dips above the waistband of his pants, hell even in this light the purple bite on his side looked sort of pretty, contrasting with his pale skin. It had been hard enough not looking at the guy when he was being an all out asshole to him, but now that he was arguably being helpful, knowing that he had spent what had to be two entire weeks devoted to keeping Izuku alive, it was practically impossible not to want the guy. Even as his arm burned and his body ached from the tension, he found his mouth watering at the thought of licking a stripe all the way from the dip in his lower back to the sensitive skin behind his ear, shuddering at the chills that ran through him.

"Cut it out," he muttered to himself, and Bakugou looked over his shoulder.

"Hah?"

"N-nothing," Izuku replied quickly, before he picked up the tank top discarded at his side. "Uh, do you want this back?"

Bakugou strode forward, taking the shirt from Izuku's hand before unravelling it out in front of him, looking down with a grimace at the spit dampened patch across the middle of it.

"Gross," he muttered, before bunching it up and throwing it to the side. "Fine, I'll go find some more fucking clothes."

"Like that?" Izuku yelped, eyes widening, glancing down at Bakugou's expansive chest, Bakugou throwing him an odd look.

"What's the problem with that?" he snapped. "You a fucking prude or something?"

"It's not that!" Izuku protested quickly. "It's just ... what about your bite? What if someone sees it?"

Bakugou scowled, looking down at the mark on his side, before huffing again.

"There's no one else out there, Deku, but fine if you're gonna make such a damn fuss about it, gimme your shirt."

"What!"

"I ain't wearing the one you gobbed all over," Bakugou snarled. "Gimme yours."

"But, I need it-"

"You ain't going anywhere!" Bakugou yelled. "And if poor baby Deku gets cold he can hug his blanky. Now gimme your fucking shirt."

"You could have at least asked nicely," Izuku mumbled, before awkwardly pulling his t-shirt up over his head with one hand. Bakugou rolled his eyes.

"Please, Deku, take your damn clothes off for me."

"*Kacchan!*" Izuku yelped, his face flushing bright red, and Bakugou dropped his hands to his hips, raising his eyebrows at him pointedly.

"See, didn't that just make this whole thing a hundred times fucking weirder? Just hurry the fuck up."

Still blushing and feeling decidedly put upon in that moment, Izuku gently pulled the shirt over his bad arm, before he threw it at Bakugou, his embarrassment only rising when it landed pathetically just a foot from him.

"Good throw, Deku," Bakugou scoffed, before snatching it up off the ground, and pulling it over his head. As if Izuku wasn't already in hell, it was pretty apparent that Deku's t-shirt did not fit Bakugou at all, the fabric stretched to it's limit over his chest and arms, and Bakugou groaned irritably.

"Why are you so fucking small?"

"Ain't my fault you're built like a fucking Greek god!" Izuku shouted indignantly, his face so hot now he wasn't entirely sure he didn't have a fever again, and his heart stopped as Bakugou's eyes darted up to his again, his expression entirely surprised and taken back, before a cruel smirk twisted on his features.

"A Greek god, huh? Got something you wanna tell me, Deku?"

"No!" Izuku yelped. "I hate you, shut up!"

"Do you still hate me if I do this?" Bakugou asked, before stretching his arms above his head and twisting his torso in such a way that made his abs pop, and Izuku threw his hands, be damned the pain, in front of his face.

"What are you doing, stop!" he screeched, and Bakugou cackled loudly.

"I knew it. I fucking knew you were about as straight as my damn dick."

"What?" Izuku said, momentarily confused. "It's *not*?!"

"Wouldn't you like to know?"

"*Oh my god I hate you!*"

Bakugou cackled again, Izuku hearing the sound of metal on metal as he kept his burning face hidden in his hands.

"Whatever, nerd. I'll be back in a couple hours."

He looked up just as the door shut, still hearing Bakugou laughing to himself as he made his way up the cobbled path, and groaned. *Fucking perfect*.

Izuku was asleep again when Bakugou returned, and he was woken up by a foot nudging his knee, startling him.

"You sleep like the fucking dead," Bakugou said. "Been nudging you for five fucking minutes."

That sounded like an exaggeration, but Izuku didn't have it in him to argue, only raising his good arm to wipe the sleep from his eyes, and blinking the sleep from his eyes he glanced up at the man standing in front of him, before doing a double take.

"That really the only thing you could find?" he muttered, and Bakugou looked down at the front of the t-shirt he was now wearing, black in colour, with the words *'extra salty',* written across the front of it.

"Yeh, what of it?"

"It suits you," Izuku replied.

"Then you'll love what I got you."

He rustled into the plastic bag hanging from his wrist, before pulling out a white t-shirt, emblazoned with a rainbow and the words, *'sounds gay, I'm in'*, written above and below, and holding it out to him with the straightest face Izuku had ever seen on the guy.

"Are you joking?" Izuku groaned, as Bakugou's face finally broke into a shit-eating grin. "You really couldn't get anything else?"

"It was either this, or *'female body inspector'*," Bakugou shrugged. "I don't wanna fucking know who owned all three."

Izuku flushed, taking the t-shirt from him and glared down at it, willing his face not to break into another beet red blush when he remembered Bakugou teasing him before he left, suddenly entirely unable to look at the man, right up until he heard him groan.

"Ah fuck. You're out, right?"

He glanced up, confused.

"Huh?"

"You already came out?" he said, putting his hands on his hips again. "Tell me I ain't the asshole poking fun at the closeted gay kid."

"O-oh!" Izuku squeaked. "No, *nooooo*, people knew. That is, I came out in high school."

"Thank fuck," Bakugou replied, before he reached back into the bag and pulled out a fresh pair of rather large looking pants and a hoody and dropping them at Izuku's feet, sounding honest to god relieved. Izuku cocked his head to one side, watching Bakugou as he yanked a hoody over his own head.

"Don't tell me you were actually worried you'd hurt my feelings?" he said. At this, Bakugou immediately stiffened, shooting him the kind of look that would have had him quailing just a month ago.

"Don't get ahead of yourself, nerd," he snapped. "Get fucking changed, you had the fucking nerve to complain about my smell as if you don't smell like shit yourself." He threw the plastic bag at him. "Fresh undies in there too, princess."

Izuku flushed again, looking down into the bag before his heart suddenly dropped down into the region of his stomach. It was the most ludicrous, *ridiculous* coincidence. Insane actually, and it was with shaking hands that he pulled out the pair of blue boxers, the name of the old popular superhero *All Might* emblazoned across them in yellow and red, and he was reminded so vividly, so *painfully*, of the very last day he'd seen them. He teasing Uraraka about her getting a pair of All Might boxers for Tenya, she joking that they were for him ... Shouto laughing at the both of them over the walkie talkie, and the dam he had built up suppressing all of the pain surrounding the loss of his friends broke. He dropped the boxers onto the ground, his eyes burning and a great wracking sob breaking free of his lips even as he raised his hands to cover his face.

"What the fuck?" Bakugou yelped. "Jesus, alright, I'm sorry I said you stink!"

Izuku lifted his knees and buried his head in them, unable to stop the wave of emotion from breaking out, crying like his life depended on it. They were gone. Ochaco, Tenya, Tsu ... Shouto. They were gone, no one left to laugh over All Might boxers with. No one left to share marshmallows with. They were gone, just like Sero, and none of them were ever coming back.

"Deku." He heard Bakugou's voice from his side, and he just shook his head, sniffing and coughing, eyes and nose streaming in grief. "Oi, the hell you crying at, hah?"

"They're gone," Izuku managed in a hoarse whisper, voice muffled by his knees.

"Oh," Bakugou sighed. There was a light thump like the man had dropped down beside him, mingled shame and misery causing Izuku to only further bury his head into his arms.

How did you come to terms with the fact that someone simply wasn't coming back? Even seeing Sero's body had made it no more real to him, hell he'd spent months expecting to turn the corner and see Ochaco standing there with her walky and rucksack full of sweets, but it seemed real now. He was alone. He was all alone.

He cried until he simply couldn't cry any more, his eyes swollen and red and sore, his head pounding, the dirty blanket wrapped around him now sodden as well as filthy, and his sobs gradually ebbed out into a heavy silence. Bakugou hadn't said a single word, though Izuku knew he was still sat beside him, and he felt decidedly ashamed to have broken down so utterly and completely in front of the man, especially over something like All Might boxers.

"Feel better now?"

He hiccuped, nodding, before shaking his head, in the end up just shrugging his shoulders and pulling his face out from the safe confines of his knees, blinking back against the light that struck him.

"Sorry," Izuku muttered, and Bakugou tutted.

"Is there anything you won't apologise for?" he chastised, though his voice not unkind. "It's whatever, nerd. It's been a shit couple years."

Izuku swallowed, nodding his head, his eyes drifting back to the underwear on the ground at his feet. Bakugou didn't prompt an explanation from him, but Izuku's mouth started working of it's own accord regardless.

"It was just a stupid joke," he muttered. "The last run we did together, the one where we got separated ... Just," he heaved a deep sigh. "Stupid shit. Ochako picked up some All Might underwear and we joked about it." A broken laugh broke from his lips, surprising him with it's softness as he thought back to that day again. "She called me a *bumhole* or something like that, and Shouto," he laughed again, smiling gently, "he told us to watch our language. And Tenya didn't realise it was him we were really making fun of ..." Bakugou stayed silent beside him again, just listening. "It didn't really matter that the world had fallen apart around us, you know? I mean, it did, but somehow those eighteen months still managed to be the best of my life and ..." his voice choked again, shaking his head. "I grew complacent. We all did, I think. We were running for our lives most of the time but we hadn't lost anyone yet. I just ... took it for granted that I never would. And that if any one them got into trouble I ... I'd be there to save them."

"You can't save everyone," Bakugou said, and his voice sounded rough, haggard. "You try. You'd ... you'd fucking die to save them. But you can't."

Izuku looked sideways at Bakugou, peering at him through his sodden eyelashes, to see the man, subconsciously perhaps, lower a hand to rub at where the bite was hidden beneath his clothes, and surely a little more understanding started to come together. One day he would ask Bakugou about how he got his bite, about the friend they had lost before Sero.

"So ... Shouto," Bakugou then said, and Izuku blinked in surprise. "You said his name a few times when your fever was really bad. Started crying at one point."

"Oh," Izuku said, face flushed in embarrassment. Did he really have to keep breaking down in tears in front of this guy?

"You and him were a thing, right?"

Izuku hadn't expected that, and his stomach jolted in a way that he had lost familiarity with over the last handful of months, the kind of jolt that always came whenever he and Shouto shared a look that lingered for too long, or the man had smiled at him in a way that made him feel like he was being the biggest idiot in the world for holding back.

"No," he replied, at last. "It was ... I guess, there was just always something else getting in the way."

And boy did he regret that now.

Bakugou hummed, almost as if he understood, and Izuku glanced over at him again. It felt weird, talking to Bakugou about Shouto ... what he had with Shouto, or rather what he could have had, felt very different from the confusing feelings he had towards the pensive looking blonde to his left. Shouto was familiar, he had been safe. He was a good friend, he was kind, he was soft and beautiful in all the ways that Bakugou wasn't, and despite a certain dogged determination there wasn't much else that the two of them had in common. But there had never been an instant attraction between him and Shouto. They had been friends for a year before Izuku started to see Shouto a little

differently, and he'd hesitated ever after that for reasons that, this day, he didn't really understand. He tried telling himself that it was only because they were in the middle of an Apocalypse, that living on the run offered so little time and room for a relationship, and yet Ochako and Tenya had managed it. He loved Shouto, *had loved* Shouto, with every fibre of his being, but what stirred inside of him when he was around Bakugou was something entirely different. And it certainly wasn't love.

"What about you?" Izuku asked, keen to keep the subject moving, to step away from the painful memories that plagued him. "Did you have someone before ... all this?"

To his surprise, Bakugou just scoffed a short laugh.

"Nah. Other shit was more important."

Izuku didn't press the matter, instead picking up the t-shirt that Bakugou had thrown at him, huffing a small sigh before he pulled it over his head and looked down at the front of it. It was ironic, perhaps, because right now relationships with other people were now the most important thing in the world ...

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 12: Better Off Undead

Chapter Summary

In which Bakugo finally reveals the origin of each of his wounds ...

Chapter Notes

CW: Blood/violence. Character death, mentions of sexual assault (though it doesn't happen).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two days later, Izuku finally felt strong enough for them to leave the outhouse.

He was still weak. The severity of his infection was certainly the closest that he'd ever come to death, if you didn't count the time he found himself cornered in an alley by a herd of zombies that it, and it had wrecked his body in more ways than he had first realised. His arm, which was still cleaned and bandaged each day, was going to remain heavily scarred, the surface pitted and raw in places, and it was likely going to be weeks before he could finally feel confident that it was no longer an infection risk. But that was far from the end of his problems. Everything about him felt so much slower, sluggish, *weaker* than before; his muscles ached from disuse, he found himself spacing out of growing dizzy at random moments, sometimes Bakugou would need to repeat himself several times before Izuku could make sense of a single word the man had said to him. It was perhaps very telling of how much Bakugou actually felt concerned for him that he only got a *little* pissed off about it. Izuku could walk, which was better than the previous couple weeks had offered them, but hardly for any real length of time. His skinny body was so feeble, so frustratingly pathetic, that not even twenty minutes away from the toilet he'd called home for a handful of weeks, he'd had to stop, palm pressed against the bark of a tree, panting and cursing. He knew he couldn't help it, he knew it wasn't really his fault, but he couldn't help but feel angry at himself anyway ... guilty, even. Embarrassed and frustrated that his body had let him down so spectacularly in a world where being able to run was pretty much the difference between life and death.

To make matters worse, summer was coming to an end. It was still warm, but the sun was rising later and later each day, the leaves on the trees starting to fade from green to yellow, a chill on the breeze that could no longer be ignored. Winter in this region was harsh, and though neither of them had mentioned it just yet, they were both fully aware of how imperative it would be to find some reliable shelter before the colder weather rolled in and snows made survival just that much more of a damn challenge for them.

But fortunately for them, particularly for Izuku, Shizouka wasn't far. It would be slow going at Izuku's current pace, but if they were lucky they could make it there before the week was out, and Bakugou had almost tentatively voiced the thought that, if the rest of the group had survived, they might well be waiting on the outskirts of the region for them. Izuku had smiled at his, an action that

was feeling more and more alien to him as the weeks went by, opting for the sunny optimism he had once been known for.

"I bet you're right," he had said. "We haven't given up on them, after all. They won't have given up on us." Bakugou had merely grunted in response.

And so, after stopping for a short while, Izuku pressing his palm against the soil under which Sero was buried, they had set off with the hope of reuniting with the rest of their friends in the city ahead of them.

It was fortunate that Bakugou had made use of the time that had been spent waiting on whether Izuku would live or not. As ever, his often times handy, if not simultaneously a little alarming, knack for survival had kicked into gear, and he'd had the foresight to bury supplies three days walk ahead of them, at Izuku's current pace. Given it was the direction that Bakugou was going to be heading, regardless of whether or not Izuku survived, there had simply been no sense in lugging the heavy supplies all of the way back to the outhouse. It was a genius idea, give him his due, but the rate at which Izuku was guzzling water, his body sweating heavily from the exertion of forcing his aching limbs to keep moving, was going to be a problem.

By nightfall, they had left the station and the remains of the RV behind them, walking along the motorway, the quickest route to the city. It wasn't the safest option for them, not that there was any *safe* way to travel in the Apocalypse, but it was the safest of all the choices they had available. In Izuku's condition, if they stumbled upon some zombies in the woods, the chances of them finding safe shelter before they were set upon was pretty slim, and Izuku didn't particularly fancy clambering up into a tree with an arm torn to shreds already. But out on the road, out in the open, they were far more likely to be spotted by something arguably much worse. Bakugou was going entirely on the fact that he had yet to see a single other person out on the road, whilst he had spotted more than enough of the dead walking through the treelines, to decide that this was a risk they were just going to have to take. It also meant that they could duck into or under cars in a pinch, if they needed to, or when they decided to take a rest.

It was Bakugou who decided that it was time for them to stop, clambering on top of a car with his red hoody tied about his waist and taking a good look around them. Izuku leaned against the side of a van, wiping the sweat from his face. God he was hot. And tired. Exhausted. And it was only the first day.

"Here." He glanced up to see Bakugou holding his own bottle of water to him, and Izuku shook his head.

"Nah, save it."

"Don't be fucking stupid. You ration food, you don't fucking ration water. If you need it, you drink it. Take it."

Izuku looked at the bottle, the clear fluid most definitely calling out to him as it seemed to sparkle in the red light from the horizon, before he sighed and took it from his hand, his own shaking slightly as he fought to unscrew the lid without dropping the entire thing on the ground. Bakugou tutted and snatched it off him again, needlessly rough in Izuku's opinion, before twisting the lid and thrust it back into his hands.

"Thanks," Izuku muttered, as Bakugou turned his back and started testing the doors on the cars around them, looking for one that was unlocked. He sighed, taking a swig of the water with his

shaking hands, before looking up and down the road.

Izuku had hoped that they would have seen some sort of sign by now, something *anything* that might give them an indication that the rest of their group were alive and had come this way. Bakugou had already told him that he'd walked further than this and hadn't seen anything himself, but that didn't stop Izuku checking almost each and every car window they walked past, hoping for something scrawled along the front ... a message, hell even just an arrow would have been enough. Just enough to renew his hope that they were alive, waiting for them somewhere ahead.

He heard a whistle, looking up from where he had been staring somewhat sightlessly back the way they had come to see Bakugou waving his hand at him from several rows of cars ahead.

"Oi, found one."

With a wince, he pushed away from the van, tightening the bottle cap as carefully as he could possibly manage.

It wasn't a bad find. Some sort of five door thing with a big boot, Izuku had never really known much about cars, but it was certainly big enough for even the both of them to lie stretched out in the back if they flattened the back seats down, which Bakugou was currently busying himself with. He was also happy to note a lack of blood stains or bodies inside of this one, something that couldn't be said for a disturbingly large amount of vehicles they had passed on their way here.

"Did you find anything inside it?" Izuku asked, leaning against the bonnet as Bakugou worked.

"Just- *fuck*," Bakugou hissed, shaking his hand as if he had just gotten his fingers stuck between the seats. "*Stupid fucking American piece of shit tin can*-" his cursing continued in a muffle as he climbed back into the car, a suspiciously loud thud leading Izuku to believe that he had either punched or kicked the seats into submission, before he climbed back out, dusting his hands his dark jeans. Izuku found he strangely missed the eye-burning orange combats and leather suspender combination, it seemed weird to see Bakugou standing there in something as ordinary as jeans.

"Nothing particularly useful. Some half melted mints in the glove box, some batteries under the front seat. Anything unlocked is going to have been raided by someone long before us by this point."

"Well, batteries will be useful now it's starting to get darker," Izuku said.

"Nah, not even the right fucking ones for the torch," Bakugou grunted. "Gimme your pack."

Izuku reached up with his good arm, holding his breath as he pulled the strap up and over his bandaged arm, Bakugou's red eyes stare decidedly dis-concerting throughout the entire process, before he passed it over to him. The lighter things, blankets and medical supplies, were all in Izuku's pack, and Izuku knew there had been no point in protesting as he had watched Bakugou fill his own with all of the food and water they had, the noticeable strain on the straps indication of how heavy it must have been. At this stage, Bakugou was far far stronger than he was, and if the man wanted to take on the larger burden at this stage then it would only be ego that had Izuku complaining.

He watched as Bakugou opened the pack, pulling out the blanket and chucking it onto the back seat, before he then moved down to open the boot, yanking the zip the rest of the way open and emptying the medical supplies out into the back.

"Right, let's take a look at it."

Izuku was pleasantly surprised, for perhaps the first time in almost three weeks, when he took a seat in the boot and carefully unwrapped the bandage around his bicep. It was still weeping, though the discharge was considerably lighter and clearer, just the natural level of plasma his body let out to keep the wound clotting, and the redness that was previously spread in a wide circle all the way up to his neck and down to his elbow had reduced. It still hurt, he supposed the scar tissue forming would always be more tender than the skin surrounding it, but it was a far cry from the shooting agony that had once spread through him when Bakugou carefully pressed a cotton bud covered in pink solution against the flesh.

"You're a lucky bastard, you know that?" Bakugou muttered, focusing on what he was doing.

"Not a lucky enough bastard not to get burned in the first place," Izuku responded with a wry smile.

"Well, that's because you're a moron with no self preservation skills," Bakugou shot back immediately. "You watch too much All Might as a kid or something?"

"Which kid our age didn't watch it?" Izuku replied, an easier grin coming to his face as he remembered Saturday mornings, face so close to the television his mum had had to keep picking him up and placing him back on the sofa, watching the new episode with a towel wrapped around his shoulders like a cape, All Might plush under one arm, his All Might themed juicebox in the other.

"I had the trading cards too," Izuku continued, lost in the memories. "I had a big wallet my mum got me to put them all in."

Bakugou seemed to twitch at that, for some reason, his eyes darting up to Izuku's face and his lips thinning. Izuku looked back at him, only for Bakugou to immediately focus on his arm again, a scowl setting across his features. Izuku wanted to ask him what his problem was, but the blonde spoke before he got the chance.

"Did you get the full set of the Shiny Ages?" he muttered, voice so quiet that Izuku almost didn't hear it, and immediately Izuku felt his lips spread into the hugest grin, realising that Bakugou, *Bakugou*, had collected the cards as well.

"Of course! I had two of the Silver Age!" Bakugou scoffed at that.

"I had two of the whole set," he said, voice taking on the tone of a brag. "Even got the full villain set."

"Ok, but did you get all the Nomu in shiny too?"

"Course I fucking did. Told you I got the full set, didn't I?"

"I had so many of the Winged Nomu."

"Ugh, that fucker was the worst. Turned up in every set."

"My mum got me the Scalextric set one Christmas."

"That thing was fucking cursed. My parents ended up taking the damn thing away because the Might Mobile kept shooting off in different directions and smashing vases."

"I lost one of the pieces," Izuku sighed, his voice sounding genuinely disappointed. "Tore the house apart looking for it. I think I cried for about a week."

"That sounds about right for a nerd like you," Bakugou sniggered, as he wrapped a fresh bandage around Izuku's arm. "Who cries over a toy?"

"An *All Might* toy," Izuku corrected with a pout.

"Yeh yeh. I bet you still got it all too?"

"Well ... yeh. I still live, uh ... lived with my mum so ..." he fell silent, his stomach churning. He'd deliberately not put much thought into home over the months. Getting back to UA, back to Musutafu had been his goal from the start, but he'd realised soon that getting there was never going to be easy. He didn't know what had happened to his home. To his mum. It was easier not to think about it, because then he could just content himself with the idea that there was nothing wrong. That it was a given that of course his mum was fine, and home would still be standing when he got there, because how could the alternative be true?

"You can show me your lame collection when we get there then," Bakugou replied, and Izuku's eyes darted up so fast they could have spun from his head. "Not that it'll be anything compared to mine."

"Oh, so you still have your toys too, Kacchan?" Izuku teased, and he saw Bakugou's cheeks flush, the man shooting him a glare so foul he could feel the heat from it.

"You wanna fucking go?" he snapped, brandishing the roll of bandaging at him. Izuku sniggered, and Bakugou just muttered a few choice swears under his breath and he shoved the medical supplies back into the bag, and nodded to the bottle of pills lying at Izuku's side.

"Just take your fucking meds, Deku."

Still grinning, Izuku popped one of the tablets into his mouth and swallowed.

"Take the boot," Bakugou said, throwing the pack to the back of the car before he slid forward out onto the road. "I'm gonna take the front seats."

Izuku frowned. "Isn't that going to be uncomfortable? Don't you wanna lie down?"

Bakugou stopped, looking back over his shoulder at him with a strange look on his face, before fully turning to face him, arms crossing over his chest.

"You wanna fucking *cuddle*, Deku?"

Izuku blinked, confused. "Wh- hah? Why would-" he then froze, looking to the boot, then back to Bakugou, his face immediately burning red. "No! Th-that's not what- I just meant that there's enough room back here!"

"Good. Because if that was some kind of chat up line it was fucking awful."

"It wasn't a chat up line!" Izuku protested hotly, willing for his face to stop firing up. "I'm not trying to chat you up!"

"Sure sure," Bakugou scoffed, before he put on an unflatteringly high voice in imitation of Izuku. "*You're built like a Greek God, Kacchan! Why don't you get in the back with me, Kacchan!*"

"I don't sound like that!"

"Nah, you're right, that's not nearly whiny enough."

"You're an asshole, you know that?" Izuku snapped.

"What, assholes not your thing?" Bakugou said, smirking at the double meaning and Izuku threw his good arm in the air.

"You're really full of yourself."

Bakugou opened his mouth, as if to say something in response, before he just shook his head and started laughing.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"What were you about to say?"

"Don't fucking worry about it."

Izuku grumbled, glaring at Bakugou as he rounded the side of the car, still laughing his almost endearingly ugly laugh to himself as he pulled open the door. He shook his head. *Not endearing. Fuck.*

"Whatever," he muttered, his retort coming far too late to have any weight as he reached up to pull the boot door shut. "What food we got?"

Bakugou reached into his pack and pulled out a long wrapped packet of cheap salami, the sort that was definitely more pig ass and salt than anything else, and held it out to him with his eyebrows raised, a poorly hidden smirk on his lips again.

"You know, where I come from this is bordering on harassment," Izuku muttered, snatching the salami.

"Yeh, and where are you from, a fucking nunnery?"

"Funny."

But he was far too hungry to argue, opening the packet and pulling out the kind of food that his mum would have never even let in the house once upon a time, but was now a staple for pretty much anybody who had survived to this point. Bakugou pulled his own from the pack, pushing the front seat back so that he could rest his mud covered boots up on the console.

"We've made pretty good progress today considering," he said, his back now turned to Izuku as he looked out of the window. "But we're running out of water faster than I thought we would."

"We should check the cars as we go," Izuku replied, resting against the side of the car so that he could see Bakugou's profile.

"What the fuck you think I been doing for two weeks, Deku?" the blonde shot, rolling his eyes. "Anything unlocked between here and where I buried that stash is done."

"What about unlocked?"

Bakugou shot him an glare from the side of his face, eyebrows flat.

"Are you joking?"

Izuku blinked. It had been a perfectly reasonable question as far as he was concerned.

"We start smashing in windows then if those fuckers from the city go by they're going to know we've been here. Idiot, how the fuck have you survived this goddamn long?"

"But that was weeks ago," Izuku reasoned. "If they were following us they'd be long gone by now."

"Or they're still looking," Bakugou shot back, turning in his seat now to face him. "They weren't fucking around, Deku. They knew who we were, and they came there that night to kill us. There's no way they're just going to let this go."

"But why?" Izuku asked, his voice insistant and hushed. "Who are they? Why do they want us dead so badly?"

Bakugou's expression tightened, and he looked away again, glaring down at the food in his hand before he threw it on the passenger seat with a snarl. Izuku frowned, swallowing and leaning forward.

"What happened? It was how you got bitten right? How you lost your friend."

He saw Bakugou's jaw clench, his head turning to resolutely stare out of his window, shutting himself off. Izuku sighed, his hand reaching out to grab Bakugou's shoulder, before he thought better of it.

"I'm a part of this now," he said, his voice as soft and firm as he could manage. "And they could be the people who killed my group too. Surely I deserve to know why?"

For a moment, Bakugou didn't speak, just staring out of the window, his breathing and the sudden steady tip tap on metal of a light late summer shower starting to fall outside, and Izuku was about ready to give up. But then Bakugou took a deep breath, rubbing his face tiredly.

"We were at Tokyo campus when it all started ..."

OOOooo...

"Oi, knock knock fuckers."

He leaned his shoulder against the heavy swinging door, the familiar fake pine that he had grown to find oddly comforting, once upon a time, the only thing keeping he and the rest of the world out of the comparative sanctuary beyond. It was crazy, quite frankly. Fucking insane that they were still here. Still here despite how many goddamn times he'd tried to tell them that they should leave, that staying where they were was only more dangerous that what lay outside of these thick walls and iron barred gates.

"One sec, Bakugou."

He growled under his breath, shifting his gaze back down the hallway as he stood there. The elevator doors remained shut, as they had done since this whole thing went down, the stairs not much safer in the grand scheme of things, but certainly safer than being trapped in an elevator. They weren't alone here on campus, in fact a surprisingly large number of students had decided to set up camp in the university, separating off into their own respective departments, or friendships groups. He, far from the most trusting of people in the world to begin with, didn't like it one goddamn fucking bit. There were some groups he hardly ever saw, ducking through the campus halls so quickly you could almost convince yourself you had imagined them, keeping mostly to the themselves as they tried hard to avoid anyone they didn't know, anyone who could be a danger to them and theirs. But there were others, dangerous others, who seemed to view the campus as their own personal playground. Everyone knew who they were, they'd had a bad reputation even before the world went to fucking hell, and they had adopted a very particular survival strategy, one that suited their fucked up superiority complex's well, and one that left Katsuki itching to beat the ever living shit out of them. And he would do. Were it not for his small collection of morons that, for some reason, he couldn't bear the thought of seeing hurt, caught up in his own personal drama.

"Any fucking time you like, headphones," he snarled, banging the back of his fist against the door again, the sound loud in the empty hallway, echoing down the spiral staircase to his right.

Finally, the door opened, narrow black eyes peering out through the gap in the door, looking him up and down in a decidedly concerned manner.

"What took you so long?"

"This the fucking Spanish Inquisition? Let me in for fuck sake."

The girl, Jirou Kyoka, sighed with a heavy roll of her eyes, taking a step back so that Katsuki could push his way past the door and into the hallway on the other side, breathing the smallest sigh of relief when he heard the door lock click into place behind him. It had been the longest fucking day.

"Where they all at?" he asked Jirou, who nodded her head towards the office to their left in response. Katsuki glanced over, just as a head of red hair peeked around the doorway, lips pulled back into a beaming grin.

"Bro! Hey, he's back!"

Katsuki walked into the office, seeing his friends lounging on the couches or desk, before he dropped the heavy pack weighing down his shoulders onto the ground with a thud. Kaminari, the blonde previously lying flat out on his back on top of the desk, perked up in interest.

"Sounds pretty heavy, man!" he said, excitedly. "What did you get?"

He grunted, gesturing to the pack and shrugging almost indifferently.

"Take a look already, I'm not listing everything," he said, reaching into his back pocket and pulling out the long knife he had started carrying around with him everywhere he went, slapping it onto the desk before gratefully dropping into the high back chair behind it. Jirou, who was still watching him, didn't miss the stain of something dark on the handle, her eyes darting up to his. The others, however, were eagerly approaching the pack, Kaminari unzipping it and pulling the flaps back before taking a peek inside, his gasp filling the small room.

"Whoa!"

"Bakugou, that's amazing!" Kirishima all but yelped, looking down at the collection of tin cans and preserved goods packed so tightly into the backpack that it was amazing it hadn't just ripped under the pressure.

"You even remembered toothpaste," Mina squealed, her pink head obscuring Katsuki's view of the bag for a moment before she pulled out the red and white tube, pressing it to her chest in glee.

"Where did you get all this?" Jirou asked, her voice uncharacteristically sharp as she frowned over at him, her slanted bob only accentuating her suspicion.

"Yeh, I thought all the empty departments had been raided already," Sero said now, his hands on his hips as he looked between the bag and Katsuki.

"There ain't," Katsuki replied irritably.

"So, where did you go?" Jirou pressed. He looked up at her, her scowl matching his, before he clicked his teeth against his tongue and crossed his arms over his chest.

"I left the fucking campus," he growled.

At that, the group froze, eyes widening and staring at him in alarm.

"Are you crazy?" Mina yelled, getting to her feet, the toothpaste dropped to the ground and forgotten. "Oh my god, are you *crazy?*"

"I fucking told you we're not relying on those fuckers any more!" Katsuki snarled back. "I'm done doing whatever they fucking ask of us and getting shit in return!"

"But we can't go out there!" Kirishima hissed. "Dude, we're safe here. The hell you risking all that for?"

Katsuki's lips curled, before he jumped to his feet, charging over to the bin in the corner of the room. He ignored Sero's protests as he grabbed the lid, flinging it across the room before snatching the bag inside and upended it out onto the floor. A handful of cans rolled out, two empty crisp packets, some shitty jerky and not nearly enough water bottles to have fully quenched any of their thirsts, before he glared back up at them.

"This is what we've had to fucking eat this week," he said, kicking one of the cans viciously, Kaminari wincing as it sailed past his face. "Fucking cold soup and jerky too goddamn salt for us to even eat. We ain't *safe* here!"

"And out there is somehow better?" Kirishima replied, his tone soft.

"I found all that, didn't I?" Katsuki snapped back. "We're better off our there than trapped here." But Jirou stepped forward, grabbing the knife on the table and holding it out to him.

"Is that so? Then why is there blood all over this knife."

Katsuki bristled. This wasn't the first time he had snuck out of campus. Not content to just accept their current situation, being trapped in this goddamn hell hole when there was a whole world out there. And sure, they'd all seen them. Everyone had seen them by now, had seen someone turn, and

seen them attack people, had seen them eat people, but they'd still been sheltered for the most part. Not one of them had had to get their hands dirty, because why would they?

"They ain't hard to kill," he finally said back, and Jirou's shoulder drooped, dropping the knife back on the table, her face looking decidedly pale. The rest of the group looked at him in shock.

"K- you've *killed* people?" Kaminari whimpered, eyes wide, and Katsuki immediately jumped to his feet, face burning hot with anger.

"They ain't fucking people, Kaminari!" he yelled.

"You don't know that," Sero whispered, his own face averted.

"One of them had it's fucking guts dragging across the side walk behind it!"

"Jesus, Bakugou," Kirishima said, running his hand through his hair, expression harried. "And you really want us to go out there? I know it's not perfect here, we all know that, but we go out there what's stopping us being the next suckers dragging our guts?"

"Me," Katsuki replied firmly, before he snatched the knife back from the table. "Follow *me*. I'm good at killing those fuckers. At finding food! We get the fuck out of here and we find somewhere better, somewhere that's actually safe."

No one responded to that, breaths hitching, eyes averting, and Katsuki had to bite his tongue to stop himself from screaming at the lot of them. From grabbing their shoulders in turn and shaking the fucking sense into them.

"We can't fucking stay here," he growled, before stomping from the room.

They're scared. He knew that, he fucking *knew* that and he fucking knew why, but what did that change? You'd be stupid not to be fucking scared these days, but they were letting their fear of what lay outside keep them from thinking clearly. But the group leading the charge, those twisted sick fucks at the top, would come for payment soon enough ...

He was woken an hour later by the sound of someone knocking heavily on the thick door separating their department from the rest of the campus, his heart racing. He and the rest of them had been at university together for almost a year now, each of them studying in the chemistry department, and when the rest of their classes had left, leaving just them, it made sense for them to form a group. Katsuki hadn't known any of them especially well, with the exception of Kirishima, but there was something about the end of the world that made any friendship that much more important, and Katsuki had soon found himself feeling fiercely protective of all of them. Not that he'd say it out loud, of course. By all account, he should just leave, he could strike out on his own, head back to Musutafu where his parents might still be alive. But when he heard that knock on the door, his first thought was to the rest of his stupid ass group and he leaped to his feet, checking that the knife was secured in his back pocket before hurrying out into the hallway.

Kaminari was standing by the door, hand held out hesitantly, looking over at Katsuki as he charged forward. The knocking came again, this time followed by a low drawl.

"Knock knock, I know you're home."

Shit. Katsuki growled, pushing Kaminari back as the rest of them crowded into the hallway.

"I'll get it," he hissed, before unlocking the door, hand on the hilt of his knife. He pulled it open part of the way, revealing a pale man with vivid bright blue eyes underneath a shock of black hair, the expression on his heavily pierced face entirely bored as he looked back at him.

"Hey hey, Bakugou."

"The fuck you want?" Katsuki hissed.

The man didn't react, just blinking slowly back at him before he raised a hand and casually scratched his temple.

"A little birdy told me they saw someone leaving the campus last night. Don't suppose you know who that could have been?"

Shit. Katsuki growled low in his throat, his hand gripping harder onto the door and the knife in his back pocket.

"The fuck's it to you?" he replied through gritted teeth, every fibre of his being urging him, screaming at him, to attack. To punch that fucker in his half metal face. The man's face twitched then, looking Bakugou up and down, eyes lingering for a moment on where one of his hands was not-so-discretely behind his back.

"I'm pretty sure Shiggy already told you that there'd be consequences if your little group keeping being a problem for us," he said, and Katsuki felt movement at his side, Kaminari stepping forward now, his palms out.

"Hey, Dabi, it's cool alright? You know what Bakugou's like-"

"I'm not talking to you."

Kaminari shut up, as Dabi reached down to his hip and pulled up his weapon, a long baseball bat with nails embedded along it's length. It was the most ludicrously absurd weapon, fitting perhaps for the psychopath holding it, and Katsuki took a step closer, obscuring the man's view of the room behind him.

"What do you want?" he demanded, and Dabi's eyes narrowed.

"I don't know how to make it any clearer for you at this point," he replied. "If you and your friends are going to live here, in *our* home, then you abide by our rules. Everyone else seems to get it, so what's your problem?"

Katsuki didn't answer, just keeping his red eyes fixed upon those cold dead blues.

"You've got two choices, Bakugou. First option, we take one of the girls. The emo chick's probably more fitting, but I don't really care which."

"Fuck you," Katsuki growled, just as Kaminari pushed his way forward again with a *"back off!"* of his own. Dabi smirked then, his blue eyes fixing upon Kaminari now.

"Second option, you give us everything that was in that backpack. And I mean everything, I'll know if it's light."

Katsuki snapped, yanking the knife out from his pocket and taking a bold step forward, pushing into Dabi's space and glaring up at him. Dabi was taller than him, but he was a hell of a lot heavier, and he'd always fancied his chances against the prick.

"Third option, you turn the fuck around and get nothing."

"Bakugou-"

"You really think that's a good move, asshole?" Dabi said, his tone still bored even as he pushed back. "You ever seen what a face looks like after it's been caved in by a baseball bat? Hah, not that you'll get to see it. You won't be able to see anything, see?"

"Fucking try me," Katsuki growled, hackles raised, blood pumping, his hand gripping the knife so tightly it could snap. But there was one thing that he hadn't accounted for, a moment in time that would haunt his thoughts right up until more horrors pushed them out, a moment in time that forced Katsuki to reevaluate whether he really could protect them. Protect all of them.

Katsuki was strong. He'd been fighting his whole goddamn life in one sense or another, but Dabi clearly hadn't been taking it easy either, and in a flash he had snatched a long skinny forearm forward, his hand gripping hold of Kaminari's hair and yanking hard. In a moment, a time stopping moment, Kaminari was at Dabi's side, the man's hand so deeply embedded into his hair that it brought tears to Kaminari's eyes, and Katsuki froze as the bat was raised, the nails pressing against Kaminari's cheek as the blonde stiffened, eyes almost comically twisting in their sockets to try and see the weapon flush against his face.

"I've changed my mind," Dabi said. "I'll take the pack, and everything that was in it. And I'll take it now."

"Ok, take it easy man, I'll just go get it ok?" Kirishima was saying, but Dabi interrupted him.

"No. I want Bakugou to get it."

Katsuki grit his teeth, his body shaking as he glared back at the burning eyes. Then, Dabi pushed against Kaminari's cheek with the bat, the nails so close to breaking his skin, and Katsuki chucked his knife on the ground.

"Fine."

He turned tail, pushing his way back into the office where Mina was busy packing away everything into the backpack. Katsuki snatched the last item, the toothpaste, from the ground and hesitated.

"Don't," Mina breathed, shaking her head minutely. *Fuck*. He thrust it into the bag before stomping back to the front door, dropping that, too, at Dabi's feet.

"There," he snarled.

"Good," Dabi replied, with a sick smile. "Now, you're going to carry it back for me."

"Wait, he doesn't need to-" Jirou piped up, but she felt silent as Dabi tightened his grip on Kaminari, causing the man to yelp out in pain.

"Or I can get this guy to carry it for me," Dabi said. "Up to you, Bakugou."

"Kat- don't-" Kaminari managed, but Katsuki grabbed the backpack, throwing it over his shoulder.

"Fine," he said, his heart racing. "You can let him go."

Dabi eyed Katsuki up and down, before mercifully he let go of Kaminari, the blonde stumbling forwards, Jirou reaching out to catch him.

"Bakugou," Kirishima hissed, but Katsuki looked back at him.

"Don't worry, I'll bring him back," Dabi said.

"I'll be fine," Katsuki said firmly, before shrugging the pack higher up his shoulder. "Let's fucking go then."

He heard Dabi laugh behind him, and he hunched his shoulders, teeth grinding together, his blood running both hot and cold in that moment, mind racing through the possibilities. He could try and get the bat from Dabi, maybe if he was quick enough he could take the fucker out. But no ... if he missed then there was every chance that he would go back for Kaminari, or Jirou. And if he didn't? Well, there were still three more of them that would almost certainly want to get back at him for it.

So, he had no choice, hearing the swish swish of Dabi swinging the nail encrusted bat behind him, his hair on end, waiting for a blow he wasn't entirely sure wouldn't come.

Where Katsuki and his friends had taken over the chemistry department, Dabi and his group had taken over the main hall, an entire level including the food hall, where they had an almost complete monopoly on the building, who came and who left. Katsuki said almost, because he had snuck out enough times before now to know that they didn't keep an especially good watch on students leaving the campus. That was until Katsuki was unlucky, or stupid enough, to have been spotted this time. Dabi was at his side, and one of his thin fingered hands gripped his bicep, squeezing hard.

"I don't need your fucking help to walk," Katsuki snarled, and at that Dabi just laughed.

"Not yet you don't."

Katsuki felt a cold dread then, his stomach dropping right down to his ass. He didn't need to take a second to guess at what they would have wanted with Jirou, and immediately his mind started to race over the scenarios ... he didn't take any of them to be good people, but somehow it hadn't occurred to him to consider that maybe they'd be interested in using, punishing *him* in the same way. He glanced sideways, and saw Dabi smirking at him.

"You're looking kinda worried there, Bakugou," he said. Katsuki looked away, glaring forwards. Maybe he should just try and kill all four of them.

Eventually he was lead towards the ex-chancellor's office, because of course this was where Dabi would set up, the sick bastard. But, Dabi wasn't the one in charge. Nah, he wasn't even the sickest of the lot.

Dabi knocked on the door three times, before a painfully hoarse voice on the other side told him to enter, and with a final smile at Katsuki, cold dead eyes now alive and twinkling with mirth and anticipation, the door was pushed open and Katsuki was not-so-ceremoniously shoved inside by a firm hand against the pack.

The white haired man was sat behind the large ornate desk, his dirty red sneakers kicked up onto the surface, with a handheld console in his hand, the altogether far too bright and happy sounding music coming from the damn thing enough to make Katsuki fucking shiver. As the door shut behind them, the man looked up over his game, before throwing his head back with an exaggerated sigh.

"Are you kidding me, Dabi? I'm busy."

"Yeh I know," Dabi replied. "But Bakugou was kind enough to offer to bring all that stuff he found to you personally."

Katsuki bristled, glaring at Dabi as the man walked away from him, taking a seat in one of the leather back chairs by the desk. Shigaraki, or Shiggy as most people now knew him, sent Dabi his own irritated glare, before dropping the console onto the table.

"Fine fine."

"Where's Toga?" Dabi asked, and to that Shiggy just shrugged, now fixing his red eyed stare on Katsuki, who stood in the centre of the room, backpack still around his shoulders, wondering whether he could just throw the damn thing in Shigaraki's face, use the distraction to get the bat from Dabi, then beat the ever living shit out of the both of them. His poker face, however, obviously needed some work, because Shigaraki went from irritated to interested in a heart beat, and his lips pulled back into a smile.

"He wants to *kill me*, that one," he said. "You see that Dabi?"

"Yep," Dabi replied. "Threatened me. Didn't think it should end so well for him."

"Nah, you're probably right," Shiggy replied.

"You want your shit or not?" Katsuki snapped, reaching up to pull the pack from his shoulders before throwing it down on the ground in front of him.

"You best hope none of that's busted," Dabi said, his voice now cold as he frowned at him. "I'm fucking serious, asshole."

"Like I give a fuck."

"What's going on?"

Katsuki's eyes darted sideways as two more people entered the room. Toga Himiko, the blonde in front, already had a very particular reputation across campus, long before this all went down, and her penchant for violence was well documented. To her side was the most unlikely of the team ... the asshole wasn't even a fucking student here. There'd always been this assumption that the librarian was off his fucking rocker, some people had sworn they'd heard him arguing with himself in two entirely different voices on more than one occasion, but the Apocalypse had fucking confirmed as much. Jin stood with his head to one side, watching him with interest.

"This is the one that snuck out last night," Dabi explained.

"Ooh!" Toga squealed, hurrying towards Katsuki with a wide grin on her face. Katsuki braced himself, his hands curling into fists as she stopped right in front of him. "We're going to punish

him, right?"

"I wanna watch! *Don't do tha*t," Jin said from his corner of the room, and Katsuki held his breath. The girl wasn't that fucking strong, she was tiny in fact, he could fucking take her, but the hungry way that Shigaraki was glaring at him made him fairly confident that their twisted leader was almost hoping that he would, to give him a real excuse to come at Katsuki himself.

"I dunno, you think he learned his lesson?" Shiggy said. "Oi, blondie, you learned your lesson?"

Katsuki bit down on his tongue, biting back all of the responses that immediately wanted to spill from his lips like vomit.

"Hey, Tomura asked you a question silly," Toga said with a bright grin.

"Bite me," Katsuki spat out. It was no fucking good. There was no way his ego was going to let him play into this, regardless of what they had in stall for him. They wanted to beat him? Well, they better be ready to fucking fight him. They wanted to fuck him? Then he was more than ready to tear their damn throats out.

"I take that as a no," Shiggy sighed, as Dabi got to his feet and started to circle behind him. Katsuki grit his teeth, raising his fists and twisting sideways so he could keep an eye on Dabi and Shigaraki both, Toga now sitting cross legged on the floor not to far from him, her eyes wide and excited. "You sure you wanna do this, kid?"

"I ain't fucking scared of you losers," Katsuki growled.

"You should be," Shigarki hissed, getting to his feet now and walking around the front of the desk. "You really should be."

It was over before Katsuki even realised he had lost. Dabi moved with that ridiculous speed again the moment that Katsuki was distracted by the red eyed crazy man stalking over to him, his arms yanked behind him and pulled into a tight hold by Dabi, opened up his chest and face for Shigaraki who grinned down at him. Katsuki pulled back, he kicked, but Dabi's grip on him was far too tight, and then lights flashed in front of his eyes, an incredible eye watering pain spreading across his face as Shigaraki's fist connected with his jaw, blood and spit splattering across the wooden floorboards.

"You scared yet, blondie?" Shigaraki asked, no amusement in his voice even as Toga cackled on the floor. Katsuki panted, glaring back at him.

"*Go fuck yourself*."

Shigaraki punched him again. And again. Katsuki lost track of time, of anything, as his face exploded in pain again and again, feeling bones crunch and eyes swell, not even leaving him enough time to take a breath before the next hit came, several times straight to the gut until he was bent double coughing bile and blood up onto the floor.

"I think he gets the point now," he heard Shigaraki say, his ears whistling and screeching too loud for him to make out much more than that. "Take him back, Dabi."

"Told you you would need my help walking, didn't I?" Dabi all but whispered, his lips close to his ear as he pulled him, Katsuki far too dazed and in too much to do much more than stumble after

him.

It was in a blur that he was dragged back to chem, Dabi knocking loudly and announcing their return to a chorus of gasps and cries as he was physically thrown forward, landing hard on the ground.

"Bakugou!"

"If you cross us one more time, next time he won't be coming back," he heard Dabi say, before he felt the warm hands of his friends on his arms, his shoulders, someone trying to lift him up, only the pain of someone pressing their hand to his cheek enough to startle him back into the present. *Weak. Fucking weak. He was weak. He'd lost and he was pathetic ...*

"Katsuki!"

He was propped up against a hard chest, only dimly registering that he'd been almost entirely lifted off the ground before being placed carefully onto something soft.

"Man, can you hear me?"

He blinked, the light almost blinding as he looked up at his friends surrounding him, their concerned faces, their goddamn pity making him feel sick.

"I'm fine," he snarled back, his jaw aching from the effort of saying just that.

"Jesus, Bakugou ... the hell did they do to you?"

"*I said I'm fine!*"

The group fell silent, and Katsuki knew if his face wasn't already burning from having the living shit ripped out of it, he'd be red with shame and resentment.

"Hey, at least let me clean you up a bit ok?" came Jirou's soft voice. He didn't argue, just glaring down at his hands through rapidly puffing eyes.

"You're right," Kirishima said. "We need to leave here."

They formulated their escape plan over the course of the next two weeks, Katsuki spear heading the plan with the kind of dogged determination that he was known for. But Katsuki wanted to do far more than just escape the campus, and though he didn't explicitly say as much to the rest of them, he knew none of them were stupid enough to think that his intentions were entirely peaceful, especially not after he decided to put his own very particular set of skills to work, spending hours in the chem lab putting together weapons a little more explosive than a shitty rust coloured knife on the office desk.

Katsuki had always been good at building shit, of understanding how things went together, and chemicals were no exception to that. As a kid he'd been fascinated by fireworks, and because he wasn't like the rest of the kids he'd hung out with back then, bar one particular nerdy little shit he hardly remembered except for the way he had once clung to his arm in equal excitement as they'd watched the New Years fireworks, he'd wanted more than to just admire how pretty they were. He wanted to know how they worked. He wanted to know what made explosions so big, so loud, so beautiful. He'd put together his first home made firework when he was only eight years old, from

taking apart the ones that his father had presumed were locked away safe and sound in the garden shed. He'd watched it fire into the sky with wide eyed excitement, dirt on his hands and knees and ash on his face, his grin bright enough to match the explosion that rocked the sky above them. His parents had lost it, his mother especially, but that hadn't phased little Katsuki. He was hooked.

And so, he threw all his attention, all his focus, into discovering what kind of reactions he could get from different chemicals, until finally getting himself a place at Tokyo University, studying chemical engineering, working on a fast track to his masters alongside his degree. Suffice to say, Katsuki could make short work of the supplies that had to hand after bagging the chem lab for themselves early into the Apocalypse, and the smell of solder filled the room as he put together his very own arsenal.

The plan was to sneak out in the cover of darkness, with Katsuki creating a distraction on the other side of the campus with one of his home built explosives, using a pre determined route to get the hell out of there before Shigaraki and the others worked out what was going on. From there, Katsuki would meet them in the parking lot of the campus and lead them towards a space house he had already put together. He'd ignored the exasperation on their faces when he explained that he'd already scoped out an abandoned building for them to hide out in for the first few nights, that it was already stocked with some water and supplies because, hell, if they were going to be fucking prepared then he sure as shit better be. It was a simple plan, and if all went well they'd be out of the goddamn place and in the safe house in less than an hour.

If all went well.

The evening of their escape was very subdued, each of them mentally preparing themselves for the uncertainty that lay ahead of them. Katsuki had already talked them through all that he'd found out about the zombies (*"don't call them that,"* Sero had whined) walking the streets beyond the campus. He'd hit enough of them square in the chest or stomach to know that the only way to take one of these things down was a direct hit to the head, take out the brain, kill them completely. Anything sharp would do it, and the most important thing they would need out there, even before food and water, would be something to defend themselves with. They were easy enough to handle individually, and with the right coordination you could take down a handful of them on your own if you needed to, but if you came across a group of them the very best thing you could do was to run in the opposite direction. Being being told how to handle them, and actually facing them, were two very different things however, and as much as he trusted his friends not to lose their shit completely, a part of him was still very worried about how they would actually act when faced with the dead.

Midnight struck, and carrying whatever small number of supplies they had, the group snuck from the halls that had been their home for almost three months, Bakugou hiding the make shift explosives in a bag over his shoulder. For the rest of the group, the hope was the entire thing would be wholly uneventful, all they had to do was run out the doors as soon as the bomb went off, when Shigaraki and the rest would be too distracted to spot them, and it was with sharp assurances from Kirishima that his friends took off, whilst Katsuki went in the opposite direction.

They had chosen the point where they were going to let the bomb off very carefully. After all, they had no intention of killing anybody (at least, they all assumed Katsuki didn't either, none of them having felt entirely ready to question that very assumption), and it would be disastrous if anyone else living in the campus got injured in the blast. There was only one part of the campus that they could guarantee would be empty at this time of the night, only because Shigaraki's goons had been very strict about no one being there after dark, or unsupervised.

Katsuki darted towards the gym, eyes wide and alert as he ran, listening for anyone who might be out past night, his heart hammering wildly in his chest despite the calm look on his bruised face. There was still plenty that could go wrong, and if they got out of here in one piece there was plenty more that could go wrong out there too. But they all knew it was only a matter of time before beating on Katsuki wouldn't be enough to satisfy the cruel hunger of those freaks who'd placed themselves at the top. These were risks they had to take. Armed with that knowledge Katsuki skidded to a halt outside of the gym, looking up and down the corridor, before gently pushing the door open.

The on-campus gym had always been one of Katsuki's favourite parts of the entire damn university. So, he was a bit of a gym rat ... hell, he'd been taking up boxing lessons as a stress reliever since he was thirteen, and Kirishima had once found him with a textbook resting on the treadmill, studying as he worked on his cardio, and proceeded to laugh his ass off at him. He felt a strange swoop of something in his chest when he looked over at the treadmills, before pushing the feeling down and fishing one of the explosives from the bag.

The fuse was simple, it wasn't anything flashy, not by any stretch of the imagination, but all he needed to do was pull a single pin from the almost grenade-shaped shell before running like motherfucking hell to escape it's path before a simple chemical reaction blasted a seven foot hole in the wall of the gym. It would be loud enough to get their attention, for sure, but Katsuki had to be certain of that before he left.

It was why he had made several more of the explosives, back-ups if he needed to get their attention. At least, that was what he had told his friends. He grit his teeth as he selected the spot, placing the explosive on the ground by one of the side walls, easily visible from the door to the gym, before pulling the pin and running, ducking out of the room and into the shadow of the lockers before the ground rocked, the sound so loud that Katsuki pressed his hands over his ears even as the feral grin broke his lips, heart racing from pure adrenaline.

He loved it. He wasn't above accepting that. There was something about it, the smell, the sound, the destructive force at his fingertips that could kill him without question if he made the smallest mistake. It made him feel far more alive than anything else in the world had, and he had to physically bite back the laugh that was threatening to break from his lips as the smoke and dust billowed out from the open doorway, the other explosives on his person practically burning a hole through the bag, begging for him to throw another. He hunkered down, red eyes burning through the gloom, as he waited for the chaos.

He didn't have to wait long. Shigaraki was first on the scene, expletives following him as he waved the smoke away, Toga and that freaky fuck Jin coming up behind him. Toga, as fucking crazy as ever looked positively excited by the turn of events.

"What the hell?" Shigaraki coughed. "Jin, get in there."

"No way! *Sure thing, Tomura!*"

Katsuki kept himself pressed against the lockers, hardly daring to breathe as he watched them. Dabi wasn't there. Did that mean Shigaraki had ordered him to stay behind? That made things trickier, or ... his stomach twisted and the grin on his face was little less than sadistic at the dark thought that entered his mind, reaching into the bag at his side almost as if reassuring himself of the presence of two more explosives.

"The whole back wall is blown out!" he heard Jin yell, and the second that Shigaraki stepped into the gym he jumped from behind the lockers, sneaking away as quickly and quietly as he could and heading towards the chancellors office.

He wasn't the only one out. He could see other students, *ex-students* wondering outside of their departments, regardless of the enforced curfew, some panicking, others simply curious, and he darted past all of them without a second glance. Dabi had to be in the office ... he knew Shigaraki would have wanted to see what the noise was for himself, but he wasn't stupid enough as to leave their area of the campus unguarded. In fact, it was entirely likely that they knew it was a trap already, except their concern would be for the supplies they had hoarded, not for students escaping past curfew. He skidded to a halt outside of the doorway that Dabi had half dragged him out of not two weeks back, and without wasting another second he kicked it open.

"Should have known this would have something to do with you."

Dabi was leaning against the desk, almost as if he had been expecting him, his expression as cold and bored looking as it ever was.

"Yeh, well, maybe you should'a done something about it sooner," Katsuki said back, hand gripping onto the strap of the bag. He saw Dabi's blue eyes dart down to it, before searching his face again.

"What do you want, Bakugou?"

"I was just going to destroy this office," he replied, voice cool and calm despite the situation. "But now I've decided to destroy you as well."

Dabi's eyebrows rose, before he quirked the smallest smile.

"You're a fucking weird little shit, you know that?" he said. "I bet your threats and pick up lines are both the same, aren't they? I gotta be honest, Bakugou, I don't know if you're trying to kill me or *fuck* me half the time."

Katsuki scowled, bristling at the absurdity of Dabi's words, and the man's lips pulled back into a full on grin now, eyes sparkling with the kind of homicidal mirth he might one day grow to recognised in the mirror ...

"Tell you what, how about we call this whole thing off and deal with the obvious tension between us instead?" He raised a thin arm, gesturing between the two of them.

"Go to hell," Katsuki spat back.

Dabi laughed then. "We're already there, kid."

There was yelling from the hallway outside and Katsuki started, glancing over his shoulder half expecting to see Shigaraki and his two psychos bursting into the room, but that was all the distraction Dabi needed to take advantage of the situation, and before Katsuki knew it the taller man was on him, swinging down hard with the nail encrusted baseball bat that was already caked in dry old blood.

Katsuki dodged. His reaction times were fast, faster than Dabi had expected perhaps going on the look of frustration that crossed his pale face as Katsuki rolled to the side, the bat missing the top of his skull by a matter of inches.

"Fucker," Dabi snarled, turning on his heel to try and swipe out at Katsuki a second time.

It wasn't the first time someone had made a mistake like this. Katsuki was used to be underestimated by those bigger, older than him. His parents had been far from poor growing up, but he'd still grown up in the kind of neighbourhood where walking around alone at night was ill advised, and he'd been in far more fights than he could count by this point in his life. And if there was one thing that he'd learned early on ... there was no such thing as honour in a brawl. His opponents never took it easy on him, whether he was younger, smaller, and he wore his scrappiness like a badge of honour, and when Dabi tried to hit him a second time, a familiar heat filled his chest. He turned, lips pulled back into a snarl, before he bodily threw himself at the man, head ducking beneath his arms as he shoved him to the ground, the bat in his hand clattering to the ground and bouncing away from them.

"Fuck!" Dabi repeated, trying to shove him back even as Katsuki pinned him down, thighs either side of his waist before punching down on the taller man's jaw, grin manic.

"How'd you like that, asshole?" Katsuki yelled, punching him again, Dabi reaching out with his long forearms and pressing his hands against Katsuki's face, gripping with sharp fingers as he tried to wrench his nose, his ears, anything he could fucking reach. Katsuki swore as Dabi grabbed and chunk of his hair and wrenched as hard as he could, tearing the hair as Katsuki felt something warm immediately flow down his temple. He punched again, this time catching Dabi in the side of the face just as Dabi brought one of his legs up with such speed that it cracked against the back of his skull, stars forming in his eyes.

Dazed, he felt himself thrown sideways, and then Dabi was on him. He was thin, sure, but there was a wiry strength about the guy that immediately enveloped itself around Katsuki's throat, and he kicked with his heels as he felt the grip tighten.

"I'm going to fucking kill you!" Dabi hissed, his voice hoarse, blood spraying across Katsuki face, and Katsuki did the only remaining thing he could think of, hand thrust into the bag at his side before he pulled out one of the grenade shaped devices and holding it up to the side of his face.

"Not before I blow you to fucking pieces," he managed over the hands wrapped around his throat, and for a moment Dabi hesitated, looking at the explosive as if it was some joke before his eyes widened.

He was mercifully released, Dabi pushing back, panting heavily as he backed towards his desk, Katsuki realising with a cruel pleasure that, in their fight, it was he that had ended up between Dabi and the only exit. He grinned, blood dripping down his face.

"Don't fucking move."

He stepped forward, his thumb pressed deliberately on the pin so that Dabi couldn't miss a single movement, those cold blue eyes darting between Katsuki, the explosive, and the exit as he tried to formulate his own escape plan. Katsuki inched closer to the bat on the floor, before snatching it with his spare hand.

"You ain't gonna be needing this any more."

"If you use that bomb you're going to need much more than that to protect you," Dabi replied, voice now unusually steady.

"I'll take my chances."

"They'll kill you. They'll kill you and the rest of your little group."

"You begging or something?" Katsuki sneered. "What, I let you go and we forget the whole thing? Something like that?"

Dabi laughed hollowly and shook his head.

"Nah. Whether you kill me now or let me go, you're all still dead. We'll kill you ourselves."

Katsuki's jaw clenched, glaring back at Dabi, his heart pounding. He didn't have to do it. He knew he didn't have to do it. He could walk away. Just walk away and not become a murderer that day. But his mind flashed back to the cruel grin on Dabi's lips as he was beaten, to Jirou and Mina and the fear he felt each day that something would happen to either of them, to Kaminari wincing in pain, and all uncertainty was gone. There was nothing to think about. He knew what he had to do.

He backed up, keeping his hand around the explosive, until he reached the door.

"I've got no problem killing every last one of you," he said, before flicking the pin free. Dabi's eyes widened before he jumped behind the large ornate desk just as Katsuki threw the explosive, stepping out and shutting the door behind him. He heard a yell, before a blast so strong that it blasted the door back out on itself and threw Katsuki across the hallway followed, his ears ringing and his mouth gasping over ash and smoke. There was more screaming, a high female voice he recognised, and he clambered to his feet, running off down the hallway, towards the front gate, not looking back.

"Bakugou!"

Mina's voice was hysterical when she saw him, and he supposed he probably did look a state ... covered in ash, blood down one side of his face, Dabi's blood stained bat in one hand.

"Are you ok?"

"Fine," Katsuki panted, gripping hold of the thick iron bars of the gate, and looking back towards the campus, where smoke was visible billowing out of one side.

"You don't look fine," Sero said now, stepping forward and grabbing Katsuki's chin so he could angle his face around, ignoring Katsuki's snarls of protest. "Jesus, man, what the hell happened there?"

"Get off me," Katsuki snapped, slapping Sero's hand away. "Told you, I'm fine! Just ran into Dabi on the way out."

"Is that what the second explosion was about?" Kaminari asked, eyes wide. For a moment, Katsuki debated not telling them, at least not until they were far enough away from this god forsaken place, but they had to know. Hell, they all probably deserved to know.

"Yeh," he replied firmly, eyes flashing between each of them as if daring one of them to challenge him, question him further. Kaminari's mouth snapped shut, averting his gaze. There was a stiff movement, Katsuki's eyes darting down as he saw Kaminari reach out and wrap a hand around

Jirou's wrist, and sure perhaps it could have been written off as coincidence, but Katsuki absolutely did not miss the way that Dunce Face pulled her towards him, *away from Katsuki*. He grit his teeth.

"Let's get out of here before the rest of them come after us," he said. "This way."

In silence, the group followed him, the cover of darkness enough to keep them virtually invisible as they kept close to the walls and curbs. The safe house that Katsuki had marked out wasn't especially far from here, but it was entirely likely that the explosions at the university would attract the rotting flesh bags, and he wanted to avoid them as much as possible. Luck, however, seemed to be on their side, as they didn't see a single one of them; Shigaraki didn't seem to be following them, the ground was wet from a rain storm that had conveniently stopped as they'd left the campus, and although Katsuki had run into Dabi, he wasn't entirely sure that had been bad luck ... hell, there was a certain dark pride thrumming in his chest at the thought, a pride that probably should have worried him. He didn't feel bad. He didn't feel fucking bad *at all*. The fuck did that say about him?

"How much farther, Baku?" Sero asked, and Katsuki came to a stop, looking back at them, and wiping the blood that was slowly trickling back into his eye away with the back of his wrist.

"Not far," he replied, glancing up and down the street.

"I haven't seen a single one of those ... things," Jirou said. "Is this normal?"

Katsuki frowned.

"They're probably attracted to the explosions or something," he said. Because it *was* weird ... he'd been lucky not to come across any particularly large groups of them, but he sure as shit wasn't used to seeing none at all. "Maybe they're just not in the area any more."

"You won't hear me complaining," Kirishima said with a short laugh.

"We gotta go down that street, then there's a sharp turn left where we can climb up on top of the buildings. Safe house is on the roof."

"Ooh, good thinking Bakugou!" Mina said with a toothy grin. Katsuki rolled his eyes as they set off again, walking down the long street, the final stretch before safety.

Of course, if there was one thing that could be guaranteed in the Apocalypse, it was that there was no such thing as safety, and what would meet them when they turned down the alleyway in which the ladder to the rooftop could be found, would remain as a hard learned lesson in complaicency. A hard lesson in that the dead owned the streets, and their abscense was just as terrifying as their presence.

The gasp that broke Mina's lip was loud in the silence of the streets, the muttered *'oh god'*, from Kirishima might as well have been a shout. Ahead of them, crowded at the far end of the alley way, was the biggest collection of zombies that Katsuki or any of them had ever seen, their bodies pressed together, arms raised in the air, some climbing on top of others as they tried to reach for something, a sight that Katsuki would never forgot. Hanging from a balcony with fairy lights wrapped around their throats, their bodies swaying and tugging as the zombies snatched at them, their legs missing from the knees down, were a man and a woman. For a moment, Katsuki couldn't move, just staring as shocked as the rest of them, until the sound of someone vomiting on the floor grabbed his attention and he started. Unfortunately, the sound or smell or fucking something also

garnered the attention of the zombies, as one by one they turned their heads, empty or rotting eye sockets fixing on them, heads swaying in interest.

"S-sorry," Kaminari croaked.

"Ladder. Ladder now!" Katsuki hissed, grabbing Mina and pushing her forward. "Go!"

He pulled the bat from where it was hanging from his belt, positioning himself in front of the ladder, between his friends and the hoard that was starting to move, having decided that the living breathing prey behind them was suddenly much more interesting than the bodies hanging above.

"Bakugou-"

"Just hurry up!"

It was perhaps fortunate that the zombies were so closely packed together, because as they started to rush forward, most of them fell over, starting a chain reaction where dead beat after dead beat piled up, but there were some breaking through, dragging broken limbs behind them, mouths wide and silently screaming, cracked and blooded fingers scrambling across the asphalt. Katsuki would like to say that he felt fearless in that moment, but truthfully he had never been more fucking terrifed in his entire life as he stood there, knees slightly bent, bat held forward in shaking hands, until he heard a yell from his left.

"Bakugou climb!"

He looked sideways, Kirishima and Kaminari on the ladder, the latter holding his hand out for him, and Katsuki darted towards them, shoving the bat back into his belt as he grabbed the blondes hand, and jumped up onto the ladder.

"Go go!" Kaminari screamed as Kirishima hurried up the ladder in front of them, Katsuki only just able to pull his leg away before the first zombie launched itself at him, hitting the bottom of the ladder so hard it shook. He heard Mina scream, and looked up.

"Hold on!"

The ladder was long, passing through three seperate balconies before it reached the rooftop, and it would be a long ass fall if any of them slipped. He saw Mina gripping the ladder from far above him, almost as if she was frozen in place, before Jirou called to her.

"You've got this, Mina! It's ok, you can do it!"

Mina whimpered and nodded, before she started to climb again, the rest of them following her, Katsuki looking up at his friends and down at the zombies below them. He honestly had no idea if they could climb or not, he saw one of them reach up high enough to grab hold of the first step, but it's bloodied hand slipped off and it collapsed down onto it's neighbour.

"Let's get to fucking stepping, shall we!" Katsuki yelled, cursing as another zombie tried to jump up and reach the frame. Katsuki glared upwards, checking their progress, just as Kirishima yelped, staring back down at the ground.

"Holy shit they can climb!"

Katsuki's heart leaped into his throat as he looked back down again, and sure enough one of them had grabbed hold, this one in better condition than the rest, fresher perhaps, the muscles in it's arms visible bulging and twisting as it pulled itself up the first few rungs of the ladder, dead eyes rolling back in it's head as it's teeth snapped after them.

"Mother*fuckers*," Katsuki snarled. "We'll kick 'em down when we get to the top!"

Mina, Jirou, and Sero had almost reached the third and final balcony as Katsuki cleared the first, swearing furiously under his breath with each step, before the ladder shook beneath him, as more zombies grabbed hold, and he pressed his body flush against it as the entire ladder seemed to sway and shriek under the weight.

"Jirou!"

He looked up, only realising then that the shriek wasn't the ladder, Jirou having slipped or something, losing her grip on the ladder. He saw Sero reach out to grab her, almost falling himself, but her foot collided with his face, knocking him aside as she fell, her body arching outwards and out of the reach of Kirishima and Kaminari who threw their hands out for her next.

"Jirou!"

Katsuki jumped from the ladder onto the balcony below, hand outstretch as Jirou reached for him, their hands connected before the both of them were yanked hard onto the metal railing of the balcony, Katsuki yelling out in pain as he was sure he felt his ribs crack under the impact, Jirou's skull colliding with the underside of the balcony with an audible crack.

"Jirou!"

He panted, looking down. Jirou was still gripping his hand tight, but there was blood running down the side of her face, she blinking and looking back up at him in confusion.

"I got ya," he huffed, reaching over with his other hand so he could grab hers. "Hey, you alright?"

"Y-yeh," Jirou muttered back, though her voice was slurred. "F-fine."

"I'm gonna pull you up!"

"Katsuki!" he heard Kaminari yelling, frantic.

"I got 'er, moron!" he yelled back, as he began to pull, Jirou's body thankfully light, before suddenly the girl was screaming again, and Katsuki looked down in panic, watching as one of the zombies on the ladder reached out and grabbed hold of her ankle.

"Shit-"

The zombie was pulled from the ladder by the swing of Jirou's body, and he saw Jirous eyes's widen in pain and shock as it began to haul itself up, fingers visibly digging into the skin of her leg and drawing blood.

"Bakugou," she whimpered.

"Kick it off," he panted, trying not to think about the blood.

"I can't," she replied. "I can't ... my legs they won't ... I can't-"

Katsuki had no fucking idea what was going on, but the pain in Jirou's eyes was real enough for him to start hauling, yelling over the pain in his rib cage as he heaved her and the zombie upwards. He could hear the sound of metal as Kaminari and perhaps Kirishima hurried back down to help him, before there was another scream, this time Kirishima.

"Bakugou look out!"

He didn't have the time to react before a weight fell into his side and pain flooded his system as if the entire right side of his torso had cramped up, the sensation sharp and sickening, and he looked down to see that a zombie had obviously been attracted by the noise, wandering out onto the balcony before sinking it's teeth deep into the flesh on Katsuki's side.

"No!"

An eery silence washed over him, as he felt the zombie opening it's mouth wide before sinking it's teeth in again, mouth tearing and pulling as if intent to pull his insides right out of him, somehow indifferent to the pain now and only on the tug on his arms as Jirou swung. He looked away from the zombie at his side, down to the girl below him, her eyes wide and full of tears as she looked at the zombie now eating him, before they slowly connected back with his own.

"No ..."

He might have been the one speaking in that moment, over the screaming of his friends, but he wasn't certain. He wasn't certain of anything besides the look in Jirous eyes as she stared back at him.

"No, Jirou ..."

"It's ok," Jirou breathed, so quietly, so softly, her face only minutely registering the pain as he saw the zombie hanging from her foot now bite down into her ankle.

"Don't," Katsuki croaked. He was being eaten, he could feel a chunk of his flesh torn free, but he couldn't register, couldn't register anything other than Jirou's hand reach and and pry his weakning fingers away from her own.

"*Jirou, don't do it!*" he screamed.

There was someone else at his side, reaching forward, but Jirou only smiled up, tears leaking down her cheeks as she wrenched her hand free and fell.

"NO!"

She fell into the mass of zombies, her body disappearing instantly under a sea of bodies, and the world stood still, Katsuki just hanging there over the railings, his arms still reaching out for her, blood and tears obscuring his vision.

"-go, man!"

He felt someone grabbing him, something heavy falling past him, the zombie that had been connected to his side thrown over the balcony and down into the mass of death below.

"Come on!"

"I had her," Katsuki whispered, voice shaking and unable to look away. "I had her ..."

"You're bleeding out, man! Come on!"

He felt hands roughly grabbing his face, turning him sound, before amber eyes filled his vision, Kaminari hlding his cheeks, his own face wet with tears.

"We need to go," he said, and Katsuki nodded numbly, almost falling fast first into the other man's chest as he tried to take a step forward, the pain in his side finally hitting him.

Kaminari and Kirishima half carried him up the ladder, Katsuki's grip growing weaker by the second, until finally they made the top, Mina and Sero heaving him upwards onto the roof, where his body completely collapsed beneath him, mind going blank as the blood pooled out around him.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 13: Grave Times

Chapter Summary

In which there are revelations, and boy are they painful.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I don't remember much after that."

It had grown dark, the rain though passed leaving a suffocating humidity that only added to the thick atmosphere in the car. Bakugou was staring forward, his eyes having not really focused on anything for a while now, as Izuku leaned against the back of the passenger seat, cheek pressed against the head rest, heart thumping and hands shaking as Bakugou shared the horrifying details of his friend's death. Of his own attack.

"I guess they found the safe house pretty quick after ... fuck, they must have otherwise I'd have just bled out on the roof. I mean, you know how it goes-" he waved his hand in an almost off hand manner, -"fever and shit, I was out of it for weeks. Apparently I told them to off me a bunch of times, and they were fucking idiots not to." He said that with a surprising degree of vehemence, his voice shaking a fraction. "I mean, fuck, I should have died, right? I should have died and fucking turned and I could have killed them and they just left me alive. For weeks."

Bakugou shifted in his seat, kicking his feet up on the console again as his arms crossed over his chest, eyes darting to the side in a sour look, and Izuku stayed silent, not trusting himself to speak.

"It was about a month before I could do anything after that. The bite fucked up one of my kidneys, so week after we started moving again I was out with another infection. And, I suppose because those morons were trying to look out for me I didn't realised they'd been hiding from fucking Dabi and Shigaraki that whole goddamn time either. I don't think I'd ever been so pissed in my entire life than when I found out that asshole was still alive."

"Explains the burns," Izuku muttered, speaking for the first time since Bakugou started his tale, and he was startled to see Bakugou jump slightly, as if he had almost forgotten that Izuku was in the car with him. He felt red eyes assess him for a moment, averted before Izuku could look back at them.

"Mhm," Bakugou grunted. "So that's that. That's how I got the fucking bite and got my friend killed. Glad you asked?"

The last part came out bitterly, but Izuku was sure that it wasn't really aimed at him. But glad? *Glad?* There wasn't a single part of him that was glad about any of this, and a part of him resented his asking, resented pushing Bakugou to explain, to share, because the look of pure agony that passed over his face, a look that he was sure Bakugou wasn't even aware he was making, shook him to his core. No, that wasn't right ... it hadn't shaken him, so much as tore open his goddamn soul as Bakugou's was laid out bare before him. Because he knew ... he *knew* how much it would

have destroyed *him* if he had had to watch Uraraka, Tsu ... if he'd had to watch any of his friends die like that. And he knew, because he was no fucking different, that he would never stop blaming himself for it.

"I don't know why I'm still alive," Bakugou said then, his voice far quieter and distant, like he had forgotten Izuku was there again. "It's so fucked up. A fucking zombie tried to tear out my kidney and I'm still alive? I still get to live whilst Jirou ... Hanta- and it was my fault. It was my fucking idea!"

"You had to," Izuku said, interrupting, recognising the spiral Bakugou was about to take. "You couldn't stay here. You had to get them out."

"Bullshi-"

"You had to," Izuku repeated firmer, reaching forward in a moment of braveness and stupidity, perhaps, and placing a hand on Bakugou's shoulder. The man jumped again, looking around at him, the whites of his red eyes raw and his face scrunched up with repressed emotions.

"You don't fucking get it, Deku!" he yelled, reaching out and shoving Izuku away.

"No, I do get it," Izuku insisted, and at that Bakugou laughed, a short cold bark the shook the car.

"Really? Because then by now you've worked out that your friends are dead because of me, right? They're only out there with a vendetta because I tried to smoke their asses."

Izuku took a deep breath. Bakugou was looking at him now, insistent, staring at him like he was daring Izuku to argue, or maybe like he was begging for him to agree, and Izuku recognised something then; this man was broken, in far more ways than one. He felt he was responsible, and yet no one had ever held him accountable for his actions, for his choices, and he couldn't forgive himself, couldn't move on until someone tore him down, prideful brick by prideful brick, and laid all of the blame on him. The drinking, the violence, was that all so that he could drive his friends away? So that they would finally take it out on him and leave him behind like he wished they had done right at the start?

"I'm not going to blame you, Kacchan," Izuku said, his voice soft.

Bakugou flinched, physically flinched, at that before his lips curled back into a snarl.

"Why the fuck not?" he yelled, leaning forward and getting in Izuku's face. "Jirou's dead because of me! She's dead because I fucking strong armed them all into leaving with me, because I couldn't even fucking hold onto her-" his voice cracked, tears swimming in his burned red eyes, only for him to growl and snatch at the front of Izuku's hoody. "And you? I tried to fucking kill you! I tried to throttle you, I've been a complete dick to you! The hell you still here for, hah?"

Izuku swallowed, meeting Bakugou's glare, refusing to look away.

"You're not going to push me away," he said. "You don't think you deserve them? Deserve to still have me around? Then leave. You wanna leave, Bakugou then fucking leave. You've always had that choice. But you can't keep pushing people away, tormenting them and hurting them until they make the damn choice for you!"

Bakugou's mouth snapped shut, his eyes widening and burning with unshed tears.

"You're a dick," Izuku continued. "And I'm willing to bet you were a dick before the world ended. But you care, Kacchan. You care, and yeh you can't make the right decision each and every time, and you're going to make mistakes and hell the cost of those mistakes are going to be high, but you took on that responsibility because you love them. Because you know, as well as I do, that no one else could have done it."

Bakugou was breathing heavily, his expression almost frightened as he looked back at him, eyes darting quickly across Izuku's face.

"You didn't die from the bite, Kacchan, but you still gave your damn life for them. Hell, there was a zombie *eating* you and you still wouldn't let go, and maybe you think they should blame you for that but how could they? Jesus, I don't know how else to put this ... they've already watched you die, you get that? Everyone knows what a bite means, and the second that zombie got to you they knew you'd already died for them."

"That doesn't ... it can't-"

"You want someone to blame you for everything? Well, it ain't gonna happen. But you know what is going to happen? You're going to get a hold of yourself, and we're going to find your friends, and you're going to keep protecting them."

Bakugou swallowed, his hands shaking around the grip on the front of Izuku's clothes, a single tear sliding down his cheek almost out of shock than anything else. And before Izuku really knew what was going on, before he could break the man's grip, he was being yanked forward, his mouth smacking against Bakugou's with such force that he was sure his lip probably split, letting out a muffled yelp as somehow unsurprisingly rough and chapped lips moved against his.

It was ... well, it was bad. He could hardly call it a kiss, it was more like Bakugou had viciously punched him in the mouth with his own, but goddamn did his traitorous heart sour anyway, his breath hitch and his fingers immediately reach up to curl around Bakugou's wrist before he was pushed away so roughly that his back thudded against the side of the car. He grabbed the back of his aching skull with another yelp, looking over at Bakugou with watering eyes.

The blonde was frozen again, eyes wide and clearly horrified at what had just happened, jaw so tightly clenched that he could hear his teeth grinding together from halfway across the car.

"Shit."

Izuku blinked, rubbing his head, before a curious flash of anger filled his chest. Izuku was far from an exemplary example of social graces and extroversion, hell he'd been an anxious muttering mess his entire life and he sure as hell wasn't an example to *anyone,* but Bakugou was something else. The guy was a complete and utter disaster, that much had been evident from the first time he met him, and yet he still kept finding himself amazed at just how much one person could keep messing up so badly when it came to interacting with another fucking human being. And sure. *Sure* he did have a thing for the stupid asshole, with outgrown shitty undercut now an explosion of spikes around his head, his bad fashion sense and poorly concealed and entirely unfairly sculpted body ... his ugly ass laugh, and matching expressions on his beautiful sweaty face. Maybe a part of him really did want to throw himself into the front seat, clamber on top of his lap, and grind his way into oblivion like the senseless horny teenage he apparently had reverted back to. But another part, a big part, was furious.

"What the hell was that!" he found himself spluttering, as Bakugou groaned and threw himself back around in the front seat, grabbing the hood of his sweater and pulling it roughly down over his spikes.

"Nothing. Fuck off. Forget it happened."

"Forget it happened?" Izuku repeated, incredulous. "Are you shitting me?"

Bakugou snarled, yanking his hood back and twisting in his seat so fast that Izuku leaned back away from him, the man's expression manic.

"The hell's your problem?" he snapped. "You're the asshole flirting with me! You bitching about a fucking hand-out kiss now?"

"A hand- That wasn't a kiss that was a punch in the face!" Izuku all but shrieked.

"Fuck you, Deku!"

Izuku laughed almost hysterically. "If that was your idea of a kiss then I dread to think what that would be like!"

Bakugou hesitated again, his mouth snapping shut at the comment, the two of them just staring at one another somewhat desperately, Izuku wanting to make sense of what was going on and Bakugou ... well, Izuku kinda got the sense he felt the same goddamn way going by the mortified cut of lips and the way his ears still burned bright red.

"You goddamn asshole," hw spat out. "I'll fucking kill you for real don't think I won't!"

"What, by kissing me?" Izuku snapped back, unable to stop himself, and something passed over Bakugou's face, a twitching of his lips, before the man was wrenching himself away from him again and thudding into the front seat with an ugly laugh. Confused, Izuku slumped back down in the boot, watching the man carefully as he grabbed the blanket and pulled it self-consciously over himself.

"Ah, fuck," Bakugou breathed, raising a hand to wipe the tears from his eyes. "Look, really. Fucking forget about it, Deku. I was just emotional or whatever, ain't gonna happen again."

Izuku did not like the rush of disappointment he felt at those words, but he pushed it aside, huffing a breath.

"I feel like you confuse someone being nice to you with someone flirting with you," he grumbled.

"Yeh, perhaps you're right, Deks," Bakugou replied, with a large yawn. "It's whatever."

"Whatever ..."

"Get some sleep, we got a lot of walking to do tomorrow."

Izuku didn't answer, just sighing as he pulled the blanket higher up his chest, watching Bakugou from the corner of his eye for a moment before the blonde shut his eyes, pulling his hood back over his head again, feet up on the dashboard.

They didn't mention the kiss again after that, Bakugou shaking him awake at some god awful time in the morning, the sun still not yet risen, the two of them cleaning and re-bandaging Izuku's burn before grabbing something high in preservatives for breakfast. Izuku wanted to forget about it, he really really did, but despite their current situation, despite the miles and miles of tarmac ahead of them, the dwindling water supplies and fatigue in his limbs, he was having a real hard time not think about it.

Because, really, Izuku must be crazy. Either crazy or desperate. Maybe crazy, desperate, and horny if he was still so attracted to the blonde after all of this. He was a grade A asshole with a drinking problem (*though Izuku had to admit he hadn't seen him pick up a drink once since the RV*) and a questionable personality at the very best. He was sweaty, filthy, loud and frankly a bad kisser, and in all Izuku felt that he was justified in expecting the combination of all of these things to be a huge turn off for him. But, instead, he was thinking about the minute slide of lips against his before they were yanked away, the effortless way Bakugou threw the heavy pack over his shoulder, hoody tied around his unreasonably narrow waist for a man with shoulders as broad as his, and wondering just what would Bakugou do if he charged over there, grabbed his stupid *'extra salty'* shirt, and yanked him to *his* lips instead. It was maddening at best, torture at worst, and Izuku really wished he could just have a sit down with himself and ask why, *why him?*

"Oi, dickweed, the hell you standing around for?"

Why? Izuku rubbed the back of his head, and followed after the broad back ahead of him, irritated beyond belief by how good his ass looked in what were, essentially, shapeless mum jeans of the worst kind.

It was just a physical attraction, he told himself as he walked. It didn't matter what kind of person he was, because Izuku was two years cold turkey on his sex life and Bakugou was attractive, in much the same way that he'd admire the jocks back at school but not really intend to do anything more about it than that. Except, hell, it wasn't just that, was it? Because before Bakugou went into full disaster mode, there was a part of him that felt warm that Bakugou was finally comfortable enough to share his traumatic backstory with him.

Because he's a friend, Izuku thought firmly. Of course he wanted the man to open up to him! In much the same way that he had wanted any of them to feel safe and comfortable around him, and it was a particularly good feeling with Bakugou because they hadn't the best start to their friendship.

Except he didn't get that thrill in his stomach when any of the others had shared bits about their lives. He didn't feel excited and nauseous each and every time they looked at him.

Face it, he thought miserably. You like this guy. Like, *like him* like him. And sure he might be a shitty kisser and there was the zombie bite shaped elephant in the room that would make ... *other* things problematic to say the least, but he still wanted to be around him. Still wanted to kiss him again. For real, he was fucked.

"The hell, Deku? You need to rest already?"

Izuku looked up, Bakugou stopping just ahead of him with his hands on his hips, scowling back, and he realised that he really had been dragging his heels, lost in thought. He shook his head.

"Sorry, coming."

Bakugou grunted, and carried on his way, Izuku following after him with a knot the size of a damn melon sitting heavily in his stomach.

They didn't say much else for the rest of that day, except for when Izuku asked if they could stop and rest, and as night started to fall he gratefully dropped down into the back seats of another unlocked car that they'd scoped out, too exhausted to say much more than a grumbled thanks after they'd cleaned and re-bandaged his arm.

The next day Izuku was feeling considerably worse. He supposed two full days of walking was a lot more than his body could really handle, and he woke feeling as though someone had spent the night jumping up and down on his limbs and twisting his joints. It wasn't enough to stop him from walking, a task that he took seriously when it was all he could really offer to their partnership at this time, and he insisted that he was perfectly fine when Bakugou almost vehemently pointed out his limp. If he needed to slow down or take a break, he'd take a break. But that didn't stop Bakugou glaring shrewdly at him as they walked, occasionally muttering something that sounded suspiciously like *'fucking moron'* under his breath.

But, on the positive side, they were nearing close to the point where Bakugou had buried the supplies and, and if Izuku just grit his teeth and kept going, they should be able to reach it by mid afternoon. After then? Well, Izuku decided it best not to think any further ahead than that.

My some miracle, Izuku was able to push himself, and yeh he might have taken a few more breaks than he had done the previous day, but Bakugou seemed to have the good graces not to be a dick about it, and they'd narrowed in on the spot where the blonde had buried several days worth of supplies.

"You definitely sure it's this spot?" Izuku asked, and if he was panting then neither of them acknowledged it. Bakugou turned around sharply, an ugly scowl on his face.

"Of course I'm fucking sure!" he yelled. "What you think I'm an idiot?"

"No!" Izuku protested, holding his hands up. "It's just ... well, this part of road looks the same as all the others."

"All except for the upturned orange sports car you dumb fuck," Bakugou snarled, spreading his arm and gesturing to the vehicle, the driver obviously having tried to use the curb to get past the line of cars already blocking the road, only to have rolled into the verge.

"Alright, alright, sorry jeeze," Izuku replied with a heavy puff of air. Bakugou glared at him for a tense moment longer, before scoffing and storming off to the verge. The second Bakugou was out of eye sight, he let out a groan, pressing the heels of his hands against his eyes. He was exhausted, his head hurt, his joints hurt, he was having a real hard time thinking straight, and truthfully he was so ready to lie down and probably not move again for a solid twelve hours. To make matters worse, there was a sort of vibration in his ears, a low insistent hum that he was sure meant he had a fucking migraine or something coming. Because that was exactly what he needed.

It took him a beat to realise that, actually, the humming wasn't coming from his own head. And it was getting louder. His eyes snapped open, hands dropping to his sides as he spun around, looking back the way they came. He caught something flashing, the dimming sunlight glinting off something faraway that was definitely in motion, and his heart sunk.

"Bakugou?"

"What?" he heard the blonde snap from behind the verge.

"I think there's someone coming."

Bakugou was up in an instant, clambering up onto the road with a wide-eyed expression on his face.

"Where?" he snapped, standing beside Izuku and shielding his eyes with his hand and squinting back down the road.

"Uh, a good minute away or- I could see light bouncing off a car."

Bakugou didn't respond for a moment, the two of them just staring, waiting for the flash of light, before it came again, bright and clear, illuminating the shape of a vehicle winding it's way through the static traffic along the motorway.

"Shit," Bakugou hissed, lowering his hand, his lips puckering into a pout.

"You think it's them?" Izuku asked, his voice hushed. Bakugou's eyelids visibly twitched at this, and he glanced sideways at him.

"Well we ain't standing out in the open with our thumbs up our asses waiting to find out," he said, before reaching and grabbing Izuku's wrist, perhaps far harder than was entirely necessary. "Come on."

He dragged him off the road, Bakugou roughly kicked the mud he had already dug up back over the bright orange carrier bag that Izuku presumed contained the supplies Bakugou had buried, before grabbing a piece of cardboard and throwing it over the disturbed dirt. But the car was already far closer than Izuku had realised, the sound of it revving now loud in his ears, and with another curse Bakugou grabbed him again and yanked him down behind the upturned sports car, the two of them pressing themselves flush against the metal, hunkering down as best as they could, Izuku holding back the grunt of pain as his bad arm connected roughly with the car.

They stayed silent as the car came closer, Izuku just silently hoping that whoever it was wasn't going to stop, that they'd just sail right on past and Izuku could collapse into whatever unlocked car was the closest, but as seemed to be the case all too often, luck definitely wasn't on their side, and it was to another of Bakugou's foul curses that they heard the car come to a stop, before the sound of heavy doors opening and closing met them.

"I told you something wasn't right with that tire," came a low drab voice that Izuku recognised instantly, his heart hammering wildly in his chest as he felt Bakugou stiffen up beside him.

"Well why didn't you fix it?" came another cold and irritated voice. Izuku glanced across at Bakugou, the blonde sitting with his teeth visibly grit, his hands fists, his face starting to burn with rage.

"Jin knows how to fix these things, don't you Jin?" It was the girls voice now.

"Anything for you little lady," Jin responded, to her giggles.

"There's a spare tire in the boot," Dabi offered.

"What a waste of my fucking time," they heard Shigaraki hiss, a soft thud as if someone had dropped onto something metal followed, before the tell tale creak of a boot being opened.

"We've hardly got any appointments to get to," Dabi replied, with a short laugh. "Stop being so melodramatic."

"Pot, kettle, black! *Shh butt out!*"

"That's right, stick that butt out!"

"What is wrong with you?"

"Let's just get on with it shall we?" Shigaraki snapped. "Dabi, see if there's anything useful in those cars."

"If you say so, *boss*," Dabi replied, the smirk obvious in his tone, the sound of feet crunching against tarmac loud in Izuku's ears. Bakugou was shaking beside him, and he knew it was taking all of the man's restraint not to jump out there right now. If he'd had a weapon, Izuku was pretty sure he would have already done so by now, but it didn't matter how badly either of them wanted to get back at them for the shit they pulled, the two of them wouldn't stand much of a chance unarmed against the four of them.

"How many more times we gonna drive up and down this road anyway?" Toga asked.

"Until I'm certain that those assholes aren't here," Shigaraki replied shortly.

"They still might all be dead," Jin spoke up, voice muffled from where he must have his face in the boot.

"Dead people don't make graves," Dabi said now, his voice a little further off, and Bakugou flinched at Izuku's side. "At least one of them survived."

"Yeh, they were alive two weeks ago," Toga said. "Doesn't mean they are now."

"They're alive," Shigaraki said. "Someone's been looting all the unlocked cars along this road. Someone smart enough to know not to break the windows."

"Bakugou better be alive," Dabi growled, now suddenly sounding colder and fierce. "Only way that fucker gets to die is when I kill him myself."

Bakugou growled low in his throat, his body twitching with the lure of the challenge, and Izuku had to reach across and grab the front of his shirt to stop the guy from jumping to his feet, shaking his head. Bakugou glared at him, his upper lip curling, but mercifully didn't make to push Izuku off of him.

"Ooh tough guy," Toga laughed.

"Shove off, bitch."

"Dabi stop being an asshole," Shigaraki said with a bored yawn. "If Bakugou's still alive then he won't be for long."

"I don't think the rest of them are even fucking smart enough to survive out here on their own," Dabi continued. "I'd be real shocked if it's one of the other morons still out here."

"I dunno, I reckon that cute one could have made it."

"Toga, you shouldn't play with your food," came Jin's voice.

"Real funny. Nah, that one with the green hair we didn't recognise."

Izuku's breath caught in his throat and he glanced back at Bakugou again, the blonde scowling, his expression tight as he strained to hear every word.

"He was the one they were all following when they left the house," Toga continued.

"Well, if he hasn't been with the group long then maybe we could use him," Shigaraki said.

"I'd rather just kill the fucker," Dabi muttered.

"When did you start getting so murderous, Dabi?"

"Yeh, speaking of which," Toga piped up, "I still can't believe you messed up your brother's face up like that. That seemed harsh even for our standards."

Izuku and Bakugou looked at one another. *Brother?*

"The hell else was I supposed to do? Just let him leave after wasting his group like that?"

"I know. Just seemed mean. He was pretty cute too."

"Shut up."

"Much cuter than you."

"I said stop talking."

"Tires done! I hate this job."

"Good. Let's get the hell out of here, shall we? I wanna do another sweep up to the city before camping for the night."

There was the sound of more footsteps across the road, a boot slamming shut and doors creaking, Izuku hardly daring to move least he get their attention right at the last minute, before the sound of the engine revving started back up again, the two of them staying where they were until the sound grew quiet.

The expression on Bakugou's face was quite something to behold, the sharp angle of his eyebrows on his still red face, and he furiously kicked an empty can across the road as soon as he climbed back up off the verge, his heaving as he glared in the direction the care had driven. Izuku swallowed, awkwardly standing to one side.

"You ... uh, ok?"

"Of course I'm not fucking ok!" Bakugou practically screamed immediately, rounding on him. "That fucker. Those fucking bastards! *Fuck!*"

He kicked more litter across the ground, and Izuku rubbed his aching arm uncomfortably, flinching at the display and the noise that echoed around them.

"We couldn't have done anything," he said, voice quiet. "If that's why you're so angry-"

"Yeh that's exactly why I'm fucking angry! They were right fucking there and I couldn't do shit!"

"Bakugou-"

"No fucking weapons, and your crippled ass to look out for! *Goddamnit.*"

Izuku fell silent, averting his gaze to look after the car as well, refusing to acknowledge the almost Pavlovian feeling of guilt that rushed through him before pushing it aside. Bakugou was just angry, emotional, it certainly wasn't his fault.

"Even with a weapon you couldn't have taken all four of them on," he said instead, and Bakugou snarled at him. "Look, it wasn't the right moment, ok? But we know they're out there, and that they're looking for us. That's more than we knew this morning."

Bakugou grunted.

"And, more than that, we also know that they haven't found the others. They're still out there, and smart enough to have avoided Dabi and the rest."

Bakugou's rage seemed to dissipate for a moment at that, glancing sideways at him before shrugging his shoulders somewhat dramatically and turning back to him. Izuku, however was busy thinking about something else that had been said.

"What's this about Dabi having a brother? Did you know that?"

The blonde huffed in disinterest. "No. And it doesn't really matter to us either way."

"But they said they took about another group," Izuku pointed out. "It sounded like he hurt his brother and killed his group ..."

"And what fucking use is that to us except to confirm what we already knew? That Dabi's one mean cocksucker. Forget about it, Deku, we got enough shit of our own."

"I guess ..."

But Izuku couldn't forget about it. He couldn't stop thinking about it, even as they climbed into the next unlocked car and Bakugou ordered him to get some fucking sleep. Couldn't stop his mind racing as he lay there in the dark, eyes wide open, hands playing with lose threading on the hem of his blanket.

"Hey, Kacchan."

Bakugou grunted irritably, his red eyes flashing in the dark. "Jesus, what?"

"Dabi ... what's his full name?"

"Hah? The hell you wanna know that for?"

"Just, please, answer me."

Bakugou eyed him for a moment longer, before he huffed. "I dunno his first name, Dabi is just a stupid fucking nickname he took on for himself. But it was Todoroki or something like that."

And just like that, Izuku's world was flipped on it's head all over again.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 14: A Ghoal In Mind

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku makes a choice and Bakugou is pissed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"But it was Todoroki or something like that."

Izuku felt as thought he'd been hit in the chest by a zombie. He felt as though the damn thing had proceeded to reach down his throat and pull his fucking heart out before eating it right in front of him. Todoroki ... *Shouto*, he was alive. Or, he had been. Dabi had killed his group, and he had injured Shouto and left him for dead. The blood ... it had been all over the place ... *I still can't believe you messed up your brother's face like that ... Shouto ...*

"Oi, what're you spacing out for?"

Izuku started, looking back up at Bakugou's confused red eyes, the man's lips tightened with something akin to irritation even under his concern.

"T-Todoroki," Izuku breathed. "Are you sure? Are you *definitely* sure?"

Bakugou scowled, eyes searching Izuku's face, before he scoffed. "When am I not fucking sure of anything, shitbag? I said I don't know his first name, but he was from some rich fucking family or something. Goddamn asshole-"

"Touya," Izuku interrupted. "Was it Touya?"

Bakugou's eyes narrowed, and he leaned forward, reaching out a hand and poking Izuku hard in the centre of his chest. "Alright, what fucking gives, Deku? Who is this guy to you?"

"I ... I've got to go!" Izuku whimpered, eyes widening with the realisation. Of course he had to go! He couldn't be *here*, couldn't be walking away from Shinagawa, not when there was even the smallest chance that Shouto was still back there. That he was alive. He was on his feet and pushing his way out of the door before Bakugou could even react, just looking at him with slack-jawed astonishment, before he too was scrabbling against the seats.

"What the fuck?" he yelled, following Izuku out onto the road. "Go? Go *where*?"

"Back," Izuku replied, grabbing a bottle of water and shoving it into the deep pocket of his hoody. "I ... I have to go back ... I can't just ..."

"Tell me what's going on!"

Bakugou was in front of him, face furious and fists held aloft, almost as if he was ready to punch an answer out of Izuku if he didn't offer it then and there.

"It's Shouto!" Izuku yelled back, his voice almost definitely tinged with desperation. Bakugou almost flinched.

"Your fucking boyfriend?" he growled sourly. "What's he got to do with anything?"

"He's the brother," Izuku replied breathlessly. "*Shouto Todoroki*."

Bakugou didn't say anything for a moment, just blinking back at him, before his lips curled and he glared sideways. "Are you fucking kidding me?" he muttered.

"So now I know," Izuku continued, his hands shaking and his heart pounding. "Now I know they're ... they're dead and that group-"

"So the hell you going back for?" Bakugou's voice was strangely muted, emotionless, his face tight and he watched Izuku from the corner of his eyes.

"Because that crazy girl said that he just injured Shouto! They killed them and then left him, so he's back there. He's back there somewhere and I have to find him."

Bakugou laughed, actually *laughed,* the sound somewhat hysterical as he raised a hand to his hairline, making a mess of the already long shocking blonde spikes.

"Shit, Deku, that's the most moronic thing you've said yet."

It was surprising that it had taken this long, that his first gut reaction when he realised who it was that Dabi had beaten and left for dead wasn't the rage that now swirled through him, and in an instant he was stepping forward. He shoved Bakugou so hard and so suddenly in the chest that the man took a huge step backward.

"What's your fucking problem!" he yelled, Bakugou looking both shocked and furious, his teeth gnashing as he visibly seemed to hold back from punching Izuku straight in the face. "I just found out my friend could still be alive and you're ... you're acting like it doesn't even matter!"

"'Coz I'm not stupid enough to get your hopes up about it!" Bakugou shot back, before he too took a step into Izuku's personal space, his finger jabbing hard against his chest again. "We were there for fucking months, Deku. *Months*, and we never heard or saw a damn thing to make us think there could be someone else out there. You think if he was alive we'd have fucking found him!"

"Not if he was injured," Izuku argued back. "Not if he was hurt and hiding. Not if he didn't want anyone to find him!"

"If he was alone and injured there ain't no way he could have survived," Bakugou said, far too coldly. "Fucking face it, Deku, your boyfriend's dead, and so will you if you go back there."

Izuku's breath hitched. Realistically, he knew that. He knew that the chances of Shouto being alive, especially if he was injured badly, were slim. Hell, Izuku nearly died from a burn on his arm, and he would have done if Bakugou hadn't been there to help him, so if Shouto was alone then what hope would he have had? He felt sick then, his wrist raising to his mouth at the thought of Shouto left all alone, whilst Izuku was with another group.

"I don't care," he finally managed. "What if it was Jirou, or Sero? If there was even a chance they were still alive wouldn't you have taken it?"

Bakugou breathed in sharply, his face twitched, his anger faltering just a fraction before he looked away, glaring furiously over Izuku's shoulder.

"I ain't coming with you."

Izuku nodded. "I know."

They stood in silence after that, Bakugou still glaring away from him, his hands shaking, Izuku watching him with a heaviness in his stomach that he wished he didn't feel. Bakugou had ... the whole group ... they had saved him, they had become his friends, and a part of him really wanted to stay with Bakugou. But it wasn't about him and what he wanted, this was about Shouto.

"Take some of the supplies with you," Bakugou finally said, his voice rough. "And at least rest for the fucking night-"

"No," Izuku interupted with a wince. "I ... I need to go now." *Or it'll be harder to leave.*

"Jesus fucking christ," Bakugou swore, rubbing his face. "Fine. Whatever."

He stomped forward, grabbing the backpack, checking the medical supplies before shoving much more food than seemed necessary into it. Izuku watched him, and he felt a familiar sting in the back of his eyes as Bakugou thrust the pack into his arms, his expression unreadable.

"There," he snapped. Izuku took it, hugging it to his chest. It didn't matter how much of a dick Bakugou could be, he was still a friend. They'd still kept one another alive, and he knew he wouldn't even be here right now if it wasn't for the angry blonde glaring down at him, and leaving was going to be hard. He swallowed, fighting back the lump in his throat.

"Uh ... thanks," he said, softly. "For, you know ... for everything."

Bakugou scoffed, and Izuku dared to glance upwards, his heart tightening painfully at the sight of burning red eyes looking back at him.

"This is a stupid idea, Deku," he ground out. "But whatever. It's your useless life to throw away if you fucking want to."

"Bakugou-"

"Fuck off then," Bakugou snapped, turning his back and waving his hand dismissively. Izuku winced, hugging the backpack tighter.

"Goodbye, Kacchan."

Bakugou paused, before he threw himself back into the front seat of the car, slamming the door shut behind him, and Izuku's shoulders sagged. What was he expecting? A tearful farewell? A heartfelt hug? Perhaps it was better this way. With a final look at the car, he turned on his heel and started to walk back the way he came, not seeing the way red eyes watching him in the wing mirror until he was obscured by darkness.

Izuku found himself needing to rest not even an hour after setting off, his body still so achy from the days walks already. He found another unlocked car to sleep in, trying not to think about the silence around him as he settled himself down in the back seats. The distinct lack of grumbling and swearing that he had grown used to over the last several months had grown far more comforting than he thought was possible, and he sure as hell missed it now. *Shouto,* he reminded himself. Shouto would have spent nights alone too ... he could handle it. He could handle it for Shouto.

The next day, after waking from an uncomfortable few hours sleep, he set off again, looking at his dwindling water reserves with a pit of dread settling in his stomach. Things were only made worse when he caught the sound of distant rumbling again, and he was forced back into the verge as the familiar station wagon drove past him. He understood rage. He'd felt it before. But as his blood boiled hot across his body at the sight of that cursed car driving past him, he realised he had never felt it like this. He sat against the side of a tree, listening to the car driving away as he counted up to one hundred in his head, trying to fight back the crazy urge to jump out onto the road and scream after them. He only hoped that Bakugou had heard them too and had been able to hide in time ...

He hadn't made much progress when he spotted it ahead of him. A thick trail of black smoke spiralling up into the sky from the road ahead, evidence of something burning, and burning heavily. The smell that reached him, even from this distance, was altogether too familiar to him at this point ... the scent of burning rubber and fuel. Whether it was Shigaraki's group, or just an accident, something had set fire to one of the cars ahead of him, right in the middle of the goddamn road.

He grit his teeth, peering out over the hood of a car, eyes darting left and right. He couldn't see anyone, hough it was still quite a distance. It was entirely possible, hell likely even, that this was a trap. A trap laid down by Shigaraki designed to draw either himself or Bakugou out. It could also be intended as a road block, hoping to slow their progress, or ... his stomach lurched. Maybe it was the rest of Bakugou's group? Maybe they were in trouble and trying to reach out?

He sat where he was, watching the fire burn for a couple of minutes, trying to decide what he was going to do. He couldn't turn back, this was the way he had to go, and walking through the woods in his current state was far too dangerous. He had to go past the fire and hope that it wasn't a trap, that Dabi and the others weren't waiting on the sidelines to grab him as he walked by. He hadn't seen any movement, not even any zombies ... Fuck, he was going to have to chance it.

He took a sip of his water, adjusted the pack on his back so it was sitting comfortably, and set off, keeping close to the cars and watching out for signs of trouble as he went. Aside from the still flickering flames from the car, the entire area was silent, eery even, and he could hear his unsteady breathing echoing across the open area.

He stopped, mindful to keep the car several metres away from his in case it decided to explode like the RV. There was a blind spot ahead of him, an overturned lorry cutting across the very centre of the road, and he knew that if they were going to be hiding anywhere, it would be there. He held his breath, before picking up a sizeable rock from the ground, feeling the weight of it in his fist. It was a long shot, but if there was someone back there, then hopefully he could at least shock them into making a sound, even if he didn't hit the. Tongue between his teeth, he threw with his good arm, the rock sailing into the air and over the side of the lorry, before it landed with a decided strange sounding thud, like it had hit something soft. His eyes widened, taking a hasty step back ... had he hit someone? Was there really someone back there waiting to ambush him? The answer to both those questions was a resounding yes, but it was far from what he had expected.

The sound of the rock, perhaps his hastened breathing, whatever it was spurred into action a flurry of movement, the hair on the back of Izuku's neck standing on end as he heard the scrabbling and thudding and he realised just how much of a fucking mistake he had just made, and sure enough the first of the zombies was rounding the side of the lorry in a heartbeat.

He was certain now that the car had been a trap, a trap intended to attract zombies. Hell, Shigaraki hadn't been opposed to using them to try and kill them before either, and he scurried backwards as about a dozen more shot around the lorry, all of them in various degrees of decomposition, two of which most definitely fresh going on the speed they threw themselves at him, and he could only turn tail and run. He had no weapon, and he was far too exhausted to face off against them even if he had done, and he swore under his breath as he ran, darting around cars and looking for somewhere to hide.

He spotted a car several feet ahead with the front door wide open, and made a beeline for it before he felt something grab him roughly, looking over his shoulder to see his pack snagged in the teeth of one of the fresher zombies, the things still blue eyes staring at him.

"Fuck!"

He slipped out of the pack, the zombie distracted just long enough for him to slip away from it, focused once more on the car before he threw himself into the front seat, reaching back intent to slam the door shut behind him before his right foot was grabbed and he felt the painful pressure against his ankle, yelling out. The zombie was biting down hard, and it was only dumb luck that it had nicked the leather of his boot. He kicked out hard with his free leg, pushing the zombie back before he slammed the door shut hard, panting heavily as he kicked his way to the other side of the car.

"Shit shit shit!" he hissed, raising a shaking hand and running it through his hair. He heard a loud bang behind him, swinging around to see another zombie pressing it's face against the window, slamming the bloody stump where it's hand had one been against the glass and smearing it.

"Goddamn it," Izuku breathed. He'd never seen a zombie smash it's way through a window before, but then he'd never seen them using one another to climb up a tree, either, and these two fleshbags looked for all the world like they could have died just a couple of days ago, right down to the pink eyeshadow still vibrant on the face of one. What he hadn't prepared for, however, was the soft click echoing through the car as the front door slowly start to open.

"What the hell?" He launched forward, grabbing the inside of the door as the pink eyed zombie on the other side slipped it's hand through the gap and shit was it strong, gripping and pulling the door even as Izuku yanked it back, trying to close it again. *Was this actually happening? Holy fuck did this zombie just open the fucking door?!*

He grunted, grabbing the door with both hands and trying to ignore the scream of pain from his damaged arm as he heaved, but another zombie, this one much more rotten, it's skin almost sliding of the face that is pushed in through the gap, mouth wide and teeth snapping towards Izuku's wrist, and he kicked down with his boot only to find his body slid forward on the seat and door wrenched open even further, almost pulling Izuku out with it. He was only just able to pull his arm out of the way before his hand was bitten off by the gnashing teeth, throwing himself back against the door opposite as, to his complete and utter panic-stricken horror, the two zombies started to climb in after him, hands reaching out and grabbing hold of his ankles. He looked around the car, desperate to find something, anything, that he could use, but this vehicle was just as empty as all the rest they

had already looted, and he looked down and fuck. *Fuck.* He'd really mess up this time. He was trapped. There was no one around to save him, he was going to be eaten from the legs up and what a fucking *disappointment-*

The door behind him gave way, opening out onto the asphalt as he was grabbed from behind, something wrenched under his arms and pulling him hard and he kicked out, swearing and snarling as he tried to beat at whatever had grabbed him with his fists, his hand reaching up and grabbing a handful of hair before wrenching hard.

"Ouch! It's me you dumbass!"

"Kacchan?!"

He was pulled back again, his feet slipping out of the reach of the zombies inside of the car before he was set on his feet, hot hands grabbing hold of the collar of his hoody.

"You bit?"

"No-"

"Good, let's go!"

He was yanked sideways and into a run just as another zombie swiped at him, and he was far too overwhelmed and confused to make sense of goddamn *anything* for a good couple of seconds, blinking furiously as he tried to work out what the hell was going on. Bakugou wrenching him again, pulling him to the right so hard he almost fell down to the ground, his legs dragged for a second before he was able to get his footing and run himself.

"Goddamn it!" Bakugou snarled. "God I hate your fucking guts you fucking son of a dick I could fucking murder you!"

"H-huh-"

"Shit!"

They came to a sudden halt, and Izuku was finally able to get his bearings, looking around them to see that they had rounding behind another car, except the dozen or so zombies there had been before had now grown into easily double that, with some of them coming at them from behind, the two healthiest and fastest zombies quickly recovering and pelting it their way.

"The lorry!" Izuku yelled, and it was his turn to grab Bakugou, the man swearing angrily yet not fighting against him as they ducked back towards the lorry, keeping cars between them and the zombies.

They only just had time to climb up onto the side of it, zombies slamming against the tires and the underside of the vehicle as Bakugou and Izuku used the piping to heave themselves up, Izuku yelping at the pain his arm again before falling flat on his back on the side of the lorry, panting hard.

"It ... opened ... the door," Izuku managed through each desperate breath. "It ... opened .. the fucking ... door ..."

"Yeh I got eyes, Deku!" Bakugou yelled. "Shit, how're there so many of them?"

Izuku raised his head, sitting up so that he could look over the edge of the lorry. They were out of reach, just, but if any of them figured out how to start climbing again then they were well and truly fucked. There was easily two dozen of them, hell probably more than that, now crowding around the lorry, hands slapping the metal and mouths wide, and all this chaos was bound to attract more of them. But for the moment, they could catch their breath, and Izuku looked up at the man stand beside him, gnashing his teeth together and looking furious.

"Why are you here?" he asked, still breathless. "Why did you come?"

Bakugou glared down at him, his hands on his hips.

"You still fucking owe me, Deku!"

"H-huh?"

"And you know what else? I really fucking hate wasting my time."

Izuku blinked. "*Huh?!*"

"I spent two fucking weeks keeping your miserable ass alive and you think you can just fuck off and get eaten whenever you feel like it?"

"I wasn't *planning* on getting eaten-"

"Shut your trap!" Bakugou yelled, resulting in a fresh rush and slamming from the zombies below them. "You *owe me*. Your damn life is mine! So we're going back to Shinagawa, we're going to find your shitty boyfriend, and then I'm dragging both your asses back to Musutafu. You hear me?"

Tears immediately spilled out onto Izuku's cheeks, unable to hold back the sobs as he wiped furiously at his eyes.

"K-Kacchan does care!"

"Are you seriously crying right now? Don't think this is because I give a shit about you, I fucking don't! But you owe me, bitch, and I intend to fucking collect with damn interest."

Izuku choked a small laugh, nodding and wiping away the tears.

"Now, let's figure out what we're doing about these things."

Izuku sniffed, before climbing to his feet, his chest warm despite their situation. And boy was their situation dire ... there was no way they could fight their way through without weapons, and it was only a matter of time before the zombies figured out how to climb up the lorry, especially the two fresh bodies that were fighting their way through the crowd.

"We need a distraction," Izuku said, looking around. "Something to draw them to one side of the lorry whilst we escape from the other."

"Your bandage," Bakugou said, pointing to his arm. Izuku looked down, noticing the blood seeping through the white gauze.

"Yeh, I must have torn the scabs," Izuku said distractedly.

"No, idiot, give me your fucking bandage!"

"Why- oh, *oh*!"

He grabbed the fabric, unwrapping it as quickly as he could, wincing at the way the skin ached as the material that had been stuck to his arm was pulled free, before Bakugou snatched it from him and marched to the furthest end of the lorry, dangling it over the edge as he went.

"Come and get it ya sick fuckers," he growled, and sure enough, the smell of the fresh blood seemed to garner their interest, and slowly they began to work their way around to the side of the lorry that Bakugou was standing, clambering over themselves in their desperation to reach the filthy bandage hanging just out of their reach.

"It's working!"

"Course it's working!"

In a matter of minutes, Bakugou had attracted all of the zombies to one side of the lorry, leaving the side heading back to Shinagawa clear.

"We're still going to have to out run them," Izuku called, looking at the way ahead. "They'll keep chasing us until they can't see or smell us any more."

"Check the cars," Bakugou ordered. "Anything unlocked and old looking. You know how to hot-wire a car, right?"

Izuku gaped. "No? Why would I know how to *hot-wire a car*!"

"Fuck me do I have to do everything?" Bakugou snarled. He looked over his shoulder. "That one," he said, pointing to a red car not far from them. "Check it's got gas!"

Izuku swallowed. "Uh ... how do I know if it's got gas or not?"

Bakugou stared at him in complete and utter astonishment. "The *fuel gage, Deku*!"

"R-right! Wait, why don't you check it? I can keep the zombies distracted."

"Because I'm faster, just go!"

That wasn't strictly true ... even on his bad days Izuku was definitely faster than Bakugou, but he didn't argue, and dropped as gracefully as he could onto the road, hurrying towards the red car and trying not to make too much noise.

The door was unlocked, Izuku suspected Bakugou at least had some idea of that when he pointed the car out to him, and he slid into the front seat, looking at the dashboard, brushing his long hair out of his eyes. The needle wasn't flat on empty, but it wasn't far off, and though he knew precisely nothing about cars, he was sure they couldn't exactly count on accuracy in a vehicle that had been left unattended for the better part of two years. He leaned back out, offering Bakugou a thumbs up, and he saw Bakugou threw the bandage into the crowd of zombies before running to the opposite side of the lorry and dropping to the ground. Izuku allowed himself a soft breath of relief when he noticed that there was no immediate sign of the zombies following him, before he twisted in the seat to get back into the car.

He would go on to regret this moment for the rest of his damn life. Would look back on it with red faced embarrassment and horror. He'd wake at night in a cold sweat thinking about what had, and what could have happened after his elbow made contact with the centre of the steering wheel, the horn blasting so goddamn obscenely *loud* that he was sure his heart stopped beating, his hands coming up to cover his mouth.

"Oh ... oh no ..."

"DEKUUUU!"

The scream of rage that followed was almost as loud as the horn itself, and he swung round in the seat to see Bakugou running towards him, his face a picture of unadulterated rage, and sure enough he saw the first of the zombies clamber around the lorry.

"I'm sorry!" Izuku wailed, leaning forward to open the door on the passenger side as Bakugou threw himself in, slamming the door behind him.

"The ignition, moron!" Bakugou screamed in his face, and hands shaking with embarrassment Izuku turned the key still sitting in the ignition, before the car roared into life.

"YOU ARE SO FUCKING LUCKY THIS THING WORKS!" Bakugou screamed again. "Now fucking drive!"

"I ... I don't know how to drive!" Izuku squeaked.

"WHAT DO YOU MEAN YOU DON'T KNOW HOW TO DRIVE?"

"I never learned!"

"BUDGE OVER!"

Bakugou clambered over, Izuku pressed himself as far back in his seat and against the door as he could as the blonde all but sat in his lap, his leg reaching out and stepping down on the gas, the car screaching, the wheels skidding in motion before it started to move, shooting off as the first of the zombie's scratched their nails against the boot.

"You're heavy," Izuku grunted, under the weight of Bakugou against him, his elbows definitely not needing to be digging into his chest as much as they were as he spun the wheel, negotiating their way through the first wall of cars, the zombies left eating their dust behind.

"Eat a dick, Deku," Bakugou snarled, before glancing up into the rear-view mirror to check their progress.

Izuku slumped back in the seat, glancing sideways at the furious cut of Bakugou's jaw, and feeling a smile tug his lips because apparently he *was* crazy ... frankly, the jury was still out on whether he would have been safer back there with the zombies.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 15: Looking Grave

Chapter Summary

In which the search for Shouto begins ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They abandoned the car as soon as they were far enough away from the herd to feel confident they couldn't see or smell them any more. It was a blow, because they would make Shinagawa in no time if they drove there, but that car was for too conspicuous, and knowing that Shigaraki's group were all too likely to be responsible for drawing the herd onto the road, they couldn't afford to risk being seen. Sneaking back into the city was dangerous, hell it was entirely fucking *stupid*. Shiggy's group had headed back that way, assuming that they had set up a base there, and the more time they spent in the city the more likely it was that they'd be found. But Izuku couldn't leave the city behind, not without knowing whether or not Shouto was alive or dead, and for better or worse Bakugou wasn't leaving either. Izuku wasn't sure what that meant ... he knew better than to think that it was only because the man though that he owed him. He'd gotten to know Bakugou pretty well over the last few months, and he was sure that was just Bakugou's way of saying *'I don't want you to get killed'*.

Of course, the kiss was still something that weighed over him. Bakugou had insisted that it hadn't been anything, just a product of heightened emotions and vulnerabilities at the time, but given that Bakugou wasn't even capable of admitting that he didn't want Izuku to *die* without covering it up by being an asshole, was it entirely unrealistic of Izuku to wonder if maybe it had meant something more? And yet, here they both were, walking back into hell together to save a man that Bakugou knew full well meant a great deal to Izuku, so maybe it didn't.

He couldn't deny how wrong it felt to be walking back towards the city, past the service station where the remains of their RV and Sero's grave could be found, walking straight forward to a city that held pretty horrific memories for the both of them, and he half expected Bakugou to bring up that fact. But Bakugou stayed quiet, didn't say anything more on how idiotic his plan was, and for that Izuku was grateful, and it wasn't until the second day, the city now in sight, that Bakugou spoke up about the subject.

"It's not gonna be the same this time," he said quite suddenly, and Izuku looked over at him as they walked, taking in the cold look on Bakugou's face as he eyed the cityscape.

"What do you mean?"

"This isn't home any more," Bakugou replied. "You get it? We're going to be in fucking enemy territory, and I don't care how familiar any of it feels, we can't afford to get complacent. You hearing me, nerd?"

"Of course," Izuku said. "I know how dangerous this is, Kacchan. And, honestly, *I'm* getting a little tired of almost dying every other day. We'll be quite, we'll be careful. Dabi and the others won't even know we're there."

"Nah," Bakugou bit out, stopping in his tracks. "We've gotta work with the assumption that they know we're here. That little stunt with the horn? How likely you think it is they didn't hear you?"

Izuku flinched.

"Exactly. We go in when it's dark, and we get off the streets as soon as we can. Stick to rooftops, alleys where we can. Travelling at night puts us at more risk of the biters, so before we go in there I'm gonna lay down some fucking ground rules."

"Ground rules?" Izuku interrupted, pulling a face. "You forgetting I've saved your life plenty of times too, I know what I'm doing."

"I've saved your ass from zombies four times, Deku. *Four*. If we go in there then we're going on my terms, this is the fucking deal, Deku. Take it or leave it."

Bakugou glared at him, and Izuku was tempted to ask exactly what he was planning to do if he said he'd leave it, but instead he just huffed and nodded, crossing his arms over his chest.

"Good. First, we don't take out any zombies unless we really fucking have to."

"Hey, I've got no problem with that! You're the one killing zombies left right and centre when we don't need to."

"You gonna keep fucking interrupting me, asswipe?"

"Sir, no sir!" Izuku shot back, raising a hand to his head and rolling his eyes. Bakugou's face twitched.

"*Second rule*, you do as I fucking tell you. I tell you to run, you run no questions."

"Sure sure."

"Finally, we need to prepare in case Dabi's group catches one of us."

The slow smirk that had been forming on Izuku's lips dropped then.

"What do you mean?" he asked, voice quiet.

"I mean, of the two of us, I'm the one they're gonna want most. If they catch you, you make a fucking deal with them. That they'll let you go if you tell them where I am."

"*What?!*"

"And if they catch me, then you leave. Don't you fucking dare try and save me, you get the fuck out of this city and you get to Musutafu."

"Why would I leave you?" Izuku spluttered, eyes wide. "Kacchan, that's crazy!"

"Because they'll fucking kill you, moron," Bakugou snapped. "If you try and save me we'll both die, and I told you I hate wasting my time."

"No," Izuku said firmly. "No fucking way. I'm not agreeing to that."

"Then we ain't going," Bakugou replied, throwing his hands in the air, and turning sharply on his heel to walk back the way he came.

"Then I'll go on my own! If you coming means I might have to leave you there then it's probably best if I go alone anyway."

"No chance," Bakugou growled, voice low as he glared over his shoulder. "You ain't going in there on your own. You agree to my fucking terms or I'm knocking you out and dragging you all the way to Musutafu."

Izuku was half tempted to call his bluff, right up until the point Bakugou yanked his hoody over his head, rolling his shoulder and clicking his knuckles.

"Alright, I fucking warned you."

"Wait!" Izuku hissed, holding out his palms and taking half a step back. "Fine. Fine, I agree to your stupid terms."

"Atta boy," Bakugou said, patting him on top of the head as he walked past, and damn did Izuku hate how his face heated up at that, glaring after the man.

"And I ain't going in there unless we've got some weapons," Bakugou continued, heading towards a nearby four-by-four. "Might have to get a little inventive ..."

Izuku thought back to the bombs Bakugou had once carried on his person and held back a scoff. He was sure that wouldn't exactly be a problem for the man.

Izuku found his own vehicle, and the two of them spend the next hour before night fell looking for weapons, or something that they could cobble together suitable for some good old fashioned zombie brain bashing. He finally heard Bakugou let out a delighted cackle, the sound almost manic, Izuku looking over his shoulder to see Bakugou standing in front of a van, the back doors wide open, a look of pure glee on his face.

"Fucking ace," he said.

Izuku walked over, peering into the back of the van to see a whole array of plumbing equipment, including several heavy metal pipes and joints. He reached past and grabbed one of the pipes, feeling the weight of it in his hand.

"That'll do it," he said, only to find Bakugou looking at him, eyebrow raised.

"You lack fucking vision," he said simply, before digging through the boxes, grabbing pipes and connectors. He looked for all the world like a kid in a sweet shop, self-satisfied grin on his face as he held pieces up in front of him, angling them this way and that, sometimes with his tongue between his teeth and Izuku quickly realised that he was in hell again. He watched with a sort of morbid fascination, the oil and grease from the pipes quickly smudging up his hands and forearms, the way his muscles flexed each time he lifted something heavy leaving Izuku chewing on his lip

before forcing himself to look away to save him from the goddamn *obscene* sight. His eyes were quickly drawn back again, almost immediately, *Izuku you hopeless case*, at the sound of tape tearing, and he saw Bakugou's sharp canines ripping the duct tape he had wrapped around the base of the pipe in his hands before he held it out with a laugh of triumph.

"Hah!"

"You, uh ... you don't think that's a little excessive?" Izuku asked.

It was a work of art, quite frankly. He's surely never seen anything quite like it, the metal pipe topped with a tee-connector, and each piece had different shaped threads and caps attached, finished off with thick knuts that looked more than capable of taking a man's jaw out. Bakugou smirked at him.

"No fucking way, nerd." He dropped it back onto the car, before snatching Izuku's pipe from his hands and digging into the box of components again. Izuku reached out and took the plumbing *warhammer*, not at all shocked at how heavy the damn thing was.

"This is way too heavy to carry around with you everywhere," Izuku protested. "How're you supposed to run with this?"

"Too heavy for you maybe," Bakugou scoffed. "Ain't my problem you ain't built like a *Greek god* like me."

Izuku blushed and dropped the warhammer.

"You ever plan on letting that go?" he groaned, and Bakugou flashed him another look, smirk only widening and Izuku feeling his stomach churn again.

"Not a chance."

He attached a lighter tee-connector to the end of Izuku's pipe, some heavy duty looking threads with square heads, before passing it over to him. It was lighter than Bakugou's, and Izuku had to admit that it did feel good in his hands.

"Not too *big* for you?" Bakugou asked, his face straight but his red eyes piercing as he looked at him. "Think you can handle it, Deku?"

Izuku swallowed, staring back at him and willing for his face not to burn any more than it already was. Had it suddenly gotten hot out here?

"Yeh, it's fine I guess," Izuku replied, smartly. Bakugou held out his hand.

"Need to wrap some tape around it, so you can get a good grip on it."

Was it still gay chicken if he was into it?

"Yeh, I don't want it slipping out of my hands," Izuku said, his mouth working quicker than his brain could catch up with itself, and Bakugou stared. He stared hard, eyes intense and searching and in that moment altogether overwhelming before he snatched the pipe from Izuku's hands again and grabbed the role of tape. Izuku let out an unsteady breath as the man finally broke eye contact, willing his undeniably horny brain to just give him a goddamn break already.

When Bakugou handed him the weapon back, he had to admit that the duct tape made it easier to grip, and he gave it a couple experimental swings. It felt good, *real* fucking good to have a weapon back in his hands again, he hadn't realised how naked and exposed he felt without one until he had something in his grip that he could reliably beat the hell out of zombies with.

"Now we lie low until it gets dark," Bakugou said, swinging his weapon over his shoulder and looking back towards the city. "Get some sleep, Deku, fed up of seeing you stumbling about."

Bossy asshole. Izuku scowled, sticking his tongue out at the man with his back turned to it. Of course, it was at that moment that Bakugou glanced over his shoulder, and Izuku froze, pulling his tongue back into his mouth and turning on his heel, whistling as he headed back to the van. Maybe he was going crazy, because he could have sworn he heard a chuckle behind him.

Bakugou woke him up an hour later with a sharp poke to his side, grunting and swiping out blindly in the dark before he sat up, feeling groggy as hell after such a short nap. Bakugou, however, looked wide awake, his red eyes shining from the light of the moon sitting bright and high in the sky.

"Time to go, Deku."

He nodded. There was a sudden weight in his stomach, a nervous jitter that spread across his limbs and down to his fingertips, and that was enough to wake him up, eyes as bright and wide as Bakugou's in a moment.

"Ok."

True to Bakugou's words from earlier, they approached the city as if Shigaraki's group already expected them, keeping to the shadows, pausing frequently to stop and listen, eyeing the buildings around them and keeping their new weapons drawn. They had already used zombies against them twice, and whilst they couldn't see or hear anything that could act as a lure for yet another horde, that wasn't to say that they weren't about to round a corner any second and walk smack bang into yet another group.

"First alley on the left," Bakugou hissed from behind him, and Izuku nodded.

It felt strange to be back here. He hadn't known this area of the city especially well, but the layout and smell of the place was so familiar to him after several months of living on these filthy streets that it almost felt like coming home.

They took the alley, and there was ladder in front of them leading to the roof of the apartment block, and after Bakugou prompted, Izuku started to climb.

The roof offered them a decent vantage, as well as some degree of safety as they got their bearings, keeping low to the ground as they crouched to the edge of the wall, peering over the top.

"Seems quiet," Izuku muttered, and Bakugou hummed in agreement.

"We know they came back this way, so they're gonna be here somewhere."

"I know they probably heard the horn, but they've got no reason to assume we'd be coming back here," Izuku said.

"Yeh, well, if assumptions sucked dick I'd be a hell of a lot happier," Bakugou responded, frowning as his eyes roved across the street.

"Where do you even come up with half of that stuff?" Izuku muttered, cheeks blushing again. Bakugou ignored him.

They stayed in place for a minute longer, assessing the area they were in, before Bakugou finally seemed satisfied that they weren't being watched.

"Any idea where your boyfriend would go if he found himself alone?" he asked.

"I never said he was my- *never mind*. Other than the safe house, we didn't really know this area that well, and we hadn't been here long enough to find somewhere new to move on to. But if he was on his own, he would have known not to stay on the streets for very long. He was the one on watch during most of our runs, I guess it's likely he would have found higher ground, or on top of building like we are now."

"That might make things easier for us," Bakugou replied. "We'll start off by going back to your old safe house, start from scratch. See if we can see any signs of someone getting out of there, and where they'd go. If the guy was injured and beat up chances are he'd left a blood trail behind."

Izuku tried not to think too much on the all too casual way Bakugou said that, almost as if he was remarking on something no more exciting than the weather, and nodded.

"This is a huge city, it's gonna take us a while to get there on foot," Bakugou continued. He huffed, looking out over the rooftops. "I don't think we're gonna be able to stay on the rooftops long."

"We should follow the tracks," Izuku suggested, and Bakugou frowned, staring at him from the corner of his eyes. "I know it's probably more open than sticking to alleyways, but with less shelter surely it's far less likely that Shigaraki's group will be over there."

"You even know how to get to the safehouse from the tracks?"

Izuku rubbed the back of his head.

"No, but ... surely we can find a map somewhere? We need more food anyway, water. Any newsagent will have a map."

He watched Bakugou chew on his bottom lip, glaring down at the street below him, making up his mind.

"Fine. Sooner we get out of this shitbox of a city the better anyway." He pointed out ahead of them. "We keep going that way we'll hit the tracks, should be plenty stores on the way. Don't forget the fucking rules I put in place, Deku. I tell you to run, you fucking run. I tell you to scratch your damn ass you-"

"Yeh yeh, I get the picture," Izuku interrupted.

They stayed high up for as long as they could, hopping between balconies and staircases, but the buildings were starting to get taller, spaced further apart, and it was becoming apparent that they would need to go the rest of the way at street level, a situation that neither of them felt particularly comfortable with. They had spotted zombies from above, fortunately no large groups, but singles or

pairs aimlessly ambling about, some of them standing dead still as if they'd simply given up with nothing around them to follow, but there were enough of them to leave Izuku unquestionably nervous. He was still weak, he'd be able to run if forced to, but he was far from capable of outrunning zombies like he had once been able to, and granted he might have Bakugou with him, somewhat of an expert when it came to killing zombies, he did still have that niggle in the back of his mind ... that worry, concern, *guilt*, that Bakugou was only here because of him. Sure, Bakugou could have just carried on, found his friends, and forgotten all about Izuku, but he had quickly begun to understand that that sort of thing simply wasn't in his nature. For better or worse, they were part of the same team now, and with that came a certain obligation you couldn't just ignore ...And if Bakugou got hurt, or worse, then it would be because Izuku couldn't let his friend go. And as for the man's crazy request to just leave him? Well ... he definitely didn't need to think about that right now.

They came across a small store on the corner of a housing block, the front window already smashed in and the door swinging wide in the breeze, and it seemed unlikely that they could find anything left inside. But, Izuku did find a map, some markers that had miraculously not dried up, and based on Bakugou's memory of the city layout, they were able to plot the quickest course to the old safe house using the train tracks.

"We'll have to follow the bridge," Bakugou said, referring to the overground track that ran through much of the city. "Means no one can get the fucking jump on us, but if we come across any z's we're gonna have to fight the fuckers. Bridge is too high to jump from."

Izuku swallowed, and nodded.

"You still don't have to do this," he said softly, looking up at Bakugou. "You don't have to come with me."

"You say that shit again and I'll punch you in the face, don't think I fucking won't," Bakugou snarled, snatching the map from Izuku's hands and started to roll it up.

"We don't know how long Kiri, Mina, and Kaminari will wait," Izuku argued. "What if you miss them because you're helping m- *hey*!"

Izuku flinched, holding his hand up as Bakugou brandished the map, threatening to smack him with it a second time.

"Exactly," he said. "So let's get a fucking move on, shall we?"

Izuku rubbed his smarting cheek, pouting at the damn asshole, before getting back to his feet.

"Besides," Bakugou continued. "How the fuck you think those morons are gonna react if I go back without you, hah? You're a part of a damn group now, as much as any of us, even if that does piss me off."

Iuku didn't really know what to say to that, just allowing the softest smile to grace his lips as Bakugou walked past.

Getting up onto the track was their next biggest hurdle. Short of walking to the start of the track, which not only added a good thirty minutes to their journey, but also had them spending that extra thirty minutes in zombie land, the next best way of getting up was by climbing up onto a high rise road that ran directly parallel to the track. Bakugou had spent enough time exploring Shinagawa

that he was fairly confident that it would be possible, and that only a series of railings separated the road from the tracks, but it still meant that they would need to need to find a way onto the road itself.

The other issue was that this particularly location, with both the track and road on one side of them, and tall buildings the other, meant they were suddenly *really* fucking vulnerable. If zombies, or anything worse decided to come after them right now, they would find themselves almost entirely blocked in, with nowhere to go but the half blocked road that lead under the bridges.

"This is so fucking dumb," Bakugou growled, as they hunkered behind the car they'd been sitting by for the last five minutes. "So fucking dumb."

"We haven't seen a single person or zombie since we got here," Izuku said. "I say we go for it."

"Question, Deku. Of the two of us, which one keeps finding themselves cornered by fucking zombies and needing their ass saved?"

"Right, and which one of us has actually been bitten?"

Bakugou's head snapped in his direction. "Motherfucker I'll beat your ass!"

"Look, it's quiet. And if we don't go up here then we've got to walk even further down the track. Besides, I've worked out how we can get up there."

"I already know how, Deku!"

"So, under the road, climb up onto the awning of the cafe, then onto the railings?"

"Fucking *duh*."

"If there's any trouble, we'll come back this way," Izuku continued, ignoring the ridiculous pout on Bakugou's face. "I'm not saying it's the perfect plan, but it's no more risky than spending another half hour at street level."

Bakugou huffed, eyeing the street again, before bowing his head with a grumble.

"Fucking fine. But remember, Deku, you do *what* I tell you, *when* I tell you, you got it?"

"Kinda hard not to," Izuku replied, "you've been reminding me all day."

"Now is not the time to be growing a fucking backbone, asswipe!"

Bakugou got to his feet, twisting his pipe hammer in his palms, and checking up and down the street once more. "Alright, idiot, let's go."

The two of them darted across the road, keeping low to ground and moving as quickly and quietly as they could, before pressing themselves up against another car just a few meters from the coffee shop. It was still quiet, no sign of life or non-life to be seen anywhere.

"Ok, you go first and I'll keep watch."

Izuku wanted to argue that perhaps Bakugou should go first, but he knew how utterly pointless that was, and he went ahead, jogging to the coffee shop whilst Bakugou shadowed him, taking his place

by the entrance, weapon in hand. There was a pull out awning covering the rusted and moss covered tables and chairs, and whilst Izuku knew that it wouldn't be strong enough to hold his weight, if he could balance himself along the metal frame attaching it to the wall of the building then he could use that to haul himself into the roof, and from there the railings separating the coffee shop from the steep concrete slope that lead to the road. It wouldn't be a huge drop at any point, but there was every chance the metal of the awning wouldn't hold, and now that he saw the concrete slope up close, he wasn't entirely sure if it would be possible to climb that either. And, looking at the state of the old table and chair sets, they could damn well collapse beneath him to boot the second he stepped foot on one.

"Any time you like, Deku," Bakugou growled, still glaring up and down the street.

Izuku rolled his eyes, before picking up the round metal table, grunting at the pain in his arm as he positioned it just below the awning.

"Watch that thing don't just collapse on you," Bakugou said, eyeing the rusted table. Izuku spared it another glance and huffed a breath.

"Only one way to find out, I guess."

Keeping his hands pressed on the outside of the tabletop, he lifted his knees and carefully as he could climbed on top of it, pausing for a moment as he waited to see whether he would fall through the centre of it or not, before he tentatively stood, hands out either side of him for balance. But it seemed luck was at least on his side for this particular stretch of his mission, and he was able to step across the surface of it, his hands gripping the awning. There was a convenient plant hook that he could step up onto, and hissing again at that darn ache he hauled himself up, shoving his feet as far into the slot between building and awning as he could, as he held into the roof.

"I think the concrete slope is going to be our biggest problem," Izuku called softly to Bakugou. "But I can get past the barrier no problem."

"Good, hurry up about it."

God he was being even more of an asshole than usual today ...

He shuffled along the edge of the awning, keeping his feet hooked with each step, his fingers gripping the rough surface of the rooftop, feeling sweat drip down his temple from the exertion, his limbs definitely shaking far more than they would have ever done before. His arm was feeling better, it was healing, but there was a weakness in his body that was going to take a long time to recover from, and he cursed internally as he sidled along, aiming for that part of the roof where he could haul himself up and grab hold of those railings. He was almost there when he heard what sounded like something long and heavy being dragged along the road above him, and his head darted up immediately, just in time to see the zombie, with what looked like a very filthy and faded wedding dress on, walk to the very edge of the high rise road above, it's midriff hitting the barrier.

"Kacchan!" he called, and Bakugou swung around, looking up to where Izuku was pointing just as the zombie thrust forward, clambering and falling over the edge of the barrier, sliding down the concrete slope with at trail of brain muck dragging behind it.

"Shit!"

Bakugou cursed, jumping backwards and out of the way as the thing smashed fast first into the concrete, before he let out a disgusted sound at the blood and filth and splattered onto his front.

"God*damnit*," he grumbled, before swinging down and embedding the head of his pipe warhammer straight into the back of the zombies skull. "The hell does that smell so bad?"

"Looks like she was carrying half the trash in the city along with her dress," Izuku said, his lip curling in distaste at the sight, the smear left down the concrete bad enough for him to smell from this distance.

"Fucking great," Bakugou mumbled, flicking the mess off of his hammer.

"Looks like you'll have to get rid of that stupid t-shirt," Izuku sniggered, turning to focus back on the railing, before more movement caught his eye, looking up to see yet more zombies hitting the barrier and threatening to tumble over the edge. "Kacchan, there's more of them!"

Bakugou stepped back, holding his hammer up as the three strong group above him grew to five, then six, pushing at each other until the first of them tumbled over, hitting the ground with a *squelch*.

"Are you fucking kidding me with this shit? Deku, get down from there before they start falling on your fucking face!"

Izuku hesitated. The zombies were all congregated above Bakugou, and if there were more of them up on the road then this would be the perfect opportunity to draw them all out and clear the road ... but if they were both down there then they would either have to take the whole lot out, or get onto the roof again quick enough not to be grabbed. He bit his lip, knowing how pissed this was going to make Bakugou, before he grabbed hold of the railings.

"Keep drawing them towards you!" he called. "I've got an idea."

"Hah?!" Bakugou's yell was almost comical, and if his eyes could have been bugging from his face then you can bet they would have been. "The *fuck* do you think you are doing?"

"Just trust me!" Izuku replied. "Keep them focused on you and falling off the road!"

"You goddamn asshole I'm going to fucking murder you!"

"Yeh, just like that-"

"FUCK YOU!"

The more Bakugou yelled, the more zombies seemed to press themselves against the barrier, falling with a varying degree of wetness to the pavement below, Bakugou cursing with each swing of the hammer, taking out each of the zombies that managed to get back to their feet again. Izuku grit his teeth together and pulled, heaving himself up onto the railing and over to the concrete slope, losing his balance for just a moment before slamming his palms down onto the rough surface.

"Whew," he breathed, looking up. No zombies seemed to be showing any interest in him yet, Bakugou was making enough noise to be enticing enough on his own, and he started to crawl up the slope on his hands and knees, cursing the pain spreading up his arm each time he palm slapped

down. Panting, he made it to the top, keeping his body low as he peered through the barrier and onto the road.

There wasn't that many of them, certainly if he wanted to compare it to the numbers he'd come across before, and even if his sorry state he was sure that he could probably handle the stragglers that had yet to meet their fate under the metal hammer of the furious madman still snarling and swearing away below him. Furrowing his brow in determination, he climbed over the barrier, twisting his new weapon in his hands.

"Hey uglies," he called, and three rotten faces twisted in his direction, abandoning their efforts to jump down from the barrier and focusing entirely on him. Izuku swallowed, realising quite suddenly that it had been a *long* time since he had felt this nervous and unsure of himself, and perhaps this wasn't the best idea he'd had in a while.

"You've handled more than this before," he told himself firmly. "Izuku, you can do this!"

Ultimately, it stopped mattering the moment they charged at him, and he twisted his heel ready to attack or dodge, his weapon held high. A sturdy swing was enough to knock the jaw out of the first zombie, and a certain haze settled over his mind after that, his body relying on muscle memory as he twisted and ducked, swinging his hammer underhand and smashing into the temple of the second, before lowering and taking out the knee of the other. Panting, he skidded around, and the zombie with the busted leg threw itself at him in a fresh fit of rage and he swung again, the end of his hammer smashing it's skull and almost bringing Izuku down onto the ground with it from the weight. Breathing heavily, he wrenched his weapon out of the mass of brain and blood, standing straight and looking over his shoulder. The road was clear, and with a self satisfied grin he ran to the edge of the barrier where the zombies had been falling and looked down. Bakugou stood below him, the poor man covered almost head to toe in guts, glaring furiously up at him.

"Got 'em," Izuku said.

"Yeh, great, fucking thanks for that," Bakugou said back sourly. "Notice you ain't got any guts on you."

"Sorry," Izuku said, in a tone that suggested he was anything but, just trying desperately to hold back his laughter. "It's clear up here."

Still grumbling, Bakugou shoved his hammer into the back waistband of his jeans and stomped towards the cafe, jumping up onto the table with much more grace than Izuku had done. As he was about to grab hold of the metal bar of the awning, however, there was a gross sounding *crunch* and a rusted part of the table collapsed, Bakugou swearing and swaying, Izuku sure for a moment that he was going to fall straight through the damn thing before he got his balance again.

"Be careful!" Izuku called, hurrying over and jumping the barrier again. "Hold on, I'll help you up-"

"I don't need your fucking help, Deku!" Bakugou yelled. Izuku hesitated, he knew Bakugou was entirely capable of looking out for himself, but the man was covered in guts and far more inclined to slip as a result. Be damned this oaf's ego, it would be far better if he was there to grab him if he needed it than to be standing up on the road entirely useless, and he slid down the concrete slope and over the railing.

"Now you're just gonna be in my fucking way!"

Izuku ignored him, hand stretched out ready to grab him if he needed it, resulting in Bakugou glaring at the damn thing as if his hand had personally insulted his entire family, before he grabbed hold of the metal partition again and started to heave himself up. But they had both been so focused on the climb, that neither of them had noticed one of the zombies lying in the pile of goo on the ground twitching, it's face half caved in and dripping onto the tarmac as it raised it's head ...

"Quit waving your filthy fucking hand in my face, Deku, I told you I don't need your help!"

"It's not in your face, Kacchan!" Izuku said back, indignant, the zombie now on the move, legs and hands slipping almost silently across the ground, broken jaw hanging yet still lined with deadly teeth. "I'm like two feet away from you- *Kacchan!*"

"Stop yelling in my ear!"

"No, *Kacchan look out!*"

Bakugou glanced down, just in time to see the grotesque bundle of flesh and bone launch itself at him, hands grabbing hold of his leg and it's head coming down hard. The world stood still, Izuku gaping, having not seen how busted up the zombie's face really was as it latched it's jaw around Bakugou's calf, before his brain kicked into action and he was jumping down onto the edge of the roof and rushing to Bakugou's aid.

"Motherfucker!" Bakugou cursed, grabbing his hammer and slamming it down into the top of the zombies head, the thing falling flat in the ground below him, and Izuku was grabbing at him before he was even aware of what he was doing, hands gripping the fabric around his shoulders and heaving him up onto the roof.

"I got, I got it!" Bakugou yelled, swatting him off and climbing up beside him.

"Kacchan," Izuku all but whimpered. "Your leg ... did it- are you-"

"Let's just get up onto the fucking road first," Bakugou hissed, shoving Izuku's shoulder and, still fighting back the panic, Izuku started to climb again, reaching to grab Bakugou's hand, the man begrudgingly accepting as they both cleared the railing and onto the concrete slope.

Once at the top, Bakugou fell back onto his rear on the road, panting and swearing, and Izuku hovered around nervously, staring at Bakugou's leg, but it was so hard to see anything over the guts and filth already caking the man's clothes.

"Kacchan-"

"Yeh yeh, I got it, stop fucking saying that every two seconds!"

With a grunt Bako leaned forward, rolling up the leg of his jeans, Izuku hardly daring to breathe. But, to his light-headed relief, Bakugou's leg was free of any marks, no bite to see. He had been lucky. Crazy stupid lucky.

"That was too close," Izuku said immediately. "Shit, Kacchan that was too fucking close."

"I told you to stop that."

"But-"

"I know how close it was Deku," Bakugou hissed, rounding on him and shoving his jeans back down. "I need you-"

"I *know*, I was trying to help you but you wouldn't-"

"I need you to stop freaking out over every tiny fucking thing!" Bakugou snarled, on his feet and up in Izuku's space in a heartbeat, his voice low, his face so close that Izuku could smell the rotten flesh still clinging to him. "I don't need *you*, you fucking- you goddamn-" but for some reason Bakugou's face was going pink underneath the grime, Izuku was sure it had to be from anger, before Bakugou rapidly turning on his heel and started to stomp down the road.

"Kacchan?"

"Let's go," Bakugou growled, and with a heavy sigh Izuku followed after him, eyes trailing back down to the street for a moment, and the three dead zombies laying across the road.

They walked in silence afer that, Bakugou still perceptive and looking around them, but he was definitely pissed, the way his jaw jutted forward and his eyes remained narrowed and hard evidence enough of that. Izuku honestly wasn't sure what it was, precisely, that he had taken such offence to on this occasion, but he was sure the embarrassment and shock of being caught out by a zombie like that had something to do with it. Izuku was reminded again, painfully, that Kacchan- *Bakugou*, was only here because of him. If that zombie had caught him, had broken the skin, if Bakugou had been bitten again then it would have been all on him. Izuku wasn't sure what would happen if Kacchan was bitten a second time, but he certainly wasn't keen to find out the specifics of that.

Dawn was only a few hours ahead of them by the time they finally made it close to the point where Izuku's old hideout could be found. The track had reached almost level ground at this stage, so getting down from it wouldn't be an issue, but it did mean that they would likely need to hold off the remainder of the search until that evening; Bakugou was still pretty firm on the *'only travel at night*' rule, plus frankly the both of them were exhausted after almost an hour walking on the uneven tracks after being on their feet for hours before then. They would find Izuku's old safe house, and spend the day somewhere close by. Izuku didn't like how that thought unsettled his stomach ... there had been so much blood, and honestly he was terrified of seeing all of that again, of being brought straight back to that place, that mindset, after months of trying to crawl back out of it.

"We gotta come off here," Kacchan said, speaking for the first time in an hour, and pointing down off the track. "You recognised any of this yet?"

Izuku rubbed the back of his head, looking out. He did remember seeing the track when he and Ochako were looking for supplies, but it still seemed pretty unfamiliar to him from this angle.

"Good job we got the fucking map then, hah?" Bakugou huffed, before he started to climb off the tracks and onto the street below them. Izuku groaned, pretty sure that Kacchan was being far more sour than he really needed to be by this point, and he grabbed the map out from his pack.

Soon enough, though, things started to make sense to him again. They walked past stores that he remembered looting many months prior, the sensation hitting him as he looked in through those empty windows that of something far more painful that simple nostalgia, and he was starting to doubt whether he really could go through with this. Could he walk into the room where he and his friends had once slept, knowing what he was going to find there instead of them? He shook his

head, forcing himself to walk a little quicker, focusing instead on the broad back in front of him, Kacchan still watching the area around them like a hawk.

And then, they were there. They were there, standing on the same spot they had been standing several months back, only this time it was just Kacchan at his side, and there was no giddy anticipation, no excitement, no swelling in his chest at the thought of seeing his friends again after some time apart. Instead, he felt only dread. A cold, suffocating dread that left his limbs feeling so thick, so heavy, so ... *so* ...

"Deku?"

He looked up. Kacchan was watching him carefully, eyes narrowed.

"You don't have to go in."

Izuku blinked, looking back to the building, then to Kacchan, unsure of what he wanted. But they were here because there was a chance that Shouto was still alive. Here because he'd already left his friend behind once and he sure as shit wasn't going to do it a second time, not until he knew. He'd search every damn building in the city if he had to, and he had to start here.

"I can do it."

Kacchan didn't say anything else, just unhooked his hammer from his waistband and walked down the alleyway leading towards the steep metal stairway.

It was much the same as they had remembered it, except now the blood had dried to a dark rust, mould covered the areas where food had splattered and spilled, and it smelled just as foul and lifeless as the rest of the world around it. It wasn't the same place of comfort it had once been, and his friends belonging strewn across the ground was a painful reminder of that.

"We don't know what happened to them," Kacchan said, speaking quietly and carefully, almost as if he was expecting his words to spook him. "But, if I was to guess, most of the blood looks like it came from a single source."

Izuku nodded, numbly, eyes drifting over it in a solemn silence.

"It sounded like Dabi must have beaten up your boyfriend pretty bad," Kacchan continued, and Izuku *did* wince at that, biting on the inside of his cheek to calm himself. "So, we should work on the assumption that the blood is his."

"Right," Izuku mumbled. He heard Kacchan huff, before he was stepping away from his side, looking closer at the blood splatters across the floor, following their course as they seemed to wind across the room.

"Whatever happened, there was a lot of blood," Kacchan said. Izuku knew he should be looking as well, but he found he couldn't do much more but stand there, watching Kacchan's progress. "Looks like they went this way, towards the back."

"Do you even know what you're looking at?" Izuku found himself saying, and Kacchan shot him a glare.

"Think I can follow a fucking blood trail, Deku. What's your lazy ass doing? It's your fucking boyfriend we're trying to find!"

"Will you stop calling him that," Izuku snapped, his head starting to pound. "I already told you he wasn't my boyfriend."

"Sure whatever," Kacchan scoffed. "Look, your not-boyfriend was hit pretty hard by something and wandered this way, looks like he was probably stumbling a lot ... I mean, sounds like he was hit in the head from what that bitch Toga said."

"Right," Izuku muttered again, following after Kacchan in somewhat of a daze.

"Stumbled here, into the back room ..."

Part of Izuku, the part that was only really vaguely aware of what was going on around him, away from all that blood and loss, berated himself for not following the blood last time, especially as he and Kacchan rounded the corner into the bedroom at the back. The window was wide open and, sure enough, the blood trail lead very clearly, entirely inarguably, out of the goddamn window.

"He ... he got out," Izuku breathed, eyes wide and heart hammering hard and fast in his chest. "He ... he left."

"Looks that way," Kacchan replied. And Izuku was spurred to action, running past the man and sprinting to the window, hands on the edge as he peered out onto the fire escape. There was more blood dried there ... faint now, very faint. No doubt the rains and the winds had washed most of it away, but there was still that tell tale rust red on the hand railings.

"He climbed down the fire escape."

"You have any idea where he'd go from there?" Kacchan asked, gently pushing Izuku aside so he could climb out of the window and onto the metal balcony beyond, looking up, then down.

"I ... I guess ..."

He'd climb up. He'd climb up so he could get an idea of what was around him. See if he had a shot of getting away from that place without being spotted ...

"Up. To the roof."

"You sure about that?"

"Yes."

"Alright ..."

Kacchan started to climb the metal ladder, and Izuku followed, spotting the odd flake of rust red here and there confirming his suspicions. His heart was beating so hard in his chest he could almost taste the damn thing in his mouth ... Shouto had been alive, at least for long enough to get out of there. How long ago had it happened before Izuku and the others turned up here? The blood had seemed ... shit, it had almost seemed fresh back then. What if he had only just missed him by a day? A few hours? What if Shouto had been on the roof the entire time that Izuku was in there, believing them all to be dead.

"Stop it."

Izuku glanced up, hearing Kacchan's voice. He might have been muttering again ... or maybe Kacchan just knew that he'd be berating himself. Hell, misery fucking loved company after all.

On top of the roof, however, the blood trail went cold. There were puddles on top of the roof where rain water had collected from a couple nights back, no doubt having long ago washed away any evidence of Shouto having been there. But ... there was something. Muddied and filthy, but Izuku recognised it immediately, he'd stared at that red check patterned shirt so many times.

"That's Shouto's," he said, hurrying past Kacchan and towards the item of clothing, picking up it. It had been torn, as if strips of it had been ripped off, and there were brown stains across most of it from old dried blood. Shouto had used his shirt to bind whatever injury he'd had, leaving the remains behind. "He was lucid enough to deal with his wounds at least."

"Yeh," Kacchan said, looking around them. The roof was fairly isolated, he certainly wouldn't have been able to made it to any of the neighbouring buildings from up here, but there was an escape route back down, the door of it wide open. "He must have either gone back down the ladder or through the door."

"He'd go through the door, I think," Izuku said. "If ... if there was blood, then maybe there would have been zombies too. Going back down the ladder might have been too risky if they had smelled him. Assuming-" his voice broke, and he swallowed, taking a deep breath. "Assuming he was alone he might have gone back down to check that no one else was ... had ... *fuck*!"

God this was hard. Why was this so fucking hard?

"Deep breath, Deku," Kacchan said, uncharacteristically softly, as Izuku raised both his hands to run through his filthy hair.

"He'd go back inside," he breathed. Kacchan nodded, before leading the way again.

Despite having bound his wounds, it seemed like Shouto had still be bleeding heavily, with marks on the wall from handprints, perhaps from staggering his way down the stairs, and as much as that broke Izuku's heart and had him feeling even more afraid that his injuries had simply been too severe for him to have survived long after, it still made it easier for them to track him. Right up until they reached the door at the very front of the building, and standing out on the street, all traces of Shouto seemed to vanish.

"I don't ... I don't see anything," Izuku said.

"Well, we know he made it out of the building," Kacchan supplied. "And, hell, if he'd been got by a zombie straight away there'd have definitely been some signs of someone having been eaten out the front here."

Izuku's stomach churned.

"It's all on you now, nerd," Kacchan said, crossing his arms over his chest. "We can't track him, you gotta think. Where would he go next?"

Izuku looked around them, dragging his hands through his hair again. He'd try and go somewhere safe, surely. If he had lost that much blood then he would have been feeling weak, and there was no

way he could have made it too far before needing to find somewhere to rest. There were buildings all around them, it really could have been any fucking one of them, but he let himself consider what he would do. Injured, stumbling, he'd fall out of the front door and ... what? He'd keep close to the walls, that's what he'd do. He'd keep close to the walls, head in a direction they had explored more thoroughly previously ... left, towards the centre of town.

"This way," Izuku said, heading off in the direction that Kacchan's own old safe house was. "I don't know for sure but ... it's the best guess I've got."

"We can't be out here for much longer," Kacchan replied. "It's getting too light."

"I know."

The two of them walked in silence, Izuku focusing on the buildings around them, Kacchan looking out for zombies or ... worse, until Izuku spotted the next residential building, a small apartment block, balconies and fire escapes on one side ... *two escape routes*.

"There," he said, pointing, before breaking into a small jog.

"Oi, Deku, slow the fuck down!" Kacchan hissed, grabbing his shoulder to stop him from running straight into the building. "Jesus, fuck, this is why you keep getting caught by zombies."

He roughly pushed his way in front of Izuku, holding his weapon out again before kicking open the door to the entrance hall, entering cautiously.

"Look!" Izuku breathed. Shouto had definitely been here. There was more blood on the floor but, most encouragingly ...

"That mud?"

He and Kacchan got close and, sure enough, there were mud tracks buried into the carpet, like someone had come and gone fairly often, and during some heavier rain. Someone, whether it was Shouto or not, had made this place their home base, and had been travelling in and out for a while, possibly with supplies. Izuku couldn't breathe. He couldn't fucking move ...

"Deku, don't get ahead of yourself," Kacchan said. "It might not be him."

"I ... I know but ... Kacchan it could be ... he could be alive-" his voice broke again, and he raised a shaking wrist to his mouth. But Kacchan was right; he couldn't afford to become complacent, after all there were other people here in the city, and they weren't nearly so friendly.

They made their way deeper through the building, following the odd mud track or scuff. Truth be told, the whole thing was starting to make Izuku more and more uncomfortable, the more he thought about it. Shouto was, had never been, a stupid man. Nor a careless one. And leaving such obvious signs that someone was here certainly wasn't his style ... which meant that either he was far too injured to take care of it, or the person leaving the trails wasn't Shouto. Either option certainly wasn't especially encouraging ... but he was so close now. Whether it was Shouto or not, he had to know.

Eventually they found their way to the top floor, the odd bit of mud still clearly visible on the cream carpets and leading ... Izuku grabbed hold of Kacchan's arm instinctively, clenching down hard. There was an open door at the end of the hall. An open door wasn't safe. Wasn't good. Wasn't-

"Let go of me, nerd," Kacchan hissed, yanking his arm out of Izuku's grip. "Can't fucking fight with you grabbing me like that."

Fight. Which meant that Kacchan had the same goddamn thought that he did. He shook himself, grabbing his own weapon, before starting to inch his way down the hallway and towards the darkened room ahead of him, each step feeling heavier and heavier, dread growing and growing, his head swimming.

"Sh-Shouto?" Izuku called, gently, despite Kacchans hiss, as they neared the doorway. "Shouto, are you in there? It's me, it's Izuku."

There was no answer, but ... yeh, shuffling ... something that sounded *wet?* Someone was beyond the door. Someone or something. Izuku's heart rate spiked, panic growing.

"Shouto?" he called again, before throwing all caution to the wind, kicking the door wide on it's hinges, flooding the doorway with the emergency lighting still flickering overhead in the hall and everything stopped for Izuku again. His whole goddamn world came crashing to a halt as there, crouched over, was the back of a zombie; it's shoes mud covered, it's scalp peeling away, the grotesque sounds of it ripping at flesh filling the hallway.

"Shit," Kacchan snapped, grabbing Izuku and throwing him to the side, and the zombie finally took notice of what was around it, looking up from it's meal, blood dripping down it's mouth and covering it's hands. It screamed silently at them, starting it's frightening scrabble across the carpet, and Kacchan swung, taking it out with a single hit of his hammer, the light now illuminating the figure laying slumped against the wall inside of the apartment, and Izuku fell to the ground.

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 16: What it Entrails

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku fights with the magnitude of his grief

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There was no way to explain some of the horrors that he had already seen in his short twenty years of life and do them justice. For anyone left still alive, they all certainly had their own list of nightmares, bad memories that would haunt them for whatever limited time they might have left on the earth, but for Izuku this was definitely the worst of it. This was the worst thing he had ever seen. The worst he'd ever felt. It hurt so badly he wanted to tear his own damn eyes out, or die, just something *anything* so that he would never have to live in this awful moment ever again.

He couldn't see anything through the fog that filled his vision except the figure slumped back against the wall; their entire face was missing, strips of flesh torn down to the throat, eyes gone and a mangled mush of flesh the only thing remaining of what had once been a person. Much of their scalp was missing, like the zombie had just torn it off in ribbons, but he could see the hair. The white hair, visible, then not, then visibly again with each flash of the emergency lighting. He wasn't close enough to tell for sure, but there was red there, so much red ...

"Deku."

It sounded as though he was submerged in water, the voice so close yet distant, muffled and foggy.

"Deku!"

He could smell it, too. Fresh blood smelled so different from the dead, like there was metal hanging in the air, but the rot was still present, it always was these days. The dead found you. The dead *always* found you.

"Deku!"

He started, a rough hand jogging him by the shoulders, a face obscuring his view of the slumped and bloody body, and he felt ... relief. Relief that he could no longer see it. Relief that he could avert his gaze without the guilt of doing it himself. Because he didn't deserve to be spared this. Shouto was dead ... he was dead because he had left him here. Alone. *All alone*.

"Oi, get a hold of yourself."

Kacchan reached out, grabbing both his cheeks and angling his face towards him, red eyes almost glowing in the gloom.

"But it's ... it's-"

"We don't know that," Kacchan said forcibly. And then his hands were on his shoulders and he was hauling him up, turning him around whilst keeping his body between Deku and mangled figure, sparing him a chance to see it again. Izuku tried to fight it, tried to turn his head because how dare he look away from this, but Kacchan was stronger, angling him away and marching him down to the other end of the hallway. Izuku's legs shook violently beneath him, and he was grateful for the wall against his back as he slid down to the floor.

"You don't have to do it," Kacchan said. "Just tell me what to look for."

"H-he ..." Izuku swallowed, his head turning, drawn back to the figure only for Kacchan to grab his jaw and yank his face roughly back towards him.

"Focus, Deku."

"His hair," Izuku managed, swallowing. "W-white on one half, red the other. It's ... it's pretty distinctive."

Kacchan eyed him for a moment longer, before nodding, getting to his feet and leaving Izuku against the wall. *Slumped* ... Izuku shut his eyes, as tight as they could do, not even offering himself the chance to look around ... to see. He heard Kacchan's soft footfalls on the carpet, walking away from him, before silence fell. A long, chilling silence.

A silence that lasted too long.

"Kacch-"

He was interrupted by a heavy wet thud, his eyes springing open, his head swinging back towards the open door. Kacchan was kneeling in front of the mangled figure, placing one hand on the top of it's head as he gently pulled his hammer from where it had been embedded into the body's skull. Izuku could have cried ... he wasn't sure why he didn't.

Kacchan got to his feet, closing the door to behind him as he started his slow march back to him, his expression hard to read. Izuku didn't want to look, because the closer he got the harder that expression grew and he knew. He already *knew.*

"Kacchan?" Izuku breathed. The man stopped, and looked at Izuku like he had never looked at him before, his expression an ugly combination of pity and discomfort. He hated it. He didn't want Kacchan to ever look at him that way again.

"I'm sorry, Izuku."

He already knew, of course he did, but his heart sunk anyway. But it wasn't sadness that he felt in that moment, only a cold rage that shuddered through him, forcing his hands into fists.

"Don't look at me like that," he snarled, his voice sounding unfamiliar in that moment. Kacchan's expression tightened, but he averted his gaze anyway, looking back towards the apartment and the dead zombie lying outside of it.

He'd been alive. Right up until that zombie found him Shouto had been alive, and how long ago had that been? He hadn't turned. He might have been alive just an hour ago. Ten minutes. If he had only been quicker, if only he hadn't been so weak, so pathetic ... *if only he hadn't stopped to help Bakugou* ...

"There isn't anywhere to bury him," Kacchan said, and Izuku felt his anger only grow. "Not here. But I can wrap him up in some blankets, leave him on the bed maybe."

"Do whatever you want," Izuku said, getting to his feet, his heart beating so hard in his chest that he felt like he was going to be sick. "They were already dead."

He wanted to grab hold of himself, shaking his own damn shoulders, scream in his face *why?* but he couldn't stop it, couldn't hold back the rage. Shouto was gone. Why was anger all he felt right now? Why couldn't take the time to do as Kacchan had suggested? Who was he so angry *at*?

At Shouto? *Was he really angry at Shouto?* God if he had just waited! If only he had just waited for him! Another hour, he only had to wait another hour ...

At Kacchan? Yeh, he was angry at Bakugou. He hated to admit it to himself but fuck he was so angry at that cold, cruel bastard that had wasted so much of his damn just yelling, refusing his help, stopping him from getting to Shouto when he had needed him.

At himself?

...

He shouldn't have left to begin with. He should have looked for him, for all of them, way back then. He should never had gone with Bakugou and his group until he was certain his friends were gone.

Kacchan didn't say anything in response, just watching him as Izuku got to his feet and headed towards the stairs, making his way back down to the lobby below, desperate to escape that burning red heat in his heart.

Kacchan joined him again some twenty minutes later. There was fresh blood on his hands and shirt, and Izuku flinched at the sight. His anger hadn't faded in his time alone down in the lobby, in fact it had only seemed to swell, swirling around inside of his body like a cancer. Kacchan stopped beside him, a single spit of blood dripping from his arm and staining the carpet.

"You can't do this, Deku."

Izuku averted his gaze, glaring down at the blood stain.

"You can't fucking shut down like this."

"And what would you know?" Izuku yelled, the fog clouding his vision again as he got to his feet. "Huh? You think you know a damn thing about dealing with this kind of shit? Look at you! You're a fucking suicidal, miserable, violent, alcoholic *asshole* and you think you can lecture me on what I can or cannot do?"

Kacchan's eyes widened, his cheeks burning under the filth.

"I fucked up. *I fucked up*!" Izuku kept screaming, tears obscuring his vision. "Shouto's dead. And I could have stopped it. If I hadn't ... if I hadn't give up so soon, if I hadn't left this place to begin with ... if I hadn't wasted so much time trying to save *you* when you hadn't even want to live anyway!"

At this, Bakugou snarled, his hands twitching as if he meant to grab him, his teeth bared and eyes burning hot under his mask of blood and dirt, before he snorted a deep breath.

"I'm gonna let that slide, shit stain, because I know you're in a real bad place," he growled, his voice low enough to rumble through Izuku's goddamn skull.. "But you don't have a fucking clue what you're talking about. You don't know me!"

"Yeh I do," Izuku hissed back. "I know you, Bakugou. I know you."

Bakugou glared at him, before turning his back, yanking the filth stained shirt over his head and throwing it to the ground.

"I'm gonna find some clean clothes," he snarled. "And in the meantime you're gonna sort your shit out. Do you fucking hear me, Deku?"

Izuku ignored him, the blood pumping in his veins so fast and so hot that zig zags danced in his vision and he looked away, falling back to the carpet. When Bakugou came back to him, dressed in a black button down and clean jeans, Izuku hardly spared him a glance, getting to his feet, unhooking his weapon from his waistband, and pushing open the doors of the apartment block.

"We need to stay low until it's dark again," Bakugou said.

"I know that. You stay here if you want to. I can't."

He didn't wait to see if Bakugou was following him, his eyes darting up and down the street for any signs of he undead, as his feet began to pound the pavement. He didn't care what Bakugou wanted to do, he couldn't stay here. He needed out of this city.

"Goddamnit," he heard Bakugou curse, his boots stomping out after him, misplaced loyalty or perhaps just the desire not to be left on his own Izuku neither knew nor cared at this point, forcing the man out into the bright morning sun caressing the city.

Izuku didn't know exactly what his aims were, but getting back on the road was his first thought, his feet treading the path they'd walked down to get here without thought. Despite his anger and the mindless drumming of his boots on the side walk, however, he was far from unaware, eyes darting and face raised so that he could breathe in the city scents, determined not to let a single one of those rotting bastards sneak up on him. But a dark twisted part of him wanted them to ... he had been frozen in place, unable to kill the zombie that had killed Shouto, and that fact settled so uncomfortably in his stomach that he almost wanted to march straight back there and continue bashing his hammer into the zombie's corpse until there was nothing left of it but blood and sinews. But going back there would be going back ... *there*. And if he could ease that burning in his chest by killing more zombies out here then he wasn't going to hold back if they approached him. Bakugou seemed acutely aware of whatever was running through Izuku's mind, his own weapon still held tightly in his hands, shoulders tense as his eyes darted between Izuku and the streets around them.

The opportunity came quickly, two zombies spotting them from an alley they were hunkered down in, the sounds of their wet fleshy hands slapping against the wall alerting Izuku to their presence before the smell of them hit him. They were far from fresh, so old that they left stains on the ground as they walked, their bodies dripping like sickly scented honey, maggots visible squirming in the jawbone of one of them. Izuku took a deep breath, stalking forward without hesitation, Bakugou growling his displeasure at the situation but not stepping out to stop him. But anger didn't sharpen Izuku's senses like it seemed to do for Bakugou ... it was an emotion he didn't know how to handle, and his hands shook as he took his first swing. The second zombie slammed into him,

forcing him to the wall, but even as Bakugou called out and started to run to his aid, he had kicked the thing away from him, embedding the pip hammer into the top of it's maggot-ridden skull.

"Damnit, Deku," Bakugou hissed, but Izuku ignored him, glaring down at the dead at his feet. It wasn't enough, it wasn't nearly enough ... it hadn't touched upon his anger in the slightest, hadn't eased the mounting grief stirring in his heart and threatening to wash over him at any moment, and he felt his breathing quicken.

"Right, I'm not playing this fucking game any more, Deku," Bakugou was saying, grabbing his forearm and tugging him around. "Scream at me all you fucking like, I'm not standing by watching you get yourself fucking killed like the absolute moron you obviously a- are you *kidding* me?"

Izuku started, eyes snapping away from the zombies and towards Bakugou, who was gesturing with a palm and an angry huff to his arm. Blinking, Izuku looked down to see that he had torn the scabs off his bad arm when he had been pushed against the rough wall, the blood trailing down his arm and dripping onto the pavement.

"Right, we're finding somewhere to hold up 'til dark," Bakugou said, pulling his arm, and Izuku snatched it back.

"Quit yanking me about!"

"Quit behaving like a fucking child, then!"

"God, I fucking hate you," Izuku snarled, and to that Bakugou laughed.

"Yeh, well, join the club," he replied, and he grabbed Izuku's arm again, his fingers tight around his wrist, digging in hard. "If you don't follow me I *will* knock you out and carry you. Do not fucking test me, shit stain."

Izuku glared back at him, chest heaving, green meeting red and a seering clash of wills, Bakugou grabbing Izuku's wrist hard enough to leave bruises, Izuku gripping his weapon. He saw Bakugou's eyes dart down to it, before he rose a single eyebrow, looking at him as if to ask *'well?'* But, as angry as Izuku was, he knew he couldn't hurt the man, and his shoulders slumped, glaring back towards the zombies.

"Good," Bakugou said, before releasing his wrist. "Now let's find somewhere we can sort out your arm, your fucking bleeding all over the place. You think the zombies won't smell that, hah? Fucking idiot ..."

Izuku hooked his weapon into the waistband of his jeans before cupping his spare hand, mercifully free from zombie gunk, over the wound to try and slow the bleeding, knowing that even if Bakugou was being such a dick about it, he wasn't wrong that leaving a trail of blood behind them wasn't the best idea, and followed after him. Bakugou lead them off their original path, seemingly with some idea of where they were going based on how confidently he took the next left, then right, before they stepped out onto a street parallel from the one they had been walking. A small market store, the windows and doors long since smashed down and the shelves inside visibly looted, stood across from them, the street lined with empty cafes and clothes stores. This street would have once been a quiet little sanctuary in a bustling city.

"I'm pretty sure I saw a vets on the map nearby," Bakugou said, before his face scrunched up and he stopped down, Izuku almost walking straight into him. "You smell that?"

Frowning Izuku raised his head, the scent of death definitely lingering on the air, before he heard an almost rhythmic rattling come from market store. He exchanged a look with Bakugou, the man rolling his weapon between his fingers before they carefully walked forward, primed and read to run or fight depending on what they found, Deku pressing his hand tightly against his wound. A sharp crash, the sound of metal shaking against it's hinges, met them as they passed the market, and for the first time in a long time Izuku felt bile rise to his stomach at the sight of the dead. There were about twenty of them, maybe even more, all pressing against the eight foot high metal mesh fence that separated the street from alley down the side of the market. The effect of so many heavy bodies pushing and shoving to get to the front of the fencing had resulted in the mesh cutting through the zombies at the through like cheese wire, guts and skin embedding into the fence, made all the worse when they spotted Bakugou and Izuku both, shuffling with fervour.

"That's gross as hell," Bakugou said, lip curling in distaste. He took a step closer, still far enough that he could get a good head start if the fencing collapsed, his eyes squinting as he looked at the locks. "Doesn't look like that things coming down any time soon, we should be alright."

Izuku scoffed. "Should be? Talk about foreshadowing."

"Shut the hell up," Bakugou snapped, almost indifferently, before he glanced back at him, his face turning red at a comical rate as he snorted with anger. "Fuck sake, Deku! You're bleeding all over the place."

"Yeh, I know!"

"Jesus, ok, shut yourself up in that clothes store over there, wrap the damn thing up. I'll go look for the vets."

"I'm not going to just sit on my ass-"

"You're not going to walk around tracking more blood around the place, either," Bakugou interrupted. "Gimme the fucking map, already."

Glaring, Izuku gestured to his arm and hand currently preoccupied with trying to stop his arm from gushing blood out all over the place with a raised eyebrow, before turning his back. Bakugou swore furiously, yanking at his backpack far harder than was necessary before pulling the map out for himself.

"Whatever," he grumbled, picking out the store opposite the wall of zombies behind the fence so he could at least keep an eye on the damn things whilst he waited. He glanced over his back to see Bakugou stomping off, before sighing heavily. His head hurt, and all this anger was frankly fucking exhausting, and he might have felt bad for how hard Bakugou seemed to be working to look out for him despite how hostile he'd been, but he was still mad at him. Unfairly so, he fucking knew that, but it didn't change facts. He might have gotten there in time if Bakugou hadn't slowed him down by refusing his help.

He grabbed some absorbent looking flannel shirt from one of the clothes racks as he passed by, the door swinging shut behind him, and proceeded to tear the shirt as best he could with his teeth, wrapping the strips around his bleeding arm, and using the rest of the flannel to mop up the blood that had dripped down his arm, onto his shirt and jeans. He supposed a change of clothes was probably in order by this point, and looking down at the gauzy looking print on the front of his tee brought another bubble of rage from his stomach. He glanced back up at the chain link fence, where the zombies were still pushing hopeless forward without any sign of the fence giving way,

and got back to his feet, browsing the store. It was women's fashion, but he supposed that sort of thing wasn't really relevant these days, if it had ever been, and looked through the selection of shirts, hoping to find something that wouldn't be too tight. He settled for a half buttoned oatmeal texture top, yanking his rainbow print shirt off his head and throwing it with much more vehemence than necessary onto the floor. The top was still tight, but given how obscenely Bakugou dressed he could hardly feel self conscious about it, and it was with another heavy puff that the started to look through the jeans, grimacing at the labels.

There was another series of shaking, and he looked up, frowning. The zombies were growing more restless again, and he paused, listening intently. After a few moments, not hearing anything unusual, he went back to browsing, pointedly ignoring the red chequered shirt hanging up beside the jeans and burying that rush of grief down *deep* as he snatched up a pair that he thought might fit him.

When he heard the zombies start to rush again, however, pushing almost desperately forward, he realised that there was definitely something wrong. Hoicking the jeans up and grabbing his weapon he took a step towards the door, pressing his face to the window to peer down the street, hopeful that the ruckus was simply because they had spotted Bakugou returning. But Bakugou, however, was nowhere to be seen, and the feeling in his gut he had long ago learned not to ignore was growing. He pulled the door open, keeping close to the walls of the shop as he looked off in the direction that he'd seen Bakugou walk, ears straining over the clinking of the fence. A noise? A voice? *Shit*. Yeh that sounded like a voice, a voice that was far too feminine to be Bakugou's. His breath caught in his throat, and gone was the anger, replaced only with fear. Was it them? *Had they found Kacchan?*

He hurried forward, walking as quietly as his boots would allow, ducking behind cars as he followed the voice, until he spotted another fenced alleyway, this one wide open, down the side of a veterinary surgery. Shit. *Shit.*

"Tell us where you friend is and maybe I'll make it quick," came a voice. It was cold, weirdly high pitched, like nails down a chalkboard and he felt the hairs on the back of his neck stand on end. He inched forward, darting across the street before he was against the wall of the alley, and slowly peered around the corner.

It was about as bad as he could have expected. Kacchan was further from him, beside the one way access back door to the surgery, a plastic bag in hand no doubt full of bandaging and cotton swabs for Izuku, his expression tense as his eyes darted between the four people standing with their backs to Izuku. He didn't need to see their faces to know who they were ... the white hair, the burns on one man's arms, were unmistakable.

"What friend?" Kacchan ground out. "Does it look like I'm here with anybody?"

"Then who are the bandages for?" Dabi asked, hands shoved deep in his pockets.

"They'll be for you if you don't get the fuck out of my way, dirtbag," Kacchan growled, reaching round to his back and pulling his pipe warhammer out in front of him. At that, Dabi laughed.

"Oh, that right? What, you gonna take on all four of us?"

Kacchan smirked. "I still like my odds. You're not looking so hot there, Dabi." And then, Kacchan's eyes roved over the group and met with Izuku's, his smirk faltering. "I've got no problem taking

you all on," he continued, looking back to Dabi and the rest. "So you should probably all just *get out of here*."

Izuku knew those words had been meant for him. Kacchan had made it perfectly clear that he didn't want Izuku to have anything to do with this, that if he got caught by Shigaraki and his group then Izuku was to just go. But it didn't matter how angry Izuku had been at him, didn't matter the words he had shouted at him in his moment of grief, there was absolutely no question of him leaving Kacchan behind. For better or worse, they were stuck with each other. And besides, if he couldn't kill the zombie that had eaten Shouto, then he could sure as hell send the cruel bastards that he killed the rest of his family to hell instead. Kacchan's eyes met his again for a moment, and Izuku mouthed *'keep them busy'*, before he ducked back behind the wall. He knew Kacchan would be furious, but he didn't have the time to worry about that, he needed to think of a plan.

He could just jump them, their backs were turned, but it was a big risk. He didn't know how well Dabi and the rest could fight, and though he knew that he and Kacchan were good at taking out zombies, killing four people wasn't exactly the same. Nah, he needed to be smart about this ... use the environment against them somehow.

His eyes widened and his jaw dropped with an *oh*, as he heard the rattle of the zombies on the chain link fence. It was crazy. It was fucking *mental*. But they had used zombies against *them*, hadn't they? It would be a risk, he would have to find a way to get Kacchan up onto the rooftop of the vets and out of the reach of the zombies and Shigaraki, but he'd seen Kacchan escape death enough times to think that it was possible. Heart in his throat he ran towards the chain link fence, the zombies pressed hard against the bloody mangled mess, getting a good look at padlock holding the door shut.

"Ok," he breathed, raising his hammer. "Ok, you can do this, Izuku."

He raised his weapon high, before swinging down with all the strength he could muster onto the padlock. It bent, but didn't break, the sound ringing out loudly down the quiet street. Swearing under his breath, he brought the hammer down again, and this time the padlock broke, clattering onto the pavement, and all at once the fence swung forward, Izuku forced to throw himself out of the way so that wasn't flattened by the wave of bodies that fell out onto the rotting flesh and sinew at their feet.

"Ok," Izuku repeated, running backwards and waving his arms to be sure he got there attention. "Oh Jesus ..."

They were after him, slower than some of the zombies he'd faced and clearly not nearly as fresh as the nightmare that had opened the car door, but fast enough to put the fear of God in him as he pelted down the street towards the vets surgery, hearing Dabi's voice ahead of him.

"I can't be fucked with this," Dabi was saying. "Let's just kill the fucker, his friend'll turn up."

Izuku rounded the corner in that moment, his feet skidding on the pavement, and making enough noise that the group turned around, and he was able to register the surprise on their eyes as he grabbed at the chain link fence and pulled it shut behind him, separating them from the group of zombies hot on his heel.

"Deku what the fuck are you doing?" Bakugou yelled, his face furious, and Dabi looked between the two of them, a cold grin on his face.

"Oh hey, here he is."

"I knew it!" Toga squealed. "I knew it was the green haired one that was with him. You're smart, aren't you?"

"Not smart enough to stay away," Shigaraki said now. "You really think you can take us on with that?"

He pointed at the weapon in Izuku's hands, and Izuku shook his head, his lips spreading into the kind of manic grin that wouldn't have looked out of place on Bakugou's face.

"Nope. With this."

On cue, the zombies rounded the corner, twenty of so rushing the fence, the hooked lock the only thing stopping them from rushing the alley.

"What the fuck?" Dabi yelled. "Are you fucking crazy, kid?"

"Little bit," Izuku replied, and now his eyes fixed upon Dabi's, and the anger rushed back. His eyes were a vivid blue, and though he hadn't the heterochromatic features that graced Shouto's, the family resemblance was obvious now. The same large hooded eyes, the same thing lips, the same sharp jaw ... His heart hammered in his chest, and his hands curled into fists around the lock.

"What did you do to piss this one off?" Shigaraki said, and from behind them Kacchan growled out a low *'Deku get out of here'* in warning, but Izuku ignored him, eyes only for murderer in front of him.

"You killed my friends," he said.

Dabi's eyebrows rose in surprise, before he laughed.

"No fucking way. You were with Shouto's group?"

Izuku just glared back at him, willing for his hands to stop shaking.

"How is Shouto? I know I didn't kill him, that little prick's always been good at slipping out of trouble."

"He's dead," Izuku said coldly, feeling the gate shake under the weight of the zombies reaching through to try and snatch at his fingers. An odd expression passed over Dabi's face at that, almost like regret, before he rearranged his features into a practised look of indifference.

"Well, that's on him. That little bastard, I told him he should come with us."

"I don't care about your brother," Shigaraki sighed. "Step away from the fence, Greeny. We all know you're not going to open it. You do that you risk you and Bakugou getting bitten as well."

"Well, as Kacchan said, I like our odds."

Dabi hardly had time to say *"who the fuck is Kacchan?"* before Izuku's eyes connected with Kacchan's, the man still looking furious but nodding his head once in agreement, before he flicked the lock and wrenched the fence door open. The zombies were stumbling forward in an instant, and Izuku darted to the fence and began to climb, fingers gripping the mesh and kicking down when he

felt a zombie try to grab hold of him. Dabi and the others were shouting, swearing, and he looked over his shoulder in time to see them pull out their weapons, preparing for the onslaught, before he heaved himself up onto the low pitched rooftop of the vets surgery. Kacchan kept one eye on him, the other on the zombies as they rushed forward, some of them crowding in on the enemy group, but as always seemed to be the case, Kacchan was apparently irresistible to some of them, and they charged towards him, eight at once. Panicking, Izuku ran faster before throwing himself onto his stomach, arm reaching out and down towards Kacchan.

"Come on!" he yelled.

Kacchan swung at the zombie nearest to him, pushing it back into the others, before turning on his heel and running to Izuku's outstretched hand. But the zombies were fast, and they were hungry, and Izuku watched in horror as one of them threw itself onto Kacchan's back and threw him bodily against the brick wall of the surgery, wide mouth biting down onto the pack on his shoulders and narrowly missing his neck.

"Kacchan!"

With a snarl Bakugou pushed back, turning and smashing his fist into the temple of the zombie trying to rip his pack from his shoulders. But the next one was literally at his throat, Kacchan only just able to hold the damn thing back as it's teeth snapped and snarled. He kicked out it's kneecaps, the zombie falling to the ground, hands snatching at his ankles, before he swung again, and again, blood and guts flying everywhere.

"Kacchan!" Izuku yelled again, spreading his fingers and desperately trying to reach for him. Bakugou grabbed hold and Izuku heaved, ignoring the way his shoulders screamed at him against the heavy weight of the man. Kacchan grabbed for the roof as he was lifted, kicking his feet as another zombie latched on, trying to bite down on his ankle before his foot connected with it's temple, and then he was up, falling on top of Izuku as the two of them fell flat onto the roof, panting and breathing heavily.

"You fucking idiot!" Kacchan was screaming and spitting, but Izuku hadn't in him to argue, just looking up at the raging man leaning over him as he tried his best not to have a complete and utter mental breakdown in that moment. Kacchan seemed to be aware enough for both of them, rolling off of him and leaning over the edge of the roof.

"Yeh you better fucking run!" he screamed, Izuku assumed to Shigaraki's group, who must be now have the entire group of zombies after them. "Coz next time I see you I'm gonna fucking murder you!"

Izuku shook, adrenaline fading until he was left, not with anger, but grief. He couldn't understand it, but as he watched Kacchan dust himself off, glaring furiously after the other group, the incredible amount of relief at seeing him alive, *okay*, mingled with his guilt at letting Shouto down. Of even blaming Kacchan. And his walls broke down. He was on his feet in a flash, not even aware of what he was doing until his arms were wrapped fiercely around Kacchan's middle, his buried in his chest.

"Wh-what the hell?" Kacchan spluttered, hands in the air.

"I'm sorry," Izuku managed through his sobs, fingers interlocked with the soft fabric of Kacchan's shirt. "I almost got you killed again."

"It- Jesus, it's ok," Kacchan said back, still standing stock still in Izuku's grasp.

"I just ... ever since I found out he-he might be alive I ... I've not been thinking straight. I just kept putting you in danger!"

"Yeh, you've been a right asshole," Kacchan said, and to his completely surprise Izuku laughed.

"Alright, geddoff me," Kacchan mumbled, not unkindly, and Izuku pulled away, rubbing his snotty nose. "They'll be coming back as soon as they lose those zombies, so we better be gone before they get here."

Izuku nodded, taking in the way Kacchan's cheeks still flushed pink from the shock of Izuku throwing himself at him. He wasn't Shouto, he wasn't even that nice, but Izuku knew so long as they had one another's back, there universe was going to have a hard time getting rid of either of them.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 17: Zombody Has to Do It

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku has to come to terms with Shouto's death, whilst he and Kacchan come to an agreement

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The possibility of hiding out in the city wasn't even a question after that, neither of them feeling especially safe lying their heads down anywhere when that league of murderers were out there and almost certainly looking for them. Izuku had tentatively voiced the option, knowing that it had been Kacchan's intention before he had gone off like an idiot and lead Kacchan straight into Dabi's hands, but Kacchan had shook his head immediately, his voice a low growl in his throat as he said there was '*no way he was going to sit around on his ass waiting for them*.'

Walking back along the tracks was the quickest route, but it was also the most obvious and under-sheltered; if Dabi and the others spotted them, all they would need to do is prepare an ambush on the other side and they'd be in a lot of trouble. Of the two options, they both better fancied their chances against the zombies, and Kacchan plotted them out a course on the map that would take them down plenty of alleys and back streets. They'd be harder to spot, but the potential for finding themselves against large groups of zombies was definitely higher. There really was no good way out of this.

And so they started walking. Izuku, having torn open his scabs again in helping Bakugou, had re-bandaged his arm, but he was certain the dizziness that he felt wasn't just from the blood loss. He'd cycled through emotions so quickly over the last hour alone that his brain was quite frankly a mess ... a garbled, mangled heap of exhausted adrenaline, grief, and anger that he still had no idea what to do with. Thoughts of Shouto kept returning to him, and he tried to remember his face. He tried so hard to remember what he had looked like on the rare occasions he had really laughed, that soft relief on his face each and every time he and Ochako came back from a run unharmed, that creased furrow between his eyes when they made a joke he didn't understand ... but he couldn't remember any of it. He couldn't see anything but the chewed up body lying *slumped* against the wall, as a zombie tore off another strip of his flesh. That zombie had eaten his face, and his memory of it along with it ...

But Kacchan seemed to have his own ideas on how Izuku should be handling his loss right now, and he pushed him hard, snapping at him to keep watch and pay attention, to not lag behind, to keep his damn focus on what was around them right now and not what they had left behind. Izuku supposed it was how Kacchan had probably handled the death of his friend Jirou, once he had recovered from the fever and bite that had almost killed him. And, sure, he had buried Sero (*he had wrapped and left Shouto too...*), but he had been forced to keep Izuku alive and just carry on with shit like his death hadn't just happened either. Kacchan didn't allow himself time for grief, not when there was a job to be done, and whilst Izuku thought he could understand it, he had also seen how the grief had eaten then man up from the inside out. He'd seen Kacchan drunk out of his mind and

offering himself up as *bait* for a zombie, for fuck sake. The man had almost killed him in a drunken rage, and the utter misery on his face and in his actions were so painfully obvious from the very first time that Izuku had met him. Burying his grief wasn't any healthier than Izuku allowing himself to break down and sob uncontrollably against a man who he had said he hated not half hour previously. No healthier, and certainly no less dangerous, than Izuku going off half cocked and full of rage, ready to take down any and all zombies in his path.

Their path from the city was far from clear, they had come across more zombies than seemed entirely fair as they tried to escape the place that held such dark memories for the both of them. Fighting all of them wasn't an option; Kacchan was fit as ever, and on his very best form when it came to zombie kills (*there were a few more that Izuku filed away into his mind's own best of compilation video*), but even he couldn't keep hacking and slashing forever, and they had been forced to hide in shops and climb onto rooftops often throughout the day. It was probably the longest day of Izuku's life, truth be told. And whilst he knew Kacchan was pushing him to keep him both occupied and so that they could get out of the city before sundown, all he really wanted was to just sit down. Sit down and finally attempt to process the whole heap of shit that had been fucking with his brain for months.

Eventually, they reached the outskirts of the city, Kacchan picking out a route that would take them away from the road they had come in on. It was frustrating, it was about to take them a hell of a lot longer to get to Musutafu if they couldn't just take the road or find a car, but better that than dead. Or so Izuku tried to reason. Instead, all he felt was the swift plummeting of his heart into his stomach as he saw the long winding trail that Kacchan had plotted out for them, wondering whether they might actually be better of waiting for that league of morons to catch up with them ... sink or swim. Kill or be killed. It was certainly a lot fucking simpler. He almost voiced this thought to Kacchan, before thinking better of it. He knew that Kacchan wanted those guys dead more than anyone, and if he wasn't choosing to lie in wait and ambush them, then there was a damn good reason for it.

And so, they started their long trek along the winding paths cut out of the woodland between the city and their destination, disconcertingly low on supplies and both entirely exhausted. With nowhere for them to hold up for the night, they were forced to take some refuge under the shelter of a large tree, Kacchan offering to keep watch for the first half of the night whilst Izuku slept. Neither of them said very much as they ate a few mouthfuls of cold tinned vegetables, and Izuku was passed out and asleep before he'd even placed the empty tin on the ground. When Izuku was woken up next, it was morning, and fairly obvious that Kacchan hadn't slept a wink, the bags under his eyes purple and heavy, and when Izuku had mentioned it he had simply shrugged, muttering something about he needing the sleep more, and starting his march uphill.

An hour in, and Izuku was seriously glad that Kacchan had experience when it came to hiking. For as tough as it had been slipping down alleys and fighting off zombies in the city, negotiating the steep climbs and even steeper falls along the mountain pathway that Kacchan had picked out was far more difficult than even Izuku in his most pessimistic state had expected. There was a small town near the base of Fiji, and though it would take them off their path some ways, Kacchan was intent on checking it out. With any luck, they would be able to find some supplies there, and if not then there would at least be somewhere for them to take shelter. What they would do between now and then, however, was another matter. One that Izuku got the impression Kacchan was keen to avoid for the time being.

The other issue with travelling through the woods was the silence. It was different from what could be experienced in civilisation these days; the silence in the city was so unnatural that it was

impossible not to feel uncomfortable, hyper aware and over-reactive. But in the woods it was a deceivingly peaceful experience. The odd bird call, the thud of squirrels dropping acorns from their trees, was about the only thing you were going to hear in the woods. The absence of the smell of death was something that Izuku hadn't realised he'd stopped smelling until they came across a small group of zombies alone the trail, dispatching them quickly and silently before carrying on. No, the silence and the gentle breeze and the soft scent of pine only made it that much easier for Izuku's mind to wander ... *red raw blood* flashing in his vision each and every time he shut his eyes. The crunch of the leaf litter beneath his feet sounding like teeth tearing at flesh with each and every step, his own heart beat deafening in his ears. Had Shouto been ... *was he still alive when ...*

"Oi, Deku."

He started, looking up and realising that he had been panting, sweat dripping down his forehead. Kacchan frowned at him, stopping from a few metres ahead of him, one hand pressed against the bark of a tree.

"You good?"

Izuku swallowed, wiping the dampness from his head, before nodding.

"Yeh. Yeh, I'm ok."

Kacchan didn't look especially convinced, but he didn't press the matter, just waiting for Deku to catch up before pushing forward.

Later on that day, Kacchan spotted a potential lifeline for them, hidden deep in the depths of the wood and off a beaten track behind overgrown bushes and a rickety old wooden fence.

"Must be one of the ranger houses," Kacchan said. Izuku stood at his side, eyeing the house cautiously. Izuku had long ago started to suspect that anything too good to be true generally was in the Apocalypse, and an empty house that they could rest in in the middle of nowhere certainly seemed to fit the bill. Kacchan was just as suspicious, eyes narrowed as he scoped out the area, his hand back on the handle of his pipe hammer.

"What do you think?" Izuku asked, his voice low. He glanced sideways at Kacchan as he bit his lip, scowling.

"Fuck ... I can't see anyone, don't mean that whoever lives here ain't inside. Or that they won't come back later."

"The place looks pretty overgrown," Izuku commented, nodding to the weeds that had overtaken the cobblestone pathway up to the front door.

"The fuck? Of course it does, who's got time for gardening right now?"

"I'm just saying!" Izuku replied with a pout. "If this house belonged to someone, someone who was still alive, maybe they'd still be taking care of the place."

Kacchan rolled his eyes, before pulling his weapon out.

"I'll check if there's a back entrance," he said. "Listen out for my call. We'll go in and double team the guy."

"Uh, call?" Izuku asked.

"I'll make a fucking bird call, idiot," Kacchan chastised. "Can't fucking hot-wire a car, don't know what I mean by call, the hell you been doing all your life?"

"Something completely different from you, obviously," Izuku muttered back, and Kacchan rolled his eyes once more before ducking around the tree and starting to circle around the back of the house. Izuku sat tight, listening and sniffing intently, hearing the light snap of a branch from Kacchan's directly. His breath caught in his throat ... *crunching tearing blood*- he shook himself, biting his bottom lip.

"Cut it out," he hissed to himself, trying to focus again.

The he heard the whistle, Izuku knew literally nothing about birds, let alone what calls they made, but it seemed out of place enough for him to assume that it must have been Kacchan, and he started forward, keeping low to the ground and pulling his weapon out to hold steadily in front of him.

Approaching the door, he realised that it was already open, swinging to on it's hinges, and frowning he nudged the door wide enough for him to step through, peering through the darkness inside. It wasn't a big house, opening into a hallway that separated out into a living room on one side, and a kitchen on the other, the stairway directly ahead of him. He guessed that the backdoor was going to be off the kitchen, so focused his attention on the living room, first, taking a step into the doorway and looking around the room.

Someone had lived here, that was for sure. There were clothes hanging on a clothes rack towards an old stone fireplace, the wood inside of it black and charred from use. He could see an ashtray on the low centre coffee table, cigarette butts filling it almost entirely to the brim, another half empty pack sitting beside of it. There was a blanket on the sofa, ruffled and kicked down to one seat, and a baseball cap lying on the floor. His eyes roved across the room once more, just to be sure that there was no one hiding behind anything and ready to jump him, before stepping back into the hallway, where he saw Kacchan coming out of the kitchen.

"*Anything?*" Izuku mouthed, and Kacchan shook his head, before pointing to the stairs. Kacchan took point, the two of them inching up the staircase, keeping silent. There were paintings lining the walls, lots of them, each of them seemingly of the same landscape scene but painted at different times of day, and different seasons. His eyes lingered on one of them, the purple lavender so vibrant even through the coating of dust that had settled on the frame that Izuku could almost smell it, before Kacchan nudged him, nodding to the three doors.

"*Got it*," Izuku mouthed, taking the first door on the right, Kacchan the one on the left. He pushed the door open, weapon primed and ready, only to find himself looking into an almost empty bedroom. Some tat and rubbish on the ground, an unmade single bed towards the back wall, but otherwise looking completely un-lived in. He stepped back, Kacchan still inside his room, before he opened the second door, and the smell that hit him had him gagging.

There had been someone living here. Someone who had decided to take an out. The body lay in the bathtub, long ago starting to decompose, jaw hanging wide and lose, the pistol still gripped in the mummified fingers where it had blasted it's brains out through it's throat. Izuku stumbled, a fog filling his vision and his breath catching like his lungs were simply unable to fill themselves back up ... *red, tearing, flesh, blood ...*

"Deku!"

Kacchan had hold of him, pulling him out of the room and slamming the bathroom door shut as Izuku slumped, god, against the wall, hand gripping his chest. *Tearing ... tearing and biting and blood ...*

"Oi, you're alright!"

Izuku swallowed, shutting his eyes tight. He found Kacchan's hand gripping hold of his shoulder and he wrapped his finger tips around his warm wrist, trying to ground himself.

"Sh-shit," Izuku breathed. "Fuck. Fuck *fuck* ..."

It took him another minute, Kacchan just patiently standing in front of him, before he felt strong enough to look up, dropping Kacchan's wrist.

"You good?"

Izuku nodded, pushing his hair back from his face, eyes lingering on the closed door of the bathroom.

"Sorry," he muttered, feeling the heat rise on his cheeks. "God, I'm sorry. I can't keep breaking down like this it's so-"

"Shut up," Kacchan interrupted him. "Take it from the suicidal alcoholic asshole here, it ain't gonna be easy for a while longer yet."

Izuku's eyes snapped up, but Kacchan had already turned away from him, walking off to the bedroom. A moment later he came out with an armful of what looked like heavy blankets.

"Come on. I saw some generators out back, some of those old style water pumps, maybe this place still has some fucking power left, huh?"

Izuku nodded, wondering at the very deliberate way that Kacchan was ignoring the dead body lying in the bathtub just a few feet away from them, before he followed him back down the stairs.

Kacchan dumped the blankets in the living room, dusting his hands off, Izuku just following him in somewhat of a daze as the man made his way back through into the kitchen and towards the backdoor.

"What makes you think this place has power?" Izuku mumbled, shivering as he stepped back out into the woods. Kacchan shrugged, heading over to the large generator that was sheltered in an outhouse. Despite the more modern (*painted red ...*) bathroom upstairs, there was still an old outdoor shower on the property, the wooden privacy screen rotting somewhat but still intact. He heard some swearing, glancing back over his shouder to see Kacchan struggling against the rotating handle on the side, pushing against it before it finally shifted, a loud metallic clank filling the air, several birds taking flight in alarm.

"Quiet," Izuku hissed, and Kacchan paused throwing him the foulest goddamn glare he'd seen on the man's face since the city, before he started to turn the handle, the whirring sound from the generator far louder than seemed wise.

"Think we might be in luck," Kacchan said, tongue between his teeth as he kept jacking the generator. Izuku supposed in any other situation he might have been unable to stop staring at the

way the muscles in the blonde's arms bulged and stretched with each rotation, but seemed he'd finally had the lust traumatised right the fuck out of him because he could only sigh, averting his gaze.

"Oi," Kacchan snapped, and Izuku looked back over at him. "I said I think we might be in luck."

"Yeh, I heard you."

Kacchan scowled, muttering something under his breath that sounded suspiciously like *'ungrateful little bastard'*, before he stepped back from the generator, the thing now making a low humming sound.

"Keep this thing going for a while and I reckon we'll have some honest to fucking god hot water."

That *did* pique Izuku's interest somewhat, and he looked back at the shower, opening the wooden door to check the condition of the thing.

"I get dibs on first shower," Kacchan said.

"Huh? How comes you get to go first?"

"Because I turned on the generator while you just stood there with your thumb up your ass, dick bag," Kacchan replied.

Izuku huffed, following Kacchan back into the house again after one final glance around at the woods around them.

It wasn't a cold evening, but they decided to gather firewood anyway, the two of them clearing out the fireplace as they waited for the generator to kick in. It certainly wasn't a bad place for them to spend the night, even with the dead man wallowing in the bathtub upstairs that Izuku was trying very hard not to think about, and it even came with a small supply of canned goods. Hell, they had enough for a decent feast that night with still enough left to last them several days after that, and if Izuku's head wasn't such a state, he was sure he probably would have appreciated it a whole lot more. But Kacchan seemed content enough, busying himself with counting the food and chucking out the old wood, before he came back down from the upper floor with some greying old towels in hand, throwing one of them at Izuku.

"Probably got enough hot water now. Come on."

Izuku blinked, getting to his feet before his words sunk in, and he spluttered.

"Hah? The hell am I coming with you for?"

"Because I need someone to hold my dick up for me," Kacchan scoffed. "The hell do you think, moron?"

"*Hah?*" Izuku squeaked.

"Oh my god. I need you to keep watch. I don't want some fucking zombie sneaking up on me with my ass hanging out."

"O-oh," Izuku breathed. That made sense.

"Yeh, *oh*," Kacchan imitated cruelly. "Come on, Deku, before it gets too fucking dark out there."

Muttering to himself, Kacchan stalked out into the kitchen, and Izuku followed, rubbing his hands over his face. *God he was way too tired for this shit.*

After being certain that there were no zombies about, Izuku leaned against the wall of the generator outhouse, twiddling his weapon between his fingers as Kacchan approached the shower stall, throwing his towel over the screen, his lips curled as he examined the state of the the shower head.

"Fucking rusted up, big surprise," he muttered, before snatching it and starting to scrape at the worst of the rush with his fingernails. Izuku opened his mouth to say something, before simply shrugging. It wasn't worth the time.

When Kacchan seemed satisfied he hooked the shower head back up, and shut the swinging door behind him. Izuku felt his cheeks heat up again as the man started pulling his clothes off, hanging them on the side of the privacy screens, his bare ankles and shoulders the only thing visible as he averted his gaze again, focusing on the treeline. Then a gasp and a loud *'motherFUCK'* filled the air, and Izuku looked back to see that clearly freezing water had dumped down on Kacchan the second he turned the facet, the man frozen in place, his hair plastered down his head.

"Guess there was still some cold water in the pump," Izuku said, unable to hold back his laughter at the sight, a shivering Kacchan turning around to glare at him.

"Shut the hell up!"

Izuku continued to laugh, even as the steam started to rise from the shower, Kacchan throwing his middle finger in the air as he ducked his head back under the stream, and Izuku's laugh quickly died in his chest, watching as the water hit the man's face and slid down his throat and shoulder. Okay, so maybe trauma hadn't *completely* killed his libido ... He looked away again, hoping that his face wasn't nearly as red as it felt that it was, forcing himself to pay attention to the woods around them again. It was quiet, it had been quite for much of the day, if he was honest. He supposed the activity of the city, the fire on the road a couple days ago, all of it had drawn the zombies away from the woods and towards areas where they were more likely to find people. His mind wandered then to the zombie that had opened the car door. With everything that had happened since, he hadn't allowed himself the opportunity to really think about that event, and what it potentially meant. He already knew that the fresher the zombie the faster they were, and the hungrier they seemed to be. He'd observed zombies seeming to queue up outside of fast food joints, wandering around old department stores as if they were just browsing, and he had surmised that something must remain from when they were alive, a habit, maybe even baser instincts, that were so ingrained on humanity by this point that apparently even death couldn't stop them. But he had never seen a zombie act with actual honest to god intelligence.

"Do you think the fresh zombies are smarter?" he asked Kacchan, and he heard the facet turn and the stream of water stop.

"Hah?"

"One of the zombies back on the road opened a car door to get to me," he continued.

"You sure that wasn't an accident?" Kacchan asked, his voice muffled, and Izuku glanced over to see him vigorously towel drying his hair.

"I don't think so."

Kacchan lowered his towel, his shoulder shifting for a moment before he kicked the door to the stall open, stepping out in just the towel around his waist. Izuku was blessed with an eyeful of Kacchan's toned stomach and wide chest before he quickly looked away again, swallowing.

"I've met plenty of fresh zombies out there, Deku," he said. "I've never seen a single one open a damn door before."

"No," Izuku muttered. "Me neither."

"Oi, your turn."

Kacchan nudged his shoulder with his fist, his clothes draped over one shoulder. His hair, already somewhat of a scruffy looking mass of spikes when dry, looked like a literal explosion on his head from towel drying, and Izuku took one look at it before bursting into laughter. Kacchan's faced burned.

"The fuck you laughing at, zombie bait?!"

"It's just ... your hair," Izuku sniggered, and Kacchan raised a hand up to flatten it, sending Izuku a foul glare.

"You look like a fucking shrub," he snapped back, only making Izuku laugh harder. "Go shower. You stink."

Still snickering, Izuku took off for the stall, throwing his own towel over one screen and his clothes the other, before turning on the facet, having the sense to at least stand back a bit in case cold water rushed out this time, too. But, instead he was blessed with hot, not just warm, but *hot* running water, hitting his face and soothing his aching muscles. Trusting Kacchan to have his back, he shut his eyes, yanking his hair out of the tangled bun at the back of his head and teasing the knots. He needed a haircut, when down his hair hung below his shoulders now, and he was sure there was nothing practical about that in the Apocalypse. He grabbed the bar of soup and started washing, watching as the water by his feet turned red and brown as it ran out of the shower.

But the hot water didn't last long, and Izuku somewhat regretfully turned off the facet, drying his own hair, before his body and pulling his clothes on whilst still in the cubicle, not entirely confident in walking about half nude like Kacchan was doing, the man standing bold as brass with his chest and stomach bare as he glared at the trees ahead of them.

"Done?" Kacchan asked, and Izuku nodded, wondering whether it would be weird to tell Kacchan to put some clothes on. He followed him back into the house, pushing across the deadbolt on the backdoor behind him.

Kacchan immediately threw himself down on some blankets on the floor as soon as they were back in the living room, now cosy from the fire flickering away softly from the head of the room. Still wearing just his towel, his body stretched out as he raised an arm and threw it over his face, the angle and the lighting did nothing for Izuku's poor bruised heart. It wasn't that he and Shouto ... that it was *definite* ... that they were- *hell*. It didn't really matter what he and Shouto were by this point, he supposed. A whole life of *could be's* were laid out ahead of him like some kind of torture porn; like someone out there was taking huge pleasure in the string of loss piled on him, like there was some gratuitous plot to put him through as much hell as possible before finally killing him off. But

there they were, those *could be's*, and *should have been's*, that flashed before him as his eyes ghosted Kacchan's features, his stomach churning so uncomfortably he started to feel nauseous. How could he be looking at Kacchan, feeling the things he was feeling, right now? Right now of all times? He was sick. Surely, that's all it was. A fever of some kind ... he raised the back of his wrist to his forehead, feeling the cool skin as if it was a kind of taunt. *Or maybe you just didn't love Shouto as much as you thought you did ...* he shivered.

"No," he breathed, shaking his head. At that, Kacchan took his arm away from his eyes and shot him an enquiring look.

"No, what?" he asked, single eyebrow raised, and Izuku shook his head again.

"Nothing," he muttered. "I didn't say anything."

"Right."

Kacchan eyed him for a moment longer, before dropping his head back down to the floor with a huff, eyes closing again. Izuku swallowed, feeling another curious swoop of anger in his chest at the sight of it.

"Could you put some clothes on maybe?" he said, perhaps a little sharper than was needed. Kacchan, however, just smirked, not bothering to open his eyes.

"Why, making you uncomfortable?" he teased, and Izuku chewed the inside of his cheeks, willing himself not to yell at the man.

"Yes, actually," he replied finally. And Kacchan *did* stir at that, looking down at him again. "What if someone finds us right now, huh? And you're just sitting there in a towel."

Kacchan glared at him, refusing to break eye contact even as Izuku's wavered, before he let out a heavy sigh.

"Fine." He got to his feet, and Izuku thought it was entirely unnecessary for him to yank his towel off as he walked by, Izuku looking away so quickly his neck cracked, face heating up and seriously hating the man for how casually he stalked past, like it wasn't a big deal that he was strolling naked through the house like that. He heard his heavy footsteps up the stairs, sure the man was stomping to make a point, before letting out a long unsteady sigh. He shouldn't take it out on Kacchan ...

That was the kind of thing that Kacchan might do.

The man in question returned a few minutes later, still topless Izuku was quick to note to his despair, but he was wearing a pair of bubblegum pink Bermuda shorts, complete with white palm leaves, and Izuku honestly didn't know what more he could fucking say to the man at this point.

"That's hardly any better," he managed, glaring at the shorts as if they had personally started the Apocalypse. "You'll be seen a mile off!"

"Well I ain't sleeping in jeans another fucking night," Kacchan shot back. "And it's all I could find."

He stomped past Izuku before throwing himself back onto the blanket again, and it was only then that Izuku saw just how exhausted he was, his expression tight and body a lose jumble of limbs caked out across the ground.

"I'll keep watch first tonight," Izuku said.

"Sure, Freckles," Kacchan mumbled, his eyes now shut and lips barely moving. And *hell*, Izuku thought as his faced burned, he really must be tired if he wasn't going to argue with him ... if he was ... *Freckles?*! Shaking himself, Izuku settled himself back on the sofa, reaching for more of the coffee they had brewed. It was cold by now, but after weeks starved of caffeine he would take what he could get, and downed what was left with a gulp. Within seconds he heard deep breathing, looking over to see Kacchan lying with his mouth slightly parted, already fast asleep, and that oh so complicated mix of emotions inside him shifted to guilt once more. Kacchan had carried them the last few days, kept them going and almost sane even whilst Izuku himself had become so reckless in his pursuit of Shouto. If Kacchan could go a day without sleep, then so could he, and he resigned himself for the long haul, determined not to wake Kacchan unless absolutely necessary. And if he cautiously stepped forward and threw one of the spare blankets over him, it was only because he was worried the man would get cold and definitely not because he wasn't sure his heart could handle having him strewn out like that in front of him all night.

The hours passed with Izuku trying to keep himself entertained, whilst also keeping an ear out for trouble, but it was a quiet night. He had found a pack of cards, using his time to play some solitaire, and when got bored of that a castle of cards. His right hand still shook, he supposed it always would do after the injuries he had gotten, but it at least made it more of a challenge. A couple of hours in he'd built what could have been the most impressive card castle in the world, and he slumped back against the sofa, stifling a yawn. But as soon as he found himself without anything to occupy himself, his mind cycled through images again ... *blood and gore and tearing...*

He knocked down the castle to start again.

The early morning sun was just visible through the curtains when Kacchan stirred. Izuku had done a good job of not just sitting there are staring at him like a creep the entire night, and he supposed he probably deserved a pat on the back for that, but his eyes were drawn to him as he moved. Kacchan's face scrunched up, his head tossing from one side to the other, and Izuku's heart hammered, pushing himself forward onto the sofa. It looked as though he was having some kind of nightmare, his arms pushing at the blanket that Izuku had thrown over him as if it was suffocating him, and Izuku was on his feet, dropping to his knees beside him ready to wake him. But Kacchan stilled, the frown still on his forehead, but his expression softening. Izuku sighed, he supposed he wasn't the only one with memories that haunted him.

"I'm sorry, Kacchan," he whispered. "It isn't fair ..."

Kacchan didn't stir, his breathing just deepening again, and Izuku settled back on his knees. It was only then that he realised how close he had gotten, the blanket kicked down Kacchan's hips, his body drawn out in front of him again, and he blushed at the realisation. He still couldn't understand how Kacchan could look this good during an Apocalypse. They hardly ate, and he sure as hell hadn't seen the man pick up any weights at any point ... It would have been entirely unfair, hell he might have even been jealous, if it wasn't for the fact that he got to look at it. He frowned, rubbing his face. *No*.

But this close his eyes were drawn to him regardless, taking in the length of his torso before they were irresistibly drawn to the large purple scar on Kacchan's side, his heart hammering for an entirely different reason.

He knew how it had happened now, at least, but he still knew so very little about the bite. That huge imprint above Kacchan's right hip, the only reminder of how he had almost died a year ago, but hell what a fucking reminder it was. He'd seen the scar before, of course, but this was the first time he was really able to look at it, and up close he could see how deep the bite must have been, the uncomfortable way the flap of skin and flesh the zombie had almost torn away had healed over, leaving the surface of his skin there bumpy and misshapen. But ... had there always been so many veins sprawling out from the old wound? He frowned, almost tempted to lean closer, his hand raising hesitantly in his desire to touch, to understand ...

When he glanced back up at Kacchan's face, his heart dropped straight down into his stomach when he saw half hooded red eyes looking straight back at him. Kacchan's face was still, tired looking, but to his surprise he didn't look angry to have woken up to Izuku ogling his scar, and Izuku swallowed, his face heating up again.

"S-sorry," he muttered. "Y-you were having a nightmare so I- I didn't mean to stare at it-"

"S'fine," Kacchan mumbled, voice still heavy with sleep. "I know your nerd brain ha'been desperate to look at it since y'found out." He shut his eyes again and rolled over so that his right side was stretched out, showing the entire of the scar. "Knock y'self out."

Izuku hesitated, looking up at Kacchan, then down at the scar, and *god* did his fingers itch to find out more ... to find out what it felt like. If it hurt, if it was warmer than the rest of him ... Kacchan's scar was a constant reminder of the tragedy in his past, there was no arguing that, but it also presented so much more than that. It was a reminder that a person could survive. That a bite didn't have to mean death, at least for one person.

Hands shaking in his mingled nervousness and eagerness, he reached out, placing his fingertips on the skin surrounding the wound, testing how sensitive it was. Kacchan flinched, his breath catching, and Izuku glanced up quickly. Kacchan's brow was furrowed, but his kept his eyes closed, face away from him, and Izuku relaxed, moving his fingers closer towards the rim of the scar, watching Kacchan's reactions, before his eyes drifted back to it.

The texture was smooth, his skin morphing from a silky suppleness to the tightly stretched surface of the scar, his fingers feeling the dips in it's very centre, and Kacchan breathed in sharply, his lips thinning.

"Does it hurt?" Izuku asked, and Kacchan frowned, shaking his head.

"Nah just ... sensitive."

Izuku supposed that made sense. He was surprised there wasn't still some residual pain there, honestly, the scar was so wide and deep, but it was definitely likely that it would feel different. The nerve endings exposed, not to mention that aftermath of severe infection, he imagined that it the whole area was more tender. If someone managed to get a hit in on him on the scar it would probably hurt, though.

His hands ghosted from the centre of the scar up to one of the purple veins that curled subtly out towards Kacchan's stomach, coiling out almost to reach his belly button, and he noted that he could feel it, a small convex on the surface of his skin, and he frowned again. It was nothing like the series of dark purple veins that he had seen spread up Sero's arm, and he remembered Kacchan himself saying how his wound had never looked as bad as that either, and he wondered if maybe somewhere in that was the key. His body had fought off the infection, perhaps quickly enough to

save his life, even if the evidence of it was still present. He ran his fingertip back down the vein, glancing up as Kacchan's breath seemed to quicken, before he gently pressed on the centre of the scar.

It was strange how smooth it felt. Looking at the scar it seemed for all the world like it would be a rough mess, and truth be told he hadn't a lot of experience with scars, bar the large burn scar forming on his upper arm at least, but it was different from what he'd expected. It was pale purple in colour, pinker in the centre, and with the pale morning light shining in from the window he supposed that it wasn't nearly as ugly as it had first seemed. No, it was a reminder that Kacchan was alive. That he had survived. That he was strong, stronger than any of them maybe. It was amazing, really. Amazing, curious, hopeful, even ... *"pretty."*

He hadn't realised he'd spoken out loud until Kacchan shifted, looking down at him with a weird expression on his face, something torn between evidently wanting to yell at him, embarrassment, and disbelief. Izuku blushed, snatching his hand away as if it had been burned.

"Uh ... I mean, it's- the colours are ... I didn't mean *you*- I mean, no that's not- I'm gonna start preparing some breakfast! The sun's up so, uh ..."

He got to his feet, almost tripping over the damn things as he hurried to the cans and packets of food they'd left on the coffee table, snatching up the pain they had used for boiling water last night and making double sure not to let his gaze stray back to Kacchan.

He heard the man sit himself up, the rustling of his stupid shorts and soft bare footfalls on the hardwood floor before he felt the man's breath brush against the back of his neck and he froze. He wasn't sure what Kacchan was doing and, evidently, neither did he, Kacchan just standing there for a moment, the soft warmth of his breath the only thing that made his presence real, before he moved away.

"Gotta take a piss."

He heard Kacchan stomp back up the stairs and he let out a shaky breath. The hell was that? *What the fuck was that, Izuku? You look like a damn creep!* If Kacchan wasn't creeped out by him before, then he sure as well was now ... he was going to think he had some sort of ... some kind of *scar kink* now, for sure. God, how embarrassing. And then say that he *didn't think Kacchan was pretty*? Why couldn't he just be normal? He groaned, dropping his head in his hands.

When Kacchan came back down the stairs, still dressed in those god-awful shorts though thankfully with a t-shirt this time, Izuku busied himself with breakfast, not trusting himself to make eye contact with him. Kacchan, however, chose to overlook the moment, shoving past him so he could grab at the coffee Izuku had brewed.

"We should stay here for another couple of days," Kacchan announced, and Izuku looked up in surprise.

"Huh? But, don't you want to get back to Kirishima and the others?"

"Of course I do," Kacchan replied, scowling at him. "But we've been on our fucking feet for weeks, and you only just woke up from a fever that almost *killed* you a damn week ago. We got hot water, four walls, food, we should stay here until we get our strength back."

"I-if that's what you think we should do," Izuku said, and for some reason Kacchan's scowl only deepened.

"The fuck you saying it like I make all the decisions for?" he snarled. "Jesus, I ain't your fucking *mother*, Deku!"

"That's not what I meant!"

"Sayin' an awful lot of things you don't mean today, Deku," Kacchan interrupted, his voice a low dangerous growl, and Izuku's mouth snapped shut. He knew it. He *knew* Kacchan was going think he was a creep, he knew it, or just an asshole or ... *fuck.*

"It ain't just my fucking decision," Kacchan continued, moving around Izuku so that he could stand beside the tower of cards that was still standing on the coffee table. "So, what do you wanna do?"

Izuku wasn't entirely sure what was going on, but it damn well felt like some kind of test, going on how intensely Kacchan was staring at him over the rim of his coffee mug. He swallowed again.

"Uh, I guess ... we'll stay here. For a couple of days. Like you said."

And though he thought it was the right answer to give, Kacchan sure as hell didn't look happy with his response, his expression souring before he dropped his half empty mug down onto the coffee table.

"Fine. I'm gonna go scope out the area."

And he reached under the table to grab his pipe hammer before reaching out and flicking the bottom card of the tower, walking away as it came crashing down, leaving a very confused Izuku behind him.

Aside from apparently pissing Kacchan off, Izuku didn't achieve much more that day. Now that he had a chance to sit down, he realised just how much his body ached, and how exhausted he really was. It was stupid, perhaps but he hadn't slept all night, and it wasn't long before he fell asleep. Only for images of blood and flesh and teeth to wake him not long later, covered in sweat and panting. Kacchan shot him a look from his end of the living room, but otherwise said nothing of it, just busy sharpening all of the knives that he had pilfered from the kitchen.

Later that evening, however, Kacchan finally broke the uneasy silence between them, placing his selection of primed weapons onto the coffee table, before dropping down on the sofa beside Izuku.

"We're gonna have to kill 'em."

Izuku didn't need to ask who he meant. His grief and confusion surrounding Shouto had left him almost entirely unable to find room for his feelings surrounding Dabi and the rest of his group, even when he was standing face to face with them.

"Yeh," he replied eventually. "Yeh, I know." He slumped back in the couch. "We have the numbers once we're all back together."

"No," Kacchan said firmly. "I meant us. You and me."

Izuku's eyebrows rose, and he sat a little taller in his seat. "Huh?"

"I don't want them doing it," Kacchan continued, staring back at him. "They've been through enough shit, as it is. Losing Jirou, and Sero ... but they've never had to get their hands dirty, not a single one of them."

Izuku wanted to point out they *he* hadn't had to get his hands dirty either, but that wasn't exactly true. He wanted to hurt them. He wanted them to be trapped in that courtyard, surrounded by zombies, watch as they were torn apart for what they had done to him, done to his friends. He might not have traded blows with them, but his hands were far from clean.

"Yeh, I guess ... if Ochako and Sh- if *they* were still alive I wouldn't want them involved in something like this either. They would have done it, to protect the group but ... it would have destroyed them."

"And you?"

Izuku was reminded then of the very first real conversation he and Kacchan had, when he had climbed up onto he rooftop to hand him the photograph of his friends, a photograph that had been lost in the explosion at the RV ... *'That other group?'* Izuku had asked, *'you think it was them?'* Only for Kacchan to glare straight back into his soul as he answered, *'and what would you do if it was?'* He had been asking him, even back then, whether Izuku had the strength of nerve to do what had to be done ... had he known, even then, that Izuku was capable of far more than he had let on?

"I don't want to be a killer," Izuku replied, honestly. "But that doesn't mean I'm not prepared to be. They're not going to just let us live. And ... people that dangerous? We can't know that it's just my group, or yours, that they've hurt."

Kacchan continued to stare at him, red eyes so intently focused that Izuku felt naked where he sat.

"You're sure?"

"I'm sure," Izuku replied firmly.

"Good. They'll come looking for us eventually. And when they do I ain't wasting a second, you hear me?"

Izuku nodded. He felt ill, and it didn't matter for the grief in his heart, they needed to end this. Dabi and the rest wouldn't stop hunting them down, wouldn't stop killing, just knowing they were out there meant that Izuku could never feel safe. Not for himself, and not for his friends. Because that was what mattered ... it couldn't happen again. He wouldn't let it happen again. There would be no more deaths like Jirou's, like Sero's. Like Shouto's ... no one else would have to lose their family like he had done, all thanks to four sick people.

"How do we do it?" Izuku asked, his heart hammering.

"I dunno yet," Kacchan replied honestly, looking away from him then. "We don't know when we'll next come across them, but we should be preparing for it anyway. You're ok with a weapon, but you need to get better."

"Ok, so how do we do that? Practice on zombies?"

"That's exactly how we do it. The hell do you think I kill so many of them, hah? You thought I just did it for fun?"

Izuku hesitated. "Uh, I don't know if that's a trick question or not. You ... do kinda seem to enjoy it."

Kacchan opened his mouth to yell at him, before he stopped, pressing his lips back together with a pout. "Alright, fuck you."

"We'll practice," Izuku agreed. "And we'll stop them."

"Good," Kacchan repeated.

"Good."

"The hell you copying me for?"

"Just trying to stay confident about it, I guess. So do we ... uh, take them out, before we get back to the others?"

"I've been thinking that through all day," Kacchan replied. "If we don't want them involved then it makes sense. But the longer we're separated from them the harder it will be to find them. I've been gone long enough already, fuck knows what kind of shit they'll have got themselves into by now." He raised a hand, looking tired again as he pushed his hair back from his temple. "*Idiots*," he chastised, but not unfondly. Izuku smiled, the sensation tugging uncomfortably on his cheeks.

"They're strong people, Kacchan," he said softly. "They're ok. I can feel it."

Kacchan shot him a look from the corner of his eyes, but didn't argue, the two of them falling into a semi-comfortable silence after that, just watching the fire dance away from the fireplace.

"I'm sorry about Shouto."

An instant coldness spread over his limbs at the mention of his name, and he wished the fire could be bigger, hotter. He wasn't ready to talk about it. He wasn't sure he'd ever be ready to talk about something like this ... but Kacchan was trying, and he knew how hard it must have been for the man to bring it up.

"It's ..." he swallowed, not entirely sure what to say. "Thank you," he finished lamely, his voice quiet.

"And I'm sorry for ..." Kacchan waved his arm in the air, mouth snapped shut and his cheeks burning red. "Y'know. Just sorry."

Izuku blinked, turning in his seat to face him. "Huh? You've got nothing to apologise for?"

"Don't fucking argue with me about it," Kacchan snarled, looking more like himself again, before he winced. "You were right, alright? If I hadn't been so fucking ... I dunno. If I had just- *maybe* we'd have fucking made it in time. Is all."

Izuku's eyes widened and he gasped, the horrible words he had thrown at Kacchan rushing back to him.

"No!" he yelped, his hands reaching out and grabbing hold of Kacchan's forearm. He seemed to wince again, eyes darting between the grip around his arm and the man staring at his so urgently. "No, Kacchan I'm- I didn't mean that! I was just angry and confused and ... it's not your fault."

"You ever say anything you actually mean?" Kacchan asked, and just like that they were staring at each other again, red eyes meeting green, and Izuku felt this heat wash over him, the challenge in Kacchan's expression impossible to miss, impossible to *understand*. He didn't know what Kacchan wanted. What he expected of him.

"Sometimes," he replied. "I was never very good at being honest with myself, let alone anyone else."

"You really never struck me as a dishonest person," Kacchan said. "An idiot, definitely. But ... you should say what you mean. Mean what you say, or some shit. I don't like playing fucking games with people."

Izuku frowned. "Games?"

"Yeh," Kacchan said, his voice still firm, refusing to look away and ... were they suddenly closer? Why was Izuku's heart beating so damn fast in his chest? Could Kacchan *hear it* or ... or was it not his own heart beat that he could hear? And then Kacchan's eyes flicked downwards, towards Izuku's lips, and the rush of understanding hit him.

Kacchan had kissed him first. It had been bad, and it had apparently been a mistake, but he had made the first move. Not to mention all the comments over the last few weeks, the way he seemed so determined to stick by Izuku's side even though he was dragging him back into the grips of death. And Izuku hadn't been so innocent either, he had lusted after the man from the goddamn moment they met but ... hell, Izuku wanted to. He really wanted to.

He was leaning forward before he had a hope of stopping himself, his eyes lingering on Kacchan's lips as he leaned in closer, before drifting back up to his face, eyes meeting red. *Red. Flesh, tearing ... blood ...*

"Shouto's dead," Izuku said, and Kacchan froze, blinking back at him.

"Hah?"

"He's dead, I-" he pushed away. "This isn't *right*. You shouldn't-"

"The *fuck*?" Kacchan hissed, face furious. "You're the one about to kiss *me* just after your boyfriend fucking died! Don't put this on me!"

"And *you* were the one about to kiss me after my boyfriend just died!" Izuku cried back.

"So, he *was* your boyfriend," Kacchan said, leaning back on the sofa and crossing his arms over his chest.

"No! He wasn't, you just keep saying it!"

"So it's alright for you to keep staring at me and touching me up just after your boyfriend fucking died, but I try and do something about it and *I'm* the asshole?"

"I wasn't touching you up!"

Kacchan barked a loud laugh at this.

"Oh, so you had to wait until Shouto died before making a damn move on me?" Izuku shot back, furious and embarrassed.

"Well, I wasn't gonna do anything when he might still be alive, was I? The hell do you take me for?"

"I dunno, Kacchan," Izuku huffed, his face burning. "I just didn't think you'd be trying to kiss me literally the *day* after I found out Shouto was dead."

"Oh, *I'm sorry*," Kacchan scoffed. "You know I've never actually made out with someone who's boyfriend had just died, I didn't realise there was a designated amount of time to fucking wait!"

"There isn't! But at least longer than a damn day-"

"You wanna or not, Deku?" Kacchan interrupted. His face was scrunched up with a burning embarrassment that Izuku had never seen on his face before, not even when he had launched a full frontal attack on his jaw with his mouth back on the road, but determined none-the-less.

"I-" Izuku choked. He wanted to. Of course he wanted to. Now Kacchan was right here, sat in front of him, so damn close and so willing and ready to just kiss him if he wanted it, of course he wanted to fucking grab the damn guy and kiss his brains out. But Shouto had just died, and every single time he closed his eyes it was all he could see, all he could hear ... Of course he wanted to, but how could he kiss Kacchan when Shouto's mangled body was all he could see?

"Right," Kacchan said, taking his silence as a no. "Point taken. Don't need to tell me twice, Deku."

"No," Izuku whined. "Kacchan, it's not like that."

"Then what is it like, Deku? Just fucking tell me coz I'm real tired of having to guess!"

"I want to," Izuku said firmly, though his lower lip wobbled, and Kacchan narrowed his eyes at him. "But I can't. Not right now. Every time I shut my eyes I ..." he swallowed, shaking his head. "I need time, Kacchan."

Kacchan looked back at him for a moment, before his shoulder sagged.

"Alright, shit ok I get it," he sighed.

"Thank you, Kacchan."

"The hell you thanking me for yelling at you for?" Kacchan snapped, and Izuku managed a small laugh.

"What if that's what I'm into?"

"*Hah?*!"

"Oh my god! No, that was a joke! Ah, oh my god I should just stop talking ..."

"Not the worst idea you've ever had," Kacchan grumbled, still looking entirely embarrassed, and dare Izuku say it, kind of adorable with his lips pouting like that and his arms crossed so resolutely over his chest. And then his red eyes darted towards him, and he huffed, holding his arms out. Izuku blinked.

"What?"

"Just fucking- *come here, idiot*," Kacchan managed through gritted teeth, and tentatively Izuku moved forward, not at all sure what Kacchan was getting at before the man grabbed hold of his shoulder and yanked him into his chest, wrapping his arms around him and pulling him into, honestly, the worst hug Izuku had ever received. It hurt, his neck was at a weird damn angle, his arms trapped between their chests, but Kacchan's warmth soothed him anyway. His scent, he now realised a kinda sweet caramel like smell now that the many layers of sweat and grime and blood had been washed off him, entirely comforting, and he smiled.

"Are you any good at affection at all?" he mumbled into Kacchan's chest, and the man snorted.

"Shut the hell up."

"I can't feel my arms, Kacchan."

"Good."

"I ... I think you might be breaking my neck."

"Fucking finally."

Izuku laughed again, shutting his eyes to appreciate the moment for what it was, before Kacchan finally let him go, averting his gaze immediately to cover up his beet red cheeks, and getting to his feet.

"I'm gonna do another walk around the perimeter before we call it a night," he grumbled.

"You don't want me to come with you?"

"Nah, I-" his face flushed, if possible, even more. "Gimme a minute."

Izuku cocked his head to one side as Kacchan hurriedly walked away, before the dawning realisation hit him and his own cheeks heat up.

"Oh."

He'd feel bad about it if it wasn't so funny. If his chest didn't feel so warm. If he didn't feel that momentary swoop of ... something. Not happiness, not exactly, he wasn't sure he'd be there for quite some time yet, but something. Whatever the hell he and Kacchan were, he at least knew that they had one another's backs. And ... hell, was he so bold as to think that Kacchan was *waiting?* Was he actually just going to be waiting for Izuku to be ready? A huge part of him hoped that it wouldn't take long, that he would be ready sooner rather than later.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 18: Got Some Skin in the Game

Chapter Summary

In which there is tension and only some of it gets resolved

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku and Bakugou spent the next two days at the house in the woods, regaining some of their strength, and resting as much as they could in between searching the perimeter for any other supplies that might be of use to them, keeping an eye out for hostiles as they went. The house was a peaceful place, wholly at odds with everything else they had been through so far in the Apocalypse; they hadn't seen even one single zombie in the three days that they had been there, and whether or not that league of bastards were looking for them, they certainly hadn't caught any sight of them yet.

Despite the obvious tension between the two of them, and Izuku's moments of introversy where he would seemingly shut down for minutes at a time, things were going better between them now. Kacchan, for as much as he had been obviously unwilling to *'goddamn tiptoe around you, nerd',* to begin with, had quickly fallen back into his own particularly brand of supportive banter and teasing. At least, Izuku was pretty sure it would be considered supportive ... But, he was also certain that Kacchan was walking about shirtless, or on more memorably occasions, just in his underwear, far more than any reasonably person ought to. It was just a relief, honestly, that Kacchan was treating him no differently, even after their weird sort of ... *confession*, if you could even call it that. He wasn't the kind of person to want anybody worrying about him, especially someone like Bakugou, and that painful hug had been the very extent of Kacchan's affections. Or, perhaps not ... Kacchan ruffled his hair now. Ok, pretty roughly to be fair, and always with a sneer or a sassy comment, but it was contact that hadn't been there before they had almost kissed a second time. Izuku decided to take it and not ask too many questions.

Whilst the lack of zombies did mean that they were offered some peace an quiet, it also meant that they had no opportunity to really start fine-tuning their fighting skills before the inevitable shown down with the bastards. Izuku honestly wasn't sure what kind of training Kacchan had in mind when he had brought it up; after all, as far as he was aware neither of them were exactly experts with weapons, or martial arts, or anything other than you basic aim the pointy end at the zombies head and smash. To add to that, fighting zombies and fighting another person wasn't even in the same goddamn ballpark ... the zombies were fast, sure, and they were blood thirsty, but they weren't intelligent. They couldn't plan an attack like their enemies could, they wouldn't play dirty like their enemies certainly would, and he brought that subject up with Kacchan on the third morning as he leaned against the front door, looking out into the woods over the mug of coffee he had in hand.

"What are we going to learn fighting against zombies?" he asked. It was an abrupt question, and Kacchan looked up from where he had been piling up new firewood, lip curling in irritation.

"Hah?"

"Well, it's just ... they're completely different from Shigaraki and Dabi," he replied. "I know how to kill zombies, Kacchan. But I don't know how to kill another person ..."

"If you can kill a zombie you can kill one of them fuckers," Kacchan grunted back to him, hoisting another piece of wood over and chucking it into the pile. "They're no more alive than the fucking dead, far as I'm concerned."

"That's ... not what I meant," Izuku said. It was still so ... uncomfortable? Surreal? Talking about this. Talking about killing another person as if it was normal. He supposed, in this new world, it was probably about as normal as it could ever get. "I'm not saying talking about morally. It's the practicalities of it that's worrying me."

Kacchan stood up straight, wiping his wrist across his sweaty brow. He was shirtless again, because of course he was, and Izuku fought to keep his eyes fixed on Kacchan's face.

"Well, that's why I'm gonna teach ya, dork."

"No offence, but what do you know about it?" Izuku replied. "I fully acknowledge you're probably quicker and better than I am when it comes to taking out zombies, but do you actually have combat skill? Experience?"

Kacchan scowled, his hands dropping to his hips, snagging on the waist band of those fucking pink shorts and jostling the butterflies in Izuku's stomach again. "Yeh, I fucking do actually, y'damn brat." Kacchan's insults certainly involved less swearing around him now, *so there was that ...* Izuku perked up, leaning to place his coffee mug down on the ground beside him.

"You do?"

"Yeh, I fucking boxed for years," Kacchan replied. "I was too busy uni and shit to go pro, but still. I was the tits."

"You, uh ... you boxed?" Izuku said, his voice coming out a little shakier than seemed fair, feeling his cheeks warm up. God, he had it bad... *He had it so bad*. He'd never shown an interest in boxing before, not in his entire goddamn life, but know that Kacchan had been good at it, he suddenly found the idea very intriguing indeed.

"Don't look so freaked out, Deku," Kacchan sneered, obviously mistaking his stutter for nerves. "I ain't about to punch you out."

"But ... you can show me how?" Izuku asked, swallowing down the spit forming in his mouth at the very thought. "I mean, you can show me how to box?"

"I'm not going to teach you boxing, moron," Kacchan snapped. "But I can teach you how to guard, how to hit, how to hold a weapon properly. The kind stuff that'll actually be useful to you."

"Ok," Izuku replied. "Let's do it now."

Kacchan looked taken back by that. "Hah? Now?"

"Yeh, why not? What else have we got to do?"

Kacchan eyes him for a moment, his eyes dragging from head to toe in a way that made Izuku shiver before his lips spread into a grin, and his eyes flashed in an entirely dangerous way.

"Alright, Deku. Let's do it right now."

Izuku felt a shiver run through him at those words, though the way he held it back and remained close to stoic was quite commendable. Kacchan stepped away from the pile of firewood and walked to the weedy lawn of the house's front garden, raising a hand and gesturing for Izuku to follow him. Izuku, feeling both excited yet decidedly nervous, followed after him, standing in the spot that Kacchan gestured to, the two of them standing to face one another.

"I dunno shit about Shigaraki," Kacchan said. "I haven't seen that creepy bastard throw hands at anyone, 'cept the zombies back there, but I do know Dabi. And that fucker is fast."

Izuku swallowed. Every time he heard that name ... *Dabi* ... his spine tingled, and his thoughts jumped straight back to that awful place, the flashing hallway, the mangled corpse, and with each flashback he only grew angrier and angrier about all that had happened.

"He nearly got the best of me once," Kacchan continued, a slight twitch in his eye the only indication that he had recognised Izuku's minor change in demeanour. "'Course, I had a fucking pipe bomb and my finger on the trigger of the damn thing so ... bomb trumps fists, I guess, no matter how fast you are."

"But, I don't have any bombs," Izuku said. "And neither do you any more."

"Only coz I ain't got the right shit to make any with," Kacchan replied, indifferently, and Izuku's quipped his brow in interest.

"Oh! You should teach me how to make them as well!"

"You wanna m- *one thing at a damn time, nerd!*" Kacchan snapped. "Fuck, you got the attention span of a fucking squirrel."

"Hmm, but squirrels are pretty cute," Izuku said, without thinking, and Kacchan froze, his cheeks visibly flushed.

"They carry fucking disease and shit everywhere!" he yelled, sounding flustered. Izuku almost grinned. "Shut up, Deku, you gonna take this seriously or not?"

"Sorry."

"As I was fucking saying, Dabi is fast, and if it's a bust up between you and him, right now I don't really fancy your chances."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat and his stomach sunk at this. He had been so focused on whether he could kill another person, that he never really stopped to think about the possibility that the other guy might be a hell of a lot better than him. By this point, he was well used to the idea that he might die any damn second, in as much as any human could really acknowledge that fact, but getting killed in a fight between himself and Dabi, or Shigaraki, or the other two assholes somehow hadn't really occurred to him.

"Oh," he said finally. "Right."

"If we wanna beat Dabi then we gotta be ready for him," Kacchan continued. "You got a fast opponent, then you focus on your defence and don't let them get a damn hit in. He's got speed, we

got stamina. We'll tire the bastard out."

"I'm pretty fast," Izuku said. "I mean, when it comes to running anyway."

"Sure," Kaccahn replied with half a shrug. "I suppose if it gets bad you can just out run the bastard. But being fast on your feet and fast in a fight ain't the same damn thing. He's gonna try and get behind you and get the first hit in before you've even had a chance to think, and he'll use his size against you too."

Suddenly, this was all seeming a whole lot more complicated that it had seemed a couple days ago. And it certainly hadn't seemed easy back then, either.

"So, what do I do?"

"You guard. You stay low, and you wait for the right opportunity to stab him in the fucking gut," Kacchan replied coldly, his eyes burning. "Dabi's got the range advantage, he fucking used it on me, too. But lucky for you you're fucking tiny so if you get in close to him he's gonna have a real shitty time of it."

"I'm not tiny," Izuku protested, with a slight pout. And then Kacchan was staring at him, perhaps unconsciously chewing on his lower lip and his eyes hooded, and Izuku felt his stomach twisting at the sight. *Fuck, fuck, Kacchan should not be looking at him like ...*

"You're a short ass, Deku," Kacchan finally replied, seeming to shift out of his own haze. "Facts are facts. I didn't say it was a fucking bad thing, did I?"

"You inferred that it was," Izuku replied, and Kacchan threw his arms out either side of him.

"I said *lucky for you*, how was that inferring it as a fucking bad thing?" he demanded, exasperated.

"It's just the way you said it!"

"I didn't say it like anything!"

"Besides, you're not much taller than me."

"Hah?!"

"Well, you're not! Like ... a couple inches."

Kacchan's face burned red and he raised his fist, growling and advancing. "I'll give you a couple inches you shit faced, cactus headed, cock-sucking piece of-"

"Oh, only a couple?"

Kacchan stopped again, and Izuku emboldened by the mortification on Kacchan's face, smirked.

"You a fucking bitch," Kacchan hissed.

"Quit wasting time, Kacchan, I thought you were going to teach me to fight?"

"No, fuck you," Kacchan growled, stepping away from him. "Figure it out on your damn own, smartass. Get dicked by Dabi for all I care, but don't come crying to me when he smashes your

thick fucking skull in."

Izuku's smirk dropped as Kacchan turned away from him, and he wondered if maybe he had taken things too far. He rubbed the back of his head. "Kacchan, I-"

"If you're not going to take it fucking seriously then I'm not gonna bother!" Kacchan snarled, looking furious now. "It ain't a fucking joke, Deku. You get that? That monster will kill you and fuck your damn corpse for good measure, and if you're not going to take him seriously then you're not going to fight him at all!"

Izuku looked down at the ground. He understood how serious this all was, of course he fucking did.

"Ok," he replied shortly. "I'm sorry. I'll take it seriously."

"Good," Kacchan snapped. "Now look at me, ain't got time for you to mope about this."

Maybe he wasn't being any nicer to me ... But Izuku looked up regardless, taking in the guarded expression on Kacchan's face as he glared back at him. He didn't need Kacchan's fucking judgement right now, either. He was already angry enough as it was.

"I'm gonna teach you some basic fucking guards to start," Kacchan said, "and you're gonna try and block me. Think you can fucking manage something like that, Deku?"

"You don't have to be such an asshole about it," Izuku huffed, feeling his anger coiling and ready to snap. "You know, Sero and Jirou might have died because of them, but neither Dabi nor Shigaraki beat any of your friends to fucking death like they did mine! The hell makes you think I view any of this as a joke?"

"Because you're messing around!" Kacchan yelled back. "You serious about it them prove it to me!"

"Fine, fuck your fucking guards. Come at me right now!"

"The *fuck*, Deku? You have no idea what you're doing."

"Well maybe I'm not a boxer or some crap but I've been in enough fights in my life to know how to handle myself! Come on! You think I can't handle it?"

"I know you can't!"

"You don't know a damn thing!" Izuku was almost screaming now, his face burning in rage his heart beating so fast in his chest it hurt. "Fucking fight me!"

Kacchan snapped, his face morphing into something ugly and terrifying as he ran at him, and Izuku only had time to think *what the hell am I doing?!* before Kacchan was on him, grabbing him around the throat and throwing him to the ground, a fist pulled back and ready to smash into his face. And shit, Izuku was angry, furious, but he was still weak, he knew he was still so damn weak, and if this was a real fight then he'd be dead right now. Kacchan's fist connected with the side of his jaw and he cried out, the wet sound echoing through his skull, embedding itself there, and the images flashed in front of his eyes again. *Red ... blood ... tearing ... flesh ...* That wouldn't be him. *That wouldn't be him.*

He threw his head forward, his forehead connecting with a wet crack with Kacchan's nose, and the man drew back, swearing loudly.

"Mother*fuck*!"

Still seeing red, Izuku took advantage of his opponents lapse in concentration and reached out, grabbing a handful of his hair and pulling him roughly to the side so that he was no longer entirely on top of him, giving him access to land a punch of his own to Kacchan's ribs. He heard Kacchan growling, a feral noise that left the hairs on the back of his neck standing up, before the front of his hair was grabbed, his head yanked up then down, hard, his skull connecting with the grass with enough force to leave him seeing stars. He kicked out, pulling his knees up to his chest so that he could press one of his heels into the area above his hip where Kacchan's bite was was, and Kacchan yelled out, a cry that was full of pain before the heavy body was off of him, Kacchan bent double and grabbing his stomach. Izuku scrambled to his feet, ready to attack again before the vomit that Kacchan spewed out onto the ground in front of him brought him back to his senses.

He panted, looking down at Kacchan as he fought for breath, raising a shaky hand to his mouth to wipe away the spit.

"K-Kacchan, I'm-"

But the look on Kacchan gave him forced him to silence, those red eyes burning with unadulterated rage and ... *God*, he had no chance to think about everything those eyes said to him before Kacchan had launched himself at him again, throwing him to the ground and pounding his fist back into the side of Izuku's jaw, and Izuku collapsed beneath him.

"You're *dead*," Kacchan snarled, grabbing the front of his hair again and pulling hsi face up. "Even playing dirty you can't fucking beat me, so how the fuck do you expect to kill Dabi if this is all you fucking got, hah!"

Izuku panted beneath him, unable to meet his eyes.

"Answer me!" Bakugou yelled in his face, and Izuku flinched.

"Wh-" he breathed, chest heaving. "What do you even want me to say?"

Bakugou growled.

"You- you made your damn point ok?" Izuku replied, his limbs feeling heavy and his body exhausted. "I can't .. I can't beat Dabi. I can't even avenge their-" he swallowed, shaking his head as much as he was able in Bakugou's grip. "*Damnit*!"

Kacchan let go of his hair, and Izuku stared dully up at the sky above them, indifferent to the pain radiating across his face.

"The hell were you trying to prove, hah?" Kacchan ground out as he got to his feet. Izuku looked over at him, noticing the blood streaming down his face from his nose.

"I broke your nose," he said quietly.

"Yeh, no shit," Kacchan snapped, wiping the blood away. "Did you aim to kick at my fucking scar?"

Izuku hesitated, feeling bad again. "I, uh ... yeh. Sorry."

"It really pissed me off," Kacchan replied, as if the look on his face after Izuku had reached out for him hadn't already pressed that point.

"I know," Izuku replied solemnly. And Kacchan seemed to hesitate, glaring down at him, before he reached out a hand, extending it towards him.

"It was an okay tactic. I guess."

Izuku lay there, staring up at Kacchan in shock, before the hand waved in his face again and he grabbed it, allowing Kacchan to pull him back to his feet.

"Kacchan, I-" but the movement over Kacchan's shoulder grabbed his attention, and he looked over to see two zombies breaking through the treeline, running at the both of them as fast as their broken rotted bodies would allow, and he grabbed one of the pieces of firewood that Kacchan had thrown to the ground earlier. "Look out!"

They dispatched the two zombies without issue, the bloody corpses dropping to a heap on the ground, but it was enough of a surprise to shake a sense of urgency into them.

"Looks like our luck's run out," Izuku said. His face hurt, Kacchan had got two solid punches in and he was sure he was going to be left a huge bruise and some swelling by the end of the day. So much for using their time here to build their strength back up. "If there's two of them, more are bound to follow."

Kacchan grunted, rubbing the blood away from his face again. "We got plenty food to be going with, the rest of the day ahead of us. We should get moving now before we find ourselves over run with them."

Izuku nodded. They had had a good run of it, two days of rest and no zombies was really more than anyone could ask these days, but there was still a heavy weight in his stomach at the thought of being out there again, and he couldn't deny that his nerves were still somewhat shot after the fight with Kacchan. The man in question stalked past him, teeth grinding audibly, and he found himself reaching out for him, hand snagging his wrist and causing him to stop, glaring back at him.

"Kacchan, look, I'm-"

"Forget it, nerd," Kacchan interrupted. "I already have."

Izuku swallowed, but nodded, letting go of his wrist.

They packed as much stuff as they could carry, and Kacchan finally changed out of his conspicuous shorts and into jeans, and within the hour they were on the move again, Izuku not enjoying the tightness in his face, but mercifully thankful that the swelling was isolated to his jaw and not spreading up his cheek. Kacchan, on the other hand, was already rapidly forming two black eyes from the sheer force Izuku had smashed into his nose, two wads of tissue stuffed up his nostrils to stem the bleeding. Izuku had tried to apologise for it again, only for Kacchan to threaten to break his nose instead, and he'd been left in an awkward limbo of guilt and amusement, Kacchan looking entirely ridiculous with tissue up his nose and purple spread across his face. At least, he reasoned, it was evidence that he really had got a good hit in.

They continued walking through the woodland, following the trail that Kacchan had picked out for them, and according to him they were still making progress for the town close to the base of Mount Fuji. It was a small isolated burrough from the city of Fujinomiya, a place that Kacchan had supposedly visited a number of times in his past when his family went on camping trips, and being such a small town there was still a whole heap of hope that residents had left long before looting the entire place. It was still easily a few hours hike away from where they had been sleeping, but despite their war wounds, Izuku was in the best health that he had been in weeks, and after several days of much needed rest he was able to keep pace with Kacchan without stopping.

When they approached the town, keeping close to the curb as they walked up the long winding road, it was with their weapons in hand and their sense primed. Izuku didn't know whether or not zombies ... migrated, in a sense of the word. If they were in a place where they were no humans to chow down on, would they continue to rove and travel until this found a place that did? After all, the zombies they had seen in the woodland all seemed to be walking somewhere, even if it was mostly aimless they certainly weren't standing still. In a town as small as this, especially if there was no one living there any more, was it right to assume that all the zombies had already left long ago? Perhaps drawn to something else? They walked down the deserted street, the buildings either side of them small and old, he supposed they would have probably been described as quaint once upon a time ...

"It seems abandoned," Izuku said, and Katsuki grunted, eyes darting this way and that as he kept an eye on every alley, every rooftop, ever doorway, his hands tightening and loosening around his weapon like it was a habit.

"There's a small supermarket towards the end of this road," Kacchan said. "If we're lucky, we can grab some supplies there, then find somewhere to hold up until morning."

Izuku nodded, following after him. He couldn't even really smell the dead here, was it possible that most people had cleared out before the pandemic grew unmanageable? A small town like this, he supposed people might have been better at looking out for one another.

The supermarket doors were wide open, and from the looks of things, however, it had definitely been looted, but Izuku could already see through the window that there were things there that they would be able to make use of ... hell, they'd definitely find some food here. He shot Kacchan a lopsided grin, wincing at the pain in his jaw as Kacchan rolled his eyes at him, before he reached out his pipe and rapped it sharply against the door frame, the knock echoing out across the street.

They waited, but there was no responding crash, no sound of bodies dragging themselves across the floor to get to them, and with a satisfied grunt Kacchan pushed through the door and took a look around.

"We need some more first aid supplies," he said. "As well as food-"

"I'll get those," Izuku said. "I know a little bit about what I'm looking for, and what medication would be useful."

Kacchan frowned at him, looking for all the world like he was about to fucking argue with him about it, before he shrugged.

"Fine, suit yourself. I'm gonna look for food."

Izuku nodded as Kacchan walked away down another aisle, before he looked up at the little sign posts hanging from the ceiling, spotting what he was after; *Toiletries and Medication*, perfect! He paused to grab one of the shopping baskets by the door before heading off in the direction of the toiletries, hopeful that there would at least be some medication left.

The aisle had definitely been raided before him, any and all pain relief was long gone, but there was bandaging, some cold and flu relief that might prove useful now that the weather was starting to turn, and he even picked up some anti-acids, having had far more than his fair share of stomach upsets throughout the course of the Apocalypse (no one mentioned how sick being forced to eat the weirdest shit, and sparingly so, could make you in those old survival horrors ...) He got back to his feet after rummaging through the bottoms shelves, pleased with his find, before his eyes drifted over to the shelf section to the right, and his face immediately burned red.

He'd always thought it a strange commentary on human behaviour that, in almost every store he passed through, the sexual health section was generally cleared out as much as anything else. And hell, he wasn't judging, he supposed it was great that people were still thinking to play it safe even as the world fell apart around him, and this was probably the first place he'd been since the very start where that section was almost intact, and his mouth grew uncharacteristically dry as he found himself staring the the colourful packaging, quickly looking up and down the aisle to be sure that Kacchan hadn't caught up with him.

Things weren't ... they hadn't ... *Shit was complicated right now*. In one sense, Kacchan had been far from opposed to something, well, happening between them. But in another, he hadn't exactly specified what that something should be and how far they would, you know, go with that something, and he sure as hell didn't want to piss Kacchan off by assuming anything. But, even if it wasn't complicated in that way, Izuku already knew that there were certain risks surrounding Kacchan that he sure as hell had never had to consider before in his whole damn life ... He knew that the zombie virus could be transmitted sexually, that much was a fact, so if things were to ever ... progress, between the two of them, then protection was an absolute must, and he hadn't seen a whole lot of that on their journey. Now would be the logical time to pick up some supplies, just to be on the safe side ...

His hand definitely shook as he reached out, looking up and down the aisle again, before grabbing the first pack within his reach. *Regular*. Nothing fancy, nothing weird, just your bog standard pack of condoms, discrete enough for him to slip into his pocket and keep hidden to avoid the embarrassment of Kacchan spotting them. But then ... he paused. It was only a six pack. Hell they had the whole damn Apocalypse ahead of him and, shit, was it too bold of him to assume that if things did progress that way between Kacchan and himself then six probably wasn't about to cut it. He put the packet back, before grabbing a pack of twenty four, a bit big but he could still bury them in the bottom of his pack. There was also the question of lube, and he could feel his stomach churning at the very thought, his neck heating up in embarrassment because there were certain things that would be a hell of a lot more difficult without it. He looked back down at the packet of condoms in his hand ... should he risk grabbing a bottle of lube too? Maybe they could make do with some lubed condoms instead ...

"What're you doing?"

Izuku shrieked, jumping and throwing the packet onto the ground with such force that it bounced and hit him square in the face, causing him to squeak again, cheeks burning bright red as he tried to step in front of the shelves.

"Uh- n-nothing! Just, uh, cold medicine, see?" he reached blindly into the basket, grabbing the first packet his hand touched and thanking whatever sick fucker that was up there that he had, indeed, grabbed the cold medication. Kacchan narrowed his eyes.

"Funny, how do condoms help with a cold, exactly?"

"Oh- oh," Izuku yelped. "Oh you mean *that*! I, uh ... you know ... Just, Apocalypse huh? Might need to, uh ... repopulate the earth or-" he trailed off, his voice high and uncomfortable, as Kacchan just stared back at him, his expression not revealing anything.

"Repopulate with *condoms*?" he said, deadpan. *Idiot*. Izuku couldn't think of a damn thing to say in response to that, just staring at him in a wide eyed fear, mouth agape.

"Uh-" he squeaked.

Then Kacchan stepped past him, grabbing the red packet that he had thrown to the ground, and looking down at it before scoffing. He threw it over his shoulder, before pushing past Izuku to get the shelves, reaching out and grabbing a purple packet before dropping it indifferently into Izuku's basket.

"Uh-" Izuku repeated, but Kacchan was already walking away from him, grabbing a chocolate bar from one of the promotional hangers by the menstrual health section, and Izuku, blushing so badly he was sure his face was about to burn off, looking into his basket and down at the purple pack.

Extra Large.

He squeaked again, eyes darting back up to Kacchan who had his back turned to him and was already at the end of the aisle, whistling to himself. Izuku paused. *Yeh* ... He grabbed the lube.

Chapter End Notes

Yup, yup that was from that one Walking Dead scene between Glenn and Maggie. But how could I resist?

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 19: Lemme Pick Your Brains

Chapter Summary

In which there are no kind revelations ...

Chapter Notes

CW: Heavy gore/violence. Mentions of alcohol abuse.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku caught up with Kacchan a couple of minutes later, after shoving his more *sensitive* of supplies into the very bottom of his backpack and layering everything else he had picked up on top of it, his face still burning and his mind racing to places where it really ought not to. Kacchan, for his part, looked entirely indifferent, expression passive as he packed his own pack, before shoving a handful of crisp packets into Deku's arms because he'd run out of space. Izuku swallowed hard, his throat feeling decidedly like sandpaper as Kacchan's hands brushed against his arms for the barest of moments, nodding far more exuberantly than seemed necessary, before clumsily filling the remaining space in his backpack. It was a pretty good haul, hell it had been a long time since they'd been able to find this much food and supplies anywhere, and it was definitely a shame that they weren't able to carry any more than they already had. It was then that he noticed something else on the conveyor belt at the till, and his heart stopped, embarrassment long abandoned as his eyes darted over Kacchan's face.

Kacchan seemed to feel his gaze on him, and looked around, eyes darting from the bottles of vodka at the till and back to Deku, before his expression hardened.

"Don't jump to any conclusions," he said sharply, and Izuku let out an exasperated puff of air, dropping his pack onto the ground.

"Kacchan, you can't be serious-"

"It ain't for me," Kacchan snapped, sounding defensive and looking very much on the verge of losing his temper, before he snatched the bottles and started shoving them into a fabric bag he had already set aside. "You wanted to learn how to make bombs, right?"

"I- oh," Izuku blinked, and suddenly felt very embarrassed again, his face burning. "Sorry, I-"

"It's whatever," Kacchan interrupted, snatching both his bags from the ground, and sounding very much like it wasn't *'whatever'*, Izuku seeing that his hands were actually shaking as he hoisted his back over one shoulder, and the fabric bag the other.

"No, Kacchan, I'm sorry I shouldn't have just assumed you were drinking again," Izuku said, hurrying forward and grabbing Kacchan's forearm. "I uh," he hesitated. "Honestly I kinda hadn't even thought about the drinking thing 'til I saw the vodka just now. You have given up though, right?"

Kacchan pulled his arm away, his brow still furrowed and his expression difficult to read. He was angry, that much was clear, but there was something else there that Izuku couldn't quite place.

"It weren't even a fucking problem to begin with," he replied, voice trembling with repressed rage. "I didn't have anything to fucking *give up*."

Izuku lowered his hand, where it was still outstretched towards him. Kacchan was already turning his back on him, and he held back a sigh. The whole alcoholic thing had stopped being an issue after the explosions at the RV, in so much as Izuku never saw Kacchan drinking and had far too much else on his plate to think anything more of it, but now he did allow himself a moment to think about it, it really had been close to a month since he had last since Kacchan drink a single drop of alcohol. Addiction was far from his area of expertise, not unless you counted his demoting of an unhealthy number of hours to video games as an addition, but he was pretty sure that any kind of addict went through a withdrawal period. And now that he thought about it, he hadn't seen any of those symtoms with Kacchan. Ok, well maybe they'd both been dealing with enough anxiety as it was for him to really notice anything different there, and Kacchan was always agitated. But considering how much it seemed that Kacchan had drunk (*and when he had thought about it he had seen Kacchan taking a swig of vodka several times each day ...*), why hadn't he seen any of the other signs? Any vomiting, tremors ... hell hallucinations or a fever? Perhaps he simply hadn't had any withdrawal symptoms, though that seemed incredibly unlikely for a man who drunk as much as Kacchan had, and the other alternative ... hell, was it a possibility that he hadn't stopped drinking at all? Was Kacchan simply better at hiding it now?

His heart started to race at that thought. Sure, Kacchan had been sober and aware and he'd protected the both of them, but if Kacchan was still drinking then that put him in a lot of danger. It put *Kacchan* in a lot of danger. He hadn't said anything the last time. He knew Kacchan's drinking was a problem, but he'd ignored it, hadn't felt comfortable saying anything whilst he was still so new to the group, and the result had been Kacchan drunkenly offering himself up to a zombie, before trying to strangle him to death, and in so leading the league of bastards straight to their door. He and Kacchan were doing well together, but he couldn't stay quiet on this subject, not this time.

"Kacchan?"

"Hah? The fuck we still standing here for, come on."

"Kacchan," Izuku repeated, firmer, and the man stopped, looking over his shoulder at him, expression tight. "You didn't answer me."

"Because I don't fucking need to," Kacchan said back, voice low and threatening. "I don't owe you-
"

"You tried to kill me," Izuku interrupted, his voice raising as he talked over Kacchan. "You were pissed out of your mind, tried to kill yourself before trying to kill me. So yeh, you owe me a goddamn answer."

Kacchan's eyes narrowed, but he didn't argue back, just glaring at him from over his shoulder in silence. Seconds passed, before Kacchan was dropping his bags onto the floor again, and Izuku

immediately felt his body tense up ... was he planning to fucking fight him again?

"This really isn't any of your business, Deku," he said coldly, taking a step closer to him, and Izuku swallowed.

"Yes it is. If you're still drinking then you need to tell me. It's not just your life that you're putting at risk by keeping that kind of thing from me."

Kacchan scoffed, his lips curling.

"I'm not in the position to judge you for it," Izuku continued, his firm tone wavering a fraction. "But you can't keep something like this a secret from me."

"Don't tell me what to do," Kacchan snapped, and it sounded childish to both of them, Kacchan wincing before he glared off to the side, grounding his teeth together.

"Me telling you to stop drinking isn't going to get you to stop," Izuku continued, sighing. And sure, addiction might not be something he had a lot of experience in, but he knew that much was true. "But I need a heads up. And if ... if you want to give up then maybe I can help you?"

"I don't need help to stop drinking, Deku!" Kacchan yelled, looking angry again. "Fuck, I haven't got a fucking problem, alright? If I wanna quit, I'll quit. I can quit any fucking time I like."

"But you haven't?" Izuku pressed, feeling the anxiety spike in his chest. "Kacchan, when was the last time you had a drink?"

"Ain't none of your-"

"Don't tell me this is none of my business!" Izuku yelled, any sense of calm lost now. "Just admit to me that you're still drinking!"

Kacchan seemed to snap then, reaching round and grabbing the fabric bag full of vodka, before upending it onto the ground in front of them, Izuku jumping back in shock as the glass shattered and smashed in every direction, vodka splashing up his clothes. He then yanked back the zip to his pack, throwing food aside before he pulled out a dark flask that Izuku hadn't even seen, then lobbing it across the supermarket, the clang of it hitting the metal shelving loud and causing Izuku to wince.

"You think I can't?" Kacchan snarled, now up in Izuku's face. "Well fuck you. I ain't got a fucking problem, asswipe! It's *you* that's got the problem, keep running off into fucking danger after ghosts, dragging me along with you! You think I'm the one with the problems, hah? At least I ain't the one with the fucking kink for getting myself *murdered!*"

"Wha-" Izuku shook his head in disbelief. *He didn't have a fucking kink for getting himself murdered!* "I don't- don't turn this back on me!" he yelled. "And you can't just go cold turkey! You'll make yourself sick-"

"I ain't going cold turkey because I *ain't got a problem*," Kacchan all but spat at him, face red and burning with rage. "And fuck you for thinking otherwise!"

"Kacchan-"

But Kacchan had already turned away from him, boots crunching through the glass on the ground as he snatched up his backpack and stormed from the store. Why? Why was it that whenever they made some fucking progress Kacchan would fly off the handle again? He sighed, watching Kacchan furiously push back the door to the shop and walk out onto the street, before he made up his mind, shoulders sagging as he walked back to the alcohol aisle. Yeh, addiction wasn't his bag, but he did know that Kacchan was only going to make himself sick if he didn't do this properly ... he grabbed a couple travel sized bottles of vodka and shoved them down into his pack, a curious sensation twisting in his stomach when his fingers touched upon the plastic box towards the bottom, thinking almost longingly back to when the only thing he had to feel uncomfortable about was something as stupid as getting laid.

He caught up with Kacchan a minute later, the two of them refusing to meet each others eyes as the latter angrily marched deeper into the town.

"A-are we gonna stay here for the night?" Izuku asked hesitantly, and Kacchan scoffed.

"I dunno, you like telling me what to do so much, what d'you think?" he snapped, and Izuku groaned, exasperated.

"Oh my god, can you stop being such a child about everything?"

"Then stop talking to me like I'm one! Hah, unless that's the kinda perverted shit you're into. You get off telling me what to do all the time?"

"No!" Izuku grabbed his hair in frustration. "I can't talk to you when you're like this!"

"You mean you'll *finally* stop fucking talking?" Kacchan shot back with a sneer. "Well, thank fuck for that! I was getting real tired of hearing your whiny ass voice yammering in my ear all the damn time."

"Oh yeh, because *I'm* the one who can't get enough of the sound of his own voice."

"Damn sight better to listen to than yours!" Kacchan said, before his voice twisted into a high unflattering imitation of Izuku's. "*Kacchan don't do that, Kacchan. Kaacchan, save me Kacchan I've been attacked by zombies again, Kacchan. Kaaacchan, wipe my ass for me Kacchan because I'm too fucking stupid to do it myse-*"

"Stop!"

"I said don't tell me what to do!"

"Fucking *stop*," Izuku hissed, grabbing the back of Kacchan's shirt and yanking him back, as he pointed into the alleyway they had almost passed by. Glaring, Kacchan followed his hand, before they were both staring at the biggest goddamn fucking zombie either of them had ever seen, standing dead still in the middle of the alleyway, face angled in their direction. The thing wasn't just tall, it was *huge*, shoulders at least twice the width of Kacchan's, muscles clearly defined and heaving with each ragged breath that it took, bloodshot eyes looking straight back at them.

Wait.

Breathed? Looked?

"The fuck is that things problem," Kacchan said sourly, clearly too angry to notice the same things that Izuku had spotted, grabbing his pipe warhammer from where it hung about his waist. Izuku's heart was beating so hard in his chest he could feel the blood pumping in his ears. The thing was definitely a zombie ... the pale skin, the awkward way it held itself, slightly crouching and predatory, the sour scent that rose from it that he could smell even from here, there was no question that this thing was a fucking zombie. But in his experience, he had never seen a zombie fucking *breathe* before, watching it's heavy shoulder rise and fall, and he sure as hell had never had one look at him. Even before their eyes rotted out of their skulls their eyes had always been useless, sightless, but this thing was tracking them, eyes rolling between the two of them.

"Let's just take care of it," Kacchan said, taking a step forward, and Izuku grabbed hold of his arm again, gripping tight.

"No, stop."

"Hah?"

"Kacchan, *look at it!*"

"Yeh, it's big and it's ugly, but I can handle it."

"That's not what I mean! Look at the damn thing!"

"I'll look at it as I'm killing it," Kacchan scoffed, raising his warhammer, and the zombies eyes followed the motion. Kacchan seemed to get it then, stopping, his breath catching in his chest.

"Is that fucking thing looking at me?"

"It's *breathing*," Izuku hissed.

"Is it even a zombie?" Kacchan replied. "It ain't moving. Oi, oi!" he yelled, raising his voice, much to Izuku's protests. "Hey, tubs, you look like shit."

"*Kacchan*!"

"You been bit or something?"

The ... *zombie?* didn't repond, eyes still fixed upon Kacchan and the weapon in his hand.

"Oi, dickhead, you alive or not? Lemme know before I kill you anyway, yeh?"

"*Kacchan!*" Izuku whimpered again, and then the huge man in front of them stirred, taking half a step forward, it's humongous head cocking to one side as it started to spread it's lips.

"*Ka ... Ka ...*" it breathed, voice so hoarse it sounded like someone scrapping metal on the concrete. "*Ka ... chan ... Kacchan*." And then, it's lips spread back further, and this high grating sound broke from them, only evident as laughter from the way it's cheeks crinkled up, the sound repeating over and over.

"What the fuck," Izuku breathed, tugging on Kacchan's arm. "What the *fuck*? Let's get out of here. Let's just go."

"Yeh," Kacchan replied, sounding decidedly unsettled. "Yeh, ok."

But before they could go anywhere, Izuku caught movement from the side of his vision, and swung round before his stomach dropped down to his knees. Somehow, whilst they'd been distracted by the big ass creature fucking laughing at them, around twenty or so zombies had managed to crowd them, standing in a semi circle and blocking their exit.

"What the fuck?" Kacchan said now, realising their predicament at the same time. The creature behind them continued to laugh, and as one the mouths of the zombies surrounding them started to open, before slamming down in time, teeth clattering, leaving a disturbing series of *click click* echoing through the alleyway, and causing the hair's on the back of Izuku's neck to stand on end.

"What the hell kinda freaky shit is this, Deku?" Kacchan said, holding his weapon in front of him.

"I don't ... I don't know," Izuku replied. "I've never seen anything like this before!"

And then the laughter stopped. The *click click* stopped, leaving them in complete silence bar the beating of their own rapid hearts in their chests. Izuku had no fucking idea what to make of any of this, but he did know that they were quite suddenly in a whole heap of shit. They were trapped; twenty zombies in front of them, a huge one behind, and nothing that they could use to climb out of danger, either. They were stuck, and the only way they were going to get out of here was to fight their way out. Kacchan seemed to think the same, twisting his hammer in his fists as he eyed the zombies carefully.

"That big thing doesn't seem to be moving yet," Kacchan hissed, voice low enough that only Izuku could hear it. "We take out the normal ones first, then double team-"

But Kacchan didn't get a chance to finish his thought, before the large *zombie?* made some sort of strangled shout, and all twenty zombies rushed them at once, mouths wide and arms stretched forwards. Izuku hardly had time to register Kacchan's cry of *"motherfuck!"* before they were on them, he raising his weapon and swiping down at the very first of the zombies to come at him, but instead of trying to bite down on his throat, the zombie bodily threw him sideways, sending him flying across the pavement and landing in a pained heap on the ground. Coughing back his pain he pulled his head back, trying to scramble back up to his feet.

"Kacchan!"

The zombies, all fucking twenty of them, had completely ignored him. They'd thrown him aside, discarded him like rotten meat, before launching an all out attack on Kacchan, the man snarling and swearing as he lashed out with his hammer and kicks, dodging and darting about on the pavement as he narrowly missed having his throat torn out by blunt powerful teeth.

"Kacchan!" Izuku screamed again, terrified. He couldn't understand what the hell was going on, but he knew he needed to help him. He was back on his feet, running towards the scrum where Kacchan, despite his valiant efforts, was being pushed further and further back towards the wall, almost entirely painted in blood and guts from the force with which he cut into them. But before he reached him, he felt movement to his right, only just throwing himself out of the way in time as the arm of the massive zombie came crashing down, aiming to take him out. Izuku swore, skidding backwards, panting heavily.

"Get out of the way!" he screamed, panicked. He looked back over at Kacchan again, alarmed for a second that he couldn't see him, before another zombie was thrown back and Kacchan's loud swearing was heard over the sound of hands scrabbling and guts flying. He tried to run forward again, but the large zombie stopped him, grabbing his backpack and throwing him as easily as if

Izuku had been a stuffed toy. He yelled as the shoulder of his bad arm connected with the pavement, flinching at the pain, before the large zombie was on him once more, both fists raised high above it's head as it swung down, intent on just fucking crushing Izuku like a big. He rolled, the fists hitting the ground with so much force the pavement cracked.

"Deku!"

He heard Kacchan's cry, and unable to stop himself he tried to run in his direction. There were bodies everywhere, but there wasn't time to marvel at how impressive Kacchan's fighting was, because as their eyes connected Kacchan was jumped on again, the man growling as he was forced to the ground beneath three bodies, gnashing and biting and intent on tearing his face off with their teeth.

"*No!*"

This time, when the large zombie grabbed him, it didn't let go, a heavy force against his chest knocking the air from his lungs before he felt an incredibly pressure around his throat, so confused and disorientated for a moment that it wasn't until he was looking down at the zombies pale, grotesquely grinning face that he realised he was being suspending in mid-air by the neck, the zombie holding him out in front of him.

"*Ka- Ka-*" he managed, before the hand around his throat tightened and he choked, digging his fingernails into it's wrist and kicking his legs out. But there was no escape, the creature was just too fucking strong, and it looked up at him with an expression he knew had no place on a zombies face. He could smell it's breath as it breathed on him, could see it's bloodshot black eyes darting across his face with a manic hunger that terrified Izuku more than anything in the world had done before then.

"*Deku!*" he heard Kacchan shout again, relief flooding his body when he realised that Kacchan was still alive, only to be pushed out again as the zombie raised it's other hand, almost as if it was carefully considering it's next move. He kicked and twisted, nails now digging into the flesh of it's wrist as hot blood, *hot*, soaked his fingernails, but he couldn't escape, he could hardly breath, as that other hand got closer and closer to his face.

The hand was cold despite the hot blood that pumped inside of it, and when it wrapped around his face there wasn't anything he could do but try and twist away as it's large thumb pressed *hard* against his left eye, and the scream that left his throat as it began to dig into the socket almost drowned out the rabid animalistic cry of another. As his vision swam and his head pounded he just about made out the sight of Kacchan, covered in blood and guts, the expression on his face desperate and murderous, throwing both of his arms around the zombies throat, clambering up it's back before he reached out and brought his hammer down into the top of it's skull. The zombie let go, hoarse screech breaking from it's lips, and Izuku fell to the ground, shocked, his face in agony, gasping deep ragged breaths. The zombie fell to the ground, throwing Kacchan aside, but he wouldn't even waste a heartbeat, standing on the creatures chest as he swung down again, and again, and again, choked noises coming from the zombie as blood and brains shot out in every direction, Kacchan screaming like an animal with each hit.

And then it was over, Kacchan standing over the zombie, shoulders and chest heaving with each gasping breath, before his hammer dropped to the ground with a clatter.

"Deku," he choked, slipping on the blood as he hurried over to him, and Izuku could only sit there, his body shaking from the shock. He raised a hand to reach for his eye, before Kacchan's own

reached out, snatching at his wrist and stopping him.

"No! You're covered in that things blood," he hissed, voice quick and panicked, and it took a second for him to work out what Kacchan meant, what he was walking about ... of course, he could contaminate himself ... he made to look down at his hands, but the movement of his eyeball burned, and he hissed in pain. He couldn't see a damn thing out of his left eye.

"C-can you open your eye?" Kacchan asked. His voice was shaking badly, hell Izuku could tell that Kacchan was shaking all over, from adrenaline, fear, or both, he wasn't entirely certain, and he was covered in so much of the zombies viscera it was impossible to make out anything bar how wide his eyes were, staring straight back at him. Izuku swallowed, not even realising that he had his eye shut, before trying to open it, groaning in pain.

He could see. Just about. But everything was blurred around the large spots of red that obscured all else.

"Good," Kacchan was saying. "Your eye's still there, that's something."

"Kacchan," Izuku said, hating how it came out as little more than a whimper. "D-did ... did they get you? Kacchan are you bit?"

"Nah," Kacchan replied, shaking his head. "I'm fucking badass, Deku, don't you worry."

"I thought," Izuku choked, and now he felt the tears start to rise, his throat tightening, and god it hurt. Crying hurt when your eyeball had almost been buried into the back of your skill. "I thought they got you," he managed. "I thought they got you and the last thing I said to you was to call you an alcoholic!" The last words came out fast, and the tears spilled over, sobs wracking his chest. Kacchan looked half panicked, but he still reached out, filth covered hands taking his shoulders and keeping him upright even as Izuku felt the need to collapse on the ground.

"It's ok," Kacchan said. "Shh, Izuku, it's ok."

"It's not ok!" Izuku wailed, unable to stop himself now. "It's not ok, nothing is ok, everything's broken and nothing's ok!"

His body sagged even under Kacchan's firm hands, and he continued to sob despite the pain that it caused him, and if he had looked up he would have seen the tear tracks making their way down Kacchan's cheeks as he leaned down, his forehead resting on the top of Izuku's head as he sobbed and shook.

Stumbling from exhaustion and shock, the two of them made their way to the nearest house they could find that unlocked upon turning the doorknob, Kacchan's hand leaving blood staining it's surface as they entered. Kacchan kept his weapon ahead of him as the passed through the hall, but the house seemed abandoned, and Izuku was sure to bolt the lock after them, hating how much his hands shook from the action.

"Upstairs," Kacchan said, once he was happy there were no zombies inside, and Izuku nodded, his head too fuzzy to argue with him. Once in the bathroom, Kacchan started to pull off his gut-ridden clothing, chucking them into a corner of the room, before pulling open cabinets and drawers, searching. Izuku's face hurt. If it wasn't bad enough that his jaw was swollen from the hits Kacchan had gotten in on him earlier, he could feel how badly the area around his left eye was started to bruise. Blood filled his vision in that eye entirely now, leaving him blind on that side, but he could

still blink and it was less of a shock to his system each time he rolled his eyes in their sockets, though it was still painful enough for him to try and keep his eyes steady as much as possible, adjusting his head so that he could look around him. He wasn't covered in as much blood as Kacchan, but given he had no idea just how badly his face was injured, he wasn't willing to take any chances of contamination, so he pulled his clothes off too, leaving him shivering in those stupid *All Might* boxers Kacchan had found for him.

"Fucking useless," Kacchan growled as he pulled drawers out of their cabinets, chucking them onto the floor. Izuku couldn't help but trace his body as he crouched over the drawers in front of him. He had seen Kacchan go down, he had seen the zombies pile up on top of him ... he had said that he hadn't been bitten but god how was that even possible? Maybe Kacchan was still in too much shock to feel the pain from it yet? Gods, what if he had been bitten ... what would be do ...

"There!"

Kacchan pulled a packet of baby wipes out from a cabinet.

"Lemme get the zombie guts off my fucking hands and I'll take a look at your eye," he said. Izuku nodded, watching him as he pulled several wipes out of the packet and started scrubbing at his hands and arms, before he stood in front of the mirror and started to scrub at his face and neck. Izuku found he really didn't have it in him to look ... his face was a mess, he could feel it. He didn't need to see it.

Grabbing a towel Kacchan cleared up the last of the blood, his skin pink from how roughly he had been wiping at himself, but now that he was clean Izuku felt relieved to confirm that Kacchan really hadn't been bitten.

"Sit," he said, knocking down the toilet lid before gesturing to it, and nodding silently Izuku sat himself down, avoiding any glances in the mirror. Kacchan pulled more wipes out of the packet, staring intently at his face before he started to gently clear the blood and filth from Izuku's face.

Even through the pain, Izuku was struck by how tenderly Kacchan tended to him, rough fingertips just grazing his jaw as he angled his head up so he could carefully clean around his eyes.

"How is it?" Izuku asked finally, once he noticed each wipe coming back less bloody. Despite staring into one of his eyes, Kacchan seemed to be able to avoid making any significant eye contact as he leaned back.

"Well, you've still got your eye," he said, chucking the last wipe into the sink, but his voice was stoic, expressionless, and not in the least bit comforting.

"But?"

"There's, uh, blood pooling in the eye," he replied, clearing his throat, and now entirely unable to look at him. "It's sort of settling in the iris-"

"Hyphema," Izuku said, his stomach churning. "It might take care of itself or ... corticosteroids, drops, would be best if ... if we can find any."

"And if we can't?"

Izuku swallowed. "I might be blind in this eye."

Kacchan huffed a breath, a short scoff followed, running his hand through his overgrowing hair and leaving it standing on end.

"It's not the worst thing," Izuku said, not sure if he was trying to convince himself or Kacchan by this point. "I'll just keep it covered for a while and we'll look for eye drops. There's got to be a doctors in town."

"Right," Kacchan said. But he still couldn't meet his eyes, looking agitated, rubbing his hands together and bouncing one of his legs like he was trying to distract himself, to stop himself from completely losing it.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, leaning forwards. "What? What is it?"

Kacchan shook his head, his hands going up to his hair again.

"We, uh, we should stay here for a few days," he replied finally, and Izuku scowled, before wincing at the pain the action brought.

"I- I guess ... why?"

"Just, uh-" but Kacchan seemed unable to say anything else, choking in his words, and Izuku got to his feet, dread pooling in his stomach over what could possible make Kacchan lost for words as he stood in front of the mirror. He looked a state, but it honestly wasn't nearly as bad as he had feared. His jaw was bruised and swollen, and there were bruises forming around his throat from where the zombie had gripped him so tight. His left eyes was decidedly bloodshot under the heavy bruises, the blood pooled visibly in his iris so that his green eye looked almost entirely red, but it didn't seem like he'd be left horribly disfigured or anything. In fact, other than a strange crescent shaped cut around the top of his eye socket, there hadn't seemed to be any broken ski- *the world skid to a halt.* It wasn't a huge mark by any means, but it was deep enough that it still steadily leaked a little blood, and it's shape was weird, very weird up until you realised that it was perfectly shaped like a sharp fingernail.

"Oh."

He had all but torn the zombies wrists to shit when he had been trying to fight free, before the zombie and reached up and attempted to gouge his eye out. And all it would take was one single drop of blood ... one single drop of infected blood ...

"I could be infected."

It came out oddly expressionless, his face matching the indifference in his voice. It seemed so stupid ... That he should face off against a zombie that large, and it would be a single cut that could kill him. A small nick in his skin that could spell his doom. And Kacchan ... *Kacchan really was amazing*. He had fought twenty or so zombies off all on his own without a scratch, before taking down that huge thing right after. Kacchan had gotten to his feet and was approaching him, and in the reflection from the mirror he could finally see the emotions clear on his face, the heartbreak, the guilt ...

"Deku," he started, but Izuku shook his head and turned to face him, cutting him off.

"If I get a fever you gotta do it."

Kacchan's eyes widened, finally now meeting his eyes. "No," he said immediately. "Deku, no-"

"You have to," Izuku interrupted, and his fear filtered through whether he wanted it to or not. "I can't go out like Sero did. Please."

Kacchan stared back at him, the tears now leaking freely down his cheeks, before he broke, grabbing hold of the toothbrush pot by the sink and throwing it across the room. "*Goddamnit!*" he screamed. Izuku swallowed over the lump in his throat, his heart breaking not only for himself, but for the the grief etched across Kacchan's features, and the lines of his shaking shoulders, before the man stood up straight, throwing his head up to the ceiling and breathing a long breath.

"Ok," he said. He reached up and furiously wiped the tears from his own bruised eyes, before turning back to face it. "But I'm not gonna need to, ok? You're gonna be fucking fine, Deku."

Izuku blinked back his tears and nodded. "O-ok, Kacchan."

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 20: A Dead Issue

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku stumbles across some answers, and wishes that he hadn't.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku felt almost entirely numb for the rest of the day. He and Bakugou were able to easily fashion a press-on eyepatch for him out of the bandaging and medical tape they had already gathered on their travels, both of them seeming to pointedly ignore the purple packet jostled into view at the bottom of Izuku's pack as he fetched the supplies. Izuku knew from experience that, if he was infected, then he would almost certainly know sooner rather than later. It had taken Sero barely two days after the transfusion to start to show signs of the infection. He remember from before he had lost Shouto and the rest of his group, instances were the unlucky victim of a bit had a fever not even a couple of hours after getting bitten. He didn't know the specifics, but if he had to guess, then he supposed the nature of Kacchan's condition was the reason for the slower transmission of the virus with Sero, and realistically he expected to have a fever by the morning, if not sooner, if he had been infected. It didn't give him a lot of time to think anything through ... to try and settle his thoughts and accept what would be coming for him. But, as much as he hated to admit that it was a queer kind of comfort, at least he wouldn't be tortured for too long by waiting for an answer.

Kacchan had been pretty keen to get out there and find eye drops for him straight away, but Izuku had insisted otherwise. They didn't know if there were more of those breathing, bleeding zombies out there, and it seemed senseless for Kacchan to take that risk when they didn't even know if Izuku was going to survive yet. That had pissed Kacchan off, the man glaring at him, demanding to know why Izuku had already given up. He hadn't even listened to Izuku's response before he was storming from the living room, leaving Izuku alone with hit thoughts again, and his thoughts were a very cold and lonely place to be that day ...

As evening came, Kacchan finally rejoined him, a saucepan between his towel-wrapped hands and a tight lipped expression on his face. Izuku had been so trapped in his own thoughts that day, sat on the sofa and staring sightlessly at the shadows that crossed over the blinds in the window from the trees outside, that he hadn't even realised that Kacchan had been cooking. But the smell of it jostled him back into awareness, and he looked up, brow furrowed at the sight.

"What's this?" he asked, as Kacchan placed it down on the coffee table in front of him.

"Fuckin' ramen," Kacchan replied with a shrug. "Whoever stayed here before us was obviously a bit of a camping buff. Found a portable stove and some fuel in the hallway cupboard."

Despite just how nauseous his anxiety was making him, the smell of the hot steaming ramen reminded him of just how hungry he was, and he was quickly leaning forward, grabbing one of the paper wrapped chopsticks Kacchan held out for him.

"Smells so good!"

Kacchan merely grunted, grabbing the armchair in the corner of the room and dragging it towards the coffee table before flopping down into the seat. Izuku shovelled the ramen, complete with peas and spices, into his mouth eagerly, unable to stop the moan of delight from breaking his lips. He had forgotten how long it had been since he'd had something as simple as ramen, and though he was sure it was likely the packet stuff that Kacchan had picked up in the supermarket, it was sill one of the best things he'd eaten in a long time.

"This tastes amazing," he managed around his mouthful, looking up at Kacchan to throw him a smile, but Kacchan wasn't even looking at him, his expression morose as he stared off towards the window, his hands in his pockets and his own chopsticks untouched.

"Are you not hungry?"

Kacchan glanced back at him, before shrugging. "Nah, you eat it."

Izuku lowered his chopsticks, watching Kacchan carefully.

"Kacchan, you still need to eat."

"I ain't hungry, alright? Just eat."

Izuku breathed out a long breath, looking back at the saucepan of ramen in front of him, his appetite suddenly gone. He knew Kacchan was upset, hell he seemed to be taking this whole thing worse than Izuku himself was, but ... he didn't know what he could do. How could comfort the man when he had no idea how he felt himself? Not only was he sitting an almost constant state of dread, and terror, waiting for that fever to hit and spell doom, but he also couldn't get that huge zombie out of his damn brain ... the way it had watched them, the way it had tried to murder him. Not eat, *murder* ... He hated the zombies, but he at least understood that their violence was caused by a insatiable hunger that only human's seemed to satisfy. This zombie? It had tried to kill him simply because he was in the way. The hell had that thing been about?

"Kacchan?" he said, his voice quiet. The man just grunted in response, still glaring at the window. "What ... what was that thing?"

For a long moment, Kacchan didn't respond. He just continued to stare, red eyes heavy and exhausted looking, before he sighed and rubbed his hands down his face.

"I don't want to talk about it."

Izuku honestly wasn't expecting that as a response. He knew it wasn't exactly easy to talk about, but he hadn't expected Kacchan to want to avoid the subject completely. He placed his chopsticks back on the table.

"We don't know if there's more of them like that out there," he pressed, as softly as he could. "We need to discuss-"

"Deku," Kacchan interrupted, not so much a warning as an exhausted pleading that left Izuku stunned, heart flopping painfully in his chest. "I don't ... not right now."

Izuku fell silent. He'd seen a whole host of emotions on that stubborn self-assured, charismatic face in the time he'd known him ... from rage, to a certain manic joy, to fear, and everything else in between. And yet, he didn't think he'd ever seen Kacchan's expression to tight and tense; the anxiety was clear on his face, the way his eyes glared at the window but seemed not to be focusing on it, and the way his knee bounced on the armchair. He wanted to push the matter. After all, in almost two years of the Apocalypse, neither of them had ever seen anything quite like the huge zombie they had faced that day. If the talking and breathing hadn't been batshit enough on their own, the way it had seemingly controlled the other zombies had huge implications, challenging everything they thought they knew about them. Was this zombie, and the one that had opened the car door to get to him back on the motorway, related in some way? Was it possible that some zombies had mutated in some way? Were they evolving? But, for whatever reason, Kacchan was unwilling to talk about it, remaining silent and stoic.

"Eat, Deku," Kacchan said, breaking the silence but still not looking at him. "You need to keep your strength up."

Izuku really didn't feel hungry any more, but the way Kacchan insisted on it, the worry in his voice, was enough to convince him. He picked up his chopsticks again, grabbing another mouthful of ramen.

They sat in silence after that, Izuku forcing himself to eat as much of the ramen as he could, though it wasn't long before he found himself mindlessly moving it around the pain, watching the water and sink with each swirl, until the heard soft breathing coming from the other side of the room. Kacchan had fallen asleep, his cheek resting on the palm of his hand, lips slightly parted as he snored softly ...

It certainly wasn't like Kacchan to fall asleep when he was trying to stay on watch like this, and Izuku felt a twist of concern in his stomach ... He supposed he had taken down twenty one zombies on his own today, one of them roughly the size of a damn house. It surely shouldn't be any shocker that Kacchan was exhausted. He placed his chopsticks gently down on the coffee table, trying not to make a sound as he got to his feet. Kacchan clearly needed his sleep, and he was far too anxious to do the same right now. He crept from the room instead, one last glance back at Kacchan's sleeping and calmer looking form, before turning his attention to the house.

It wasn't anything particularly special, a fairly typical Japanese home for this area of the country, fairly modest in it's size and layout, and Izuku could see that Kacchan had already raided the kitchen for any supplies, the contents of the cupboards now sitting on the small dining table, and there were a fair amount of tinned goods there. It looked like someone, whether it be the original owner of the home or not, had been living here for some time before they had found the place. He hadn't really thought much of the mud tracks in the hallway carpets when he'd first walked into the place, but now that he saw the kitchen bin, almost entirely full of empty cans, some with mould growing on their surface, as well as the unlocked door, it seemed entirely likely. Whoever it was had left some time ago, going on the state of the bin, and now that he noticed the paler patches on the walls where there had probably once been photographs hanging he assumed it had to have been the owner of the place. Well, he supposed if Kacchan had felt there was any danger then he would have said something about it ...

He started to wander up the stairs, taking each step as quietly as he could and wincing at the odd creak, hoping that he wouldn't wake Kacchan, before finally reaching the hall. There were just three doors, the one to the bathroom wide open, and he presumed the two bedrooms shut. The first looked like a girls room, the bed made, the room itself neatly laid out like whoever had lived here

had cared about it a lot ... before he spotted the paintings pinned to the wall. Whoever had painted them were clearly talented, the artwork frankly took his breath away, but the feelings twisting inside him were not eased by the sight of them, as beautiful as they were. A girl, floating in a pool of water, surrounded by lilies and what had to be blood ... blood seeping out from her chest. He swallowed, hand raised and gently brushing his fingers across the surface, before he felt his eyes start to sting. He swallowed, snatching his hand back. Stupid. *Stupid, don't think about it*. He took a deep breath and left the room, shutting the door behind him.

The bedroom opposite seemed fairly unassuming at first glance. He noticed the bed wasn't made here, sheets kicked onto the floor as if someone had gotten out of it in a hurry ... but they had taken time to shut the door. He shrugged away the shiver that came from that thought, eyes adjusting to the low light levels until he spotted the desk in the corner of the room. At least that solved the puzzle of where the photographs had gone ... there were six of them, leaning up against the back wall, where a notebook and pen sat in front. Curiosity getting the better of him, he approached, looking at the photographs.

Everything ground to a halt for a second. Just a moment of pure mind numbing terror that left his body frozen in place, unable to even breath as he stared at the photograph closes to him, before he was reaching out, hands grabbing the frame so quickly that the glass cracked. Blood was rushing past his ears, his heart pumping in his mouth, his hands shaking because there he was. Except in this photo his skin wasn't pale, his shoulders not nearly so broad, and the smile on his lips entirely different from the manic grin that he had been forced to look down into.

"No ..." his voice came out in an urgent whimper, and he grabbed another photograph from the desk to be sure, but it didn't change the truths. The man in these photographs, smiling with arms around who must have been his wife and daughter, was the very same zombie that had met his end under Kacchan's hammer, his brains still strewn across the tarmac where they had left him.

Shaking hands dropped the photographs back onto the desk, flashes of a large hand coming closer and closer to his face coming to mind, and he took a hasty step back from the desk, hand grabbing the fabric at his chest as he tried to calm himself down. This wasn't that strange, this wasn't unusual, of course it stood to reason that the zombie was from this town? But seeing him, seeing the person he had once been, was so jarring and caused such a pain in his chest that he could do nothing but stand there for a moment, taking deep breaths. It was ok ... he was safe ... He swallowed, and looked back down at the desk again, before he spotted the diary placed in the centre of the desk.

He could only presume it had belonged to the man's wife, if the blue and yellow flower print across the front of it that matched the shirt she had worn in one of the photos was anything to go by, and despite the fact that she was presumably long gone, he still felt his face heat up at the thought of nosing through another person's diary ... But, there had to be a reason that it was placed there, surrounded by family photographs. He hesitated a moment longer, looking down at the diary, but his need for answers, his insatiable desire to solve any puzzle, was far too strong to ignore, and he slipped into the chair and pulled the diary closer to him.

At the start, it didn't seem like anything out of the ordinary. The wife, named Yuki, spoke about her day, the every-day things she was lamenting or remembering fondly, the way she could casually complain about how dry and chapped her lips were all the time despite the balm, made it clear that she had started this diary before the world had ended, and it brought a pang to Izuku's chest. It had been so long since he had even thought about the sort of things that he used to do ... lie-ins on the weekend, watching anime instead of sleeping, going to the supermarket when he fancied some

snacks, walking around the block when he needed to clear his head ... all of this stuff he had once taken for granted. Skimming through the entries, he saw her talking about the finale of a book series she enjoyed being released the following week, and he was suddenly reminded of his favourite manga series, how important each weekly update had been, and how he would now never find out how it would end. It brought such a deep wave of sadness that he had to take a moment, chewing on his lip and willing himself not to cry over something so stupid as that when he still had no idea whether or not he was going to live to see the end of the week. He took a deep breath, rubbing his face furiously, and buried himself back into the diary.

Things soon started to shift, and he read with an intense, morbid interest as the entries grew shorter. The Apocalypse had hit this sleepy town as it had done any other, and apparently most people had fled early on. The family, however, had decided to stay in their home, afraid to leave on account of a their daughters epilepsy ... Soon, the entries stopped filling pages, and became a single line, with a date to the side of it; *"we're still alive."*

Pages and pages of the same thing ... Izuku flicking through, his heart growing heavier. They had survived here for months, almost an entire year, before the next block of handwriting came into view, and he paused, heart hammering in his chest.

"Kumi is very sick. Makato wants to leave, we're running low on her medication and I know it's for the best, but I am afraid. I am so afraid. We cannot fight those monsters, Kumi is not strong enough. I am scared that we are going to die."

With shaking hands, Izuku turned the page, noting that this entry was an entire week after the previous.

"Kumi had her last seizure. She is at peace. I wish I was with her."

Izuku's eyes darted up to the photographs, landing on the one where the father had his arms around both Yuki and Kumi, the girl had to have only been about twelve years old ... If this world had been cruel to those who were fit, who didn't rely on medication, then it had been downright evil to anyone who had not been so fortunate ...

There were no more entries for a while after that, just empty pages, and he wondered if maybe Yuki had stopped writing after that, before there came another entry, dated three weeks after Kumi died, and the breath was knocked from him.

"Makato was bitten today. It was my fault, it's all my fault. I didn't want to leave, I couldn't leave my home, couldn't leave Kumi's grave, so we stayed and they found us. I don't know how but they found us. Makato fought them off, but he was bitten, I don't know what to do. Please, I don't know what to do."

Izuku took in the date of the entry, just six months ago, and his breath came to him no easier. Six months ... If Makato was bitten, then he would have died of the virus and the fever in a matter of days if he even lasted one. The zombie had smelled of death, but it certainly hadn't *acted* dead, there certainly hadn't been six months worth of rot on that body, it made no sense ... He hurriedly flipped to the next page, almost tearing it in his haste, before find himself looking at entirely different handwriting.

"Yuki died today.

I know I should feel bad writing in her diary, but she valued this thing so highly. Always looking through the early entries. I never thought that was healthy.

But Yuki died today. I still don't know why. She wasn't bitten, I was the one who was bitten, I'm the one who is sick, but she got a fever too. She died two hours ago, the last thing she asked was for me to end it before she turned.

I think I'll die soon too. The fever has ravaged my body, I hardly have the strength to sit here and write, but it's what Yuki would want. This diary meant a lot to her."

She ... *died?* That made no sense. Unless he had infected his wife some way? His stomach churned uncomfortably at the thought, he knew that the virus could be spread sexually, but if they really stayed in their home that long, presuming that watched the news, then surely they would have known that too?

He flicked to the next page, surprised to see even more entries.

"I'm not dead. I don't understand how. My fever broke, looking back at the diary I've been in and out of fever dreams for five days. My bite is even healing. It doesn't make any sense how I can be alive, but my wife who was bitten died. Is this a joke? Is this some stupid fucking joke that I should outlive both my wife and child?"

If Izuku's hands were shaking before, then they definitely were now, his eyes wide as saucers as he looked down at the page. This man, Makato, had survived his bite. He had fucking survived it! His eyes darted to the door, half expecting Kacchan to be standing there, but the hallway beyond remained empty. So, he wasn't the only one? There had been others that had survived their bites. Except ... he hadn't. They had seen him. He had been a zombie. Did that mean ... he feverishly dove to the next entry.

"I've worked it out. I'm no scientist. I worked as a plumber for twenty years, and if by any chance anyone else ever reads this, please know that this is only what I could figure out for myself, but I know why Yuki died.

We already knew that the virus could be transmitted through bites. Blood, sexually, those were facts made clear before the broad casts finally stopped coming. But it still spread so fast. I can tell you, after being bitten, there was no way that I would have been able to engage in anything sexual. I'm sorry for being so crude, but it's true, so how could the virus have spread so fervently? We weren't all biting one another, after all.

But see, here is the thing. This virus? It was fucking designed for us. Designed by the evillest spirits to thrive on the one thing humans crave most. Affection. Because if it can be spread by biting, then surely it's in our saliva?

My wife, she always struggled with chapped lips. I know it was because she was chewing on them all the time, she'd always deny it of course. It was worse than ever, the stress I suppose. So that's it. I infected her. I infected my wife.

We cannot kiss our loved ones goodbye."

Izuku had to place the diary onto the table before it simply fell from his shaking fingers. It made sense, of course it made fucking sense. The virus was in their damn DNA, all it had to do was get into the bloodstream and you were done for, and Kacchan ... *Kacchan*. Jesus, they had already

kissed once, even if that sudden smash of lips could hardly have been considered a kiss, and hell if he hadn't been so fucking bad at it then he could have infected Izuku even back then and ... they had almost kissed the other day. Izuku dragged his fingers through his hair. *Kacchan ... poor Kacchan ...*

He turned the page, looking for the next entry, and Makato had continued to write, continued to debate ending his life in almost every entry, only to return with the next one, and the next. Makato had survived his bite, he seemed not even to have any side effects of it, until ...

"I feel strange. I've been feeling strange for a while, but I can never put my finger on what. I get headaches a lot, I suppose, that's the main thing, but it's more than that. I feel different, yet the same. I feel ... stronger, invincible some days, the dead are always coming for me, it's like they know I live here and every week more and more find their way to the town. I killed five of them today. I didn't even need a weapon to do it."

Izuku's lips shook, his blood running cold.

"I lost consciousness. I think, I don't really know. I just know that I was angry. I came to and here were bodies all around me, and I think it was me that did it. There were body parts everywhere. I think I'm losing it. I know I need to end it."

Is that what happened? Did he take his own life? This was just four weeks ago ... just four weeks ...

"I think this will be my last entry. My body, my head, I hardly feel like myself any more. I black out, more and more, I come to outside. The dead are still drawn to me, but they don't attack me any more. They just stand there, almost like they're fucking waiting for me or something. I tried to take my own life, but my neck broke the rope. I tried to cut my wrists but my hand wouldn't move. I'd shoot myself if I could find a gun. I'm changing. I don't know what I'm changing into to.

I should have done it sooner. I should have died with Yuki. I'm sorry, my love. I am so ashamed."

And that was it. The last entry. Izuku flicked through to the last page of the diary, desperate for more, for something else, but there was nothing. He didn't even realise that there were tears falling down his cheeks until the first drop hit the page, and he screw up his face in anguish. Makato had turned into that thing out there ... he had survived his bite, he had lived for six months before his body had changed into something else. And Kacchan ... *Kacchan ...*

"Deku?"

He jumped, looking up from the diary and towards the door, where Kacchan stood, concern on his face as he took in the sight of the tears streaming from Izuku's eyes.

"K-Kacchan," he managed, making an effort to shove the diary aside like it was nothing, though he saw Kacchan's eyes track the movement. "Uh, sorry, I'm fine, I was just exploring the house-"

"Why are you crying?"

Kacchan's voice was soft, but his tone invited no argument, looking back at him with firm red eyes.

"It's nothing," Izuku said quickly, reaching up and wiping the tears from his face. "I'm just being silly. Let's just go back downstairs."

He got to his feet. He knew Kacchan had a right to know, but how could he show this to him? Right now, of all times? But Kacchan wasn't so easily distracted, and he was already walking forwards, eyes fixed on the photographs on the desk, before they widened, he too recognising the man.

"That's the zombie," he said, pointing, and Izuku flinched, rubbing his arms.

"We don't know that f-for sure-"

"Deku," Kacchan's voice was low now, in warning. "What's going on?"

"N-nothing! Look, maybe it's him but it's not like it's a surprise that he used to live here-"

"Why were you trying to hide that book from me?"

So, that was that. His shoulders sagged, knowing that there was no way that he was going to be able to keep it hidden from Kacchan now. The man was far too smart, and far too quick. He sighed, shaking hands picking up the diary from it's place behind him, clutching it to his chest.

"Kacchan," he said, meeting his confused and irritated gaze. "Whatever ... whatever it says, it might not be true, ok?"

But that was apparently the wrong thing to say, because Kacchan thrust his hand out, laying the palm flat and gesturing for the book, his eyes suddenly hardened.

"Just give me the book, Deku."

A dry sob broke his lips as he passed it over. Kacchan took the diary from his hands, before sitting cross legged on the bed in the middle of the room, throwing Izuku another guarded glance as he opened it up and started to read. He could see the confusion on his face as he flipped through the first pages, Yuki just talking about her day, before the minute narrowing and pause let Izuku know that he had reached the point where things had started to go sour. Izuku dropped shakily back into the chair at the desk, his fingers gripping the backrest so hard that his knuckles went white.

Kacchan read in silence, turning the pages, his eyes never leaving the diary, his expression hardly changing from that hard narrow glare, until he finally shut it, placing it down on the bed beside him. He was silent, face blank, the only hint that he was feeling anything was the minute shaking of his hands before he clasped them together, looking down at his lap. Izuku felt the panic rising in his chest, the fear, the heartbreak ...

"S-six months," he stuttered. "He was bitten s-six months ago and ... Kacchan, it's been over a year, right? So, it's not the same. And you haven't had ... black outs or- this doesn't have to mean anything!"

"I could have killed you."

His voice was quiet, broken, shaking with emotion, and Izuku pressed his wobbly lips together tight.

"We didn't know-"

"That doesn't matter!" Kacchan's voice broke, and he was on his feet. His shaking hands were spread, eyes wide and manic. "If ... if you hadn't stopped me the other day I would have killed you!"

Tears were spilling out of Izuku's eyes again, his vision obscured, but Kacchan's red eyes clear, the pain in them mirroring the shattering of his own heart in that moment.

You cannot kiss your loved ones goodbye.

He couldn't get the words out of his head.

You cannot kiss your loved ones goodbye.

Kacchan was ... he was already so alone. He had already turned one of his own friends, even if it had been in trying to save the man's life, and he knew how dangerous his own blood was, and now he found out he could turn someone with so much as a kiss? He couldn't even imagine how that must feel. How scared Kacchan must be ...

"I'm ok," Izuku said, without thinking. The look that Kacchan gave him almost broke him again. "I- this isn't your fault. We don't know if I'm even infected yet, ok? Look, it's been hours and I don't even have a fever! A-and that zombie it ... it's completely different-"

"How is it different?" Kacchan hissed, incredulously. "The dumb bastard was bitten, fucking same as me. He killed his fucking wife like I already killed Sero. I already told you about the headaches! Jesus, Deku, it's the same. It's the fucking same. And if you aren't infected you need to get as far the fuck away from me as you can!"

Izuku blinked, shocked. "Wh-what?"

"Twice I could have killed you, you dumb fuck!" Kacchan all but screamed, face burning with rage and horror. "I know you have little in the way of self-preservation as it is, but you really think staying with me is going to do anything more than get you killed?"

"I'm not leaving you," Izuku said immediately.

"Then you're an idiot," Kacchan snarled viciously. "You ain't got a fever? Good. You wake up tomorrow and you ain't dead then you get the fuck out of here. Go to Musutafu, find the others, and fucking forget about me."

"No!" Izuku said, firmer, getting to his feet, and Kacchan immediately took a step back away from him, fear flashing across his face. "Jesus, Kacchan, we've already been through so much! I don't ... I don't care what that diary says. We're going to find Kaminari, Kirishima, and Mina together."

"I can't ... what if I hurt them-"

"You won't," Izuku said firmly. "And I'm not just saying that to make you feel better. This- this guy had more than just headaches. He kept blacking out! He said he could feel things changing and ... there was warning, weeks and weeks of it, and nothing like that has happened to you."

"Yet."

"It might never happen! Kacchan, I cannot leave you here. How am I supposed to go back to them without you by my side? How am I supposed to survive any of this without you by my side?" His voice wavered, another sob breaking his lips before she shook his head. Kacchan's arms fell to his sides, the anger he had initially showed now morphed to grief. "I- I promise you, if you start t-to black out or anything else that happened to that guy, I'll ... I'll help you."

They both knew what those words meant, knew the full weight of them.

"I promise you. I won't let what happened to him happen to you."

"I can't put that responsibility on you," Kacchan replied, hoarse voice now barely more than a whisper.

"You think me leaving you here is going to hurt any less?" Izuku demanded. "You can't ask me to leave you, Kacchan. I won't do it. So ... stop being an idiot and asking me to."

He was sure for a moment that Kacchan was going to start shouting again, his face heating up once more, before his shoulders sagged, and he dropped back down to the bed with a heavy puff of air. Izuku hesitated for a moment, before walking over, picking up the diary so that he could sit down beside him.

"Whatever happens," he said, his voice quiet and hesitant, as he rotated the book in his hands. "I don't want to do it alone."

He felt rather than heard Kacchan's breath hitch at that. He chanced a glance through his eyelashes at him. The man looked exhausted, he hadn't realised until recently just how tired he appeared to be, and the shadows under his eyes were only highlighted by how bloodshot his eyes were, red on red. But without the creases of anger on his cheeks, the gentle slope of his brow, his eyes wet beneath the overgrown blonde bangs that now almost hang in them, he also realised he had somehow never looked quite so beautiful.

He looked down to Kacchan's hand laying on his lap, dirt beneath his fingernails and cuts and scrapes across it's surface, and before he could over think it he reached out with his own, placing his palm across the top of Kacchan's hand and interlocking their fingers. Kacchan started, his hand tensing.

"We don't know what's going to happen," he said softly. "We could both turn tomorrow. But it's just as likely we'll die some other way, right?" Kacchan scoffed.

"Is that supposed to make me feel better? You sure you ain't got a damn fever?"

"I just ... I dunno, I find it kind of comforting, don't you?" Izuku shrugged. "To just accept that we don't know what's going to happen tomorrow, so we give all we have for today."

"*The fuck kinda hippy*- Gimme your damn forehead," Kacchan snapped, reaching out with his free hand to place the back of his hand over Izuku's head, and Izuku surprised himself with a laugh. After a moment, Kacchan pulled back, a pout on his face.

"Huh, you really don't have a fever at all."

"I told you that."

"Alright, asshole."

Izuku snorted another laugh again, before his eyes dropped back to their hands, still entwined despite how nervous Kacchan had felt about it.

"We should sleep," he said. "Fuck knows what tomorrow is going to be like."

"Thought we were giving our all to today?" Kacchan replied with a smirk. "The hell happened to that, hah?"

Izuku rolled his eyes, before he started to scoot back on the bed, still keeping his fingers entwined with Kacchan pulling his arm with him. Kacchan, however, seemed to panic, his arm freezing, and shooting him with a desperate glare.

"Deku," he said, voice a low warning growl, but Izuku shook his head, tugging again.

"I just wanna sleep."

For a moment, Kacchan didn't move, still looking at him, eyes darting from their interlocked hand to Izuku's face, and to the bed, before he audibly swallowed, and allowed himself to shift up towards the pillows. Izuku threw him a smile, finally letting go of Kacchan's hand so he could lay down, watching in amusement as Kacchan fisted the pillow into shape in a way that was just so classically *him* that he wasn't surprised at the comfort that vaguely aggressive sight brought him. As soon as Kacchan stretched out across the bedspread, Izuku lay down beside him, resting his head on his chest. He tensed again, and honestly Izuku really hadn't planned on anything like this, but now that he was here, laying against him, feeling his heart hammering in his chest, the smokey scent filling his nose, he was pretty sure there was no force on earth that could persuade him to move.

"The hell do you wanna be this close to me for?" Kacchan asked, voice vulnerable. "You know I'm basically a fucking zombie too, right?"

And that ... *hurt*. Shit, it hurt more than it ought to have done, his chest felt like it had caved in, and he was pulling his head up so fast he all but cracked his neck.

"Don't you dare say that," he breathed. "I'm serious, Kacchan. Don't you dare call yourself a zombie again."

"Whatever I wanna fucking call myself, it doesn't change the facts. I'm dangerous."

Izuku swallowed, his neck still twisted in an uncomfortable angle so he could look up at him, refusing to break his gaze.

"You were always dangerous, Kacchan."

He saw the confusion, even the hurt, that passed across those red eyes in that moment, and he took a deep breath, letting his head rest back on his chest, one of his hands reaching across his body until his palm lay above Kacchan's scar, the fabric of his shirt not hiding the way his skin bunched and folded around it.

"But for some reason, you're who I feel safest around."

Kacchan didn't say anything at first, but the rate his heart was hammering in his chest was response enough.

"Such a fucking nerd," he finally muttered, and Izuku laughed again, burying his face in Kacchan's chest. "Just get some fucking sleep, 'fore I knock you out just to be sure."

"Ok, Kacchan," Izuku replied, with a yawn, before he let his eyes shut.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 21: Refleshment

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku wakes feeling hot ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Izuku woke the following morning, the first thing he realised was how hot he was. His entire body felt as though it had been dipped in a scolding bath, simultaneously soothing his muscles and fogging up his mind. The second thing he noticed was that ... he wasn't afraid. There was a certain relief, almost, there were no worries now. He wasn't dealing with the anxiety of a fever to come any more. It was relaxing, calm. So, this was it. This was the end of it, then.

But the longer he lay there, in a state of drowsy consciousness, the more he realised that this didn't feel like a fever. Sure, he was hot, but that didn't explain how he didn't feel sick, or the weight across his waist that he hadn't been completely aware of when he first woke. He frowned, willing his eyes to open despite how heavy they were.

He was still in the zombie's bedroom, though he wish that hadn't been his first consideration to call it, laying on his side on the bed, a blanket thrown around him, and a soft rhythmic sound coming from behind him. Kacchan was still fast asleep, and the heat hadn't been a fever, far from it; one of Kacchan's arms was laying out beneath his head, Izuku resting on his bicep, and the other was wrapped around his waist, Kacchan's face buried in the crook of his neck, each hot breath sending a wave of heat across Izuku's body.

He flushed. Sure, he himself had drawn Kacchan into the hug last night, but he hadn't expected to wake up with Kacchan curled so tightly around him, one hand cupping his elbow as if he was afraid that Izuku might roll away and leave him there. Kacchan had always felt hot on the occasions they had gotten close, but he hadn't expected him to run quite so hot, and far from it being an interesting titbit for him to file away in his growing internal notes on everything Bakugou Katsuki, it only prompted a twist of dread in his stomach.

All these things he had noticed about Kacchan and just considered part of what made the man more and more interesting, potentially now came with darker, more disturbing consequences. Had Kacchan always just run hot? Was it normal for him? Or was he running hotter on account of his bite. His strength, the way he seemed to maintain muscle mass despite being half starved for much of the time, what is that too was because of his bite? Had his body been changing all this time and Izuku had never even noticed? Had not considered the *possibility* that there might be something more to it? He grit his teeth as his eyes started to sting ... it might not be true. There might be nothing more to it. He hadn't blacked out or lost track of time or ...

His hand gripped instinctively around Kacchan wrist when he considered that there were things that couldn't be explain away as coincidence. The zombies always swarmed him, they had always seemed far more interested in Kacchan over anyone else, just as they had been Makato before they

had started *listening* to him instead ... But his grip around Kacchan's hand woke him, and Kacchan started, sitting up immediately, red eyes bright in the semi darkness.

"What is it?" he hissed, looking around for the danger, his reactions so fast that it had Izuku's stomach twisting in on itself again.

"There's nothing," he said quickly. "I'm sorry for waking you."

Kacchan blinked, looking confused for a moment, before his expression eased and he slumped back onto the pillows again with a huff. Almost immediately his eyes snapped open again, and Izuku squeaked as the man reached out and grabbed the front of Izuku's shirt, yanking him close before he slapped his hand across his forehead.

"How are you feeling?" he asked urgently, Izuku catching up slower than was reasonable.

"O-oh! Fine, no fever, I think I'm ok."

Kacchan continued to feel his forehead, with the back of his wrist and even the side of his forearm, before he seemed content to agree.

"Jesus, Deku, you really are one lucky son of a bitch, you know that?"

"I wouldn't go that far," Izuku replied, but he couldn't deny that it was certainly something that he wasn't showing any signs of having contracted the virus, particularly given just how likely it had seemed that he had gotten some of Mr Zombig's blood in the cut. "Hey," Izuku said, mulling the thought over. "Maybe I wouldn't turn either. I mean, we know that there are other people like you out there now."

"I still got a fever," Kacchan replied shortly, and Izuku hummed.

"Fair point."

"Whatever, you were lucky, but you might not be next time. We've had way too many fucking near misses and I've had just about enough of 'em to be honest."

"Hazards of living in the zombie apocalypse," Izuku said, but Kacchan frowned, glaring at him.

"No, habits of living with your careless ass," he snapped. "We ain't taking any more risks after this, you hear me? What was it you kept fucking saying?"

"*No Unecessary Risks*," Izuku replied, his lips squishing out into a pout. "And I'm not that careless, Kacchan!"

"Right," Kacchan scoffed.

"I'm not!"

"Bullshit."

Izuku was glad that Kacchan was acting relatively normal at least, even if he was unfairly calling him the careless one. Yesterday had been a lot to handle, even more so when they found the contents of Mr Zombig's diary, and it could hold a whole heap of shit for them in the future, but for

now as far as Izuku was concerned their plans had not changed. They still needed to get to Musutafu in the hopes of rejoining their group.

"So, what's our course of action now?" he asked, as Kacchan swung his legs over the side of the bed, standing and stretching his arms up over his head with an audible pop.

"We scavenged plenty of supplies from that supermarket," he replied, before bending forward and touching his toes. Izuku was sure that it wasn't intentional, not even Kacchan was that fucking obvious, but the view he got of Kacchan's rear was enough to make his face flush and his ears burn hot.

"You don't want to rest up here any longer?" he asked, resolutely keeping his eyes averted from the man in front of him, as Kacchan stood and started stretching out his shoulders.

"Fuck no."

"Yeh," Izuku sighed. "Mr Zombig was freaky enough for me, thanks, I don't fancy sticking around here for much longer than we need to."

Kacchan paused, looking over his shoulder, the expression on his face incredulous.

"I'm sorry, Mr *what now*?"

"Mr Zombig," Izuku replied, his cheeks still definitely burning pink when Kacchan made eye contact with him. "You know, like ... Mr Big but .. he's a zombie so-"

"I swear to god if you use that name again I'm dumping you out here."

"Kacchan!"

"No, I'm serious. I've taken a lot of crap from you over these last months but I'm fucking drawing the line at giving those assholes fucking nicknames."

"Well, what else do we call them?" Izuku protested.

"We don't. Or if you really fucking have to then call 'em fucking zombie like all the others."

"Won't that get confusing?"

"Not for regular fucking people, Deku!"

"Kacchan, that's mean."

"I am mean!"

Izuku laughed, the irritation on Kacchan's face only growing more and more hilarious with time, and Kacchan glared at him, before he suddenly yanked the blanket from beneath him, almost throwing Izuku straight onto the ground.

"We're taking this, it's getting way too fucking cold out there. Let's eat and go, I'm tired at looking at this place."

Izuku continued to snigger, getting to his feet and following Kacchan as he stomped from the room. He deliberately didn't allow himself to look back, the desk and photographs sitting as they had left them, a lone vigil over what had once been, and what may never be again.

After taking some time to eat and toilet, Izuku going through their supplies and making sure that they had everything packed, they set off. Izuku knew that there was still a chance that he might get a fever later on, however unlikely it may seem going on the timelines of other people he knew that had been infected, but it made no sense for them to wait for that to happen or not, not when they had already lost so much time going back to the city. Right now, the only thing that mattered was finding the others. They weren't stupid, not even close to, but Izuku knew they weren't so adapt at survival as either himself nor Kacchan, and he suspected that, whilst Kacchan never said it out loud, he was worried for them. No, they had deviated enough, they had one goal to focus on right now.

Except ... Izuku was finding it pretty tough to stay focused, if he was being honest. Kacchan did not bring up the events of the previous night with him, his face expressionless for the most part as he walked slightly ahead of Izuku has he lead them out of the sleepy little town that had proven to be anything *other* than. Past where Izuku knew the bodies of Mr Zombig and his small zombie army lay pulverised on the ground without so much as a single glance in their direction. But just because he wouldn't talk about it, didn't mean that Kacchan's thoughts were almost plagued with the hundreds of questions Mr Zombig's diary had asked.

Kacchan had been bitten a year ago, that was double the length of time it had taken Mr Zombig to finally succumb to the virus and turn into whatever the hell that had been, and it seemed as though he had experienced strange symptoms for a good portion of that time to boot. And yeh, there were some things about Kacchan that Izuku had to wonder about, but there had been no black-outs, and any explosion of rage that the man had displayed had never really felt ... out of place. Sure, he had tried to choke Izuku at one point, but he had also been drunk and emotional, and he wasn't sure he could blame the virus for that one. No, there was actually a chance here that Kacchan simply wouldn't be affected by the virus in the same way that Mr Zombig had been.

But, they knew he still carried the virus. Sero's devastating loss was proof of that. Kacchan was still infected, and he could pass that virus on through his blood, through sex, through ... *kissing* ... And god, was he ashamed that these thoughts had his stomach twisting in a way that the others didn't. Because, he liked Kacchan, didn't he? He'd been quick to pass it off as simply horny attraction stemming from two years of forced celibacy, but the more time he spent with him, the more he realised that yeh, he really liked Kacchan.

He was a dick, there was no way around that. He seemed cruel, even, on the outside, he swore more than any other person he'd met in his life and the faces he pulled were downright horrifying on occasion, but Izuku had come to realise that it made him no less soft when he wanted to be. Kacchan had risked his life for him over and over again, had walked straight into danger so that Izuku could find Shouto. He was strong and focused, and in the right conditions, the rare times his face wasn't contorted in rage or pulled back in a sneer, there was no denying that he was quite beautiful. His ash blonde hair, his burning red eyes, the tanned skin, all of it a combination that had Izuku's heart racing, and as he walked a few steps behind him, eyes trailing upon the cut of his jaw and the lips pouting in concentration, he realised that he really did want to kiss him. And not the weird crashing of their mouth parts that transparently hadn't even garnered enough fluid exchange to infect him by some small mercy ... he wanted to wrap his arms around Kacchan's shoulders, bury his fingers in those blonde locks, and fucking devour him. God, he wanted to fucking kiss him so badly it wasn't even funny any more.

Not funny. Because he couldn't. Not unless he fancied turning into a zombie himself. Kacchan was right there, and fuck he had been willing, and Izuku couldn't do a damn thing about it.

He was fairly confident that two condoms would be enough to protect him from infection by ... other means. Or hell, there were plenty of things they could do without risking any fluid exchange at all. Izuku's eyes drifted down, from his wide biceps, that stupidly narrow waist, and to the toned ass that was entirely swamped by the baggy ass jeans that Kacchan was wearing and hell, Izuku really wasn't a man of preference. And it wasn't for him to presume that Kacchan was either, or that he would be opposed to Izuku being the one to do the fucking- *STOP. Shit, Izuku, stop this.* He groaned, raising both his hands and clapping them against his face.

"Oi?" Kacchan said, so quickly that it made Izuku jump. "What is it?"

"Nothing," Izuku said quickly, pulling his hands away, but Kacchan didn't seem to believe him, and before he knew it hands were gripping the front of his shirt again and pulling him close as another slapped against his forehead. "Do you need to keep grabbing me?" Izuku yelped.

Kacchan ignored him, rotating his wrist again as he checked his temperature. Izuku was frozen in place this time, his mind still full of the sort of thoughts he really would have preferred didn't come to him when he was just taking a goddamn walk in the woods, and Kacchan's proximity to him was fucking scorching. He could smell him, the scent of the sweaty man simultaneously gross and oh so sexy, and if he wanted to he could just reach forward, stick out his tongue, and taste the bead of sweat that was threatening to drop from his jaw.

"You're fine," Kacchan snapped, pushing him away far rougher than was necessary. "The fuck you whining about?"

"I wasn't ... hah?"

"Whatever. Can we go?"

"I wasn't stopping us!"

Kacchan grunted, before turning on his heel, adjusting his pack and setting back off along the trail, and Izuku let out an uneasy breath.

It wasn't like ... things were entirely out of the realm of possibility for them. And sure, they couldn't kiss, but Izuku had a particularly memorable encounter during the first months in university, when he had ended up with mono. He'd been sort of seeing a guy back then, though it had only really lasted a couple dates and a couple more make out sessions, and despite how sick Izuku had felt he'd still performed quite marvellously, if his partner was to be believed. The catch had been that they hadn't been able to kiss, of course, and they'd been inventive enough for that not to have been an issue. Izuku would definitely prefer if he and Kacchan could kiss, but it didn't mean that they were completely barred from taking whatever weird tensiony thing was going on between them to another level. *Right?*

But taking things to the next level he was pretty much sure would mean him making a move. He'd made it clear to Kacchan that he hadn't been ready, and by some twist of fate that had probably ended up saving his fucking life, so he couldn't rely on Kacchan to be the one to push things now. Nope, this was all on Izuku, and if he was being honest, the idea terrified him. And not because he thought Kacchan would turn him down, but because Kacchan was ... *Kacchan*. Confident, self-

assured, how exactly did you make a move on a guy like that? And he couldn't every well just fucking kiss him now could he?

Izuku sighed. He supposed he should feel lucky really. Fortunate that things were quiet enough for him to even spare a moment thinking about stuff like this. Birds sung from the trees, insects still buzzed whilst it was warm enough to do so, a gentle wind rustled the uppermost branches of the trees surrounding them, and for now Izuku should really be letting himself enjoy that. Enjoy the peace that the forest offered them before the metaphorical rug was inevitably wrenched from beneath their feet again. He hesitated then, eyes darting back to Kacchan then, before drifting down to the arm swinging at his side ... they had cuddled already. Maybe Kacchan liked the softer stuff. Maybe he wouldn't mind if Izuku just reached out and let their fingers interlock. Maybe he would welcome the contact as much as Izuku would, especially given how soft and peaceful the forest was. He swallowed, fingers twitching at his side as he sped up to walk at Kacchan's side, and taking a deep breath.

"I'm pretty sure there's a river up this way," Kacchan said, and just like that his hand was pulled out of Izuku's reached as he pointed ahead of them and looked across at Izuku. "After that we'll have long passed the safari and be on our way to Fuji. We could probably make Shizouka in the day if we're not stopped."

"I wonder how all the animals in the safari are doing," Izuku said, and Kacchan raised an eyebrow at him.

"Dead, Deku. Fuck maybe some survived, but with no one feeding them for two fucking years how do you expect them to be?"

"Maybe they escaped?"

"Great, keep your fucking eye out for lions then."

Izuku pouted, watching as Kacchan's hand dropped to his side again, but the moment was gone. He grabbed the straps on his pack and hoisted it higher up his back.

"Maybe we could befriend one of them."

"One of who?"

"The lions."

"You're really talking some shit today, Deku, you know that?"

"I'm just saying, it would be useful to have a lion on our side. I bet he could handle the zombies no problem, and no one would mess with us if we had a pet lion."

"You can't befriend a lion."

"Sure you can! Lions like their keepers right? What about that story of the lion that was raised by people as a cub, and when the lion saw them again in the wild it ran over to play with them?"

"Well if you can find a lion cub without getting eaten by mum then I won't stop you."

"What would we call it?"

"We wouldn't, shut up."

"But we'd have to give it a name. Like ... Rory?"

"No."

"Maybe something cute like Mr Tiddles. Fishsticks! Wait, Roar Might!"

"Call it Little Fucker for all I care, Deku, we ain't naming a damn lion!"

"Kacchan, you can't call a lion Little Fucker! That's cruel!"

"So's domesticating a wild fucking animal but sure *sure*, I'm the asshole. Let's just focus on where we're going yeh?"

Izuku huffed. "Fine."

Kacchan shot him a side glare, and Izuku could have been almost convinced that there was the smallest of smiles on the man's lips before he was staring forward again, pulling a map out from his back pocket.

"We'll stop at the river for a bit. I dunno about you, but I still feel pretty fucking gross from getting covered in guts yesterday, and we could drink without wasting our water supplies. But after that, we'll be heading into civilisation again."

Izuku glanced over at him.

"Shouldn't we ... avoid that? We still don't know if those bastards are following us, it's harder for them to track us out here."

"Yeh, but if wanna do that we'll have to trek, uphill, another four or five hours that way-" he pointed to the right of them. He looked back at the map, frowning. "Then it's gotta be another days walk on top of that to avoid Fujinomiya ..."

"*No Unecessary Risks*," Izuku said, and Kacchan looked back at him again, chewing on his bottom lip, before he sighed.

"Fuck. Yeh, ok. Fuck ... we've already been separated from them for so long."

"I know," Izuku replied. "But you said it yourself, we have to be more careful now. Especially with the zombie from back on the road, and Mr Zombig back in the town, we don't know what else is out there any more."

"I said not to call the damn thing that," Kacchan snapped, before folding the map and shoving it into his back pocket.

"Oh. Sorry."

"Let's just get to the river, and work out what we're going to do from there."

"Ok."

Izuku winced as Kacchan stormed past him, his expression suddenly foul again. He supposed he could understand why Kacchan was so keen to avoid talking about, or even mentioning, the zombie they had fought back at the town, and though Kacchan seemed as straight faced as ever, he knew that the man was worried. How could he not be?

They walked in silence the rest of the way to the river and fortunately they didn't run into a single zombie on their way there, the forest as quiet as it had ever been, apart from the alarmed squawk of jays as they flushed them from the bushes.

The river turn out to be much smaller than Izuku was expecting, barely a stream in places before it opened up until a wide dam a little further down, but the water flowed quickly, and cleanly. He supposed in the rainy season, the entire area was probably prone to flooding, which explained the large concrete dam, but for now it was enough for them to wash up and drink before moving on.

Kacchan hesitated as they walked out into the open, his eyes darting up and down the length of the river, but it just was quiet as the rest of the forest, minus the sound of rushing water, and he seemed satisfied enough to head out, Izuku following him. The ground underfoot was tough and dry, it was far from the picturesque scenery that Izuku had been expecting when Kacchan had said there was a river ahead of them, but then he had to remind himself they were hardly there for the views.

"It's deep enough to bathe near the dam," Kacchan said, marching forward with renewed purpose, and Izuku hurried after him. He did not expect, however, for Kacchan to immediately start pulling his shirt over his head and chucking it to the ground, hands dropping to undo the belt at his waist. Izuku's faced flushed, and he just about held back a groan of frustration. How could he forget that Kacchan had precisely no iota of shame? He averted his eyes as he heard Kacchan's pants drop to the ground, followed the sound of splashing, and he glanced sideways. Yup, Kacchan was naked as they came, his pale ass impossible to miss in the low morning light before he waded in deep enough for the water to cover him, hearing Kacchan make a hissing sound.

"Fuck me it's fucking freezing!"

Good, Izuku almost said out loud. It was a hell of lot harder to be interested when his balls were freezing off. He checked that Kacchan wasn't watching him before hurriedly pulling his own clothes off, hands comically hiding his privates from view as he waded in after him. Kacchan, give him his goddamn due, kept his back to him, shivering and swearing until Deku approached him.

"It's not *that* bad."

"Fuck you," Kacchan growled, his teeth chattering so loudly that Izuku couldn't hold back a laugh when Kacchan finally turned to face him. The man looked miserable.

"Baby," he teased, before dropping down in the water until he was submerged up to his chin, enjoying the fresh feeling across his body. And sure, the water was cold, but he was certain that Kacchan was over-exaggerating. Kacchan glared at him, before he suddenly shoved his hands forward, causing a wave of water to cascade over Izuku's face, and he coughed and spluttered, hair drenched.

"Kacchan!"

"Oh, who's a baby now, hah?"

But Izuku was not one to be out done, and he launched forward, hand reaching out blindly under the water before snatching at Kacchan's knee and yanking. With a yell Kacchan lost his balance, crashing into the water, the expression on his face more shocked than Izuku had ever seen, and he started laughing so hard that he had to grab his sides, tears streaming down his face and Kacchan let out a chorus of the most colourful swearwords he knew, echoing over the valley.

Kacchan was never one to back down from a challenge, and before Izuku could even get his breath back, his hand waving in front of him weakly in an effort to hold him back even as he laughed, Kacchan threw himself at him, barrelling into Izuku's chest with his fucking *head* and throwing him back.

"K-Kacchan!" he half laughed, half screamed, as he crashed into the river.

"Take that, bitch!"

Izuku kicked out, his foot connecting with something that caused Kacchan to let out an *'oof'* of pain before Kacchan was grabbing at him, arms wrapping around the back of his knees and lifting, Izuku screeching in shock as his feet were knocked entirely from underneath him and he was submerged again. He twisted about, hand tightening around Kacchan's wrist as he attempted to drag him down, but Kacchan was still the stronger of the two of them, and the fastest, and before he knew it he was being pulled forward, Kacchan's arms twisting until Izuku's hands were clasped flush between them. He felt a strong grip around both his wrists, another hand around his chest, Izuku completely immobilised.

"N-no fair, Kacchan!" Izuku spluttered as water dripped down his face, and he wiggled to try and break free.

"HAH!? That was completely fair!"

"You don't pin someone in a water fight!"

"Says who?!"

Izuku pouted and huffed, before all at once he was aware of just how close they were to one another; Kacchan's breath was coming out in short puffs against the shell of his ear, the arm wrapped around his chest leading to a hand that cupped his shoulder and kept him flush to him. He dared not move his hands, but from the hard heat against his finger tips he was certain they were trapped between the small of his back and Kacchan's protruding hipbone. He couldn't breathe, frozen by the river water yet burned by the insane heat of Kacchan's body ... no wonder he couldn't tolerate the cold when he ran this hot. He hardly managed a gulp, Kacchan still looking indignant before he, too, seemed to realise their predicament. Their eyes met, Izuku not daring to blink, that searing red strangely soothing, the hand around his wrists twitching, the heart beating in the chest pressed to his back racing fast enough for Izuku to wonder whether it was his own heart beat he felt, or Kacchan's.

"Kacchan-"

Kacchan's face flushed, and before he could do a damn thing about it, the arm around his chest released him, and Kacchan was grabbing the top of his head and roughly dunking him under the water again. Izuku gasped and spluttered as his face broke the surface, just in time to see Kacchan storming away from him, shoulders swinging and hands curled into fists, his luminously pale yet

painfully adorable ass twinkling from the water trickling off it, and Izuku's good mood swiftly faded again.

Kacchan didn't say a single word to him as he roughly pulled his clothes back on, not even looking at him as Izuku approached and offered him one of the cups from his backpack so that Kacchan could drink from the river. He wanted to say something, but what was there to say? Somehow, he didn't think it was embarrassment that was getting to Kacchan ... he'd never been afraid of teasing Izuku, hell he had deliberately walked around naked the last time they had almost kissed just to mess with him. No ... if Izuku knew Kacchan like he felt that he did by now, then Kacchan was afraid. They had come close. If Izuku had kissed him back then, then there was every chance that he would be dead by now, and there was no way that wasn't haunting Kacchan as much, if not more, than it was him. One wrong move, one slip up, and any affection they shared between one another could become deadly.

He took a deep breath as he started to pack the cups away. What did he want? Did he want to be close to Kacchan? How could he when he was starting to realise that it brought Kacchan real pain ... He got to his feet, the silence between them deafening as Kacchan wordlessly adjusted his pack, eyes downcast and deliberate. He could just ... ask him. They could talk about it, couldn't they? They'd been through so much together why shouldn't they just be able to talk about this? But the severe cut of Kacchan's face, the way he seemed to refuse to meet his eyes, told him that Kacchan wasn't ready. He turned away, gripping the straps of his pack, his wet hair still dripping onto his shoulders leaving him feeling cold.

"Let's go," Kacchan finally said, and Izuku nodded, following Kacchan back along the trail, cold pit in his stomach.

Kacchan didn't say anything, but the way that the ground underfoot started to gently lead into a steep uphill hike, Izuku assumed that he was indeed leading them away from the larger expanse of Fujinomiya city. Izuku was tired, no matter how much sleep he got the night before, walking for this long over so many weeks was going to result in a deep rooted fatigue that never seemed to go away, and that had only gotten worse after Izuku's burn had gotten so badly infected. But, it was far better to walk the long route than risk walked through a city they had absolutely no need to go through. They had enough supplies, they had weapons, they were as prepared as they had ever been, and if the last two years had taught Izuku anything, it was that cities were some of the worst places to find yourself during a zombie apocalypse.

It was half way along their trail that Izuku spotted their first sign of life outside of the usual birds and insects that hummed and scattered around them. A gentle rustle from their left that Izuku, at first, assumed would be a zombie, his hand already dropping to his weapon before he'd even got a good look at the creature stepping through the under-brush, before he gasped softly.

"Kacchan!" he whispered. "Look!"

Kacchan grunted, looking to where Izuku was pointing. It was a deer of some kind, a dark brown in colour that mingled with the dark backdrop of the forest, white stripes across it's back, and white markings on it's face. Izuku didn't know a lot about deer, but looking at it he didn't think it was a species native to Japan.

"Holy fuck," Kacchan breathed, voice quiet. "Looks like some animals did escape the safari after all."

"*Lions*," Izuku whispered, fisting one hand into the palm of the other. He felt rather than saw Kacchan's withering stare.

There was movement at his side, and he glanced over to see Kacchan carefully pulling his pack from his shoulders and placing it on the ground, before he pulled his weapon out from his belt.

"*What are you doing?!*" Izuku hissed.

"What do you think I'm doing? I'm fed up of eating canned fucking vegetables-"

"But he's a survivor! You can't eat him!"

"Survival of the fittest, Deku! If the thing's stupid enough to let me get close enough to hit it with this then it deserves to be eaten."

"No, Kacchan you can't!" Izuku whined, grabbing hold of Kacchan's wrist as he started to move forward.

"Stop being such a fucking wimp! We gotta eat!"

"Then how are we any better than the zombies?" Izuku pleaded, and Kacchan froze, glaring back at me.

"Are you fucking *kidding me?*"

Kacchan's voice rang out through the woods, starting the deer that immediately took off, and Kacchan growled again.

"Goddammit!"

"I'm not sorry," Izuku replied stubbornly. "I wasn't going to let you kill the poor deer!"

"I don't give a shit about the deer, Deku!" Kacchan yelled, turning on his heel to face him. "The hell is wrong with you, hah? First you're naming the fucking things, now you think it's fucking ok to compare *me* to one of 'em?"

Izuku froze, eyes widening, when he noticed the vulnerability there beneath the surface, fragile and afraid beneath the hard angles of Kacchan's face, chipping away at him piece by piece, and Izuku had not felt so guilty in a long ass time.

"Kacchan," he breathed. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean it that way-"

"Either I'm a zombie or I aint," Kacchan interrupted, his entire body seeming to vibrate with repressed rage, fear, anguish ... there was just far too much swimming in his red eyes for Izuku to unpack in that moment. "You can't just keep changing your mind when it fucking suits you!"

Izuku blinked. "H-huh? What do you mean changing my mind?"

Kacchan heaved a deep breath, his lips wobbling over the glint of his teeth, before he scoffed.

"Work it out. I ain't fucking around with you like this."

"Like ... like *what*?" Izuku asked, alarmed as Kacchan turned again and started to walk away from him. "Kacchan! Like wh-"

"My name ain't fucking *Kacchan*!"

His yell rang through the forest, so loud that it sent several birds up in the sky, and left Izuku stuck in place, his heart hammering and his eyes wide and shocked.

"It's Bakugou," Kacc-*Bakugou* snarled into the silence. "I know your dumb ass can fucking say it."

Izuku felt like he was falling, desperately reaching out to try and grab hold of the fabric of reality as he saw Kacchan shut himself down, saw the glow in his eyes die, saw him physically close himself up in the way his hands curled into fists and his back hunched, and over his shock and his panic he had only one clear conscious thought.

"No."

Kacchan looked at him again then, his expression dumfounded, mouth going slack. *"No?"*

"No," Izuku repeated, firmer. "You might not want to hear this, but I've come to know you pretty well over these last months."

"I swear to god-" Kacchan snarled, taking a step towards him.

"You're not shutting me out over this," Izuku said, refusing to budge even as Kacchan glared at him, anger radiating off him, his expression pulled back into the most intimdating facade he could manage. "I know it's a lot to take in, I know you'd rather just fucking ... run away from it. From me. But I'm not going to let that happen."

"I don't run away from shit!" Kacchan yelled.

"Yes you do." Izuku could feel his lips starting to wobble, high on adrenaline even as his nerves started to shake. Sure, Kacchan was a scary guy if you were caught on the wrong side of him, but honestly? He had faced worse. He had survived worse, and he knew deep down that Kacchan wasn't going to hurt him. He would never go that far again.

"You're always running," he continued, his voice shaky yet soft, imploring. "You won't let yourself stop and just *feel* things. You find out that the zombie back in that town was a bite survivor and the first thing you want to do is leave! But you can't do that, so now you're trying to shut me out, pushing me and forcing *m*e to be the one that leaves."

Kacchan was close to him now, his body shaking.

"But I'm not leaving. We've been through too much for that."

Kacchan scoffed, raising a trembling hand up to drag through his hair.

"What the hell do you want from me, Deku?" he said, voice as unsteady as his hands, before he gestured between the two of them. "The fuck do you want from this, hah?"

"Kacchan, I don't want anything from you-"

"Right," Kacchan said with a pained laugh. "Now who's running away from shit, hah?"

"Kacchan-"

"Look, it was one thing when we couldn't fuck," Kacchan interrupted him, and Izuku winced at the honesty of his words. "Life sucks, whatever, but now I can't even *kiss* you without-" Kacchan's voice choked, and he glared furiously above Izuku's head, lower jaw jutting out. "You ever thought maybe *I'm* better off on my own?"

"How could you be?" Izuku asked, and Kacchan scoffed again, swallowing audibly.

"Because then I wouldn't be fucking feeling ..." he stopped, shaking his head.

"Feeling?"

"*This*," Kacchan replied shortly, looking back at him again. And far from red cheeked and awkward as he would have usually been admitting something like that, he looked broken. Izuku opened his mouth to reply, before realising he had no words to offer. He took a deep shaky breath before reaching out, ignoring the way Kacchan tensed as he took one of his rough hands.

"I ... I don't know," Izuku finally replied, looking down at the fingers beneath his thumb. "I don't want you to hurt, Kacchan. I don't know what, if anything, we could have but I ..." he sniffed, feeling his eyes sting as he raised blushing red cheeks to matching eyes. "I do know that I want you with me. However long that might be."

Kacchan didn't move, but he didn't snatch his hand away either, and for a time they just looked at each other, Kacchan's eyes searching, unsure, as if he was trying to determine whether or not Izuku would like about something like this, before his shoulders slumped and the tension in his body seemed to drop away.

"Fine."

Izuku raised an eyebrow. "Fine? What do you mean *fine?*"

"If you have to keep using that stupid nickname then ... *fine.* Whatever."

Izuku smiled, chuckling softly, gently massaging Kacchan's fingers between his own. "I open my heart out to you and you're just like ... *you don't have to call me Bakugou*," he lowered his voice into an exaggerated imitation of Kacchan's own low rasp, and Kacchan glared at him.

"Fucker, I was honest about stuff too!"

"Ok ok, I suppose you were."

"Still pissed about the deer though, Deku. The fuck do you think is in those shitty ramen packets, hah?"

"I'm not saying I'm going vegetarian," Izuku protested. "I just didn't want you to kill Bambi! He was so pretty-"

"Do not fucking name that shitty deer, Deku, I swear to god."

Izuku laughed, realising that he was still holding Kacchan's hand, and that Kacchan wasn't pulling back. In fact, his fingers were curling back, his thumb softly rubbing back and forth over the underside of Izuku's hand.

"Think we can finally get out of this fucking forest?" Kacchan asked gruffly. "Gonna take us long enough to get to Shizuoka without stopping every five miles to bitch at each other."

"I'll stop bitching if you do," Izuku replied with a grin.

"I hate you."

"You love me."

He only realised after the words had left his lips how goddamn fucking loaded a statement that was, and in a flash of panic he imagined Kacchan pulling away again, but his eyes only narrowed, his lips pouting.

"Shut up, let's go."

Kacchan let go of Izuku's hand, gently pulling away, before he grabbed his pack and heaved it over his shoulder again. Izuku smiled, the warmth radiating through his chest an entirely welcome one.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 22: Corpse Your Heart and Hope to Die

Chapter Summary

In which Deku takes a leap and hopes Kacchan is there to catch him.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There was still an undeniable tension that lingered between the two of them that day, though the nature of it had shifted greatly since their earlier conversation. It was a certain expectation, a kind of tentative longing that hour by hour, moment by moment, seem to only grow, until Izuku realised by the afternoon that he had had a hard time looking away from the man even once. He knew that it felt like to handle a new crush, the butterflies that came at the start of a new relationship, but he had never felt anything quite like the feelings that stirred inside of him as Kacchan walked at his side, seemingly unaware of Izuku's eyes trailing him. But Izuku found he no longer felt guilty for letting his gaze linger on Kacchan's face, his body, the subtle movements of his fingers and lips as he concentrated on the scenary. He was ... captivating. And still it was so much more than just fascination. So much more than the desire to hold him, touch him, spend every moment he had just looking at him ...

In truth, it scared him. He had felt something for Shouto, he knew that and he had accepted it. Thinking about Shouto, about the man he might have been holding at this moment if things hadn't gone to hell, yanked at the bloodied scar in his heart that he was sure was never going to heal. And yet he had never felt ... *this*. He had never looked at Shouto and felt like he could fucking fly if he had asked him to. Looking at Kacchan stirred something that he hadn't even realised he possessed, and sure he absolutely would have died for any of his friends. He would die for any of the companions he'd had over the last two years because if there was one thing that Izuku was capable of, it was unbridled compassion and a desire to protect those that mattered to him. But for *Kacchan?* For Kacchan he would swim across oceans. For Kacchan he would scream until his lungs were torn. For Kacchan he would fight to his last breath. For Kacchan ... he would kill.

What were you supposed to do with a feeling like that? Was it supposed to bring him courage to know that he was already ready to run off into battle with him the moment he asked? But, shit, it was *more* than that. It wasn't just that he'd do anything for him. There was a flame kindled inside his chest that he could never hope to put out, something on the edge of his consciousness at all times, a possessiveness that he didn't know how to handle. He wasn't stupid ... Despite all his assurances to Kacchan, all of his soft words, he knew deep down that it was likely that there would be a day when he would lose Kacchan to the infection that still raged in his veins. He had to accept that, one day, Kaccha might not be ... himself any more, and far from a suffering sadness, he felt a fierce anger. He wanted to protect Kacchan. He wanted him to be safe as much as he wanted to feel his strong arms protecting *him* when he felt afraid. The more he thought about it, the more primal the whole damn thing felt. Kacchan was his, and he would fight tooth and claw to keep him that way, to stop anyone else from hurting Kacchan in the ways that he had already been hurt.

These thoughts were distracting enough that several times Kacchan had to snap at him for not paying attention, at one point flicking him hard between the eyes so suddenly that Izuku had yelped.

"Stop staring off into space!" Kacchan yelled furiously. "If we get fucked up the ass because you weren't paying attention I'll grab a damn spoon and finish the job!"

Izuku blinked, rubbing his forehead, mumbling an apology before his face scrunched up in a confused frown.

"Hah?"

"Whadya mean *hah?!*"

"Usually your insults make a twisted kind of sense by why would you ... with a spoon ..?"

"Your eye genius!"

"*Kacchan!* That's a little harsh ... I could still go blind, you know?"

"Very fucking funny, asshole."

"I'm not joking! I feel ok now but if my eye does get infection then it's only going to get worse-"

"And you're only telling me that now?!"

"I told you back when it happened!"

Perhaps they had talked through whatever emotional tension was hanging over the both of them. Perhaps it was now abundantly clear that there was an attraction between them that they were both equally as frustrated about, but their communication skills were still pretty lacking. And Izuku wasn't entirely sure it was really *his* fault at all ...

"Like hell you did!"

"Ok, point is, I still don't know how my eye's gonna be until I take the patch off."

"Well, does it hurt?"

"Of course it hurts, Kacchan, a zombie tried to jam it's thumb into my brain!"

"Alright smartass," Kacchan growled, before reaching a hand up to massage his temple with such ferocity that it looked damn hear painful.

"Are you ok?" Izuku asked, his heart clenching at the sight, and Kacchan paused, yanking his hand away.

"Fucking fine."

"Kacchan-" Izuku started, seriously, but Kacchan shook his head.

"I'm fine," he snapped. "Quit worrying before you damn need to."

Izuku shut his mouth, not feeling the least be reassured. Mr Zombig's diary had talked about the headaches, plus Kacchan was insisting on going cold turkey on the vodka ... he shift a hand back to press against the bottom of his pack, the shot-sized bottles of vodka a reassuring weight against his finger tips.

The woods, again, proved to be a safer way for them to travel, as they didn't come across a single damn zombie in their trek from the town higher up the mountain and to the edge of a small district of Fujinomiya. It wasn't ideal having to cross through anywhere civilised, but Kacchan felt sure that it would be quiet enough here for them to pass through without being bothered. Apparently, this area of the city was more of a tourist trap, a *'fucking waterfall or some shit'*, as Kacchan put it, and there really wasn't any reason for anyone to have hung around here after the start of the end of the world. As such, it probably was a safe point for them to cross the city as they were going to get without walking further and further away from Shizouka. Plus, a small part of Izuku was actually pretty excited about it, a waterfall sounded almost ... well, didn't it sound *romantic?*

They approached the outskirts of the district cautiously. They'd been burned way too many fucking times to take it easy regardless of how unlikely it had seemed that they would come across any signs of life, undead or otherwise, and Izuku kept his weapon to hand as they carefully picked their way through the undergrowth. This part of the city sure seemed deserted, though there was evidence all over that a lot of horrible things had once happened here ... there was debris all over the place, but the most alarming thing were the corpses. It wasn't like Izuku wasn't used to seeing dead people by now, but stumbling across a corpse that wasn't also trying to tear his throat out was still a disturbing experience, especially when there seemed to be so many of them ... There wasn't much left, just sunken bodies, filthy bones covered in cloth, even the blood stains beneath them almost entirely washed away by two years of rainfall, but it was a sobering reminder of how ... *fuck*, how lucky they had been to have even survived the feeding frenzies that had spread like wildfire at the start.

"I guess the outbreak started early here," Izuku said quietly. "They must not have been able to evacuate before-"

But he was interrupted by the sound of choking at his side, and he swung around to see Kacchan throwing his head into a trash can at the side of the road.

"*Kacchan*!"

Kacchan held out a hand, coughing weakly into the can, as if to hold Izuku back, and he hesitated. *He knew it ... he knew something wasn't right!*

"I'm fine," Kacchan snapped, as if in reflex, as he straightened up, wiping the back of his hand across his mouth, and Izuku felt a flash of anger.

"You're not fine!" he said, walking forward and grabbing Kacchan by the arms so that he would look at him. There was a fine sheen of sweat forming across Kacchan's forehead, and he swore. "I told you going cold turkey was a bad idea!"

"Shove off, Deku," Kacchan growled, averting his gaze, but he didn't fight him, his hands shaking minutely in Izuku's grip.

"Well, lucky for you at least one of us has some sense," Izuku sighed, before he let go and dropped his pack on the ground, digging through it. The purple packet of condoms rose to the top as if they

were fucking haunting them, but he ignored them and dug down to the bottom, before he pulled out one of the bottles of vodka and held it out to Kacchan.

"No."

He could have sworn he saw a slither of fear pass over Kacchan's face as he looked down at the bottle, could hear the harsh swallow that came after, feel the tension in the air as Kacchan's entire body tightened up.

"Going cold turkey is dangerous," Izuku said, as patiently as he could. "Especially right now."

"I don't fucking need it, Deku!"

"I'm not going to fight you on this, Kacchan!" Izuku snapped, getting to his feet. "I'm serious. Half now, half later, ok?"

Kacchan's face twitched, seemingly unable to take his eyes away from the bottle in Izuku's hand, and Izuku wasn't ashamed to admit that it hurt ... he wished that Kacchan had just been honest with him about this problem. He wished he wasn't still trying to pretend like it *wasn't* one, especially with the way his entire body seemed to zero in on the clear liquid being presented to him.

"Fine," Kacchan said. Izuku looked up in some surprise, expecting him to have argued some more, before Kacchan was snatching the bottle from his hand and unscrewing the lid. He hesitated, lower lip pouting, before he downed half the contents, swallowing loudly as he twisted the lid back on.

"Thank you, Kacchan," Izuku said, breathing a sigh of relief as he took the bottle offered back to him.

"The fuck you thanking me for?" Kacchan mumbled.

"For not being any more of a dick about it," Izuku replied smartly, ignoring the glare Kacchan sent him as he packed the bottle back in favour of a small smirk. "We should rest for a bit, take five?"

"Nah, I'm fine and I'm tired of having to keep saying it," Kacchan growled. "Let's just keep going."

Izuku was half tempted to insist otherwise, but Kacchan was already walking away from him with purpose, his weapon back in hand and, not wanting to be left behind, Izuku hurried after him. Kacchan had at least accepted some help from him, and he supposed that was far better than he should have expected.

Aside from the dessicated corpses littering the streets, this part of the city proved to be entirely empty, worthless even to the zombies that had no doubt once crowded the place before they had moved on. Izuku was still curious about the migration patterns of the zombies and, wanting to keep Kacchan's mind occupied with something other than the feeling of going cold turkey, he mentioned as such.

"When do you think the zombies decide to leave a city?" he asked, Kacchan glancing sideways at him with a cocked brow.

"I don't think they fucking decide anything," he replied. "I think they just keep walking and end up in my damn way."

"There seemed to be a lot more of them just ... milling around at the start," Izuku continued. "We saw it a lot, you know? There'd just be groups of them hanging around outside fast food restaurants, or tech stores, almost like it was a habit you know?"

Kacchan didn't respond.

"I assumed they must retain some sort of memory of being alive ... or at least, they retained some of their old habits. You spend your life stopping at the same coffee shop every morning, seems like you spend you're, uh, *un-life* doing the same. But these days whenever you see them they're on the move, or in large groups."

"Maybe they're hungrier," Kacchan replied, and Izuku felt a chill run through him.

"You think they're actively looking for people now?"

"Yeh, why not? They've got to keep going somehow, right?"

"But they'd still come after you just as fast back then when they spotted you as they do now," Izuku reasoned, and Kacchan shrugged.

"Then maybe they forget. I mean, fuck, their brains are literally rotting away in their damn heads, eventually whatever habits they had are gonna rot away as well. The real fucking question is how they keep fucking going. You kill 'em by destroying the brain, right? So why the fuck aren't we finding dead zombies about the place after their brains have completely rotten away?"

Izuku stopped, eyes wide. He, somehow, had never considered that before. He looked over at the dried up husks laying a little way aways from them ... he couldn't know exactly how long ago these people had died, but they were certainly decomposed enough that none of the soft flesh remained, not for a long ass time, so why weren't the zombies decomposing at the same rate?

"It's like they're decomposing slower," Izuku muttered, hand coming up to his chin in thought. "But what you said makes sense. Assuming the brain doesn't die right away? Their are still neurons firing, their baser instincts, memories without a consciousness, and it's why they still appear to have some, well, human characteristics right at the start. Hell, I saw one of them walking around with a damn dog lead once, just hanging there as it ambled through the park."

Kacchan stopped, looking back when he realised that Izuku had stopped walking.

"Over time, the brains rots, those neurons stop firing ... and all that's left is the basic need to feed. But the only way they could possibly be decomposing slower is if they're, well, still *alive* in some way."

"Jesus, Deku," Kacchan hissed, expression tight and uncomfortable, but Izuku was far too lost in thought to notice.

"And that's not even taking into account that they must have some form of digestive system ... I've never seen a zombie poop, I mean ... but I've also not seen any of them with huge bloated stomachs which is the only thing that could happen if they were eating without expelling waste in some way, well not except that one back in the apartment that-" he froze, realising quickly where his train of thought had been taking him. He had seen bloated zombies ... he'd seen the zombie so full of eating Shouto that it's stomach had been distended. He felt an unwelcome wave of nausea, and snapped his jaw shut.

"I dunno if I really wanna fucking talk about zombie's shitting, Deku," Kacchan said, though his tone was softer than the words warranted. Izuku shook his head and swallowed, steeling himself.

"It ... there's still so much we don't know about them," he continued after a deep breath. "But they're definitely behaving differently now from how they used to, not to mention the two zombies we've met that didn't seem to act like any of the others. The way that Mr Zombig was able to control the other zombie,s it still ... It freaks me out, even if it is interesting."

As was his tendency when he was in a muttering spree, he lost track of his surroundings for a moment, and didn't even notice the huge flinch that Kacchan made when Mr Zombig was mentioned, the way his lips curled up and he glared furious up at the sky.

"The zombie back on the road," Izuku continued. "She didn't seem to have any control over the other zombies, at least that I could see ... but she was definitely different. Fresher, for one thing, like she'd only just turned. And opening the car door wasn't an accident. But Mr Zombig? He could talk ... he wasn't trying to eat us-"

"Deku!"

Izuku started, looking up. Kacchan looked tense, his hands curled into fists.

"I ain't ... fucking ready to talk about it, alright?" he said, voice coming out harsh from between his gritted teeth. "The only fucking time I wanna hear the word zombie come out your damn lips is if you see one, get it?"

Izuku's shoulders slumped, feeling guilty that he had made Kacchan feel uncomfortable again, but also part of him a little frustrated that Kacchan had insisted on placing a goddamn gag order on him. He knew it was hard to talk about, especially with the consequences this train of thought might have on Kacchan himself, but surely that was why they should talk about it? Surely avoiding talking about it wasn't helping him either. But the almost desperate look in Kacchan's eyes, close to pleading, stilled his tongue.

"Ok. I'm sorry."

Kacchan grunted, before he started walking again, and Izuku followed in silence.

He could hear the waterfall before he could see it, just off in the distance, the entrance to the nature reserve surrounding it visible from afar, but he quickly realised that Kacchan was leading them away and around it, his decidedly disgruntled gaze fixed forward.

"A-aren't we going past the waterfall?" he asked tentatively.

"Why?" Kacchan replied shortly. "It's not on the way."

"I know but ... I kinda wanted to see it."

Kacchan looked over at him incredulously.

"Wha- are you serious? You wanna fucking *sight-see?*"

Izuku shrugged. "Not like I'm going to get a chance to see it again after this."

"You didn't even know there was a waterfall here until I told you about it!"

"That's not the point! I just ... can we go see it? I won't take long."

Kacchan opened his mouth sharply to argue, before he growled, rolling his eyes in frustration.

"Jesus, fine. But only so can I prove to you what a waste of fucking time it is."

Izuku flashed him a wide smile, but Kacchan only clicked his tongue at as he dramatically stomped past him and towards the park, and feeling decidedly pleased with himself Izuku trotted after him. Maybe the scenary would calm Kacchan down again.

Kacchan easily jumped the toll booth at the entrance to the park, Izuku clambering over the top of it, the loud rushing sound of the waterfall growing louder as they walked down the hill leading towards the main attraction, Izuku noting how overgrown the entire area had become. It always left him feeling conflicted, when he saw nature taking over ... after all, there had once been people here. Families had walked these paths, hand in hand and happy, and it was a lot to accept that something like that may never happen again. But seeing trees blooming unhindered, the amount of wildlife that flourished, brought a different sort of comfort to him. He supposed the earth really had just been looking for a chance to recover and set things back the way they had once been ... He stepped over a tree root that had started to break through the surface of the cobblestone, before his eyes widened with glee at the sight before them.

The overgrowth opened up onto a bridge, and from here Izuku could see the almost horseshoe shaped cliff face from which the showering waterfalls fell, cascading into the deep blue pool at it's case. With the trees left to grow wild, the place looked and *hell it even smelled* quite beautiful, and he couldn't hold back the little gasp as he looked at the sight. He was sure it was far from the biggest waterfall around, but the peace of it all, the serene kind of chaos that came from the spray that rose up from the pool, was still enough to lighten the weight on his chest.

"There," Kacchan said, his voice low and grumpy sounding. "Told you it wasn't worth it."

"What are you talking about?" Izuku breathed, leaning over the side of the railings and staring in wonder. "It's beautiful!"

Kacchan didn't respond, and after a moment of gaping and smiling, Izuku glanced sideways at him, their eyes meeting for less than a second before Kacchan was glaring purposefully forward, his cheeks looking suspiciously pink. Izuku's smile softened, his heart souring for an entirely different reason now.

"It's pretty," he said. "Admit it."

"It's water falling off a damn cliff, what's the big deal?"

"I know you have this whole *tough guy* vibe going on, but there's no way you can't appreciate how nice this is."

"I don't have a *tough guy vibe*!" Kacchan protested, crossed his arms over his chest. "I *am* a tough guy, I don't need to fucking vibe it." Izuku laughed.

"Ok, Kacchan."

"Don't fucking *ok, Kacchan* me you little shit!"

Izuku laughed again, before resting his cheek on his arm, leaning out over the railing and looking back to the waterfall. It was nice here ... And sure Kacchan might not be feeling particularly receptive to the idea, but it was fucking romantic. This beautiful natural feature, the sound of the water cascading in front of them, birds and bugs in the trees behind, the air smelling fresh and sweet, no one there but the two of them. It was the perfect confession spot, when he thought about it. Hell, it was the perfect *first kiss* spot, and at that thought his smile faded and his stomach twisted itself back into knots again.

"Goddamnit," Kacchan sighed, and Izuku glanced over, at first thinking that perhaps some zombies had snuck in on them, before he realised that they were still alone. "I thought this was gonna cheer you up. The hell you look so miserable for again, hah?"

"I'm not miserable," Izuku replied, honestly. "I'm just ..." He fell silent, not really knowing how to finish the thought. Kacchan seemed to hesitate for a moment, looking between him and the waterfall, before he huffed a breath and leaned his crossed arms onto the railings beside Izuku. He might still be glaring daggers at the waterfall through no fault of it's damn own, but Izuku still felt the warmth from his arm as it gently rest beside his. He looked back at the waterfall, and the two of them standing there in silence for a while longer, just taking in the view, Izuku trying to enjoy the small contact he had with Kacchan, and the shared moment that stood between them for as long as he could.

"Kacchan?" Izuku finally said, voice quiet and hesitant.

"Hmm?"

"We could ..." *We could what?* They could hold hands, Izuku could probably kiss Kacchan on the cheek, they could jerk each other off in the damn waterfall, what could they do? What did Izuku want? What did Kacchan want? Would it all just feel empty? Did Kacchan even want him touching him after all they had learned? The hell could they really have?

"What?" Kacchan said, voice soft but notably tipped with something else ... irritation, confusion? Was Kacchan every bit as confused as he was about all of this?

"Nothing," Izuku replied.

Kacchan didn't seem like he was going to press the point, staying where he was. He had no idea if Kacchan felt the same level of tension as he did, the heat that burned from just the barest of touches between them as their arms pressed together, but the way his heart was beating in his chest left him certain that Kacchan could feel the damn vibrations through his arm. And then Kacchan shifted, lifting his left hand from beneath his arm and placing it on top, his fingertips now just brushing against Izuku's elbow, and Izuku couldn't stop his eyes from wandering down to them, his face hidden beneath the hair that had fallen lose from his bun. And perhaps he was reading entirely too much from the gesture, because Kacchan was still glaring at the waterfall, lips pouting in disinterest, and if Kacchan had wanted to hold his hand then surely he would have just done it? Izuku swallowed, his right hand hanging over the edge of the railing, before he decided to throw caution to the wind. He reached up, letting his fingers grace the tops of Kacchan's and settle between them.

Kacchan made no indication he had even noticed except the smallest intake of breath, but he didn't move his hand away, and the contact felt like a jolt of electricity, Izuku relishing in the heat that came off his fingers alone. He wasn't sure how long they stood there, Izuku's hand resting atop Kacchan's, the two of them watching the water fall and the trees wave in the wind, the warmth from

Kacchan's hand having spread up to his chest and throat, the sensation wholesomely comforting as the chill of the autumn air crept up and over his cheeks.

"We should keep going," Kacchan finally said, voice gentle, and Izuku hummed, not really wanting to move from this spot but knowing they couldn't stand there forever. He moved just as Kacchan did, the two of them now finding themselves standing chest to chest and impossibly close. He heard Kacchan's gentle gasp, and for a moment all he could do was stand there, staring at Kacchan's collarbones and frozen in place, before he tentatively looked up.

The expression on Kacchan's face was quite unlike anything he'd seen before, and honestly it all but stole his breath away. The gentle hot haze between them felt thick and suffocating, but in a way that left Izuku certain he'd gladly die that way ... Kacchan's usually burning and bright eyes were soft and heavy, eyelids almost entirely shut as he looked back at him the barest slither of crimson, his chest rising and falling with soft puffs of air that clouded between them, and Izuku simply couldn't look away and it ... it *hurt*. Fuck, did it oh so suddenly hurt to be this close to him, to already feel as though he was enveloped in his presence, and to not be able to close that final gap and press their lips together. He was sure he had never wanted to kiss someone so much in his life before now.

"Kacchan," he breathed, unsure, the longing clear in his tone and, all at once, the weight of it all seemed to settle on the blonde, too, and his eyes shut, head falling forward with an air of defeat, and something about that only seemed to tug at the already fractured pieces of his heart. He leaned forward, stretching up onto his tip toes, and Kacchan seemed to be only aware of his movement when Izuku's breath brushed over his ear.

"Deku-"

Izuku pressed the lightest of kisses against the soft skin of Kacchan's cheek, his senses alight with the sweetness of him, from the taste of him on his lips to the smallest hint of caramel that seemed to come from his hair, and as much as he wanted to dive deeper into the warm honey that was everything Kacchan, he moved back, already missing the warmth against his own cheek as their faces brushed.

Neither of them spoke for a moment, Izuku still standing close, his face almost entirely hidden against Kacchan's shoulder as he waited. Waited for him to say something, or push him away, he wasn't sure what would happen next, but what he hadn't expected was for the hoarse sounding voice to rumble through him, with a sadness as sweet as his taste.

"It's dangerous."

"It's just a kiss on the cheek," Izuku replied softly, but he knew what Kacchan meant. Of course he knew ...

"It's not enough." And perhaps to an outsider Kacchan's words might have sounded harsh, but the subtle shake to his voice, the way he seemed to tremble before him, conveyed the meaning enough. "I know it should be but it ... It's not-"

"I know," Izuku said. He swallowed ... he knew what he wanted to say, but he wasn't sure if saying it would only hurt Kacchan more, would only make everything that much harder. "I ... I want more too."

Kacchan took a deep shuddering breath.

"It'll hurt," he said firmly. "It'll fucking hurt, and everything already hurts enough, and I don't want- I don't think-" He shook his head, the movement forcing their bodies to brush together once more and Izuku shut his eyes tight. "What if I ain't fucking strong enough?"

Izuku swallowed. He knew it must take a lot for Kacchan to admit something like that, to say those words out loud, and he found himself strangely proud of him even as the tears dripped down his cheeks.

"Maybe you don't have to be," Izuku whispered. "Strong, I mean. Maybe ... it's ok to let someone else carry you for a while."

Kacchan let out a strange muted laugh. "Jesus, Deku, what does that even mean?"

"It means I want to look after you, too."

Kacchan's chest heaved, his body tensing, and all Izuku wanted to do was wrap his arms around him, chase away that doubt that it was ok to let that happen. That ... *hell, that it was ok if it hurt?* What was their life these days if not a continuous painful mess. And what if for once they could choose their own pains, could invite the inevitable pain of losing one another if it meant they could steal moments like this until that day came?

"We've been here too long," Kacchan said, stepping away from Izuku and clearing his throat. "Come on, the lights going to start fading soon, we need to find somewhere safe for the night."

Izuku nodded. "Ok, Kacchan."

He lead them back the way they came, back up the shallow hill to the entrance of the park, the both of them silent again as they walked. As it turned out, they really had spent far longer down by the waterfall than they should have done, and Izuku could feel the chill of the evening moving in, their shadows growing longer. They probably wouldn't be able to travel much further from the city before it got dark, which meant they were better off finding somewhere here for them to rest for the night. He opened his mouth to say as much to Kacchan, but he seemed to be already head of him, pointing to three small houses in a terrace ahead of them.

"One of those will do."

They approached the first house in the same practised fashion they always did, Kacchan taking the lead whilst Izuku flanked him. Kacchan placed his hand on the door handle, glancing over at Izuku to check he was ready, before pushing, the door already unlocked and swinging inwards.

It seemed empty at first glance, the hallway clear, the living room and kitchen coming off of it holding no surprises for them, and the benefit of having not needed to kick down the door certainly made it seem like a suitable place to hold up for the night. They progressed deeper into the house, taking the flight of stairs, checking each bedroom, before pausing at what Izuku assumed to be the bathroom, the door shut. Frankly, Izuku had grown to become quite nervous of bathrooms over the last few months ... he'd seen one too many unfortunate things inside of them, and he swallowed as Kacchan reached for the handful.

"Careful," he muttered, surprising himself. Kacchan shot him a weird look, before he pushed the door.

At first, Izuku couldn't work out what was happening. A loud buzzing filled the hallway, and Kacchan let out a choked cry, stumbling backwards as a cloud of black seemed to descend upon him. Izuku yelled, rushing forward, not entirely sure what he was trying to protect Kacchan from, before the smell hit him.

"Hold up!" Kacchan called, voice muffled by the hand pressed to his mouth and nose, the other waving through the black cloud as it started to disperse, and it was then that Izuku realised that it wasn't a cloud, but *flies*, almost certainly drawn by the smell coming from the bathroom.

"Are you ok?" Izuku gasped, walking forwards.

"I've fucking been better," Kacchan managed, before he reached out and slammed the bathroom door shut. "You don't wanna go in there."

Izuku could only take his word for it, watching the insects scurrying across the walls and buzzing around the hall.

"Next one?"

"Next one."

It might have been empty, but neither of them wanted to spend a night in a house with a maggot infected corpse just sitting upstairs from them. They took the next house, this time sure to peek slowly into the bathroom before barging in, and settling down in the living room after they were certain it was safe.

"We should look at your eye," Kacchan said, after Izuku had wrapped himself in one of the blankets on the sofa. Izuku nodded, as Kacchan grabbed the backpack with their medical supplies and dropped onto the couch beside him. He could feel Kacchan's heat already, which sure as hell didn't help ease him as the anxiety surrounding what they would find beneath the patch started to grow. He'd done well not to think about it, but he really could do with the use of both his eyes again, his depth perception had gone to hell and he really didn't need another handicap in the Apocalypse.

Kacchan dug through their supplies, that goddamn box of condoms returning to taunt them as it had done time and time again, though this time Kacchan grabbed it and purposefully shoved it back down in the bottom of Izuku's backpack, before he started to place the pink disinfectant and fresh swabs and bandages onto the sofa beside them.

"How does it feel?" Kacchan asked, scooting closer.

"It hurts," Izuku admitted, as Kacchan reached out, his finger tips brushing against his cheekbone as he gently peeled at the tape holding down the patch. "But not as much as I thought it would, honestly."

"That's good," Kacchan muttered. "You ready?"

Izuku nodded, bracing himself as Kacchan pulled the remainder of the patch away, still keeping his eye shut. He took a deep breath, before blinking.

The first thing he realised, was that his depth perception was really no better, wondering whether he had even opened his eye. The next thing he realised ... was that he couldn't see a damn thing out of his left eye.

"Anything?"

"Uh," Izuku swallowed, frowning and trying to focus harder, but it really was of no use, his vision was completely obscured in his left eye.

"Shit," Kacchan breathed, rough fingertips grabbing Izuku's chin as he angled his head up and towards the light.

"Maybe something a little more encouraging than that, Kacchan?"

"Can you see anything?"

"No. What does it look like?"

"Completely bloodshot," Kacchan muttered, leaning closer. "Iris looks like it's full of blood."

"Shit," Izuku mirrored.

"So what does that fucking mean?"

"Means I'm going to need those corticosteroids if I want even a chance at being able to see out this eye again."

"Should have stayed in that damn town for longer," Kacchan growled, before he let go of Izuku's chin and leaned back. "We'll have to look for a pharmacy here. Fuck."

"It's dangerous in the city."

"It's fucking dangerous if you can't see shit," Kacchan replied sharply, before he let out a heavy sigh. "C'mere, lemme put another patch over it."

Kacchan busied himself with cleaning the cut above Izuku's eye, he wincing at the sting of pain that came with it, before he gently pressed and taped another patch across the socket.

"There," Kacchan muttered, as he started to shove the supplies back into the pack. "That'll do for now."

"Thanks, Kacchan."

Kacchan merely grunted in response, getting to his feet and pulling some food from the other backpack. It was obviously a complete lack of thought on Kacchan's part when he threw the pack of crisps in Izuku's direction, the latter reaching out to grab them only to completely miss and for the bag to hit him smack in the face.

"The hell? Can't you fucking catch!"

"No, I can't," Izuku replied, deadpan, gesturing to the patch over his eye. For a moment, neither of them said a word, before in unison they broke out in laughter. Kacchan's laugh was, to put it simply, ugly as hell, and that only made Izuku laugh harder at the strangely high bark that broke from Kacchan's lips.

"Fuckin' asshole!"

"You were the one that threw it at me!" Izuku managed, collapsing back on the sofa.

"Yeh, well."

He sat down beside him, own bag of chips in hand, and Izuku held out half of the blanket, Kacchan only hesitating for a moment before he took it, pulling it across his chest.

"Fucking hate winter," he said. "At least last time we had the damn house."

"There's still a couple months before it gets really cold," Izuku said. "We might be at UA by then."

Kacchan grunted again, before shoving a handful of crisps into his mouth and chewing loudly.

"We'll search as much of the city as we can in the morning," Kacchan continued, still popping crisps into his mouth as he talked and leaving Izuku wondering, again, how he could have fallen for someone with precisely zero manners to speak of. "Find you them damn eye drops and then get back on the road to Shizouka. No breaks, we can probably make it in a couple days tops."

"You think they could be waiting there?" Izuku asked.

"Not if they have any damn sense. They *should* carry on to Musutafu like we planned, but they'll know we'll cut through Shizouka. If they're alive, then they'll have left some sort of sign."

Izuku hummed.

"Hey, I never asked," he said. "How did you guys hear about Musutafu and UA being a safe place? I mean, I grew up there, went to UA, but didn't you all go to Tokyo?"

"There were rumours at the start," Kacchan replied with a shrug. "What with the fucking walls and everything keeping everyone out. After leaving Tokyo we didn't really have anywhere else to aim for."

"Oh."

"Plus ... I kinda just wanna get back there, you know?"

Izuku frowned, confused at what he meant. "Get back there?"

"My parents live in Musutafu," Kacchan said. "Didn't I fucking tell you that already?"

Izuku's eyebrows rose in surprise. "What?! No, you didn't tell me that! Where did you grow up? What school did you go to? Wait, what if we already knew each other and didn't realise it?"

"I think I'd have fucking remembered if I'd met you before, Deku! How many fucking nerds with green hair do you think live in Musutafu?"

"But, it just seems crazy that our paths never crossed," Izuku argued. "Musutafu isn't the biggest city."

"But it's still a damn city."

"So why didn't you go to UA?" Izuku pressed, leaning forward on his place on the sofa. "I mean ... you seem smart enough."

"Tokyo had the better course," Kacchan replied, somewhat doggedly. "Besides, the hell were you doing in Shinagawa in the middle of term?"

"I told you about No Coal Japan, didn't I?" Izuku said. "There was a protest due, and I had a week free so decided to come stay with Ochako and Tenya."

Kacchan nodded, tearing at the bag with his teeth. Izuku watched in morbid fascination as he licked the salt and crumbs from the inside like the damn animal he clearly was.

"I was with them when it started, Tsu and Sh-Shouto had already travelled down from Tokyo, so it was the five of us from the off. We met other people early on, on the road and in safe houses, we were part of a much larger group for a while but ... well."

Kacchan hummed in acknowledgement before chucking the wrapper over the back of the sofa.

"We stayed away from other people after the campus," he said. "Couldn't trust anyone else until, well, I had to save your ass."

"Why did you?"

"Huh?"

"Why'd you save me? You could have just carried on, given how unlucky you'd all been with other people, it would have made sense to just leave me."

Kacchan blinked at him, face scrunched up in confusion.

"You were about to get *eaten* by a group of zombies," he snapped. "The hell do you think I saved you? Just because I can't trust anyone else doesn't mean I'm ok watching someone get fuckin' eaten. Besides," he added, and his cheeks turned suspiciously pink again, "you looked like you could be useful."

It was Izuku's turn to look confused. "Useful?"

"You were gonna take them all on with just that toothpick of a weapon you had," Kacchan explained. "I was curious."

Izuku grinned broadly at this. "Curious, huh?"

"Yeh, *curious*," Kacchan snapped back, his cheeks still burning. "Either you were on your own in which case you might be worth adding to the team, or you were with another group that could be a threat to us. Either way, didn't make sense to let you get eaten. Don't fucking think anything more into it, nerd!"

"I wasn't!" Izuku replied, still grinning.

They fell into another silence, this one much more comfortable, and Izuku put what remained of his crisps onto the coffee table in front of them, settling back into the couch. His body was getting stronger, day by day, but he was still tired. His head hurt, his eye ached, his muscles still strained from the fight the day before, and the temptation of sleep was already starting to call to him.

"Get some sleep," Kacchan said, seeming to notice how tired Izuku was. "I'll take first watch."

"Are you sure?" Izuku mumbled. "You always take first watch-"

"You're more tired than me, nerd."

"Ok. Kacchan?"

"Jesus, what?"

"The vodka in my bag, don't forget to drink what's left of that bottle."

"I feel fine, Deku."

"I know. But you won't if you don't drink it."

"... fine."

"Ok, Kacchan."

He yawned, before letting the comfort of the sofa encompass him, his eyes drifting shut.

When Deku woke up later, it was still dark. Laying on his side, curled up under the blanket, he could feel something warm and firm beneath his cheeks and, after a moments more slow sleepy consideration, he could feel something soft and soothing at this temple. It took him a few moments to realise that, at some point during the night, he had ended up with his head on Kacchan's lap, and the gentle motions against his temple was Kacchan slowly running his fingers through his hair. He didn't dare to move, keeping his eyes shut, listening to Kacchan's soft breathing, willing for his heart to stop beating so damn fast before Kacchan felt it and stopped what he was doing. It was confusing ... one minute Kacchan seemed like he wanted to keep him at arms length, but when he was asleep he'd wrap his arms around him or stroke his goddamn hair, and leave Izuku feeling like there really was something more between them now.

The movement in his hair stopped, and he tried not to feel too disappointed at that when he felt the warmth of Kacchan's hand move away. Maybe if he carried on pretending to be asleep Kacchan would put his hand back ...

"I know you're awake."

Kacchan's voice was gruff, and Izuku half winced. The gig was up. He opened his good eye and rolled onto his back so that he could look up at him. He couldn't make out much in the dark, especially with only one damn eye, but he could see the low glow of red in the gloom as Kacchan looked back down at him.

"You're a softie at night," Izuku mumbled.

"I've never been fucking soft a day in my life," Kacchan responded immediately. "You're the one who clings like a damn koala."

Izuku hummed, smiling. "Nah, you were definitely the one hugging me yesterday morning."

"Hah? No, I wasn't."

"Hmm, yeh you were," Izuku replied smugly. Kacchan clicked his tongue against his teeth before he shut his eyes, and Izuku was sure there would be another pretty blush on his cheeks if it were

light enough to see it.

"What time is it?" Izuku asked quietly, and Kacchan just shrugged his eyes still closed, and his hand resting just beside Izuku's shoulder.

"Dunno. Three or Four in the morning."

Kacchan made no effort to move either of them, just letting his head rest against the back of the couch, eyes shut and breathing softly. Izuku was struck, in that moment, by how ... calm he looked. Even now he wasn't used to seeing Kacchan relaxed, the absence of the usual snarl on his lips and the scowl in his brow not quite so jarring as it once had been, but still oddly intimate. He couldn't help but find himself wondering whether Kacchan let himself be this vulnerable around the rest of the group ... it occurred to him that it had never really seemed like he had. And he had no doubt that Kacchan had trusted them, all of them, but there was something different about the relationship he had with his friends, and the one that they had built together. Even now, all Kacchan wanted to do was protect them ... Perhaps it was just the kind of man he was, perhaps it was the role thrust upon him against his will, he still wasn't entirely sure on that part. But regardless it was only now that the two of them had spent so long together, hearts bleeding out in front of one another time and time again, that he saw just how much of a front he had always put up. How that dangerous smirk, those flashing eyes, that quick yet vulgar tongue, was the facade his group had needed to see.

But Izuku didn't need that. Izuku had seen him for the bad and the worst, had witnessed his mistakes, his tears, his frustration ... there really wasn't much that Kacchan had been able to keep hidden from him, like he had done Kirishima and the others. And this Katsuki Bakugou? This Katsuki Bakugou with his breaths so soft, his body so open and unguarded, the wrinkles on his forehead smoothed out, was beautiful. This Kacchan was the one Izuku both wished the world could see, but also one he wanted to guard and protect with his goddamn life.

He sat up, Kacchan taking a deep breath and uttering a short grunt at the lack of contact, rousing him from where he had been drifting off.

"Where'you goin'?" he mumbled sleepily, his hand reaching out almost instinctively for Izuku, brushing against his forearm.

"Nowhere," Izuku replied, voice scarcely more than a whisper, but certain his heart was probably beating loudly enough to speak for itself. "I'm not going anywhere."

He hesitated for a moment longer, kneeling at Kacchan's side, feeling his fingers almost absently brushing up and down his forearm, before the desire to be closer to him, to feel his his heat again, overcame his nerves, and in one quick movement he shifted forward, straddling Kacchan's lap and letting his hands press against his chest.

He knew that there was still a chance Kacchan might push him away. His eyes sprung open, and Izuku basked in the seering glow as those red orbs focused on him with such an incredibly intensity. It wasn't like Izuku hadn't at least partially thought this through ... he knew there were risks involved, but he had faith in himself, and in Kacchan, that they could work around them. Kacchan deserved to feel as loved and cared for as anyone, regardless of what might be pumping his veins.

"Deku," Kacchan breathed, his tone low, an uncertain warning, both asking him to stay away and betraying his desire to pull him closer. The conflict between head and heart so clear to see in the wideness of his eyes and the tightness of his lips. "*Deku*-"

"Do you trust me?" Izuku breathed, leaning closer, not daring to tear his eyes away from him for even a moment and miss a damn thing that face was trying to tell him. Kacchan swallowed audibly, his breath hitching, before that beautiful face was pulled back into a frown.

"Course I fuckin' do."

"Ok." Izuku took a deep breath, his eyes drifting shut as he moved forwards, the tips of their noses touching, Kacchan's heart beating so hard in his chest Izuku could feel it shuddering down his arms. "Ok, Kacchan."

Kacchan gasped when Izuku's lips made contact with his cheek a second time. A soft kiss, a gentle warmth against his skin, and the fingers now gracing the top of Izuku's thighs were encouragement enough for him to let his lips graze lower, lips parting as he tasted the sweetness of Kacchan's jawline. Kacchan himself seemed frozen in place, entirely unable to move, and Izuku would have doubted the entire thing were it not for the trembling beneath him. He kissed him again, soft sucks and kitten licks as he worked his way across Kacchan's jawline and marvelling again in just how warm he was. How being this close to Kacchan felt like slipping into a scolding bath after a long day, like walking into a cloud of heady smoke and letting yourself be overwhelmed by it. He was intoxicating. He felt like ...

Why did he feel like home?

He wasn't even aware that he was crying until Kacchan was cupping his cheek and gently pulling them apart, half lidded eyes looking at him in concern.

"I'm sorry," Izuku breathed, sniffing. "Ugh, sorry I dunno why I'm crying this is stupid."

He raised a hand to wipe away the tears on his cheeks only for Kacchan to catch it and hold him back.

"It's not stupid," Kacchan said, before his thumbs swept across Izuku's cheeks, brushing the tears away himself.

Izuku swallowed, not sure if he had ruined the moment or if somehow this was better ... this Kacchan looking back at him, sweet and soft and safe. And then Kacchan's arms were wrapping around him, drawing him close, allowing Izuku to bury his face into the crook of his neck as a large hand cupped the back of his head.

"I know I said I'd wait until you made the first move," Kacchan mumbled into his shoulder, "but ... Deku there's ... *so much* to think about. To wrap my damn head around I-" Kacchan seemed to shudder beneath him. "Shit, I want to. You have no damn idea how much I want to but ... fuck, gimme some time? Just ... lemme figure this shit out."

He sounded so raw, so confused, that Izuku wished he could take it all away. He wished more than anything in the world he could kiss away the pain Kacchan felt, hell the pain they both felt. He took a deep breath, the sweet, sweaty, smoky scent of Kacchan now his favourite thing in the damn world.

"I'm not going anywhere, Kacchan."

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 23: Give me an Outbreak

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Kacchan chance a trip into the hospital ...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku woke to that same all-encompassing warmth he had done the previous morning, coming to the realisation far sooner this time that Kacchan's arms were tightly wrapped around him. He supposed one of them should have really stayed on watch, but they were still alive, nothing had decided to snack on them during the night, and he could afford a few moments to enjoy this for what it was.

He took a deep breath, burrowing his face deeper into Kacchan's hoody, the scent of the man strong even through the fabric, and he felt Kacchan's fingers tighten in their grip on the small of his back in response.

"So fuckin' clingy."

Izuku let the smile warm him face.

"Hmm, you're the one with your arms around me," he said.

"Only so you wouldn't roll of the damn sofa."

"Sure, ok."

They lay there for a few minutes longer, safe in their little cocoon, before Izuku felt Kacchan shift beneath him, his arms loosening their grip around his body as he sat up. He considered, for a moment, grabbing hold and pulling Kacchan back down on top of him, to get him to stay there a little longer, but Kacchan was already too far from him and he let out a sleepy yawn instead, sitting up.

"We should take a look at your eye," Kacchan said, already straight to business and dragging the backpack towards him, and Izuku couldn't stop his damn smiling. Sure, last night might have taken a turn he hadn't exactly planned for, and as far as he aware this didn't make them a couple, *boyfriends*, but they were still ... something. He at least knew where he stood around Kacchan now, knew that he probably did feel the same way. The only thing really holding them back was the delicate nature of Kacchan's *'condition'*, and maybe that was something that Kacchan would, one day, be willing to work with.

Kacchan's hair was getting long now, even if it didn't grow at the ridiculous rate that Izuku's did, which was now pretty much permanently pulled back into a bun so that his already crappy vision wasn't made any worse. If Izuku had wondered whether Kacchan had deliberately styled his hair into that weird spiky style he'd had when they met, he certainly didn't need to wonder now; the

back of his blonde hair stood up in every which direction, one side sitting oddly flat to his face from where he had been sleeping on his side and it had yet to spring back into it's regular ashy explosion. He watched with a warm fuzzy feeling in his chest as Kacchan blew irritably at the bangs now hanging into his eyes.

"We don't need to," Izuku replied. Kacchan looked over at him, eyebrow quirked in confusion.

"Hah?"

"Well, if it's any worse we can't do anything about it right now," Izuku reasoned. "And if it's better I still need to keep it covered until at least the blood drains. There's no point wasting the bandaging."

Kacchan scowled, puffing at his bangs again.

"We can find more bandages."

"It's fine, Kacchan. Honestly, there's no need to look at it again just yet."

Kacchan grunted in a manner that indicated that he definitely disagreed, but he didn't push the point, just zipping up the pack again in a decidedly disgruntled way.

"Do you know if there's a vet or pharmacy near here?"

Kacchan shook his head.

"Not a damn clue, I don't really know the area. We're gonna have to look the old fashioned way."

"Great," Izuku sighed.

There was no denying, they were much more accomplished in the art of zombie kills these days, but it was still a risk that they sure as hell would rather not need to take; that it would also put them back in their mission to finally get to Shizouka to find their friends was something else that sat poorly with the both of them.

"Lets eat, then get going," Kacchan said. "Sooner we're on the move the better."

Fifteen minutes later they were stepping out onto the street once more, the low morning light casting a beautiful red hue to the streets that contrasted grotesquely with the dessicated corpses that littered it, hinting at the blood that had once flooded the sleepy town.

"It's mostly tourist shit up this way," Kacchan said. "We'll probably need to go deeper into the district to find what we're looking for. Keep your eyes peeled, it looks quiet but that don't mean shit."

"I got it," Izuku replied, rolling his eyes with a smirk and causing Kacchan to only pout at him further and flip him the bird before he started to walk. Izuku, still goddamn giddy with the thrill that had come with waking up in Kacchan's arms a second time, just laughed. So, they weren't ... together. Not *officially*, right. But he still felt like a damn school boy with his first crush and ... *hell, how did he let that happen?* How'd he let that grubby, angry blonde do this to his damn heart in the first place? And sure, he might still only be twenty, but he felt a hell of a lot older than that these days. It felt silly for him to be feeling this excited buzzing in his chest, to feel the giggles and smiles threaten to explode out of him each time their eyes met. It was damn distracting, is what it was.

They continued through the edge of the city, stopping at a tourist information spot to find a map, before realising that not too far from the waterfall itself, there was a whole damn hospital. The place had almost certainly been looted by now, Kacchan reasoned, frowning down at the map, but a hospital was a hell of a lot bigger than any pharmacy or veterinary surgery they'd come across, and surely they were far more likely to find what they were looking for there.

"It's a big building to in to without knowing the layout," Izuku muttered, as they examined the map. "And I know it was a long time ago that the hospital was in use but ... there were probably a lot of people turning there at the start."

"Probably why this part of the city is such a mess," Kacchan said, glancing up from the map and back towards where they had stayed the night before. "They probably had no way of containing any of it, zombies coming from the hospital, killing everyone here who weren't quick enough."

Izuku tried hard not to imagine what that must have looked like ... *felt* like. Fuck, *sounded* like. It was then that it dawned on him that, as bad as it was out here, it was likely to be even worse once they stepped foot inside the hospital.

"Have you had any more of that vodka?" he asked, and Kacchan tensed, not meeting his eyes.

"No."

"*Kacchan*," Izuku sighed, before he stepped forward and reached out for Kacchan's forehead. The man ducked out of his reach, glaring. "Come on, you know you need to! If we're going in there you can't be dealing with withdrawal, we have no idea what we're going to find!"

"I feel fi-"

"I swear to god, Kacchan, if you tell me one more than that you *feel fine* I'm going to be the one to kick your ass this time!" Izuku snapped, taking both of them by surprise. It wasn't like this was the first time he'd lost his temper with him, but he'd sure as hell never sounded quite so much *like* Kacchan before.

"You wanna try that again?" Kacchan growled, far from intimidated.

"Just drink it," Izuku huffed, reaching into his backpack and slapping the bottle into Kacchan's hand. "Half now-"

"Yeh yeh yeh, fuck," Kacchan snarled, twisting the lid off and tipping his head back, furious red eyes not leaving Izuku's once as he gulped down half the liquid. "Fucking happy now?"

Izuku rolled his eyes, before he started to head back the way they'd come, not waiting for Kacchan to say anything else on the matter.

The hospital itself wasn't a huge one. It looked more like one of those small private affairs, the kind that only took in very specific patients, but it was still large enough to make Izuku uneasy. He hadn't stepped foot in a hospital since long before the world ended. Truthfully, he hated the damn places, reminding him way too much of things that he'd rather forget; the long endless hallways overwhelming, the smell of disinfectant and sick people making his stomach churn and the anxiety spread. He was not good in hospitals even when there hadn't been the risk of the dead waiting behind every corner, or laying in every bed. And as much as he knew that time was of the essence

when it came to preserving his sight, a huge part of him was now doubting if it was worth the damn cost.

Kacchan, for all his gruffness, didn't miss Izuku's growing hesitation as they got closer to hospital, and he stopped.

"What is it?"

Izuku hesitated. He didn't really want to get into a discussion about why he hated hospitals, why the places freaked him out so much, certainly not now.

"I've just seen enough zombie movies to know that nothing good comes out of going into a hospital," he said, and Kacchan laughed, shaking his head as if the whole thing had been a joke.

"I'm serious!" Izuku pressed.

"Yeh, I know you are," Kacchan replied. "I just find it fucking hilarious that you're talking about zombies movies as if you ain't been living through the zombie apocalypse the last two fucking years."

"Well, two years of living in the zombie apocalypse tells me this is a bad idea too," Izuku huffed, and Kacchan shrugged.

"Course it fucking is, but you need those damn drops. We'll take it slow, alright. Be fucking cautious."

Izuku sighed. "Look, this was kinda my thing, back with my group," he said. "This is what I was good at, getting in and out without being seen. So, if we're doing this, then we're going to do it my way."

Kacchan raised an eyebrow, lips quirking almost as if it had been a damn challenge.

"Oh yeh? Well, come on then. Tell me how the great Izuku Midoriya would handle this any fucking differently than I would."

Izuku tried not to think too hard about how his real name in Kacchan's gravelly tones made his toes curl.

"We scope escape routes first," he replied. "We gotta know where they are and where they lead, anything locked we see if we can unlock. Anything blocked needs to be unblocked. I'm not going in there unless we know of at least two other ways we can get out of there in a hurry if we need to."

"Alright, what else?"

"It's a hospital, which means there'll be a map in the foyer," Izuku continued. "Most hospitals have their own inbuilt pharmacy, and if it doesn't then there will at least be a place where all the medication is kept and distributed from. We'll plot a course there and a way out before we go any further into the hospital."

"No, duh."

"And if we get in there and there looks to be too many zombies, we bail. No arguments."

"I don't see how any of this is any different from how I would'a handled it, but sure nerd. We'll do this your way."

"Ok," Izuku said, with some relief. "Let's scope the perimeter first for exits."

Fortunately, a place such as a hospital, was already fitted with emergency exits and an alternative entry points for staff and A&E patients. If anything, there were so many possible ways for them to make an escape if they needed to, that Izuku was doubting whether he would he able to remember all of them. The upside was that besides one door that they couldn't get open, everything was already unlocked or wide open; after all, there would have been people fleeing the hospital on mass at the very worst of it all, and there were enough mummified corpses in the hospital grounds to make it clear that not everyone had gotten away quickly enough. Izuku couldn't help but wonder over how terrifying it must have been ... so many people all at once ...

Once content, Izuku led them back to the front of the building, swallowing back the rising anxiety in his chest as he looked at those wide double doors, and the dark foyer beyond.

"So, we gonna do this?" Kacchan asked, and Izuku nodded, taking a deep breath. Cautiously, they pushed the doors open.

Were it not for the corpses that lay inside, the foyer would have been entirely empty. Izuku could see bodies pressed against the walls, crumpled beneath chairs, dark brown blood streaks across the floor, and it was clear that something truly awful had happened here. Izuku knew that it sometimes took a couple days for people to turn after being bitten and infection, which meant to account for the sheer number of deaths here, the hospital must have still been trying to treat the infected, rather than turning them away or, as was happening by the end of it, killing them. They had still been taking in infected, trying to save their lives, and hell knows how many of them must have been here ... a whole damn army of the infected waiting to turn. The staff, other patients, they wouldn't have stood a chance one the infected started to turn. His stomach churned at the thought, eyes drawn to a tiny legless skeleton crawled beneath a table in the waiting area.

"Sweet."

Izuku started, looking around to see Kacchan walking forward with purpose, grabbing the small bowl of wrapped yellow candies on the reception desk, before pulling his pack around and pouring the entire contents into the front pocket. Izuku watched as he unwrapped one and popped it into his mouth, before offering one to him.

"Want one?"

Izuku shook his head, and Kacchan shrugged.

"Suit yourself. Let's look for that map then, yeh?"

Izuku wasn't sure if perhaps these things just didn't affect Kacchan any more, not in the same way that they did him. Or maybe Kacchan had an entirely different way of handling things like this, not even sparing the bodies a second glance as he looked around the foyer.

"There," Kacchan pointed, before he frowned. "Oi, earth to Deku, you paying attention or what?"

Izuku nodded, following after him and wincing at the loud crunch as Kacchan cracked the candy in two with his teeth. Damn, he was so much more on edge than he thought he had been ... and of

course it was good to be aware of what was going on around him, but it wasn't good to be jumpy and skittish. He needed to get a grip.

He mentally shook himself, taking a deep breath as he stood beside Kacchan and took in the map of the hospital. The layout was, as seemed unanimous with all hospitals, confusing as fuck. There were multiple wings for different departments, each colour coded to make things as easy as possible for the guests, but the many winding corridors and rooms, the large blocks of waiting areas in each wing, made for little less than a damn maze. At least the fire exists were marked ...

"Pharmacy's there," Kacchan said, pressing a finger to the plastic. His fingernails were filthy, dirt tracked beneath them, the edges of the nails far from smooth, almost like he had been chewing at them. Odd, he didn't think he'd ever seen Kacchan once bit his nails ...

"Oi." Fingers snapped in front of him, and he looked up to see Kacchan leaning close, brow furrowed as he look at him. "You keep spacing out."

"Sorry," Izuku muttered, turning his attention back to the map.

"Nah, talk to me, Deku. What's going on in that head of yours?"

"Nothing, really," Izuku replied. "I'm just ... nervous. It's fine, I'm ok." He needed to get a hold of himself. "Ok, pharmacy is close, that's good. Figured it wouldn't have been far from the reception. It looks like we can just go up the stairs and cut through the waiting area. We can be in and out in five minutes."

"Easy," Kacchan muttered, still watching him carefully with narrowed eyes.

"And if the pharmacy is cleared out, um ... looks like there's an optometry department two floors up from that." He eyes tracked along the coloured corridors, looking for the nearest exit. "Even if we can't cut back the way we came for any reason, it should still be a quick trip. We can go through the blue zone, past phlebotomy, and down those stairs."

Kacchan nodded, adjusting his pack. "Let's get on with it, then."

He didn't miss the less than subtle way that Kacchan immediately took the lead, leaving him with a mingled sense of shame and irritation. This had been *his* call ... he ought to be the one taking the damn lead, not following behind Kacchan like he needed protecting, like he had no idea what he was doing. But there was no sense in arguing with Kacchan about it, not when he truly did trust the man implicitly by this stage. If Kacchan was taking the lead, then there was a damn reason for it, and it was on him, now, to get his head back into shape before he made some stupid mistake.

He followed Kacchan up the slight of stairs, their footfalls echoing across the foyer, kicking dust up from the ground with each and every step. By all appearances, nothing had so much as moved in this place for a very long time; the smell was the musty scent of aging decay, a smell that once upon a time Izuku couldn't have even imagined, much less one that he had become so familiar with that he could place it in an instant. It certainly didn't smell like a hospital any more, death so strong in the air he could practically taste it, but that growing sense of dread that swelled with each and every step further into the depths remained the same. Each shaky breath fuelling the stuttering thuds of his heart.

"Hold up," Kacchan said, holding an arm out, and Izuku stopped dead, trying to ignore the wild hammering in his chest. The hallway ahead of them was dark, the fluorescent lighting having long

ago died, along with everything else here. There was just enough light filtering in from the foyer, and through open doors, for them to see where they were going.

"Oi, we still got that torch?" Kacchan asked.

"Yeh," Izuku replied, before pulling his pack around and starting to dig through it. "I don't know how good the batteries are, though."

"They don't need to last long," Kacchan replied, taking it from him as he held it out. He pressed his thumb against the switch, a bright but narrow beam filled the hallway ahead of them.

"Clear. Come on."

The hallways were, if possible, even worse than the foyer below. Old brown blood staining the walls and floors, bodies spread eagled on the ground or in piles against the doors ... they really hadn't stood a chance once the dead broke free. Each step over a bundle of bones sent shivers down Izuku's spine.

"The pharmacy is just on our left here," he said, tapping Kacchan's shoulder. Kacchan nodded, taking a wide step over two corpses and into the waiting area.

Izuku's heart dropped when the pharmacy came into view. The door was wide open, the small window at the front completely smashed where someone had broken through. It was still possible that it had happened right back at the start and the stocks weren't completely done, but the drag marks covered with a finer layer of dust than the rest didn't exactly fill him with confidence.

"Shit," Kacchan sighed, walking boldly towards the pharmacy. "Guess it was a lot to hope no one had found this before us. Still, who the fuck is gonna want eyes drops?"

"Let's just see what we can find," Izuku said.

As it happened, whoever had come here before them had all but cleared the shelves of anything even vaguely antibiotic or medicated. Izuku huffed tiredly as he and Kacchan pulled out drawers, only succeeding in blowing yet more dust in their faces, as they came up empty.

"Oi," Kacchan said, holding up a small bottle, a vaguely hopeful look on his face. Izuku leaned closer, peering at the bottle with his single good eye, before shaking his head.

"Nah, that's pretty much just saline," he sighed. With a grunt, Kacchan threw it over his shoulder.

"Who the fuck would need fucking eye drops?" he growled.

"They're still anti-inflammatories," Izuku replied. "Whoever cleared this place out knew what they were looking for ... Hell, maybe they got allergies or something, I don't know ..."

"We still go the eye department to try," Kacchan said.

"Yeh ..." Izuku swallowed, taking a step back out into the waiting area and looking around. "But it's still two more floors up, it's risky."

"What's fucking *risky* is if you end up half blind," Kacchan snapped, glaring at him. "Look, I'm guessing you got some kind of deep rooted anxiety around hospitals or something."

"That's not-"

"But so far the place has been empty," Kacchan interrupted. "We've got more to lose by going back, so lets get to the eye department and find you those fucking drops and we can get out of here."

Izuku hesitated for a moment longer, Kacchan staring at him expectantly, before he conceded, nodding his head.

"Good." Kacchan clapped him on the shoulder. "'Sides, you got me with you, the hell do you think is gonna happen?"

"*Please don't say stuff like that*!" Izuku whispered frantically, looking around him as if expecting zombies to spill out of the damn walls at Kacchan's words. "Did you want any horror movies growing up? Saying stuff like that is bad luck!"

"I've never cared for horror nor fucking superstition, Deku," Kacchan shot back, rolling his eyes. "Come on, already."

Izuku sure as hell didn't feel any more reassured, and he cast one last look around the waiting area before he spotted something that had him stop in his tracks.

"Kacchan."

"*What now?*"

"Look."

Kacchan looked at where Izuku was pointing, where something dark was slumped against a wall. At first glance, it looked like every other body in the hospital, that was until you noticed the scuff marks in the dust around it, the way the hand, though definitely in the later stages of decomposition, still looked altogether too fleshy. He and Kacchan approached, each of them pulling their weapons free, and raising their hands to their faces as the smell hit them.

"Shit," Kacchan hissed, as they looked down at the corpse. Forensic pathology was Izuku's bag, he'd already studied decomposition, and knew that in an environment like this it would be hard to guess exactly how old a corpse was, but looking down at it, it was perfectly clear that this person had died long after the the rest of the corpses they'd walked past. Whoever this person was, hadn't died quietly, the state of the corpse, the way that half of their skull was missing, all left Izuku's close to shaking on the spot.

"Oi, your the fucking forensic whatever it is," Kacchan said, his voice notably hoarse. "How long ago do you think this happened?"

"I don't ..." Izuku coughed, grimacing as he leaned closer. "It's hard to say for sure but ... I dunno, a couple months? It's not *recent* recent."

"Looks like it was more than one zombie too," Kacchan muttered, now looking up and down the corridors. "To have ... you know, pulled them apart like that."

"Kacchan, we should go," Izuku hissed, lowering his voice. "There was obviously still zombies here when this happened."

But Kacchan shook his head.

"We don't have far to go, Deku," he replied. "And this guy was on his own."

"We don't know that."

"Deku, I know you're freaked out and all but we need the damn drops. The way back behind is clear, we seen any, we fuck off out of here. Alright?"

Izuku shook his head, but he didn't fight Kacchan on the matter.

"Stairs, let's go."

Izuku dragged his eyes away from the body and followed Kacchan back towards the foyer, the two of them now even more aware of everything that was going on around them, and trying not to make a damn sound as they crossed back down the corridor. The access for the staircase to the rest of the hospital behind yet another set of wide swinging doors, and Kacchan paused to check their blind spots before starting to climb. It was just two flights of stairs, certainly not far to go, but delving deeper into the hospital, especially after finding the body, only came with heightened dread, especially as the doors swung shut behind them, leaving them entirely incapable of keeping an eye on anything that might choose to follow. Even Kacchan seemed less confident in his steps now as he lead them upstairs, eyes darting about and hands gripping both weapon and torch. If the echo of their footsteps had been loud in the foyer, then they were damn dear deafning here, anything with range would be able to hear them, no question of it.

"Alright, second floor," Kacchan said, pointing to the door, before a sound cut him off, causing them both to freeze. It was subtle, but the echoes clearly brought to their attention the sound of something banging, a light thud, followed by a clattering from below them. Kacchan thrust the torch into Izuku's hand, holding his pipe warhammer out in front of him as he walked to the edge of the staircase, peering over the glass banister to look down.

"Anything?" Izuku whispered, and Kacchan just shook his head, leaning far enough over the banister that Izuku considered grabbing him and yanking him back.

"Nah. Could have been a rat or something," he muttered, though sounding less than sure of that, and looking back over his shoulder at him. "But keep your eyes peeled, Deku, too many places for these things to fucking crawl out fro- *fuck!*"

It took Izuku a moment to work out what the hell had happened. One moment, Kacchan was there, and the next something big and dark seemed to fall from the damn ceiling, and Kacchan was gone with a shocked cry. He sprinted forward, throwing himself over the balcony as he heard the sickening crunch, looking down to see the tangle of limbs landing on the ground two floors below him.

"Kacchan!"

For an insane moment, he debated just jumping over the banister himself, before he was taking the stairs three and four at a time, his heart racing, watching the chaos below as the zombie thrashed, Kacchan still on his back on top of the damn thing.

"*Motherfucker*!" Kacchan snarled, Izuku skidding across the lino floor. Kacchan had his elbow buried in the zombies throat, holding the gnashing teeth at bay, kicking his heels back as mutilated hands grabbed hold of his hoody and continued to pull him backwards, preventing Kacchan from getting to his feet.

"Hold on!" Izuku cried, volting off the side of the last half of the staircase, before he watched in horror as the zombie pushed forward, Kacchan's elbow disappearing almost entirely in it's throat, indifferent to it and the hood covering half it's face and biting down on the soft muscle above Kacchan's shoulder.

"No!" Izuku hadn't even readied his weapon in his haste to get to Kacchan, and all he could think to do was throw himself to his knees beside them and grab the things head, yanking back hard. Kacchan swore again as the zombies jaw was torn away from him, before he pulled an arm free and thrust the end of his hammer into one of it's eye sockets.

"Fuck!" Kacchan pushed himself up, hand scrabbling a the zombie's twitching arms as he thought to break free of it's grasp. "Fucking thing fucking jumped me!"

Izuku was panting, sweat dripping down his temple, wide eyes indifferent to the zombie now focused entirely on Kacchan.

"It ... did it?!" he cried, panicking.

Kacchan pulled back the neck of his now torn hoody, trying to look down at this own neck before Izuku was at his side. The damn thing had done it's best, and there was a ring of red marks where it had bitten down, and bitten down hard, but by some mad twist of luck it hadn't been able to bite all the way through the thick layers of the hoody, and break the skin.

"Fucker left it's damn teeth in me," Kacchan hissed, picking out the teeth still embedded in the fabric. Izuku continued to pant, his hands shaking so badly that he had to clasp them together.

"That was too close," he breathed, starting to pace. "*That was too close!*"

"We've had plenty of near misses in the past, Deku, get a hold of yourself," Kacchan said, getting to his feet. "We're fucking fine, alright?"

"That's not the *point*, Kacchan!" Izuku whispered furiously. "I said this was a bad idea! I told you!"

"News flash, *nothing's* a good idea these days," Kacchan snapped back, before he inexplicably pocketed the teeth he'd plucked from his hoody. "You need to get your damn head on straight, Deku, and think clearly! The fuck's changed, hah? You've never been this fucking jumpy before."

"Because I don't want to lose you too!" Izuku practically whined, hands going to his hair, unable to stop the shaking. And the irritation immediately fell from Kacchan's face, leaving an open honest shock.

"Deku-"

There was another thud, and the two of them looked up, seeing yet another zombie pressed precariously against the glass three floors above them.

"Come on."

A rough hand wrapped around Izuku's wrist, dragging him back towards the stairs.

"Kacchan, we should get back-"

"We're getting you these fucking drops, Deku!" Kacchan interrupted. "And if you bitch one more goddamn time you'll never have to worry about losing me again coz I'll fucking skin you and wear you like a fucking keychain!"

"Wha- *what?*"

He let out a loud squeak as Kacchan yanked him forward, ignoring the second zombie falling from the floors above them and hitting the ground with a *squelch*, before he shoved back the doors of the floor to optometry.

"Alright, Rain Man, where the fuck now?"

"Uh, down this corridor, a right then second left."

Without another word, Kacchan snatched his wrist again, and Izuku was lead down the corridor, taking a sharp turn right and through another set of double doors.

"They might have treated people on site," Izuku panted, feet stumbling as he fought to keep up with Kacchan. "We'll check the consultation rooms first."

"You fuckin' got it."

But what Izuku really had *got*, it seemed, was just a whole lot more trouble.

They had made too much damn noise. This was supposed to be a quiet mission ... in and out, quick and easy, but there wasn't a damn thing quiet about Bakugou Katsuki, not a damn thing easy about the Apocalypse, and when they took that second left, torch bouncing a beam in front of them, it was the find a sold heaving mass blocking the very end of the corridor. Bodies pressed together, almost as if they were fucking penguins in a snow storm, shuffling and scraping against the wall.

"Holy fuck," Kacchan breathed, letting go of Izuku's wrist and taking an uncertain step forward.

It was impossible to tell just how many of them there was, with their bodies pressed so tightly together, none of them yet facing them. Izuku noticed Kacchan's weapon moving at his side, and it was his turn to grab at him, pulling back.

"No," his whispered. "There's obviously a lot of them in there, we can't even kill them, that might just bring more."

"Motherdick," Kacchan growled, looking back over their shoulder.

"I don't think they've spotted us yet-"

"Nah, but they have."

Izuku swung around to where Kacchan was now looking, seeing yet more zombies coming up from behind them, the only thing slowing down their pace behind the guts dragging on the ground, and the zombie at their head that stopped. Her long hair hung down, almost entirely obscuring her face and the stained fabric of her dress, but it did not completely hide her eyes, bloodshot yet still, very clearly, focused on Kacchan.

"Is it another one?" Izuku breathed, and then the eyes flicked towards him for a moment, a tongue darting out to lick her teeth that lay bare to the world under her torn upper lip, the skin ripped

almost entirely up to the cheek.

"In here," Kacchan hissed, pushing open the door to the first consultation room to their right and shoving Izuku inside.

"It's another one!" Izuku said, rounding on Kacchan as he slammed the door shut and flicked the lock. "It's another one of the smarter zombies!"

"Yeh, I fucking saw, Deku!"

There was a bang, making them both jump when the first body slammed up against the door, it's gribbly silhouette visible through the frosted glass.

"Block the door!"

Izuku grabbed the heavy chair in front of the fancy writing desk in the middle of the room and dragged it towards the door, Kacchan helping him to prop it beneath the handle, just as the door shook again with the weight of a second, then a third, zombie throwing themselves against it.

"This is a disaster!" Izuku cried, heart hammering.

"Not yet it ain't," Kacchan replied, as he hurried back to the desk and started to rummage through the drawers.

"Are you kidding? We're trapped in here!" Izuku snapped, the last hold he had on his tempter snapping. "That was the *one fucking thing* we had to avoid! Now we're trapped in here with one of them out there! We should have gone back down the damn stairs!"

But then Kacchan stood straight, a triumphant grin on his face as he held a bottle up in the air.

"Gotcha!"

"Oh great," Izuku said sourly. "At least now I'll be able to fucking *see* the zombies when they eat me!"

"Stop being so damn dramatic all the time!" Kacchan yelled, storming over and slapping the bottle against Izuku's chest. "I got you your damn drops, didn't I? And I'll get us out of this damn room! Would it fucking kill you to trust me for once?"

Izuku's breath hitched.

"I-" he took the bottle, looking down at the drops in his hand. "What the hell does that even mean? Kacchan, I trust you with my life, you know that!"

Kacchan averted his gaze, glaring at the door as the zombies continued to slam their hands and bodies against it. "Well, *you* can't be trust with it," he muttered, though his cheeks were definitely tinted pink. Izuku's shoulders slumped, and he reached up a hand to rub at the temple of his aching hand.

"Ok, how do we get out of this?"

Kacchan took a step back, looking around the room.

"The window looks big enough for us to get through," he said, walking over and pulling back the locks. He hoisted the large pane upwards with a grunt, the wood having obviously swollen and getting stuck, before he peered out. With another uncertain glance towards the door, Izuku wandered up beside him, only to look down at the ground three damn stories below him.

"After you," Izuku said dryly, only for Kacchan to throw him another glare.

"You sassy asshole, I've got rope! We can just climb down."

Izuku blinked, looking from Kacchan to the concrete below, the thought doing very little for his anxiety over the shitty situation they'd found themselves in.

"That's uh ... seems a long way to climb."

"Hardly. What, you never been mountain climbing before?" Kacchan scoffed.

"No!"

"It's easy, just ease yourself down the rope a little at a time."

"Kacchan, I've only got one good arm," Izuku protested.

"Then I'll tie the end to your damn waist and lower you down."

A small whine left Izuku's throat, before the thudding at the door started to build up, and he realised they didn't really have much choice in the matter.

"Fine," he huffed. "But we are never going into a hospital again."

"Stop getting yourself beat up, Deku, and we won't have to."

"Why are you such an asshole?"

But Kacchan was laughing again, pulling the rope from his pack.

"I gotta find something to tie this on to," he said, holding one end of the rope and looking about, before he spotted the radiator against the wall.

"Will that hold?" Izuku asked, and Kacchan glared.

"You fucking doubting my knotting skills now, bitch?"

"I meant the radiator!"

"Well, it sure as shit weighs more than your scrawny ass," Kacchan scoffed, as the tightened the knot around the pipe secured to the wall.

"And you?"

"I dunno, how much to Greek Gods weigh these days?"

"Oh my god."

"Yeh?"

"*Stop it!*"

"Arms up."

"Wh- *why?*"

"Because I got to tie the other end around your waist, Deku!"

"O-oh."

Kacchan snorted again, Izuku blushing as he raised his arms up and the rope was wrapped around him, Kacchan's big arms warming Izuku's entire damn body for a moment before he started to tie a complicated looking knot, yanking on it to test it was secure.

"There. Alright, over you go, Rapunzel."

"Have you ever thought about just calling me by my name?" Izuku sighed, as the tentatively climbed onto the window frame.

"Don't make me drop you."

But then, just as Izuku was about to ease himself out over the edge, Kacchan seemed to stiffen, looking back at the door.

"What? What is it?"

Kacchan didn't respond, but it only took Izuku a moment to realise what had changed. The banging had stopped. Gone were the bodies obscuring the frosted glass, instead a single figure could be seen, silhouetted in the gloom. Not sure what the hell was going to happen next, Izuku hooked his legs back into the room, gripping hold of the window frame.

"She's going to try and open to door," he breathed. And sure enough, the handle began to turn. But this zombie, whoever she damn was, wasn't strong enough to force the door open, not through the lock and the chair keeping it propped shut, and Izuku breathed out a sign of relief.

"She can't do it."

But Kacchan still hadn't moved, and Izuku grew aware of suddenly just how heavy the man's breathing had become. He looked up to see Kacchan's eyes fixed on the door, his chest heaving.

"Kacchan?"

"Open the door."

Izuku froze, his bloody running cold. The voice came from behind the door, high and cracked from misuse, the zombie's silhouette standing firm.

"Open the door."

"Come on, let's just go," Izuku breathed, grabbing Kacchan's arm and tugging, but Kacchan didn't move. "Kacchan, come on!"

"Open the door."

And then Kacchan started to walk, away from the window, and towards the door, face entirely blank.

"Kacchan!"

"Ka-chan open the door."

Izuku threw himself in front of him, hands pressed against Kacchan's chest to hold him back, but Kacchan seemed entirely indifferent to his efforts, and was far too strong, just pushing him back. Not knowing what else to do, felling altogether too panicked to think of any more reasonable a plan, he reached a hand back, and slapped Kacchan as hard as he could around the face, the sound ringing through the room.

"Kacchan!"

Kacchan started, blinking, hand raised to his face and looking down at where Izuku was pushing against him.

"What the fuck are you doing?"

"What am *I* doing?" Izuku cried, before the sound of an angry scream came from behind the door, the zombie behind now slamming her fists against the class in a fit of rage.

"We gotta go!"

"Yeh *I know,* I told you got climb out the damn window! The fuck you hitting me for, dickbag?"

Izuku swallowed. Kacchan looks confused, and pissed off, and seemingly entirely unaware of what had just happened, but there was no time to unpack that right then, and the urgency was made even more clear when, with another loud scream, the zombie slammed her fists against the glass once more and a large crack appeared.

"I got the damn rope, just climb down, Deku!"

With just a slight moment of hesitation, Izuku climbed over the frame again, the rope around his waist immediately cutting painfully into his back as he let himself drop down the wall, feet pressed firmly against the rough brick surface, hands clinging desperately to the rope itself. He could hear more banging and shattering from inside the room.

"Alright, walk your way down, I'll hold you steady," Kacchan breathed, as he braced one foot on the windowsill, arms flexing as he gripped hold of the rope. Izuku nodded, swallowing, and started to walk his way down the wall as quickly as he dared, Kacchan easing more and more of the rope free as he went, eyes darting back over his shoulder to check the progress of the zombies efforts to clamber into the room.

Izuku clumsily made his way to the bottom, feet touching the ground and breathing out a sigh of relief at the contact, before he looked back up to see Kacchan already started to climb over the frame.

"Untie the damn rope, Deku!" Kacchan yelled, and with fumbling fingers Izuku hurried to untie the rope around his waist, feeling it tug gently as Kacchan put pressure on the other side. He eventually

got it lose, calling up to Kacchan, who used that moment to kick off from the wall, and slide down the rope, clearing the wall in a matter of moments.

"You better still have those damn drops, Deku," he breathed, and Izuku touched the bottle in his pocket, nodding. "Good, let's get the fuck out of here."

"Kacchan!"

Izuku grabbed at the man, and *god they really couldn't get a damn break, could they?* There were zombies already spilling out of one of the exits, and with another glance, there were yet more all but sprinting across the carpark to the hospital in their urgency to get to them.

"Fuck me!"

"Back to the street," Izuku yelled, "we need to get back on the rooftops or something!"

"Fucking zombie fucks," Kacchan growled, but he didn't disagree, and the two of them took off just as the first zombie fell from the window, it's leg getting tangled in the rope in the process.

They raced around the front of the hospital, the zombies chasing after them, the horde seeming to grow bigger and bigger as yet more of them spilled from the exits, and it became apparent very quickly that they had got themselves stuck in a pretty terrible situation. The zombies, at least, seemed to be only coming from the hospital, the street ahead of them looking empty, and their feet pounded the pavement, breath coming in sharp pants.

"How are there so fucking many of them?" Kacchan yelled. And Izuku looked back over his shoulder, a startled yelp leaving his lips as he saw three of them break free of the pack, sprinting at them in full pelt.

"Fresh ones!" he called, and Kacchan glanced back, pulling his weapon free.

And fuck, they were fresh, they could have passed as living were it not for the missing arms and guts falling lose. It had been so long since Izuku had met fresh zombies that he had almost forgotten just how much faster they were than the rest of them, and if they weren't careful there was every chance that they might even fucking catch up with them. He might have forgotten how fast they were, but he sure as hell hadn't forgotten how violent.

"Keep going!" Kacchan yelled, as they skidded around a corner, the wide open street ahead of them. None of the buildings here were very tall, and none of them looked secure, just little shops and tourist traps dotted here there and everywhere, and as much as they were used to it, neither of them could outrun the horde forever.

"Which way?" Kacchan said, Izuku realising just then how much Kacchan had come to rely on Izuku's sense of direction, and feeling goddamn terrified at the thought.

"I don't, uh ..." Izuku panted, looking around. "Residential area's that way," he said, pointing right. "We need apartments, something tall!"

"Shit," Kacchan slowed his pace, and Izuku looked around to see that the three zombies that had cut free from the rest of the group were fast on them. "We gotta take these guys out."

Izuku nodded, stopping beside Kacchan and holding we weapon up as the three zombies threw themselves at them. He caught the strong stench of decay as Kacchan swung first, taking out the jaw of one, Izuku ducking low so that he could smash out the kneecaps of another, sending the the thing flying. The third aimed straight at Kacchan, as they all seemed to goddamn do, but Kacchan side stepped without fanfare, his pipe hammer hitting it hard in the back. Izuku jumped forward, bringing his weapon down into the back of it's skull, before he kicked out at the other now dragging itself across the ground on broken legs.

"Ok, keep going," Kacchan said, as the rest of the horde came into view, and they ran off again, Kacchan following Izuku's lead as he zipped them down alleys and towards where he had spotted the residential area on the map. They cut over a small green, feet skidding in the muddied earth, down another pathway, and out onto a road, housing lining it, and Izuku let out a cry of frustration at the quaint little houses in front. Cute, but essentially fucking useless to them.

"They'll bust down the doors of any of these in a second," Kacchan snarled. "Fuck!"

"We either run deeper into the city or back into the woods," Izuku said, running a hand through his hair as they hesitated on the spot, hearing the drumming thuds of the zombies still hammering after them.

"Both pretty shit options, Deku!"

"Hey, *you wanted to go into the fucking hospital!*" Izuku yelled.

"Hey! Hey over here!"

Izuku started, head snapping in the direction of the voice that called out to him. Across the street, standing between two cars, was another person, perhaps not much older than themselves, his messy brown hair standing up in all directions.

"Who the fuck is that?" Kacchan growled.

"Hey!" the man yelled again. "You wanna live or you wanna get eaten by zombies?"

"Let's go," Izuku breathed.

"We ain't just going with some random asshole, Deku!"

"Wait ... holy fuck, *Bakugou*?"

"Hah?!" Kacchan squinted in the man's direction, before the thundering of hundreds of feet grew louder, and Izuku pushed him squarely in the back.

"Let's go!" he yelled, and the two of them took off towards the man still waving at them.

"Quick, down this way!" the man said, turning his back and running.

Izuku and Kacchan pushed their way down the narrow gap between the two houses, round to yet another street as they cleared the gardens, sprinting past another row of houses, before the man stopped, reaching down to a heavy metal manhole.

"Oh great," Kacchan said sourly, coming to a halt, and Izuku swallowed. They'd settled for a lot during the Apocalypse, but they had yet to find themselves resorted to hiding in the damn sewers,

but the man just laughed, gesturing at the opening with his hand.

"You're still an ungrateful bastard, huh, Bakugou?"

Kacchan's eyes darted up, seeming to take in the person in front of them for the first time, before a growl left his throat.

"*Shindo?* Fuck no. No, I'd rather be fucking eaten."

And Kacchan actually made to walk away, before Izuku snatched at his arm, yanking back.

"Get in the damn hole, Kacchan!" he yelled, incredulous, and Kacchan shot him a glare before throwing his hands in the air.

"You first," he growled at the man, *Shindo*, who raised an eyebrow, before shrugging.

"Suit yourself, but make sure you completely pull the cover into place after you."

"Don't tell me what to do!"

Izuku had no idea what kind of ridiculous feud was going on between Kacchan and this stranger, but he was fast losing patience for it, and as soon as Shindo disappeared down into the tunnel, Izuku pushed Kacchan forward, ignoring his complaints, aware only of the zombies that had already cleared the first alley. He jumped down after Kacchan, reaching up and heaving the metal cover over, filthy hands reaching out to him filling his vision before he was thrown into complete darkness.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 24: Bone To Pick

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Kacchan discover that they're not the only ones trying to survive the Apocalypse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first thing that Izuku noticed after he slid down the metal stepladder, boots hitting something soft and unpleasantly squishy, was that that the sewers really didn't smell any damn worse than the rest of the city these days. The only light came from deep down the tunnel, a light glow that silhouetted the figure of the stranger, Shindo, just in front of him, and on instinct his hand reached out to the warm presence at his side, snatching onto the fabric of Kacchan's hoody to steady himself on the uneasy footing below.

"Everyone here?" Shindo asked. He had an easy sounding voice, far too jovial than anyone had any damn right being considering the situation, and the low growl from Kacchan to his left didn't settle Izuku's might any.

"Yeh," Izuku replied, when Kacchan said nothing. "Uh, thank you. We might have got ourselves into a bit of trouble up there if you hadn't helped us."

"We'd have been fucking fine," Kacchan muttered. "Don't need his damn help."

In the almost complete darkness, Izuku couldn't see the expression on either man's face, though the short scoff coming from Shindo was indication enough that he had definitely heard him.

"Don't mind him," Izuku said, apologetically, "he's just-"

"Oh, I know what he's like," Shindo interrupted, with a laugh. "We know each other pretty well, don't we, Katsuki?"

Katsuki? Izuku wouldn't like to admit that his stomach lurched at that, or that the smirk that he could hear on Shindo's face bothered him. Kacchan said nothing, the sound of grinding teeth the only indication that he had acknowledged Shindo in any way.

"Well, follow me," Shindo said brightly. "We got a camp set up deeper in the tunnels."

"We?" Izuku asked.

"Oh, yeh! What, you think I was just one guy in a sewer?" Shindo asked with a laugh, waving his arm in the air and starting to walk.

"Wouldn't be the weirdest thing we've come across," Izuku replied, honestly. A sharp tug from his left reminded him that he was still holding onto Kacchan, and he let go somewhat regretfully, not

wanting to pull Kacchan over as he fumbled, his arms thrusting outwards as he tried to negotiate his way down the dark and foul tunnel after Shindo.

"Hmm, you got a point there, uh-"

"Midoriya," Izuku offered. "Izuku."

"Midoriya! Name's Shindo Yo," Shindo said, turning on his heel and holding his hand out to him. Izuku almost walked straight into him, half skidding on the soiled ground in his effort not to find the outstretched hand buried somewhere in the region of his gut.

"Uh, nice to meet you," Izuku replied, taking the hand, Shindo gripping back with both of his large palms and shaking enthusiastically.

"Well, Midoriya Izuku," Shindo continued, turning his back again and trudging forward. "We sort of ended up here by accident, myself and a handful of others, after we had to retreat back towards the mountains. We stumbled across this part of the city, then, uh ... well, I won't bore you with the details, but we couldn't leave straight away. And then we saw someone else come through, and another ... Realised pretty quick that we couldn't just up and leave this place, not when people just kept turning up."

"How many people are here?" Izuku asked, eagerly. Kacchan remained silence, his boots stomping heavily through the filth.

"There's almost thirty of us now," Shindo replied. "And truth be told it's getting kinda cramped."

Izuku felt his jaw drop. *Thirty people?* He hadn't seen that many people in one place in over a year, and even back then it had been far from sustainable. He quickened his pace, leaving Kacchan smouldering behind him and steeping in time beside Shindo.

"How do you manage to feed thirty people?" he asked, almost breathless. "Not to mention medicine, clothing ... it's hard enough to get by out here in a small group, let alone one as large as that!"

"It's not easy," Shindo said honestly. "But everyone pulls their weight. Almost there ... hey, I'm gonna need you both to hold here for a moment."

"Why?" Kacchan snapped immediately, speaking for the first time since they'd entered the tunnel. But suddenly a painfully bright light filled the tunnel, Izuku holding his hand up in front of his one good as the heavy beams threatened to blind it. He heard Kacchan swear at his side.

"Sorry about that!" Shindo called. "Probably should have warned you about the lights. Anyway, I gotta check you for bites before we leave the tunnel."

Izuku squinted through the bright lights, obviously from some kind of heavy duty stage lighting or something at the end of the tunnel, installed to light up the place and, no doubt, shock anyone who might accidentally find their way here.

"We ain't bit," Kacchan snarled.

"Yeh, well, you'd be surprised how many people aren't exactly honest about that," Shindo replied. "Arms up."

"Fuck you."

"Kacchan, just do as he says," Izuku muttered, raising his arms, before a sudden terrifying thought occurred to him. Because they *hadn't* been entirely honest ... one of them most certainly had been bit. But he didn't have time to do much about it before Shindo was in front of him, patting him down.

"Mind taking off the hoody?"

Izuku hesitated for a moment, before he yanked it over his head, Shindo throwing it over his shoulder as he started yanking at the arms of his shirt.

"Oh, jeeze, that looks pretty gnarly," he said, and Izuku realised that he was talking about the large burn scar over his left arm.

"Yeh, old injury," Izuku said, before he was sharply turned around, and his top yanked upwards, Shindo checking his back and midriff for any bites. He glanced sideways, his and Kacchan's eyes meeting, knowing that he was sure as hell thinking the same thing from the way his expression had hardened.

"Alright, all good." Shindo dropped his top, before handing the hoody back to him. "Sorry for the manhandling, we had someone sneak in with a bite a few months back, it uh ... let's just say it wasn't pretty."

"Oh, that's ok," Izuku said, before Shindo turned to Kacchan.

"Your turn, Katsuki," and Shindo grinned, his eyes darting up and down the blonde's body in a familiar way that had Izuku feeling very uncomfortable again. "Off with it."

"Fuck you," Kacchan repeated firmly.

"Don't be like that," Shindo said with a small pout. "It'll only take a minute-"

"Get your damn hands off me before I break 'em!" Kacchan slapped Shindo's hand away as he reached out for him. "The zombies up there didn't fuckin' bite me. Believe me, or don't, but you ain't putting your filthy hands on me."

Shindo hesitated, the teasing smile gone, as he eyed Kacchan's body again, though this time in a decidedly more searching way.

"I got twenty eight people living down here, Katsuki," he said, voice low and serious. "I know you're not exactly *familiar* with the concept of giving a shit about others, but I care about their well-being. Their safety. They're my responsibility and if you're putting them in danger by being here-"

"He's not," Izuku said quickly. But even as the words left his lips he was reminded of Kacchan's blank face, the way his body had been drawn towards the door in the hospital when that zombie had called to him and fuck, fuck. He'd never felt more dirty in his whole damn life. But he did have faith in Kacchan, right? He had to at least have that. "We weren't bitten by the zombies up there, you have my word."

"I dunno what you think your word means to me, stranger," Shindo said, dark eyes darting to Izuku for just a moment before he stared back at Kacchan. "But know, if I find out you're lying to me, I won't hesitate to put both of you down. Right in these damn tunnels if I need to. You hear me?"

"We understand," Izuku said, with some relief, holding his hands forward. Kacchan, however, just glared, his lower jaw jutting forward at the challenge.

"One of you does."

Izuku stood with baited breath, looking between the two of them. Kacchan, so cold and so angry, and Shindo, his face firm but his lower lip shaking just a fraction, as if he was holding back something that Izuku in that moment didn't understand.

"Believe me or don't," Kacchan repeated. "I might be a lot of fucking things, but a liar? Think you know far fucking better than that."

And Shindo's face twitched, looking away and back down the tunnel, before he sighed and raised a hand towards someone that Izuku couldn't see through the beams.

"You better not be, Kat," he muttered.

"It's *Bakugou*," Kacchan replied sourly.

Shindo was silent for a moment, before he huffed a dry laugh. "Right. Follow me."

Izuku rubbed his arm, feeling decidedly self conscious as the two men had squared off against one another. And sure, it was a relief that no one had seen the massive goddamn bite on Kacchan's side, but this new level of tension was certainly something he really didn't wanna deal with. He glanced over at Kacchan, but he was staring dead ahead, eyes fixed on the back of Shindo's head and hands curled into furious fists, not offering Izuku anything, and he sighed. He suppose he'd have to bother him for answers later ...

Once they were outside of the tunnel, Izuku still adjusting to the new light levels, he realised that they were being led up yet another step ladder, this one short and bring them up to a mezzanine of sorts, the old sewage system running through the centre of the room and out down another tunnel. The entire thing had almost dried up, something that Izuku was pretty glad of, if he had to be honest, just the trickle of draining rain water making it's way through the tunnels. On the mezzanine stood a woman, her brown eyes narrowed and shrewd, but the most alarming thing perhaps was the gun in her hands, aimed towards the ground though still very much gripped with firm hands.

"Oh, don't worry about that," Shindo said, when he saw both Izuku and Kacchan tense. Guns weren't easy to come by in Japan, ammo even harder still, and Izuku had seen very few of them in the entire two years of the Apocalypse ... not without a dead body attached. Seeing it hit him just how serious Shindo was about protecting this place and he felt the guilt churn.

"It's just backup," Shindo explained. "You know, just in case."

"You ever had to use it?" Izuku asked, in a hushed voice, but Shindo ignored his question and gestured for them to follow him.

"This way."

Izuku chanced a glance in Kacchan's direction, noting the way his eyes lingered on the gun as they walked past the sentry, his entire body tense.

"There's a service station of sorts, or whatever you wanna call it, further up. Doesn't offer anyone much space and privacy, but there's room enough for tents and to separate the sleeping area from where we cook and eat. There's room for you both to stay, too."

"We ain't staying," Kacchan growled. "We're only here until those bastards up there clear off."

Shindo glanced back over his shoulder, chewing his lower lip. "Right ..."

Barely a minute later, they exited the tunnel, stepping out onto another mezzanine that opened up to a large flat area of concrete, a closed off office area to the far left of it, large pipes jutting through the walls, around which a cluster of tents could be seen. The place was lit with lamps, Izuku guess they had to be oil or something going on the gentle flickering, though the light itself wasn't strong enough to penetrate all the way to the top of the high ceiling, giving the place a claustrophobic feeling to it that had Izuku shivering. It had been so long since he had seen so many people in one place ... hell, it had been a long time since he had *smelled* them, either, and he was reminded quite strongly just how much a group of frightened people living on the edge of civilised smelled. The mingled sweat and burned food was a stark contrast to the decay topside, something that he had grown quite used to over the years. But, it was also a reminder of life. People were living here. They were survivors.

A few people mingling in the area looked up in their direction as Shindo held out a hand over the barrier.

"Home sweet home," he said, with a broad grin, and looking back at them. "I know it ain't much to look at, but there's a lot to be said for somewhere safe these days."

Even Kacchan's face was removed of some of it's bitterness and he stepped closer to the metal railing. It was far from paradise, but it was enclosed and it seemed safe, and that was exactly the sort of thing that izuku had been unable to find since the world had ended. He wondered if maybe they had found this place sooner ... if he had been able to get Uraraka, and Shouto, Tenya and Tsu ... Sero ... here then maybe they would all be alive right now. As his thoughts swirled, he caught movement to his right and looked over to see two small children, one of them clutching what looked like a notebook of sorts, staring wide eyed at them. He smiled, raising a hand in greeting. The oldest, a girl, grabbed the boys hand and dragged him away.

"You got kids here?" Kacchan said, his voice oddly strained.

"Yeh, they came here with their dad but he, uh ..." Shindo cleared his throat, and rubbed the back of his neck. "We lost him when we tried for the hospital."

Izuku's breath caught in his throat, and he swung around; remembering the broken and ruined body they had found back there, the way it had been torn apart ...

"The fuck you doing taking their damn father out on run?" Kacchan breathed.

"Everyone pulls their weight," Shindo replied, his expression now hardening. "He wanted to go."

Kacchan scoffed, and Izuku found his eyes drifting back to the two children, the little girl still dragging her brother after her and shooting them distrusting looks.

"It isn't easy," Shindo continued, "looking after so many people. Feeding them alone takes almost all the time and resources we have, and it's still barely enough to scrape by. We lost someone, but we still got a lot of much needed medication out of it, including medicine for one of the kids. So you can stand there and judge me all you fucking like, Bakugou, but you don't know a damn thing about what I've already had to do to keep these people safe."

Shindo's lips tightened, his dark eyes burning as he squared his shoulder, and for a moment Izuku felt as though he might have been looking at a darker, taller version of Kacchan, that challenging glare so similar to one he had seen so many times before. Kacchan, predictably, didn't look as though he was about to back down easy; he breathed sharply through his nose, standing tall, eyes fixed on Shindo like he was ready for a fight, and Izuku was close to pulling his damn hair out at the sight. *What the fuck had happened between these two?*

"We're not here to judge you," Izuku said hurriedly. "Or tell you how to look after your group. Are we, Kacchan?"

Dark and red eyes darted in his direction, and Izuku almost shrank back at the intensity of their glares, and were it not for how pig headed Kacchan was behaving in that moment and the frustration Izuku felt, he might well have done.

"*Are we, Kacchan?*" he repeated, firmer this time. Kacchan seemed furious, looking for all the world like he might decide to punch Izuku in the face, before with a snort he finally backed down, shoving his hands into the pockets of his hoody. Shindo looked between them, making a soft 'huh' noise before he cocked his head to the side.

"Ah, I get it."

"Get what?" Izuku asked, but Shindo simply shrugged.

"Come on, I'll show you around."

Conflict forgotten, Shindo gestured over his shoulder as he started to climb down the ladder of the mezzanine. Izuku grabbed hold of Kacchan wrist as he made to move, pulling him back.

"I dunno what kinda history you two have, but you've got to calm down," he whispered urgently, and Kacchan yanked his wrist away.

"Don't tell me what to do, Deku."

Izuku held back a frustrated whine as Kacchan started down the ladder. He was used to Kacchan being difficult, but it had been a long time since the man had left him feeling so on edge.

"So, this is where we prepare and eat food," Shindo said, once Izuku had caught up with them. It was a fairly modest set up, a table for cutting and preparing, and pretty archaic on the face of it; two metal crock pots suspended over a fire pit, but Izuku supposed it was probably the only way that they could safely cook enough food for almost thirty people without electricity.

"We're pretty lucky to have Makabe with us," Shindo continued, and a man by the crock pot got to his feet. Ocean blue eyes glancing over Izuku for less than a beat before focusing on Kacchan. "Don't ask me how but he's pretty good at making our supplies stretch pretty far."

"Bakugou," Makabe said.

"Baldy," Kacchan grunted through gritted teeth.

Makabe laughed, before turning back to Izuku and holding out his hand.

"Midoriya," Izuku offered, shaking his hand, with the smallest bow. Kacchan scoffed.

"Nice to meet you. Good job on making it this far despite that pain in your ass."

Izuku blinked. "Uh ... what?"

"Real fucking funny, asshole," Kacchan snarled.

"Everyone gets two meals a day," Shindo continued. "Unless supplies are low, in which case we have to reduce it to one. We were due to go on a supply run today but ... well."

"Sorry," Izuku said awkwardly.

"Over there is where everyone sleeps." Shindo pointed towards the tents. "As I said, it feels pretty cramped, but everyone at least gets their own space. We emptied out one of the outdoor suppliers down the street, so we were able to get some tents big enough for the couples or the smaller groups that still don't feel safe sleeping alone."

"You had people come in in groups?" Izuku asked, his mind immediately jumping to Kirishima, Mina, and Kaminari.

"Yeh, we've had some people wander in on their own, of course. They tend to be the ones that need the most time ... but mostly they trickle in in groups of three or so, we had a group join us just three weeks ago."

"Who?" Kacchan demanded, and Shindo looked taken back.

"No one you'd know," he said, before his eyebrows rose. "Wait, it wasn't just the two of you?"

"We were part of a larger group," Izuku explained. "But we got split up from them, uh, well about a month ago now. Their names are Kirishima, Mina-"

"Holy shit, weren't they some of the students in your damn chem classes?" Shindo interrupted. And now it was making sense, they must have all gone to Tokyo together.

Kacchan grit his teeth, looking for all the world like he'd rather not say a damn thing to Shindo. "Yes," he snapped.

"Don't hold back on me," Shindo laughed. "Who did you get out of there with?"

Kacchan clicked his tongue, childishly crossing his arms over his chest and glaring towards the tents. "Most the department made a run for it at the start," he replied shortly. "Just me, Kirishima, Jirou, Kaminari, Sero, and Mina realised we were better off making a base on campus."

"*Kaminari?*" Shindo grinned in cruel delight. "I thought you couldn't stand that guy."

"He's annoying as fuck but he can handle himself."

"So, uh, Jirou's with the rest of your group?" Makabe piped up, with thinly veiled interested in his tone, and Kacchan tensed.

"...No."

The playful smirk on Shindo's face faded, and Makabe averted his gaze.

"Jirou and Sero didn't make it."

"Oh," Shindo breathed. "I'm ... I'm sorry."

"Don't need your sympathy," Kacchan shot back immediately.

"I'm sorry for them."

Kacchan's face screwed up and he turned his back, looking towards the office just behind them. "What's that?" he demanded, and Izuku knew that he was trying to move the subject on.

"That's where we monitor topside," Shindo replied. "We try and have people up there at all times to report back, let us know if there are any people headed our way. We also managed to hack into some CCTV feeds, converted the cameras to battery rather than mains, so alongside the eyes up there we have a pretty good idea of what's going on at all times."

"Can we see?" Izuku asked, eyes lighting up in curiosity.

"Yeh, don't see why not."

The two of them followed Shindo towards the small office block, the door squeaking loudly on it's hinges as he pulled it open, revealing several grainy monitors, and a row of controls.

"We get a pretty good idea of what's going on topside from here," Shindo explained. "The CCTV feeds are useful on their own right, being able to see where the zombies are makes it a hell of a lot easier to plan our routes when we go up there for runs. And, uh, as you can see they're pretty active right now."

Izuku frowned as he looked at the screens, squinting with his good eye to make out the details on the low resolution cameras. Shindo wasn't wrong, he could see zombies on every monitor; it was impossible to count just how many, in some places he couldn't even make out the street from the mass of zombies that seemed to group around certain points in the town.

"There's so many of them," he muttered, and Shindo scoffed a low laugh.

"Tell me about it. And they're always more active after someone is spotted out there. It's why we have to plan our trip topside carefully and why, regretfully, we've lost almost as many people as we've saved. If we get caught out, it'll be days before they stop canvassing the joint."

Izuku looked across at Shindo. "How many people have you lost?" he asked quietly.

"Our people? Oh, not too many. But one of the reasons we always have at least two of three people topside at any given moment is so that we can find the stragglers that wander in here before the damn z's do. By the the time they spotted you, however, you were already heading towards the hospital. Honestly, we were pretty sure you were done for, who the fuck walks into a hospital during an apocalypse?"

"It looked deserted from the outside," Izuku muttered, feeling his cheeks warming up.

"Yeh. Almost like the perfect trap, huh?"

Izuku wasn't entirely sure what Shindo meant by that; zombies didn't plan. They didn't make traps for people, they weren't smart enough to lure people in like that ... at least, not most zombies. There were some, after all. Some that he and Kacchan had had more than their fair share of run ins with to this point, that might well be perfectly capable of that sort of thinking. Izuku wondered, then, how much Shindo knew.

"Either way," Shindo continued, "eventually the zombies stop swarming our exit points and go back to the hospital. Provided we don't make too much noise, and don't get too close, we can move about the city without being detected."

"They go back to the hospital?" Kacchan asked sharply, and Shindo glanced back at him with only the mildest of surprise.

"Yeh, like it's a fucking nest or some shit," he said, with a shudder. Izuku eyes darted towards Kacchan, who shared the smallest of guarded looks with him. "It's not normal for z's to stick around in the same place like this, right? At least, that's what we figured out over the last however many fucking years it's been. But the zombies here don't fucking leave, and more and more of them keep wandering in."

Izuku swallowed, looking back to the monitors.

"It's almost like ... something is drawing them in."

Izuku did not miss the leading in Shindo's tone, the almost conspirational way he said those words, and the hairs on the back of his neck stood on end.

"Maybe it's the fact you got thirty fucking people living underneath them," Kacchan snapped.

"If that was the case they'd stay on the streets," Shindo replied. "Nah, there's something else drawing them here."

The female zombie ...

"Look, I'm just gonna come out and say it," Shindo sighed, leaning against one of the tables and cross his arms over his chest. "You see it, or not?"

See what? Izuku wanted to reply, but his voice caught in his throat. It wasn't strictly ... fuck, it wasn't a *secret*, between Kacchan and himself. It stood to reason that if these things were out there, then others had seen them, but Izuku wasn't afraid to admit to himself that he was scared. He was scared of the implications, of the questions, scared that it wouldn't take long for others to discover what he had. And after that, how long before Kacchan was found out? How long before they started treating Kacchan like a threat?

"We saw it," Kacchan replied coldly, and Shindo took a sharp breath, standing straight.

"Fuck," he breathed. "Fuck, I knew it. I *knew* I hadn't imagined it!"

He started to chew on his thumbnail, face scrunched up in heavy thought, and Izuku's entire body felt tense.

"So, I got a theory-" Shindo started, before he was interrupted by a sharp scratch on the walkie, loud enough to make the three of them jump.

"Yo! Come in Yo!"

Shindo snatched the walkie up, holding it to his lips as he pressed down on the bright red button on it's side.

"Tatami? I hear you, over."

For some reason, Kacchan scoffed, crossing his arms over his chest and glaring freshly sharpened daggers at Shindo, who seemed to wince.

"Asshole, I've been trying to reach you! Over."

"Well, I was with our new guests," Shindo replied, now refusing to meet Kacchan's eyes. "Uh, over."

"Those morons," the woman named Tatami replied. *"I've never seen anyone quite so stupid and quite so lucky in my damn life!"*

Kacchan growled, and Shindo at least had the good graces to look sheepish.

"Actually, Tami they're here with me at the moment, over."

There was a prolonged silence on the over end of the walkie.

"Oh. Well, I ain't wrong. Anyway, Yo, we've got a problem up here, over."

Shindo frowned, looking back at the monitors.

"What kind of problem? Over."

"The z's are all over Block Thirty exit, I'm watching literally hundreds of them starting to swarm over the manhole. I swear to fuck, Yo, I've never seen this many of them in one place, before, it's creepy. Over."

Shindo grabbed a controller, and started to flick through several different feeds on one monitor before settling on one, and Izuku gasped out loud. Tatami hadn't been wrong. The manhole that they had escaped into wasn't even visible any more, and there were so many zombies trying to push their way down the street that they were being rammed against the walls, some of them looking almost entirely crushed from the weight of the horde.

"Jesus fuck," Shindo breathed. "They all from the hospital, Tami? Over."

"I don't ... maybe? It's hard to tell, they're coming in from all over the place! I dunno what those two morons did in that damn hospital but these zombies are pissed."

Was it possible that the female zombie was still after Kacchan?

"I've even seen a couple of them try and grab the fucking manhole, Yo. Over."

"What the hell?" Shindo hissed, before he rounded on the both of them. "What did you do down there?"

"We didn't do a damn thing!" Kacchan snarled. "We went in, grabbed Deku's fucking eye drops, then ducked out!"

"Oh hell no," Tatami breathed on the other end of the walkie. *"Yo, tell me my ears are playing tricks on me and that ain't who I think it is."*

Kacchan snarled, before he lurched forward and snatched the walkie talky from Shindo's hand, the man yelling in protest and trying to snatch it back before Kacchan pressed down on the receiver.

"Oi, is that creepy bitch out there too?" he said.

There was silence, Kacchan scowling and holding the walkie away from his face for a moment as if to check it was still running.

"Oi, Nakagame I'm fucking talking to you!" he yelled.

"You're supposed to say over," Tatami replied smartly.

"Are you fucking kidding me!"

"Gimme the damn walkie back, Katsuki!"

"Fuck you, Shindo. Turtle Neck, your boyfriend here already fucking told us you've seen that mutated bastard, so is it out there or not? Fuckin' *over.*"

"I don't see it," Tatami replied, sounding as though she was doing so through gritted teeth. *"Go suck a dick, Bakugou. Over."*

"Already did, and better than you," Kacchan replied immediately, and Izuku rose both his hands to his face in horror, as Shindo's face burned bright red. "*Over.*"

"Gimme that back!" Shindo yelled, clambering over a table to snatch at the walkie, which Kacchan let him take with a smirk, flipping him the bird as he did so.

"*Oh my god*," Izuku breathed.

"You still there, Tami? Over," Shindo asked, his face still red and glaring at Kacchan who was now leaning languidly against the wall, his smirk positively devilish.

"If the zombies want Bakugou then I say we give em Bakugou," Nakagame replied, immediately. *"Over."*

"We ain't doing that," Shindo sighed, tiredly rubbing his temples, just as Kacchan called out a fuck you! "Are there any exits clear up there? Over."

"Yeh, Blocks Twenty One and Thirty Six look clear for the moment. Over."

"Good. Keep an eye on what's going on up there, if it looks like they might start to break into the sewers then we can evacuate through a clear exit. It could just be that we hadn't realised until now

just how many z's have wandered in the last few months, ok? Keep calm, chances are they're disperse in a day or two like normal. Over."

"Fine. I got Eito keeping an eye on the other exits too, we'll keep you updated if anything changes. Over."

"Ok," Shindo breathed. "Just ... be safe up there, alright? Stay on the rooftops. Over."

"No fucking duh, Yo, I'm not an idiot," Nakagame snapped.

"I didn't say that!" Shindo protested, his cheeks heating up again, before he turned his back on them and lowered his voice. "I'll see you soon, alright? Love you, over."

"Over and out," Tatami replied tartly, before the walkie cracked out.

"Ouch," Kacchan said, smirk broadening.

"What the hell is your problem?" Shindo yelled, turned back and hooking the walkie into his back pocket. "You realise we could all be in deep shit because of you, right?"

"Hey, we didn't ask for your help!" Kacchan snapped back. "You're the one with a boner over playing hero."

"Stop!" Izuku yelled, and Shindo and Kacchan turned their glares towards him now. "Look, if we had realised how much trouble this would have put you in, we wouldn't have come down here," he continued, once they had fallen silent. "I am sorry, I really am. The last thing I'd ever want is to put anyone at risk like this."

Shindo huffed.

"Your friend said there were two exits clear, right? Would it help if we left right now?"

"Wha- *no*! Jesus! I'm pissed off but doesn't mean I want you to get eaten," Shindo yelped. "No, this'll pass like it always does, alright? Just ... there's some spare tents, pretty sure the orange on the far right it empty. Set yourselves up, I gotta talk to everyone else about what's going on."

Shindo pushed past Kacchan, letting the door swing shut behind him and leaving Izuku and Kacchan standing in silence. Izuku barely made it to *three* in his head before he was rounding on Kacchan.

"What the fuck, Kacchan!" he whisper yelled, throwing his hands in the air.

"What?" Kacchan replied sourly, and Izuku huffed a short laugh.

"Don't play dumb with me, you know exactly what! Shindo saved our fucking lives, why you got to be such an asshole for?"

"Oh shove off with that shit, we'd have managed fine without him."

"No! No, I don't think we would have!" Izuku cried, hands going into his hair in exasperation. "I'm guessing this guy is your ex-boyfriend-"

"He weren't my fucking boyfriend," Kacchan growled fiercely.

"I don't care," Izuku interrupted, not the least bit intimidated. And that ... was definitely a lie. The uncomfortable grinding in the pit of his stomach since he had put two and two together was being loud enough to make him sure of that. "I really don't. But you cannot be a dick! Jesus, there are *kids* here, Kacchan!"

That wiped the indignant snarl from Kacchan's face.

"Shindo might not have a clue, but we know why the zombies are trying so hard to follow us. We've put these people in danger, so we're gonna shut up, do as we're told, not cause any problems, and get the hell out of here as soon as we can, get it?"

Kacchan growled, and Izuku rubbed his hand down his face.

"I feel like a damn ... *criminal,* or something," he muttered.

"We didn't put that zombie there, Deku," Kacchan said coldly. "Don't matter if we're here or not, if Shindo's gonna insist on keeping people here with that thing in the fucking hospital eventually shit's gonna turn sour."

"Yeh, you're probably right," Izuku sighed. "If they could take out that female zombie ... I bet the rest of them would just move on."

When Kacchan didn't respond, Izuku looked up to see the tense and guarded expression on the man's face.

"What?"

"You know what," Kacchan replied. Izuku shifted from foot to foot.

"I mean ... I'm right, though. If we had been able to kill her back then-"

"We can't stay here, Deku. You said it yourself."

"But we do owe them ..."

"Jesus christ ..."

"We do!"

"So we give them supplies or some shit! That doesn't mean we go *back in the there* and kill that thing!"

"That's not what I said."

"But it's what you're thinking."

"But it'll be interesting to see what happens, right?" Izuku said. "To see whether the rest of the zombies do just leave if she's not controlling them."

"We ain't talking about this," Kacchan said sharply. "This is idiotic, Deku, even for you. There is no way in hell we'd be able to get in there, kill her, without getting eaten ourselves."

Izuku pressed his lips together, looking back out the window towards the group of people that were now gathering around Shindo, their expressions, both fear and panic, wrenching at Izuku's heart.

"*Deku,*" Kacchan growled.

"Yeh yeh," Izuku sighed, but the looks on their faces, on the children's faces, seemed burned into his mind.

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 25: Green Eyed Monster

Chapter Summary

In which Kacchan takes a late night walk, and Deku follows...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Three days later, and the zombies topside continued to swarm.

Izuku would be the first to admit that there was still so much about the zombies that they didn't understand, in fact everything he thought he knew about the zombies had been flipped on it's head the moment he saw that large purple scar on Bakugou's side. But, that didn't mean that there hadn't always been some fundamental laws surrounding the undead that Izuku had felt that he could rely on over the last two years, laws that had saved his life more than a few times, and one of those was that zombies tended to lose interest once they could no longer sense you.

And sure, at the very start, the zombies had tended to stick in one place a lot, driven perhaps by instinct, this engrained habitual desire to be where people had once been, causing them to crowd tech stores and fast food joints, but in most cases they'd gradually drift on to the next spot. Izuku had been caught out enough to know that, whilst the zombies definitely did hang around for a bit after being riled up, provided they could no longer sense him they would eventually leave. So why, then, were the zombies topside still swarming like grotesque ants around a sweet on the street?

To make matters worse, Kacchan seemed entirely uninterested in talking about it. In fact, Kacchan seemed uninterested in pretty much everything in the days following their hospital mission, choosing to keep himself secluded in the tent they'd secured. Any attempts Izuku had made to speak to him had been met with irritated grunts, or his back, sleeping with his sleeping bag wrapped around him and as much space between he and Izuku as was possible in the small tent they shared. Izuku wasn't sure what he had expected from Kacchan at this rate ... they hadn't talked about what had happened in the hospital, though Izuku had been sure that Kacchan would demand to know why he had hit him around the face back then. And as for Shindo? Well, Izuku had tentatively asked him what their history was, only for Kacchan to call him a *'jealous nosey bitch*' and storm out *'to take a piss*'. Izuku knew that Kacchan was under a lot of stress, he supposed finding yourself trapped in a sewer with people who seemingly hated him whilst zombies swarmed outside waiting for you to show your face would probably do that, but the attack had still surprised him. Had still upset him. *Jealous?! Him?!* So, he didn't bring it up again after that, just leaving Kacchan to his brooding whilst he attempted to help out in the camp as much as he could.

Despite their dislike for Kacchan, Izuku was relieved to find out that this animosity didn't extend to him, and Shindo had been grateful for his offer of help, setting Izuku up on cleaning duty after meal times. It allowed Izuku a chance to speak to most people in the camp, sometimes sure he could feel eyes on him from across the camp, only to glance up and see the zipped up door of an orange tent looking at him instead. Izuku had considered, briefly, asking Shindo what the deal was between him and Kacchan, but he wasn't ready to have two people seemingly pissed at him.

On the third day, Izuku was collecting stray plates by the tents when he heard shuffling to his side, and he looked up. The two children on the camp had avoided him completely, something he was assured he shouldn't take personally by Shindo.

"They're both pretty shy," he had said, with a shrug when Izuku asked if maybe he had frightened them. But Izuku wasn't entirely certain whether shyness was their issue ... the youngest, the boy, seemed curious enough, and Izuku had caught him staring at him in interest on more than one occasion, before his sister had dragged him away again. Shyness wasn't their issue ... these were two children who had been given enough reason in the last two years not to trust strangers.

So, Izuku was somewhat surprised to see the boy standing in front of him, his eyes wide and round as he looked at him from beneath the brim of the hat he always wore, his hands fiddling with the front of his scruffy dungarees. Izuku glanced around, expecting to see the younger girl as well, before he smiled.

"Hey there!"

The little boy blinked, looking down at the plates in Izuku's hand.

"People shouldn't leave their dirty plates lying about."

Izuku, too, looked at the plates, before he laughed lightly.

"You think so?"

"Mahoro said adults can be lazy sometimes," the boy replied. "Papa always said we should tidy up after ourselves."

Izuku felt his smile fade a fraction at the mention of their father.

"Is Mahoro your sister?" he asked, keeping his tone bright and placing the plates back on the floor so he could swivel on his knees and face the little boy. The boy nodded.

"She takes pretty good care of you, huh?"

At that, the boy scrunched his nose up. "She's bossy," he replied. "She won't let me talk to people."

"Hmm, I'm sure she's just trying to look out for you," Izuku said.

"It's annoying," the boy huffed, and Izuku laughed.

"Yeh, I get that."

"Does your big brother stop you doing stuff too?"

Izuku blinked, cocking his head to the side in confusion. "My big brother?"

"Yeh, that angry one who's always yelling."

"Oh!" Izuku laughed again. "Kacchan's not my brother. He's my friend, though."

"Oh."

The little boy fell silent, fiddling with the front of his dungarees again.

"So, Mahoro's your sister's name, what's yours?"

"Katsuma," the boy replied.

"Well, my name is Izuku," Izuku said, bowing his head for a moment. "It's nice to meet you, Katsuma!"

And then, a small tentative smile brightened Katsuma's face for the first time since Izuku had met him. It was fast, almost like Katsuma had quite forgotten how, and Izuku felt an uncomfortable tugging in his chest.

"So, why'd you come and talk to me, Katsuma?"

Katsuma blushed, suddenly looking quite sheepish.

"Uh ... you come from outside, right?"

"Sure do!"

"So, uh ... do you ..." Katsuma grabbed his hat and pulled it further down his head. "Do you have any comic books?"

Izuku's brow rose.

"Comic books?"

"Yeh. The ... that last people who came from outside had comic books with them, but I've read them all now."

"Oh!" And Izuku felt awful in that moment. "I'm sorry, Katsuma, I don't have any comic books."

Katsuma's little face fell. "That's ok."

"But, tell you what," Izuku continued. "When I go back out there, I'll find a whole bunch of comic books and bring them back here for you, how does that sound?"

Katsuma gasped, before the biggest broadest grin brightened his features.

"You'd do that?"

"Sure! So, what comic books are your favourite?"

"All Might is my favourite!" Katsuma replied, his voice loud and excited now, and Izuku couldn't stop himself from beaming.

"No way! All Might's my favourite too!"

"Really?" Katsuma grabbed at the yellow bag around his shoulder and pulled it forward, before he started digging around in it. "Look what my papa got for me!"

He held out a collection of stickers on his small hand, all of them with All Might, or other characters from the show, his face practically glowing with pride.

"Wow, these are so cool!"

"This one's my favourite," Katsuma said, holding out one of the All Might stickers. He had his huge trademark smile, one that Izuku had spent many hours trying to replicate in the mirror when he was much younger, pointing with the words *'you too, can be a hero!'* underneath in bold red and white. "One day I'm gonna be a hero just like All Might," Katsuma continued. "I'm gonna save everyone from the monsters and then we can go home."

Izuku's smile dropped again, and he looked up from the sticker at Katsuma's face, his eyes bright and fierce, his jaw set and determined.

"KATSUMA!"

Katsuma jumped, shoving the stickers back into his bag as he turned around. Mahoro stood by their tent, her hands on her hips, glaring daggers in Izuku's direction.

"I gotta go," Katsuma muttered. "Bye Mr Izuku."

"I'll speak to you later, Katsuma," Izuku said, and Katsuma hurried off, Mahoro huffing a "papa said it's dangerous to talk to strangers!" before dragging him into their tent. Izuku got to his feet, the plates entirely forgotten, and his chest aching. It wasn't fair. This wasn't how life was supposed to be ... this wasn't how things were supposed to go ... He sighed, looking back over his shoulder before pausing. Kacchan stood outside of their tent, expression difficult to read as he looked back at him. For a moment, Izuku thought that maybe Kacchan would speak, would reach out to him in some way, but instead he turned away, opening the tent and disappearing inside.

It wasn't until later that night, when Izuku climbed into the tent, dutifully trying not to disturb the tuft of blonde hair that stuck out over the top of the green sleeping bag, that Kacchan finally mentioned anything about their predicament. Izuku slipped into his own bag, casting a concerned and, by now, irritated look at Kacchan's back before he doused the oil lamp at his side, staring up at the roof of the tent, flickering from the light from outside, his mind still focused on his conversation with Katsuma earlier.

"You look like you're enjoying yourself here."

For a moment, Izuku wasn't sure that Kacchan had spoken. He was so quiet, muffled by the thick fabric of his sleeping bag, almost like he wasn't sure whether he wanted to be heard or not. Izuku looked at the back still facing him.

"I guess," Izuku replied, softly. "It's nice to have so many people to speak to again. You know one of the men here is- *was*, an actor? I've actually seen some of the films he's been in. And they have a veterinarian, too, which has been pretty handy."

Kacchan didn't respond, and after the better part of three minutes in silence, Izuku assumed the conversation was already over, and with a light sigh he rolled onto his back again, pulling his arms up beneath his head.

"You could stay here, you know."

He knew Kacchan hadn't really intended to piss Izuku off ... at least, he hoped as much, but instead of quiet contemplation, Izuku was struck by a seething anger that had him sitting upright, glaring at the indifferent ball of self pity at his side.

"Is that why you've been so grumpy the last three days?" Izuku asked, his tone sharp. "Honestly, Kacchan, I'm just so tired of this now! We can't seem to go one fucking week without you bringing up the topic of me leaving!"

"Yeh, well, each week there's a new fucking reason that you should!" Kacchan growled in response, though he kept himself buried in his sleeping bag, face hidden from view, and Izuku groaned in exasperation.

"What damn reason, Kacchan? Nothing's changed!"

"I know I blacked out."

Izuku's breath caught in his chest.

"Back in the hospital. It's why you slapped me, right?"

"Why have you waited this long to say anything?" Izuku sighed.

"You didn't bring it up," Kacchan muttered.

"You wouldn't let me!" Izuku whisper yelled, turning to face Kacchan now, glaring at those stupid dumb spikes. "I've been trying to talk to you the last three days but you've been ignoring me!"

"I've been thinking!"

"What does that even mean?"

"It means-" and Kacchan moved now, sitting up and pushing the cover down from his chest, the dark circles under his eyes clearly visible even in the flickering orange gloom, "-that I'm just one step closer from turning into one of those damn things out there! And I've been trying to ... shit, I've been trying to figure out what I should be doing with the time I have left."

Izuku's shoulders sagged, the corners of his eyes instantly started to prickle, and it was only through dogged vehemence that he was able to stop the tears from leaking out, Kacchan's words hitting him like an axe straight to the damn chest. *The time he had left?*

"Don't say that," Izuku breathed.

"Deku-"

"I'm serious!" Izuku bit his lip, realising that he had started to raise his voice.

"So am I. Fuck, Deku, I know you think you can just keep ignoring it, but I can't! And before you say shit, I get it. It might be weeks, months, fucking *years* for all I know, but we know it's gonna happen eventually."

Izuku swallowed against the lump in his throat, shaking his head weakly.

"We don't know if we'll find Shitty Hair and the others," Kacchan continued, voice quiet. "So, isn't it worth considering? You staying here."

Izuku shook his head. "No. I wanna help these people, Kacchan, but I can't stay here."

"And what if you end up on your own?" Kacchan said bluntly.

What if he *did* end up alone? It was a possibility ... hell, it always was in the Apocalypse. He had lost his entire group, after all, and if he hadn't thrown himself over Kacchan in the explosion, he might well have ended up on his own after they lost the RV, too. Ending up alone wasn't exactly an unrealistic threat these days, and when his partner was possibly slowly succumbing to a bite he had received over a year ago, the odds only increased. And ending up alone, more often than not, meant ending up dead. And Izuku knew, *knew*, that Kacchan was looking out for him, that he wanted some assurances that Izuku would be as safe as he possibly could be should the worst happen, but a dark selfish part of him simply didn't care. Weeks, months, years, Izuku wasn't about to let Kacchan deal with whatever time he had left alone.

"It's the Apocalypse," Izuku replied. "I'll end up alone eventually. That doesn't mean I'm going to leave you alone now. I don't care how much time is left, I meant it when I said I'm not going anywhere."

Kacchan sighed, bringing up his hands to rub his tired face. "Idiot ..."

"Yeh, well, you already knew that."

Kacchan huffed a humourless laugh, before he lay back down, hands on his chest as he stared up at the roof of the tent.

"You really wanna help these people, huh?"

"E-even if we just help them gather supplies once the zombies clear."

"And comic books?" Kacchan asked, quipping an eyebrow and looking back across at him. Izuku scratched the back of his head.

"I'm pretty sure I saw a manga store on the map," he replied, somewhat sheepishly. "And don't look at me like that! Katsuma lost his dad and lives in a sewer, I think the kid deserves some silly All Might comics ..."

Izuku fell silent, and Kacchan's eyebrow only arched higher, the beginnings of a smirk on his face as Izuku shuffled in place, biting on his lip.

"Ok ok! They're not silly!" he burst out. "I can't believe Katsuma loves *All Might,* Kacchan! That's from our time! They stopped making new comics probably before he was even born!"

"Such a fucking nerd," Kacchan snorted, but Izuku was sure he wasn't imagining the fondness in his voice, or the shadow of a smile on his lips as he shut his eyes. "Whatever, get some sleep, Deku. We'll work out how we're gonna get hold of those comics in the morning."

"Wh-*really?*"

"Yeh, really, now shut up and go to sleep!"

Izuku grinned broadly as he shuffled himself back into his sleeping bag. It was amazing how soft this asshole could be when he let himself ...

It was dark when Izuku found himself roused from his sleep. He and Kacchan had fallen asleep in their separate bags, but inevitably Izuku had found himself worming towards the heat radiating

from the living furnace beside him, and no matter how carefully and quietly Kacchan had likely been getting up and leaving the tent, it had only taken Izuku a matter of moments for his subconscious to realised that something was wrong. His eyes snapped open, squinting in the darkness at the sleeping bag beside him before he realised the shape was all wrong. He sat up, pressing down on the empty blanket to be sure, before looking around the tent for it's other occupant.

"Kacchan?" he muttered, voice still thick with sleep. He stifled a yawn as he wrapped a blanket around himself, shivering as he inched closer to the exit of the tent, reaching up to tug on the zip as quietly as he could, and peering through the small gap he created.

He spotted Kacchan immediately, his blonde spikes illuminated from the light of the oil lamps, making his way to the centre of the quiet camp, towards another figure that Izuku, through his blurry good eye, took a moment to register as Shindo.

Izuku's eyesight might be severely compromised, but he'd always had a fairly sharp sense of hearing, and as he strained he just about made out a furious tone say, "*now*," as Kacchan crossed his arms over his chest, Shindo looking up in surprise from where he was sat in front of the fire.

"Now?" Shindo repeated.

"Don't make me repeat myself."

It felt like ice was sliding down his throat as he watched Shindo get to his feet, nodding his head towards the tent that stood slightly apart from the rest of them, the tent that Izuku knew to belong to Shindo. It was perhaps that moment that he realised there probably had been some truth in it when Kacchan had called him '*jealous*', and that growing chill in his chest only spread tenfold as they both walked towards the tent, and Kacchan looked up, once, in his direction. Izuku had such a tiny gap to look through, he was certain that he wouldn't be able to see him from that distance, but the idea that he was checking, that he was making sure that Izuku hadn't followed him, made him feel far more than simply jealous. He swallowed, biting back the urge to call to him, as Shindo opened his tent and the two of them went inside.

He allowed himself precisely three seconds to consider that whatever was going on simply wasn't his business before he was unzipping the tent and stepping out. Three seconds to consider that he was stooping to a whole new low before he was striding across the camp, socked feet all but silent on the stone floor, ducking behind the tents so as to be sure not to cast a shadow. He allowed himself another two seconds to reconsider his options, to go back to the tent and mind his damn business, before he settled himself down in the shadows behind Shindo's tent, and wrapped his blanket around his mouth to quieten his unsteady breathing as he listened intently.

"-why you took so long to come to me," came Shindo's voice, muffled and quiet, like he was keen not to be overheard.

"You didn't come to me either, dickwad."

"Yeh, well, I was waiting for you to make the first move."

Izuku tried to ignore the butterflies waging a damn war in his stomach.

"Fuck you, I wasn't planning on making any damn move at all."

"What, so you were just gonna sit in my camp for days and pretend I don't exist?"

"Yeh, something like that."

"Come on, Kat," Shindo sighed. "I already apologised, didn't I? The hell kinda asshole you gotta be to still hold a grudge when the world has literally ended?"

"I ain't holding a grudge," Kacchan replied, somewhat waspishly. "I just think you're a prick."

"On what grounds?" Shindo hissed. "I'm not the same person I was, Kat!"

"Bakugou," Kacchan corrected.

"No, fuck you. I know I made some mistakes back then, but we were still close once. And right now, we all need each other more than we'd care to admit."

"No, we weren't close," Kacchan growled. "We fucked because we hated each other's fucking guts, that's all there was to it."

Izuku frowned, feeling mingled vindication and guilt as he crouched in the dark eavesdropping.

"I don't think that's all there was," Shindo replied reproachfully, before he let out a soft laugh. "You don't let someone fuck you because you hate the-"

"I will fucking kill you right now," Kacchan hissed, sounding entirely serious, and Shindo wisely seemed to stop there. "I ain't here to talk about that shit. I'm here to talk about Deku."

Izuku was glad he had his blanket in front of his mouth with the sharp gasp left his lips. Shindo, on his part, seemed just as surprised.

"Uh ... what?"

"He wants to help."

There was silence from Shindo for a moment, before he hesitantly replied. "I ... know? And I already gave him some jobs that he can do. He doesn't really seem like the sort to complain but, like, if he doesn't like the jobs I've given him he doesn't have to send you to talk to me on his behalf?"

Izuku felt his face flush indignantly at that.

"Fuck, you're an idiot," Kacchan snapped. "That ain't it. He don't need me to fight his damn fights for him. He would kick your ass up and down this whole fucking camp if he wanted."

"Kat, baby you're so damn predictable, you know that?" Shindo said with a snigger, and Izuku could sense the way Kacchan must have bristled at that.

"Hah?!"

"I'm just saying. You got a type."

"Fuck you."

"Hmm, we both know your preferences in that regard-"

"Will you shut the fuck up!" Kacchan whisper yelled, sounding so close to losing his shit, and Shindo continued to laugh. "You might be a piece of shit not worth more than a meal for those fucker's up top, but the rest of the people here ain't."

"Oh come off it, Kat, you haven't spent two minutes with them."

"Quit interrupting me! I dunno how much of the rest of the world you saw before holing up here, but me and Deku have seen some shit. Shit that makes me pretty sure that you're not going to be able to stay down here for long, not whilst that thing is still up there."

Shindo remained silent for a moment after that. "What are you getting at?"

"It doesn't matter how safe it seems," Kacchan replied. "It won't be this way forever. Just ... fuckin' trust me on this shit, Shindo, that zombie up there is bad news. Either it'll figure out a way to get down here, or you'll end up so over-run topside that you'll all starve down here."

Izuku frowned, his heart hammering.

"So, you're saying we have to leave?" Shindo said. "Where the fuck am I supposed to put thirty people, Kat? You have any idea how hard it is to find somewhere big enough? Forget safe enough!"

"Nah, I'm saying we take out the zombie."

"You're fucking crazy."

"We've already killed one of them," Kacchan said.

"One of- *there are more?*"

"You said you had a theory on that thing up there, yeh?"

"Uh- yeh. I mean, it can control the other zombies, right? This virus is gotta be like any other ... mutations happen all the damn time, seems more absurd to assume there hasn't been any mutations of *Z*. Whoever that person is up there got bit by a zombie carrying some mutation, turning them into fucking hive queen zombie."

"However it happened, there are other zombies out there that aren't like the others. Me and Deku have come across two already before the one in the hospital, and it's more than just being able to control the other zombies ... the fuckers are smarter, too. The first one opened a car door, didn't really do much else after that, but it was smart enough to figure that out. The second could talk, it sent a bunch of zombies after us, and when it got hold of Deku it didn't show any interest in eating him. Just ... it tried to kill him by jamming it's fingers in his eyes."

"Oh, so that's why he wears the patch ..."

"Ye- the fuck is that what you're focusing on?"

"I'm just trying to gather my thoughts, man ... How did Midoriya get away?"

"I killed the fucking thing," Kacchan snarled, coldly. "I'm good at killing 'em. *We're* good at killing 'em. It was Deku's idea to take out the zombie in the hospital, and if anyone can pull it off he can."

If Izuku had been starting to feel guilty for following Kacchan before, he sure as hell squirmed with it now ... he had honestly thought that Kacchan was going to Shindo to ... what, *have sex with him?* Rekindle old fucking flames or ... Maybe he really was a jealous, nosey bitch.

"I know you've already lost people," Kacchan continued, "this is entirely up to you. But if you wanna take that thing out, then we'll help you."

"Kat, I ... Why? You almost didn't make it out of there once already, the hell would you help me like this? After ... everything."

"I ain't doing it for you," Kacchan snapped, before he sighed, and Izuku could imagine him running his hand across his face. "I ... got my reasons, alright? And those damn kids out there deserve better than this shit."

Kacchan soft ... Izuku thought to himself, his smile hidden by the blanket still wrapped around his face.

"Well, holy shit," Shindo breathed. "If you hadn't insulted me twenty times already I'd be wondering if you were the real Bakugou Katsuki. You wanna keep Midoriya around, seems like he's been good for you."

"Shut up," Kacchan hissed. "Think it through, talk with the rest of your group. You got 'til the zombies topside clear up to give me your decision, or me and Deku are gone."

There was a sharp noise, followed by stomping feet, and Izuku realised with a slight panic that Kacchan was leaving the tent. He froze, he couldn't very well be caught hiding behind the tent like this, but Kacchan was sure to notice the Izuku-shaped space in his sleeping bag when he got back. *He could surely blag a toilet break or something* ... He waited until Kacchan was inside the tent, and he was sure that Shindo wasn't about to come out, before hurrying back through the shadows. He took a deep breath, unzipping the tent and climbing in.

"Oh, there you are," Izuku said brightly, when his eyes landed on the figure sitting at the other end of the tent, his arms crossed over his chest and a pissed off expression on his face. "I was just-"

"Spying on me?" Kacchan interrupted. "Yeh, I knew you were back there, nerd, you realised you were still fucking mumbling right?"

Izuku's face paled.

"What?! I wasn't- oh, shit, did Shindo hear-"

"Nah, I heard you muttering something about pretending to be taking a piss as I left the damn tent," Kacchan said.

"Oh."

"Yeh. Oh."

Izuku stood on the spot, fiddling with his blanket, as Kacchan just glared at him. He wasn't sure which of them was gonna be the one to break the silence ... *it probably ought to be him, right? Or maybe Kacchan would wanna know what he heard? Or maybe he'll just talk about the plans-*

"Oh my fucking god, Deku," Kacchan snarled. "Just sit your ass down, fucking hell ..."

Izuku yelped, realising that he had probably been muttering again, before he hurried back to his sleeping bag.

"I hope you feel guilty as shit," Kacchan snapped.

Izuku shifted uncomfortably.

"Following me about like you trying to catch me out on cheating or some shit," Kacchan continued. "Turns out I was just supporting the fuck outta you! Bet you feel like real shit right now, hah?"

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but suddenly Kacchan was grinning, a dangerous, triumphant looking grin that Izuku realised with a pang he hadn't seen on the man's face in weeks.

"I think that makes *me* the better person!" he said, jabbing his chest with his thumb. "Hah! I win! Suck it, Deku!"

"You really go from one to a hundred in no time at all," Izuku muttered, his cheeks flushed pink.

"Says the morally inferior person in this tent," Kacchan replied, still smirking as he lay back and stretched out on his sleeping bag.

"Ok, I'm sorry I followed you," Izuku said.

"Sorry you *spied* on me," Kacchan corrected, and Izuku huffed.

"Alright! I'm sorry I spied on you, you happy?"

"Almost. *Sorry I spied on you I'm-*" and Kacchan raised a hand in a rolling wave, eyebrows raised.

"I'm sorry I spied on you, I am morally inferior to you in every way, will you ever forgive me?" Izuku said, and Kacchan grinned only more broadly.

"Sure, I will. Because that's what a good person does, Deku."

"Asshole," Izuku muttered, as Kacchan shut his eyes. But hell if he wasn't also smiling by this point.

"What did you think I was gonna do, anyway?" Kacchan said, with a loud yawn. "Sleep with the guy?"

Izuku blushed. "You could have killed him if you did ..."

At that, Kacchan opened one eye, looking seriously in Izuku's direction.

"What?" Izuku asked, panicked.

"I'm reconsidering."

Izuku grabbed his pillow and smacked Kacchan hard in the face at that. Kacchan immediately retaliated with his own, Izuku not at all prepared for the power behind the slap, before he launched at him again.

"DIE!" Kacchan yelled, counteracting Izuku's attack with his own.

"Shut up!"

Izuku and Kacchan froze.

"Oops," Izuku breathed, before Kacchan burst out into laughter, throwing in another hit for good measure, before he punched his pillow back into shape.

"I'm serious now, nerd, get some sleep. We'll talk through some battle plans in the morning."

"Ok, Kacchan."

They both lay back down, Izuku doing a poor job of hiding the grin still sat on his lips ... until all at once the reality of it hit him. And sure, it had been his idea ... to a point. He had sworn to himself the second he got out of that dump that he'd never step foot in a hospital again after this, let alone the same damn hospital he'd almost been killed in. But ... his thoughts wandered to the children, to the decomposing body of their father, to the chance these people had if only they could rid them of the zombie bringing more and more zombies to their doors, and he realised this was a risk worth taking.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 26: 'Til Death Do We Part

Chapter Summary

In which Shindo finally reveals the plan to the group, and Izuku and Kacchan get a moment to themselves.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the end, Shindo considered Bakugou's offer. In truth, he had very little choice in the matter; it was day five now. Five days since the zombies had flooded onto the streets and proceeded to swarm the small town, and yet still they remained, huddled around the same manhole that Shindo, Izuku, and Kacchan had escaped into almost a week ago. The only comfort was there were simply too many of them for there to be the space to lift the manhole and climb in after them. And that truly was the *only* comfort. It was towards the evening of the fifth day, Izuku and Kacchan both restless and jittery as they waited for Shindo to make up his mind or for the horde to clear enough for them to continue on their way to Shizuoka, that the walkie-talkie at Shindo's hip crackled, the frantic voice of Nakagame sharp on the other end.

"Yo! Pick up, Yo!"

Izuku looked up from where he had been scrubbing dishes, everyone else within earshot also taking notice. Shindo grabbed the walkie, flashing those that could see it a comforting smile that hardly covered the anxiety clear beneath, before he got to his feet and headed towards the office. Izuku hesitated for only a moment, glancing back towards their tent where he saw Kacchan poking his head out with a frown, before he got to his feet and followed Shindo, Makabe also quick at his heel.

"Tami, I hear you, over," Shindo said, throwing the mildest of disgruntled looks at Izuku and Makabe when he saw they'd followed him into the office, mouthing, *"This could be private!"* Makabe snorted, nudging Izuku hard with his large elbow.

"He's still pretending Tatami isn't mad at him," he sniggered.

"Shut up, man!" Shindo snapped before the walkie buzzed again.

"Yo! We've got a problem. A big one."

The door swung open again, and Izuku glanced back to see Kacchan stepping in.

"What's going on?"

"Shh," Shindo hissed, waving his arm for silence. "Tami, what kind of problem? Over."

"You're gonna need to see this for yourself, Yo," Nakagame replied. *"You got the monitors on? Look at the hospital, east side exit. Over."*

Shindo frowned, picking up the remote and flicking through the camera before stopping on the view of the hospital, and Izuku felt his breath catch in his chest.

"Wait..." Shindo breathed. "Is that..?"

It was hard to make out too much detail with the grainy low-resolution cameras, but there was no mistaking the zombie that was now boldly walking across the parking lot. Her long hair hung down over much of her face, her dirty and faded flowery dress fluttering in the breeze, her gait confident and far too coordinated for it to be that of a regular zombie.

"It's never left the hospital before," Makabe said. Izuku looked over at Kacchan to find him already staring straight back at him with a steady assurance. Kacchan raised an eyebrow, and Izuku nodded his head. There was no doubt in his mind what Kacchan was asking him.

"I dunno what she's doing, Yo!" Nakagame said. *"But I don't fucking like it. Not one bit!"*

"You made up your mind yet, or not?" Kacchan said bluntly, taking a step forward and pushing his way in front of Shindo.

"I..." Shindo swallowed. "Fuck-"

"She's out in the open," Kacchan said firmly, pointing to the monitor. "This is the best fucking chance we'll get."

"Best chance for what?" Makabe asked, looking between Shindo and Kacchan.

"Wait! Wait, there's something happening!"

The four of them looked back to the screen, watching in confusion and dawning horror as the female zombie stopped dead in the middle of the parking lot, her head thrown back, casting into sharp relief the way half her face below the cheeks was missing.

"What's she doing?" Shindo said, holding the walkie up to his mouth. "Tami, you got eyes on this? Over."

"It ain't her I'm looking at right now! The zombies they're... they're moving-"

"Maybe she's calling them back to the hospital," Izuku said, hardly daring to hope at this point.

"They're not moving towards the hospital!" Nakagame said. *"It's hard to make out... there are so many of them- shit it... it looks like some are staying put, but some are moving deeper into the town."*

"That doesn't make any sense," Makabe hissed. "Not unless-"

"Shindo, where exactly are the other exits?" Izuku interrupted, hurrying forward to snatch the remote from his hand and flicking through the cameras on the other monitors.

"Holy shit," Nakagame breathed. *"I don't believe it. They're heading to the other exits! How do they know?"*

"She's trying to starve us out," Kacchan said, his voice low, and the room fell silent. Kacchan kept his gaze fixed on the monitor, at the female zombie with her head still thrown back, eyes shut.

"But... they're not that smart," Makabe said weakly.

"They can't be at every exit yet," Izuku said. "Kacchan's right; if we're going to do this, it needs to be now! Whilst she's distracted."

"I- *fuck.* I haven't spoken to anyone about this yet!" Shindo yelled in frustration.

"Are you kidding me?" Kacchan snarled, tearing his gaze away from the monitor and shoving his palm roughly against Shindo's chest. "You know what? Fuck you. I can deal with this myself."

"Kacchan, don't-"

"She's moving, over!"

They froze again, and sure enough the female zombie was taking another step forward, two steps, before she stopped in her tracks. They waited, silent, breaths held, fists clenched, until the female zombie turned and faced the camera.

"What the hell kinda horror-show shit is this?" Makabe breathed.

Izuku felt as though ice was trickling down his spine as he looked at the monitor, looking at the zombie undeniably staring straight at the camera, what remained of her tattered lips pulled back into a snarl, or a grin – it was impossible to say – before she raised a thin, wasted arm and pointed directly at them.

"What the fuck?" Shindo hissed. "What the *fuck?!*"

But Izuku knew in his bones what this was. This was a challenge. The female zombie knew they were still here, and she was not going to be giving up that easily.

"She's going back inside, over!"

"Shit," Kacchan snapped, sounding frustrated. "Now it's only going to be harder to get at her!" He rounded on Shindo again, who was still watching the monitor in shock. "The hell is wrong with you, hah?!"

"Kacchan, don't," Izuku said softly, seeing the confusion on Makabe's face and the building horror on Shindo's. Kacchan glanced up at him, looking for all the world as though he was about to tear Izuku a new one as well, before he grunted and his shoulders sagged.

"Fuck," he breathed, running a hand through his hair.

"Is someone going to tell me what's going on, huh?" Nakagame said. *"Anyone?"*

"Yeh, I'd really like to be clued in as well," Makabe said, and Shindo shot him a harried look.

"I- ok, I don't know what in the hell is going on with that zombie, but... Kat and Midoriya, they got a plan."

"Fuck no," Nakagame said immediately. *"I ain't doing a damn thing that fucking lunatic suggests, Yo! And neither should you!"*

"Just hear me out!" Shindo snapped, as Kacchan scoffed. "I think Kat's right. That thing up there? It's not gonna give up this time, and we've only got so much food before we all start to get real hungry down here. The only way we clear the zombies is to take out the one controlling them."

"That's suicide!" Nakagame yelled. *"If you could see what I can see from up here, you wouldn't even think about doing something so stupid. There are hundreds of them, Yo. Hundreds! And in a few minutes every exit we have is going to be completely blocked."*

"Then we fight our damn way out of whichever has the least amount of zombies," Kacchan replied. "Maybe I ain't made this fucking clear enough for you yet, Turtleneck, but those fuckers can outlast us, and then some, and there are more and more zombies coming into town every day. If you don't want the people down here to starve to death, then we have got to take her out!"

"Kacchan's right," Izuku said. "If I thought there was even a chance that we could outlast this, I wouldn't be suggesting it."

Makabe frowned at him but didn't argue.

"Look, I know it's risky," Izuku continued. "But right now, almost all the zombies are out on the street, and that leaves her vulnerable. With a quiet and skilled enough team, we stand a chance of ending this thing before it's too late to do anything about it."

"Skilled enough?" Makabe said. "I dunno if you've taken a good look at the people here, Midoriya, but they're exhausted, and they're scared. Some of them haven't even seen a zombie in months-"

"You took people into the hospital before," Kacchan said, "and only lost one. They can't be that useless."

"And those that did come back remember what it was like in there," Shindo said, his voice quiet. "I don't ... I don't know if I can ask them to do it again."

"They die out there, or they die in here."

"We don't need that many people," Izuku said. "Me and Kacchan are good at handling the zombies, and Nakagame is already out there as a spotter. Give me three good people, Shindo. That's all I need."

Shindo kept his gaze trailed to the monitors, chewing his lips, before he let out a heavy sigh.

"Ok."

"Yo!"

"Ok, but... we move in the morning, ok? I'll talk to them. Today. I'll get you the people you need."

"About fucking time," Kacchan said.

"Thank you, Shindo. I wouldn't have suggested this if I didn't think there was a good chance we could pull it off."

Shindo nodded, eyes drifting back to the monitors again.

"Yeh... I get it," he said. "Do you, uh, do you mind if we have a moment?"

It took Izuku a moment to realise that he was asking for Izuku and Kacchan to leave the room, and he started.

"Oh! Of course!"

"I'll let you know as soon as I've made a decision."

Shindo's tone didn't seem to be inviting any further discussion, and after spotting Kacchan shrug and make for the door, he nodded and followed suit.

"I dunno why he's taking so fucking long about this," Kacchan snapped after the door swung shut.

"He doesn't want to lose anyone," Izuku replied softly. "Are you saying you wouldn't be the little bit cautious if it was our friends we were considering taking in there?"

Kacchan grunted in response, shoving his hands in his pockets.

"The longer he leaves it, the more likely he is to lose people, Deku."

"I know," Izuku sighed. "But if my plan works, they might not have to fight any zombies at all."

"Right," Kacchan said, before he stopped. "About that-"

"Mr Deku! Hey, Mr Deku!"

Izuku looked up to see Katsuma waving at him before the kid started to jump over the supplies on the ground in his hurry to get to him.

"*Mr Deku?*" Kacchan repeated, with a raised eyebrow.

"He started calling me it yesterday," Izuku replied. "He must have heard you calling me Deku."

Kacchan scoffed as Katsuma skidded to a halt in front of them, his eyes wide and alight with excitement.

"Hey Katsuma," Izuku said, smiling at him. "You're in a good mood."

"Mahoro said that you're going to go out there to fight the monsters again soon!"

Izuku's eyes widened in surprise. "Oh. And what makes Mahoro think that?"

"Everyone's thinking it," Katsuma continued. "Mr Okina says the monsters are here because you are."

Kacchan let out a short, humourless laugh.

"Oh," Izuku replied.

"But, it's like the twelfth issue of Plus Ultra," Katsuma continued excitedly, "when All for One sent his Nomu army to the school! And everyone thought he wouldn't be able to fight without the kids getting hurt, but it only made All Might wanna be a hero even more!"

"Uh..." Izuku hesitated, paralysed to the spot by the pure, unadulterated hope and certainty in Katsuma's round eyes. "I guess."

"And the students helped too," Katsuma said. "When you go out there, I wanna come with you. So I can protect Mahoro!"

"Not a chance, squirt," Kacchan said immediately, towering over the kid with a scowl on his face. "This ain't an All Might comic. Kids stay here, where it's safe."

"B-but I c-can fight them!" Katsuma replied, lower lip puckering and small fists shaking.

"Look, brat, kids who go out there get eaten. You got it?"

"Kacchan!" Izuku admonished, shocked by the harsh way Kacchan spoke to Katsuma.

"What?" Kacchan said bluntly, as Katsuma watched him with terrified eyes. "The damn kid's gonna get ideas if you keep this up. Stay inside, brat; do as your elders tell you."

Kacchan turned on his heel and marched back to the tent, leaving Izuku kneeling at Katsuma's side as he watched his lips wobble and his eyes start to shine with nervous tears.

"Katsuma, you know you can't go out there, don't you?"

Katsuma swallowed.

"B-but why not? H-how comes you get to be a hero? I just... I just wanna help. I'm not... I'm not scared!"

Izuku smiled sadly, reaching out to place a hand on the top of Katsuma's fluffy head.

"I know, you're very brave!" he said. "But that's why you need to stay here. You need to look out for your sister and everyone else here whilst we're gone. You understand?"

Katsuma looked as though he was going to argue before his shoulder slumped with a dramatic sigh.

"Ok."

"Ok," Izuku replied with some relief. "Being a hero is about helping where you're needed most, and the people here need you, Katsuma."

"Yes, Mr Deku."

"Oi, Midoriya."

Izuku got to his feet, looking over his shoulder to see Shindo coming out of the office.

"Meeting in one hour; need you and Kat there."

"Sure."

"Is the meeting about how you're going to fight the monsters?" Katsuma asked, and Izuku placed a hand on his head again.

"You should go find your sister, Katsuma," he said. "Before she comes looking for you."

Katsuma blinked up at him before he let out another small puff of air and nodded. Izuku flashed him a smile as the kid turned tail and hurried back to his tent, but he was left with an unsettled

feeling in his chest as he watched him go.

That feeling followed Izuku straight into the meeting an hour later, he and Kacchan joining the group of people meeting in the centre of the hall. Izuku was on friendly terms with most of them by this point, even if it did turn out that there were some who seemed to personally blame him and Kacchan for the predicament they were in. But Kacchan had yet to make much effort, and Izuku didn't miss the guarded and downright hostile looks thrown in his direction. Looks that Kacchan seemed entirely indifferent to as he stood there, arms crossed over his chest and running his tongue across his teeth.

"Thanks for coming, everyone," Shindo said.

"What's this all about, Shindo?" one of the group asked.

"Have the zombies left yet?"

"When can we get Nakagame and Eito back?"

"What's happening with the food?"

"We're working on it," Shindo said, holding his hands forward. "But first, I need to talk to you all about something pretty important, and I'd appreciate if you all waited until I was done before asking any questions."

"Maybe if we knew what was going on, we wouldn't have to keep asking questions," one man grumbled, to a chorus of grunts and nods.

"Hey, give him a chance to talk," Makabe said firmly.

"It's fine, it's fine," Shindo said. "Look, I'll just put it plainly: things aren't getting any better out there, and if we don't do something soon, they're only going to get worse."

"What do you mean worse?!"

"*Do something?*"

"Hey!" Makabe yelled now, bringing the group to silence. Izuku hadn't felt this much damn tension in the air since the aftermath of Kacchan attempting to drunkenly strangle him to death.

"There are more zombies coming into town," Shindo continued, "and the larger the horde gets, the more from the surrounding areas they'll attract. They have our main exit blocked, and, as of an hour ago, they've proceeded to block every other exit that we have."

Gasps and cries followed his statement.

"If things carry on as they are, we'll be out of food in a week. We've got two choices: either we escape and find somewhere else to go, or we take our chances up there and do something about it."

"There's a third option," one woman said, before her dark eyes narrowed in Izuku and Kacchan's direction. "We never had problems like this before those two turned up here. If they had any decency, they'd leave and take the damn things with them!"

Izuku knew that things were only growing more tense as the days went by, but he still couldn't help but feel hurt at the murmurs of agreement that followed her words. He thought, on the whole, that the people here were starting to like him...

"Hey, lady, I got no fucking problem leaving," Kacchan said. It was, perhaps, the first time some of them had even heard him speak. "But my conscience here," he jabbed his thumb in Izuku's direction, "won't let me."

"They didn't bring the zombies here," Shindo said. "Granted, they definitely stirred them up a bit by going into the hospital, but we always knew that place was a ticking time bomb. The problem isn't Midoriya or Bakugou; the problem is what's in the hospital."

Silence followed this, more looks shared, and more shuffling feet.

"Those of you that saw it when we went to the hospital the last time know what I'm talking about," Shindo continued. "And we saw it again today. She came out of the hospital, and after that the zombies started to move to our other exits. Whatever the hell it is, it's controlling them, and until we stop her, we're not going to be free of that horde up there."

"So, what are we supposed to do?"

"Midoriya has a plan," Shindo explained, holding a hand out towards him, and a room full of faces looked over, leaving him suddenly feeling very exposed. After a moment, he felt Kacchan nudging him in the side.

"U-uh, yes," he said, swallowing back the wad of spit forming in his throat. "W-well, right now, most of the zombies are on the street, and whilst I don't for a second think that there won't still be some zombies left in the hospital, it leaves the female zombie more vulnerable than she would be at any other time." He took a deep breath, hiding his shaking hands behind his back, and wondering why speaking to thirty people seemed harder than fighting thirty zombies. "My plan is to make it look like we're trying to sneak out a party for food and supplies, get the zombies' attention on them whilst a smaller team goes into the hospital to kill the female zombie."

"He's insane."

"Watch it," Kacchan snarled.

"No, it's crazy! What you're asking is for people to go up there to die!"

"We'll die if we stay down here!" Makabe spoke now, voice raised and hands spread. "Don't you get that? If we stay down here, we'll starve!"

"Better take that chance than get torn apart by hundreds of zombies."

"If it helps your decision any, starving to death takes longer," Kacchan said bluntly, indifferent to the gasps and curses thrown at him.

"Jesus," Shindo hissed. "Look, I'm asking for three people. Just three. We already got Tami and Eito up there as spotters; they can make sure that those distracting the zombies don't run into any dead ends or get themselves trapped."

"And we already know where the female zombie is likely to be," Izuku added. "All we need to do is sneak into the hospital, find her, and take her out."

"And what if it figures out it's a trap?" someone else asked. Izuku opened his mouth to reply before he paused. *What if she did realise?* He looked in Kacchan's direction, but the man only offered him a shrug.

"We know she's smarter than the other zombies," he replied, "but we don't know if she's *that* smart. It took her five days to realise that she could cover the rest of our exits, don't forget."

"That's a pretty huge variable in your plan," Makabe said. "Say it is smart enough to realise it's a trap? Say it waits until it knows we're in the hospital, and it calls the zombies back to it?"

Another murmur of agreement followed this, and Izuku bit his lip.

"That's always going to be a risk," he said. "But that's what Nakagame and Eito are there for. If they even think the zombies might be returning to the hospital, we get out of there as quickly as we can."

"And the other alternative?" a woman said. "The one where we just escape and find somewhere else to live?"

"It's an option," Shindo replied. "But we'll still need someone to distract the zombies, or we'll have that whole horde following us."

"Not to mention that thing in there might follow us too," Makabe muttered. "We still don't know if it wants us out of this town or if it wants us all dead."

"I'd bet on the latter," Kacchan said in a low voice. "We've met other zombies like it, two of 'em. And they all tried to kill us."

"There are *more* of them out there?" a man barked, frantic.

"Let's just focus on the one we got right now," Shindo said, raising his hands for silence. "I get how dangerous this is, I really do, and I can't tell you how hard it is for me to have to ask any of you to risk your lives like this. But I honestly believe that it's our best chance right now." He took a deep breath. "Which is why I'm volunteering."

Izuku didn't miss the exasperated scoff from Kacchan, and he was sure that Shindo probably didn't either, but Izuku couldn't deny that a big part of him was relieved. He'd seen Shindo out there already; he was fast and quick, and he knew the streets. They'd be stupid not to accept his offer.

"So we just need two more people," he said, looking around at the group. "And I don't mean just anyone ... I need people who are quick on their feet and who have experience killing these things, you know, just in case it comes down to it."

"I'll go," Makabe said, but Shindo shook his head.

"No, I want you to stay here," he said. "We need people who can fight here too, in case things go south."

"Then you stay and I go," Makabe growled. “Out of the two of us, I'm the one we can afford to lose-"

"No." Shindo's voice was firm, his eyes glaring at Makabe. "I ain't gonna ask anyone else to do something I'm not prepared to do myself. I want you here."

In spite of their situation, for a moment Izuku fancied that he could understand what Kacchan had once seen in Shindo. There was a strength and a defiance to the man that was all the more obvious right now, and a fire in his eyes that he was begrudging to admit was little less than admirable. Feeling that unwanted hot feeling in his chest, Izuku threw a subtle glance in Kacchan's direction, only to find him looking more pissed off than ever, his upper lip curled. Izuku didn't really want to examine why that bothered him more than if Kacchan had just looked impressed.

"If you're confident, then I'd be glad for your help," Izuku said, before he looked at the rest of the group huddled there and the uncertain faces looking back at him. "We need two more."

"I'll do it." A woman stepped forward, her dark hair pulled back into a long plait. "I was always the one to do the runs before I lost my group."

"Daisuke, thank you," Shindo said.

"If Suke's going, so am I," said a young man.

"Hanzo, you don't have to-"

"You're not going out there on your own," the man named Hanzo said bluntly. "Besides, I was one of the ones that went to the hospital last time; I know the layout as good as any."

"That would be useful, thank you," Izuku said.

"Ok," Shindo breathed. "Well, we've got our team. We'll make our move first thing in the morning; give us a chance to get a plan ironed out."

"What you got here in the way of weapons?" Kacchan asked. "Was that the only gun back there?"

"Yeh, it's the only one," Shindo replied, "and I'd feel better if it was here."

"So, what else?"

"I'll show you what we've got," Shindo said, before he looked back at the group. "Daisuke, Hanzo, you best come with us. Everyone else, uh ... fuck it, music, cook something good, we'll meet back here tonight."

Izuku could see that a party of any size certainly wasn't at the forefront of anyone's mind as he considered the people gathered there, but he couldn't begrudge Shindo making the effort considering the situation they were in.

"This way," Shindo said, waving his arm over his shoulder, as Izuku, Kacchan and the two newest members of their little party broke free from the rest of the group.

"We've gathered quite a lot of weapons over the months," Shindo said, as they followed him to the back of the campsite. "We don't demand anyone turn over their weapons, but most people are happy to; if not right away, then after they realise that this place is safe, so we keep everything in the same place."

They walked behind the tent that Izuku recognised as Shindo's own to a large plastic chest, the sort that he recognised the groundskeepers locking tools in back at UA.

"You keep all the weapons in the same place, unlocked?" Kacchan said in disbelief, and Shindo threw him a reproachful look.

"I trust everyone here!"

"Yeh, well, there are plenty of people out there that you can't, and you're lucky you haven't let any of them in already," Kacchan huffed, pushing his way past Shindo to look at the weapons. "Get a damn lock for this thing, moron."

Shindo's face flushed, Diasuke and Hanzo shared uncertain glances, and Izuku could only smile and shrug when those looks ended up drifting his way.

"The hell?" Kacchan snapped, as he started to push the weapons aside, holding up a knife and eyeing down the length of it before he chucked it aside. "You didn't think to clean this shit before you shoved it in here? Half of it's fucking rusted!"

"If you see a machete in there with red string around the handle, that's mine," Daisuke said, leaning forward slightly so she could look into the chest.

"Sure, if it ain't fucking ruined ..."

"What are you even looking for?" Shindo asked with a heavy sigh.

"We're going to need decent weapons going up there," Izuku supplied, as Kacchan grunted his acknowledgement, head still buried in the chest. "Something long and blunt for the most part, nothing that will get stuck in the zombies and slow you down. Plus, you need something as a backup if they get too close to you."

"A machete will probably do," Kacchan said, as he pulled free the black-handled object, the red string darkened in places by what Izuku was sure had to be blood. Kacchan huffed as he looked at it before holding it out to Daisuke. "At least this ain't rusted to shit."

"I'm sure there's enough in there we can make use of," Izuku said, as Kacchan threw him a foul look and kept digging.

"You got any damn tools here?"

"A few basics," Shindo replied.

"Welding, anything like that?"

"I think it's pretty clear we don't have a fucking metal workshop down here in the sewers," Shindo snapped. "We got a hammer, a saw, a couple of screwdrivers... probably a bunch of nails and screws somewhere."

"That'll have to do."

Kacchan seemed to have gathered a small supply of weapons that he looked happy enough with: a heavy-looking metal chain, a metal bat, another machete of sorts, and what looked like a fireman's

axe. Then, just as he was about to look away, he spotted something else, and pulled out a wooden bat with a sharp *'hah!'*

"Pick something from that," Kacchan said, kicking the axe and swinging the wooden bat over his shoulder. "There's plenty of knives in there; just grab some that ain't rusted and put them where you can easily reach them."

Izuku looked down and hesitated. His plumbing pipe was perfectly satisfactory, but he couldn't deny the fireman's axe was calling to him. He glanced up to double-check neither Shindo nor Hanzo had their eyes on it before he snatched it up, feeling the weight in his hands. It wasn't his wakizashi, not by a long shot, but it would be good for pushing zombies back as well as smashing skulls.

"Why the hell did you pick the wooden bat when there's a metal one right there?" Daisuke asked as Hanzo reached for the metal one, and Kacchan's lips spread into a dangerous grin.

"Oi, Shindo, show me where the tools are."

The next handful of hours were spent going through the battle plan, and Izuku not so secretly watched Kacchan as he hammered nails into the wooden bat with a look on his face like a child in a sweet shop, hiding his fond smile under his hand. How it was that Kacchan putting together a weapon designed to spread the brains of his enemies across the ground was somehow one of the most adorable things Izuku had seen in a while, he'd never know, but for his part he was just glad to see Kacchan passionate about something again. His fondness for the man only increased when he started to chuck bottles of white spirit and rags in his direction.

"Mollies are piss easy to make," Kacchan said. "Pour the spirit into bottles, make sure the rag fits flush- *the fuck you grinning at?*"

"Nothing!" Izuku said quickly, hurrying to snatch up the supplies thrown his way, pretending not to see the way Kacchan's gaze lingered on him for a moment before he huffed and carried on giving instructions.

Eventually, they had a good arsenal of weapons and makeshift bombs that they could use as a distraction should they need it and a plan in mind for how they were going to tackle the female zombie, and yet it was to a tense and muted atmosphere they returned to when they joined the rest of the group. Izuku could see how unsure they all were, how concerned. After all, if this plan failed, it would leave everyone trapped here. If they couldn't kill the female zombie, then what was left for them here but to hope the zombies left them in peace before they starved to death? Even Katsuma and Mahoro seemed to know that there was something wrong, the eldest keeping her brother close to her as they walked around the camp. But, as requested, Makabe had put together his most delicious-smelling ramen yet, there was music playing, and as Izuku watched a few bottles of something dark passed around, he presumed it was only a matter of time before things started to pick up.

"I'm grabbing some food, then heading back to the tent," Kacchan muttered from his side.

Izuku frowned, grabbing Kacchan's arm to get his attention.

"You not going to at least try?" he asked, voice low so they couldn't be overheard.

"This ain't my kinda thing," Kacchan replied. "I'd rather sleep."

"Do you want me to-"

"Enjoy yourself," Kacchan interrupted, averting his gaze. "Just... make sure you get plenty of rest."

Kacchan tugged his arm from Izuku's grip and headed to the pot, leaving Izuku feeling somewhat confused. And granted, he knew already that Kacchan wasn't entirely into social events... even back when they first met, he'd rarely see him hanging out in the kitchen with the others, preferring to be on watch, out on patrol, or in his room. But Izuku had to wonder how much of that was simply because he never felt like he could relax in the same way that everyone else could. He'd realised long ago now that Kacchan was always prepared, always ready; the Apocalypse had honed him into a weapon in his own right. But it had come at a cost that Izuku was only starting to really understand... he watched as Kacchan grabbed his bowl with a grunt of thanks to Makabe and head back to the tent with a certain sadness in his chest, the light that had been in his eyes just an hour ago all but gone.

"I wouldn't take it personally."

Izuku almost jumped at the voice suddenly at his side, looking to see Shindo now standing beside him, his eyes also fixed on Kacchan as he stalked off.

"He always liked his space."

Izuku blinked.

"I don't take it personally," he replied, to which Shindo simply hummed, hands shoved deep into his pockets as he still stared after Kacchan, even as the tent was sharply zipped shut. Izuku ran his tongue over his front teeth, feeling decidedly uneasy.

"So... you guys are a thing, right?"

Sure enough, Shindo asked the one question that Izuku had been dreading ever since he found out that Shindo was Kacchan's ex ... of sorts. The one question that Izuku really didn't want to answer. "I mean, you share a tent and all. Plus, you've got those nicknames for one another."

Izuku's mind was already racing... *were they a thing?* The obvious answer was a resounding *yes*. Enough had happened between them, enough had been said, that Izuku was sure it was a question of timing more than anything now. But what was going on between the two of them was... private. Intimate in ways Izuku had never really experienced before now, and still hella fucking confusing, if he had to be real honest with himself. It wasn't the sort of thing Izuku felt he would have been comfortable talking to any of his friends about, let alone with Kacchan's ex.

"No," Izuku replied instead, and Shindo looked around at him, eyebrows almost at his hairline in surprise.

"Hah?" he said, sounding so much like Kacchan that Izuku almost winced. "You sure about that?"

Izuku bristled. "I think I'd know," he said, waspishly. "Why're you even asking?"

"Oh! Oh, I'm not getting in your business or anything!" Shindo said, with an all too wide smile. "It's just... look, I've known Kat for a long time, and he seems so different from what I remember."

Izuku wanted to say that Shindo hadn't known Kacchan for at least the last two years, but he knew how petty it would sound.

"Well, I don't know what Kacchan was like back in high school," he said, "but he's changed plenty since I first met him too."

"Hmm," Shindo hummed again. "Well, I guess the Apocalypse will do that to you, huh? The Kat I knew had a lot more fire in him, you know? I mean, sure, he's still a grumpy bastard, but he feels real... docile."

Izuku didn't want to feel pissed off by this. He was sure that, deep down, Shindo certainly meant no harm in what he was saying, but what the hell else did he expect? No one was the same person they were before the Apocalypse! And, from the little he'd gathered about the relationship Kacchan and Shindo had, it was far from the happiest one. Was it unreasonable to think the *'fire'* that Shindo missed so much was simply goddamn unhappiness?

"Look," Izuku said, not doing a good job at hiding the sharpness in his tone, "I'm not going to pretend I know anything about what went on between you and Kacchan. He hasn't told me, and I'm not going to ask; it isn't my business."

Shindo huffed. "'Course he hasn't."

"But he's been through some shit," Izuku pressed. "We all have."

"I think you got me all wrong here, Midoriya. This isn't an interrogation! The dude's my friend; I'm just concerned."

"Well, don't be," Izuku snapped. An awkward silence followed, Izuku realising quite how defensive he was being as Shindo looked back at him with an indignant expression on his face.

"Uh," Izuku breathed out through his nose. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to snap-"

"Nah, I get it," Shindo interrupted. "Let's be frank here. You like him, and I'm the mysterious ex he won't tell you about; it's awkward."

"I don't-"

"I ain't trying to take him from you. Been there, done that, as they say!" Shindo laughed, and Izuku felt the bile rise to his throat. "All I'm gonna say is, under all the bells and whistles, I still can't figure out what kind of guy he is, and the way he's changed? Shit, I dunno, it makes me uncomfortable. Something feels off about him, and I can't figure out what."

"There isn't anything off about him."

"Right." Shindo sighed. "Well, word of advice, stay cautious."

Shindo clapped a hand on his shoulder in a companionable way, flashed him another wide smile, then walked away, leaving Izuku with his mind racing and his stomach churning. He wasn't a complete stranger to jealousy, especially recently, but he still couldn't quite figure out whether Shindo's words were genuinely ones of concern or a warning, or if he was simply a manipulative bastard under the surface. He watched Shindo for a moment longer as he interacted with others in

his group before he let out an unsteady breath and let the hands he hadn't realised had curled into fists hang loose at his side.

"Mr Deku!"

Izuku dragged his eyes away from Shindo to look at the boy at his side, surprised to see a second pair of large eyes staring up at him, those narrowed and suspicious above a pout.

"Hi Katsuma, and Mahoro too!"

"I'm only here coz Katsuma wants to talk to you," she said immediately, her arms crossing over her chest, and Izuku couldn't hold back the grin. Now that he thought about it, she reminded him an awful lot of another pouty blond...

"Well, that seems fair," Izuku said, crouching down in front of them.

"You're really going out there tomorrow, Mr Deku?" Katsuma asked.

"I am," Izuku replied, before adding for good measure, "You're going to look after the people here for me?"

"See, I told you," Mahoro said. "Even this guy thinks you need to stay here."

This guy? Izuku was fairly certain Kacchan would have gotten a kick out of that.

"I know, I know, I heard you," Katsuma mumbled, his cheeks burning pink. "You're being so bossy."

"Hey, it'll be over before you know it," Izuku said with a smile. "And I haven't forgotten my promise, either! I know just where I can find some more All Might comics for you."

Katsuma's eyes lit up. "Will you read some of them with me when you get back?"

"Sure, of course!"

"Ok, are you done now?" Mahoro said, grabbing her brother's hand again. "I'm hungry."

"Ok... bye, Mr Deku!"

"See you later."

He would be sure to grab as many All Might manga as he could physically carry, just as soon as the female zombie was dealt with. He wondered if maybe he could get an All Might doll or something for him as well. Hell, maybe he could find more stickers; those kids certainly deserved it. This whole thing was showing no signs of stopping... Izuku had long ago given up that vague hope that someone, somewhere, was devising a vaccine. That he would one day wake up to find the army sweeping through the streets and that he and his friends would be taken to somewhere safe and far away from this hell. By all appearances, the zombies were here to stay, and Katsuma and Mahoro wouldn't be the only children out there who would grow up knowing little else but the Apocalypse. Running, starving, not being able to enjoy the things that he had taken for granted when he was a kid; a whole generation that would spend their entire lives living like that. And if some All Might manga could make Katsuma forget about all of that, for even a moment, then surely it was worth

any risk. At that thought, he looked back to the tent that Kacchan shared. He wasn't certain, but something told him that Kacchan would understand that too.

Izuku stayed another hour at the party after that. After all, the food was good, and now that there were some bottles being passed around, the mood had begun to lift. He'd laughed along with everyone else as Katsuma and Mahoro had danced to the music, dragging some of the adults into the circle with them, and it had only been a matter of time before he was wrenched forward into the fray. It felt good to even pretend that he could relax for a moment, that he could just enjoy the music and the food and the laughter around him, but a large part of him ached. He had laughed a lot once, and whilst it hadn't been in a sewer deep underground, he remembered parties in Ochako's dorm room; he remembered giggling uncontrollably as she tried to get Shouto to dance with her, the man tripping over his own feet and looking more embarrassed than he could remember seeing him. There had even been that brief moment, oh so long ago now, where Sero had started to feel better, seeing the relief on the faces of those around them when he had eaten a full meal and smiled back at them. But those memories never came to him alone. They were paired with images of blood across an empty room, or a body slumped against the wall with its face missing, of dead eyes and a snapping jaw as hands pressed against his chest.

But he could make this one a good memory. All he had to do was kill the female zombie, and he could save all of these people. He could look back to Katsuma's grinning face without seeing blood.

It wasn't until the children started dancing with the other adults that Izuku decided to excuse himself. He needed space to think; he needed to go over this damn plan from top to bottom, be sure there was nothing that he had missed, and that every possible angle was covered. And, though he knew that Kacchan was dealing with it in his own way, he wanted to check on him too.

When he unzipped their shared tent and stepped in, it was to find Kacchan sitting cross-legged on his sleeping bag, sharpening the collection of knives spread out to his side, and certainly not sleeping as Izuku had half expected to find him. Surprised, Kacchan looked up, brows raised.

"Ain't the party just started?" he grunted, and Izuku shrugged with a small smile, sitting down across from him.

"I'm kinda tired," he admitted, and he felt it, too. "The kids keep wanting to dance."

Kacchan snorted, placing the knife in his hand down with the others and wrapping his hands around his knees with a smirk on his face.

"You mean I missed watching your dorky ass try to dance?"

Izuku flushed, his lower lip pouting.

"Real funny, Kacchan."

Kacchan huffed a laugh, the smirk fading into what could be considered a ghost of a smile as he continued to watch him. When Izuku made eye contact, however, his gaze dropped down to the knives at his side, that solemnness that lingered about him returning. Izuku inched forward.

"Hey," he said, and Kacchan's eyes immediately darted back to him. "Are you ok?"

A classic scowl returned to Kacchan's face. "Hah? Course I fucking am, nerd!"

"Is it the mission tomorrow?" Izuku continued, not believing Kacchan for a moment. "Because, it's ok to be worried-"

"I ain't worried about it," Kacchan snapped, sounding harried. "And quit calling it a *mission*, dumbass. You read too many comic books."

"Ok, so if you're not worried about that, then what? Because I know there's something up."

"There ain't."

"Is it just being here?" Izuku pressed. "I guess it's probably still weird for you, right? What with Shindo being here and everything."

"Will you qui- *that ain't it*!"

"The female zombie, then?"

"Holy fuck, you are not gonna make this fucking easy for me, are you?"

"Make what easy?"

Kacchan snapped his mouth shut, his cheeks turning pink. "Nothing."

"Kacchan what?" Izuku all but whined, reaching forward and grabbing hold of the loose fabric of his pants without thinking. Kacchan seemed to rear back, eyes widening, before he snatched at Izuku's hands and yanked them away from his knees.

"You're so fuckin- *why're you so*-" Kacchan let out a strangled growl, Izuku just sitting there, palms spread under Kacchan's tight grip around his wrists, confused. "You were supposed to stay out there, asshole! Have fun, for fuck sake! At least gimme a damn minute to figure this shit out!"

Izuku blinked. "Figure what out? Wh- wait, the mission? Kacchan, it was basically your idea! We can't change our minds now!"

"No, not the damn mission!" Kacchan snarled before dropping Izuku's wrists and running both hands through his hair. "Dammit, Deku."

He sighed, shoulders slumping as his hands fell into his lap, and Izuku's stomach twisted tightly.

"Kacchan, what's going on?"

Izuku spoke as softly as he could, recognising the obvious distress behind Kacchan's hard eyes and trying not to let himself panic. Kacchan sighed again and looked up, eyes visibly darting across Izuku's face.

"What?" Izuku repeated.

"Shit," Kacchan hissed, still looking at him. "This is awkward as fuck when you can't just..." He raised his hands in exasperation.

"Can't just *what?*" Izuku asked, feeling frustrated now.

"When I can't just kiss you!" Kacchan snapped, and Izuku froze, eyes widening.

"Oh."

"Yeh, oh," Kacchan huffed, crossing his arms over his chest and looking away in an effort to hide his reddening face. "Bitch."

Izuku sat in place, feeling his cheeks burn, Kacchan refusing to look at him, and suddenly the mere foot of space between them felt like a mile. He could be reading this entirely wrong, but he was sure from the blush on Kacchan's face that he wasn't. The man wasn't wrong. He couldn't think of an instant in his entire life where someone hadn't made their intentions clear by first kissing him. It was a solid first move, wasn't it? Lean in, kiss, and the rest just sort of happens after that. And yet here they both were, awkward as all hell with no reliable icebreaker. *Not to mention ...*

"I don't think calling me *'bitch'* helps," Izuku found himself muttering. "Killer move."

Kacchan seemed to choke, mouth gaping. "Son of a- I'm doing my damn best!"

"And ‘bitch’ was it?" Izuku quipped back.

Izuku wasn't even aware that Kacchan had moved until he felt his back on the ground, a hand against his chest knocking a yelp from his throat, fingers scrabbling at Kacchan's shoulders as he found himself blinking up at sharp teeth in shock.

"You're so fucking annoying!" Kacchan snapped. "You never stop talking! And you're always putting others before yourself, getting into damn trouble all the time. You're a goddamn self-sacrificing *bastard,* and for what, hah? It's always my dumb ass pulling you out of trouble! When is it gonna get into that thick fucking skull of yours that I'm not- that I ain't-" Kacchan swallowed, throat bobbing, the anger on his face simmering down to a look close to desperation, and Izuku felt his breath catch in his already tight chest. "Hell, Deku, I ain't always gonna be there to save you!"

A stunned silence followed his words, the two of them staring at one another, Kacchan seemingly on the brink, his eyes pinning Izuku to the spot almost as if he was desperate for Izuku to understand.

"Kacchan," he breathed, but Kacchan shook his head furiously.

"Don't you fucking pity me," he said. "And don't talk down to me about this shit. We both know I'm gonna turn and I-" Kacchan took a deep, shuddering breath. "Fuck, I got regrets. I got a lot of them. And I just wanna do this last fucking good thing, help these assholes, those fucking kids, but if it gets you killed I-"

"It won't," Izuku said firmly, and Kacchan laughed humourlessly.

"You don't know that," he breathed.

"There's a lot of stuff we don't know, Kacchan."

Kacchan's eyes searched his face again, Izuku lying where he had been pushed, Kacchan's heavy yet comfortingly warm weight against his chest, watching as he took another deep breath.

"I know one thing," he finally replied, voice low as he looked back at Izuku with a steadiness that left Izuku feeling dizzy. "I know there are some things I don't wanna regret. Moments I don't wanna look back on when I-" He paused again, and Izuku's heart swelled in his chest when the hand

gripping his t-shirt moved up to cup his cheek, the rough burning heat of Kacchan's palm at odds with the chill as the hairs on his arms stood on end.

"I know one thing," Kacchan repeated.

Eyes simultaneously soft yet molten drifted to his lips, to his chin, and down as Kacchan's face followed suit, Izuku feeling the soft brush of hot lips against his jaw. His breath hitched, hands instinctively tightening around Kacchan's shoulders, and that was all the encouragement he needed. Kacchan's mouth shifted across the length of Izuku's jaw before setting on the point just below his ears, an open-mouth kiss followed by the gentle swirl of a tongue and the insistent tightening of lips. Izuku had to bite back a moan... it had been so long, so embarrassingly long, since someone had been this close to him, had touched him like that; even the sensation of Kacchan's breath in his ear was close to overwhelming.

"Is this ok?" Kacchan asked, voice rumbling through his chest and across Izuku's entire body. Izuku, completely unable to speak, nodded, raising one hand from Kacchan's shoulder before embedding his fingers into the long spikes of his hair, marvelling at how soft it was and how easily his fingers slid through the strands, such a stark contrast to the mess atop his own head. The movement ushered the smallest of purrs from the back of Kacchan's throat, and it occurred to him that Kacchan was probably every bit as touch starved as he was. Every brush of his lips against his neck felt soothing yet electrifying all at the same time, and god, he wished he could meet him. Oh, how he wished he could taste the lips that were stoking a fire inside of him.

Hands drifting down his body pushed the thought from his mind however, his breath hitched when he felt large palms against his ribcage, drifting downwards, the rough pad of a thumb running across the bare skin above Izuku's waistband. He couldn't see much besides the top of Kacchan's head from this angle, and damn would he have liked both of his eyes back right now so as to not miss a chance to count a single strand of golden hair.

"Where are you scratched?" Kacchan murmured into his neck.

"H-huh?"

"Scratched, or cut," Kacchan said, pulling his head back so that he could look at him again, cheeks flushed that beautiful pink. "I need to know where to avoid and-"

"O-oh!" Izuku breathed. "Right, I... uh, just some on my arms and hands, I think."

Kacchan took his hand from Izuku's waist, leaning back so that he was now sat on his thighs, the sight of Kacchan stretching out over him like that causing his heart to skip a beat. Kacchan reached out to take his right arm, pushing up his sleeve to his shoulder before his fingers started to trace down his skin, as if he was mapping to memory each and every mark, his thumb ghosting each cut and scar. Izuku knew the reason for it; if any of them were fresh, if Kacchan accidentally kissed anywhere there was cut skin, it would put Izuku at risk of being infected, and at that thought it was like a fist had squeezed his heart. He looked back to Kacchan's face, seeing the uncertain furrow of his brow as his fingers traced the outline of his burn scar.

"Wait."

Kacchan looked up.

"We should... before, I mean. Talk about what's safe and, uh," he swallowed, hoping his face wasn't as red as it felt.

"Right," Kacchan replied, nodding. Izuku expected Kacchan to move away, but he stayed there, sitting on top of him, hand sliding down to his wrist before he gently tugged Izuku's arm towards him. Izuku swallowed as he watched Kacchan stare at his hand almost intently, thumb brushing across the inside of his palm.

"It's a good idea to make sure there aren't any cuts or anything I haven't noticed or forgotten," Izuku started, trying to sound confident enough for both of them, the uncertainty Kacchan was feeling so clear in the furrow of his brow as he focused on the hand in his. Kacchan nodded, remaining silent. "And, well, we know we can't kiss. Uh, on the mouth at least."

Kacchan's eyes, subconsciously or not, darted to his lips before immediately drifting back to his hands. Izuku swallowed.

"I mean, uh... I dunno how- or if you-" he cleared his throat, his free hand starting to play with the fabric of the sleeping bag beneath him. "Anything that might, uh, you know, exchange fluids-" *god this was so fucking uncomfortable!* "-we should either u-use condoms or not... uh, do."

"Fuck me," Kacchan said suddenly, raising one hand to his face before he let out a nervous laugh. "You look like you're about to shit yourself."

Izuku's lips clamped together before pouting outwards.

"This is awkward!" he protested.

"Alright."

Kacchan cleared his throat, gently dropping Izuku's hand. "Rule number one, then. No kissing on the mouth." Izuku nodded as Kacchan held up a single finger. "Rule two, check for cuts and scratches first." Another nod, and another finger. "Rule three, we use a condom. I guess you won't have to for everything, but I do."

"S-sure."

"Rule four," Kacchan continued, his cheeks still decidedly pink but looking more confident, "I can go down on you if you wear a condom, but you can't on me."

Izuku hesitated. "Uh, but if you're wearing one-"

"Fuck, Deku, I ain't gonna put your life in the hands of a bit of fucking plastic. What if it breaks?"

"O-oh." *Did he sound disappointed?* Going on the minute raise of one of Kacchan's eyebrows, he was sure he probably did. "Ok, that makes sense."

"Good. Rule five. I bottom, you top."

If Izuku had been blushing before, his face was no doubt on fire now. And it wasn't like he hadn't already thought about that... If he couldn't give Kacchan a damn blowjob for fear of the condom breaking, then there was certainly no way that he'd risk topping. But Izuku realised with a sliver of anxiety that he wasn't exactly experienced in this area. He'd topped before, but generally speaking

his partners had all preferred to be the ones doing the fucking, and he'd never exactly taken issue with that. Right up until he'd realised what Kacchan's condition meant, he just figured if anything happened between them, it would be the same way. No, the idea of him fucking someone like Kacchan was entirely terrifying.

"Is that a problem?"

Izuku realised that he hadn't responded and shook his head.

"Ok." Kacchan took a deep breath. "Ok, anything I'm forgetting?"

Izuku shook his head again. "I- uh, I think we can both use common sense for, you know... everything else."

"Ok," Kacchan agreed. "So."

"So."

Izuku's chest tightened in anxiety again at the awkwardness of the situation before, to his entire full-body relief, Kacchan grinned. It was that familiar teasing smirk that he had grown so used to and so fond of, and frankly, he had missed it so damn badly these last weeks. The anxiety began to roll off him.

"*So*," Kacchan repeated, before he leaned back over, his hands pressing either side of Izuku's head. "Damn dork."

"Brave words from someone who's also a dork," Izuku replied, his voice breaking into a laugh, blessed with a genuine smile from Kacchan before his face ducked down again, lips latching back onto the point on Izuku's jaw that had drawn gasps from him before.

"Rule one," Kacchan muttered into the kiss, his lips trailing down Izuku's throat, finger hooking into the neck of his tee and pulling it down so that he would have access to Izuku's collarbone. It was heaven – the sensation, the warmth, the laugh that still rumbled in his chest turning to a moan, fingers quickly finding soft golden locks again. Hands drifted back to his sides, fingers pulling at the fabric of his shirt, before he felt two hot palms against his skin.

"Rule two," Kacchan said, looking up at him. And Kacchan really, truly, was a dork. He might be the one calling Izuku a nerd, but for all his damn insults, for how cock-sure he'd always appeared, Kacchan was less than smooth. But the smirks and the way he counted down the rules only had Izuku's heart swelling. He nodded.

Kacchan took hold of Izuku's shirt and started to pull it up his body. With a wiggle, Izuku pushed himself up, his arms raising over his head as the article was discarded, goosebumps appearing across his skin. Izuku knew he was far from his best... he'd always been thin, but there was a time when the litheness was also partnered with some muscle structure. These days, however, he was little more than skin and bone, his body just another reminder of how hard it was to survive out here, and the second Kacchan's eyes dropped to his bare torso, Izuku began to feel anxious again. Izuku suspected it had something to do with Kacchan's condition, another part of the complicated puzzle, but he looked like a damn twig in comparison to Kacchan's wide biceps, and it was hard not to feel self-conscious about it.

"Cute."

Izuku blinked, looking up at him. "H-hah?"

"What? I can say nice things!" Kacchan snapped, his cheeks turning pink again, and Izuku's heart fluttered. Hands went back to his midriff, Kacchan mapping out his stomach just as he had done his arms, thumb running over the dip of his navel, bringing attention to the scars that Izuku had almost forgotten about. There was the obvious one on his side from where he had impaled himself on the tree branch all those months ago, the injury that was perhaps partially responsible for bringing Izuku to Kacchan, but there were also smaller marks: white nicks in his skin from climbing fences, ducking through bushes, and all the things he'd needed to do to survive. Kacchan seemed almost unable to look away, fingers inspecting each mark, and Izuku had never felt so exposed and yet, so safe. Flat palms ran up his ribcage and to his chest, Kacchan's hands so wide that they more than spanned the entire width of Izuku's chest, resting across the smallest padding of muscles that remained there, doggedly holding onto Izuku's former physique. Kacchan then swiped his thumbs, each one brushing against Izuku's nipples and ushering a hiss from Izuku's lips. The almost innocent expression of curiosity on Kacchan's face morphed into another smirk.

"Good to know," he said, voice low.

And then his hands drifted lower again, Izuku watching almost in reverence as those large palms covered almost the entirety of his torso, fingers slotting into every dip and groove, and coming to rest at the waistband of his jeans. He remembered, with a flush, that he was still wearing the lower-cut women's pair he had grabbed all the way back in the city, though thankfully they had since stretched enough to be comfortable. But Kacchan didn't seem to voice any complaints, his eyes lingering on Izuku's protruding hip bones before they darted back to his face again.

It was almost adorable, the way Kacchan seemed to check in with him each and every step of the way. It was hard to imagine now that this was the same man who had almost drunkenly strangled him to death not weeks after they had first met, the same man who had spit hatred in his direction at every opportunity. Fingers curled into the waistband of his jeans, making Kacchan's intent entirely clear, and Izuku nodded, watching with his breath held as Kacchan made quick work of the button and zipper. He proceeded to pull both jeans and underwear down, Izuku's skin prickling and face burning as he found himself bare to the cold air, still only half hard and scarcely able to breathe. Then he heard Kacchan's intake of breath, saw the heated way his eyes lingered as his jeans were pulled the rest of the way, and Izuku hurried to kick them from off his feet, leaving him butt naked on the sleeping bag.

"Anywhere you don't have them fuckin' freckles, Deku?" Kacchan breathed, his voice suspiciously ragged, that teasing drag of his fingers working their way back up from his feet, inspecting his calf muscles for marks. When Kacchan brushed over his knees, Izuku jolted, an embarrassing squeak leaving his lips, Kacchan immediately looking upwards as Izuku clamped a hand down over his mouth. Kacchan hummed, hands massaging the outer edges of Izuku's legs in a way that spread chills up his spine, and he moaned into his palm. Apparently he was just that touch-starved ...

"Interesting."

"Kacchan," Izuku whined. "Don't make fun of me."

"Oh, I definitely ain't making fun of you."

Hands drifted from his sensitive calves and up to the expanse of his thighs, his legs perhaps the only part of his body that hinted at what he had once been pre-apocalypse, months of climbing and running honing him into the picture of survival. Kacchan squeezed, pulling another squeak from

Izuku's lips, seeming to delight in the sound as he chuckled and started running his thumb across the soft skin of his inner thigh, and suddenly it all felt like fire against him. He tried not to pant for air, as that gentle friction alone brought him to full hardness, his dick twitching obviously and wantonly, Kacchan's eyes drawn to the sight and another dark chuckle filling the tent.

"Turn around."

"Hah?"

"I gotta check your back, too, Deku," Kacchan replied. Izuku wanted to say that they were nowhere near finished with his front yet, but the gentle pressure on his hips and that damn insistent smirk convinced him otherwise, and still feeling red-faced in embarrassment, he let himself be lifted, rolling onto his front.

Kacchan groaned, the sound leaving his throat so suddenly Izuku almost jumped, looking back over his shoulder to see Kacchan's eyes obviously fixed on his ass, and it was Izuku's turn to smirk, his smile half hidden by his shoulder.

"Should I have mentioned I have freckles there too or...?"

Kacchan looked up, cheeks flushing when he realised that Izuku was watching him.

"You think?" he grunted, before he grinned. "I wonder..."

"Wonder wh- *ahh*!" Izuku squeaked as Kacchan's fingertips dragged up the inside of his legs. "Kacchan!"

"Deku," Kacchan mimicked, voice still teasing, before he leaned forward and pressed his lips against the inside of Izuku's right knee. He whimpered again, electing to bury his burning face in the blanket beneath him, toes curling at the sensation. He wondered if his body had always been this sensitive – the life before now seemed so very far away – or if it was Kacchan and Kacchan alone who made his skin burn like this. Kacchan, who touched him so tenderly and gently, like he couldn't remember being handled before. Kacchan, who... Izuku gasped as the warmth from Kacchan's breath started to rise, the hairs on his thighs standing on end, his ass clenching. He stopped wondering, stopped trying to remember, and stopped thinking altogether and let his body slump where it lay, shoulders relaxing, a needy mewl of pleasure breaking free. Kacchan's hands, his goddamn *hands*, grasped each cheek, fingers dipping into the soft flesh of his ass and spreading, and when he felt the tongue dragged up so close to his hole, he moaned. A sound far too loud for the confines of their tent, a sound that had Kacchan suddenly caging him in, palms spread either side of his head, the weight of his body against his back.

"What a surprise you're loud," Kacchan all but whispered in his ear, lips brushing against the skin. "But you gotta keep it down, Deku."

Izuku wanted to say that was far easier said than done. He hadn't intended to make that much noise to start with, and with Kacchan's entire body spread out on top of him, the heat was overwhelming. The rough fabric of Kacchan's jeans scratched against his ass, the hard outline of his dick almost slotted between his cheeks, and the thrill of that contrast, skin against denim, was the kind of thrill he hadn't considered before. The fact that his own dick was pressed tightly between his stomach and the bedding beneath him certainly wouldn't let him think of much else.

"You done with rule two yet?" Izuku spluttered instead, and Kacchan hummed.

"Not yet."

Kacchan leaned back; Izuku was sure he was deliberately letting his weight press against Izuku's ass, deliberately rocking back then forward again as he spread his hands over his shoulders.

"*Kacchan,*" Izuku whined.

"Fine, fine..."

Kacchan scooted back, and Izuku took that opportunity to push himself up and flip over. Kacchan half sat, thighs spread either side of Izuku's as Izuku leaned forward to reach him, fingers gripping hold of the fabric across his chest. Kacchan looked so smug, like he knew what he was doing to Deku, like having him naked beneath him was all just part of the plan, like he was the one in control of this situation. Izuku felt his chest swell, adrenaline spiking when he realised what he really wanted.

"When can we get to rule five, huh?" he breathed, and that smug look faltered. Kacchan's cheeks flushed, his breath quickened, and he sucked his lower lip in sharply. And hell did Izuku enjoy this feeling. Fuck, did he enjoy that sudden spike of excitement. Izuku was used to taking a certain role in the bedroom, and it sure as shit wasn't this. But he realised he wanted it. He wanted to make Kacchan whine and wanted the thrill of making a man such as he sob if he could.

He leaned forward, reaching around Kacchan and grabbing his pack. Kacchan watched in silence, not saying a word as Izuku finally fished out the purple box that had haunted the both of them for so long. He tore at the plastic with his teeth, pulling one of the packets from inside before pushing it into Kacchan's hand.

"Rule three, Kacchan," Izuku said, leaning back on his elbows and gesturing to his dick, and Kacchan was ripping the packet in an instant, chucking the plastic over his shoulder, before a growl left his lips.

It probably wasn't the most pressing matter, certainly not during the Apocalypse, but when you were constantly on the run, sleeping in close quarters with other people, getting off suddenly became an entirely elusive prospect. Izuku couldn't quite honestly remember the last time he'd jerked off, and as such his poor neglected dick wasn't at all prepared for the searing pressure that gripped it in that moment. Kacchan rolled the condom on in one swift movement, causing Izuku's hips to buck up to meet him and a moan to leave his lips again.

"What now, *Deku*?" Kacchan said, purring his name in a way that was driving Izuku wild. Something about hearing his nickname spilling from those lips, in that low gravelly tone that Izuku had only ever heard in relation to him, and hell, maybe Kacchan still had the control after all. How could one word affect him like this?

"R-" Izuku huffed, his confidence fading as Kacchan's hand tightened around his dick again, tugging ever so subtly upwards. "Ru- *hah-"*

"Just say it, Deku," Kacchan breathed. Izuku whined; his face was so hot, but Kacchan continued to stare at him, his face so close, waiting... expecting...

"Rule f-four," Izuku gasped, and Kacchan threw him another smirk before he leaned down, hand gripping the base of his dick before immediately wrapping his mouth around the head and sliding down, sucking hard.

"Ahh!" Izuku cried before slapping his hand over his mouth, falling back onto the blanket. He wasn't one to brag, but he'd always been pretty good at giving head. If his partner's reactions were to be believed, at least. But receiving had always been a bit of a mixed bag. Izuku, generally speaking, preferred to take things slow. Soft and sweet, that had always been his experience, so when Kacchan pressed hard against the underside of his dick with the flat of his tongue and swallowed, Izuku couldn't move. He could hardly breathe, a soft whine the only indication that he was alive at all. He felt that tongue slide back down, the circle of Kacchan's thumb and pointer finger tightening around the base, and his hands swung down, holding onto Kacchan's hair as if for dear life. At Izuku's grasp, Kacchan let out a moan of his own, low and drawn out, and Izuku finally felt as though he had the strength to raise his head and look down.

The sight that met him would have taken his breath away if he had any left to steal. Kacchan's eyes were shut, his lashes fluttering against his cheeks, an almost serene expression on his face as his hand tightened and loosened around the base of Izuku's dick. His other hand lay against Izuku's thigh, the thumb rubbing almost lazily against his skin, and Izuku was stunned. Each hard swallow drove him wild; it took everything he had not to buck his hips up into Kacchan's throat, but they were so at odds yet so... fitting to the calm contentment on Kacchan's face. The premature lines in his brow from probably a lifetime of scowling were softened, his hair hung so elegantly onto his face, and Izuku was struck by how pretty he was. Sexy? Sure, he'd always been that, but pretty? His features looked so delicate, despite his hands seemingly swallowing his frame whole. How had he never noticed how pink his lips were before now? Kacchan drew back, the image of his lips sliding to the tip of his dick before swallowing him whole again no doubt burned into his memory from this point on, and it was enough for Izuku to realise quite how close he was to cumming here and now.

He pushed an elbow back before tugging gently on Kacchan's hair. Kacchan looked up, mouth still around his dick, his expression blissed out and content, and Izuku whined again.

"Sl-slow down, I'm gonna-" Izuku managed, and Kacchan pulled off of him, his nose brushing against the length of his dick, and he smirked, that slow grin somehow even more powerful when paired with the already fucked-out look on his face.

"That's what I was aiming for."

Izuku sat up, pushing against the heavy weight of Kacchan's shoulder until Kacchan was sitting on his haunches, looking amused.

"Not yet," Izuku said, and Kacchan raised an eyebrow.

"Ok, then tell me what you want, *Deku*."

Did he have to keep saying his name like that? Izuku reached forward and grabbed the hem of Kacchan's shirt, and he was quick to assist, raising his arms above his head. Izuku had the pleasure of looking at and *touching* Kacchan's body on multiple occasions now, but that did little to ease the sudden dryness of his throat, his eyes dropping to the powerful torso stretched out in front of him. Hands immediately jumped to his chest, fingers caressing each and every defined muscle, a parched tongue darting out to circle one of Kacchan's nipples and ushering a moan from him. If Izuku wasn't so intoxicated by the sight and smell of Kacchan, he might have teased him for it; instead, he just let his hands continue to rove and explore until the texture of the skin changed and Kacchan let out a gasp and shuddered. Izuku opened his eyes, realising that his thumb was brushing against the large purple scar at Kacchan's side, and his breath caught for an entirely different

reason. There was no denying it; the veins were darker, reaching up high over his torso and spreading across his stomach, raised beneath his fingertips.

"Kacchan..."

"Not now," Kacchan said immediately, and Izuku looked up to meet his eyes.

"But Kacchan," he breathed. "It's looking worse; we need to talk-"

"*Not now*," Kacchan repeated, grabbing both of Izuku's hands, and Izuku did not miss the air of desperation about him, pleading with Izuku to drop the subject.

"Ok."

Kacchan eyed him, uncertain, before he let go of Izuku's hands and instead pressed against his chest, pushing Izuku onto his back once more. Izuku allowed himself to fall, the soft blankets beneath him plush against his skin as he took in the sight of Kacchan still kneeling at his thighs, the angle allowing Izuku to take everything in. He was paler than he remembered, now that he really looked. The puncture marks surrounding the darkest part of his scar stood out pale against the purple, and Izuku could have cried. He could have pulled Kacchan to his chest and screamed into his hair, were it not for the look in Kacchan's eyes. He needed this every bit as much as Izuku did. He needed to feel *alive* in that moment.

Kacchan's fingers dropped to the waistband of his jeans, unbuckling his belt, hands trembling enough for Izuku to notice. He placed his own on Kacchan's thighs; for as much of a mess as his own feelings were right now, he wanted to be as comforting and encouraging as he could for Kacchan. Spurred on, Kacchan raised his knees, positioning himself between Izuku's legs as he pulled his jeans and underwear down in a single motion.

Izuku vaguely remembered a comment from oh so damn long ago, something about Izuku being as straight as his dick, certainly something crude like that if it had been Kacchan saying it... Of course, Kacchan was as sexy below the waist as he was above, his dick a perfect curve up towards his stomach, his thighs strong, and the light dusting of blond hair visible in the flickering from the oil lamp. Izuku made to move forward, to grip hold of his thighs again, before Kacchan was caging him in once more, arms spread either side of his head. The sensation of Kacchan's bare skin pressed against his, hot and electrifying and comforting all at the same time, was enough to leave Izuku feeling breathless as he stared into red eyes. Beautiful, haunted... *alive*. He reached out, caressing the side of Kacchan's face, watching lashes flutter shut against cheeks.

"Kacchan's so pretty," Izuku found himself breathing, and Kacchan's eyes opened, his face immediately burning red.

"Shuddup," he snapped, and Izuku smirked, leaning in to press a kiss on the end of Kacchan's nose, somehow making the man blush even more.

"Even prettier when you're blushing," he said, and Kacchan groaned in embarrassment. Izuku smiled as he started to press kisses across Kacchan's cheeks, moving across to his ear and down to his jaw, enjoying the way Kacchan's breath hitched. Then, Kacchan was moving again, an embarrassing whine left Izuku's lips when Kacchan's skin was out of reach, and he looked down to see Kacchan grabbing the purple packet again and tearing at a fresh condom. He wanted to reach out and pull the condom on himself, but Kacchan slipped it over his dick before Izuku could so much as blink and caged him in again. Izuku wasted no time latching his lips to Kacchan's jawline

again, lapping up each and every unsteady breath as he licked his way down to his collarbone, resisting the growing urge to bite down.

"*Deku*," Kacchan said, the sound close enough to a whine that it went straight down to his dick, twitching against his stomach. He wouldn't have been able to stop his hands from gliding down the shivering skin of Kacchan's side and grabbing hold of the ass sat on top of him, fingers digging into deceptively plush muscle.

"*Fuck*," Kacchan grunted into his hair, and Izuku's pulse quickened as he responded by grinding down, Izuku's dick sliding between his cheeks and making the both of them gasp. Izuku glanced up, meeting the red eyes staring hungrily back at him, and any uncertainty Izuku had washed away. He tightened his grip on Kacchan's ass and rocked his hips up, a certain haze drifting over him as he watched Kacchan's eyelids flutter, his bottom lip snagging between his teeth.

"Lube," Izuku spluttered, and Kacchan opened a single eye beneath his scowl.

"Ha- oh, fuck, hold on-"

Kacchan reached out again, his body stretching perfectly out to the side and giving Izuku a damn good look at the seemingly endless row of obliques and abdominal muscles and leaving his mouth feeling very dry again. In the next breath, Kacchan was sat up, sliding himself down Izuku's body onto his thighs as he squirted a sizeable dollop of lube onto the palm of his hand before that, too, was chucked over his shoulder. Izuku watched a single drop slide from the side of Kacchan's hand and onto his stomach, the breath knocked out from him as a slippery palm gripped his dick, the wet sound almost masking his groan. Kacchan pumped up and down three times, grip almost painfully hard and *all-too-Kacchan,* before shifting back up and positioning himself above him. Izuku blinked, dazed for a moment, before he caught on to what Kacchan was about to do.

"W-wait," he said, voice tipped with concern. "It's gonna hurt, don't you wanna-"

"Don't worry about it, I'm fine-"

"Kacchan, I don't want to hurt you! At least let me prep you!"

The lubed hand that had been gripping hold of Izuku's dick a moment earlier now held Izuku's wrist as he made to reach down between the two of them.

"You don't- I already fucking did it, alright?"

Izuku short-circuited, his jaw dropping, ears whistling.

"You- uh, already..." he squeaked, before clearing his throat and blushing. "Is that what you were doing in here before, uh..."

"Duh," Kacchan replied, somewhat waspishly. "That a problem?"

"Nope!" Izuku squeaked again. As much as Izuku found himself aching to push Kacchan's hand off of his wrist and continue reaching between them, he couldn't deny that the idea of Kacchan opening himself up in the tent whilst he had been out there with the party was goddamn hot. "Though, uh, next time lemme, you know... do it," he said, almost in a mumble. The indignant look on Kacchan's face faded for a moment, and Izuku was sure he saw his lips tremble before they were torn back into a scoff.

"Right."

He let go of Izuku's wrist before gripping Izuku's dick again and shifting up, lining himself up, and looking back up at him for confirmation. Izuku squeezed Kacchan's thighs, and he sank down.

The sensation was everything Izuku could have hoped for and more; he stuttered and moaned, *'fucks'* leaving both of their throats as Izuku was buried deeper and deeper into Kacchan's scolding heat. Inch by torturous inch Kacchan made room for him, until he bottomed out with a final gasp, wide eyes staring at one another over flushed cheeks and panting lips.

"Holy fuck," Kacchan choked. Izuku preened at the ragged words, the expression on Kacchan's face, and the idea that it was him pulling such sounds from his mouth, somehow hotter even than the fact that he was inside of him. He rolled his hips up, something that was surprisingly difficult to do under the weight on top of him, but the resulting moan was more than worth the effort. In response, Kacchan leaned forward, bracing both of his hands on either side of Izuku's head, clearly holding himself back.

"What're you waiting for, Kacchan?" Izuku breathed, not even completely aware of the words he was saying under the rush that came from the adrenaline of seeing Kacchan so eager above him. A fierce grin came to Kacchan's lips, his eyes flashed, before he raised his hips and slammed back down hard, Izuku crying out in surprise.

"This what you wanted, nerd?" he purred, before he bounced upwards again, setting a rough, fast pace.

"F-*fuck*," Izuku whimpered, unable to do much more than hold on as Kacchan rode him, the heat around his dick seeming to spread across his entire body. He was already so dangerously close after Kacchan had sucked him off, and if he had thought that was pleasurable, it was nothing compared to how tightly Kacchan's ass gripped him, sucking him in, the heavy weight of his dick against his stomach impossible to ignore. He brought a hand up to his mouth, biting down on the side of his thumb to stop himself from screaming out and alerting the entire goddamn party to what was going on inside the tent.

Kacchan growled, Izuku stuttering as his wrist was immediately wrenched from his mouth.

"K-Kacchan they'll h-ah, oh *god*-"

"Then be quiet," Kacchan replied with a smirk before he sat up. Izuku whined as Kacchan leaned back, his hands reaching behind him and balancing his weight on Izuku's thighs. His entire body lay open to him, chest high, abs tight, dick perfect and pretty, the pre-cum dripping from the tip collecting against the latex.

It wasn't fair, not really. Izuku might have thought that he was in control of the situation; the little noises that he had pulled from Kacchan were the biggest ego boost imaginable. But when he looked down to see Kacchan spread out on top of him, killer smirk on his lips, eyes burning, he knew he was entirely at this man's mercy. Kacchan rocked back and forth, setting a much slower pace this time, clenching around Izuku's dick each time he pulled out, the pressure making Izuku's head swim. He took one hand from Izuku's thigh and started to lazily stroke at his own dick, watching Izuku carefully.

"Like that?" he said, and Izuku whined, eyes drawn to the sight. "Huh, what about..?"

The hand withdrew again, Izuku following the motion with his hazy eyes, before he felt wet fingertips dragging over the top of his legs, and he shuddered.

"So sensitive," Kacchan purred with a grin.

It was Izuku's turn to growl. He bucked his hips up, almost unseating Kacchan for a moment as he reached forward. Perhaps he was surprised, perhaps Izuku was far stronger than he thought, or maybe he just let it happen, but one way or another, it was Kacchan who found himself landing on his back with a grunt, Izuku rearing over him.

"We'll see who's sensitive," he said, before grabbing hold of the underside of Kacchan's knees and heaving, bending him almost in two before he plunged back into the empty hungry hole spread open for him.

"Fuck!"

"Too loud, Kacchan," Izuku said, before he thrust hard and fast. Kacchan moaned, biting down hard on his lips, eyes shutting and brow screwed up. Izuku wondered at how easy it turned out to be to wipe that smirk off that pretty face, how easy it was to morph that confidence into an expression of pure abandon. He pushed down, opening Kacchan up further with each and every thrust.

"*De-Deku fu-fuck, fuck, holy shit, holy fuck-*"

The words quickly become unintelligible whimpers and moans as Izuku fucked him, torn between wanting to destroy him, leave him a blubbering, panting mess beneath him, or hold him closer. There would be time for rougher stuff later; right now he just needed to feel *alive*, needed Kacchan to feel alive, wanted, *loved*. He kept up the pace, pushing as deeply as he could, taking one hand from where it was gripping Kacchan's leg and placing it against his face. Kacchan's eyes fluttered open as he leaned into the contact.

"*Deku, fuck-*"

"Kacchan," Izuku panted. "G-god, *you feel so good*, ah!"

Kacchan bucked his hips into the contact, taking a gulp of air, and Izuku could tell from the way his movements stuttered, the way he was only letting out whines at this point, that he was close.

"Kacchan," he whimpered. "I'm... I'm close, ah-"

And then Kacchan reached out, pulling him close, his knees almost around his own ears at this point, grabbing the hand that had been pressed against his cheek and holding it against his chest. Izuku didn't need to ask to understand, to know what that look in his face meant. He could feel it, loud and booming and alive; Kacchan's heart beat so fast, his chest heaved, and Izuku grabbed Kacchan's hand and pressed it against his heart before the coil snapped. The immeasurable pleasure forced all the air from his lungs, Kacchan clenching hard around him as they came together.

It took several long moments for Izuku to become aware of anything beyond the afterglow, the sensation of Kacchan's hot body beneath him, that strong chest heaving and raising him up and down.

"That was..." Izuku panted, forehead against Kacchan's chest. Kacchan grunted, and Izuku rolled off of him, lying flat out on his back.

"*That was...*" he repeated, not entirely sure what to say, and glancing sideways as Kacchan let out a tired-sounding laugh.

"Fuck yeh, it was."

Kacchan's expression was more relaxed than he's perhaps ever seen him, with his brow softened and a gentle smile on his lips, eyes shut and breathing deeply.

"Roll over."

Kacchan opened one eye, looking at him quizzically.

"Huh?"

"Just roll over for me," Izuku continued, reaching over and grabbing Kacchan's sleeping bag.

"Ugh, Deku, I'm covered in lube-"

"I got it."

"Hah? Don't baby me-"

"Stop resisting my affections," Izuku interrupted, sticking his tongue out at Kacchan even as he grabbed a pack of wipes. Kacchan blushed again, that pretty pink almost addictive at this point, before he rolled over. Izuku shimmied up behind him, gently wiping the lube from between Kacchan's cheeks, trying to ignore the way his dick twitched again in interest and the indignant grunt from Kacchan, before he threw the wipe aside. He grabbed the sleeping bag and threw it over the both of them, nestling up against Kacchan's back.

"Oh what, so now I'm the fuckin' little spoon?" Kacchan snapped, and Izuku laughed.

"Mhmm." He pressed a kiss against Kacchan's shoulder blade before nuzzling up as close to the man as he could get, wrapping his arm around him.

"Dork," Kacchan grunted.

"Your dork," Izuku muttered, sleepily. Too content to notice the way Kacchan's breath hitched, too happy to feel the hard and heavy beating of Kacchan's pulse, too tired to see the way red eyes scrunched shut and pleasure morphed to grief.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 27: The Corpse of True Love Never Did Run Smooth

Chapter Summary

In which the attack on the hospital begins.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Izuku woke, it was to the sensation of being somewhat crushed. A heavy weight pressed across his cheeks, something was definitely wrapped over his hip, there was a strangely sweet smell filling his nose, and with a grunt he forced his eyes open.

Kacchan lay in front of him, half on his front, half on his side, with his face pressed into the blanket, mouth wide and drool pooling. Izuku, meanwhile, had his face pressed against Kacchan's armpit, his heavy arm wrapped around his head, whilst his leg kept Izuku flush against him. At first, Izuku blushed. They were so tightly wrapped together Izuku had a horrible feeling that they would be pasted together with sweat, but the absurdity of it; the graceless way Kacchan lay beside him and, seemingly, remained curled around him like he was a plushie, was adorable. He couldn't hold back the laughter once it started, the way Kacchan's lip had been pulled up from his mouth possibly the most unflattering and hilarious thing he'd seen in a long time, and Kacchan started to stir. His eyes opened, brow immediately forming a frown, glaring dazedly at Izuku as he continued to laugh in place in his armpit.

And then, Kacchan spotted the drool, and his face flushed as he pulled his arm back and immediately shoved his hand in Izuku's face and pushed him away, making Izuku only laugh harder.

"Yeh yeh, laugh it up," Kacchan said in a voice still rough with sleep, sitting himself up and wiping the drool from his chin.

"What?" Izuku said, still giggling. "You looked cute."

"You take that shit back! I never looked cute a day in my life!"

"Hmm, yeh, well I'm the authority on Kacchan's sleeping faces."

"You can be the authority on Kacchan's foot up your ass if you carry on."

"Oh, would you?" Izuku purred and Kacchan froze, his face flushing and voice spluttering, prompting Izuku to only laugh harder.

"Little shit," Kacchan finally managed, before he started to push the blanket off of him and paused, looking down with his nose crinkled. "Fucking gross, you let me fall asleep with the condom still on?"

It was Izuku's turn to flush now, sweet and hot memories of the previous night swirling pleasantly around his brain. He glanced down, realising that he must have woken up at some point in the night and chucked his away.

"I didn't let you do anything," he replied.

"Yeh, well, it's still your fuckin' fault I'm covered in jizz."

Izuku couldn't hide the grin on his face if he had tried, all too bright and encompassing as he reminded himself that, yes, he was the reason.

"Stop sitting there looking so damn proud of yourself and hand me the wipes, would ya?"

"Hmm, sure Kacchan."

There was something strangely domestic about it; Kacchan wiping at his dick with many a grimace and curse, Izuku lying at his side and smiling up at him like a love-sick puppy dog, the low hum of voices and activity from outside of their tent. Izuku had no idea what really lay ahead of them after today, but for now he could sit here and pretend this was their life.

"What time is it?" Kacchan eventually asked, grabbing a plastic bag and shoving the wipes inside, before taking the time to meticulously clean his hands with another.

"I'm not sure," he replied. "Hard to tell down here, but from the sound of it it's gotta be breakfast time."

Kacchan hummed, eyes trailing on the door to their tent. "Make sure you eat a decent amount, nerd, you're gonna need all your strength today."

And then, just like that, the happy fantasy that Izuku had created in his head was crushed. Gone was that fantasy where they were safe, where Kacchan wasn't bitten, where the only plans they had for the day was to remain naked under the sheets. The smile dropped from his lips.

"Right."

Kacchan looked back down at him, face scrunched up in concern.

"You good?"

"Yeh, I'm ..." Izuku sighed, before rolling onto his back. "Just ... I wish it wasn't like this, you know? I wish we could just stay in bed all day, watch stupid cartoons, eat cereal from the box. Just normal stuff. Like we're a normal co-" he paused, glancing back at Kacchan, his cheeks dusted pink. Kacchan looked back at him, a strange expression on his face, grief hidden in the creases of his brow.

"Yeh," he finally grunted, before looking away. "Though, we probably wouldn't have met if it wasn't for all ... this."

"We might have done," Izuku reasoned. "We grew up in the same town, we might have run into each other at some point."

Kacchan snorted. "I was a dickhead before all this," he replied with a shrug. "You'd have hated me."

Izuku sat himself up then, shimmying closer to Kacchan's side.

"I'm sure that's not true."

"Lay off it, I was a complete bastard."

"Oh, I don't doubt that," Izuku replied, smiling as Kacchan flashed him a look. "But no way I would have hated you."

Kacchan grunted, and Izuku leaned forward, placing a soft kiss against his cheek. A warm fuzzy feeling filled his chest at the blush that formed in response.

"Would have been nice to have more time," Kacchan said, his voice quiet, and Izuku reached out, taking his hand.

"We've got plenty of time," he said, squeezing. "Today will go fine. I got a plan, remember?"

Kacchan didn't reply. He just looked back at him, before leaning forward, one hand cupping Izuku's cheek as he pressed their foreheads together. Izuku didn't move, enjoying the heat from him, and the way the thumb brushed so gently over his cheekbones. It would never not break his heart that he couldn’t reach over, cross those last few breaths, and taste pink lips. But this? For Kacchan, this was the height of intimacy. Somehow, a forehead against his own left him feeling more loved, and more adored than any kiss had done before then.

"Alright, let's get on with it," Kacchan said, pulling away. Izuku nodded.

Ten minutes later, the two of them left the tent. Outside already a buzz of activity, the smell of breakfast was good enough to make Izuku's stomach growl as he eagerly headed towards the pot.

"Nice of you both to finally wake up."

Shindo was sitting at the table closest to the pot when they approached, eyeing them both with a bored expression on his face. Izuku noticed how his gaze lingered on Kacchan for a little longer, and while, realistically, he knew there was nothing to worry about, he felt a twinge of jealousy as a result.

"Shove it," Kacchan grunted, grabbing a bowl and filling it with porridge, before handing the bowl to Izuku. Izuku knew his face was blushing again at such a simple act, and Shindo's eyes narrowed.

"So, what's the game plan?" Kacchan continued, indifferent and shoving a large spoonful of food into his mouth. "Effryone else m'ready?"

"Daisuke and Hanzo are still eating," Shindo replied, nodding his head back towards where the two of them were sitting speaking to others in the group. "Then we'll go into the office and get in touch with Tami."

"You relay the instructions as I asked?" Kacchan asked.

"Yeh, fortunately the zombies are so focused on where we are that it was actually pretty easy for them to get around and pick up what they needed. Right now, they're on top of the old bank. Had to climb over with ropes from what I understand, so there's no chance of the Z's figuring out where they are and climbing up after them."

"Good," Kacchan replied.

"Means they're not particularly mobile though," Izuku added.

"It don't," Shindo agreed, and he took a deep breath. "There are going to be areas that they're not able to see from that viewpoint. It's gonna be especially hard on whoever is distracting the Z's."

"We'll figure it out," Kacchan said before Izuku could respond. He tipped back his head and shoveled what remained of his breakfast into his mouth before dropping the bowl down onto the table with a loud 'clunk'. "Let's get this party started shall we?"

A while later, the five of them, plus Makabe, grouped in the office, Shindo holding the walkie-talkie to his mouth as he flicked between the CCTV images on the monitors. Kacchan leaned against one of the tables, and despite the situation, Izuku realised he was somehow having an even harder time keeping his eyes off the man now. Especially after last night ... There was plenty of spare clothing in the camp, and it looked like Kacchan had made a point to raid the supplies at some point. He leaned there in a black turtleneck sweater, the fabric unfairly clinging to the sculpted torso Izuku had his hands all over not even eight hours ago. Kacchan, obviously feeling his eyes on him, looked up, and Izuku almost squeaked in shock as he immediately snapped his eyes to the front.

"Tami, you there? Over."

There was a heart-stopping moment where Nakagame didn't respond before the familiar crackle of the walkie filled the room.

"We're here, Yo. Over."

"Good, how are things looking out there? Over."

"About the same. I think we gained some new zombies overnight, but not a huge amount. Exit on Block Three Six is probably still our best bet. Over."

Shindo flicked through the screens again, before settling on the CCTV that just looked over the manhole on block thirty-six. It was still surrounded, but there were notably fewer zombies there than on all other exits.

"That works," Izuku said, stepping forward. Shindo clicked on the walkie so that Nakagame could hear him too. They had a large map of the town up on one of the walls and he pointed out the exit on block thirty-six. "If we head up, we can turn right and it's pretty much a straight shot from there to the hospital. Most of the buildings there are apartments. We can probably get onto the roof no problem and avoid the streets completely."

"There are fire escapes up the side," Makabe confirmed. "I've used them myself back when we were still raiding that area."

"That's perfect," Izuku replied. "From up there we can mark out the safest route straight into the hospital, whilst the team distracting the zombies can lure them back down towards twenty-fifth, and up onto the apartments there."

"We need to decide who's doing what," Shindo said. "We've been dancing around it, but I think we need to send the larger team into the hospital."

"You guys go into the hospital, I've got the zombies."

The room fell silent, and Izuku swung around quickly to look at Kacchan.

"Hah?" Shindo snapped.

"Think it through," Kacchan said, rolling his eyes. "You need enough people to watch one another's backs in the hospital right? It only takes one person to be zombie bait."

"And why is that person you?" Hanzo asked. But Izuku didn't need to ask why, he knew why. He knew, and no one else in the room did. He already considered the fact that Kacchan would need to be part of the zombie distraction team; that zombie in the hospital had already controlled him once, they couldn't risk it happening again. Not only would it put them at risk, but it would also open them up to a lot of difficult questions. But, he hadn't intended for Kacchan to go it alone.

"Because I'm fast and I can handle myself," Kacchan replied gruffly.

"Kacchan," Izuku started, hesitantly.

"We got a plan, right?" Kacchan interrupted. "I can make enough noise to get a butt load of those fuckers after me. All I've gotta do then is get on top of that apartment building. Oi, Turtleneck, you gonna watch my back?"

Shindo's eyes widened minutely at that, looking back at the walkie-talkie almost nervously.

"As much pleasure as I'm sure I'd get out of you being eaten, I'm not a complete fucking monster," Nakagame replied tartly.

"Jesus, Kat, if you're sure-"

"I got it, already," Kacchan snapped. "Now just focus on how you're going to get into that hospital and what you're doing when you get there."

Izuku looked at Kacchan for a moment, not enjoying how Kacchan seemed to be deliberately avoiding his eyes. His stomach churned uncomfortably before Shindo clearing his throat brought him back to attention.

"Uh- yes, right."

He pulled a folded piece of paper from his back pocket and laid it flat on the table in the centre of the room.

"We don't have a map of the place, but this is roughly what I remember of the layout."

"Wait, that's rough?" Daisuke said, in disbelief. Izuku blushed. Sure, it was pretty detailed, but Izuku wished he could have done a better job.

"Uh, well it's not complete," he said, rubbing the back of his neck. "When me and Kacchan went in there, we found her at the optometry department, amongst the block of consulting rooms, which isn't too deep into the building."

"It wasn't that far when we saw it," Hanzo supplied, before tapping his hand on the area of the map that Izuku had marked out as 'pharmacy'. "It was close to that point."

"She was in the pharmacy?"

"No, but that's when we were jumped," Hanzo replied. "We were cleaning out the stash of meds, I think we'd only been there for two minutes before they jumped us. Came around the corner, poor Shimano didn't stand a chance."

"What did you see of the female zombie?" Izuku asked, stomach churning at the thought of what remained of Shimano inside of the hospital.

"Not a lot," Hanzo said honestly, scratching his chin. "I just thought it was like the rest of them before it just stopped dead and started directing the damn things. We just had to run for it after that."

"So, we can't assume to know where she's going to be inside of the hospital," Izuku said, looking back at the map. "That makes things more difficult."

"She might not even stay in the hospital," Shindo said. "Once Kat starts making enough noise, she might well come out to see what's going on for herself."

Izuku glanced up at Kacchan again, the man staring down at the map and still avoiding eye contact with him. He couldn't be certain, of course he couldn't, but a big part of him felt that it was Kacchan, not the group, that the female zombie was targeting. It was entirely possible that, if she realised he was trying to escape, she would send her full forces after him.

"We know it's smart," Daisuke said, "but we don't know it's smart enough to know a trap when it sees it."

"Yeh," Hanzo nodded. "The damn thing could just walk right out there and we could take it out that way!"

"Ok, but assuming that doesn't happen," Kacchan said, "how the fuck you plan to search an entire fucking hospital looking for her?"

"I don't," Izuku replied before he reached over and grabbed one of the spare walkie-talkies. "We know that they're drawn by noise, so we draw her in."

"We use someone as bait?" Shindo cried, eyes widening in shock. Izuku shook his head.

"No, just the walkie-talkie! We drop this thing in a location where we can get a high view without being spotted, and Nakagame connects to it when I give her the green light. All she has to do is act like she's talking to one of us, sound really panicked, perhaps about the zombies outside of the hospital. That way, the female zombie will know we're there and head to the walkie to stop us."

"It's a big hospital," Daisuke said. "What if she doesn't hear it?"

"Yeh, assuming this thing isn't completely brain dead, it'll soon figure out something's up if Nakagame keeps shouting and no one responds."

"Then we move to the next location," Izuku replied. "There are three areas that I think will work in our favour." He jabbed his finger onto the map.

"The main foyer is the ideal spot. We'll need to carefully scout out the bottom floor, make sure she's not down there before locking the doors to the other areas of the hospital except the ones leading to

the upper floors." He tapped on where he had marked out the doors. "We can assume she won't be alone in there, there's bound to be some zombies with her. But, if we're quick enough, we can jam those doors shut and lock her and some of them in the foyer with us."

"How do you plan on actually taking her down?" Shindo asked.

"Same way we do any of the others," Izuku replied. "We don't know if her physiology is exactly the same as the rest. She might not actually be ... well, dead. But we should aim for the head anyway, just to be sure."

Izuku knew that Kacchan was looking at him now. He could feel the heat from his eyes against his skin.

"If the foyer fails ... We didn't make it there, but there's a second large waiting area on the third floor, near a café by the looks of it."

"It'd be harder to control an area like that," Kacchan said.

"Right, and the third location is right in the center of the building, that would be even harder still."

"So, we basically need her to hear us in the foyer, that the gist of it?" Hanzo said, and Izuku sighed.

"Ideally."

"We need to go through some basic safety shit," Kacchan said, quite suddenly, and Izuku glanced up. "We're communicating through the walkies, right?"

"Right."

"We can't have someone talking at the wrong moment," Kacchan continued. "So we should keep radio silence unless it's an emergency."

"That's pretty much how we always did our runs," Izuku replied, though he didn't enjoy the feeling in his stomach at not being able to stay in touch with Kacchan the entire time. "We'd ask for radio silence if things got dicey."

"What counts as an emergency?" Shindo asked, and Kacchan scoffed.

"You kidding me? If Turtleneck suddenly sees a bunch of fucking zombies losing interest in me and going to the hospital, then she can contact your group."

"I'm just trying to be clear about stuff."

"We can each contact Turtleneck," Kacchan continued, waving a hand. "But she can't contact us unless it's life or fucking death. And we shouldn't contact one another."

"Huh?" Izuku all but yelped.

"Same thing applies, Deku," Kacchan replied with a frown. "You think I wanna get a bunch of zombies jump me coz you wanna know what the fucking weather's like?"

"Right, right, I get it," Izuku said, but that uncomfortable feeling in his chest grew.

"I presume we're leaving a line of communication between us and here, too?" Kacchan continued. Shindo nodded. "Ok, then they contact Turtleneck, not us, if anything goes wrong."

"Makes sense," Hanzo said. "Best check they're all on the same frequency before we go out there."

Izuku handed his walkie-talkie to Hanzo as he proceeded to check that they were all turned into the same frequency as Nakagame's.

"Ok, everyone happy with the plan?" Shindo asked, and as one they nodded, Kacchan grunting. Shindo then took a deep breath and clapped both his hands together.

"Alright, collect your weapons, meet at the east exit, we're leaving in ten."

"Got it, boss," Hanzo said, as he and Daisuke filed out after him, Kacchan making to follow before Izuku reached out and grabbed his wrist.

"Kacchan, wait."

The door swung shut, Shindo casting them one last look over his shoulder as he left. The silence in the room after felt heavy, in a way that Izuku didn't really understand.

"I know why you wanna do this alone, and I get it. You probably will move easier without other people to worry about but..." he swallowed, letting go of Kacchan's wrist. "I still don't like the idea of you out there all on your own."

Kacchan turned to face him, Izuku half expecting him to roll his eyes, probably call him an idiot, and tell him he had it covered. Instead, he reached out and cupped Izuku's cheek, raising his head.

"I get it," he said, voice gentle. "But I thought it through, Deku."

Izuku scrunched up his face.

"Don't be a brat," Kacchan snorted, and the roll of his eyes was entirely welcome. "I'm making the right choice. I need you to believe that."

Izuku frowned, the choice of words seemed so odd to him. And then Kacchan was leaning forwards and pressing a kiss to his forehead.

"Come on, let's go kick ass."

"Ok."

But for all the comfort of Kacchan's words, Izuku couldn't find it in himself to feel entirely soothed. He was going to be walking back into that hospital, the same hospital he had almost died in once before, into the arms of that damned zombie ... So why was Kacchan the one he was worried about most?

When they walked out into the hall, Izuku spotted the rest of their small team speaking to others of the group or among themselves. The sombre expressions on the faces of those around them enough to make the already heavy weight of what they were about to do all that harder to carry. Katsuma immediately broke free of the group the moment he saw Deku and started to run towards him.

"Mr. Deku!"

"Hey, Katsuma," Izuku said, forcing a smile to his face as the kid skidded to a halt in front of him.

"Before you go, I got something for you."

"Wh-oh!" Izuku's eyes widened in shock as Katsuma dug around in the bag over his shoulders and pulled out a familiar sticker. The face of All Might stared back at him from Katsuma's tiny palm, the words 'you too, can be a hero!' bold and loud beneath it.

"Katsuma, I can't take that!" Izuku protested. "You said that was your favourite."

"It's for luck," Katsuma said, thrusting the sticker out to him. "Besides, you can give it back when you come home."

Kacchan made a strange noise in the back of his throat, and Izuku swallowed. His eyes were stinging. Goddamnit, he wasn't about to cry in front of Katsuma! He took a deep breath and reached out, taking the sticker.

"Th-thank you, Katsuma," he said, his smile wobbly and honest. "I'll get it back to you real soon."

Katsuma nodded, grinning in satisfaction when Izuku slipped the sticker into the breast pocket of his plaid shirt. Then, as his sister irritably called his name, he waved and ran back to the group, Izuku staring after him. He smiled, hand still pressed against the pocket of his shirt.

"You ready?"

He looked around to see Kacchan impatiently jerking his head to the side and nodded.

"Yeh. Let's go."

Despite how much Izuku had gone over the plan in his head, despite painstakingly going over every single detail and every possible issue, there was still a very real chance that they would be thwarted right at the start. Getting to the hospital involved, first and foremost, actually getting topside. Something that was much easier said than done when every exit from the sewers was guarded by the undead. The exit on block thirty-six was consistently the least guarded, perhaps because the female zombie didn't believe they'd make an escape effort so close to the hospital itself; but there were still easily forty dead heads out there at any one time. More than enough to make short work of their small team if they were overpowered. It was fortunate that they already had people on the outside to assist, or it would have been entirely likely that no one was going to be getting out of this place.

The group walked along the dry, spongy tunnels of the sewers. Shindo walked ahead with a torch lighting their way, their footfalls and breath loud as it echoed off the concrete. Scurrying through old dried-up waste wasn't exactly something Izuku had imagined for himself, even going back a week. He supposed it was telling of just how much the world topside stank these days that he hardly even registered the smell down here. Kacchan walked ahead of him, his large sturdy shoulders blocking the light with each swing, and Izuku felt comforted for a moment.

"Alright, we're here," Shindo said, his voice low and quiet in the gloom as the light from his torch illuminated the cover above them. He pulled his walkie from its holster and held it to his lips.

"We're at three six, over."

A crackle and a scratch, and Nakagame was responding.

"Ok, we've got eyes. I count forty-six Z's in the immediate vicinity, but the rest aren't too far behind. Over."

"Ok," Shindo took a deep breath, looking over at Kacchan. "You sure about this?"

"Yeh yeh, stop stalling," Kacchan hissed. "Just gimme the all-clear."

"Ok," Shindo repeated, swallowing audibly. Kacchan started forward, and Izuku was filled with a rush of panic, reaching out and grabbing hold of his wrist.

"Be careful," he said, almost pleaded, when Kacchan looked back at him. He didn't speak, eyes darting across his face for a moment, before he simply nodded. Doubtfully, Izuku let go. His heart thudded hard in his chest as he watched Kacchan approach the stepladder.

"Got your weapon, walkie all good?" Shindo asked and Kacchan clicked his tongue against his teeth.

"I got it, let's do this already."

"Tami, we're good to go. Over."

"Lighting the bombs," Nakagame replied. *"Ok, firing! Over!"*

Izuku could just hear the low humming and thudding from above, the only evidence from below of the horde of zombies waiting for them. The faintest sound of smashing glass met them.

"Second bomb firing, over!"

Another smash, this time a loud crash entirely audible to all over them, and Izuku stood with bated breath, staring up at the ceiling. It had to work ... it had to ...

"They're on the move! It's working!"

"Just gimme the green light, Turtleneck," Kacchan snarled, as he climbed to the top of the ladder and pressed a palm to the underside of the manhole cover.

"Almost ... hold on ..."

Izuku could hear the shuffling, the thudding; the zombies were moving. He hadn't been completely certain it would work. He knew that fire and noise had drawn zombies in the past, but if it would offer enough of a distraction to release them from the female zombie's hold was another thing entirely.

"Shit- they're slowing down, they're not going all the way over there. Damnit, Bakugou if you're gonna go you need to go now!"

"Alright," Kacchan replied, before he heaved at the cover and climbed out onto the street, Izuku's eyes following the heel of his boot before the cover dropped back into place with a heavy thud. Izuku felt sick ... sicker than he'd felt in a long time, the desire to immediately run up there after him, to be with him, to just see him so strong. This was stupid ... no, stick with the plan, Izuku, stick with it ...

"Hey, fuckbrains!"

They heard Kacchan's voice ring out loud and clear from above them before Nakagame was on the walkie again.

"They've seen him! They're ... holy fuck ..."

"What?" Izuku breathed, running forward and snatching the walkie from Shindo's hand. "What's going on?!"

"Keep coming, assholes!"

Kacchan was yelling again, though his voice sounded quieter this time.

"Nakagame?!" Izuku cried.

"They're going after him! Oh jesus ..."

Izuku shoved the walkie at Shindo's chest and jumped onto the stepladder, his heart racing. Kacchan was in trouble, this had been such a stupid idea-

"Midoriya, wait!" Shindo said, grabbing a hold of him and pulling him back. "Tami, what's going on? What the fuck is that noise?"

The previous thuds from above were almost thunderous at this point, as if hundreds of feet were stomping above them.

"It's ... Bakugou, pick up!"

"Quit fucking yelling!" came Kacchan's yell over the walkie, and Izuku let out a whimper of relief.

"Bakugou, it's more than just the zombies from before! It's like ... fuck, there's fucking hundreds of them, all coming from other exits and straight towards you!"

"Good!" came Kacchan's response, Daisuke spluttered in disbelief from behind Izuku. *"I can outrun 'em."*

"You better fucking hope so!"

"Deku! I got this. Soon as Nakagame gives you the all-clear you get your scrawny ass to the hospital, y'hear me?"

"But-" Izuku started.

"Stick with the fucking plan! Fucking over and out."

"Kacchan!" Izuku protested, but there was no response, just the sound of more thudding and his own panicked breathing.

"They're ... almost passed over," Nakagame said, her voice strangely subdued. *"Uh, it's not all of them, there are still some on other exits but ... I think the plan worked a little too well, Midoriya, it's like half the damn zombies up here are going after Bakugou. Over."*

This wasn't supposed to happen ... Izuku couldn't be certain if the female zombie was after all of them, or if Kacchan was her main goal, but this certainly cleared up that particular mystery. She wanted Kacchan dead, and she was willing to send half her damn forces to be sure that happened. It didn't matter how fast Kacchan was, how good he was at fighting them, if there really were hundreds of zombies running after him right now there was no way he could defend himself against that!

There's still time to change the plan. He could give up the hospital, he could go after Kacchan, see if there was a way that he could help. His hand reached up to his pocket again, feeling the outline of the sticker there, and his eyes snapped shut. It wasn't just about him, hell it wasn't even about Kacchan ... it was about these people. Those kids. He couldn't just back out now.

Kacchan would probably chew him out if he did.

"Ok," he breathed, more to himself than anything else. "Ok, let us know when it's safest and we'll head straight to the hospital."

"Just a few stragglers left now ... Ok, ok go!"

Izuku was first to the top of the stepladder, pushing back the manhole cover just as Kacchan had done and climbing out onto the street. It was bright, days underground had left him somewhat accustomed to the gloom, and he hissed and squinted, hand held up over his eyes as he adjusted to the glare. And, as it so happened, he had seemingly forgotten what topside smelled like, because the stench of death and decay was so strong he swiftly took his hand from over his eyes and clapped it to his mouth. The ground was filthy, blood and remains and grime caked to the tarmac after days of the undead walking over it, and to his immense distaste, he saw an arm lying discarded to the side of him. It must have just ... rotted right off. But there wasn't a single zombie in sight, even as he stared off in the direction he knew Kacchan ran.

"Midoriya." He glanced over, watching as Daisuke gripped Hanzo's hand and helped him up from the hole. Shindo was eyeing him, cautiously, as if trying to decide for himself whether Izuku would abandon the plan and run after Kacchan.

"Ask Nakagame how things look between us and the hospital."

Shindo nodded, with some notable relief, before he raised the walkie.

"How's it looking, Tami? Over."

"Honestly, it's looking almost entirely clear out here," Nakagame replied. *"Uh, wait, hold on, looks like more zombies are peeling off from twenty-five and headed your way. Over."*

"How many?" Shindo asked as Izuku looked at the street around them, spotting an alleyway and waving for the group to follow him.

"Not many, about thirty, I'd say."

"We could wait them out," Daisuke offered, and Izuku nodded. They jogged to the alleyway, a large skip between them and the street, and ducked down, Izuku keeping close to the edge. They didn't need to wait long. Within a minute, they heard the zombies running closer, the vile wet sounds of their bodies hitting the concrete loud across the street.

As Izuku expected, the zombies didn't take any time to investigate, running straight past where he and the others were hiding.

"This is insane," Hanzo whispered. "I thought that zombie had control over all of them, why are they just running off after one guy?"

"So long as Kat stays ahead of them he'll be fine," Shindo said. "Can't deny this has seriously worked in our favour."

Izuku honestly wanted to punch the man, biting his cheek to stop himself from snapping something in response. But none of them knew ... none of them knew the real reason for this. None of them knew just how much danger Kacchan was in.

"We clear?" Shindo asked.

"That looks to be the last for now. If you're quick, you can probably avoid using the rooftops altogether. Over."

"Let's go," Izuku hissed.

They carried on down the street at a jog, Izuku's eyes darting left and right for any signs of the undead, trying hard to focus on the job at hand rather than what was going on with Kacchan. He desperately wanted to speak with him, to check that he was still ok. He wasn't sure how long Nakagame would have eyes on him, could alert them if there was trouble, but he took her silence on Kacchan's situation to be a good thing.

The streets were quiet, still. Evidence of the undead lay all around them, but for as long as it was silent he paid the blood and grime no heed. He just had to stay alert. Stay focused. The sooner he took care of the zombie in the hospital the sooner he could get to Kacchan.

They made it all the way to the outskirts of the hospital without any interruption at all bar the first band of zombies that had passed them. It was still deathly silent, the empty carpark deceptive, ignorant, or perhaps in spite of the danger that lurked within. They hunkered down at the very edge, eyes alert.

"Tami, can you still spot us?" Shindo said, looking back over his shoulder in the direction that Nakagame was hiding.

"Just about," Nakagame replied.

"How's Kacchan? Can you see him?" Izuku asked.

"I ... there was so much movement I lost track of him," Nakagame replied. *"I've been keeping eyes on the apartment block he was aiming for but I don't see him yet. O-over."*

Izuku felt his body shake.

"And the zombies?"

"They're swarming the area," Nakagame said. *"Look, I don't think they've got to him, they'd probably turn tail and come straight back to you if they had. But he's over there somewhere, hiding if he knows what's good for him, and they're waiting for him to come out. Over."*

What Izuku wanted to hear was that Kacchan had made it to the apartment block, that he was sat on the rooftops making just enough noise to keep the zombies interested in him and away from them. What he wanted to hear was that he was at least halfway safe ... where was he now? Was he hiding somewhere? In a car, a building, back underground? Was he trapped?

"Thanks, Nakagame," Izuku said. He could feel Shindo staring at him. "We just have to trust that Kacchan can handle himself and make the most of the distraction."

"If anyone can handle a hundred fucking zombies, it's Kat," Shindo said, nudging Izuku and chuckling. "Hardass could probably get bitten and still come up trumps."

Izuku paled at that.

"In the nicest possible way, shouldn't we be focusing on the hospital right now?" Hanzo whispered. Izuku started.

"Right."

With no zombies about, they really couldn't afford to waste this time they'd been given. He expected the distraction to offer them somewhat of an opportunity, but this truly was unprecedented. They had to push forward.

"Ok, the front of the foyer is just windows, so we should be able to see whether there are any zombies there. But, just to be safe, move with the assumption that there are zombies around every corner."

"So, we go in, clear the bottom level, and set the trap," Daisuke asked. Izuku nodded. "Got it, let's go."

"Radio silence," Shindo hissed into the walkie, before the four of them took off across the carpark, moving at a jog, keeping their bodies low to the ground, Izuku taking the lead. The carpark was so quiet that there was no disguising their footsteps, no matter how carefully they ran; but no zombies stuck their filthy heads up over the abandoned vehicles, no horde came out from the hospital door. It really seemed as though all the zombies in the area had gone after Kacchan. Within moments, they were outside of the large double doors of the hospital, looking into an empty foyer.

"Why would I feel better if there were zombies in there?" Hanzo asked, his voice low. Izuku had to agree with him.

"There's no reason to hold back now," Shindo said. "Come on."

The inside of the hospital looked just as Izuku had remembered it; evidence all around of the massacre that had once taken place here, the decomposed corpses littering the ground where they had been eaten alive. It smelled just as he remembered, too. Decay, rot, and death.

"It's so quiet," Daisuke hissed, their footfalls echoing around the empty foyer.

"Yeh, well, it was this quiet the first time we were here, too," Hanzo muttered. "Don't forget how that went."

"We should split into two groups," Izuku said. "One take the rooms to the right, the others on the left. Take it slow, avoid fighting with any zombies unless you have no other choice, that always

ends up bringing more of them. We wanna be sure she's not down here, then close off the main access points to the foyer."

"If anyone gets into trouble and needs help, three clicks on the walkies," Shindo said, demonstrating with three bursts of static. "Otherwise, radio silence. Midoriya, we'll take left."

Izuku nodded his head at Hanzo and Daisuke as they took the right wing of the lower floor before he carefully pushed open the door to the left. He and Kacchan hadn't explored this area the last time they were here, though Izuku was at least somewhat familiar with the layout from what he remembered of the map. It was mostly consultation rooms, a small cafe a little ways down; an L-shaped wing that eventually opened up to the rear of the hospital. Izuku was entirely grateful that the hospital wasn't any larger. Even at this size, it could potentially take a long time to search if the female zombie didn't seek them out first.

Izuku and Shindo walked side by side, each covering the other as they peered into the rooms they passed. They needed to be quick, quiet, and thorough. The very last thing any of them needed was for a horde of the damn things to come crashing into the foyer the second they placed the bait. But, the deeper they went, the clearer it became that there were no zombies here. None milling about in any of the consultation rooms, no groups around any corners, the hospital was, in every sense of the word, dead.

"I get this is messed up," Shindo said, his voice low as he shut one of the consultation room doors, "but somehow not seeing any zombies is making me more nervous."

"It's possible that, if they’re still in the hospital, it’ll be wherever she is," Izuku replied. "When Kacchan and I were here, she was in the middle of a large group of them."

Shindo hummed but didn't say anything else, the two of them working in silence as they began looping back around to where they started.

"What do you think is going on?"

The question was so sudden that Izuku thought he misheard him at first, blinking dumbly back at Shindo as the man slowed his pace to check another room.

"Huh?"

"With that zombie," Shindo continued. "You said you'd met others like it. So, what's with that? A mutation of the virus? This damn thing evolving, you think?"

"I ..." Izuku swallowed. He hadn't talked to anyone else besides Kacchan about what they discovered in that diary. It was possible that he and Kacchan were the only people in the world to know about this now, so was there any real reason as to why Izuku felt the need to keep it secret? Was it simply because it involved Kacchan now too?

But, Shindo didn't know that Kacchan had been bitten, that was something only he and their group knew about. Surely there was no harm having more brains in on the matter, after all...

"We met another one of them," he said. "In a town near Fuji."

Shindo glanced looked over at him but didn't respond.

"He had lived there before he turned into a zombie," Izuku continued, "and we stumbled across his home whilst we were looking for somewhere to lie low so we could deal with our injuries. He kept a diary."

Shindo's brow perked up.

"He was bitten," Izuku sighed. No, this didn't implicate Kacchan in anything, but he still felt strangely dirty talking about it without him there. Especially to Shindo. "But he didn't turn right away. According to the diary, he lived another six months after he was bitten before he finally turned into ... one of them."

Shindo stopped dead. "The fuck ... you're kidding?"

"I wish I was," Izuku sighed, his already unsettled stomach churning. "I don't know why some people don't turn straight away, but my guess is that any of the smarter zombies we've met were the same as him."

"That's ... fuck, that really changes shit, huh?"

"What do you mean?"

"It means, someone could be bitten and you just wouldn't know it," Shindo continued, a heavy scowl forming on his face. It was Izuku's turn to freeze then. "Presuming they don't look like absolute shit, all they'd have to do is keep their bite hidden. You wouldn't fucking know anything until they turned into whatever these fuckers are."

"Y-yeh," Izuku muttered, wishing now that he hadn't said a damn thing. Shit ... what had he been thinking? But then, Shindo gasped, and Izuku almost jumped from his skin, his blood chilling to ice when he found Shindo's eyes focused on him, his mouth a thin line.

"Say, Midoriya ..."

"W-what?"

"I don't fault your logic," Shindo continued, his voice low and careful. "But, it's a pretty big assumption to make after meeting just one zombie that didn't turn straight away, don't ya think?"

Izuku swallowed.

"There's something that's been bothering me. And at the time I thought maybe it was just because of our history but ... Bakugou really didn't seem keen on me checking him for bites."

"He was just-"

"And it seems real strange to me that he wanted to do this alone," Shindo interrupted. "Especially when you start to consider how the behaviour of the zombies changed after you both arrived. How literally all the fucking zombies in the area ran after him like that."

Izuku's chest felt tight. Shindo's head cocked to the side as he looked at him, the grinding of his teeth audible in the quiet corridor.

"Shindo-"

A loud thud interrupted them, and they both swung around at the sound. It seemed this level wasn't entirely empty. Izuku could see the arm reaching through the open door, swiping through the air at them. The hospital bed in the corridor was the only thing stopping it from climbing out after them. Izuku breathed out an unsteady breath, walking over and pushing against the bed, ignoring the frantic swiping of the zombie's arm as he tried to get the door shut. There was no need to kill this damn thing and risk bringing others their way.

Shindo watched him for a moment, silent, before stepping forward, standing in place beside Izuku and helping him push. One last slap, a crack, and the door shut tight as the zombie's arm was drawn back into the room. Izuku hardly dared to breathe.

"Let's go, shall we?"

The unease boiled in his stomach as he watched Shindo walk away, the man's face hardening.

Shindo didn't mention Kacchan again after that, though Izuku knew better than to be relieved. Not another word was exchanged as they made their way back to the main foyer and set about blocking the door behind them. Daisuke and Hanzo joined them a couple of minutes later, the lack of blood on their weapons assuring Izuku that they hadn't run into any trouble either. It was unsettling.

"Nothing," Hanzo said after he and Daisuke blocked their own door. "You?"

"Just one," Shindo replied. "But let's not get complacent."

"Believe me," Hanzo said with a quiet laugh, "there's no chance of that."

"We'll set the walkie up under the chairs," Izuku said, stepping forward as Shindo passed him the walkie from his belt. "That way she has to actually come into the foyer to investigate the source of the sound."

He placed the walkie beneath one chair before standing straight to look back at the wide double doors leading to the upper floors. Keeping it shut wouldn't be easy. There were no external locks on the doors, and aside from a large pot plant in the far corner, there wasn't exactly anywhere he could run to, should a group of zombies burst through them. He glanced about the room, spotting a broken chair, the screws holding one of the legs in place hanging loose. That would have to be enough.

"As soon as she steps into the foyer, I'll bar the doors," he said, grabbing one of his knives and using that to undo the screws before pulling the metal leg free. "I don't think we'll be so lucky as to get her on her own, but we'll need to work as a team, taking care of the regular zombies." He swung the leg over his shoulder. "I'll take care of her."

"And if shit goes sour?" Daisuke asked.

"Get out of here," Izuku replied. "If we get overwhelmed, we get out of here and onto the nearest rooftop."

Daisuke nodded. Hanzo and Shindo exchanged nervous glances before the three of them head off to get into place, taking refuge behind tables and pillars as Izuku ducked behind the large pot plant that was, by now, little less than a damn twig.

"Ready?" Shindo called to him softly. Swallowing back his nerves, Izuku nodded. On Shindo's queue, Hanzo whispered the okay into his walkie. After a tense moment, Nakagame's voice filled the foyer.

"Yo, come in, Yo."

Izuku found himself immediately tensing up, gripping the table leg hard in one hand, and his axe in the other. There was still so much that could go wrong at this stage. There was a big chance that the female zombie wouldn't even be lured by the sound, that she was smart enough not to take the bait.

"Yo!" Nakagame repeated, her voice sounding more urgent, and even in his present state of anxiety Izuku had to appreciate her dedication to the role. *"Hey, what's going on? Can you hear me?"*

Izuku looked up at Shindo from where he was just visible behind the reception desk.

"I'm serious, where the fuck are you?"

Shindo shifted, and for a moment Izuku was worried that he might reach out to respond.

"It's Bakugou," Nakagame said, and Izuku's head snapped up, his heart hammering in his chest. *"I think you better get out there-"*

But Izuku didn't catch the rest of what Nakagame said, as deep from within the hospital, Izuku heard a low wet thud.

"Eat."

Izuku's breath came out hard and fast, the high rough voice chilling the blood in his veins.

"Oi, answer me! Shi- oh god, I can't ... I can't watch this ..."

Izuku wasn't sure Nakagame was acting anymore.

"Eat. Tear. Kill."

His entire body shook, his lips wibbling as he fought back the desire to scream.

"This ain't a fucking game anymore, Yo!" Nakagame yelled. *"That bastard is gonna die!"*

A second wet thud - a third, a fourth - interrupted Izuku just as he lurched forward, freezing him to the spot. And there she was, her ruined face beneath long tangled locks coming into view as she placed a bare foot onto the tiles. The scent of decay filled Izuku's nostrils, coming from the putrid wound on one of her legs, the skin around the edges black and dead. This kind of infection was enough to kill her twice over. But ... she breathed. She breathed as her eyes swept the room.

"Ain't no way," Nakagame was saying, voice shaky.

He's ok. Izuku's eyes shut tight, holding onto the weapons in his hands like they were his lifeline. *He's ok, he's ok, he's ok ...*

But, when he opened his eyes, the entire world stood still as yellowing, bloodshot orbs above sunken cheeks stared straight back at him. One side of her face was almost entirely missing, the teeth and sinews beneath visible in the low light filtering through the hospital doors. Her jaw hung

slack, a hand reaching out to push the dead twigs and branches aside, so she could get a better look at him. But it wasn't just the shock, the smell, the rot, that left Izuku shaking and unable to move. It was the complete lack of emotion on her face, the almost patient interest with which she watched him as if he was little more than a rat in a cage.

"Midoriya!"

He heard Shindo scream to him, and he started, reality hitting him hard. She was alone. She was completely alone and this was their fucking chance!

He launched forward, lashing out with the leg of the chair with one arm as the other lagged with the axe. All he had to do was knock her down, knock her off her feet so he could bury the axe in her damn face. But, to his horror, the zombie blocked his blow, grabbing a hold of the leg with a strength he didn't expect. She wrenched him forward, his nose connecting hard with the ground as she threw him.

He could taste the blood before he felt it, one good eye widening in confusion. The female zombie no longer looked calm, her tattered lips torn back into a snarl as she screamed at him.

"Over here, bitch!"

Something black was thrown across the room, smacking the zombie hard in the face. She screamed again, shoulder hunching as she swung around to face her attacker.

"Yeh, that's it, come and get me!"

Izuku couldn't work out who was speaking at that moment, his ears ringing, nose filling with blood. The female zombie no longer seemed to be interested in him. She started walking into the foyer before, to his horror, he heard more banging and thudding.

He scrambled to his feet, grabbing the table leg from where it fell on the ground, making it to the door just in time to see about a dozen zombies thundering towards him.

"Shit, shit, shit!"

He slammed the doors shut, the table leg jamming on the first try. He panicked, twisting it and fumbling, crying out in shock and frustration as the door threatened to open on him. The leg slid into place between the handles just as the full weight of the zombies hit the doors.

"Midoriya!"

Another desperate scream. He looked over his shoulder just in time to see the female zombie grabbing for him, fury in her bloodshot eyes. He ducked, but her hands still snatched at him, throwing him aside yet again with a strength that felt entirely unnatural. He grunted in pain.

"She's opening the door!"

Izuku darted forward without thinking, his body colliding with hers just in time to stop her from pulling the leg free. Nothing could quite explain the horror that came from feeling the cold, clammy arms wrap around him, fingers digging into his back, putrid breath on his neck. At that moment, Izuku was certain this was it. It didn't matter how quick he was, how smart, he was going

to die here. His throat torn open, his skin peeled from his body, not knowing if Kacchan was alive or not ...

"Got her!"

A loud scream filled his ears and he instinctively flinched back. He was blind, he could hardly breathe, but that hot breath was no longer at his neck and someone was wrenching him backwards.

"Kill her! Fuck sake, kill her!"

The female zombie screeched, the sound high and desperate and afraid. He wiped the blood from his eye, blinking furiously, as the shape of what was happening started to come into view. Hanzo had the zombie on the ground, grimacing and holding his face as far away from her swiping hands as he could whilst also holding her down. Daisuke was running to his aid, her weapon held high over her head.

"Get her!" Shindo yelled from his side, and Izuku realised it had been he who saved him from the zombie's snarling teeth.

Daisuke swung, her katana slicing into the zombie’s face with a loud wet slap, the screaming coming to an abrupt halt.

Panting breaths filled the foyer. The zombies on the other side of the door continued their assault, metal knocking against metal.

"Is she dead?" Shindo breathed. Hanzo leaned forward, panting hard and grimacing at the sight of her face cleaved almost into two.

"Fuck, I sure ho-"

But Hanzo never had a chance to finish. Izuku cried out, but there was nothing that he could do as the zombie reached forward,the top of her face seeming to slide out of place. Her jaws snapped shut around Hanzo's throat, tearing as her weight pulled her back down again.

Daisuke screamed as Hanzo gaped wordlessly, the only sound coming from his lips, the bubble and gurgle of the blood frothing at his neck.

"Hanzo!"

Daisuke was at his side, pressing hopelessly at his neck, tears streaming down her face.

"It's ok," she whimpered. "It's ok ... shh, it's ok."

Hanzo stared at her in shock, almost as if he still hadn't figured out what had happened to him. Izuku knew that there was nothing he could do, but in a moment he was at their side, tearing the sleeve of his shirt and applying pressure alongside Daisuke.

Hanzo tried to speak again, a fresh wave of blood coming forth, blinking so slowly as he looked back at Daisuke, her hand against his pale cheek, before he went still.

"Fuck," Shindo was breathing. "Fuck, fuck, Hanzo ... fuck ..."

Izuku couldn't take his eyes off him. He'd seen a lot of traumatic shit over the last two years but this ... this was the first time he'd seen someone die like that ... with their blood still hot on his hands and leaking down his wrists, a loved one sobbing beside him.

"Daisuke," he breathed. "I- I'm so sorry, I-"

"Don't," Daisuke choked. "Please ... don't ..."

His hands fell into his lap. The screaming had stopped, but it still seemed to echo around his brain anyway. This wasn't how things were supposed to happen. They weren't supposed to lose anyone.

"Yo, please come in, Yo!" came Nakagame's desperate voice. *"Yo!"*

Shindo hurried forward, slipping a little on the blood on the floor, and grabbing the walkie-talkie.

"Tami," he said, voice thick. "Tami, jesus ..."

"Are you ok? What happened? Is she dead, did you get her?"

"We got her," Shindo replied. "But ... shit, we lost Hanzo."

Nakgame didn't reply straight away. Izuku got clumsily to his feet, pausing long enough to place a hand on Daisuke's shoulder that was immediately shaken away, the guilt eating away at him. This had been his idea, they were only out here because of him, because he and Kacchan had come to this goddamn town and ... Kacchan.

He turned to Shindo.

"Kacchan," he breathed, voice cracking. "I ne- was she telling the truth about Kacchan?"

Shindo swallowed.

"Tami, any word on Kat?"

"Yeh," she replied. *"Yeh, I heard from him just now. It- wait."* There was a click over the line. *"Bakugou? You still there?"*

"Nowhere else to be."

Izuku could have cried as those low gravely tones met his ears, and he grabbed the walkie from Shindo's hand.

"Kacchan!" he cried. "Are you ok? What's going on?"

"Did you get her? You fucking safe, Deku?"

"I-" Izuku swallowed, taking a deep breath to try and stop the shaking in his voice. "She's dead. Daisuke got her but ... uh, we lost Hanzo."

"Fuck," Kacchan sighed, and Izuku could hear a hitch to his tone. *"Damn."*

"Are you ok?" Izuku pressed.

For a long moment, Kacchan didn't respond.

"Ka-"

"I got bit."

Izuku didn't know much of hell, but he was certain this was it. The world fell away around him, the floor beneath his feet gave way, the waves came crashing in.

"W-what?"

"I got bit, Deku," Kacchan said, voice firmer this time.

"That might not matter," Izuku found himself saying quickly, entirely indifferent to the people listening in. "We don't know what it means-"

"Listen to me, Deku."

Izuku stopped, breath hitching.

"I'm not coming back from this, ok?"

"Kacchan! You don't know that! Where are you, I'm coming to find y-"

"Deku!" Kacchan yelled down the walkie. *"Goddamnit, will you just- stop, ok. You can't fix this. Fuck, you can't- you can't fix everything, ok? I know you wish you could, but some shit can't be changed."*

"I don't ... no, I don't believe that," Izuku whispered, shaking his head, the tears spilling down his bloody cheeks. "You can't just give up!"

"I'm not giving up, Deku," Kacchan said, voice crackling, the signal wavering. *"You're gonna survive this, you hear me?"*

"N-no," Izuku choked. "Not- without you, I can't-"

"Quit it," Kacchan interrupted. *"No crying, ya damn nerd."*

"Just tell me where you are. Please ..."

"Ain't no fucking way I'm gonna let you remember me like this," Kacchan interrupted, though his voice was growing soft, quiet. *"I need you to promise me you're gonna survive this, yeh? Can you fucking promise me you'll do that?"*

"Kacchan," he whimpered. It couldn't be ending like this. It couldn't end this way ... "I can't-"

"Please."

The word was barely a whisper, and Izuku shut his eyes tight, shoulders shaking.

"I- I promise."

"Good," Kacchan breathed. *"That's my nerd."*

"Kacchan ...."

"I gotta go now."

"Wait," Izuku breathed.

"Thanks for putting up with my shit."

"Please, don't leave."

"I love you."

Izuku's breath caught in his throat, the euphoric bliss he should be feeling morphed into agony as his heart shattered.

"K-Kacchan," he sobbed. But there was no reply, no static. "Kacchan?"

He was gone. And all Izuku could do was stand there, walkie in his shaking hand, cheeks wet.

"Midoriya?"

Shindo's voice was soft, tentative. He felt his hand on his arm.

"I- I'm sorry."

"He's not dead yet," Izuku found himself saying, shaking his head. "He's not dead."

"Midoriya I ... shit, I wish he was ok, too, but you gotta respect his last wishes."

"I don't gotta do shit," Izuku hissed. And hell, he was angry now. Because Kacchan had left him. He had fucking left him.

"I know how hard this is," Shindo seemed to plead. "But don't do this. You saw how many zombies went after him. You won't come back."

"Oi, Shindo you there? Come in!"

Makabe's voice interrupted them, and Shindo was prying the walkie from Izuku's shaking fingers.

"Yeh, here Makabe, what is it?"

Izuku shut his eyes, willing his body to stop shaking, for his mind to clear so he could think. Just think. Kacchan wasn't dead yet. And so what if he had been bitten again? He'd been bitten once before and he survived. He'd survive again. He just needed to stop being stubborn and let Izuku help him.

"We got a situation, a big one. It's the kid, Katsuma."

Izuku's thoughts ground to a halt, and his head snapped up.

"What about him?"

"I don't know how! We were all watching him, but he managed to slip past and ... none of us can find him. I even check the monitors and nothing. But he kept going on about wanting to help. I think he's gone up there!"

"Katsuma," Izuku breathed. "No, no fucking way. Not him too."

He was moving before Shindo could stop him, snatching his axe from the ground and running to the doors.

"Midoriya wait!"

The streets were still as empty as when they entered the hospital. The zombies, wherever they were, were still distracted by Kacchan, and if Izuku stood a chance of reaching him he had to find Katsuma soon.

Katsuma ... Shit, he should have known; he should have warned someone! He was stupid to think the kid wouldn't try to follow them up there, so determined to make a difference. Izuku, at least, could understand how hard it was to stay put when people he cared about needed him. But Katsuma was a kid. He couldn't handle himself up here! His feet thundered against the tarmac, breath coming in short sharp gasps as he raced towards where they had first climbed up onto the street, his weapon heavy in his hands.

He almost missed the group of zombies coming at him, so silent were they and so focused was he, but his finely tuned sense of smell alerted him at the last moment. He dodged, jumping back as a zombie careered past him, smacking hard against the brick wall.

"Hey, hey, hey!"

Izuku looked up to see Shindo running towards him, trying to split the attention of the zombies before they all threw themselves at Izuku at once. He swung, smashing the skull of the zombie against the wall before caving in the chest of the second at his shoulder with the back swing. Shindo slammed his metal bat into the top of another's head, and together they took care of the remaining two.

"You can't run off, idiot," Shindo panted, glaring at him.

"Come on," Izuku grunted, ignoring him. "We have to find Katsuma."

They continued to jog forward, reaching the manhole, but they couldn't see any sign of Katsuma. It was possible that he had climbed up onto the street from any of the other exits in the town, finding him wouldn't be easy.

"You see him on any of the cameras?" Shindo said into the walkie.

"No," Makabe replied. *"I'll keep looking. Over."*

"Damn kid," Shindo grunted, grabbing his hair in frustration. "The fuck was he thinking?"

Izuku looked around, eye squinting and desperate for a sign, anything at all to give them an idea of where Katsuma had run off to.

"He knew we were going to the hospital," he said. "But we would have seen him if he went that way. Which means he must have gotten lost. Or," his stomach churned, "something turned him around."

"That way," Shindo said, pointing down the street. "Streets open, that's where I'd run if I were a scared kid."

"Make sure Makabe keeps looking," Izuku replied. "He's ok." He knew he was trying to convince himself at this point. "He's fine. All the zombies are still after Kacchan."

"You're not going after him once we find Katsuma, are you?" Shindo asked, falling into place beside Izuku as they ran down the road. "You can't be serious with that shit."

"What I do has nothing to do with you," Izuku snapped, eyes darting up and down the alleyways they passed.

"You get what happened, right?" Shindo insisted. "I'm pretty certain I'm right about the bite, Midoriya. At some point, Kat was bitten, and you both fucking knew that he was gonna turn into the same kinda fucked up monster as that thing back there."

Izuku swallowed, gritting his teeth together so that he wouldn't bite his tongue.

"Maybe Kat has changed in the last two years since I saw him, but I know for a fact he wouldn't wanna turn into something like that. Jesus, Midoriya, he knew he was coming up here to die today, you do get that, don't you?"

And Izuku was reminded, suddenly, painfully, of the night they had spent together ... of the way Kacchan had pressed his palm against his thundering heart.

He thought of how Kacchan had insisted on being the only one to lead the zombies.

Idiot.

How the fuck had he not realised?

"Katsuma!" he yelled, tears starting to roll down his cheeks again in frustration, the patch over his eye so sodden that it was barely holding onto his face.

"Katsuma!"

The sour smell of zombies reached him, and his heart raced. Either these were stragglers, or the zombies were starting to return to the streets. Neither option bode well for Katsuma and he hurried, following his nose, following-

"No ..."

He could hear it, thudding and shuffling, and as he ran up the street something else came into view. Something yellow, lying abandoned on the ground. A sticker flew past him, picked up by the breeze.

"No! Katsuma!"

But it didn't matter how much he pleaded, how much he begged for it to not be true. It didn't change a damn thing as he skidded to a halt, the tearing and snapping so loud down the narrow alley, zombies hunched over and obscuring everything bar a single blue shoe.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 28: Ghoul Intentions

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku travels alone.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wasn't sure how many zombies he took down that day. Once the blood started spraying, he lost track of the count, focusing only on the little body in the alley. The logical part of him had known that there would be nothing left to save, that Katsuma was dead. But the part driven by grief wouldn't let him stop, and he hacked and sliced until there was nothing left to hack and slice at.

There wasn't much for them to bring back to the camp, and what remained wouldn't have brought anyone any peace. In the fogginess of his brain, Izuku knew that he'd rather die than let Mahoro see the remains of her little brother. But, all of his energy had gone into slaughtering the zombies that had killed Katsuma, and by the time he'd seen the body he'd collapsed in exhaustion on the ground. He couldn't even summon a single tear, hardly acknowledging Shindo choking out a response to Daisuke on the walkie. After some minutes of silence, he and Shindo had gathered what they could; his shoes, and the yellow bag now stained with blood before returning to the camp.

It was only when he reached the woods that Izuku remembered the sticker still in his pocket.

There had been no question of Izuku staying at the camp after that. They'd lost Hanzo, and they had lost Katsuma, both deaths Izuku knew, deep down in his heart, he was responsible for. This had been his fucking idea, after all. His idea, and he was the one to walk out with little more than a bloody nose? And it had been he and Kacchan that had drawn the zombies from the hospital in the first place, and started all of this. Shindo had tried to stop him, though Izuku couldn't understand why he still cared. Shindo had asked him, at the very least, to stay the night so that he could get some rest. But every second he spent there felt wrong. Every second spent not chasing Kacchan was painful.

And so, Izuku had left. He'd gathered the supplies from the tent he and Kacchan had shared, chest tight, still unable to cry despite the constant sting. He'd felt eyes on him as he walked across the camp, head low. When he summoned the courage to look up, he saw the hateful expression on Mahoro's face. This little girl, clutching a yellow bag to her chest, her cheeks blotchy and flushed, staring at him like she knew. This was his fault. He had killed her little brother. And she knew.

He had never felt more like garbage.

The street was still suspiciously empty, once he climbed back out of the manhole. And, despite not hearing any response, Izuku still tried contacting Kacchan as he walked, his weakening, pleading calls the only sound as the sky above him darkened to a bloody red. No zombie rushed out to meet him, even when he approached the tall block of apartments that they had originally planned to lure the zombies to. He did, however, find his first signs that someone had fought here. Zombies lay

strewn across the street, heads bashed in, foul smelling blood on the asphalt. At first, there were just a couple of them, dotted sparingly like Kacchan had been able to keep a good lead on them, taking out any that got too close. But then the bodies grew more numerous. Closer packed.

Izuku came to a halt beside an old faded yellow van, bile rising to his throat as he looked at the stain across the front of it and the zone zombies lying beside it. The blood was, unquestionably, fresh. And there was a lot of it. Someone, he had to assume Kacchan, had hit the side of the van pretty hard; there was a large dent in the bodywork. Perhaps he had hit his head? He had fought them off, he had to have done or Izuku would have seen a body, and then he had pushed forward, trailing blood across the ground. Izuku's body began to tremble. Was this where it happened? Was this where Kacchan had been bitten?

He followed the blood trail to the outskirts of the town, wondering how Kacchan had been able to keep moving, keep out-pacing what had to have been a hundred zombies, maybe more, whilst he was bleeding this much. At some point, he had to have found somewhere safe to have been able to speak to Izuku, and it looked like he had gone into the woods to try and thin out the herd. It was dark by now, and Izuku had only his torch that was almost out of juice; going into the woods would be dangerous. Fuck, it would be *stupid*, but there was no question of turning back. Of waiting. Kacchan could still be alive, he could still be hiding where he had made the call. Alone, and waiting to die. Izuku was going after him, dark or not. He pulled out his torch, pointedly ignoring how dull the beam was, and stepped into the treeline.

Whatever trail there had been, Izuku had lost some time ago. His frustration led to tears, finally bubbling past his lashes and streaming endlessly down his cheeks as he walked. He shook, his teeth chattering, small wines left his lips as he fought back the growing urge to scream. Panic was setting in now, as he realised that he was probably only getting more and more lost. *Kacchan* wouldn't have gotten lost. The thought kept coming back to him, again and again. Nah, if things had been the other way around, and Izuku was the one who had vanished into the woods, Kacchan would have been able to find him. He'd have swooped in, right in the nick of time, that pissed off look on his face, swinging his bat and whisking him off to safety. Kacchan was built to survive this shitty world so why, *why*, was it Izuku still walking?

His feet hurt. His muscles ached. His clothes were still stained with zombie guts, and the stress was taking its toll. And then, he stumbled onto the hide.

There were a lot of dead zombies here. Shit, there were dozens of them, and Izuku gaped at the sight. It seemed inconceivable that anyone could kill this many of them, if that someone had been anyone *other* than Kacchan. His aching legs stuttered into a run, lungs heaving, hardly daring to hope though his damn heart betrayed him anyway. This had to be it, that had to be where Kacchan had called him from.

"Kacchan!"

He started to climb, hand whipping back suddenly as he felt something sticky and wet on his fingertips. There was blood here too; a few hours old, and tacky.

"Kacchan!"

He hurried up, slipping on several rungs of the ladder in his haste before crawling onto the wooden perch, pushing back the rough plastic flap across the entrance.

It was a dark cloudy night, and by now there was very little light to illuminate the interior of the hide, and he fumbled with the torch, breathing hard. It was a small thing, hardly big enough for two people to lay down in, but he still checked it twice - three times - regardless. Because Kacchan wasn't here. The only things here were the blood stained wood, scraps of a shirt ... and an abandoned walkie-talkie.

It didn't matter that Izuku wanted to keep searching, his body collapsed then and there, chest heaving as painful sobs filled the empty hide. His grief-addled brain was already running through the possibilities. Kacchan would have wrapped his wounds and kept going once the zombies lost interest in him, which was entirely plausible now that the female zombie was dead. He'd left the walkie behind because he didn't think he'd need it again, it was just something else for him to carry. Or ... Kacchan had died here. He had died, and then he had fallen from the hide and walked away.

When he felt an alien warmth on his cheek he realised that he must have fallen asleep, hands clutching the abandoned walkie-talkie despite the blood that stuck to it. Bright morning sun invaded the holes in the hide, burning his eyes as he squinted back. It took him a moment to realise that the blurriness in his vision had nothing to do with the sun, and he reached up to touch his face. The patch over his eye had fallen away. He'd been taking the drops religiously since they had found them, and whilst there definitely was some improvement, Izuku was pretty sure that his vision impairment was permanent. He sighed, pushing himself up and digging around in his backpack, before applying the drops and placing another patch over his eye.

Though it had definitely cost him time, the sleep had at least cleared his mind somewhat. The panic from last night still sat with him, that urgent need to move and move fast. But, shit, it didn't matter how big and blooming the romantic in him was, his practical side - the side that had kept him alive for so long - was as strong as ever. He *had* to accept, had to acknowledge, that he might not find Kacchan alive. But that didn't lessen his resolve. If Kacchan had turned, then Izuku had made a goddamn fucking promise, and he intended to keep it. He needed to be able to keep at least *one* promise. He shoved a piece of jerky into his mouth and climbed down from the hide.

In the harsh light of the day, the mass of bodies around him seemed even more unbelievable. But Izuku knew Kacchan; he was intimately familiar with how he fought by now, the precision with which he killed these damn things, and the person that had fought these zombies had not been in control. There were body parts all over the place, guts strewn across the leaf litter, some that had been hit four or five times across the body before their skulls had been smashed. Kacchan had truly been fighting for his life.

In spite of his grief, Izuku realised that pride still bloomed in his chest at the thought. Kacchan hadn't lied to him. He hadn't given up.

He took a deep breath, dragging his eyes from the horror laid out in front of him, and looked around. The real question was whether Kacchan, or zombie-Kacchan, would head in the same direction. Izuku once thought he understood a little about what drove the undead, but the more months went by the more he realised he hadn't a fucking clue. If he had been drawn back to the town, then no doubt Izuku would have stumbled across him in the dark with all the noise he had been making. Which meant, he must have gone in a different direction. He pulled his backpack around to his front, and took out the map from inside.

If Kacchan had survived, then chances are he would be headed somewhere he could safely rest up and have a chance of finding some provisions. Izuku knew Shindo had been right about one thing; Kacchan had come out here to die yesterday. In one sense or another, Kacchan had decided that he

was going to leave Izuku behind. The thought left his hands shaking with anger and frustration. He wasn't stupid, he fucking *knew* what Kacchan had been thinking. Hell, he'd hinted at it enough over the last few weeks alone. Kacchan had resigned himself to turning into one of those things, he supposed seeing the female zombie had been the trigger for him to take matters into his own hands. Whether he died out here or not, Kacchan was not intending to come back.

It was a fine plan, in all honesty. But Kacchan clearly didn't know Izuku as well as he thought he had. Hadn't quite accepted just how stubborn he could be. Because one way or another, Izuku was going to find Kacchan. He just had to hold onto that dying hope that he would be alive when he did.

Looking at the map, Izuku realised that if he carried on the course from town, he was only going to be walking closer and closer back to Fuji again. He couldn't know for sure where he was, exactly, not after stumbling through the woods in the dark like he had done. But if he was looking at this right, if he kept going uphill he could well find himself back at the little village where they had come across Mr. Zombig. He pulled absently at his lips as he frowned down at the map. He couldn't see why zombie-Kacchan would head that way, but he sure as shit could see why Kacchan would. There was food there, plenty of places for him to lie low, and Izuku had to admit there was a twisted kind of romance in Kacchan returning to the place where he had realised what the future held for him. It was still a shot in the dark, but it was best guess he had.

The way to the village was not easy. A hundred or more zombies had followed Kacchan into the woods, and it looked like they had simply continued to wander once they were no longer under the control of the female zombie, and the woods suddenly became a lot more deadly. He passed several groups as he trekked uphill. The urge to kill all of them was strong, but Izuku knew that killing just one zombie out here could lead to a damn swarm of them, and he sure as shit wasn't strong enough to fight off a whole herd. It made the going tough, fighting against the environment and hiding from the zombies; at one point he had been forced to hide behind a tree for twenty minutes as he waited for a group to pass. If he wasn't so consumed with thoughts of finding Kacchan, he might have found it interesting. Without the female zombie to guide them, without prey to draw them, the zombies looked lost and aimless. Sad, dead things that wandered in circles, would stop with their heads tilted back, staring with empty sockets up at the sky.

He had not, at least, spotted Kacchan among those sad, dead things.

Despite his albeit slow progress, Izuku was fully aware just how easy it would be to get lost in these woods, if he was not lost already. There wasn't much in the way of standout landmarks that he could use to navigate, so to that effect his map was almost entirely useless to him. And besides, if he ever did manage to figure out where in the hell he was, the number of times he'd had to shift entirely off course just to avoid a group of zombies ahead of him made it almost impossible to keep track. All he could do was keep heading uphill and follow the dispersing zombies. But, he was tired, and he had only enough supplies to last him the next couple of days. Before long, his situation would become dire.

Izuku's feet were lagging and the sky was starting to darken before he came across any sign other than the dead out here, and he was brought to a sudden, shuddering halt when the loud thud broke the silence, and an arrow embedded itself in the ground at his feet. As exhausted as he was, his instincts were so finely tuned by this point in the Apocalypse that he was ducking behind the nearest tree before he'd even fully taken into consideration what had happened. He flattened himself against the bark, heart racing, good eye wide and looking around him. Zombies didn't use

arrows ... And shit, in all the mess surrounding Kacchan Izuku had clearly forgotten that there were still people out here that wanted him dead.

"Hey you! Come out with your hands over your head or the next one sticks you in the belly!"

Izuku frowned. He didn't recognise the voice as anyone from those League of Bastards.

"How do I know you won't stick me anyway?" he yelled back, turning his head slightly to try and peer back around the tree.

He drew back with a yelp as the second arrow embedded itself in the bark, merely an inch from his cheek.

"Like, I'm a really good shot," the person called out, her voice breaking into a bright chuckle. "If I missed you, it's because I meant to."

"Look, I'm not here to bother you," Izuku replied. "I'm just passing through. You could just let me go?"

"Man, you're sounding just like that other guy," the stranger sighed. "Though he was a lot ruder about it."

Izuku's heart leaped, and he was stepping out from behind the tree before he could think twice about it. He held his hands in the air, searching for the stranger.

"Please, this other guy," he said. "D-did he have blond hair? Three scars on his face?"

For a moment there was silence, before a figure stepped forward from the trees, her bow hanging at her side.

"You know him, huh?" she said, quipping an eyebrow. "Yeh, he looked like that. Probably a total babe if he weren't so pale."

Izuku almost collapsed onto the ground, his hand reaching out to grab the tree and steady himself as the relief washed over him.

"He gave off a major gay vibe, and I'm not usually wrong!"

Izuku let out a weak little laugh.

"How is he? Can I see him?"

"Oh." The woman's face fell, giving him an empathetic pout. "It might be easier if you just came to the camp."

"Easier? What do you mean easier?"

The woman nodded her head, to the trees behind her.

"This way, boo."

"Boo?"

But she just shrugged and started walking, and Izuku was far too anxious about seeing Kacchan to consider how irresponsible it was to just be walking off with a stranger like this. He just had to hope that, if this was a trap, he was strong enough to fight anyone off.

"The name's Camie, by the way," the woman said, throwing him a charming smile over her shoulder. "I'm not usually such a buzz kill, honest. But the woods have been real noisy today, I thought you might have been one of the zombies at first."

"M-Midoriya," Izuku replied, hurrying to her side and bowing his head quickly. "Uh, yeh, it might get a little noisier, honestly."

"Yikes."

"The town not too far from here? Well, I just came from there and, uh, let's just say there were a lot of zombies there that have dispersed into the woods."

"Weird of them to leave a town to come into the woods," Camie said, placing a finger to her lip in consideration. "Usually it's the other way around!"

"Right," Izuku replied, rubbing his scarred arm awkwardly. He'd already given away too much to Shindo, he had to be careful about what he said to people, especially when it put Kacchan at risk. "So, my friend, is he badly hurt?"

Camie glanced across at him, but didn't reply, just holding her arm out in front of them. Izuku followed the gesture, and saw a small camp in front of him. The camp itself wasn't large; only about five tents, supplies dotted about the place, and barbed wire wrapped as a barrier that he and Camie had to duck beneath to enter. It was far from the comparative mansion the sewers had been, but it was far more than Izuku himself had right now.

"Here's home away from home," Camie announced.

Izuku's eyes darted, half nervous, half anxious, over the camp, listening out for the sound of rough swearing, perhaps a glimpse of blond hair, but the only person greeting them was a very large man who couldn't have been much older than himself. He stood with his arms crossed over his broad chest, a grin that looked anything other than friendly on his face as he eyed Izuku cautiously.

"You found another stray then, Camie?" the man asked, and for some reason Camie laughed.

"Aww, but look at him. He's tiny, I couldn't leave him out there!"

Izuku tensed. Her tone sounded friendly enough, but having his size brought up in front of a man who could probably break him over his thigh didn't exactly fill him with confidence.

"I-I'm sorry to impose," he said, holding his hands out in front of him. "I don't mean any harm. I'm just looking for my friend."

"Oh." The man's face fell, and Izuku's stomach began to twist into knots.

"H-he's ok, isn't he?" he stammered.

"I couldn't tell ya," the man replied.

"Yeh, he hightailed it out of here pretty quick," Camie said. Izuku shut his eyes tight. "Sorry, little dude."

"Is there anything you can tell me?" Izuku asked, looking between the two of them. "Please, how injured was he? Which way did he go?"

"He wasn't looking so hot," the large man replied, somewhat hesitantly. "Pale as you like, big bloody bandage around his head."

"We thought he might have been bit," Camie added.

"We offered him a bunk. But he seemed pretty keen to get out of here. Just asked if he could swipe some of Nagamasa's stash and that was that."

"St-stash?"

"Oh, alcohol. Nagamasa likes to pick up anything that takes his fancy."

Izuku paled.

"Which way did he go?"

"He carried on uphill that way," Camie said, pointing to their right.

"Ok, ok thank you!" Izuku bowed quickly.

"Wait, it's getting dark! You can't be out there all night-"

"Thank you for your concern, but I really have to find my friend!"

Izuku darted off, ducking beneath the barbed wire, ignoring the confused shouts from behind him. Alcohol? *What was Kacchan thinking?*

He probably wasn't.

Izuku knew that Kacchan had at least taken a pretty bad blow to the head, if the blood and the dent in the van had been anything to go by, though he wasn't so badly concussed that he couldn't take care of the zombies that had been after him. He had also been bitten a second time, which was no doubt going to be the most pressing concern for him. Shit, Kacchan was a recovering alcoholic, why *wouldn't* he down a bottle or two of something now that he was alone, and his chances of survival were dwindling by the hour?

But that only put Kacchan in more danger. If Kacchan got himself as drunk as he had done that night he had choked him, who knows what kind of trouble he might get himself into? Izuku's stomach churned. Who was to say he didn't just offer himself up as zombie bait again?

He had to find him. He had to catch up with Kacchan. He couldn't be more than a few hours ahead of him, twelve tops, and if he was drinking then it was possible that he would also start slowing down. He couldn't afford to rest. He took a swig of water, and kept going.

It was almost completely dark, and Izuku was exhausted, when he finally stumbled across his first concrete sign of Kacchan since the hide.

He almost tripped over the damn thing, so busy staying focused ahead of him that he didn't notice the empty bottle until he was lurching forward on top of it. He snatched it from the ground, holding it up to the little light from the moon above him.

"Vodka," he muttered to himself, tipping the bottle and watching a single drop fall back down to the leaf litter. He was sure Kacchan wouldn't be exactly picky at this stage, but vodka had definitely been one of his preferred drinks, and Kacchan was an entire damn bottle down of the stuff. Izuku had never been one for drinking, his tolerance was low, but even he knew that this was enough to knock Kacchan out, if he hadn't vomited it back up first. Hell, given the state he was in, this could possibly be enough to *kill* him. Maybe, Izuku thought with a shiver, that was the point.

With a fresh sense of urgency, Izuku started up again, splitting his focus from the woods around him and the ground at his feet until, at long last, he found himself back at the small village where Mr. Zombig had lived.

It was quiet. *Deathly* quiet. The clouds drifted across the moon leaving a cold shimmering sheen to the empty streets, causing Izuku to shiver. He looked around him, focusing first on the ground and then the buildings around him, as if half convinced that, if he stared hard enough, he might make out Kacchan's figure in the shifting shadows.

There were a couple of places where Izuku could start his search. Chances were, if Kacchan was still standing after downing one bottle of vodka, then the first thing he'd do would be to get hold of more alcohol, which meant the small supermarket they had raided on their way out. Izuku hiked his backpack higher up his shoulders, his fatigue long forgotten now that he found himself so close. He hurried down the street, running past the little houses before a familiar corner came to view and, in spite of himself, he felt his feet stumble to a halt.

He couldn't have stopped himself from looking if he had tried, his head turning to look down the street where he had almost died for the hundredth time this Apocalypse. He had seen way too many horrific things the last twenty-four hours for the sight of Mr Zombig's remains to elicit a gag from him, but it was a pretty close thing. The decomposing corpse of the huge zombie lay on the ground, chest and face caved in and picked clean by night time scavengers. Izuku knew he was dead, knew there was nothing much left that could have crawled after him, but he still found himself staring intently as if waiting for the damn thing to start dragging itself across the tarmac. He wondered if Kacchan had seen it ... wondered what thoughts had been going through his head when he had ... Shaking himself, he pushed past the corner and marched towards the supermarket.

Izuku needed only to step foot through the glass doors to confirm that someone had definitely come to the supermarket since the last time Izuku had been here. One of the stands closer to the front of the store had been knocked over, like someone had walked into the thing. The wall of alcohol facing the till had definitely been raided, but by someone with either shocking co-ordination or, far more likely, completely inebriated. Half the contents of the display lay smashed on the floor, like the entire wine selection had been swept off the shelf, and there was a space where Izuku guessed the vodka had been. Izuku’s stomach twisted uncomfortably. It was insane to think that Kacchan was still standing after the first bottle, let alone that he had gone looking for more, and with a fresh sense of urgency Izuku searched the small store, dreading turning a corner and seeing a body slumped against the shelving.

But, the store was empty. Wherever Kacchan was now, it wasn’t here, and he rubbed his face tiredly as he tried to figure out where Kacchan would have gone next. Any of the houses here would technically do; would he have to search all of them until he found him? Or …

“It can’t be that simple,” Izuku muttered, eyes darting up the street. It wouldn’t make sense for Kacchan to want to go back to that place but … alone, injured, and drunk Izuku wasn’t sure how much sense would be factoring into his thinking right now. It had been a safe house for them for a single night, the only other place that they knew of here for sure would be unlocked and empty. If Izuku had an entire night of kicking down doors ahead of him, he might as well start there.

It only took him a few minutes to reach the house of Mr Zombig, and sure enough he approached the home to find that the front door was wide open. Izuku broke into a run, heart hammering. Kacchan. Kacchan …

But, as he reached the door, he stumbled to a halt. Kacchan had drunk a lot, he had a head injury, had been bitten, and survival was so built into the both of them by now that an open door was a big fucking sign that something was seriously wrong. He might … not find Kacchan inside. At least, not the Kacchan that he remembered. His hands shook as he reached for the knife secured to his thigh, leaning the large fireman’s axe against the wall as he inched through the open door and into the hallway. He took a deep breath, and pushed deeper into the house.

In the end, after miles of heartbreak and frustration, when he finally saw Kacchan again it was far from the huge, emotional moment that Izuku thought it might have been. Instead, he walked into the cozy living room to see Kacchan sprawled across the sofa, face-down, and snoring loudly. But the relief was still so overwhelming that Izuku found himself sliding down the wall anyway, tears immediately springing to his eyes and wrapping his hands over his mouth to hide the sound of his choking sobs.

Kacchan looked like a damn mess. Strips of his black sweatshirt were wrapped around his head, so soaked with blood that even the dark fabric looked red and sticky in places, and what remained of his shirt was clutched in his hand like he had collapsed the moment he had pulled it over his head. There were scratches and cuts across his arms and what Izuku could make out of his torso, a huge purple bruise on his shoulder, but no obvious sign of a bite. Beside the couch lay two more empty vodka bottles, and another laying on its side, the contents soaking the rug. There was a full bottle lying half out of a shopping bag, and thank fuck he had passed out before reaching that. But, he was alive. And each snore seemed to bring Izuku more and more comfort, until he was able to take a shuddering breath and climb to his feet.

“Ka-” he paused. No, he didn’t want to wake him up just yet. He approached the couch, putting his knife away, and looked down at his busted, bloody body.

Kacchan said that he had been bit. That was Izuku’s main concern right now, he inched closer, hands hovering over Kacchan’s back as he looked for the bite. He’d definitely been through it, some of the scratches on his back looked like they could have been either from branches or snatching hands, but he hadn’t yet found the bite. He frowned, hesitating for a moment before he gently took each of his arms and rotated them. It was perhaps telling of how gone Kacchan was, that he didn’t so much as stir. If a zombie had stumbled in here, drawn by Kacchan’s snoring perhaps, he would have been eaten alive.

“Idiot,” Izuku breathed. He proceeded to pat his hands down Kacchan’s legs, but there was no large tear, no blood mark on the fabric, and Izuku had to surmise one thing.

Kacchan had fucking *lied* to him about the bite.

He had half a mind to shake him awake, to scream his frustration at him for scaring him, for leaving him behind! But then, his eyes dragged across his torso and his breath caught in his chest.

The last time Izuku had seen the bite scar on Kacchan's side it had spread across half his stomach and chest, the black and purple veins coiling out as if trying to strangle his entire body. The *last* time it looked for all the world like Kacchan was at the turning point. But now, Izuku found himself staring at pale skin where there had once been veins. There was no doubt about it, the bite scar was smaller than it had been just two nights previous. In fact, it had almost reduced to the size it had been the very first time that Izuku had seen it, all those months ago.

"What the hell?"

Kacchan grunted in his sleep, head turning, before snoring again. His face was still pale, the dark rings under his eyes and the blood sticking to his forehead and temple not helping matters, but he didn't look quite so sallow any more. Izuku backed towards the wall again, sliding down it, staring in confusion and disbelief.

It didn't make any sense. How was Kacchan's scar looking better? Was it perhaps something to do with the female zombie? Had it gotten worse whilst she was controlling him and Izuku just hadn't put two and two together? Was it better because she was dead? Was this perhaps a side effect of Kacchan being close to a zombie *like* him or-

Izuku gasped, his eyes dropping to the vodka bottles on the floor. Maybe it was much more simple than that.

The headaches, the sickness, Izuku had accounted for it all as withdrawal with Kacchan trying to deal with his addiction, but what if it had been more than that? Now that Izuku thought about it, the spacing out, the scar, it had all gotten worse after Kacchan had stopped drinking. And, if Izuku was right in his assumptions, Kacchan had turned to alcohol not long after he had been bitten, and had been drinking ever since. And now that Kacchan had somehow managed to drink enough alcohol to kill a regular person, the effects of his bite were reversing.

Perhaps, in this, was the answer to all of it. Was Kacchan's ability to metabolise so much alcohol because of his bite? Or was his ability to metabolise so much alcohol why he hadn't been killed like he ought to have been? If Kacchan continued to drink, would he be able to hold off the virus indefinitely? And was that why Mr Zombig had turned so much quicker than Kacchan had? This changed things. This could change *everything.*

Despite how exhausted he was, his mind was racing far too much for him to even consider getting any sleep. He climbed to his feet, shut and bolted the front door, grabbed a blanket from the bedroom upstairs, and set himself back down against the wall facing Kacchan. In spite of his revelations, the shrinking scar on his side, the relief in seeing him again, Izuku couldn't deny the hot searing rage that simmered in his chest. Kacchan had lied to him, had left him behind, had tried to drink himself to damn death … Kacchan had a lot of explaining to do once he finally woke up, and Izuku wasn't going to take any more bullshit from him when he did.

It was morning by the time Kacchan stirred, a muffled grunt and groan prompting Izuku to lift his tired and heavy head from where it had slid down against the wall. Kacchan's face was still pressed into the fabric of the sofa, his brow scrunching as he turned his head, heavily bloodshot eyes blinking dazedly out across the living room before eventually crossing with Izuku's. For a moment, neither of them moved, Kacchan staring and blinking, before a croaked, *'fuck*' left his lips and he burried his face into the sofa again.

Izuku didn't trust himself to speak, just watching Kacchan's back rise with a large, shaky breath. Another minute passed before Kacchan was squinting in his direction again.

“You’re still here,” he muttered, voice so thick and gravelly that Izuku could only just make sense of what he was saying. “Thought ‘magined it.”

“You lied to me.”

Izuku hadn’t meant for that to be the first thing he said to him, but the words came out regardless, tight and emotional, shaking like the hands that he gripped together beneath the blanket.

“What’re you doin’ here, stupid Deku?”

“You *lied* to me!” Izuku repeated, words tearing at his throat, furious at how quickly Kacchan tried to redirect, to evade the point.

Kacchan let out a tired sounding huff, a half-hearted roll of his lips, before he pushed himself up into a sitting position on the couch. Izuku felt anger dipping when he saw the dark blood caking his right temple, plastering the hair on that side of his head to his face, the sight grim and nauseating. A nasty gash ran down from his collarbone and over his chest, and Izuku winced at the dirt he could see clinging to the ragged flesh. Any lingering fury was gone, and he was on his feet in an instant, running over and grabbing Kacchan’s cheeks and turning his head.

“You should have used some of that alcohol to clean your damn wounds,” he hissed. “You idiot.”

“I didn’t lie ‘bout shit,” Kacchan said back, pushing Izuku away before he could reach for the bloody fabric probably glued to his head by this stage. Izuku froze, eyeing Kacchan up and down again, before his anger flared back up.

“You said you got bit!” he said, voice raised. “You told me you were fucking bitten and that’s why you couldn’t come back!”

“I *was* bitten!” Kacchan snarled. “Two damn years ago. The hell do you think started all this shit?”

“You’re a bastard!” Izuku lashed out, pushing hard against Kacchan’s uninjured shoulder, causing him to slump back onto the sofa with a grunt. “Twisting the truth is still *lying,* you cruel bastard! How could you do that to me? How could you make me think you were … you were dead or- Who the fuck do you think you are?!” Izuku was screaming now. He knew he must look half mad, eyes bugging and lips all but foaming. Kacchan stayed where he had fallen, arm propped behind him, staring back at him.

“You planned this from the beginning! And like an *idiot,* I didn’t realise until it was too late!”

“De-”

“And then, after everything we’ve been through, you hide behind a fucking walkie-talkie to say goodbye?” Izuku shook his head, his cheeks hot and his vision blurring. “To tell me that you l-love-” his voice broke, hiccuping over a sob. “You’re a coward, Bakugou Katsuki! A fucking coward! You left me and came out here to die! You bastard, you fucking cowardly piece of- of-” But Izuku was too tired, too emotional, his voice shaking too hard for him to finish, shoulders slumping forward and hiding his face behind one of his hands.

“I didn’t leave so I could die,” Kacchan said, voice uncharacteristically quiet. “I left so you could live.”

Izuku shook his head again, the word *'bastard'* falling so easily from his lips again.

"Nah, fuckin' listen to me," Kacchan said, a hand reaching out to grip hold of Izuku's wrist, tugging his hand away from his face. "Just *listen.* How long you think we got, hah? Days? A week? A month? No, fuck that, how long do you think *I* got? But you? You've got a whole fuckin' life ahead of you, Deku!"

Izuku's nose crinkled, holding back the screams he wanted to unleash in Kacchan's face.

"I saw an opportunity. I couldn't fuckin' stay there, not when I can turn any day now. But you could! You could have started something there, in that place, with all those people. The only thing holding you back from that was me."

"You could have talked to me-"

"I tried!" Kacchan interrupted, voice shaking. "Don't gimme that *shit,* Deku. You know I've tried, but you won't listen. This was the only thing I could think of."

Izuku sniffed, his teeth pulling at his lips. "No."

Kacchan snatched his hand back like he had been burned, his expression dissolving into one that Izuku had never seen on his face before. Painful, defeated, he pressed both of his hands to his face.

"You want me to fuckin' beg?" he choked into his own knees, and Izuku's throat stung, his heart racing. "Fine. You win. *Please.* Go. Just go, Deku. Please, leave me and go!"

Kacchan was sobbing now, his shoulders shaking, pitiful sounds filling the room. And Izuku knew how much he was hurting, he knew why, he understood. He really truly understood what Kacchan wanted, what he needed but …

He climbed onto the sofa beside him, his entire body shaking with the apprehension of what he was about to say, knowing what it would do to Kacchan. Knowing how much pain it was going to cause him.

"No," he whispered.

Kacchan choked mid-sob, before wrenching his face from his hands and fixing Izuku with a disbelieving glare, made all the more gut wrenching by the redness of his eyes, the blood and snot leaving tracks down his skin.

"I don't want you to die!" Kacchan screamed. "Izuku, *please!"*

"I'm not leaving you," Izuku repeated, firmer. "I have lost every single person I have ever loved, ever cared about, and I wasn't there for any of them when it happened. My best friends were killed and I wasn't there to help them. Sh-Shouto was eaten and I wasn't there to stop it. My mum-" his voice wavered. "I know she's gone too, and I was half-way across the country. You know, that was the first time I'd ever been so far away from her and …" He took a deep breath. "I'm not leaving, Katsuki. Days, weeks, months, you're not dying alone. There is no living for me, if living means leaving you behind."

His hot tears landed on his lap, the both of them threatening to drown. Kacchan choked and sobbed, his lips wobbling, before he collapsed, falling forward into Deku's chest, hands grabbing hold of

the fabric of Izuku's shirt to stop himself from sliding onto the floor. Careful to keep the bloody fabric away from his mouth, Izuku angled his chin to rest on top of Kacchani's head, wrapping his arms around him. Kacchan continued to cry, hard, body shaking with the sobs that wracked through him, Izuku letting himself sway gently as he stroked the back of his head, his back, uttering soft sounds of comfort even as he soaked Kacchan's shoulders with his own tears.

He wasn't sure how long they sat like this. Kacchan's sobs had petered out into sniffles long ago, the shakes became trembles, became a weak, limp body propped against his chest, as Izuku continued to stroke his palm against his hot skin. After a while, he felt Kacchan stir, gently pulling himself from Izuku's grip, hand coming up to wipe his nose.

"Fuckin' embarassing," he muttered, and Izuku found him smiling.

"Yeh, crybaby."

Kacchan shot him a glare that held no heat, before averting his gaze again and pouting down at the bottles at his feet.

"Let me look at your wounds," Izuku said, and with a grunt Kacchan nodded. Relieved, Izuku got to his feet and grabbed his backpack from where it lay against the wall, opening it wide to reveal the solution and swabs he had kept with him since the sewers.

"What happened?" he asked, reaching towards the torn fabric around Kacchan's head. His wrist was snatched again, Kacchan twisting his hand palm upwards.

"Hold on, you ain't got any cuts or anything on you hands, right?"

Ah. Right.

Izuku looked down. There was already some of Kacchan's blood across his wrists, and dirt tracked under his nails, but that there weren't any obvious cuts across his hands didn't mean there wouldn't be abrasions that he hadn't noticed.

"My hands are dirty anyway," he mumbled, before digging back into his pack and pulling out a box of disposable gloves, thankful that he had thought to grab them before leaving. Kacchan grunted again as Izuku pulled the clear latex over his fingers.

The wound on the right side of Katsuki's head looked bad. The skin had been split, Izuku feeling somewhat sick at the pale bone visible beneath the congealed blood, it was frankly a miracle that Kacchan was still conscious after an injury like this.

"One of the zombies hit me," Kacchan muttered, in way of an explanation, as Izuku tried to clean the wound. "Smacked my head pretty hard against a van or some shit."

"Yeh, I saw the dent," Izuku replied. "I'm surprised it didn't knock you out."

Kacchan grunted. "I was pretty dazed for a bit."

"Well, your decision to wrap it up is probably the only reason you hadn't bled out," Izuku said. "Kept most of the gunk out, too."

"Gunk the professional term?"

Kacchan sounded exhausted, but the gentle tease in his voice rang through anyway, and Izuku felt a relieved smile come to his lips.

“The bad news,” Izuku continued, “is this is going to need to be stitched.”

“Great.”

“The worse news,” Izuku said with a sigh, “is I can’t do it right away. It’s been open too long, I can’t risk closing up if it becomes infected.”

“So how long have I gotta be walking about with a hole in my head?”

“Uh, a couple days. Four … maybe five. It will depend on if it gets infected. And uh, you remember what we had to do with my arm? With all the dead tissue …”

Kacchan barked a short humourless laugh.

“Right.”

“For now we just keep it clean. How’d you get that cut on your chest?”

Kacchan looked down, and shrugged. “Tree or some shit, I dunno. Wasn’t a zombie, though.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeh, m’sure,” Kacchan replied.

Izuku started to clean and flush the wound, very much aware of how quickly they were going to be getting through the antibiotic solution. Once it was clean, Izuku was pleasantly surprised to see that it wasn’t nearly as bad as it had first appeared.

“It’ll scar,” Izuku said, “but I think we can avoid stitches for this one.”

“What’s one more scar, hah?”

“Hmm, it’ll just add to the appeal,” Izuku replied without thinking. It was only after Kacchan didn’t respond that he realised quite what he said, his cheeks starting to burn even as he glanced up.

“You don’t say?” Kacchan said. It was a poor effort, even Izuku saw that, but the hint of a teasing smirk on Kacchan’s face, the wobbly pump of his eyebrows, eased his heart more than he could say.

“Shuddup,” he mumbled.

Kacchan huffed a short laugh, letting himself rest back comfortably on the sofa.

“So, how were the extras at the sewers before you left?” he asked, and Izuku froze, like a fist made from ice had suddenly gripped him by the throat, as images of a tiny body torn beneath him filled his brain and left him choking back the freezing bite.

“Deku?”

Kacchan had noticed, because of course he had, and Izuku realised that he could just … not tell him. Kacchan had been through enough, he had *lost* enough, he didn't need to carry this burden.

"They're fine," he said, the words tasting ugly and bitter on his lips. Kacchan furrowed his brow, eyes narrowed as he watched him doubtfully.

"Deku," he started, voice low and tipped in warning, but Izuku shook his head.

"I'm just … I'm not ready to talk about it right now," he said hurriedly. "But they're ok, everyone's … ok."

Kacchan didn't look convinced, Izuku was certain that he knew that he wasn't being honest with him, but he didn't press the matter.

"More importantly," Izuku continued, pulling his hands back to his lap in the hope that he could hide how much they had started to shake. "We need to talk about your bite."

Kacchan frowned.

"Hah?"

"You haven't even noticed."

"Noticed what?" Kacchan snapped, before he raised an arm so that he could look down at his side. "Great, I'm still bit, what the fuck am I supposed to be-" he paused. The expression on his face would have been almost comical if Izuku wasn't fighting so hard not to have a panic attack at any given point. Kacchan then checked his other hip, almost as if convinced that the sprawling mass of dark veins had somehow switched sides. "What the *fuck?"* he hissed.

"I've got some theories," Izuku said, and Kacchan glanced up at him.

"'Course you fucking do."

"But what matters is the infection seems to be … uh, reversing? I don't know if that's the right word for it, whatever it is."

"*How in the fuck?"* Kacchan breathed, running a thumb across the bite. "Alright, talk you walking medical degree, how the fuck has it gotten better?"

"I had a few thoughts," Izuku replied. "At first I thought maybe it had something to do with the female zombie back in the town, maybe being that close to one of them makes the infection get worse? But then, I remembered that your symptoms had been getting worse before then."

"Yeh, coz I'd stopped drinking," Kacchan said. "That had fuck all to do with the bite-"

"But what if it did?" Izuku interrupted, somewhat breathless. "Kacchan, think about it! You've been drinking ever since you were bitten, right?"

Kacchan frowned, looking uncomfortable. "I … look, it wasn't a *problem* back then-"

"That's not what I'm saying. You started drinking right after you were bitten, that's my guess, and you've been drinking, sometimes a lot, ever since then."

“You wanna get to the point?”

“As soon as you stop drinking, your bite starts to look worse! And now-”

“Now I started drinking again,” Kaccha muttered, looking down at the bottle around them. “Hold up, nah that’s bull. If fucking *alcohol* was the cure we’d know it by now.”

“I don’t think it means that alcohol is the cure,” Izuku replied, “but it’s got to be part of the puzzle. You’ve got some kind of resistance to the virus, or maybe you were bitten by a zombie with a mutation of it, and the alcohol just adds to that resistance. Maybe this is why you’ve not turned yet, whilst Mr Zombig did.”

“Mr Zom- fuck me, ok, so if that’s *true,* then what? Either I drink enough that I kill my liver or the bite gets me?”

“Kacchan, you drank *four bottles* of vodka,” Izuku replied seriously. “I don’t think killing your liver is going to be that easy.”

“Bastard, I only drank three.”

“Four, I found another bottle in the woods.”

“That … weren’t mine,” Kacchan replied doggedly.

“Point is, we know more than we did before. Maybe if you keep drinking, the infection might not get any worse.”

“Hey, you were the one that wanted me to stop.”

“I know, but only because I was worried about you. You definitely don’t need to be drinking a whole bottle of vodka every day.”

“None of this shit makes any sense,” Kacchan sighed. “But when was the last time *anything* made any sense, anyway?”

“This is good news, Kacchan,” Izuku insisted. “This …” he took a deep breath. “This is really good. This gives us some control back. You keep talking about days, weeks, what if … what if this is all it takes to give us years?”

“Don’t get over excited,” Kacchan said. Though there was something akin to a smile on his face, if Izuku were to look closely enough, a softness in his eyes that was just about as rare as the smile these days. “I still got a hole in my head, remember? Plus, there’s that self-sacrificial attitude of yours to work on. Ain’t gonna be years if you take it upon yourself to fix everyone else’s problems all the damn time.”

“Right,” Izuku replied, cheeks flushing. He looked back at the wound on Kacchan’s head then, satisfied to see that it hadn’t started bleeding again, but applying a little more solution to it none-the-less. The last three days had been no less than horrific, so much had happened that he wasn’t sure he would ever be able to unpack it, and there were traumas there that would sit with him for the rest of his life, as if the Apocalypse hadn’t already given him plenty. But, Kacchan was here. He was alive, and for the moment he was safe.

“Did … did you really mean what you said?” he asked softly, and Kacchan hummed.

“You gotta be more specific, I say a lot of important shit.”

“Well, when you said … you said you loved me.”

Kacchan stiffened, and Izuku watched his ears turn red before his very eyes.

“In my fucking defence I didn’t think I’d have to follow up on it,” he grumbled, voice low, and definitely awkward. “Don’t you think we’ve talked about enough mushy shit today? Hell, this *year?”*

“Hmm, you said it,” Izuku replied, sitting back down on the sofa again.

“Fuck off,” Kacchan muttered, averting his gaze and pouting.

“You love me,” Izuku said, the grin on his face now impossible to hold back.

“It was a slip of the tongue, didn’t mean anything.”

“Na’ah, *you* said it, and I thought the great Bakugou Katsuki never said anything he didn’t mean.”

“I will crush you like a bug.”

“With hugs because you looooove me.”

“Fuck you.”

“We could do that because, as we’ve already established, you love me.”

“You’d fuck someone with a head injury? And I thought you were supposed to be decent. Fucking gross, Deku.”

“Wh- no, wait, that’s not what-”

“Can’t believe you’re such a pervert.”

“No, I’m not!”

“You better not have done anything whilst I was sleeping.”

“Kacchan! Don’t be mean!”

“Hmm, I’ll let it slide this one time. But *only* because I love you.”

“Why’re you so- oh.” Izuku grinned, lopsided and happy, enjoying the way Kacchan still kept his eyes averted despite the smallest smile tugging on his lips.

“I love you too.”

Izuku leaned forward and pressed a kiss to the end of Kacchan’s nose.

“Gross, I told you enough mushy stuff.”

But Izuku could only laugh.

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 29: Brain Drain

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Katsuki finally set their sights on Shizuoka

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The two of them ended up staying a further five days in the little village at the base of the mountain.

Kacchan had been the most frustrated by that. Despite his initial quest to find some degree of solitude whilst the virus caught up with him, now that they had discovered that the effects of his bite could be quelled with alcohol, he had an entirely new single-minded goal. They had been separated from the rest of Kacchan's group for months now. Frankly, at this stage Izuku couldn't even be confident in how much time had passed since they had lost Sero, but he did know that it had been far *too* long. The residual summer warmth was all but gone. Izuku was waking up cold each and every morning; if they didn't move soon, then there was every chance that they would never find them.

But, Kacchan still had a damn hole in his head. And Izuku refused to go anywhere until it had been stitched up. By some miracle, no hint of infection had set into the wound; he'd been religious about hygiene, even if they had resorted to spirits for cleaning the wound once the antibiotic solution had run out. But, in this kind of environment, it was still unusual that the wound had stayed looking so clean. There hadn't even been much in the way of dead tissue for Izuku to cut back before finally stitching Kacchan's scalp back together. He wondered quite how much of that the virus was responsible for.

Whilst they waited for Kacchan to be healed enough to travel, the two of them made the most of the quiet village; searching each and every house for food and supplies, replacing their old battered backpacks and sleeping bags with new ones. Izuku also found a small, collapsible camping stove that fit neatly into Kacchan's pack. It was also a week that, in spite of Kacchan's indignation over the matter, Izuku began trying to calculate just how much alcohol he ought to be drinking. There was a fine line between keeping the zombie virus under control, and leaving Kacchan's senses dulled and his words slurring. Not to mention, Izuku had to keep in mind that Kacchan was an alcoholic, though his situation meant it unlikely he could ever be classed as recovering. Kacchan grumbled and swore each and every time the subject was brought up, bristling and glaring when Izuku watched him as he drank, and flipping him off when Izuku told him to stop. But, he still did as he was asked. Despite Izuku's anxiety over the situation, he could see that Kacchan was really trying. It would, realistically, take far longer than a week for them to figure out what worked, but for now Kacchan was filling his hip flask and finishing it throughout the course of the day, with no ill effects to his demeanor, and no increase in the size of the scar.

The morning after Izuku had stitched up the wound on Kacchan's head, he was woken by

something kicking him in the shin, insistent and irritating, and far too cruel for this time of the morning.

“Oi, you lazy fuck.”

Izuku groaned, grabbing his blanket and pulling it up over his head. Now that he and Kacchan knew where they stood, knew the extent of their feelings towards one another, he had honestly expected more mornings much like the one they had shared that day in the tent. Arms wrapped around him, soft kisses against his neck, slow smiles… but their honeymoon period had extended to and ended on that singular morning. Instead, he would find himself woken up each day by hands or feet planted square against his back, shoving with complete and utter indifference to his desires for affection.

“Kacchaan,” he whined, hiding beneath his blanket. “Stop waking me up like this.”

But the blanket was pulled back, leaving Izuku shivering on the bed, and glaring up through sleep-crusted eyes at the man staring down at him.

“I’ve been awake for an hour. Maybe if you got up at a decent time I wouldn’t have to fuckin’ wake you.”

“Or maybe you could just stay in bed for a bit longer,” Izuku sighed, sitting himself up and rubbing his eyes, trying to get a better grasp of his surroundings. His eyesight, he had come to accept, was permanently damaged. He no longer needed the drops, and the blood had drained from where it had once pooled in his left eye, but the world around him had become a very blurry place.

“No time, Deku. We’re getting our asses out of here today.”

Izuku hummed tiredly, grabbing the water bottle at the bedside.

“You sure you’re ready?”

He looked to his right, vision clearing enough that he could actually make out the face, and the paired glare staring back at him, before his eyes darted upwards.

“Where’s your hair?!”

He hadn’t really intended to shout it. He was so used to the long spiking locks that had come to obscure the entire of Kacchan’s forehead, that seeing the wide expanse of it again came as quite the shock. It wasn’t the best of jobs, it was pretty clear that Kacchan had taken to hacking back at the lengths with a pair of scissors, but he supposed he probably looked far better than Izuku did right now.

Kacchan flushed, his lips pouting as he continued to glare defiantly down at him.

“Well, I wasn’t gonna walk about with a fuckin’ bald spot, was I?” he snapped. And then he paused, eyes drifting up to the long shaggy mess that hung to Izuku’s shoulders, and a sinister looking grin came to his lips. “You want me to cut yours?”

“No,” Izuku said quickly, shimmying himself across the bed and out of reach. Kacchan smirked,

and began to stalk after him.

“Come on, baby, I’ll be gentle.”

“Don’t you dare touch my hair!” Izuku yelped.

“You look fucking stupid. Just a little off the ends.”

“No!”

A tussle ensued, Izuku trying to leap from the bed just as Kacchan ducked forward and wrapped his arms around his chest and threw him back down. Izuku always managed to forget just how strong Kacchan was, and was left winded as hands pinned him to the bed.

“Now, lay there like a good boy whilst I go get the scissors.”

“No scissors!”

“You’re right, I’m gonna need a fucking lawn mower to cut through this mess.”

“I hate you,” Izuku replied, laughing in spite of himself. “You’re such a bully, anyone ever tell you that?”

“Never to my face, they wouldn’t dare.”

“Get off me!” Izuku grunted, still laughing as he pulled his feet up and started trying to prise Kacchan’s body from his.

“Don’t wanna.”

A shiver ran down his spine, and all resolve faltered when he felt the breath against his ear, and a kiss pressed against the point of his jaw.

So, Izuku may not get lazy, kiss-filled mornings, but things certainly had changed between them. All for the better, so far as he was concerned. He wasn’t all that surprised to discover that Kacchan was a very tactile kind of person; a hand at his elbow, a kiss on his cheek, a grab of his ass … Kacchan *liked* touching him. And Izuku had entirely no problem with that.

“I thought we were gonna get out of here?” he said, trying to sound unbothered as the kiss became a long lick down his throat. And Kacchan, ever the horny bastard, ground his hardening dick against Izuku’s hip.

“Hmm, five minutes,” Kacchan mumbled into his neck.

“F-five mi- What do you take me for?” Izuku yelped, grabbing Kacchan’s shoulders and pushing him back.

“Hot and efficient,” Kacchan replied with a smirk. Izuku blushed, even if he knew that Kacchan was trying to insult his stamina.

“Alright,” Kacchan sighed dramatically. “Ten minutes. Though I still reckon I can make you come in five.”

Izuku’s blush became darker. It was senseless to argue with the man. Kacchan approached their new-found relationship with the same dogged passion as he did everything else, and Izuku would not have changed that for the world. He pretended to think about it, raising a hand to his mouth and pulling his bottom lip in consideration.

“Fine.”

“ *Fine?* ” Kacchan repeated, with a scoff. “Man, don’t strain yourself.”

“Clock’s ticking, Kacchan,” Izuku replied.

“Wash that filthy mouth out,” Kacchan growled, grinning at the challenge. “Turn over.”

Izuku shimmied onto his side, letting Kacchan manhandle him into the position he wanted, Izuku back flush against Kacchan’s chest, hot breath against the shell of his ear. Kacchan wasted no time grabbing the waistband of the joggers Izuku slept in, and yanking them down to his thigh, Izuku hissing in the chill.

“Cold!” he said with a pout, glaring over his shoulder at Kacchan.

“Don’t worry, baby, I’ll warm you up.”

Baby... Izuku never thought pet names would be his thing, but coming from Kacchan, the word had him preening and melting. Kacchan pulled him closer, before he wrapped one of his large, hot hands around Izuku’s hardening dick. Izuku keened and bucked at the sensation, the warmth alone enough to get his blood boiling. Satisfied with his reaction, Kacchan tightened his fist and started a slow, purposeful drag upwards before swirling his thumb over the tip. Izuku whined again.

“Wh-what about you?” he breathed, before Kacchan’s free hand grabbed his hip and pulled him backwards, his clothed dick nestling between Izuku’s bare cheeks.

“I gotta change these jeans anyway,” he replied, before he started to pick up the pace, wrapping and twisting and clenching his fist around Izuku in time with the rock of his hips against his ass.

The very thought of Kacchan coming in his pants, coming in his pants because of *him* was more than enough to drown Izuku in heady lust, and he quickly surrendered to the sensations. The pleasurable pressure around his dick, the insistent grinding of denim against his ass, the hot panting in his ear, the odd ‘ *fuck* ’ thrown into the mix, all made for one of the hottest moments of his life.

True to Kacchan’s word, Izuku soon felt the heat boiling in his lower stomach, the stuttering of his hips as he both thrust into Kacchan’s fist and ground back against his lap.

“F-fu- I’m gonna- Kacchan, I’m gonna-”

“Fuck yeah.”

Izuku cried out as he spilled into Kacchan's hand, vision going white and mouth hanging open. Kacchan growled into his neck, the rough sound becoming a soft whine as he thrust forward once more, hard, and trembled.

" *Fuck fuck fuck …* "

The two of them sagged, Kacchan panting and Izuku basking in post-orgasmic bliss.

"T-told you I'd make you come in five," Kacchan breathed smugly into the back of his neck.

"My hero," Izuku replied, rolling his eyes. "Five minutes run-time is all I've ever wanted from a lover."

"Alright, smart-ass, you want me to wipe your cum on your face?"

"Gross, geddof!" Izuku laughed, pushing Kacchan away. Kacchan pressed one last kiss to the shell of his ear before rolling off the bed, grimacing down at the wet patch across the front of his jeans. He shrugged, and wiped his hand across his thigh.

This is the one? Izuku thought, before shaking his head and smiling.

"What're you grinning 'bout?"

"Oh, nothing," Izuku replied, pulling his joggers up around his waist and sliding from the bed. "I'm gonna wash up, then we can get going?"

"You bet."

It turned out that, not only had Kacchan found time to give himself a terrible haircut whilst Izuku had been sleeping, he'd also packed away their supplies in his eagerness. Izuku was amused to find him waiting by the front door, dressed in fresh clothes, tapping his foot irritably on the ground. It was good, great even, that Kacchan had this new focus and was no longer so preoccupied with the consequences of his bite. His enthusiasm had been enough to prevent Izuku from spiralling too far; the guilt he felt, that acute sense of loss, was a ticking time bomb and Izuku knew it. Eventually he would have to stop hiding from it, running from it, burying the memories to the bottom of his backpack along with the sticker he could no longer look at.

"You done fannying about?" Kacchan said.

No, Kacchan didn't leave any time for wallowing.

"Yeh, just about ready."

Izuku double checked his pack, re-tied his shoes for good measure, and grabbed the fireman's axe resting against the wall.

"Ok, let's go."

"About damn time."

It was another cold morning, the frost settled on the overgrown vegetation creeping out over the pathways entirely untouched, cracking beneath their feet. Izuku's breath immediately puffed out in clouds in front of him, the heavy, fleeced denim around his shoulders no longer enough to hold back the bite of the cold. Kacchan made a disgruntled sound from beside him, zipping up his coat and pulling the fur hood over his head.

"No detours this time," he said, sniffing and swinging his bat over his shoulder, red eyes taking in the street ahead of them. "No other groups, no mutant zombies, no hospitals, just smooth sailing from here to Shizuoka. Deal?"

"I'll stay out of trouble if you do," Izuku replied, a wobbly smirk covering the fresh chattering of his teeth.

"Fuck you," Kacchan grunted without bite, shoving his shoulder.

The woodland that surrounded the little village, that offered them the quickest route to the highway that would lead them straight to the heart of Shizuoka, was always going to be somewhat of an obstacle for them. It wasn't anything that Izuku didn't feel confident in their ability to handle, particularly given just how many zombies Kacchan alone had fought just to get here. But ducking and hiding from the zombies they spotted along the way was time consuming. There weren't a huge number of them, at least from what Izuku could best guess; it had been long enough, perhaps, that those that had followed Kacchan from Fujinomiya were mostly scattered. Still, there were enough of them about that taking care of the singletons and groups they spotted could prove problematic if it drew more of them in. Izuku knew that Kacchan was itching to just get on with it, he could see the way his hands tightened in a death grip around his bat each and every time Izuku dragged him behind a tree to wait it out. But, Izuku knew from experience that trouble was likely enough to find them as it was… it would be foolish of them to go looking for more.

Despite the frequent stopping and starting, they made good progress and were nearing the border of Fujinomiya by the early afternoon, the waterfall and hospital directly ahead of them. There hadn't been a question of avoiding the place; Izuku didn't want to go back. He wasn't ready, and if running from the bad memories and the guilt churning up inside of him meant he could at least be there for Kacchan, then he would sure as hell embrace denial. He didn't miss the strange look that Kacchan gave him when he saw that he didn't want to pass through the town, the way his mouth opened as if to ask him something before huffing and nodding his head. It was fortunate that Kacchan himself had no interest in dropping in, because he didn't argue the matter.

But, the decision to avoid this section of Fujinomiya meant that they would need to continue hiking through woodland, adding more time to their journey, and passing through a smaller town along the way. Kacchan estimated that it would likely end up adding another two or three hours to the walk, and almost certainly meaning that they would need to find somewhere to rest for the night. Neither of them were especially happy about that; finding somewhere to sleep meant stopping, and stopping meant they were just giving trouble an opportunity to catch up with them. But walking through the night was too dangerous, not with the dead and the living ready to take advantage.

By nightfall, they had reached Shibakawa. The overgrown crop fields, and deserted farm houses felt more than a little spooky in the dwindling light, and the small stores and old groceries in this area had been gutted just as thoroughly as any in the busier towns. A large house among the fields grabbed their attention, far enough from the road and with open enough surroundings that they would be able to see anything coming long before it saw them. With feet crunching over cold, hard

soil, they left the main road behind them, holding their weapons in front of them and eying the doors and windows.

The house, fortunately, was empty. Whoever had lived here had left in a hurry, doors wide open, gardening equipment discarded around the front. A single eroded body lay some feet away, almost entirely bone by this point, and when Izuku spotted the small van still parked out front, he realised that it was likely that the previous tenant hadn't been able to make it in time after all.

Kacchan set them up in the living room at the front of the house, pushing back the dusty curtains so that they could see the moon-bathed road. They made a quick meal of one of the cans of vegetables that Kacchan had stashed in his pack, before Izuku stretched out across the couch and heaved a heavy sigh.

"You should sleep first," Kacchan said, from the chair he had dragged beside the window. Izuku furrowed his brow.

"Wh- you sure? I don't mind taking first watch."

"I said I'd take it, didn't I? Besides, you look dead on your damn feet, Deku. Can't have you dragging behind me the rest of the way."

"First of all, rude, I've got just as much energy as you do."

"Hm."

"Second of all, fine, you can take the first watch. But only because I know you just want to watch me sleep."

Kacchan spluttered, looking away from the window and glaring at him. "Hah?"

"Deny it all you want, I felt you lovingly brushing your hands through my hair like a sap last night."

"Bullshit. You can't prove it."

"Don't need to," Izuku replied with a hum, smiling to himself as he unrolled his blanket and burrowed himself beneath it. "We should check if there's any decent clothing here in the morning," he continued, yawning. "It's getting real cold."

"Sure, sure." Kacchan kicked his feet up onto the windowsill just as he pulled a small black fabric wallet from the front of his pack and unsheathed one of the knives stored on his calf. Izuku watched with doleful interest as Kacchan unwound a leather cord from the wallet.

"What're you making, anyway?"

"Never you mind. Just shut your damn eyes and get some sleep, I'll be waking you up in four."

"Fine fine …" Izuku pouted, but rolled onto his side, pulling the blanket up below his nose. "Night, Kacchan."

“That don’t sound like sleeping to me.”

True to his word, Kacchan woke him up precisely four hours later, jostling his shoulder and ignoring Izuku’s whines of protest.

By day break, the both of them were up and moving again. A brief exploration of the house unearthed some old, frayed looking woollen jumpers and thick shirts; clothing decidedly more suited to the cold than what the both of them were both wearing beneath their coats, as well as some cans of food that were mercifully still in date. As they were leaving, Izuku paused, looking across at the flatbed van standing on the drive.

“Why don’t we drive from here?”

Kacchan stopped, looking back at him with a frown on his face.

“You know why, Deku.”

“Right, but this town is pretty rural. We can ditch the van before we hit the highway.”

Kacchan shook his head.

“No, we’re walking. Didn’t I tell you that we’re not getting side-tracked this time? Cars are loud, people notice them, we’re better off staying on foot.”

Izuku sighed. “But it’s still such a long way…”

“Exactly, so let’s get to fucking stepping shall we?”

Casting one last forlorn look at the abandoned vehicle, Izuku followed after Kacchan. At least, he figured, he was a bit warmer this time.

They walked along the long winding road through the valley, the mountains either side opening up for them, pausing only to refill their water supplies from the river, and so Kacchan could break the glass across the front of a couple of vending machines and snatch the sodas inside. The canned coffee particularly took Izuku’s interest; it had been so long since he had drunk coffee, and he eagerly downed it, indifferent to the slight tang of it being so close to the turn. They didn’t see a single zombie on the road. It was peaceful, the sun shining over the frosty hills around them, bird song and wind rustling through the trees the only sounds besides their own footfalls on the tarmac. Closer to the center of town, the road became more narrow, stone walls and outhouses pushing in on them from either side, and Izuku found himself musing how ideal a spot this would be for someone to attack them. No such thing happened, but that didn’t stop the both of them letting out a breath of relief when the road finally opened up again.

It wasn’t until they made it to the train station that they spotted their first group of zombies since the woods surrounding Fujinomiya, and the first proof that there had at least been one other survivor in this town with them. They heard the screams, the agonised howling of someone in unbearable pain, and Izuku was running before he could even put any thought into it, leaving Kacchan swearing and shouting for him to come back. He darted and ducked between the abandoned cars in front of him, straight towards a dark underpass that swallowed the road in front of them. Kacchan, despite his strength, wasn’t as fast as Izuku, and it was only when a van hindered

his way that Kacchan was able to skid to his side, grabbing hold of his arm and tugging hard.

“What the fuck are you doing?” he hissed, eyes wide and furious.

“Someone needs help!” Izuku replied. There was another scream, this one weak and drawn out, coming directly from the tunnel.

“This could be a fucking trap, idiot.”

“Or maybe it’s someone who’s hurt,” Izuku countered immediately, eyes blazing. Kacchan glared at him, searching his face, before he sighed and clicked his tongue across his teeth.

“Fine, fuck. Ok, lemme grab the torch, we’re not going in there blind. And if I get any bad vibes from this, we’re out. You hear me?”

“I *know* , Kacchan,” Izuku huffed, staring intently back at the tunnel. They inched forward, Kacchan deliberately keeping himself in front of Izuku the entire way, torchlight landing upon nothing but the odd car and black tarmac. Inside of the tunnel, the wailing echoed in a way that left the hairs on the back of Izuku’s neck standing on end.

“P-please,” came a voice. “Please st-stop.”

“Deku,” Kacchan growled in warning, just as Izuku sped up, hurrying towards the voice.

And then, a wet sound filled the tunnel, and dread filled Izuku’s chest. He snatched the torch from Kacchan’s hand, marching forward with purpose, although he already knew that he was too late. He didn’t need to see what was happening to know. He knew these sounds, he would never fucking forget them.

They found the zombie hunched over just ten feet from the exit to the tunnel, saw clearly the way it’s victim still dragged themselves forward, a trail of blood behind them, the zombie scuffling on it’s knees to keep up as it devoured the flesh from the thighs down. Izuku felt the bile rise, his hands shaking, and in that moment he was no longer in the tunnel. He was back in that filthy alley, staring at a yellow shoe and hearing the wet slurps of flesh and sharp cracks of bone. He couldn’t feel anything other than the pressure of the blood pumping through his veins, couldn’t breathe beyond the weight in his chest.

It was only when Kacchan swung his bat, caving the zombies face in as it was thrown against the side of the tunnel, that Izuku tumbled harshly back to earth. The person managed a broken-sounding cry, body collapsing on the tarmac, and Izuku rushed to her side.

“Hey, it’s gone,” he breathed, gently trying to coax her over and onto her back. “You’re safe.”

But the person trembled beneath his hands, more choked breaths, broken finger nails making one final grab at the ground before she fell still and silent.

Izuku didn’t need to roll her over to know that she was gone. The trail of blood behind her, the suspiciously blooming patch of red at her side, all made it clear that this woman had been through far more than her body could have handled a moment longer, and his hands dropped uselessly to his side.

“Damnit,” Kacchan sighed, rubbing the back of his head and looking out from the tunnel across the river. “We should take care of her before she turns.”

“R-right.”

He had been too late. *Biting tearing* ... He had been too late again. *Blood flesh ripping* ... How many more? *Red wet suffocating drowning* ...

“Deku!”

Izuku started, looking up to meet Kacchan’s eyes as he kneeled in front of him, hands on his cheeks.

“H-huh-”

“Deep breaths, Deku. I got you.”

Izuku blinked back at him, brain foggy, face itching. It was only when he raised a hand to wipe at his cheek that he realised that he was crying.

“I’m fine,” he whispered. Kacchan snatched his hands away as if they had been burned.

“Right,” he said shortly, before getting to his feet. Watching Kacchan’s shoulders hunch, turning his face away, Izuku felt the panic rising again.

“W-wait!”

Kacchan paused, pulling one of the knives from the holster about his thigh.

“I’m not… fine,” Izuku breathed. “But I can’t…”

Kacchan eyed him carefully, expression hard to read. “Deku, what happened in the hospital?”

Izuku shook his head. “Not at the hospital,” he said. “Please, Kacchan I… I can’t talk about it yet. I-”

I killed him. I killed the little boy.

“I can’t.”

He hadn’t meant for the words to come out sounding so weak, so pitiful, so desperate, but Kacchan’s face softened all the safe.

“We need to talk about it,” he said. “If you’re going to be having fucking panic attacks, Deku, we *have* to talk about it.”

“I- I know. Just… not yet.”

He felt awful keeping things from Kacchan, particularly after how angry he got over him doing the

exact same thing, but Izuku wasn't ready to talk. He didn't think he could.

Kacchan grunted, before he dropped back to his knees and drove the knife into the side of the woman's skull with a slight grimace. It seemed to slide in so easily, so simple an action. Kacchan jostled the knife up and down as he pulled it back out again in a practiced move, stepping away to avoid the spurt of blood that always came once the knife was pulled free. He wiped the knife on a rag pulled from a pocket on the side of his pack, before sheathing it back in place and getting to his feet again. So mundane, so ordinary … like this was something that Kacchan had done every day of his life.

Izuku wasn't sure when he suddenly stopped being ok with that.

Truthfully, he couldn't say when these things had started to feel normal for him either. One day he woke up and slicing his wakizashi into the skull of a zombie didn't feel like that big of a deal any more. He went months after that, not thinking twice, not feeling a single shred of guilt, safe in the knowledge that it was him or them. He was the hero, the zombies were simply the villains that needed to be dealt with. But something … something was changing in him. Something *had* changed. Because when he saw the poor woman dragging herself across the ground as she was eaten alive, when he saw Kacchan sink his knife into the side of her skull, he was struck by the understanding that he didn't want to do this any more.

He didn't want to watch more people die. He didn't want to live in a world where this was normal. He didn't want to be a killer. Something needed to change.

"Kacchan?"

Kacchan looked back at him, expression guarded despite his relaxed stature.

"What?"

"You really think UA is still standing?"

The slight rise of his brows was the only indication that Kacchan was surprised by Izuku's question. He bit his lip, before leaning to grab his bat from where he had dropped it to the ground.

"I never thought it would be."

It was Izuku's turn to be surprised.

"What? But … wasn't that where you were all headed?"

"We'd just lost Jirou," Kacchan replied. "I'd almost died, and the freak brigade was up our assholes. If they wanted to believe that UA would still be there, then who the fuck was I to say otherwise?"

"But UA has all sorts of security," Izuku said quickly. "Defenses, some of the smartest minds in Japan work there!"

"Look, I'd love to be wrong," Kacchan countered. "But I've been out here long enough now to have a healthy dose of fucking cynicism, Deku."

“So, if it’s not for UA, what’s still driving you?”

“You, dumbass!” Kacchan snapped, looking angry now. “Kirishima, Mina, even fucking Dunce Face. For whatever reason, I ain’t dead yet, and since you won’t let me get on with shit in my own way, I should probably make the most of it.”

“O-oh.”

“And if we get to UA and it’s gone to shit like the rest of the fucking world, what’s gonna be driving you then?” Kacchan countered, eyes narrowed shrewdly.

“I …” Izuku swallowed.

“Huh,” Kacchan hummed. “Looks like you’re the one who still has some shit to figure out then, Deku.”

Kacchan started walking away, leaving Izuku standing near the two bodies, his brow furrowed, worrying his lips between his teeth. For so long it had just been about survival, but there had always been this shining beacon of hope beyond the horizon, this unspoken promise that whatever else happened, UA would still be there. The idea stood pristine in his mind, unspoiled and untouched, like it was a reward that he had already earned long ago, and the idea of it being taken from him was so ludicrous, and so cruel, that it never bore thinking about.

“It’ll still be there,” Izuku said to himself. It had to be.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 30: Flesh Start

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Katsuki finally come across familiar faces.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A tense silence had fallen over the two travellers after Izuku's breakdown in the tunnel. Izuku knew that Kacchan was pissed at him; Kacchan took brooding to a whole other level, which was ironic given just how many reasons Izuku had to be angry at *him* up to now. He walked with a sour look on his face, grunting in response to anything that Izuku would say, and it might have been funny if Izuku wasn't so irritated by it.

Regardless of whether Kacchan's reaction to Izuku's hesitancy to share what he was feeling was justified or not, his words had still given Izuku a lot to think about.

He had never really considered UA in a real tangible way, not since he and his group had first come to the decision to go there, with naive hope running through their veins. Since then it had just been this vague goal lying ahead of them, the vision of it smothered by the fog of uncertainty, and the daily struggle to survive. How could UA hold Izuku's focus when every ounce of energy he had was put into keeping his friends alive? But he had failed in that mission, and for now at least it was just he and Kacchan; two wounded, scarred, exhausted survivors with nothing to lose but each other. Two survivors who matched one another not only in their rough and beaten exterior, but in the renewed drive in their chests. Even in accepting his coming end, Kacchan had still hacked and sliced his way through perhaps hundreds of zombies to get here, and Izuku was pushing through the kind of guilt that he really had no business in pushing through. The only difference was that Kacchan was alive through sheer vehemence and Izuku… he was sure Kacchan would have something to say about it, but in his mind it was just dumb luck that he was still here. His desire to survive was born less out of the dogged refusal to die, and more from the understanding that people *had* died through his inaction and poor choices. He had no right dying now. He hadn't the pleasure of simply giving up.

The fog was fading now, growing more sparse with each and every step Izuku took along the frostbitten ground. Was it crazy to think that maybe this all had to mean something? That all of the death, all of the fighting, all of the heartbreak might have been part of a grand future plan? Maybe it was just his guilt talking, creating this fantasy in his mind where his destiny was to reach UA and … and *what* ? Cure the zombie apocalypse?

"Mother fucker."

Izuku looked over, jolted from his thoughts by Kacchan spitting harshly onto the ground.

"Fuck, bug flew in my mouth or some shit."

“I hope it was the former,” Izuku murmured, ignoring the simmering glare thrown his way in response.

Yeh, curing the zombie virus. If he was living in one of the mangas he used to obsess and theorize over then he was sure that would be the end goal. But Izuku didn’t have an equation stored in his head that would change the damn world. He didn’t have miracle blood that could be injected into the undead and turn them back into the living.

But maybe Kacchan did.

Perhaps that was it, then. Perhaps Izuku’s role in this tale was to simply survive so that he could bring Kacchan to UA, and then Kacchan could save the world. This wasn’t Izuku’s story, it was someone else’s and he was just one of the many extras that helped the main character reach his goal.

That sounded about right.

Kacchan’s estimations on how long it would take them to get to Shizouka hadn’t taken into account just how many hills they would have to climb, or how many turns the road would take, and they were still only about half way there when it started to get dark again. Izuku couldn’t deny that he would be grateful for the break, and when Kacchan grunted out that they should stop at another farm situated off yet another long wind in the road, he nodded. Kacchan didn’t say much as they approached; checking for zombies, banging on the front door to wake anything that might have been skulking once they got inside, throwing his pack on the table with indifference dragging a heavy-looking armchair to the front window.

Izuku sighed, pulling off his coat and grabbing the blankets from his pack. Kacchan threw him an irritated glare at the sound.

“What do you want to eat tonight?” Izuku asked. “We’ve got canned vegetables or a couple instant sobas.”

“Don’t care,” Kacchan replied, pulling his own coat off and throwing it onto the table with his pack.

“You’re pissed at me,” Izuku said.

Kacchan paused for a moment, before he let out a loud scoff.

“Hah! Don’t flatter yourself that anything you could do could affect me that much, nerd.”

He sounded so much like the old Kacchan then that Izuku wondered if they had inadvertently stepped back in time when they’d passed through that tunnel. Kacchan, however, continued to make far more noise than necessary, slamming stuff down, huffing in irritation, and making it entirely apparent that his words had been utter bullshit.

“I agreed to tell you when I was ready,” Izuku said quietly, watching him as he pulled a woollen jumper over his head.

“You didn’t agree to shit,” Kacchan snapped back waspishly, chucking his jumper harshly onto the table.

“I don’t understand why you’re so mad!” Izuku threw his arms out on either side of him. “I wouldn’t push you into talking about something if you weren’t ready!”

“No, clearly you *don’t* understand!” Kacchan crossed his arms over his chest, and Izuku noticed the leather cord now hanging around his neck. “If you think my bad mood has anything to do with that.”

“Hah! So you admit you are in a bad mood with me?” Izuku countered immediately, pointing at Kacchan triumphantly. His lower lid twitched, a lip curling to reveal a snarl.

“You know what? I shouldn’t have to explain it! If you can’t figure it out then that’s on you.”

“Are you being serious right now?”

“Serious as a fucking zombie bite.”

“Don’t say that.”

“Don’t tell me what to say!”

Izuku let out an irritated cry, dropping his hands to his side as Kacchan turned on his heel and stormed from the room. Either he was bluffing, and Izuku not telling him what had gone down back in Fujinomiya was the real reason he was angry and he didn’t want to admit it, or Izuku had done something else to piss him off. Considering Kacchan’s temper, the list of possibilities seemed entirely endless; he could fart in the wrong direction and Kacchan would take it as a personal insult.

“Well, I’m making soba and you can’t complain about it!” Izuku yelled, huffing and stomping to his pack to grab the supplies.

“Fuck you!” came the reply from one of the other rooms.

Izuku hadn’t done or said anything else that could have made Kacchan this pissed. He started going back through the events in his head, from the panic attack that seemed to have arisen from nowhere to the conversation they had afterwards. When was the first time he seemed to get genuinely angry? When he’d brought up UA? No…

”So if not for UA, what drives you?”

“You dumbass!”

He supposed that had been an unfair question given all that they’d been through the last handful of weeks alone.

“And if we get to UA and it’s gone to shit like the rest of the fucking world, what’s gonna be driving you then?”

Izuku groaned.

“Idiot,” he muttered to himself with a sigh.

He heard a series of bangs from upstairs, and got to his feet. He found Kacchan lying on a mattress, exaggerated pout on his lips as he threw a tennis ball against the wall, catching it on the bounce back. In spite of everything, Izuku felt a smile tug at his lips as he leaned against the doorway.

“Obviously it’s you,” he said.

Kacchan didn’t look back at him, and just threw the tennis ball again.

“What’s me?” he snapped. “You better not be fucking blaming me for this.”

“You’re the reason I’m still going,” Izuku replied.

Kacchan paused, still pouting and glaring at the wall, but the growing pinkness on his cheeks was enough to let Izuku know that he’d hit the mark.

“Let’s go eat some dry ass soba,” Kacchan grunted, pocketing the ball as he got to his feet and walking past him.

Well, at least that was one mystery of the Apocalypse solved.

Conversation came a little easier after that, the soba seeming like a veritable feast compared to the canned vegetables and soup they had been eating, Kacchan seemingly more at ease now that his ego had been stroked, and Izuku feeling a certain warmness in his chest that the man had cared that much. He supposed there were worse missions in life than to keep this madman alive.

“You going to show me what that is?” Izuku asked, after they had finished eating and Kacchan was setting up ready to take the first watch. He paused, looking down at his chest where Izuku was pointing at the leather cord visible beneath his shirt. He seemed to hesitate a moment, before he pulled the cord up to reveal five mangled looking teeth hanging from it.

“Are those… teeth?” Izuku asked flatly.

“No shit, Deku.”

“I don’t-” and then he remembered. “They’re from that zombie in the hospital? The one that almost bit you?”

“Good memory there, Popeye,” Kacchan scoffed, before he roughly pushed the cord back under his shirt.

“Right, right, because of the eye,” Izuku said, gesturing to his face. “Real clever, Kacchan. Now stop evading the question.”

“It’s just… I dunno, a reminder or some shit,” Kacchan replied gruffly. “Stop riding my dick about it.”

“I’m not!” Izuku protested. “I think it’s… cool. Like a good luck charm.”

“Yeh, well, carrying a zombie foot around seemed like overkill,” Kacchan said. “Now-”

“Go to sleep,” Izuku finished for him. “Yeh yeh, I know. Wake me up in four.”

“You’re lucky I don’t wake you up in two for being a smartass.”

“Goodnight, Kacchan.”

The remainder of their journey to Shizouka passed mostly without consequence; a zombie group here, a lone roamer there, nothing that hindered their progress in any significant way until they finally reached the highway they had been aiming towards for months. Izuku let out a breath of relief as soon as it came into view through the treeline. UA was so close from here. If they didn’t stop, they could be there in a matter of days, but that in itself lead to another issue.

“So, how are we going to find them, if they’re in Shizouka?” Izuku asked.

Despite the relief that came with being so close to their destination, the open road ahead and behind them offered little in the way of cover, and Kacchan kept them walking close to the verge.

“We had measures in place, in case we ever got separated,” Kacchan replied. “The aim was always Shizouka, so if someone got lost we would head there and leave signs behind.”

“Signs like… actual signs or?”

“Kind of,” Kacchan was busy staring ahead of them, eyes squinting through the low winter sun. “But nothing that would put anyone in danger? Can’t exactly go putting *‘we’re here’* on a fucking billboard.”

“So you came up with secret codes!” Izuku gasped, excitedly. “That’s so smart! So you could say things like *‘spider bite’* and mean left! Or- or All Might for right!”

“What the fuck are you talking about? We just use the opposite directions to where we are.”

“Oh.” Izuku tried not to sound too disappointed in that.

“You shitting on our plan now, Deku?”

“What? No! It’s a great plan. Kacchan’s so smart.”

“Fuck you.”

“So, if they made it here, we just follow the signs they’ve left?”

“That’s the general fucking idea, yeh.”

“And if we don’t find any signs?”

Kacchan stopped walking then, glancing back at Izuku with a serious look on his face.

“Then we go to UA. We always knew that getting split up was a possibility, we took our contingency plans seriously, Deku. If they haven’t left any signs, then we’re not going to find them here.”

Izuku knew what Kacchan really meant. If there were no signs, then they would be safe to assume that Kirishima, Mina, and Kaminari hadn’t made it.

They walked for another twenty minutes before they finally mercifully, after months, saw the first evidence that their friends had, in fact, survived. Izuku spotted it first, something he might have been eager to brag about considering he only had one good eye, and he grabbed Kacchan’s wrist, pointing to one of the vehicles up ahead.

“Look!”

The bumper of one of the cars by a level crossing was swung open, bold black writing contrasting to the red of the metal, emphasised by the light of the now fading sun.

BKG
MDR

“Is that them?” Izuku asked. “I don’t see them pointing us in any direction.”

Kacchan and Izuku approached, Kacchan checking the boot of the car, and beneath it, before looking into the front seat.

“Bakugou, Midoriya,” he said, reaching out to touch the paint on the boot. It had long since dried. “It’s probably them, yeh.”

Izuku laughed in relief.

“They’re alive!”

“Well, they were when they did this,” Kacchan countered back. His tone and expression were controlled, like he wasn’t allowing himself to feel excited just yet. “And no direction means we just have to keep going this way. They’re just letting us know they got this far.”

“Directions or not, finding them in the city isn’t going to be easy,” Izuku said.

Izuku was fairly familiar with the Shizouka Prefecture, he’d lived there his entire life prior to the apocalypse, but a knowledge of it’s layout and where to find the best take-outs and manga stores wasn’t exactly going to help them find three people. Shizouka had many sprawling streets, alleys, and plenty of places that a person could hide if they wanted to.

“They’ll have stayed on the edge of the city,” Kacchan replied, before he shut the boot. “Found somewhere close enough that they can go there for supply runs when they need to, but in a location where they can see what’s going on around them. Plus, if they left this here, then they’re still hoping that we’ll turn up. They won’t have taken up someplace where they wouldn’t be able to see us before we saw them.”

“There’s a smaller estate not long before the river. It’s mostly residential, but there are some industrial buildings too, probably tall enough to keep watch from… it’s where I’d go.”

“You would, because you’re from Shizouka,” Kacchan replied. “But they ain’t, I don’t think any of them have ever been here before. And it’s been months, don’t forget. They might have already left for Musutafu by now.”

“They would leave a sign if they had though?”

“Yeh, hopefully. Let’s keep walking, it’s gonna start getting dark again soon.”

The next sign came soon after the first, barely a stone throw away from where the Okitsu river opened up to the ocean. Another open car boot, with the letters *‘BM’* painted across the front of it, this time with an arrow pointing to the right.

“Looks like they came off the highway here,” Kacchan said, looking down over the side to the steep overgrown verge, before turning his head to face the left. “There’s the tunnel there. Guess your hunch was right after all, Deku.”

“This isn’t a big area,” Izuku said, unable to stop the excitement from bubbling over. “Kacchan, they could be so close!”

“Just… keep your damn head, alright?” Kacchan said seriously. “I’m pretty sure it’s them, but it could just as easy be a trap.”

Izuku’s stomach jolted. He hadn’t even considered that as a possibility.

“Keep on guard, watch the buildings. If we see anything fishy we bail, you hear me?”

“Right.”

They clambered down the steep decline to the narrow road beneath the highway, the both of them grumbling and swearing at the brambles that cut into their skin as they went. Izuku felt himself tense at the sight of the underpass, however short it might be, but he pushed through with Kacchan leading the way, ignoring the arrow and heading in the opposite direction. An old metal supply warehouse appeared on their right, obscuring their view, but for Izuku at least he felt entirely more comfortable here than he had done on the highway. But they still kept their wits about them, weapons held aloft, peering around every corner and eying up every building they passed.

Eventually they came to a fork in the road, the left leading uphill, the right continuing onwards, and Izuku looked over at Kacchan in question. There was no sign left behind here, no clue as to which way they should go.

“They’re probably close by,” Kacchan said, voice low. “If they left a sign here it would be too obvious.”

Izuku looked up each road, his eyes hovering on the tall warehouse to their left.

“That has the best vantage point,” he said. “They can definitely see the road from there.”

Kacchan hummed. “If they were there, they’d have already seen us.”

The two of them stood there for a moment, looking for some kind of sign, any hint at which direction they should head, before a voice called out to them. Izuku felt his heart soar, his lips stretching into a big grin, long before he saw the figure running along the road towards them, her hand in the air, a matching smile on her face.

“Katsuki! Midoriya!”

“Well, holy shit,” Kacchan breathed, before a laugh left his throat and he started to hurry forward. It was perhaps testament to how much he had missed his friends that he didn’t complain when Mina threw herself at him, her arms tightening around his neck as she dragged him into a painful looking hug.

“About fucking time!” she yelled into his ear. “We had just about given up!”

“Yeh, well, I don’t die easy,” Kacchan grunted. His arms were still straight at his side, but after Mina made it clear that she was not letting go, he huffed and wrapped his arms around her waist.

“I fucking swear, Katsuki, you better never ever die ever.”

The rare smile that had formed on Kacchan’s lips faded at that, his eyes darting up to meet Izuku’s in a moment, before Mina pulled away.

“Izuku!”

It was Izuku’s turn now to get the full force of Mina’s hugs, surprisingly powerful for a person her size, and he laughed as she squeezed his neck and pressed a loud wet kiss to his cheek.

“I’m glad you’re ok, Mina.”

“Oh, I’m fine,” she said, dropping back to the tarmac and framing Izuku’s face in her hands. “Look how long your hair has got! You have no idea how much I missed your pretty face. Looking at dumb and dumber all day long gets old.”

“Kirishima and Dunce Face are ok?” Kacchan asked.

“Yeh, they’re fine too. We’ve had some scrapes but honestly we look a hell of a lot better than you do, what the fuck happened to your head?”

Kacchan reached up to touch the stitches on his scalp before shrugging.

“It’s a long fucking story.”

“And Midoriya, your eye,” Mina breathed, looking back at him and the patch.

“Uh, also a long story.”

“Well, I can’t wait to hear it,” Mina replied. “Come on, I’ll show you where we’re staying!”

They followed Mina up the road to their left, Izuku feeling almost dazed by the entire thing. It had been months and, not only had they found them, but their friends were alive and uninjured and it was little less than a miracle. He glanced over at Kacchan, the relieved smile on the man's face making his heart flutter. They had found them, they had really found them.

"We get a pretty good look of what's going on around us up there," Mina said, pointing to a tall building on their right, metal stairs opening up to a mezzanine. Izuku figured that it wouldn't have been hard to jump up onto the roof from there either and, looking back the way we came, it definitely was a good pick for a look out post.

"We've not seen anyone come close to us, besides you guys of course," she continued. "But after the trouble we had on the highway, we try and keep someone on watch as often as we can."

"What happened on the highway?" Kacchan asked sharply.

"All in good time."

Kacchan grumbled at this, but he didn't push the matter. They walked to the end of the road, before Mina pointed at a large blue house on the corner.

"That's us. Wait here just a moment whilst I let them know we're here."

Mina hurried off, and Izuku took that moment to slide closer to Kacchan, lowering his voice.

"So what exactly are we telling them?"

Kacchan looked down at him, brow furrowed.

"What?"

"I mean, are we telling them everything? About the zombies, the bite, the alcohol?"

Kacchan sighed, pinching his brow.

"Yeh. Fuck, yeh, they deserve to know."

"Only if you feel comfortable with it," Izuku replied, offering him a soft smile. He heard a series of knocks on a door, three sharp raps, a pause, another knock, a pause, and then two more.

"Uh… do we tell them about us?" he asked, feeling awkward for a moment. Kacchan looked surprised for a moment, but before he could respond, there was an ungodly scream from the house, and that was about all the warning they got before Kaminari launched himself at them, tackling them to the ground.

"What the- GET OFF ME, PIKACHU!" Kacchan yelled. But Izuku was too busy laughing despite the pain in his tailbone and the weight on top of him to care.

"You're alive!" Kaminari wailed, one arm wrapped around each of their shoulders as he yanked their faces to his chest.

“Not for much longer if you don’t GET OFF!”

Kacchan started shoving, Izuku patting Kaminari’s back comfortingly, before the man was sitting himself back on his knees, tears visibly trailing down his cheeks.

“We were starting to think you really hadn’t made it!” he sobbed loudly.

“He’s been pretty emotional about it,” came another voice, and Izuku looked up to see Kirishima standing at his side. The red in his hair had long ago faded, his black hair now pulled back into a low ponytail.

“Yeh, I can fucking tell,” Kacchan replied, holding his jaw. It took a moment, before he and Kirishima were grinning broadly at each other, Kirishima extending his hand to help him from the ground.

“Katsuki,” Kirishima said, his voice strained.

“Shitty Hair,” Kacchan replied.

“And Midoriya!” Kirishima continued, extending his hand now to Izuku. “Dude, it’s so fucking good to see you both.”

“It’s good to see you too,” Izuku said. Kaminari got to his feet, still sniffing and wiping his nose on his sleeve.

“Seriously though, what took you so long? You have any idea how fucking worried we’ve been? We were getting ready to leave for UA!”

“It’s been a fucking bizarre ride,” Kacchan said.

“Good, coz you’re going to tell us all about it over some food!” Mina said, before wrapping an arm around Kaminari’s waist and squeezing him. Kaminari looked about as dazed as Izuku felt, and he reached out a hand to place it on his shoulder. Kaminari just nodded at him gratefully, and looking at him Izuku realised that Kirishima really hadn’t been joking… Kaminari looked much thinner than he remembered, his hair lacking it’s usual electric pulse, his face pale. Kacchan too, seemed to spot how stressed Kaminari looked, his brow furrowed.

“Don’t tell me you haven’t been eating,” he said sharply. “Idiot, it don’t matter if we weren’t there, you have to take care of your damn self.”

Kaminari seemed to flinch at that and Izuku’s concern immediately became alarm. The irritated look on Kacchan’s face fell.

“Alright, fuck. Come ‘ere.”

Kacchan pouted his lips resolutely, holding his arms out. Kaminari blinked, taken aback.

“Well come on then!”

In a moment Kaminari fell into Kacchan’s arms, burying his face in Kacchan’s neck before he

started to sob freely, his shoulders shaking.

“You idiot, we’re fine,” Kacchan said, tone soft as he patted Kaminari’s back.

“D-don’t you e-ever d-die on us again, Katsuki!” Kaminari sobbed.

“I ain’t died once!”

“I m-mean it!” Kaminari shouted, pulling away, a defiant look in his red, wet eyes. “After K-Kyoka, Sero I … I can’t do it again!”

“Kami, baby it’s ok,” Mina said, rubbing a hand over his back soothingly.

“You’re not going to have to do it again,” Izuku said firmly, ignoring the look Kacchan gave him, and he realised that he meant it. He meant the words he spoke with all his heart.

Kaminari nodded, wiping his face again.

“Ok, ok …”

“Come on, Kami,” Mina said soothingly. “Let’s all get inside, yeh?”

Kirishima led them inside the house, and Izuku could still feel Kacchan’s eyes on him as he followed. He knew what that look was about, but for once Izuku didn’t feel a single shred of doubt. They were together again, and there was not a force on earth that was going to take another one of his friends away from him.

The house had obviously once been very well taken care of; pristine white furniture, traditional layout and careful architecture. But years of neglect had left the acer’s little more than sad looking twigs sticking out of crumbling soil, and the sliding windows caked with dust. Almost every surface was covered in something, be it poorly folded laundry, food stores, and weapons, and Izuku had to chuckle at the look that passed over Kacchan’s face when he saw the mess.

“So, here’s home away from home,” Kirishima said, standing proudly in front of them with a grin on his face. “Nice place, huh?”

“It was,” Kacchan grunted. “How the fuck can you find anything in this mess?”

“I think you’d call this organised chaos,” Kirishima said with a smirk. “Besides, it’s nice to have the space to keep everything out in the open. Easy access, you know?”

“Right,” Kacchan scoffed.

Izuku pulled off his pack, and looked doubtfully around the living room.

“Oh, just shove it anywhere,” Mina said.

Izuku looked back at her then towards Kacchan, before he shrugged and grinned, chucking the pack into the corner of the room with a flourish.

“Fucker.”

“We found a bunch of food in the houses nearby,” Mina continued. “If we ever wanted to change our mind about going to UA, we could probably stay here comfortably for months.”

“Yeh, we were lucky to find this spot,” Kirishima agreed. Kaminari, still unusually quiet, sat down on a cushion close to the television, fingers pulling at the hem of his sweatshirt.

“How did you find it?” Izuku asked, pulling off his jacket and dropping it on top of his pack. It was still cold, but the four walls around him took the edge off.

“It was just luck, really,” Kirishima explained, taking a seat himself and grabbing a packet of snacks from the table in front of him. “Hungry?”

Izuku’s first instinct was to decline the offer, but the rumbling in his stomach couldn’t be ignored.

“Yeh, actually.”

Izuku fumbled with the packet as it was thrown at him, only just catching it, a heavy blush forming on his cheeks.

“Oh- sorry, dude, I didn’t think-”

“It’s fine,” Izuku said quickly. “It’s taking me a while to get used to it.”

“What happened?” Kaminari asked, voice sounding more level now that all of them were inside and the tears had dried off his cheeks. “Do you still, uh… have an eye under that thing?”

“Of course he’s still got a fucking eye!” Kacchan said. “The hell kinda question is that?”

“I’m just asking!” Kaminari protested.

“I still have an eye,” Izuku replied with a laugh, reaching up to pull the make-shift patch back to show them. “It looks fine now, it’s just that everything is really blurry. Kinda makes it hard to see, you know? I prefer having it covered when I’m out there.”

“Dude, that has got to suck,” Kirishima said.

“Well, I actually feel pretty lucky, considering the circumstances,” Izuku replied seriously, the patch dropping back into place.

“Did it happen in the explosion?” Mina asked, her voice quiet, eyes darting to Kaminari who seemed tense again.

“No, no it was after that,” Izuku replied, chest feeling tight. None of them had mentioned Sero yet, and he wasn’t sure that he was ready to be the one that did. “A zombie did this.”

“Holy fuck!” Kirishima gasped, leaning forward. “H-how?! I mean, no offence here Midoriya, but how aren’t you dead?”

“I would have been if Kacchan hadn’t been there,” Izuku said. A strange silence followed that, eyes darting between himself and Kacchan. Kacchan just rolled his eyes in response, looking next to bored as he chucked a snack into his mouth.

“Ok, back track,” Mina said, shifting away from the weird moment. “How does a zombie just get your eye and not, well, *kill* you?”

Izuku opened his mouth, then paused, looking across at Kacchan. He shrugged and gestured for Izuku to continue.

“Well, it’s a-”

“Long story,” Mina finished for him with a smile. “Guess we all have one of those.”

“You tell it, Deku,” Kacchan said, leaning back with his arms spread across the couch.

“I- oh, ok. I guess I’ll just start at the beginning then?”

He took a deep breath.

“You were there when the RV exploded so you all know that much. I think the explosion must have knocked me out for a bit, so Kacchan had to carry me out of there. Then we bumped into some zombies in the woods but my arm was badly injured and we didn’t have any weapons so we couldn’t fight them properly. So we climbed up into a tree and I think then we stabbed the zombies with sticks before going back towards the RV but we couldn’t find any of you, and there were way too many zombies around but Kacchan knew about a public toilet that was close by so we hid there, which was really gross. And because I was injured badly we couldn’t really do much and-”

“Holy fuck,” Kacchan growled, interrupting and pinching the bridge of his nose. “Ok, scrap that, I’ll tell it before you get a fucking nosebleed.”

Izuku blushed again, scratching the back of his neck.

“Deku’s arm got fucked in the explosion,” Kacchan continued. “The burn was bad enough that he got sepsis or some shit-” the group collectively winced, “-and because I had to keep his ass alive whilst he spent two weeks taking it easy, we weren’t able to look for you guys.”

“I almost died!” Izuku protested, hotly. “I was unconscious, not taking it easy!”

“You got out of wiping your own ass for a week, that’s taking it easy in my books.”

Izuku flushed, just as Kirishima started choking on his food.

“D-dude!”

“Whatever. Either way, Deku almost died, until I found antibiotics on the road. Two weeks after we lost you all at the RV we left for Shizouka.”

“You were there for two weeks,” Mina said, voice strained. “We wanted to come back to look for you both, we really did.”

“Yeh, but we were driven to the road by the z’s pretty much straight after the explosion,” Kirishima said. “We saw you both run off into the woods, but more and more of them kept coming before we could follow you. They blocked us off from the RV.”

“It was insane,” Kaminari said. “I’ve never seen so many of them in one place before, we still don’t know where they all came from so fast.”

Izuku looked up in interest at that.

“I guess that explains why there were so few of them left bothering us,” Kaccan said. Izuku furrowed his brow. In their experience, zombies were far more likely to come for Kacchan if they were given the choice, so why hadn’t the same thing happened then?

“And that’s not even the worst of it,” Mina continued, sharing a harried look with Kirishima. “But… ugh, you’ll probably think that sounds crazy.”

“We’ve heard a lot of crazy,” Kacchan said with a sigh. “Hit us.”

“It’s… it’s like they were hunting us, or something.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku asked quickly, sitting up straight.

“I mean, sure it’s easy to get overwhelmed when there’s a bunch of them, but they’re not exactly hard to lose if you put enough ground between them,” Mina replied. “Usually they just forget about you, right?”

“Except this group didn’t forget,” Kirishima said. “We’d lose them in the woods, only for them to catch up with us an hour later. And they would fucking… *circle us* , box us in.”

“It was kinda terrifying,” Kaminari said.

“I know it doesn’t sound possible,” Mina said. “But it really did feel like we were being played with, like they were just scaring us for fun or something.”

“How did you get away?” Izuku asked, his heart thudding in his chest.

“I don’t know,” Kirishima replied, honestly. “It’s like they finally got bored and decided to get back to Shinigawa.”

“It was weird,” Mina breathed. “Really weird. I still don’t know what to make of it.”

“Did there seem like there was one zombie leading them?” Izuku asked.

“ *Leading* ?” Kaminari yelped. Kirishima laughed nervously.

“No offence, Midoriya, but that *does* sound kinda crazy.”

“You didn’t see any of them active differently, ‘cept following you,” Kacchan interupted. “Anything that felt fucking weird?”

“There was one,” Mina said quietly. Kirishima and Kaminari both tensed. “I thought maybe I was seeing things at the time, but… I swear, one of them was looking at me.”

“Fuck,” Kacchan groaned, rubbing his face tiredly. “How many of these fucking are there?”

“Uh, wh-what *things* ?” Kaminari squeaked, looking nervous, his voice raising when Kacchan didn’t immediately reply. “Hey, guys, what things?!”

This was it . Izuku took a deep breath.

“There are some zombies that don’t act like the others. We’ve met three of them on our way here. They’re part of the reason why it took us so long to find you.”

“We met the first one on the way back to Shinigawa,” Kacchan confirmed.

“Hold on, hold,” Mina said, holding her hands up and shaking her head in confusion. “What do you mean they *‘don’t act like the others?’* And why did you go back to Shinigawa?!”

“I- uh, we saw Dabi and the others on the road,” Izuku explained. The entire room took a deep intake of breath, and a low sound came from Kaminari’s throat. “They didn’t see us, but we overheard them talking. They said something that made me believe that at least one of my friends could still be alive… I had to go back and look.”

“Oh,” Mina said softly. “And I… I take it, um-”

“The group didn’t kill him,” Izuku replied, fighting over the lump in his throat, and feeling Kacchan’s eyes on him. “But, by the time we got there a zombie-” he paused, and cleared his throat. “A-anyway.”

“The one on the road to Shinigawa,” Kacchan continued for him, still watching Izuku carefully, “it didn’t seem like much at the time. I kinda overlooked it, honestly. But it opened a car door to get to Deku, seemed smarter than the rest of them. It didn’t follow us, though.”

“And the other two?” Mina asked.

“The second one we found in a village by Fuji,” Kacchan said. “That was the fucker that damaged Deku’s eye.”

“It wasn’t anything like the other zombies,” Izuku explained. “It didn’t want to eat us, not only that but it seemed to have some control over the zombies around it. The zombies went straight for Kacchan, and then this thing grabbed me and jammed it’s thumb into my eye. It would have killed me if Kacchan hadn’t stopped it.”

“That’s badass, man,” Kirishima whistled. “How’d you handle it and the zombies?”

“Don’t ask me,” Kacchan muttered. “Adrenaline or some shit.” Izuku saw his hand, perhaps subconsciously, drift down to where the bite lay on his side. “Took a hammer to the head as well as any of them. The third we found in Fujinimoya,” he continued. “That fucking thing had turned a hospital into some sort of nest.”

“That’s the one that held us up the longest,” Izuku added. “We went into the hospital to get some drops for my eye, and that’s where we found her. She set hundreds of zombies on us after that, the only reason we’re alive is because there was another group of survivors there. Kacchan’s friend Shindo-”

“Wait, *Shindo?* ” Kirishima yelled.

“Holy crap, as in *‘Best Fuck of my Life’* Shindo?” Kaminari cackled. “Oh man, how’s he doing?”

“Shut the fuck up,” Kacchan growled through gritted teeth, his ears burning red and looking absolutely anywhere but at Izuku. Izuku wasn’t entirely sure why he felt as sick as he did just then, after all he knew that Shindo and Kacchan had a history, had slept together. But *‘Best Fuck of my Life’* definitely hadn’t been mentioned, and was not making him feel any better about the situation.

“You rekindle any of the old romance?” Mina teased, smirking at him. “Fighting zombies, bathed in the moonlight?”

“You shut your mouth, witch,” Kacchan hissed furiously. “Deku, carry on with the fucking story!”

“R-right, uh… So, yeh. Shindo saw us go into the hospital. We only managed to get away because he led us into the sewers. That’s where his group lives.”

“They live in the sewers?” Kaminari asked, wrinkling his nose.

“Look, the specifics don’t matter,” Kacchan said, hotly, still looking flustered. “This fucking zombie bitch could control all the other zombies, and there were too many people trying to survive down there for us not to try and do something about it. Deku took the fucking thing out, it’s dead now, but it sure as shit looks like there are more of them out there.”

Izuku knew that Kacchan was skipping past a good portion of the story, but truthfully he couldn’t blame him for that. Izuku didn’t want to have to explain that he hadn’t been able to save everyone, or that they were the ones responsible for the zombies attacking to begin with.

“Are you sure that’s what you saw?” Kirishima asked. “I’m not doubt you, I just wanna-”

“We’re dead sure, Shitty Hair,” Kacchan replied darkly, arms crossing over his chest.

“But, what are they?” Mina pressed. “Just… random mutations, or something?”

Izuku swallowed, feeling as though beads of sweat were starting to collect at his temples. He looked toward Kacchan, who was staring hard at the floor, hands pressed against his bite. Kacchan took a deep breath.

“There’s something I gotta tell you,” he said. The room immediately grew tense, Kaminari looking at him with saucer-wide eyes, Kirishima and Mina sitting straight in their seats. “And don’t- don’t fucking interrupt me until I’m finished, alright?”

“Kacchan-” Izuku started, but Kacchan held up his hand.

“It’s fine, Deku.”

A moment filled with tension followed, Kacchan rubbing his hands together like he was preparing himself for battle; the minute tremble in his arms and the tightness in his jaw was not missed by any of them.

“These zombies are people who were bitten, but didn’t turn,” he said. Kaminari jumped to his feet, quickly realising what Kacchan’s words meant, and Kacchan held up his hand again with a glare. “I said don’t interrupt- fuck!” He took a deep shaky breath. “The zombie near Fuji kept a diary, before it turned. We read the whole thing, about how he had been bitten just like I had. He got sick, got the fever, but he didn’t turn. Not until six months later when he turned into… one of them.”

“S-six *months* ?” Mina breathed.

“Obviously, I ain’t fucking turned yet,” Kacchan continued. “But, I can still infect other people. That’s… that’s why Sero turned. It was my fucking blood that killed him.”

“No,” Kaminari whispered, eyes wide and empathetic. “Bakugou, it wasn’t your fault.”

Kacchan stiffened, and Izuku decided to step in.

“We’ve figured out how to slow the virus down,” he said. “There’s a reason why Kacchan didn’t turn after six months just like that man did, and we don’t have the full answer or know how it works, but alcohol seems to be what’s stopping Kacchan’s infection from progressing too far. When Kacchan stopped drinking, the scar around his bite got worse and worse, but if he drinks enough then he can reverse it, to a point. It’s not a cure, not by any means, but there’s no reason to assume that we can’t hold off the infection for a lot longer if he keeps drinking. Certainly until we get to UA.”

“R-right, UA!” Kaminari shouted, still on his feet. “I bet they can even cure him!”

“We don’t fucking know that,” Kacchan said.

“They’re the only ones that could,” Izuku continued, the excitement rising in his voice. “There are some pretty incredible people there. Some of my tutors are the smartest people I’ve ever known, they’ve worked with infectious diseases before. And thanks to Kacchan, we already know so much more about the virus than we did at the start! If we bring him there, then they could probably find out even more!”

Izuku was too excited to notice the look that flashed over Kacchan’s face.

“It’s the next logical step, right?” Izuku continued, blinded by hope. Kaminari nodded emphatically. “As far as we know, Kacchan is the only person in the world who has resisted the virus for as long as this. And if UA can run some tests then who knows what we could discover!”

“Ok, ok,” Kirishima said, holding his palms out. “I get what you’re saying, I do. But is this really such a good idea?”

Izuku looked over at him in surprise.

“I mean… come on, you watched movies, right? What if they turn out to be a cult of cannibals or something, or they take Bakugou and do experiments on him?”

Izuku felt like his stomach had dropped out of his ass, swiftly turning on the spot to face Kacchan. Fuck, how had he been so careless? So selfish? Getting so excited about the possibilities that for a moment he almost entirely forgot about Kacchan, and what he would want. Kacchan was not meeting his eyes, just glaring straight at Kirishima.

“As if they fucking could,” he growled “Those old bastards at UA couldn’t do shit to me. You’ll have to find another fucking science experiment,” he added with a lip curl in Izuku’s direction, and Izuku winced.

“That’s not- ok, maybe I got a little carried away,” Izuku said hurriedly. “Of course, you wouldn’t have to do anything that you didn’t want to-”

“Damn straight, Deku,” Kacchan snarled. “I already told you I didn’t want to be fucking experimented on!”

“I didn’t mean it like that!”

“Yeh, then how did you mean it?” Kacchan challenged, indifferent to the growing tension in the room.

“I just meant… maybe they’ll have some answers. They could learn a lot from just a drop of your blood alone! Isn’t it worth considering?”

“Looks like you already have,” Kacchan replied, leaning back on his palms with his face twisted into an ugly expression that made it clear that this argument was far from over. Kaminari, however, seemed all too keen to keep the conversation moving, much to Izuku’s relief.

“In all seriousness, man, how do you feel?” he asked, leaning forward and eying Kacchan in concern. “Do you feel sick or anything? Like, you’re not craving brains or-”

“I’m feel fucking fine, dumbass!” Kacchan yelled, finally pulling his murderous gaze from Izuku. “No different from before.”

“What does this all mean?” Mina asked, fiddling with the leather straps around her wrists. “Is the virus evolving? Could it mean that any one of us could be immune like Bakugou is?”

“I’m not *immune* ,” Kacchan replied. “I already told you that I’m infected, weren’t you listening?”

“There are a number of possibilities,” Izuku offered. Kacchan turned to him with a *growl* , a look on his face like Izuku hadn’t seen since he’d first joined the group. “Th-that, I can think of at least,” he continued, looking away. “It could be a mutation in the virus itself, sure. Perhaps it happened within the host, so if you’re bitten by a zombie that carries this particular mutation, then the virus affects you differently.”

“But, if that’s the case then… wouldn’t Sero have, you know…” Kirishima rubbed the back of his neck.

“Not necessarily,” Izuku continued. “It could be a combination of things. A slight mutation in the virus, paired with external triggers like Kacchan’s drinking, or something else about Kacchan’s physiology that didn’t apply to Sero.”

“Well, we already know injecting my fucking blood into people don’t work,” Kacchan said shortly.

“The way I see it, this doesn’t have to change anything,” Kirishima said firmly. “You’re both alive, we’re together again, I’m all for focusing on just that for a while, you know?”

“Deku went about it like a prick,” Kacchan announced, making Izuku wince again, “but we can’t completely ignore this shit. Assuming the place is even still standing, you think they won’t check us for bites getting in?”

“I didn’t think about that,” Kirishima muttered.

“We could just… not go to UA,” Mina said quietly. “We’ve been doing fine out here, we hardly see any zombies going by.”

“Yeh, but zombies ain’t the only thing we have to worry about though, are they?” Kacchan said. “We had a run in with Dabi and the rest of those fucks back in Shinigawa. They’re still out there.”

“You don’t think they’d come all the way out here, do you?”

“I don’t fucking know what they would or wouldn’t do at this point,” Kacchan replied. “But if we heard about UA, you can bet they did too.”

“But, if Midoriya explained it, I’m sure that they wouldn’t let them in,” Kirishima said.

“Yeh, I doubt they’d accept them into UA if they knew what they’ve done,” Izuku replied quietly.

“And if we run into them before UA?” Kaminari asked, his voice cool.

“Kaminari, sweetie, we’ve been over this,” Mina said, looking nervous. “We can’t just-”

“They killed Sero!” Kaminari yelled, uncharacteristic fury on his face as he got to his feet. “It’s their fault that Hanta and Kyouka are gone! And Midoriya’s friends too! Who’s to say they’re not going to hurt a lot more people?”

“Well, what do you expect us to do?” Mina replied, running a hand tiredly over her face. “Kaminari, obviously I’m heartbroken about Sero, and Jirou, and Midoriya’s friends but… what can we do?”

“We could kill ‘em.”

It was the calmness in Kacchan’s voice, perhaps, that disturbed Izuku the most. They had already had this discussion, the two of them had talked about what they could do, but hearing Kacchan say it so bluntly in front of them sent shivers up his spine.

“Wh-what?”

“We kill ‘em,” Kacchan replied firmly. “Nah, *I’ll* kill ‘em. I can do it.”

“K-Katsuki, *no*- ”

“I’ll help you,” Kaminari interrupted firmly, still on his feet.

“H-hold on! I can’t believe we’re actually having this discussion!”

“Kaminari is right,” Kacchan said. “They tried to kill us, they succeeded in killing people we all cared about, and they’re not gonna fuckin’ stop just because they can’t get into UA. We should have taken care of them before the RV. Before any of that shit happened!”

“It’s *murder* !” Kirishima cried, looking shocked and panicked. “This isn’t like killing zombies, man! They’re *people* -”

“They’re not people,” Kaminari hissed.

“I’m not asking you to be involved, Kirishima,” Kacchan said firmly. “M’not gonna force any of you into doing something you don’t want to do. I told you, and I meant it, I will take care of them. I’m much fuckin’ stronger than you guys anyway.”

“No!” Mina shook her head, lips wobbling. “No, I- I won’t let you. You can’t do it! That’s a road you can’t come back from! You won’t be able to live with yourselves-”

“And if someone else dies because we didn’t do anything?” Kaminari argued, his entire body trembling. “I can’t live with that either, Mina!”

“But… Midoriya!” Mina turned to Izuku now, expression desperate. “Say something!”

“I-” Izuku’s voice caught in his throat. He didn’t know what to say… When he thought about Dabi and the others, a biting rage built up in his chest like nothing he had ever felt before. He couldn’t deny that dark desire inside of him to hurt them every bit as much as they had hurt him and the people he loved. And yet, the visions of Shouto’s dead body, or Katsuma’s abandoned shoe… of Hanzo’s confused expression as the blood pooled between his lips… He couldn’t handle that any more. He couldn’t deal with yet more death.

He didn’t want to be a killer.

“I don’t know what to say,” Izuku whispered, looking away from Kacchan’s intense stare. “I’m angry, and I know they’re responsible for that but I don’t want to hurt anybody.”

“Finally,” Mina breathed, “a voice of reason.”

“And if it comes between them or us?” Kacchan said.

“Look, we really don’t need to talk about this right now,” Kirishima said. “We’ve all been through enough just to get here! And now we’re together again and I just wanna keep our focus on getting to UA. On finding somewhere *safe* .”

“We can’t just ignore the issue!” Kaminari protested.

“We’re not ignoring it,” Kirishima replied. “But right now isn’t the time to discuss this, ok? Please, let’s just try and enjoy the fact that we’re all together again.”

“Not all of us.” Kaminari sat back down, but the shadow across his face hadn’t lifted. Izuku knew the kind of pain that he was in… but Izuku had acted emotionally in the past, and it had almost gotten other people killed. It *had* gotten people killed. They needed to take time on this.

Kacchan, for what it was worth, didn’t push the matter any further. But his eyes lingered on Kaminari, something passing between the two of them that left Izuku’s stomach churning.

“It is getting kinda late,” Izuku said, keeping the conversation from drifting back. “We still need to decide the best route to UA. Not to mention, ah…” Izuku rubbed the back of his neck. “Well, Kacchan and I both have family in Musutafu.”

“Oh, shit yeh,” Kirishima breathed.

“If UA is actually a safe place, then my folks are smart enough to go there,” Kacchan said. “But I still wanna check my old place anyway.”

“Yeh,” Izuku nodded. “Me too.”

“How far did you guys live from UA?” Kirishima asked.

“Not far,” Izuku replied. “It was only a fifteen minute tram away.”

“Much the same,” Kacchan grunted.

“Ok,” Kirishima nodded. “So, we visit your folks’ places first, then we head to UA, sounds easy enough.”

“You don’t have to follow us to our homes,” Izuku said quickly. “It could be dangerous-”

“We’ve been separated long enough,” Kaminari interrupted. “No way are we going to split up again!”

Izuku nodded.

“For now, let’s just get some rest,” Mina suggested. “You both must be pretty tired from all the walking you’ve done.”

“We’re fine, Pinky,” Kacchan sighed, rolling his eyes.

“Well, there’s three bedrooms in this place,” Kirishima said, getting to his feet with a stretch, “unless you wanted to kip out here. Me and Mina got the one at the front, you can either bunk up with Kaminari or grab the spare.”

“Oh thank *fuck* ,” Kacchan said. “World’s worst fuckin’ secret ain’t secret any more.”

Kirishima flushed.

“I’m glad you guys are here, I’ve been third wheeling for months,” Kaminari whined.

“Oh don’t be dramatic, it hasn’t been that bad,” Mina huffed.

“Easy for you to say.”

“We’ll take the spare,” Kacchan announced, getting to his feet and grabbing his pack. Izuku tried not to show his surprise at that, certain that Kacchan was still pissed enough that he would demand he sleep out here on the couch.

“Oh, so much for no longer being a third wheel,” Kaminari muttered. “If you two are fucking as well we’re gonna need to start setting some ground rules.”

Izuku tensed, pretending that he was busy rummaging through his pack for bedding because he knew for sure the colour of his cheeks would give them away in an instant. Kacchan, however, scoffed.

“He should be so fuckin’ lucky,” he said with a derisive snort. Izuku’s heart dropped, looking up in spite of himself. Kacchan was glaring straight at him, and the air around them seemed to cool from cold to freezing. “Hurry up, asshole.”

Izuku scrambled to repack his bag. “U-uh, which room is it, Kirishima?”

“One next to the bathroom, sorry, pulled the short straw there,” Kirishima replied, watching the both of them nervously.

“That’s fine!”

Kacchan was already storming off up the stairs, and Izuku hurried after him with a quick smile back at the others. So, Kacchan was definitely still pissed.

The tension didn’t shift any once they were in the room, Kacchan throwing his stuff on the single bed closest to the door and kicking the door before Izuku was even fully in the room. He skipped to the side with a yelp, almost dropping his pack on the floor.

“You got ten seconds to explain yourself before I throw you out that fuckin’ window,” Kacchan snarled, rounding on him immediately. Izuku glanced over at the reinforced glazing and swallowed.

“L-look, Kacchan, I just got ahead of myself, ok? Obviously I don’t think anyone should do experiments on you!”

“Is that what you fucking meant by me being the reason you’re still going, hah?” Kacchan hissed, stepping forward into Izuku’s space and jabbing a finger against his chest. “I’m just a fucking experiment to you? A walking petri dish?”

“No! That’s not it at all!”

Kacchan pushed hard against him, causing Izuku to stumble backwards onto the second bed. “You’ve always been so interested in them,” he said, glaring down at him. “Coming up with all

these damn theories about the poor mutated fucks we came across."

Izuku frowned. He had never heard Kacchan use anything that even bordered on compassion when he talked about the zombies.

"First thing you did when you found out I had been bitten was ask all these fucking questions," Kacchan continued. "So, what? That the real reason you came after me? You couldn't let your experiment get away?"

"Of course not," Izuku replied, feeling angry now. "After everything we've been through you really think that's how I see you? It's got nothing to do with that! If you tell me right now that you don't want to go to UA, we won't go to UA. We'll go anywhere else you want to go."

"Oh real fucking convincing, Deku," Kacchan snarled. "You know full damn well that doesn't mean shit, I'm not gonna put their lives at risk like that-"

"Kacchan!"

Izuku got to his feet, pushing back against the man towering over him. In a move that was either very brave, or very stupid, he reached forward and placed his hands on Kacchan's cheeks. Kacchan froze, expression murderous, ready to tear away, before a flicker of uncertainty passed through his eyes, enough for Izuku to sense his reluctance.

"I got carried away, that's all that was," Izuku said, refusing to let go as Kacchan started to back away from him. "Of course I thought about the possibility of UA being able to make sense of things, maybe even find a cure for you. And recently I… I guess I've been thinking about it a whole lot more. But that's never what getting to UA was about, and it's not why I'm still here with you now."

Kacchan was still tense in his arms. But in spite of the daggers still being stared down at him, he looked less murderous than before, shoulders dropping just enough for Izuku to no longer think he was going to do good by his threat to lob him out the nearest window.

"I'm still pissed at you," Kacchan said, almost as if he felt like he had to.

"I know."

Kacchan grunted, grabbing Izuku's wrists and pulling them away. He then went to the bed by the door and started to drag it across the room.

"What're you doing?"

"What does it look like? Move your scrawny ass out the way."

Izuku jumped back, watching as Kacchan shoved the two beds side by side, grabbing Izuku's pack and throwing it onto the floor.

"What happened to *'I should be so lucky'* , huh?" Izuku muttered.

"Don't push your fucking luck."

“I thought maybe you were gonna break up with me.”

“If only it were that easy.”

Kacchan grabbed a couple pillows, shoving them into the gap left between the mattresses in a much more violent manner than was really necessary.

“Are we really not going to tell them?”

Kacchan huffed, throwing half a look back at him over his shoulder as he laid out the blankets.

“Pretty sure they already know, Deku.”

“Huh?”

“You keep calling me *Kacchan* ,” he replied pointedly, standing straight and placing his hands on his hips. “We’re sharing a damn room. Give them such fucking credit, Deku, they’re not complete morons.”

“Oh.”

Sure enough, there was a light knock on their door, before Kaminari called out down the hallway.

“N’night, keep it down in there, yeh?”

Izuku flushed. At least that was one awkward subject they wouldn’t need to bring up, and the lack of privacy was probably a small price to pay for having their friends back.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 31: Raise a Laugh from the Dead

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Kacchan finally visit their folks' homes and find more than they bargained for.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Why does the sun go on shining?

Why does the sea rush to the shore?

Don't they know -

Izuku hadn't thought about his mother in a very long time.

It wasn't because he didn't want to, and it certainly wasn't because he had forgotten her in the long two years since the world had come to an ugly end. At the very start, his mother had been at the forefront of his mind; waking up shivering from nightmares where she always slipped out of his grasp each time he reached for her. He and his mother had always been close and, up until he met Uraraka and the others, he had never been further than a half hour bus trip away from her in his entire life. His friends would say that it was sweet; a boy caring for his mother that much. But to Izuku it was always a little more than just him caring for her. His mother was a lonely woman, had been for as far back as he could remember, and it hurt him to think of her sitting alone in their tiny house, watering that same houseplant she had watered every day for four years.

At first, Izuku had been intent on getting back to her as soon as possible. He told himself over and over that she would still be there, still in that house, door locked and safe. Every night for weeks as they holed up in the makeshift shelter of Iida's apartment, Izuku debated leaving. His friends seemed fine; no zombies had tried to break in, or even seemed to have spotted them. They would be *fine* without him, whilst his mother… His mother *needed* him. She wouldn't know how to survive in a world as fucked up and frightening as this. And how long before his mother decided that *she* couldn't wait any more? How long before she came searching for him? The thought brought panic to his chest and bile to his throat as he peered out of the windows and watched the undead amble about on the street far below them. He would mentally plan out his escape route, trying to see if there was some kind of pattern to how the zombies moved, often in packs, that he would have been able to take advantage of. He had already packed his bag the night he first came face to face with the undead.

It was a miracle any of them had survived their first real encounter. The zombies had stumbled on their hideout, perhaps drawn by sound or smell, and the sheer weight of their bodies had been enough to break down the door. It was the first, and last time, that Izuku would ever let them be so goddamn careless. They had trusted a fucking *door* to save them, and they almost died because of

it. It was sheer dumb luck that got them out of that apartment alive. Izuku and Iida both hacked away with knives at anything that got too close, as the others used the flat plain of the door to push the rest back down the hall, almost falling down the stairs with them. They were fortunate that the other group on that floor had been hospitable people.

Leaving only got harder after that. His small band became part of a much larger group of survivors, and despite their number, Izuku had experienced just how quickly things could change. It was no longer a case of leaving his friends and telling himself they would be fine without him. *No* , if he left his friends, he knew that there was every chance that he'd be leaving them for dead. And, despite the agony that came with not knowing whether his mother was alive, his conscience wouldn't allow him to leave.

Their larger group grew into smaller groups soon after that. Any peace that there had been between them came to a tumultuous end one stormy night, after weeks of tension and fights that had been breaking out over resources and differences of opinion. Izuku, ever the peacemaker, did his best to stop things from falling apart, but he was small and powerless and there wasn't much that he could do to stop the man from being stabbed in the gut for cutting the line at dinner. Nothing that he could do when the man tore the throats out of three other people before he was killed for a second time.

After that, Izuku knew that there was no hope of getting back to his mother. Perhaps, not ever. The first night he and his friends spent he had cried and choked until the early hours, knowing his group could hear him and hoping that they wouldn't ask him about it. He decided he wouldn't think about his mother after that… not to think about whether she had survived, or not. Unsure what was more painful: that she hadn't survived, or that she had and she was still in that damn house, alone, waiting, watering that damned plant.

When Izuku awoke in the morning, his very first thought was of his mother.

He was closer to her now that he had been in so long, than he ever thought he would be again, and the ache that filled his chest the moment his eyes cracked open was so powerful that he shuddered. His fingers unconsciously tightening around the forearm draped over his waist, hard enough to jolt the owner awake. Kacchan was on his feet so quickly it ought to have given him whiplash, his red eyes alert and staring around the room.

After a moment, Kacchan seemed to realise where they were and that there was no danger, and looked back at Izuku with an irritated expression on his face.

"Deku, what the fuck?"

Izuku sat on the bed, hand still pressed to his aching chest.

"Sorry," he mumbled, distracted. "Must've been a nightmare or something…"

Kacchan eased up then, taking a deep breath and sitting on the edge of their bed, hand brushing Izuku's calf. But, for once, Izuku wasn't thinking about the volatile blond.

Two years was a long time, if it had even been that long. Shit, at this stage, Izuku had no idea how much time had really passed since he had last seen his mother. He didn't know how long it had been since he allowed himself to think about her for longer than a moment before pushing his thoughts to something else. He knew, deep in his heart, that any chance of finding her had been lost

long ago; there was no way that she would still be there, in that tiny house, waiting for him to just stroll through the door. The only hope he had was that she was sensible enough to go to UA, and not wait for him, not search for him, trust that he too would eventually find his way there. But, what kind of hope was that? In a world where most of the people he cared about were dead, what kind of vain childish belief was it that would convince him that his mother wasn't among them?

And yet, after all this time, he was finally in a position where he *could* go. He could leave the group and be back within the day, two at most, and he would finally know. Finally *know* if his mother was there or not.

"-eku?"

Izuku started, feeling a hand against his forehead and looking up. Kacchan had a concerned look on his face, marred only by the crease of frustration in his brows.

"Oi, the fuck you staring into space for?"

Izuku swallowed. "S-sorry," he muttered again. Kacchan's lips pursed as he pulled his hand away.

"Don't fuckin' apologise, just tell me what's up. You look all creepy and shit staring at your damn hands like that."

Izuku glanced down, seeing both his hands lying palm up on his lap. *Had they always looked that dry?*

And then Izuku remembered, it wasn't just *his* mother that was closer than ever.

"I want to look for our parents," Izuku said. "Today." He hesitated for a moment, before looking up to meet Kacchan's eyes. "Just us."

Kacchan looked surprised, before he nodded in understanding, looking away towards the window of their small room with a low hum.

"Yeh," he said. "But I don't think the three goons are gonna like it."

"They did say they wanted to come with us," Izuku agreed, thinking back to the conversation last night.

"Which is a bad fucking idea," Kacchan growled in response. "They're safe here, I don't wanna drag them into the center of Musutafu just to look for my folks."

"They just… they don't want to be separated again," Izuku sighed. "I can't blame them for that."

"Yeh yeh, I get it," Kacchan replied. "It's not like I wanna separate straight away, either. But I'd rather they were pissed at us for a while than for any of them to get fucking killed out there for our sake."

"You wanna tell them, or should I?" Izuku asked, with the smallest smirk on his lips.

"Damn coward," Kacchan grumbled, before he grabbed Deku's head and tousled his hair far

rougher than was necessary. “I’ll fucking do it.”

The other three were already in the living room by the time Izuku and Kacchan made it downstairs, the familiar smell of porridge drifting through the large home from the large pot nestled on some towels in the center of the coffee table. Izuku approached it eagerly, bowing his thanks before throwing a hefty spoonful into a bowl.

“I’m so fucking hungry even watery porridge smells good right now,” Kacchan grunted, also grabbing some food.Kami

“Hey, I added sugar!” Kaminari said, looking put out, a pout on his lips. “Those are damn good oats.”

“You guys sleep well?” Mina asked, sitting cross-legged on one of the sofas, bowl in her lap.

Izuku nodded, throwing her a wide grin.

“Been a while since we’ve not had to split shifts during the night,” Izuku said. “What with only the two of us to keep watch.”

“Normally we’re still splitting shifts,” Kirishima said, stretching his arms up above his head in a loud yawn. “But we try to make sure everyone gets at least six hours sleep each night. Now we can go back to taking it in turns, just like we used to back at the old place!”

“We’ll take a couple days for you both to get plenty of rest, and then make plans on how we’re getting to UA,” Kaminari said, leaning forward and smelling the porridge with a curious expression on his face. “It *does* smell good…”

“Well, uh, actually,” Izuku started, growing more hesitant as three sets of eyes immediately focused on him.

“Me and Deku are gonna be gone for a day, maybe two,” Kacchan supplied, matter-of-factly.

A tense silence followed this, before Kirishima cleared his throat.

“Uh, why?”

“Because, dumbass, we wanna see if our folks are still… about,” Kacchan replied. “And before you argue any, no you’re not coming with us. It ain’t worth the risk.”

“We’re not splitting up again!” Kaminari cried, getting to his feet. “I thought we already decided on that!”

“Nah, *you* decided that,” Kacchan shot back. “Fucking relax. It’ll be easier for me and Deku to sneak through the city than all five of us. We’ll go then come right back.”

“That doesn’t make any sense,” Mina said, dropping her bowl loudly to the table. “I swear you’re both as bad as each other!”

“Hah? The fuck you getting at, Pinky?”

“So, you’re gonna go into the city on your own. Then come back, maybe with your parents with you, only for us all to have to go back into Musutafu to get to UA anyway?!”

“She’s got a point,” Kirishima said.

“No, she doesn’t,” Kacchan snapped. “It’s *different* if we’re going to UA, we’re doing that for a fucking reason! But if something happens to any of you just because I dragged you along to my old place-”

“Something could happen if you left us here!” Mina protested. “Maybe another group finds us. Maybe a herd of zombies come by and we have to relocate! Anything could happen, and we have no way of communicating with you! No, I say we stay together, just as Kaminari said. We stick together, we find somewhere safe close to your folks place. We can take it slow as we need to, but we’re *not* splitting up again.”

“Unless you fancy tying all three of us up you’re not gonna stop us from following you,” Kirishima said, with a wry smile. “Face it, dudes, you’re stuck with us now.”

“Yeh, honeymoon is over, you two,” Kaminari said with a grin.

“Honeymo- that don’t even fucking make sense!”

Izuku sighed, rubbing his face. He didn’t *want* any of them to come with him, he didn’t want that fucking responsibility. Not again. But Mina made a good point, and when it really came down to it, what could they do to stop them?

“I think they’re right, Kacchan.”

“Wha- you gave in too easy!” Kacchan yelled.

“Well, how exactly are you planning on stopping them?” Izuku asked, raising an eyebrow.

“I’ll kick their asses if they follow us!”

“Man, no you won’t,” Kaminari smirked. “We all know you’re really a teddy bear.”

“You’ll fucking die for that, Dunce Face!”

“Oh no, what you gonna do? Passive aggressively care for me to death?”

“I’ll kill you!”

Kacchan was on his feet, and Kaminari squeaked, eyes wide, before launching himself over the table away from Kacchan’s grabbing hands.

“So, it’s decided then?” Mina asked Izuku calmly, over the shrill screams of Kaminari and the thundering of Kacchan’s feet as he chased him around the outside of the living room.

“COME BACK HERE!”

“I’m not- look, I’m worried about it, ok?” Izuku replied, honestly. “A lot of… People have been hurt because of bad decisions I’ve made. I don’t want that to happen again.”

“But, this isn’t just your decision, man,” Kirishima said, leaning forward with a gentle smile. “We don’t want to be split up, and we need to go into the center of Musutafu anyway. This way, we at least got each other's backs. Right?”

There was a bang from the kitchen, the sound of more screams, before the thundering stopped.

“TAKE IT BACK!”

“We need to be so careful,” Izuku pleaded. “We don’t know what we’re going to find in there.”

“Midoriya, we made it this far alone. Trust me, we’ll only be stronger together.”

“I YIELD, I YIELD!”

“Ok. Ok, we’ll do it together.”

Izuku could tell that Kacchan was furious. Granted, it wasn’t like he was usually prone to keeping that kind of information to himself, but that the grinding of Kacchan’s teeth could be heard over the group loudly collecting their belongings was a little alarming. That, combined with the long list of demands and requisites that he had given for allowing Kirishima, Mina, and Kaminari to tag along, Izuku was almost in awe at how carefree the three of them seemed to be; laughing, joking, teasing like they were getting ready for a picnic down the park.

As eager as Izuku was to get going, and soon, he understood that they were going to need a little more preparation than he had grown used to, when it had just been the two of them. He still had his fireman’s axe, a weapon that he had come to grow rather fond of given how the weight of it seemed to make up for the strength his arms still lacked, even now, but it was heavy, and it wasn’t exactly ideal for sneaking through tight city alleys and darting along exposed streets. Looking as though every single word pained him, Kacchan had spat out a *‘if they were doing this fucking thing’* then he wanted something similar to the set-up they had going for them the last time they travelled as a group. Which meant Izuku’s axe had to go. If Izuku wasn’t certain that their safety was Kacchan’s main priority, he might have thought he was taking his axe away out of spite.

Fortunately, Kirishima and the others had stock piled a rather impressive arsenal in the weeks they had been calling their hideout home: knives, bats, hand axes, poles, fish cleavers; anything they had come across that might be useful they had swiped. Whilst Katsuki kept his bat and slipped knives in various places about his person, Izuku settled on a rather beautiful looking hunting knife, the blade of which had a swirled oxidised effect down the length. Taking a page from Kacchan’s book, he also slipped an axe into his belt. They weren’t quite his wakizashi, but they’d do.

And yet, despite being as prepared as they could possibly be, Kacchan continued to throw the foulest glares over at all of them as he sulked by the front door, almost as if he thought if he stared hard enough they might change their minds. Izuku knew the guy was fighting a losing battle.

“So,” Kaminari said brightly, hoisting his backpack up with a beaming grin on his face. “Who’s place are we going to first?”

“Whoever is closest,” Izuku replied, looking over at Kacchan hoping for something more helpful than a grunt. He wasn’t to be so lucky.

“We’ve got a map of Shizuoka, if that helps to plan our route a little better,” Mina offered.

Izuku knew the area well, but some visualisation might help the rest of them get their bearings. He nodded, watching with an amused smirk as Mina proceeded to grab the back of Kirishima’s pack, and spinning him around so suddenly the man almost toppled over.

“Easy!”

“Here we are!” Mina slapped the map onto Izuku’s out-stretched palm. Pushing the rubbish and empty cans aside, he opened it out and laid it onto the table, taking a moment to get his bearings.

“So, that’s UA,” he muttered, pointing to the largest selection of buildings on the map, the border of the expanse of land it lay on marked out with a thick-set line. UA was surrounded on all sides by a tall, thick wall, imposing to look at and the source of a great many rumours over the six decades it had laid a solitary claim over that area of the city. Izuku had heard them all; most notable and ludicrous to him had been the idea that the walls were erected, not to stop something from getting in, but rather to stop something from getting *out* . UA was a school of science, every tutor working there was a notable person in their field, and the campus was certainly large enough that all sorts of research and experiments had taken place there… but the idea that UA had been creating monsters, or some terrifying new pathogen had always seemed bat shit to him.

“It’s so big,” Kaminari said.

“It’s pretentious, is what it is,” Kacchan scoffed from his place against the wall. “What kind of fucking university needs walls like that, hah?”

“Well, good job for us it does, because those walls are exactly what we’re hoping will have kept the zombies out,” Mina said. Kacchan huffed.

Izuku traced his finger along the map, picking out the train line he had travelled almost every day for an entire year, back to the station near his home.

“That’s me,” he said, pointing to an area just right of the Daiya river. “Ikeda.”

“Hah?!”

Kacchan pushed himself off of the wall, indifferently shoving into Izuku’s shoulder as he stared down at the map to where Izuku was pointing.

“What?” Izuku asked.

“No fucking way do you live in Ikeda,” Kacchan snapped, looking pissed off.

“I, uh, think I’d know where I’ve lived my whole life, Kacchan,” Izuku replied, confused.

“Well obviously you were a fucking shut-in or some shit because I’d have known you!”

“Wait, you’re from Ikeda too?”

Kacchan had pushed Izuku entirely to the side now, pulling the map towards him and glaring at it, before jabbing at it roughly with a wide finger.

“There, that’s me, by the shrine.”

Izuku’s eyes widened in understanding. “ *Oh.* ”

“Oh? What the fuck do you sayin’ *‘oh’* like that for?!”

“Yeh, I lived in the apartments near the river,” Izuku said. “I didn’t spend a lot of time over where the rich kids played.”

“Excuse me, *rich kids?* ” Kacchan turned to him, looking affronted.

“Yeh,” Izuku continued with a shrug. “It’s all parks and big houses that way.” He sighed. “I bet you have a really lovely house, you’re so lucky, Kacchan!”

“Sure, but I didn’t hang out there all the damn time!” Kacchan snapped back, looking far angrier than the situation warranted. “Fuck you, Deku! I ain’t no *rich kid!* ”

“But your parents had money?”

“I- *well yeh, but-* ”

“Kacchan’s a rich kid,” Izuku said with a wide grin, enjoying the flustered look on Kacchan’s face.

“This is *fascinating* ,” Kaminari said, resting his chin on his palm as he watched the two of them. “He just called you a posh boy, you gonna take that lying down, Bakugou?”

“Stay out of it, bastard!”

“I still can’t believe we lived so close to each other,” Izuku said, his voice a little higher. “We might have seen each other all the time and not known it!”

“I think I’d remember you!”

“Why?”

“Yeh, why would you remember him, *Kacchan* ?” Kaminari asked, teasing lilt to his voice and smirking over his palm. Kacchan hesitated for a moment, his face looking suspiciously pink.

“Coz how many people you know with green fucking hair?” he ground out, before pushing away from the table and stalking back to his favoured spot against the wall. “Whatever, just make a damn plan already.”

Izuku still felt the grin on his face as he looked back down at the map.

“Well, Kacchan’s place is closest,” he said, “so we should aim for his place first. Plus, it might be a little bigger for us to stay in if we need to.”

“No,” Kacchan said so suddenly, it made Izuku jump. “We ain’t staying at my place, we should look for something close by that’s safe first.”

“Why, you got embarrassing posters up on your bedroom wall or something?” Kirishima said with a snigger.

“Big muscular All Might on the ceiling,” Kaminari added, laughing too.

“And if we all get there and my parents are dead in the damn house, what then, hah?” Kacchan said coldly. At that, the smiles quickly fell from their lips, and all of a sudden the reality of it came crashing back in on them again.

“Sorry, Bakugou, I didn’t think…” Kirishima started, but Kacchan spoke over him.

“Yeh, well if you wanna come with you should probably start giving thinking a fucking try,” he said.

An awkward silence followed, Izuku looking over to where Kacchan stood, resolutely not meeting his eyes. Izuku had been so focused on finding out what had happened to his mother, that he hadn’t even considered the possibility of… *finding* her. He swallowed.

“W-well, good news is we can just follow the train line from the bridge all the way to Higashi station,” he said, pushing his hair back from his eyes. “We could probably come off before then, find somewhere close by that seems safe.”

“Won’t we be really open on the tracks?” Mina asked. Izuku thought back to how he and Kacchan had gotten around when they had been looking for Shouto.

“Yeh,” he said, “but it’s the quickest route, and it also means we can get a good look at what’s around us. It’ll be much harder for a group of zombies to sneak up on us that way.”

“But easier for *people* to spot us,” Kaminari said. “Right?”

“If there are any groups here, they’ll be keeping an eye on the main routes in,” Kacchan said. “The highway is pretty close to the tracks, I’d bet anyone here would be more concerned about groups coming in by road than on the train tracks.”

“The problem is, if we go along the streets, not only will it take us much longer, but we’ll be walking blind pretty much the whole time,” Izuku explained. “I know the tracks are risky, but it’s how Kacchan and I got into Shinigawa.”

“Well, if you’re confident,” Kirishima said, clapping Izuku on the back. “I’m with you, Midoriya.”

“Ok,” Izuku said, feeling somewhat nervous at the confidence that Kirishima had in him. It was

great to have their friends back, but feeling responsible for more than just Kacchan and himself was doing a huge dis-service to his nerves. “Then, let’s do it.”

It was late morning by the time they finally left the safety of the house, with rucksacks over their shoulders and weapons in hand as they walked down the sunlit hill towards the bridge. It was a cold morning. Their breath fogged up in front of them, and the harsh crows of a bird soaring overhead echoed through the frigid air. Izuku had always loved this time of year… the promise of snow, the comforts that come from cold winters in front of a warm stove. But, the apocalypse in winter brought far more challenges than hot chocolates and marshmallows could fix. He remembered the last winter with a heavy sadness in his chest; he and his friends huddled up close to one another under moth-eaten blankets, too scared to start a fire in case it attracted the interest of the zombies shuffling around outside of their room. It had been a dark and terrifying time, and there had been many points where he had honestly doubted how much longer they could hold on, and despite the beauty of the clear blue sky above him, and the frost tickled grass swaying in the gentle breeze, he felt dread pooling in the pit of his stomach.

At least, this winter, they would have the walls of UA around them.

He hoped.

On a good day, Izuku guessed that it would take them about three hours to walk to his apartment block if they followed the tracks and there were no distractions along the way. They really had no way of knowing what they were going to find the deeper they walked into Shizuoka; entirely empty, or the streets teaming with zombies, either option was just as likely for as best they could guess. It was far safer for them to go ahead with the assumption that they *would* run into trouble, and be ready to handle it if they did. After all, being on the tracks also made it very difficult for them to find somewhere to hide at a pinch, and fighting their way out of a situation was a much more likely scenario. Izuku felt as confident as he could that they could handle it… after all, they had each survived this far, and Kacchan was a force to be reckoned with, *especially* if he was still pissed off. But he wasn’t sure how much experience would count against sheer numbers if they were to find themselves overwhelmed by a hoard on the tracks.

He didn’t even want to think about their chances if they came across a hostile group of humans.

But, despite the danger, the group were in remarkably good spirits, and even Kacchan’s pout wasn’t enough to dampen the rays coming from Kaminari’s smile as he strode confidently beside them.

“What are you fucking grinning about?” Kacchan snarled through gritted teeth as Kaminari positively skipped at his side.

“It’s a beautiful day!” Kaminari replied brightly. “The sun’s shining, we’ve got the band back together, what’s not to smile about?”

Kacchan chose not to answer.

Izuku decided that it would be easiest to access the tracks via Okitsu Station instead of trying to jump the chain link fence running along the length of the track. It also served to be a good top up spot for their supplies, Kaminari making a beeline for the vending machines inside of the ticket office.

“Hey, no one’s looted these things yet!” he said. “How’s that for some good luck, huh?”

Izuku honestly wasn’t sure if Kaminari’s positivity was entirely honest or not… a part of him considered the possibility that it was, in part, an act to keep the spirits of the group up. Either way, Izuku was grateful for it, and he grabbed Kacchan’s bat from his hand.

“Oi!”

“Don’t worry, I’ll give it back,” Izuku teased as Kacchan glared at him. “Move over, Kaminari.”

With a large swing, he smashed the front of the vending machine, multi-coloured packets spilling out onto the floor.

“You best hope no one heard that,” Kacchan snapped, snatching the bat back from Izuku as he held it out to him.

“We haven’t seen anything the entire time we’ve been walking,” Kirishima reasoned, bending to help Kaminari collect the snacks and stuffing them into his pack.

“Doesn’t mean there isn’t anyone out there!”

Kacchan huffed, keeping his eyes fixed on the door to the station. Izuku knew that Kacchan was just being cautious - they each knew from experience just how quickly things could change out here. But Izuku wasn’t strictly used to this new overly-cautious Kacchan, his knuckles white over the strength with which he gripped his bat, jumping at each and every noise. He waited until the group had climbed down the station step onto the track before reaching out and grabbing the sleeve of Kacchan’s coat, getting his attention.

“Hey, is everything ok?”

Even with Izuku holding onto him, Kacchan wasn’t quick to meet his gaze, still letting his eyes trail along the treeline and up and down the tracks.

“What do you think?” he hissed, under his breath. “We’re walking into new territory and they’re treating it like it’s some sort of day trip! And *you* , I would’ve thought *you’d* be more fucking careful.”

“I am being careful!” Izuku protested. Kacchan looked at him then, shooting him a disdainful look. “Ok ok, I won’t make any more noise. But you need to relax-”

“ *Relax?* ” Kacchan whisper-yelled. “Are you kidding-”

“You’re too tense,” Izuku interrupted. “I’m serious, Kacchan. It’s one thing to be prepared, but it’s no good jumping at every shadow.”

“Fuck you,” Kacchan replied. But his voice was empty of malice, and he sighed as he looked back towards the group. “C’mon, before those idiots walk themselves into a ditch or something.”

It occurred to Izuku then, watching Kacchan stride away from him with his shoulders squared that he had seen him this stressed before. Now that he thought about it, Kacchan had *always* seemed

this stressed, back when they had first met, when he had been a complete asshole with a personality to compliment a kick in the teeth. Sure, he'd had confidence, but he had always been ahead, always watchful, always *tense* … Kacchan hadn't exactly calmed down in the time they had travelled, just the two of them, but that weight on his shoulders had slipped away little by little. It was only now, seeing those wide strong shoulders hunch again, that he even realised he'd even been shedding the weight to begin with.

Izuku was well used to the feeling of being responsible for his friends; Iida, technically, had been the one making much of the decisions back then, but Izuku had still felt like it was him on guard the most, doing absolutely anything he could to keep his friends safe. And though the restless nights, being on watch, not feeling like he could ever relax like some of them could, wasn't something he'd ever complain about, it had taken its toll on him. Seeing Kacchan now, he realised he had immediately dropped back into that same role he'd given himself back when things started: their protector.

It wasn't that it was a bad thing, not entirely. After all, anyone could do much *much* worse than have a man like Kacchan watching their back all the time, and his experiences made him all the more alert. And yet…

Izuku sighed.

He wasn't sure that it was such a good thing for *Kacchan* . The man had had way too many breakdowns, and those were just the ones that Izuku *knew* about.

The sooner they get to UA, the better.

The group spotted some of the undead as they walked, loners stumbling along the roads running parallel to the tracks, and at one stage had to press themselves back against the chain link fence as a mass of about thirty crossed an overpass. There were enough zombies for all of them, including Kaminari, to remain on guard and keep quiet as they walked, but Izuku was still surprised that they hadn't come across more of them by now. Shizuoka was a big prefecture, and it had always been a busy place to live growing up, and part of him really had expected to be dodging hordes of the undead. The longer they walked, nearing their half-way point and, by now, deep within the City, the more Izuku started to notice something curious about all the zombies that they saw.

"Hey," he muttered, under his breath, as the five of them crouched on the tracks waiting for a pair of zombies to pass over the level crossing ahead of them. "Have you guys noticed something weird about these zombies?"

"You mean, aside from the obvious?" Kirishima asked, gesturing to one of the zombies, who was dragging an inflatable pig behind it, the cord tight around it's throat.

"It's bringing home the bacon," Kaminari whispered, to which Kacchan offered him a simmering glare in response.

"No, not that," Izuku replied, rubbing his nose to mask his smile. "I mean, all the zombies we've seen, they all seem to be heading in the same direction."

A silence followed that, the five still watching the unusual pair stumble their way down the road.

“Yeh, you’re right,” Mina said. “I haven’t seen a single one of them leaving the city. It’s almost like something is drawing them in.”

“Fucking fantasic,” Kacchan growled.

“Well, we always knew they were drawn to places with more people,” Izuku reasoned. “Cities and the like.”

“You think this means that there are survivors here?” Kirishima asked. “Maybe UA is still standing after all.”

Izuku pulled the map out from his back pocket, glancing around. The two zombies were out of sight now, and he felt confident standing again, holding the map in front of him and noting the landmarks around them to get his bearings.

“Well, it’s hard to say for sure, there are so many roads in the city,” he said. “But… if I had to make the assumption, it seems like they’re all walking towards UA.”

“That’s both good news, and really *really* bad news,” Kaminari said. “I mean, what reason would they have to head to UA if not because it’s full of people? But, also, what if the place is surrounded by them?”

Izuku had to admit, he had never considered this as a possibility. He’d been so focused on just getting to UA, that getting *in* hadn’t crossed his mind.

“If it’s really a safe place, they’ll have ways of getting people in,” Kirishima said. “Don’t worry about it just yet.”

But Izuku found it impossible not to worry after that. The deeper they walked into the city, the more zombies they saw, all of them unquestionably heading in the same direction, seemingly so focused on their goal that not a single zombie had spotted them over the last two hours. It was weird, it was fucking *creepy* , and Izuku nerves were already close to breaking point by the time they ran into their first bit of trouble.

At first, Izuku wasn’t sure *what* he was seeing, but as they got closer, the group quickly realised that something really wasn’t right in Shizuoka. There had been heavy storms, sure, but nothing that could help explain the destruction in front of them. An expressway ran through the entirety of Shizouka, often raised above the roads surrounding it, and at the point where it went over the track, the entire bridge had collapsed, rubble and bent steel piling up high and completely blocking their path.

“How did that happen?” Kaminari breathed. “Typhoon?”

“There’d be damage all around the place if it was,” Kacchan replied. “Nah, it’d take a fuck tonne of explosives to bring that thing down.”

“Explosives?” Mina looked nervously behind them at that. “But who would do that?”

“The military?”

“Think about it,” Izuku said. “Whoever did this cut off two of the main entry points into the city in one go. They really didn’t want anyone to get in.”

“Or get out,” Kacchan said coldly. Izuku felt a chill run down his spine.

“This is creepy,” Kaminari whined. “We should get out of here.”

“Yeh,” Izuku breathed, looking around. “We’re not far away now, we should come off the track here, find somewhere safe.”

“There are loads of buildings around here,” Kacchan said. “We’re bound to find something. C’mon.”

Izuku cast another thoughtful look at the collapsed bridge in front of them, before following Kacchan and the others over the fence. Izuku was no expert in demolition, but it would surely take a lot more than a handful of molly’s to break through the thick concrete of the bridge. Perhaps it was the leftovers of the military’s attempt to keep things under control back at the beginning, but if it wasn’t, then who would have the means? Izuku wondered if there would be more evidence of this level of destruction elsewhere in the city.

They decided to take a break at the first empty house they came across, Kacchan taking the lead with his bat in hand as he kicked back doors and checked every closet. It was a tiny home, but being so deep into the city Izuku thought being in a room where they could pretty much see every entry and exit point wasn’t such a bad idea. Kaminari let out a relieved sigh as he dropped onto a cushion, stretching his knees out with an audible *crack* , as Kirishima quickly set about grabbing snacks from his pack and throwing them to each of them.

“So, how far away are we from your homes from here?” Mina asked.

“Maybe half an hour, if not less,” Izuku replied, taking a bite from the stale chewy chocolate bar. “Sport stadium is that way-” he jabbed his thumb over his shoulder, “-I’m not far after that.”

“There’s a sports stadium?” Kirishima asked, interested.

“We’re not stopping to sight-see,” Kacchan said immediately. “Get that idea out of your fucking head.”

“Ok, ok! Sheesh…”

“So, are we setting up here for the night after we go looking?”

“We’ll find somewhere closer to Deku’s place,” Kacchan said, not looking at any of them as he glared out of the window onto the street. “I don’t like how close this place is to the bridge.”

“Isn’t your home closer?” Izuku asked. “We should go there first-”

“Nah,” Kacchan interrupted. “We’re going to yours first, then finding somewhere safe. Too fuckin’ open around my folks’ place, we’ll deal with that tomorrow after we’ve all gotten some rest.”

Izuku didn’t argue, though the tension in Kacchan’s voice was obvious for any of them to hear.

They allowed themselves fifteen minutes, before heading off again. It felt much more claustrophobic on the streets, despite the roads ahead of them being entirely empty and deathly quiet. Ordinarily, Izuku would have walked past the stadium, he used to enjoy looking at the huge structure back in the day, but something about being so close to it sat uneasy in his stomach, and so he lead them down residential streets, winding this way and that, the familiarity of the place stirring something painful. It had been years since he had last walked these streets yet it felt like just yesterday, his eyes fell on stores he used to go to with his mother, even the homes of kids that he had played with when he had been much younger.

“I know a place we can go,” Izuku said, as even the pavement beneath his feet became familiar to him, down to the dog-shaped chunk of gum welded to the gutter. “There’s this boutique clothing store that my mum used to work at, I doubt it’ll have been raided, and the upstairs is like a staff room-kitchen area, we should be able to see around us from there.”

Kacchan made a sound like he was about to say something, before seemingly thinking better of it, and the group came out onto a highway through the town.

It seemed that Izuku had been wrong about the old store being looted; the glass on the front door was smashed in, the door itself wide open, and Izuku tensed as he got close. It was likely that anyone checking out the gas station nearby might have just decided not to pass the store over, but he was still cautious as he walked through the front, eyes adjusting to the darkness. The cash register was wide open, the box of lollipops that usually sat on the counter was half empty, but otherwise most things were still intact. He supposed no one really had much use for floral scarves and stringy sandals in the apocalypse.

“Aww, cute,” Mina said, grabbing a denim jacket with flowers and a dragon sewn into the back. She then hesitated as she pulled it off the hanger, looking over at Izuku with a guilty expression on her face. “Uh… should I pay for it or-”

Izuku was so confused by the question at first that he just stared at her, before a laugh rumbled in his chest and he wheezed.

“You can have it!” he said. “Besides, my mum hasn’t worked here in years.”

“Sweet!”

“Is there a men’s section?” Kaminari asked, eyeing Mina’s new denim jacket with jealousy.

“No, sorry.”

“Kaminari, sweetie, the women’s jackets will absolutely fit you,” Mina said with a smile. “You wanna match?”

Kaminari tried, and failed, to look indignant. “I’ll have you know my shoulders are way too broad!”

“Keep telling yourself that,” Kacchan grunted, following Izuku to where he was standing behind the counter, opening the drawers and checking if there was anything useful left inside. Izuku heard a rustle, glancing up to see Kacchan selecting one of the lollipops and tearing the wrapper with his

teeth. “Your entire body is about as wide as one of my legs.”

“Yeh yeh, well, we can’t all be built like Greek gods now, can we?”

Izuku almost choked, his fingers fumbling and dropping the tape he’d grabbed. Kacchan turned to face him with a wide smirk, sticking out his tongue and resting the candy on top.

“Y’hear that, Deku?”

Izuku slammed the drawer shut, feeling his cheeks burn and ignoring Kacchan’s low snigger.

“Let’s go check upstairs, shall we?” he said, his voice coming out unnaturally high, and trying hard not to notice the way the others were looking at him.

The door to the staff room was open, but fortunately it hadn’t been broken, and other than the empty cupboards, it seemed like a perfectly reasonable place for them to set up for the night. The entire front of the store was a wide window, and they could easily flick back the blinds to see up and down the street and keep watch. It wasn’t the perfect safe house, but it would certainly do for now.

“My apartment is pretty much around the corner from here,” Izuku said. “We can be there and back in less than ten minutes.” He hesitated for a moment. “You, uh, you don’t all have to come with me. It might be better if there’s just a couple of us. Some to keep watch back here, you know?”

“Me and Bakugou can hold the fort here,” Mina offered. “I’m sure you boys can handle yourselves.”

Izuku felt a rush of panic at this, eyes automatically snapping to Kacchan. He couldn’t help it, couldn’t help thinking back to the last time they had been separated from one another, how Izuku had been so afraid that he had lost him.

“Yeh, we got it,” Kaminari said, clapping Izuku on the shoulder, not aware of anxiety coursing through Izuku’s veins.

“You sure, babe?” Kirishima asked Mina, and Kacchan scoffed.

“What, you don’t think we can watch a damn store?”

“Bakugou, I’m flattered, but you know I wasn’t actually talking to you-”

“I know that!”

“Hey, Midoriya got to spend months hanging out with Bakugou,” Mina replied. “It’s my turn for some quality Blasty time.”

“Kirishima, swap with me,” Kacchan ground out, but Kirishima let out a loud laugh, grabbing Izuku’s shoulders and turning him around on the spot.

“Nope! She’s all yours!”

“What the f- why d’you gotta say it so ominously?” Kacchan yelled.

“Come on, Midoriya, time to go!” Kirishima said in a sing-song voice, marching Izuku along.

“But-” Izuku started, heart racing.

“Let’s leave the ladies to their hair braiding,” Kaminari sniggered.

“ *Hah?!* ”

“Wait-”

But Izuku was steered out of the room before he had a chance to protest, Kirishima and Kaminari either side of him and boxing him in as they made their way down the stairs. Izuku knew they weren’t aware of what had happened outside the hospital, but it didn’t help to ease his anxiety any. Being *apart* from Kacchan hadn’t been part of the deal.

“So, which way do we head from here?” Kaminari asked brightly as they stepped out onto the bright street.

“Uh,” Izuku swallowed, trying to settle the mangled mess that was his brain. “We, uh, gotta follow the road to that turning over there.”

“Alright, let’s go find some clues on mumma Midoriya!”

With a deep sigh, Izuku followed the pair of them. His home *was* close, it wasn’t like he was going to be separated from Kacchan for long.

“So, Izuku, can I call you Izuku?” Kaminari asked, and Izuku threw him a confused look.

“I’m pretty sure you’ve called me Izuku loads of times before now.”

“ *Izuku* ,” Kaminari continued. “Now that we have you alone, you gotta let us ask you some questions.”

Izuku groaned. He should have known this was coming.

“Look, if it’s about Kacchan-”

“Let’s start with that, shall we?” Kaminari said, looking back at him. “When did you start getting away with calling him that?”

“I- uh,” Izuku rubbed the back of his head. “I dunno. He just… never really seemed bothered enough to stop me-”

“Bakugou? *The* Bakugou, not taking offence to you giving him a cutesy nickname? Sounds awful sus to me, Izuku.”

“I don’t think he’d want us talking about him,” Izuku grumbled, his cheeks feeling warm.

“Technically, we’re talking about you,” Kirishima offered, glancing up and down the next street before they crossed the road.

“Right, right,” Kaminari nodded, almost sagely. “You know, I’m just gonna come out and say it. You and *Kacchan* , are you guys a thing?”

Izuku almost tripped, squeaking when Kirishima grabbed his arm to steady him.

“Do we really need to talk about this right now?” he yelped.

“You’d rather we sneak you away to talk about it again later?” Kirishima asked with a grin. Izuku glowered at him.

“Hey, I’m pretty sure you and Mina were supposed to be a secret too,” he said.

“Ahah!” Kaminari whisper-yelled, jumping on the spot and pointing at him. “You said ‘too’! You said they were supposed to be a secret *‘too’!* ”

Izuku groaned, raising a hand to rub at his aching temple, and willing for his face to stop feeling so goddamn hot. Kacchan was gonna *kill* him.

“I don’t think we should be talking about this right now,” he repeated. “I can’t just talk about Kacchan’s business like this. It’s… private.”

“All signs point to *‘yes’* ,” Kirishima said, nodding his head at Kaminari.

“For real, Izuku, we’re happy for you both,” Kaminari said with a smile. “You have any idea how long we’ve been trying to set him up with someone?”

Izuku definitely felt curious about that, glancing sideways at him, and chewing on his lip.

“So, uh, is that what the deal with Shindo was about?” he asked, hesitantly.

So much for not talking about Kacchan’s business, Izuku…

“Oh, he didn’t tell you the deal with him and Shindo?” Kirishima said. “Huh, I suppose that tracks, it wasn’t the healthiest relationship in the world.”

“We didn’t set them up,” Kaminari offered. “Bakugou and Shindo were that kinda dirty romance novel the girls read instead of watching porn, you know?”

“What?”

“Yeh, like, they were really bad for each other but it was intense,” Kaminari continued. “Couldn’t keep their hands off each other, it was kinda gross thinking back.”

Izuku didn’t know what to say to that. He knew it was stupid to feel jealous over something that happened before Kacchan even *met* him, but he’d heard enough snippets about the two of them now that the thought was starting to make his stomach churn. The words, *‘best fuck of my life’* and *‘couldn’t keep their hands off each other’* swirled around and around in his brain.

“Oh!” Kaminari stopped, looking horrified. “Shit, I’m sorry! I didn’t mean…”

“Dude,” Kirishima sighed, shaking his head.

“L-like I said,” Kaminari continued quickly, holding both his hands forward. “It wasn’t healthy, I’m pretty sure Bakugou hated his guts by the end of it, Shindo was kind of a liar! He had a girlfriend the entire time that he didn’t tell him about-”

“ *Dude* !” Kirishima repeated.

“Who, Tatami?” Izuku asked, remembering the girlfriend Shindo had.

“Yeh!”

“Oh, well that explains why she seemed to hate Kacchan so much, I guess,” Izuku said.

“Yeh,” Kaminari replied with a nervous laugh. “Don’t envy you having to have been in the middle of that, man. It was pretty messy. For what it’s worth, he seems much happier with you.”

Izuku didn’t get a chance to respond to that, realising when his foot hit a familiar curb that they were now standing right outside his apartment block. The breath was knocked from his lungs for what felt like the sixth time that day alone, and his neck craned back to take in the sight of tall grey concrete that he had looked at almost every single day of his life until he took that fateful trip to Tokyo. The building itself didn’t really look all that different from what he remembered; sure, the area out front was severely overgrown, and some of the balconies seemed to be teeming with unattended house plants, but otherwise it stood just as it had always done, waiting for him to return.

“Is this it?” Kirishima asked, and Izuku nodded, swallowing back the lump in his throat. All this time, not allowing himself to even think about, to *hope* , and here it was. His home.

“How high up are you?”

Izuku raised his hand, pointing to the first balcony on the fourth floor, not trusting himself to speak yet.

“Alright.” Kirishima took a deep breath, spinning his axe deftly between his fingers. “I’m guessing the hallways in there are pretty narrow, what about the staircases?”

“They, uh, they’re towards the back of the building,” Izuku supplied, mouth feeling dry. “Visibility isn’t going to be great, but you can jump the railings easy enough if we need to make a quick get away.”

“Does each level open up onto the stairway or-”

“There are doors. I mean, they might be propped open, I guess, but usually they’re closed. So unless we make a lot of noise, hopefully anything trapped inside won’t hear us and follow us up.”

“Well, you take the lead, Midoriya. We’ve got your back.”

Izuku nodded, noting with relief the confidence with which Kirishima and Kaminari both gripped their weapons. He supposed he and Kacchan weren’t the only ones that had gotten stronger over the last few months.

Evidence of the apocalypse was much stronger inside the building, and the moment Izuku pushed back the heavy door he knew the already slim chances of finding his mother here were non-existent. It was the smell that hit him first; that easily distinguishable scent of years worth of rot and decomposition contained inside a building that had stood empty for two sweltering summers. It didn’t matter how used to it he was, he still had to cover his mouth and nose with the sleeve of his coat, grimacing and hoping his stomach was strong enough to overcome it. Kirishima and Kaminari also covered their faces, the latter letting out a groan of displeasure.

“Damnit,” he muttered into the wool of his jacket collar. “Hate that smell.”

Izuku proceeded along the hallway cautiously, one hand over his mouth, the other holding the decorative knife, eying up each and every door as they passed. Those that were open, he reached out to quietly close, preventing any deceased occupants from following them up the stairs and cutting off their only escape route, trying not to think too much about how he knew practically every person who had lived here.

On the first floor, they came across the main source of the bad smell, a pile of sunken, mummified corpses collected in the center of the hallway that they had no choice but to climb over. Izuku was thankful that they were so far gone that he couldn’t really recognise any of them, though it didn’t stop his eyes trailing over the clothing and concave flesh looking for hints of green.

They climbed up the staircase in silence, alert for danger, until finally Izuku stopped outside the door to his floor.

“This it?” Kirishima asked in a hushed voice. Izuku nodded, tightening his fist around his knife, before pushing the heavy door back. *Fuck* , it even creaked the same way it had aways done, a sound way too damn loud and internally he found himself cursing the landlord that always had an excuse as to why he hadn’t fixed it yet. Frozen, the three of them stood in the doorway, hearts thudding, waiting for the sound of dozens of feet thundering in their direction, but the silence stretched out.

“Hey.”

Izuku looked back to see Kaminari holding a small knife out to him.

“Prop it under the door.”

Izuku nodded, sliding the knife into place with some effort, hand hovering for a moment to check that the door wouldn’t swing shut anyway. When satisfied, he jerked his head back to the others, and crept down the corridor towards his door, right at the far end.

He’d done a remarkable job of keeping things together up until now. Keeping a steady head, focusing only on getting into the building without any of them being heard, but his steely resolve buckled when his eyes landed on a single green pot outside the door to his home. His mother, for

whatever reason, had never been good at keeping their house plants alive… Izuku couldn't say he'd done any better a job, and it was a mercy that he had never bothered his mother for a pet when he was younger, but his mum had always been *awful* at it. He remembered the look of mortification on his mothers face when she was presented with a cast-iron-plant the day she left her job at the clothes boutique. And yet, against all odds, this particular plant seemed to be made of much stronger stuff than any of the others; strong enough to survive the Midoriya-curse, certainly. For almost three years that plant had continued it's brave vigil of the front of their home, basking in the light that came from the tall window at the further end of the hallway, defiant as it was boring to look at. And now, two years on, it was just a couple of brown molding twigs sitting in dry soil.

The sob broke from his lips like he was choking, pressing the back of his wrist to his mouth and willing himself not to break down here in the hallway. It was only desperation that compelled him to hurry forward and wrap his hand around the cold brass doorknob. He knew, he already *knew* , that he wouldn't find his mother here.

"Midoriya," Kirishima hissed, placing his hand on his shoulder. "Take it easy, alright?"

Izuku nodded, hardly hearing a word he said, before turning the handle. The door was already unlocked, swinging open with a gentle creek.

It was quiet inside his apartment, lines of light illuminating the pale carpet, the place looking as tidy as it had always done. He crept down the hall, past the closed doors of his room and his mothers, almost entirely forgetting the two men following him as he entered the living room at the far end of the home. It was bright in here, the curtains pulled back, a warmth hitting his cheeks in a way that made him tear up, the urge to whisper *"mum, I'm home"* to the empty apartment blooming in his chest like an ulcer. How many times had he come home to the same sight, that same comforting warmth, the home lit with yellows and greens from the net curtains over the top of each window. Trees swayed outside, casting undulating shadows across the counter tops, somehow making the home feel alive despite the distinct lack of life within.

"I'm sorry, man," Kirishima said.

"Yeh," Izuku murmured, not entirely sure what he was feeling. And then, his eyes fell on the front of the refrigerator, his heart leaping to his throat when he saw the magnet letters his mother had refused to throw out.

IZUKU

He all but ran across the small apartment, swerving past the dining table and ignoring the dig in his hip as he caught one of the chairs. There, pinned to the fridge with the *'U'* was a note. He reached out, hands shaking as he unfolded the neat line of the paper.

- My baby,
I know it must seem awfully crazy, your mum leaving you a note on the fridge like I'm reminding you to pick up the groceries or something, but I don't know how else to reach you. Things are a little hectic out there right now, but I'm sure you've noticed that.
You'll make it home, baby. Call it mother's intuition, maybe, but I know that you'll make it home. You're a smart boy, Izuku, a strong boy, and if anyone can survive this it's you, I am sure that it is. I'm just sorry that I can't be at home waiting for you.
Your professor actually came looking for me, can you believe that? He always thought so highly of

you, I don't mind saying that I think you could be his favourite student, and I suppose you must have told him that you were going to Tokyo because he was worried about me being all on my own. He says that UA is safe, so that's where we're going. When you get here, baby, that's where you need to go too. I'll be there.
Remember that I love you.
Mum -

Izuku felt his knees buckle, and he only just managed to pull out one of the chairs in time, sinking onto the dusty cushions with a disbelieving laugh, looking down at the carefully written note in his hand.

"What is it?"

"It's…" Izuku laughed again, the smile on his face so wide that it almost hurt. "She got out," he managed. "She got out! She's at UA!"

After a quick pit stop, Izuku raiding his kitchen cupboard, and grabbing some supplies he knew might be useful from his room, the three of them walked the short distance back to the boutique. Izuku felt positively giddy, his mother's note still gripped in his hand. At best, he had expected to go home to find an empty apartment, at *worst* there had been the chance of finding a body. But, a *note* ? A note that not only increased the odds that his mother was still alive, but that confirmed UA had, at least, been a safe place at the start, was more than he could have hoped for. Kirishima and Kaminari were in good spirits, too. They took great comfort in the news that UA had been taking people in, and that Izuku happened to be on pretty good terms with one of the faculty.

"We'll get in, no problem!" Kaminari had said after reading the note, pumping the air enthusiastically.

This single note changed so much for them… and as they crossed the dead street to the boutique, Izuku found he couldn't wait to tell Kacchan. He couldn't *wait* to give the man some good news, finally.

Mina and Kacchan, both, were at the door waiting for them when they got back. Mina was fiddling with the sleeve of her new denim jacket, eyeing them nervously at first before her eyes widened in surprise at the upbeat smiles on their faces. Izuku grinned broadly the moment he met Kacchan's uncertain gaze, heart thumping loudly in his chest.

"What?" Kacchan asked, looking at each of them as if he expected one of them to produce Izuku's mother out from beneath their jackets. He raised his lip in an entirely confused manner. "What're you grinning for?"

"My mum, she left this," Izuku said, almost breathless, and holding the note out for Kacchan to take. "I think she's ok! She's really ok!"

"Really?" Mina asked, immediately standing up on her tiptoes so she could read the note over Kacchan's shoulder. Kacchan looked down at the paper with a light scowl on his face, before his eyes darted up to meet Izuku's again. Izuku's heart only continued to hammer when he saw the honest, bright smile, Kacchan cocking his head to the side as he held the note back out to him.

"So, are you Midoriya's all just born lucky bastards?" he asked, tone fond. "You got some kinda

super power where you cheat death over and over?"

Izuku was too happy to disagree, laughing as he took back the note, slipping it into his breast pocket.

"That's not everything," Izuku said, excitedly pulling his backpack around to his front. "We still had a load of batteries, they might still work. Plus, I got these."

Izuku grabbed two red and blue walkie-talkies from out of his pack, grinning widely as he held one out for Kacchan to take. The bright yellow stars across the front, the red and white stripes, were unmistakable. Izuku saw Kacchan's face shift for just a moment, a kind of childish excitement lighting his eyes before it was quickly masked, Kacchan forcing his lips into a smirk.

"Are these All Might themed walkie-talkies?"

Hah! As if Kacchan actually needed to ask, Izuku thought to himself. Kacchan probably had a set of his own.

"You fucking dork."

"Their love language is pretty unique," Kaminari muttered to Kirishima, voice not quite low enough for them to miss. Kacchan, however, chose to ignore him.

"You sure they work?"

"Batteries are dead, but lucky I have plenty more."

"It's a shame we've only got the two walkies," Kirishima said, "but they'll be useful."

"Yeh, we can use them when some of us go to Kacchan's place," Izuku said. "I bet your parents went to UA, too! We're going to find them, Kacchan, I just know it!"

"Sure, nerd," Kacchan replied, his smile fading. That was about the start and end of Kacchan's good mood that night.

Izuku wasn't entirely sure why Kacchan seemed willing to put it off, but when he told them that they would go to his place tomorrow none of them argued, even if Izuku knew they would have had the time to do it. They did get some good news today, however, and so far as Mina was concerned that was reason to celebrate. She gathered the five of them up in the staff room with a pack of cards, surrounded by the vending machine sweets, Kacchan protesting that someone had to keep watch, slinking off to sit beside the window whilst the rest of them played Buta No Shippo. Izuku was worried about Kacchan, but truthfully it had been far too long since he'd felt in this good a mood, and it showed in how effortlessly he beat his friends, hand slapping down on the deck with a delighted laugh. Eventually, it began to get dark, and the group decided to settle in for the night.

"You want me to take over watch?" Kirishima asked Kacchan, stretching his arms up over his head and twisting his spine. Kacchan glanced over, and nodded with a grunt.

"Sure, I'm gonna take one of the buildings further down the street."

Izuku looked up, confused.

“What? Why do you want to do that?”

“Because we can’t see shit from this window alone,” Kacchan replied, not meeting his eyes. “I’m not about to let a bunch of zombies fuck us up the ass.”

“Well, I can come with you if you like, take turns?” Kaminari asked, now watching Kacchan carefully. Kacchan shrugged dismissively.

“Don’t need it,” he said shortly. “We’ve got the walkie-talkies now, I’ll just take one of them.”

Izuku felt as though an icy hand was gripping his throat. He watched as Kacchan reached for Izuku’s backpack, pulling out the walkie-talkies and rummaging around for the spare batteries.

“I don’t think it’s a good idea for us to split up like this, Bakugou,” Kirishima said, uncertainly. Kacchan scoffed, throwing him a glare.

“I’m gonna be three or four buildings down, tops,” he snapped. “I can handle myself out there better than any of you.”

“I’m not really sure that matters,” Kirishima replied, under his breath.

Izuku sat frozen on the ground, the cards he had been collecting forgotten in a pile at his feet, unable to move despite the growing panic in his chest as he watched Kacchan switch on each walkie, speaking through one to test.

I gotta go now.

“I ain’t going far,” Kacchan repeated, clipping one of the walkies to his belt whilst chucking the other to Kirishima. “Hit me up if you see anything. And I mean *anything* .”

Thanks for putting up with my shit.

“Please don’t leave.”

The words came out as barely a whisper, none of them hearing him. Izuku still seemed entirely unable to move, despite how much he was panicking, and Kacchan wasn’t *looking at him* . Still didn’t say a single word to him as he stalked past, ignoring Kaminari’s protests. It wasn’t until the staff room door swung shut that Izuku’s body finally started listening to him, and he scrambled to his feet.

“Kacchan, wait!”

“Midoriya!”

Izuku ignored them, hurrying to the door and chasing Kacchan down the stairs.

“Kacchan!”

Kacchan stopped, not looking back, his heavy exasperated sigh filling the store.

“What now, nerd?”

“What do you think you’re doing?” Izuku hissed, knowing full well how desperate his voice must sound as he stepped out in front of him. Kacchan shot him a frustrated glare.

“I just fucking said, didn’t I?” he snapped. “We can’t see enough from up there.”

“So, why are you going alone?” Izuku pressed. “There are enough of us now you don’t need to do that!”

“Fucking hell, Deku, I’ve got the walkie-talkie!” Kacchan growled, exasperated.

“And I’m just supposed to trust you after the last time you left with just a walkie-talkie?”

Izuku’s words hung between them, the air static with the tension. Kacchan’s harsh face softened, shoulders slumping as he rubbed the back of his neck.

“Deku, it isn’t like that, ok?”

“How am I supposed to know?” Izuku replied. “You’ve been acting weird all day, and now you’re just walking off on your own? What am I supposed to *think* , Kacchan?”

“Maybe I just need some fucking space, Deku!” Kacchan countered, voice stressed from trying to stay quiet. “I can’t…” he growled, shaking his head. “I need space, alright? That’s it.”

“Space,” Izuku repeated.

“Yes.”

Izuku swallowed, looking up into Kacchan’s face, the other resolutely meeting his gaze. But, Izuku knew Kacchan too well by now, well enough to know that he was still hiding something, still not willing to give Izuku the entire truth.

“Kacchan, what’s going on?” he asked. “You can tell me.”

Kacchan’s left eye started to twitch, and he roughly pushed past him. “There’s nothing going *on* . I just need a break from your clingy fucking ass for five fucking minutes, Deku! I’m not a child!”

That *hurt* . Izuku stood dumbly in place, watching as Kacchan stormed across the store, stepping over the broken glass and not looking back once as he stalked down the street, leaving Izuku standing in darkness. Had… *had he really been that clingy?* And the hell did it matter if he *was* , especially given what Kacchan had already put him through. Mingled anger and worry churned in his stomach.

“Midoriya?”

Izuku looked back, seeing Mina standing at the bottom of the stairs, face concerned.

“You ok, sweetie?”

Izuku turned to watch the street for a moment longer, before he sighed.

“Yeh, yeh I’m fine.”

“He’ll be alright,” Mina said. “He used to go out on his own all the time, remember? I think sometimes he just needs a bit of space.”

“Space,” Izuku repeated, with a bitter life. “Right.”

“Come on, let’s head back upstairs.”

Izuku knew there would be no sleep for him that night, and he immediately sat himself in front of the window when he got upstairs. The others looked uncomfortable, none of them really sure what to say to him, but Izuku was too angry to feel bad about it. Every time he thought Kacchan was making some real, honest to fucking god progress, he slipped back into being an asshole. A *stupid* asshole, at that. Eventually, there was a click on the walkie, Kirishima grabbed it as Kacchan’s voice filled the room.

“I’m on top of some restaurant at the end of the road,” Kacchan said, voice crackly over the walkie. *“Over.”*

“On top?” Kaminari yelped, leaning forward so that he could talk into the walkie. “Dude, it’s freezing!”

“It ain’t that fucking cold,” Kacchan snarled back. *“I’ll be in touch again if I see anything. Over and out.”*

Izuku sat there for precisely three more seconds before he angrily got to his feet, shoving his coat back on.

“Whoa, Midoriya, where are you going?”

“To the restaurant,” Izuku replied. “I don’t care if he’s in a bad mood, he’s being an idiot going anywhere on his own.”

“Midoriya, I wouldn’t do that if I were you,” Kirishima said, laughing nervously. “I’m serious, that’s a really bad idea.”

“Why, what’s he gonna do, try and kill me again?” Izuku asked, rolling his eyes. Kaminari sat up.

“Wait, what do you mean *again?* ”

“I’ve grown pretty immune to his bitching,” Izuku said. “If he’s gonna insist on being an idiot, then he’s going to get treated like one.”

“Sweetie, not that I don’t love this side of you and all, but please try not to get into a fight with him,” Mina sighed. “I’m too tired to break it up.”

“Don’t worry, you won’t need to,” Izuku replied. “I’ll let you guys know when I get there.”

“Play nicely, kiddos,” Kaminari called, to which Izuku grunted.

He was completely *over* Kacchan acting this way; his drama queen attitude that only served to get one or both of them into some kind of trouble. So, he wanted some space? Well, tough shit! There were plenty of things that Izuku wanted, but what with it being the fucking *apocalypse* and all he had to accept he wasn’t always going to get what he wanted! Kacchan said he wasn’t a child? Well, then it was about time he started acting like an adult!

Izuku seethed the entire way down the road, knife held in his grip just to be on the safe side. He was familiar with this road, he knew the restaurant that Kacchan was talking about, and he huffed an angry breath when it came into view. The first thing he noted was that he couldn’t make out the shape of anyone on the rooftop, the second thing he realised was that Kacchan had no doubt seen him coming by now, and it was only a matter of time before he heard the man’s dulcet tones calling out to him in outrage. The third thing he noticed was movement at the side of the building, and years of experience immediately had him throwing himself against the side of a car, pressing his body close.

It only took him a moment to figure out that the dark figure standing in the shadow of the restaurant was Kacchan, and not a hungry zombie looking for an opportunity. Izuku’s anger only grew when he saw Kacchan step forward, red eyes visible in the gloom as he looked up and down the road, before swinging his bat over his shoulder and starting to walk down the road.

“I knew it!” Izuku hissed. He looked back the way he had come, the boutique just visible behind the large bank building, before getting to his feet.

Aside from the fact that he was a dirty fucking *liar* , Izuku knew a few facts about Kacchan. And one of those facts was that he was a decidedly private person, despite demanding attention on him at any given moment. Sure, it was *possible* that Kacchan was making a break for it… they’d found their group, after all, and Kacchan probably felt that Izuku was about as safe as he could be. But Izuku felt it was far more likely that, if Kacchan still planned on leaving them, then it would be once they got to UA. No, if Kacchan was heading off on his own, he’d bet any weapon he had on him he was going to his parents’ place. He’d been so hesitant about it from the start, so insistent that they didn’t look for them today…

“Idiot,” Izuku breathed again.

He followed Kacchan from a distance, keeping to the side of buildings, and ducking down behind cars should Kacchan look back. Izuku wasn’t sure whether the fact that Kacchan hadn’t spotted him yet meant that Izuku was just that good, or that Kacchan was distracted, but they made it almost ten minutes of walking before the walkie-talkie at Kacchan’s hip came to life.

“Oi, Bakugou, you there?”

Kacchan stopped dead, immediately wrapping his hand around the walkie to muffle the sound and looking around him. Izuku also looked around them from where he hunkered beside a rusting van, relieved not to see any zombies within earshot. Kacchan unclicked the walkie and held it to his mouth with a sharp hiss.

“Over, moron.”

“Huh?” came the immediate response, Kirishima, Izuku had to guess from what he could hear.

“Say *‘over’* when you’re done,” Kacchan huffed. “Now, what do you want? Over.”

“Oh… ok, well, we were just wondering if Midoriya was there yet or not. Over.”

Kacchan threw his head back, sighing loudly to the heavens.

“God-fucking-damnit.”

“Uh, Bakugou? Over. I said over?”

“Yeh, yeh, he’s here, Shitty Hair,” Kacchan replied shortly. “Over and out.”

Kacchan clipped the walkie back into his belt, the silence drawing out for a moment, before he turned around, glaring vaguely at the location Izuku was still hiding.

“I know you’re there, Deku.”

Izuku hesitated for just a moment longer, before stepping out from behind the van. Kacchan’s eyes narrowed at the sight of him, sucking audibly on his teeth.

“You’re like a fucking leech.”

“I’ll try not to take too much offense to that,” Izuku replied, coldly.

“No, take offence. I meant it as an insult, dummy.”

“What are you doing out here, Kacchan?”

“I’m fairly confident you’ve already figured that out,” Kacchan scoffed.

“I meant *alone* ,” Izuku said. “Come on, you can’t be this stupid!”

Kacchan glared, storming up to Izuku and pressing hard against his chest. “I weighed up the fuckin’ pros and cons, Deku, and decided going on my own was the safest option. If you had just fucking left me to it, I’d have been there and back before anyone had realised a thing!”

“You could have just told me!”

“What, and you wouldn’t have insisted on coming along?”

Izuku bit his tongue.

“Exactly.”

“Well, I’m here now anyway, so you best just suck it up,” Izuku replied waspishly. “And you should probably just accept that you can’t lie to me.”

“You wanna bet?”

“Yes, I do. You’re too easy to read, Kacchan.”

“Fuck off.”

“Let’s just get on with it,” Izuku said. “We’re close to your place, right?”

Kacchan glowered at him, face contorted in indignance, the effect almost cute in the right light. Too bad Izuku was too pissed off to be affected by it.

“Fine,” Kacchan growled. “But I’m pissed at you. You ever think maybe there’s a reason I didn’t want anyone around when I did this?”

Izuku glanced back, then, feeling almost bad for just a moment. He knew from experience how difficult this was. Kacchan was a private person, and it was important for him to maintain the facade he’d created around them. He never wanted to appear weak, and despite all that he and Izuku had gone through together, Izuku supposed that sometimes having even him witness that weakness was more than Kacchan could bear.

“I get it,” Izuku replied, quietly. “But it’s dangerous. If it helps, I’ll wait outside.”

For a moment, Kacchan didn’t respond, just glaring at him, before he rolled his eyes.

“Let’s go, then.”

Kacchan’s house wasn’t much farther. The streets were quiet, aside from the odd zombie they saw ahead of them, still curiously heading deeper into the city. At one stage, they heard an all-too-familiar sound, looking down an alley to find two zombies crouching over something on the ground, and they pushed past, both pretending not to have seen. Izuku realised that he had never been to this area before now. He’d known of it, of course, but he’d never had any reason to wander this far when he’d been younger. It was nice; wide streets, pretty houses… it was just about as overgrown as every other part of the city, but the bones remained and Izuku had no doubt that it had been a lovely place to live. Kacchan eventually brought them to a stop outside of a large gated home, three stories high, and easily one of the biggest on the street. Izuku’s jaw dropped to his chest.

“Whooooa, you lived here?!”

“Yeh, quit making a big deal out of it!” Kacchan snapped, slapping him around the back of the head, Izuku muffling his yelp with the collar of his jacket.

“Sorry, it’s just… your family is really rich.”

“Were,” Kacchan corrected. “My parents worked in fashion.”

At that, Izuku paused, thinking back to all the memorable outfits that he’d seen Kacchan in during the time he’d known him.

“I literally would have never guessed,” he said, with a smirk. Kacchan’s nostrils flared.

“Fuck you, I have great fashion sense.”

“Ok, Kacchan.”

With an angry snort, Kacchan tugged at his hair again, before taking a step towards the house.

“Stay here,” he instructed. “I’ll be right back. Whistle if you hear anything.”

Izuku opened his mouth to protest, before letting his jaw fall shut. He knew this wasn’t easy, and whilst it was risky he also didn’t want to push things too far. He nodded, before walking forward to stand beside the tall wall, keeping his eyes on the street.

He wanted to know what was going on in the house, anxiety creeping in just as it ever did the longer that Kacchan was in there, but he hadn’t heard any yelling, banging, anything that might suggest that he was in trouble. Finally, after what felt like an age, he heard the sound of a door opening, and looked back over his shoulder. His heart plummeted.

Kacchan wasn’t meeting his eyes, his hands playing with something around his neck, Izuku catching the sight of two gold bands twinkling in the starlight before they were thrust under the front of Kacchan’s coat. There were no tears, not that Izuku could see, no redness to his eyes, but he could almost feel the pain radiating off of Kacchan’s sloped shoulders.

“Kacchan?” he breathed, hesitant.

Kacchan shook his head, staring resolutely over Izuku’s head.

“A-are you sure? If they’re not in there it doesn’t mean-”

“They were in there,” Kacchan replied shortly, the wobble of his lower lip before he bit down on it the only evidence of the hurt he was feeling. “C’mon, Deku. Let’s get back before they figure out we’re not there.”

Izuku watched him soldier past, his jaw set, eyes staring forward, not a single hint of weakness on his face. At least, to an outsider. Izuku remembered, with a rush of guilt, how certain he had been that they would find Kacchan’s parents. In silence, he followed. It was only when he remembered the zombies they’d seen in the alley that he spoke up, softly suggesting that they take an alternative route. Kacchan didn’t argue.

Their route took them closer to the stadium, and in hindsight, it might well have been better for them to have simply carried on past the zombies enjoying their meal, even if it had come at the risk of Kacchan breaking down and going on a zombie killing spree. They were cautious, eying the high tennis courts to their right as they passed. It was getting a lot colder, and even with the collar of his jacket pulled right up around his face, Izuku was having a tough time holding his teeth back from chattering. There were a lot of taller apartment buildings around this area, Kacchan muttering a low *“stay alert”* to him as they neared the end of the road. Izuku was just starting to think that maybe they ought to have just gone the way they had come in, when a voice spoke out, cold and firm, loud in the frigid night air.

“Hands up. Both of you. Right now.”

Izuku froze, eyes wide, glancing across to Kacchan who spat out a curse.

“Where is he?” Izuku breathed, trying to look at the buildings without moving his head. Kacchan let out another curse when three clicks answered Izuku’s question, directly to their left.

“Gun,” Kacchan murmured, just loud enough for Izuku to hear.

“Hands up. I won’t ask again.”

Kacchan gave a curt nod, dropping his bat to the ground and holding his hands up in the air. Izuku followed suit, curiosity getting the better of him and looking to their left, trying to spot the person holding a gun to them. The buildings were tall, there were several balconies, any of which could hide three or four people each if they needed to. Izuku might have found some comfort in it being just the one, but it wasn’t an awful lot to go on when that one person had a gun and they had knives and a goddamn bat. There was another sound, something like someone taking a deep breath, before Izuku caught sight of movement, a light reflection against one of the sliding doors.

“Izuku?”

Izuku started, fixing his gaze on the balcony, as a figure came into view, previously shielded by a trellis. At first, he wasn’t really sure *what* he was seeing… the person didn’t make much sense to him, a mismatch of colours that, from this distance, made a mess of his silhouette, but then things started to fall into place. Red and white hair, a single blue eye that shone brighter than any of the stars surrounding it, and Izuku’s entire body shook. Fear, shock, disbelief, *pain* , he felt all of it in that moment. His hands dropped to his sides.

“...Shouto?”

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 32: Old Habits Die Hard

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku finally finds out what happened to his friends, and Katsuki's fate grows all the more certain.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pathetic fallacy. Somewhere, in the dark recesses of Izuku's mind, his brain supplied the phrase to him as the first drop of freezing rain hit his cheek. In a moment of agonising silence, the sky opted to provide a soundtrack; the melody becoming faster and lyrical as more rain fell. At any other time, it might have been beautiful. The rain smelled so sweet, drifting in from a place far from where he was, like little sparkles of moonlight Izuku could reach out and catch in his hands if he could move. It *should* have been beautiful. After all, the face looking down at him had always been beautiful… Had been, right up until Izuku watched a zombie tear it away in ribbons, hungrily devouring that lovely thing and Izuku's last hopes with it. And yet, nothing trickled down those porcelain cheeks now besides the rain. No blood, no flesh, just sparkles in the moonlight.

"Shouto?"

His voice came out as little more than a whisper; the rain, light as it may be, still almost drowning him out. It didn't make any sense, and Izuku wondered if perhaps the entire thing was a dream. Maybe he had fallen asleep back at the boutique; maybe he had never followed Kacchan to begin with, his heart and his soul so painfully homesick that it would create this fantasy despite the pain that came with it. But Shouto's face didn't look as he remembered it… that scar covering one of his eyes alone convinced him that *something* about all of this must be real. Had to be.

"How?"

The word rang out sharp like a gunshot, and Izuku flinched. Any softness there had been on Shouto's scarred face was gone in a moment, and instead of warmth, a cold glare looked back at him. It was jarring, and the ache in Izuku's chest was suddenly very real.

"H-how?" Izuku repeated in a croaky voice, too confused to raise his hands back up in surrender as Shouto eyed him like he was an enemy. "What-"

"How!"

Shouto's voice broke, his shout wavering over an emotion that Izuku understood all too well, even through his confusion. With gritted teeth, rain running down his cheeks, Shouto raised the rifle again, aiming it straight at Izuku's heart.

"Hey! Asshole, you better point that fucking gun elsewhere before I personally tear you a new

one!”

Izuku had almost forgotten Kacchan beside him, jumping as he took a bold step forward and stood between Izuku and the gun. Shouto’s eyes darted up, like he too had forgotten that there was someone else present, before slowly aiming for Kacchan’s head instead.

“Wait!” Izuku pushed forward, but froze when Shouto’s mismatched eyes fixed on him once more.

“Tell me how,” Shouto repeated, unsteady. “Tell me *why.* ”

Izuku grew cold at the pain in Shouto’s voice, far colder than even the rain soaking into the ground.

“Shouto,” he said, as calmly as he was able. “I’ll explain, ok? Just put the gun down-”

“We looked for you,” Shouto interrupted, tears now mingling with the rain, eyes screwed up in misery, emphasising the scar covering half his face. “We looked… for *days* all we did was look. We thought you were dead! But you’ve been alive this whole time? Why? Why didn’t you come back?” Shouto grimaced bitterly, shaking his head. “How could you just leave us like that?”

“I didn’t leave you!” Izuku cried, tears cascading down his own face. “I came home, as soon as I could but you- you were already gone.”

“As soon as you *could* ?” Shouto repeated in disbelief. “We needed you!”

“He’s not lying,” Kacchan said, palms extended forward and not letting his gaze leave Shouto for even a moment. “Look, I found him alright? The dumb fuck was injured and cornered by a hoard of zombies and I took him back to my group. We went looking for you as soon as he could walk. Shit, he’d have fucking crawled there if we had let him, so how about you cut him some fucking slack, yeh?”

Shouto glanced back at Kacchan again, seeming to take him in for the first time, eyes darting to the bat on the ground and the bandaging still tied around his head, expression harried and confused.

“We found the walkie talkie, saw the blood,” Shouto said, almost as if to himself, brow furrowed, like thinking back that far was difficult for him. “And all these… the zombies were burned up-”

“I’m sorry,” Izuku sobbed, wiping the rain and tears from his eyes. “I didn’t want to leave you! I never stopped thinking about you, about everyone and I…” Izuku shook his head, each breath painful. “I’m sorry I was too late to s-save you, to stop any of it from happening.”

Shouto looked back at him, still silent, still crying, before finally the rifle dropped to his side with a clap. Not saying a single word, he turned his back and walked into the building, leaving Izuku and Kacchan standing in the downpour. Izuku lasted barely a second before he started forward, stumbling towards the door at the front of the building. Kacchan grabbed at his sleeve, trying to hold him back.

“Deku, wait it might not be safe-”

Izuku yanked his arm free, because now he was panicking; afraid that it really had been a dream, and not sure he could handle losing his friend for a third time. When Shouto stepped out through

the door, all anger gone from his face, Izuku couldn't stop himself from launching at him, arms wrapping around wet shoulders as he buried his face into Shouto's neck, a scent that he had long forgotten filling his senses. He was real… he was cold, his face was scarred, and he was so painfully skinny… but he was *real* .

"Izuku," Shouto croaked into his ear, before he entwined his hands around the small of Izuku's back and held him tight. "I can't… I thought you were dead. I didn't think I would ever see you again."

"I guess that makes two of us," Izuku replied with a sob. "I can't believe it's really you. We went looking for you, we went back to Shinagawa." Izuku pulled back, drying his face with his sleeve so that he could take Shouto in up close. The scar was huge, evidence of a painful looking burn that had left the skin red and raw, and Shouto turned his face slightly, as if obscuring the worst of it from Izuku's gaze.

"Why would you go back?"

"The… people who attacked you, they attacked us too."

Shouto's breath caught in his chest and his eyes widened.

"They passed us on the road, and we overheard them saying that they left you alive, so we went back to look for you. And we found… I thought-" Memories of that day came rushing back to him again, flashes of red, the sound of wet flesh, and his hands tightened into fists around Shouto's jacket. "We tracked you and there was a body a-and there was a zombie eating it and I thought… I thought it was you."

A flash of recognition passed over Shouto's face.

"That was you? You wrapped Honenuki?"

"Honenuki?" The words came as a weak croak, Izuku feeling light headed. It hadn't been Shouto… all this time, it had been someone else. If they had just waited, Shouto would have come back, but they had left Shinagawa and Shouto behind. Izuku had left him *again.*

"We were together for a short while after… everything happened," Shouto explained. "But he got sick, I left to try and find supplies and came back to find the dead zombie and Honenuki wrapped up on the bed."

Izuku had been so *sure* … so certain that Shouto was dead. If only he had just waited, settled his head…

"Thank you," Shouto said suddenly, startling Izuku for a moment. "For taking care of him."

"I-It wasn't me it was Ka-" Izuku's voice caught in his throat, and his blood ran cold. Kacchan had been the one to take care of the body. He had been the one who told him it was Shouto.

"I'm sorry for being so hostile."

Izuku started again, and followed Shouto's gaze over his shoulder. Kacchan was still standing

where he had left him, indifferent to the rain soaking the wool collar of his coat. His expression was guarded and sharp, distrust evident in the way that he glared at Shouto from under heavily furrowed brows. But there was no shock there… no surprise…

"My name's Shouto," Shouto said, walking forward and holding a hand out to him. "Todoroki. I should probably thank you for helping Izuku way back then, as well. And for letting him be a part of your group."

Kacchan looked down at his hand, expression unchanging, before he deliberately thrust both his fists into the pockets of his coat. Shouto blinked back in surprise, hesitantly lowering his hand.

"Bakugou," Kacchan replied coldly. "And you can thank me by watching where you point your fucking gun in future, scar face . "

"Kacchan!"

But Izuku's correction had come far too late, and he watched with dawning horror as Shouto tensed, drawing himself up to his somewhat considerable height and towering over Kacchan in the process.

Izuku had not seen Shouto for many months, and the scar alone was enough to prove that the man had probably been through a *lot* in that time. The quietly sarcastic, but kindly and calming person that Izuku had loved way back then had hardened into a survivor, just as Izuku had. It was a sobering reminder of how hard-fought a resource such as trust had become when Shouto and Kacchan locked in on one another, tense and poised like dogs in a ring. Kacchan recognised the threat, taking Shouto's posturing as the warning it was intended to be; it was so normal a reaction to all of them now that it was only when watching it go down between his two friends that he realised how fucked up things had become. He'd witnessed stand-offs in the earlier days, folk eyeing one another up at a bar, preparing to throw punches if the other guy said the wrong thing, but this was no punch-up at a bar. Kacchan, Izuku *knew* , was willing to kill to protect himself and his own… and Shouto? Izuku could have no clue as to the things that Shouto might have done since he had last seen him, but he had been very comfortable pointing a gun at them.

Whatever they had or could be capable of, it became clear in a matter of seconds that neither man was willing to back down. This ludicrous alpha male display, that Izuku would have been so quick to ridicule once upon a time, had now become all too dangerous, all too real, and Izuku was forced to physically place himself between the two of them. Shouto might have seemed happy to see him once the shock had passed, but Izuku knew better than to shove him, instead pushing Kacchan back to break the tension.

"Stop," Izuku said, forcefully.

Shouto relaxed his shoulders but refused to look away, Kacchan glaring straight back at him.

"Kacchan, you don't have to insult him the first time you meet!"

"Deku, this asshole was pointing a gun at you not two fucking minutes ago," Kacchan snarled in response, hands no longer in his pockets but braced at his sides.

"Only because he didn't know who we were!"

“Nah, I’m pretty sure he was still threatening you after that.”

“It was a misunderstanding,” Izuku said, keeping himself between the two of them, sweat beading down his forehead.

“Well, maybe he’ll understand my boot on his throat.”

“The hell is your problem?” Shouto replied. “I was just trying to thank you!”

Kacchan stepped forward with a fresh snarl, but Izuku threw caution to the window and pushed both of them square in the chest.

“Stop!”

Izuku rubbed his face in frustration, the both of them seeming to mercifully listen to him, pausing in their advances towards one another.

“Whatever weird dick measuring competition you’re in, just quit it,” Izuku sighed. “Kacchan, you can’t insult my friends like that! Shouto, don’t let him get to you. He's like this with everyone at first but he’s a good guy.”

“Charming,” Shouto muttered, just as Kacchan spat out a *“fuck you.”* But, both of them stood down, even if they didn’t completely relax, and Izuku allowed himself to brief a small sigh of relief.

“So, is it just the two of you?” Shouto asked, finally returning his attention back to Izuku. “Or are there more of you?”

“Don’t answer that,” Kacchan spat.

“There’s three more of us,” Izuku replied, ignoring him. “They’re at my mum’s old boutique not far from here. Are you here on your own?”

“No,” Shouto said, as Kacchan threw his hands in the air in frustration, and Izuku’s heart skipped a beat. “Hagakure and Yaoyorozu are at the complex near here-” Shouto pointed his thumb over his shoulder. “There were more of us but… well, that’s all there is now.”

Izuku felt like he had been punched in the throat, swallowing over the large lump that suddenly formed there.

“So… Ochako, the others, they’re not..?”

A dark shadow passed over Shouto’s face. “I… I was the only one they left alive.”

What had he been hoping for? That somehow all four of them had managed to escape whatever terrible thing had happened to them in that building, that the blood Izuku had seen splattered across the place had belonged to someone else? Shouto wouldn’t meet Izuku’s eyes, staring hard at something just above his elbow, jaw clenched tight.

“They’re gone,” Shouto said, voice forcibly devoid of emotion. “I will tell you about it, I promise, it’s just... “ Shouto swallowed and Izuku nodded his head.

“Yeh. I get it.”

“So, uh, where have you been all this time?” Shouto asked, an alien brightness to his tone that looked disagreeable even to him.

“You really want to small talk out in the fucking open like this?” Kacchan cut in sourly, and for perhaps the first time that night, Izuku felt inclined to agree with him.

“You’re right,” Shouto said, shouldering his rifle. “As I said, we’re in the complex just by here, the carpark is just over these bushes.”

“Nah.” Kacchan stepped forward, snatching his bat from the ground and hooking it into his belt. “No way. We’re not going anywhere with you.”

“They’re not going to bite,” Shouto replied dryly, with a roll of his eyes.

“Says you, and I don’t fucking trust you,” Kacchan said.

“But I do,” Izuku cut in. “Kacchan, we can trust Shouto. We’re not just going to leave after finding him again!”

“And you’re willing to put the group at risk like this?” Kacchan replied in disbelief. “Deku, I don’t care how much *you* trust him, I don’t. Not after he had a gun aimed at our fucking heads. We don’t know anything about these people and now, thanks to your big fucking mouth, this asshole knows exactly where to find us!”

“That’s not strictly true,” Shouto said. “I don’t know where Izuku’s mum used to work.”

“Well, it won’t be that hard to fucking figure out!” Kacchan fired back, before he grabbed the hood of Izuku’s coat and tugged him backwards. “Whatever, we’re not arguing about this, shitty nerd. Let’s fucking go.”

There was a clatter, and before Izuku could do so much as protest Kacchan’s manhandling, Shouto had raised his gun again. The tip was barely two inches from the centre of Kacchan’s forehead and he froze. Izuku could only watch with wide eyes as the expression on Shouto’s face eased from downright murderous to shocked, lowering his gun immediately, the weapon swinging from his shoulder, as he held his hands out.

“I’m sorry,” he said quickly. “I just… Look, I’m kinda jumpy. A lot has happened, and I know you have little reason to trust me.” Shouto swallowed, speaking directly to Kacchan now. “But I would never do anything to put Izuku in danger. You have to believe that.”

There was a strange expression on Kacchan’s face, a kind of resignation, almost *relief* that Izuku couldn’t make any sense of, before it was quickly masked by another sharp scowl.

“We’re going back to our people,” Kacchan said firmly. “If the *whole* group decides it’s in our best interests, then we’ll be back here at first light. If you’re not here to meet us, or if I find that gun in

my face one more fucking time, we're out of here. I don't give a fuck who are. You understand me, half and half?"

"I understand."

"Wait," Izuku said quickly, looking between Kacchan and Shouto. "No, we're not leaving him behind again-"

"Deku, the whole group deserves a decision in this," Kacchan said.

"He's right," Shouto sighed. "I should talk to my people first."

"But-"

"I'll see you again," Shouto insisted. "First light, ok? I'll be here."

"O-ok. Ok, I'm coming back. I promise, I'm not leaving you."

"C'mon, Deku," Kacchan grunted, tugging on Izuku's hood once more and pulling him away. For a moment, Izuku couldn't take his eyes away from Shouto, afraid that the instant he did the man would disappear and he would never see him again… But, despite how frantic and panicked he felt, he knew they were both right. It wasn't just about him and Shouto… With a last firm nod, mouthing *'I'll be here'* , Izuku turned around, batting Kacchan's hand away as they started to head back to the boutique.

Besides… there were some things that he and Kacchan needed to talk about.

Neither of them said anything for the first few minutes. The shock of seeing Shouto was starting to fade, and left behind was a searing anger that Izuku was doing all he could to keep a lid on. He tried to remind himself that Kacchan had just found out that both of his parents were gone, and that he was already dealing with enough of his own hardships that explained his hostility towards Shouto.Yet none of that explained why he had told Izuku that Shouto was dead all those months ago. The body had been mangled, and Izuku wasn't naive enough to have expected an accurate identification from Kacchan, especially considering he had never met Shouto. But, if he hadn't been sure then why hadn't he said so? Why? Could Kacchan have really lied to him?

He lied to you tonight.

Izuku slowed to a halt. This wasn't the best place to have this conversation; out here, on an unknown street in the dark, in the middle of a zombie infested city. But, they couldn't talk about it when they were back with their friends, and Izuku had to know. He *needed* to know.

"Deku-"

"Why did you lie to me?"

Kacchan stood rigid, before he raised a hand to brush it through his short, choppy hair.

"Shit…"

“Shit isn’t an answer, Kacchan.”

“I didn’t lie to you,” Kacchan replied, turning to look back at him.

“And I’m supposed to just believe that?” Izuku said, fiddling with the hem of his coat just so he had something to do with his hands. “Kacchan, I have lost count of the number of times that you’ve lied to me!”

“I’ve only ever lied to protect you!” Kacchan shot back.

“That doesn’t make it ok!” Izuku knew they were being too loud, but now that he had started he realised that he couldn’t stop. “You made decisions *for me* , over and over again. Shouto was *my* friend, you had no right!”

“I didn’t lie to you about that!” Kacchan yelled.

“Oh yeh? Then how come we just saw him?”

“I thought it was him,” Kacchan replied, throwing his hands in the air. “You told me his hair was half white, and half red, that’s all I had to go on! This poor fuck definitely had white hair on the half of his fucking scalp that hadn’t been eaten yet, and the rest of him was covered in so much blood I couldn’t tell for sure. But it *looked* red.”

“It ‘ *looked red’* ?” Izuku repeated, voice shaking in disbelief. “You guessed it was him? You fucking *guessed* about something as important as that!”

“I don’t remember you looking at the guy!”

“You know that I couldn’t! You should have just said you weren’t sure-”

“I was pretty fucking sure, Deku,” Kacchan spat. “We knew we were following his fucking trail, so why would I assume that the body belonged to anyone else? Why the fuck would I deliberately *lie* to you about this?”

“Because you didn’t want to go back there to begin with!” Izuku exclaimed, exasperated. “You just wanted to go. You saw your opportunity and you took it!”

Kacchan’s nostrils flared.

“Fuck you, Deku.”

“No, not *fuck me-”*

“Yes, fuck you. Fuck you fucking hard. How long have you fucking known me now, hah? You think I’m the kind of person to manipulate a situation like that? If I didn’t want to be there, if I didn’t want to *help you,* then I would have just kept walking to Shizuoka without you.”

“Then you did it because you were jealous,” Izuku snapped. “You didn’t want the competition!”

“Oh, don’t flatter yourself, Deku!”

“Really? You’d already tried to kiss me. You kept referring to Shouto as my boyfriend with this bitter look on your face.”

“Mother *fucker* .” Kacchan stomped forward, standing over Deku. “I am *not* the kind of fucking person who is going to lie about something like this just to get a piece of ass! And fuck you for thinking so!”

“What else am I supposed to think, Kacchan? You told me he was dead, when he wasn’t. You could have told me that you weren’t sure, and we could have kept looking for him! But you didn’t want that. You didn’t want to keep looking, and you didn’t want the fucking competition. Or hell, maybe it’s just because you hate people and didn’t want another extra hanging around.”

“Yeh, maybe you’re right,” Kacchan growled, stepping back and throwing his hands in the air “Maybe your elite powers of fucking deduction, and intimate knowledge of everything that goes through my head discovered the truth!”

There was a noise from one of the side streets, and Izuku looked back to see a zombie had started to shuffle into view, dragging itself along on its stumps, bone and rotten flesh dragging behind it.

“That’s right,” Kacchan continued, indifferent to its approach, placing a hand on his chest and bowing dramatically. “Bakugou Katsuki, a right piece of shit ain’t he? He lied to you about the man you were obviously in love with being dead because he wanted you to fuck him. He decided to leave an injured person behind in a city full of zombies just because he didn’t fancy having to make conversation! That sound about right, Deku? *Hah?* That seem like the kind of man I am?”

There was the heavy sound of something being knocked over, before a fresher zombie stumbled onto the street, hands and feet scrabbling as it raced towards them. Kacchan let out a frustrated yell, unhooking his bat and striding to meet it.

“We’re trying to have a fucking conversation!”

“Kacchan, calm down!”

Kacchan swung, smashing the zombies’ face in with expert precision.

“Calm down?” he countered, swinging the bat and spraying blood on the concrete. “You wanted to talk about it, Deku. You wanted to do it, right here, so let’s talk!”

“This isn’t talking! And all your yelling has just attracted a bunch of zombies!”

“You were yelling too!”

There were more zombies now, three more hurrying down the street towards them, sightless eyes and breathless mouths wide, limbs flailing. Kacchan advanced all too eagerly, eyes flashing with rage as he twirled the bat in his hands.

“Why do you have to go over the top about everything?” Izuku cried, frustrated tears now falling down his cheeks. “Why can’t you just admit you made a mistake?”

“I never said that I didn’t, Deku!” Kacchan replied, grunting as he swung again and again. “I just told you that I didn’t fucking *lie* to you!”

“You told me Shouto was dead! You told me it was him when you didn’t even know, *you didn’t know!* ” Izuku was panting now, hands shaking. “We left my friend behind in that fucking city based on what you told me.”

“Fine!”

Kacchan brought his bat down one final time, crushing a zombie’s head with a sickening crunch, viscera spilling over the concrete.

“I’m sorry! That’s what you want to hear, right?” The bat hung heavily in his hand, and he glared down at the blood staining his boots. “I’m sorry. I fucked up. I thought it was him, why else do you think I wrapped up the body? You ever seen me doing that for any other poor dead fuck we find on the road, huh?”

“I-” Izuku shook his head, heart feeling heavy in his chest. “Kacchan, I don’t think sorry is going to cut it this time.”

“Then what do you want? What do you fucking want from me, Deku?”

“I don’t know!” Izuku yelled back, grabbing his hair in frustration. “I don’t know what I want! I don’t know what can make this better! I don’t know if anything *can* -”

“So after everything we’ve been through, that’s it?” Kacchan shot back, looking back at Izuku again. His hands were visibly shaking, even from this distance, sweat dripping down his forehead despite the frost in the air. “Over an honest fucking *mistake* .”

“Kacchan, it’s not just about that-”

“No?” Kacchan scoffed, shaking his head. “Nah, you’re right. This isn’t just about me, it’s about *him.* ”

Izuku stiffened.

“What are you talking about?”

“I get it,” Kacchan continued, swinging his bat over his shoulder and glaring contemptuously at the zombie still dragging itself slowly over to them on what was left of its limbs. “He was the one that came first. The only reason there’s anything between you and me is because you thought he was dead, right?”

“Kacchan, that’s not what happened!”

“Of course it is! You know how many times you called for him when you were out of it with that fever? You were in love with this fucking guy and now he’s back.”

“I wasn’t-” Izuku paused, both hands pushing back the hair that had been tugged loose from his bun. Sure, there had always been *something* between Shouto and himself, something unspoken that neither of them were brave enough, or *stupid enough* to do anything about. But he was never… he hadn’t been… “Kacchan, I wasn’t in love with him.”

“Now who’s lying, hah?”

“No, listen to me! I wasn’t in love with Shouto! Sure, there could have been something, and maybe if the Apocalypse hadn’t happened there would have been. I loved him, but I didn’t walk back into that city to find him because I was *in love* with him.”

“Well, maybe you should give it a try. Being fucking *in love* with the pale freak.”

Izuku blinked. “Wh-what?”

“We both know this is a dead end relationship, Deku,” Kacchan countered, jabbing his thumb at his chest. “Pun definitely fucking intended.”

"That’s not what I was trying to say!”

“We know that I can’t keep going on like this forever. And now your ex- *whatever* is back on the scene, just in time to pick up all the broken fucking pieces.”

“What are you talking about?”

“It makes sense, don’t it? I can’t fuck you. I can’t kiss you,” Kacchan’s voice trembled, before he shook his head. “But *he* can. And given he was about ready to blow my head off for grabbing you back there, I’d say he’d be more than capable of protecting your clumsy ass.”

Izuku gaped back at him, speechless, before the anger began to rise again.

“Are you fucking kidding me?!”

Kacchan had the decency to at least look taken back by Izuku’s outburst, his shout echoing across the street.

“So this is just *another* excuse for you to leave?! I can’t believe you right now!”

“Hey, you were the one who said you didn’t think an apology was going to fucking cut it!”

“That doesn’t mean I want you to leave!”

There were more bangs, more clattering, and Izuku dragged his incredulous gaze away from Kacchan to see five zombies racing towards them. Kacchan let out a frustrated snarl, teeth bared as he threw his head back.

“Oh, fuck *off* !”

The zombies stopped in their tracks, two of them tripping over themselves and coming to a halt on the ground in a grizzly heap, and for a moment Izuku could only sigh in relief before the reality of what had just happened sunk in. Silence fell, suffocating and terrifying.

“Kacchan?”

Kacchan stood frozen to the spot, his eyes wide, panting heavily as he stared at the zombies that had stopped not twenty feet from them.

“Izuku?” Kacchan whispered, his voice small, looking and sounding more afraid than Izuku had ever seen him, and just like that the spell was broken. The zombies fell forward, clawing at the ground, jaws snapping and teeth clicking, as they continued their pursuit with renewed vigour, all five of them focused entirely on Kacchan. But despite Izuku calling for him, Kacchan didn’t move. He ran ahead, snatching the bat from Kacchan’s limp hand.

Taking out the five zombies on his own felt easy. It felt easier than it had done for a very long time, a spiteful vengeance rising in Izuku’s chest as each zombie dared to ignore him, and within seconds all five of them lay a battered mess on the ground. Kacchan hadn’t stepped forward to help, and Izuku looked back at him, the situation with Shouto suddenly entirely forgotten.

“Kacchan? Hey, snap out of it, can you hear me?”

Kacchan blinked, dazed eyes barely able to focus on Izuku.

“I…” Kacchan shook his head, grabbing his left temple. “I don’t…”

“It’s ok,” Izuku said firmly, reaching forward and placing his hands on Kacchan’s forearm. Kacchan quickly pulled away from him, his trembling hands reaching for the zip of his own coat, and grabbing at the multiple layers of clothing to lift them up past his midriff. Izuku’s eyes snapped to the bite scar on Kacchan’s side, but it looked no different from what it had done the previous week. If anything, Izuku could say that the scar itself seemed smaller than he remembered.

“What the fuck?” Kacchan croaked. “ *What the fuck?* ”

“Kacchan, calm down, ok? We don’t know what this means.”

“We know exactly what it means, Deku!”

“The scar isn’t worse. Just… take a minute. Don’t do anything rash.”

They both knew that Izuku meant running. Izuku could sense it, could see the tension across Kacchan’s body, tightly coiled, desperate to escape, and Izuku did the only thing he could think of; his hands wrapped tightly around Kacchan’s shoulders, tugging him down.

“Don’t leave.”

Kacchan shuddered beneath him, his jumper dropping down, feebly holding him.

“I need to lie down.”

“Ok.” Izuku stepped back, taking a deep shaky breath. “We’ll talk about it all later. Let’s just get back.”

A dragging sound caught Izuku’s attention, and he looked down to see the legless zombie he had entirely forgotten about, reaching its hand out, fingers falling just inches short of Kacchan’s leg.

“I’ll get it,” Izuku said, but Kacchan shook his head.

“Nah,” he said, voice weak. “Leave it.”

The look of complete shock on Kaminari’s face might have been funny at any other time; his jaw hanging down to his chest as he took in the bloodied, messy appearance of the two of them once they returned to the boutique.

“Dudes, what happened?” Kaminari managed.

“We, uh, ran into a bit of trouble,” Izuku replied with a weak laugh. Kacchan said nothing, still staring down at his feet.

“Yeh, no shit!” Kaminari pinched his nose shut. “How many zombie guts do you got on you?”

“There were a few of them,” Izuku said, hoping that someone would have a change of clothes for the both of them. “Actually, we ran into a little more than just some zombies.”

The change in Kaminari’s demeanour was immediate, eyes sharpening and hardening.

“Who?”

“I’ll explain,” Izuku said. “But we should probably wake up the others first.”

Kaminari nodded, gaze lingering with some concern over Kacchan’s quiet figure, before leading them back up the stairs.

“Hey,” Kaminari called softly. “Wake up, lovebirds.”

Kirishima groaned from his sleeping bag, arms still wrapped tightly around Mina’s waist before the two of them stirred.

“What’s up?” Mina asked, voice still heavy with sleep.

“Midoriya says he’s got to talk to us about something.”

Mina seemed to notice the blood on Izuku’s clothes then, and she sat up suddenly, jolting a startled *‘oof’* from Kirishima.

“What happened? Are you both ok?”

“We’re fine,” Izuku assured her. “It’s just zombie blood.”

“We gotta move?” Kirishima muttered, yawning, his long hair hanging around his face.

“Maybe,” Izuku admitted. “But not just yet.” He looked at Kacchan, who still stood silently beside him. “You want me to explain?”

“Yeh,” Kacchan grunted. “You do it. I’m gonna lie down.”

Kacchan shuffled past him, ignoring them as he pulled off his coat, and kicked off his ruined jeans. Entirely indifferent to the fact that he was wearing just boxers and his over-sized jumper as he snatched Izuku's sleeping bag and dragged it to the opposite side of the room. Izuku realised that Kacchan's stuff must still be at the restaurant.

"Did the zombies get into the restaurant?" Kaminari asked, chewing on his lip in concern as he watched Kacchan lie down and roll over with his back to them, pulling the blanket over his head.

"No, we bumped into them on the road on our way back."

"On your way back from where?" Mina asked, just as Kirishima exclaimed, "What were you doing on the road!"

"Oh, right." Izuku's stomach lurched when he remembered why they had been out there in the first place, feeling guilty all over again. "Uh…" he looked over at Kacchan again, but the man was offering him nothing, just an indistinguishable, sad lump under Izuku's ugly orange sleeping bag. "We went to Kacchan's house."

Kirishima looked for all the world like he was about to yell at him, indignation on his otherwise friendly features before he froze and he too looked in Kacchan's direction.

"Oh," he breathed, understanding dawning on him.

Izuku silently berated himself for forgetting all too quickly that Kacchan had lost his parents tonight, with everything else that had happened after.

"We bumped into someone on our way back," Izuku continued, knowing that Kacchan wouldn't want any of them to dwell on the issue, or show him any pity, if he was still listening. "That's what I need to talk to you about."

"It wasn't *them* , was it?" Kaminari asked.

"No, actually it was someone from my old group. You remember I told you about my friend Shouto, who we went back to Shinagawa for?"

Mina gasped.

"No way!" Kaminari gawped. "Man, that's crazy!"

"Wait, wait," Kirishima said quickly. "Isn't this *good* news?"

Izuku glanced at the body in the bag again, before he nodded. "Yeh, potentially it is."

"Potentially?"

"He's with other people, two of them, and I think he'd like to combine our two groups."

The other three all exchanged looks, surprised and curious.

“We agreed to meet at the same place he found us,” Izuku continued, in somewhat of a rush. “At first light. If we want to.”

“Well, it has been a long time since we met anyone new who wasn’t trying to kill us,” Mina reasoned. “And if one of them is a friend of Midoriya’s, then perhaps we can trust them.”

“But we don’t know the other two,” Kaminari reasoned, throwing Izuku an apologetic look. “We got to at least consider the possibility that it could be a trap.”

“It isn’t,” Izuku said quickly. “I trust Shouto.”

“And what does our esteemed leader think about it?” Kaminari asked, voice lowering as they all nervously looked to the far side of the room.

“He-” Izuku paused. *Well, maybe you should give it a try. Being fucking in love with the pale freak.* “He’s on board. It was Kacchan’s idea to go back in the morning.”

Kaminari didn’t look entirely convinced, but he nodded regardless.

“Alright, hey if Midoriya trusts this guy then I think we should give it a shot.”

“It will be useful to have more people around,” Mina agreed. “And they might know a bit more about what’s going on around here.”

“There’s one more thing you should know,” Izuku said, his gut twisting. “About Shouto.”

The other three fell silent, watching him.

“His name is Shouto Todoroki,” Izuku said, after taking a deep breath.

Kirisihima and Mina looked confused, but Kaminari immediately got to his feet.

“Wait,” he said quickly. “Wait, wait, why do I know that name?”

“Because he’s Dabi’s brother.”

“What?”

“And you said you *trusted* this guy?” Kaminari shook his head furiously. “No. No way. Not a chance.”

“Hold on a minute,” Kirishima said, waving his hand to try and calm Kaminari down. “Didn’t you say that Dabi and the others killed your group? Doesn’t that mean they tried to kill him too?”

“Yes,” Izuku replied, looking up at Kaminari. “I know it sounds bad, but Shouto is nothing like his brother. Dabi hurt him and left him for dead, and there’s a scar on his face to prove it.”

“We don’t know he left him for *dead* ,” Kaminari countered. “What if he left him alive on purpose? What if they’re working together!”

“They ain’t working together.”

A tired grumble came from the sleeping bag, before Kacchan sat up, glaring at them over his shoulder.

“He’d be with them if they were. Plus,” he added, before flopping onto his back once more, scowling up at the ceiling. “He had no idea who I was when I told him my name. Didn’t even register. If he was working with them he’d have to know who we were.”

Izuku thought back to the way Kacchan had coldly told Shouto his family name, and wondered now if Kacchan had done that on purpose.

“How far from here are they?” Mina asked.

“Not far,” Izuku replied. “It looks like they’re in one of the buildings by the stadium.”

“I dunno,” Kirishima sighed. “I get why Kaminari is worried, but I say we should give this a shot. I mean, the plan is to eventually get into UA, right? We’re going to have to get used to trusting new people sooner or later.”

“I don’t like it,” Kaminari said simply. “But I’ll go with whatever you guys decide, on one condition. If he gives us reason to think he might be a threat, we get out of there.”

Izuku thought back to how quick Shouto had been to aim a gun at Kacchan’s head and bit his lip. Hopefully he would get a chance to talk to Shouto about everything, explain what had happened between his group and Shouto’s brother. He realised that Shouto probably had no idea that Izuku knew about their relationship.

“Ok,” Izuku breathed. “I can agree to that. So, are we in? Are we going to meet them in the morning?”

“We’re in,” Mina said with a nod.

“We’ve probably only got a couple of hours before we need to leave,” Kirishima said, looking out of the window. “Midoriya, you and Bakugou should get some sleep since you probably haven’t had any, we’ll wake you up when it’s time to go.”

Izuku nodded. Kacchan immediately rolled back over and buried himself into the sleeping bag again, and Izuku realised that Kacchan had stolen his only place to sleep.

“You can use my sleeping bag,” Kaminari offered, leaning close to Izuku’s ear so that only he could hear him. Izuku nodded gratefully. Truthfully, he wasn’t sure if there was any chance of getting sleep that night given all the thoughts swirling around his brain, and his eagerness to just get back to Shouto. But, as soon as he lay down and his head hit the floor, exhaustion washed over him, and he was asleep in minutes.

True to his word, Kirishima woke them two hours later, gently nudging Izuku’s shoulder and calling him. Izuku sat up, excitement and apprehension mingling in his stomach as his thoughts immediately turned to Shouto. Seeing him again, meeting the rest of his group… Izuku was desperate for a chance to really talk to him, and ask him what had happened in the time they had

been separated. But, there was always a risk that his group, and Shouto's, wouldn't get along. Izuku didn't know what he would do if he found himself forced to make a choice between Shouto and the others…

At that though, his eyes drifted over to Kacchan, who managed to completely avoid his gaze as he got out of bed and shuffled towards Kirishima's pack to find some spare clothes. Izuku wished he could have an opportunity to speak with Kacchan before they met with the other group. It wasn't just about him and Kacchan now… Whatever had happened out there with the zombies was a development that they *needed* to talk about, and Izuku couldn't help but worry whether it was entirely fair to involve three more people in their mess. Still, it would only be until they got to UA, he reminded himself, at that point they could find Kacchan some help…

The entire group was silent and watchful as they made their way to the stadium, stopping briefly to recover Kacchan's belongings from the restaurant. The rain had stopped, much to Izuku's relief, but his coat and boots were already uncomfortably damp, adding to the chill as they walked down the streets. He made a mental note to find some better footwear, maybe even some warmer clothes. Izuku was frustrated, but not surprised to find that several zombies had congregated around where he and Kacchan had killed a bunch of them last night. It would have been easy enough for them to clear the area; there weren't that many of them, after all. But they decided it would be a much better use of their time to slip past them. Kacchan didn't say a word, taking up the rear of the group just as he had done when they entered the city, his eyes fixed on the road ahead.

When they reached the end of the road that would lead them to where they had found Shouto, Kacchan finally spoke, calling the group to a halt.

"Oi, Kirishima. You still got those binoculars?"

"Sure!"

Izuku watched as Kirishima pulled his pack to his front, and started to rummage through it, throwing brightly coloured sweet wrappers aside before finally pulling the binoculars free.

"Tahdah!"

"Just give 'em here, already!"

Kacchan snatched the yellow binoculars from Kirishima's outstretched hand, scowling as he raised them to his face. Tensely, Izuku stood by, squinting down the road in the low light.

"I see 'em," Kacchan grunted. "That half and half prick, and the two others."

"You already have a nickname for this guy, huh?" Kaminari sniggered.

"How do the others look?" Izuku asked, unable to hold back his curiosity. Kacchan lowered the binoculars, making eye contact with him for the first time all morning.

"Like every other fucking extra we've met. What the fuck were you expecting?"

"I dunno," Izuku sighed, feeling his face heat up in irritation, and throwing Kacchan a glare. "Do you think they look like murderers? Are they carrying blood-stained machetes? Do they have crazed looks in their eyes?"

“Newsflash, that’s how *everyone* looks these days,” Kacchan shot back, before peering through the binoculars again. “I don’t see any weapons, and pretty boy don’t have his gun.”

“Hold on, they have a gun?” Kaminari yelped. “Where did they even get it? That’s super illegal!”

“I’m not sure there’s anyone about to really enforce gun laws anymore, Kaminari,” Kirishima said.

“There are guns about,” Izuku replied, before an unwanted memory came back to him of a man lying in a blood bathtub. “We found one in a house back on the road.”

“And you didn’t take it?” Mina asked in disbelief. Izuku flushed.

“It’s illegal…”

“I think it’s about as safe as it can be,” Kacchan announced, interrupting them, and shoved the binoculars into Kirishima’s hand. “C’mon, let’s get this over with.”

Kacchan took the lead this time and, despite the nerves he was feeling, Izuku let him, following closely at his heel.

Shouto was standing between his two companions, expression quietly keen and relieved when he and Izuku made eye contact again. Izuku couldn’t help but smile, raising a hand in greeting. There were two women standing either side of him, one tall with a high dark ponytail, and other with a choppy brown fringe.

“You came back,” Shouto said, the relief evident in his tone.

“You didn’t bring the gun,” Kacchan ground out. Shouto nodded stiffly.

“I said that I wouldn’t.”

Kacchan grunted, his scowl deepening when Shouto turned his attention back to Izuku.

“These are my friend, Yaoyorozu-” he gestured to his right, and then to his left,”-and Hagakure.”

“It’s so nice to meet you!” Izuku said excitedly, realising then that he was still grinning. “And this is my group. Ka-Bakugou, who you’ve already met. Then this is Kaminari, Kirishima, and Ashido.”

“Everyone calls me Mina,” Mina corrected, with a sunny smile and a wave of her hand.

“Pleased to meet ya!” Hagakure said brightly.

“It’s a pleasure,” Yaoyorozu said, with a slight bow, and Mina clapped her hands together.

“It’s been so long since I’ve been able to talk to another girl!” she said, excited. “The boys are fine and all, but I’ve missed having another girl around.” Hagakure laughed.

“Oh yeh, I get that,” she replied. “Especially with this guy-” she jerked her thumb at Shouto. “He’s so serious all the time, and sure he’s cute and all but sometimes the dark and brooding thing gets old.”

Shouto flushed.

“I don’t brood.”

Izuku laughed. “You do.”

Shouto’s flush deepened into a blush, and Kacchan made an audible gagging noise from Izuku’s right.

“Well,” Mina said, “us girls are gonna be best friends, I can feel it!”

And, just like that, any tension that had been in the air seemed to fizzle out. Izuku knew that Kaminari was still watching Shouto carefully, but with Mina so at ease, already hooking her arms around Hagakure and Yaoyorozu’s shoulders, Izuku felt confident that Kaminari was willing to reserve any judgement. At least for the time being.

“We could go back to our safe house?” Shouto suggested, cocking his head to Izuku. “If you want?”

“Yeh, it’s probably safer to talk there,” Izuku agreed. He hesitated for a moment, looking back at Kacchan. He could see just how uneasy the man still was, but he offered a stiff nod, rolling his shoulders.

“Let’s fucking go, then.”

Shouto nodded and turned on his heel, leading them back down the road to a large hole cut out of a chain link fence and climbing through. The thick bushes either side opened out onto a large empty car park, and ahead stood a white tented building that Izuku had seen many times before from the upper deck of a bus. There was a faint rumble through the ground beneath them, almost undetectable, and Izuku wondered if that meant that there were generators inside.

“Why here?” Kacchan demanded, looking around them, eyes narrowed and scrutinising. “Why pick somewhere that stands out this much?”

“I have to admit, I am surprised that you’d pick the stadium to hide out in,” Izuku agreed.

“It is an odd choice,” Shouto replied, looking back over his shoulder at them. “And I’ll explain a bit more when we’re inside. But, we have been here a while now, and no one has found us. The zombies never really seem to come by any more, either.”

“Uh, any more?” Kaminari asked, nervously.

“As I said, I’ll explain more when we’re inside.”

Kacchan shot Izuku a pointed glare, and Izuku decided to speak up before Kacchan could lay his thoughts down with a bang to the table.

“Why inside?”

Shouto paused, eyes widening a fraction as if he seemed to realise then how suspicious he might have sounded.

“Oh, I just figured… it’d be safer…”

“Zombies don’t come by often,” Yaoyorozu said, her voice authoritative yet gentle. “But, they do

seem to be more active after last night; we spotted a small group headed in the direction you came from just an hour ago. We probably don't want to attract any more attention to ourselves than necessary but having a conversation out in the open."

Izuku managed a stiff nod. A quick glance back at Kacchan's tight expression, and he knew that both of them had a good idea why the zombies had been more active. He wished he had a chance to speak to Kacchan about what happened before coming here…

"That makes sense," Kirishima replied, looking back over his shoulder at the gap through the fence. "We dodged a few of them back up the road, there's definitely plenty about."

"Don't worry," Hagakure said with a bright smile, her round eyes twinkling with clear excitement. "Our place is about as safe as it comes right now. You'll love it!"

Kacchan scoffed, thrusting his hands back into his pockets again.

"Ok, then lead the way," Izuku said.

He stepped into place beside Shouto as the new, larger group walked across the car park, almost entirely devoid of vehicles beside one beat-up looking truck parked over several spaces. The rumble, Izuku noticed, seemed to only grow more noticeable the closer they got to the tented building until Izuku was certain that it wasn't something he had simply imagined.

"Do you have power?" Izuku asked Shouto.

"We have one generator," Shouto replied, nodding his head. "It's one of those old manual things, you know the sort you have to power up by hand? It isn't a lot, but we can cook and heat water."

Izuku was certain that a single mobile generator wasn't enough to create the vibrations he was feeling, and he felt a sense of unease growing. He looked back over his shoulder, Kacchan walking closely behind with a heavy scowl on his face. Their eyes met for a moment, and Kacchan offered a rough tilt of his chin, eyes darting to the ground; he had noticed it too.

"What's that noise?" Izuku asked. "The rumbling through the ground?"

Shouto spared him a quick glance, before focusing on their destination once more.

"Oh, that's pretty normal for around here. You will stop noticing it after a while."

Shouto offered no further explanation, and as much as Izuku wanted to trust the man entirely the unease sitting inside his chest continued to grow.

"Any booby traps?" Kirishima asked.

"No need," Yaoyorozu explained. "Really, we've never been bothered here, not by anyone. And we've been here a while now."

"It could have been *yeears* for all we know," Hagakure sighed. "Each day blends into the next, ya know? Meeting you guys is the most exciting thing to happen to us since Halloween!"

“Uh, what happened at Halloween?” Kaminari asked, sounding apprehensive. Hagakure looked back at him like he had grown an extra head.

“Halloween, of course!”

“...Right.”

Izuku heard Mina doing a very poor job of stifling her giggles from behind him.

“Well, here it is,” Shouto said, reaching out to push open the door to the front of the building.

“Oi, hold up.”

Kacchan pushed past Izuku, unceremoniously shoving Shouto aside before taking his stance in front of the door.

“We got no idea you’re not hiding shit or other people in here,” Kacchan growled, glaring at Shouto. “You didn’t bring the gun, but I still don’t trust you as far as I could throw you, and I could kick your sorry ass halfway across this parking lot if I wanted to.”

“Only halfway?” Shouto shot back immediately, arms folded and brow quirked, the hostility towards Kacchan coming off him in waves.

“Fuck you,” Kacchan snarled.

“Ka-”

“Fuck you, too.” Kacchan interrupted Izuku, not even sparing him a glance. “I’m going in first, and if I decide it’s safe, then the rest of my group can follow. You got that, half and half?”

“You really don’t need to be so angry about it!” Yaoyorozu said.

“It’s alright, Momo.” Shouto offered Kacchan a curt nod. “You can go first if it makes you feel better.”

Kacchan stood his ground a moment longer, eying Shouto carefully, before snorting and unhooking his bat from his belt, his rough hand pressing against the door.

“Wait here,” he said, before pushing it back and stepping inside, the darkness within swallowing him in almost an instant. Izuku swallowed, nervously looking from where Kacchan had disappeared, to Shouto.

“He isn’t going to find anything,” Shouto assured him. “You’re safe here, Izuku. I mean it.”

Izuku felt an unfamiliar warmth at those words… Someone he knew, someone he had trusted with his entire life, stood in front of him, telling him that it was safe with such certainty that Izuku almost couldn’t doubt it. Shouto looked back at him with a softness in his eyes that Izuku hadn’t realised he had missed, and he nodded with a smile. It was at that moment that Kacchan shoved his way back through the door, pausing for a moment as he glanced between Izuku and Shouto, his jaw clenching.

“Seems ok,” he grunted, fixing Shouto with perhaps the most petulant glare Izuku had ever seen on his face, which was saying something.

“I told you it was safe,” Shouto replied with an indifferent shrug.

“It isn’t that we think you were hiding something,” Izuku said hurriedly, before Kacchan could cut in. “It’s just…well, we have a reason to be cautious.”

“I think we all do,” Yaoyorozu offered. “It’s ok, we understand.”

“Come on, we’ll show you around!” Hagakure said, hooking her arm through Mina’s and dragging her forward.

Izuku had a rough idea that this building was used as some sort of créche, but he still wasn’t expecting the explosion of colour that met his eyes almost the moment he stepped into the place. There was a small foyer, decorated in yellows and blues, that opened out into a playzone that he was sure his younger self would have traded any number of toys to get a chance to play in. Climbing nets, several jungle gyms, and crazy slides all surrounded a huge ball pit, filled to the brim with multicoloured plastic balls. There was no question of this being the weirdest hideout he’d even found himself in during the Apocalypse, including the public toilet that he and Kacchan had called home for a number of weeks, but he could see the genius of it…

“I can’t remember the last time I was in a place like this!” Kaminari exclaimed, stepping up beside Izuku, curious despite how tensely he had been eying Shouto since they had gotten here. “Man, I used to love the monkey bars!”

“Told you you would love it!” Hagakure said brightly. “Momo and Todoroki are too big to fit in the slides.”

“You tried?” Izuku asked, turning to Shouto with a laugh. Shouto flushed.

“Well… yeh.”

“It feels weird,” Kirishima said. “Being somewhere so, I dunno, *bright* during the Apocalypse.”

“Why’d you pick it?” Mina asked.

“There isn’t anything here,” Shouto replied. “There’s no food, or weapons, no supplies that you could really make use of. Plus, it’s so close to the stadium, most people won’t come here.”

“Because of the rumbling?” Izuku asked. “Does it have something to do with the stadium?”

Yaoyorozu looked at him curiously. “How long have you been in Shizuoka, exactly?”

“Not long,” Izuku supplied. “We’d been on the outskirts of the city until a couple days ago.”

“Why?” Kaminari blurted, dragging his eyes away from the ballpit.

“Well, that explains why you don’t know about the stadium,” Yaoyorozu replied.

“Alright, enough with this shit!” Kacchan snapped, stalking back towards them. “Stop being so fucking cryptic, won’t ya? What the hell is wrong with the stadium?”

“Dude, chill out,” Kirishima said. “Give them a chance to explain.”

“Actually,” Shouto said, “it might be easier for me to show you.”

The shift in the atmosphere was palpable; a tenseness that Izuku knew had been picked up by everyone in the room.

“No,” Kaminari said firmly. “No way! You got any idea how sus that sounds, man?”

Shouto frowned. “I don’t understand. We haven’t given you any reason not to trust us.”

“Really?” Kaminari scoffed. “I know who you really are. *Todoroki.* ”

Izuku’s heart jumped to his throat, swinging around to face Kaminari. The man’s expression was tight and furious, nostrils flaring.

“Kami-”

“I know who your brother is,” Kaminari continued. “Maybe Midoriya feels like he can trust you, but after everything that sick bastard brother of yours has put us through, I’m not so sure. And we’re not going anywhere with you unless you explain yourself!”

Shouto paled, scar stark on his paper-white skin, and the room fell silent. Mina stepped forward, placing a comforting hand on Kaminari’s tense shoulder, his face red and hands shaking with emotion.

“I-” Shouto’s voice shook, and he turned wide helpless eyes towards Izuku. He heard Kacchan scoff from behind him, and for the first time Izuku felt a rush of anger towards his own group… could they not see how much this was hurting Shouto? Did they not see the scar on his face?

“I’m sorry,” Izuku said. “I didn’t want it to come out like this.”

“The hell you apologising to him for?” Kacchan muttered darkly. “It was his fucking brother.”

“What’s all this about, Todoroki?” Yaoyorozu asked.

“See? He didn’t even tell his own group!” Kaminari exclaimed, pointing at Shouto. “No way are we going to trust him. He’s no different! Hell, he might still be working with them!”

“Cut it out!”

Izuku’s yell cut through the room, stunning Kaminari into silence. Shouto’s shock had started to melt away into anger, his eyes flashing and hands shaking.

“I am *nothing* like him,” he hissed through gritted teeth. “Nothing.”

“I know that,” Izuku said hurriedly, before he took a deep breath, running his hands through his tangled hair. “Ok, maybe it’s best I explain everything now.”

“That’d be super sweet,” Hagakure said, with an awkward giggle. “Because I’m really confused right now.”

“Before they found me, Kacchan, Kaminari, Kirishima, and Mina had a bad experience with your brother, and the group he was with.”

“It wasn’t just us,” Kaminari interrupted, voice shaking. “Jirou was there. Sero too.”

“Yeh,” Izuku sighed. “They… they were there too.”

“Jirou died before Deku joined us,” Kacchan grunted. “Sero was bitten after your scumbag of a brother and his fucking henchmen set a horde of zombies on us.”

“But it isn’t Shouto’s fault!” Izuku protested. “Dabi injured him too, killed *our* friends, he didn’t want any of that to happen!”

“Wait, your *brother* was the one who gave you the scar?” Hagakure asked, eyes wide. “Wh-why didn’t you tell us?”

“I didn’t want to talk about it,” Shouto replied, turning his face so that his scar was partially obscured from them. “It wasn’t something I wanted to keep reliving.”

“You haven’t exactly given *us* any reason to trust you, either,” Yaoyorozu countered, looking at Kaminari. “If you don’t mind me saying, you’ve been pretty rude despite us opening up our space to complete strangers. Todoroki doesn’t have to tell you anything if it makes him uncomfortable.”

“You trust this dude even though his brother is an actual psychopath?” Kaminari exclaimed.

“Ok, ok, let’s just all calm down-” Kirishima started.

“I’ll tell you.”

The knotted rope of dread tangled up inside of Izuku’s chest tightened at Shouto’s words. There was a resigned helplessness to his tone that Izuku didn’t like one bit.

“If you’re not ready-”

“No, Izuku,” Shouto interrupted, looking up at him. “You deserve to know what happened, too.”

Anxiety and anticipation joined the dread, and Izuku could only manage a single nod.

“We were looking for you when we first spotted them,” Shouto explained. “We had to wait until the horde cleared before we could make it down the street. Found the walkie talkie and the blood, and followed your trail right up to an alley where there were all these burned up zombies. There was nothing for us to follow after that, but we hadn’t found… uh, *remains* , so Ochako was certain that you hadn’t been eaten.” Shouto swallowed, his face looking, if possible, paler.

“That was where Kacchan found me,” Izuku supplied softly. “I think I passed out so I don’t really remember a whole lot.”

“Well, we didn’t know if the zombies had been burned before or after we lost you,” Shouto continued. “Ochako thought maybe someone else had gotten to you first, but there were no clues other than what we found in the alley. We looked for two days, before Touya’s group spotted us.”

Izuku felt sick.

“They only found you because you were looking for me!”

“And Ochako was only alive because you drew the zombies away from her,” Shouto said. “You survived. You’re not allowed to blame yourself for surviving.”

He said it with a kind of finality that made Izuku think that he had repeated those words to himself…often.

“I didn’t recognise Touya at the time. His face was all scarred up and he’d dyed his hair, so when I saw them ahead of me on the road I decided it was best if we went back to our hideout. I thought we’d been lucky and they hadn’t spotted us.” He took a deep breath. “But then they ambushed us. They must have known where we were, because almost as soon as we felt like it was safe to leave and go looking again, they surrounded us. The really twisted thing about all this is that I was so *happy* when I realised it was Touya. He had walked away from my family when I was still young.”

A long forgotten memory started to stir in Izuku’s mind… he was sure that, at some point, Shouto had mentioned something about an estranged family member.

“It’s… complicated,” Shouto said, shifting uncomfortably. “But my family were never very happy. I was angry when Touya left, though deep down I knew he had no choice… father always was harder on him.”

Izuku nodded. Shouto had never gone into details about his family life, but he knew that it had been far from healthy.

“I couldn’t believe he was really there… even with all the scars I could still tell that it was him close up, and like an idiot I went right to him.” Shouto shook his head bitterly. “I saw him and I didn’t even think about how dangerous it could be, that the people he was with might not be friendly, or that maybe they had something to do with you going missing-” he nodded his head at Izuku. “I was worried about him. His face and arms were covered in burns, I don’t know how anyone could have survived such a thing.”

“He *shouldn’t* have,” Kacchan growled. “He should’ve been in a hundred filthy fucking pieces.”

Shouto looked up sharply. “You did that?”

“Yeh,” Kacchan replied, staring him dead in the eye. “I did that.”

“ *Why?* ”

There was an urgency to Shouto’s tone, almost as if he was searching for some kind of vindication.

Izuku was surprised to see so little anger on his friend's face, despite Kacchan's admission that he was the one responsible for the terrible burns that Dabi suffered from.

"Because he threatened my group," Kacchan replied simply. "Because he tried to kill me, and because he's a scumbag."

"Right…"

Shouto reached a shaky arm up, pushing his hair back from his face.

"Well, he wasn't so happy to see me. As soon as I asked him if he was ok, what happened to him, he told me he would give me my own scars to match if I didn't cooperate with them. I should have acted then but I… I was so confused. I couldn't understand why he was behaving that way. And then-" Shouto's voice caught in his throat, and he shook his head furiously.

"Iida was the first one to act. One of the people Touya was with said they wanted our supplies, and Iida told them we would work with them if everyone stayed calm but… I don't think they ever planned on letting us live, whether we cooperated or not. Touya grabbed me before I could do anything, and then another man came out of nowhere and he-" Shouto looked back at Izuku, eyes full of anger and pain. "He had a fucking *zombie* . They use them as *weapons,* Izuku. He let this zombie loose and it ran straight for them and… I wasn't strong enough. I couldn't get away from Touya, and the zombie got Tsu. Uraraka tried to help, tried to pull the zombie off but then it dropped Tsu and went for her a-and…"

Izuku stood in stunned, sickened silence, unable to stop his brain from filling in the gaps; the look of pain on Tsu's face as a zombie bit through her throat, Uraraka screaming and crying as she tried to pull it away before the zombie started to bite her arms…

"Iida tried. I've never seen him like that before, so frightened and… angry. He had the zombie's head in his hands then the girl in Touya's group came forward." Shouto rubbed his hands roughly over his face, visibly fighting back his tears. "She stabbed him. In the throat. And I… I couldn't *do* anything! I just stood there and watched them die."

"Shouto…"

"I can't stop thinking about it," Shouto continued, tears leaking down his face now, his entire body shaking. "All of the blood, th-the *sounds* … I-I couldn't even scream, I couldn't *move* … they were dying a-and I couldn't…"

"Hey, Todoroki it's ok," Yaoyorozu said softly, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. "You did everything that you could."

"No," Shouto said, pulling away from her and shaking his head furiously. "No, I should have fought him harder. They shouldn't… they shouldn't have died like that. Izuku, I'm so sorry."

Izuku didn't know *what* to think. He felt sick. He had seen it too many times, had *heard* it too many times; the sound of someone being eaten, of flesh being torn and shredded from bone… And they had been alive when it happened. Alive as the zombie ate them. Bleeding out. Watching it all happen. This was worse than anything Izuku could have imagined.

“Deku?”

Izuku started. Kacchan was at his side again, a hand resting on his forearm.

“H-how did you get away?” Izuku asked unsteadily.

Shouto looked back at him in morose silence for a moment longer, before bowing his head.

“I didn’t… not right away, anyway. T-Touya and the others just laughed as it all happened. He told me that I needed to man up. That if I hadn’t been so weak then none of this would have happened, as if he wasn’t the one responsible for it,” he added with a snarl.

“He’s fucked up in the head,” Kaminari muttered.

“He forced me back to our hideout so that they could take what was left of our supplies,” Shouto continued. “I can’t remember much about what happened then… they beat me, broke my nose… there was blood everywhere. They must have made something to eat, because the kettle was whistling.” Shouto swallowed audibly. “Eventually, they just left. Except Touya. It was just the two of us…”

He shook his head furiously. “I should have done something then. I *wanted* to. But I still couldn’t move, everything hurt, it was like my entire body was frozen and stuck there.”

“He was still your brother,” Yaoyorozu said softly.

“ *No.* That man back then wasn’t *my* brother. I don’t know who that monster was, but it wasn’t him, it wasn’t the Touya I knew.”

Shouto dragged his palm down his face.

“The bastard asked me to join him. After everything that had happened, after killing my friends like that, he just asked. Said I either stayed there and died, or I went with him and survived… I told him I’d *rather* die. I’d rather be eaten than go anywhere with him. That was when he got angry, *really angry.* He grabbed the kettle and threw boiling water over my face.”

Izuku’s breath caught in his throat.

“He left me after that. Said he’d leave the doors open so that my friends would be able to find me, and then he just walked out… I still don’t know why he did it. They can’t have needed our supplies that badly, and if he had taken me then at least it would have made sense, right? But he killed them, he burned me, and then he left me to die and I can’t understand why he would do it. I just sat there, confused and… and frightened, and hurt. Th-then Tsu she-” Shouto choked. “I almost let her get me. I don’t know why I didn’t.”

Izuku shook his head, trying to shift the image of Tsu, bloody and pale and undead, biting down on Shouto’s throat.

“I was alone for a while after that, until I found Honenuki. And then he fell sick, and a zombie got him, and I was alone again. It was weeks before I ran into Yaoyorozu and Hagakure, and they were kind enough to trust me to be part of their group. I… haven’t seen Touya again since.”

A long silence followed Shouto's explanation, though Izuku was sure that the entire room could hear just how loudly his heart was beating. He could feel Kacchan's eyes burning into the side of his face, could sense how tensely Shouto watched him, as if waiting for him to blame him for everything that happened.

"Deku," Kacchan asked after a few moments. "You good?"

No, he was not *good* , but what else could he do? Shouto was the one who had been there, had lived through all that, who carried the pain and the guilt with him every long hard day. Izuku knew what it felt like to blame himself for the deaths of others.

"I'm sorry you had to deal with all of that on your own. That I wasn't there for you, for all of you," Izuku said softly. Shouto's mismatched eyes were full of pain, and he immediately shook his head, almost as if he didn't deserve to hear Izuku's apology.

"It isn't your fault, Izuku," Shouto replied. "I just… I wish I had been able to protect them."

"Hey man," Kirishima said, stepping forward tentatively. "We've all been there… all wished we could have done more, or… or acted faster, you know? But this world is a mess, and you were doing the best you could, yeh? No one is going to blame you for that."

"Kirishima's right," Izuku said firmly. "You're not to blame. It's *Dabi* that's to blame, him and his group. They're the ones who have caused so much pain."

"And they're going to pay for it," Kaminari cut in. "Some day, somehow, they're *going* to get what's coming to them. We'll make sure of that."

Shouto eyed him solemnly.

"Well, do you believe I'm not working with him now?"

Izuku looked over his shoulder at Kaminari, who shifted uncomfortably on the spot, scratching at the back of his head.

"Yeh, I… fuck, yeh, I'm sorry I judged you so quickly, man."

"It's fine," Shouto replied. "I understand why you did. After losing two of your own, I get how hard it is to trust anyone these days, let alone someone who is related to one of the people who hurt you."

"The Apocalypse, huh?" Kirishima said, with an awkward laugh.

"Yeh, well, speaking of which," Kacchan interrupted, still looking at Izuku. "You were going to show us what's causing this rumbling?"

"Right," Shouto said, nodding. "Come with me."

Izuku hesitated for a moment longer, but Kacchan was already pushing forward, close at Shouto's heel as he started to lead them out of the building again. Izuku felt like he had whiplash, mind still

reeling from finding Shouto alive, before learning of the awful things that had happened to him in the time they had been apart… And *Dabi.* Izuku hated him, he hated all of them, and that hatred was growing darker and darker in his chest, a cancer beginning to swell and consume everything else. He was starting to understand that there were people in this world that simply did not deserve to live… And yet, whilst he still had friends who relied on him, who he needed to keep alive, he couldn't let himself be overcome by these thoughts. Perhaps Kaminari was right. Perhaps justice would find Dabi and his group in time.

They followed Shouto across the car park again, this time heading towards the rest of the buildings that made up the stadium. It was still freezing outside, the morning sun finally settled in place, the low angle and the frost-covered ground leaving Izuku squinting through the gleam. His breath puffed up in a fog, the world around them still as only a cold morning in winter could be. The silence did very little to ease him, his mind still racing, and that low deep rumble setting his teeth on edge.

They stopped just outside the main stadium, the structure looming over them.

"We need to go through here to be able to see," Shouto explained. "It should be safe, but stay alert anyway, sometimes stray zombies end up here."

Izuku nodded, reaching for his hunting knife, Kacchan all too eagerly swinging his bat over his shoulder as Yaoyorozu eyed him nervously.

They climbed over turnstalls, careful not to make too much noise, before finding themselves just outside the stands, the track field opening out ahead of them. Izuku had very vague memories of the place, perhaps from sporting events he had been involved in when he had still been very young, but memories from before the Apocalypse were much foggier than they had once been.

"This way," Shouto said, nodding his head towards the stairs that led them to the upper levels of the stands. Frowning in confusion, Izuku hurried after him, staring down at the track trying to spot whatever was responsible for the vibrations. He expected to see a bunch of generators, at the very least, but couldn't understand why that would keep people away…

At the very peak of the stands, they had an incredible view of the stadium below, and if Izuku looked up he could see some of the city sprawling out behind it. The frost sat untouched on virtually every surface, almost like a layer of fine snow, but as beautiful as it was, Izuku didn't know why Shouto had brought them up here.

"I don't get it," Izuku said, still looking at the track. "What're we looking at?"

"Holy fuck."

Izuku swung round at the sound of Kacchan's voice. He stood stock still, bat hanging loosely at his side, staring with wide eyes out over the side of the stadium. Izuku swallowed, standing beside him and following his gaze, before feeling as though he had been dunked in a bucket of ice.

"What the hell?" Kaminari croaked.

The baseball stadium stood not half an acre away from them, its lower walls giving them an unrestricted view of what was inside. Tall metal and wire fences had been put up around the

perimeter of the court, some of the fence visibly buckling in places. The rumble wasn't so obvious from this high up in the stands, but there were other noises now; gross, vile, wet thuds that left Izuku feeling nauseous. And the smell… Now that they stood high, the light breeze shifting in their direction, there was no mistaking the overwhelming stench of rot and decay. No denying the sight of what had to be over a thousand zombies, all corralled in the stadium right at their doorstep.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 33: Blood, Sweat and Fears I

Chapter Summary

- Blood, Sweat and Fears Part 1 of 4 -

In which the group make a plan.

Chapter Notes

CW: Mentions of suicide and self harm.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Why does my heart go on beating?

The strangeness of the Apocalypse had almost lulled Izuku into believing that there wasn't anything really left that could surprise him. Expecting the unexpected was a way of life out here on earth owned by the dead, under a dark looming sky, suffocating in its indifference. And yet, Izuku found himself sitting in numb silence, staring down at scuffed and marked lino, unable to think of much beyond the image of a thousand zombies undulating and swaying like they were part of some macabre dance. With each low, pulsing rumble shuddering its way up his spine came an unwelcome tightening in his chest, edging his anxieties closer and closer to a climax.

This wasn't the first time that Izuku had seen large groups of zombies in one place; he was sure that there had been that many or more in and around the hospital, and none of those had a metal barrier keeping their teeth from his throat. But, despite this, Izuku was far more disturbed by the zombies in the baseball stadium than he had ever been by those infesting the hospital like roaches. It was inconceivable; to think that anyone could be capable of rounding up this many zombies into such a tight space. It was *impossible* , even. Unthinkable. Unless…

Kacchan hadn't said a single word since they had come back to the play area. From the look on his face, Izuku was certain that the man had been thinking the exact same things as him after seeing what waited for them in the stadium. Izuku was willing to be proven wrong. Hell, he'd be fucking *delighted* if anyone could think of another way this could be possible. But, from all that he had learned these last few terrible years, there was only one thing capable of containing a large group of zombies without massive bloodshed. This, in turn, only brought more questions than it did answers; what possible motive would a mutant zombie have for corralling other zombies into a baseball stadium? A stadium that, from what Izuku had been able to make out, was securely gated from the outside, preventing any of the zombies from escaping. All he knew about the mutant zombies was evidence against any of them doing something like this… none of it made any sense.

The newly expanded group were sitting silent, expressions overcast and grey in comparison to the candy-coloured interior of the play area. Kaminari was sitting in the ball pit, buried up to his chest with his arms hooked around the side, and yet even surrounded by his new treasures, he couldn't summon a single smile, his eyes just about as haunted as the rest of them.

"So," Kirishima said, after what felt like an age, cutting into the custard-thick tension surrounding the group. "Overlooking, just for a moment, that we're fifty feet and one fence away from over a hundred hungry zombies, I suppose I ought to ask the obvious question."

Izuku looked up, dragging his hazy eyes from the blue floor. Kirishima hadn't stopped pacing since they had gotten back; walking up and down beside the ball pit, a pink hair tie dangling from his mouth from where he had tried, and failed, to tie his hair back with trembling hands.

"Who put them there?" Kirishima asked. "And *how?* "

"That's two questions," Kaminari mumbled blankly, staring sightlessly at the ground.

"Ok, so two obvious questions." Kirishima finally stopped his pacing, turning to look back at Shouto, Yaoyorozu, and Hagakure.

"Honestly? We don't know for sure," Yaoyorozu replied. "The zombies have been there for… months, maybe even longer than that. They might well have been there since the very beginning for all that we know. Perhaps this is what remains of the city's efforts to contain the virus before things got really bad."

"Someone was obviously trying to do something about all of it," Hagakure said. "Did you guys see all the bridges that have been destroyed, in and out of Shizuoka? I'd bet anything that was done to try and stop more zombies from getting in."

"Are there more places in the city where zombies are contained?" Kacchan asked, speaking for the first time in a half hour.

"There might be," Shouto replied.

"What kind of fucking answer is that?" Kacchan snapped, waspishly. "How long you been here? Don't you think that's something you ought to have fucking looked into?"

"Why would we?" Shouto countered, shrugging his shoulders in a tired manner. "We've been safe here, even with the zombies in the stadium. What difference would it even make to find out?"

"Because if there is that means someone out there is keeping a fucking army of zombies on standby!" Kacchan yelled, exasperated. Izuku paled at that. He hadn't, not for one moment, considered the possibility that the zombies were contained for any reason other than to keep them away from people… If what Kacchan said was correct, then suddenly the thought of mutant zombies putting them there didn't seem quite so strange any more.

"Whoa," Kaminari said, drowned out for a moment by the sound of plastic balls shifting as he leaned forward. "You- you really think that's what's going on?"

"You don't?" Kacchan countered, eyes drifting across the entire group. "Who, in the right fucking

mind, is going to get this many zombies together and not blow the hell out of them? Why go through the trouble?"

"M-maybe they didn't have a way of killing them all?" Kaminari asked.

"But, someone already blew up the bridges," Izuku said, before raising a hand to rub at his aching temple.

"Exactly. Assuming we're talking about the same group of people responsible for this, and the bridges, all they'd need to do is wire up some explosives, take down the stadium, and kill the bastards inside. Nah, those zombies are still alive because someone *wants* them to be."

"That's-" Hagakure shook her head. "Come on, that's crazy!"

"Who could possibly want that?" Yaoyorozu asked, looking alarmed.

"Pretty boy's fucking brother has used zombies against us more than once," Kacchan ground out, jabbing a thumb in Shouto's direction. "And you heard how he did the same with Deku's group."

"Wait, you think *Dabi* is behind this?" Mina gasped.

Kaminari looked intensely between Kacchan and Mina, and Izuku felt that hard, knotted ball of dread in his stomach tighten. He was starting to like that look on Kaminari's face less and less…

"I'm not saying that," Kacchan replied. "But, there's shit going on in this city that we really need to fucking know about. Oi, Ponytail, what's the deal with UA?"

Yaoyorozu looked confused for a moment, before realising that Kacchan was speaking to her.

"Uh… the deal?"

"Yeh namely, why are you *here* , and not *there* ? Ain't that the only reason anyone would be stupid enough to come to this death trap of a city? It's the only fucking reason we're here."

"Actually," Izuku said, looking at Shouto. "I was wondering about that, too."

"Believe me, we tried," Shouto sighed. "But it's impossible to get anywhere near the place."

"Uh, what do you mean?" Kaminari asked, looking nervous again.

Shouto shifted, pulling his long legs underneath him and leaning forward. "UA is surrounded by zombies," he replied. "About as many as in that stadium, if not more. We spent days outside of it, trying to figure out how we were supposed to get in, but the zombies just kept coming."

Izuku's heart dropped.

"We never saw anyone try to leave, either," Shouto continued.

"You're kidding?" Kirishima groaned, sitting down heavily. "After all this?"

“I’m sorry. That’s probably not what you wanted to hear.”

“We don’t even know if there’s anyone in there,” Hagakure said.

“There has to be,” Izuku interrupted. “I went back to my old place to see if my mum was still alive, and she left me a note. She said that my professor had come to find her, to take her back to UA where it was safe! She told me that I had to go there!”

“Izuku, do you even know how long ago that was?” Shouto asked apologetically. “Look, I don’t know a lot about the zombies, but they’re drawn to where people were, as much as where people *are* . If your mum was taken to UA right at the very beginning of all this, then that’s two years ago. She couldn’t have predicted that things would have gone on this long, or that they wouldn’t have been able to stop the zombies building up outside of UA.”

“Who said they wanted to stop them?” Kacchan said.

“What do you mean?” Izuku asked, surprised. Kacchan frowned.

“What do you think I mean?” he replied. “It kept *them* out, didn’t it?” He nodded his head to Shouto and the others. “No one is going to be able to fight their way through thousands of zombies. I know you got this idea that UA is gonna somehow save us, but let’s face it, letting the horde accumulate like this is a real good way to keep everybody else out.”

“Right, but it also keeps *them* in,” Mina reasoned. “It would mean everyone is just… trapped at UA. I know it’s a big campus, but they’d still run out of food eventually.”

“You sure about that?” Kacchan countered. “You don’t think they’re capable of growing their own food there? Makes sense to me that they’re the ones putting zombies in pens, who took out the bridges, and you don’t think they’re also capable of taking care of the zombies outside their front door if they wanted to? I’ve said this shit before. We need to stop assuming that *anyone* at UA is on our side.”

“You’re wrong.”

The words spilled from Izuku’s lips before he could stop them, spat with such force that Kacchan’s jaw dropped in shock. The rest of the room fell silent.

“Excuse me?”

“I said, you’re wrong,” Izuku repeated, breathing hard. “You’ve always had a problem with UA, I get it, but you don’t know anything about the place, or the people there. But *I do* . The professors, my classmates… you think they’re creating this army of zombies? I’m telling you they’re not capable of that. No one there would do that!”

“Deku,” Kacchan said, his voice shaking yet controlled, like it took everything he had left in him to stop from screaming at him. “It’s been *two years* . You have no fucking idea what they could do. Fuck, you don’t even know if that place wasn’t already taken over by somebody else!”

“You don’t know that it was!” Izuku shot back. “But I *know* that Professor Toshinori took my mum there, and he wouldn’t have done that unless it was safe.”

“Fuck,” Kacchan snapped, before taking a deep breath and dragging his hands through short choppy hair. “Deku, I swear the closer we’ve gotten to UA the thicker your fucking skull has gotten. You really want to risk your life, *their* lives-” he gestured to the room with a wide sweep of his palm, “-on the chance that UA is safe?”

“You want to risk their lives on the chance that it isn’t?” Izuku replied. Kacchan paused, jaw clenching and eyes glaring back. “We have to try. We can’t stay here. Say you’re right about the zombies in the stadium, what happens when whatever is keeping them locked in decides to let them out?”

“There are other places in the city,” Shouto said. “It doesn’t have to be UA.”

“But for how long?!” Izuku sighed. “We’ve *never* been safe for long, you know that. Each time we thought we were, we lost someone because of it.”

“Look, I say we give UA a shot,” Kirishima said. Kacchan threw his head back with a dry laugh. “Bakugou, dude, I get what you’re saying, I really do. There’s definitely some fishy stuff going on here and I wanna know what it is. But, we came all this way just to get to UA. We can’t turn back without at least checking it out.”

“Did you all just forget what I said about the place being surrounded?” Shouto asked, raising an eyebrow.

“Oh, oh!”

Kaminari jumped to his feet, spilling balls out across the floor, and making half the group jump.

“W-what if we could take out two stones with one bird?”

“It’s two birds with one stone, sweetie,” Mina said.

“Right, right that.”

“What’re you talking about, dumbass?” Kacchan sighed.

“C’mon, I think I got a really smart idea here!”

“Kaminari!” Izuku pressed.

“Oh, sorry. So, what if we took care of the zombies in the stadium?”

“No way could we fight all of them on our own!” Hagakure squeaked. But, Kacchan stood straight, a slow, feral grin spreading across his lips.

“We wouldn’t have to fight them,” Kaminari continued, voice high with excitement. “If we used explosives, made enough noise, then-”

“Then UA would come to us,” Kacchan finished.

“Dude! Quit stealing my thunder!”

“Ok, two problems with that plan,” Shouto said, getting to his feet. “First of all, we risk bringing more than just UA to us if we make that much noise. And second of all, where are we supposed to get enough explosives to take down an entire stadium?”

“Bakugou’s got you covered on that last point,” Kaminari said, with a grin. “Goddamn madman can make an explosive out of two toothpicks and a stick of gum.”

“What?”

“Shouto does have a point, though,” Izuku said, raising a hand to his lip in thought. “If we could pull it off, and take down the entire stadium, then every zombie with fifty miles of us, if not further, is going to hear it.” He froze, looking up, eyes going wide. “ *Including the zombies outside of UA* ! Kaminari, you really are a genius!”

“I get by.”

“But, how does that help us?” Kirishima asked. “Todoroki said there were even more there than in the stadium.”

“Well, we rig the explosion to go off at a certain time,” Izuku said. “Kacchan, that’s possible, right?”

“Of course it’s fucking possible.”

“We’ll be outside of UA,” Izuku continued. “Set the explosives to go off once we’re in the clear, and when the zombies are drawn away from the campus towards the noise, that’ll be our chance to get in.”

“It sounds risky,” Yaoyorozu sighed. “How far away can you remotely detonate?”

Kacchan shrugged, hands shoved back into his pockets. “If I use the walkie-talkies as the detonator, ‘bout thirty miles. At least. UA will definitely be in range.”

“Wait, you’re being serious,” Shouto said. “You can actually do that?”

“You think they were making it up?” Kacchan snapped. “I’m gonna need the supplies, though. That’s going to be the hard part.”

“Where can you find what you need?” Izuku asked.

“There’s bound to be a demolition contractor in the city,” Kacchan replied. “Someone with a licence to use explosives.”

“Would they just have, like, dynamite laying around?” Kaminari asked.

“Don’t be stupid. You think that’s legal? If a contractor needs to use explosives, they have to apply for the exact quantity they need for each job, it doesn’t just sit around in a warehouse.”

“You’re right, how stupid of me not to know that,” Kaminari muttered.

“Besides, even if we were lucky and they’d got some in the morning of a job before everything fell to shit, it’ll be long gone by now. Probably used to blow up the fucking bridges.”

“So, why are we going to the demolition contractor?” Izuku asked.

“Casing, wires, protective equipment, y’know the kinda shit that that’ll stop me burning holes through my fucking hands.”

“Oh.”

“So what do we do about the actual explosives?” Yaoyorozu asked.

Kacchan started chewing his lower lip, eyes darting sideways to look out of the window, through which the corner of the stadium was just visible.

“That thing’s probably made up of mostly steel and concrete,” he replied. “The peroxide shit I made back in Tokyo ain’t gonna cut it.” He took a deep breath, raising a hand and scratching the back of his head. “I’m gonna need to make nitroglycerin.”

“...And you *know* how to do that?” Shouto asked, looking entirely unconvinced. Kacchan dropped his hand and glared at him.

“You think I’m talking out of my ass, half n’ half? Yeh, I know how to fucking make it! But I can’t do it here. There’s a bunch of chemicals I need, equipment, not to mention nitroglycerin is unstable as fuck, wouldn’t be safe for me to make it where you’re all sleeping.”

“Aww, dude, that’s so sweet,” Kirishima laughed.

“Um, how dangerous is it, exactly?” Izuku asked, wringing his hands nervously.

“You’re joking? It’s *nitroglycerin* .”

“I know, I know, I just… What if something goes wrong when you’re making it? You… you could get hurt or…” Izuku trailed off, and the group looked up at Kacchan.

“I know what I’m doing,” Kacchan replied shortly.

“Have you made it before?” Mina asked. To that, Kacchan bristled.

“...No.”

“Then forget it,” Izuku said sharply, shaking his head. “We’ll think of something else.”

“There is nothing else!” Kacchan yelled. “We can’t get into UA without doing something about the zombies outside, and I sure as shit ain’t leaving those fuckers in the stadium alive.”

“But it’s not worth you dying over!” Izuku protested.

“I am so fucking tired of this *shit* , Deku,” Kacchan snarled, glaring at him. “If survival ain’t worth dying over, then what the fuck else is, hah? I *know* what I’m doing! Just because I ain’t made nitroglycerin before don’t mean I can’t. I studied this shit, I’m *good* at this shit.”

“It isn’t that we don’t believe you, man,” Kirishima said quickly, taking a step forward. “It’s just… It’s a huge risk, y’know? We just like you too much for you to blow up.”

“Blown up, eaten by zombies, starving to death, it’s all the damn same,” Kacchan replied, counting his points off on rough fingers. “It’s a good plan, and none of you are gonna talk me out of it. *So* ,” he put his hands on his hips, “I gotta find somewhere with the chemicals I need, plus a location for me to make the explosives.”

Izuku was forced to sit on his hands, biting the inside of his cheek to stop himself from getting to his feet and slapping Kacchan around the face. *He* was tired of this shit? Izuku was exhausted with the way that every time Kacchan opened his mouth he was guaranteed to give Izuku a damn heart attack. But, he knew that it was hopeless to try and talk Kacchan out of it. The only thing he could do, the only thing he could *ever* do, it felt like, was to go along and try to stop the man getting into too much trouble. He sighed.

“Shizuoka University. It isn’t too far, and they have a science department.”

Kacchan eyed him for a moment, before nodding his head. “Right… yeh, I remember looking at the place before I settled on Tokyo. That could work.”

“But you can’t make the explosives there,” Izuku said.

“Why not?” Kirishima asked.

“Because it’s like two miles away and impossible for us to defend,” Izuku replied. “I get we can’t exactly set up a pharmacy here, but we still need a location close by. Somewhere with good visibility on all sides. We’re going to need at least one person on watch at all times.”

“There’s a little police station nearby,” Kacchan said. “It’s not exactly fucking ideal, but there’ll be bars on the doors so we can lock the place up overnight.”

“Alright… so we do that,” Kirishima said. “We can go get the supplies Bakugou needs first thing tomorrow, yeh?”

“Fine.”

Izuku watched, feeling uneasy as Kacchan walked up to the window, peering out of the stadium with a deep scowl on his face.

“I’m gonna go scout out the area,” Kacchan announced. “Check out that police station. Oi, Half n’ Half, gimme the gun.”

Shouto laughed.

“You are kidding, right?”

“Do I look like I’m fucking joking?”

“Come on, man,” Kirishima sighed, shaking his head at Kacchan.

“Sorry, but I just don’t feel comfortable giving you our only gun,” Shouto said. “The only reason you’re here right now is because Izuku vouched for you, but I still don’t trust you. If you want to take the gun, then I’m coming with you.”

It was Kacchan’s turn to laugh now, a cold sneer on his face as he eyed Shouto up and down. “Forget it, I don’t need the gun that bad.”

“Well, I’m coming with you anyway,” Shouto declared, shrugging.

“ *Hah?* I don’t need your damn help!”

“Is he really always like this?” Yaoyorozu asked Izuku, her voice low. Izuku glanced back at her, scratching the back of his head awkwardly.

“Uh, well not *all* the time…”

“No one should be walking about out there on their own,” Shouto continued, indifferent to the murderous look on Kacchan’s face. Izuku had to admit, Shouto had a unique way of handling the man. “It isn’t safe.”

“As if you’d be any help,” Kacchan spat.

“Then I’ll come,” Izuku offered. He still needed to talk to Kacchan anyway, and if it put an end to the insistent bickering between the two men, for just a moment-

“Fuck no, that’s even worse,” Kacchan said, suddenly refusing to meet Izuku’s eyes. Izuku’s stomach churned. Kacchan was still avoiding him, as if he could pretend nothing had even happened last night. “If you’re coming, you damn bastard, you better not get in my way.”

Izuku watched as Kacchan stormed to the door, not waiting for any of them.

“You’ll get used to it,” Kirishima said, with a bright smile.

“I’d rather not,” Shouto mumbled, before grabbing the gun from one of the bright yellow lockers behind the front desk.

“Please don’t kill each other!” Mina called to Shouto’s retreating back. Izuku found he didn’t really appreciate the humour, feeling decidedly queasy as Shouto raised a hand and disappeared into the carpark after Kacchan. A part of him wanted to run after them, but there was only so much he could do without drawing even more attention to the matter. Plus… Kacchan and Shouto wouldn’t *really* hurt one another. Would they?

Izuku sat down heavily on the edge of the ball pit, staring gloomily at the door.

“Well, whilst they’re gone, I can show you all where we sleep?” Yaoyorozu asked.

“There’s not much to show,” Hagakure said, with a laugh. “We kinda just sleep wherever we fit.”

“Shotgun the ballpit if no one else has claimed it,” Kaminari said, before sitting back down and submerging himself. Kirishima stepped closer, peering down over the side.

“You're not serious. That can’t be comfortable.”

“Plus you’ll just keep waking us up,” Mina added. “You fidget all night long!”

“Sorry, can’t hear you from the pit,” Kaminari replied, voice muffled.

“You guys pick,” Izuku said, getting to his feet again. He was far too agitated to stay here. “I want to go back to the stadium, check how secure the place really is.”

“Are you sure?” Kirishima asked, before he smiled brightly. “I’ll come with you! Mina, you good?”

“I’m sure I can handle picking a place to sleep,” Mina replied, rolling her eyes, as Hagakure laughed again.

Izuku checked the knife in his belt, and the axe at his hip, before starting towards the door, Kirishima in tow. It had become quite a beautiful day; the winter sun hung low in the sky, bouncing up from the still damp tarmac and giving everything around them an ethereal glow. The smell of freshly wet earth was almost enough to overpower the constant reek of decay, and Kirishima had a sunny smile on his face. Izuku, however, didn’t have it in him to appreciate any of it, and he trudged across the carpark towards the exit, where the walls of the athletic stadium stood tall in front of them.

“So,” Kirishima said, after a moment, “do you think it’s weird that this isn’t, y’know, *weird* ?”

Izuku looked back at him.

“What do you mean?”

“Well, finding your friend, and essentially adding three new people to the group just like that. I thought being around new people would make me nervous, but it kinda feels like we already knew them.”

“I already knew Shouto.”

“Well, yeh, I guess that’s true. Maybe if they were *completely* new people it’d be different, but I don’t feel nervous leaving Mina with them.” Kirishima stopped. “Hold on, was that a really stupid thing to do?”

“I think you can still sense who to trust,” Izuku replied. “I mean, I didn’t really feel unsafe around Shindo and his group, and there were a lot more of them.”

“Yeh, but Bakugou knew them.”

Izuku snorted a laugh. “I guess that’s true. There you go then!”

“I still can’t believe he agreed to this, honestly,” Kirishima continued. “Actually, he’s been really chill about it. Before we met you, there’s no chance he would have taken the risk.”

“He knows that Shouto is important to me,” Izuku said, unable to keep the sigh from his tone. Kirishima fell silent, the two of them walking across the decorative paving that led to the furthest part of the complex. From here, the rumbling beneath their feet was impossible to ignore, and any of the calming scents from the morning rain had been fouled by the aroma of so many rotting corpses pressed so closely together. The fact that neither of them were doubled over, chucking their guts up at the smell, was proof enough a person could get used to anything, given long enough.

“You really think they’re secure in there?” Kirishima asked.

“That’s what we’re here to find out,” Izuku replied. “I’m pretty sure I saw one of the front fences starting to bow, from up there on the stadium. I don’t know if there’s any way we could reinforce it, but I’d still like to know what condition it’s in.”

“We need to be careful, getting so close,” Kirishima muttered. “If those things notice we’re here, then that fence is definitely coming down.”

“Yeh,” Izuku replied, stomach churning at the thought. “Come on, quietly.”

It was harder for them to get a good look at the zombies from the ground. On either side of the stadium were entrances, across which thick metal gates had been drawn. Izuku couldn’t remember if they had been here the last time he’d come to a baseball game, and they seemed out of place enough for him to assume that they had been installed here by whoever had managed to contain the zombies. An outer gate created a vacuum of space between themselves and the fences inside, the tall thirty foot backstop towering over them, with a sturdier metal fence about eight foot high erected around its perimeter. Whoever had put the effort into it had done a pretty good job, the main issue was that, if they stepped out in front of the outer fence, there would be nothing to block them from the zombie’s view. It seemed like a huge flaw in the design, so far as Izuku was concerned… unless it had been done on purpose. Izuku and Kirishima both peered around the corner, three eyes scouring each inch of the fence that they could see for signs of damage, trying to ignore the bags of flesh walking their slow unending circle, like a snake trying to eat its own tail.

“There,” Izuku whispered, pointing to the left. “The backstop, it’s almost entirely collapsed.”

Kirishima squinted at where Izuku was pointing, before spotting it. The backstop was erected in panels, and Izuku supposed that if it got wet enough, and if the weight of enough bodies pushed against it, it wouldn’t be too difficult to dislodge one of them.

“Yeh, I see it. But, if anything it’s just going to fall back and land on all of them. It might do us a favour.”

“Maybe,” Izuku replied, “but we’ve seen them climb on top of one another before. If it fell and crushed enough of them, the rest could just pull themselves out.”

“But there’s a thicker fence after that,” Kirishima reasoned. “And even if they get past *that* , they’ve gotta get past these gates here. I don’t think they’re gonna get out of here, not without help.”

Izuku hummed, still looking over the fence. Kirishima was right; it would take a whole lot of bad luck for the backstop, the fence, and the gates to all fail. But there was one thing that Kirishima hadn't considered.

"There's hundreds of them in there," he whispered. He watched as one of the zombies on the outer edge of the group was pushed by a wave of movement from within, its face dragged along the diamond-shaped wire of the fence. The rotting skin on its cheek caught, and the zombie remained entirely indifferent to the ribbon of flesh torn away as it continued to walk, leaving a filthy wet chunk behind it.

"Gross…"

"It doesn't matter how sturdy these gates are," Izuku continued. "If something gets their attention, and they all rush in the same direction, I don't think much could stand up to the combined weight."

"Then…" Kirishima swallowed, pulling back so that he was no longer peering through the gate. "Should we even be here at all?"

"Probably not," Izuku muttered, leaning away to join him. "But that's not what's worrying me."

"It's not?"

"How is Kacchan supposed to install the explosives without a single zombie noticing?"

Kirishima's eyes widened.

"I mean… it's not like I have any experience in this," Izuku said, raising a hand to his lip, brow furrowing. "But if Kacchan just attaches explosives to the outside, then surely most of the zombies in the centre of the stadium will survive it. We'll just be giving them a lot of exits to suddenly pick from."

"But we can't go *in* the stadium," Kirishima said. "That would be suicide!"

Izuku nodded.

"Could we… just chuck some explosives in?" Kirishima asked. "Like, ricochete them off from the top of the athletic stadium so they clear the fence?"

"I guess… maybe? Kacchan said nitroglycerin, right?"

"Yep."

"Which means he's probably making dynamite. But it would still make noise when it lands… if we miss and hit a gate or something, then that could make all the zombies rush in that direction."

"Well, Bakugou's the expert on this stuff," Kirishima said. "Maybe he's already thought of how to get the explosives in there. We'll just have to ask him about it tomorrow."

"Yeh… maybe."

Izuku already had his misgivings about the plan, particularly when it so heavily involved Kacchan dealing with dangerous chemicals. But now that he looked at the practicalities of it, he was feeling less certain of its validity. Even if they did get the explosives made and at the stadium without incident, what if they inadvertently unleash hundreds upon hundreds of zombies on the city? They couldn't be the only survivors here, unknowingly protected by two thin fences…

"Hey, are you ok?"

Izuku glanced over, seeing concern on Kirishima's face. After assessing the stadium, they had started to walk back along the path, Izuku's nostrils so caked in the putrid smell from behind them that he wasn't sure if he'd ever be rid of it.

"I'm fine," Izuku replied, almost without thinking, nodding far too enthusiastically. Kirishima, as simplistic as he might seem at times, was surprisingly shrewd when he wanted to be; Izuku didn't doubt for a moment that he was smart, and empathetic to a fault, and it was hard to get anything past him. If the quietly considering expression on his face was anything to go by, he knew that Izuku wasn't being entirely honest with him.

"You can talk to me, you know?" he said, softly.

Izuku forced a smile. He knew that his friends cared about him, but talking about his feelings was something that Izuku had found harder and harder to do the longer the end of the world dragged on.

"I know," he replied, looking back ahead of them as they started to circle around the complex, making use of their time out here to patrol the borders. "But I'm ok, Kirishima. Honestly."

Kirishima didn't speak for a moment, Izuku fooled into thinking that the man would just let the matter go, until he felt a hand on his shoulder.

"Look, I…" he hesitated, his warm sunny face looking nervous suddenly, like he had no idea how Izuku would react. The expression, the hesitation, stunned Izuku. He wasn't the sort of person that people were afraid to talk to. He had *never* been. Had his time with Kacchan hardened him more than he thought it had? "I mean… I guess I already have an idea of what's bothering you."

Izuku's eyebrows rose, his feet coming to a halt. His heart, as it so often did, started racing a mile a minute; had Kirishima known about what had happened last night? Had he somehow seen the progression of Kacchan's sickness?

"Uh," he said, an unsteady smile still plastered on his lips. "You do?"

Kirishima swallowed, before nodding. "Well, maybe I'm wrong but… you and Bakugou have been acting kinda off since you got back."

The smile dropped from Izuku's face.

"I'm just saying… if you need someone impartial to talk to about Katsuki, who *also* happens to know the guy and his uh… *unique* challenges pretty well, then I'm your man, ok?"

Izuku hesitated, looking back in the direction of the stadium. So, Kirishima didn't know about Kacchan controlling the zombies at least, but perhaps it *would* be good to talk to someone. About

Kacchan, about finding Shouto again. About how worried he was… He took a deep breath.

“How well do you know Kacchan?”

It was Kirishima’s turn to look surprised, as if he really hadn’t expected Izuku to say anything.

“We were best friends in Tokyo,” Kirishima replied. “I mean, we really haven’t had a chance to talk since… you know. Since Sero. But we hung out the most, worked out, spent breaks together, that sort of thing. It took him a while before he opened up about *anything,* though, but he’s told me some stuff. Why d’you ask?”

“It’s just…” Izuku took another deep breath. “Last night, after we found Shouto I said pretty terrible things to him. And, I want to apologise for it but-” Izuku swallowed. “He lies to me. Like, a *lot* . Things have… happened that make me wonder if I can really trust anything that he says to me. It feels like there’s some ulterior motive to everything he does and I don’t know what to do with that. And, if I just apologise, he’s going to think that it was all… ok.”

“Oh.” Kirishima chewed on his lip for a moment, lower jaw jutting forward. “How do you know he’s lying to you? Honestly, I’ve never known Katsuki to lie to people. He’s far too blunt for that.”

“I *know* that he has,” Izuku replied. “He hasn’t told you what happened at the hospital, has he?”

“Other than what you guys already told us, no.”

Izuku never planned to tell anyone what had happened that day, the things that Kacchan had said, or the people that had been hurt, but now he felt like he was standing on the edge of something. He was alone on the cliffside, the waves below beckoning him with soothing whispers, and the words tumbled from his lips.

“Kacchan wanted to be the bait. We needed a way to draw the zombies surrounding the hospital away so that we stood a chance of getting inside, and he offered to be the one to get their attention.”

“That sounds like Bakugou,” Kirishima said.

“Me, Shindo, and some others went to the hospital as *hundreds* of zombies ran after him. H-he said he was safe, over the walkie-talkie, that we should keep going. We killed the mutant zombie, but one of the people with us, Hanzo, died. And I just… all I could think about was Kacchan, if he was ok, if he was safe.”

“Hey, that’s not something you should feel guilty about, man,” Kirishima said. “We’re always going to be thinking of our loved ones more.”

Loved ones…

“But he was important to them,” Izuku replied. “And I just *left* Daisuke there holding him…”

“Why did you leave?”

“Kacchan called. He asked if we’d gotten the zombie, if I was ok and-” he paused, fighting back the wave of anger that rolled over him. “He said he’d been bitten. Said a zombie had got him.”

“What?” Kirishima yelped, eyes wide. “He’s been bitten *again* ?”

“No, that’s the thing. He *lied* about it. He told me that he’d been bitten, and that there was no hope for him, or any way to get out and tha-that I should carry on without him! I followed him, eventually. Took a while to find him, passed out drunk in a village, and no damn bite.”

“That’s…” Kirishima gaped, before swallowing. “I mean, yeh that is pretty messed up to have lied like that. But you have to know why he did it?”

“Oh, I *know* why,” Izuku replied, tone sharper than intended. “I know what that idiot was thinking… He’s scared of turning, of putting me and everyone else in danger and I *get* it. I do! But doesn’t he get how frightened and worried I am? How much I want to find a way to help him? He could have just talked to me!”

“Is that what your fight was about last night?”

Izuku glanced up. He hadn’t told Kirishima that they had fought, though he supposed the energy between Kacchan and himself, the way he had admitted to saying terrible things to him, didn’t take a genius to make sense of.

“Sort of. He lied to me again, this time about going to the restaurant to keep watch. He went to his parents' place on his own and I was so *angry* with him but… damnit, I still understand why he would do it.”

“He’s a private guy,” Kirishima said. “You know that as well as I do. Having all of us there wouldn’t have made the whole thing any easier for him. Honestly, I kind of had a feeling he’d pull something like that.”

“Right…” Izuku sighed. “But, then we found Shouto.”

“Your boyfriend?”

Izuku choked, looking around at Kirishima wildly. “Wh-what? No! Why does everyone keep saying that?”

“Oh! My bad, I just got a uh, vibe.”

“A vibe.”

“Yeh, like… finding the love of your life alive after thinking they were dead for the better part of a year. That kind of vibe.”

“I don’t…” Izuku felt himself panicking. “I don’t give off that vibe! Do I?”

“No, but *he* does,” Kirishima replied, with a knowing tilt of his head. “The guy hasn’t stopped looking at you since we got here.”

Izuku flushed.

“It isn’t like that…”

“Well, whatever it’s like, Katsuki’s definitely noticed it, too,” Kirishima continued, before his eyes widened. “Which isn’t your fault! Not at all! I mean, we all had lives before all this, right? Important people we’ve lost. It must have been awkward as hell when you guys found Shindo, after all.”

“It was… kinda.”

“But, point is, Todoroki is in love with you. And *Katsuki’s* in love with you-”

“Wait-”

“Nope, nah, sorry man but he’s whipped. The problem is, Katsuki’s in stupid love. He’s an idiot. He doesn’t know how to do relationships without being a moron about it anyway, and the whole zombie thing means he’s probably even stupider.”

“But that’s… fuck, that’s what worries me!” Izuku hissed, dragging a hand over his tangled locks. “The body we found back in Shinigawa, the one I thought was Shouto? *Kacchan* was the one who told me that it was him. And, before all this happened, before the hospital, before last night, I *never* would have even considered the possibility that Kacchan knew.”

Kirishima fell silent for a moment, red eyes, so much darker than Kacchan’s, staring back at him.

“You think he knew it wasn’t Todoroki?”

Izuku let out a frustrated growl, pacing up and down in front of him. “I don’t *know* what to think! He says he didn’t, that he really thought it was Todoroki, and I want to believe him but I just… I’m so confused! And I’m only now realising how easy it was, you know? For me to trust him with everything. With my *life* . To trust that he wouldn’t hurt me, after everything, and now I don’t…” His hands flopped to his sides. “I don’t know what he’d do.”

Kirishima chewed at his bottom lip again, brow furrowed in thought and concern. Izuku knew how it must have sounded; he was accusing the man who had sacrificed so much for all of them of letting Izuku believe a person he cared about was dead. That wasn’t just *nothing* . What was worse is Izuku really had no idea whether his accusations were true or not. What was Kacchan capable of?

Of putting them all at risk on a drunken rampage.

Of trying to strangle him to death.

Of lying about a bite.

Of being a zombie.

Izuku scrunched his face up as the dark thoughts filled his brain, taunting him, cruel and vile. How could he think these things of Kacchan? Of the man that had given up so much just to keep Izuku alive. And yet, those things had happened… Those things *could* happen.

“I think you just have to trust that Katsuki won’t do anything unless he really believes it’s for the best,” Kirishima finally replied, his voice soft. “I know it doesn’t justify anything, especially after the stupid mistakes he made at the start. I haven’t forgotten that night either, you know? He’s… capable of things that I’m not sure I am, or ever could be. But, after that night, he changed. And at some point you became really important to him. And Katsuki would do anything to protect what’s important to him.”

“That’s what scares me…” Izuku whispered. “You have to feel it, too. You have to know that he’s going to try and leave us again, when we get to UA.”

Izuku hadn’t allowed himself to think too much about it, but the moment the words left his lips he knew them to be true. Kirishima bowed his head.

“Yeh… Yeh, I figured as much, too.”

“S-so what do we do? I already told you, I can’t trust him to tell me anything straight any more, I can’t trust him not to be planning his next attempt to leave!”

“Maybe… maybe we don’t do anything.”

Izuku felt himself go rigid, his muscles freezing, breath catching in his chest.

“What?”

“Look, I…” Kirishima swallowed, shaking his head and looking nervous again. “I’ve had this… feeling, ever since you guys got back. Like, things aren’t the same as they were before we lost Sero.”

“What do you mean?”

“It was hard, *real* hard, before we got to Mina’s grandma’s place in Shinigawa. You have no idea how difficult it was the first few months after Katsuki was bitten. The dude tried to off himself, like, five times. He was convinced he was still going to turn, that he was going to kill us all in our sleep or something. He demanded that we keep him tied up half the time, just in case.”

Izuku grew pale.

“He tried slashing his wrists, overdosing on painkillers and alcohol… it became a full time job just keeping him alive and… I’ve never seen him like that before.” A haunted look came over Kirishima’s face. “I remember the first time it happened. I’d left him for, like, two minutes to check on the others and I came back to blood everywhere. It took three of us to wrestle the damn glass off him, and he just screamed and cried, begging for us to let him do it.”

Izuku looked back at Kirishima with wide eyes, his heart racing, feeling nauseous.

“Shit… I’ve never really talked about this before,” Kirishima said, voice shaky. “It stopped happening after a while. The drinking never stopped, but he didn’t get stupid drunk often so we just cast a blind eye. It wasn’t healthy, but it was better than begging us to kill him, and eventually he started to take the whole survival thing seriously. We wouldn’t be alive without him, none of us.”

Kirishima heaved a tired sigh, lifting his arms up to wrap around the back of his neck as he looked up at the sky.

“Sero changed shit. He was always so scared that he could hurt us, and he let himself believe for one moment that maybe he really wasn’t infected. Then Sero died and everything he had been so afraid of came true. It just gave him one more reason as to why he needed to get away from us.”

“And now I’ve finally driven him away,” Izuku whispered, throat too raw to manage much more than that. He could feel himself starting to shake, and Kirishima reached forward, placing both his hands on Izuku’s shoulders.

“I’m so scared I can’t fix this,” Izuku breathed.

“Look, it… it’s not on you, Midoriya,” Kirishima said. “Katsuki has made some shit choices, and maybe they were made with the intent to keep his friends alive, but… that doesn’t mean he hasn’t hurt you and those around him. You’re entitled to be upset, and doubt the things he’s said. After all, these days trust is everything… But, Midoriya, it sounds like you’re so caught up in your own plans that you’ve overlooked Katsuki’s feelings too.”

Izuku swallowed. “What do you mean?”

Kirishima sighed again, letting go of Izuku’s shoulders, hands dropping to his sides.

“It ain’t just you. We’ve… we’ve all done it. Me especially. I forced Katsuki to keep living, despite the pain he was in and honestly? I actually hate myself for it. I’m glad Katsuki is still here, but we took the choice away from him. We’re still doing it. And the more time that passes, the harder and harder it’s gotten.”

“Wh-what are you trying to say?”

“I don’t know, man,” Kirishima replied, rubbing his face. “We think we understand, but none of us really know what it must be like knowing that you’re infected, that you could turn at any moment and kill the people you love. I mean,” he laughed bitterly, “sure, we could *all* turn if we get bit. But it’s easy to live in denial that it won’t ever happen to you, you know? Katsuki doesn’t have that luxury. He knows that chances are, one day he’s going to turn into a zombie and who knows how horrible that will be.”

“You’re saying we should let him go?” Izuku breathed, unable to believe his ears. “After everything he’s done for us? With UA so close?”

“I’m saying he deserves the right to make the choice for himself,” Kirishima replied. “In this world as it is, I think we should all be able to choose how we leave it, don’t you?”

Izuku’s brain and heart felt like they had been snatched from his throat and thrown into a blender, reeling from Kirishima’s words. He *wanted* to be angry at him; to yell at the man for even thinking this. But then he remembered that night in the RV. The look on Kacchan’s face upon realising that *he* was the one that turned Sero was the most heart-wrenching thing Izuku had ever seen. His biggest fear had already come true, and he probably would have let Sero kill him then, if it hadn’t been for Izuku. He probably would have given up after that, if Izuku hadn’t needed him to survive. And, when Kacchan finally felt he had found a place where Izuku could be safe and happy… Izuku

had refused to let him leave and dragged him straight back into the struggle.

“I’m not trying to make you feel bad, or responsible,” Kirishima continued. “And I ain’t saying we give up on Katsuki. If anything…” Kirishima took a deep breath. “You guys need to talk, and you need to be honest about how you’re feeling, before you both miss your chance.”

Izuku swallowed, nodding his head slowly. They *did* need to talk. And it wasn’t just Kacchan who needed to be honest; Izuku was still keeping secrets of his own.

“Yeh… yeh, I get what you’re saying,” he replied quietly. Kirishima watched him for a moment longer, before clapping his hands to his hips and forcing a wide smile onto his sunny face.

“C’mon, we should head back. Maybe Bakugou and Todoroki are done checking out the police station.”

Almost as if on cue, the pair of them heard a harsh voice, carried on the breeze. The hostile tones of a man clearly on their last nerve, but trying to stay quiet about it.

“Speak of the devil,” Kirishima said, with a light laugh. The pair of them continued along the path to the carpark, Kacchan and Shouto coming into view ahead of them. Kacchan was unquestionably pissed off; hands curled into fists at his sides, back hunched as he leaned into Shouto’s personal space. Shouto looked exasperated.

“I’m just saying,” came the dulcet tones, “don’t you think it’s up to him?”

Izuku frowned and Kirishima, obviously not wanting to risk overhearing something he didn’t want to, raised his hand and called out to them.

“Hey!”

Kacchan and Shouto came to a halt, looking over their shoulders. Kacchan’s eyes met Izuku’s for a moment, haughty and cold, before the man thrust his hands into his pockets, walking away without a word. Shouto had a strange look on his face, which was quickly masked with polite interest the moment Izuku cast his questioning glance in his direction. It didn’t take a genius to figure out that they had been talking about him… He sighed, following Kirishima who broke into a light jog to try and catch up with Kacchan. He knew talking to him would be much easier said than done.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 34: Blood, Sweat and Fears II

Chapter Summary

- Blood, Sweat and Fears part 2 of 4 -

In which the group Izuku and Kacchan finally talk...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Why do these eyes of mine cry?

As predicted, Kacchan made it impossible for Izuku to find a moment to speak with him that night, keeping busy with the rest of their group, doggedly avoiding any eye contact. Izuku woke the next day, alone, cold and uncomfortable on the lino floor of the indoor playground, the weight of his worries immediately crushing him and preventing any effort he might have made to sit up. He had hardly slept at all that night, brain buzzing with the things that Kirishima had said to him, the implications of what they meant, and what would happen when, *if* , they finally made it to UA. It sure as hell didn't help that Kacchan was making such obvious efforts to distance himself from him; with things as they were, Izuku honestly had no damn clue if it was because he was still mad, or if he was hoping Izuku would get frustrated enough to just walk away. Bitterly, he supposed it could well be both.

He heaved a large sigh, blinking up at the white tarpaulin high above him, only just tinted with orange from another heavy and indifferent sun. It wasn't like things hadn't been painfully difficult for him before now, but it had been a long time since he had felt the pressure of his responsibilities and his losses so badly, and he had to begrudgingly accept that he was not over the trauma of what had happened back at the hospital. Living in a constant state of anxiety was suffocating enough, but the guilt he felt over the deaths of Katsuma and Hanzo, and his fear of losing Kacchan, were the weights around his ankles dragging him down into the murky depths of his grief. It was no longer enough to remind himself that UA was waiting, his mother was waiting, not when the cost of reaching them was more than he could afford to pay.

After several more minutes, he eventually unzipped his sleeping bag and pushed himself up, looking around the room. Shouto was the first one to notice him, offering him a hesitant smile as he came up with two bowls of steaming rice in his hands. Izuku realised with a pang that he hadn't even spent much time with Shouto since he had found out he was still alive, taking advantage of his hospitality and willingness to let Izuku and his friends into his life despite the risks involved.

"I didn't want to wake you," Shouto said, holding one of the bowls out to him, before dropping to his haunches at the foot of Izuku's sleeping bag. "Looked like you had a rough night."

Izuku took the bowl, the warmth of it in his cold hands offering some comfort.

“It’s fine,” he replied. “Just lots to think about is all.”

“Yeh,” Shouto said.

The silence drew out between them, and Izuku scooped out a handful of the rice to give him an excuse to break the uneasy eye contact, nodding his head gratefully as he took a bite.

“It’s good.”

“It’s no soba,” Shouto said with a shrug. “But it’ll do.”

Izuku laughed, the sound surprising the both of them.

“I forgot about that,” he replied, an honest smile on his face. “I still kept an eye out for packets of it, you know? Just… just in case.”

Shouto smiled softly, ducking his face so his long multi-tonal hair covered his eyes.

“Actually, I have something for you.”

“You do?”

Shouto nodded, placing his bowl on the floor before getting to his feet and walking back towards the bright yellow lockers. Izuku watched curiously as he pulled out a backpack, and came back towards him.

“It’s probably really silly now,” Shouto said, clearing his throat awkwardly as he sat back opposite him again and unzipped the pack. He pulled out a cellophane plastic package, the contents of which were covered with brown paper, and handed it to him. Izuku reached out, looking at the neatly wrapped gift, hesitating just a moment before starting to peel back the cellophane.

Inside was an Oreo cookie, no doubt stale, but the sweet scent of it immediately made Izuku’s mouth water. He held it, fingers trembling around the delicate item before he noticed the layer of thick marshmallow pressed between the biscuit, and he gasped.

“It’s a-

“Midoriya Mallow Special,” Shouto finished. “O-Ochako insisted on making one for when we found you.”

“You kept it all this time?”

“Yeh, just… just in case.”

Izuku looked up, meeting Shouto’s achingly familiar, mismatched eyes. The scar covering half his face only partially concealed the obvious blush on his cheeks, and Izuku realised then just how much he had missed the man. He and Shouto had been so close once… And now, the person he had shared all his hopes, dreams and fears with, the man who he thought he might have one day fallen in love with, was within his reach. He hadn’t needed Kirishima to point it out to him; the look in Shouto’s eyes was enough…

“When you done eye fucking each other, you lazy assholes gonna get ready or what?”

Izuku jumped, almost dropping the cookie in his hand. He looked up to see Kacchan standing beside them, glaring petulantly over his crossed arms, eyes dripping with venom as they fixed on Shouto. Any of the good feelings Izuku had gained from the cookie were gone in an instant, that all too familiar feeling of guilt forcing him to quickly wrap the gift back up so that he could jump to his feet.

“We weren’t-”

“Shut up. Get dressed, take a piss, brush your fucking teeth, and get ready if you think you can handle those basic tasks. You’ve wasted enough of my time.”

Kacchan was storming away before Izuku could say a single thing, still not making eye contact with him even once. Izuku bit the inside of his cheek, feeling an unwelcome sting in the corner of his eyes as he watched the man leave.

“You shouldn’t let him talk to you like that,” Shouto said firmly, now getting to his feet. Izuku bristled.

“You don’t know him,” he mumbled.

“I don’t need to,” Shouto replied.

“Look, we’ve been through a lot together,” Izuku found himself snapping, Shouto looking taken aback. “He’s going through some stuff, you wouldn’t understand.”

An uncomfortable silence drew out between them, and Izuku shut his eyes, regretting his outburst. It wasn’t Shouto’s fault that Kacchan was acting this way… and it wasn’t his fault for not understanding the relationship between the two of them, either.

“We’re all going through *some stuff* ,” Shouto finally said, voice gentle but firm. “But he’s the only one here that I see taking it out on you.”

Izuku sighed. “He’s not- it’s more complicated than that.”

“It isn’t an excuse.”

Shouto grabbed his pack, and walked away, leaving Izuku standing beside his bundled up sleeping bag, wondering how things just kept getting messier and messier.

A short while later, Izuku was dressed in his coat and making sure that all his weapons were within easy reach on his body, preparing himself for the day ahead. They had spent some time pouring over the map, Kacchan spotting an industrial estate not too far from Shizuoka University that he was pretty sure housed a construction company. It shouldn’t be a difficult journey for them; the University was only an hour’s walk from the playground, and two of them had a good enough knowledge of the area that getting lost wasn’t a concern. But, the city had been full of plenty of nasty surprises so far that each of them was taking it seriously.

“I’m going to leave the gun here with you,” Shouto said to Yaoyorozu. “We’ve not had any trouble, but there’s always a chance we’ll be gone longer than we expect. I’d feel better if you had it.”

“Hold on,” Hagakure said, pouting from beneath her bangs. “Why are just the guys going? This is totally sexist!”

“It’s not like that,” Kaminari said quickly, sliding a knife into his pocket. “It just could be dangerous, you know?”

“What and we can’t handle d *angerous* because we’re *girls* ?” Hagakure countered. Mina threw Kaminari a shit-eating grin over Hagakure’s shoulder.

“Yeh, Kaminari, what’s all that about?”

“Huh? Wait, no that’s not what I meant!”

“You think girls are too weak, is that it?”

“No! No, that’s not it at all!”

“So, it’s something else then?”

“No! It’s… *Kirishima!* ” Kaminari threw Kirishima a panicked look. Kirishima glanced between him and Mina, before shrugging.

“I’m not getting involved.”

“Hah?!”

“Relax, sugar, I’m messing with you,” Mina replied. “You boys go do your… thing. Someone really needs to go through and catalogue our supplies, we’ve not been especially careful with our food lately.”

“I’m still mad about it!” Hagakure said. “Why do we have to stay behind?”

“You don’t have to,” Shouto replied. “It’s more that Momo is the only other person I trust with the gun.”

“What the hell!”

“Fuck sake, just make your minds up!” Kacchan yelled. “I don’t give a fuck who comes and who stays, but we need people here, and if you come with me and get in the fucking way I’ll turn you into dynamite instead!”

Hagakure pouted. “Rude.”

“We’ll stay here,” Yaoyorozu said. “Just be careful out there.”

“We’ll be ok,” Shouto replied.

“Can we just get on with it?” Kacchan snapped.

They said their goodbyes, Kirishima pressing a quick kiss against Mina’s cheek before the five of them were off. It was another beautiful day, and Kaminari threw his head back, sighing with satisfaction when the winter sun warmed his face.

“Shame it’s so cold, it’d be real nice out if it wasn’t.”

“I like the cold,” Shouto said.

“Of course you do,” Kacchan growled, his breath puffing up around his head as he pulled the woollen collar of his coat up. “Come on, let’s go.”

The quickest route to the University was back past the apartment buildings where they had first found Shouto, down a narrow lane with homes and garages built up on either side, narrowing their vantage point pretty much down to nothing. This, Izuku realised, was one of the worst parts of being back in a city; it was impossible to feel at ease here, not when the shadows between homes and down streets seemed to move as they got closer. Even Kaminari fell silent when they came across a small cemetery among the rows of houses, the tall stone structures eerie in the morning mist.

“What’s that?” Kaminari asked, putting the entire group on alert, as he pointed out a dark mound of charred fabric towards the centre of the cemetery. Izuku felt a shiver run up his spine, remembering all too clearly the mass hysteria that had erupted at the start of the pandemic, the dead piled up and burned, the very few that had been buried rather than cremated dug back up from the ground and added to the stack. Back then, it had been thought that any of the dead could come back to life, not just those that had been infected.

“They must not have finished burning them properly,” Izuku said, voice quiet. Kaminari flinched, dragging his eyes away from the disturbing mess and hurrying past the cemetery.

Eventually, the group came to a halt outside of an underpass. It was wide, but the tunnel itself was long and curved enough that they could barely see daylight at the other end. The safety lights along the roof of the tunnel had given up long ago, and the darkness left Izuku feeling nervous.

“We could go around it,” Kirishima suggested after no one had spoken for a minute. Kacchan was busy looking at the map, brow furrowed before he glanced up.

“We can cross under the expressway further down,” he said, “but we’re gonna be out in the open if we do.”

“At least we’d see if anyone is coming,” Kaminari muttered.

“Yeh, or they’ll see us,” Izuku added. “If it were me, I’d be banking on people not feeling comfortable coming through here and choosing another route.”

“The tunnel ain’t that long,” Kacchan said, before rolling up the map and shoving it into his back pocket. “We stick to the route Deku planned out.”

This was the first time Kacchan had mentioned Izuku in days where the words hadn’t felt like a

cutting insult, and Izuku hated how hope immediately bloomed in his chest.

“Man,” Kaminari whined, rubbing his arms. “This place gives me the willies.”

“Would you like my torch?” Shouto asked.

“No lights,” Kacchan snapped. “We don’t know who or what is on the other end of this tunnel, you wanna make it obvious we’re in there?”

“You want us to walk around in the dark?” Kaminari yelped.

“Fuck me,” Kacchan hissed under his breath, before stomping forward into the mouth of the tunnel. “I can see daylight from here already. Stop being a fucking baby.”

“So not wanting to walk through a pitch-black tunnel in the middle of zombie land makes me a baby?”

“No, your whining is what makes you a baby. What, you wanna hold my fucking hand the whole way?”

“And catch your gross, sweaty cooties? No thanks.”

“You can hold my hand if you like,” Shouto said, voice and face deadpan as he held out his palm.

“Man, you’re adorable. Izuku, you should totally dump Kacchan’s ass and date this guy instead.”

An uncomfortable silence followed Kaminari’s words, Kacchan’s back stiffening as he glared down the tunnel, Shouto looking between him and Izuku with a strange expression on his face, doing a poor job of hiding his shock. Izuku tensed, staring resolutely up at the bushes and foliage covering the top half of the tunnel.

“What I say?”

“C’mon, man,” Kirishima grunted, reaching out and grabbing Kaminari’s hand himself and tugging him into the tunnel.

Izuku could feel Shouto’s eyes on him as he followed the two of them. It wasn’t that he had purposefully decided to keep his relationship with Kacchan a secret from him, it was more that, right now, Izuku had no idea *what* that relationship was any more… Kacchan refused so much as to look at him, let alone talk to him. How could he tell Shouto when there wasn’t anything to tell?

The tunnel smelled damp, with a certain muskiness that only came from dark enclosed spaces, and once inside the light at the end helped to illuminate the concrete walls surrounding them. Despite how quietly they walked, their footsteps echoed, bouncing off every surface and forcing a shiver down Izuku’s spine. Kacchan walked confidently ahead of them, one hand resting on his belt the entire time, and despite the anxiety they all felt, they made it through the other side without anything jumping out at them.

The last leg of their journey felt much less claustrophobic than the first; along a long road that led them past old farmland and larger houses secured in their own plots. The farmland had started

taking on a life of its own probably not long after the dead did; wildflowers peeking out over the shrubs, the air filled with the delightful sound of birds singing. Here, you might have been forgiven for thinking that there was nothing wrong with the world… It had taken back control, and these fields were evidence enough that all but the humans were thriving. Kirishima had stopped them partway when he had spotted a large strawberry bush growing out onto the road from a front garden.

“Mina loves strawberries,” he explained, eagerly collecting the fruit and carefully wrapping them up in his pack.

Closer to the University, it started to feel more like the city again; a grocery store with the windows smashed in and empty of supplies reminding them that the Apocalypse was very real. And yet, Izuku realised as they inched closer to the campus, they had yet to see a single zombie. They knew from what they had found in the stadium, and what Shouto had told them about UA, that the city held thousands of them, perhaps drawing zombies in from all around them; still, the streets were empty. No zombies, no other survivors. This huge city had become a ghost town.

The University campus itself was set over a large uphill area, consisting of multiple faculty buildings dotted over a background beneath Mt Fuji. Logistically, it was a *fucking nightmare* , in Kacchan’s words, and they were taking a huge risk even coming near the place. But it was their best chance of finding the things that they needed, and with the campus being in a position so difficult to defend, they had to hope that no one was stupid enough to have tried to make it home. Izuku’s knowledge of Shizuoka University stopped at its location, so it was down to Kacchan to direct them from this point on, and he drew them to a halt outside of a cafe, just before the entrance to the campus

“Ok,” he said, gathering their attention. “The science faculty is through there, and to the left.” He pointed to a short staircase that passed beneath a covered walkway. “It’s not deep into the campus, but we’re still gonna be at a big disadvantage. Plus, the building we need is big, it’s not going to be a quick *in and out* .”

“How far from the entrance do you need to go?” Shouto asked, eying the walkway, eyes drifting over it and to the buildings on either side.

“Not far,” Kacchan ground out, like every word he said to the man caused him physical pain. “You’re not gonna be able to see shit from on top that walkway if that’s what you’re thinking.”

“No, but I think I can use it to get onto that building there.” Shouto nodded to the building to its right. “It’s not the tallest, but I’ll still be able to get a pretty good vantage point. I can definitely see back down the hill we climbed up.”

Izuku nodded. “I think that’s a good idea. Shouto and I were pretty good at getting in and out of places without being seen. I think we should handle it how my group used to.”

Kacchan bristled. “We’ve handled shit just fine up until now, Deku.”

“Like at the hospital?” Izuku cut back. “We weren’t careful enough, then, and we both nearly died.”

“You weren’t careful enough,” Kacchan spat. But they both knew that wasn’t the truth, Kacchan avoiding his eyes and glaring up at the campus. Izuku sighed.

“We had a good system when it was me and Shouto and the rest of my group. We have one person on lookout high up. Before we go in, we make sure there are at least two exits and keep one person on each, that way we can warn those inside if one of the exits is compromised.”

“So, Todoroki is on lookout,” Kirishima said.

“Fuck that,” Kacchan snarled. “I don’t know this asshole. I don’t trust him to watch my ass.”

“I can assure you I’m not the least bit interested in your ass,” Shouto replied.

“Hah?!” Kacchan grabbed the front of Shouto’s coat. “How about I put my foot in yours, bastard? See how fucking smart-mouthed you are then!”

“C’mon, man, we don’t have time for this,” Kirishima sighed, putting his hand on Kacchan’s shoulder.

“I know what I’m doing,” Shouto said, brushing his coat down smooth when Kacchan finally let go. “And so does Izuku. So let him finish.”

Kacchan fixed Shouto with perhaps the filthiest look that Izuku had ever seen on his face. But, decided not to argue, just crossing his arms over his chest.

“Go ahead, *Izuku* ,” Kacchan said, with a humourless laugh.

Izuku huffed, feeling more than a little exasperated by this point. It wasn’t like he expected Kacchan and Shouto to be best friends, but all this bickering was going to end up getting one or both of them killed if they weren’t fucking careful... He chewed on the inside of his cheek, willing himself not to bite back with a petty response, before taking a deep breath.

“Shouto is on lookout,” he confirmed. “Kacchan, how many ways into and out of the building?”

“Two, that I know of,” Kacchan replied shortly. “Main entrance. Was shown where the fire exit was when I toured the place.”

“And you’ll know how to find it once inside?”

“What do you think?”

“Then I guess, Kirishima you watch the main entrance, Kaminari the fire exit. With all three of you on lookout, hopefully, it’ll be very difficult for anything, or any *one* , to sneak up on us.”

“And where exactly do you think you’re gonna be?” Kacchan asked.

“I’m coming in with you. And don’t be an ass about it,” Izuku added, just as Kacchan tore open his mouth to argue. “You can’t carry everything on your own, or search whilst keeping watch. Going in by yourself would be stupid.”

Kacchan scoffed, but he didn’t argue.

“We should double-check that all the walkies are on the same frequency,” Kirishima said. “Todoroki, you have the two you brought?”

“Sure.”

Shouto shrugged his pack off his shoulders and handed Kirishima a busted up old pair of walkie-talkies. Izuku immediately recognised them as the same ones that they had been using back when it had just been him and his group and realised with a pang that they must have picked up the one he lost after he was attacked.

“Thanks.”

Kirishima tested each of the four they had brought with them, before dishing them out among the five of them. Izuku attached his to his belt, before dusting his hands off and stretching his arms over his head, mentally preparing himself for what was to come.

“Alright, let’s do this.”

They paused only at the covered walkway, Shouto spotting a fence that allowed him to reach the railings, his long limbs reaching up to pull himself up onto the roof of it. Izuku had seen Shouto somehow find his way up onto weirder places than this before, the man lithe as a cat, footsteps almost silent as he hurried across the curved metal roofing. At the end of the walkway, there were two levels of the building, Juliet balconies jutting out just enough to give Shouto something to grab onto as he jumped. He made short work of the entire thing, balancing on the final balcony, taking a quick leap, and heaving himself up onto the roof of the building.

“Damn,” Kaminari whistled. “That was pretty impressive.”

“This is why we always had Shouto on lookout,” Izuku replied.

Shouto offered them all a thumbs up, before pointing over his shoulder, indicating that he was going to go and get into position. Izuku nodded, and the four of them continued up the avenue towards the science faculty until they reached a large car park.

“Ok, where from here?”

Kacchan gestured to the large building directly in front of them.

“This is the one we want. There are all those trees in the way, but fuck face back there should still be able to see us. But the rest of the campus opens up directly behind it, so we need to be on guard.”

“Ok,” Izuku said, ignoring the *fuck face* comment. “In that case Kirishima, maybe you should stay around here? You can see the front of the building and also back the way we came, anywhere that might be blocked from Shouto’s view.”

“I’m your man,” Kirishima replied, jabbing his thumb at his chest. Kacchan rolled his eyes, before waving his arm for the three of them to follow.

The faculty building Kacchan had in mind wasn’t as tall as some of the others, but it was still large

enough that Izuku knew that it would take some time if they had to search it room-by-room. A sign above the door told them it was the Joint Research Laboratory, the white paint on the double doors worn out from all the hands that had pushed them open over the years.

“There’s the fire exit around the back, just up those stairs,” Kacchan said, pointing to the stairs cutting through a verge.

“On it!” Kaminari replied, throwing them a quick salute before starting a light jog up around the back of the laboratory. Izuku pulled the walkie-talkie out from his belt.

“Shouto, are you in position? Over.”

“Yes. I can’t see you, but I can see Kirishima from where I am, and back down the hill. If anyone tries to sneak up on us, I’ll spot them. Over.”

“Great,” Izuku replied with a small sigh of relief. “We’re just about to go into the laboratory. If anyone sees anything, crack the receiver twice, but only answer when it’s safe to. Everyone got that? Over.”

“Loud and clear,” Kaminari replied.

“Got it,” Kirishima and Shouto said simultaneously.

Kacchan reached over and grabbed the walkie from Izuku’s hand.

“Remember,” he said, “this ain’t gonna be a quick in and out. I don’t know how much of the stuff in there is gonna be any good for starts, so we might have to search other buildings on the campus. But, if no one hears from me or Deku after twenty minutes, assume something’s gone wrong.”

“Twenty minutes, huh?” Kaminari sniggered. *“Please, I wouldn’t dream of interrupting you two before that.”*

“I didn’t say over, you fuck!” Kacchan snarled down the walkie. “If you ain’t heard from us, then get out of here and regroup. Don’t come in there unless you’re sure it’s not a trap. You got that? Over.”

There was a moment of silence before Kirishima buzzed in.

“Yeh… Ok. Just… be safe in there, you guys. Over.”

“Sure, sure,” Kacchan replied. “Over and out.”

He chucked the walkie-talkie back to Izuku, before squaring his shoulders and marching towards the front door.

“C’mon, let’s do this.”

Izuku hooked the walkie-talkie into his belt, adjusting his axe in his hand before following him, the two of them slipping through the double doors silently.

A long hallway opened out in front of them, dark aside from the light that filtered in through the doorway. Plastic bottles and old crisp packets littered the ground from a bin that had been knocked over, likely in the panic that had ensued as students had rushed to get themselves out of the campus. A glass notice board, the surface of which smashed and splattered with old dried blood, contained a poster detailing the candidates for faculty president, the smiling faces looking back at them sending a chill down Izuku's spine. Entering places like this, entering *homes* , only felt more and more perverse as the Apocalypse dragged on, like they had walked in on something private. Izuku had started to find that photographs were his least favourite things to come across, leaving a bitter taste in his mouth when he was forced to consider that these people probably weren't alive anymore. Or… that he could very well have hacked their reanimated corpses to bits long before then. The notice board was a stark reminder of how vibrant the campus had once been, and he adjusted his pack and forced himself to look forward, the sight of old blood and scuff marks much more familiar to him.

Kacchan paused just beyond the notice board, brow furrowed as he looked at the faculty map pinned to the wall.

"They had us take a bunch of fucking detours when I was here last," Kacchan muttered, raising a hand to drag his finger over the laminated surface of the map, tracing the route, before tapping his finger against one spot. "There. That's where we gotta go. Third floor. Looks like we can go up these stairs and follow the corridor all the way down."

"Kacchan-"

"Hurry up."

Kacchan turned on his heel, not sparing Izuku a glance as he marched to the staircase, proving that even though it was only the two of them, he was determined to continue giving him the cold shoulder. Izuku hurried towards the stairs, taking them two at a time so that he could catch up with the man.

The building seemed quiet as they made it to the third level; the only movement was rats scurrying away down the hallway, frightened by the sound of Kacchan's heavy boots hitting the tiles. Izuku's stomach churned as his eyes landed on the sunken husks of what had once been students; the rats having long ago eaten their fill of what little the zombies left behind. Kacchan stepped over the remains, boots raised high as he tried not to disturb them, and Izuku followed, trying hard not to look down at the mess beneath his feet.

"Kacchan?"

Kacchan ignored him again, head bobbing as he peered through doorways, and Izuku felt his hands curl into fists, frustration boiling over.

"Kacchan!"

The man seemed to flinch, his shoulders hunching and stiffening before inclining his head in Izuku's direction.

"What do you want, Deku?"

The words were spat with so much venom that Izuku took half a step back, jaw tightening. He knew that he had said some unkind things… He knew Kacchan was hurting, and probably afraid, but there was no way that he had earned such contempt from the man, not after everything they had already been through. He swallowed and looked down at his feet. The ageing blood that had once pooled there had stained the tiles a vulgar brown.

“We need to talk.”

A silence followed before Kacchan scoffed, abruptly starting to walk forward again.

“We’re a bit fucking busy, Deku. *Later* .”

“What, so you can just blow me off again?” Izuku replied, doing a poor job of hiding his anger and frustration. “I’ve been trying to talk to you, but you’re doing everything you can to avoid me.”

“Whatever. I’ve had other shit on my mind.”

“Like what?” Izuku demanded. “Your next get-away? The best way to fake another zombie bite?”

Kacchan grew rigid again.

“Don’t be stupid-”

“Why can’t you just be honest with me? For once!” Izuku said, exasperated. Kacchan turned on his heel, his fierce eyes suddenly glaring right back at him.

“ *Me?* ” he said, pressing a hand to his chest, a short humourless bark of laughter echoing down the corridor. “ *I’m* the one not being honest? That’s a bit fucking rich, Deku.”

“I’ve never kept how I’m feeling from you-”

“What happened after the hospital?” Kacchan interrupted sharply.

Izuku froze the blood in his veins turning to ice at the question. Kacchan’s face contorted into a grimace, his bat swinging up to hang over his shoulder.

“C’mon then,” he ground out. “You want us to be honest with each other, right? Then start. Tell me what happened.”

“I-” Izuku’s voice shook, his jaw clamping shut, memories of that day flashing before him, leaving him light-headed and nauseous. Kacchan’s nostrils flared, and he scoffed.

“There’s a fucking surprise.”

Kacchan took a deep breath, eyes drifting back down the corridor.

“It’s Shindo, ain’t it? He’s dead.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “Sh-Shindo?”

“I figured it had to be something like that,” Kacchan replied. “I was trying to work out what could possibly be so bad that you wouldn’t wanna tell me. He was at the hospital, with all the zombies there. You know he and I-” Kacchan hesitated, before sniffing sharply, his mouth thinning into a tight line. “So just… just fucking tell me.”

Izuku felt the tears start to run down his cheeks, unbidden, soaking his patch and leaving his eyes burning.

“N-not Shindo,” he said roughly, swallowing back the painful lump in his throat. He couldn’t say it… He knew Kacchan deserved the truth but how could he possibly tell him when each and every memory made him feel like his chest was caving in? “K-Kacchan I- I can’t-”

“If not Shindo then who?” Kacchan pressed. Izuku shook his head frantically, his tongue feeling twice as big in his mouth, threatening to choke him on the name that had been burning into the tip of it. It was then that Kacchan seemed to understand; his eyes widened, and his breath caught in his chest.

“Not-” he swallowed, his next words coming out strained, his own head shaking in disbelief. “No, not one of the kids.”

Izuku averted his gaze, not wanting Kacchan to see the tears now flowing freely.

“Katsuma?”

Izuku’s face scrunched up, nodding his head in jerky movements, and there was a thud as Kacchan’s arms fell to his sides, the head of his bat chipping the dried blood from the ground.

“But… *how?* ”

Before Izuku could answer, Kacchan groaned, rubbing his face.

“He followed us up, didn’t he?”

“And it’s all my fault,” Izuku said bitterly. “It was my plan! My great fucking idea!”

“And no one could fucking watch the brat?” Kacchan snarled, face turning red. “Fifteen fucking people and not one of them saw him leave?”

“I-I don’t-”

“Fuck!”

Izuku flinched as Kacchan’s yell filled the corridor. There was a clatter, followed by one of the doors to their left shaking on its hinges as something collided with the other side. Kacchan took a deep breath, watching the door shake for a moment, before turning to face Izuku.

“It’s not your fault.”

Izuku felt sick. He knew the words were supposed to bring him comfort, but he didn’t need to hear them. He didn’t need someone to try excusing the role he had to play in what happened, to try and

convince him that, if it hadn't been for him, Katsuma might still be alive right now.

"It is," Izuku replied, ignoring the insistent scraping of the zombie. "Face it, the second we walked into that town we were responsible for everything that happened there. We disturbed the zombies. We woke that female one up, and we were the ones she was after."

Kacchan didn't reply, just staring back with a look of clear exhaustion on his face.

"I wasn't quick enough," Izuku continued. "Makabe called just after you did, said that no one could find him and-" *red, cracking, tearing*- "I was just too slow. The zombies got to him first."

There was complete silence following his words, aside from the zombie still trying to break its way through the frosted door, worked up into a frenzy. Eventually, Kacchan spoke, his voice uncharacteristically quiet.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Izuku looked up, the sad, tired expression on Kacchan's face making his heartache.

"You already had so much to worry about," he replied. "And I…" he took a deep breath. "I couldn't talk about it. Not then."

Kacchan nodded, a quick jerk of the head before he lifted his bat and started towards the rattling door.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, "we… we still need to talk."

"I know," Kacchan sighed. "Later. We got a fucking job to do."

Izuku nodded, adjusting his grip around his axe as Kacchan pulled the door open, side-stepping the rotten, filthy thing that fell from the room as it landed on its face. The zombie had clearly been trapped since the early days of the Apocalypse, its body so degraded that its jaw cracked upon contact with the ground, skin and muscles all but entirely wasted away.

"Wait," Izuku said quickly, as Kacchan raised his bat to finish the job.

"What? Why?"

"Just, hold on a moment."

Izuku stepped closer, watching as the zombie struggled to raise itself from the floor, broken jaw hanging pathetically as it attempted to drag itself towards Kacchan. It was probably the first time Izuku had seen a zombie that had been completely isolated since the beginning, presumably unable to feed, and he was not about to let the opportunity to investigate pass. He dropped to his haunches beside it, the zombie seeming to finally spot him and spinning itself in place as it lunged at him.

"Stop!"

The zombie paused, and however short the moment was before Kacchan brought his bat down onto its skull, Izuku didn't miss it.

“I told you to wait,” Izuku said, throwing his hands in the air.

“Why, you fucking nutjob?” Kacchan snarled back, before kicking the damn thing for good measure. “It nearly had your damn face!”

“It was nowhere near me,” Izuku sighed, looking down at the zombie. “It’s just… we’ve not seen one in this state before. And this thing had to have been here since the start, right?”

Kacchan ground his teeth together. “S’pose.”

“So, this is what happens to them when they don’t eat,” Izuku explained. “Assuming it really has been here for the last two years, then we know they can survive that long without food.”

“Yeh, but look at the fucking state of it,” Kacchan said. “Damn things broke itself just coming out the door.”

“Right, which means that food must be sustaining them in some way.”

Izuku grabbed his knife from where it lay against his thigh, reaching forward so he could push the zombie into its side without touching it. The body was partially decomposed, the remaining skin tight and flush around its bones, but Izuku was surprised to see the thing had a large bloated stomach.

“Guess again,” Kacchan said with a grimace. “Must’ve been eating the rats or some shit.”

“We don’t know if they do that,” Izuku replied. He hesitated, glancing up at Kacchan. “I gotta know.”

Kacchan swore under his breath.

“Get on with it then, you crazy asshole.”

Izuku shuffled forward on his knees, tentatively pressing his hand above the swell of the zombie's abdomen. Kacchan groaned, looking very uncomfortable with where things were going, and Izuku took a deep breath, before plunging his knife in.

The stomach gave way like butter to a hot knife, and Izuku only just scrambled back quick enough to avoid the contents as they spilled out onto the floor. A sour vulgar smell rose from it, causing Izuku to gag, covering his mouth. Kacchan groaned again.

“That’s so fucking disgusting,” he managed over his wrist. “What the fuck, Deku?”

Izuku coughed, fighting back the wave of nausea, the smell of rotten eggs clinging to his nose and throat. He steadied himself, before inching back forward, knife outstretched as he started to pick through the guts and rot covering the tiles. Sure enough, there was a collection of small bones mixed in with the viscera.

“You’re right,” Izuku said. “It ate the rats.”

“Ok, mystery solved, can we fucking go now?”

“Wait,” Izuku instructed, still searching, his brow furrowed. “This doesn’t… it doesn’t smell right.”

“What the fuck do you mean it don’t smell right?” Kacchan exclaimed. “What were you fucking expecting it to smell like? Ass and roses?”

“Ass and- never mind. Doesn’t it smell kinda… sweet to you?”

“Have you fucking lost it?”

“It’s kind of like… acetone. And rotten eggs.”

“So, gross and fucking gross. Why the fuck are we doing this?”

“I’m serious, this doesn’t smell like I expected it to.”

Kacchan grunted, his face looking a little green as he peered down over his wrist. “Smells a little like when my dad tried his hand at making wine. Whole thing was a fucking disaster.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “Wait, wait you’re right! This is just… it’s fermentation! That’s how the zombies break down the contents of their stomachs!”

Kacchan blinked. “Hold on, they break it down into *alcohol* ?”

“A little fermentation is a normal part of the digestion process,” Izuku said, getting to his feet again. “But to this level? That’s not even close to being normal.”

“Ok, so what does this fucking mean?” Kacchan pressed.

Izuku raised a hand to his head, pushing his hair back, his mind racing. “Holy fuck…”

“ *What?* ”

“That’s… that’s the key. There’s this condition, it’s super rare, but basically, their bodies convert carbohydrates into alcohol, and the fermentation happens at such a rate that it’s enough to make the person drunk even if they never touch alcohol.”

Kacchan frowned.

“We already know that alcohol has something to do with how you’ve been able to resist the virus for so long. But, what I don’t understand is how alcohol sustains the virus in the zombies but slows it in you. Or, for that matter, how the amount of alcohol in the body can even affect a virus, to begin with.”

“That don’t make any sense,” Kacchan said.

“Unless… unless how the body processes alcohol has something to do with it,” Izuku continued, not even fully listening to Kacchan at this point. “You get bit or infected in some other way, the virus spreads and eventually turns you into one of those *things* . The virus does something to your

gastrointestinal tract and gives you this condition where your body starts to break down all the sugars and starch you eat into alcohol. Perhaps… Perhaps that's what prolonged the virus for so long? The more alcohol the body produces, the more it feeds the virus in some way… If they don't eat, if the fermentation process never happens, then the virus dies off and they start rotting away. Maybe that's why they all look so different. Those that have fed, and those that haven't."

"Right, that's fucking great and all, but what does that have to do with me?"

"We know if you don't consume alcohol, the virus gets worse. For whatever reason, it's affected you differently. For you, alcohol fights the virus, it doesn't sustain it."

"So, that's the difference? I got a strain of the virus that doesn't work the same way?"

"Maybe," Izuku replied. "But… but if that was the case why did Sero die? If you had a different strain, then anyone you infected would have the same. No, there's something different about your physiology, something that we don't have, something about how your body breaks down alcohol."

"Right, but there was no alcohol at the big zombie's place," Kacchan said. "Didn't look like a damn alcoholic to me."

Izuku bit his lip. Somehow, he hadn't even really considered that…

"Then maybe that's why he only lasted six months after getting bitten."

"Six months is still a long fucking time," Kacchan grunted. "There's some other shit going on here."

"Yeh…"

Izuku looked at the zombie at their feet, gross-smelling waste slowly seeping across the tiles. He felt like he was so close to something… so close to understanding, and yet each step they made towards finding an answer to all of this only seemed to present more questions.

"We're wasting time," Kacchan said shortly. "We'll talk about this later."

Izuku nodded only somewhat regretfully, putting his knife away and stepping over the zombie so that he could follow Kacchan down the corridor. No other doors rattled on their hinges as they passed by, leaving him somewhat certain that there weren't any other zombies waiting to launch themselves at them. Izuku had to admit he was somewhat disappointed by this; a second zombie he could cut open might have helped give some more footing to his theory.

The room that Kacchan wanted was almost all the way at the far end of the corridor, separated off from the hallway by a large dutch door, the lower half of which pulled shut whilst the upper had been swung open.

"This it?" Izuku asked.

"Should be," Kacchan replied, ducking his head around the door so that he could see into the room beyond. "Gross. Something nasty went down here."

“What do you mean?”

Izuku hurried up to his side, peering over his shoulder. A series of cabinets lined the entire back wall, the metal drawers only recognisable as having once been white and green from those high enough up to have avoided being caught in the horrific splattering of blood that covered the rest.

“Did *anyone* make it out of this place?” Izuku asked, curling his nose at the sight.

“Not alive they didn’t,” Kacchan replied with a grunt as he reached out to grab the lower half of the door, yanking it towards him. “Hah? The door won’t-” Kacchan paused, looking down and Izuku followed his gaze. The gruesome sight of two boney decayed hands met him, fingers curled and clawed into the surface of the wooden door like something had held on for dear life.

“This place is getting creepier and fucking creepier the further we go,” Kacchan said, rolling his lips in distaste, before wrenching the door hard. The bones cracked loudly, a sick sounding thud filling the corridor as the remains of the body on the other side of the door slid down. “At least this one’s actually dead.”

They picked their way through the remains and the blood staining the floor until they reached the cabinets. Another door led to a much larger room, this one furnished with stainless steel tables and shelving, various equipment and apparatus dotted about the place, some that Izuku recognised and others he couldn’t place. Kacchan pulled a torch from his pack, appraising the contents of the cabinets.

“Good for us, the chemicals we need shouldn’t have gone bad yet,” Kacchan muttered, brow furrowed as he leaned closer, trying to read the labels through the layers of blood and grime. “Provided they ain’t been mixed with anything else, anyway.”

“Could they be?”

Kacchan shrugged, reaching for one of the drawers and pulling it open. “Maybe. Probably find glycerol mixed with all sorts of shit, but we can’t use that anyway.”

“Oh, right. So, uh, what are we looking for?”

“Glycerol, nitric acid, sulfuric acid,” Kacchan replied. “As much as you can find.”

“And what if we can’t find any of that?”

Kacchan slammed the drawer shut, turning to look at him, eyes twitching in irritation. “Then this was a big waste of time. So get looking already!”

Izuku sighed, looking at the room to his left, where some bottles were sitting in plastic trays on the shelves, and deciding that he’d start there instead, put a little elbow room between Kacchan and himself before the man worked himself up into another tantrum.

Most of the contents of the room had been smashed up in the chaos, the ground sticky from an unpleasant cocktail of blood and unknown chemicals, making the room smell almost as bad as the contents of that zombie's stomach. He pressed the sleeve of his jacket over his nose, breathing through his mouth and shimmying his way over to the few shelves that had survived the initial

outbreak. He was already pretty familiar with most of the chemicals and compounds he was unearthing from his studies in pathology, and it was becoming depressingly obvious that he wasn't going to be finding an awful lot of what they needed; a couple opened bottles labelled *'glycerin'* was about as big a prize as he could hope for, scooping them up and making his way back to where Kacchan was still searching.

"Found some glycerin," he said, holding one of the bottles up so Kacchan could see. Kacchan merely grunted, not taking any notice. "They're already open, is that going to be a problem?"

"What's the concentration?" Kacchan said, dragging another drawer open.

"Uh…," Izuku leaned back into the previous, brighter room so that he could read the label. "Ninety-nine point five."

"It'll be fine," Kacchan replied, slamming the drawer shut with a frustrated growl. "Damnit!"

"You found the other stuff you need?"

"Does it fucking look like I found it?"

Izuku huffed, rocking back onto his heels. Kacchan tentatively grabbed the handle of another drawer, the entire front of it brown, before letting out a loud *'hah!'*

"What?"

Kacchan pulled out a brown bottle with a large white label across the front of it, turning it in his hands as he read under the torchlight.

"Shit," he hissed, lowering his hand before starting to dig back through the contents of the drawer, inspecting every label. "Fuck."

" *What?* "

"It ain't concentrated enough," Kacchan replied, placing several other brown bottles onto the cabinet beside the first. "Which means I gotta purify it."

"But you can do it?"

"What do I look like to you?" Kacchan huffed. "Of course, I can fucking do it, it just means I gotta waste a whole damn day on it."

"Kacchan, we still have time," Izuku said, as softly as he could. "Me and Kirishima checked out the stadium, the zombies aren't about to knock down the fences any time soon if they even could."

Kacchan didn't say anything, the tightening of his jaw only obvious by the way the shadows shifted over his face, and Izuku's stomach clenched uncomfortably, thinking back to the fraction of a second that zombie had paused before Kacchan caved its skull in.

"This'll have to fucking do," he grunted, before starting to pile all five bottles into his backpack. "Check those drawers over there, we're gonna need more glycerol than that. And we still need

sulfuric acid."

Izuku nodded, the pair working in silence as they searched through the last remaining drawers. To Kacchan's relief, they were able to find a sufficient amount of sulfuric acid, but they came up dry when it came to the glycerol.

"Well, it could have been worse," Kacchan said, stuffing the supplies into his pack. "I can make more glycerol, but we're gonna have to do a bit more scavenging for that."

"What do we need?"

Kacchan grabbed a large white bottle from the cabinet beside him, with the words *'caustic soda'* written across the front. "This. And vegetable oils. Problem is, anyone smart enough would have been grabbing that shit for fuel, we might struggle to find any of it left in stores."

"We can check homes on the way back to the playground," Izuku said. "We're bound to find something."

Kacchan hummed in response, leaving his pack on the cabinet before pushing past Izuku to get into the larger room.

"Those dead bastards went to town here," he said. "Half this shit's broken!" He kicked a smashed beaker on the floor as if in a demonstration, looking around the room in frustration. "This couldn't just be easy, could it?"

"What do we need?"

"Conical flasks, boiling flasks, columns… anything you can find still in one piece grab it. Oh, and clamps. Lots and lots of clamps."

Together they collected any glassware that remained intact, carefully wrapping each one with scraps of fabric as they went, knowing that it would be too far to come back if they ended up damaging all this stuff. Izuku was just zipping up his pack when there were three short static bursts on his walkie. He glanced up at Kacchan, before raising it to his mouth.

"We're here. Over."

"Hey, it's me," came Kirishima's voice. *"You good to talk freely? Over."*

"Yeh, it's all clear in here now, go ahead."

"Todoroki?"

There was another static burst, and Shouto's voice filled the room.

"Izuku? You're going to need to finish things up in there soon as you can, we've got company. Group of zombies twenty-five, maybe thirty strong heading in our direction. Over."

"That many?" Izuku replied. "We've not seen a group that big in the city before, not if we don't count the ones in the stadium…"

"They're heading in the wrong direction for UA too," Shouto said. *"I dunno, maybe they know we're here somehow? Over."*

"How could they know that?" came Kaminari's voice now. *"We've not made any noise or killed any on our way here!"*

Izuku looked over at Kacchan again, who shrugged.

"We had to kill one here," Izuku said. *"But there's no way they could have heard us. Look, it could just be bad luck. We're done here now anyway, we'll be right there. Over and out."*

He hooked the walkie back into his belt, grabbing his pack and shouldering it. Kacchan followed after him, casting one last look about the room before the two of them started back down the corridor.

Kirishima was waiting for them outside, looking a little anxious, eyes darting back towards the building Shouto was using for lookout.

"You get everything you needed?" he asked.

"Nah," Kacchan replied. "But we should be able to find the rest on our way to the industrial estate. Where's Dunce Face?"

"I'll just call him."

Izuku looked up and down the car park as Kirishima radioed for Kaminari to come and join them, the road still mercifully empty. A few minutes later, the four of them were half jogging back to where Shouto was now easing himself down from the roof, leaping sprightly from balcony to balcony until he was back on the ground.

"Did you get it all?" Shouto asked.

"Almost," Izuku replied before Kacchan could say anything. "There wasn't enough glycerol, so we're going to need to find some vegetable oil so Kacchan can make more."

"There's that supermarket we passed," Kaminari said. "They'd have some, surely?"

"Not if people swiped it all for fuel," Kacchan grunted.

"Besides, we're going to need to find an alternate route out of here," Shouto said, looking back down the hill. "I had a chance to count them, there are twenty-seven zombies heading straight towards us, and they're pretty spread out. We could probably handle them but-"

"We can't risk any of the equipment getting fucked," Kacchan interrupted. "Or whatever weird fucking pheromone shit they do to attract more of them after we kill them."

"Kacchan's right," Izuku said. "It's not worth the risk."

"We can still reach the industrial estate if we go that way, past the football field," Kacchan

continued, pulling the map out from his back pocket and rotating it in his hands. “There. There’s an underpass under the expressway, we can put a fair bit of distance between us and the horde.”

“Another tunnel?” Kaminari sighed. “Really?”

“It’s that or be zombie chow, your choice.”

The small group followed Kacchan’s lead after that, past the large football field and down a narrow alley that cut from the edge of the campus to the expressway. They didn’t see any other zombies on the way, passing through the underpass with only the smallest grumble from Kaminari, before finding themselves on the outskirts of the industrial park. Izuku wasn’t at all familiar with this part of the city, and Kacchan only knew about it in passing, so they had to rely on the map and their sense of direction to negotiate the large sprawling area. Finally, they found the construction company, putting Shouto, Kirishima, and Kaminari at key lookout points whilst Izuku and Kacchan went inside.

Kacchan busied himself collecting the things that he needed whilst Izuku scoped out the communal areas, letting out a whoop of triumph when he pulled open the cupboards in the kitchen and found a large bottle of vegetable oil.

“Will this do?” Izuku called, holding it up so that Kacchan could see. “It’s out of date by a couple of months but-”

“That won’t matter,” Kacchan replied, as he stuffed two bags of charcoal into a burlap sack. “Grab it.”

They left the warehouse feeling decidedly more accomplished than they had after the University, Kacchan confidently swinging the large burlap sack over one of his shoulders as if it didn’t weigh a damn thing. Satisfied and relieved, the five of them decided that it would be quickest to follow the river back towards the Sports Complex, Kaminari not being the only one who didn’t fancy ducking through tunnels again after the morning they’d had.

They hadn’t gone far, however, before Kaminari was drawing them to a halt. A convenience store stood ahead of them, a meagre looking warehouse-cum-office block sitting just beyond the store's small car park, and upon seeing it, Kaminari waved his arms frantically, making harsh shushing noises at those that shot him quizzical looks. Kacchan, walking ahead, hadn’t noticed the drama until Kaminari grabbed the neck of his coat and yanked it backwards.

“What the fu-”

“Shh!”

It was testament to how much trust he had in Kaminari that Kacchan didn’t immediately slap away the hand wrapping over his mouth to quiet him. Kaminari dragged a half-heartedly struggling Kacchan back behind the nearest building, the rest of them following in complete confusion.

“Kaminari, what’s going on?” Izuku hissed.

“The carpark,” Kaminari replied in a frantic whisper, letting go of Kacchan who dropped the coal to the ground with a huff. “Right at the back. *Look* .”

Izuku inched forward, peering around the side of the building and looking down the street towards the convenience store. It took him a moment to figure out what Kaminari had seen before his heart dropped right down to his ass.

A station wagon was nearly parked behind the Seven Eleven, the nose of the vehicle only just visible from where they were now standing. But Izuku didn't need to see the rest of it to be able to recognise the dark blue bodywork and ugly wood panel running up the side. He could feel the others peering out past him.

"Is that them?" Kaminari whispered loudly in his ear.

"It's them," Kacchan growled from somewhere above him, the timber of his voice vibrating along Izuku's spine. "I know that number plate."

"Them?" Shouto asked before Izuku grabbed his arm and pulled him back behind the building. Shouto shot him a confused look. "Izuku, what is it?"

"It's them," Izuku whispered back. "Dabi, and his group."

Shouto immediately went rigid, mismatched eyes darkening as he looked over Izuku's head towards the vehicle.

"We can't stand here," Kirishima said urgently, and Kacchan nodded.

"Behind the building. Come on."

Izuku had to tug several times on Shouto's arm to encourage him to move, the five of them slipping down the alley behind the building Karminari had pulled them to, and out of view of the car. A rancid-smelling skip filled the space behind them, full of *what,* Izuku had no intentions of finding out, huddling with the others as they exchanged nervous glances.

"So," Kaminari whispered harshly, "what do we do?"

"We don't *do* anything," Kirishima replied immediately, his harried gaze drifting between Kaminari and Kacchan as if he already knew what each of them was thinking.

"But they're right *there* ," Kaminari hissed. "We've got the element of surprise! We might never get a chance like this again!"

"We don't even know where they are," Izuku reasoned. "We can't just rush into things without a plan."

"Deku's right," Kacchan grunted, leaning forward so he could peer around the building again. "We don't do anything right now."

"So we wait," Kaminari replied, expression tight and stubborn. "We wait and see what happens."

"That's not really what I had in mind, either," Kirishima said, rubbing the back of his head nervously. "Look, I think we should just drop it, ok? Focus on the plan and on getting to UA-"

“I’m not dropping anything,” came a cold hard voice from behind them, making Kirishima jump. Izuku looked back over his shoulder to see Shouto’s body rigid and poised, the tension almost deadly in the way his fists tightened, static electricity seeming to light from his shoulders.

“See?” Kaminari said, gesturing towards Shouto. “They *can’t* get away with it, Eijirou! Not again!” He whirled around to look at Kacchan, who was watching Shouto with a guarded expression on his face. “You agree with me, don’t you, Bakugou?”

Kacchan glanced back at him, his jaw clenching before he let out a heavy sigh.

“No. Not right now.”

Kirishima and Kaminari’s jaws both dropped in shock, staring at Kacchan in disbelief. Izuku, who had absolutely expected Kacchan to be chomping at the bit to go after them, was just as taken back.

“Are you shitting me?” Kaminari breathed.

“Look, we aren’t ready,” Kacchan replied shortly, fixing his hard stare on Kaminari. “We’ve hardly got any weapons with us that would be remotely suitable for something like this. We don’t have a plan. We don’t even know which fucking building they’re in!”

“But-”

“We know they’re here,” Kacchan interrupted. “We’re going to go back, regroup, and come up with an actual fucking strategy.”

“We don’t come back at all!” Kirishima breathed, spreading his arms wide in disbelief. “How are we still even considering this? I know they’re responsible for some terrible things, but we have a *chance* here, don’t we? We can get to UA. Alive. All of us!”

Izuku, for all the rage and hatred he still felt towards Dabi and the rest of his group knew that Kirishima was right. There had been a time, not even that long ago when he had been prepared to face them; to stand by Kacchan’s side as the two of them avenged the people they had loved and lost. Through every terrible trauma that had followed that day in the woods, he hadn’t forgotten that promise… The promise that he and Kacchan had made to stop them so that their friends wouldn’t have to bloody their own hands. And yet, standing here now, seeing the sheer panic and desperation lining Kirishima’s face, he realised that he had been foolish to have ever believed the decision could be so simple. They were together now, all of them, the choice was not his and his alone anymore. To fight that league of bastards was to acknowledge that they might not survive the encounter. And, Izuku realised with a sharp tug to his heart, that he was far more afraid of losing another person he cared about than he was Dabi getting away with his crimes.

“They’re not going to get away with it,” Shouto said, cutting through Izuku’s thoughts almost as though he had been reading them. “But we’re not the only ones this affects. We can’t leave the girls in the dark like this.”

Kaminari shook his head in disbelief, eyes darting between each of them as if hoping for a lifeline. When none came, his shoulders slumped, lips thin and trembling.

“Fine,” he said shortly, quickly turning his back on all of them and marching out of the alley. Kirishima hurried after him, looking concerned, and Kacchan spared Izuku and Shouto a curious look before he too was following them. Izuku took a deep breath.

“Hey,” he said softly, looking over at Shouto. “Are you ok?”

“I will be,” Shouto replied shortly, not meeting Izuku’s eyes. “When he’s dead.”

Izuku watched as Shouto stalked away, the lead-tasting dread filling his chest so rapidly he thought he might choke on the fumes.

The group was subdued by the time they made it back to the indoor playground, Kaminari having walked silently ahead of them the entire way, refusing to meet any of their eyes. Izuku knew why Kaminari was so hurt. He knew why he was so *angry* . He had been there, mind clouded by hatred and thoughts of revenge… Despite the empathy he felt for Kaminari’s situation, he couldn’t stop himself from hoping that, eventually, Kaminari would understand that it had been the right thing to do; it had been the *only* thing to do, regardless of how long he had been harbouring these dark thoughts.

Mina was the one who greet them at the door, her keen sunny smile fading the moment she took in the expressions on their faces, stepping aside so that Kaminari could push past her, not even grunting so much as a *hello* . She looked at Kirishima, and he sighed.

“We’ll explain,” he said softly. “Let’s… let’s just get inside first.”

Mina nodded, chewing on her lip and eying the rest of the group curiously before following Kaminari into the playground. The man in question flopped himself into the ball pit the moment they were inside, a sight that might have been hilarious if the situation had been any different. Mina watched him in concern, her hands wringing before she turned back to face Kirishima.

“What happened?”

“Did you not find the things you needed?” Yaoyorozu asked, as she carefully placed the gun back in the yellow locker. There was a pause, awkward and filled with tension, none of them knowing how to bring up the subject. Even Kacchan looked somewhat hesitant, heaving the burlap sack onto the counter and remaining silent as he started to pull his backpack from his shoulders. Izuku swallowed.

“We… think we found Dabi and the others. We might know where they are hiding,” he said.

Mina’s reaction was immediate; her eyes widened and her loud gasp filled the room. Yaoyorozu and Hagakure both looked at Shouto, who kept his gaze fixed on the ground.

“A-are you sure?” Mina asked, voice hushed.

“It was definitely their car,” Izuku replied. “We didn’t see them, but it was outside a Seven Eleven, maybe an hour out from here.”

“We *should* have stuck around to confirm it,” Kaminari spat from his pit, arms crossed over his chest as he glared up at the ceiling. “But these guys all wanted to leave.”

“We had other fucking priorities,” Kacchan said shortly, words punctuated by the loud sound of his bat hitting the counter. “Like it or not, Dunce Face, that weren’t the fucking ti-”

“You don’t know that!” Kaminari yelled the room stunned into silence by the vehemence in his voice. “Quit acting like you talk for all of us!”

“We owed everyone the chance to decide,” Izuku said quickly, raising his hands placating as Kacchan began to snarl. “Just give us a moment to talk it over, ok Kaminari? All of us?”

Kaminari glared at him for a moment, before he scoffed. “Whatever.”

Izuku swallowed again, his eyes meeting Kirishima’s for just a moment, their concerns mirrored, as Mina spoke up.

“M-may we don’t have to do anything,” she said, even as Kaminari whirled around to gape at her. “Look, we have a plan, don’t we? One that’s already dangerous enough as it is! So, why don’t we just stick to that?”

“You want to just leave them there?” Kaminari demanded. “After everything they've put us through, you just want to walk away?”

“I don’t want to fight them!” Mina cried back. “I’ve never wanted that!”

“So, they just get away with it? For killing Jirou, *Sero* , they just get a free pass because you’re too much of a coward-”

“Hey!”

Kirishima’s voice, low in warning, struck them, his red eyes hard as he glared at Kaminari.

“Be mad all you like, but don’t you dare take this out on her,” he said.

“Ei, it’s ok, he’s just upset,” Mina said quietly.

“But how is what I said not true?” Kaminari countered, seemingly unbothered by the warning in Kirishima’s gaze. “We should have dealt with them after we left Tokyo. Sero shouldn’t have died! You all know I’m right!”

“And say that we had,” Kirishima shot back, looking furious now. “Say we did take a shot at them, and we messed it up and they came back and killed more of us?”

“We wouldn’t have let that happen,” Kaminari replied stubbornly before he looked over at Kacchan. “ *He* wouldn’t have.”

Kacchan paused from where he had been taking the supplies from his pack, a slither of red darting over the room as he sensed their eyes on him.

“It was never as simple as that!” Kirishima yelled. “Bakugou was too sick to do anything for months, Kaminari, *months* after we left Tokyo. And we had no idea that they had followed us to

Shinagawa!"

"Yeh we did!" Kaminari shouted back. "Bakugou saw them! Days before they came after us, he saw them!"

"Midoriya had *just* joined the group," Kirishima replied, running a hand through his hair, tense and exasperated. "We agreed that it wasn't fair to drag him into our mess-"

"We didn't agree *shit* ," Kaminari interrupted, the words spat from his lips. " *You* decided for us!"

"Oh, so that's just how it goes, huh?" Kirishima's eyes flashed, and Izuku had never seen the man so angry before. "It's just me or Bakugou making all the choices, and you never had a damn say in anything that went down, right? It's a hell of a lot easier to blame us, *right* ?"

"Ei-" Mina began, but Kirishima was quick to interrupt.

"No, Mina! I'm done listening to this!" Kirishima's voice seemed to tighten with the effort of holding back his emotions, his cheeks burning and his hands shaking. "So, what, we're cowards because we don't want to kill them? As if getting revenge is the *only* thing that matters, huh? Well, Mina matters to me! *You* matter to me! I am not going to risk the lives of more people I love over something that will only cause more pain!"

"Then Kyouka and Hanta must not have mattered as much to you as they did to me," Kaminari replied, voice cold and expression even cooler, a chill spreading over the room, the air harsh and frigid. Izuku saw the agony on Kirishima's face, the way that Mina seemed to deflate, and he stepped forward.

"That isn't true," he said firmly, almost standing between Kaminari and Kirishima now. He remembered it then… the pain that had been carved onto Kirishima's kind face the night that Sero died; the haunted ache in his eyes when Kacchan offered himself up to a zombie; the struggles he had faced trying to keep their group together after all that had happened. Kirishima loved them, he loved them fiercely.

"You know it isn't true," he continued, tone softer, looking directly at Kaminari now. "So stop this. Please, just stop, before you say something you can't take back."

"There is another way we can handle this," Kacchan announced, dragging their attention towards him. "We don't all need to go."

Izuku's mouth fell open. "What?"

"I don't need your help," Kacchan replied shortly, staring back at him. "I've got more than enough stuff here to make the dynamite I need for the stadium and then some. Me and Kaminari can deal with this all on our own."

Izuku wouldn't have believed it if he wasn't already very aware of how long Kacchan had been nursing his own grudge on Dabi and the rest.

"No," he said, shaking his head. "No, that's not a better way at all!"

“So, you’re on *their* side, then?” Kaminari spat, dragging Izuku’s attention back to him. “Even after he killed your entire group?”

“There are no *sides* ,” Izuku replied, as calmly as he could despite the frustration bubbling close to boiling point. He could feel Kacchan’s glare on him, heavy and impossible to ignore, and he tore his patch from his eye, head pounding heavily, a sharp pain forming in the arch of his brow.

“Look,” he said, after taking a deep breath. “I do understand, ok? You think I didn’t want them dead? That I wasn’t just as determined as you not so long ago that killing them was the only option we had? But then…” he shook his head, body trembling with emotion. “But then we found each other again. Kirishima is right. If you do this, if you go after Dabi, then they will kill you.”

“That’s why we’re fucking smart about it,” Kacchan snapped. “We do this shit right they won’t even know we’re there until it’s too fucking late-”

“And if you don’t do it right?” Izuku demanded, whirling around to face Kacchan again. “When was the last time something actually went right for us, huh? Hell, all it takes is one zombie! What do you think happens if it goes wrong?”

“Man, I… I won’t put Mina in danger like this,” Kirishima said, voice hushed. “Please, don’t-” he shook his head, his eyes looking pained and watery. “Don’t force me to choose between you and keeping her safe.”

Kacchan’s face seemed to soften, looking back at Kirishima in silence for the longest moment before he sighed.

“Ok, Shitty Hair.”

“Huh?” Kaminari looked at Kacchan in shock, seemingly the only one of them not flooded with relief as Kacchan backed down. “Just… just like that?”

“What the fuck do you want from me?” Kacchan said.

“This isn’t the only opportunity we’ll have,” Shouto said, speaking suddenly. “You’re all right, I’m not willing to drag Momo and Hagakure into a fight that has nothing to do with them, either. But if we get to UA, and everyone is safe, I’m not going to just let this go.”

“Shouto,” Izuku breathed. “I know they hurt you, but-”

“It isn’t just about that,” Shouto replied. “It isn’t just about what they’ve already done to me, or you, or anyone else here. It’s about what they could do to someone else. He’s *my* brother. And I know he only did it to torture me, but he left me alive, and it’s my responsibility to be sure that he regrets that.”

A heavy silence filled the room, Izuku looked back into Shouto’s determined face, his chest aching.

“Fine,” Kaminari all but whispered, after a moment. “But after UA I’m going to help you.”

Shouto nodded. “I won’t stop you.”

The tension between the group somehow only grew after that. Izuku could see that Kirishima and Mina were both deeply affected by the things that Kaminari had said; much to his surprise, he saw little effort on Kaminari's part to reconcile, either. Kaminari had never seemed like a cruel person, and despite the cruel *words* that had left his lips, Izuku still didn't believe for a heartbeat that he was. But, his hatred for Dabi, and the festering wounds left behind by the loss of Jirou and Sero, had all carved scar tissue that ran deep, and that wasn't something that he could get over in a single day. Izuku hoped that it would only take time for him to heal, and not something far more valuable.

That very same day, Kacchan took Kirishima and Mina to the Police Station that he had in mind to prepare the chemicals and explosives. Izuku tried not to feel too disheartened by being asked to stay behind because he knew that it made sense. Kirishima, Mina, and Kaminari each needed space from each other right now, and Kacchan wasn't about to trust Kaminari alone with people that he hardly knew. But, feeling as though he was left here on babysitting duty didn't exactly ease any discomforts he had after the last conversation he and Kacchan had had. The man *had* promised that they would talk, Izuku could only trust that he meant it.

But, for the following week, Izuku saw very little of Kacchan. It had been decided that Kaminari would be the one to accompany him to the Station each day, to assist and keep watch when it was needed, and Kaminari sure as shit wasn't stupid enough not to realise that it was done so Kacchan could keep an eye on him. They only returned to the playground to sleep, and more nights than not, Kacchan would take off for a late-night patrol alone before coming back in the early hours of the morning. He was exhausted, Izuku could tell as much on the rare occasions he saw him, but Kaminari seemed to slowly ease back into his old self. Izuku was relieved to see Kaminari sitting with Kirishima and Mina on the morning of the fourth day, the three of them laughing about something like nothing had even happened.

Spending so much time away from Kacchan did have one perk, however. Izuku was with Shouto most hours of the day, the two of them going on patrols, finally offered the chance to catch up and rekindle the comfortable friendship they had once had. The last six months had changed the both of them, that much was obvious, but Izuku was happy to realise that talking to Shouto felt as easy as it had ever done, laughing and smiling softly over old memories. But, Izuku was surprised that it took until the fifth day for Shouto to finally bring up the elephant in the room, the two of them walking in companionable silence back from a recent patrol around the perimeter of the Station where Kacchan and Kaminari were working in.

"Are you and Bakugou dating?"

Izuku almost tripped over his own feet, expecting the question at some stage, but not for it to be worded like that or announced quite so suddenly. He steadied himself, looking back over his shoulder at Shouto and hoping his face didn't look quite so red as it felt.

"Uh," he replied. "I wouldn't call it *that* …"

"What, dating?"

"Right, right… well, you can't really d-date in the Apocalypse, y'know?" Izuku said, with an awkward laugh, twisting his axe in his hands anxiously. Shouto nodded, his expression looking serious as he hummed.

"So you're sleeping together, then?"

Izuku squeaked, the axe flying right out of his fingers and clattering to the pavement.

“Uh!” he repeated, grabbing the weapon and shoving it into his pocket.

“It’s fine, you don’t have to answer if it makes you uncomfortable.”

Izuku swallowed, Shouto looking back at him calmly, not giving any hints as to how he was feeling. Izuku knew there was no sense in lying; he’d never kept anything hidden from him before, and he certainly didn’t plan to start doing that now. But he was acutely aware of the potential to hurt Shouto’s feelings, and he would never forgive himself if he caused his friend yet more pain.

“No, no it’s fine, uh…” He rubbed his arms, eyes darting up and down the road they were standing on out of sheer habit. “Yeh. We… once, yes.”

Shouto’s eyebrows rose just a fraction, his face finally betraying a certain curiosity and, to Izuku’s unease, relief.

“Oh,” he said. “Well, I guess that makes sense. He’s kind of an asshole, but I suppose he’s not exactly bad looking and sounds like you were alone together for quite a while.”

Izuku started to chew at his lips, realising that Shouto had quickly come to his own conclusion as to the nature of his and Kacchan’s relationship.

“It isn’t-” he started, fighting the frightening desire to step back when Shouto looked at him again. “That is to say… We only slept together once but we’ve done… other stuff. A few times..”

“Oh,” Shouto said again, but there was a hesitation there this time, and he laughed to himself. “Right, sorry, I’m being an idiot.”

“No, you’re not,” Izuku protested immediately. “ *I’m* sorry. I should have… said something sooner, I guess.”

“Why didn’t you?”

“Because…” Izuku sighed. “Honestly, I don’t really know what Kacchan and I are right now if we were ever really anything like… y’know *that* .”

“Oh.”

“Things have just gotten awkward, and he doesn’t want to talk to me anymore and…” Izuku raised a hand to idly press at the patch over his eye. How exactly did he explain to Shouto that he was probably terminally in love with a man that he couldn’t kiss, who hardly said a single word to him, and who had displayed little else than disdain towards him ever since Shouto had joined the group? But Shouto just looked back at him with that endlessly patient and understanding face, and Izuku knew he had to say *something* .

“It’s complicated,” he said with a groan, hating how it sounded like he was talking about a crush in high school. Shouto nodded, watching him carefully.

“Do you want to talk about it?” he asked.

Izuku hoped to god that his expression didn’t betray the fact that that was the very *last* thing he’d ever want to talk to Shouto about, and shook his head.

“I’m ok,” he said. “Plus, there’s more important things to worry about right now than silly things like that.”

Izuku could tell that Shouto was disappointed and curious, but he mercifully chose not to push the matter, and he didn’t bring up Kacchan again after that.

Two days later, a full week after Kacchan had started working to put the bombs together, Izuku was woken from another fitful night's sleep by a sharp nudge to his side. He twitched, hand reaching for his knife as his blurry vision took a moment to figure out who the figure looming over him was the slightest hint of red in the gloom.

“Kacchan?” Izuku put a hand to his chest, his heart still hammering, and he slid the knife back into place on his thigh. “You scared the shit out of me. Is everything ok?”

Kacchan said nothing, just a jerky nod as he glared expectantly down at him. Izuku frowned, glancing to the side to see that Shouto was still fast asleep. It was dark, probably still very early, and the only person he could see awake was Kaminari, sitting on the counter by the door, back against the wall as he turned the page of a manga he was holding, reading by candlelight. He sat himself up, reaching for the black elasticated eyepatch that Hagakure had fashioned for him, Kacchan becoming more clear as he covered his bad eye.

“Kacchan, what’s going on?”

“Kaminari’s taking the day off,” Kacchan replied, his voice a low grunt as he did his best not to be overheard. “You’re coming with me instead.”

Izuku looked across to Kaminari again, before his eyes darted back to Kacchan. Izuku supposed that this was his way of saying that he was ready to talk.

“Ok, sure. Lemme just get my stuff.”

Kacchan offered him another jerky nod, before turning on his heel and marching back towards Kaminari. Izuku grabbed his pack and pulled a stick of old gum from one of the pockets, fully aware that Kacchan probably didn’t have the patience to wait for him to brush his teeth, and got to his feet. He paused for just a moment, debating waking Shouto and telling him where he was going, but realised that there was probably no sense in worrying the man when Kaminari could explain the situation later.

When he joined Kacchan by the front door, Kaminari was pointedly trying not to show too much interest, but the way his eyes kept darting up from the manga betrayed that he was at least aware of something, and Izuku wondered how much he already knew.

“You good to explain everything to Kirishima when he wakes up?” Kacchan was asking, and Kaminari offered him a salute and a nod.

“No problem, boss.”

“Don’t fucking call me that. I got the walkie, give us a heads up before you go on patrol, just so I know it’s you creeping around out there.”

“Yes, sir!”

“Fucker, take this seriously!”

“I am, I am,” Kaminari replied with a snigger. “I got it covered. You two have fun on your date, m’kay? Be home by dinner.”

“Fuck you.”

Kacchan marched towards the door, not stopping to check that Izuku was following, and Izuku quickly dropped Kaminari a wave before he hurried after him, the two of them stepping out onto the dark parking lot outside.

It was freezing, the sky above so clear that the light of the moon was enough to illuminate their way, their hot breaths clouding up around them. Kacchan grunted out a short *“come on”* , waving his arm in a gesture for Izuku to follow, and the pair started to make their way to the Station in silence.

Izuku didn’t trust himself to speak for the first ten minutes of their journey, staying quiet and alert, doing his very best to watch the streets around them rather than the back of Kacchan’s head, short hair entirely obscured by the camo print bobble hat he had yanked down over his ears. Izuku wasn’t especially keen on the cold, but Kacchan *hated* it, bundled up in so many layers to keep warm that he was always complaining about how much it hindered his mobility. Izuku wondered if he had always been this sensitive to the cold, or if it had started after his bite, before immediately forcing himself to think about something else.

But, Izuku was suddenly offered plenty to think about when Kacchan took an abrupt left turn, heading in the opposite direction of the Police Station, and Izuku hurried up beside him, pointing back to where they ought to have been walking.

“Kacchan, the Station is that way.”

“I know that,” Kacchan replied shortly.

“So?”

“So what?”

“So, why are we walking in the opposite direction?”

Kacchan heaved a long-suffering sigh, flashing Izuku with an irritated glare.

“We’re going somewhere else, obviously.”

“Oh…” Izuku chewed his lower lip. “Uh, where?”

“You’ll find out when we get there.”

Izuku opened his mouth to argue the point, before shutting it with a huff, knowing that there really was no point in pushing the matter, and after only a few more minutes, Izuku realised where they

were headed.

The wide-open street was still stained with blood, the bodies of the zombies that he had killed barely over a week ago now decomposing in the middle of the road, and Izuku found himself slowing to a halt, his heart hammering hard in his chest.

“Kacchan, why are we here?”

He hadn’t meant for his voice to come out so quiet, a shiver of fear running through his words, and Kacchan stopped in front of him, back turned and head hanging.

“You wanted to talk,” Kacchan replied. “But I’m just… I’m so tired of talking, Deku.”

Izuku frowned, those words sending a chill down his spine. “What do you mean?”

Kacchan kept his eyes on the ground, shoving his hands into his pockets.

“I’ve been coming back here every night since we found that stupid fucking station wagon,” he replied. “I thought maybe I could get some answers, at last. Make my damn mind up.”

“Make your mind up about what?” Izuku breathed.

Kacchan sighed, before finally looking back over his shoulder. Any facade he had been showing to the rest of their group was now gone, the man looking suddenly much smaller than he had ever done before. He looked exhausted, his arms hanging at his side, eyes somewhat unfocused, and he appeared so… so sad. Not angry, not annoyed, just achingly sad, and Izuku already felt his eyes start to sting.

“Kacchan,” he started, walking forward, arms outstretched almost entirely on instinct, wanting nothing more than to pull Kacchan close, touch his face and wipe that expression away. But Kacchan held out a palm, shaking his head.

“This way.”

Izuku didn’t hesitate to follow him as Kacchan began to approach the garden of one of the larger homes on the road, a large wire gate surrounding the property, the front of it secured with what looked like a telephone wire. Kacchan came to a halt just in front of it, and as Izuku walked to his side he heard the sound of something dragging itself across the scuffed turf. Izuku immediately recognised the zombie that came into view; its legs were missing from the knees down, pulling itself along by its hands, the tips of its fingers worn down and bloody up to the second knuckle. This was the zombie that Kacchan had told him to leave, the night that they had found Shouto.

“Figured it wouldn’t be too hard to find her,” Kacchan said, and Izuku was struck by the way Kacchan said *‘her’* and not *‘it’* like he normally would, the unease only growing. “Turns out she hadn’t gone far in a couple of days, what with her hands being all busted up, too.”

Izuku stayed quiet, eyes darting from the zombie to Kacchan, a distinct lack of emotion on his face as he watched it drag itself right up to the gate, teeth gnawing on the metal wire.

“I know you noticed it,” Kacchan continued. “You see everything, always have. The zombie back at the university listened to me too, and I couldn’t stop thinking about it. So, I came back here.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathed. “Please, it doesn’t have to mean what you think it means-”

“No, it does,” Kacchan replied simply before he took a deep breath. “ *Stop.* ”

At once, the zombie in front of them stopped its incessant biting at the wire bars, freezing with its mouth wide open, and Izuku felt his entire body go cold.

“She doesn’t understand what I’m actually saying,” Kacchan said. “Only the basic intent behind the words, at least that’s what I’m guessing. If I tell her to touch her face she won’t, because she doesn’t have any fucking clue where her face is. She’s a sack of rotting flesh, there’s nothing of the person she was in there.”

Izuku listened in silence, hardly daring to breathe.

“Tried all sorts of shit,” Kacchan continued. “But only thing I can really make her do is stop, follow and-” he paused, his expression now darkening, a haunted look in his eyes as a low growl left his throat “- *eat.* ”

The zombie immediately threw itself forward, frantic in its movements and jaw snapping around the metal gate so violently that Izuku took a step back, his hand dropping down to the weapons at his belt. Kacchan didn’t flinch, just watching with an eerie calm as the zombie grew desperate to break through the bars.

“I can’t do anything once she’s in this state,” Kacchan said. “Once they’re in this feeding frenzy it’s just all instinct until they can’t detect us anymore. She’ll stay like this until I leave.”

Izuku was breathing heavily now. He watched as the zombie’s hand thrust forward, seeming to get in the way as it bit down again, catching itself on the arm, before all at once the violence intensified, and the zombie started to bite down harder, ripping and tearing its own flesh. The bile rose to this throat as the zombie proceeded to eat itself, cracking through bone with only the mindless desire to fill its filthy stomach.

“There isn’t anything for us to talk about,” Kacchan muttered. “I’m turning. Might only be weeks, hell *days* before I’m one of those things.”

“No,” Izuku said immediately, reaching out to grab Kacchan’s arm. The man didn’t resist as he pulled him around, hands resting against Kacchan’s cold cheeks so he could look him in the eyes. “We don’t know that. Have you been having the blackouts? The headaches?”

Kacchan looked back at him, before slowly shaking his head.

“There you go then!” Izuku exclaimed with a somewhat desperate laugh, drowning out the sound of the zombie devouring itself for just a moment. “Kacchan, *baby* , we still have options, ok?”

“Deku-”

“I know how you feel about it, I really do, but UA could have answers. Some of the most brilliant pathologists in the world worked there, they could still *be* there! And your ability to withstand the virus for so long could bring answers and I *promise* I won’t let them hurt you. I won’t let any of them do anything you don’t want-”

“Izuku.”

Izuku paused, as Kacchan reached his hand out, brushing a thumb against his cheek.

“You’re the smartest man I know, but somehow you still manage to be so fucking dumb sometimes.”

“Kacchan?”

“They already have people like me,” Kacchan replied. “Come on, Deks. The stadium full of zombies? Who do you think put them there, who really? And how could they do it without someone like me who can control them?”

“No,” Izuku replied immediately, without thinking. “No, that isn’t… maybe they had another way-”

“That is the only way. They have people like me in there already, and they’re not using them to try and cure this fucking virus, they’re using them as a weapon. I won’t do it, Deku. I’m not going with you to UA.”

Izuku felt his world crashing down around him, the blood rushing past his ears so loudly he couldn’t hear a damn thing. He wasn’t sure when he had started to cry, but his cheeks felt tacky, his patch clinging uncomfortably to his skin. He sniffed, raising a hand to roughly wipe his face clean.

“Then I’m going wherever you’re going,” Izuku said firmly. Kacchan’s face crumpled then, shaking his head.

“I don’t want you to.”

“No,” Izuku said. “No, I’m not doing this again-”

“I want you to go to UA,” Kacchan interrupted, grabbing his face firmly. “I want you to take our dumb fucking friends somewhere safe, and I want you to keep protecting them. I want you to find your mum. I want you and that burnt face fucker to fall in love or some shit so he can make you happy, *actually happy* . I want you to live, Izuku. Really, truly live.”

Izuku shook his head, almost dislodging Kacchan’s hands as he began to sob freely. “I don’t want any of that!” he cried petulantly. “I want you! I just want-” the words caught in his throat as he remembered, all too suddenly and painfully, what Kirishima had said to him only a week before.

“I’m saying he deserves the right to make the choice for himself. In this world as it is, I think we should all be able to choose how we leave it, don’t you?”

The sob that left his throat hurt, and Izuku fell forward, pressing his wet face against Kacchan’s chest as he clung to him. He felt arms wrap tightly around him, Kacchan seeming to sway gently in place as he pressed his cheek on the top of Izuku’s head. They didn’t speak for a moment, just holding one another, the sound of the zombie now just background noise. Eventually, Izuku found the strength to ask.

“What are you going to do?”

“I’m gonna take care of the zombies in that stadium, for starters,” Kacchan replied. “Continue the plan so you guys can get into UA.”

“A-and then?”

“I’m going to kill Dabi. Kaminari and that fancy fuck won’t be pleased, but at least they won’t get themselves killed in the process. I’ll take care of them, and you won’t have to worry about them

anymore."

Izuku scrunched his face up. "A-after that?"

Kacchan was quiet for a moment, his hand slowly rubbing up and down Izuku's back before he replied. "If I have time? Back to Shinagawa. I don't doubt UA will take you in when they realise who you are, but there's another one of the mutant zombies back there, and I want to get to her before they do."

Kacchan took a deep breath. "And that's what I'll do. I'll look for more zombies like me, put them out of their misery, so that no one can use them, right up until the time I can't anymore."

Izuku didn't need to ask what happened then. He already knew, and he only clung tighter.

"Izuku," Kacchan said softly, pausing. "I need to know if you are going to let me do that."

A whine left Izuku's throat, grimacing against the unbearable pain in his chest.

"'Zuku." Kacchan took his arms, pushing him back so that he could look him in the eye, and Izuku was filled with so much love and adoration as he stared back at that beautiful face, tears leaking as freely down his cheeks as they did Izuku's. He loved him, and he wanted to die with him. He wanted to stand by Bakugou Katsuki's side right until the very end. But if he did that, if he followed this man to the ends of the earth… then he would break his heart. To go with Kacchan would be to destroy him, and no matter how much he loved him, Kirishima was right. Izuku had no right to do that to him.

"Yes," Izuku finally replied, his voice no louder than a whisper.

Kacchan shut his eyes tight, before he was pulling Izuku to him again, now crying into his shoulder, no longer trying to hide anything. Kacchan cried and cried, Izuku whispering soft words, stroking his head, his back, and Kacchan thanked him between sobs. The two men clung to each other for some time after that, as the sun rose and the rotting bodies cast strangely beautiful shadows across the ground, bathing them both in a warm comforting light.

They left sometime after that, hand in hand as they walked to the Police Station, and once inside Izuku could not stop himself from pulling Kacchan to him once more, and pressing soft needy lips against his jaw and his throat. They peeled their clothes from one another, featherlight touches and gasps as if neither of them could believe that they were being allowed to touch, allowed to be so close, until the thread snapped and Kacchan was begging, wanting Izuku closer *closer* . It had been entirely on accident, but Izuku always kept the condoms and wipes in his pack, and as time passed in a heavy daze, he was inside Kacchan again, clinging to his shoulders, his hips, anything that he could reach as he became lost in a sea of crimson. And when the climax came, like waves hitting the shore, it was to a chorus of *I love you's* soft lips and delicate touches against their skin.

The day continued in a kind of haze after that. They didn't speak much, Izuku standing slightly off to the side as he watched Kacchan work, the latter occasionally explaining what he was doing like he thought one-day Izuku would be able to replicate until it began to grow dark again. The two walked back to the playground hand in hand before it became impossible to see.

Kirishima looked puzzled when the two of them came back, a frown on his face as he looked expectantly past them at the door.

“Hey,” he said. “Isn’t Kaminari with you?”

Alarm bells immediately started to ring.

“No, he was supposed to stay here today.”

Shouto approached them, furious and glaring at Kacchan.

“Where is it?” he demanded, and Kacchan bristled, standing himself tall and snarling right back.

“Where’s *what* , you candy cane freak?”

“The *gun* ,” Shouto replied, throwing his hands in the air. “I know you took it!”

“I didn’t take shit, asshole!”

“Oh no,” Izuku gasped, feeling sick. “Oh god…”

“What?” Shouto asked. But Kirishima was already staring at Izuku in shock, and Kacchan had stiffened.

“No,” Kirishima breathed. “No, fuck no, he wouldn’t?”

Izuku took a shaky breath. “He’s gone after Dabi.”

Chapter End Notes

Welp.

This chapter was so satisfying to write, even if I did genuinely make myself sob a little as I was writing it. I've mulled this conversation between Izuku and Kacchan over in my head so many times over the last freaking year and it felt good to get it out.

Also, we got a nice little expansion to the zombie lore! Finally, you're starting to see the tangled mess of theories in my head. I appreciate that it probably won't hold up to any scientific scrutiny, and I'm certainly not saying that auto-brewery syndrome is the starting point on the path to cannibalism, but damn I was so excited to be able to start dropping in more hints. Also, if you don't hear from me again after this, it's because the FBI kicked down my door after looking through my search history for this chapter...

I hope you enjoyed this chapter (pffft, yeh right I hope it motherfucking HURT) and thanks for reading.

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Chapter 35: Blood, Sweat and Fears III

Chapter Summary

In which our group finally comes face to face with the League of Bastards

Chapter Notes

CW: Character death. Graphic descriptions of gore/violence. Body horror. Gun violence. Brief mention of rape though it does not happen.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Don't they know it's the end of the world?

"What do we do?"

Frantic voices filled the room, a flurry of activity that left Izuku's already thrumming head spinning as he tried to make sense of what was going on around him.

"When did he leave?"

"Did he really take the gun?"

Izuku looked across the room, his eyes landing on the only other person who wasn't yelling. Mina stood beside Kirishima, her hazel eyes sparkling with unshed tears, ghostly against her dark skin.

"Mina," Izuku said, cutting through the noise and getting her attention. Kirishima started then, looking down to see the frightened look on her face. "Do you know when he left?" Izuku asked, softly.

"He- he left with you guys, right?" Mina replied, voice thick as she tried to hold back her tears. "He woke us up to say he was going like he's done every morning this week. He just said that you were coming with them and… I didn't think there was anything wrong! Oh god, he's been gone all day and we didn't even realise!"

"Hey, hey," Kirishima said, placing a hand on her shoulder and bending so that he could look her in the eye. "It's ok, he didn't want you to know, we couldn't have known-"

"How could I have *not* known?" Mina choked back, pushing his hand away and shaking her head. "He's my friend! He's my friend, I should have noticed."

There was a loud thud from behind them, and Izuku looked around to see Kacchan grabbing a box that he had filled with weapons and alcohol, scraps of cloth spilling out onto the floor as he dug about.

“What are you doing?” Hagakure asked.

“Going after the dumb bastard, what do you think?” Kacchan said back, grabbing a leather satchel and securing it around one of his thighs.

“Do you have any of the bombs ready?”

“No, nothing is fucking ready yet,” Kacchan replied, irritated. “And if he’s been gone since this morning then I don’t have time to make anything else!” He slipped knives into the satchel, before attaching more around his waist. “Not like I’ll have the element of surprise on my damn side, either. That moron!”

He got back to his feet, reaching for his bat and snatching at one of the walkie-talkies.

“Lock the doors behind me,” he instructed. “As big an idiot as he is, I don’t think Kaminari would ever willingly give away our position to them, but that don’t mean they haven’t already figured it out.”

“Kacchan, wait,” Izuku said, “I’m coming with you-”

“The hell you are!” Kacchan snapped, spinning on his heel, his voice so loud it made Izuku wince. “I already got one lost dumbass to go find, I don’t need another!”

“Yeh, I’m coming too,” Mina announced.

“What the fuck? No, you’re not!”

“If Mina’s going then so am I,” Kirishima said.

“He’s my brother, I’m not letting you guys handle him on your own,” Shouto added.

“I don’t need any of you coming with me!” Kacchan yelled. “I swear to *fuck* keeping you idiots alive wouldn’t be this fucking difficult if you just *listened* to me!

“Katsuki, I know you’re just trying to look out for us,” Mina said, “but if you keep yelling at me, I *will* kick your ass.”

“ *Hah?!”*

“What Mina’s trying to say is that you can’t stop us,” Kirishima interrupted. “Not this time, buddy. We’re coming with you.”

“We’re stronger as a team,” Izuku agreed. “There’s still time to come up with a good plan.”

Kacchan glared at him before he swore and threw both hands in the air.

“Fine! But you follow my fucking lead, you hear me? Oi, fuck face!”

Shouto hummed, looking up at Kacchan. “I presume you mean me.”

“You *are* the only fuck face here I see,” Kacchan replied waspishly. “Those zombies you saw at the University, how many were there?”

Shouto’s brow rose in surprise. “Why do you ask that?”

“Just fucking answer me!”

Shouto scowled. “Twenty-seven.”

Kacchan chewed on his lip, eyes dropping down as if he was deep in thought before he nodded. “Right, that’ll have to do. Now grab your shit, we’ve wasted enough time already.”

“Wait, Bakugou,” Kirishima said, grabbing his arm. “What do we need the zombies for?”

Kacchan and Izuku’s eyes met for barely a moment before he was pulling his arm out of Kirishima’s reach.

“They used zombies against us before, right?” he said. “Well, I say it’s about time they got a taste of their own fucking medicine. Last chance if you want out.”

Not one of them wanted out. Even Hagakure and Yaoyorozu set off with them; Yaoyorozu reminding them that, if something happened then it would only be a matter of time before Dabi and his group came looking for them. Kaminari had taken their gun, and that left the both of them very exposed if they had stayed behind, and despite Shouto’s protests, there was no dissuading them. As determined as the group might seem, weapons in hand and focused, Izuku marched alongside them with dread pooling in his gut, willing his heart to stop hammering and for his palms to stop sweating around the grip of his axe.

“I don’t understand why he would do this,” Hagakure said, after a prolonged period of silence, clearly aching to ask the question since they had set off. She hesitantly looked around at them, before continuing. “He must have known how dangerous this was.”

“Of course, he knew it was dangerous,” Kirishima said, voice rough. “I guess he just… he didn’t think he had any other choice.”

The group fell silent again now, following Kacchan’s lead, the man himself had not spoken a word since they had left, his expression hard.

“Hey, Katsuki,” Mina said eventually. “Did… did he say anything to you? The time you were together?”

Kacchan glanced back, his jaw clenching for a moment, before doggedly avoiding her gaze.

“Yeh. He said some stuff.”

When Kacchan didn’t elaborate, Mina hurried forward to walk beside him, her hand reaching out to

touch his arm. “Katsuki?”

Kacchan looked uncomfortable. “Look, it ain’t my place-”

“Dude,” Kirishima interrupted. “If it’s important… if there’s something we missed, please tell us.”

“He told me shit in confidence, Shitty Hair,” Kacchan snapped back, expression harried. “Look, he didn’t say anything to make me think that he would go off on his own like this if that’s what you’re asking. He was angry, and he sure as shit took losing Jirou and Sero harder than any of us probably realised, and that’s on us for not realising. But when I outright asked him he said he weren’t gonna do anything stupid. And that’s on *me* for fucking believing him, I guess.”

Kacchan felt betrayed, that was clear to see. But Izuku could also see the guilt etched into his tired features, a faraway look in his eyes that Izuku had seen all too many times before. He knew that Kacchan was blaming himself for not seeing just how hurt his friend was; for not being there to step in when he had needed to most. And in a sense, it was a feeling that they all shared. Izuku had *seen* it. Over and over again he had seen that Kaminari wasn’t ok. He had seen the red veil of anger that draped over Kaminari every time Dabi and his group were mentioned and saw the agony in his eyes whenever they talked about Sero or Jirou. He watched the hatred grow, becoming poison whilst the rest of them slowly learned to live with it, maybe even… to move on. From what Kacchan had told him, Izuku was sure that Kaminari had loved Jirou, perhaps he had even been *in love* with her. And Sero had been his anchor, had been his closest friend, the person that had talked him off the proverbial ledge before he too had been taken away by the very same people that had stolen Jirou. Izuku knew that Jirou and Sero’s deaths had impacted Kacchan in a big way, and fuck he had turned to alcohol and violence as a means to deal with that. But Kaminari? He cracked his jokes, he charged onwards, he hid behind his humour just as Kacchan hid behind his rage, the facade cracking just a little more day by day until he could no longer shelter behind it. As frustrated and as afraid as he was, Izuku found Kaminari’s snap perfectly predictable; and he was disgusted with himself for not having done something about it sooner.

No one spoke again after that, not until they had finally neared the University, Shouto wandering up to stand beside Kacchan.

“It’s not likely that the zombies will still be here,” he said, ignoring the foul look that Kacchan shot in his direction. “It’s been a week.”

“Me and Deku killed one of them things in there,” Kacchan replied shortly, jabbing his thumb over his shoulder. “And that group wasn’t heading towards UA like the rest of ‘em. I got a hunch they’ll still be around, and all we gotta do is get their attention.”

“How do we do that?” Mina asked.

Kacchan roughly shoved Shouto’s side, pushing away from them and pulling one of the knives from the holster about his thigh, before throwing her smirk.

“Two fucking years of the Apocalypse and you don’t know how to attract zombies?”

Kacchan extended his arm and pulled up his sleeve, and Izuku barely had time to yell his name before Kacchan sliced along his upper forearm, blood immediately splattering onto the ground.

“Kacchan what the fuck are you doing!” Izuku yelled, darting forwards with arms outstretched, ready to help. But Kacchan wrenched his arm away, blood steadily leaking down to his fingertips.

“Don’t touch it!” he snapped back, sounding all too frantic to be angry, and Izuku halted, eyes dropping to the bright red liquid dripping onto the tarmac, remembering all too slowly just how dangerous Kacchan’s blood was.

“What the hell, Katsuki! I can’t believe you just did that!” Kirishima was saying. “What if it gets infected or something? We don’t have any meds!”

“It’ll be fine, moron. I take care of my knives unlike any of you,” Kacchan said. “Just grab me something to wrap it with will ya?”

Kirishima grumbled angrily to himself as he pulled his pack around and started to rummage inside.

“You didn’t have to do that,” Izuku said, quiet enough that only Kacchan could hear. Kacchan huffed.

“How else were you planning on attracting ‘em? We know them fuckers all wanna eat me first. Give me a break, Deku, I’ve thought this through.”

Izuku sighed, looking up as Kirishima approached with a length of bandaging, Kacchan taking it with his good arm and proceeding to wrap it around his wound.

“Right,” Kacchan said, bandaging between his teeth as he pulled it tight, the rest of the group watching him in alarm. “If they’re about, they’ll smell that. And Deku’s girly screaming probably only helped.”

“Hey!”

“We wait, fifteen minutes tops. If no zombies come then we’re doing this without them, Kaminari has been with those assholes for way too long already.”

“When you say *doing this without them* ,” Shouto asked, eyeing the blood staining the ground. “How exactly were you planning on doing this, uh, *with them?* ”

Kacchan rolled his eyes, tucking the bandage in on itself before he pulled his sleeve back down. “We’re gonna lead a bunch of zombies towards their hideout,” he replied. “Use them to escape as soon as we get our idiot back.”

“But, what about Kaminari?” Mina asked, nervous. “Aren’t we just as likely going to get him killed?”

“Nah,” Kacchan replied firmly. “What do we know about these assholes? Firstly, Dabi’s got a fucking hard-on for me and there’s no fucking way he’s going to resist the urge to start gloating when he realises I’m out there.”

Shouto made a strange choking noise from the side.

“Secondly, they’re not going to kill Kaminari until it benefits them to do so.”

“That’s cold,” Kirishima muttered. “But you’re probably right.”

“Unless by some miracle Kaminari has managed to get the bastards, they’ll be holding onto him waiting for us to come and rescue his ass, so…” Kacchan threw his bat over his shoulder. “I say we offer ‘em a trade.”

“A trade?” Izuku repeated blankly. “We don’t exactly have anything we can offer them. I don’t think food or weapons is going to cut it.”

“None of that,” Kacchan replied before he pulled another smirk that far more resembled a grimace. “We trade me.”

Izuku felt his jaw drop as Mina and Kirishima erupted, staring at Kacchan in disbelief.

“I don’t understand,” Shouto said, his even voice cutting through the outraged splutterings of the couple. “Why would they trade Kaminari for you? If we should be trading anyone it should be me.”

“First of all, far as we know they have no idea you’re still alive. We can use that. They’ll expect these three to be there, but you, Ponytail and Bangs can have the element of surprise if we need it.”

Shouto frowned.

“And second of all, *I’m* the one Dabi wants. I pissed him off back in Tokyo, then I blew half his fucking face off. Trust me, Half ‘n’ Half, they’ll do the trade.”

“And then they’ll shoot you and try to shoot us after!” Izuku interrupted, exasperated. “This isn’t a good plan!”

“They couldn’t shoot all of us,” Shouto said, and Izuku swung around to gape at him. “Not quick enough anyway. It only holds four bullets at a time.”

“So they can still shoot *four* of us, what’s your point?”

“The point is, they ain’t stupid,” Kacchan replied. “They’ll agree to the trade because it’s the best fucking deal for them, and once they get me Dabi’s not about to shoot me in the head and be done with, that sick bastard is gonna want to enjoy it.”

“That is not making me feel any better about this, Kacchan!”

“They won’t shoot Kaminari because then the trade’s off,” Kacchan continued loudly, talking over him. “And if they shoot anyone after the trade then, not only would they risk attracting a bunch of zombies to them, but they’ll have a fucking fight on their hands to boot.”

“So, the only way to get Kaminari back is to let them have you?” Kirishima said, shaking his head. “Nah, that’s stupid. We’re not doing that!”

“They don’t get to keep me, Shitty Hair,” Kacchan said. “That’s what the zombies are for.”

“Katsuki-”

“The second you guys get Kaminari back, I’ll call the zombies to me,” Kacchan said. And Izuku *understood* , he knew exactly what Kacchan meant by that, but none of the others had any idea that Kacchan had any control over them, and Kirishima gaped at him like he was crazy.

“Since when were you a freaking zombie whisperer!” Mina cried, throwing her hands into the air. “ *Katsuki-* ”

“Just, trust me alright?” Kacchan said, reaching out to grab her arms and lowering them down to her front. “Ain’t no one spent as much time around these things as me. I had hundreds of them on my tail back at the hospital and gave them all the slip. I got a pretty good idea of how to manage them. Besides, *I’m* the one that smells of blood. They’ll be focused on me. All we have to do is keep ahead of them, and you let me do the rest.”

“This still sounds like a massive risk,” Kirishima said. “If any of those zombies are, y’know, *fresh* then it’s not going to be so easy to stay ahead without losing half the horde when we’re running.”

“They aren’t fresh,” Shouto said, his brow raised in understanding as he looked to Kacchan again. “But, you already knew that, didn’t you?”

“Deku figured some shit out at the University,” Kacchan explained. “They need to eat to survive, otherwise they just rot away.”

“How did you figure that out?” Yaoyorozu asked Izuku.

“Well, there was one in there that was almost too weak to even stand,” Izuku said. “I’ve not seen a zombie in that state before, and it must have been trapped in that one room at the university since close to the start of all of this.” He hesitated for just a moment, knowing how gross this was going to sound. “I, uh, well I cut it open, just to see what it had been living off the last two years.”

“Man, that’s nasty,” Kirishima muttered.

“It had been eating rats!” Izuku continued. “Without humans around, they still *have* to eat to sustain themselves.”

“And, think about it,” Kacchan said. “The longer this thing goes on for, the less food there is for the fuckers, and the hungrier they’re going to get. That’s probably why we’re seeing them travel across an entire city just to get to the one location people are definitely in. Those zombies that fuck face saw? They must have caught scent of us, and they’re probably starving enough to have been driven off course to find us.”

“And if they’re that hungry, they probably won’t have the energy to go very fast,” Shouto said, tapping his lower lip. “Smart.”

“Of course it’s smart, I thought of it,” Kacchan replied, rolling his eyes. “And besides, if there happen to be zombies in the group that can run, we just take them out and use the rest.”

It still sounded like way too simplified a plan for all the things that could go wrong with it, especially as no one else here had any idea that Kacchan would be able to have some limited control over them. Izuku expected more of an argument, but Kirishima looks satisfied, and the rest

of them looked like they were willing to see how things went.

“Not much of a plan if the zombies don’t turn up, though,” Hagakure said, looking around. “Why is it when you want some zombies there’s not a single one to be seen?”

Izuku laughed dryly at that. They must have been standing there for almost ten minutes already, before long it wouldn’t, and they would have to go after Kaminari without their backup plan. But, to his relief, it was only a short while later that the familiar and indescribably vile smell carried over on the breeze, and Izuku looked up to see the group of zombies dragging and stumbling their way towards them.

“About time,” Kacchan said.

Kacchan’s hunch had been right; these zombies didn’t look as bad as the one they had found in the university, but they weren’t far off it. Their skin was so sunken and leathery that it was impossible to determine what was skin and what was bone on their faces. However many months of travelling had gradually torn almost all of their clothing from them, just strips of fabric clinging onto areas where the rot had fused it to their bodies. Any distinguishing features were long gone; empty eyes sockets and wide gaping mouths were the only things looking back at them.

“If anything, they might be too far gone,” Izuku said, and Kacchan hummed, watching as the zombies made their unsteady way towards where his blood still stained the ground. Izuku then watched in shock as they did something he had never seen zombies do before then; they dropped to the ground, almost thirty of them jostling and smacking together as they scraped their jaws across the pavement, the high scratching sound like nails down a chalkboard leaving shivers running up Izuku’s spine. Without tongues, they couldn't lap up the blood, some of them biting down on the stone with enough force to crack their teeth.

“Oi!” Kacchan yelled, walking forward and waving his hands at them like he was trying to scare off a flock of pigeons. “You dumb fuckers, you ain’t gonna be any use to me if you got no teeth left!”

Only some of the zombies seemed to even acknowledge him, so focused on the blood that they didn’t even realise that a whole damn meal was yelling at them. Those that did suddenly scrabbled forward, getting their legs caught in the group and falling, only one of them managing to make any ground as it threw itself towards him. Kacchan side-stepped with ease, watching with something akin to disappointment as it landed on the ground again.

“They ain’t gonna put up much of a fight,” he said. “Fuck… it’ll have to do. Get ‘em riled up enough maybe there’s enough of them to get the job done.”

“Kacchan, by your foot,” Izuku said, watching a weak arm swipe out towards Kacchan’s boot. The man merely grunted, taking half a step back.

“Alright, let’s do this.”

Regardless of how slow these zombies were, Izuku could see that no one else in the group was nearly so comfortable as Kacchan was. *As he was* , he realised with a weird tug to his stomach, noticing for the first time that these zombies simply didn’t scare him like they should have done. Kacchan began to clap, waving his arms in the air again to try and get the attention of the zombies

still focused on the bloody pavement, and uncertainly their friends started to move, each of them casting nervous glances back as the zombie herd finally started to take notice, and shuffle after them.

It was a tense walk, the sound of cracking and thudding and scraping enough to unsettle even the strongest of stomachs as they lead the zombies towards the street corner where they had seen that League of Bastards' station wagon, Kirishima taking point as Kacchan and Izuku hung back to occasionally encourage the zombies to move faster. Kacchan's wound had bled through his bandaging, leaving a dark stain on his jacket that, when he saw Izuku staring at it, was dismissed with an irritable scoff. It took far longer than any of them would have liked, but eventually, they started to near the spot, Kirishima drawing them to an uncertain halt.

"OK, how are we doing this?" he asked.

"Fuck Face, Ponytail, and Bangs, it's best if you stay out of sight," Kacchan said. "If this goes to plan, none of you are gonna need to fight, but having someone watching our backs in case any more zombies come up would be useful."

Shouto hesitated, his jaw clenching.

"Look, I know this is about getting Kaminari back," he said, "but there's no way I can just watch Touya leave again. I'm not going to let him get away."

"If the zombies don't take care of him, I will," Kacchan replied firmly. "You don't do shit unless something goes seriously wrong."

Izuku could see that Shouto wanted to argue, but Kaminari was their biggest concern right now, and he understood that, looking instead around them for somewhere ideal to keep watch.

"We can probably use the balconies on those apartments there," he said, pointing to their right. "You got the walkie-talkie?"

"I've got it," Yaoyorozu replied, nodding.

"Alright," Shouto sighed. He met Izuku's eyes, looking back at him seriously. "Be careful."

"Always am," Izuku replied, both of them knowing what utter crap that was but still taking some comfort in his assurances. Izuku watched as Shouto, Yaoyorozu, and Hagakure hurried off in the direction of the apartment buildings, leaving their small band behind with the zombies gradually closing the distance between them again.

"We can't come at them from the same direction," Kacchan said. "I need the zombies following just me, not all of us."

"We should split into three," Izuku said, "so that it's not obvious that you're staying separate from us. Make it look like we're trying to be strategic."

Kacchan nodded his agreement. "Good idea. Puts them at a disadvantage too."

"They've almost caught up to us," Mina said, looking back at the zombies. "We need to move."

“Got it. You two take the block to the left, Deku you take right. I’ll lead the zombies straight down the middle.”

Kirishima and Mina nodded and headed off, and just as Izuku began to walk there was a gentle tug on his sleeve and he looked back.

“Don’t do anything stupid,” Kacchan said, eyes narrowed. “I fucking know you.”

“I just want Kaminari back and safe,” Izuku replied. Kacchan nodded, his throat bobbing as he swallowed.

“Be careful.”

Izuku smirked, before nodding his head towards the zombies now barely five meters from them.

“Me? You’re the one babysitting twenty-seven zombies.”

“Asshole.”

Izuku smiled again, hesitating just a moment before leaning forward and pressing a quick kiss to Kacchan’s cheek, hearing his sharp intake of breath at the contact. Before Izuku could get cold feet, he took off, ducking through an alley so that he could approach the Seven-Eleven from the right, trusting that Kacchan had his angle covered.

Once alone, Izuku began to feel the reality of the situation creep up on him again, his anxiety growing. No matter how he looked at it, they were still walking into this completely blind. They had no assurances that Kaminari was even there yet, and though Kacchan had seemed pretty certain of it, Izuku found he didn’t share his confidence when it came to how likely they were to have left Kaminari alive. They hadn’t heard any gunshots; something Izuku had kept to himself, but that unsettled him nonetheless. Sure, perhaps they had been outside of earshot, but Kaminari had taken the gun with the intention of *using* it, of that Izuku was damn sure, so why hadn’t he? Had he been caught before he even got the chance? Maybe he hadn’t even made it here… Kaminari was capable, sure, but alone in a city full of zombies wasn’t exactly the ideal situation for anyone, let alone someone dealing with as much anger and upset as Kaminari was. He climbed over the rubbish littering the alleyway, eyes focused forward as the store finally came back into view, and suddenly he didn’t have to wonder over Kaminari’s fate anymore.

The group were waiting for them; whether they had spotted them coming from some way back, or if they had just known they would be there, Izuku didn’t know, but all four of them were standing in the parking lot, Shouto’s gun held in Jin’s hands, a mean smile spreading across Dabi’s scarred face as his eyes focused on something ahead of them. There, crouched on the ground in front of them with blood covering half of his face and bruising obscuring the other, was Kaminari; his puffy eyes widening and his head shaking desperately as he, too, saw who was coming towards them.

“N-no!” Kaminari yelled, panicking, and pulling at the heavy black cable ties that secured his bloody wrists. “Get out of here!”

“Shut the fuck up.”

Kaminari yelped as Dabi raised a boot and kicked him in the back of the head, pushing him forward onto his face. Izuku heard an angry snarl, just as he clambered out onto the street.

“You touch him one more fucking time and I’ll break every single one of your fucking fingers,” Izuku heard Kacchan say, before Dabi started to laugh, reaching down and grabbing hold of the back of Kaminari’s jacket, wrenching him upwards again. Blood was streaming out of his nose, his mouth wide as he gasped for breath.

“Where are your fun little friends?” Toga asked with a pout on her lips. “You come here all on your own?”

“Nah, they’re here,” Shigaraki said, his cold voice sending shivers up Izuku’s spine, face turning to look at him. Izuku grit his teeth, his hands gripping hold of his axe as he boldly walked forward. Kacchan came into view to his left, and ahead of him he could see Kirishima and Mina closing in, and Dabi laughed again.

“If this was your idea of an ambush, it was a pretty shitty one,” he said. “You all outta tricks this time, huh?”

“You could make this easy,” Izuku said. “Let us have our friend back, and we’ll leave. No tricks, no fighting, we can still go our separate ways and forget all about this.”

Izuku could feel Kacchan’s eyes on him, but he didn’t acknowledge them. He *had* to try, however unlikely it might have seemed.

“So, you’re that stupidly optimistic kind, huh?” Dabi said, head thrown back with a wide smirk, his fingers now gripping hold of Kaminari’s hair so tightly his knuckles turned white. Kaminari groaned at his feet, blinking back the blood and grime in his eyes as he fought to make eye contact with Izuku as well.

“G-go,” Kaminari managed. “I-idiot-”

“And this one never stops talking,” Dabi interrupted, shaking his hand roughly and tearing a pained gasp from Kaminari. “How many times I gotta warn you, kiddo?”

“Just let him go,” Izuku said, hooking his axe into his belt and opting to hold both bare palms forward. “Don’t you think enough people have died already?”

Dabi hummed, finally letting go of Kaminari’s hair, the man slumping with relief.

“Jin.”

Before any of them could make a move, Jin took half a step back and aimed the gun directly at the back of Kaminari’s head, the barrel burying itself into his tangled hair.

“Don’t!” Mina cried.

“In fairness, one of *your* guys came here to kill *us* ,” Shigaraki said, lazily thrusting his hands into his pockets. “We’ve been minding our own business since Shinagawa. He’d have shot Dabi here right in the back of the skull if Toga hadn’t got the drop on him first. You’re not in a position to

negotiate *anything* .”

“You killed our people first,” Kacchan growled, voice low. “Our stray idiot sure as *shit* don’t make up for anything.”

“Technically, we didn’t kill either of them,” Toga said, rocking backwards and forwards on her heels with a delighted smile on her face. “Zombies did.”

“Your dumb lost puppy here had a lot to say about that before you got here,” Dabi said. “But far as I see it, the only person responsible for the emo chick dying is *you* .”

Izuku bristled, watching the way Kacchan’s expression darkened as Dabi smiled at him.

“Say, you got any idea what happened in Tokyo after you blew the place half to hell? Bet you’ve never even given it a fucking thought, have you?”

“Sh-shut-” Kaminari managed, before Jin thrust the gun against the back of his head again, pushing him forward. Dabi looked down at him, eyes gleaming, before he dropped to his haunches beside him, reaching out and grabbing Kaminari’s jaw, angling his face upwards as Kaminari whined in pain.

“Say, why don’t you tell him, dumb puppy?”

“Get your fucking hands off him!”

“Don’t push it, man!” Jin said. “I don’t wanna hurt him. Gah, but I wanna use the gun!”

Izuku felt the sweat dripping down the back of his neck, watching the way Jin swayed on the spot, fingers flexing and unflexing around the gun. He had no idea what this guy’s deal was, but having someone so obviously at odds with themselves in possession of the gun pressed to the back of his friend's head was nothing short of terrifying.

“Come on,” Dabi teased, “your jaw is only a little broken. Tell him what happened.”

Kaminari squinted through the blood dripping down from his hairline, looking back at Kacchan and shaking his head.

“Fuck, you’re no fun.” Dabi sighed, getting to his feet again, before promptly spitting onto the ground in front of Kaminari. Izuku was taking a step forward before he even realised it, anger boiling in his chest, his hands itching to reach for his weapon again, before the one with the white hair, their *leader* , met his eye, head cocking in apparent interest, pointedly looking towards the gun again. Izuku stumbled to a halt.

“I don’t give a fuck,” Kacchan said. “We ain’t here for a fucking catch-up.”

“You really still think you’re the good guy, don’t you?” Dabi said. “You and the rest of your shitty little crew, acting like we’re the only monsters around here. Well, you’re right, we *are* monsters. But boy we sure are nothing compared to you, Bakugou.”

Kacchan’s eyes flickered over to Izuku’s for just a moment, and his mind started to race. *Did they*

know? How could they have found out?

"You left the university in a hell of a state. And, the thing about explosions is, they're loud. Probably loud enough to attract a whole lotta zombies, don't you think?"

"Some of the students probably got out," Shigaraki said, with a shrug. "Most of them didn't."

The silence that followed Shigaraki's silence was painful, leaving Izuku with a chest full of thorns and nothing to dull the pain as the reality of those words sunk in. Kirishima and Mina both looked like they were about to throw up, pale and shaking, and silent tears left tracks through the blood and grime on Kaminari's face. But Izuku only had eyes for one person; Kacchan's expression was almost blank as he stared back at Dabi's smirking face. He had already experienced so much guilt, carried so big a burden on his shoulders, and this could be one too fucking many. But then, Kacchan started to smile. It was wide and full of teeth, his eyes remaining cold as the smile broke into a loud laugh, the harsh barks bouncing off the buildings around them, rattling in Izuku's skull.

"Like I said, I don't give a fuck!" Kacchan called, throwing his arms out to either side of him. "Those extras? Chances are they'd have all died eventually anyway, right? Why should I feel bad about that? If anything, I did 'em a favour by not prolonging it."

Izuku saw Kirishima's jaw drop, and Izuku might have been fooled by Kacchan's words too if his red eyes didn't blink a little too rapidly if he didn't see the minute way that Kacchan's hands shook as he stood there, defiantly smiling that cold smile.

"You think I'm a monster? I *know* I am. I don't give a shit what any of you assholes have to say. But you can guess again if you think there's a single thing I ain't prepared to do for my friends."

" *Kacchan,* " Izuku breathed. Dabi's face looked sour, but he shrugged and turned to Dabi.

"Shoot the kid."

"No!"

Someone screamed, Izuku had no idea who, watching with horror as Jin nodded, then shook his head, then waved the gun around wildly in front of him.

"I never shot someone before! I don't wanna! You do it! No, wait, ok ok I'll do it!"

"Stop waving that fucking thing around you moron!" Shigaraki snarled, and Jin froze on the spot, clutching the gun to his chest. "Before you shoot someone by mistake."

"Sorry, Shigaraki," Jin said.

"I can take the gun if you like?" Toga offered. "I can shoot him."

"No one's shooting anyone!" Shigaraki said, before glaring at Dabi. "Not yet."

Dabi glared back, looking for all the world like he was going to snatch the gun and do the job himself before he shrugged and rolled his eyes.

“This is boring,” Shigarakia drawled. “I’m bored now.”

“You and me both, so how’s about we just get on with this, hah?” Kacchan sneered back. “You’re pissed that Kaminari got in and almost killed one of you and you want compensation for that, yeh? And we just want our idiot back.”

It had taken them far longer to catch up than Izuku expected, but he caught movement from his left and saw the zombies starting to make their way up the same road that Kacchan was standing on. Shigaraki tensed, eyes flicking up to watch them, and Dabi dropped a hand to his side to touch the handle of the knife he was carrying.

“What’re you suggesting?” Shigaraki asked before he nodded to the zombies. “Better make it quick, asshole, we’re running out of time.”

Kacchan didn’t even acknowledge the zombies coming up behind him.

“I’ll make you a deal,” he said. “You give us Kaminari back, and you get me instead.”

Kaminari immediately began to squirm.

“No! K-Katsuki this is my fault! This was my dumb idea! You can’t-”

“Fuck me!” Dabi cried, grabbing the top of Kaminari’s head again and yanking back hard. “Stop. Fucking. Talking.”

“That’s the deal!” Kacchan called. “No fucking tricks. I ain’t saying I’m gonna make it easy for you, but we both know Kaminari ain’t the one you want.”

Shigaraki frowned.

“I want the bat,” Dabi said immediately. Kacchan growled low in his chest, but unhooked the weapon from his belt and threw it the distance between them, it landing with a loud clunk a few feet from Dabi’s feet.

“The rest of your weapons,” Shigaraki added.

Kacchan grit his teeth, before he started to untie the holsters about his thighs, pulling out the knives concealed about his person, and chucking them all out of reach one by one.

“It’s a trick,” Jin said, the gun swaying dangerously in his hands.

“What did I just say about that gun?” Shigaraki hissed. “Of course, it’s a fucking trick.” He turned to face Izuku now. “And what do his filthy friends think about this, huh?”

“That they do as I fucking tell ‘em, is what,” Kacchan said harshly. “They know better than to piss me off. And so should you, so let’s fucking do this already, yeh?”

Shigaraki narrowed his eyes, staring back at Kacchan, and Izuku knew that he was trying to figure out what the catch was. His eyes drifted up to the zombies for a moment, then to Mina and Kirishima, then back to Izuku, where his gaze lingered, causing the hairs on the back of Izuku’s

neck to stand up.

“Do it,” Shigaraki said.

“But Shiggy-”

“I said do it!”

“This is a bad fucking idea,” Dabi growled, but he still grabbed Kaminari by the elbow and hoisted him up, the man wobbling and almost falling to the ground again. “Now, you’re gonna walk towards the two dipshits over there, fucker. You got that?”

Kaminari squinted in the direction of Mina and Kirishima through the one eye that hadn’t swollen shut before he shook his head again.

“K-Kat, I-”

“Just do as the bastard says,” Kacchan interrupted.

More tears leaked down Kaminari’s cheeks. Now that he was on his feet, Izuku could see that he had taken one hell of a beating before they had gotten here; his jaw hung weirdly on one side, giving his face a lopsided look, and one of the fingers on his right hand was crooked and swollen. Izuku thought that he would be able to leave the anger behind him, he really did, but seeing Kaminari like this only reminded him of just how fucking monstrous these people were. Kaminari hesitated again before he started to hobble his way towards Mina and Kirishima.

“Jin, make sure you keep that gun pointed to the back of his head, yeh?” Dabi said, and Kacchan growled low in his throat as the gun swerved through the air again. “Any funny business, shoot him.”

“I dunno, boss,” Jin said, throwing a worried look in Shigaraki’s direction. “This whole thing stinks. It’s a trick!”

“Just do it,” Shigaraki said. “Now you, walk towards us, and hands where we can see them.”

Kacchan scoffed but held his palms up in the air as he made his way toward them. Izuku’s eyes darted from Kacchan to the zombies, his heart hammering in his chest, as it dawned on him that they were just too far away… the zombies were too slow, too rotten, to make that distance quick enough for it to matter. Shigaraki was expecting something, there was no way he wasn’t about to bind Kacchan the moment he reached them. Sure enough, when Kacchan was only a few feet away from them, Dabi pulled another thick cable tie out from his back pocket.

“On your knees, Bakugou.”

Izuku saw the way Kacchan stiffened, his pose defiant and his glare dangerous.

“Do it,” Dabi sneered. “Don’t forget we still got a gun on puppy’s head.”

Kaminari was still only halfway, unable to stop himself from looking back at Kacchan. Jin waved the gun again, muttering quickly under his breath, sweat visibly dripping down his forehead, and

Kacchan had no choice but to drop to his knees in front of them, lip curled. Dabi's face broke into an ugly grin.

"Not gonna like, Bakugou, I kinda like you like this."

"Yeh, well, I bite asshole," Kacchan hissed, holding both his hands forward. Suddenly, Shigaraki eyes widened.

"Hey! Hey, what happened to your arm?" he said quickly.

Kaminari froze, and Izuku felt his stomach drop as he watched Shigaraki take in the zombies again, his face twitching in understanding.

"Don't you fucking move," he hissed at Kaminari.

"What's going on?" Jin asked, voice rising in panic. "What is that? Is he bit?"

"It's just a cut-" Kacchan began, but Shigaraki cut across him.

"Bullshit. Show us your arm, do it right now or Jin shoots your friend in the face."

"Wh-Katsuki-"

"Fuck, Kaminari it's fucking fine!" Kacchan yelled before he grabbed his sleeve and pulled it back, unwinding the bandaging on his wrist. "See? A cut, just like I said."

Toga reached out, grabbing Kacchan's wrist and wrenching it towards her, Kacchan hissing in pain.

"And how exactly did you get a cut like that, hmm?"

"Boss, I don't like this!" Jin whimpered.

"Will you shut up? I can't think with all this damn noise!"

"It's a trick! It's a-"

It took Izuku a moment to realise the source of the deafening bang that filled the air, reverberating off every surface, making Izuku wonder for one mad moment whether Kacchan had somehow managed to let off an explosion. And then, there was movement, a burst of red, and Izuku watched in slow motion as Kaminari fell forward, body arching back almost gracefully before he hit the ground. The silence that followed felt far away, the ground beneath Izuku's feet seemed to tilt on an axis, sliding him sideways across the pavement as he fought just to stay standing. And then someone screamed, and the surreal quiet gave way to chaos. Mina and Kirishima were running forward, and Jin was crying.

"I didn't mean to! I didn't- I wanted to shoot- I didn't- I didn't-"

"Moron!" Shigaraki yelled.

Izuku stumbled forward, feeling for a moment like he was the only one who saw the scene in its

entirety. Kaminari was on the ground, blood quickly spilling from a wound somewhere on his back, Kirishima and Mina falling to their knees beside him. The noise and the smell of blood seemed to finally grab the zombie's interest, their brittle limbs pushing them forward with a new urgency. And Kacchan… he remained silent, kneeling on the ground staring in the direction of Kaminari, watching as Kirishima tried to roll him onto his side. Izuku fought for breath, his lungs burning, breaking into a run as Kacchan turned back to Dabi, his face twisted and contorted into a vicious snarl.

“Wait-”

“ *Eat.* ”

Despite the noise on the street, Kacchan’s voice still rung out clear and loud, dripping with venom, and in a flash the zombies were running, *sprinting,* bodies cracking and smacking together in their desperation to reach their prey.

“Get Kaminari out of here!” Izuku screamed because Kacchan had lost his fucking mind. There was blood across the pavement, it stained Kirishima’s fingers as he held Kaminari to him, and there was no way the zombies were going to be able to resist. They were going to rush right at them, and Izuku was too far away to help.

“Kirishima!”

But even as Kirishima drew his weapon, and Mina took her place in front of the both of them, holding her axe aloft, the zombies kept running. They ran past them, ignoring the blood and the easy meal to their left and straight towards Kacchan and the League.

“What the fuck?” Dabi said before he was fumbling for his weapon, and Izuku could only watch as the zombies rushed them, ignoring Kacchan who remained kneeling on the ground, and throwing themselves straight at the bastards, the four of them yelling and thrashing with their weapons as they fought to push back the onslaught.

“Kacchan!”

“No, get Kaminari,” Kacchan called back coldly, getting to his feet. “I’ll handle them.”

Izuku panted, eyes darting from the group being pushed out onto the street by the zombies, to Kaminari, before he swore and ran towards him.

“Where was he shot?” Izuku gasped. “Is he-”

“His shoulder,” Kirishima replied shakily. And to Izuku’s huge relief, he looked down to see Kaminari staring back at him over his bloody and swollen cheeks.

“I’m fine,” Kaminari muttered. “Just… just a flesh wound…”

“Man, stop talking,” Kirishima sighed, before biting back a loud sob. “Goddamn it.”

“Ok, hold still, I’m going to pack this as best I can,” Izuku said quickly. “Mina, what’s going on over there?”

“I… I don’t-” Mina sounded panicked. “They’re trying to run away I- I don’t understand. Why didn’t the zombies come at us? Why didn’t they touch Katsuki? He’s just… he’s just stood there!”

“I’ll explain everything later,” Izuku replied, grunting from the effort as he tried to peel back Kaminari’s coat without causing more pain to his already bruised and busted joints. “Right now, we just have to get Kaminari out of here before they kill all those zombies, or more of them come.”

“What’s going on?”

Izuku looked up at the sound of Shouto’s voice.

“We heard the gunshot!”

“Kaminari’s shot,” Izuku replied, stuffing as much bandaging between Kaminari’s shoulder and his coat as he could. “It’s his shoulder, he should be ok. But the plan worked, Dabi and the others are too busy dealing with the zombies to worry about us.”

“Where’s Bakugou?” Hagakure asked.

“Don’t worry about him right now,” Izuku said, though every fibre of his being couldn’t *help* but worry.

“And Touya?” Shouto asked.

“I’m pretty sure Kacchan’s gone to make sure the zombies finish off the job,” Izuku replied, his voice low. “Kaminari, do you think you can stand?”

“I- y-yeh I can… fuck, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry, I was so *stupid*- ”

“Shh, it’s ok,” Mina said, running a hand through his hair. “We understand. We’re sorry none of us could see just how badly you were hurting.”

More tears leaked down Kaminari’s cheek, and with another whine, he clung to Kirishima as he and Izuku helped to ease him to his feet. A cry broke from his lips as he stumbled again.

“It’s ok, I got you,” Kirishima said.

“Uhh, guys!”

Izuku looked up, gaze following the direction Hagakure was pointing and his breath caught in his throat. They were naive to have thought that there were no other zombies in the area, and sure enough, more were spilling out onto the street, drawn by the blast of gunfire and the scent of blood on the air.

“Shit!”

“We have to get out of here,” Shouto said urgently, looking around. “That way!”

“But what about Katsuki?” Mina asked, taking Kaminari’s other arm and wrapping it around her

shoulder.

“He can handle himself,” Izuku replied, trying hard not to think about it. “We’re running out of time, come on!”

The group made their way down the street as quickly as they could manage, Kirishima and Mina half dragging and half carrying Kaminari between them. Izuku couldn’t see a single sign of Kacchan, or the bastards that he had gone after, but he could only trust that the man would be ok.

“Watch out!”

They skidded to a halt, three zombies coming out from behind a building ahead of them, not sparing a moment before they began to sprint toward them. Izuku grit his teeth, rotating his axe in his hand before charging forward, ducking and twisting his body to the right as he swung, his axe cutting into the forehead of the zombie closest. Shouto was quick at his heel, slamming down with his crowbar, and the third and final zombie met its end at the point of Yaoyorozu’s blade.

“Don’t stop!” Izuku panted. “Keep going!”

But, as quick as they had taken care of them, the zombies had slowed them down enough that those following them were suddenly hot on their trail. Izuku realised that there was no chance they were going to be able to outrun them, not with Kaminari in the state that he was in, and his mind raced for a solution. Ahead was a chain-link gate, separating the street from the back alley of a restaurant; not perfect, but it might just buy them enough time to figure out what to do next.

“I’ll hold them back,” he said, waving urgently at them. “Get to that gate!”

“Wh- no way, man!”

“Just do it!”

The zombies were fast. Izuku wasn’t sure if it was pure bloodlust and starvation driving them, or if something else played a part in getting them so charged up, but he sure as shit hasn’t seen zombies so quick and focused since the hospital. Ten of them were running straight at him, two thudding against the side of a building as their limbs skidded across the pavement, and Izuku knew that he was in for the fight of his life.

“I’ll take left, you take right,” came a voice at his side, and Izuku looked around in a panic, seeing Shouto taking his stance.

“No! Go with the others!”

“I’m not losing you again,” Shouto replied simply.

Izuku gulped, but there was no time and no sense in arguing. In a moment, the zombies would be on them.

“Let’s do this,” Izuku breathed, raising his axe.

The wave hit hard, Izuku swinging and launching himself to the right, using the weight of the first

zombie to knock aside the one that came after, before he immediately felt something hit his side. It was only instinct that had Izuku ducking, the zombie falling almost entirely over the top of him, and Izuku hacking into its knee and following the momentum out from below it. He was on his feet again in a moment, just in time to jut his elbow into the throat of the first zombie coming back at him, gritting his teeth as he saw its neck twist, teeth scraping against his coat before he was able to bring his axe down into the top of its head. But he had swung too hard in his panic, his axe sticking into the bone, and he was forced to push the limb rotting corpse back, using it as a shield as yet more teeth snapped at him. His eyes darted around wildly, spotting Shouto pulling his crowbar out of the face of one, before swinging at a second.

"Shit," Izuku hissed, pushing hard. The zombies fell, and he was able to grab the knife at his waist, before launching forward, taking advantage of the chaos to stomp onto the head of one zombie, and thrust his knife into the skull of another. *Four down* . Panting, he swung around to see Shouto swinging and ducking, trying to avoid the biting teeth of the two zombies bearing down at him, and he ran forward. He grabbed hold of the filthy jacket of one zombie, wrenching back and stabbing hard. Shouto was able to dodge once more before his crowbar finally found its mark.

"You ok?" Izuku asked. Shouto nodded, but there wasn't time to say a whole lot more, because the remaining four zombies, though slower than their counterparts, were almost on them. But, as Izuku was preparing for the second attack, there was a roar and a blur of movement in front of them, another body launching itself from an alley and swinging down hard. Blood splattered across the street, a horrifying crack filling the air, followed by a sickening thud, and another… another… *another* until all four zombies lay on the ground, skull and brain spread so far that it caked the side of the building.

"Kacchan!" Izuku cried in relief.

Kacchan was panting heavily, and he was covered in blood from head to toe, the whites of his eyes intense against the filthy dark canvas.

"No one bit?" Kacchan asked, seemingly indifferent to his startling appearance.

"No," Izuku replied, shaking his head.

"Touya," Shouto said immediately. "Where is he?"

Kacchan let out a frustrated snarl. "I fucking lost him," he said. "The hag's dead, zombies got her first, but all the noise attracted a bunch of 'em. I saw Dabi go down, but I couldn't confirm shit, only just managed to get out of there."

That, at least, explained why Kacchan was covered in so much blood.

"And the others?"

"I don't fucking know!" Kacchan snapped. "Where's Kaminari?"

"With the others. He was shot in the shoulder. Come on let's go."

Izuku found himself grabbing Kacchan's wrist and tugging him forward. The others had made their way to the chain-link gate, and Yaoyrozu stood holding it open, waving her arms towards them.

“Hurry up!” she all but screamed, “there’s more of them!”

Izuku glanced back to see yet more zombies barreling down the street, and the three of them started to spring towards the gate, Yaoyorozu stepping back so that they could throw themselves in.

“Wait!”

A voice called out to them, and Izuku felt his stomach drop as he realised that it wasn’t just zombies racing toward them. Jin, the man who had shot Kaminari and almost killed him, was running hard, limbs spiralling, eyes wide and terrified, and for a moment Izuku had no idea what to do. This was one of the men who were responsible for the death of his friends, who had tortured Shouto, Kaminari, *shot him,* and if they shut the gate on him now then the zombies coming up close behind him would make sure that he could *never* do anything like that again. But… Jin was still a human being; one with tears in his eyes, one not in his right mind. One who was asking for help.

“Wh-what do we do?” Yaoyorozu asked, still at the gate.

“Out the way!” Kacchan spat, pushing her roughly aside and grabbing the gate himself. Pausing for just a moment, before yanking it shut with a finality that made Izuku shiver.

“Wait,” he said quickly, hurrying forward, as Jin yelled out again in panic. “Wait, Kacchan, think about this-”

“Nothing to think about,” Kacchan replied, his voice low and cold, eyes emotionless as he stared out over blood-stained cheeks.

“C-come on, Midoriya’s right!” Kirishima said. “We’re not those people!”

“Kacchan,” Izuku hissed urgently. “I know you’re angry, but we can’t do this. *You* can’t do this.”

Jin crashed into the gate, fingers gripping hold of the wire, his fearful eyes meeting Kacchan’s.

“Please, man,” Jin said, shaking his head. “I’m sorry, alright? I didn’t mean to shoot him! I didn’t mean to! Please lemme in!”

The zombies were close now, in a matter of seconds they would be at the gate. Izuku tried to grab at the lock himself, but Kacchan’s strong hand refused to budge.

“Just go!” he yelled at Jin. “If you go now you might still make it!”

Jin wailed, looking back over his shoulder, but just as he made to leave a hand reached forward, grabbing hold of the front of Jin’s coat and wrenching back, the man’s face colliding painfully with the gate.

“Kacchan!”

“N-no!” Jin screamed, trying to wrench himself backwards against Kacchan’s grip. “Let me go! Let me go!”

“Fuck you.”

Jin’s face fell slack, horror written across his features. Izuku tugged at Kacchan’s wrist, fighting with all the strength he had to make the man let go, but Kacchan was too strong, roughly pushing Izuku away.

“Kacchan, don’t do this!” Izuku begged, feeling tears start to drip down his cheeks now. “Let him go!”

But there was nothing that Izuku could do but watch in horror as the first zombie latched itself to Jin, biting down hard into the back of his neck, Jin letting out a blood-curdling scream. Izuku was crying freely, his hands pressed to his mouth, knees threatening to buckle beneath him, unable to look away as zombie after zombie piled against the gate, crushing Jin beneath their weight. They fought to reach parts of him to tear away as Jin shrieked, a sound so animal and so piercing that it would go on to haunt him until the day he finally met his own end. The pops of cracking bone, the sound of ripping flesh, the screams, and yet through all of it Kacchan still held on tight, staring Jin straight in the eye until the moment a hand wrapped around Jin’s face and a final *crack* brought an end to the screams.

Someone was crying behind them, weak sobs filling the alley, and Izuku shook where he stood. Kacchan stepped away from the gate, turning to face them, and as one the group flinched. Kirishima and Mina drew Kaminari close to them, the man staring at Kacchan in disbelief. Shouto immediately raised his weapon, taking a quick step in front of Yaoyorozu, and Hagakue was crying, what looked like vomit dripping down her chin on the floor, her body shaking uncontrollably. And Kacchan seemed entirely unaffected, looking over them once before he picked up the bat discarded on the floor.

“Let’s go,” he said flatly. Walking forward, not even flinching at the way Shouto held his weapon higher. Izuku felt like he couldn’t breathe, clutching at his chest. No one moved to follow him, and for the first time since Kacchan had throttled Izuku in the park, Izuku felt doubt, *fear* , looking at the man he loved.

“I said let’s go!” Kacchan suddenly yelled, turning back to them, eyes flashing furiously. “That ain’t gonna distract them for long.”

Izuku flinched again, and sure enough, the gate was already starting to buckle under the weight of the zombies on the other side.

“C’mon,” he muttered, staring after Kacchan. Shouto stared at him in disbelief, but Izuku just shook his head, and after a moment of hesitation, the rest of the group started to follow them.

They made their way carefully through the streets, Izuku doing his best to keep an eye, not only on the alleys around them but on Kacchan as well. He was entirely silent, not meeting their eyes, focused only on the road ahead, and Izuku had no idea what to do. Kacchan had been angry, he knew that. He was hurting and full of so much rage and fear and everything else that Kacchan had to deal with, things that none of the rest of the group knew about. But… Kacchan had crossed a line today that none of the rest of them had. Of course, Izuku had figured if it came down between him and his, and someone else, then he would be prepared to fight to the death for those that mattered to him. But Jin had been helpless, unarmed, and Kacchan had not only prevented his escape but held him there as he died in the most horrific way that Izuku could imagine. Kacchan had killed him.

Kacchan had *killed* him and he was desperately searching for justification. Izuku had begged and pleaded for Jin's life, and Kacchan had killed him anyway.

"Where are we going?" came Kirishima's hesitant voice after a while. "Back to the stadium?"

"We don't know if Touya and their leader are dead yet," Shouto replied, still keeping his wary eyes on the back of Kacchan's head.

"Kaminari's hardly in the position to fight right now, don't you think?" Mina suddenly snapped, sounding angry. "What the hell is wrong with you? With all of you?"

She came to a halt, gently lifting Kaminari's arm so that she could step out from under it, and charging forward. Izuku started, feeling an unwelcome panic in his chest when he saw her reach out for Kacchan, her palm pushing him squarely in the back. Kacchan froze, looking back at her with an unreadable expression on his face.

"What *was that?* " she demanded, breathing heavily. Kacchan scowled.

"What exactly did you think it was gonna look like, huh?" he replied coldly. "You knew the fucking plan!"

"Whatever… whatever *that* was, it wasn't the plan!" Mina replied, incredulous. "You… you *murdered* him!"

Kacchan's lips tore back with a snarl.

"Yeh, I killed him. And I don't feel the least bit fucking bad about it. You wanna know why? Because *he's* dead, and we're not."

"Bakugou, the way he died-"

"What's your point, huh? What *exactly* are you trying to get at?" Kacchan interrupted, before he looked around at all of them, eyes narrowed and furious. "You think that's what I fucking wanted, hah? You think I enjoyed that?"

"Kacchan-"

"No, I'm fucking talking!" Kacchan snapped. "None of you have ever been prepared to do what it takes to survive. You would have stayed back in Tokyo, slowly starving to fucking death, raped, tortured, and whatever the fuck else those bastards fancied doing with you, if I hadn't made a fucking decision! You won't fight, but *one* of us has to. *One* of us has got to do the soul-destroying, nasty fucking shit so that we can all stay alive and *that* -" he pointed back to where they had come, to where Jin's body was probably still being devoured "-is just the tip of the fucking iceberg."

Mina shook, looking back at him before she took a deep breath.

"You had a knife."

The beat that followed was silent and heavy, the scowl on Kacchan's face fading as her words sunk in, a realisation that was just as uncomfortable to watch as it must have been to experience hitting

him.

There was a clatter, and the group looked up to see the contents of a skip spread out over the street, the tall shadow creeping around the corner alerting them that the zombies were on the move again and that they were going to catch up if they hung around for much longer. Kacchan swallowed.

“We can’t keep outrunning them with Kaminari as beat up as he is,” he said. “We need to find somewhere to hide.”

“We’re close to the industrial estate,” Izuku said. “We can probably find somewhere with sturdier doors and windows than on the street.”

“Right,” Kacchan muttered. “Let’s go then.”

They hurried forward, Izuku taking Mina’s place in supporting Kaminari after seeing how much Mina was still shaking. Kaminari was paler than usual, and definitely in a lot of pain, but he had stopped bleeding for the most part and kept up with them as well as they could ask given the circumstances.

“I’m sorry,” Kaminari croaked, his voice quiet and weak. “This is all my fault.”

“It’s ok, man,” Kirishima replied, looking up to meet Izuku’s eyes over the man's head.

“Let’s just focus on getting you safe, ok?” Izuku agreed.

But reaching safety was not going to be easy for them. Eventually, a suitable-looking warehouse came into view, the sliding garage-type door ajar enough that they would be able to heave it open, and hopefully wait things out until it was safe enough for them to head back to the stadium. But the street ahead of them was wide and open, leading onto the parking lot outside of the warehouse, and any lingering in the area behind the other warehouses would be on them in moments.

“It’s that, or we try and make out way back down all these streets again,” Kirishima said.

“Fuck face and I will take the rear,” Kacchan said. “Rest of you take point, keep Kaminari between us, got it?”

Izuku nodded, adjusting his grip on Kaminari.

“You good?” he asked him, and Kaminari nodded with a grimace.

“Yup, peachy.”

“Ok, go.”

Mina and the other girls hurried ahead, weapons in hand, Izuku and Kirishima hot on their heels. They had hardly made it half of the way before Shouto called out from behind them.

“Two o’clock!”

Izuku glanced back to see the zombies rushing out after them, this group larger than the one he and

Shouto had to face back in the alley, and just as fast.

“Let’s get to fucking stepping!” Kacchan yelled, and Izuku and Kirishima started to run, Kaminari yelping in pain. But the zombies were quick, quicker than they were, and Izuku was sure for a moment that they weren’t going to make it. Mina reached the warehouse first, lifting the door up, shouting for them to hurry, and it was with joint cries of relief that Izuku and Kirishima dragged Kaminari into the dark warehouse.

“Get in!” Kacchan was yelling. “We’ll get the door!”

Mina ducked inside, and Izuku looked back in time to see Kacchan and Shouto hurrying to the door, two dropped zombies just behind them. Shouto grabbed the lever, preparing to drop it as Kacchan skidded beside him, before Izuku saw the zombie dart out, previously unseen from where it had been hiding around the side of the warehouse.

“Shouto!”

Shouto spun, but he was too slow, the zombie bearing down on him, jaws aimed for his throat. Kacchan jumped in, colliding with the zombie with a yell, a flurry of swearing and snaps and movement before he was able to bring his knife down into the side of its skull. Shouto didn’t move, staring at Kacchan.

“Guys!” Izuku screamed.

The two of them both bolted back into action, Shouto grabbing at the lever again and pulling the door shut behind them with a grimace, before casting them all into darkness, the warehouse lit only by the sun pouring through the windows framing the very top of the walls. There was a thud, and several crashes as the zombies threw themselves against the door, but it held, and Izuku sunk to the ground, carrying Kaminari with them.

“That was too close,” Kirishima muttered, wiping the sweat from his forehead. “Everyone good?”

They each attempted their own replies, mostly coming out in grunts and wheezes, but two of them remained standing. Izuku looked up, to see Shouto still staring at Kacchan, his eyes wide.

“Why?” Shouto managed, and Izuku was tense again, getting back to his feet.

“Why what?” he asked before he realised that Kacchan was standing with his side to him, one hand reaching around and wrapping tightly around his cut arm. “Kacchan?”

Kacchan swallowed, avoiding his gaze before he took a deep breath and held his arm out. It was difficult to see, what with the padding of his coat turn and red, but when Kacchan pulled his sleeve aside there was no mistaking the deep, jagged bite in his flesh.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 36: Blood, Sweat and Fears IV

Chapter Summary

In which sacrifices must be made.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There had been a lot of theories floating around in the early days of the Apocalypse. Some of them had even seemed viable; a virus, at best guess, was the most widely accepted cause. After all, this wasn't the first time in history that a virus had decimated a population. But Izuku had come across plenty of people in the early days who were confident that the dead rising was a sign of divine intervention; angry spirits possessing the corpses of wrong-doers and taking payment in one pound of flesh for your every sin and act of wickedness. For a person to be consumed in their entire spoke only of the amount of evil that had resided within. Be it adult or child didn't matter, for sin was sin. To escape consumption with a single bite meant that the spirits had only chosen you as their next vessel; your soul not yet beyond redemption, perhaps, if only you could consume enough wickedness to earn your way to the next life. But whether it be a virus or the rage of spirits, both parties seemed to agree on one thing; surviving a bite was impossible. And surviving two? Well, that was beyond comprehension.

And yet, staring at the jagged open wound on Kacchan's right forearm, Izuku could do little but calculate the odds; how long had Kacchan been sick after the first time? Three months, he had said, before he felt anything close to himself again. But there had been complications; one of his kidneys had been damaged, so how much of his original sickness could have been related to that? How quickly might he have recovered if that hadn't been the case? This was a bite on the arm, and secondary infections were a huge risk; necrotising fasciitis was the biggest and most pressing concern, it was a miracle that Kacchan had avoided that with his first bite, and septic shock would be soon to follow. Cleaning the wound and antibiotics were essential, chances were Izuku would need to cut away any of the infected tissue, and even if Kacchan could withstand the zombie virus there had been nothing to suggest that his immune system was strong enough to handle any of the many bacteria likely already teeming in his bloodstream.

He had no awareness of what was going on around him. He was indifferent to the shuffling of bodies and the panic-stricken yells and frightful gasps as the room at large responded to bite on Kacchan's arm. Kacchan, it seemed, was just as deaf to it all as Izuku was; watching him in silence as Izuku stared at the wound, Izuku's response the only one that mattered. Dimly, in the back of his mind, Izuku knew that how he acted now would dictate all that remained of their time together. It would make the difference between Kacchan allowing him to care for him, or lashing out and using this as the final reason to disappear from Izuku's life completely. And he *knew* that Kacchan had already requested that Izuku let him leave, but there was a difference between watching Kacchan walk away with his body intact, and Kacchan slinking off with a bite on his arm and leaving Izuku forever tormented with images of bacteria eating the flesh from his bones and dying alone in some ditch. Izuku *needed* Kacchan to trust him, needed him to accept his help, there was no alternative.

Not one that he could live with.

As everyone around them panicked, Izuku quietly walked forward, Kacchan not resisting as Izuku took his hand, gently pushing the sleeve further up his arm so he could finally get a good look at the bite. It was bad; it was a *bite* after all, but the zombie had been pretty intent on taking as much flesh away as it could, the teeth marks imprinted deep. It was perhaps testament to how quickly Kacchan had reacted that the entire area of flesh between the indents hadn't been torn away.

"What kind of first aid do we have on hand?" Izuku asked, and the room fell silent.

"Uh," Kirishima finally said, his voice shaking badly as he pulled his pack from his shoulders. "W-we didn't bring much, just like anything that would help in an immediate emergency."

"Antibiotics?" Izuku asked. Kirishima shook his head.

"N-no, we left them back at the playground."

We can make it , Izuku's brain supplied before a fresh wave of hammering cut through the fog, the zombies outside still ravaged by hunger and bloodlust, eager to put the idea of a quick escape to bed.

"Izuku-" Kacchan began.

"I'm thinking," Izuku interrupted sharply, firmly, not the least bit willing to hear anything that Kacchan had to say at that moment, knowing all too well what self-sacrificial crap he was bound to spew.

"What good are antibiotics going to do now?" Hagakure all but wailed from where she now stood, as far away from Izuku and Kacchan as was possible in the small warehouse. Izuku ignored her.

"Ok, just gimme some of whatever we have," he said. "I need to clean the wound at the very least. Kirishima, did you fight any of the zombies? Any at all?"

"No," Kirishima replied.

"Good, then I need you to take care of Kaminari's wounds. I have zombie blood and Kacchan's blood on my hands, I can't do it now."

"Shit," Kacchan swore. "Kaminari, are you ok?"

"Are you kidding me right now?" Kaminari yelled, making Izuku jump. Kaminari was sitting on the ground, leaning against Kirishima's shoulder, tears leaking down his battered and bruised face. "The fuck you worrying about me for! You've the one been *bit!* " Horror dawned on Kaminari then, his swollen jaw falling as slack as it could be given its state. "And it's my fault… This is all my fault."

"Don't fucking start that," Kacchan grumbled, but Kaminari was inconsolable, his entire body starting to shake and suddenly Kacchan's bite wasn't the only pressing matter, Izuku realising only then just how pale the strips of skin visible beneath the grime on Kaminari's face was.

“Shit,” Izuku hissed. “Shit shit-” he was trying *not* to panic. As far as he knew, he was the only person in that room with any degree of medical training, and he needed to keep his head, but things were all too quickly starting to spiral as he recognised the signs of shock on Kaminari’s face, knowing that it wasn’t safe for him to personally intervene right now.

“Kaminari,” he said, “I need you to take some deep breaths for me.”

But Kaminari could no longer hear him, beginning to hyperventilate, Kirishima looked down at him in alarm, before meeting Izuku’s eyes desperately.

“H-he’s probably going into shock,” Izuku said, letting go of Kacchan’s hand, the man calling Kaminari’s name. “Lay him on his back - gently! Raise his legs, use Mina’s pack to keep them elevated. Just… keep talking to him, Kirishima, ok? I need to… *fuck,* I need to clean Kacchan’s bite or it’ll be too late-”

“‘Zuku!” He felt rough hands on each of his shoulders as he was turned back to face Kacchan. “Take a breath.”

He was already panicking, his body jittery, far from the calm that was *supposed* to come over him when his friends truly needed him. Kacchan was in a state; there was blood splattered across his face and chest, but his expression was strangely calm.

“You got this, alright? What does Kaminari need?”

“But-” Izuku shook his head. “But I have to clean the bite! I have to clean it or-”

“I’ll be fine,” Kacchan interrupted. “You know me. Kaminari first.”

Izuku saw the unspoken *‘please’* in Kacchan’s eyes, and his shoulders slumped and he swallowed hard.

“Izuku, just tell us what to do, we can help,” Mina said, back at Kaminari’s side. He didn’t look good; now the adrenaline was starting to pass, the amount of pain he must be in from his injuries was quickly beginning to overwhelm him, and though it didn’t look like he was bleeding from the bullet wound in his shoulder, Izuku had failed to take into account any internal bleeding that might be happening as a result of the obvious beatings that had been inflicted on him. He couldn’t touch Kaminari, but that didn’t mean he couldn’t be close, guiding Kirishima through it.

“Ok,” he breathed, dropping to his knees beside them. Kirishima had gotten Kaminari to lie down, but he was looking spacey, breathing heavily and shaking all over. “Kaminari, hey, can you hear me?”

Kaminari didn’t respond, his eyes instead starting to drift shut.

“Hey, stay awake, man,” Kirishima said, reaching forward and brushing his hair back from his eyes. “Denki, look at me.”

But Kaminari already seemed too far gone, his head just lulling to the side.

“Need to check for any signs of internal bleeding,” Izuku said. “Get his jacket off.”

“I-is there anything we can do to help?” Yaoyorzu asked, nervously.

“Just keep an eye on the zombies,” Izuku replied. “Let us know if it looks like they might find their way through.”

After a quick battle with the zip, Kirishima was able to undo Kaminari’s jacket, grabbing the hem of his shirt and gently lifting it, working to shift it across his back without jostling the man too much. There was bruising upon Kaminari’s side, a large one on his left hip where it looked as though he had received a particularly hard kick, but otherwise, his pale skinny body didn’t look as bad as Izuku feared it might. There was no swelling or bruising across his abdomen or ribs, nothing that might leave Izuku thinking that he was rapidly bleeding into his chest or stomach.

“Is he ok?” Shouto asked quietly. Izuku took another deep breath.

“I don’t know,” he replied, honestly. “I don’t think he’s bleeding out, but his jaw is probably broken or dislocated, there’s no exit wound for the bullet, he’s been beaten…” he swallowed. “He’s been through a lot, and his body is only just starting to realise that.”

“So, what can we do for him?” Kirishima asked, gently lowering his shirt.

“Right now?” Izuku ran his hand over the top of his head, fingers catching into the tangles of his hair. “Nothing except keep him warm and calm as possible, for as long as possible.” He shut his eyes tight, knowing all too well what that would mean for Kacchan. “Even without the zombies outside, he couldn’t travel right now.”

“If we stay quiet, the zombies will eventually move on,” Mina said. “But, what does that mean for Katsuki?”

As one, all conscious faces in the room turned to look at Kacchan, who was standing where Izuku had left him, supporting his wounded arm in his other, and scowling down at Kaminari.

“We know what it means,” he said. “Don’t matter. Ain’t doing shit to risk that idiot getting worse.”

“We have *no idea* what it means!” Kirishima protested. “We don’t know what’s going to happen!”

“He was bitten,” Shouto said, still strangely hushed. “We know what happens next.”

Izuku ignored them, grabbing Kirishima’s pack and searching for the pink-tinted antiseptic solution he was sure had been pre-packed just in case they ever needed it, letting out a breath of relief when his fingers brushed against the bottle.

“No, this is different,” Kirishima replied. “You don’t understand-”

“What’s to understand?” Hagakure hissed, holding her arms around herself. “That’s one fact about this mess that never changes. You get bit, you get infected, you turn into one of them things!”

“A little tact, please,” Yaoyorozu whined.

“No, I’m confused too,” Mina said now, watching Kacchan and Izuku intently as Izuku started to

clean the bite on Kacchan's arm at long last. "Why didn't those zombies come at us back there, Katsuki?"

"Just lucky-" Izuku found himself saying, before Kacchan interrupted him again, gently pulling his arm out of Izuku's reach.

"It's alright, Deku."

Kacchan took a step back, before starting to pull his jacket off, dropping it to a heap on the floor as he reached for the buttons of his shirt.

"Uh, what's going on?" Hagakure asked, sounding alarmed. Kacchan pushed his shirt aside, before grabbing at his tee and tugging, revealing the sizeable purple scar on his left side. The reaction was instant; Hagakure all but screamed, and Shouto had marched forward, pushing Izuku aside and standing between the two of them before Izuku had even registered that his friend had moved, his knife raised once more.

"You were already bitten?" he snarled.

"Shouto, calm down-" Izuku began.

"No! This asshole was already bitten and he didn't tell us? He's dangerous! This whole time, he could have turned at any minute!"

"It isn't what you think!" Izuku protested as Kacchan dropped his shirt back down, eyeing Shouto coldly. "He was bitten nearly two years ago, look at the scar! This isn't recent."

Shouto looked back at Izuku, eyes wide and confused. "Wh- No, that's not possible."

"It's possible, fuck face," Kacchan growled.

"So he's *immune* ?" Yaoyorozu gasped.

"No, it- he's still infected with the virus," Izuku explained. "But for whatever reason, he recovered from the fever and didn't turn like everyone else."

"But… that's…" Shouto shook his head, before he suddenly stiffened, an agonising realisation coming to his face as he turned back to Izuku again. "He's still infected?" he asked, voice hardly louder than a whisper.

"Yes," Izuku replied, eyes darting over Shouto's shoulder to Kacchan. "But it's ok, we know how to manage-"

"You know all the ways it can spread, right?" Shouto asked seriously. " *Izuku?* "

It took Izuku a moment to understand what Shouto was asking, but when he did he felt his face heat up, eyes widening. "Oh! N-no, it… we've been careful-"

But that was the wrong thing to say, and Shouto was whirling on Kacchan, a furious look on his face, the temperature in the room seeming to drop with all the rage that dripped from his icy

exterior.

“What the hell is wrong with you?” Shouto demanded, voice cool and dangerous, the knife held firmly up to Kacchan’s throat. “You piece of shit, you put him at risk like that?”

But Kacchan did not seem intimated, no matter how much Shouto towered above him. His lips pulled back into a sneer, the whites of his eyes glowing among the blood caking his skin.

“You need to get the fuck outta my face, asshole, before I make you wish that zombie *had* bitten you.”

There was a sudden fresh wave of activity from the zombies outside, the hammering and thudding increasing in intensity following Kacchan’s words. He hardly looked human at that moment; teeth bared and the smell of death coming off him, as Shouto finally seemed to acknowledge, *truly* understand, that this was a fight that he could not win. He took a hurried step back, eyes wide as they darted between Kacchan and the door, his knife still held out between them.

“How are you doing that?” Shouto asked, in a tremoring hiss, the door shaking violently. “How did you get away from all the zombies back there?” He took a sharp breath. “The zombies we lead here… they didn’t just follow us because they were hungry, did they?”

“Shouto,” Izuku all but pleaded, hurrying forward and grabbing the arm holding the knife, pulling it away from Kacchan. “Just calm down a minute, ok? I can explain everything.”

“ *You* can explain?” Shouto said to him. “You… you kept this from us, too. You-” Shouto paused, looking back over his shoulder to where Kirishima and Mina still kneeled at Kaminari’s side. “You all knew.”

“No one was trying to trick you, man!” Kirishima said. “Honest. Katsuki was bitten so long ago we didn’t think-”

“I don’t know you,” Shouto interrupted coldly. “So maybe lying and deceiving others is how you’ve managed to stay alive for so long. I don’t particularly *care* , but *you?* ” Shouto turned back to Izuku again, and the look on his face was enough to drain the colour from Izuku’s cheeks, his heart thudding weakly in his chest. “You never lied to me before. *Never* .” Shouto’s voice shook, the tremor of emotion running through only making Izuku feel worse. “You lied, you put *my* friends in danger, and for what? *This* asshole?” Shouto pointed his knife back at Kacchan again, eyes flashing with rage.

“Shouto, please,” Izuku said, as calmly as he could manage. “I told you that I can explain-”

“What is there to explain?” Shouto yelled, the zombies outside banging against the door once more. “I *trusted* you. Don’t you get that? I don’t care if this bastard can end the goddamn Apocalypse, you had no right to abuse our history like this. You had no right to put Momo and Hagakure’s *lives* in danger. You had no right to *use me!* ”

Izuku’s mouth snapped shut, blinking rapidly against the onslaught of tears he already knew was coming. Because, no matter how he looked at it, Shouto was right. He had accepted Izuku and the rest of his group without knowing precisely what that entailed, and what dangers they brought along with them. And Shouto had done it without hesitation. Izuku had taken advantage of the fact

that he knew, deep down, that Shouto would have never refused him.

Izuku swallowed, his face dropping so that he could no longer see the hurt look on Shouto's face. "You're right," he said. "I'm so sorry, Shouto. I thought-" What had he thought?

I thought I could keep you both.

"I wasn't thinking," Izuku admitted.

There was a thud, Izuku looking up again to see that Shouto's arm had dropped to his side, the knife hanging loosely in his grip.

"I know that's not true," Shouto said quietly. "The Izuku I know is *always* thinking. You were always three steps ahead of us, even before all of this happened. Any terrible thing that happened to us, it was you that got us out, so don't tell me you weren't thinking."

Shouto sighed before he cast another cold glare in Kacchan's direction. Kacchan, for once, remained silent, watching what was happening with narrowed eyes, bristling as he felt Shouto's eyes on him once more.

"He was thinking about *you* ," Shouto said, the bitterness evident in how he spat the word. "He'll do anything. For *you.* "

Kacchan frowned, his jaw tensing, and Shouto let out a tired-sounding laugh, before sheathing his knife once more. Without looking at either of them, Shouto walked towards the wall of the warehouse, his back sliding against the dusty surface as he dropped to his haunches.

"So, go on then," he muttered. "Explain it. What's so special about you, huh?"

Kacchan's eyebrows rose in surprise. Izuku didn't know what to say, or what to do, feeling eyes on him, waiting on him, the weight of his guilt already heavy on his shoulders now dragging on each of his limbs. To his wretched relief, it was Kacchan who finally spoke.

"I was bitten nearly two years ago," he explained. "I got a fever, got sick, but I didn't die and I didn't turn. We lost one of our group not long after Deku joined us. He was infected by my blood, so we know that I still carry the virus. I can still infect people, and in a few weeks, *months* if I'm lucky, I'm probably going to turn."

"What do you mean?" Mina cried, getting to her feet."How can you know that?"

"Because, at this fucking stage the amount of alcohol I need to drink to keep the virus at bay is virtually fucking impossible to maintain," Kacchan replied shortly. "It's been getting worse for a while. The headaches and shit. But," he sighed, "turns out I can also control those dead fuckers out there. Kinda at least."

"So that's why the zombies didn't come after Kaminari," Kirishima asked. "Why none of them touched you?"

"I didn't realise I had that amount of control," Kacchan replied. "I been practising, on zombies out there when I'm on patrol, and once they go into a frenzy like that I usually don't have any control

at all. They'll eat them-fucking- *selves* if there's nothing else available… I don't know why they just went after Dabi and the rest and ignored all of you."

"How long have you been able to control them?" Mina asked.

Kacchan shrugged. "I dunno. Couple weeks maybe? Fuck, it might'a been longer and I just didn't realise it, y'know?"

"How- uh," Yaoyorozu cleared her throat, nervously. "How do you know that means you're doing to turn? It's just… no one's been able to control them before, right? That's not a normal symptom after a bite."

"Deku and I found some shit whilst we were out there," Kacchan replied. "Turns out I ain't the only one that's survived a bite. We met one, 'cept this guy was ahead of me in the… process, or whatever you want to call it. He'd been bit, didn't turn until six months after, but before he did he was getting headaches, blackouts, he was able to control them too."

"He told you this?" Shouto asked, voice still quiet and dull.

"Sorta," Kacchan grumbled with a shrug. "Kept a diary. Deku found it after I wasted the fucking thing."

"So, that's what this is all about, then?" Shouto gestured between Izuku and Kacchan. "The fixation with UA. You're hoping maybe they can stop you from… *progressing.* "

Kacchan hesitated, glancing at Izuku before he nodded jerkily. "Right."

"But now you've been bitten a second time, and you have no idea what that's going to mean."

"I can make a pretty good fucking guess," Kacchan replied. "It's not like I've been getting any better, is it? Fuck, last time I almost died from a kidney infection, now I got an arm full of whatever nasty shit lived in that zombie's mouth."

"But you survived once," Shouto said. "You could again."

Kacchan scowled at him, before he shrugged, turning his attention back to Kaminari once more.

"Whatever. There ain't shit anyone can do about it but there is no fucking way this asshole is gonna die, so how about we just focus on that for now, hah?"

The group turned their attention back to Kaminari, who Kirishima had wrapped in his jacket, holding him close to his chest. Kaminari was shivering, his body shaking and trembling in Kirishima's arms despite the two coats draped over him, and the damage inflicted upon him was startlingly clear on his ghostly skin.

"There's gotta be something more we can do," Kacchan said.

"Until I clean up, I can't touch him," Izuku replied, regretfully stepping away from Kacchan and dropping the bottle of antiseptic into the pack. "He could be going into shock from the pain and trauma he's been through or he's bleeding heavy somewhere that I can't see. We don't have

anything I can use for a transfusion, no saline no *nothing* .” Izuku resisted the urge to press his hands against his face to ease the pressure in his aching temple. “His jaw is busted up, but anything I do now is just going to cause him more pain. We are doing all we can right now.”

“Could you do more for him back at the playground?” Shouto asked.

“Maybe, but we can’t move him right now either. There’s no way to safely carry him, and he sure as shit can’t walk on his own!” Izuku replied voice laced with frustration. “Not to mention there are dozens of zombies outside that still know we’re in here.”

“They’ll leave eventually,” Mina replied. “If we stay quiet and don’t draw any attention to ourselves, they’ll move on like they always do.”

“But we have no idea how long that will be,” Shouto reasoned.

“Deku,” Kacchan said, grabbing his attention. “What is there at the playground we can use?”

“I-” he hesitated, already knowing that Kacchan was about to suggest. “There’s a box of hydration tablets,” he sighed. “Water. More antiseptic so I can clean. There isn’t a lot, but there was a small stockpile of pain relief back there too. It… it’d help.”

“Right,” Kacchan replied. “Hand me some of that bandage, if there’s any left.”

Izuku swallowed, looking back at him.

“Deku, you know well as I do there ain’t anybody else who can take this risk,” Kacchan said firmly. “And fuck knows how soon after the bite I’ll start feeling like horse shite warmed up. I do it now or we hang around here watching him get worse.”

“Are you seriously going back out there?” Mina asked.

“Look, for all we know I’m half the reason the zombies ain’t left us alone yet,” Kacchan replied shortly. “I already gave over a hundred of them the slip back at the hospital, I think I can manage the ones out there.”

“Someone should go with you,” Kirishima said. “Just in case you get overwhelmed.”

Kacchan let out a growl of frustration. “I swear it’s like you want to get eaten!” he snapped. “I don’t need your help. Only reason I got bit is ‘coz this asshole is so fucking slow-” he jabbed his thumb in Shouto’s direction. “It’ll be safer and a hell of a lot quicker for me to go on my own.”

“But… what about Dabi?” Mina asked, nervously. “The others. Aren’t they still out there?”

“The chick is dead,” Kacchan replied shortly. “I saw Dabi get dragged down but no idea if he’s dead or not. As for the Shigaraki, I got no clue. But I can handle it.” He grinned tightly, not a lick of humour in his expression. “I can always set more zombies on them.”

Izuku’s stomach churned, but no matter how hard he tried, he couldn’t think of a better option right now. He was kicking himself for taking Kaminari’s wounds so lightly at the start, and the looming realisation that things might only get worse from this point was like an ache in his gut, growing and

gnawing until he was certain that it was only a matter of time before it was all he could think about. With a sigh of resignation, he grabbed at the little remaining bandage, the frayed edges hanging from the pack, and approached Kacchan once more.

“I got it,” he mumbled, grabbing Kacchan’s uninjured arm and tugging him towards the corner of the room, Kacchan giving in to the pressure and following after him.

“I can do that,” Kacchan said, as Izuku placed the bandage just below the bite, and started to wrap.

“Or you could just let me help?” Izuku sighed, not meeting his eyes as he focused on what he was doing. “Does it hurt?”

“Nah,” Kacchan scoffed. Izuku glanced up, knowing his gaze was needlessly harsh when Kacchan at least had the good graces to look chastised.

“Fine. It hurts like hell, you happy?”

“Not even close.”

They stood in silence as Izuku continued to wrap his wound, tucking the edge of the bandage in on itself as best as he could, given how little of it they had. It wouldn’t hold for long, but it might at least prevent the dirt from Kacchan’s clothes from making situations worse. Once he had finished, there was a prolonged silence between them, Izuku still holding onto Kacchan’s outstretched arm, neither of them making a move.

“You know I’ll be back, right?”

Izuku started, looking up at Kacchan.

“I know that,” he replied softly. “That’s not… You leaving us right now isn’t what’s worrying me.”

“Deku,” Kacchan sighed, taking his arm back, and dragging his sleeve back down. “It’s not like this changes anything.”

Izuku scowled. He wanted to tell Kacchan that this *did* change things, this changed so fucking much and Izuku had no idea where to even start when it came to organising his feelings over all of this, but now was not the time. They had other things to worry about.

“The hydration pills are in a blue box,” Izuku replied instead, ignoring the way Kacchan’s brow furrowed. “With the rest of the medication. Bring towels, if you can, wipes, anything I can use to make sure my hands are clean.”

Kacchan remained silent for a moment, his expression scrutinising as he looked back at Izuku, before finally nodding.

“Make noise at the door,” he said, louder so that his voice carried across the room. “Need to make an opening so I can get out of the front exit.”

He grabbed his bat from where he had dropped it onto the ground, checking the weapons attached to his hips and thighs before making his way across the room.

“Be careful out there,” Kirishima said. Kacchan grunted, before nodding his head once at Izuku. Izuku began to pound against the thick metal panels of the back door, the sound loud and causing the zombies to slam against it with renewed vigour, and Kacchan took advantage of the moment to slip out of the door, Yaoyorozu shutting it behind him and flicking the lock back in place. There was a tense moment, where they heard nothing from outside besides the thumping of the zombies before a shrill whistle rang out.

“Come on, you nasty fucks, let’s go!” Kacchan yelled from the street. It took a few moments and more curse-encrusted encouragement from Kacchan, but the banging against the door started to die down as the zombies lost interest in their quarry within, and took notice of Kacchan. Kacchan’s voice grew quieter as he moved away from the warehouse until finally they were left in heavy silence, Izuku swallowing back the bile churning in his gut.

“How is he looking?” he asked, turning back to Mina and Kirishima.

“Still out,” Mina replied. “But I don’t think he’s shivering quite so much now.”

“That’s good,” Izuku breathed. “Kacchan’s quick, unless he runs into trouble, he shouldn’t be gone more than a couple of hours. We just need to do what we can until then.”

Izuku half expected Shouto to start asking questions, but he remained silent and somewhat detached, the smallest of creases on his brow as he looked down at the knife he was slowly twisting between his fingertips.

The time that followed passed by agonisingly slow. The zombies, from the sounds of things, hadn’t found their way back to the warehouse, offering them some respite from the banging and hounding at least. But without the zombies outside, they were instead forced to listen to Kaminari’s laboured breathing, each of them tensing with each shaking exhale, waiting for the inhale. Kaminari remained unconscious the entire time, his body mercifully warming up through the efforts of Mina and Kirishima huddled on either side of him, and Izuku wasn’t sure if that was a good thing or not. At least unconscious he wasn’t suffering from the pain in his jaw and poor abused body.

Finally, after what Izuku guessed to be a little over an hour, there were three sharp raps against the door, Kacchan’s rough low voice calling out to them from the other side. Izuku rushed to his feet, unlocking the door and wrenching it towards him.

Kacchan somehow managed to look filthier than he had before he left; blood soaked his jeans now, the front of his coat ripped deep enough for the padding to show through, and Izuku wondered just how many zombies he had fought to get back here.

“Meds and cleaning supplies in the pack,” Kacchan said, thrusting the bag at Izuku. “And I brought one of the ten jugs, it’s only half full, but should do.”

He dropped a ten-litre jug onto the floor in front of Izuku, before kicking the door shut behind him.

“You have any trouble?”

“No, no one bothered us after you left,” Izuku replied, dropping to his haunches so he could inspect the contents of the bag, relieved to see the hydration tablets and some mild pain relief among the

towels and antiseptic solution.

“And Kaminari?”

“He hasn’t woken up,” Kirishima said. “But he doesn’t seem to have gotten any worse.”

Izuku set to work, pulling off his outer clothes despite how cold it was until he was left standing in his t-shirt, before scrubbing at his blood-covered hands and arms.

“You should clean up, too,” Izuku said, glancing back up at Kacchan.

“Don’t you need that shit?” Kacchan replied shortly. “I’m fine.”

“Honestly, man, for our sanity, it’d be cool if you got rid of some of the zombie, uh… *stuff* off your face,” Kirishima agreed, and with an irritated grumble Kacchan snatched the pack of baby wipes.

Izuku washed his hands three times before he felt confident he had removed all of the blood from his skin and beneath his fingernails and approached the unconscious Kaminari. The first thing he needed to do was figure out what injuries he had, exactly, and how many of them he could handle right now. His jaw was the obvious first hurdle, and he asked for Kirishima and Mina to sit Kaminari upright so that he could get a closer look, his fingers gently pressing along the sides of Kaminari’s face.

“I think,” he muttered, feeling the way that his jaw protruded forward, “that it’s just dislocated, not broken.”

“Is that a good thing?” Kirishima asked. Izuku nodded, offering him the briefest smile.

“This is probably gonna hurt,” he said, “but, uh… at least it’ll wake him up.”

“Wait… what are you doing?” Hagakure yelped, as Izuku opened Kaminari’s mouth, his thumbs sliding through parted lips and pressing flush against his back teeth.

“I’ve never done this before,” Izuku admitted, looking up to the rest of the group. “But I know the general idea of what to do. Unless anyone has any better ideas?”

Hagakure swallowed and shook her head, and Izuku took a deep breath, focusing his attention back on Kaminari. He’d seen illustrations in textbooks on how to do this, but a couple of lines on a page hardly prepared him for how terrifying a situation it was… too much pressure and he risked making everything worse, and with too little, he’d just be hurting Kaminari for no good reason.

“You sure you got this, man?” Kirishima asked, and Izuku flashed him an irritated look before he pressed down hard on the back of Kaminari’s jaw with his thumb. There was a tense moment, a loud *pop* filling the air so obscenely that Hagakure started to whimper again before Kaminari’s eyes snapped open. Izuku, in all his wisdom, had somehow not considered the very natural reaction that would come from waking up in a huge amount of pain and with someone’s fingers in your mouth, and he felt Kaminari clamp down hard on his thumbs. He shouted out in surprise, his hand instinctively pulling back just as Kaminari became aware of what was going on and letting go.

“Izuku!” Shouto called out in alarm. “Are you ok?”

Izuku thrust his hands beneath his armpits, holding back the colourful curses that wanted to spill from his lips as his thumbs throbbed. He nodded.

“Fine!”

“Kaminari,” Kirishima said breathlessly, and Izuku looked up to see Kaminari’s dazed and confused face, blinking back at him, swaying where he sat.

“Where-” Kaminari groaned, his hand coming up to cup his jaw.

“Hey, Kaminari, how are you feeling?” Izuku asked. His thumbs were going to be hurting for a while, both of them growing red, but the skin had not been broken at least.

“Ungg,” Kaminari moaned, his face screwing up in pain.

“Ok, can you hear me?” Izuku asked. “Raise two fingers for yes.”

With another groan, Kaminari lifted a shaky hand, and Izuku smiled back at him.

“Good, that’s good! Can you point to where else hurts?”

Kaminari frowned, eyes widening beneath his brow as he waved his hand across his chest, gesturing to his entire body.

“Anywhere that hurts most?” Izuku asked. “Except your jaw, that is.”

Kaminari seemed to consider for a moment before he slowly shook his head, and Izuku was able to let out a sigh of relief. Kaminari’s state of unconsciousness was most likely due to the stress of the situation, the dip in adrenaline, and not anything more serious than that.

“You think you can swallow some pills?”

Kaminari whined, shooting Izuku a somewhat desperate look before he slowly nodded.

“Ok.”

Kacchan was already at his side, dropping the pack and the jug of water down on the ground within reach before he, too, hunkered down, getting a good look at Kaminari’s face. Then, all at once, Kaminari’s eyes filled with tears.

“Kah-”

“Don’t try to talk, moron,” Kacchan chastised, his tone far more gentle than normal. “I’m fine.”

Kaminari shook his head, the tears leaking freely down his cheeks.

“You’re noh!” he whimpered. “You goh bih!”

Kacchan shrugged his shoulders. “Hardly,” he replied. “It barely grazed me. You know zombies

ain't got shit on me."

Kaminari didn't look the least bit convinced, the pain in his expression no longer just from the injuries on his body.

"The important thing right now is that we get you back to the playground," Kacchan continued. "There's still a chance one of them is out there, or the zombies are drawn back here."

"I think Kaminari should rest a little longer," Izuku protested. "He's only just woken up."

"We can afford to stay here a little longer," Mina agreed. "No one has found us yet, and even if the zombies do come back, they're not going to be able to get in here."

Kacchan's jaw jutted forward, a scowl dropping to his face as he got back to his feet. He looked agitated, Izuku watching as his right hand clenched and flexed.

"We can't stay here forever," he replied shortly. "I still need to finish putting the fucking dynamite together before…" He trailed off, but Izuku knew what he was trying to say. *'Before I can't anymore.'*

"We don't all need to stay here," Yaoyorozu said. "We could split up, some of us stay here with Kaminari, and the rest go back with you to finish the bombs."

"No," Kacchan snapped. "Splitting up like that is too dangerous. You think you can handle a horde alone if they came back?"

"I can wahk," Kaminari said. "We don' habba wai-"

"You're probably still dehydrated," Izuku interrupted softly. "It'll do us no good if you pass out when we're out there. I get what Kacchan's saying, but right now staying put is the only option we have, at least for another few hours."

Kacchan grumbled, but he didn't argue, instead setting himself up against the garage door, legs kicked out in front of him, and arms crossing over his chest.

"Let me take another look at your bite at least."

"Why? You already bandaged it up. Not like it's gonna have changed much in a fuckin' hour."

"But I didn't get to clean it properly-"

"It's *fine* , Deku," Kacchan huffed. "Get off my dick about it, won't you?"

An uncomfortable silence followed, the rest of the room trying very hard to appear like they weren't listening, and Izuku sighed. He knew better than to try and force Kacchan into anything, and for the time being, at least, there wasn't much more that Izuku was going to be allowed to do for him. All he *could* do was wait.

By the morning, Kacchan was running a fever.

They ended up staying in the warehouse until first light, none of them feeling entirely comfortable travelling in the dark when they still had no real idea if either Dabi or Shigaraki might still be out there. Kacchan, for what it was worth, made a valiant effort to hide his worsening condition from all of them, and it was only because Izuku was so familiar with the man that he noticed the flush on his cheeks, the guarded way that he held himself, keeping his distance from the rest of them when they finally left the warehouse. It wasn't like it was unexpected; Sero had started running a fever soon after his bite as well, and even if Kacchan's body *was* going to fight off the infection as it had before, a fever was inevitable. But, seeing the symptoms, so obvious to him when he knew what to look for, was still enough to leave Izuku's blood running cold. It was confirmation… it made it all too real, and Izuku had no idea just how sick Kacchan was going to become. It didn't help that getting Kaminari back to the playground proved to be no small fete; he had some horrible bruising on his hip where he had been beaten, and it left him with a painful limp that made him slow and clumsy. Without Kirishima supporting him, Kaminari wasn't able to get far at all, and there was arguably nothing more hazardous than being unable to run in a zombie Apocalypse.

Fortunately, they had some luck that morning; aside from the odd pair making their way in the direction of UA, they hadn't seen many zombies on the road, and none they weren't able to sneak past. Neither Dabi nor Shigaraki made an appearance either, and Izuku allowed himself to hope that maybe the horde had taken care of things for them. If *Kacchan* had only just made it out, then it certainly didn't look good for either of them…

Once they were back at the playground, and Kaminari was laid down with strict instructions to rest for the remainder of the day, Kacchan was quick to change, shamelessly stripping to his underwear now that he no longer had to keep his scar hidden away, before pulling on clean clothes.

"I'm headed straight to the police station," he announced, as he threw both a bottle of water and an unopened vodka into his pack and snatched a can of peaches. "I still probably got two more days of work left to do before we have enough explosives to destroy the stadium, and not just a part of it. Then we have to rig the things and get the dynamite in there."

An uncomfortable silence followed his words, the group watching him as he checked the knives attached to his many belts and straps, and tightened his pack around his shoulders.

"Is… are you going to have enough time?" Hagakure finally asked tentatively. Kacchan glanced up at her for just a moment.

"Yes," he replied firmly. "I won't be back 'til it's done. I got the walkie, so all you have to do is stay alive. Don't take any fucking risks, you hear me?"

He aimed his next glare at Kaminari, who nodded, his face flushing bright pink.

"You need someone to go with you," Kirishima said. "You can't stay on the lookout if you're focusing on what you're doing."

"I'll go."

Izuku stared at Shouto in shock, the rest of the group just as taken back.

"No, I should-"

“Deku, you need to stay here with Kaminari,” Kacchan interrupted firmly. “I know you wanna come with me, but if anything else happens to this idiot then you’re the one that can help him.”

Izuku swallowed. Kacchan was right, of course, it made more sense for him to stay here with Kaminari, to protect the group should anything else happen whilst Kacchan was gone, but the light sheen of sweat beading on Kacchan’s forehead was impossible for anyone to miss now.

“Besides,” Kacchan continued, jabbing his thumb in Shouto’s direction. “If I can count on any of you to gimme a solid hit in the skull if I start turning it’s this asshole.”

“Kacchan, that’s not funny,” Izuku said immediately.

“It’s kinda funny,” Kacchan replied with a shrug. “Two days. We’ll be back, Deku, I promise.”

It took Izuku a moment to realise that this was the first time that Kacchan had ever made him a promise like this… All that they had been through, the goodbyes they had already said, not once had Kacchan ever made him a promise that he would come back to him. Kacchan looked back at him, his words written all over his face, open and earnest, and Izuku found that he believed him.

“Ok,” Izuku finally said. “But we’re going to need updates, every hour if it comes to it I don’t care, you can’t go radio silence on us for two whole days.”

“I’ll radio every four, how does that sound?” Shouto asked.

Izuku took a deep breath and nodded.

“Great.” Kacchan yanked at the laces on his boots before dusting himself off. “Let’s go, fuck face.”

“You could try using my name,” Shouto replied blankly.

“I got bit for you I’ll call you whatever I fucking like!” Kacchan snapped in response, and Izuku watched the two of them leave, refusing to allow himself to even consider that it might be the last time that he would, and swallowing down the lump in his throat threatening to choke him. This was for the best… and maybe Kacchan and Shouto spending some time together might convince the latter that he could still have some faith and trust in them.

“Hey, maybe they’ll bond,” Mina said as if she knew what he was thinking. Izuku snorted a weird, strangled laugh at that.

“I’ll just be happy if they don’t end up trying to kill each other,” he admitted.

True to his word, around four hours later Shouto radioed in to tell them that they had made it to the police station and that Kacchan was already working on the next batch of explosives. And that was how things continued for that first day, Izuku either watching Kaminari sleep or watching the walkie-talkie, relieved with each piece of reassurance that Kacchan was still alive, and that the virus didn’t seem to be moving all that quickly.

It wasn’t until four that following morning that Izuku got his first indication of how much trouble Kacchan was really in.

Izuku wasn't expecting the walkie to crackle into action then; it had only been a couple of hours since Shouto had last spoken to him, and it was with a jolt that he snatched at it. The rest of the group were asleep, Izuku offering to take the watch given that he was going to be awake waiting on Shouto anyway, and it was with frantic whispers that he responded.

"Shouto?"

"Izuku," Shouto replied, his voice quiet like he was hoping not to be overheard. *"Sorry, I hope I didn't wake you."*

"No, no I was already awake," Izuku replied, glancing up at the rest of the group. He got carefully to his feet and walked towards the front of the playground and away from where they were sleeping, leaning against the door and peering out into the parking lot. "Is everything ok?"

There was a prolonged silence from the walkie, and Izuku felt his heart rate spike once more.

"Shouto? I said is everything ok? Do you copy?"

"I… uh, copy," Shouto replied. *"It's… look, Bakugou's asleep, I thought this would be the best time to… talk. Over."*

Izuku paled. "Oh," he breathed, shutting his eyes. "Shouto I… I am sorry. You're right, what I did, keeping all this from you, endangering your group it- Shit, I shouldn't have done it. It was wrong of me, and I never meant to betray your trust like that, not ever."

"That's not- Izuku, I'm still mad at you, I admit that. And we're definitely going to need to talk about that at some point, but it's not actually why I'm calling you. Over."

"It isn't?" Izuku replied, confused. "Then what-" his breath caught in his throat. "Kacchan, is he ok? Over."

"He seems pretty determined to ignore everything," Shouto replied. *"But no. He's not. I don't think the virus is moving as quickly as I'm used to seeing it, but it's affecting him. I just… I just thought you should know because something tells me he wasn't about to admit it to you himself. Over."*

Izuku stared out over the parking lot, the walkie held slack in his fingers.

"Izuku?"

"Yeh, sorry, I heard you, Shouto," Izuku replied softly. "Do… do you think you need to come back? Over."

Shouto didn't respond immediately, perhaps trying to decide whether or not Izuku's reply ought to have been expected before he eventually spoke.

"I don't think Bakugou would agree to that. Over."

Izuku surprised himself with the gentle laugh that left his lips, a ghost of a smile gracing his feature. "That sounds like Kacchan."

He heard a groan from the other side of the room, and realising Kaminari was waking up, he stood up straight and rubbed his tired eyes roughly, his right all the more blurry given how little he had slept.

“Kaminari’s waking up, I have to go.”

“Do… uh, do you want me to say anything to Bakugou?”

Izuku had all too much that he wanted to say to Kacchan. But he had made a promise, and Izuku had faith in him to keep it.

“Not right now, just let him sleep before he overworks himself again in the morning,” Izuku replied. “I’ll speak later. Over and out.”

Shouto didn’t mention Kacchan’s condition again after that.

The following day, he contacted them to tell them that they were ahead of schedule and that the next thing they needed to focus on was transporting the dynamite to the stadium. Even if they were very lucky, the chances of finding a car with a working battery and fuel that hadn’t completely degraded over the last two years were impossible, so their only option would be to carry several kilograms worth of live dynamite from the station to the stadium. It was risky, especially if they ended up running into trouble along the way, and now that Kaminari was recovering, it was decided that Izuku and Kirishima would come along to help.

“How are we going to get the explosives in the right locations when we get there?” Izuku had asked after.

“Most of it we can apply to the external of the building,” Kacchan had responded, *“but we’re gonna have to lob some into the herd, that’s gonna be the hardest part.”*

“But the dynamite will explode!” Mina had yelped, and despite the distinct roughness to his voice, Kacchan had wasted no time yelling back about how they didn’t know shit about dynamite and that this was his damn job and *didn’t they think if it was gonna explode on impact he wouldn’t have fucking suggested it in the first place?!* Izuku was at least somewhat comforted by the fact that Kacchan still had the energy to argue.

Despite how eager Izuku was to see Kacchan, they had to wait until the first light of the third day before setting off. Kacchan didn’t want to waste any time, and installing the dynamite and setting up the rigs was his main priority, but it wasn’t something that they’d be able to do in the dark. The plan was to put the dynamite in place, and then for the entire group to head towards UA and put enough distance between them and the stadium before Kacchan finally set it off to blow. If everything worked smoothly, the explosion would be big enough and loud enough to grab the attention of half the city, if not *more* , and would drag the zombie’s attention away from UA long enough for them to get close. If there was indeed anyone in UA, they’d notice the explosion too, and with any luck, Izuku could use his links to UA and the professors to get them inside.

That was if everything went to plan. And Izuku had every confidence that it would, at least… up until he saw Kacchan again.

Nothing could have prepared him for the pale, sunken-eyed man that greeted them outside of the

police station early that morning. Kacchan looked rough… bruising around his eyes and his lips so dry that blood stained them from where they had split. He stood in just a t-shirt despite the cold, the sweat dripping down his temple and the black veins coiling upwards out of the bandage and towards his inner elbow.

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathed, frozen in place.

“Yeh yeh, I look like shit,” Kacchan replied sourly, refusing to meet Izuku’s eyes as he instead gestured to the four packs at his feet. “Grab a bag, let’s go.”

“Wait,” Kirishima said. “Dude, you look like you’re gonna keel over any minute! Maybe we shouldn’t do this right now-”

“You’d rather wait til I’m a zombie instead?” Kacchan spat. “Dangle a fuckin rat in front of me and say *mush?* We’re doing this right fuckin’ now, Shitty Hair.”

“But… Katsuki,” Kirishima choked. There were tears in the man’s eyes as he looked at his friend and Izuku… Izuku didn’t know what to say. He was all too numb to do more than stare, feeling too much and too little all at the same time.

“Just grab a pack,” Kacchan said. “We’re heading to UA after, right? Worry about me then.”

Kirishima sniffed, rubbing the tears from his cheeks as he selected one of the backpacks. Shouto stood silently by the door, and Izuku could feel that his eyes were on him as he reached forward too. Up close, Kacchan looked even paler, and Izuku could stop himself from reaching out, his fingertips ghosting over Kacchan’s cheeks before his hand was hurriedly brushed away.

“Later.”

That was all Kacchan said before shouldering a pack of his own and stomping forward, refusing to let his condition slow any of them down, despite the sweat dripping from him, and the harsh breaths cutting his lips as they walked.

They reached the stadium a little under an hour later, the rumbling of a thousand zombies walking slowly in circles was disturbing enough, but the smell coming from such a large group of rotting bodies was overwhelming, and as they neared Kacchan darted from the path, bent double as he hurled into a bin, knuckles white as they gripped hold of the metal rim.

“Kacchan!”

Izuku rushed to his side, Kacchan weakly waving a hand back at him as if ushering him away.

“I’m- fine-”

“You’re not fine,” Izuku said firmly. Kacchan wiped the back of his wrist over his mouth and stood straight again. He was breathing harshly, and Izuku could feel the heat radiating off him even as he stood a foot away. Kacchan’s hands were shaking, and he swayed dangerously on the spot for a moment before Izuku steadied him. It was bad, worse than bad… Kacchan was suffering the full effects of the virus, and there wasn’t anything that Izuku could do to help him.

“Kacchan,” Izuku said softly, “you don’t have to do this. You’re in pain, you should be resting.”

“I have to,” Kacchan replied. “‘Zuku… I…” Kacchan swallowed, taking a deep, rattly breath. “I gotta do this. It’s the best… the best chance any of you have got.”

“Not if it kills you,” Izuku hissed back. He knew Shouto and Kirishima were watching, but thankfully both of them had decided to hang back, giving Izuku and Kacchan a moment to talk.

“I ain’t dying yet.”

Kacchan’s response was firm, and he looked up to meet Izuku’s eyes at last. They were bloodshot, bruised, but still just as fiery as they had ever been, just as determined.

“I need to do this.”

Izuku looked back at him, and when he raised a hand to brush the short sweaty strands of hair back from Kacchan’s forehead, he didn’t push him away.

“Ok,” Izuku replied. “But let me help you.”

Kacchan nodded stiffly, not fighting back as Izuku took Kacchan’s left arm and wrapped it around his shoulder, steadying Kacchan so that he could continue towards the stadium, holding onto him until they were only a few metres away.

“We need to place dynamite on every entry and exit point to the baseball stadium,” Kacchan said. “The pitch is huge, so we’re probably not going to take out every zombie with the blast, even if we do get some dynamite inside, so we need to make sure that those that do survive, can’t escape from the rubble.”

“How do we get the dynamite inside?” Shouto asked.

“We’re gonna have to do that last,” Kacchan replied. “If we can get high enough, we can just throw them as far as we can into the group. There’s a risk that the noise will cause a stampede, but I’m banking on the fact that they’re not only driven by sound, but by smell too. They’re making enough noise in there just walking, so only those closest are gonna hear the dynamite drop, and if there’s no smell, hopefully, they’ll just ignore it.”

“But won’t the receiver break?” Izuku asked.

“Possibly,” Kacchan replied, and Izuku noted the lack of irritation, the almost complete lack of cursing, as he gave his explanation. “But that’s why I’ve wrapped four sticks with the padding of my jacket, if we’re lucky that’ll be enough to prevent anything from breaking. But-” Kacchan took a deep breath, “-there is a downside to that.”

“Downside?” Kirishima asked.

“Yeh. Namely that the signal ain’t gonna send as far, not through that and all the zombies hunkered around it.”

And that was it… *This was the moment* . Izuku stared at Kacchan as he kept his gaze focused on his

pack, pulling out the four wrapped sticks and placing them on the ground.

“So, we’re going to need to be closer?” Kirishima asked.

“One of us is,” Kacchan replied. “You guys need to go ahead, get Kaminari and Mina as close to UA as you can get. I’ll need to detonate from the playground and follow you after.”

“No.”

It was Kirishima who spoke this time, and Kacchan shut his eyes tight, already expecting the argument. Izuku knew what this was about… he knew that Kacchan was probably lying about the signal, about one of them needing to stay behind. But Kacchan had already told Izuku that he had no plans on going to UA, and this would be it. A perfectly reasonable explanation for why Kacchan couldn’t go with them before he could slip away, leave them behind, and let them carry on their lives without him.

“No!” Kirishima repeated, in a furious whisper. “That’s crazy, man! You can hardly stand, how are you supposed to catch up with us and avoid any of the zombies?”

“I’m the only one who knows how any of this shit works if something *does* go wrong,” Kacchan replied. “And with Kaminari as he is, you guys need a head start.”

“Fine, then I’ll stay here with you-” Kirishima started, but Izuku interrupted him.

“You should be with Mina and Kaminari,” he said. “I’ll stay behind with Kacchan, just in case. I’m good at making a getaway, and I know the area better than anyone, I can get me and Kacchan back to you before you know it.”

Kirishima and Shouto both looked unsure, but Kacchan didn’t give them enough time to argue, before barking his orders.

“You two place the dynamite around the back, two per exit, and then get back here to meet us,” he said. “Me and Deku will take care of the main entrance. Don’t get fuckin’ seen.”

Shouto nodded, gesturing for Kirishima to follow him, and after a moment of hesitation, he did, leaving Izuku and Kacchan alone.

“Kacchan-”

“I haven’t changed my mind.”

“I’m not asking you to.”

Kacchan looked up in surprise at that.

“Kacchan, I promised I would help you,” Izuku replied his throat tight. “And I… I meant it.”

It hurt more than he could ever explain, but seeing Kacchan this sick, this *tired* was infinitely more painful than anything else.

“Ok,” Kacchan breathed. “Let’s get the dynamite on the gate.”

The front entrance to the baseball stadium was shut with a deadbolt and a chain wrapped around the gate; secure against anyone who might wander in out of curiosity, but nothing against the several kilograms of explosive dynamite that Izuku proceeded to attach to the outside, Kacchan not trusting his trembling fingers enough to do it for himself, despite the obvious embarrassment he felt at saying that. It didn’t take long before Kirishima and Shouto were joining them again, and Kacchan passed them the wrapped sticks.

“Don’t get seen,” he said firmly. “Four sticks, try and keep ‘em evenly spread, but as close to the centre as you can throw them. Got it?”

Kirishima nodded, taking two sticks.

“Once they’re in there, we just need to hope that they weren’t too damaged to detonate.”

Izuku was even tenser after that, half expecting to hear the zombies inside rush and charge at the gates any second, but after four nerve-wracking minutes, both Kirishima and Shouto returned, confirming that they had thrown the dynamite without causing the zombies inside too much.

“Anything else we need to do?” Shouto asked. Kacchan shook his head.

“Let’s get back to the playground,” Kirishima said.

“You go ahead,” Kacchan said. “I wanna check everything one last time. And it’ll give you guys a bigger head start.”

“Are you sure?” Izuku asked, unable to stop himself, his chest aching at the realisation that Kacchan wasn’t planning on saying goodbye, on seeing them all one last time.

“Kaminari needs as much time as we can give him,” Kacchan replied firmly.

“Ok,” Kirishima sighed. “Just… be careful, alright? Both of you. We’ll meet you outside of UA in a few hours, right? Just like we planned.”

“Just like we planned,” Kacchan said.

Kirishima stood where he was for a moment longer, looking back at Kacchan, before he nodded.

“See you soon,” Shouto said to Izuku, and with a last glance back, the two of them were off, carrying their empty packs. Izuku waited until they were out of earshot before he turned back to Kacchan, feeling his eyes starting to sting.

“You didn’t want to see them again?” he asked, voice hushed. Kacchan shook his head furiously, scowling back at him.

“Better this way.”

“Better for who?” Izuku pressed. “Kacchan-”

“Better for me,” Kacchan snapped. “That what you want to hear? I can’t… I can’t do it, ok?”

Izuku blinked back the tears. “Ok. Ok, Kacchan, I’m sorry. You want to check everything one last time before we go?”

“Nah, I only said that so we’d have a good excuse to hang back, I know I set everything up fucking perfect.”

Izuku nodded. It was feeling more surreal with the passing of every second, a sluggishness settling deep into his bones like he was swimming through custard and struggling not to drown in it, to not think about what came next.

“Where’s the detonator?” Izuku asked, and Kacchan pointed to one of the packs left down by the path. “I’ll grab it and we’ll start walking back, yeh?”

Kacchan nodded. Izuku turned and walked towards the pack, flinching against the wave of dizziness that hit him as he leaned down to grab it. None of this… none of it felt real. It was just some kind of joke, surely? Any second now, Kacchan was going to laugh that loud, ugly laugh of his and tell him that everything was fine and he was just messing around, that *of course* they were going to go to UA together. Of course, he wanted to see his friends again. Of course, he wasn’t going to leave. But as he held the pack to his chest, fingers ghosting over the shape of the detonator inside, no laugh met his ears; only the slow, miserable thud of his heart. He took a deep breath and turned before the wind was immediately knocked out of him.

“Kacchan!”

Kacchan lay face forward on the pavement, blood spreading out from the old wound on top of his head, and Izuku was racing towards him, the pack abandoned on the ground.

“Kacchan!”

But he hadn’t even made it halfway back across the path before pain exploded in the back of the head, and he fell forward into darkness.

When Izuku next stirred, it was to the smell of death and a dim ringing in his ears, a groan breaking from his lips as his head and shoulders ached. He blinked furiously, trying to clear the fog, and it was only when he tried to reach a hand up to check for any bleeding on the back of his head, that he realised that he couldn’t move them. His wrists were bound behind him, the reason for the pain in his upper body clear becoming clear. He shook his head, his left eye blurry and useless in the dark, looking around as he tried to make sense of what was going on.

He had been tied to a post of some kind, sitting on the cold stone floor. He didn’t recognise where he was; he was inside a building of some sort, but from the rumbling beneath him and the stench, he figured that he must be close to the stadium if not… if not *inside* of it. He shut his eyes tight, shook his head again, and looked to his right.

Kacchan was there too. He, like Izuku, had been bound and tied to one of the supporting beams in

the room, blood dripping down the side of his face, his chin sitting against his chest as he sat there, still unconscious. Izuku's heart raced, as he slowly started to piece things together. He struggled to look behind him, flinching and groaning at the pain. If they were here, then that meant…

"Well, look who's finally awake."

There was no mistaking that droll voice and Izuku felt the hairs on the back of his neck stand up as the shadowy figure walked out from behind him, towering over his vulnerable form. The grin on that scarred face all but glowed in the darkness, filling the entire room with dread.

"Dabi."

"The one and only," Dabi replied before he dropped to his haunches in front of Izuku, still grinning that terrible grin. "Bet you thought you were rid of me, huh?"

"I should have known better," Izuku spat. "Cockroaches aren't easy to kill, after all."

Dabi laughed, a loud sound that echoed around the empty room.

"You really are just spit and vinegar, ain't you?" he said. "Shame the same can't be said for your boyfriend over there."

Izuku glanced over at Kacchan. He was still unconscious, despite the noise. Izuku's eyes were starting to get used to the darkness now, and Kacchan looked even paler than he had done before, his entire body limp and lifeless.

"What do you want from us?" Izuku asked, trying not to think about how much blood Kacchan must have lost.

Dabi's eyebrows rose. "I wanna kill you, of course. Or at least, that was the fucking plan… but *someone* had to go and get bit, didn't they? Ain't gonna be quite so satisfying to kill him when he's already halfway dead, is it?"

"Then let him go," Izuku said immediately. "You already won. What have you got to gain from hurting him now?"

Dabi sighed, and got to his feet, making his way over to stand in front of Kacchan.

"It's the principle of the thing. I promised this asshole I'd kill him someday, so I got to. Especially after the little stunt, you guys pulled."

"You shot our friend!" Izuku yelled, tugging against the string binding his wrists, feeling more frantic the closer Dabi got to Kacchan. "What did you expect us to do?"

"Your friend came after us first," Dabi shot back. "But I really don't give a shit. I'm going to kill both of you, and I'm going to enjoy it. The only question left is who do I gotta kill first?"

"'Zu-gu-"

Kacchan's muffled groan grabbed both of their attention, Izuku crying out as Dabi grinned once

more, leaning close.

“Finally with us, huh, Bakugou?”

Kacchan’s head bobbed against his chest, entirely bloodshot eyes blinking and unfocused, the sound leaving his lips sounding less like words and more a combination of sounds like he was trying to speak but had forgotten how.

“Hey, I’m talking to you.”

Dabi kicked out with his foot, his boot connected with the side of Kacchan’s face, and Izuku screamed as blood sprayed against the ground. Kacchan slumped in place, coughing up wads of phlegm and blood.

“Oi, you still aren’t listening.”

Dabi crouched down, reaching out and grabbing the front of Kacchan’s hair, tugging his head forward. Kacchan gasped, looking entirely dazed, before Dabi punched forward, a crack filling the air as his fist broke Kacchan’s nose.

“Leave him alone!” Izuku screamed, tears streaming down his face, tugging frantically, his wrists burning from the effort.

“This isn’t even fun now,” Dabi muttered, before spitting on Kacchan’s broken face. Kacchan’s head dropped back to his chin the second that Dabi let go, lying still, still blinking and unfocused, blood bubbling up with every cough.

“Just leave him,” Izuku pleaded, choking on his sobs. “Please. He can’t fight back, *please!”*

“Why, you volunteering to go first?” Dabi sneered, looking back at him. “Maybe that’s just as well. Bet seeing how far the mighty Bakugou has fallen is punishment enough, huh? It’s probably cruel to let you watch this any longer.”

Izuku continued to tug, glaring back at Dabi. “Yeh, I’m volunteering,” he growled. “Not before I kill you! I’ll kill you!”

“Them are some mighty big words for someone in your situation!” Dabi laughed. “How exactly do you plan to kill me with your hands tied up, huh? Look at you, you’re just as fucking pathetic as he is.” Dabi lifted his leg as if to kick Kacchan again.

“I said leave him alone you bastard!”

Dabi sniggered, dropping his leg.

“Well, if you really insist. Let’s you and me have some fun first, huh?”

He began his approach, Izuku glaring up at Dabi over snarling teeth, pulling against the rope around his wrists. He knew that his hands were bleeding from the hot wetness dripping down each of his fingers, but he could also feel the threads start to give. If he kept pulling…

"-ou."

Another garbled attempt at speech came from Kacchan, and Dabi paused, looking back at him.

"What was that, Bakugou? Got something to say?"

"Fu- g- ou-"

"Damn, I don't think he can speak. Did I really hit you that hard?"

Dabi abandoned his approach, and started to walk towards Kacchan again, his expression delighted.

"No!" Izuku gasped, pulling with all his might. "Stop, leave him!"

Dabi hunkered down in front of Kacchan and leaned close.

"What was that, *Kacchan*?" he said. "I can't seem to understand you."

"Fug- ou-" Kacchan mumbled again, only quieter this time, his breath sounding wet and bubbly, and Dabi leaned in closer, the light dancing in his eyes twisted and perverted. And then, Kacchan launched, the movement so fast and unexpected that it made Izuku jump before a loud scream filled the room. Kacchan's expression was feral, eyes burning dangerously as he tore into Dabi's face, his teeth ripping an entire chunk of his cheek free as Dabi reared backwards in his shock. Kacchan spat the flesh onto the ground, blood covering his face as his lips tore back into a triumphant grin.

"I'm infected you dumb fuck!" Kacchan all but screamed. "And I got you! *I got you! I GOT YOU!*"

Dabi stared in shock, sinew visible beneath the missing part of his face, the realisation hitting him before he was on his feet once more. He kicked, and there was nothing Kacchan could do to avoid it, taking another hit to his face even as he laughed, the maniacal sound inhumane, laughing only harder with each kick. Izuku screamed, pulling with all his might before he felt the rope snap, and launched himself forward, colliding with Dabi's side.

He didn't hold back, pulling his fists back and swinging as hard as he could. He wasn't sure who was yelling loudest, everything becoming a blur after that, as he felt the bones crack beneath his knuckles, the thuds becoming wetter and wetter until the screams stopped, and Dabi lay a mangled mess beneath him.

Izuku heaved, breathing in deep gulps of air as he stared down at the indistinguishable lump, before pushing himself back.

"Kacchan!"

He ran forward, dropping to his knees in front of him. Kacchan's laughing had finally stopped, his head lolling from side to side again, as Izuku grabbed his cheeks and gently lift his face.

"Kacchan, can you hear me?"

"I can hear ya, damn nerd," Kacchan muttered. His nose was badly broken, his right eye swollen entirely shut as blood oozed from a large gash above it. Izuku couldn't stop the ugly sob as he

looked at him, finger brushing over his forehead, his cheeks, his lips.

“Kacchan,” he breathed. “Kacchan, baby, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry.”

“Stop apologising.” Kacchan’s left eye, as bloodshot as it was, was focused on him. “It ain’t your fault.”

Izuku sobbed, shaking his head. “I’m gonna get you out of here.”

He let go of Kacchan’s face and shuffled around behind him, pulling at the rope and starting to untie the knot. He shook his head, trying to rid himself of the tears. His knuckles were split, and he was covered in blood; if he wasn’t infected by now it would be a fucking miracle, but he didn’t have time to think about that, focused on only getting Kacchan out of here. He let out a cry of relief when he finally tugged at the knot right, and the threads came free, pulling it aside quickly. Kacchan gasped once he was free, his hands pulling back around to his front.

“Ok,” Izuku breathed frantically. “Ok, come on, I’ve got you.”

With some effort, he was able to lift Kacchan from the ground, wrapping his arm around his shoulder and dragging them both to the exit. There was a lot of noise behind them, banging and scrapping, and Izuku knew it meant the zombies had heard them, that they were all pressed against the inner gates. It was probably only a matter of moments before the gate gave way, and they had to be out of there before that happened. The exit was only a few feet ahead of them, the chains that had once held the gate shut lying on the ground.

“The detonator,” Kacchan grunted. “Where is it?”

“I… I dropped it,” Izuku replied. “It’s still in the backpack.”

“Go get it. There’s no time, go and get it I can manage.”

“But Kacchan-”

“Go, Deku!”

Izuku let out a pained whine before he removed Kacchan’s arm from his shoulder, Kacchan swaying on the spot, but still standing. He didn’t waste a second, sprinting on his wobbly legs towards the red backpack, lying abandoned on the ground some twenty feet away. Then, as he reached it, he heard a sound that would haunt his nightmares for what remained of his lifetime; the dull squeak, followed by a thud, and he turned around in slow dawning horror, just in time to see Kacchan pulling across the deadbolt, shutting himself inside.

“No!”

Izuku ran back, hands slamming against the gate, trying to reach for the internal lock. It didn’t matter how hard he tried, his hands were just too big to fit through the bars, fingers tapping uselessly against the metal.

“Kacchan! What are you doing?”

“I had the detonator,” Kacchan replied quietly, reaching into his back pocket.

“I… I don’t-” Izuku tore the pack open and looked inside, and instead of the small black receiver that was currently held in Kacchan’s hand, he was instead looking at a misshapen piece of metal.

“Don’t be mad,” Kacchan whispered. “I needed a backup.”

Izuku looked back at him, dropping the pack to the ground, his hands now wrapping around the bars.

“Kacchan, don’t,” he pleaded.

“It’s ok, ‘Zuku,” Kacchan replied.

“No, it’s not! It’s not ok!”

“‘Zuku.” Kacchan reached up, placing his hands over Izuku’s. “It’s better this way.”

Izuku shook his head. “But… Kacchan, I can’t-”

“Sure you can. You can do anything. Always could.”

“I don’t want to lose you,” Izuku choked. “I’m not ready.”

It was Kacchan’s turn to sob now, tears leaving tracks down his bloody face. “Me neither,” he said. “You got- you got no idea how much I wish shit could be different. How much I wish I could be with you. Could keep fighting with you. Could keep lov-” Kacchan’s breath hitched, and he gripped Izuku’s hands a little tighter. “But I can’t. It’s time. I’m tired, ‘Zuku, and this way is better.”

“Then, I’ll stay with you,” Izuku whispered, leaning forward so his head pressed against Kacchan’s fingertips. “Together. We go together.”

“They need you, ‘Zuku. I’ve been so scared to leave them. To think what’ll happen to them, but with you? I know they’re safe with you. And I need you to go on protecting them. Please.”

Izuku shook his head.

“Hey,” Kacchan said, and the gentle laugh had Izuku lifting his head again to look back at him. “Besides, you owe me, remember? Back at the truck outside Shinagawa. Your life is mine. And I ain’t about to let you throw it away.”

Izuku sobbed again, and there was a louder thud from behind Kacchan, the loud squeak of metal.

“You gotta go.”

“Kacchan…”

“I fucking love you.”

“I know,” Izuku whispered. “I know. I love you. I love you so much.”

“Go. Get to them before they get themselves into trouble again, huh?”

Izuku nodded, and slowly he let his hands slide away from the warm fingers and the cool metal, taking a step back. Kacchan leaned his head against the bars, holding the detonator up beside his face.

“You gotta run.”

“I love you,” Izuku said again.

Kacchan smiled, and breathed out a long sigh, as Izuku took one final look at his broken yet beautiful face, basked in the last remaining rays of the god-like figure of Kacchan, before he turned and started to run. He could barely see through the tears in his eyes, barely breathe through the sobs, his chest feeling as though someone had taken a hammer to it, crying openly and loudly as he ran.

It wasn’t supposed to end this way.

It wasn’t supposed to end at all.

He wasn’t supposed to fall in love with a man so loud and so deadly as the explosions he created. He wasn’t supposed to fall in love with a man who burned so bright and so quickly as the flames he left behind.

He stumbled, falling forward onto his knees, a cry of pain breaking from his lips.

It was never supposed to hurt this bad.

He slowly pushed himself up, gasping for breath, and against his better judgment, he looked back. The stadium was out of view now, far enough behind that, he couldn’t see Kacchan’s face, no matter how desperately he wanted to.

“I can’t do this,” Izuku breathed. “I can’t…”

He got shakily to his feet. He couldn’t leave Kacchan to die alone. And he knew it was selfish, he knew that his friends needed him, but Kacchan couldn’t die *alone*. He took his first unsteady step forward.

“Ka-”

The explosion was huge, the earth beneath Izuku’s feet rumbling. And Izuku could only watch the big, beautiful red flame burst into the sky before the force hit him square in the chest and he fell once more into darkness.

It ended when you said “goodbye.”

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 37: Fortune Favours the Grave

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku seeks answers.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What the fuck are you doing?"

Izuku started, looking up from the large tree branch he had been dragging through the dirt and wiping away the sweat that had formed on his brow. It was a beautiful day. Sure, there was a chill in the air reminding them that winter wasn't too far away, but the sun was just as bright as it had been all summer. It filtered through the canopy of the forest, creating an ethereal green shimmer over the inviting soft leaves of the trees, and Izuku couldn't help but quip a smile at the way it danced over the golden strands of Kacchan's blond hair. It was a remarkable contrast to the harsh angle of his eyebrows and the irritated pout on his lips.

"I'm collecting firewood," Izuku replied, dusting himself down. "That's what you said to do, right?"

Kacchan blinked before his right hand reached up to squeeze at the bridge of his nose.

"How the fuck have you survived this long, idiot?"

Izuku made an indignant noise. "What do you mean?"

"You see the size of that thing? You think that's gonna burn?"

Izuku pouted, looking down at his prize.

"Maybe…"

Kacchan sighed. "How would you manage without me, huh?"

Izuku woke up with a gasp; the comforting green glow and warm autumn sun were replaced by the bitter bite of winter and a harsh blinking red bleeding around the gaps to his door. He took a shallow, shaky breath, fingers gripping into the rough fabric of his blanket, shutting his eyes against the insistent glare.

It had been this way for three months. Each night, *he* would visit. His dreams would play the same memories on loop; Kacchan chastised him for the simplest of things, looking as beautiful as Izuku remembered, as alive and vibrant and strong as he had always been. And then, he would wake, and those comforting memories would be snatched from him and replaced by images he was still too

afraid to forget. Three months to dream of smooth, *breathing* skin under a gentle green canopy. Three months to wake to black veins coiling around rotting and broken flesh, raw like the marks he had fitfully gouged into his own chest.

Izuku didn't need to look out of his window to know that it was still early; he couldn't remember the last time that he had slept a whole night, no matter how exhausted he got. Awake, he would be reminded of the things that had happened, and those that he had lost, and asleep those same things would haunt him. And, despite what everyone promised, time wasn't making it any easier. He gulped down the bitter taste on his tongue, reaching up to wipe the wetness on his cheeks he already knew would be there, and wished not for the first time that erasing the pain was just as easy. There was no sense in trying to get more sleep now. He swung his legs over the edge of his cot, reaching for the threadbare jumper he had discarded the night before, pulling on his jeans and checking for the items in his pocket, and got to his feet.

This had become his new routine. Wake early, creep down the corridor outside of his room, careful not to wake anyone else sleeping on his floor, and make his way to the stairwell. He had done it so often now that he didn't bother with the lights, knowing each straight and turn by heart, skipping the last two steps at the bottom knowing that they would creek if he didn't. The common room of his dormitory was always empty, the clock illuminated against the far wall telling him it was anywhere between three and four in the morning. And every morning he would pause, just long enough to toe off his slippers before replacing them with his boots and walking out to the courtyard towards the main campus.

It had taken surprisingly little convincing for him to secure a position at UA's lab. All of Izuku's hopes for the place had turned out to be true; UA had been researching the virus since the very beginning, studying the zombie specimens captured and contained within the campus itself, working hard to understand its origins and, ultimately, a way to put a stop to it. But Izuku knew that there was more to all of it than the little he'd been let in on; there *was* no way for thousands of zombies to be corralled into the baseball stadium without something leading them there. But, when Izuku had brought up the matter off the stadium, it had been met with stony silence and practised ignorance. Izuku was new here, and if he wanted even a chance of finding out what was going on behind the scenes, he'd have to play the game and talk the talk, buttering up his superiors and proving to them how invaluable his skills were. Because… Kacchan had died to bring that fucking place to the ground, and Izuku would die himself before he let that sacrifice go to waste.

"Young Midoriya?"

Izuku paused. He didn't even remember the walk here; so lost in his own thoughts and memories that he'd been entirely unaware of his surroundings. He was standing in the main corridor to the science department, and numbly he looked back over his shoulder, noting the trail of water he seemed to have left behind him.

"My boy, are you ok?"

Izuku blinked, looking up. The man meeting his gaze looked so genuinely concerned for him, that Izuku felt a rush of guilt at having worried him like this, and he forced a beaming smile to his face.

"Professor Toshinori!"

Toshinori's lower lip jutted out, hands gripping the doorframe of the room he was leaning out of.

He was a towering man; tall and thin, his blond hair unkempt and wild, blue eyes kind despite how deep-set they were into the dark circles around his eyes. Toshinori had been one of the very first people that he saw after waking up in a hospital bed, wrist cuffed to the cot, gently trying to calm him as he panicked and thrashed in his attempts to break free, and he had been the one to vouch for him after that. Izuku knew that he owed the man more than just his own life; his mother was alive, and safe, because of him, too.

“Sorry,” Izuku said, laughing and rubbing his neck nervously. “I guess I was in a world of my own on the way here, I didn’t even realise it was snowing.”

Toshinori hummed, not looking entirely convinced but deciding not to press the matter.

“Well, best dry yourself off as soon as you can. Your mother isn’t going to be impressed if you catch a cold.”

Izuku smiled again, strained when he saw the deliberate way his old Professor stared at him, not missing the obvious hint. It wasn’t that Izuku had ignored his mother; far from it. He saw her every day, even when he was busy. But she knew that he wasn’t being honest with her, was keeping things from her, and the more time passed the more he could see how worried she was. But opening up about everything, about *Kacchan* , wasn’t something that he could do right now. Perhaps, not something he could ever do.

He hadn’t told anyone at UA about Kacchan.

“You’re right,” Izuku replied. “Sorry, sir.”

“You don’t need to apologise,” Toshinori said softly. “Are you planning to start work?”

“Yeh,” Izuku said. “I like to get in early.”

“Well, could I perhaps trouble you for five minutes of your time, young man?” Toshinori asked, pointing back over his shoulder.

“Oh! Yeh, ok.”

Toshinori grinned broadly, before ducking his head back under the doorframe, the tips of his mane-like hair brushing against it and after a moment of hesitation, Izuku followed him. In truth, he had hoped to get into the lab early today; it didn’t open until half four, and he certainly wasn’t the only one for whom sleep had become a desire of the past. But, he had been trying and failing to find the lab all to himself the entire time he had been working there.

Toshiniro’s office was sparsely decorated; the only adjustments to what Izuku had remembered of it was the propane stove sitting on the coffee table, replacing the electric water heater that had once lived there. A motivational poster of the famous tv hero, All Might, hung partway obscured by a large cheese plant, and Izuku knew it was only still there because Toshinori hadn’t the heart to take it down.

“Take a seat.”

Toshinori gestured to one of the couches in the room, and feeling a little bad for the fact his hair

was probably still dripping, he sat down.

“Tea?”

Izuku nodded, and Toshinori started to pour him some green tea, the steam all too comforting as Izuku wrapped both his hands around the mug.

“Thank you.”

Toshinori nodded, smiling as he poured his own drink before he sunk back into his couch.

“So, you’ll be pleased to know that I spoke to Shigaraki about offering you higher clearance in the labs.”

Izuku’s eyes widened, his tea forgotten as he leaned forward eagerly.

“You did? What did he say? Am I on the team?”

Toshinori hummed again, fingers drumming against the side of his mug.

“He said that he would consider it,” he replied carefully. “I’ve known Shigaraki for a long time; if he was going to say no, he would have done so already *but* that doesn’t mean you should get your hopes up. You have only been here three short months, he might well want to see more from you before granting you access.”

Izuku nodded. “But… you did tell him that I already know about the smart zombies, right?” he pressed. “That I’ve seen them. That I might know things that could help us to understand them a little better?”

Toshinori raised a single eyebrow.

“Of course I did. Now, what do you take me for, young man? Shigaraki is aware of how useful your skills might be. You just need to give it a little time.”

Shigaraki . It had been three months, but he still felt a shiver crawl up his spine any time someone mentioned the name. He had never really put two and two together before now; Shigarki wasn’t a unique name, but he still had a bad feeling that the Shigaraki here, an esteemed pathologist and head of the entire department, might well be related to the Shigaraki out *there* . Izuku knew better than to bring it up. He, and his friends, had not made a single mention of Shigaraki, Dabi, or any of the group that had tried to kill them, just as they had all mutually decided that it was not wise for them to mention Kacchan either. Something was happening inside of UA; the black tape was impossible to overlook, and they all knew far too much already to feel safe quite yet.

“A little time,” Izuku repeated. “Right.”

“I know you’re disappointed,” Toshinori said softly. “But these are sensitive subjects, and it always takes some discussion to make a final decision. Right now, you’re doing invaluable work where you are, so be patient.”

Invaluable work. Izuku would laugh if he didn’t want to avoid insulting his mentor. Almost all of

the research that Izuku was limited to was identifying different strains of the virus in the samples provided to him. There was very little investigative work on his part, and he was feeling frustrated. Coming to UA had cost far too much for so little reward.

Not that he should consider any of this a reward.

“And speaking of which,” Toshinori said cheerfully, “I was taking a look at your results from last week, that’s two new mutations.”

Izuku nodded, sipping his tea, considering for a moment.

“I know- I know there are things I’m not allowed to know, but… it’s getting worse. The virus is mutating almost too quickly for us to study.”

Toshinori scratched the back of his neck. “Well, yes but it’s not that unusual. Considering just how much of the population was infected, there are plenty of opportunities for the virus to mutate, even at this rate. What *is* surprising is seeing such a high mutation rate across such a small pool of regular samples.”

“By regular, you mean not the smart ones?” Izuku pressed.

Toshinori hesitated, meeting his gaze before clearing his throat. Izuku didn’t feel good about this, about leaning on his mentor for information he knew he wasn’t allowed to offer him, but he couldn’t be content knowing the little that he did. UA had access to the smart zombies, he was sure of that, and all that remained was for him to find proof of it.

What he would do after that, though, he had no idea.

“Well, you should be off if you wanted to start early,” Toshinori said, busying himself quite suddenly with gathering his and Izuku’s mugs and taking them to the sink. “I’m not supposed to pre-warn you, really, but Aizawa is planning on a spot inspection at some point today, so be on your best behaviour.”

Izuku glanced up, watching Toshinori’s back carefully as he began to rinse the mugs before he nodded.

“Ok. Thanks for the tea, Professor.”

“Any time, my boy.”

Izuku got to his feet, excusing himself and shutting the door behind him. Toshinori was quite possibly the smartest man that he had ever known, he had admired him as All Might as a child, before growing up to respect him as a scientist later in life. He had been his hero and his mentor, and he had never known him to act without purpose. If Toshinori had warned him about the inspection later, then he had to know that Izuku was up to something…

He shrugged his shoulders and started to trudge his way towards the lab. It didn’t matter if Aizawa was coming, Izuku had a plan, and he intended to go through with it.

The department was quiet when he arrived; a couple of researchers had made it in before him, much to his frustration. And it wasn't that he didn't like the people he worked with. Shinsou, a young man his age and from his year at UA, had never left the university after everything went down, and Izuku had been pleased to see a familiar face on his first day. But, having someone who was actively interested and invested in the life he had led outside of the campus these last two years, came with its own issues, and privacy was hard to come by.

"Morning, Midoriya."

Izuku flashed Shinsou a smile, pausing at the door to grab the clipboard with his name on it, before pulling off his damp jumper and boots and replacing them with his lab coat and rubber pumps. It was the same thing each morning; his samples would be preassigned, and he would need to collect them from storage before testing each for the virus and sending them to the incinerator to be destroyed. He never got to see where the samples came from, or how the techs would get them, but each sample varied from a thick congealed mess to almost fresh. Somehow, the fresh ones always disturbed him the most.

"Sleep ok?" Shinsou asked before he scoffed at the look Izuku gave him. "You're right, stupid question."

"You can hardly talk," Izuku replied, taking in his companion's appearance. He always looked tired; the bags under his eyes were enough to rival Toshinori's on a good day, and his purple hair collected into a bun just as messy as Izuku's own. "Weren't you here later than me last night?"

Shinsou rubbed the back of his neck, smiling wryly. "If I had left earlier I would have been invited to that damn movie night." He paused, looking back at Izuku carefully. "Did you go?"

Izuku winced.

"I've seen it before."

"You know that's not the point."

"Why are you so concerned with what I do?" Izuku snapped, slamming his locker shut. But Shinsou wasn't phased, the man rarely was, and he watched him calmly.

"Your friends miss you."

Izuku swallowed, averting his gaze and looking down at the clipboard in his hand. He didn't need Shinsou to tell him that, he knew how much they worried about him, but none of them understood. They were here now, and Kacchan's last request was for him to protect them, keep them safe, and Izuku could only do that once he found out what was really going on at UA. He bit his lip, choosing not to respond to Shinsou before opening the door to the lab, focusing instead on the work ahead of him for the day.

Usually, he would assess something between fifteen and twenty a day, more if the powers that be were feeling particularly generous, and Izuku had paid attention to every single part of the process that he was allowed access to. The samples had already arrived by the time he was allowed into the lab, and no matter how early he got here, he had not yet seen the people that provided them. The

area of the department beyond the lab was strictly off limits; accessible by a door that remained locked at all times, and so far as Izuku could see, only those higher up had access to a key. Izuku had to presume the samples came from deeper within the department, which meant the zombies they came from would also be there. It made sense; the one area of the university that no one was allowed access to seemed just about the only place they could hide a collection of the undead. And, if Izuku's assumptions were correct, it was inside here that he would find the *smart* zombies, the creatures that Toshinori refused to speak of, and that other members of the faculty failed to acknowledge even existed.

Regardless of what was hidden beyond that locked door, once the samples were in the lab, they were remarkably freely accessed. Izuku rarely had anyone looking over his shoulder as he tested them, looking for similarities and oddities in the chemical makeup, and he was trusted implicitly to dispose of the samples once he was done with them. It was curious that a project so secretive as this was so carefree with its samples, which led Izuku to another conclusion… They didn't care much for them. Whatever Izuku was doing, it wasn't of any real value to the *real* studies going on, a by-product of the actual research that he still wasn't a part of. Izuku had confirmed, over the last eight weeks, that no one was going to take the samples from him at any stage, and that the results of his tests weren't corroborated by anyone else in the faculty. Toshinori would check the final results, and no doubt relay that back to Shigaraki or whomever he spoke for, and that was that. It gave Izuku the perfect opportunity to conduct some research of his own.

He collected his samples from the refrigerated unit, chancing a glance over his shoulder to see Shinsou pouring over his clipboard before he slipped open the drawer to the cabinet, blindly snatching a fresh sample tube. This was the easy part, and he had dropped it into his pocket and leaned his hip discretely against the drawer by the time Shinsou looked up at him. His mouth opened, like he wanted to say something, apologise perhaps for what he had said earlier, before clicking his tongue and shaking his head. Izuku carefully carried his samples toward his workstation and breathed a small sigh of relief.

The hardest part had been securing the equipment that he needed. Despite being a lab, things such as syringes and needles were absent here, and Izuku supposed that made sense; they were handling infected blood all day long, and the last thing anyone wanted was to find themselves contaminated with it. He pulled out a pair of latex gloves from the cardboard box on the tabletop, snapping them loudly in a show of irritation, hoping that it would give Shinsou enough of an incentive to keep his distance for a while, before reaching down to the back pocket of his jeans.

A trip to the infirmary had been required for this one. Izuku couldn't risk injuring himself in a way that might have prompted the doctors to take a blood sample, so instead, he had taken the painful option of slamming the little finger of his left hand in his wardrobe, using the opportunity to snatch a syringe and needle from the surgery when the doctor left to fill a prescription for mild pain relief. His finger was still bruised, but it was a worthy sacrifice considering the circumstances, and he carefully switched the needle and syringe from his jeans to his lab coat, watching the back of Shinsou's head the entire time.

Just like Izuku, Shinsou was a creature of habit, having fallen into his own routine in the years he had been here. Every day, he would prep his samples in the centrifuge, flick the switch, before pulling his chipped and bent-up headphones from his pocket, and slip them over his head. Izuku had always been the sort to work better in silence, but he thanked the spirits that Shinsou was not that type, the tinny opening beats to *'We Didn't Start the Fire'* just audible from across the lab. Izuku felt an uncomfortable tug in his stomach when he considered just how funny Kacchan might

have found that, before grabbing the syringe once more.

It was simple. All he needed to do was draw enough blood from his arm to fill the sample tube, and switch it for one of the samples he had been given. He knew he couldn't risk All Might getting hold of the results, so he would need to record fake ones at the end of the day. That in itself wasn't hard to do; there was a fair deal of variation on strains, but there were several that came up most frequently, and no one would think it out of place for just one more sample to pop up with the same five digits beside it. Then, he would just have to incinerate his own sample, along with the sixteen others he had been given, and no one would be any the wiser. He took a deep breath, glancing up at Shinsou one last time, before pressing his thumb down hard against the inside of his left wrist, patiently waiting for the vein he had already picked out to pop up.

He had been sure to hydrate himself plenty the previous night, and to his relief, the blood flowed easily once he had set the needle in place, filling the syringe without fanfare. He kept looking between his arm, to Shinsou, to the door, until he had enough blood, pressing down on the vein as he removed the needle. He grimaced as a few drops of blood dripped down onto the floor, surreptitiously rubbing his rubber boot over it until the mark subsided, before grabbing the sample tube and unpopping the cork. Billy Joel had switched to *'Time After Time'* , Shinsou casually bopping his head to the music as he watched the centrifuge, and Izuku began to squirt his blood into the tube. After that, it was a case of selecting one of the samples at random, peeling off the label, and placing it on his own, releasing a puff of air when he slipped the original sample into his pocket.

It was then that Shinsou chose to look up, their eyes meeting, before he inclined his head curiously, pulling one of the earpieces away from his head.

"Uh, ain't you gonna start?"

"Yeh," Izuku replied, somewhat breathlessly. "Yeh, sorry, just… I didn't get much sleep."

Shinsou hummed, before turning back to his work.

Izuku was quick to start, placing each tube into his centrifuge as he prepped everything else that he needed, feeling more anxious now than he had done in the lead-up to all this. Because, one way or another, now he would know.

The day Kacchan died haunted him, in way more ways than one. It had… become harder for Izuku to recall the faces of those that he had lost. Uraraka, he knew, had been bright and beautiful, that her cheeks had always been flushed and a smile never far from her lips, but no matter how much he tried, he could no longer recall what she actually looked like. The same was true for Tenya, Tsu… Sero. Their faces were a vague collection of features that never quite matched the real thing, but Kacchan? It seemed like, with every passing day, his memories of him only grew stronger, more painful, more *real* . Everything about that last moment, the last look he had of the man he loved, was seared into his brain, burning and eating away at him like acid. His eye swollen shut, the cuts and abrasions, the unnatural angle of his nose and the pallid skin beneath all of that were painful enough, but the way he looked at Izuku? The regret, still simmering beneath his bravado as he asked Izuku to live for him, the tears dripping down to his bleeding mouth as his lips trembled. The memories of that last moment never faded, and each time Izuku shut his eyes or allowed his mind to wander, it was that moment it went back to. Hurting him, taunting him, making his soul ache to have done something, *anything* , different.

But, it wasn't just Kacchan that pained him about that day. It had taken some weeks, his concussion had been a bad one, but eventually, he started to remember everything that had taken place; the way he had lost control and driven his fists into Dabi's face over and over until the bone gave way to the soft, tacky meat below, splitting his knuckles open in the process. He hadn't hesitated, not a second, before turning to Kacchan, indifferent to his blood mingling with Izuku's own… Izuku had some lucky escapes, but that should not have been one of them. There was no way that he should have walked away from that day without becoming infected with Kacchan's blood. And, the more Izuku allowed himself to think over it, the more he started to consider that maybe he hadn't been lucky at all. He had never *been* lucky. Perhaps, like Kacchan, he had been infected this whole time.

It was a thought that plagued him, kept him awake, and had him putting up the barriers between himself and his friends. His mother, bless her soul, wanted only to comfort him, hold him, pull him close, but he couldn't allow it. He would come up with stories; tell her that he found contact difficult and that he would be ok soon. But it was harder to keep the truth from his friends… They knew how Izuku might be affected by Kacchan's death, and once the shock passed after he told them that he was gone, they too had only wanted to comfort him. But, until he knew, he couldn't risk it. He had come in contact with infected blood, and whilst he might not be feeling any symptoms now, he knew from experience that meant very little.

The day was a quiet one, Izuku carrying out his research and trying not to fixate too obviously on the results. If Shinsou noticed his skittishness, he chose not to mention it, and Izuku had forgotten Toshinori's warning of an inspection by the time the door to the lab swung open, a dark-haired man with a tired-looking expression entered the room. Izuku started, looking down at his samples to be sure that nothing was incriminating on his workspace.

"Mr Aizawa," Shinsou said, also surprised, and removing his headphones. Aizawa nodded, hands thrust deep into the pockets of his oversized black cardigan, eyes assessing the lab before landing on Izuku.

"I'm here to do a random inspection," Aizawa said, looking decidedly bored by the whole ordeal. "If you wouldn't mind standing against the back wall for me, so I can look at your workstations."

Shinsou nodded, stepping away from his microscope and standing against the far wall. Izuku swallowed, following suit. In truth, this was the first inspection that he had experienced at the lab, but right now he had no clear results visible at his desk; nothing that might indicate that one of his samples had been switched. Nothing, that was, except that tube sitting heavily in his lab coat pocket.

Aizawa silently inspected each workstation, opening drawers, looking through files, disinterest plain on his face as he worked. Izuku tensed as Aizawa approached his, leaning forward so that he could look at the labels on the side of each sample without disturbing them, before letting out a soft hum and pointing towards one of them. Izuku's heart plummeted when he realised that it was at the tube containing *his* blood.

"What happened here?" Aizawa asked, looking over his shoulder at him. "The label is peeling."

Izuku swallowed. "Uh, there was some moisture on my glove," he replied quickly. "Must have removed some of the adhesive, but I was able to dry it quickly enough."

Aizawa eyed him, irises as dark as his pupils boring into him before he stood straight.

“And you’re sure whatever it was didn’t contaminate the samples?”

“Certain of it,” Izuku said. “I haven’t opened any of them yet.”

“Right.”

Aizawa moved away from Izuku’s workstation, much to Izuku’s relief, taking a moment to look at the incinerator, before turning to Shinsou.

“Arms up, please, I need to check your pockets.”

Shinsou raised his arms t-pose without question, and yet more panic flooded Izuku’s system. He quickly reached into his pocket, hooking his fingers around the sample and pushing it up his sleeve and laying his hand at his side again. He watched as Aizawa reached into Shinsou’s pockets, and patted him down, grunting in satisfaction, before turning to Izuku. He quickly held his arms out, trying to act as cool as possible as Aizawa approached, praying that he wouldn’t think to feel his wrists. Several uncomfortable moments later, Aizawa slipped his hands into his jean pockets as well as his lab coat, he was told to drop his arms, and Aizawa took a step back.

“You can return to work now.”

Holy fuck holy fuck holy fuck, Izuku thought, knowing that a bead of sweat collecting at his temple was in danger of dropping at any moment. Aizawa wandered back towards the door, before pausing.

“Oh, Midoriya,” he said, and Izuku bit back a squeak. “You’ll have a meeting. Tomorrow. Toshinori will give you the details. Six AM sharp. Don’t be late.”

“Y-yes, sir,” Izuku breathed, and the door shut loudly.

“A meeting?” Shinsou asked, curious. “Wait… you didn’t really request a transfer, did you?”

Izuku looked back at him, the weight of the blood vial in his sleeve seeming altogether much heavier than was reasonable.

“Well, I wouldn’t know if I didn’t ask,” he replied. Shinsou looked put out, for whatever reason, before he grabbed his headphones again and turned his back.

By the end of the day, Izuku was ready to collect his results, checking his list of samples and going through the motions, trying not to appear too keen as he reached his own, eyes darting down the list of numbers printed out from the computer before he froze. In all sixteen of the samples, the biomarkers indicating the presence of the virus were present. In all, except one. He stared, muttering to himself as his eyes jumped along the line showing the levels of procalcitonin, registering at an entirely normal range in his sample. It… didn’t make sense. Sure, he wasn’t feeling the effects of the infection, the sepsis that was present in every single sample he had looked at since getting here, but for the levels to be normal when he had come into contact with infected blood?

He tore the paper from the printer, before hurrying back to his workstation, opening his sample and squeezing a single drop onto a slide, before placing it under the microscope, leaning close.

There was nothing there. No indication of the bacteria usually present, and no signs of the virus whatsoever in his blood. How? How could something like that be possible? There was no way… *no way* Kacchan's blood hadn't mixed with his that day.

"Hey, you ok?"

Izuku jumped, rearing back from his microscope and breathing heavily. Shinsou stood at his side, brow furrowed and concerned, eyes dropping down to the slide.

"No," Izuku replied immediately. "No, uh, I think maybe I shouldn't have come in today! I feel… uh, a bit faint? M-maybe I didn't eat enough yesterday!"

"You've been acting weird all day," Shinsou said.

"I'm sorry," Izuku said quickly. "But, uh, I'm done with my samples for the day." He reached out, grabbing the slide. "I'll clean up and write my results, then I'll probably call it quits until tomorrow."

Shinsou watched him as Izuku began to place his samples in a plastic tub, shoving the printout of the results into his pocket and grabbing for his clipboard.

"Alright, well… if anything comes up."

Izuku nodded, hoping the smile he offered Shinsou was a warm one, as the man turned and went back to his desk. Izuku's hands shook, almost dropping the pen as he reached for it. He could have messed up. Perhaps the blood hadn't separated properly. Perhaps the biomarkers were wrong, but Izuku knew that wasn't the case. Often, the best answer was the most simple, and the most simple answer was that, somehow, Izuku was not infected by the zombie virus.

The knowledge sat heavily on him as he disposed of his samples, hurriedly made up some results, and began to trudge his way back to the dorm through the snow. When he allowed himself to think about it, *really* think about it, he had more near misses when it came to the virus than just about anyone else he knew. The supermarket, back in Shinagawa, where he and Kacchan had fought their way through all those zombies in the dark, leaving Izuku caked in foul-smelling guts. Their first and only kiss, brief as it might have been, was still a kiss, and though they had been so careful, how many times had he been splashed with blood? His stomach churned when he remembered gagging himself on Kacchan's shirt to stop himself from biting his tongue. The zombie that had tried to gouge his eye out, and the way his fingernails had torn tracks into its wrists as he tried to stop it. And when he and Kacchan had made love… they might have used protection, but the kisses upon his skin, seemingly so inconsequential at the time, could well have been enough to seal his fate. Finally, there was the stadium, and there was simply no way for him to write that off as luck. So what? What did it mean? Was he… *could he be* …

"Izuku."

He stopped, looking up from where he had been numbly tugging at the laces of his boots, to see that the common room of the dorm was not empty this time. Shouto stood by the kitchen, useless

really when they had no running water or facilities to cook anything, with a half-filled bottle of iced tea in his muddy hands. Of all his friends, Shouto was the one he perhaps saw the least; he worked in the gardens, tending to the freshly grown crops that enabled UA to have flourished so long as it had, and so independently of the rest of the city, so he was often up even earlier than Izuku was. But, Izuku knew that wasn't the only reason… Shouto, for all the love and care that he had shown him, despite *everything* that happened, was the one that made Izuku *feel* the most. It was impossible for him to look at Shouto without being reminded, again and again and again, of what he had lost.

"Oh, hi Shouto."

Mismatched eyes watched him, intense in their appraisal, assessing him from head to toe as he pushed his boots to the side and grabbed his slippers, doing his absolute best to avoid looking back at them. Shouto always had a way of reading him like no one else could, and keeping his feelings hidden from the man was just about as exhausting as the emotions themselves.

"How are you?" Shouto finally asked, his tone soft and hesitant. It had probably been two weeks since he had last had a conversation with Shouto, and the guilt writhed under his skin.

"Oh, you know," Izuku replied, with a noncommittal shrug. "Busy. Uh, how have you been?"

Shouto didn't reply immediately, watching him in concerned silence as Izuku stood awkwardly by the door. Izuku had… he *had* missed him. He had missed his friend. He hadn't had a chance to enjoy his companionship even before Kacchan had died and everything in Izuku's world felt as though it came to an end. They never had a moment to reconcile for the way Izuku had deceived him, and Izuku had shut Shouto down the very moment he looked as though he might try to apologise for what happened to Kacchan. Shouto wasn't responsible… It wasn't his *fault* that Kacchan had been bitten a second time. But Kacchan had taken the bite for him, and that ultimately had been the moment Izuku lost him.

"Also busy," Shouto finally said, voice quiet. "The snow makes it hard."

"I bet," Izuku replied, with a nervous laugh that sounded ugly even to his ears. An uncomfortable silence fell between them, a distance drawing out that made Izuku's heart ache even if he knew he was in no position to bridge it.

"I'm pretty beat," Izuku eventually said. "I'm gonna turn in early. It was nice seeing you, Shouto."

He began to hurry past, eyes fixed on the ground before Shouto reached out to him.

"Izuku! Wait. Please."

The *'please'* had him like a noose, tugging at his throat and cutting off his airways, bringing him to an abrupt halt.

"Izuku, it's been three months."

Izuku shut his eyes tight.

"I know how long it's been."

“So don’t… don’t you think it’s time to talk to someone? To your friends? We’re- *I’m* worried about you.”

“There’s nothing to talk about,” Izuku replied, turning to face Shouto, forcing a smile to his face. “I’m fine, Shouto. It’s just work, that’s all.”

“I know that’s not true,” Shouto whispered. “I know… I know you’re in pain. I just wish you would talk to me.”

The smile dropped from Izuku’s face as though it had never been there, heart thudding like a rock against his ribcage.

“He… he talked about you before it all happened, you know,” Shouto continued softly. “Before everything that happened with Kaminari.”

Izuku remembered. He remembered the heated conversation he and Kirishima had almost walked in on that day, remembered Shouto saying something along the lines of, *“shouldn’t that be up to him?”* It had never occurred to him to ask Kacchan what that had been about.

“I just figured he planned on leaving. I didn’t understand why, not back then anyway. I thought maybe he was only helping all of you to get to UA before going to look for his family or something. And… I wanted to tell you, but it felt…” Shouto sighed and shook his head. “It doesn’t matter. The point is, he asked me to look out for you and to make sure that you stayed at UA, no matter what else happened.”

Izuku’s breath hitched, and to his horror, he felt the familiar itching behind his eyes.

“I was always worried about you,” Shouto continued, looking down at his feet. “I could see how much he meant to you, and part of me was afraid that he was using you, and I couldn’t bear to see how heartbroken you would be when he left. I know now that I was wrong. I’m not saying that I was in any way fond of him, just so you know,” he added quickly, rubbing the back of his head. “But I was wrong to think that he didn’t love you like you loved him.”

Izuku swallowed, and all he wanted to do was flee. But his treacherous legs wouldn’t let him.

“And I know… I know what it’s like to lose someone you love. I’m not saying our pain is the same, I could never say that, but I’ve been there. I’ve been alone, after losing everyone, I went on believing the person I loved was dead for a long time. And if you need someone to talk to, I’m here. As your friend.”

Izuku’s lower lip wobbled, the tears already streaming, one of his scarred and lumpy fists grabbing hold of the fabric at his throat. Shouto looked up, his eyes widening in alarm when he took in Izuku’s appearance, and perhaps on instinct more than anything else, he started forward, his hands outstretched, ready to comfort and hold and be the shoulder Izuku so desperately needed. But Izuku found himself rearing away, backing up so quickly his legs hit one of the bar stools and knocked it back, landing with a loud clatter. Shouto froze, and Izuku couldn’t stand to see the hurt in his eyes, the rejection, the *concern* growing with each breath.

“I-” Izuku choked on his words, shaking his head and forcibly wiping the tears from his face. “It isn’t that simple,” he whispered hoarsely.

“Why?” Shouto demanded, frantically. “Why can’t you just let us be there for you? And if not me, if you still blame me for what happened, at least lean on one of the others.”

“No!” Izuku gasped. “Shouto, that isn’t it. I don’t blame you for what happened, I never have! It’s just… it’s just-”

Fresh tears leaked down his cheeks, no matter how hard he tried to brush them away or hold them back.

“It’s complicated.”

A shadow seemed to cast over Shouto’s face, his shoulders slumping in defeat.

“I’m sorry,” Izuku whispered.

Shouto nodded, sniffing loudly before grabbing his drink again.

“Kirishima and Mina wanted to tell you something yesterday, at movie night,” he said, voice thick. “I know they wanted to say it in person, but they said I could tell you if I saw you first.”

Izuku wiped at his face, filled with yet more anxiety. Was one of them sick?

“Mina is pregnant,” Shouto said, with the smallest smile. “Eight weeks. I get the impression it wasn’t planned but they seem excited. Happy. It would probably mean a lot to them if you saw them.”

What should have been good news, *great news* , instead felt like a bucket of ice water being chucked over him. He stood stock still as Shouto gave him another last, mournful glance, before heading towards the living area of the common room, leaving Izuku standing beside the upturned barstool.

“-I know they’re safe with you-

-I need you to go on protecting them-

-Please.”

Izuku woke with a hoarse cry, sitting up in his bed before immediately bending double, his hands wrapped tightly around his stomach. He rocked in place, sobbing brokenly, the ache unbearable as he pined and pleaded and begged for it to cease.

“I’m trying,” he gasped, shaking his head. “Kacchan, I’m trying.”

How long could he keep doing this? How long could he keep living like this?

It was a miracle that he had even fallen asleep last night, so consumed with anxiety, the very real grips of his fear tightening around his throat harshly enough to leave bruises. He should have felt happy, overjoyed even, at the news that Mina and Kirishima were going to be bringing a child into the world. He ought to be so fiercely proud of them for taking the bold, brave step towards a future they had never thought would come. But instead of happiness and anticipation, he felt only dread. What if something happened to Mina? What if the walls to UA crumbled? What if it was on him to lead them again and he… and he…

What if he failed? What if he failed to do the one thing Kacchan had asked of him before he died? What if he couldn't be the man that Kacchan believed him to be? Because he *wasn't* Kacchan. He wasn't even close. He was a pale comparison, a shitty compromise, so weak that he couldn't even shoulder his heartache long enough to spend a minute of his time in the company of the people that Kacchan had loved so fiercely.

He pressed his hands against his face. He had to stop this. He *had* to move on.

"There is no living for me, if living means leaving you behind."

Those had been his words, right? His promise to Kacchan? How fucking *romantic* , insane words from an insane mind, willingly ignorant of the fact that the world didn't give a shit about his promises. No living? Well, he had been right about one thing. This was no life. Mourning and pining for a man long dead, avoiding the people that cared about him, only ever hurting them when he ought to be keeping them safe.

What a fucking joke. Kacchan would have been ashamed of the man he had become.

He rolled forward in his bed, hooking his legs over the edge, glancing at his clock. It was nearing four in the morning again. He hadn't seen Toshinori yesterday, too eager to get out of the lab and back in his room, and he needed to get the details of his meeting in a couple of hours. He brushed away the tears, grimacing at the scarred backs of his hands, before pushing himself to his feet. No more of this. No more. If he wanted to keep them safe, if he wanted for there to be a place Mina and Kirishima could raise their child, then he needed to focus. First things first, he needed to gain higher clearance so that he could find out exactly what UA was hiding. Secondly, he needed to figure out what the *fuck* was going on with his blood.

He knocked on Toshinori's door the moment he arrived at the department, knowing full well that he would be awake. Toshinori, it seems, slept even less than he did, and sure enough, the door swung open, curious blue eyes warming when they landed on him.

"Young Midoriya! I was hoping that you would come by. I didn't get a chance to speak with you yesterday."

"Yeh, I'm sorry about that," Izuku said. "I wasn't feeling very well."

Toshinori paused, watching him for a moment before he stepped back and gestured inside of his office.

"Feeling better today, I hope?" he asked, already reaching for a mug so that he could pour Izuku some tea.

“Fine, thanks,” Izuku replied, taking his seat. “I hope I didn’t worry you.”

Toshinori smiled, holding the tea to him, Izuku grateful for the heat as he all but clutched the mug to his chest, breathing in the comforting herbal scents.

“Aizawa said that I have a meeting today?”

“That’s right. It will be informal, just between us and Aizawa.”

Izuku’s eyebrows rose. “Wait… Professor Shigaraki won’t be there?”

“Ah, no,” Toshinori replied. “But I wouldn’t take it personally. You will get a chance to meet him eventually.”

“So,” Izuku felt his stomach plummet. “I’m not in. He refused?”

It was Toshinori’s turn to look surprised.

“Oh! I’m sorry, I didn’t realise how that would sound. Your referral request has been accepted. You’ll be working one on one with me from now on.”

Izuku placed his mug down so as not to drop it, sitting up in his seat. “Really?”

“Really! Although, I was only supposed to tell you this in the meeting. Promise you’ll at least try to look surprised when Aizawa joins us,” Toshinori said, rubbing the back of his neck and laughing nervously.

“Of course! Of course I- I’m just… wow! This is great!”

Toshinori smiled warmly at him. “You earned it, kid.”

“So… so, this is it? I’m actually going to be studying the virus with you now? Do- do we have leads on a cure? A vaccine maybe? Will I be able to study the zombies up close? I had theories-”

“I’m sorry to interrupt,” Toshinori said, holding both his palms forward. “But you’re getting a little ahead of yourself. There will be a lot to explain and…” he hesitated, looking nervous for a moment. “It will be quite something to take in, I’m afraid. I do think we should discuss it all in detail later.”

Izuku nodded, trying not to look too disappointed.

“But before then… There is something I wanted to ask you, Young Midoriya. Just between us.”

Izuku’s eyes darted up, his initial curiosity mingling with apprehension when he saw the serious look on Toshinori’s face.

“I looked at your results from yesterday,” Toshinori said. “And I was a little… surprised, about two of the samples.”

Izuku's blood ran cold, his fingers twitching involuntarily, even as he fought to retain his cool.

"O-oh?"

"Hmm," Toshinori hummed. "We expect to see the same strain of the virus appear among the samples, but it's very unusual for the white blood cell count to be exactly the same."

Shit.

"You're not in any trouble," Toshinori assured, noting how stiff Izuku had become. "And I haven't flagged it up. But, between us, is there something that you want to tell me?"

Izuku hesitated. It hadn't occurred to him that he might be able to include his professor in this. The man had the most brilliant mind of any pathologist he had known, and if anyone could help him figure out the puzzle of his blood, then it was Toshinori Yagi. But to invite him in, would mean he would have to tell him everything; about Kacchan, about their relationship, about the bites and the people that had hunted them down and killed most of the people he loved. And though he trusted Toshinori to have his best interests at heart, he still worked for UA, and how much could Izuku divulge to him before he was forced to share the information with Shigaraki and the others?

"No," Izuku replied. "I mean… yes. I, uh, I misplaced the results before making note of them. I thought I had remembered all of them but I guess I was wrong. I'm sorry, Professor, it won't happen again."

Izuku bowed his head, tensing in the silence that followed, knowing that Toshinori didn't believe a word of what he had said. He braced himself, waiting for the accusations, but instead, Toshinori let out a small chuckle.

"No harm done, young man," he said brightly. Izuku looked up, startled. "But mistakes like that can't happen from now on, you understand?"

Toshinori smiled at him, but he continued to stare a little too hard, refusing to break Izuku's eye as he looked back at him.

"Yes sir."

"Right, well how about a game or two of Koi-Koi before Aizawa gets here, hm?"

Toshinori knew that Izuku wasn't being honest with him, but what Izuku couldn't figure out was *why* he hadn't pursued the matter and called Izuku out on the lie. The thought plagued him as he lost two games in a row to his mentor, the man looking delighted at his wins even as he assured Izuku that he would beat him next time. This pattern continued for another hour before there was a knock on the door.

"Ah, that will be him," Toshinori said, getting to his feet and heading to his door, opening it with a smile. "Aizawa, pleased you finally made it."

"I'm early," Aizawa replied, with a light scowl. Izuku jumped up, standing and bowing his head all too frantically as Aizawa's dark eyes landed on him.

“Good morning, Mr Aizawa,” he said.

“Sit down,” Aizawa sighed. “And drop the Mr, I’m not your homeroom teacher anymore.”

“Uh, yes, sorry sir!”

“Never mind.”

Aizawa rolled his eyes, thrusting his hands back into his pockets, and remained standing partway between them and the door even after Toshinori offered him a seat. Izuku sat back down, but only because Aizawa had asked him to, shifting under his intense stare. It wasn’t that he was *afraid* of Aizawa… well, maybe he was a little afraid of him. But he was certain he could see straight through him; aware of the bullshit yet willing to overlook all of it. And not because he was being considerate; no, Aizawa was the kind of man to bide his time. Observe, collect information, and patiently wait for the most devastating time to act on it. Izuku, despite his once blind faith in the man, still had no idea where his loyalties lay.

“I trust Toshinori has already told you everything?”

“Uh, o-only that my clearance was granted,” Izuku replied. “Nothing much more than that.”

Aizawa scowled, looking back at Toshinori.

“I thought you’d want to brief him together!” Toshinori said, holding his palms out.

“I would have rather saved the time,” Aizawa grumbled in response, before sighing again. “Alright, let’s get this over with. Midoriya, you’re happy to walk and talk at the same time?”

“Huh- oh, yes! Yes, I can do that!”

“What a relief. Come on then, with me.”

Izuku hurried to his feet again as Aizawa turned his back and marched towards the door. He glanced at Toshinori, who shrugged in a resigned sort of way before the two of them followed Aizawa out into the corridor.

Shinsou was already in the lab as they arrived; heavy curious eyes glancing up at the sound of the door opening and widening in surprise when he saw the three of them, a slight pout on his lips when he and Izuku made eye contact.

“Good morning, young Shinsou,” Toshinori said warmly, and Shinsou offered a stiff bow in response, still watching Izuku.

“Morning, Shinsou,” Izuku said. But Shinsou didn’t reply, instead grabbing his clipboard and hastily turning his back. Izuku supposed he would have time to think over his strange reaction later, as he was swept through the lab towards the locked door at the rear and his eagerness to see what was behind it mounted. He had been curious about this for months; often wondering what would happen if he tried to break in, or was able to steal Toshinori’s key. But now, he was about to find out, and his excitement wasn’t without apprehension.

“This is your key,” Aizawa said, holding up a keycard between two fingers, and looking back at him. “ *Do not* lose it. Do not let anyone use the key besides yourself. Do not bend it, break it, or otherwise mistreat it in any way. If you do, the payment for replacing I guarantee is far steeper than what you’re worth to the lab. Do I make myself clear?”

“Yes, sir,” Izuku replied with a gulp. Aizawa eyed him for a moment longer, before handing the keycard to him, Izuku begging his fingers not to fumble as he reached out and took it.

“You’ll need to activate it,” Aizawa said shortly, taking a step back and gesturing to the door.

“O-ok.”

Izuku walked forwards, holding the keycard out with trembling hands, and sliding it into the slot above the keypad. The panel made a *click* sound, and Aizawa stepped forward, shielding the keypad from view with one hand as he typed a code with the other. Three more *clicks* followed, and the door unlocked.

“Do *not* forget your keycard in the door,” Aizawa said immediately, and Izuku quickly snatched the card back, and slipped it into his back pocket. “Right, follow me.”

Izuku stepped back so that Aizawa could make his way through the door and into the brightly lit corridor on the other side, hearing a sharp *click* as Toshinori shut their exit behind them. Izuku already had some thoughts on the area behind the lab, based on his limited knowledge and what he remembered when he was a student here. This part had always been off limits; used mainly by the faculty and guest researchers for studies that required discretion. UA had been much more than just a university, back in its hay day, and a great many notable studies had happened here, particularly in the field of pathology and disease management. Izuku had always longed to find his way here… To see what went on behind closed doors, and witness his seniors and idols doing what they were famed for. He never thought this would be how he’d make it. And yet, a small part of him couldn’t fight the thrill that ran down his spine as he followed Aizawa deeper into the block, feeling genuine excitement for the first time in three months.

Aizawa led them to another lab, the external comprised of thick glass panels so that Izuku could see inside. He saw several researchers, all of them dressed in hazmat suits with bright orange gloves and boots, green masks covering the lower part of their faces.

“This is where the samples that you have been working from are collected and processed,” Aizawa said, drawing the three of them to a halt.

Izuku peered through the glass, brow furrowed as he tried to make out what was going on.

“I don’t see any zombies,” he muttered, before his eyes landed on five gurneys against the farthest wall, the bunks angled high and tipped over five wide metal trays that were, from what Izuku could tell, full of fluid ranging from very red to a foul looking brown. He couldn’t make out the forms in the bunk; the angle almost entirely obscured them from view, but it didn’t take a genius to figure it out.

“Taking blood samples in the conventional way is a waste of time,” Aizawa explained. “And often impossible. It’s far easier to just drain the bodies and process the blood from there.”

Izuku understood the need now for such extensive personal protective equipment; the risk of accidental contamination in a place like this was ridiculously high, no matter how careful you were.

“No one is allowed access to the lab without the correct PPE,” Aizawa confirmed. “But you’re unlikely to ever need to step foot in there.”

“This isn’t where I’m going to be working?” Izuku asked. Aizawa shot him a strange look before he turned on his heel and started to walk down the corridor once more. Izuku hurried after him, trying not to get too sidetracked by the many doors leading off of the hallway. Eventually, they stopped again, this time outside of an elevator that Izuku could only assume would lead them to the basement levels of the department. Aizawa pressed his finger against the panel, and in a matter of seconds, the wide double doors of the elevator swung open, revealing its stainless steel interior. Izuku found himself glad that the elevator was a large one, as Toshinori practically folded himself into the compartment.

“You’ll have only one role in the department from this point on,” Aizawa explained, as the door shut behind them. “And that will be the management of one of our key test subjects.”

Izuku’s brow rose, looking over at Toshinori for confirmation. “Uh… management?”

“Each of our subjects have a designated handler,” Aizawa continued. “This person is responsible for tracking their treatment and medication needs, maintaining hygiene, body condition, extracting and testing samples, as well as overwatching experimentation.”

“These subjects,” Izuku said, voice hushed, “they’re not like the rest of the zombies, are they? You *do* have them here. The smart ones.”

Aizawa didn’t respond, casting him a look from the corner of his eye before the elevator doors opened once more.

A huge area of space opened up in front of Izuku; it almost looked like his dormitory in its layout, with a seating area at the very centre and a rudimentary kitchen towards the front. The farthest wall was lined with yet more glass-walled rooms, and Izuku’s eyes were immediately drawn towards the one at the far left, where there were three treadmills set up, and a muscular and beautiful-looking woman, with her long white hair, pulled back into a high ponytail and sweat glistening on her dark skin, ran. A woman stood in front of her, the two seemingly in easy conversation and not yet noticing the three of them entering the dorm.

“This is where you are going to be spending most of your time from here on,” Aizawa said. “You’ll report directly to Toshinori, who oversees these studies, and he reports to Shigaraki. You must adhere to this chain of command.”

Izuku nodded, still looking with wide eyes at everything around him. Nine more doors were coming off of the main area, one of them with *‘Shitter’* haphazardly scribbled across the front of it in black ink, the others with keypads and porthole windows that looked to be made from thick glass even from this distance.

“Your keycard will give you access to each of the rooms here,” Aizawa said. “And will need to be used to exit the floor. It must stay on your person at all times, and special care needs to be taken to ensure that none of the test subjects gains access to it. Do you understand?”

Izuku nodded, eyes drifting back to the woman running on the treadmill. She looked normal, if not in ludicrously good shape for someone living through the Apocalypse, and she reminded him strongly of Kacchan in that way. Finally, she seemed to take notice, looking up, and Izuku felt a lump in his throat as red eyes flashed back, simmering with a fire he believed he might never see again. There was a moment, the kind Izuku would wonder if he had imagined after, where *something* passed between them; a sort of understanding, that passed before his next heartbeat, and the woman looked away, laughing with her companion once more.

"Who…" Izuku started, sounding breathless even to his own ears. "Is she-?"

"Yes," Aizawa replied shortly. "You will be introduced to each of them. We have four Nomu here in total."

"Wait- *Nomu* ?" Izuku turned on the spot, looking back at Aizawa and Toshinori. *Nomu* ; that had been the name of monsters from the old All Might comics. Creatures, *homunculi* , devoid of emotions and humanity, and created by the villain. Izuku couldn't help it; his hands curled into fists, his brain feeling foggy and heavy as a rush of adrenaline and anger flushed through him. *Nomu* . Kacchan had been more than that. He had never been *that* . Aizawa and Toshinori both seemed taken aback by his reaction.

"Of course, it's just a name," Toshinori said quickly. "It doesn't necessarily speak for how we view the subjects, don't misunderstand us."

"It's cruel," Izuku breathed. "They're still… they're still human beings."

"The evidence suggests otherwise," Aizawa replied firmly. "But you'll see what we mean soon enough."

Aizawa pulled out his keycard once more and began to walk toward one of the doors on the far right of the dorm.

"Before you meet your test subject, Toshinori is going to explain a few things to you."

"Right," Toshinori said, clearing his throat. "Well, as you already told me, you are no stranger to the Nomu, and have come across several of them already. We've been able to secure the four that we have here, and they have all agreed to assist us with our studies. Well… almost all." Toshinori tugged at the collar of his shirt somewhat nervously, his eyes darting toward the door for a moment.

"What do you mean, *almost all* ?" Izuku asked.

"We'll get to that. Currently, our understanding of the Nomu, and what makes them possible, is still limited. We know that they were all individuals infected by the same strain of the virus, the most common strain as it so happens, and yet for some reason, they are not infected in the same way as the vast majority of people."

There went Izuku's theory that Kacchan had been infected by a unique strain.

"Our extensive studies of the virus have surmised that it affects the endocrine system. It seems to massively alter the hormones within the body, affecting everything from our stress response to the

rate at which our cells die and reproduce. The long and short left unmanaged, the virus completely changes the body."

"Is that how they can survive for so long? Why they can't remember who they were?"

"It looks that way. Biologically, it shouldn't be possible. No combination of hormones in the world should be able to sustain the zombies past the point of natural death, and yet it does. The basic neurons are still firing, and the endocrine system that replaces our original is simple enough to fuel our baser instincts; to feed and to reproduce."

Izuku suppressed a shudder at this. "So, how do the N- how do the special subjects differ?" he asked.

"This is where things get really interesting," Toshinori replied, sounding almost giddy for a moment, and Aizawa bit back a groan. "Curiously, we have found that the second most common reason for death in the infected, after necrotising fasciitis and sepsis, is liver failure."

"Which makes sense," Izuku interjected, eyes widening. "If it's been trying to filter the hormones."

"Precisely. The infected often have darkened areas of the skin, raised bumps and veins, and yellowing of the eyes, all clear signs of cirrhosis of the liver. The more damage is done to the liver, the less effective it becomes at managing hormone levels, the quicker the virus progresses."

"But that…" Izuku scowled, thinking back to what he had learned from Kacchan's condition. It made sense for most zombies, sure, but for Kacchan the more alcohol he consumed the less the virus seemed to affect him. "It doesn't make sense," he said. "For the smart zombies I've met, some- we found that drinking alcohol slowed the virus. Surely, it ought to have been the opposite? The more their liver was damaged, the quicker the infection would spread?"

"This is exactly what we're trying to understand," Toshinori replied, nodding eagerly. "We discovered early on that initiating cirrhosis was the best way to reverse the worsening effects of the virus. It almost seems like the body needs to be actively infected to fight that infection. That, without the virus teeming in their bloodstream, they're far more likely to succumb to infection and become… whatever version of the zombies it is they become."

"An immune response?"

"Possibly. What we have discovered, however, is that the endocrine system is still affected. The hormone levels in the Nomu are significantly altered, almost to the stage where it has become unrecognisable. In that regard, the Nomu aren't strictly human anymore… They don't function as we expect, and it makes studying them incredibly difficult."

"Out there, there was a zombie I found," Izuku muttered, rubbing his chin. "It was completely emaciated, but still, y'know, *alive* . I gutted it to see what it had been surviving off, and I found out that the entire contents of its stomach were fermented. The smart zombies, do you know if they function in the same way?"

Toshinori's eyebrows rose. "That's quite some dedicated to the cause, Midoriya my boy," he said, with a nervous laugh. "But yes, we have discovered increased levels of fermentation in the gut. Not quite to the same level as the zombies, but the alcohol levels in their blood at any given time are

significantly high. We suspect that it contributes to their chronic liver disease, among other things."

"This is…" Izuku took a deep, shaking breath. This didn't answer nearly as many questions as he had hoped, instead creating a whole bunch of new problems for Izuku to puzzle over. "This is kinda crazy," he finally finished. Toshinori laughed.

"That's not even the half of it, young Midoriya."

"What do you mean?"

"Well, the abilities that the Nomu possess, whilst they are still in a cognitive and arguably human state of mind, are incredible. They heal much faster than we do, their metabolism is so slow that they do not need to eat nearly as much as a regular person, but they still maintain a high muscle mass. In short, they are faster, stronger, and much more durable than we could ever be. We have seen them survive injuries that would be impossible for any normal human to recover from, which-" Toshinori paused, glancing at Aizawa for a moment, who nodded stiffly. "Which, leads me to your subject."

Izuku felt himself bouncing on the balls of his feet all of a sudden, anticipation growing. It was unorthodox, and Izuku couldn't quite ignore Toshinor's comment earlier that not *all* of the test subjects had agreed to be cooperative, but this was what he had been working towards. This is where he needed to be. This was his chance to understand, and behind that door was the person who might help him make all of that possible.

"His appearance might come as a shock to you," Toshinori said, looking downright nervous now. "It will probably be less traumatic for me to explain his injuries to you now before you see him."

Izuku paused mid-bounce. "Traumatic?"

"Yes, uh…" Toshinori looked to Aizawa for help, but the man just shrugged.

"This one's on you."

"Right…"

"Professor?" Izuku asked, and suddenly all the excitement was gone. All that was left was a growing sense of dread, a fear trickling down the back of his spine. Traumatic? Injuries? Why was Toshinori so uncomfortable? It couldn't- "What's going on?"

"For fuck sake," Aizawa hissed, all too harshly, making Izuku jump. "When we found him, he had extensive injuries; blunt force and penetrating trauma, third-degree burns, several broken bones, and severe dehydration. He ought to have been dead, and yet he was still quite lucid when we found him. I'd say he was lucky to have survived an explosion of that magnitude, but he didn't look all that lucky to me."

Izuku's ears started to ring, the breath freezing in his lungs as he stared at Aizawa. "E-explosion?"

"We have kept him under sedation since he got here," Toshinor said urgently, palms spread as though he was trying to placate him. "And whilst we don't know of his exact relationship to you, we guessed he is probably one of your group-"

Izuku was rushing forward before either of them could stop him, thrusting the keycard into the lock so quickly he almost bent the thing, and pushing hard against the doors as he waited for the mechanism to unlock.

“Midoriya! Wait, just a minute! It isn’t safe!”

But Izuku was no longer listening, all but falling into the room in his haste before coming to a dead stop, the air brutally pounded from his chest as his eyes fell upon the person lying on the bed in the centre of the room. Half of his face was badly scarred, his ash blond hair buzzed down to the roots, wires and needles and tubes embedded in his arms and stomach, and a large ugly gash ran up the entire length of his wiry yellowed torso. He looked dead, could pass as dead, were it not for the steady beat from the heart monitor beside the bed, and Izuku felt hands grab at his arms before he could take a single step closer.

He looked nothing like the Kacchan that visited in his dreams, that haunted his every waking memory and brought such agonising pain with him, but there was no mistaking him. Kacchan was alive.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 38: Katsuki Alone

Chapter Summary

In which Katsuki is found.

Chapter Notes

CW: This is a very gore and trauma-heavy chapter. Mentions of suicide and graphic descriptions of severe injury.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sun against his cheeks was warm. Though he was blind, there wasn't a single part of him that felt lost; the air was humid enough to carry the taste of the fresh grass tickling against the back of his neck and palms. The cicadas were chirping their whirring tune, and far from just darkness, his vision was full of soft umbers and greens, swirling and dancing their languid dance. It felt like he had always been here. Those dark memories kissing the edges of his awareness were only unfortunate dreams during the life he had spent lying in the grass. Yeh, he had always been here, and if he so chose to, he would never have to leave.

So, this is what death felt like?

He took a deep breath; more to see if he could do so than any desire to breathe, and he felt the tingle rush down to his fingertips, a gentle buzz across his body that had him smiling in delight. He breathed again, and that smile turned into a quiet laugh when he realised that the motion was free from pain. He supposed he hadn't realised how much pain he was in until it was gone.

"Hey! That was mean!"

There was a soft thud, something rolling gently across the grass before tapping against his arm. Far from being alarmed, he reached out, his fingers brushing against a warm smooth surface, thumb stretching until he felt the soft tear of the material, and the rough texture beneath. It seemed strangely familiar to him.

"Uh, excuse me, sir?"

A voice, so nervous for such a beautiful day, piped up from his left. He stayed where he was for a moment, watching the colours dance before it occurred to him that maybe he wasn't blind after all.

"Uh, sir, are you… ok?"

"I dunno," Katsuki replied, honestly.

The sound of his own voice felt strange to him; light and carefree, absent of its usual rage and malice, no longer hindered with a defensive uncertainty that always had him second-guessing, and he smiled once more.

“Oh. Did you hit your head or something?”

Katsuki opened his eyes. He was right, he wasn’t blind here. The sun was bright, and the sky impossibly blue, looking for all the world like the perfect example of what a sky ought to look like. He blinked, relishing the warmth before inclining his head to the left.

Wide green eyes looked down at him, teeth teasing a wobbly lower lip as tiny hands entwined nervously. The boy couldn’t have been any older than four; his hair a shade darker than his luminous eyes and sticking out in every direction. His chubby cheeks, flushed and curious, were stained with the sweet golden hues of his freckles. Katsuki blinked again.

“Deku?”

The boy cocked his head curiously, worrying at his lip again.

“Do you need help getting up?”

Katsuki looked down. He was wearing clothes he didn’t recognise; a simple white t-shirt over white slacks. But there was nothing keeping him restrained to the ground.

“No.”

Katsuki sat up, crossing his legs beneath him, his arm wrapping around the leather football at his side and dragging it onto his lap. He looked down again, fingernail scraping against the tear.

“Oh, that’s good!”

The little Deku at his side did sound genuinely relieved, and Katsuki looked up to see a smile brighten his dimpled features.

“What are you doing here?” Katsuki asked.

Suddenly Deku looked nervous again, stretching out the hem of his t-shirt and peeking over his shoulder. “My friend… he accidentally threw the ball too far. Could- could we have it back please, sir?”

Katsuki’s eyebrows rose before it was his turn to tilt his head.

“Deku, don’t you remember me?”

Deku’s brow furrowed, his lips puckering and his face contorting in concentration as he looked back at him.

“Umm…”

“It’s me. It’s Katsuki.”

“Kat- Katsch-”

“Kacchan.”

Deku blinked, eyes widening. “No, you’re not Kacchan! Kacchan’s *five* ! Besides, his face doesn’t look like that.”

“Look like what?”

“ *Buuut* only Kacchan calls me Deku,” Deku reasoned, a tiny chubby hand reaching to his chin as he began to chew on his thumbnail, expression deep in thought.

“That’s right,” Katsuki replied, unable to hold back the smile when he thought back to all the times he had already seen that look on Deku’s face.

“Oi! Deku!”

A loud voice interrupted them, one that Katsuki *definitely* recognised. Across the park, another young boy came stomping toward them, the white skull on his black t-shirt almost comical in such a picture-perfect location, and the irritation clear on his screwed-up little face. Deku jumped and squeaked.

“S-sorry, Kacchan!” he called back. “ I was just getting it!”

“Then why is it taking so long?” Little Kacchan scoffed, and Katsuki found himself looking back at a replica of himself, only some fifteen years younger.

“Who’s this?” Kacchan demanded, glaring down at him. “Hey, give us our ball back, old man.”

“Kacchan!” Deku yelped, his hands coming up to cover his mouth. “That’s rude!”

“So? *He’* s the one who stole our ball. He’s the rude one. Now give it back.”

Katsuki tore his eyes away from them and looked back at the football cradled in his lap. He *did* remember it… He remembered playing with it so often as a kid, so strong scent of leather and wet grass awakening fuzzy memories of other warm summers. So, why couldn’t he remember the little boy standing beside his younger self, nervously tugging at the hem of his t-shirt?

“You didn’t remember me, either?” Katsuki asked him, and Deku looked confused again.

“Why the fuck would he remember *you?”* Kacchan said petulantly, pouting and placing his hands on his hips. Katsuki watched as the boy also took a large step in front of Deku, placing himself between the two of them.

“Kacchan, you can’t say that to an adult!”

“Why would you forget him?” Katsuki breathed urgently, staring at Kacchan. “If this- if this is a memory, why would we forget Deku?”

Kacchan looked wary now, eyes narrowing shrewdly before he launched forward, grabbing the ball from Katsuki's lap and snatching it away.

"Whatever, creepy old man. Come on, Deku, aunty will be mad if she catches you talking to strangers."

The peace that Katsuki had previously felt seemed to be falling away bit by bit, and it was only when the two younger versions of himself and Deku started to walk away that he realised that there was pain returning to his body. It was a deep pain, aching and growing, swelling from his core and forcing him to tear his eyes away from them. He grabbed at this stomach. He stared, those sweet breaths no longer offering him that contented buzz, but bringing a steady staccato of pain, and his white t-shirt began to pool with red, spreading from his left side and up to his chest. He gasped, frantically pulling at the hem of his shirt as the crystal blue sky above him began to darken; the soft grass beneath him grew hard and unforgiving. The sweet chirp of the cicada became a dull creek, and the taste of the grass fouled to rot and iron in his mouth.

No… this *is what death felt like.*

It took Katsuki a moment to realise where he was, so overwhelmed by the unbearable pain in his midriff that all he could do was cry out, breathing hard and fast, his mangled right hand slapping uselessly against the metal sticking out of his stomach. It was dark, but there was just enough light from behind him to make it clear that he was trapped beneath a load of rubble; heavy slabs worked with the rebar sticking out of him to keep him pinned to the hard concrete floor. Every breath brought pain, and he screwed his eyes shut, trying to will himself to calm down. He needed to stop panicking so that he could figure out what the *fuck* was going on.

But it hurt. Fuck, it hurt so goddamn *bad* . It didn't make any sense. He ought to have been obliterated in that explosion, not buried beneath the roof of the stadium. He grit his teeth, the movement stretching his stinging skin, and he hissed.

After several minutes of lying there, taking shallow breaths, he finally opened his eyes and looked around.

The reinforcement bar was the first thing to grab his attention; the textured surface was stained red from his still hot blood, and his eyes followed the length of it before he was filled with complete and utter horror. It was a blood-curdling moment of mingled clarity and confusion, fear spiking when he realised that he was looking down at his guts. The force of entry had torn at his midriff, leaving a large open wound that he ought to have bled to death from within minutes, and from which his insides had ruptured. He stared, head swaying and vision starting to blacken at the corners, entirely unable to look away from his glistening entrails even as he lost control over his body, slumping back down. He must have fallen unconscious because when he opened his eyes again, it was a little darker and harder for him to make out what was going on around him.

He swallowed, his mouth dry around the blood that caked it, and he looked around once more. His right arm had been damaged; it was badly broken by the looks of things, the fingers swollen and twisting at an unnatural angle. The right side of his face stung, and he bit back a cry when he touched the burning surface with his good hand. He couldn't feel his legs at all.

His mind raced. He was still in the stadium, that much was clear. His proximity to the dynamite at

the gate should have assured a quick and painless death, blowing apart the front foyer and his body along with it. But, the fact he was now buried beneath the rubble meant one thing; the ignition had failed. It made no sense… there had been nothing wrong with the received or the dynamite, he was fucking *sure* of that. Which meant someone had disconnected it. Someone had made sure the dynamite at the gate wouldn't ignite.

Katsuki didn't need to think hard to figure out who it must have been. Even in death, Dabi had succeeded in royally fucking him over.

He took another series of shallow breaths, trying not to move his torso too much before arching his neck back. He could see the gate, open from the force of the explosion, but the two steel columns on either side remained intact, protecting the dynamite he had placed just outside of them. It was shitty luck; a one-in-a-million chance made one in a thousand by that crispy-faced motherfucker, and Katsuki let his head fall back to the concrete again, exhausted and trying to think his way through his predicament.

His legs were probably crushed. If he tried to remove the rebar then his guts would likely just spill out of him like eels at a buffet; that he wasn't already dead was nothing short of a miracle. And, if help *did* come along then there was nothing anyone could do to save him at this stage. He was trapped here until he eventually bled to death. It wasn't a good way to go, but he supposed as things went in the Apocalypse, there was decidedly worse.

As if the universe was keen to prove a point, there was a scraping sound from behind him, and he twisted his back again, stuttering a curse, heart rate spiking as he saw the zombie making its slow way toward him on one broken ankle.

"Fuck," Katsuki breathed, his left hand patting down to his hip to try and reach one of his knives. But at this angle, with the rebar preventing him from twisting his torso at all, his fingers only brushed against the handle of the knife attached to his thigh.

"Fuck!"

He girt his teeth against the pain as he tried once more, only for the frantic slapping of his hand to slide the holster further down his thigh and entirely out of his reach. He looked up, the zombie now only a few feet away from him, its head turning this way and that, eyeless sockets seeming to stare at him as it followed the metallic scent of his blood and fear.

"Get- get outta here!" Katsuki grunted, waving his left hand as if that would somehow be enough to deter it. But the zombie wasn't intimidated and dropped to all fours, crawling closer, mouth wide and tongue waggling. A while bubbled up in Katsuki's chest as he realised that there was no way that he could stop this thing. The zombie was close enough now that his hand slapped uselessly against its face, trying to scratch away at rotting flesh. Up close he could see what he originally thought was its tongue was just a mound of meat writing with maggots, its blunt teeth a filthy brown, the stench of death so overpowering that Katsuki's eyes leaked. So, this was how he was going to die; slowly torn apart and consumed by the face of his every nightmare combined.

But, just as that horrible mouth was just a few inches from his face, the zombie stopped. He watched, frozen in place as it raised its head, jaw dropped like it was trying to taste something in the air before it got to its feet again, and began to stumble away. Katsuki didn't dare move, eyes wide and holding his breath as he watched it go by, wandering deeper into the stadium, and his

head dropped back to the concrete once it was out of sight.

He was certain that it hadn't been him controlling the zombie; it didn't seem to have listened to him at all, even when he was trying to command it. It was only now, so consumed with everything else his body was already going through, that he remembered the bite on his arm and the fever that had been running rampant through his body before the explosion.

His arm was too busted and blood for him to make out a bite now; the blood and mangled flesh melded into one hideous mess. Checking his temperature for fever was pointless given that he was certain he had burned half of his face off and everything felt hot to the touch. He felt like crap… A deep down, bone-tired kind of exhaustion that could have been from any of the many stressors he had experienced over the last few months alone, and it would be impossible to say what was from the virus or the blood loss. But that zombie had got a good sniff of him and his blood, and that it had decided to ignore him sure as shit couldn't be good news.

Not that it mattered at this stage. If the zombies were ignoring him that at least he didn't have to consider the possibility of being eaten alive, and could instead entertain the guarantee that he would eventually pass out from blood loss and feel nothing from that point anyway. He shut his eyes, thinking longingly of how soft the grass had felt beneath him, how comforting the sun had felt on his cheeks, and started to drift in and out of consciousness.

Three hours later, he was met with a terrifying realisation.

Despite how improbable, how *impossible* , Katsuki woke again. The stadium was dark save for the gentle shimmer from the moon and stars, and he felt no more disorientated than he had done before falling asleep. He was exhausted yet he felt no sicker. And despite the amount of dried and caking blood pooled around him, he had still not yet bled to death. He lay there, staring up at the cracked concrete, his breathing less controlled and his heart hammering in his chest as his mind raced, forcing him to come to a horrifying conclusion. He wasn't going to die any time soon. He was stuck here, exposed with his insides on display, his face burned and his arm broken, with no hope of escape.

Had he already turned? Was his mind still intact, trapped inside his slowly rotting corpse, doomed to lay here as the insects and elements slowly ate away at him before his eyes until they, too, were finally gone? How long did it take for a zombie to decompose fully? *Months?* Was this where he would still be, years from now? Was this… was this really his fate? There was no way he could rationalise his way out of this, no way to calm himself as he began to hyperventilate, the frantic thumping of his chest bringing yet more pain and he started to hit at the pole in his stomach.

No . He refused. He *fucking refused.* He was not going to go out like this. Maybe the rebar was plugging the hole, preventing the rest of his blood from pooling out, and if he could tear himself free of it, he could spill whatever remained, and he would be dead in minutes. Ignoring the pain in his right hand he wrapped his fingers around the rebar and began to heave, pulling his torso up.

The pain was unimaginable. Katsuki screamed, his voice so loud that he was probably drawing every zombie in the area toward him, but he continued to pull, slowly raising his hips and sliding the rebar through his body until his arms were shaking so badly he lost his grip and fell back down again, tearing another scream from him.

"Ah! Fu- fuck, no you- you fucking don't-"

He grabbed hold once more, fingers slipping over the hot, bloody surface, desperately heaving, but it was no use. He didn't have the strength, and he collapsed, his agonised screams turning to wailing sobs.

"Fuck! FUCK!"

He beat furiously at the rebar with his left first, crying and yelling out his frustrations and fear. Blood gently oozed from him, but he didn't think it was enough… all he had succeeded in doing was tearing a larger hole in his body, fucking himself over even more, and his sobs grew pitiful; weak whines filled the cavernous space, mind desperately chasing ideas.

He looked around, arm reaching out blindly in every direction. He had several weapons on him when he went down. It wouldn't take much for him to slit his throat if only he could reach something- *anything!* But there was nothing. All his weapons were out of his reach, and he cursed, throwing his bloody hand over his face.

He wasn't sure how long he lay there after that, hand covering his eyes, breaths shallow, almost too tired to think before he heard the sound of shuffling again. With a pained groan, he looked up, seeing six zombies walking toward him. As awful as it was, as much as he had promised himself that he would never *ever* go down this way, he didn't know what else he could do. It was his last hope. His last option.

"H-hey," he croaked, waving his arm. "Oi!"

His voice was worn ragged from the screaming, but it was enough to grab the attention of the zombies ambling their way through the stadium.

"C'mon," he grunted.

Two of them appeared fresher than the others, stumbling just a little bit faster than their companions, but *fuck* it didn't make a lick of difference to the smell. The first was missing almost all of its teeth, mouth parting and gaping as it considered him. Another had a backpack of sorts attached to it, Katsuki watching in dawning horror as another zombie dug its tiny hands into its shoulder, trying and failing to heave its small body out of the carrier. He knew he was crying again, slapping his hand on the concrete, making as much noise as he could manage, as the zombies continued in his direction

"C'mon," he repeated. "C'mon! Hey- no- hey!"

But these zombies, just like the last, paused just long enough to stretch open their mouths before they too passed him, turning back the way they had come.

"Hey!" Katsuki yelled. "Wa- wait!"

But it didn't matter how loudly he shouted. It made no difference. The zombies no longer had any interest in him.

"C'mon," he sobbed, hand stretching out toward them. "Pl-please, come back-"

Frantically, he found his hands wrapped around the rebar once more, pulling and heaving, too tired and broken to scream, his wails and cries childlike in their desperation and their pleading.

“Please! Please, please- help… help! Izuku-”

But no help came. No miracle. There was no Izuku here to hold his hand and stroke his hair and promise him that things were going to be ok. Nothing and no one to ease his suffering as lay there. Exhausted. Frightened.

Alone.

He was all alone.

“Hey, boss, I think I found something!”

Katsuki stirred. There were… voices? It sounded like voices. Voices that he didn’t recognise, that he only just registered over the agony writing inside of him. A weak groan left his lips, his head lolling from side to side as he attempted to peel back his tear-swollen eyes.

“What is it?”

“Reckon we found him, just like the kid said.”

Katsui swallowed, his mouth full of so much dried blood that even the act of dragging his tongue over the arch made his throat burn.

“Holy fuck, he’s alive.”

The amount of effort it took for him to open his eyes was almost enough to leave him panting again; his vision entirely blurred until a dark shadow covered his face. He blinked urgently until he could focus on the man crouching over him. He was pale, one of his tired-looking and heavily hooded eyes covered with a black eyepatch, scars tracking down the right side of his face. His black hair was pulled back into a ponytail, and despite the roughness of his appearance, his expression was soft.

“It’s alright, kid,” the man said, reaching out and placing a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder.

Katsuki blinked again, brow furrowing painfully.

“He’s been stuck like this for nearly two days,” someone else said. “Fuck…”

The black-haired man gave Katsuki’s body a once over before those calming eyes drifted back.

“Look,” he said. “I’m going to be honest with you, it doesn’t look good. Expecting any kind of recovery from this is… illogical.”

Katsuki shut his eyes and managed a small nod.

“Just… do it,” he rasped. “Kill me.”

The man sighed, the hand on his shoulder tightening just a fraction.

“Look for it.”

Katsuki’s head lolled again, confused. *Look for what? What did they want?* He felt movement, hot hands touching his body, dragging another scream from his swollen and burning throat as he tried to recoil.

“Be careful!” the man growled.

Katsuki flinched, a pitiful whine leaving his lips, and his eyes cracking open once more. He could see another figure standing beside the first, pulling at his clothes, and dragging a dirty sleeve up his left arm, before tentatively tearing his shirt and bringing another wave of pain.

“Wait!”

“Shit. Are you sure?”

“It’s right there, boss, no mistaking it. The kids' hunch was right.”

No. Wait- no-

“Fuck. *Fuck.* ”

“We gotta take him in, boss.”

No!

“It’s definitely a bite?” the dark-haired man said, getting to his feet to take a look for himself. “Fresh?”

“Old, sir. Really old.”

“Well, shit.”

“No-” Katsuki choked. “You- you’re from-”

“Easy there, kid,” the dark-haired man said, looking down at him with something akin to pity on his face.

“Just- just kill me!” Katsuki cried, his eyes widening, hands grabbing at the rebar once more. “Do it! Pl-please, just-”

“I can’t do that,” the dark-haired man replied solemnly. “I’m sorry, kid.”

“No!” Katsuki snarled, some of the flame returning in the face of that soft-eyed devil standing over

him. “Fuck you! Fuck *you!* I ain’t going!”

“I think we’re going to need to tranquilise him.”

“No! Get the fuck *off* me! I’ll kill you, I’ll fucking kill all of you!”

“You got the needle?”

“Here, boss.”

“I’ll tear you apart! *FUCKERS!* LET ME GO!”

“Hold him down.”

A hand grabbed his wrist, another roughly fisting in his hair, twisting his head to the side and exposing his throat.

“Get off me! I ain’t going, I ain’t-”

A sharp pain blossomed from this neck.

“I can’t- I won’t-”

“Shh, it’s ok, kid. It’ll be alright.”

Katsuki’s world went dark again.

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 39: Sick to Death

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku learns some hard truths, and a new battle begins.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The world tilted on its axis for one, startling moment, and it wasn't surprising how that sudden shift rolled everything back into place. It was almost as though he had been looking at everything the wrong way up; a painting on the wall that for three long months he had been sure was abstract until someone took it from its place above the rusting fireplace and turned it one-eighty. And the painting he looked at now, despite being entirely the same, was also somehow wholly new; the harsh jagged and *confusing* lines now the gentle sweep of a jawline, the angry dark shades the shadows cast over worn hands. He had been searching for meaning in this place, with this life that he had stumbled into when all he had needed to do was flip the canvas.

Disbelief had no business in Izuku's mind these days. Disbelief, suspended or otherwise, only took time away from the reality in front of him, and in a world where time was in ever-high demand, it wasn't something that he could afford to waste anymore. There wasn't even a moment when Izuku doubted the reality of what was in front of him and he had only one singular thought in his mind.

Protect him.

Unfortunately, Izuku wasn't the only one who had learned to act quickly in the Apocalypse, and even as he made his first bold step towards the man lying prone and sallow-skinned on the hospital bed, arms wrapped tightly around his wrists and yanked them to the small of his back, a cry of pain leaving his lips.

"He told you it wasn't safe."

The voice in his ear wasn't without compassion; Izuku knew that Aizawa wasn't entirely indifferent to his emotions or the pain that started to blossom in his chest the longer he looked at Kacchan. But, it *was* without mercy. Aizawa pulled him back, firmly and without argument, Izuku's heels dragging on the ground as he was heaved away by a man much bigger and stronger than himself. Izuku didn't even feel himself panic, so steadfast in his duty that he somehow believed he could break free from Aizawa's grasp right up until the point a large heavy door shut in his face and broke his line of sight with Kacchan. That was when he started to yell and kick and do all that he could to find his way back to him.

"Let me go!" Izuku cried, teeth gritting as he bucked in Aizawa's grip. "Damnit, let me go!"

"Not until you calm down," Aizawa said, voice monotone as if holding Izuku back required no effort on his part. It probably didn't; Izuku was still little more than skin and bones.

“Aizawa, please be gentle with him!”

“I’m not hurting him.”

Fortunately, if there was one thing that Izuku always had over Kacchan, it was his ability to deescalate, and Izuku knew that there was no way he was going to be able to free himself from Aizawa’s grip through sheer force alone. He took a deep breath, allowing himself to go slack in his arms.

“Good, deep breaths, kid. Count to ten.”

Feeling like a child, and shutting his eyes against the stinging of his pride, Izuku continued to breathe, slow and steady, until Aizawa’s grip softened.

“I’m going to let you go, now. But if you cause me any more trouble, I won’t be so gentle this time, you hear me?”

Izuku nodded, and he smartly pulled his hands forward, thumbs working circles around his red and sore wrists. No one spoke for a moment, Izuku dimly aware that there were others in the room now, five new sets of eyes watching him with varying degrees of interest from across the room. He took another breath, before turning to look back at Aizawa and the Professor, both of them watching him warily.

“Let me see him.”

“Absolutely not.”

“But he’s- you have to let me see him!”

“I don’t have to do anything, not until I’m certain you’re not going to do something stupid and get him or one of us killed.”

Izuku’s mouth snapped shut, biting back a snarl of frustration and looking back at the door again. It felt as though there was some force tugging at him, grabbing hold of the flesh above his heart and sinking its claws into the crevices between each rib; a desperate, aching, *frantic* feeling. Kacchan was here. He was *here*. Alive. And just behind this door. He needed to see him. He needed to touch him, hear him, *anything* to confirm that what he had seen in that room wasn’t just another of his nightmares. Because he didn’t think he could handle it if it were… he couldn’t go through that again.

“I know you’re probably confused, young Midoriya,” Toshinori now said, his voice as soft and soothing as the palm touching his shoulder. “But you *have* to stay calm. For his sake as well as yours.”

Confused wasn’t how Izuku would describe his feelings right now. Confusion was just another emotion he had no damn time for. *Nothing* had felt real here. None of it. Not even his mother. It had all been beyond his grasp, somehow. Seen from behind a veil. And yet, when he looked at Kacchan even in that state, all he had felt was clarity. Certainty. Of course, Kacchan hadn’t died… now that, *that* was insanity. The world hadn’t felt real because it *wasn’t* real. It had all been an interlude, half-

truths and vapid hurdles until the world tilted back into place again.

“How long has he been here?” Izuku asked.

“Three months,” Toshinori replied. “Aizawa brought him back a couple of days after you arrived here.”

“Th-three months?” Izuku gaped. “He’s been here this whole time and you didn’t tell me?”

“We had no reason to tell you,” Aizawa replied bluntly. “I think you’re forgetting how this works, kid. This whole thing exists on a need-to-know basis, and you didn’t need to know shit before now. If Shigaraki hadn’t agreed, for some illogical reason, to grant you access to the project then you would have never known he was here. And you need to come to terms with and accept that pretty sharpish before we’re forced to make you forget again.”

“You can’t do this,” Izuku replied, ignoring Aizawa’s warning. “He isn’t some mindless zombie for you to do experiments on! You can’t just keep him here against his will!”

“Am I supposed to just let him walk out the door right now?” Aizawa replied tersely, rubbing at his temple. “Come on, kid, I know you’re not stupid.”

“Then you- you wake him up and-”

“Young Midoriya,” Toshinori said gently, “Your friend is still unwell, and if we were to wake him up now he would be in a great deal of pain. You have to trust me, we are doing what we believe to be best for him.”

“Wh-what’s *best for him*?” Izuku said in disbelief. “He doesn’t want to be here! Please, Professor, maybe you think you’re doing the right thing, but the Kacchan I know wouldn’t want this, *any* of this. He didn’t want to be experimented on, he just… he wanted-” He felt his throat start to close up, the tears spilling furiously down his cheeks.

“Perhaps we should discuss this somewhere a little more private,” Toshinori said, looking up at Aizawa. Aizawa sighed before he gestured towards one of the doors on the far side of the room. Izuku felt Toshinori’s hand on his shoulder again, gently guiding him forward, Izuku put up some resistance when he realised that he was being led further away from Kacchan, but the gawking faces of the others in the room were only making it that much harder for him to breathe.

“Kayama,” Aizawa said, “get everyone back into their rooms for now.”

There was a gentle *beep*, and the door was opened and Izuku found himself ushered into what looked like a small bedroom; there was a single bed against the far wall, an empty desk and bookcase opposite, entirely devoid of life or character much like the rest of this godforsaken place.

“Please, take a seat,” Toshinori said, and Izuku perched himself on the edge of the bed, looking up at his Professor and Aizawa expectantly as the door shut.

“He wouldn’t want to be here,” Izuku insisted immediately. “After he was bitten the second time I thought he might change his mind, but he didn’t. He never wanted to be part of some big experiment. He wouldn’t *consent* to this!”

Aizawa and Toshinori exchanged a look before Aizawa crossed his arms and leaned back against the door.

“You are no longer my student,” he said, “so I am not going to speak to you as if you were. Shigaraki seems to think that you are useful and capable enough to be here, so I expect you to at least *act* as if that’s true for a moment. Listen to what I have to say, and don’t interrupt.”

Izuku chewed on the inside of this cheek, fighting the urge to respond.

“When we found the nomu- this young man, what did you say his name was?”

“Ka-Bakugou. His name is Bakugou Katsuki. *Not nomu.*”

“Bakugou, then. When we found Bakugou he was severely injured and trapped beneath the stadium. By rights, he shouldn’t have survived as long as he did; he was dehydrated, had lost a lot of blood, and both his stomach and bowels had been perforated and exposed to the elements.” Aizawa took a deep breath, Izuku’s fingernails digging into his knees as he was immediately bombarded with mental images. “And yet, aside from his obvious exhaustion, he was able to talk to me quite sanely. He seemed aware and nothing like any of the final stage nomu that we’ve dealt with. That was reason enough for us to bring him back here with us.”

By *‘final stage’*, Izuku assumed he meant the smart zombies as Izuku had met them. Zombies like Mr Zombig, and the female at the hospital. The sort that Kacchan had been afraid of turning into… his heart ached.

“But, once we got him back here and Toshinori started to run the usual tests, his hormone markers indicated that he was, in fact, final stage.”

Izuku sat up straight, eyes wide.

“Wait,” he breathed. “You don’t… you don’t mean-”

“I asked you not to interrupt,” Aizawa sighed. “We’ve tried to bring nomu back from final stage in the past without any success. We had concluded that it just wasn’t possible to undo that level of change and that the only solution for those that reach that point was termination. But Bakugou, for whatever reason, is different. Not only was his body starting to recover and heal from such extensive injuries, but when liver failure was induced his hormone markers began to shift back to the levels that we would expect to see in the incubation stage.”

“Incubation stage?” Izuku asked.

“It’s the stage post-bite after the subject has seemingly recovered from infection and before they progress to full nomu,” Toshinori explained. “They all show some of the physical characteristics of the virus but mentally they still appear to behave as they normally would.”

“Arguably, it’s the most dangerous stage,” Aizawa said. “Because unless someone saw the bite, most people would have no idea that they had an infected person among them, and without management, the incubation phase only tends to last, at best, six months.”

Mr Zombig, Izuku thought, remembering the diary and how quickly he had seemed to succumb to the virus compared to Kacchan.

“So… does that mean Kacchan is recovering?”

Aizawa seemed to hesitate for a moment, before shrugging one shoulder. “In a sense. Physically, at least. But this is where you will need to put your personal feelings aside.” Aizawa fixed him with a steady, dark gaze. “We have a moral responsibility to protect what is left of humanity, Midoriya. As scientists, and as survivors, that is our only goal. Bakugou may be your friend and maybe he didn’t consent to come here, but as far as myself and everyone else at the facility is concerned, he is dangerous. He is a threat, just like all the nomu you see here. They are each carefully monitored, and more importantly, they cooperate because they are all sane and rational enough to understand what’s at stake.”

“Aizawa,” Toshinori said softly, but Aizawa ignored him, keeping his eyes on Izuku.

“Your friend? He cannot and will not ever leave this facility. And if he refuses to cooperate then either he remains restrained and sedated, or he is terminated.”

“Wh- you can’t do that!”

“Yes, I can,” Aizawa replied. “I will do anything to protect UA.”

“But… you have to listen to me, Kacchan isn’t like that! He’s not dangerous! His first bite? It happened almost two years ago and all that time he was with his group and hadn’t hurt any of them. We were alone together for months after we got split from the rest of our friends and nothing happened. He tried to blow himself up before letting the virus get so bad that he’d turn into one of those things!”

“You said he was bitten twice,” Aizawa said, seemingly unmoved. “When was the second bite?”

“I-” Izuku paused and cursed himself internally. He hadn’t been thinking. He’d been so emotional that he’s just spewed out everything to them. “Uh, three days before we took out the stadium. Maybe four, I- I’m still a bit fuzzy.”

“Was he affected by it?” Toshinori asked urgently.

“I don’t know if I should tell you,” Izuku replied honestly, eyes wide and fingers pulling at the frayed edges of the blanket beneath him. “If you’re going to hurt him-”

“Midoriya,” Toshinori said softly, “I know how bad it looks. But all we have done so far is try to save his life. I won’t sugarcoat anything for you, but I promise you that no one here has any desire to hurt him.”

Izuku swallowed, searching Toshinori’s eyes for any sign of a lie. It was ludicrous, these statements, said so boldly when Kacchan had been here, almost certainly against his will, sedated for three months. But, he couldn’t bring himself to consider that the Toshinori he knew and trusted, who had risked his life to bring Izuku’s mother back to safety, would ever purposefully hurt Kacchan.

“Yeh, he got a fever,” he finally replied. “He was pretty sick, all the symptoms you’d expect from someone who had been bitten, and probably why the virus had progressed so much when you found him. But he was sane, right? That’s what you said. He wasn’t acting like one of the smart zombies. He isn’t *dangerous*.”

“So, he’s never harmed anyone?” Aizawa asked. “Had he behaved violently previously?”

“N-” Izuku froze, his face falling as he remember tugging desperately at Kacchan’s clenched fist, begging for him to let go of Jin before the man was torn apart beneath his fingertips.

“I see,” Aizawa hummed. “And was he able to control other zombies?”

Izuku felt his face burning in frustration. The urge to lie was huge; his heart begged for him to say something, *anything*, to protect Kacchan. But he had never been a very good liar, and his silence and wobbling lower lip easily betrayed the truth, and Aizawa sighed again.

“Look, I know how hard this is. I’ve… I’ve had to make similar decisions in the past, and I lost a good friend of mine in this very facility. What we’re asking of you is… it’s immeasurable. But you’re a *scientist*. And that young man out there? For better or worse, he is different from the rest and understanding him could be the key to understanding this virus. We need you to convince him to cooperate.”

“That’s the only reason I’m here, right?” Izuku asked, quietly. “You knew he was a friend and now you’re almost ready to wake him up you want me to help you.”

“Does it matter why you’re here?” Aizawa asked. “Does it matter why any of us are here? You think smarter and stronger people than us haven’t already died senseless, pointless deaths? The why isn’t important. But you *are* here, and you have a moral duty as a scientist and a survivor, to do everything it takes to end this thing.”

Izuku looked down at his hands, scarred and bent and busted from years of wielding splinter-ridden weapons and doing everything he could to survive. Against the odds, he had dragged his weak body here, and maybe, just maybe, there was a reason behind this. The idea of fate had always been there, buried deep in thoughts and denying his ego the opportunity to explore it, but there had to be something to this, right? There had to be a *reason* he had made it this far. A reason Kacchan had survived. A reason… a reason neither of them had turned despite the universe doing its fucking damnedest to make that happen.

“Ok,” he said finally. “I’ll help you. But we have to do this my way. Kacchan is… he’s got a stronger will than anyone I’ve ever known; he’s proud and stubborn but more than that he will die for what he believes in, and for the people he cares about.”

“Then by that logic, we won’t have any problems,” Aizawa said bluntly. “Because those are exactly the people who are going to be depending on his willingness to cooperate.”

“What do you mean by that?”

Aizawa hummed from his nose, averting his gaze to look out the porthole window in the door. “We can’t hide here forever. The virus will outlive us if we don’t kill it first.”

Izuku shut his eyes, his chest aching so badly that he raised a hand to rub at it. “Can I see him now?”

“He’s still unconscious.”

“I know that I just… I thought he was dead. For three months I’ve been-” *grieving, mourning, dying…* “-Please, I just want to see him.”

“Aizawa? Surely we can allow that?”

Aizawa scowled, still staring out of the window before he rolled his head back tiredly. “Fine. You’ll need to put on PPE, he’s still susceptible to infection and other contagions whilst he’s recovering from the last round of amiodarone. Look but don’t touch.”

“Ok, yes ok, thank you!”

“Come on, then.”

The common area was still empty when Izuku eagerly made his way back to Kacchan’s door, the other infected were still in their rooms, and Aizawa grabbed two sealed packets and directed Izuku to a sink against the wall, standing at his side as Izuku thoroughly scrubbed up his elbows, wincing slightly at the sting of the alcohol wash. After pulling on a pair of latex gloves and securing a mask over his face, Aizawa and Toshinori did the same, the door was opened once more.

Izuku was a bundle of nervous energy; eager to see Kacchan again, but also feeling undeniably sick over the possibility of this all being some terrible joke. A part of him was convinced that the room would be empty. But the steady beeping of the heart monitor and the rhythmic hiss of the ventilator brought a welcome reassurance as Izuku stepped into the darker room.

Seeing Kacchan again came with as big of a gut punch as the first time, and for a moment he found himself frozen, fear trickling like ice through his veins. Somehow, even the Kacchan with a face broken and beaten and covered in blood as he had last seen it, felt far more alive and real than the one lying on the blue cotton sheets, almost like he was a morbid doll laid out to satisfy someone’s gross fascinations. From across the room, Kacchan was just a still, small mass, more plastic than person, covered in a complicated web of tubes and wires.

“You can go a little closer,” he heard Toshinori say at his shoulder, misunderstanding Izuku’s sudden apprehension. Izuku nodded, taking a deep shaky breath, and started to walk forward until he was standing barely two feet from the foot of the bed.

There was tape over Kacchan’s eyes; two thin strips keeping them from opening, and that perhaps was what drove Izuku closest to breaking point, biting down hard on his lower lip to stop himself from screaming. Kacchan was naked atop the blue sheets, save for a strip of fabric across his hips that at least offered the illusion of modesty, the expanse of his injuries bare to him. The right side of his face was scarred; perhaps not so bad as Izuku had initially thought, but the skin was pink and puckered and raised from his jaw to his temple. His right arm was far worse, the scarring and damage so severe that Izuku couldn’t even make out the marks from his second bite, understanding why Aizawa and Toshinori hadn’t known about it, and there was one large surgical scar running almost the entire length of his abdomen. Up close, Izuku could now see that the tubes coming from his stomach and from beneath the sheet covering his hips were from the colostomy and catheter, the

electrodes on his chest and the ventilator over his face all desperately trying to keep his body functioning. To see Kacchan like *this*… so vulnerable, so much smaller than Izuku remembered… he felt another scream growing in his chest.

"Wh-when can all this stuff come off him?" he found himself asking, eyes drifting back to Kacchan's face. Half of his right eyebrow had been scorched off, the rest of his hair haphazardly buzzed short, like someone simply hadn't felt up to the challenge of keeping it clean.

"If his vitals remain stable, we are looking to wake him a week from now," Toshinori replied. "We could have woken him sooner with a strong course of pain relief, but we have no idea what state he will be in when he regains consciousness. We were concerned that if we woke him too soon, he might struggle and cause more damage."

"Y-you said his stomach was perforated," Izuku whispered. "Is that… healed?"

"Yes," Toshinori said. "His recovery from what was, uh, much quicker than we expected. Actually, it was a little incredible how quickly the tissue began to regrow, and we suspect the virus might be responsible for that. But we'll need to keep him on a carefully managed diet until we're sure he can handle it."

"A-and the burns… will they?"

"It's hard to say. Appearance-wise, they've been improving with treatment, but curiously the external healing doesn't seem to be nearly so efficient as internal."

Kacchan's body was covered in scars, most of them familiar to Izuku after the nights spent tracing his fingers over them, scars that stood out stark against his pale skin, and that had faded no more than any of Izuku's had over the years.

"Yeh," he muttered, distractedly, watching the gentle way Kacchan's chest rose and fell with each breath. "A week."

"That's the hope."

"And until then? What do I do?"

"It's going to take some time to get you up to speed with everything we're doing here," Toshinori replied. "And I still need to introduce you to the rest of the team. As for the rest of the day? Take it as a break. Get some sleep, and we'll deal with everything tomorrow once you're rested."

"Can't I stay here?"

"The longer we're here the greater the risk," Toshinori said apologetically. "I'm sorry. But you'll get to spend more time with him soon."

"Come on," Aizawa said. "It's time to go."

Izuku nodded, still watching Kacchan's steady breaths, and his soft and silent face now etched with the evidence of his every trial and hurt, and allowed himself to step back when he felt the hand upon his shoulder.

I'll be back, Kacchan, I promise. I'm coming back for you.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 40: Over My Dead Body

Chapter Summary

In which Inko has information that changes everything.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He wasn't even sure how he ended up outside of his mother's door; the walk from the lab to the dorms was just another stolen moment of his life, the memories swallowed by the growing fog in his mind with all the rest. He was certain that she would still be asleep; her responsibilities as a nurse at the facility meant that she kept a very different schedule from Izuku, usually only overlapping by an hour or two each day. It never felt like enough, but considering he had gone close to two years thinking that he might never see her again, they were hours that he still found the heart to cherish, despite everything. He missed her. He missed his mum. And right now, when the thought of going back to his lonely, dark room, alone with his thoughts was unthinkable, there wasn't anywhere else that his feet might take him.

He knocked, the thuds echoing down the still-dark corridor, half sure that she wouldn't answer. However, less than a handful of seconds later he heard a sleepy ' *I'm coming!'* from the room, before the door opened, green eyes peering somewhat hesitantly around the door before widening at the sight of her son.

"Izuku, baby? What's wrong?"

It took Izuku a moment to realise that his face was wet, and he raised a hand to wipe away the tears he didn't know he'd been crying before the door was swung open and he was immediately pulled into a warm embrace.

"Come inside, tell me everything."

He followed her into her room, the light switched on as he was ushered to the bed, his mum fussing over him and brushing his long bangs back from his eyes as she checked his temperature. He couldn't tell her everything, even if he had felt ready to… Before leaving the lab, Aizawa had made it painfully clear that he wasn't to tell a single person about what he had seen at the lab. The existence of the smart zombies at UA was a selfishly guarded secret, and Izuku wasn't ready to put his mother, or anyone else, at risk just so he could get a few things off his chest. But with the tears dripping freely from his chin and onto his lap, he couldn't very well insist that he was ok.

"You don't have a fever," Midoriya Inko said, still gazing into his face with concern in her eyes. "But you look tired, baby. What's wrong?"

Izuku swallowed. Despite her worry, the warmth his mother radiated was still a comfort, and he gratefully took her hand when she reached it out to him.

“I… I was reminded of someone today,” he said, quietly. “S-someone I-” his voice caught in his throat, and Inko smiled softly, the hand took holding his gently stroking his cheek.

“Someone you lost?”

Lost . The word stung. He nodded.

“Oh, baby.”

Inko pulled him into another hug and Izuku buried his face into her shoulder. She was so much smaller than he remembered; thin and fragile like almost everyone was these days. They stayed that way for a little while longer, Izuku sniffling and feeling bad for getting her sweater so wet on such a cold morning, but she didn’t complain. Eventually, she shifted and sat beside him, stroking his hair back again.

“Your hair is getting so long,” she said quietly.

Izuku hummed. She looked at him for a moment longer, eyes drifting across his face before she smiled again and got to her feet.

“I have an idea.”

“Hmm? No, mum, I’m sorry, you only came off your shift two hours ago. I should let you get some sleep.”

“Nonsense,” Inko replied, her voice bright and encouraging as she rummaged through the top drawer of an old dresser. “I’ve already spent far too much time sleeping in this life, and right now my baby needs me. Ah, here they are!”

She stood straight, holding a pair of scissors in her hand.

“It’s a bit of an odd time for a haircut, mum.”

“Maybe, but you’ll feel better once it’s done. Trust me.”

Izuku hesitated for a moment, somewhat confused at the turn of events, but she looked so keen, and Izuku realised that perhaps something so mundane and so domestic as cutting her son's hair was exactly what she needed. He nodded.

“Ok, sit on the floor in front of me, let’s tidy that up a bit.”

He slid from the bed, crossing his legs beneath him and reaching up to untangle his hair from his mess of a bun, vaguely acknowledging that it had probably been days since he had last done so. Inko took her place behind him, taking locks of his long hair and brushing through them, careful not to snag too badly at the many knots and tangles.

“Would you like to tell me about them?” she asked gently, after a moment. “Would that help?”

Izuku felt a smile tug at his lips, surprising as it was, when he realised that the haircut had simply

been a way of distracting Izuku from his spiralling thoughts, to keep them both occupied so that he could organise them. He considered for a moment… did he want to talk about Kacchan? Was he even capable of that right now? For three months, he hadn't said a word about him to anyone… and it wasn't like his friends hadn't tried to bring the subject up. They missed Kacchan too, and naturally, they wanted to know what had happened, but except for when Izuku had first woken and told them that Kacchan had stayed behind after the detonators failed, he hadn't been able to talk about him again. Any time Kacchan had been brought up Izuku had found a way to leave, and perhaps that in part was one of the reasons he had retreated so much.

But, it was different now. Kacchan was *alive* . And yet… and *yet* …

Kacchan still felt very much lost to him.

"I love him."

He hadn't planned on those being the first words he'd use when he finally told his mother about Kacchan, but after they left his lips he realised how *right* they felt. What he had with Kacchan, what he felt, what they had been through, was complicated. Except when it wasn't. Every twisted, ugly, beautiful part of their history was easily explained by that one fact. He loved him. His mother paused, just for a moment, before she resumed combing through his hair, her hands radiating warmth.

"Then, he must have been very special."

Izuku shut his eyes tight, the tears threatening to spill once more.

"Yeh. We-we kept each other alive," he continued. "R-remember when I told you I had been separated from my friends for a while? He was the one I was with."

"So he's the one I should thank, hmm?"

He felt his hair pulled back behind his head, a gentle tug as his mother cut through the mass she had collected in her hands, and immediately felt lighter.

"Yeh," he replied. "I wouldn't be here if it wasn't for him."

"Hmm, much better," Inko said, brushing more of his hair back and starting to trim it in a way that was familiar to him, despite it being years since his mother had last given him a haircut. "Did he have a name? This hero of yours?"

Izuku hesitated. Could he tell her his name? He had been sworn to secrecy, and whilst surely she would have no idea who he was talking about, it wouldn't do good for her to let it slip to one of her friends. But he didn't need to tell her his full name.

"Kacchan."

Inko stopped with a sharp intake of breath following his words and her hands fell away from his head. Izuku frowned, craning his neck over his shoulder to look at her.

"I-is everything ok?"

“O-oh, I’m fine,” she said quickly. “It’s just… well, it’s been a long time since I heard that name.”

Izuku blinked, gaping at her in confusion.

“Uh… what do you mean? When would you have heard it before?”

It was Inko’s turn to look confused then, her hands coming to rest in her lap as she looked at him.

“Well, that was what you used to call the little boy you played with, you used to follow him around everywhere when you were both small. Don’t you remember?”

Izuku’s brow furrowed, trying to think back, his cheeks heating just a touch when he realised how embarrassing it was that he might have inadvertently named Kacchan after a childhood friend he couldn’t even remember. It was certainly the kind of thing he’d be mad about, he could imagine the jealous-looking pout on his face even now.

“I don’t,” he replied honestly. “I can’t believe I used the same nickname for someone else.”

Inko watched him for a moment longer, before she started to trim his hair again, gently angling his head forward.

“I suppose you did stop playing together when you were five. I’m not sure I can remember all of my friends from when I was a child.”

“What was he like?” Izuku asked, interested, only vaguely noting that talking about something different was easing some of the tightness in his chest. “Maybe I’ll remember.”

“Oh, he was a right firecracker,” Inko said, with a laugh. “I’m sure plenty of kids didn’t really get on with him, but he brought something out of you.”

Izuku could at least understand now why he had subconsciously applied the name to Kacchan.

“He swore a lot for a boy his age,” Inko added, sounding disapproving in a way that only a mother could. “But it never seemed to rub off on you, at least. He was always knocking on our door, face and hands smudged with dirt, asking if *Deku* could come out to play.”

Izuku froze.

“What?”

“Oh, it was an awful nickname, really,” Inko replied. “I always worried that he was bullying you, but you were so happy to see him every time, and it got you out of the house and away from that computer.”

“What did he look like?”

Inko was quiet for a moment.

“He had blond hair,” she said. “Messier than yours a lot of the time. Hmm… what else? He had red

eyes, I think. Red or brown, I can't quite remember."

Izuku was trying to keep his heart from racing, fighting to keep his breathing steady. It *could* be a coincidence, after all, there had been any number of blond-haired children in the world, and what were the chances that, not only had Izuku forgotten his childhood friend, but *Kacchan* had too? But, they had grown up so close to one another… He chewed on his lip, nervously considering his options. If he said Kacchan's name then he would know for sure, but was it safe?

"Mum," he said quietly, "if I ask you something, can you promise not to mention it to anyone? Not anyone at all?"

"Of course, sweetie… what's this about?"

"The boy, my friend from back then… can you remember his name?"

"Oh, uh, shoot what was it? Bakugou? Katsuki Bakugou, I think it was."

Izuku sat up straight, his mother squeaking in alarm as she hurriedly withdraw her hands to stop herself from cutting him with the scissors.

"Izuku!"

"Tell me everything," Izuku breathed, turning on the spot and looking at her, eyes wide.

Inko looked confused. "But your hair isn't quite done-"

"Mum," he reached out, grabbing both her hands in his. "Please. I need to know."

"Baby, you're worrying me."

"Th-that's *him,* " Izuku said urgently. "They're the same Kacchan! But I don't remember him at all. How can I not remember him?"

"Are you sure?"

"Yes! Blond hair, red eyes, and every other word out of his mouth are a curse. He's even always covered in dirt!"

"Well, you knew each other since you were babies," Inko replied. "Mitsuki, his mother, was a good friend of mine, and I had you not long after Katsuki was born. So, sometimes we'd babysit for one another. The two of you saw each other all of the time."

"But why did we stop playing together?"

"Hmm, you probably don't remember, but you got very sick with glandular fever when you were five. You and Katsuki both did."

"Glandular fever?" Izuku repeated. "But… that can't be right. I had glandular fever back at university, I thought you could only get it once?"

“Usually, but I suppose there must be cases of it happening twice,” Inko replied, though she looked puzzled. “But either way, lots of kids were coming down with it at the time, some of their parents and teachers, too. It was terrible, I was so worried. You and Katsuki both ended up with hepatitis as a result, after you were hospitalised, the doctors were worried that you might have permanent liver damage.”

“L-liver damage?” Izuku repeated numbly.

“Perhaps it was the trauma of what happened,” Inko continued. “But Katsuki stopped coming by after that, and you never asked after him. The Bakugou’s moved to the other side of Ikeda not long after.”

“That’s…” Izuku shook his head, regretting the action as it began to spin and he grabbed the side of the bed to steady himself.

“Izuku! Are you ok?”

“I’m fine,” Izuku replied before he got to his feet. “I’m sorry, I-I gotta go. I need to check on something in the lab.”

“But your hair-”

“Thank you, it feels a lot better! I’ll come see you before your next shift, ok?”

“Izuku-”

Izuku pressed a quick kiss on his mother’s cheek before hurrying from the room and running down the corridor, indifferent to the noise he must have been making so early in the morning. Because this… this was it. This was fucking *it* , he was certain of it. Kacchan’s resistance to the virus and his rapid healing, Izuku’s possible immunity to the virus, all of it was related to this illness that both of them had as children. An illness that had them both forgetting huge chunks of their childhood, including knowing one another. An illness that affected their *livers* … this couldn’t be a coincidence. It just couldn’t. And all the other smart zombies, the ones they had met, had they also been infected with the same illness? His mother had said that parents and teachers had gotten sick, too, so it stood to reason that so many people in Ikeda at the time could have been infected, especially with a virus so contagious as fucking *mono.* A virus, as it so happened, that relied on human affection and intimacy to spread, no different from the one that had killed off almost the entire population of Japan.

He still had to figure out how it all connected, whether the illness that had been going around fifteen years ago was the cause, or if it simply offered those infected with it some degree of resistance. Perhaps the virus was similar? No, no that couldn’t be it. He was sure that Toshinori would have compared the zombie virus with something so common as the one responsible for mono. And, as far as Izuku was aware, mono never turned anyone into a flesh-hungry walking corpse. But Toshinori might be able to make the connection. He was the smartest man that Izuku knew. He’d know what to do, and Izuku was sure of it. And with Izuku and Kacchan both at the facility he could… he could…

Izuku found himself slowing to a halt, his eyes widening and heart hammering in anguished realisation. If he told Toshinori about this, he would also need to tell him that he suspected he had

immunity to the virus. There was no way, *no way* , that UA would be able to leave that alone. Would Izuku find himself sedated and tied to a bed, too? If Izuku was the one being tested, who would be looking after Kacchan? How could Izuku find a way to free Kacchan if both of them were trapped in the facility, labelled a danger to what was left of the human race?

As desperately as he wished he could, he couldn't trust Toshinori. He couldn't trust any of them. Not whilst they could take Kacchan's life at a moment's notice. He had to figure this out for himself, for Kacchan's sake.

"I'm going to fix this," Izuku breathed. "I *can* fix this."

Over the next week, Izuku kept his head down, dutifully following the rules and doing as Professor Toshinori and Aizawa asked of him. Toshinori hadn't been exaggerating when he said that there was a lot that he needed to fill Izuku in on, and despite Izuku's eagerness to see Kacchan again, a week wasn't even nearly enough time to catch him up. Not only did Izuku need to meet each of the nomu, and the other people working in their department, but he also needed to learn pretty sharpish how the equipment seemingly keeping Kacchan alive *worked.* Toshinori was confident that he wouldn't be relying on it once they woke him, but until then Izuku earned himself a crash course in medicine, recognising what was normal and what wasn't when it came time to check on Kacchan's vitals. Despite this placing Izuku close to Kacchan, a mask over his face and gloves on his hands as he carefully cared for him, it also quickly became his least favourite part of the day. Seeing Kacchan like this, *sponge-bathing him* , checking for crystals in the catheter and replacing his colostomy bag, felt like the ultimate betrayal on Izuku's part. Kacchan had been kept alive through sheer force of will, against his wishes, and here Izuku was, now a part of that.

He didn't know if Kacchan would ever be able to forgive him.

Meeting the other nomu was an undeniably awkward moment. Izuku couldn't help but feel fascinated by them; after all, Izuku had been so focused on what the smarter zombies were, what they meant, that meeting more besides Kacchan who wasn't actively trying to murder him, seemed surreal. There were four other nomu; three of them, curiously, about ten years older than Izuku, and one of them who Izuku guessed was only about five. It flew in the face of Izuku's theory that the illness he and Kacchan had as children had something to do with the virus, given that he would have expected to meet more nomu his age, and only made it that much more frustrating that he couldn't reach out to Toshinori for help. Regardless, he kept those thoughts to himself as he met each and introduced himself.

Real names weren't used at the facility, not for the nomu. Each of them had a nickname, a codename of sorts, that Izuku supposed was to prevent their real identities from getting leaked topside. Mirko was the first to greet him; a powerful-looking woman who gripped his hand hard enough to crush his knuckles together, confidently grinning at him all the while. Her long white hair was pulled back in a braid that reached her lower back, a belt cinching the waist of her ugly-looking jumpsuit that did little to hide the muscle beneath. Her right leg was prosthetic from the knee down, the jumpsuit rolled up to allow room for it, and her red eyes blazed with a fire that Izuku recognised all too well.

The second to introduce himself was a large man by the name of Fat. His voice was loud but welcoming, and supposedly he was unique among that nomu in that his hormone markers fluctuated far more sporadically than the rest, resulting in cycles of rapid weight loss and gain, hence his nickname.

The third, Hawks, was friendly, though more reserved than his two louder counterparts, watching Izuku carefully before it was his turn to hold out his hand. He had wild blond hair, curiously scruffy-looking eyebrows, and was the younger of the four, his nice-looking face not too heavily worn by the elements. Mirko was quick to assure Izuku that Hawks was usually much more extroverted than this, causing Hawks to sigh and rub the back of his head in a bashful sort of way.

The final, however, did not say a word to Izuku. He was a sullen-looking man, seemingly only there because he had been asked to be, eyes bloodshot and he glared at Izuku from the corner of his eye. Overhaul had lost both his arms from the elbow down, and when Izuku offered a quick bow in greeting, he had scoffed and turned his glare to Kayama, the other researcher at the facility.

“Great, I met him, can I go now?”

“Sure,” Kayama sighed, watching as Overhaul stalked back to his room, pushing down on the handle with his hip before kicking the door shut behind him.

Given the circumstances, Izuku didn’t feel like he could begrudge the man for not being as strangely jovial as Mirko and Fat were.

The number of staff at the facility was low, with only those granted the very highest clearance allowed access. Kayama and Toshinori were the two lead scientists, the former responsible for overseeing the general care and support of the four nomu. Whilst Izuku’s main job was to look after Kacchan, he was also expected to help Kayama wherever she needed. There were other researchers, usually coming and going with samples and supplies, maintaining the equipment, but rarely staying long enough for more than an exchange of names. It meant that, for the most part, Izuku was left to his own devices; the list of things that he had to do that week was long enough that he’d not had much spare time, and it sure as shit kept him from doing any research of his own. How he was going to get blood from Kacchan and each of the nomu’s to compare to his own was anyone’s guess, and his anxiety over the situation was only continuing to grow.

Eventually, the day set aside for waking Kacchan from his three-month-long coma arrived, and Izuku hadn’t slept a wink. He had ended up staying in the common area of the facility, instead of going back to his room, eyes darting to the clock above the television throughout the night. It was still only five in the morning when Kayama arrived, glasses hanging by a thread around her neck and yawning loudly as she shuffled in. Her brow rose in surprise when she saw Izuku sitting there, knees pulled to his chest on the sofa.

“You stay here all night?”

Izuku nodded. Kayama was a kind woman, if not eccentric in a way that studying zombies seemed to demand. Her curiosity seemed outmatched only by Izuku’s, and her dedication to her job was clear from the moment Izuku met her. Her dark hair was pulled up in a lazy-looking bun, her hand reaching beneath her sweater to scratch at her stomach.

“Oh, that’s right. It’s Dynamite day.”

Izuku nodded again, his face scrunching up the tiniest amount at Kacchan’s given codename. It was in poor taste, Izuku thought, even if he imagined that Kacchan might very well have seen the humour in it.

“Hey, I’m sure it’ll be fine,” Kayama said. “He’s a friend, right? One look at your sweet face he’ll calm down.”

“I wouldn’t be so sure about that,” Izuku mumbled.

“Coffee?”

“Uh… yeh, thanks.”

Kacchan had been given his final dose of sedatives late last night, and Toshinori had explained that he would begin waking up once the final dose had worn off. How long that took, was anyone’s guess; he had been sedated for far longer than was advised in any normal situation, and the risk of addiction to the drugs used was high. If Kacchan started to show signs of withdrawal, then they would have no choice but to use a short-term sedative in place of it, which could extend the process by days or even weeks. There was no guarantee that Kacchan would even wake up today, and that only added to Izuku’s anxiety.

“When are the old codgers coming by?” Kayama asked, passing Izuku a mug of steaming black coffee that he gratefully clutched to his chest.

“Soon, I guess.” He glanced at the clock again. “He was due the propofol half hour ago.”

“Yeh, waiting is never fun,” Kayama agreed. “Took Overhaul three days to wake up, and he was only induced for two weeks.”

“Well, Kacchan has always had a way of defying the odds,” Izuku said, eyes drifting to the door of the hospital room. Kayama nudged him, taking him by surprise.

“You need to get out of that habit,” she said. “And quickly. Unless you want everyone here calling him that.”

“I don’t think I can call him Dynamite,” Izuku muttered. “He’d kill me.”

He took a large gulp of the coffee, indifferent to the scalding heat, before starting to gear up for the day. Whether it took Kacchan three hours or three days, Izuku still needed to be by his side the entire time, watching his vitals and determining that when Kacchan did open his eyes, the first thing he’d see would be Izuku. He couldn’t bare the thought of Kacchan waking up in a place he didn’t recognise, entirely alone, and he wasn’t prepared to wait on Toshinori and Aizawa to finally turn up.

Kacchan was just as still and silent as ever when Izuku entered his room, ventilator and breathing tube still in place, his heart rate steady.

“How’re you feeling, Kacchan?” Izuku said into the silence. Kacchan, predictably, didn’t respond, and with a sad sigh, Izuku approached, hesitating a moment before reaching out and brushing his fingers through Kacchan’s short tufts of hair. It might take time for Kacchan to wake, but he was determined to preserve as much of his dignity as he could when that time came, and he carefully placed the fresh hospital gown he had brought beside him on the bed.

By the time Toshinori arrived, Izuku had already removed the catheter and cleaned and dressed the incision sites, and was in the process of putting on the gown, rolling Kacchan's body to the side so that he could tie it shut. He looked over his shoulder when the door to the hospital room opened, his mentor poking his head through.

"How is he doing, Young Midoriya?" Toshinori asked, voice full of warmth. His Professor had been especially gentle around him since Izuku had first found out about Kacchan's condition. It left Izuku feeling guilty, in more ways than one. He *knew* Toshinori was trying, that he felt genuine remorse for how things had gone, and he wanted to forgive him for it, for all of it. But Izuku still had no idea who he could trust.

"Still out," Izuku replied, as he eased Kacchan onto his back again. There had been no change to his vitals, no indication that he was regaining consciousness any time soon. "But it's probably only been a little bit over an hour since he was due the propofol."

Toshinori nodded, before entering the room. Now that Kacchan was all but recovered from the induced liver failure, there was no need for masks in the room anymore, so Izuku could see the soft smile on his mentor's face.

"These things can take time," he said. "The important thing is not to rush it, he's going to be confused enough as it is when he finally wakes up."

Izuku nodded, looking back down at Kacchan's scarred and sleeping face.

"Are you worried?" Toshinori asked.

Izuku nodded. "I have no idea how he's going to react when he wakes up," he said. "What- what if he hates me?"

"I would highly doubt that," Toshinori replied. "He's your friend, after all."

That's the problem , Izuku thought.

It was another four hours before Kacchan started to stir. At first, Izuku thought he imagined it, but when the fingers on Kacchan's right hand flexed a second time, he sat up straight, looking up at Kacchan's face half expecting to see him looking right back at him.

"He moved!" Izuku called Toshinori.

Kacchan fell still again and Izuku got to his feet, reaching for the breathing tube still taped to his face.

"You think I'm ok to remove this now?" he asked. Toshinori nodded before he too got to his feet.

"I'll bring Aizawa and Kayama."

Carefully, holding Kacchan's mouth open with one hand, Izuku began to remove the tube, praying that Kacchan wasn't conscious enough to react to it, breathing out a sigh of relief when the most that happened was Kacchan's throat bobbing as he swallowed reflexively. Aizawa and Kayama were in the room not a few minutes later.

“You’re sure he’s waking up?” Aizawa asked, coming over and looking at the reading on the heart monitor. In response, Kacchan’s fingers twitched again, movement beneath his eyelids as he started to stir. “Ok, restrain his arms and legs. Better safe than sorry.”

“I don’t think-”

“Midoriya,” Aizawa said firmly, pulling at the leather straps at the base of the bed. “I’ll remind you he was final stage when we brought him in. This is just a precaution.”

Izuku swallowed, feeling sick at the thought of Kacchan waking up restrained, but he took each of his wrists and tightened the buckles around them, keeping his arms flush with the bed.

A tense twenty minutes followed, where Kacchan’s hands or legs would twitch, his breathing no longer as steady as it had once been as his body fought for consciousness. Izuku stayed at his side the entire time, holding onto Kacchan’s hand and stroking his thumb across the back of it. Then, at long last, Kacchan’s eyes opened.

At first, it was entirely uneventful. Kacchan stared blankly up at the ceiling, blinking slowly like he wasn’t entirely conscious just yet. Izuku got to his feet, leaning forward so that he could look down at him.

“Kacchan, can you hear me?”

Kacchan blinked again, gaze slowly drifting to Izuku’s face.

“De-ku. Y’big ‘gain-”

“Shh, try not to talk,” Izuku said gently, not sure what Kacchan was talking about, and sure the beating of his heart could be heard by everyone in the room. There was an aching kind of joy rising in his chest, hope tentatively blooming as Kacchan’s unfocused eyes trailed over his face, lingering at his cheeks. “Your throat is going to be sore.”

Kacchan didn’t reply and his brow furrowed slightly. It was only when Izuku’s vision started to blur that he realised he was crying again, slow silent tears gathering in the corners of his eyes.

“W’you cryin’?” Kacchan mumbled, voice hoarse and words slurred from the after-effects of the sedatives. His arm seemed to jolt suddenly, Izuku realising that he had tried to raise his hand. He saw the confusion grow on Kacchan’s face as he tried to move his arm again, looking away from Izuku’s face and down to his side.

“Wha-”

“It’s ok,” Izuku said quickly, watching as Kacchan’s gaze become suddenly more focused and he began to wrench his arms up harder, worried that it may send Kacchan into a panic.

“Wha’s goin’ on?” Kacchan tugged again, eyes darting up and around him before he finally saw that there were others in the room with them, his body freezing.

“You’re safe, Kacchan,” Izuku said urgently. “I promise. They’re friends, ok? No one is going to

hurt you."

But Kacchan was staring at Aizawa now. His eyes were wide, hands curling into fists under their binds, and the monitor betrayed just how fast his heart was now beating.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, trying to capture his attention once more and taking one of his hands. "I need you to calm down." But, when Kacchan finally did look back at him, the confusion that had once been in his eyes was now gone, replaced instead by what could only be described as devastation.

" *Deku?* "

He sounded so small… His head shook back and forth, staring at Izuku like he was a stranger to him. Izuku reached out desperately, his knuckles tracing Kacchan's cheek.

"It isn't what you think," he said. "I'll explain everything, ok?"

"Midoriya, his heart rate is too fast," Aizawa warned. But that seemed to break the spell over Kacchan as he flinched, his eyes hardening.

"Lemme go."

"Ok," Izuku said, nodding. "Ok, take a deep breath for me. I'll undo-"

"We can't do that," Aizawa said. "It's too risky."

"Lemme *go* ."

"I- I can't. Kacchan, please, deep breaths-"

"Get away from me!"

Izuku winced as Kacchan reared back, pulling out of reach of Izuku's hand and yanking so hard at his restraints that the bed rocked for a moment.

"Shit, he's going to hurt himself," Aizawa said. "Kayama?"

"On it."

Izuku saw movement to his left, and looked around as Kayama grabbed a bottle and a syringe, her tongue between her teeth as she began to draw up the clear fluid. Panic rose in Izuku's chest. They were going to try and sedate him *again.*

"You don't have to do that!" he said quickly, before turning back to Kacchan. "Kacchan, I promise I'll explain everything, but you need to calm down. They're here to help you-"

"Fuck you!" Kacchan was frantic now, angry, hurt tears streaming down his cheeks, tugging hard enough that the leather straps had begun to stretch. "Y-you *bastard.* You l-lyin' piece o' sh-shit. Lemme go. Fu-fuck, let me go!"

Kacchan was beginning to hyperventilate, the heart monitors all but screaming in the background.

“We have to sedate him before he breaks his damn wrists.”

“No!” Izuku protested. “Just wait, please, give me a moment to- *Kacchan* -”

“Get the hell off me!” Kacchan all but screaming, recoiling and rocking the bed again. Kayama swore and ran to his other side, syringe in hand. But, as she touched Kacchan’s arm he swung around, lunging and snarling like a cornered animal, and Kayama screamed in shock as blunt teeth snapped shut an inch from her fingertips.

“Fuck,” Aizawa swore, stepping forward now. “Shut this down. Shut it down right now.”

“Lemme go!” Kacchan howled, expression crazed before, with one final hard tug, the buckles around the left binding snapped, a piece of metal hitting Izuku in the face with a sharp sting, and Kacchan’s left arm was free. He didn’t waste a moment, reaching around and grappling with the buckle keeping his right hand tied to the bed.

“Toshinori!”

Izuku was pushed back roughly, his back colliding with the wall, staring in shock as Toshinori and Aizawa launched themselves at Kacchan. Toshinori grabbed his left arm, yanking it towards his chest, and Aizawa wrapped his elbow around Kacchan’s throat so that he couldn’t reach anyone with his snapping and snarling teeth.

“Do it, now!” Aizawa yelled.

“LEMME GO! I’LL KILL YOU!”

Kayama stuck Kacchan with the needle, bucking hard in their grasp as he tried to break free, shouting and screaming for a few moments longer before he began to slow, the sedative taking effect. It was only after his eyes drifted shut and he stopped moving completely that Aizawa dared to let go, breathing hard.

“Damn,” Kayama whistled, pushing her hair back from her eyes. “That could have gone better.”

Izuku stood with his palms flat against the wall, his entire body shaking in shock. He knew there was a chance that Kacchan wouldn’t have handled this well, that he might have been angry and violent, but this was far worse than Izuku could have imagined. Kacchan wasn’t just angry, he was confused and *terrified* . The look in his eyes when he realised that Izuku was one of the people doing this to him burned into his skull. He grabbed his chest, biting back the sobs, gasping for breath.

“We’re done,” Aizawa said, looking angry and disappointed. “Kayama, did he get you?”

“No, I’m ok.”

“Aizawa-”

“ *Don’t* ,” Aizawa said firmly, voice low and dangerous as he turned to glare at Toshinori. “Do not

tell me we'll try again."

Izuku looked up in horror. "What?"

"He tried to *bite* Kayama." Aizawa was breathing hard, and far less composed than Izuku could ever remember seeing him. "You know what would have happened if he had managed to?"

"But we can't leave him like this!"

"We are not waking him up again."

"Aizawa," Toshinori said, palms held forward. "He's too important, we can't just give up."

"And the next time we wake him up he kills someone, what then?" Aizawa shot back. "No. He is too far gone. I won't take the risk."

"You can't just keep him sedated forever!" Izuku yelled. "He was scared! He was just scared and angry and I- that I've… we have to try again."

"Restart the propofol when it's safe," Aizawa said shortly, no longer looking at him. "I have to speak with Shigaraki."

Aizawa stormed from the room, Kayama pausing just long enough to offer Izuku a sympathetic smile before she followed, leaving Izuku alone once more with Kacchan and Toshinori. He covered his mouth, hands shaking as he looked at the man lying on the hospital bed, arm still flung over the side and the sheets kicked up around him.

"I'm sorry, Midoriya," Toshinori said, placing a hand on his shoulder.

"He wasn't gone," Izuku breathed urgently. "When he woke up he was still himself. He was fine until he realised he was tied up!"

"That may be the case but he has shown just how dangerous he is," Toshinori replied. "Let me talk to Aizawa and Shigaraki, ok? There might still be more than we can do to protect ourselves so that he doesn't need to stay sedated. It just may take some time."

Izuku nodded, taking an unsteady step towards the bed before reaching for Kacchan's hand.

"Come on, let's get him comfortable again, shall we?"

Izuku knew that he couldn't blame Aizawa for being cautious; none of them knew Kacchan. They didn't know how much goodness lay beneath his volatile exterior. But Kacchan's reaction had surprised even him, and the ferocity with which he had fought to break free had been little short of terrifying to witness. And yet, how else was Kacchan supposed to react to waking and finding himself restrained like that? It might have been three months for Izuku, but for Kacchan the explosion at the stadium would have felt like yesterday, and he couldn't imagine the amount of fear and pain Kacchan had been in whilst he had laid beneath the rubble. He just… Kacchan needed *time* . He needed time to adjust, and if Aizawa had it his way then Kacchan would never get the chance. But Izuku refused to give up just like that, no matter how bleaks things seemed.

He would get Kacchan out of this place.

After a while, Toshinori took his leave to give Izuku some time alone with his friend. Before leaving, he reminded Izuku that he would shortly need the second dose of sedative and if he had the energy to care he might have been offended by that. As if his Professor didn't trust him not to deliberately skip the dosage. But, he was far beyond caring what anyone thought of him at this point.

He didn't know what he could do. A desperate part of him was mapping his way out of UA as if he could break Kacchan free before Toshinori returned. But, despite his show of strength earlier, Kacchan was still recovering from his ordeal at the stadium, not to mention the three months in which he hadn't used his damn legs. There was no guarantee that Kacchan would be able to walk even if he wanted to. He took a deep breath, leaning forward in the chair at Kacchan's bedside, holding his left hand in both of his as he watched him sleep. After a while his eyes and limbs grew heavy, the exhaustion of the last twenty-four hours finally starting to catch up on him.

He was jolted awake sometime later by the sound of loud voices. Aizawa could be heard from the common area, his words muggled but his tone frustrated and Izuku frowned, carefully releasing Kacchan's hand and getting to his feet. He had only managed a few tentative steps towards the door before he heard another voice, one that he didn't recognise, and froze. Was it possible it was him? Was that Shigaraki?

He didn't have to wonder for long. The door to the hospital room opened, Izuku left standing there like a fish out of water as a man as tall as Toshinori but three times as wide stepped in, vivid red eyes pinning him to the spot. He looked Izuku up and down, a soft yet decidedly ungentle smile on his lips as he cocked his head back on his muscled neck. This man looked like he could easily snap Izuku's body over his knee and he found himself thinking of Mr Zombig… The calculated, *cruel* way the zombie had looked at him before it had deliberately begun to dig its thumb into his eye was all too frightfully paralleled with the way this man stared him down.

"You must be Izuku Midoriya."

Aizawa and Toshinori came in after him, the latter looking nervous and the former all but steaming from the ears, a vein pulsing angrily on his temple.

"Y-yes," Izuku replied, willing for his voice box to cooperate.

"Well, it's good to finally meet you, Midoriya. My name is Shigaraki."

Izuku swallowed. "G-good to meet you, too."

With his red eyes and neatly styled white hair, it wasn't hard to see the resemblance between this Shigaraki and the one that had hunted them for months. Izuku no longer had any doubts that the two were related. But, whereas *that* Shigaraki had been slight and boney, *this* one hardly looked like there had been a famine at all.

"When will the sedatives wear off?" Shigaraki asked, looking away from Izuku to address Toshinori.

"Unless Young Midoriya has already given him the second dose, I would say maybe an hour.

Perhaps two."

"That's too long," Shigaraki said. "Wake him now."

"But that could have severe side-effects," Toshinori reasoned. "He could have a seizure."

"I seriously doubt that," Shigaraki replied with a laugh, the sound sending chills down Izuku's spine.

"What's going on?" Izuku asked. Shigaraki glanced over, almost as if he had forgotten entirely that Izuku was in the room, and smiled again.

"Aizawa told me that you had some issues with the nomu the last time you woke it up," he said, Izuku's gut churning at the use of *'it'* to describe Kacchan. "He wants to keep it sedated, but that doesn't really work for me. It probably doesn't work for you either, does it?"

Izuku looked at Aizawa but there was a sharp snap, Izuku realised that Shigaraki had clicked his finger to get his attention. A simmering hot feeling ran through him.

"You don't need to ask him for permission to speak your mind," Shigaraki said.

Aizawa glowered. "This is a bad idea. You didn't see what happened last time."

"From what I understand, the nomu was fine before it realised it was restrained." Shigaraki shrugged. "We try again. No restrains. If he acts out again, I guarantee I can handle it."

"Handle it *how* ?" Izuku exclaimed, alarmed. Shigaraki didn't reply.

"Reverse it. Now, please."

Toshinori sighed before he started to dig through the medication cabinet and prepare a syringe.

"You're not going to hurt him, are you?" Izuku demanded, frustrated at the giant of a man ignoring him. "If you do-"

"As much as I'd love to hear the end of that threat, I have no intention of hurting the nomu," Shigaraki interrupted. "It's much more useful to me in one piece."

Toshinori approached with the syringe, rotating Kacchan's right arm and pressing the needle into the soft flesh of his inner elbow. "You best move back, Young Midoriya," he said softly. Izuku shook his head.

"No, he needs to see me first."

Aizawa huffed in exasperation. "When this goes wrong don't tell me I didn't warn you."

"Duly noted," Shigaraki replied, with another laugh.

Kacchan's rise to consciousness was far quicker this time; there was still the same look of foggy confusion on his face as he tried to focus on the room around him, but when his gaze met Izuku's

this time, his expression hardened immediately.

"Deku."

"Kacchan, I'm so sorry," Izuku breathed. "Please, just take a moment before you freak out, ok?"

But the moment Kacchan realised that his arms and legs weren't bound, he pushed himself up, face agitated as he looked up at the three other men in the room watching him.

"Ah, you're awake. That's better."

Kacchan didn't waste a second, grabbing the edge of the bed and hauling himself forward. But it had been three months since he had last walked, and the moment he tried to stand his legs buckled beneath him, Kacchan grunting in pain as he fell.

"Kacchan!"

Izuku hurried forward, ready to support him, but Kacchan recoiled, swiping out furiously as he clutched the edge of the bed.

"Get the hell away from me!"

Izuku hesitated, watching his jaw tense as he tried to haul himself back to his feet, knees shaking violently from the effort.

"You're going to hurt yourself! Just let me help-"

"I don't want your fucking help!" Kacchan spat. Izuku watched helplessly as Kacchan miraculously pulled himself up, unsteady on his weak legs but still standing, dark glare fixed on the men ahead of him.

"This has gone too far," Aizawa said, stepping forward just as Kacchan began to make his wobbly way away from the bed, but Shigaraki thrust an arm out to stop him.

"It's fine. Let him go."

"What?"

Izuku felt sick. Shigaraki was playing with him, he knew it and he knew Kacchan knew it too, hunched over like a starving wolf, eying the door like it were a poisoned piece of meat. Still, he took his chance, shuffling forward and ignoring Izuku's pleas for him to be careful, before grabbing the handle of the door and tugging on it. The door was locked, only opened by a keycard, and yet Kacchan still tried, furiously shaking the handle, a low growl leaving his throat.

"Let me out."

"I just want to talk," Shigaraki said.

"Fuck you. I don't give a shit what you have'ta say. Let. Me. *Out.* "

“No.”

Kacchan snarled, eyes flashing dangerously before he threw himself at Shigaraki, indifferent to the fact that the man was three times his size and standing with a smile on his face. It ended in a heartbeat, a wet choking sound filling the room before Izuku could do so much as blink. Shigaraki stood with one large hand around Kacchan’s throat, lifting him in the air. Kacchan’s legs kicked, eyes wide and confused, and Izuku was running, pulling a fist back ready to punch this asshole in whatever part of him he could reach.

“Let him go!”

Aizawa collided with him, grabbing him about the waist and heaving him back.

“You’re not gonna win that, kid,” he said, grunting with the effort of holding Izuku back this time as he kicked and punched with all he had.

“You’re hurting him! Let him go!”

And Shigaraki did, dropping Kacchan to the ground with a cry. His legs buckled once more and he grabbed at his throat and heaved, yellow bile gushing out over his knees.

“Kacchan!”

“So, you’ve given breaking down the door a shot. Tried me on to boot, both without any success,” Shigaraki said, almost jovially. “Are you perhaps willing to listen to me now?”

“F-fuck you,” Kacchan wheezed.

“Aren’t you even a little curious about where you are?”

“I know where I am!” Kacchan sounded awful, his throat torn and ragged by the breathing tube and being choked out, but he spoke with the same fire he always did, glaring at Shigaraki through watery eyes. “And I ain’t helping you. So you can fucking forget it!”

“It’s not really up to you.”

Shigaraki took a step closer to Kacchan, and Izuku struggled harder.

“Stay away from him!”

“I don’t need your fucking help, Deku!” Kacchan yelled, sounding almost hysterical. “I know what you want! I know what you’re after, what you fuckers are doing here. You ain’t using *me.* I won’t do a thing you ask! So you might as well kill me now.”

Shigaraki looked genuinely put out for a moment, his brow furrowed as he ran his hands through his hair in obvious frustration. Then, he looked at Izuku, seeming to stare through him for a moment, tongue running over his teeth before he threw both hands into the air.

“Fine! I know a lost cause when I see one. I’m not happy that you’re forcing me to get this ugly though, you should know this.”

Kacchan seemed to stop breathing for a moment, his anger abating as he looked hurriedly between Shigaraki and Izuku.

“Oh, I know what you’re thinking,” Shigaraki said, smiling with genuine delight. “But, I actually *need* Midoriya for the moment. Just like I need you. What I don’t need are, ah…” He paused, reaching into his back pocket and pulling out a notebook. He flicked through the first few pages, everyone in the room watching tensely before Shigaraki seemed to find what he was looking for.

“Midoriya Inko,” he said, with some satisfaction, looking over at Izuku. He felt his blood run cold. “Your mother, right?”

“Shigaraki, this is taking things too far,” Toshinori said immediately.

“Not yet it isn’t.” Shigaraki cleared his throat, looking back at the notebook. “Kaminari Denki, interesting name. Then we have Todoroki Shouto. Son of Todoroki Enji, I’m guessing? A fine policeman, reliable to bribe I heard. Who else? Ah, Hagakure Toru, Yaoyorozu Momo, Kirishima Eijirou and-” he flipped to the next page of the notebook. “Ah, Ashido Mina. Two months pregnant, I believe?”

“Don’t,” Izuku choked, shivering in Aizawa’s arms.

Kacchan didn’t say a word, his entire body shaking, doing nothing to hide the misery and agony on his face.

“Whilst I need the both of you, I can probably make do without the rest. Inko’s a fair nurse, so I may have to weigh out the pros and cons with that one, but the others are arguably already a drawing on our limited resources. The pregnant girl, most of all.”

“Bastard,” Kacchan managed weakly.

“I would rather that you hadn’t reacted like that,” Shigaraki said, snapping the notebook shut. “I don’t enjoy threatening anyone, and it puts me in a pretty bad light. But, there is far more at stake than you seem to realise, nomu. What’s the life of six extras when compared to the entire human race?” He smiled broadly again. “So, here’s the deal. You co-operate. I’m sure it sucks terribly to be in your situation but perhaps you could consider being a little less selfish? Most people would *kill* for their lives to be even a fraction as valuable as yours.”

Kacchan’s face was contorted in rage, his upper lip curling and hatred in his eyes.

“Every day that you refuse, I’ll have one of your friends removed from the facility. Starting with the pregnant girl. It isn’t like we’re asking for much, and I’m sure in time you’ll come to appreciate the valuable work we’re doing here.”

“The *value* ?” Kacchan spat. “You’re creating a fucking army, not a cure!”

“That isn’t what we’re doing here at all!” Toshinori said suddenly, palms forward. “We’ve only ever been working towards stopping the virus.”

“So *he* tells you.”

Shigaraki grinned. Izuku saw Toshinori and Aizawa exchange tense looks before the larger man clapped his hands together, the sound loud enough to make all of them jump.

“Well, I think that’s settled. Aizawa, you can let Midoriya go now.”

Aizawa hesitated for a moment before he released his grip around Izuku’s waist.

“I have to get back to work,” Shigaraki said. “Oh, Toshi I wanted a word with you about something if now’s a good time? I had some thoughts on some of the results from last week's batch.”

Shigaraki stepped past where Kacchan was still kneeling on the floor, removing the keycard from his pocket and unlocking the door. Toshinori hesitated, looking from Kacchan to Izuku before Aizawa nodded.

“I got this, go on.”

Toshinori followed Shigaraki from the room, the latter not even sparing Izuku or the others a glance as he left, the three of them now alone in the room.

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathed, hurrying forward. “Let me help you.”

“Get away from me!” Kacchan spat, slapping his hand away.

“But, Kacchan-”

“No! Get out! Get the fuck out!”

Kacchan was shaking all over, his scarred face contorted, lips trembling furiously, and Izuku’s arms fell uselessly to their side.

“Midoriya, I think it is a good idea if you leave for now.”

Izuku felt like he had been submerged in ocean water, swaying on the spot as the pressure of it all crushed his lungs. Kacchan wouldn’t look at him, staring down at the vomit on his knees, his breaths coming out in ragged pants, and Izuku couldn’t imagine leaving him right now. Like *this* .

“I *can’t* ,” Izuku managed, shaking his head. “Kacchan, you’re *hurt* -”

“And who’s fucking fault is that, huh?” Kacchan screamed, finally turning to face him. “I don’t *want you here!* I want you gone! Get out! Get out get the fuck out get OUT!”

Tears were rolling down Kacchan’s cheeks, the sheer amount of grief in his eyes tearing a hole through Izuku’s chest when he realised that Kacchan saw Izuku as the cause of his pain. He took a deep breath, hitching part way, and nodded.

“Ok. Ok, Kacchan.”

His legs almost gave out on *him* as he began to walk to the door, clumsily pressing the keycard

against the lock, and stumbling out of the room, only just making it through the door before he fell to the ground, burying his face in his arm to muffle his scream.

Chapter End Notes

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#deadicationtwt

Chapter 41: A Brain of Truth

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku and Kacchan finally talk.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku went twelve hours before finally seeing Kacchan again.

Twelve hours , but to Izuku that could have been a lifetime. He refused to leave the common area the entire time; sitting on the couch or pacing back and forth, watching Aizawa and Kayama as they bustled in and out of Kacchan's hospital room, ignoring him when he asked if Kacchan was ok. His heart rate spiked each time the door opened, eyes darting with pinpoint precision as if expecting to see Kacchan standing there. But he saw, and he heard *nothing* . No raised voices, no yelling or threats… either Kacchan was sedated or he was cooperating, and he wasn't sure which of those two options made him more nervous.

Izuku was no stranger to drowning. He felt like he had been doing it for two whole years; some days dragging him to the ocean floor and making it that much harder to kick his way back to the surface so that he could take in a lungful of harsh, frigid air before he was submerged again. Not knowing what he was feeling, why he was feeling, and how he could make it *stop* was his new normal, but he was sure that he had often felt as conflicted as he did in those twelve hours.

Because, ultimately, Kachan wasn't the only one who felt betrayed. The hatred that had boiled in watery red eyes as the accusations were screamed into Izuku's face demanded a person far strong than himself to push away without leaving a scar. The two of them had been through so much, *together* , but at that moment, it was like none of it even mattered. Kacchan hadn't even seemed to consider any of it. And yet, despite the hurt, Izuku wouldn't be Izuku if he wasn't also thinking about how Kacchan must have felt… If *Izuku* was afraid, then it was nothing compared to the thoughts that must have been running through Kacchan's head. Shigaraki, that *bastard* , had barely introduced himself before threatening their friends - their *family* - with exile, and Izuku's face was the only one that Kacchan recognised. He had been the only direction to which he could aim his grief, and Izuku had taken it. But it didn't change the fact that, after all this time together, Kacchan hadn't any faith to offer him.

Despite his insistence that he didn't need any rest, it was only after he began to nod off on the couch that he heard someone gently calling to him. He started, confused for a moment as he always was when he woke up to half his vision so obscured, before finally seeing Aizawa standing over him. Izuku, honestly, wasn't sure why the man was still here; he worked security, or so he said, and yet he seemed to spend far more time down here with the researchers than he did anywhere else. As Izuku blinked up at him, he fancied that there was something in those dark eyes, something beyond the stoic indifference that had become more commonplace, that reminded him of the person his teacher had once been to him. Outside of his mother, there had once been few people that he

genuinely felt like he could trust, and knowing Aizawa was no longer one of them sent a shot of longing through his chest that he thought he had long outgrown.

“Mr Aizawa?”

Aizawa’s face twitched like he was going to correct him before he thought better of it.

“He wants to see you.”

Izuku was on his feet in an instant, no longer foggy and heavy with sleep, disentangling himself from the blanket he had wrapped around his shoulders.

“Not so fast,” Aizawa said, grabbing Izuku’s wrist. “There are some ground rules to cover first.”

Izuku tugged half-heartedly, eyes daring towards the hospital room before he turned his gaze back to Aizawa.

“He has been docile and cooperative since Shigaraki left,” Aizawa explained. “And whilst I have no real reason to suspect they would do anything considering what you’ve both been threatened with, he was still especially volatile towards you. Honestly, I am more worried about him hurting himself than you at this stage, so if he starts to appear stressed I expect you to remove yourself from the situation. For his sake.”

“I-” Izuku hesitated, not sure what to say to that. “I wouldn’t do *anything* to hurt him!”

“I’m serious, Midoriya. It was my opinion that you shouldn’t have any future interactions with him. But, considering there is only one way for Shigaraki to be certain you don’t remember anything that happened here, I’m willing to give you a chance. You get what I’m saying, don’t you, kid?”

Izuku stared back at Aizawa, and there it was again… *something* beneath the harsh angle of his brow and the heavy bags under his eyes. Sentimental in a way that Izuku was far too cautious to place.

“He’ll have me killed.”

Aizawa’s throat bobbed, the only indication that he had been affected by Izuku’s statement. He nodded.

“No one knows what happens down here,” he said firmly. “Your friend is right about one thing. There is more going on than first meets the eye.”

Izuku’s breath hitched. “Are you… are you saying that it’s true? Shigaraki is creating an army?”

Aizawa frowned before he reached out and sharply turned Izuku about to face the hospital door.

“You have fifteen minutes and I’m coming in. I’ll be outside, so assume that anything you say I can hear. Got it?”

Izuku nodded, puzzling over Aizawa’s words and the shiver that ran down his spine following them as he allowed himself to be pushed towards the door. He hesitated just a moment, before reaching

into his pocket and swiping his keycard over the pad, the door unlocking with a loud *click* .

It was bright inside the hospital room, the atmosphere entirely different now that all the lights were lit and there was no longer the humbling sound of a heart monitor. The room had felt bigger then, colder, and all those dark anxieties faded to the background once Izuku's eyes fell on the man sitting upright in his hospital bed, expression decidedly guarded as he appraised him.

At first, neither of them spoke. Izuku kept his distance and Kacchan looked smaller and more unsure than Izuku could remember seeing him. It brought yet more pain to Izuku's chest, his lower lip already trembling and the corners of his eyes starting to itch.

"You cut your hair."

Kacchan's first words to him since his hurtful, desperate accusations came out rough; his voice was haggard from chronic disuse followed by rapid overuse, and left him sounding much more vulnerable than Izuku could stand. He reached up distractedly, fingers pulling the shorter curls at the back of his head.

"Yeh."

Kacchan continued to look at him. In the new light of the room, with his eyes no longer darkened by anger and confusion, Izuku realised that the iris of his right eye was a milky pink, the Apocalypse so eager to blind and mark them both.

"I need an explanation."

It wasn't a demand. In anything else, the words sounded like more of a plea and Izuku bit his lip and gestured to the chair beside Kacchan's bed.

"Can I sit?"

Kacchan nodded stiffly. Izuku hated how wobbly his legs felt over the short distance from the door to Kacchan's bedside, sure that he wouldn't miss the way his hands shook at his sides before he gently slipped them into the pockets of the jumpsuit he had been wearing for the last three days. Kacchan didn't say a word as Izuku sat down, and his eyes drifted perhaps out of habit to the hand lying flat at Kacchan's side, the same hand that he had clung to as he waited for Kacchan to wake up finally. He felt the weight of Kacchan's gaze before he hesitantly stumbled for words.

"I thought you were dead," he said, almost breathlessly. "I had no idea that… If I had I- I would have come sooner. I promise I would."

"It really wasn't you?"

"I'd *never* do that to you, Kacchan."

Kacchan seemed to deflate then, his torso crumpling and his head dropping into his palms, his right arm wrapped with fresh bandages up to his shoulder.

"Shit," he choked, and Izuku scooted forward, alarmed.

“Kacchan?”

Izuku placed a hand on Kacchan’s shoulder, eyes flicking over his entire body as he tried to assess why Kacchan was in pain.

“Fuck.”

Kacchan’s voice sounded wet, and sure enough, tears began to bubble over his palms, dropping steadily down onto his lap. Any hesitation and doubt Izuku felt were gone in an instant, and he climbed onto the bed, positioning himself behind Kachan and wrapping his arms around his body. Kacchan immediately slumped backwards, curling into him, replacing his hands with the fabric over Izuku’s chest as he began to shake with the force of his sobs.

“Shh, hey it’s ok,” Izuku breathed.

“I’m sorry,” Kacchan choked into his shoulder. “I- I shouldn’ta-”

“It’s *ok* ,” Izuku repeated, raising a hand and brushing it through the short tufts of hair over Kacchan’s head. “I understand, it’s ok.”

Kacchan continued to cling to him for a while longer, Izuku rubbing his arms, his shoulder, lips pressing against the top of his head and breathing in the gentle, smoky scent that his heart had mourned for. Kacchan was warm, firm, *solid* in his grasp, if not unbearably smaller than he had once been, the sharp angle of his hip bones digging into Izuku’s thigh. When Kacchan eventually pulled away he hurriedly wiped at his cheeks, wincing as his wrist dragged over the scars beneath his right eye.

“Fuck,” he repeated, voice still thick. “Bet you were glad to be shot of my crybaby ass, huh?”

Every day without you I died a little more.

“Not even close.”

Kacchan sighed, swearing under his breath again, angling his blotchy face and bloodshot eyes away so that he could have a moment to compose himself.

“So,” Kacchan said finally, sniffing and shifting so that he could easily look Izuku in the eye. “What actually happened? That dog-eyed bastard won’t tell me shit.”

“Do- do you remember *anything* ? From after the explosion?”

Kacchan grimaced.

“Yeh,” he said, not offering any elaboration. But Izuku didn’t need to press him for it; Aizawa had already told him how badly he had been injured, and he was certain those were memories he wouldn’t be in any hurry to revisit.

“I guess they must have investigated the stadium after the explosion and found you,” Izuku said. Kacchan was no longer resting against his chest, but his warm weight was still comforting between his thighs. “Aizawa brought you back here but your injuries were so bad they had to keep you

sedated until now."

Kacchan's left hand drifted down to his stomach, his body tensing.

"How long have I been here?"

"Three months."

Kacchan took a deep shaky breath. "And… how long have you known?"

"A little over a week."

"Fuck."

"No one else knows you're here," Izuku breathed. "They won't let me tell anyone."

"And are they… Kaminari?"

"They're all here," Izuku replied softly. "Kaminari he- well, he took it hard after what happened. I think maybe he blamed himself for a lot of it but… he's doing ok."

"And Mina? Is she really..?"

"Nm, yeh," Izuku said, with a nod and the smallest of smiles.

"Fucking idiots," Kacchan said, sounding more like himself for a moment. "We managed t'fuck without turning you into a zombie, but they couldn't keep that shit wrapped up properly? Damn, morons!"

Izuku stiffened, Kacchan's words twisting something in his gut as he was reminded of exactly *why* it was that Izuku had been so lucky as to not find his ass turned in the months they had been intimate with one another. Kacchan, for all his months in a coma, was still sharp as ever and he noticed Izuku's change in posture immediately, twisting back to look at him with eyes narrowed in scrutiny.

" *What-* "

Izuku shook his head furiously, looking pointedly at the door.

Not here. He's listening.

Kacchan's eyes searched his, infinitely curious and frustrated before he relented with a grunt.

"They happy about it at least?"

"Yeh, I-" Izuku hesitated, realising that he had *no* idea how Mina and Kirishima felt. Despite his promises to Shouto, he hadn't even seen them yet. He hadn't seen any of his friends for almost two whole weeks. Kacchan scowled.

"You don't know."

“Huh? No, that’s not it! Shouto told me they seemed happy-”

“ *Princess told you?* ”

“Kacchan, you’re being mean-”

“Why don’t you know yourself? The *fuck* , Deku, don’t tell me you spent these whole three fucking months moping about?”

“I wasn’t *moping,* I was working!” Izuku protested.

“So, you been avoiding them, then.”

“Kacchan, it-” Izuku swallowed, averting his eyes. “It’s been hard.”

“You idiot,” Kacchan said shortly. “You fucking dummy.”

“ *Kacchan?* ”

“You know I was fucking serious when I told you to live your life, right? What good was my heroic fucking sacrifice if you didn’t make something of it, hah? You goddamn asshole, I should kick your ass!”

“In my defence, getting over you isn’t easy,” Izuku pouted. “You ever tried it? The world kinda sucks without you.”

Kacchan huffed, his ears turning pink even as he tried to maintain his anger.

“Well, whatever. Now you know I been dragged kicking and screaming from the fucking grave *again* you can take some time to connect, yeh? Shit, Deku, the one fucking thing I asked was for you to look out for them.”

“And I have been,” Izuku protested, frowning. “Why do you think I’ve been working so hard? Why I agreed to help them here before I even knew you were what they wanted help with? I’ve been trying to find *answers* , Kacchan.”

Izuku raised his eyebrows, staring at him and hoping that he was picking up what he was laying down. Kacchan’s face shifted, and he lowered his voice, leaning closer so that only Izuku could hear him.

“And have you?”

Izuku nodded. Kacchan’s eyes searched his face for a moment before he leaned back.

“Well, you’re still an idiot,” he announced, voice deliberately louder than it had been. “And given my ass is probably stuck here for a while, you’re gonna spend some time with those friends we both almost died for like a hundred fucking times. You got it?”

“Yes, Kacchan,” Izuku sighed.

Kacchan rolled his shoulder, stretching his back with a series of pops, before releasing a puff of air and eying Izuku curiously.

“Say, we knew each other as kids, right?”

Izuku’s eyes widened in surprise. “What, how did you know that?”

“The *fuck* ? Why didn’t you bring it up sooner? I had these… I dunno, memories, dreams, whatever when I was in the stadium.”

“I didn’t know,” Izuku replied urgently. “I had no idea until my mum told me-”

There was a sharp click, Izuku and Kacchan both looked up to see Aizawa stepping into the room, hands in the pocket of his jumpsuit and looking as tired as ever. He paused when he saw the two of them sitting on the bed together, before sighing and kicking the door shut behind him.

“You might want to try being less obvious,” he said bluntly.

Izuku flushed, but Kacchan had stiffened between his legs, body tense as he glared in Aizawa’s direction.

“And why’s that, hah?” he asked.

Aizawa dragged his lower lip through his teeth, eyes looking back at the door a long moment before he turned back to them and started to walk closer, stopping only when he was at the foot of the bed, appraising them seriously.

“Because people will start to ask questions. Specifically, they will start to ask questions about *Midoriya.* ”

“What kinda questions?” Kacchan demanded.

Izuku swore that Aizawa muttered a *‘fuck me’* under his breath before he grabbed the back of the chair beside the bed, pulling it out pointedly. Izuku quickly got the message, but even as he moved to leave the bed Kacchan’s good arm reached around and grabbed his thigh, gripping tight.

“What kinda questions?”

“The sort of questions that might lead some to wonder how he isn’t a zombie by now,” Aizawa replied in a low irritated voice, and Izuku froze. *Did… how did he..?*

“The hell does that mean?” Kacchan scoffed, entirely ignorant of the subtext. “We don’t kiss and we use condoms when we fuck. It ain’t rocket science.”

“ *Kacchan!”* Izuku squeaked, mortified.

“Be that as it may,” Aizawa said tightly. “It wouldn’t be ideal for anyone to suspect Midoriya of having a resistance to the virus, would it? Unless you want him locked here with you.”

Kacchan snorted again, even as Izuku found himself sweating beside him. His mind raced, thinking back to every interaction he had with Aizawa until now, anything he might have said that might have given Aizawa reason to think that there was merit to him having some kind of resistance.

“If he were anything like me we’d know it by now,” Kacchan said. “Besides, ain’t no way you haven’t already run a blood test on him to check he ain’t carrying.”

That’s right! Izuku looked to Aizawa, who stared back with his furrowed brow. Izuku had been unconscious when he had first arrived at UA, but he knew from speaking to the others that blood samples were taken from all of them once they got here to be sure no one was hiding anything. When Izuku took his test, his results had been completely normal, there was nothing in his blood that might make anyone think he carried the virus or had any kind of immunity to it. Unless they had *purposefully* infected him whilst he was unconscious, then surely they would have no idea.

“Of course we did,” Aizawa said eventually. “But that doesn’t mean no one is going to suspect anything after the fact.”

“I-it’s ok, Kacchan,” Izuku said, shifting forward and off of the bed, his chest clenching at the way Kacchan pouted at that, his hand still out-stretched towards him as if trying to usher him back within reach. “Mr Aizawa has a point. With Shigaraki around, we don’t need to arouse any suspicion.”

“At least one of you is making some sense,” Aizawa sighed. “The rest of the nomu already know you have some weird codependent thing going on already, so let's leave it at that shall we?”

“Nomu,” Kacchan said suddenly. “That bastard Shigaraki called me that, too. What the fuck does that mean?”

“It’s what you are,” Aizawa replied. Kacchan scowled, face scrunching up as if he were chasing a memory before his face flushed.

“Like the fucking monsters from the old All Might comics?” he said.

“Exactly like that,” Aizawa said shortly. “Shigaraki decided on the term, as a way to separate the infected such as yourself from your average, run-of-the-mill zombie. You’re not a zombie, you’re not even strictly human, but something in between.”

Izuku tensed, watching as a range of emotions crossed over Kacchan’s open face. It might have been funny in any other situation, Kacchan jumping from confusion to outrage to indignance to confusion again at a rate that would have rivalled a cartoon character, but he surprised Izuku by crossing his arms over his chest and staring Aizawa in the eye.

“How many other nomu are here?”

Aizawa, too, seemed taken aback, blinking for a moment before placing his hands on his hips.

“There are four others,” he said. “As soon as Professor Toshinori is happy with your recovery you’ll be introduced to them. I’m not sure how much Midoriya explained to you-”

“You didn’t give him enough time to explain shit,” Kacchan interrupted waspishly. Izuku couldn’t

deny that it was good to see the man being his usual, argumentative self.

“If you had spent those fifteen minutes talking instead of spooning you would have found them to be plenty,” Aizawa said immediately. Kacchan’s face twisted into a mockery of a grin, and Izuku’s relief quickly morphed to alarm when he recognised the expression.

“Uh, I can explain now!” he said quickly, voice high, not so discretely stepping closer so that he was only an arm's reach from the both of them. But Aizawa didn’t seem concerned by the challenge in Kacchan’s eyes.

“Some of the nomu here have been with us from the beginning, others found their way to us, or we found them,” he continued. “And they have been aiding with our research, *willingly* , ever since. There are key differences between your physiology, and ours, clues that we hope will eventually give us an answer to the virus, and how we can put a stop to it.”

“And that’s *all* you’re interested in, huh?” Kacchan said. “The zombies in the stadium. Tell me how they got there.”

Aizawa’s brow rose. “I don’t have to tell you anything.”

“But you’re gonna. You threatened my friends, that’s one fucking thing, but I can still make shit difficult for you. And Deku’s smart,” he added, gesturing to Izuku who started. “Whatever you don’t tell me he’ll sure as fuck figure it out.”

Aizawa glanced over at Izuku before he hummed. “I’m really rather counting on it.”

I. Not we. I. Izuku frowned.

“We put the zombies in the stadium,” Aizawa said, taking both Izuku and Kacchan by surprise. “It was part of an experiment, to see whether it was possible to contain that number of them and whether doing so would attract others.”

“An experiment,” Izuku repeated. “You needed that many of them? How did you do it?”

“You’ll soon realise that not all nomu are created equal,” Aizawa replied. He looked down at the chair that Izuku had vacated in his concern, and yanked it closer, away from Izuku so that he could sit down, looking up at them over newly steepled fingers. “They each appear to have unique traits and abilities. Little *quirks* that make them different from one another. It’s part of what makes them so fascinating, but just as frustrating. Are these quirks determined before infection by some factor we don’t yet understand? Or are they random?”

Izuku found himself sitting on the bed beside Kacchan again, looking at Aizawa intently.

“One of the first things we realised was that all of them have *some* degree of control over the zombies, something you might have noticed for yourselves already?”

Izuku nodded, and Kacchan huffed.

“But how much control a nomu has varies. Overhaul, one of our newer nomu, has a great deal of control over the zombies, almost a frightening amount of control frankly. Whereas Fat, who has

been with us the longest, can maybe only control two or three at a time."

"That makes sense," Izuku breathed. "The first nomu we met, do you remember, Kacchan? The one that opened the door? Compared to the nomu in the hospital she didn't really seem to do anything to control them."

Kacchan grunted.

"But it seems to be more than just zombie mind control," Aizawa continued. "Mirko is strong, inhumanely so. And Hawks is fast. The nomu you met out there must have had some defining trait too."

"I don't know about the first," Izuku replied, honestly. "She didn't even seem all that smart. But Mr Zombig… he was huge, he controlled the zombies too. And the zombie at the hospital? She seemed to strategise, she used the zombies to trap us underground."

"Some of the nomu are much more of a threat than others," Aizawa said. "In the state that *you* are at," he nodded at Kacchan, "these abilities can be maintained and, most importantly, they can be controlled. They can even be useful, like when Overhaul helped us to contain over a thousand zombies before you decided to break down the door and let them go."

"If you could contain them you could kill them," Kacchan said fiercely. "You left them alive because you wanted to. A thousand zombies you can control with one fucking nomu? The hell does that have to do with finding out a cure, hah? Why're you wasting time and energy on that shit if you don't plan to use it?"

"When we find the cure we still have to roll it out," Aizawa replied. "It's one thing immunising everyone at UA, but there's still a whole world out there, survivors that need a vaccine just as much as we do. How exactly are we supposed to go out there and find them if we can't defend ourselves?"

Kacchan paused, his lip curling.

"Your reason for being here isn't just because we hope the answer can be found somewhere in your blood," Aizawa said, getting to his feet once more. "Best estimations, two percent of the population of Japan have survived, another twenty percent devoured or burned or destroyed beyond the ability to reanimate. That still leaves ninety-eight *million* zombies between us and getting the cure to those survivors. You're also here to help us with *that* . So yes, maybe we are creating an army, but who exactly did you think was our enemy?"

Aizawa turned to the cabinet against the far wall, opened a drawer and pulled out a bottle of pills, that he slapped unceremoniously into Izuku's hand.

"I'm not going to pretend Shigaraki went about this in the right way," he continued. "And, I can promise you, Bakugou, that I took no pleasure in keeping you alive against your will. But, this isn't about you. The only ones more useless than the dead are the living that refuses to act. Now, I am going to call Toshinori. Midoriya, those are Bakugou's pain relief. He's fifteen minutes behind on his next dose."

Aizawa left the room, Izuku and Kacchan sitting in uncomfortable silence as Izuku looked down at

the bottle of pills in his hand.

“He’s hiding something,” Kacchan said finally.

Izuku breathed heavily, pulling both of his legs up beneath him and tapping the bottle against his knee in agitation.

“I think he knows more than he’s telling us,” he agreed. “But, ugh, damnit Kacchan he does have a point, right? It does make sense that we’ll need nomu on our side?”

“Sure, but that still doesn’t explain why those zombies were still *alive,* ” Kacchan argued. “That… Overhaul, whoever the fuck he is, if he’s so capable of controlling that many zombies at once why is UA surrounded by them? Why are the bridges in and out of the city destroyed? Why did we have to blow up a whole fucking stadium just so we could get in here in the first place?”

“I don’t know.”

“And *why* is he so concerned about anyone here thinking you might have some resistance to the virus?” Kacchan continued, throwing a hand out in exasperation. “Why is it so fucking important that *you* can move about this place freely?”

Izuku frowned, fingernails playing with the cap of the bottle.

“I don’t know,” he repeated, with a tired sigh. “But, for so long as I can, I’m going to make the most of it. They asked me here to watch you, but they never said that I couldn’t still be part of the research. The more I can find out about this virus, the more useful I’ll be to them, and the more Shigaraki might trust me.”

“There’s no way that asshole doesn’t have some fucking evil villain plan. And I ain’t wrong, right, he and that chapped-lipped fucker from Tokyo are related?”

“I haven’t mentioned him, or Dabi,” Izuku replied. “But they have to be. Somehow mentioning that we probably killed his nephew or son or something like that seemed like a bad idea.”

“We don’t know that Shigaraki is dead,” Kacchan said seriously. “I never saw him go down. And… at the stadium…”

Kacchan’s voice trailed off for a moment, his face scrunched up painfully.

“Kacchan?”

“It was deliberate,” Kacchan said, voice shaky but firm. “And maybe that was Dabi’s doing, but someone defused the dynamite at the entrance to the stadium. That’s why the whole thing didn’t come down on me, how I managed to survive the blast. And I been thinking about it all day… it doesn’t make sense for Dabi to have done it.”

“He came to kill us,” Izuku breathed, understanding. “He’d have no reason to defuse them.”

“Exactly. And, when dog-eyes found me, they said… *‘we found him, just like the kid said.’* And they *knew* to look for a bite. That’s why- why I thought that you-” Kacchan swallowed audibly,

shifting where he sat. “Someone else knew I was there, knew I had been bitten, knew enough to defuse the dynamite so I might survive the explosion.”

“You think it was Shigaraki? That’s who they meant?”

“Who else?”

“It does seem like a pretty huge coincidence that the guy who runs this place shares the same surname,” Izuku agreed before he reached up and furiously rubbed at his aching temple. “But does that mean Shigaraki has been working for UA this whole time? Is that why they were following us- no, no he seemed surprised when he realised that you were bit.”

“Fuck, I dunno,” Kacchan sighed. “But I do know both Shigaraki’s are evil assholes, and there’s no way I trust either of them. Whatever is going on here, whatever Shigaraki is planning, it goes beyond a cure, I’m fucking *certain* of it.”

Izuku nodded, chewing on his bottom lip. Aizawa wasn’t back yet, and for the moment he and Kacchan seemed to be alone. Though he didn’t have proof of anything he could tell Kacchan that Aizawa wasn’t totally off the mark when it came to his concerns over any suspicion surrounding Izuku’s resistance to the virus. But… if he were wrong if he had been mistaken somehow… No, he had to know without a shadow of a doubt that he was immune before he told Kacchan. It would mean so much for Izuku, for *them* , to give either of them any false hope right now.

“We keep playing the game,” he said. “We’ll find out what’s going on here.”

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 42: Grave New World

Chapter Summary

In which we move from one prison to the next.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For the next three days, Kacchan remained in the hospital room under the scrutinising supervision of Aizawa and the research team.

Kacchan's frustrations and complaints were many, entirely as vocal as the Kacchan Izuku remembered now that he was awake and more accustomed to his surroundings. But he was cooperative for the most part, providing that Izuku was the one performing the majority of the more hands-on tasks, and the tests in place to track his healing and hormone levels. It was a strange position for Izuku to find himself in; though drawing blood was something he could do with his eyes closed by this point, inserting the midline into Kacchan's upper arm wasn't a procedure he had ever done before. Kacchan, for better or worse, had complete confidence in him, barking out a "*just shove the damn needle in, Deku!"* after Izuku spent a solid minute muttering over whether he had found the right vein and how much it would hurt without anaesthetic. Kacchan hadn't so much as winced when Izuku summoned the courage to stick him with the big needle, though he stared a little *too* hard at the ceiling throughout the entire process. After that, Izuku was able to quickly take a sample every twelve hours, passing the blood off to Kayama who took it away for inspection. According to Toshinori, Kacchan's hormone markers remained consistent and typical of what they were expecting, and he felt confident that Kacchan would be able to leave the hospital and join the other nomu once the three days were up.

The whole ordeal left Izuku with very little time to spend with his mother, and he hadn't seen his friends at all despite Kacchan's forceful demands that he did. The first day, Izuku had managed to steal an hour in which he told her that he was busy working on something important in the labs and that he would probably be staying there for the next few days at least, and not to worry about him. She *had* been worried, of course, Midoriya Inko had always been a worrier where her son was concerned. But for the most part, she seemed pleased that Izuku had found a purpose at UA. Izuku wished he could tell her more… he wished he could tell her all about Kacchan so that they could meet. The thought of Kacchan and his mother meeting left him feeling giddy in a way that he had forgotten he could feel, and that giddiness brought a certain kind of comfort. He was still capable of feeling these things, these almost mundane emotions, these fragile anxieties that fluttered in his chest, tied to something so sweet as introducing his boyfriend to his mother. Normalcy… sometimes it was there. Small, fleeting moments. And he held onto them for dear life.

Finally, on the morning of the fourth day, barely a week after Kacchan had been woken up, he was given the all-clear to leave the hospital.

Professor Toshinori was the one who came to give them the news. Kacchan, fed up with the open-

back hospital gowns that *'kept giving the whole fucking campus an eyeful of the good stuff each time he got up for a piss'* was yelling at Izuku about finding him some decent clothes when Toshinori opened the door, peeking his head through somewhat apprehensively at the raised voices.

"Kacchan! I'm not gonna walk around naked just so you can wear my jump- oh! Hi Professor!"

"Young Midoriya," Toshinori replied, face spreading into the beaming smile he seemed to reserve for Izuku. "I've just finished assessing the last of Young Bakugou's blood samples."

Kacchan, whose fist was still tangled in the fabric of Izuku's sleeve, turned to face Toshinori, Izuku pinwheeling his spare arm for a moment as he tried not to be dragged over in the process. It had only been a few days of eating solid food again, doing what exercises he could in the tiny hospital room, and Kacchan already seemed notably bigger and stronger. Izuku wondered whether the virus had something to do with that.

"So, am I good, old man?" Kacchan demanded.

"There is a slight increase in some of the hormone markers," Toshinori replied, looking down at the paperwork in his hands. "We've seen much the same with Overhaul, but small doses of amiodarone, when the markers start to rise, have kept him stable in the time he's been here."

"So, what does that *actually* mean?" Kacchan said, finally releasing Izuku's arm. "If I don't take that shit I'll turn?"

"Essentially, yes," Toshinori said. "Midoriya explained that you were using alcohol previously, to manage the progress of the virus. From what I understand you have been exposed to any number of strains of the virus. Your second bite was probably about the limit that your body could handle, and it complicated things somewhat. You recover remarkably quickly, which is a good thing, but it would appear you have a shorter turn-over rate than the other nomu."

"Right," Kacchan grunted out. "And the amio-whatever, what does that do to me?"

Toshinori seemed to hesitate for a moment, looking between Izuku and Kacchan, before he cleared his throat.

"Professor?" Izuku asked, concern rising.

"Ultimately, our goal when it comes to managing the virus is to prevent the excess production of the hormones that trigger it," Toshinori explained. "There's a lot that we don't know, but for those infected with the virus, there is a sudden and alarming increase in the production of hormones the liver is responsible for synthesising. The hormones mutate, the liver continues to make more, and within a matter of hours, the hormones are unrecognisable as human. The body starts to behave completely differently, from how it gets energy to the rate at which cells die."

"Wait," Kacchan said, brow furrowed. "So, why don't you just give the amio to people after they've been bitten? Stop the virus in its tracks?"

"Because the amount we'd need to give would kill them," Izuku replied glumly. He had already asked Toshinori the same question when trying to understand things better for himself. "The liver is

good at healing itself, but there are limits."

"Exactly that," Toshinori said, nodding and throwing Izuku a proud grin. "We tried this very early on when finding people who had been exposed to the virus wasn't a difficult task. The only person to have survived is Fat, who was the first nomu to join us and who helped us get the understanding that we have now."

"So, what, our livers heal faster or something?"

"That seems to be the case. Not only that, but the hormones mutate differently. Your bodies can withstand, well for lack of a better term, much more abuse than an average human. But that doesn't mean that you're immune to the side effects."

"Right. So, the side effects of the amio are a bitch, that it?"

"Uh, yes I guess that's the easiest way to put it. We've tried a lot of other drugs in that time, but it seems to be the most consistent in getting the results that we need. Unfortunately, it is also one of the higher-risk medications, which in some ways is ideal but in other ways? Not so much. Some of the side effects we've noted are-"

"Don't tell me," Kacchan interrupted sharply, placing his hands on his hips. "You tell someone they gonna start feeling nauseous or some shit then, of course, they're gonna puke. Forget it, old man, I'll deal with it."

"I can keep an eye on him," Izuku said.

"Don't need you doing that either," Kacchan muttered reproachfully.

"The amount that we need to give Overhaul is mild," Toshinori continued. "He does experience some of the side effects, unfortunately, but he insists that they are not unmanageable. If regular doses of the amiodarone are needed, then I'm sure he will be happy to talk you through the steps he's taken to deal with it."

"Noted," Kacchan replied dryly, as though talking to anyone else about this was the last thing he wanted to do.

"I've asked Aizawa to come by to talk you through the next steps and integration with the rest of the nomu, as well as what your medical care will look like from this point on."

"Can I go outside?"

Izuku looked across at Kacchan, noting the hopeful look in his eyes.

"With supervision," Toshinori replied. "We can't risk you being seen by anyone outside of the facility, so we have a private recreational space set up just for the nomu."

Izuku could hear Kacchan's teeth grinding, his body tensing up at that, anger thrumming through him even if he chose not to vocalise it, and it seemed to fully hit Izuku for the first time that Kacchan was a prisoner. He opened his mouth to protest before a sharp rap on the door interrupted him, and Aizawa slouched his way into the room. His long hair, usually pulled back in a bun, was

hanging past his shoulders obscuring his face from view as he scrutinised a clipboard in his hand, an ugly-looking old plastic shopping bag hanging from his elbow.

“Explained about the hormone markers?” he grunted, not even looking up at Izuku and Kacchan.

“Yes, we just covered that.”

“Code name?”

“We hadn’t got that far.”

Aizawa looked up, idly passing a fumbling Toshinori his clipboard, dark eyes assessing Kacchan from beneath his furrowed brow.

“Soon as you step out of this room, you will no longer be called Bakugou,” he said.

“ *Hah?* ”

“The identity of the nomu *must* remain secret, we cannot risk your name somehow being leaked topside, particularly given there are people up there who will recognise it and ask questions. All of the nomu have codenames.”

“Do I get to pick it?” Kacchan asked, with a tone that suggested he already knew the answer.

“Of course not. We already use your codename in the research lab, so there’s no changing it either. From this point on, you will be referred to as Dynamite.”

There was a beat of silence before Kacchan burst into loud laughter, so raucous and unexpected that it made Izuku jump. Aizawa stared.

“You’re a piece of shit,” Kacchan managed, shaking his head. “Fuck you.”

“I didn’t come up with it,” Aizawa said, seeming almost reproachful. “Anyway, that goes for you too, Midoriya. If I hear one more *‘Kacchan’* you’ll find yourself back in the lab.”

“Yes sir,” Izuku said, with a pout.

“Before I introduce you to the rest of the nomu, I need to go through a breakdown of how your days will typically go. Midoriya, you will have a little bit more leeway and I think it’s important that you still make time to visit your mother and friends, if only so that no one starts to ask questions about your whereabouts, but assume that your schedule will be similar.”

“I’m with Kacchan all of the time?” Izuku asked, relieved. Aizawa glared, his nostrils flaring, and Izuku started. “Uh, Dynamite, I mean! I-I’m with Dynamite all the time?”

“No,” Aizawa ground out. “We’ve gone to the trouble of moving the contents of your room down here at the facility with the other researchers. You’ll need to be on call day and night. You’re awake when Dynamite is awake, and if you’re lucky you’ll sleep when Dynamite sleeps. You’ll assist with the everyday care and research, much like you’ve seen Kayama doing for the other nomu, but you’ll also be spending time in the lab with Toshinori.”

“I was able to convince Shigaraki you were more useful to us than just a glorified babysitter,” Toshinori said, to which Kacchan spluttered, “ *I don’t need babysitting!”*

“You will not be permitted inside Dynamite’s room after lights out,” Aizawa continued.

“What? Why?” Kacchan demanded petulantly. Aizawa threw him an exasperated look.

“You are infected,” he replied bluntly. “Midoriya is not. We’d like to keep it that way.”

“There are huge risks for those of us working alongside the nomu,” Toshinori said hurriedly. “I know the two of you have been travelling together for a long time and avoided contamination, but I’m afraid the risks of infection are so much greater here. There are strict protocols in place if any of the researchers come into contact with any body fluids of the infected. You need to understand, the ways in which any one of us could become infected are numerous.”

“Has it happened before?” Kacchan asked. “A nomu infecting someone here.”

“Unfortunately, yes,” Toshinori replied. “One of our researchers was infected by simply drinking from the wrong glass. Any physical contact between you is prohibited unless necessary for the task at hand.”

Izuku suddenly found himself thinking of the time that he and Kacchan had spent together out there. They had been careful of infection, and meticulous about not sharing the same bottles and cutlery, but now he thought about it they had taken some serious risks. Izuku had fallen asleep wrapped up in Kacchan’s arms on more than one occasion, their bodies close to one another. Izuku had once had a mouthful of Kacchan’s sweaty tank top, and that in itself was utter insanity. Izuku had no idea, really, the exact amount of exposure necessary for the virus to take, and he had allowed himself to believe that unless it was through a bite, there needed to be a somewhat significant exchange of bodily fluids. But, if what Toshinori had said was true, that someone had become infected by doing so little as drinking from a glass a nomu had already drunk from, then that only added more evidence to the theory that Izuku, himself, had immunity. He chanced a glance to his side, taking in Kacchan’s furrowed brow and the gentle tug of his teeth at his upper lip and wondered if Kacchan was also beginning to come to the same conclusion.

“Morning routines won’t be too different from what you’ve gotten used to this past week,” Aizawa said, as though he had never been interrupted. “Blood samples will be taken at six-thirty each morning, and again at six-thirty each night. Breakfast begins at seven, and all nomu eat in a separate part of the canteen to avoid cross-contamination. Tea and coffee facilities are available in the kitchen, but nomu must *only* use the receptacles provided and they must be disposed of immediately after use. Similar precautions must also be taken when showering and toileting. Each nomu is provided with a bar of soap, a toothbrush and their own toothpaste which are kept in a sealed bag when not in use, and nomu *must* shower each morning and after any exercise. I know it sounds wasteful, but we have discovered that sweat is another infection source and it’s simply not worth the risk. As well as the shower cubicles there are two separate stalls in the bathroom, and the toilets are equipped with a bidet, *use it* . Furthermore, you piss sitting down, I’m not about to risk our cleaners getting infected because you don’t know how to aim properly.”

Izuku spluttered, and Kacchan yelled an indignant - *“I can aim just fucking fine!”*

“Your daily routine will vary depending on what tests we plan to run, if any. There will be days where you’ll mostly have to entertain yourself and I’m sure the other nomu will be able to involve you in their activities. You get one hour of recreation time each day, which you can choose to spend outside in the gardens if you wish. There are only two meals each day, and dinner is at six. Lights out at eight-thirty, you will not be permitted to leave your rooms after that time. If you need to use the bathroom during the night, then you’ll contact Midoriya via the pagers we’ll give each of you and he’ll escort you. Any questions?”

“Yeh, exactly what kind of fucking tests do you think you’re gonna be running on me?” Kacchan asked.

“It depends on the state of our research at the time,” Aizawa replied. “But, mostly we’re interested in tracking hormone levels, seeing how you react to certain medications, how exercise or lack thereof affects the virus.” He hesitated a moment. “We’re also very interested to see what kind of passive abilities you have, the degree of control you might have over the other zombies.”

“And if I refuse?”

Izuku looked over at Kacchan and Aizawa fixed him with a stern glare.

“I believe Shigaraki already made it clear that’s not an option.”

“Right,” Kacchan ground out. “So, is that everything?”

“Almost.”

Aizawa lifted the bag that had been hanging from his hand and threw it across the room at Kacchan, who caught it easily.

“These are your clothes. The jumpsuit is for day-to-day, the workout clothes and pyjamas are self-explanatory. Clothes are rotated weekly, but if yours get dirty or soiled before then Midoriya can put in a request for an early replacement.”

“And, uh, how do I make requests, exactly?” Izuku asked. “What if Ka-Dynamite needs anything else?”

“Well, Kayama usually reports to me, but as you’re going to be working most closely with Toshinori, just ask him for what you need. You’ll have our numbers on your pager, it’s not going to be hard to reach out to either of us if you need anything.”

“Once Dynamite has settled you’ll be able to spend more time outside of the living area,” Toshinori said. “And move a little more freely. I’m hoping to get you back in the labs with me as soon as possible, after all!”

“If that’s all your questions, get dressed. We’ll introduce you to the other nomu after. Midoriya, follow me outside for a moment.”

Izuku looked at Kacchan, who simply shrugged, reaching into the bag and pulling out a bright orange jumpsuit, rolling his nose.

“Really? Fucking *prison* getup?”

“You can keep wearing the hospital gown if you prefer,” Aizawa said shortly, before waving his hand and gesturing towards the door. “Midoriya.”

“Right, right.”

Izuku hurried after Aizawa and Toshinori, allowing Kacchan to dress in privacy. Each of the other nomu was already sitting in the living area, looking up with various degrees of interest as the door opened, some nursing paper cups.

“What is it?” Izuku asked once the door swung shut behind them.

“Here’s your pager,” Aizawa said, thrusting the black device into Izuku’s hand. “All the important numbers have already been added, including the one that we’ll be giving Dynamite. Upon request, you have also been given Shigaraki’s number.”

“Requested by who?”

“Do not use it,” Aizawa pressed, ignoring him. “Unless either myself or Toshinori give you permission or Shigaraki contacts you first. Understand?”

Izuku nodded, curious as to why he had been given a number that he wasn’t allowed to use, and looked down at the pager in his hand. He had never used one of these things, the appearance so archaic compared to the phones he had once owned, but it seemed easy enough to navigate through the contacts. He put it in the back pocket of his jumpsuit.

“Good.”

Aizawa knocked on the door, waited for Kacchan’s indifferent grunt on the other side, and headed back inside. Kacchan stood at the foot of his bed, the orange jumpsuit at least one size too big for him and baggy around his lower half, and he grumbled as he tugged the zip up to his neck.

“Good to go?”

“One thing,” Kacchan said, thrusting his hands into the oversized pockets at his hips. With his short, cropped hair, baggy clothes, and that resting pout, he somehow managed to look even more like a delinquent than usual, and Izuku found himself needing to hide a grin under his hand. “My stuff. Where is it?”

Aizawa looked genuinely confused. “Your stuff?”

“Yeh. I had two gold rings on a cord tied ‘round my neck. You take ‘em or what?”

Aizawa looked at Toshinori, who shrugged before he looked down at Izuku, who shook his head.

“I don’t have them. But Kacchan was wearing them when- uh,” he swallowed.

“I’ll look into it,” Aizawa said, grabbing a pen from the breast pocket of his jumpsuit and leaning into Toshinori’s space to jot something down on the clipboard he carried. “The clothes you were

wearing at the time were incinerated, but anything valuable like that would have been saved. I'm sure they're about."

"Better be," Kacchan grumbled, averting his eyes and glaring down at the floor. "Let's go meet these other poor fucks then, yeh?"

Kacchan followed them outside of the hospital room, leaving it for the first time in three months. Izuku had to resist the urge to reach for him and wrap his hand in his own. He could sense the nervousness Kacchan felt, even if his face refused to show it, and he could only content himself with surreptitiously brushing his fingers over Kacchan's elbow as they drew closer to one another. Kacchan nodded minutely, before deliberately forcing his way to the front, hands in pockets, legs wide and head held high as he took in the four other nomu in a display of dominance Izuku was far too used to by now. The four stared back at him, before Mirko, the muscular woman with her long white hair tied into a bun, let out a loud bark of laughter, placing her hands on her hips.

"I knew it! Hah, Fat hand 'em over."

Fat sighed, digging around in his pockets before handing over two packets of what Izuku swore were Kit Kats before she safely nestled them into her breast pocket.

"Uh, knew what?" Izuku asked, nervously glancing over at Kacchan to see how he would handle Mirko laughing at him the very first time they met. Kacchan scowled.

"Oi," he snapped. "If that's a bet about me then don't I get half that shit or something?"

Mirko froze, the grin sliding off her face as she looked over at Fat, who shrugged.

"Dunno seems fair to me."

" *Motherfucker.* "

Mirko grabbed one of the chocolates and threw it at Kacchan, who was able to yank his hand out of his pocket in time to grab it, a smug look on his face.

"Right," Aizawa said blankly. "Well. Everyone, this is Dynamite. He's the fifth nomu to join the facility. I'd ask you all to play nice, but this isn't a nursery and I don't care whether you like one another or not so long as you're not starting fights. Dynamite, this is Mirko, Fat, Hawks and Overhaul. I'm sure you'll have plenty of time to get to know one another more."

"We have nothing but time," Hawks said, his handsome if not somewhat ruffled face arching into a wry smile before he stepped forward with his hand outstretched towards Kacchan. "I look forward to getting to know you more."

Kacchan glared, his hand reaching out and slapping Hawk's away sharply. "Tell that to your face," he replied. "Because that look in your eyes says fucking otherwise."

Hawks only smiled more broadly, putting his hands back into his pockets and rocking back on his heels.

"Great, now that we've met," Aizawa said with a heavy sigh, before gesturing to a door across the

room from them, “you can see where you’re going to be living from now on.”

Kacchan promptly ignored the rest of the nomu, marching toward the door. Izuku and Hawk’s eyes met, his amber gaze burning into Izuku in a way that made him shiver before he hurried after Kacchan and Aizawa.

“The door is locked overnight,” Aizawa said, “and can only be opened by keycard, which Midoriya will have access to. During the day, however, you’ll be able to move in and out freely.”

“Lucky me,” Kacchan grunted. Aizawa ran his keycard through the slot, a *beep* and a *click* following, and before Aizawa could reach for the handle Kacchan was already pushing his way through.

The room was small, Izuku had been in here once before so he knew what to expect. It wasn’t quite a prison cell, but in his opinion, it wasn't far off from that; a single bed was pushed back against the furthest wall, ugly blue bed sheets and a white pillow neatly stacked on top. There was a desk opposite, and the bookcase beside it was now stocked with a selection of books that Izuku hadn’t seen the last time he was here, and the bedside table was adorned with a small LED lamp so that whoever lived here could read any time that they liked. A clean sink was near the door, and the soap, toothbrush and toothpaste that Aizawa had mentioned were sitting in the basin inside of a zip-lock bag.

“So, what if I gotta piss during the night I just use the fucking sink?”

“I can’t stop you,” Aizawa sighed. Kacchan threw him a cool look.

“And if I gotta take a dump?”

“If you want to spend your night wallowing in your filth go right ahead. Or, you could just page Midoriya as I’ve already mentioned.”

“Right,” Kacchan scoffed.

“Any other questions, or can I leave you to Midoriya now?”

“Y’know I think I got it.”

“Good. We’re not going to be expecting anything of you today, just mingle, or don’t. Tomorrow we’ll begin easing you into your day-to-day.”

“We’ll speak later, Young Midoriya!” Professor Toshinori said from the doorway, raising his hand with a cheery smile. Izuku nodded and watched as Toshinori and Aizawa walked away, abruptly leaving him and Kacchan alone once more. Izuku heard a thump from behind him and looked back to see Kacchan dropping heavily down onto the bed, arms crossed over his chest and back slouching against the wall.

“This blows.”

Izuku lifted his lips in a sympathetic smile before gently closing the door.

“At least you’re not locked in the hospital room any more,” he said, sitting himself down on the desk chair and swivelling it around to face Kacchan. He scoffed and rolled his eyes.

“Great, from one prison cell to another.”

“It’s…” Izuku hesitated, watching Kacchan’s face as he glared glumly at the wall. “It’s not so bad,” he offered, leaning forward. “We’re not constantly looking for food, or hiding from zombies. We’re alive.”

“I felt more alive out there than I ever could in here,” Kacchan replied, before he visibly winced, eyes darting up to meet Izuku’s. “I’m not blaming you.”

“I know.”

“It’s just…” Kacchan sat up, running a hand through his hair in visible frustration before he looked up, seeming to track the four corners of each room. “Fuck, this is the last place I ever wanted to be.”

“I know,” Izuku repeated, softer.

“And so long as that asshole at the top keeps a knife at their throats there’s no fucking way out of here, either.”

Izuku didn’t need to ask whose throats he meant, his thoughts shifting anxiously to his mother and their friends.

“So I don’t-” Kacchan shook his head, his face contorting as though he was trying to hold back his emotions. “Dunno what to fucking do.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku said, getting up from the chair to sit down beside him, their knees knocking together. “I’m gonna fix it. I swear I will. Just… give me some time, ok?”

“Fix it *how* ?” Kacchan hissed, not looking the least bit comforted, eyes widening in alarm. “Shitty Deku, if you’re thinking of doing something stupid-”

“I’m not,” Izuku replied firmly. He wanted to tell Kacchan everything, all of his suspicions, but first, he *had* to be certain. He needed to be sure. He took a deep breath. “Do you trust me?”

Kacchan looked taken back, his eyes searching Izuku’s face. Izuku had grown used to the mismatched eyes now, the chalky pink of his right vibrant against the red scarring over his cheek, but the growing familiarity did nothing to quell the errant beating of his heart, and the guilt that he knew he would always feel when he looked at Kacchan.

“‘Course I do,” Kacchan said, at last, his voice not wavering.

“Ok,” Izuku replied. “I’m going to need some of your blood.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you everyone who patiently waited for this update! It's been a busy four months and whilst I can force myself to draw through the apocalypse no problem, I am a fair weather writer who bruises easy.

Unless I get carried away with one or two of them, we have about five more chapters to go.

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Chapter 43: Decaydent

Chapter Summary

In which Izuku is finally ready to explain some things to Kacchan.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku leaned onto the refrigerator, the white light casting ugly shadows over his tired face in the otherwise dark room. It was late, perhaps two or three in the morning, but despite the hour, he had no plans on sleeping.

Getting samples of Kacchan's blood was simple enough; filling a second syringe with just enough blood to work with without Toshinori noticing was far easier than it ought to have been. Izuku might have felt bad for betraying the Professor's trust were the stakes not so high. What *wasn't* simple, however, was finding the time to study the samples in the eight hours or so before they were of no use to him. The first week had been a complete bust; the labs had been busy, so busy that even in the middle of the night there had always been at least one researcher pottering around the lab. No one would find his presence there suspicious, he *was* working below Toshinori now after all, but it still might invite questions, and the last thing he needed was for some nosey scientist to ask him where the blood had come from.

The second week, with the ninth sample of Kacchan's blood burning an angry hole in his pocket, he finally found the lab empty. Well practiced by now, he prepared the sample and mixed Kacchan's blood with his own, waiting in the dark for an hour until he felt sure that his sample ought to be infected. Stashed in the refrigerator, unmarked beside his assigned samples from earlier that day, he only hoped that he would be so lucky as to find time the following evening to study it.

But tonight, by some uncharacteristic stroke of good fortune, he had returned to the lab to find it empty, and trying to ignore the anxiety gnawing a hole in his gut he reached for the sample, hand shaking so much that he almost dropped the glass on the hard floor.

"Easy, Izuku," he breathed to himself, lips pursing as he looked up to make sure he hadn't been heard. The lab remained deathly quiet, and carefully he carried the sample to his workstation.

The blood was completely dry now, and whilst dry blood was useless to him in the earlier stages he knew from his studies that, once it had colonised a sample, the virus could survive for weeks in this state. Hormone markers were a more reliable indication of infection in a living subject, but the virus itself was visible under a microscope, and if his sample was infected it should be teeming with it, impossible to miss. He took a deep breath, scraping off a couple of shavings of the blood onto a slide, looking over his shoulder one last time, and peered down the eye of the microscope.

Although the light from the fridge was enough to light his workstation, he still flicked on the lamp at his desk so that he could be *sure* of what he was seeing. The sample had most definitely been

infected twenty-four hours ago: he had watched the virus bodies attach themselves to the cells, spike proteins spread out like a starburst, almost like small explosions blasting their way inside. But, no matter how long he looked, squinted, adjusted his position and refocused, he couldn't find *any* of those starbursts now. The sample appeared completely and utterly normal. He exhaled an unsteady breath, stepping away from the microscope so that he didn't end up crushing the thing as his knees began to shake.

This *was* what he had expected to find; the same results had come back each time he had contaminated his blood with that of a regular zombie. But seeing it happen again, with *Kacchan's* blood, left him trembling. He all but threw himself forward, fumbling hands scraping more of the dried blood onto the slide, but there were still no starbursts, still no sign that the virus had even existed in the first place. He rubbed his hands over his eyes.

"Holy shit."

It was real . It was all fucking *real* .

It hadn't been a fluke, he hadn't just been lucky all these months after all. He briefly found himself wondering just how many times he had been infected by the virus these last two years, how dead he would have been if he hadn't, by some miracle, been immune. But those thoughts swiftly fell out of his mind as the reality of the situation came crashing down on him.

He was immune to the zombie virus.

"Holy *fuck.* "

But, he shouldn't get ahead of himself. He knew there was still one last test to perform, the only way that he could feel entirely confident in his results before he even *thought* about telling Kacchan the news. Testing his blood was a damn good indicator, it *was* reliable. But unless he was prepared to infect himself, then he couldn't in good conscience say that he was entirely immune. He needed to replicate the experiments, with his functioning endocrine system and all other variables intact. He needed to inject himself with Kacchan's blood.

Kacchan wouldn't ask questions. He could just say that tonight had been another bust; there had been people in the labs and he'd needed to scrap the sample. All he needed was one last sample of Kacchan's blood and he could infect himself in the morning. But despite the evidence he had gathered so far, he needed to consider the possibility that he might get infected this time, and what he was going to do about it if he was.

It was an uncomfortable thought. He couldn't allow anyone to know that he had been infected with *Kacchan's* blood. If it all went wrong, Kacchan needed to be protected, he needed to have nothing to do with it. He could tell Toshinori that he had accidentally pricked himself with a needle. Let them do what needed to be done after that. He briefly considered ways in which he could end things himself, but he knew that he couldn't do that to his mum, to Kacchan or his friends. It needed to be, for as much as it made his stomach churn to think about it, *by the book.* A simple lab accident.

His hands dropped down to his sides loudly, throwing his head back and looking up at the ceiling. *God, this was insane* . After two years of running from it, tomorrow he was going to purposely infect himself with the virus that had been slowly ravaging Kacchan's body and taking the lives of

his friends.

Kacchan was going to be furious.

Fortunately, Kacchan didn't seem to suspect a thing the following morning, when Izuku turned up for the usual morning routines. He was grouchy as ever, slouched over on the edge of his bed, arm already propped on a pillow when Izuku entered his room. His mismatched eyes darted up to meet Izuku's and he sat up a little straighter.

"Well?" he muttered. Izuku shook his head, the lie feeling like acid in his veins as Kacchan flopped back onto his bed, arms spread wide.

"Not gonna have any fucking blood left at this rate."

"I'm sorry, Kacchan." And he meant it.

"The fuck you sorry about, ain't your fault," Kacchan replied, before sitting back up with a grunt. "Alright, stick 'er in me."

Izuku went about taking his two usual samples, hiding one in the pocket of his jumpsuit and placing the other in a cellophane bag that he clipped to the paperwork. Kacchan glumly looked back at his reflection in the mirror over the sink, angling his jaw this way and that as if inspecting his scars from different angles. He hadn't said anything about them, not yet. Izuku wasn't sure when he had first been shown the extent of the damage but he supposed that Kacchan must feel *something* about it all.

He leaned back, watching Kacchan for a moment longer before he seemed to realise that Izuku was done, and he raised both arms above his head and stretched with a loud undignified yawn.

"Do they bother you?"

Izuku hadn't meant to blurt the question out, and his face burned in embarrassment when Kacchan looked back at him, arms dropping to his lap.

"Do what bother me?"

"The, uh-" Izuku swallowed, hand reaching up to gesture vaguely to his face. "The scars."

Kacchan's face remained impassive.

"Do they bother *you?* "

"Of course not!" Izuku replied immediately. "It's just that… you've not said anything about them. And I want you to know that you can talk to me about it if- if you ever needed to."

Kacchan continued to look at him for a moment longer, Izuku feeling itchy under his intense gaze before he shrugged.

"Course they *bother me* ," he said. "Blasted half my face off, and I can hardly see shit out of this eye now. I'd much rather be that handsome bastard with twenty-twenty vision again. But-" he took

a deep breath, waving both his arms around vaguely. “I dunno. I don’t really care. It’s just… whatever. Another shitty thing in a long line of shitty things.”

“Well, I think you’re still handsome,” Izuku replied, trying to ignore how red his face must be at this point. “And your eye is pretty.”

But, instead of smiling back at him, Kacchan tensed.

“You don’t have to do that,” he muttered.

“Do what?”

“Say shit like that. Make up stuff so I feel better about it. I can still see, Deku, I know how bad it looks.”

Izuku spared the doorway a glance, to be sure that no one was checking in on them before he stood in front of Kacchan. He gently nudged his way between Kacchan’s spread knees, reaching out to take Kacchan’s face in his hands so that he would look up at him. For all his gruff bravado, Kacchan suddenly looked very unsure.

“I’m not making stuff up,” Izuku said firmly, heart beating in his throat. Sentimental was never really them, not spoken out loud at least, the both of them choosing to let their actions say what was needed. But, Izuku had spent far too long tasting the bitter-sweet words that he had never said, and he wasn’t about to take that chance again.

“I spent three months thinking I’d never see your face again. No amount of scars will ever stop you from being the most beautiful thing in the world to me.”

And Kacchan blushed, his cheeks and ears flushing to the purest shade of pink and making his bad eye glow.

“What the fuck,” he croaked, voice small and hoarse. “You can’t just- *you can’t just say shit like that.* ”

“Sure I can,” Izuku replied, with a bright smile, before he leaned forward and pressed a kiss against Kacchan’s forehead. “What are you gonna do about it?”

“At least- *fuck* , at least warn me first.”

Izuku snorted, leaning back, Kacchan’s face still in his hands. For a moment, they could do nothing but stare, Izuku enjoying every colour in Kacchan’s eyes before he watched them drift down, Izuku feeling his lips burn for the heartbeat that his gaze touched them, then Kacchan was pulling away, clearing his throat and rubbing his palms down his thighs.

“I’m starving.”

“Yeh, me too.”

When Izuku excused himself for the bathroom after breakfast to infect himself with Kacchan’s blood, what he should have been thinking about was what it could mean for the world if this

worked. But instead, his only thoughts were of what it would be like to finally feel more than Kacchan's gaze on his lips.

Izuku checked his blood twice. Once twelve hours after, and then again twelve hours after that, and each time the results were the same. No symptoms, no starbursts, *no virus* . No signs that he had ever been infected and Izuku was left to make a final, life-changing, *impossible* conclusion.

He really was immune.

No longer in theory, he was to his knowledge the only person in the world immune to the zombie virus and as much as he felt sure he should be celebrating right now, rushing off to Kacchan to tell him the good news, he was plagued with the question of *why* . How was he immune? What made him so different, and what was it that left him able to fight the virus off entirely whilst Kacchan was still infected? There could be any number of factors, but his thoughts kept spiralling back to the same thing… the illness that he had when he was a child, the one that wiped almost all of his early childhood memories from his mind, including knowing Kacchan. And there was only one person who might know more than they already told him.

Late that morning found Izuku standing outside of his mother's room, hand raised and hesitant. He knew that she would be sleeping after working the night shift, and he didn't want to wake her, but it was important and though he wouldn't be able to explain just *how* important, he hoped that she would understand. He took a deep breath and knocked.

"Mum? It's me, I'm sorry to wake you."

There was some shuffling behind the door, and before long it was opened, a worried look on her face.

"Izuku! Baby, is everything ok?"

"I'm ok. I just… I need to ask you something if that's ok? It's… it's important."

Inko only appeared *more* concerned at this, nodding her head and gathering her dressing gown around her as she stepped back to let him in.

"What happened?" she asked immediately, shutting the door and turning on the light. "Something in the lab? Oh baby, you didn't get hurt did you?"

"No, nothing like that!" Izuku said. "I'm really ok, mum. Honestly. I just needed to ask you about that time I was sick as a kid."

Inko looked puzzled, if not somewhat relieved. "But it was such a long time ago, Izuku. Why do you need to know about that?"

"I think it's important," Izuku replied. "And I can't tell you why exactly, not yet anyway, but it would really help if you could tell me everything you remembered about it."

"Important?" Inko breathed. " *Virus* important?"

Izuku swallowed. As much as he wanted to tell her everything, there was no way he could put her

at risk with what he knew.

“Mum, please.”

Inko’s eyes were wide, fingers worrying with the sleeves of her dressing gown, but she nodded. “Ok. Ok, uh… what do you need to know?”

“Whatever you remember,” Izuku urged gently. “Mum, why don’t you sit down first?”

“Right.”

Inko paced a little more, before finally sitting on the edge of the bed, Izuku dropping down beside her.

“I try not to think about it too much,” Inko admitted. “It was… it was the worst time of my life before, well, before all of this.” She breathed shakily. “I might have played down how serious it was, but you got very ill. What started with a case of mono, something children get over all the time, turned into something far more serious and so much quicker than I could deal with. You were having these… these stomach pains, I’d never seen you cry like that.”

Her voice wobbled and she sniffed, choking back a sob. Izuku reached out and took her hand.

“It’s ok, mum. I’m ok.”

Inko nodded, not trusting herself to speak for a few moments before she continued.

“The doctors had never seen anything like it. You were diagnosed with Epstein-Barr the Monday morning, and by Tuesday night we had to rush you into the emergency room. Massive organ failure, they said. Liver, kidney, they were shutting down and I- I didn’t know what to do.”

She looked up at the ceiling, blinking furiously.

“They put you into a medically induced coma for two weeks, you were just in so much pain and you were so sick they… I’m glad that I had Mitsuki at the time, I don’t know how I would have survived that without her.”

“Was Kacchan just as sick?”

“Worse,” Inko replied softly. “He crashed two days in. We all thought that- well.”

She wiped her sleeve over her eyes, and Izuku’s stomach churned.

“It was a very rare reaction to the virus, and you were only getting worse. Nothing the doctors did seemed to help, it wasn’t until they suggested a trial medication they had developed for autoimmune hepatitis that we started to see any improvement.”

Izuku sat up straight at this.

“Can you remember the drug's name?”

Inko shook her head. “No, I hardly paid attention to it at the time. It didn’t matter *what* it was, only that it worked. It- *Izuku* , what does this have to do with the virus? Baby, please, is there something you need to tell me?”

Her eyes were wide, pleading, full of unshed tears and Izuku had to bite back his own.

“It’s… just a hunch. I’m sorry, I-” he hesitated. "Please, trust me?”

“Oh *Izuku* ,” Inko whined, the tears spilling down her cheeks now. “What have you gotten involved in?”

“Nothing I can’t handle,” Izuku promised. “The drug, did they give it to both of us?”

“Katsuki? Yes, you were both given it. There were other children, teachers and parents I think, who were getting sick at the same time but not all of them were as ill as you were.”

“And who gave it to us? Was there, like, an organisation or- or something?”

“It was just the doctors,” Inko replied, shaking her head somewhat hopelessly. “Maybe I should have looked into the drug more, but at the time it-”

“It’s ok, I understand,” Izuku said, with a soft smile.

“You were still sick for a while after that, it took months for you to recover enough to be able to go back to school, and even then things like your memory were affected. We worried that there would be more long-term effects but, well, unless…” She gave him a decidedly anxious look but didn’t say any more.

“What else did I forget?” Izuku asked. “Besides Kacchan, I mean.”

“It’s hard to say for sure,” Inko replied. “It’s not like you forgot who you were, or who I am, but we’d realise there were events you couldn’t remember, things you’d learned at school that you needed to learn again. It never seemed to affect you, though Mitsuki and I were often puzzled by how neither of you remembered one another. Once it was all over, we thought you’d go back to playing together, but you didn’t seem to like little Katsuki much after that. And they moved shortly after.”

Izuku frowned, trying to remember ever meeting Kacchan as a child, but there was nothing. It felt far too coincidental for memories of Kacchan to have been lost, but surely there wasn’t a drug that could attack certain memories? That felt even more nonsensical than the zombie virus itself. But what wasn’t a coincidence was just *how* sick he and Kacchan had been, the liver damage, the symptoms that mirrored so much of what was already seen in bite victims.

“Ok,” Izuku said. “Thank you, I’m sorry you had to think about it all again.”

“Izuku.” Inko shifted around to face him, taking both his hands in hers. “Are you *safe* ? Can you at least tell me that?”

Izuku hesitated, the hair on the back of his arms standing on end as the weight of those words sunk in.

“Yes,” he lied through his smile. “Don’t worry, nothing is going to happen to me.”

He could tell that she didn’t believe him.

When he wandered back towards the lab that afternoon, Kacchan gave him a significant look when Izuku drew just one syringe of blood, and Izuku breathed a quiet *‘tonight’* before going back to his room, mind a mess, and passing out for several hours.

It was two in the morning when he woke up, late enough that he felt confident that none of the nomu would be awake, and he was unlikely to run into Aizawa or Toshinori at the facility. He felt a little bad for keeping Kacchan waiting this long, especially if he hadn’t slept the entire night expecting Izuku to turn up, but now that the time had arrived Izuku felt sick with anxiety. He still didn’t have *any* answers for Kacchan, if anything it would all prompt more questions, and there was the absolute certainty that Kacchan would be furious with him when he revealed the lengths he’d gone to to prove his theory. He dressed slowly, pausing to brush his teeth and freshen up where he could, certain thoughts drifting just below the surface, and made his way towards the facility where Kacchan and the others were kept.

It was blessedly dark and quiet and he walked down the corridors, excuse in place should anyone see him and ask where he was going, but there wasn’t a single soul around, and the living area of the facility was silent beside the hum of the refrigerator. He crept towards Kacchan’s door, pulling out his keycard and wincing at the gentle click of the lock that might well have been a gunshot for how it filled the room. He paused, breath held, but when no one stirred he quickly slipped inside and gently shut the door behind him.

Kacchan was wide awake, sitting on his bed and leaning against the wall with a book in hand, reading with the pitiful night light at his side.

“I was starting to think something might have happened,” he said, throwing the book down.

“Sorry,” Izuku replied. “I guess I was more tired than I thought.”

Kacchan scowled.

“Don’t tell me you’ve not been sleeping through all this? Come on, Deku-”

“I’m fine,” Izuku interrupted, altogether tired of telling people this. He took a deep breath, Kacchan staring at him with both brows raised. “Ok, there’s something I need to tell you. And I need you to listen. Please don’t interrupt me or- or get angry-”

“Why would I get angry, Deku?” Kacchan interrupted immediately, his voice a low growl of warning as he sat up straighter on the bed.

“See? This is what I’m talking about! I’m never going to be able to get through this if you keep interrupting me!”

Kacchan gnashed his teeth together, hackles still up but he raised his hand, twisting it in a *‘go on’* gesture.

“Right.” Izuku wrung his hands together and began to pace, anything so that he wouldn’t have to see the expression on Kacchan’s face when he told him what he needed to tell him. “Ok. So, I realised something these last few months, ok? About you, but mostly about me too. And it was like… like I knew something wasn’t right, but the more I thought about it the more impossible it all felt.”

“Deku, if you want me to stay quiet you’re gonna need to start getting the point a whole lot quicker.”

“Sorry! Sorry, you’re right, uh.” He stopped pacing, turning on the spot, dragging a hand through his hair. He really should have planned this all out before coming here. “Fuck, I should probably just… just say it.”

“Say *what* ?” Kacchan hissed.

“I think I’m immune.”

Kacchan gaped, the silence drawing out between them.

“What?”

“I mean, I *know* I’m immune,” Izuku continued. “I proved it. With absolute certainty.”

Kacchan mouthed silently, a dumbfounded expression on his face before he shook his head almost violently and scooted to the edge of his bed.

“What do you mean *immune?* ” He paused, and his face tightened dangerously. “Deku. What do you mean you *proved it?* ”

“Just… think about it,” Izuku said. “How many times should I have been infected but wasn’t? After the RV, I had a massive open wound and you took care of me and somehow not one drop of your sweat got in? The time you kissed me, and Mr Zombig, and- and how close we were to one another all the time-”

“Might have been lucky,” Kacchan grunted.

“Right, and that’s what we *told* ourselves. But then there was Dabi. And I-” he hesitated, thinking back to that day, the confusion and the pain, the rage he felt as he threw himself onto Dabi and punched him with all the strength that he had. “You infected him when you bit him, and maybe back then I could have told myself that it didn’t happen that fast, but I’ve been here long enough to know just how quickly the virus moves. I split my knuckles open punching him, his blood was mixed with mine. And you were bleeding so much, and it was all over my hands. There’s *no way* I wasn’t infected then.”

“Dog Eyes, he said himself, you weren’t infected when they tested your blood. Deku, if you were infected then you should be like *me* -”

“But I’m not. I have tested my blood over and over and there is no sign of the virus. None at all.”

Kacchan stared at him, eyes wide.

“But I- I needed to be sure. So I took samples of my blood, mixed it with infected blood, from zombies, from *you* . And the virus died, every single time.”

“What- what about the hormone markers or whatever?”

“Normal. That’s… that’s not all though. And I really need for you to not freak out over this, ok? Someone could hear and-”

“I swear to fuck Deku if you don’t come out with it right now I’ll shake it out of you.”

“I infected myself with your blood.”

For a moment, Kacchan did nothing. He sat there, staring at Izuku, face impassive, and Izuku thought that perhaps he was going to take this far better than expected. But then Kacchan was on his feet, his face turning red with anger, stomping towards him.

“You-” he stopped, nostrils flaring, hand raised and pointing aggressively towards Izuku. “Hng- you- *hrrngh* -”

He threw his hands into the air, marched in a circle, grabbed at the short tufts of his hair, snorted, then marched back to Izuku again, hand reaching out and grabbing hold of the front of his jumpsuit.

“You *infected yourself* ?” he hissed, voice as quiet as he could manage and looking like he was about to explode. “ *I’m going to kill you!* ”

“I thought you might react like this,” Izuku said sheepishly, shifting under Kacchan’s burning hot glare.

“ *And that still didn’t stop you?* ” Kacchan had him in both hands now, shaking him furiously.

“Ka-ah-stop shaking me!”

He grabbed Kacchan’s wrists, and mercifully he stopped trying to dislodge his head from his body.

“How are you so clever and so *stupid* ?” Kacchan all but whined, dropping Izuku and dragging his hands over his own face.

“I had to,” Izuku breathed. “Kacchan, I was as certain as I could be that nothing would happen to me, ok? And it *didn’t* . I’m not infected. I’m clean.”

Kacchan spread his fingers, peering at him from over his hand almost as if he was afraid to.

“Oh you better not be screwing with me,” he hissed.

“I’m not. I promise. I don’t know why I’m not affected the same way you are or anyone else, but… I can’t get it. The virus won’t infect me.”

Kacchan made an uncomfortable-sounding noise in his throat and began to pace again. For several minutes, he didn’t say a word, scowling, pacing, throwing glares at Izuku any time he opened his

mouth to speak. Finally, he stopped.

“No one can know.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku said softly. “I’m going to have to tell them at some point-”

“No,” Kacchan snarled. “No fucking discussion, you cannot tell anyone.”

“But what’s the point of being immune if I can’t *help people* ,” Izuku insisted. “What if what’s made me immune can be used to cure others.”

“Have you looked around recently, Deku?” Kacchan threw his arms out either side of him. “I am a prisoner here. They locked me up and took my blood and they’re never letting me go, and *I’m* infected! What do you think they’ll do with you when they find out?”

“They wouldn’t kill me-”

“Oh, bullshit. They only keep us around because we can herd zombies or what the fuck ever. We’re useful. But you? They’ll scrap you for fucking parts! You can’t tell them. This stays between us. Forever.”

“You know I can’t do that.”

Kacchan threw him a helpless look, before he walked back over, grabbing Izuku’s wrists.

“Deku, all of this, everything that’s happened, I can tolerate just about fucking anything so long as you’re alive and you’re safe. So help me, Deku, if anything happens to you I will kill every fucking person in this place.”

Izuku swallowed. “Th-that’s sweet, Kacchan but it almost sounds like a threat.”

“It is,” Kacchan growled. “It is a threat, you dumb bastard. I’m not good like you. I never have been. I am angry and selfish and fucking dangerous so you best believe me when I say there is nothing that could stop me from getting to you if they took you from me. You got it? You tell them, you *kill them* . I don’t care if you hate me for it.”

Izuku could hardly breathe, the air so thick and so hot around him, grateful that Kacchan had so tight a grip on him that he wouldn’t stumble and fall to the ground. And it should hurt, it should be killing him, hearing Kacchan talk like that, his expression hard and scared and desperate all at the same time. He should be disgusted, frightened even, but instead, he remembered the endless rage he had felt when Dabi kicked Kacchan in the face, seeing only red as he pounded his fists into the man over and over until there was very little left to hit. Izuku was no different, no better. He wasn’t good, either. How could he be, when deep down he knew what Kacchan had already accepted, when it came between Kacchan and everybody else, there was never going to be a competition.

“I could never hate you,” Izuku breathed. Kacchan’s face softened, eyes searching Izuku’s face. “I won’t tell them. Just… just between us.”

“Just between us,” Kacchan agreed.

Their breaths simmered, their faces so close and so hot, and Izuku swore he could taste the static coming from him as Kacchan, subconsciously or not, licked his lips, the flash of pink drawing Izuku's attention immediately. Kacchan seemed to have stopped breathing, his hands clammy around Izuku's wrists, lips parting as Izuku breathed in.

"You won't infect me," he whispered.

Izuku looked up from Kacchan's lips, and gasped at the intensity with which Kacchan was watching him, pupils already blown wide.

"Deku," he choked. "Are you *sure*- "

He couldn't wait any more, a year of *wanting* too hard a thing to fight back as Izuku grabbed Kacchan's face and crashed into him. Lips were crushed against teeth, and hot breaths were exchanged as Kacchan curled his hands into Deku's hair and tugged. Izuku wasn't sure who moaned, whether it might have been both of them, but the delicious, desperate sound was like liquid fire in his veins, and he opened his mouth, wet and clumsy tongues sliding against each other as though desperate to crawl inside.

It hurt, his lips stung and Kacchan's teeth were dragging hungrily against his tongue, but he never wanted it to end. Perhaps he imagined their first real kiss to be romantic, and sweet, but this filthy, uncoordinated dance, as desperate as it is, was perfect.

Kacchan tugged harder on Izuku's hair, dragging a groan from him as he began to haul him backwards, his strength never more apparent in the way he effortlessly pulled Izuku down, the two bouncing slightly as they landed on the uncomfortable bed. Kacchan's legs spread as Izuku found himself between them, their lips never parting, hungry moans filling the room when Izuku grabbed Kacchan's lower lip and dragged it through his teeth.

" *Kacchan* ."

The kiss grew softer as they learned to move together, Kacchan's tongue dipping in and sampling every part of Izuku's mouth that he could reach, and Izuku lost himself in the sensation. He couldn't believe that he ever thought Kacchan would be *bad* at this, filling him so completely and possessively, fingernails scratching at his scalp in a way that had him shivering. Everything was so wet and dimly Izuku thought that maybe it was all too wet, alarm bells ringing as he drew back slightly, eyes unfocused and hazy and he looked down at Kacchan, seeing the tears dripping freely down his face.

"Kacchan?"

He reached up, thumb sliding over the tears on Kacchan's cheek. Kacchan watched him through heavily lidded eyes, panting and breathless.

"Don't you dare stop."

When Kacchan tugged him back, Izuku went willingly, chasing the pleasure that Kacchan was offering him, tongues tangled together as Izuku was full of the overwhelming need to *touch* . He needed Kacchan closer, he needed to feel everything, all of him until he was more the perfect, *beautiful* man beneath him than he was himself. With a fumbling, shaking hand, Izuku reached

between them, grabbing as much of Kacchan's hard cock as he could reach over the ugly pyjama bottoms, and Kacchan moaned, body arching and gasping into Izuku's mouth.

"More," Kacchan whined. "God, more, Deku *more* ."

And Izuku was all too glad to oblige, shifting himself down, preening at the way Kacchan chased his mouth and whimpered when it was out of reach.

" *Deku* -"

"Shh," Izuku whispered, fumbling with the waistband of Kacchan's pyjamas and underwear, tugging them down as one until his dick sprung free, the heady scent from between Kacchan's thighs making Izuku groan, burying his face into Kacchan's neck to muffle the sound. Kacchan gasped, trembling and pushing his hips upwards into Izuku's grip, his hot length finally in his grasp.

" *Fuck.* "

"Kacchan," Izuku whined, feeling dizzy with it, overwhelmed by how hot and how soft Kacchan's skin was in his hand, the slide growing wetter each time Izuku curled his palm around the tip of his cock before dragging downwards. Kacchan was making sounds like he was in pain, trying to muffle his cries with his fist, Izuku entirely uncaring of whether or not anyone could hear them as he chased after Kacchan's pleasure as if it were his own. And it might well have been, everything fuzzy around the edges, each tight-fisted pump up and down Kacchan's cock matching the pulsing of his own, still trapped in his clothes, the only pressure the desperate press of himself against Kacchan's leg.

"I'm gonna-" Kacchan gasped, and Izuku heard himself whimper, pressing open-mouthed kisses across the front of Kacchan's throat.

"Please," he breathed. "Let go, I've got you."

But Kacchan shook his head, weakly pawing at the back of Izuku's head, fingers tangling into his hair.

"Deku, *Izuku* , kiss- kiss me-"

Izuku couldn't bring himself to stop touching Kacchan for a moment, his lips dragging clumsily over his throat and jaw until he was falling into his mouth once more, Kacchan eager to meet him. It took one more swipe over the head of Kacchan's cock, dragging the wetness there downwards at the same time that he licked into the roof of Kacchan's mouth, and his body was arching perfectly. Hips crashing upwards, small desperate gasps and pleas, as Kacchan came, filling Izuku's hand with hot cum. Izuku felt dazed, ears ringing, whispering *something* , he honestly had no idea, onto Kacchan's lips as he came down.

They lay there, panting against one another, Izuku only dimly aware that he was still hard in his jumpsuit as his hand dripped onto Kacchan's stomach, and that he probably ought to do something about that before it stained their clothes and prompted some awkward questions.

"You good?" Izuku whispered.

“Hnngk,” Kacchan replied, intelligibly, eyes shut, and Izuku laughed.

Kacchan’s eyes snapped open then, looking down between them.

“You go?”

“Nah,” Izuku replied softly. “But it’s fine, don’t worry about me.”

“Not on your fucking life,” Kacchan replied immediately, in a display of his strength that would always leave Izuku swooning, Izuku found himself pinned beneath Kacchan’s thighs, his soft dick still hanging out of his bottoms, this lower stomach stretched out and visible beneath his tank top, and Izuku was left breathless all over again.

Kacchan wasted no time unbuttoning the front of Izuku’s jumpsuit, tugging impatiently as if trying to restrain himself from tearing them straight off.

“Mhm- wait, Kacchan-”

He raised his hand, and Kacchan’s eyes darted over, narrowingly hungrily as he saw the cum smeared over his palm and wrist.

“Keep it, I might want it.”

“Wh- *hah?* ”

Kacchan went back to what he had been doing, undoing the last buttons and tugging at the already baggy crotch of Izuku’s poorly fitted jumpsuit. He hooked his fingers into his boxers and dragged them down too, Izuku gasping as his painfully hard dick is finally free.

“Mhm, Kacchan-”

But the words are punched from his chest as Kacchan leans down and, without any hesitation, shoves Izuku’s cock to the back of his throat, gagging hard but squeezing his eyes shut. It was Izuku’s turn to gag himself, frantically grabbing what he could of Kacchan’s blanket and shoving it between his teeth as Kacchan swallowed once, *twice* , around his dick and drew back. Mismatched eyes met Izuku’s, and he supposed he must look ridiculous, sheets in his mouth and eyes wide because Kacchan grinned like the cat who just got the cream.

“Gimme that.”

“Fwahmt?” Izuku puzzled into the blanket before Kacchan reached up dragged his fingers over Izuku’s filthy hand and Izuku realised he was probably only three breaths away from fainting in the spot. He had barely a second to steady himself before he felt wet, hot fingers circling over his hole, Kacchan thrusting up to the second knuckle at the same time he swallowed him down into his mouth again.

Izuku might have screamed, it was hard to tell *what* was happening around the gag in his mouth and the ringing in his ears and the tears in his eyes. He writhed, back arching, wanting to fuck into Kacchan’s mouth at the same time as fucking down onto his finger as he filled him with his own

cum. Never, in Izuku's life, had he been with anyone like Kacchan, and for all their gentle sweet lovemaking of the past, as much as he had *adored* it, there was something more than a little addictive about seeing a Kacchan set free. A Kacchan wanting and finally able to enjoy Izuku's body just as he wanted to. They'd never talked about their kinks, about what really got them going, but as he watched the blissed-out expression on Kacchan's face as he moaned around Izuku's cock, the pumping of his big, strong arm, Izuku realised he couldn't fucking wait.

When Kacchan introduced a second finger, pressing firmly up against the bundle of nerves he was as talented at finding on the first try as he was everything in life, Izuku came undone. His back arched, keening high and desperate into his gag, spilling down Kacchan's throat who swallowed it all like it was a gift, before they both collapsed onto the bed.

After a few moments, Kacchan dragged himself up, Izuku reaching for him blindly and tugging until he flopped down over Izuku's chest, grumbling something into his neck. Izuku laughed.

"Still good?"

"Better than," Kacchan managed, and Izuku could feel the grin against his skin, the only warning he got before Kacchan was gently tugging at his skin with his teeth.

"Don't eat me," Izuku protested with another laugh.

"M'why not. You taste good and m'always hungry."

Kacchan nuzzled up against him, pressing a kiss on the spot he had just bitten, and Izuku's heart did somersaults in his chest.

"Never thought we'd be able to do that."

"Me neither," Kacchan said.

"It's much better with kissing."

"Definitely."

Izuku smiled, enjoying the warm weight of Kacchan lying half on top of him, and let his fingers trail gently over the short hair on the back of his neck, Kacchan breathing deeply.

"I think that's the first time I've had angry sex."

Kacchan snorted, looking up at him. "Funny, coz the first time I had sex that *wasn't* angry was with you."

"Really? That's… oh."

"Don't you pity me," Kacchan said before he bit down on Izuku's jaw. Izuku yelped, watching the cruel grin twist on Kacchan's face and realising, perhaps for the first time just what he had signed up for in choosing Kacchan. "You liked it, right?"

Izuku blushed and nodded.

“Well then, lucky for you I’ve got *loads* of experience,” Kacchan smirked.

“Oh.” Izuku picked at the blanket beneath him. “Uh, how- how much experience?”

“You asking me my body count? Damn, we must be pretty serious.”

“Kacchan! Don’t make fun of me.”

“Well then, more than six, less than a dozen. How’s that?”

“Oh.”

“Oh?”

“That’s… it’s… oh.”

“So, what about you?”

“A lot less.”

“Aww poor baby,” Kacchan purred, and Izuku could see the delight sparkling behind his eyes as he leaned forward, their lips just touching. “Guess you got some catching up to do.”

Izuku sighed into the kiss, so much softer and lazier than the ones they had shared until now, and probably the very best kiss of his life. He lost himself in the sensation, the taste of Kacchan, his closeness, the gentle caress of his cheek, until their lips parted and Kacchan let his head rest back against Izuku’s shoulder.

“Y’know, I still had more to tell you,” Izuku ventured eventually. “I have a theory about what happened, about why we’re both different from everyone else when it comes to the virus.”

“Yeh?”

“Do you remember being sick when you were a kid?”

Kacchan shifted, propping himself up on his elbow and looking down at him.

“Me?”

“Yeh. You said you remember knowing me back then, that we used to be friends, right? In a dream or something?”

Kacchan’s eyes searched his face before he nodded. “I think it was a memory,” he said. “I dunno, I thought I was dying. It could have been a hallucination for all know.”

“I think it was real,” Izuku replied. “Our mums knew one another, we used to play together.” He paused and blushed. “I think you were my best friend, actually.”

“Guess you were always weak to my charms,” Kacchan said with a smirk.

“We both got sick when we were four or five. I asked my mum about it yesterday, and she said that we both almost died, we were in medically induced comas and our livers were shutting down.”

Kacchan scowled.

“The fuck? I knew something had happened back then, my parents mentioned it enough, but I don’t *remember* being in fucking hospital and almost dying. They’d have told me! You sure your mum’s got this right?”

“I’m certain,” Izuku said.

“Well, what the hell got us so sick?”

“Mono.”

“ *Hah?* ”

“That’s what she said. We got mono, we got really sick, liver and renal failure.”

“Liver failure,” Kacchan repeated.

“Right. That can’t be a coincidence. And there’s more.”

“More?”

“They decided to put us on a trial drug, something used for treating hepatitis, and it worked.”

And at that Kacchan stared, before he let out a bark of laughter, making Izuku jump as he flopped back onto the bed.

“Oh, you gotta be fucking kidding me.”

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 44: Dead Set

Chapter Summary

In which things come to light and secrets are revealed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku supposed he came to his senses far too late; clamping a hand over Kacchan's mouth and attempting to smother the hysterical laughter he hooted to the ceiling. There were tears in his eyes and he was charmed enough to allow Izuku's attempts to pass with little more than a hard slap to his chest.

"Why are you laughing?" Izuku hissed, only slightly winded from the impact. "Someone is going to hear you!"

"I'm laughing because it's *funny,* Deku," Kacchan replied as if it were obvious. He wiped the tears from his eyes and sat up. "It's fucking hilarious."

"I don't see what's so funny about it," Izuku huffed, casting a nervous look towards the door. "If I'm right, we were *drugged* , Kacchan. They drugged kids!"

"If you're right they've been doing a whole lot worse than that." Kacchan cocked his head towards the wall to their left. "And *he's* gotta be five years older than us. Fat and Armless a good ten."

"So why is it funny?" Izuku repeated brow scrunched together.

"Because! The whole situation! Dumbass, someone did this on purpose and you've gotta come to the same conclusion I have by now. You've been sitting on this shit far longer."

" *What* conclusion?" Izuku asked, feeling irritated now.

Kacchan sighed, rolling his eyes dramatically. "You don't think it's just a little bit too much of a fucking coincidence? I bet you anything that all the nomu lived in Musutafu at some point. Fuck, I bet they all went to the same damn hospital where they got injected with the same fucking trial drug. And now they end up here to be studied? I'm telling you, Deku, this shit was home-brewed."

Izuku swallowed. He *had* already considered this.

"You really think it all started here?" he asked, reaching up to tug his lower lip.

"At this point, I'd be shocked if it *hadn't* ," Kacchan replied.

Izuku groaned, pulling his knees up to his chin and rubbing his hands over his face. Of course, he

had considered this. Kacchan was right, it was far too much of a coincidence, but it still made his head hurt.

“We don’t know it was started on purpose,” Izuku reasoned, through the gap between his palms. “The drug we were given as kids might have nothing to do with this, it might just be luck that it’s given us some kind of… of *resistance* to a virus later down the line.”

“I’m no doctor, but don’t all vaccines have an expiry date?”

“Well yeh, but some only last a few years, others last longer than your average human lifespan. It varies.”

“Well, that’s helpful,” Kacchan huffed.

“My mum said it was offered to us as a trial drug. Why would they be trialling the same medication every, what, five years?”

“Improve their sample size? I don’t fucking know.”

“They can’t have *given* us the virus,” Izuku reasoned. “We know that you can infect people, and it isn’t like you’ve been turning people into zombies your whole li-” Izuku froze, his eyes widening.

“What?”

“Wh-what if we’ve always been infected?”

“You *just* said we’ve not been turning people into zombies.”

Izuku got to his feet, only vaguely aware of the fact that his jumpsuit was hanging down by his knees when he almost tripped over, scrabbling to yank it up around his waist. He heard Kacchan groan, before flopping back on the bed with a *thud* .

“Stop nerding out.”

Izuku ignored him, pacing back and forth, hands fumbling with the sleeves of his jumpsuit as he tried to slip his arms back into them.

“Say this drug we were given when we were five, say it was- was a *version* of the virus as we know it now. A prototype or something.”

“Say it is.”

“And every five years, there’s a convenient outbreak of mono and they inject a bunch of kids with it, and send those kids back out into the world where they can proceed to spread the virus to virtually everyone that they come into contact with.”

Kacchan supported himself up by his elbows, looking down at him.

“Which means, for the last fifteen- no, scrap that, the last *thirty* years at least the virus has been gradually spreading across the entire of Japan, the rest of the *world* , infecting everyone without

anyone knowing, without there being any symptoms."

"I see where you're going with this," Kacchan interrupted. "But how can a virus just lay *dormant* for fucking years and suddenly get switched on?"

Izuku stopped and pulled at his lower lip again as he looked back at Kacchan, considering. It *couldn't* , at least to his knowledge it wasn't possible to do something like that, certainly not on purpose. But somewhere among these facts were the clues he needed to put this thing together if only he could find them.

"Unless it ain't the same virus," Kacchan said with a shrug.

Izuku's eyes widened, and he gasped. "Hepatitis!"

"Excuse you?"

"That's what the drug we were given was supposed to treat! That's what almost killed us, a liver infection!"

"So… the virus is *hepatitis* ?"

"No no," Izuku said, rushing forward excitedly and grabbing both of Kacchan's hands. "It's… oh, it's genius!"

"Clearly."

"There's a type of drug used to treat hepatitis, called IFNs-"

"And that means?"

"Interferons," Izuku replied, with a hasty shake of his head. "The name doesn't matter, what does matter is that there are some viruses that, sort of, *antagonise* the IFNs, meaning that you might get much sicker than you would have done without it. What if… what if there was a way to bioengineer one of these drugs so that it would multiply and spread like a virus, but it never made you sick? It just speeds up the pathogenesis of *another* virus."

"So, it's like a sleeper agent?" Kacchan said, still allowing his hands to be gripped far too tightly in Izuku's own. "Unlocks the doors to let the actual fucking enemy in?"

"Exactly!"

"But why? Why not just release the zombie plague, why the thirty years of extra work?"

"The zombie virus changes the function of our endocrine system, it changes how our bodies *work* . Just because you can engineer a virus like a zombie virus doesn't mean you can guarantee it'll infect everyone, not without prior immunosuppression."

"So, what makes us different?"

"We're patient zero," Izuku replied. "Perhaps the original host isn't affected in the same way.

Though… I can't make sense of how that would work right now."

"You're saying that someone has spent the last thirty years, *at least* , cultivating the fucking apocalypse? Fuck, I knew Shigaraki was a dick but that's going a bit overboard."

"We don't know that it was Shigaraki."

"We don't know it *wasn't* ," Kacchan reasoned. "I mean, how old is that guy? How long have he and your Professor been working together? I was in a different field of chemistry but even I knew about them, they've been in virology for decades."

Izuku paled, and stepped back, his hands sliding out from Kacchan's.

"Professor Toshinori wouldn't do something like this."

"And Shigaraki?"

Izuku swallowed, glancing back at the door again.

"I don't… I never met him. I know he and Professor Toshinori worked together, but it's not like he walked around calling himself a villain or something."

"Well, it's still too big a coincidence," Kacchan reasoned with a shrug. "Musutafu is ground zero for this thing and UA is at the fucking centre of it."

Izuku couldn't argue with that.

"Not that any of this helps us," Kacchan continued. "You could come up with the cure tomorrow and it'd be buried. Whilst Shigaraki is still running this place we're fucked. What we *should* be doing is figuring out how we can get rid of him."

"If- if we could find some way to prove that he was the one who started the virus, that he did it on purpose, maybe no one will be willing to work for him anymore."

"Sure, it's a start. But Shigaraki threatened our friends if we didn't go along with what he wanted, what makes you think he hasn't used this same tactic for everyone else? You see any armed guards around here? Because I don't. He doesn't need to show his hand, everyone already knows the fucking score, I don't think anyone will stand up to him if it means their friends and family getting thrown out to the zombies."

"So… what's the alternative?"

"You *know* the alternative," Kacchan replied coldly. Izuku's breath caught in his throat.

"I- Kacchan, are you asking me to-"

"I'm not asking you to do anything, Deku." Kacchan got to his feet. "You're immune to the virus, but I'm the one that can get bit and blown up and gutted and still come out standing." He grimaced. "If he's the one to blame for all this shit, I'm gonna make damn *sure* he regrets making me."

“That- *Kacchan* , it’s too risky-”

“So we take our time,” Kacchan interrupted. “We keep playing along, doing what they tell us, let them think we’ve given up. Until the time is right.”

Izuku let out a shaky breath and nodded.

“Good boy,” Kacchan said, openly smirking when Izuku immediately felt the blood rush to his cheeks. “It must be getting pretty late. You don’t wanna get caught.”

“R-right,” Izuku looked down at his watch, seeing that it was nearing four in the morning. “Shit, there’s going to be people in the labs soon.”

“You gotta be back here in two hours. Look, we need to think this shit over anyway, we’ll talk again in a couple nights' time?”

Izuku nodded, buttoning up his jumpsuit and turning towards the door.

“I’ll- I’ll see what I can find out from Toshinori, without being obvious about it. I dunno, ask him some things about his old research, there are books lying around it’s not like we’re not allowed to talk about it.”

“Sounds good. Oh, and Deku?”

“Hmm?”

Izuku looked around just in time to feel Kacchan’s fingers wrap around his jaw, gently but firmly tugging him forward, letting out a muffled squeak when Kacchan’s lips pressed against his. He might have been embarrassed about how quickly he leaned into it, all but melting into the kiss and dragging his hands up Kacchan’s chest before it abruptly ended, Izuku blinking dopily as he attempted to find his lips again.

Kacchan, ever the tease, grinned, teeth glinting in the low glow from the night light.

“See if you can find some lube for that talk in a few days.”

Izuku knew his face must be bright red by this point, and he could only nod as Kacchan lay back on his bed, smirking at him from between his spread legs.

“N’night, Deku.”

“N-night,” Izuku replied, backing towards the door until he bumped hard against it, regretfully dragging his eyes away from Kacchan as he fumbled with the lock, and eased his way out into the common area.

No one else seemed to be awake yet, which was incredibly fortunate. Despite his fear of running into Aizawa at any moment, Izuku couldn’t stop his mind from drifting back to Kacchan’s room. They had *kissed.* He had kissed Kacchan, and Kacchan had kissed *him* . They’d fucking *kissed and it had been perfect.* Shit, they had kissed and they could have been doing it for a whole year if they had known. So what if Izuku was currently more irritated by all the kissing and sex they had missed

out on than he was by the knowledge that Shigaraki might have purposefully caused the Apocalypse? So what if he walked into a wall because he was too busy thinking about the tears that had leaked down Kacchan's cheeks as he begged Izuku to kiss him? *Shit* , he really should start paying attention to what was going on around him before-

"Midoriya Izuku. You're here early."

Izuku skidded to a halt, eyes wide and a chill running up his spine, as the smooth deep voice washed over him. Izuku was no stranger to fear; he had spent the last two years completely terrified. But the sensation in his limbs, his heart hammering so fast and so sudden that his chest ached, the chill in his cheeks as his blood ran cold, *was* new. Slow, steady footsteps brought the person closer behind him, the air only growing colder.

Slowly, Izuku began to turn, his eyes barely level with the chest of the man that towered over him, head tilting back to see a smile somehow only more terrifying in how gentle it was, not meeting molten eyes.

"Sh-Shigiraki," Izuku stuttered, mind racing. "Uh, sir?"

Shigaraki shrugged, shoulders shifting like boulders beneath his tailored suit jacket.

"Shigaraki is fine, I'm not your teacher."

"R-right." Izuku swallowed, taking a full step back and wincing at how obvious it had been. Shigaraki raised an eyebrow.

"Do I make you nervous?"

"I-" Izuku hesitated, glancing up and down the corridor. "I don't know how best to answer that," he admitted.

Shigaraki laughed, and Izuku tried not to let on how much his gut churned at the sound.

"So, why are you here at-" Shigaraki looked down at his watch, a Rolex of course, and hefty enough that Izuku was sure it could be used to bludgeon him to death if Shigaraki took the fancy- "four in the morning?"

"I'm always here this early," Izuku answered. And, he wasn't lying, not entirely. "I've been working. I just, uh, just wanted to wash up before the day started."

"A hard worker!" Shigaraki positively beamed. "You came highly recommended you know. Yagi has only good things to say about you. Not that I necessarily doubt Yagi's judgements, but he is quite sentimental, and given his relationship with your mother I thought perhaps his recommendation was biased. I'm pleased to see that's not the case!"

"I-" Izuku frowned. "Wh- relationship with-"

"Oh, you didn't know?"

Izuku blinked, so taken back and floored by the turn in the conversation that he could only mouth

silently for a moment, before mumbling a confused, *"No?"*

"Oops," Shigaraki said, with a cruel grin. "I'm surprised, I thought you and Yagi were close. Sort of makes you wonder what else he could be keeping from us, am I right?"

Izuku stared back, unable to speak. And then Shigaraki's hand clapped down on his shoulder and Izuku couldn't hold back his cry of shock when the man crowded in, his face close.

"Never mind, I'm sure he had his reasons. But I am impressed with you, Midoriya. Very impressed. I've been keeping a *close* eye on you since you got here, and I have to say though I disapproved of your extra-curricula studies at first, the results speak for themselves."

Izuku's eyes widened.

"Keep up the good work."

Shigaraki patted his cheek, his large thumb brushing the corner of Izuku's bad eye in a way that forced all the air from his lungs, his heart beating so fast he was afraid he might pass out there in the corridor, before Shigaraki stood straight and walked past him, not looking back. Izuku was able to hold out until he heard the door at the end of the hall swing shut, before he collapsed against the wall, grabbing his chest and hyperventilating.

He knew.

He already knew.

Izuku was far from composed when he finally made it back to the nomu lab just before six. Dressed and showered, and doing his very best to act as though he was simply tired when he entered Kacchan's room, he should have known that there would be no fooling the man. Kacchan stayed quiet, watching Izuku closely as he went through the motions, taking the blood sample, and it wasn't until Izuku placed the clipboard and sample down and removed Kacchan's tourniquet that he spoke.

"What happened?"

Izuku stiffened, glancing up but not entirely meeting Kacchan's eyes.

"Someone catch you?" Kacchan persisted, lowering his voice. " *Deku?* "

"I-"

A loud knock on the door took them both by surprise, and Izuku turned sharply as Aizawa entered, hair pulled back into a low bun, and a dark stain blooming on the pocket of his khaki jumpsuit.

"Blood tests done?" Aizawa asked.

"Yes!" Izuku replied, holding up the cellophane packet containing the sample. "Just heading down to the lab."

“Don’t,” Aizawa said. “New plan. You’re to leave that with Kayama to take care of. Today you’re both with me.”

“Doing what?” Kacchan demanded, narrowing his eyes.

“Recon,” Aizawa said as though that explained everything. “Hawks and Overhaul are coming too. No time to eat, I’m afraid, follow me and suit up.”

“Suit up?”

“We’re going topside. You’re going to need some protection.”

Izuku and Kacchan exchanged a look, taken back.

“I said follow me,” Aizawa sighed, already out the doorway.

Izuku found himself hesitating, but Kacchan shrugged in a ‘ *how bad can it be?’* gesture and followed Aizawa.

Hawks and Overhaul were already waiting outside. Mirko lounged on the couch with a pissed-off look on her face.

“Why do I have to stay here?” she demanded. She noticed Izuku and Kacchan following Aizawa and threw her hands up. “Are you kidding me? They’re going too? They’re babies!”

“Who the fuck you calling a baby, snaggletooth?” Kacchan immediately yelled.

“I don’t need you or Fat today,” Aizawa replied, holding his arm out as Mirko got to her feet, she and Kacchan glared daggers at each other. “This is already overkill if you ask me, but I need to see how they can handle themselves.”

Mirko scoffed, crossing her arms over her chest.

“I’m not happy about it, Aizawa.”

“Noted.”

“Maybe I’ll bring you back a souvenir?” Hawks said cheerfully. “I’ll keep an eye out for those sweets you like.”

“I don’t need your pity, so you know. But see if you can find the melon ones.”

“Yes ma’am!” Hawks saluted.

“Enough,” Aizawa said, raising a hand on dragging it tiredly over his face. “I don’t have the time for this.”

“Sorry, boss,” Hawks said, before pointing at Aizawa’s chest. “You’ve got ink on you.”

Aizawa looked down, grunting irritably when he noticed the dark blue stain on his pocket, before

reaching in and pulling out a ballpoint pen.

“Nothing works in this place,” he sighed, before chucking the pen onto the trolley where the blood samples were stacked. “Let’s go.”

Overhaul wordlessly followed Aizawa, not sparing any of them a glance. Kacchan, however, was still glaring at Mirko, as she raised her arm as if to say goodbye, before turning her palm and flipping him the bird. Kacchan launched forward, stopped only by Izuku wrapping his arm around him.

“Can’t you drop it?” he grunted, with effort. Kacchan huffed.

“We’re not done, asshole!” he snarled at Mirko, before stomping off after Overhaul. Izuku sighed in relief, watching him go until movement in the corner of his eye grabbed his attention. At first, he wasn’t sure what had happened; Hawks was standing beside the trolley, hands shoved nonchalantly in his pockets, and it was only after Hawks winked and turned on his heel that he realised that the pen Aizawa had thrown down was gone. A spike of anxiety ran through him, looking between the trolley and Hawks’ rapidly departing back, mind racing before Kacchan barked a sharp ‘ *oi!’* back to him and Izuku rushed to catch up, deciding to keep this information to himself for the time being.

Aizawa led the four of them through the corridors of the lab before stopping outside of a room that had always remained locked until now. Izuku had no idea what was inside of it, and he peered curiously over Kacchan’s shoulder as Aizawa reached for his keycard.

“There’s only one way in and out of the facility,” he explained, pushing at the handle after the lock beeped. “It keeps things secure but makes sneaking the nomu out without anyone being recognised difficult. No one outside of those with top security clearance knows that you exist, and we want to keep it that way.”

He stepped into the room, waving for them to follow, and Izuku took in the rows of rockers lining the far wall.

“Anyone going outside the walls is equipped with basic personal protection equipment. It has the added benefit of covering your face and hiding your identity. For obvious reasons, nomu can’t share.”

Hawks and Overhaul were already heading towards the lockers, their names stamped into the metal. Aizawa raised a foot to kick the locker closest to the door and looked at Kacchan.

“This is yours. You mustn’t share this equipment with anyone else. You mustn’t wear anyone else's equipment. You must not remove this equipment unless and until I authorise you to do so. Do you understand?”

“I ain’t stupid.”

“Let’s hope not.”

Kacchan spared Aizawa a glare, before trudging up to his locker, *‘Dynamite’* written across the front. Inside was another jumpsuit, this one made from thicker and darker material, along with

heavy-looking boots, gloves, and what appeared to be a black face mask. Kacchan picked it up, nose curling in distaste.

“I don’t need all this shit.”

“Then stay behind and I’ll bring Mirko instead.”

Kacchan threw Aizawa a dark look, before snatching at the jumpsuit and pulling it on over the one he was already wearing. The mask itself covered his entire face from below the eyes, extending out like a muzzle with filters inserted on each side. With his buzzed hair, large scar, and mismatched eyes, it was likely that not even their friends would be able to recognise him now.

“Good. Midoriya, we’ll be issued with PPE topside. Everyone ready? Let’s go.”

Izuku fell in step beside Kacchan as they followed Aizawa, watching with some amusement as Kacchan pulled angrily at the crotch of the second jumpsuit, which seemed too small for him.

“This is gonna cut off the circulation to my balls,” he said grumpily, voice muffled by the mask.

“That seems like an exaggeration.”

“I hope yours is tight enough your dick drops off.”

Izuku snorted.

Soon enough, after a short elevator ride, they were outside of the labs and onto the main campus, Kacchan taking in his surroundings shrewdly. Some might have called it a simple curiosity, but Izuku knew Kacchan far better than that, and he was well aware that the man was cataloguing *everything* , taking note of each doorway, each hallway, staring hard at every person they passed as though burning their faces into his memory. It left Izuku feeling the strangest mix of emotions; *relief* that Kacchan was still as acute as ever, but there was no denying the anxiety that came with knowing what Kacchan intended to do with all this information. Kacchan wasn’t going to stay in that lab forever; his escape was inevitable. What *remained* uncertain was the chaos his escape would create.

Though he had never been there, Izuku knew that they were homing in on what had essentially been designated as the barracks. Izuku had been here long enough to have been reassured that over a hundred individuals, all trained in armed and hand-to-hand contact, lived at UA. But, besides seeing the odd gaggle of men and women dressed in camo in the food hall, Izuku had never come across them. Their presence was almost an urban legend at UA; something to ease the ever-present anxiety of what would happen if the zombies outside finally found their way in, perhaps. But Izuku had his reasons to be cynical, and part of him felt that Shigaraki was keeping that particular hand close to his chest. He inclined his head towards Kacchan, to ask him what he thought when a familiar voice grabbed his attention.

“Midoriya?”

Izuku took a sharp intake of breath, and he felt Kacchan stiffen beside him.

“Hey man, that you?”

Izuku looked up and saw Kaminari standing at the side of the corridor, a mop in his hand. He had been assigned cleaning duty when they arrived here, something that he was still complaining about three months on. He had a limp, a scar on his left temple and over the hood of his right eye, reminders of how badly he had been beaten by Dabi, but he had still come out of that ordeal remarkably unscathed.

“Oh, uh, hi Kaminari,” he said, aware of Kacchan walking silently at his side.

“Whoa, dude… are you being arrested or something?” Kaminari’s eyes darted over the group as they marched past him, taking in the three with masks over their faces before lingering on Kacchan, and Izuku’s heart skipped a beat. Kacchan looked different, sure, but so different that Kaminari wouldn’t recognise him? Kacchan kept his glare facing forward, not acknowledging him at all.

“Midoriya, hurry up, we’ve got places to be!” Aizawa barked, and Izuku gratefully hurried forward.

“Sorry, Kaminari, I’ll catch up with you later!”

“Sure, I guess? Oi, you better not miss the baby shower this weekend, Mina’s got all those pregnancy hormones so she will murder you.”

“Wouldn’t miss it for the world!” Izuku turned on his heel so that he could wave back at Kaminari, and his stomach dropped when he saw him staring at the back of Kacchan’s head, a light frown on his face.

“Shit,” Izuku breathed, low enough that only Kacchan could hear him. “You think-”

“Nah,” Kacchan said immediately. “Moron could never keep his mouth shut, he’da said something.”

They walked in a tense silence after that, Izuku glancing at Kacchan’s face, but his eyes remained fixed ahead and unreadable. Before long, Aizawa called their attention as they arrived in the barracks area, and he and Izuku were kitted up with their own masks and protective clothing, Kacchan loudly complaining about how Izuku’s clothes fit him. There were several other people there, none of whom Izuku was introduced to as he bustled from one area to the next, feeling very much like Aizawa didn’t want them to be lingering in any one place for long, until they eventually found themselves standing in a large garage, staring at a huge black vehicle.

“Whoa,” Izuku breathed, voice muffled by the mask around his face.

“You guys got an armoured truck?” Kacchan said, staring at the thing. “You don’t think that’s fucking overkill?”

“There are thousands of zombies out there, dude,” Hawks said. “Trust me, you’ll be glad for this thing.”

“Shouta!”

A loud voice grabbed Izuku’s attention, and he was momentarily distracted from the truck to see a

moustached, rocker-type guy heading towards them, his impractically long hair pulled back into a bun and a large duffle back hanging from his shoulder.

“You’re late,” Aizawa said.

“These the new kids?” the man asked, ignoring Aizawa and marching towards them with his hand outstretched. “Yamada Hizashi, but everyone calls me Mic.”

“Oh, uh, nice to meet you,” Izuku said, taking his hand and wincing as it was shaken all too enthusiastically. “M-Midoriya Izuku. And this is Ka- uh, Dynamite.”

“Another one for the team, huh?” Mic said, now holding his hand out for Kacchan. To Izuku’s surprise, Kacchan took it, though his expression remained guarded, and he acknowledged him with a grunt.

“Mic will be joining us,” Aizawa explained, as Mic placed the duffel bag onto a table with a heavy *thud* . “He’s one of our weapons experts and happens to have the most experience out on the field. He’ll be watching our back and making sure that nothing gets out of hand.”

“I’m here to make sure the zombies don’t eat any of you!” Mic said, his voice loud and enthusiastic. He unzipped the bag, and Izuku was left momentarily confused as he pulled out something long and yellow, before he realised that it was a painted assault rifle.

“The hell is that?” Kacchan asked.

“This is DJ Punch,” Mic said, his face split by a toothy grin, tipping back his sunglasses.

“What the fuck?” Kacchan breathed.

“Don’t ask him any more about it,” Aizawa said, ignoring the way Mic waggled his eyebrows at him as he reached into the bag and pulled out his own modestly sized handgun. “We’re on a schedule.”

“Before you say anything, no we’re not allowed a gun,” Hawks said. “It’s like they don’t trust us or something.”

“Carrying a firearm requires training and you are busy with other things,” Aizawa said, dismissively. “Overhaul, you all set?”

Overhaul stood separate from the rest of him. His facemask was slightly different from the rest of them; elongated, looking almost like a plague mask, with a ribbed section across the top, and Izuku wondered if that had something to do with his nomu abilities. Overhaul, as silent as ever, simply nodded.

“Good, alright, the four of you back of the truck.”

Feeling decidedly apprehensive, Izuku climbed into the back of the armoured vehicle. It smelt strangely clinical, the poorly padded seats cold even through two layers of clothing, and there was so little legroom that he had no choice but to slide his way across the seats so that Kacchan could fit next to him, grumbling at the way his knees knocked against the metal partition in the centre.

Next came Hawks, who took his seat opposite Izuku, and Mic sat beside him. The door slammed shut, echoing around the metal box they had found themselves in, and Izuku couldn't help but jump. He had never been claustrophobic, but being cooped up inside an impenetrable cage with no idea of where he was being taken didn't feel great.

One of the doors at the front opened, and Overhaul climbed into the passenger seat before the door was shut behind him. Just a few moments later, Aizawa was in the driver's seat and he turned around to look at them.

"Buckle up."

"Are you serious? What could even crash into us?" Kacchan scoffed, but Aizawa scowled.

"Safety first."

Rolling his eyes dramatically, Kacchan reached for the seatbelt.

Once he was satisfied that everyone had put on their seatbelts, Aizawa nodded his head to someone outside of the car. Izuku could barely see anything from where he was seated, but over Overhaul's shoulder he watched daylight pour in as the large double doors at the front of the garage were opened, and that was when Izuku realised with a jolt that this was the first time he would be outside for almost four months. He looked across at Kacchan, and from the tightness of his brow, he figured that he was thinking much the same.

The vehicle rolled forward, Aizawa's expression entirely relaxed as though this were a simple drive to the store, and Izuku leaned forward as much as he could, trying to get a good look outside. The tall walls of the UA grounds loomed ahead of them, much like he had remembered them, though they had never felt quite so intimidating when he had been a student. The gate was still the same blue it had always been, but with barbed wire lining the top of it, and thick security bolts in place. A red light flashed at its centre, and Izuku heard the garage doors shut behind them with a *clank* . They didn't move for a few seconds, until the light turned green and Aizawa tugged at the gearstick, Izuku watching with bated breath as the gates began to open.

There were yet more walls and gates on the outside of UA, heavily reinforced, and spaced out in layers of around three or foot feet, creating a wide metal barrier between them and the outside world. And yet, even that felt like it simply couldn't be enough to be holding back the literal *thousands* of zombies surrounding them, the noise and the smell so bad that, even through the thick bulletproof walls of their vehicle, it could not be missed.

"Fuck," Izuku breathed, reaching up to cover his nose. A silence fell over the group, then. The horrors of the undead were unfathomable; rotting, bloated, gnashing *things* , pressed against the wire fence, the outer ring a deep rust-red, stinking entrails hanging from it like a macabre tinsel as the movement and pressure gradually disembowelled the zombies closest. Somehow, in the last four months, Izuku had almost managed to forget the sheer intensity of it, of *them* . He felt warmth at his side, realising that Kacchan had grabbed his hand, squeezing tight.

"Overhaul, you're up," Aizawa said.

He leaned forward, grabbing what looked like a mic from above the dashboard and holding it close to Overhaul's face.

“Stop.”

The voice echoed through Izuku, sending shivers up his spine. He felt Kacchan tense beside him and watched as instantly the zombies outside stopped moving. The sudden silence was nearly overwhelming.

“Step back.”

That voice, low and demanding, amplified by what must have been speakers on top of the vehicle, shuddered through him again, and the zombies began to step backwards, an uncoordinated action that left some falling into heaps, and others pulling the skin from their fronts as it caught on the fences. But, move back they did, leaving a wide path through the centre.

There was a thud at his side, and he looked around to see Kacchan holding his head, his eyes scrunched up in pain, feet knocking against the metal barrier.

“Kacchan!”

“ *Fuck* ,” Kacchan gasped. “M’fine.”

Izuku watched in concern as Kacchan rubbed at his temples.

“Yeh,” Hawks said, his face drawn out and tense. “It takes some getting used to.”

Aizawa pressed a button behind the steering wheel, and the metal gates began to open in series. He spared a last look at Overhaul, who nodded stiffly and began to drive forward. Izuku’s hand found Kacchan’s again, gripping tight as they drove through the throngs of zombies, their bodies pressed close, the smell close to unbearable. It must have taken a solid minute to drive out of the mass of bodies, and just as they were reaching the end, Overhaul took a gasping breath.

“ *Aizawa* .”

He sounded pained, his body shaking, and Aizawa nodded, putting the pedal to the metal and gathering speed.

“You can let go now.”

Overhaul sagged in his chair, breathing hard, sweat dripping from his hairline. Izuku jumped when there was a series of hard bangs against the back and side of the vehicle, enough that it rocked for a moment before Aizawa sped out of the reach of the zombies.

“There’s almost too many of them again,” Overhaul muttered. Aizawa sighed.

“Can’t be helped. There’s the zombies from the stadium, not to mention those drawn by the explosion.”

Izuku shifted uncomfortably, glancing at Kacchan’s entirely unmoved expression before realising that Hawks was staring at them. His amber eyes dropped to where he and Kacchan were still holding hands, and he flushed, dropping it like he had been burned. Hawks grinned.

“We’re going to have to try and draw them away eventually,” Mic said, leaning back in his chair and picking at his teeth. “A problem for another day.”

Aizawa grunted, before taking a left turn, driving past another small group of zombies that appeared to be making their way to UA.

“So, what are we out here for today?” Hawks asked, leaning forward so he could rest an elbow on the back of Aizawa’s seat.

“Scouts reported gunfire, near Abekawa Station, about an hour ago now. Shigaraki wants us to investigate, see if there are any survivors.”

“Well, if our fearless leader asks us to go then who are we to argue?” Hawks replied, with a wink at Izuku.

“So, what the hell do you need us there for?” Kacchan asked. “You already got that guy to control the zombies.”

“This will be an opportunity to see how useful your nomu abilities will be to us,” Aizawa replied. “Overhaul has exceptional control over the zombies, better than any other nomu, but controlling that many takes a huge toll and we need to preserve his energy so that we can get back into UA.”

“And what about you?” Kacchan asked, pointing at Hawks.

“I can control a couple,” Hawks replied with a shrug. “But not for very long. The zombies don’t listen to me like they do Overhaul.”

“So, what good even are you?”

“Kacchan!” Izuku yelped.

“What did I tell you about that, Midoriya?” Aizawa snapped, and Izuku flushed.

“Nah, it’s fine. I’m fast,” Hawks said, with a grin. “Very fast.”

“So you can run away quickest, big deal.”

“It’s a little more than that. But I suppose, yeh, push comes to shove all I need to be able to do is outrun you guys if the situation gets dicey.”

“Great,” Kacchan sneered.

“We know you’re physically resilient,” Aizawa continued, not taking his eyes away from the road as they drove. “None of the other nomu could have survived the injuries you did, and from what Midoriya has mentioned you *can* control zombies to a point. But, make no mistake these outings are strictly organised, and we only bring along nomu that can genuinely assist. If you can’t do anything that Hawks, Mirko and Fat can’t do already, we’ll have no use for you out here.”

“Good to know,” Kacchan said darkly.

“Um, why am I here?” Izuku asked.

Aizawa didn’t reply at first, staring ahead for a good long moment, before he sighed.

“Shigaraki thought it would be a good idea.”

Izuku thought back to the man cornering him that very morning and any lingering doubts he might have had over him knowing *something* about Izuku’s immunity were quashed. He realised that Hawks was staring at him again, the lightest frown on his face.

They drove for another fifteen or twenty minutes, their progress slowed by debris and abandoned vehicles on the road, and Aizawa needing to take numerous detours before they joined a main road from which the tracks were visible. Izuku vaguely recognised the area, having passed through Abekawa Station on the occasions he decided to head home by train, but it seemed anywhere close to UA had been hit hard; every house they passed had its windows smashed, doors hanging from their hinges. The vegetation along the tracks had overgrown so much that they were almost obscured, and Izuku saw far more bodies, now just bones or mummified flesh, than he cared to acknowledge. They passed over a river, the vehicle barely able to squeeze down the narrow road as they got closer to the station, and after a few more minutes of driving, Overhaul tensed up.

“Zombies ahead.”

“Any idea how many?” Aizawa asked.

“Fifty. Maybe.”

“I don’t see ‘em,” Kacchan grunted, shifting and craning his neck to look out of the front of the vehicle.

“He can *sense* zombies, too,” Hawks explained. Kacchan threw the back of Overhaul’s head a wary look.

“Neat trick,” he muttered.

They didn’t need to drive much further until a child’s playground, a large and unassuming concrete square came into view, and Overhaul nodded his head to the right.

“There.”

Aizawa eased the vehicle around the narrow corner and almost instantly found their way blocked, fifteen or so yards ahead, by a mass of zombies, pushing and pressing against one another as they tried to reach something at the further corner of the playground. Aizawa stopped the truck, and leaned forward, squinting as he tried to make out more.

“They’re attracted by something,” he muttered. “But I can’t see shit through the trees.”

“Oh, is that my cue?” Hawks asked, brightening up.

Aizawa hummed, leaving the truck running, before turning back to look at Mic.

“Check it.”

Mic offered Aizawa a salute, grabbing his eyesore of a rifle and getting to his feet. Carefully, he opened the back of the truck, peering out, before giving Hawks a thumbs up.

“Back in a bit!”

Hawks was gone before Izuku could even track what happened, darting out of the vehicle, his legs bent and braced for a moment before seemingly shooting upwards. There was a light thud from the roof of the vehicle, as though Hawks had been able to make it up there in a single bound.

“I’m gonna have to go higher.”

Izuku jumped, looking to the side to see Hawks’ face peering down from the top of the van.

“Go ahead,” Aizawa said.

Hawks disappeared again, and Izuku leaned forward.

“So, he can jump really high?” he asked.

“Really *really* high,” Aizawa confirmed with a stiff nod.

They sat in silence for perhaps a minute more, before Hawks touched down, climbing back into the vehicle, Mic still standing watch just outside of it.

“What did you see?”

“There are survivors alright. Two of them, male and female. They’re on top of some outhouse building in the corner of the playground. Don’t got long by the looks of things, the zombies have stacked themselves up and are climbing on top of one another to reach them.”

“They look injured?”

“Not that I could tell, but I didn’t want to get much closer. There’s quite a lot of zombies over there, probably drawn by the gunfire.”

“Did they have weapons?” Mic asked. Hawks shook his head.

“If they do, they aren’t using them.”

Aizawa hummed again, scowling.

“So, why don’t he just call ‘em off?” Kacchan asked, nodding to Overhaul.

“They’re already in a frenzy,” Overhaul explained. “Can’t control them now, don’t you know that?”

Izuku remembered Kacchan saying that he couldn’t do anything with the zombies once they had entered that state.

“Hah? *You’re* the freak who can count ‘em without seeing ‘em, how am I supposed to know what you can do?”

“The hell did we have to bring this asshole along for?” Overhaul growled, face dark.

“The fuck you call me?”

“Hey hey, you wanna quieten it down? Lots of zombies out here might hear you,” Mic hissed.

Aizawa seemed to make up his mind, then, undoing his seatbelt and shifting in his seat.

“Mic, you and Overhaul stay here. Anyone turns up who even looks like they might be considering taking the truck, shoot them.”

“Right you are, boss.”

“Hawks, Dynamite, you come with me. We’ll take the long route around the playground, see if we can’t entice these bastards towards the station long enough for those people to escape.”

“What about me?” Izuku asked.

“Stay in the truck.”

Izuku’s face flushed indignantly.

“I’m not staying here.”

“You’re not a nomu, and you don’t have a gun, you’re staying in the truck.”

“I can handle the zombies,” Izuku protested. “What if the people are injured? What if they go the wrong way?”

Aizawa glared at him for a moment longer, before sighing.

“Fine, but you stay close to the truck until the zombies clear out.”

It was hard not to feel insulted by this, considering how long Izuku had been out here, where it was *real* and dangerous, where he had faced off against more zombies than these in the past. He could handle himself just as well as Kacchan could, he probably had more experience than Aizawa and Hawks combined by this point. But, not wanting to irritate Aizawa further and end up being told to stay inside, he nodded, and with Mic signalling the coast was clear, he and Kacchan slid from the truck.

It was almost a relief to find himself back on solid ground, the blue sky opening up over him, the barest of warmth from the winter sun hitting his cheeks. He almost missed it, being out like this, were it not for the sound and smell of a herd of zombies so close by. Kacchan looked brighter than Izuku had seen him in some time, hands twitching over his mask as if itching to pull it off and take a deep breath of the fresh, crisp air.

“We’ll cut around this side,” Aizawa said, pointing to the line of trees beside them, and unholstering his gun. “Hawks, it’ll be on you to distract them, lead them towards the station. Dynamite, you stick with me, and we’ll handle any that peel off-”

A piercing scream cut him off, and Izuku felt the hairs on the back of his neck stand up. The two people on top of the outhouse, just visible from where Izuku was standing, were shouting. There was a rush of air at Izuku’s side, and Hawks had leapt up onto a tree beside them, before hissing down.

“They’re climbing onto the outhouse, the zombies are stacked up.”

“There ain’t time for this shit,” Kacchan growled suddenly. “Fuck the both you, we can handle this.”

Aizawa’s eyes widened. “Wh-”

But Kacchan was sprinting off across the playground, and Izuku was hot on his heels. There wasn’t time for them to sneak around, and they had given plenty of zombies the slip in the past, this felt no different. As they neared the outhouse, Izuku raised his arms and started to yell.

“Oi! Assholes, over here!”

It took a moment, Izuku and Kacchan both whistling and clapping their hands to make a noise, but finally the zombies started to take notice, distracted from the two people clinging to one another and frantically kicking out at the zombies closest to them.

“There ya go,” Kacchan called, walking backwards. “Keep coming.”

Izuku saw Aizawa and Hawks standing, seemingly stunned, back near the truck.

“I know this area,” Izuku said. “Well, sort of. There’s a subway, just across the road, that goes under the track. We can trap them other side of the station and cut back through.”

“Works for me,” Kacchan replied. The zombies were beginning to run towards them now, those at the bottom of the pile clambering their way out from beneath the others.

“Birdbrain, Dog Eyes, take care of anything that’s left!” Kacchan yelled, before smacking Izuku against the shoulder and gesturing for them to run. Izuku didn’t waste a moment, taking off with Kacchan, each of them checking over their shoulders to make sure the zombies were following them.

Izuku led the way, jumping over the ground-level fence of the playground and onto the road. The subway was directly ahead of them, its walls tantalisingly low. They could probably get some of the zombies to climb it, fall face-first onto the concrete below and take them out that way, but there were far too many of them for it to be an option for all. He pointed to the far entrance to the subway.

“Down there!”

Kacchan nodded, turning around for a moment and hollering once more. Some of the zombies were

struggling with the fence, their ankles catching and snapping under the weight of their bodies, but they would need to double back and take care of the stragglers.

“Come on, pricks! I ain’t got all day!”

Most of the group was after them now, and clapping his hands in satisfaction Kacchan joined Izuku at the top of the staircase, leading down into the subway. The emergency lighting was still intact, if not tentative, low and flashing, but enough to guide their way.

“Watch out!”

Izuku skidded to a stop, Kacchan’s arm thrust out across his chest, as a body landed in front of them with a *crunch* . Izuku looked up and saw that there were other zombies caught on the low wall, their torsos leaning over the edge and threatening to fall.

“It’ll take care of some of them,” Izuku breathed, before grabbing Kacchan’s hand and tugging him forward. They continued down the stairs, sidestepping the bodies falling from above, before fleeing into the subway itself. Izuku couldn’t help it, a laugh broke from his lips, a euphoric feeling in his chest at the pure thrill of the adrenaline rushing through his system. He missed this… he had *really* missed this.

“You crazy bastard,” Kacchan cackled, eyes blazing over his mask as he looked back at him. Izuku squeezed his hand tighter.

“This way, come on!”

They ran to the other end of the subway, the sound of slapping feet and cracking bones deafening in the enclosed space. The staircase back up was just ahead of them, and Izuku took a moment to see how many of the zombies were still on their heels.

“Think we lost a few,” he panted.

“They’re either jam or old enough they can’t keep up,” Kacchan said. “We’ll pick them off on the way back if we need to.”

Izuku nodded as they charged up the stairs, meeting sunlight again. The train tracks were on their left now, the large building of the station directly ahead.

“We either cut through the station or jump the fence,” Izuku said, pointing.

“Station’s enclosed. We dunno what state it’s in. Could get stuck.”

“Fair point! I don’t know how strong the fences are, so we best put some distance between us and them so they don’t all rush at once.”

“Think you can keep up, Deku?” Kacchan teased. Izuku laughed.

“You’ll be eating my dust.”

“You’re fucking on.”

For all his big words, Kacchan wasn't as fast as Izuku and they both knew it, the former swearing as Izuku outpaced him, laughing all the while. Izuku ran past the station, eyes peeled on the road and pathways coming in from their right for any other zombies that might have been drawn by the commotion. The coast remained clear, and Izuku eyed up a part of the fence that they would easily be able to scale.

"Son of a bitch," Kacchan growled, skidding to his side a moment later. "The fuck they feed you?"

"The zombies still see us," Izuku said, panting from his sprint. "But they're spaced out enough, they shouldn't be able to push down the fence."

Kacchan nodded, stepping up onto a concrete block before hoisting himself up and swinging a leg over the top of the fence. He reached his hand back to Izuku, and the two of them clambered over to the other side, landing in the thick vegetation.

"Up to the track, come on!"

They scaled the hill, fighting their way through stubborn brambles, catching on their clothing, until they touched the metal of the train track, both of them breathing heavily and looking back over their shoulders. The zombies were at the fence now, but instead of their weight being focused on a single point, they were spaced out, none of them alone able to push it down or climb over the top.

"That should hold them," Izuku said, grabbing his facemask and pulling it down so that he could breathe properly. It was hardly away from his mouth for a second when he felt strong hands grabbing his jaw and yanking him to the side, colliding with hot, needy lips. Izuku groaned, falling into Kacchan all too eagerly, meeting the greedy swipes of his tongue, leaving his mouth a wet mess.

"You're so fucking hot," Kacchan growled into his mouth. "Wanna fuck you on this damn track."

Izuku moaned, feeling his face heat up.

"Don't think we have time."

Kacchan pulled away, lips swollen and shiny with spit, reaching a hand up to drag through Izuku's hair.

"When we get out of this, all of this, I'll take you back to that dumb waterfall you liked so much and blow you in it."

Izuku blushed. "That's… oddly romantic, Kacchan."

"'Course it's fucking romantic!"

There was an ominous *creek* , and Izuku looked over to see a part of the fence buckle as the zombies gradually began to pool in one spot.

"Let's head back."

“Wish we could get outta here,” Kacchan grumbled, staring wistfully along the track. “Just bail.”

“Our friends, Kacchan.”

“Yeh, yeh I know.”

They crossed the track, easing their way down the hill on the other side, and scaled another fence.

“We just need to follow this road and we’ll be at the playground,” Izuku said, brushing down the front of his jumpsuit.

“Deku,” Kacchan growled, his voice low in warning. He turned on the spot, movement grabbing his attention, to see Hawks standing between them and the station, waving a hand in a cheery wave.

“There you are!”

“We weren’t gonna run off,” Kacchan snapped. “Dog Eyes didn’t have to send his fucking guard goose after us.”

“I knew you wouldn’t go anywhere,” Hawks replied, with half a shrug. “As for Aizawa, we’ve got a few minutes before he starts to worry and comes looking.”

Izuku frowned.

“A few minutes for what?”

“Y’know, you kids should be more careful about what you talk about, and where,” he replied. “The walls at the lab are very thin.”

Izuku felt the colour drain from his face.

“Fucker, you better think twice,” Kacchan growled, already advancing on Hawks. “I got no problem pounding your head into the concrete.”

“Relax, I’m not here to threaten you. Actually, I think we can help each other.”

“Likely story!”

“Kacchan, wait, maybe we should hear him out?”

“Hah?”

“He’s right, you should,” Hawks said. “Besides, if something happens to me, do you really think Aizawa is going to believe it was an accident?”

“Who said anything about it being an accident,” Kacchan snarled.

“If I wanted to tell Aizawa that Midoriya is immune, I would have done so already,” Hawks reasoned, holding his palms forward. “We’re on the same side, here.”

Kacchan still looked doubtful, but he stood down, his shoulder slumping. Hawks checked behind him before he reached up and pulled his mask away from his face.

“Good. If it makes you feel any better, I didn’t *try* to overhear you last night.”

“Just get on with it.”

“Well, you said you thought Shigaraki was behind all of this. I’m here to tell you that I *know* he is.”

Izuku’s eyes widened.

“You do? How?”

“Before all this, I worked for the Cabinet Intelligence and Research Office. I was assigned to the Counter-Terrorism Unit and headed an investigation into a potential homegrown terrorist act.”

“You’re a bit young for that, ain’t you?” Kacchan said suspiciously.

“Huh? Oh, I’m very smart.”

“Dick.”

“There’d been some suspicion surrounding Shigaraki for a while, and the legitimacy of his research and how it was conducted, and I started to investigate a string of unusual illnesses in the Shizuoka area, dating back the last thirty years.”

“So it’s true? It is related?”

“Yeh, your deductions were on the money, Midoriya. I had a personal interest in it, having been one of the children that almost died but was saved-” he raised his fingers into air quotes “-by a miracle drug. I had no unusual symptoms after, my bloodwork came up clean, and there was no reason to suspect there was anything wrong with me, but Shigaraki is a dangerous character.” Hawks smiled sadly. “Actually, we thought that maybe he was intentionally infecting kids with something, we just had no idea what.”

Izuku frowned.

“Why didn’t you stop him?”

“Because we had nothing *to* stop,” Hawks explained. “I had no proof he was making the kids sick. The treatment was PMDA and FDA-approved, and whilst it was weird that it was still being classed as a trial drug after almost thirty years, I had nothing but a hunch to go off. If I could have stopped this, believe me, I would have done.”

“So, the shit he pumped us with, that was the zombie virus?” Kacchan asked. Hawks shook his head.

“No. And I’ve been scratching my head over it for years, trying to work it out, until I overheard you talking last night. I think Midoriya is right; the trial drug was some sort of viral immunosuppressant, designed to let the zombie virus work at max capacity.”

“And Shigaraki released the virus,” Izuku breathed. “But why? I don’t understand why he would do it.”

“You won’t be familiar with all of Shigaraki’s research over the years,” Hawks replied. “He was very selective about what he made public. His work in virology was world-famous, but that’s not what his true goal was.”

“His true goal?”

“Immortality.”

A stunned silence fell over them, Hawks’ face stony and serious.

“You’re kidding?” Kacchan said.

“I wish I was. I mean, it sure *sounds* like a joke, right? Mad scientist looking for the secret to eternal life? But Shigaraki was serious about it. And he spent a lot of money trying to figure it out.”

“So why… *this* ?” Izuku gestured around them. “Why a virus that turns everyone into zombies? What does that have to do with him wanting to live forever?”

Hawks shrugged. “Honestly, I don’t know. I wasn’t even certain that Shigaraki was behind this until I got infected. I was already at UA when the virus hit, interviewing for a job in the research department as part of my cover, so I was safely inside for most of it. I was bitten about six months into the pandemic after an infected was able to conceal a bite on their foot. It’s the only breach UA has had, but I was unlucky enough to be in the crossfire when the woman turned.”

Izuku winced.

“Fortunately, Toshinori decided he would try and treat me with medication instead of a bullet to the head, though I’m certain Shigaraki already had an inkling of who I was. I didn’t turn, instead, I became their second nomu, and my suspicions over the link between the trial drug and the zombie virus grew. Every new nomu that joined us, it turned out, had a similar period of illness and was treated in the same hospital in Musutafu.”

“Holy fuck.”

“Right. And don’t you think it’s a little weird that UA was so perfectly equipped to handle an apocalypse? That it’s about the only place still standing after two years? Almost like the man who owned the place was preparing for something.”

“Do you know what makes us different?” Izuku asked. “Why we haven’t turned like everyone else who was exposed?”

Hawks shook his head.

“No. But, with you here, I think we can work it out. After all, what do we have? Between the three of us, we have super speed, regeneration, and immunity. Who’s to say it stops there? You could be immune to *any* virus. Dynamite here could well be immortal for all that we know, even if he’s not

immune to becoming a zombie."

Kacchan started.

"That's a bit of a fuckin leap."

"Is it? I *saw* you when you got here, all your insides were on the outside and you had less than a litre of blood left in your entire body. You should be dead ten times over."

"Aizawa didn't… he didn't say it was that bad," Izuku breathed, eyes wide.

"I ain't fucking immortal," Kacchan snarled, looking furious and, to Izuku's trained eyes, decidedly terrified. "Don't be ridiculous."

"The point is we don't know," Hawks said, with a shrug. "But it sure sounds to me like we're prototypes for the kind of person that might be, don't you think?"

Izuku's stomach churned as they stood in an uneasy silence.

"So, what do we do?" Izuku breathed.

"Until now, I thought all I needed to do was prove it," Hawks said, looking visibly frustrated. "Prove that Shigaraki was responsible and watch everything else fall into place. But, it's like *you* said last night-" he nodded his head at Kacchan. "UA is his house. He controls everything that happens there, and no one even knows I exist, so why would they listen to me? But *you're* the key, Midoriya. People know you, you've walked freely about UA this whole time, and you're *immune* . Maybe you can prove-"

A snap to Izuku's right interrupts them, and expecting a zombie Izuku braced himself to run. Instead, he finds himself staring into the wide, dark eyes of Aizawa, carefully approaching them with his gun hanging at his side.

"Ah," Hawks said, laughing nervously.

"M-Mr Aizawa!" Izuku holds up his hands. "We were just…" He swallowed, mouth dry, before his shoulders slumped in defeat. "H-how much did you overhear?"

At first, Aizawa didn't respond, looking between the three of them, a bead of sweat visible on his brow, before he took a deep shuddering breath and raised his gun, pointing it directly at Izuku.

"I need you to listen-"

But Aizawa didn't have a chance to finish before there was a blur of movement to Izuku's left, Kacchan launching himself forward and colliding with Aizawa. There was a loud bang as the gun went off, firing into the sky as Aizawa was thrown onto the ground, and Izuku could only watch in slow motion as Kacchan grabbed hold of the back of Aizawa's head and ground his face into the dirt.

"Kacchan! Stop, if anything happens to him- our *friends* !"

Kacchan snarls, the sound animalistic as he opens his mouth, teeth bared. Aizawa's face stretches in horror, unable to move beneath the heavy weight of the man straddling him, and Kacchan leans down to snap his mouth shut, almost grazing his cheek, the sound as finite as the gunshot.

"Don't think I won't tear your fucking face off," Kacchan says, voice low and deadly, "if you ever aim a gun at him again."

Aizawa is breathing heavily, face bloody from the gravel beneath him. Hawks and Izuku hesitantly approach.

"He heard us," Izuku said, shakily. "What are we supposed to do?"

"If we let him go he'll tell Shigaraki," Hawks said. Aizawa grunted, trying to move, but Kacchan pressed his palm against his face.

"Stay down."

"But we can't… we can't kill him." Izuku dragged his hands through his hair. "Mic will know it wasn't an accident, and if we go back without either of them there's no way Shigaraki isn't going to figure it out. He'll kill our friends."

"Well we don't exactly have long to figure it out, Mic will have heard the gunshot."

"J-just-" Aizawa shifted again. "Damnit, just *listen* to me-"

"After you aimed a gun at Izuku's head? I don't fucking think so."

Aizawa groaned. "Sh- shit ok, that was dumb, but I was just trying t-to buy some time. I didn't think you'd go full attack dog."

Kacchan rears back slightly, before spitting onto the dirt in front of him, Aizawa staring at the wet stain as if looking down the barrel of a gun.

"Oh, that was dumb alright."

"What was it you wanted to say?" Hawks asked. "And you better be quick about it, because if Mic finds us you know we'll have no other option but to kill you both."

Aizawa hisses in pain as Kacchan presses more of his weight onto his back.

"Sh- shit, hold the fuck on."

Kacchan eases back a bit so that Aizawa can breathe, and Aizawa scrunches up his face.

"I've known, since the beginning, th-that Shigaraki was a part of this," he said. "But, until now, I couldn't prove it."

"You knew?" Izuku gasped. Aizawa nodded his head, wincing as his cheek dragged over the ground.

“It’s like Hawks said, what are the chances UA would be fully prepped for an apocalypse? I’m the head of security, for fuck sake, I see things and I hear things. It’s my damn job.”

“So why didn’t you do anything?” Kacchan snarled.

“You’re not the only person with people to protect.”

Izuku shut his eyes tight. “Right.”

“You’re buying this shit, Deku?”

“He’s never given us any reason not to trust him,” Izuku said.

“Are you kidding? He’s given *plenty* of reasons!”

“I can get you in a room with him,” Aizawa gasps out, as Kacchan presses on his back again. “Alone. Just you and Shigaraki.”

“Just *me* ,” Kacchan hisses. “Izuku don’t get anywhere fucking near him.”

“That won’t be as simple.”

“Then no dice.”

“Kacchan!” Izuku starts, but they hear a voice calling in the distance, and Izuku realises Mic is probably only moments away. “ *Kacchan* ,” he repeats, earnestly. “We can’t kill him and I- I think we can trust him.”

“Midoriya’s right,” Hawks said, and Kacchan looked up at them, outraged. “What other option do we have? If we go back to UA without him, it’ll be a fight, and we’re not prepared for that.”

“I can’t believe this *shit!* ”

“Shouta, you over there?”

“Kacchan, please. Trust *me* , ok?”

Kacchan looks torn, furious, and when he looks down at the man beneath him Izuku feels sure for a moment that he is going to kill him anyway, but he gets to his feet, roughly grabbing the back of Aizawa’s jumpsuit and hauling him up with one hand just as Mic rounds the corner, his gun drawn.

“Sho- what’s going on here?” Mic demands, taking in the scene before him. Kacchan starts patting Aizawa off with much more force than was necessary.

“This dumb asshole tripped and set off his gun,” he said, by means of an explanation. Mic looks unsure, watching Aizawa before he nods and shoves Kacchan off of him.

“I’d rather you hadn’t told him that,” Aizawa grumbled. “But yes, that’s what happened.”

Mic still seems doubtful, but he lowers his gun, and Izuku lets out an internal sigh of relief.

“What about the two survivors?” Aizawa asked, after wiping the grit from his face.

“Oh, they seem ok, if not a little shaken,” Mic replies. “They dropped most of their weapons, and emptied the only gun they had, that must have been what the scouts heard.”

“Good, let’s get back to the truck.”

Aizawa reholsters his gun and doesn’t spare any of them another look as he marches off in the direction of the truck, Mic following. Kacchan glares at Izuku.

“Hope you’re right about this, Deku,” he says, low enough that only he could hear.

Overhaul is leaning against the truck when they get back. There are a few zombies dotted about the playground, their skulls already crushed, and the two people they had saved were propped up against one another.

“You’re lucky these two didn’t decide to just drive off with the truck,” Overhaul called dryly. “Not like I could have stopped them.”

Aizawa ignores him and trudges up to the survivors, and as Izuku gets closer he realises that he recognises them. The man, tall and heavily built, and the woman, much shorter and slender, were the couple he had met back at that campsite when he had been trying to find Kacchan. Camie seems to recognise him, too, because her eyes widen when she spots him.

“Oh, hey, it’s that kid! Hey, kid!”

Aizawa stops, looking between them. “You know each other?”

“Oh yeh, we ran into each other ages ago! Hey, thanks for the assist, kid, we were in a real pickle.”

“It’s fine!” Izuku said with a smile.

“Say, did you ever find your friend? The one you were looking- oh! Oh, there he is!” She waves again. “Looking a little rougher than the last time we saw you, and that’s saying something.”

Kacchan scowled. “Thanks,” he said dryly.

“You know him, too?” Aizawa asks, voice hushed. The smile drops from Izuku’s face, as he realises he’s not the only one who sensed the sudden change of atmosphere when Inasa nudges Camie.

“Nah, we don’t know ‘em,” Inasa said. “Just… met them in passing. No idea who they actually are.”

Inasa shifted uncomfortably, carrying himself in a strange way, as though he couldn’t distribute his weight evenly. Izuku glanced down, and his sense of foreboding grew when he saw the dark wet stain on his calf. Aizawa, too, tenses beside him, and Izuku begins to panic.

“Mr Aizawa-”

Camie finally caught on to the situation, and steps in front of Inasa, her hands spread and a nervous smile on her face.

“Oh, that? It’s nothing! Just caught his leg on the fence back there, that’s all.”

But her movement only draws attention to herself, and the red stain in the inner part of her arm. Aizawa reaches for his gun, aiming it at her head.

“Show us your injuries.”

“Wh- no, it’s nothing, I swear! Hey, kid, you’ll vouch for us, right?”

“If it’s nothing, then you don’t have anything to worry about,” Aizawa said, voice soft and firm. “But we have to know.”

Inasa looks especially rattled now, looking between each of them, his large body tensing as he takes an unsteady step forward, pausing when Mic raises his gun.

“Just listen to him, dude.”

Izuku could see the cogs turning, the frantic way that Inasa searched for an escape, but Camie placed a hand on his arm and he sighed. With shaking hands he pulled up the leg of his combat trousers, revealing a large, fresh, bleeding bite mark.

“Goddamn it,” Aizawa breathes, his gun lowering.

Camie is crying as she follows Inasa’s example and rolls back her sleeve. Her bite was shallower, like her coat had taken the brunt of it, but teeth had still pierced the skin and it oozed gently. Izuku couldn’t stand it, seeing the terror in their eyes. Aizawa was no longer pointing his gun at them, but his eyes were dark, and Izuku stepped in.

“Hey,” he said, looking between them. “It’s ok, alright? We’re from UA, that’s where you were heading right?”

Camie nods.

“Well, there’s a hospital there,” he explains, looking back at Aizawa. His expression is tight, but he doesn’t interrupt. “Maybe we can help you. Right, Mr Aizawa? We can bring them back with us?”

“You really know each other?” Aizawa asks.

“Kind of,” Izuku admits. Aizawa looks at Kacchan, who shrugs.

“ *Barely* ,” he said. “I passed through their camp months ago, weren’t even there a night.”

Aizawa is quiet for a moment longer before he jerks his head, and Izuku smiles in relief.

“Ok. But we’ll need to restrain you, you understand.”

Inasa and Camie nod gratefully.

“Turn around,” Aizawa instructs. There’s a beat, and Inasa’s eyes widen and he nods. He grabs Camie’s hand, turning them both.

“Do we have any rope-” But before Izuku could finish, he was interrupted by two loud *pops* , one after the other, and Inasa and Camie dropped to the ground. Izuku feels someone snatch at his wrist and pull him away, but through the ringing in his ears and the way the earth seems to tilt away from beneath him, he can’t figure out much. The silence draws out, Izuku staring, before he comes back to himself, pulling himself out of Kacchan’s grasp.

“You didn’t have to!”

“Yes, I did.”

“No, they were-”

“They were infected,” Aizawa interrupts. “And they knew who you were, I had no choice.”

“You didn’t even give them a chance!” Izuku yelled. “They could have been like us! They could have made it!”

“They would have never made it through the door! It was the kindest option, the *only* option. He understood that at least.”

Aizawa gestured to Inasa, lying face down on the ground. Izuku fell silent, hot tears streaming down his cheeks. It took him a moment to realise that he was the only one who was shocked by it all; Overhaul was staring up at the sky as if nothing had happened, and even Kacchan wore a sullen expression on his face. Izuku shook his head furiously.

“We should have *tried* .”

“Yeh, well, look where trying has already got us, kid.”

Aizawa walked away, towards the van, and after briefly squeezing Izuku’s shoulder, Mic followed.

“Deku-”

“We’re ending this, Kacchan. One way or another, we’re ending this.”

Chapter End Notes

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 45: One Foot in the Grave

Chapter Summary

In which everything has a deadline.

Chapter Notes

Please mind any additional tags added over the last few chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For Izuku the drive to UA passed in a blur.

It had been some time since Izuku had felt anger quite like this; he was deaf and blind to the world around him, foggy for the dizzying sensation monopolising his focus. He couldn't *stop* thinking about it… The gunshots, the sound of Camie and Inasa hitting the ground, those heavy *thuds* … They brought yet more vile memories back to him, such as the wet sound of flesh being stripped from bone with only a single foot visible beneath the pile of zombies, and a disfigured corpse slumped against a wall in a room full of blood. So many senseless, agonising deaths, over and over and *over.*

It had to end. It *had* to.

He only realised that Kacchan had been holding his hand once he let go, and Izuku felt so light-headed with the sudden loss of contact that he needed to reach out and steady himself, fingers scrabbling uselessly against metal.

"Deku, hey, we're back."

He blinked, looking around and seeing the inside of the garage now visible from the open doors of the truck. He allowed himself to be guided out, Kacchan supporting his weight as he tried not to stumble. He could feel the intensity of Kacchan's stare, not missing the way he stumbled, and he found he couldn't bring himself to meet his eyes.

He removed his PPE and handed it to a person he didn't recognise, and when Aizawa asked them to follow him back to the lab he went without argument. It was hard to find the energy to protest, or do anything but follow when his mind was playing Camie and Inasa's deaths on a loop. He should have done something. He should have done *more* . Anything to spare them from dying like that. He was *immune* , wasn't he? And what good had that been? What good, beyond sparing his own life? His blood could hold the fix to all of it, the *end* to all of it, and yet he couldn't do a single shitty thing to save people when it counted. He couldn't save them. Or Ochako. Or Tenya or Tsu or Sero or even one little boy.

“Oi-”

“Don’t say it isn’t my fault,” Izuku interrupted immediately, refusing to look at Kacchan. He huffed but didn’t argue, and the two of them walked side-by-side to the labs.

Further on, they were stopped again, Kacchan and the nomu removing their PPE and placing them in plastic bags before they were carted away on a trolley by a masked and gloved researcher, but it wasn’t until they entered the nomu dorms that anyone spoke.

“I’m going back to bed,” Overhaul grunted, not sparing any of them so much as a glance before he slouched away, ignoring Mirko’s curious head tilt before she came bounding forward, hand outstretched expectantly.

“Oh!” Hawks shifted and laughed awkwardly. “I, uh… I forgot.”

“You kidding me?” Mirko sighed.

“Next time,” Hawks promised, and Mirko glared at Aizawa.

“Next time I better be the one going.”

Aizawa didn’t say a word and dragged a hand tiredly over the back of his neck. Izuku still needed to speak with him, to find out exactly how he had figured out Shigaraki was behind it all, and just what he meant by getting him and the man alone together, but it wasn’t something he could talk about in front of everyone here. Sure, Hawks knew, but whether Mirko, Fat or even Overhaul were in on this was unknown to Izuku. He considered for a moment asking if he and Aizawa could talk privately, before a raised voice caught his attention.

“Shouta, finally back? Good, I need to show you something.”

Kayama made her way out of the hospital room that Kacchan had been held in for months, paperwork in her neatly manicured hands. She caught Izuku’s eye, flashing him a smile that seemed far too bright and far too forced before she gestured for Aizawa to follow her. He sighed.

“Go eat, if you’re hungry,” he said.

“We’re not done,” Kacchan warned, voice a low growl, but Aizawa ignored him, thrusting his hands into his pockets and making his way over to the hospital room. Izuku heard a surprised, *“What happened to your face?”* before the door was shut.

“Wonder what that’s all about,” Hawks said before he turned to Mirko and Fat. “You got any idea?”

“Probably Overhaul’s hormone count,” Mirko replied, lowering her voice and glancing at the closed door of his room. “But who really knows?” She sighed and dropped heavily onto the couch. “That’s how shit goes around here. On a-”

“ *Need to know* ,” Fat and Hawks finished in unison. Hawks huffed.

“It’s getting old.”

Izuku hardly heard a word of their exchange as he stared at the hospital door, almost hoping that if he looked hard enough he might catch something of what was being said inside.

“So, what happened out there? Oi, newbie, care to fill us in?”

“Hah?” Kacchan’s low voice managed to break Izuku’s concentration for a moment, and he glanced over. “The hell is it to you?”

“You’re not going to give us an inch are you, bomb boy?” Mirko said. “You know you’re stuck here with us now, right? The least you can do is put in a bit of effort.”

“Who cares?” Kacchan grunted, crossing his arms and looking over at the hospital room, too. “We ain’t friends.”

“Not with that attitude!” Fat said, with a loud laugh.

“Fuck off,” Kacchan grumbled, just as distracted as Izuku was.

“There were a couple survivors,” Hawks provided instead before he too dropped down on the sofa beside Mirko. She quickly raised her legs and crossed them over his lap. “But they had already been bit, so-” he mimed raising a gun to his head “- *bam* .”

“ *Bam* ?” Mirko snorted. “You need to stop reading so many comics, they’re not good for you.”

“Bossman didn’t want to bring them back?” Fat asked.

The silence drew out, and Izuku realised that the three of them were staring at him and Kacchan. He bristled uncomfortably.

“What?”

“Well, Aizawa seemed more concerned about the fact they already knew you and Dynamite,” Hawks said. “Not to stick my finger in the wound.”

“Then why the fuck did you?” Kacchan snapped.

But Hawks didn’t get a chance to respond before the hospital room door opened and Aizawa and Kayama walked out.

“Dynamite, Midoriya,” Aizawa said. “A word.”

Izuku glanced at Kacchan, whose nonchalant shrug did little to mask the interest on his face. Aizawa cocked his head at the hospital room, and they followed, Izuku’s curiosity and anxiety growing when he saw that he had picked up the paperwork that Kayama had been holding.

“Now, I don’t think we need to be worried right away,” Aizawa said before he nodded his head at Kacchan. “But, your bloodwork from this morning came back abnormal.”

Izuku’s stomach plummeted.

“What does that mean?” Kacchan said. “Abnormal how?”

“Your hormone markers are shifting closer to the range we’d expect to see in someone experiencing active infection,” Aizawa replied. Izuku started.

“What?”

“As I said, we’re not worried. Not yet. But it’s looking like Toshinori was right when he said that Dynamite is likely to need more medication to manage his infection.”

“That’s the shit that fucks up my liver, right?” Kacchan asked, his even tone at odds with the rollercoaster that was Izuku’s pulse. “Ain’t I already on that?”

“Yes, but a very low dose,” Kayama replied. “Normally that’s all it takes to set the markers right in all the other nomu, with the exception of Overhaul. But you and he are the only ones who have been bitten twice, and it looks like that makes a difference.”

“He was bitten twice?” Izuku asked, and Kayama’s eyes widened, glancing at Aizawa.

“What? Oh! Did I say twice? I meant, uh-”

Aizawa groaned. “Forget it. It isn’t important. What *is* important is figuring out what dosage keeps you from turning. We’ll increase your daily amiodarone to the same as Overhaul for now, and track your markers over the next three days.”

“Great,” Kacchan grumbled.

“In the meantime, I’ll need you to stay inside of the dorm. You’ll have your meals brought to you.”

Kacchan scowled, but he didn’t argue.

“Kayama, have you told Toshinori?”

“Not yet,” Kayama replied. “I’ll go now, we might need to adjust the dosage a little, on account of Dynamite being heavier.”

Aizawa nodded, and Kayama left the room, leaving the three of them alone. Just like that, Izuku felt his anxiety return. He was still angry, *furious* even, but he was even more worried about Kacchan. He felt like he was about to explode.

“Now isn’t the time,” Aizawa said immediately, seeing the look on both of their faces, and Izuku felt the thread snap. He stomped forward, drawing himself up as tall as he could and glared at Aizawa.

“No, it is,” he said, his breath trembling as much as his hands. “I decided to trust you back there, we *could* have killed you. So you owe us some answers.”

“Answers to what?” Aizawa sighed.

“Why did you kill them?”

“Deku-”

“No! Kacchan, I want to know!”

“Because they would have been a security risk,” Aizawa said bluntly, not flinching from Izuku’s glare. “The chances of either of them being resistant to the infection is less than one in a million. And you must have an idea of what would have happened to them if we had brought them back here and they hadn’t been nomu, don’t you?”

Izuku frowned, and Aizawa threw his head back, glaring up at the ceiling and rubbing the bridge of his bruising nose.

“Midoriya, at some point I’m going to need you to start thinking - and by that I mean *really* thinking - about what this place is and what happens here.”

“The hell does that mean?” Kacchan asked.

Aizawa took a deep breath.

“People are a resource,” he said. “And not just the living ones.” He ran his tongue over his top teeth, looking more conflicted than Izuku could remember having ever seen him. “There is a basement level to UA. A basement *below* this one.”

“And what’s there?” Izuku asked, suddenly afraid of the answer.

“Resources,” Aizawa replied simply.

Izuku felt a cold dread creep up his spine. He and Kacchan stood in silence.

“I meant what I said back there. I believe that Shigaraki was involved in this from the beginning, and I don’t think it’s done. He might tell the rest of us that he’s looking for a cure, but in two years there hasn’t been a single breakthrough. Not one.”

Aizawa dragged his hand down his face, resting it over his mouth as he began to pace. Agitation was a strange look for the man, and it only made Izuku’s anxiety grow as he watched the scowl deepen.

“I-” he paused, voice muffled, staring intently at them. “Shigaraki has been collecting nomu since this all started. Overhaul, Hawks, Fat, Mirko… but I have never seen him so ecstatic as when we found the both of you. Whatever he has planned, whatever the end goal of all of this is, I’m certain he was waiting on you so that he could achieve it.”

“Immunity,” Izuku breathed.

Aizawa smiled dryly. “Your immunity, and Bakugou’s physical resilience? I’d say you’re both a pretty precious resource.”

“So, why are we waiting?” Kacchan demanded. “You’re the head of security, right? You got access

to the bastard. You and me, we go right now and fucking end it."

"I told you it isn't that simple," Aizawa replied. "I need time, and we need a plan. If we fuck this up then the people we care about will be the ones to suffer for it."

"So we don't fuck it up!"

"No," Aizawa replied shortly. "We do this smart or we don't do it at all. Those are my terms."

Kacchan glared, but to Izuku's relief, he didn't argue. He understood Kacchan's frustration and his urgency, but he at least agreed with Aizawa on this. They needed time to formulate a plan, they couldn't afford to rush this.

"For now, I need both of you to act as though nothing has changed. Besides, we need to get a handle on your infection so that you're strong enough to handle whatever is coming."

Before either of them could respond, Aizawa threw the door open, nodding his head and gesturing for them to leave.

"Fine," Kacchan growled, stomping past with his shoulders hunched, and Izuku followed. Hawks, Mirko and Fat watched them with unmasked curiosity, causing Kacchan's hackles to rise as he marched to his room.

"Midoriya," Aizawa called, as Izuku made to follow. "You're still needed in the lab today."

Izuku deflated, desperate to follow Kacchan, but as his door slammed shut he nodded begrudgingly.

"He'll be ok, right?" Izuku breathed, turning back to Aizwa. "You're not going to let him turn?"

Aizawa's face softened, only the barest amount.

"That's the last thing I want."

It was almost impossible for Izuku to focus on his work for the remainder of that day, and when Izuku almost spilt an entire sample of congealing zombie blood over himself he was momentarily grateful for his immunity. He was sharing the lab with Shinsou again and he could feel the man watching him, as if considering whether he ought to step in before Izuku got himself into real trouble. Fortunately, he decided to keep his distance, and Izuku was able to slink from the lab just before eight, realising that he had missed dinner. His stomach churned and growled loud enough to catch Shinsou's attention, and with his face burning Izuku waved his goodbye and ducked out into the corridor.

He could go and fetch one of the protein bars from his room. But, going back there at such busy and sociable hours came with its challenges; he had been able to successfully avoid his friends for days, except for Kaminari. He'd kept his immunity and Kacchan secret from all of them, but it was no easy task. He could see how concerned they were for him, how worried, and every bone in his body wanted to reach out and reassure them all that he was ok. But, for as much as everyone had been careful to skip over the topic these last four months, it was only a matter of time before the subject of Kacchan came up. And Izuku had never been a very good liar.

After bumping into Kaminari that morning, seeing the way he had stared a little too long at Kacchan as they passed, left a heaviness in his gut that had little to do with his own safety. If Kaminari had even the smallest suspicion, and he brought it up to Izuku right now, there was every chance that he'd see through Izuku's lies. And, if that happened, how long before Kaminari ended up as a *precious resource* just for suspecting too much?

He decided it would be safer to skip dinner.

Izuku instead spent his night in the rec area, bundled up against the cold as fine snow kissed his nose and cheeks. It was one of the few places on the campus where he could be outside, and if he lay in the middle and stared directly up, without the buildings and tall walls of UA obscuring his view, he could almost convince himself that he wasn't here at all. It wasn't lost on him how messed up it was that he was missing the months that he had spent just trying to survive out there in the world with Kacchan. Despite the grief, the fear, the pain, the *loss* … there had been but one simple rule. Survive.

And they had been good at it. Out there, side by side, there had been almost nothing that he and Kacchan couldn't do together. But here, in these walls where their lives and the lives of their friends were up to the will of Shigaraki, he had far less control than he had ever done out there with the dead.

He often wondered, if things had gone differently - if he and Kacchan had never found Kirishima and the others - if they had just survived out there, the two of them, if maybe everyone might have been safer. Perhaps their friends might have found their own way inside of UA one day, gone on to live their lives without him and Kacchan putting them in danger. How long could they last out there? Months? *Years* ? If Kacchan had never been bitten that second time, would the alcohol have been enough to keep the infection from spreading? He fancied, in his most vulnerable of moments, finding their way back to that cabin in the woods. Settling down, just the two of them, where they could have kept one another safe.

But Izuku knew it was only a fantasy. Kacchan wouldn't have been able to live with himself had he just given up on finding his friends, and deep down Izuku knew he'd be the same.

As evening progressed into midnight, Izuku figured that it was safe for him to try and sneak his way into Kacchan's room. Aizawa had already paged him that afternoon to tell him that Kacchan's blood work was being taken care of by Toshinori and that he should remain in the lab, so he hadn't seen him since that morning. They hadn't agreed to meet, but after all that had happened today, Kacchan was probably expecting Izuku to turn up. He gathered his coat around him, fingers numb and shaky from lying in the cold for so long, and made his way to the nomu dorms.

Just as he hoped, the corridors and the lab were completely empty, and when he pushed open the door to the dorm it was dark save for the light coming from the kitchen area. The doors did a decent job of soundproofing each of the rooms, but as he crept closer to Kacchan's room, he could just make out the sound of snoring coming from one of the others and, as confident as he could be that all of the nomu were asleep, Izuku pressed his keycard against the lock and slipped inside of Kacchan's room.

The night light was on, and that was about all he saw before something hit him, hard, in the face. It was all he could do to slap his hand over his mouth so that he didn't screech out loud and wake up the entire dorm, and he backed up, squinting through watery eyes.

“Oh. Shit, my bad.”

“What the hell?”

“I said *my bad* .”

“What did you even throw at me?”

Izuku looked down at the paperback lying at his feet, before reaching down and grabbing it, the words *‘Call Me By Your Name’* across the dog-eared cover. He glances back up.

“Are you reading erotica?”

Kacchan glares, his arms crossed over his chest and he slumps lower onto the bed. “Who even calls it that? Also, fuck off, there’s sod all else to do in here!”

“It’s looking pretty well-read,” Izuku says, surprised to find his lips curling into a smirk when Kacchan’s face only gets redder as he holds up the book. “Compared to the other books on the shelf.”

“It looked like that when I got here,” Kacchan grumbled. “Double fuck off. Besides, *you* know what it is. I’m only reading it because it’s between that and a history of sheep in Japan.”

“Who keeps sheep in Japan?”

“Exactly. It’s a dull fucking read. But my point *is* , you chose to read it.”

“Hmm, ok Kacchan.”

“Don’t ‘ *ok Kacchan’* me!”

“It’s kind of a sad story,” Izuku said, placing the book down on the table beside Kacchan’s bed. “You know they don’t even end up together in the end?”

“Gee, thanks for the fucking spoiler, Deku.”

Izuku sat himself down on the edge of Kacchan’s bed, close enough that he could get a good look at him. His cheeks were still decidedly pink, and there was the slightest glistening of sweat on his forehead, but otherwise he looked like he always did.

“How are you feeling?”

Kacchan bristled.

“Fine, Deku.”

“Just…” Izuku hesitated. “The hormone markers-”

“I feel fine, idiot. If they were worried I was gonna turn overnight they would have bumped my

meds already. Quit worrying."

"They haven't upped them yet?"

"They're morning only, Deku."

"Oh, right. Right, yeh…"

Kacchan scowled.

"I told you already, I feel fine. Besides, don't we got other shit to be dealing with?"

"Right," Izuku repeated. He places his hands on the bed, pulling his legs up beneath him so that he could sit cross-legged, facing Kacchan. His fingers quickly drop to the sheets, anxiously folding the fabric between his fingers.

"You think we can trust them? Aizawa and Hawks, I mean."

"No," Kacchan replied immediately. "I don't think we can trust a single fucker in here. But what choice do we have?"

"None."

"Unless we figure out a way to do all this by ourselves. But Dog Eyes is only going to be watching us more now." He raises an eyebrow. "He probably already knows you've been sneaking down here."

"Well, he hasn't stopped it, so he can't feel too threatened by us talking alone."

Kacchan grunts, before leaning forward, his blanket dropping down to his lap.

"One thing I don't get. If your immunity and my… resilience, whatever, is what Shigaraki's been waiting for, why ain't he experimenting on us already? Why's he not taking us apart and figuring out how shit works?"

Izuku tried not to think too hard about the image that brought to mind.

"He already has our blood, Kacchan. Who's to say he needs any more than that? He keeps the nomu around for a reason, it might be better for him long term to keep us alive and working for him."

Kacchan grunted but didn't look convinced.

"We're all important to him in some way," Izuku continued. "We're a *resource* , remember? Better to keep us in one piece."

"Maybe he thinks we'll be loyal to him or some shit. The other nomu? They do as they're fucking asked, because far as they're concerned in here being bossed around is better than out *there* being eaten." Kacchan nodded his head towards the door. "Probably thinks we'll be exactly the same."

“Then we let him keep thinking that,” Izuku replied. “And wait to see what Aizawa has planned.”

“Fucking hate this.”

“I know.”

They sat in silence, Izuku looking down at the sheets as he twisted the fabric around his pointer finger lost in thought until, after a moment, he began to feel the weight of Kacchan’s eyes on him. He looked up, to see Kacchan leaning forward, elbow on his knee and chin propped on his hand, watching Izuku with a strangely calm look on his face.

“What?” Izuku asked, feeling suddenly self-conscious and reaching up to touch his face, almost expecting to find something there. Kacchan quirked his lip.

“Wanna fool around?”

Izuku spluttered, feeling his face burn. Kacchan’s growing confidence, and his apparent ability to say whatever the hell he wanted without crumbling immediately afterwards, was surely going to be the end of him.

“You just- you just *ask* ? Just like that?”

“How else do you expect me to go about it?” Kacchan said, looking amused.

“I dunno! It’s just… we’ve never… y’know, it’s been a while since anything felt-”

“Normal?”

“I was going to say *casual* , but I guess normal’s right.”

Kacchan’s brows rose.

“You saying we just casual, Deku?”

“No! That’s not-”

“Whatever, I’ll just go back to reading my *erotica* .” Kacchan did an unflattering imitation of Izuku’s voice as he reached for the book, only for Izuku to hurry forward and slap the back of his hand. There was a moment, Izuku shocked by his own reaction, and Kacchan looking at him like the cat that got the cream, before Izuku drew back into himself, hands covering his face and groaning.

“I’m sorry! Oh, that was so embarrassing.”

“It really was,” Kacchan snorted.

“It’s just… ugh! I’m still getting used to everything!” Izuku whined, peering at Kacchan over the tips of his fingers. “We’ve always had to keep each other at arm's length, or watch out for zombies or-”

“Izuku.”

“What?”

“Quit overthinking everything and kiss me.”

“Ok.”

More than grateful for the guidance, Izuku scooted forward, hands grabbing Kacchan’s knees as he tried not to tumble forward, but his movements were still clumsy as their lips met, Kacchan grunting under the impact. Izuku had little time to feel embarrassed before he felt weightless for a moment, his body yanked forward and cushioned by the bed beneath him. Kacchan was on top of him in an instant, his weight centred on Izuku hips, and hot palms cradling his cheeks, angling his face upwards so that Kacchan could slot their lips together in a much more satisfying way.

Izuku melted into the contact instantly, giving in to the demanding nips against his lower lip, and sighing as he felt Kacchan’s tongue slide against his. Izuku had been kissed before, and he’d been with people that he’d felt a connection to, in one way or another, but *nothing* compared to how every single movement Kacchan made lit his nerves on fire. The gentle swipe of a thumb against the corner of his lips, the squeeze of bare thighs - *since when did Kacchan sleep without pyjama bottoms?* - around his hips, the warm breath panted into his mouth each time Kacchan adjusted his angle, all of it left his body and his soul feeling so full. It was everything, all the sweetness that he craved, and Kacchan was *oh-so generous* with it.

After curling his tongue against his front palate and earning a long low groan from Izuku, Kacchan pulled back just enough so that he could look Izuku in the eye, pupils blown wide and highlighted by the night light.

“When was the last time you showered?”

Izuku flushed, embarrassed for a whole different reason now.

“Like, yesterday morning. Why, do I smell that bad?”

“No, idiot.” Kacchan leaned back, seeming to appraise him from his higher position. “Wanna eat you out.”

Izuku squeaked.

“You really do just say what you think, huh?”

“Dumb not to.”

Kacchan threw him a truly *devastating* grin, before he began to slide downwards, hands coming to the waistband of Izuku’s trousers.

“Wait!” Izuku grabbed his wrists. “I mean, I *showered* , sure but it’s not… it’s not like I was *thorough.* ”

“Like I give a shit,” Kacchan said, unperturbed and shaking Izuku’s hands loose, continuing to his

goal regardless.

“Kacchan!” Izuku whined, grabbing hold of Kacchan’s ear this time, and earning a simmering glare. “I mean it, it’s… I didn’t clean expecting that kind of audience.”

“Audience?” Kacchan snorted.

Izuku’s lips pressed together, and Kacchan rolled his eyes dramatically.

“Give over, Deku. I know what your ass smells like.”

“I really wish you didn’t!”

“Ugh, fine!”

Kacchan flopped down onto his stomach, his chin resting over Izuku’s hip as he glared up at him, lower lip sticking out in an exaggerated pout.

“Are you sulking?” Izuku asked, his wobbly exterior giving way to mirth as he took in the ridiculous sight. Kacchan, somehow, only managed to look more sour.

“I don’t sulk.”

Izuku laughed. If there was one thing that he knew for certain, it was that Bakugou Katsuki sulked, and often. That, however, seemed like the last straw for Kacchan, and he sat himself up on his knees, grabbed a rough handful of Izuku’s hips and dragged. It was another of those occasions where Izuku was reminded of just how absurdly strong Kacchan was, before finding his legs wrapped around Kacchan’s waist, staring into narrowed pink and red eyes.

“Trying to blow your mind here, Deku.”

“You don’t need to try. You blow my mind every day.”

Watching the blush form on Kacchan’s cheeks in real-time was about one of the most satisfying things Izuku ever experienced; seeing him, so confident and so headstrong, so flustered from Izuku’s words alone was a high like no other, and he couldn’t stop himself from pressing the lightest kiss upon the tip of his nose. Kacchan stuck out his tongue, making a gagging sound.

“Gross.”

“Says the man who just offered to eat me out.”

“Still less gross than whatever shit comes out your mouth, Deku.”

“That’s disgusting.”

Kacchan made a dismissive sound in the back of his throat, before attacking his mouth once more, all teeth and tongue and desire, and it was all that Izuku could do to keep up, his head swimming and toes curling, as he clung onto the man on top of him. He groaned as their crotches pressed together, the firmness unmistakable even through Izuku’s layers of clothing, and a guttural, feral

sound rumbled low in Kacchan's chest as he reached down, grabbing a handful of Izuku's ass and tugging, leaving no space between them as they ground together.

Izuku felt so dizzy, hot, he was certain his face must be bright red as Kacchan's mouth began to trail over his lips and down to his jaw, before licking a long wet stripe up his throat. He gasped, fingers tightening around Kacchan's shoulders, just holding on as best he could as Kacchan took the reins.

"Off," he managed to gasp, tugging at Kacchan's shirt. "Clothes. Off."

Kacchan dropped Izuku back on the bed with a *thump* that was far too loud for the early hours of the morning, the shaking of his hands as he tore his shirt over his head betraying just how affected he was by all of this. His briefs were gone almost as quickly, the bed bouncing and Izuku having to grab hold of the sheets so that he wasn't rolled onto the floor with how much Kacchan was kicking his legs out to rid himself of the last of his clothing before he looked back down at him.

Izuku's mouth watered, saliva filling his mouth at a frankly alarming rate as he stared at the man towering over him. His body, always so muscular and lithe, heaved and trembled with every breath, the network of scars running from his face to his thighs prettier than anything Izuku had ever seen.

"Yours too."

Izuku nodded, frantically reaching for the button of his jeans. With Kacchan's help, Izuku was naked in record time, and Kacchan fingers were digging almost painfully into the flesh of his ass as he lifted Izuku's hips again and ground against him, the still dry drag of their dicks leaving Izuku scrambling for purchase on the sheets beneath him.

"Ka- *Kacchan*- "

"Yeh?" Kacchan leaned in close, his voice rumbling in Izuku's ear and his hot breath sending shivers down his spine. "Tell me what you want."

Izuku had no *idea* what he wanted. He could barely formulate a solid thought besides the need to be closer, *closer* , and he just whined, tightening his legs against Kacchan's waist.

"Sh-shit," Kacchan gasped, and Izuku could feel his body shaking. "Ok, fuck, ok wait-"

Kacchan leaned back, Izuku's arms dropping heavily onto the bed, watching through hazy eyes as Kacchan got to his knees, bruising grip lifting Izuku's hips higher, Izuku's back arching to accommodate the change in position. Kacchan's thumbs dragged over his hip bones, Izuku shivering as the nails scraped over his skin. He could almost feel the heat as Kacchan stared, eyelids heavy, Izuku more exposed than he had ever felt before whilst Kacchan took in every inch of his figure, lingering on his dick. His soul all but left his body when Kacchan lowered his head and spat directly onto his aching shaft, Izuku's desperate whimper filling the room.

"Gonna need you to hold on, baby."

Izuku tightened his legs, locking his ankles together when Kacchan took one hand away from his hip and wrapped it around Izuku's cock, then any and all pretence of decorum was lost, his head thrashing back onto the bed and his hips bucking into Kacchan's fist.

“Fuck, *Izuku* .”

Kacchan watched with unmasked wonder as his hand dragged over his dick, thumb brushing to collect the pearl of precum before dragging it back down to the base, Izuku keening as he began a torturously slow pump up and down, cock starting to glisten with the spit coating it. Just as Izuku began to pant, unable to stop his hips from bucking and urging more *more* , Kacchan spat again, the sound wet and obscene, before he angled his hips and closed his fist tightly around both of their cocks, groaning and hanging his head.

It was a sight to behold, the muscles on Kacchan’s arms strained and bulging as he held Izuku in the air and jerked them both off, his breathing heavy, the softest whines and pants breaking from his lips, sweat dripping from his forehead and landing on Izuku’s stomach, and Izuku’s entire being focused on the points where their bodies connected. But he wanted more, needed *more* , Kacchan suddenly altogether too far away, and all but delirious with want he bucked his hips hard, Kacchan’s palm slipping from his ass, throwing his hand out just in time to stop them from falling flat onto the bed. Izuku’s first instinct was to apologise, but any such thoughts were knocked clear from his mind when he looked up to find himself caged in with a low snarl, a strong arm stretched out above him, hot palm so close to his face it almost burned. Kacchan panted openly, still working his hand between them, red eye almost as clouded as the milky pink, and a thrill ran through him.

“ *Kacchan.* ”

He reached up, gently gliding his hand over Kacchan’s cheeks, before reaching the short tufts of hair on his head and tugging, coaxing the beautiful, *perfect* snarl from Kacchan’s throat again. Kacchan turned his head, his teeth clamping down on the soft, vulnerable skin of Izuku’s inner wrist, the sharp sudden pain blooming with a heat that ran straight down to Izuku’s dick as he gasped.

Izuku never thought he was one for danger, not until he realised quite how alive he had felt out there, out-running zombies with Kacchan at his side. And as lust and pleasure clouded his thoughts, he reached for Kacchan’s wrist with his other hand, tugging, watching Kacchan’s eyes widen in understanding as he raised his chin, exposing his throat.

He was perhaps too gone to understand the true weight of what he was asking, just wanting to feel more of that desperate, carnal desire and Kacchan’s strength. Kacchan’s eyes, alert once more, darted over Izuku’s face, tense and unsure.

“Please,” Izuku whispered.

Kacchan seemed to melt into the role, pupils blown wide, mouthing at Izuku’s wrist one last time before sitting back on his heels again, dragging Izuku with him. His free hand pushed its way up the middle of Izuku’s chest, the pressure already so much before he even wrapped long fingers around Izuku’s throat. He didn’t squeeze at first, just keeping his hand there as he let go of their cocks and grabbed Izuku’s ass again, rocking his hips and building up a rhythm. Izuku swallowed, feeling his throat bob against Kacchan’s palm, the liquid smooth friction of his dick against the hard planes of Kacchan’s stomach as he frotted against him. Izuku reached up, wrapping his hand around Kacchan’s wrist and squeezing, watching the tension roll from Kacchan’s shoulders at the realisation that he *wanted* his.

Kacchan gripped, fingers squeezing the sides of Izuku's throat, and just like that Izuku felt himself slipping, tumbling, falling in a space where the only thing in the world was the heat of Kacchan's hands, the pressure on his dick, and the loud slaps as hips met thighs, all blooming into a white-hot pleasure that left Izuku gasping and back arching. Spots danced over his vision, there was a ringing in his ears, as he came harder than he had ever done in his life.

He might well have passed out after that, everything around him so dark and so warm, a weight on top of him and a voice murmuring in his ear. It was only when he felt himself being shoved, that he took stock of his surroundings again, seeing a frantic face staring down at him.

"Oi!"

Izuku hummed, laughing softly, reaching up and lazily patting the entire of Kacchan's face.

"M'alive."

"Asshole. Don't fucking pass out after I choke you."

But Izuku was drifting, comfortable basking in the afterglow, and he tugged Kacchan down towards him.

"Nhg, lemme clean you up first at least."

He felt something soft drag against his front, Kacchan muttering that he was going to need to burn his shirt before a weight dropped down onto the bed beside him again.

"You can't stay here all night," Kacchan said. "Unless you want us to get caught."

"I won't sleep long," Izuku replied, dragging Kacchan in and pressing his face against his chest. "Body clock'll wake me up at five, can slip out then."

"Yeh well, your body ain't usually this fuckin' cock drunk."

"Shuddup and c'mere."

Kacchan grumbled some more, but he still leaned in, arm hooking over Izuku's shoulder and burying his face into Izuku's hair, and within moments Izuku was back in the dark, warm, comfortable place, and drifting off to sleep.

"I think it's this way."

Izuku doesn't, not when the walls on either side of him seem to have no end, extending out to the inky darkness ahead. But Kacchan is in front of him, and he walks with such purpose that Izuku is helpless but to follow.

And follow.

He isn't sure how long they walk, but it feels like a lifetime, down that endless hallway where the paint seems to peel in exactly the same way.

“I think it’s this way.”

Izuku doesn’t, not when Kacchan has told him this already. Not when it started to get warmer the longer they walked, Izuku reaching up and tugging on his shirt collar to try and find some relief from that stifling heat.

“I think it’s this way.”

Izuku doesn’t, not when Kacchan says it like that. Kacchan would be certain. He’d know. But Kacchan is still ahead of him, and he trusts him with his life. So he follows. He follows until Kacchan stops.

“It’s here.”

Izuku swallows, and all at once it’s suffocating. The heat is oppressive and unbearable, and Izuku can only gasp, tearing at a shirt that refused to give, only tightening its hold on his throat the more that he struggled. He stumbles backwards, his back hitting another wall except this wall gives. It’s wet and it’s hot and Izuku has never been so scared in his life when he feels the hands begin to wrap around his body, inching over his face, fingers pressing into his temple, the sockets around his eyes, the corner of his lips.

He tries to scream, to shout out for Kacchan who is just right there *. Barely three feet away from him, back turned. He’s dying, the pressure against his skull is crushing him, the hands around his waist burrowing into his flesh. He’s* dying *.*

And finally, Kacchan turns around. Except, this isn’t the Kacchan he knows. His skin is sallow and tight over his skull, deep sunken rings around his mismatched pink and red eyes, and there is a hole where his nose should be.

Izuku jolts, eyes springing open and gasping, thrashing in place as he still feels the heat. Something is wrapped around him, and it takes him several long, *terrifying* moments before he realises that it’s just Kacchan, lying beside him, face still intact, eyes shut and sleeping. He blinks, trying to calm himself down before he realises that something is wrong.

Kacchan has always run hot, but right now he was scalding. And as Izuku squints back at him in the low light, he realises that there is sweat beading across every inch of bare skin, brow furrowed and body trembling and shivering.

“K-Kacchan?”

He pushes himself up, able to break free from Kacchan’s grip, but the man doesn’t stir, and Izuku starts to feel nauseous. He reaches out, gently rocking Kacchan’s shoulder.

“Kacchan?”

Kacchan groans, the sound low and cascading, but his eyes stay shut, and Izuku reaches out with both hands now, shaking him more insistently.

Eventually, Kacchan wakes, eyes unfocused and foggy, and Izuku cries in relief, inching closer so that he can help Kacchan sit up.

“Hey, you ok?” He reaches forward, raising his hand so that he can press his wrist to Kacchan’s forehead before he’s startled by a sharp, animalistic sound, and a hot heavy weight against his chest.

It’s a miracle that he’s able to get his hands up in front of him fast enough to stop Kacchan’s teeth from snapping shut over his cheeks, grunting over the effort of holding back a man so much bigger and stronger than him. Kacchan snarls pupils tightened into pinpricks, and Izuku cries out, the panicked '*Kacchan, stop*!' leaving his throat in a tight scramble, arms shaking and beginning to give way just as Kacchan seems to become aware of his surroundings once more. There’s a moment, where the light returns to his eyes and he just stares, before he’s throwing himself backwards, back hitting the wall hard enough to shake the books from the shelf.

“Kacchan?” Izuku rushes towards him, indifferent to how close Kacchan had come to hurting him, and only wanting to ease that terrified and devastated look on his face, but Kacchan shrank back further, feet kicking.

“Stop!”

His voice is broken, desperate.

“Do-don’t come-”

But that seemed to be about all he could handle, breaking out into violent trembles, his eyes rolling to the back of his head, and slumping onto his side.

“Kacchan!”

Izuku reaches for him, but no matter how hard he shakes, Kacchan doesn’t stir, and he begins to panic. The virus… it had to be… *the hormone markers*...

Izuku scrambles to his feet, reaching for his discarded jeans and shoving his hand into the pockets until he finds the pager and, not knowing what else to do, he sends a frantic message to Aizawa.

“Come quick. Kacchan. Turning.”

Chapter End Notes

Happy Kacchan Week, you guys.

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 46: Brain Before Brawn

Chapter Summary

In which Aizawa risks his neck.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“We’ve put him in another coma whilst we administer the amiodarone at its highest dosage. Hormone markers were high, high as what we’d expect to see in a fully infected. Honestly, Midoriya, I can’t say whether we’ll be able to reduce them this time.”

Izuku barely registered the words as he stood at the bottom of the bed, looking over at the pale figure of the man he loves. The last ten hours had been *hell*; after Izuku's page, Aizawa had wasted little time turning up at Kacchan's door, flanked on either side by Professor Toshinori and Hawks, with what looked like a pistol in his hand. It had been no small mercy that Kacchan had been a shivering heap on the ground, unconscious and unreactive so that Hawks could be the one to carry him, still naked and covered in sweat, to the hospital room. Izuku had hovered, arms outstretched and darting at Hawks' side to help, only dimly aware that he himself was barely dressed.

To his grief, Izuku hadn’t been allowed in the hospital room at all for ten hours. He’d paced, grabbed at his hair, and fought back the urge to vomit, his thoughts only on Kacchan. *Kacchan* . Aizawa had taken him aside not long after Kacchan was taken away to ask him exactly what had happened. Izuku had been hesitant. He had no idea what they were doing with Kacchan, or what state he was in; he had been taken away from him without explanation, and anything he said could put Kacchan in even more danger.

“I’m on your side,” Aizawa said, placing a hand on Izuku’s shoulder, voice hushed and uncharacteristically soft. “I’ll keep what I can from Shigaraki, but I *need* to know the truth if we’re to stand a chance at helping him.”

It had hurt, the words scalding against Izuku’s tongue as he told Aizwa all he could, far too worried about Kacchan to feel embarrassed about the more scandalous details. Kacchan had been fine when he got to his room, when they had made love, when they eventually fell asleep, and then he had woken up to Kacchan feverish and unaware of where he was before passing out, keeping just how violent Kacchan had been to himself. Toshinori had joined them by the end of his explanation, and Izuku couldn’t remember ever seeing the man angry until that point; how could Izuku have been so foolish? Despite Izuku’s assurances that they had been careful, nothing had eased Toshinori’s mind, not until he had given a fresh blood sample to prove that he hadn’t been infected.

The hours that followed had been harrowing. Izuku was scared for Kacchan, but he was also very much aware that he had been exposed to the virus just hours ago. Would it show up in his blood? Would it look like he was infected? Was the secret of his immunity about to be unceremoniously revealed? And if it did, how long before he found himself unconscious and belted to a hospital bed

just as Kacchan had been?

Eventually, he was allowed to see Kacchan, and all thoughts of his blood test were quickly erased. It was at the foot of Kacchan's bed that he found himself now, staring numbly as Aizawa spoke.

"Even Toshinori couldn't predict that his hormone levels would spike so dramatically overnight, or we would have hospitalised him yesterday. As it stands, all we can do is induce the cirrhosis and wait to see what happens."

Izuku nodded, though the words made very little sense to him. Just twelve hours ago, Kacchan had been so full of life, smirking openly, panting against his throat and licking into his mouth as they writhed on his bed together. Now, he looked like a corpse; pale skin already turning yellow, tubes and wires attached to his face and chest and arms, the ventilator once again breathing for him.

"You'll also be pleased to know that your bloods came back negative. Your secret is safe, for now. Not without your best efforts to sabotage it."

Izuku almost asked what secret, stomach dropping at the thought that Aizawa knew about the immunity before he realised that he must have been talking about Izuku and Kacchan's relationship. Aizawa was right, though; even with a clear blood test, there would be questions. After all, how could someone get so close to an infected and not become infected themselves? He couldn't find it in himself to feel ashamed or guilty, however. If Izuku hadn't been there, how long would it have been before Kacchan was found? How long before he would have fully turned? No, Izuku didn't regret any of it.

"The markers," he said instead, voice distant even to himself. "Are they higher than when you first found him?"

Aizawa sighed, the sound heavy and filling the room. Izuku winced. For the first time in what felt like hours, he dragged his eyes away from Kacchan and looked at Aizawa.

"I don't think you heard what I said, kid. Every single test we've run, far as the results are concerned, Bakugou has turned."

"But his tests said that before, didn't they?" Izuku pressed. "You said he was final stage then, too. So, there's still hope."

Aizawa stared back at him, expression tight, something in his eyes that Izuku couldn't decipher, but before he could respond, there was a knock at the door, and Professor Toshinori walked in, zeroing in on Izuku.

"Young Midoriya," he said somewhat breathlessly. "Has Aizawa told you the good news?"

It took Izuku a moment to figure out what could *possibly* be considered good news before he realised that Toshinori must be talking about his blood test.

"Yeh, he-" Izuku swallowed, feeling hot around the collar and feeling the need to defend Kacchan, defend their choices. "It wasn't the first time that we- we've *always* been careful. Took precautions, so that I wouldn't be infected."

If he thought that the Professor would be in any way eased by this, he swiftly gave up that notion as he began to pace, dragging both hands through his wild hair and staring at Izuku in horror.

“Young man I- I don’t even know where to begin!” He cried. “The risk of infection is extraordinarily high! There’s just no way to guarantee that any precautions would have guaranteed your safety. You put yourself and Bakugou at risk! If something had happened- think of your *mother-* ”

Izuku flinched. He had not spoken to the Professor or his mother about the relationship that Shigaraki had hinted at, and right now it was something he really didn’t want to think about.

“-If I had known that your relationship with Bakugou was this close, I would have never agreed to you working with him. Frankly, if I had the heart to do it, I would be firing you right now.”

Izuku didn’t respond, gaze drifting back to Kacchan, lured by the sickening rhythm of his heart monitor and ventilator.

“Right now, there’s not an awful lot more that we can do,” Aizawa said. “We’ll continue to assess Dynamite over the coming days. Luck has hardly been on our side these last few years, but maybe we’ll see the hormone markers drop, and we can talk about the possibility of waking him up. Until then, we wait.”

The possibility. Kacchan was strong, stronger than anyone he knew, and Izuku refused to believe that there was even a chance that he wouldn’t wake up from this.

“I need to be here,” he said. “I can’t leave him.”

At that, Aizawa pressed a hand to his face, shrugging his shoulders.

“He’s *your* researcher,” he said to Toshinori. “So, I’ll let you decide what to do with him. Right now, I have damage control to take care of.” He paused for a moment, meeting Izuku’s eyes. “Man up top was pretty disappointed to hear that Dynamite’s virus progressed to final stage.”

“It’s a blow for sure,” Toshinori agreed. “The nomu are our best defence, and our best chance at finding a cure.”

But Izuku knew a *cure* wasn’t what Shigaraki was interested in. It wasn’t for the sake of a damn cure that the man was so disappointed.

“It’s in your hands for the moment, Toshinori,” Aizawa said, now heading to the door. “Keep me updated on Dynamite’s condition. Midoriya.” He jerked his head in acknowledgement before leaving Izuku and the Professor alone in the hospital room.

“Is there anything I can do to help?” Izuku asked. “M-maybe Kacchan’s medication? Watch his vitals?”

“Kayama and I have that more than covered,” Toshinori replied, voice still tight. “I know it’s not what you want to hear, young Midoriya, but there’s nothing more you can do for young Bakugou. Right now, I want you to go back to your room and get some decent sleep. And maybe-” Toshinori offered him a small, wobbly smile “-maybe you should give your mother a visit? When was the last

time she got to see you?"

Izuku flushed, averting his gaze. It had been days since he had last seen her. Hell, at this stage, it could well have been weeks.

"I don't want to leave him."

"You have my word that if anything changes, you'll be the first person I contact," Toshnori replied softly.

Izuku had no idea what time it was once he stumbled his way back to his dorm room. He was exhausted. That aching oppressive weight on his shoulders showed no sign of relenting, a fogginess starting to fray at the edges of his sanity, but the idea of sleeping, or even shutting his eyes, whilst Kacchan lay in yet another coma was unthinkable. That he was here, once more in this state of constant fear, so soon after getting Kacchan back, was starting to push the limits of what he could handle. His chest *ached,* and he could feel the lacklustre effort of his heart to pump blood to his arm as he pushed open his bedroom door.

At first, he almost didn't notice the people in his room, chalking up their figures as some sort of delirium prompted by his exhaustion. But when the murky shadows didn't vanish despite pressing his knuckles against his one good eye, he realised that two people were waiting for him, one sat on his bed and the other leaned against the metal bars across the window.

"His royal highness returns!"

Kaminari's voice was far too loud for the quiet of the dorms, shocking a hiss from Izuku as he shut his door behind him. Kaminari's hair, longer than it had been, was pushed back with a fluffy-looking headband, putting the scars on his face in sharp relief. Despite the obvious resentment in his tone, there was a genuine smile on his face as he held his arms out in welcome.

"You know how many mornings we've been here trying to catch you?" he said. "Mina isn't going to be happy when she finds out it wasn't on her shift."

"Uh… *shift* ?"

"We've been trying to talk to you for days."

Shouto speaks from Izuku's bed, and he feels his heart drop. Shouto's expression didn't hold any of the warmth that Kaminari's did, mismatched eyes boring into him and adding to the seemingly endless pile of guilt that Izuku had begun to accumulate where Shouto was concerned over these last two years. It had been a long time since he had last seen him… weeks? Months? In truth, Izuku had completely lost track.

"I've been busy," he replied, doggedly avoiding Shouto's piercing stare. "You know that."

"Too busy for Mina and Kirishima's baby shower?"

Izuku groaned, rubbing his hands over his face. *Of course. God, he had promised…*

"I- I'm sorry. I just… I lost track of time, is all and-"

“It was important to them, man,” Kaminari said, head tilting to the side.

“I know, I’ll go see them in a few days and-”

“That’s not the point. They really wanted you to be there, man. They had the whole thing planned early because they wanted us all there for it. We haven’t been together for months, not since…” Kaminari trailed off, and Izuku knew what he had been about to say. *Not since the stadium. Not since they had lost Kacchan.*

“I don’t know what you want from me,” Izuku replied, the stress leaving him feeling irritated and on edge. “I was *busy* . I forgot. Mina’s not even halfway yet, right? There’s still time for us to get together!”

“ *Is there?* ”

Izuku started at Shouto’s cool voice.

“What does that mean?”

“You don’t look well, Izuku. And every time I catch a glimpse of you, you look worse.”

“Yeh, man. Come on, you look even skinnier than when we were fighting the zombies.”

Izuku bristled. “I keep *telling you.* I’m busy. Sometimes I forget to eat, but I feel fine. Really. You don’t need to worry about me.”

“But are you busy?” Shouto asked bluntly. “Or are you just trying to avoid us?”

Izuku blinks, mouth agape.

“ *What?* ”

“Uh,” Kaminari jumps in, laughing nervously. “Ok, we weren’t just going to come out and say it - *so much for that script, Todoroki* - but, look. We’re just… since we got here, you’ve hardly said a word to any of us. And even when we try to talk to you, it’s like you can’t get away quick enough.”

“What is there to say?” Izuku demanded, raising his arms and his voice in frustration. “We fought so hard to get here, and now that we are here, I am just doing what I can to help! To figure it all out!”

“But you don’t have to push us away to do that!” Shouto yelled back, getting to his feet before he seemed to sway, and his voice grew tight. “Please don’t push me away.”

The breath caught in Izuku’s throat, and all at once, the anger he was feeling faded.

“Shouto-”

“I know it’s my fault. I know that he died because of me, *instead* of me. I took him from you, and I have no right to ask for anything.”

“No, Shouto, it’s not like that!”

“But *please* don’t cut me out,” Shouto continued, eyes dropping to the floor. “I can’t stand it. Everything, everyone we’ve lost. It’s selfish, but losing you, seeing you pull away from me, I-” Shouto’s voice wavered, sounding thick and wet, and all at once the reality of the situation truly dawned on Izuku, and he felt sick to his stomach. Kaminari stood silently to the side, not looking at either of them, eyes misted over with something of his own, and Izuku swallowed.

“Todoroki isn’t the only one who feels that way, you know?” Kaminari said. “Ka- Katsuki wouldn’t have had to save me if I hadn’t seen such an idiot. Hell, if I had just *listened* to you instead of thinking that I knew best, going after them like that, none of you would have been out there.”

“No,” Izuku shook his head. “No, I don’t think that. I don’t blame you, either of you, and neither does- *would* Kacchan. I’m sorry, I’m so sorry. I was just so caught up with my own thing and work, I didn’t realise how much it was hurting you or what you were thinking. I- I’ll do better. I’ll be here.”

But the words stung as they clawed their way out of his throat, knowing that no matter how much he meant them, how much he wanted them to be true, they couldn’t be. Shouto’s jaw tensed, his red-rimmed eyes lingering just to the left of Izuku’s face, a heaviness about his features that showed he knew that too.

“We just want to know that you’re ok,” Kaminari said. “That’s all. We never talked about it. About Katsuki. It was all just such a mess after we got here, it’s like we hardly got the chance.”

“It’s-” Izuku sighed. “I don’t know what to say. Of course, it was hard after, but I never blamed either of you for what happened.”

“Hard because… because no one really saw what happened, right?” Kaminari said, his voice hesitant, leading. “I mean, you saw the explosion but…” He trailed off, but his expression was intense, watching Izuku. It was then that Izuku remembered the way Kaminari had noticed Kacchan back then, had eyed him curiously even through the face mask and the heavy scarring that ought to have made Kacchan unrecognisable.

“I saw the explosion,” Izuku confirmed, willing for his voice to remain steady. “Right after Kacchan locked himself in the stadium with the zombies.”

“Right, but…” Kaminari shifted, glancing at Shouto, who sat back on Izuku’s bed, his fingers steepled and shoulders hunched uncomfortably. “We don’t *know* that… I mean, he survived one zombie bite, right? We don’t know that he didn’t-”

“He was surrounded by dynamite and holding the detonator,” Izuku said sharply. “It isn’t like another zombie bite.”

“Midoriya-” Kaminari paused, shaking his head and pushing away from where he had been leaning against the window. “I’m just gonna say it. That guy, the one I saw you with the other day, it’s just… he looked a whole lot like-”

“It’s not.”

Kaminari froze, taken aback by the abruptness of Izuku's words, the coldness in his tone.

"It isn't him. Kacchan's dead, and you should just let this *go* ."

Kaminari's head tilted to the side, eyeing Izuku like he was some complicated math problem before his eyes widened, his mouth forming a soft *'oh'* of realisation, and the nervous pit in Izuku's stomach only grew.

"We're not supposed to know. There *is* something going on here, in this place, but we're not supposed to-"

"Kaminari," Izuku interrupted, heart racing, unable to stop himself from glancing back at his door to the window, sweat beading against his skin and the hair on his neck standing on end. He almost expected someone to kick down his door at any second, for Shigaraki to stride in and take care of Kaminari and Shouto both. The fear must have been obvious on his face, because Kaminari fell silent, and Shouto tensed up like he was about to get to his feet again.

"Please. There's nothing- it isn't anything like that."

"Are we safe here?" Shouto asked suddenly. "Izuku, are *you* safe?"

"Yes," Izuku replied hurriedly, waving his hands about in a way that was far from comforting. "I told you, everything is fine. *I'm* fine."

Nothing was reassuring about the silence that followed, Shouto's expression painful and desperate as he looked at him, and not for the first time, Izuku felt truly trapped. It would have been better if his friends had gone on believing that he wanted to avoid them, that he wanted nothing to do with them.

"I've had a long night," Izuku said. "I'll, uh, I'll stop in with Mina and Kirishima soon, but right now I just want to get some sleep."

"Right," Kaminari said tightly. "Sure, yeh, of course, man. We'll get out of your hair."

Kaminari walked to the door, but Shouto made no move to follow him, just looking at Izuku with an expression that damn near shattered what was left of Izuku's heart. Everything in him screamed to reach out to his friend, to reassure him, to ease the worry creasing the corner of his eyes, but now more than ever, he knew that distance mattered. Distance was what kept Shouto and the others safe.

"Izuku," he said. "If… if you need *anything* -"

"I know," Izuku replied softly. "Thanks, Shouto."

Shouto searched Izuku's face for a moment longer before he took a deep breath and nodded tightly.

"Right."

He left the room after Kaminari, and Izuku felt his world shift, eyes searching wildly for a moment before he realised that he had simply fallen onto his bed, his legs no longer able to hold him. His

hands shook, and instinctively he raised his knees, allowing his arms to wrap around them and for his face to burrow into the darkness, breathing hard. They knew. God, they both knew. Kaminari probably told them all about it the second he suspected the scarred man he saw was Kacchan. How long ago had that been? A week? Longer? He couldn't remember anymore. All of this, every ounce of *Kacchan's* suffering, had only been softened marginally by the fact that their friends were none the wiser. That they were as safe as they could possibly be. He trusted that they would stay quiet, if only through their fear that something would now happen to Izuku if they didn't, but Shigaraki had eyes and ears everywhere in this place. What if he already knew?

Then they'd be dead already. His thoughts, sounding alarmingly like Kacchan's, eased him a fraction. Shigaraki wasn't willing to let his secrets spill. If he even suspected that anyone else knew about Kacchan's existence, then he'd shut them up immediately. All they had to do was stay quiet, to not let on that they knew any more than nothing at all. Say nothing, *do* nothing, not until…

Izuku sat up, his feet falling heavily from his bed. There was only one thing to do. One option. Aizawa wanted them to wait, but it was pretty clear to Izuku that simply wasn't an option. Shigaraki was disappointed in Kacchan's condition worsening, which meant that Kacchan was still very much a part of whatever the man had planned. His heart hammered in his chest, and he got to his feet, pulling his tacky clothes from him and grabbing a handful of clean ones, before picking up his pager.

' *I need to talk to you.'*

Aizawa somehow looked even more exhausted than when he had last seen him a little over an hour ago. He stood in the nomu rec area, scowl on his face, bundled up against the cold as it began to snow once more, looking back at Izuku expectantly. Izuku hadn't planned out what he was going to say; he'd been more focused on getting to say it, and for the longest moment, he just stood there, arms wrapped around himself, staring uncertainly into the eyes of the man who had once been his teacher. But the snow continued to fall, and the soft whispers of each flake reminded him to breathe.

"We can't wait."

Aizawa shut his eyes, breath blooming around him.

"I told you, we need time to do this properly-"

"And I'm telling you we don't have it," Izuku interrupted. "We don't know what Shigaraki has planned for Kacchan, but right now he's running out of time as much as we are. The virus is getting worse. Whatever Shigaraki wants from Kacchan, he's going to need to take it sooner rather than later, right?"

Aizawa looked back at him, expression tight, before he nodded.

"Right," Izuku breathed, voice shaky. "You said you could get me in a room with him. Just me and him."

"Eventually," Aizawa replied. "Shigaraki isn't stupid, Midoriya. I tell him you want to see him

now, he's going to know that something is up."

"What if you tell him that I want to talk about Kacchan? That I'm just… I'm worried, want to know if he has any ideas-"

"So he'll be doubly suspicious," Aizawa said shortly.

"Ok, well, you're head of security, so you come up with the ideas!" Izuku said, voice rising in frustration. "We've got to do this. Before Kacchan wakes up."

"Fuck, kid," Aizawa breathed, rubbing his face. "Dynamite could be out for weeks, hell, he was out for months the last time. We have time-"

"My friends know."

Aizawa's face dropped, eyes widening, and Izuku felt sick. He hadn't planned on this, he hadn't planned on saying any of this.

"Fuck, I don't… I don't even know why I'm telling you-" Izuku began to pace. "I just watched you shoot two people in the back of the head because they *knew* me. Shit. *Shit.* "

"What do they know? About you?"

"Wh- no! No, they… one of them saw Kacchan. I didn't confirm anything, but they're not stupid. Shit. Fuck, *Mr Aizawa-* "

"It's ok, kid. I'm not going to say anything, and I'm not going to hurt your friends."

"But you know why we have to do something now, don't you?" Izuku pleaded. "Everyone I- *everyone* I care about, he's going to take them away."

Aizawa bowed his head, kicking at the snow beneath him with one foot. Izuku watched anxiously.

"Ok. Alright."

"Alright?" Izuku breathed.

"Shigaraki spends most of his time in the basement," Aizawa continued. "And there's CCTV set up, there's no way of reaching him without him seeing us coming."

"So, what do we do?"

"We need a reason to go down there, a valid one. He's going to be suspicious, no way around that, but maybe if *I* can get him alone… a syringe of zombie blood, it's all I'll need."

"You're going to do this *alone*?" Izuku started. "No, I can't ask you to do that."

"You already did, kid."

"But…" Izuku shook his head, searching for a response. "Wh-what if it doesn't work? You'll need

back-up-"

"I can't bring anyone else down there with me. Not on short notice. And if I get noticed, then it's just on me, you hear me? It's just me and a grudge and a missed opportunity."

"What if… what if we just stormed down there? Hawks would help, I know he would-"

"Then we'll find an empty room and no Shigaraki," Aizawa replied shortly.

"But he'll kill you," Izuku whispered. "Even if you get him with the syringe-"

"If we had more time, then we could have come up with a better plan. One that doesn't involve me getting my neck snapped for my troubles. But you're right, Midoriya. We don't have that." Aizawa sighed. "The truth is, I should have done this a long time ago. I've had access to him, I could have ended things before…" He fell silent, looking down at the snow again. "It has to be me. It makes sense for it to be me."

"There's something else we haven't considered. What if he's like us? What if the virus turns him nomu?"

"It won't," Aizawa said with certainty. "There is no way that he has infected himself with the same thing that he infected all of you with, not before it was ready. This is the man who was prepared to use the entire world as his petri dish before risking his hide. He won't turn nomu."

"And if you're right, it will still take time for the virus to kill him," Izuku continued. "What if he tries to take this whole place with him in the meantime?"

Aizawa frowned, chewing on his lip. "I'd say you have a surprising amount of insight into how Shigaraki's mind works."

Izuku tried not to think back on Kacchan's ' *there is nothing that could stop me from getting to you if they took you from me* ' speech and shrugged. "Point still stands."

"Then we best hope that Hawks was serious when he said he wanted to end this thing. The nomu, the rest of them, I mean, they're loyal to the facility because it gives them purpose, but that doesn't mean that they're loyal to Shigaraki. You'll need them."

"What if they don't listen to me?"

"Kid," Aizawa replied, with a long-suffering sigh, the corner of his lip creasing for a moment. "There's no one on this planet more persistent and annoying than you. You'll make them listen, of that I'm certain."

Izuku looked down, unsure whether to take the compliment or not.

"There's one other thing you need to know about the basement."

"It's full of zombies?" Izuku said with a slight laugh. "Kinda caught onto that."

"Right. And if Shigaraki does decide to take this place down with him, then his first move will be

to let them out. Overhaul can hold them back; he's strong enough now, but if *any* of them break through, we'll have a massacre on our hands."

"So, we don't let them through," Izuku replied firmly. "The basement, can it be shut down externally?"

"You need key cards or a manual override to open the doors, and that manual override is inside the basement, with Shigaraki. All he has to do is enter a code, and the zombies will be topside."

"But the lab? Surely they won't be able to make it out of there?"

"Any of the electric locks can be opened from the basement, except for where the nomu are kept which is designed to lock in the event of a containment breach," Aizawa replied. "If he wanted, Shigaraki could direct the zombies through every wing of this place without ever leaving his room. If they get out, bar physically blocking the exits, the only way they can be handled is with the nomu or weapons."

"It's risky," Izuku breathed.

"Very. But whatever Shigaraki is working towards, I don't think we have long left to stop it. If you want to save your friends, if we want to stop him from harvesting what's left of your friend Bakugou… you're right. We don't have a lot of time to come up with a better plan."

"So, when do we do this?"

"I still need to organise a private meeting between Shigaraki and me," Aziawa replied. "And I need a syringe of zombie blood."

"I can get that."

"When I go down there, there is a good chance I'm not coming back up again."

"Mr Aizawa-"

"No, this is important. If I'm successful, I can send you an emergency alert on your pager. I need to only press a button. And you'll need to gather the nomu and prepare yourselves for zombies coming up from the basement. If you don't hear from me, *do not follow me down to the basement.* Do you understand? If you don't hear from me, I've failed, and you and everyone else need culpable deniability."

"But-"

"Just say you understand, kid. I'm not going down there until you promise to uphold your side of the deal."

"I promise."

"Good. If I fail, hopefully, Shigaraki will only be angry at me and not suspect anyone else. It doesn't help your friends or Bakugou, but at least you'll survive to fight another day. Ok?"

“Ok,” Izuku replied, the words tight in his chest.

“Right, we should get back to the labs before anyone-”

Aizawa was interrupted by a shrill ringing, his hands patting his hips as he searched for the pager, his brow furrowing as he looked at the screen.

“What is it?”

Aizawa tilted his head back, a rare if somewhat grim smile on his lips.

“My excuse to see Shigaraki.”

Chapter End Notes

It's been a wee bit, eh?

My mojo went away for a while, but it's back now and we're so close to the end. Following this setup chapter, will be the two-part finale, at long last.

Cheers readers old and new.

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 47: DEADICATED: Part One

Chapter Summary

In which the dead don't die.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What is it?"

"My excuse to see Shigaraki."

It was bitterly cold in the isolated courtyard; small and empty, bar the half-hearted attempt at a basketball court and a pitiful-looking plant pot. The times he had watched Kacchan pace this space like a lion in a cage left him feeling so hateful towards it now. It was a mockery of everything they'd fought for and been through til now. And standing here, with Aizawa's expression turning grim as he thrust the pager into the long pocket of his overcoat, he found himself hating it all the more.

"What do you mean?"

Aizawa levelled Izuku with a steady stare, eyelashes flickering ever so slightly as the snowfall thickened.

"There's something else that you should know," he replied.

"Great," Izuku sighed, unable to stop himself. The corner of Aizawa's mouth tightened for a moment in response.

"Back then, at the stadium, it wasn't just you and Dynamite we found."

Izuku's stomach dropped.

"Don't tell me Dabi *survived*?"

Aizawa frowned. "I don't know anyone by the name of Dabi. The person I'm talking about calls himself Tomura. *Shigaraki* Tomura."

Izuku felt himself reeling, staring up at Aizawa in shock. *Tomura?* The leader of that League of Bastards, the one whom Kacchan had lost track of? The one who had apparently *escaped* the zombie attack?

"I don't-" Izuku took a deep shuddering breath. "I don't get it. How- he was *there*?"

“After we found your friends, Mic and I kept going to the stadium,” Aizawa replied. “That’s where we found him, standing above what I assumed was a zombie at the time with a rock in his hands. As soon as he clocked us, though, he tried to make a run for it. Mic tranquilised him.”

“He was fighting zombies?”

Aizawa angled his chin, clearing his throat.

“Actually, he was trying to kill *you*, kid.”

That stunned a hoarse laugh from Izuku. He could just imagine the scene now; lying unconscious on the ground from the force of the explosion, with Tomura above him, ready to finish the job. None of it felt out of place at all.

“That aside,” Aizawa continued, “he wasn’t in a good way when we found him. Been attacked by zombies, either a bunch of them or a few really violent ones, had to be about a dozen bites across his arms and face from fending them off. And, I’d say from the looks of them and the healing that was beginning to take place, it happened several days before we got to him.”

“No way,” Izuku gasped. “Are you saying he’s a *nomu*?”

“Yes. I wasn’t being entirely truthful when I told you that Overhaul was the only nomu we knew of other than Dynamite that had survived multiple zombie bites. The amount Tomura had? It’s a miracle he wasn’t eaten entirely during the attack.”

“I can’t…” Izuku looked down at the ground, and an unwanted image sprang to mind of Tomura being pulled apart by zombies whilst he was still alive, dragging himself away in the process. He was reminded then, with a sickening jolt, of Kacchan holding Jin in place whilst zombies tore him apart, and he shut his eyes tight. “I can’t imagine what that must have been like.”

“Well, he never told me how it happened. When he woke up back at UA, he wouldn’t cooperate with me. The only thing I could get from him was that another kid survived the explosion at the stadium with extensive injuries. Though I’m sure Tomura wasn’t trying to help Dynamite, he’s the reason he’s here.”

“Probably wanted to finish Kacchan of himself,” Izuku said grimly. “He thought he’d get his chance if we were all here, stuck in the walls. So, wait, if Tomura is a nomu, then why haven’t I seen him? Why isn’t he with the rest of them?”

“And that, kid, is my excuse,” Aizawa said. “Shigaraki *senior* whisked Tomura away the instant he woke up, not wanting him to be anywhere near the rest of the nomu. Instead, he was transferred to a similar hospital setup in the basement, and he’s been down there ever since.”

“I can’t believe it,” Izuku said, unable to hide the bitterness in his tone. “This whole time he’s been at UA with us.”

“Shigaraki has been very cagey about Tomura’s condition and treatment since he got here. I haven’t been allowed access to him since before you joined the research team, and all I knew then was that Shigaraki had a management plan specifically catered to his nephew that involved him being in a medically induced coma most of the time. However,” Aizawa pulled his pager from his pocket,

looking down at the screen, “he now wants my assistance. Perhaps with Dynamite no longer seeming as promising to him, he’s decided it’s time to wake up Tomura.”

“We can’t let that happen,” Izuku said, seriously. “You don’t know half of what Shigaraki Tomura is capable of. He and his group *killed* my friends. He led a herd of zombies to where we were living to flush us out and kill us. He got another one of our friends bit, he’s the reason Kaminari got shot, he wants me and Kacchan *dead*. There’s no way he can just walk around with everyone else!”

“I understand that, Midoriya,” Aizawa replied. “I promise you I’m not taking any of this lightly, but the plan stays the same. I get to Shigaraki first, infect him with the blood before he can wake Tomura up.”

Izuku wanted to have full faith in his ex-teacher; after all, the man was about to risk his life for everyone who lived at UA. But, if what he said about Tomura was true, then he had survived more bites even than *Kacchan.* A person like that would have to be valuable to Shigaraki, *invaluable* even. Infected or not, what was to stop Shigaraki from waking his nephew up anyway?

“We don’t have any more time to discuss this,” Aizawa said, interrupting Izuku’s train of thought. “Shigaraki is only so patient, and I still need to get my hands on some infected blood before I go down there.”

“Right,” Izuku said, mentally shaking himself and trying to refocus. “The labs are probably empty this early, so we should head there.”

“Not *‘we’*, Midoriya.” Aizawa shook his head firmly. “I’ve said it before, there needs to be culpable deniability should the worst happen and I fail down there. We can’t be seen together, not at this time and definitely not in the labs. What I need you to do is to go back to your dorm, ideally your room where everyone else sleeps, and go about your day as normal. Either I succeed, and Shigaraki dies in a few days. Or… I don’t, and nothing changes. Either way, anything you do right now to help will only make things more difficult for me.”

“But if something goes wrong-”

“All the more reason for you to *stay out of this*,” Aizawa pressed. “Even if I’m successful, chances are that things around here won’t look too pretty for a while. Shigaraki certainly isn’t about to go quietly. He has full control of the entire of UA from down there, except the nomu, which I set up on a separate system for security purposes. In the event of a security breach, the only way to get to the nomu is with either mine or Shigaraki’s fingerprint *or* a security code, something that I made sure you had.”

“Uh, I do?”

“You still have Shigaraki’s pager number, right?”

Izuku blinked, reaching into his pocket to wrap his hand around the device.

“Yeh.”

“Good. If I’m not around, if something goes wrong, you’ll need to be the one who goes down there. Worst-case scenario and Shigaraki releases zombies into the campus, you’ll need the nomu to fight

them. Overhaul could probably handle them all on his own."

If I'm not around. Izuku swallowed, giving Aizawa a jerky nod. It was such a messy plan, however Izuku looked at it.

"I know you said we don't have time to go into details, but… what if this doesn't work? What do we do if Shigaraki wakes up Tomura? How long before he comes after Kacchan?"

Aizawa reached a hand out, resting it on Izuku's shoulder. "I don't know, kid, but if I have faith in anyone to figure it out, it's you."

"Great," Izuku replied weakly, and Aizawa offered him a rare smile.

"Guess I just won't fuck up. Besides, this is my school. These are my staff and my students. I'm responsible for their safety. Have faith in your homeroom teacher just once more, huh?"

Izuku swallowed, his eyes betraying him as they so often did and starting to sting.

"Ok, Mr Aizawa."

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

*** ! ! ! ***

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

It takes a while for the shrill, obnoxious sounds of the siren to finally rouse the stubbornly dead; a body still tinted yellow if one could make out enough of the skin beneath the blankets and equipment covering him. He shifts, a low guttural sound making its way from deep in his chest, thick wrists catching sharply on the leather strap tying him to the bed.

His eyes open, sharp and alert in an instant. There's something in his throat, there are wires on his chest, and his wrists and feet are bound, and he feels himself thrashing against the restrictions, anger overriding any panic he might feel. Because he had *had it.* He was so fucking done waking up with metal bars in his stomach and leather around his wrists, and if that siren didn't *shut the fuck up,* he wasn't gonna be held responsible for the damage he would cause shutting the damn thing up himself.

He grunted, putting all he had into wrenching his right arm up and away from the bed, a loud rip filling the room as he finally pulled himself free. He wasted no time grabbing the tube deep in his throat and pulling, choking and gagging as it came free and sucking in deep mouthfuls of air. The next to go were the other leather bands holding him to the bed, before he was on his feet, stripping himself of the wires and syringes, doing a piss poor job of keeping him in what he assumed had been another goddamn coma. Oh, he was going to kick Dog Eyes' *ass* for this.

Katsuki looked around him, squinting and shaking his head as he tried to clear the drug-induced fogginess numbing him around the edges. He was back in the hospital room, that much was clear, though he couldn't remember how he had gotten there this time. He scowled, casting a filthy glare at the red bulb in the corner of the room flashing in time with the siren, trying to think back on the

last thing he *could* remember. He had been in his room, Izuku had been there… they had been so *close*, trading breaths, he remembered Izuku's gasps and cries, gripping both their cocks in his hand and then… *then*... he'd had his hand around Izuku's throat. He'd tightened, *squeezed*… He reared back, stumbling as his hip hit the edge of the bed before sliding down onto the floor. The panic set in then, breathing seeming impossible, and he grabbed short tufts of hair in both his hands. He had tried to choke *Izuku*? Had he tried to *kill* him? Is that why he was here?

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

*** ! ! ! ***

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

"Shut the fuck up!" Katsuki roared, voice hoarse and heart thumping so fast in his chest he was half sure he was having a heart attack. But the siren didn't stop, and he was forced to look up through his shaking hands, taking in the room around him again.

There was no doubt about it. He was here because he had tried to hurt Izuku. He noticed then the yellowing of his hands, the veins prominent and his wrist steadily bleeding from how violently he tore the needle out of it. He'd lost control. Fuck, he was probably turning again, and they had put him in a coma and upped the dose of the amiodarone to try and reverse the spread of the virus. That, at least, explained why he was here and why he had been strapped to the bed. What, then, of the siren trying to burst his eardrums?

He shakily got to his feet, tentatively running his hands over his face, chest, and legs, checking for anything he might have missed or any obvious injuries. He still *felt* like himself… no murderous rage, beyond the typical, no craving for raw meat, no thoughts of *brains brains brains!* running through his head, so perhaps the treatment had worked and he was back to himself again. Regardless, he *needed* to see Izuku. Aizawa could be as pissed at him as he wanted, because all that mattered right now was making sure that Izuku was ok, that he hadn't been hurt. That, and finding out where that alarm was coming from and if there actually was a fire.

To his surprise, the hospital room door opened without resistance when he pushed on it; whoever had last been in to check on him obviously hadn't felt the need to lock him in here, so maybe they had been in the process of waking him up when the alarms started. The siren was, somehow, even louder out in the main room, and he wasn't surprised to see the rest of the nomu standing there, looking every bit as confused as he felt.

"Dynamite?"

It's Hawks who speaks first, surprised to see him and cautiously looking him up and down.

"What the fuck is going on out here?" Katsuki barks, still feeling drug-heavy and irritable as all hell.

"Shouldn't you be in a coma right now?" Fat asks. Katsuk scowls. *So much for the theory that someone had woken him up.*

"Who the hell cares about that? Where's the fire?"

“Not a clue,” Hawks replies, though his gaze lingers on Katsuki. “Got woken up by it, and when I came out here to check things out, the door was locked up.”

“Must be a safety feature,” Mirko said, tapping her lip. “I’d bet this place couldn’t fry if it tried.”

“Not going to help us when everyone else dies and we’re left to rot here,” Overhaul said darkly. He was standing separate from the rest of them, face as closed off as it ever was.

“No one’s dying,” Katsuki snapped, marching forward and roughly pushing Hawks aside. The LED screen on the keypad had the word *‘LOCKED’* in red letters, but Katsuki still grabbed at the handle anyway, using all his strength to twist it down.

“Oh, because none of us thought of trying to turn the handle,” Mirko scoffed.

“Shuddup.”

Katsuki grunted before beginning to run his fingernails around the edge of the keypad, finding two pressure points that, when he pressed, allowed the front to fall free with a pop, revealing a clear screen below.

“Did you try that?” Katsuki asked sarcastically, throwing the cover over his shoulder.

Hawks peered over his shoulder, Katsuki bristling at how close he was and glaring. “It’s the bioscanner,” Hawks explained. “I already knew it was there.”

“Yeh, we were *trying* to figure out the code, but you’ve gone and pulled off the keypad,” Fat sighed.

“How in the hell were you gonna figure out the fucking code?” Katsuki shot back. “There’s gotta be a million possibilities.”

“Billions,” Hawks corrected, all too cheerfully.

The siren continued, only adding to Katsuki’s anxiety.

“Ok, so we break the fucking thing down! I ain’t staying in here if there’s a fucking fire, not when Izuku’s out there.”

“I gotta be honest with you, I don’t think there *is* a fire,” Hawks said seriously, hands on his hips.

“Hah?”

“Do you remember anything before they put you in a coma again?”

Katsuki swallowed, the hairs on the back of his neck standing on end.

“*Why?*”

“Let’s just say I’m really surprised you’re capable of having a normalish conversation right now,” Hawks replied. “Instead of, you know, the *urrghs* and the *aarrrghs*.”

“Get to the fucking point, birdbrain!”

“They don’t tell us much,” Fat interjected, “but you were *gone*. Like, Aizawa was pretty certain you fully turned. I don’t think he was planning on waking you up at all this time.”

Something hot and unpleasant pooled in Katsuki’s gut, his throat burning from the pressure. He looked to Hawks, unable to mask the fear he was feeling.

“Izuku? Is he ok? Did I-”

“Oh, the little guy's fine,” Hawks interrupted quickly, recognising Katsuki’s fear. “You didn’t hurt him or anything, just gave him one hell of a scare turning overnight like that.”

Katsuki took a deep, shuddering breath. *Why couldn't he remember?* And the hand around Izuku’s throat? Had that not really happened? *No…* he could *feel it*. He could feel the bobbing under his palm as Izuku tried to swallow, the faraway look in his green eyes as he squeezed. Had Izuku lied to protect him?

“What does this have to do with the fire?” Katsuki asked instead.

“It just seems like a pretty big coincidence, is all. You know as well as I do that Shigaraki has no use for a nomu that’s unconscious the whole time; the only good you’d do is under a microscope. I don’t think Midoriya would take too kindly to that, do you?”

Katsuki’s stomach fell to his ass, and he shook his head fiercely.

“He wouldn’t. Izuku’s not a fucking idiot, he wouldn’t take a risk like that.”

Hawks raised an eyebrow pointedly, and Katsuki was all too quickly reminded of the fact that Izuku had injected himself with *Katsuki’s blood* to try and prove a theory, and he groaned.

“Fuck me, he’s an idiot.”

“I’m in the dark just as you are,” Hawks continued, “but I have a really strong feeling that your boyfriend has something to do with this.”

Katsuki felt cold, the pressure in his chest rising to an intolerable level. *Of course,* Izuku wasn’t about to lie down and allow anything to happen to him. That insufferably loyal *asshole* would burn the fucking world down for Katsuki, just as he would for him, and he’d proved that time and time again.

“Fuck!”

Katsuki turned on the spot, eyes darting around the kitchen, looking for anything that he could use to wrench the door open. He began pulling open drawers, eyes lighting up when he spotted a roll of aluminium foil and throwing it onto the counter.

“What are you doing?” Fat asked, uncertainly.

“Opening that fucking door,” Katsuki snarled, crouching down and yanking open the cupboard doors below it, snatching up each of the cleaning products below. “I’m getting out of here if I have to blow the thing down.”

“Whoa, whoa, I don’t think we need to go that far!”

“Unless you got a better idea, shut the hell up and let me focus!”

“I told you that was a bioscanner,” Hawks said. “What, you think I spent all this time down here, watching Aizawa and Shigaraki, to not have a plan in case something like this happened?”

Katsuki paused after upturning one drawer onto the floor.

“*Hah?*”

“I’ve been working on this for *months*,” Hawks said, his expression turning giddy. “Poor Aizawa, he just thought that Shigaraki was cheaping out and sending him a load of bum stationery.”

“Get to the damn point before I blow you up with the door!”

“Two secs!” Hawks replied, hands raised, before ducking into his room. Mirko looked between the door and Katsuki, her face twisted up in confusion.

“What is going on here, exactly?” she asked. “You’re both acting like it’s the end of the world, which, *ok,* it pretty much is, but-”

“Shigaraki started this whole fucking thing,” Katsuki spat back, no longer caring about keeping any of this information close to his chest. “The virus. The fucking nomu’s. It’s all down to him.”

“What?” Overhaul asked sharply.

“Birdbrain will give you a full fucking rundown *after* we get out of this room,” Katsuki replied shortly, as he emptied a bottle of cordial down the drain. “I have more important shit.”

“Here we are,” Hawks announced, coming out of his room and holding what appeared to be a piece of tape between his fingertips.

“Hold up, *Shigaraki started the virus*?” Mirko demanded. “How in the hell did you figure that?”

“What is that?” Katsuki snapped, ignoring Mirko and marching over to Hawks.

“I’ve been sabotaging Aizawa,” Hawks replied, holding the tape up beside his face. Katsuki could see what appeared to be a clearly defined blue fingerprint across it. “It took a while to get a complete enough print, but each time he threw out one of my discreetly broken ballpoint pens for leaking, I inspected them for fingerprints. Shigaraki might like to think it’s top of the line, but the security system in place here is totally amateur. Child's play, really. Hopefully, this-” he waggled the tape “-will be enough to trick the scanner.” He paused, grinning. “Unless you want to still try your cute little explosive idea.”

“I’ll kill you,” Katsuki snarled. “Just open the damn door, already!”

“So, you’re just going to keep ignoring me, huh?” Mirko huffed. “Just let us stay in the dark about all this?”

“It’s a lot to explain right now,” Hawks replied, glancing back apologetically. “But yeh, Dynamite gave you the rundown. You might even remember being sick when you were kids, right? Spent a bit of time in Musutafu General? Shigaraki *created* us, injected sick kids with something that turned us into whatever the hell we are as soon as we were exposed to the virus, which he released.”

“That doesn’t make any sense!” Fat rushed, as Hawks hunched over the lock. “Why would anyone release a virus onto the world, then go through the trouble of making some people immune to it?”

“We ain’t immune,” Katsuki snapped, watching as Hawks pressed the tape against the scanner. “We’re still infected, we just don’t turn like normal people. Hey, is that thing working or not?”

“Gimme a minute,” Hawks huffed, pulling the tape away and rubbing at the screen with his sleeve. “Maybe it’s just dirty.”

“Ok, ok, so we’re still infected, but my point still stands,” Fat continued. “Why would he deliberately make people like us?”

“What, wipe out and turn almost the entire population of Japan into zombies, have people who can control them, and threaten those people into doing whatever you ask?” Overhaul said, his voice cold. “Yeh, can’t imagine why that would appeal to anyone.”

Katsuki glances in his direction, taking in the stiff lines of Overhaul’s body as he stood there, before there was a loud *beep* and a click, and the door to the dorm swung open.

“Voila!” Hawks announced, standing straight and holding his hands out. “Told you. Totally amateur.”

“Great, now let’s get out of here.”

“Ah-ah, hold up there, lover boy,” Hawks said, throwing out his arm and catching Katsuki across the chest. “You really wanna go out there without a plan, and your ass hanging out?”

“Hah?”

Katsuki looked around, and Hawks nodded his head pointedly downwards. It was only then that Katsuki realised he was still wearing a hospital gown, having been gracing the lot of them with an eyeful of his ass this entire time.

“Damnit,” Katsuki growled, reaching around and pulling the fabric shut over himself. “You couldn’t say anything sooner, you asshole?”

“Hey, you looked pretty busy. Chill out, I’ve got a spare jumpsuit in my room.”

Cursing, Katsuki took off, mind racing. He thought back to all the things that Aizawa had told him and Izuku about Shigaraki, and about the facility they were held in. There had been a basement,

right? That's where Shigaraki scurried away to, and almost certainly where Izuku would go if he wanted to find him.

"Damnit, Deku."

He hurriedly grabbed the gown and tore it off him, snatching up the folded orange jumpsuit on Hawks' bedside table. The place was bound to be locked up tight; there'd be even more security in place, not to mention the zombies that Aizawa confirmed were held down there, an army in waiting should Shigaraki decide he needed to use them. But that in itself made little sense, because didn't he need the nomu to control them? Wasn't he in just as much danger of being eaten by zombies as the rest of the people at UA if they got out?

A scream caught his attention, the jumpsuit still only half on as he hurriedly tied the sleeves around his waist and ran from the room, his stomach sinking and his worst fears for the situation confirmed.

"Where the hell did they come from!" Fat yelled, hurrying backwards as three zombies barged into the dorm, their bodies disturbingly fresh, throwing themselves forward and bouncing off the door. Katsuki charged, not thinking about much beyond stopping the zombies before they managed to sink their teeth into Hawks, now pressed against the door and entirely shocked by what was happening. Then, a tingle ran up his spine, the blood in his limbs thickening, and his body stumbling.

"*Stop!*"

The three zombies came to a halt, their feet stopping before the momentum of their moving bodies caught up to them, and they tumbled to the ground.

"Shit," Mirko breathed, running both her hands through her hair as she looked down at the frozen zombies.

"Take 'em out," Overhaul grunted, "I don't wanna keep holding them."

Without hesitation, Katsuki grabbed one of the wooden drawers he had discarded earlier, raising it above his head and bringing it down hard and fast onto the skull of one zombie, the sickening crack satisfying in a way Katsuki realised he missed. Within seconds, the remaining zombies were dispatched just as easily.

"How the hell did they get here?" Mirko yelled. "Is there any more of them?"

Hawks peered out of the doorway before uttering a low curse and shutting it, careful to keep his hand on the handle to prevent it from locking.

"Yeh," he said, leaning his weight against the door. "I see another two at least, coming this way."

"Shigaraki must have let them lose," Katsuki said, trying to ignore the sensation of hot blood now pooling around his still-bare feet. "Fuck, this is bad." *Izuku, what did you do?*

"Which means they could be all over the campus by now," Fat said. "It'll be a blood bath!"

“Not if we can help it,” Hawks said. He grit his teeth together as the door behind him jolted, the two zombies he had spotted now trying to force their way in. “C’mon, this is what Aizawa was training us for, right? To deal with the zombies?”

“I’m not risking my life for a load of nobodies that don’t know we even exist,” Overhaul said. “I came to UA to get away from the zombies, not fight them.”

“Well, if we don’t take care of the zombies, there’ll be no UA left,” Katsuki said. “Birdbrain, you got that door held yeh?”

Another loud bang and a jolt almost threw Hawks forward, but he stood his ground, pressing his back against the door. “For now.”

It was unlikely that the five zombies they’d come across would be the bulk of them, and nomu or not, they still needed something to defend themselves. Typically, almost everything in their dorm was designed to be sterile, disposable at a pinch, and there wasn’t an awful lot sturdy enough to make a decent weapon. He glared around the room, eyes drifting over to the plastic side table beside the couch.

“You’re gonna need better weapons to fight these fuckers, but for now-” Katsuki grabbed the table and then swung it hard against the wall, shattering it “-these’ll do.” He yanked the legs from the table, holding out each for Mirko and Fat.

“We’re gonna need to split up. I dunno how good you guys are at fighting zombies, but with Overhaul able to stop them where they stand, you should be able to hack down a bunch of ‘em.”

Mirko and Fat took their table legs, looking somewhat doubtful.

“Three of you make your way out of the labs, take out whatever you find. And don’t let anyone get eaten!”

“Where are you going?” Overhaul asked, frowning.

“Hawks and I are going down to the basement. You know where it is?” he shot at Hawks, who nodded.

“Uh, and what are you planning with the basement, exactly?” Mirko asked.

Katsuki threw one of the two table legs to Hawks, before twisting the remaining in his grip. “Gonna kill Shigaraki, and save my dumbass boyfriend.” He nodded his head a Hawks. “Let ‘em in, I’ll kill ‘em.”

“Alright, man.”

Hawks moved away from the door, and the two zombies tumbled in, running blindly forward. Despite the hangover from whatever drugs they had pumped into him to keep him unconscious, as soon as the zombies made a beeline towards him, Katsuki’s senses felt as keen as ever, and he sidestepped the first body without hesitation, swinging the table leg directly into the back of its skull. Before it could recover, he kicked the second down, slicing and smashing the leg through its eye socket. The first zombie, still on the floor, scrabbled towards him, mouth wide and reaching for

his ankle, but Katsuki lifted his foot and stamped down as hard as he could.

“Gross,” Fat said, his nose scrunching.

“Get used to it. Oi, Birdbrain, you gonna show me where the basement is or what?”

The group split toward the end of the corridor, Katsuki and Hawks turning left as the others headed right. The siren continued to blast, red light crawling up the walls like blood as the two of them hurried by, Hawks leading the way.

“How’d you know where to go?” Katsuki asked, as Hawks took an abrupt right turn, pushing open a set of double doors. “Ain’t this place top secret or some shit?”

“My job to know,” Hawks replied, slowing down slightly as they passed by what appeared to be a lab. The upper half of the wall was made of glass, allowing the two of them to see inside, several hospital beds lined up side-by-side. One of the beds, however, was entirely upright, and even with brains stuck to his foot, he was disgusted by what he saw. A zombie, clearly deceased, was suspended upside down, blood gradually oozing in a wide trough placed below it.

“This is where they harvest the blood for sampling,” Hawks explained. “The ones with blood left to sample, at least. Gnarly, huh?”

“This place is fucked up,” Katsuki agreed.

“C’mon, I don’t see any moving zombies, but that doesn’t mean there’s not more about. Elevators are probably out, but there should be a flight of stairs past the labs that takes us to the lower levels.”

“Hey,” Katsuki said, unable to take his eyes away from the suspended zombie. “How long have the sirens been going off?”

“All in, I’d say about twenty minutes.”

“Long enough for any zombies down here to have already made their way out of the labs.” Katsuki’s gut churned as he thought about Mina, Kirishima, Kaminari and the others. “You reckon the ones we saw were just the stragglers?”

Hawks’ jaw tightened as he glanced back at him.

“Can’t think about that right now,” he said. “He’s far from the chattiest guy around, but Overhaul is the best asset we've got. He can stop thousands of zombies if he wants to. Hell, tens of thousands maybe. And Mirko and Fat can hold their own.”

“Right,” Katsuki grunted. He needed to focus; he needed to get to Izuku first, take care of Shigaraki and whatever else was going on in that basement, then they could go and help their friends together.

“Hey,” Hawks hissed, holding his hand up. “You hear that?”

Katsuki paused, listening intently, and sure enough, he fancied he could make out the faint sound of screaming, someone yelling out for help.

“Guess there’s more zombies down here after all.”

Katsuki and Hawks hurried forward, following the sounds of the screams until they became louder, and sure enough, they spotted what Katsuki assumed were lab workers, two cowering behind a third, who was holding a zombie at bay with a chair, the thing pressed entirely against it and swiping with furious hands.

“I got it!” Katsuki charged, pushing open the door to the lab with his shoulder. The workers looked up, tears streaming down their cheeks, crying with relief as Katsuki grabbed hold of the zombie and heaved, pulling its weight off and away from the chair. It recovered quickly, launching itself at him just as he swung with the table leg, breaking the zombie's jaw and sending it flying. With a yell, Katsuki thrust his weapon into the thing's skull, and it fell silent.

“Thank you,” a woman was wailing, holding onto Hawk's arms as he helped her to her feet. “Goodness, thank you, I thought we were done for!”

“Are there any more of them?” Hawks asked.

“Hundreds,” the man who had been holding the chair whispered, his eyes wide with horror. “Hundreds of them, all coming from the lower levels. They didn’t see us… thought we were safe. Until that one.” He pointed a shaking finger at the zombie at Katsuki’s feet.

“Hundreds?” Katsuki repeated.

“They-they must have gotten loose,” the other woman whimpered. “There were so many…”

“We need to keep going,” Katsuki said. “You three, get the fuck down and stay down, lock the door if you can.”

“You’re leaving us here?”

“Can’t stay,” Hawks said, offering them a winning smile. “Got a zombie breach to plug.”

“You’ll be fine so long as you don’t get their attention.” Katsuki hesitated for a moment before throwing the man the table leg he had been holding. “Any get close, give ‘em a whack around the head with this thing.”

He didn’t waste any more time after that, leaving the room with Hawks on his heels.

“Sure, it was heroic and all,” Hawks said, catching up with him. “But you think leaving your only weapon with them was such a great idea?”

“I don’t need it,” Katsuki growled.

“Well, with any luck, they’re the only ones dumb enough to stick around, and everyone evacuated before the zombies made their way up here.”

It didn’t take long for them to realise just how vain a hope that was. As Hawks led them deeper into the labs, the sheer scale of this growing disaster became clear. Devoured bodies littered the halls, people who had been torn apart as they tried to escape the army of zombies that had broken free of

the basement. These people hadn't stood a chance; unarmed and untrained, probably people who had spent the entire apocalypse safe inside these walls, mowed down by an unstoppable force.

"Oh god," Hawks breathed.

Katsuki took in the scene, heart hammering in his chest. Who the hell let the zombies out? Shigaraki? If so, *why?* Why would Shigaraki let an army of zombies lose on UA? What would prompt this? And Izuku… *if Izuku had been caught up in it…*

"Enough gawking," Katsuki snarled, grabbing Hawks by the collar and yanking him forward. "We don't have fucking time for this!"

Wading their way through the blood and remains, Hawks eventually pointed out the final staircase, the two of them descending another floor before they came upon a heavy-looking steel door, wide open, the ominous darkness inside devoid of the red blinking safety lights that made the rest of the labs look all the more morbid.

"This is it," Hawks whispered. "The open door doesn't feel like a good sign."

"Do you have any idea what's actually inside here?" Katsuki asked.

"Secret lab, zombie torture dungeon, typical villain stuff. Outside of that, your guess is as good as mine."

"So, be prepared for fucking anything then."

Hawks held up his table leg with a crooked smile. "After you."

At first, the basement felt entirely unremarkable; a blank hallway, the walls marked and scuffed with filthy handprints and smeared blood from the zombies marching down it, but otherwise empty. The only thing that Katsuki could see of note was the security cameras, mounted on the walls in full view as though they themselves would have been enough of a deterrent for any regular person who found their way here. Still, if anyone did decide to ignore the fact that they were almost certainly being watched, the basement had another way to make sure they turned back.

The bars of the cages were thick, narrow enough that nothing could squeeze its way through them, but Katsuki imagined a stray, decaying arm could have easily fit through to swipe and grab at anything that walked by. The cages were stacked together like prison cells, long corridors of them branching off from the main hall, the door to each cell wide open. But, most overwhelming, was the smell. Katsuki was no stranger to the stench of rotting corpses these days, but contained here, underground with little to no ventilation, was overwhelming. He coughed, holding his wrist up to cover his nose, eyes watering as he looked around.

"Fuck, how the hell does Shigaraki live with this?"

"I haven't seen the elevator," Hawks replied, voice muffled beneath his hand. "Maybe he skips this bit."

"The lab geeks said they saw hundreds of 'em go by, but this place could hold thousands, I reckon. Shigaraki really was keeping an army of zombies under the campus, huh?"

“And *someone* let them out.” Hawks inspected one of the nearest cells, nose curled in disgust at the sinew and flesh melded against the metal of the bars. “I wonder if it’s a fail-safe, something in place in case Shigaraki is threatened or injured. *Kill me, and everyone here dies with me,* sort of thing.”

Katsuki’s heart gave a feeble lurch, thinking again of Izuku.

“I think I see some light ahead. C’mon.”

Sure enough, peeking through the frosted windows of another heavy set of doors, a muted light was visible, flickering ever so gently. Katsuki glanced over at Hawks, who held his table leg up and nodded, before Katsuki eased the door open and peered inside.

A much grander room lay ahead of them, the walls decorated with wooden panels and a rich velvety paint. Plants with shiny, rubbery leaves stood on either side of an elevator, beneath artificial white lightning, and hanging on the walls were paintings that Katsuki felt as though he must have seen before; scenes of great battles centuries past, samurai standing stoic with their arms resting upon their weapons. He wouldn’t be surprised if these were original paintings, perhaps worth millions.

“There.”

Hawks pointed to a door directly opposite the elevator. This, unlike all of the others down here, was shut tight, and Katsuki felt a stab of relief run through him. If Izuku were down here, maybe the zombies hadn’t been able to get anywhere near him. He nodded his head at Hawks, and the two of them walked forward, testing the door and pushing it open silently when they felt no resistance.

The luxurious feel of the place continued here, too. It was like the hallway of some fancy hotel, speaking loudly of the rich tastes of whoever lived here. It was fitting for Shigaraki, Katsuki thought, the fucker who walked around with a Rolex watch despite the world ending, and he couldn’t wait to smash the shit out of the place the second all of this was over. There were rooms off the corridor, a bathroom here, a kitchen there, the basement decked out like its own apartment building and no doubt entirely self-sufficient from the rest of the campus, should Shigaraki need to isolate himself. They found a bedroom as they explored, simplistic and stylish, and Katsuki had to fight back the childish urge to trash it all as Hawks tapped on his shoulder to grab his attention.

“What?”

Hawks was pointing through the doorway of another room, and Katsuki edged closer, eyes widening when he saw what was beyond. A hospital room, the setup almost identical to the room he’d unfortunately grown to find familiar in the time he’d been kept at UA; the bed itself was empty, but the equipment pushed haphazardly to the side, the velcro straps torn lose and the bedding lying across the floor made Katsuki certain whoever had been kept here had been about as willing a patient as he himself had been.

“What the hell?” he hissed, looking around the room. “Who’d he keep down here?”

“If I were to hazard a guess,” Hawks replied, picking at the velcro restraints. “A nomu.”

Katsuki looked back at him, brow furrowed. “Why the hell keep it separate from the rest of us? What exactly was so wrong with this thing that he had to keep it a secret?”

The loud clatter had them both standing to attention, eyes darting to the doorway and Hawks holding his weapon to his chest.

“A zombie?” he whispered.

“Or Shigaraki,” Katsuki replied in a low growl. “C’mon.”

They left the hospital room beside them, continuing down the hallway towards yet another door. There was clearly someone inside, whether that someone was still alive or not was uncertain, but the clattering continued, followed by a groan and a thud, sounding all too much like someone in pain for Katsuki to be able to ignore any longer.

“Be ready,” he hissed at Hawks. He was primed and willing to launch himself at whatever danger lingered beyond the door, lack of a weapon be damned, and with a forceful kick, he smashed the door open.

A brightly lit room lay beyond, large monitors covered the walls almost entirely, a glance confirming that it must offer surveillance over much of UA, if not the entire of it. Three laptops sit on the dark wood desk, some sort of program open on each, but Katsuki pays little mind to the details, his eyes instead drawn to the huge mass lying on the ground in front of it.

“What the *fuck*?”

“Dynamite?”

Katsuki pauses, his blood-soaked feet skidding on the ground as a weak voice grabs his attention, looking away from the body for a moment to see none other than Dog Eyes himself, slumped against the wall, a bloody hand pressed against his neck.

“Oh my- *Aizawa*? What the hell happened here?” Hawks cried, pushing past Katsuki and dropping to the floor in front of the injured man, reaching out as if to pull his bloody hand away from his neck.

“Don’t!” Aizawa gasped, his voice sounding painful. “*Don’t*. I’m bit. There’s nothing you can do for it.”

“You’re *bit*?”

That’s when Katsuki sees another body in the room, this one partially hidden by the open door, flesh rotted and its skull caved in.

“What happened?” Hawks asked, looking around the room wildly. “Wait, is that-”

Katsuki started his approach to the large body beside the desk, his heart thumping loudly and violently in his chest. There was no doubting it; the tailored suit, the hulking shoulders, the white hair once neatly styled, now falling over a neck so unnaturally contorted that Katsuki couldn’t figure out *what* he was seeing at first. Shigaraki’s dead eyes stared out at nothing, his head having

been twisted so violently that the bones of his neck protruded from beneath his skin.

Katsuki stared, arms at his side, trying to process the scene in front of him. Trying, and failing to do so, because the only thing that mattered to him now was Izuku. *Where was Izuku?*

He whirled around, looking down at Aizawa. The man was deathly pale; he must have been there for some time. The pressure he was placing on his neck was probably the only thing keeping him from bleeding out on the spot. His heavy black eyes met Katsuki's, who dropped to his knees.

"Izuku. Fuck, tell me he wasn't here. Tell me he wasn't down here, too."

His voice came out desperate, weak, but he didn't have it in himself to care, staring at Aizawa with wide, panicked eyes. Aizawa's head shook a minute amount, and he took a wet-sounding breath.

"No. I told him to stay in his dorm. He's safe. He should be safe."

Katsuki could have collapsed in that moment, both hands falling flat to the floor to ground himself, head hanging with relief.

"What happened?" Hawks repeated. "Shigaraki… did you kill him?"

Aizawa shook his head again, grimacing at the pain and the fresh trickle of blood that seeped between his fingers.

"No, Shigaraki. The other Shigaraki."

Katsuki's head snapped up, blood running cold as a sickening realisation dawned on him. *The hospital room.* If a nomu had been kept there, Shigaraki must have had a damn good reason to keep it separate, to keep it secret. Katsuki had wondered… the surnames were the same, after all. The same as the leader of that League of Bastards. The leader that Katsuki had lost sight of in all the chaos back in the city, slipping away from him and the rest of them when the zombies started piling in. He had searched, *fuck,* he had looked everywhere he could before the cries of his friends had pulled him away, and he hadn't found him. No body. No nothing. But was it possible, after everything that he and Izuku had learned since then, that Tomura Shigaraki had survived? Not just survived, but that he had become a nomu?

"Tomura," he said urgently, leaning close to Aizawa. "You mean Tomura Shigaraki?"

Aizawa nodded slowly.

"He's a *nomu*?"

"Nmh."

"And he…" Katsuki looked over his shoulder. Shigaraki's body was all the more grotesque at this angle. "He snapped his neck?"

"Everything went wrong," Aizawa explained, grunting and allowing Hawks to assist when he tried to shift himself further up the wall. "Midoriya… he was going to try and stop Shigaraki himself, so I had t- had to-" His face twisted up in pain.

“Hey, hey, take it easy,” Hawks said, but Aizawa shook him off, brow furrowing.

“Your friends worked it out,” he continued, looking at Katsuki. “That you were alive. And y-you turned zombie again. I-it was only a matter of time before Shigaraki-”

“Killed me and them both,” Katsuki finished. He thought back to when Kaminari had spotted them, and grimaced. How a person could be such an idiot and yet so goddamn perceptive was a mystery to him.

“I was supposed to inject Shigaraki with infected blood,” Aizawa explained. “B-before he woke his nephew. But he realised. I-” Aizawa shut his eyes tight, his feelings over his failure visible across his entire face. “B-broke my legs. Woke Tomura up anyway.”

“Had he turned?” Hawks asked. “Entirely?”

“N-not according to his blood tests,” Aizawa replied. “He should have been lucid, like the r-rest of you.”

“So, why did he kill him? Why would he kill his own uncle?” Hawks insisted. Katsuki took a deep, shuddering breath.

“Because he knew. Fucker. Maybe he fucking knew all along that his dear old uncle was responsible for all this shit. But guess he had no idea he was one of the kids experimented on til he woke up nomu.”

“D-Dynamite’s right,” Aizawa confirmed. “H-his nephew was his hope. He’d survived countless bites, being mauled alive, whatever Shigaraki was aiming for in creating the nomu and releasing the virus, his nephew was the closest he got. But he was strong. He blamed his uncle. Killed him. Blamed m-me for bringing him here.” Aizawa’s head dropped back against the wall. “He released the zombies. Called one of ‘em in here and left me alone with it. I don’t know where he is now.”

“Does he know I’m here?” Katsuki demanded. “Does he know *Izuku’s* here?”

The heavy look in Aizawa’s eyes was the only answer he needed, and he pressed his hands against his face.

“Shit. *Shit.* Then I know where he’s fucking going. I know who he’s gonna be looking for.”

“I-I told Midoriya to go about his day as normal,” Aizawa offered. “He could have been in the lab, the dorms-”

“I’ll find him,” Katsuki said firmly.

“Y-you have to do something,” Aizawa said. “About Tomura. About the zombies-”

“Overhaul, Mirko and Fat are already on the case,” Hawks assured. “They went up top to help everyone they could whilst we came down here. But I don’t know if they can kill hundreds of zombies all on their own. We could still lose people.”

“Y-you have to get the zombies back d-down here,” Aizawa replied firmly. “I can access anything from here. I can lock the basement down.”

“But that’s suicide!” Hawks cried, and Aizawa managed a rough laugh.

“I think my time’s already up.”

“We don’t know how long it’ll take,” Katsuki said seriously. “What if you croak before we get them down here?”

“It’s not as bad as it looks,” Aizawa replied. “My throat isn’t torn out, if I can keep the pressure on… I’ll hold out. I’ll make it. But my legs… I need help getting to the desk.”

Katsuki nodded, and between them, he and Hawks were able to carefully lift Aizawa. Hawks kept his hand cupped over the one Aizawa had pressed to his neck, keeping the pressure on as they walked, before they eased him onto the desk chair.

“Don’t fall off the damn chair,” Katsuki said. “Be a real shitty way for things to end if you can’t lock up the basement because you’ve fallen on your ass again.”

“Noted,” Aizawa replied dryly. “Your concern for my well-being overwhelms me.”

“Yeh, well.” Katsuki sighed, eyes drifting towards Shigaraki, who lay barely a few feet away from them. “Ain’t like you’re entirely blameless in all this. You could have told us all this so much sooner. Could’a ended this a different way.”

Aizawa took a deep breath, faltering at the end and wheezing slightly. “I know.”

“Still.” Katsuki rolled his head back, meeting Aizawa’s gaze. “You did what you could, right? To keep this place safe. I can understand that at least.”

“Dyna- *Bakugou*, before you go, there’s something else you need to know. In Tomura’s hospital room, there’s a drug. It’s what Shigaraki was using to suppress the virus in his nephew, to keep him from turning.”

“Like the amiodarone?” Hawks asked.

“I don’t know how related they are,” Aizawa replied. “Shigaraki didn’t tell me much; he was too busy gloating on how easy he stopped me, but he did say that it was experimental, that it wasn’t the same drug we’ve been using on you. Take it. Give it to Toshinori, to Midoriya. Maybe they can make more of it, maybe it can help.”

Katsuki nodded.

“Good. Now go. I’ll be watching the surveillance. I’ve g-got it covered this end.”

“Hey, it’s been wild, teach,” Hawks said softly, placing a hand on Aizawa’s shoulder. “See you around, huh?”

“Yeh,” Aizawa replied. “See you around.”

Katsuki didn't feel much for the man propped up on the desk chair. He had captured him, restrained him, forced drugs onto him and allowed a madman to threaten him and his friends, and yet he couldn't help the heavy feeling in his chest as they began to walk away. For better or worse, Izuku *had* trusted him. Had cared for him. And despite everything, Aizawa was about to sacrifice his own life for the benefit of all of them. He slowed his pace as he reached the door, looking back over his shoulder.

"Hey. Aizawa."

Aizawa looked up.

"The people you were trying to protect. The ones Shigaraki threatened. Who are they?"

In his fragile condition, the ex-teacher wasn't able to school his expression as he might usually have done, his surprise obvious.

"My students," he said, after a moment's pause. "Kayama. My ex-husband, who-" Aizawa let out a sad laugh, shaking his head. "Mic. I guess I'll never get a chance to apologise to him after all."

"I'll save them," Katsuki said firmly. "I won't accept anything less than a perfect victory. You have my word."

And Aizawa smiled, perhaps the first honest smile Katsuki had ever seen on the man. "I guess I can accept that."

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

*** ! ! ! ***

Fire alert. Please evacuate to the nearest assembly point.

"Midoriya!"

Bodies jostled Izuku as he fought his way through the crowd, hurrying in the opposite direction to everyone else. It had been barely an hour since he and Aizawa had parted ways; *not enough time*, his brain supplied on loop as the siren blasted into his eardrums and the world around him flashed red. Maybe Aizawa had been successful, but the fire drill in the early hours of the morning could in no way be a coincidence. No, this had to be Aizawa's attempt to warn him, to warn the campus, to get as many people out as possible.

Before the zombies got to them.

"Midoriya!"

Izuku ignored the person calling him as he lost himself deeper into the growing crowd of panicking people. His pager sat heavy in the pocket of his jeans, smacking against his leg with every step, and Izuku's only focus was getting into the labs and getting to the nomu dorms before the zombies from the basement cut him off.

“Goddamnit, *Izuku!*”

But Izuku was out of reach of whoever was yelling for him, finally free of the halls of his dormitory and racing the familiar path to the labs, across the snowy courtyard and throwing himself at the double doors, his wet feet squeaking against the lino.

It was early, but not so early that the labs would be empty, with those pulling their night shifts making their puzzled way to the nearest assembly point, most of them watching Izuku run past with stunned expressions. Stunned, but alive, no one was falling prey to a herd of zombies coming up from the basement. *Perhaps,* Izuku allowed himself to think, *perhaps they were still down there.*

“Whoa, Midoriya!”

Izuku swore, his feet skidding beneath him and only just able to avoid a collision with the man in front of him. Shinsou stood there, his hair as wild and his eyes as dark as ever.

“Damn, where’s the fire?” Shinsou asked, Izuku staring at him in complete disbelief for a moment before Shinsou’s face crumpled. “Ok, not really the time, I hear you. Still, do you have any idea what’s going on?”

“Not yet,” Izuku said, already starting to dart past Shinsou. “But get out of here!”

“Wait-”

“I’m serious! Grab anyone you see and get as far away from the labs as you can!”

The nomu labs weren’t far now, and he reached into his other pocket to wrap his fingers around his keycard. Aizawa said that the nomu dorm was on a separate system, and he had to assume that the fire alarm would be enough to prompt the area to lock up. He’d need the code that Aizawa had given him to release the nomu, to get to Kacchan. He was still in a coma, and Izuku had no idea what condition he would be in, if he could even wake him up, but he had to get to him.

The smell hit him first, like it so often did. That sweet, putrid scent that could only be the smell of death on the air, before the ground beneath him seemed to rumble.

“Shit!”

He skidded to a halt, cursing his luck. He was *so* close to the dorms, but there was no doubt in his mind that the zombies would be on him in moments, *seconds* even. He looked around wildly, spotting an office to his right that, mercifully, opened when he pulled on the handle. He threw himself into the room, groaning loudly when he realised there was no lock on the inside either. He’d just have to stay quiet, stay out of sight; these were just regular zombies, not smart enough to know to check every room they passed for people hiding in them. He thought, then, of Shinsou. Of everyone else he had passed, and with his hands pressed against his mouth, he slid down with his back against the door. His friends, his *mother*, almost everyone he cared about were back there, and none of them knew what was coming for them.

“Stupid,” he breathed. He heard a thud, something colliding with the door. Another, and another, the thundering of footsteps deafening. He dared not look, dared not move from the spot he was in

as the zombies swarmed past the office. The time it took them, the noise they made, there had to be hundreds of them. Maybe more. He dragged his hands up his face, covering his ears instead, waiting until the trembling stopped.

Eventually, the zombies passed, and Izuku could breathe again, climbing to his feet and peering cautiously through the door window. The corridor beyond was filthy; blood and residue smeared the floor and walls, the impact of rotting bodies hitting every surface as they passed. But he couldn't afford to get squeamish now; time was running out, and the nomu could likely be the only chance UA had.

He opened the door, peering out and looking up and down what he could see of the corridor. It seemed empty, no stragglers that he could make out, and a bit more confidently, he left the office. He'd only made it a few steps, however, when something stepped from the corner of the corridor, bringing Izuku to a stop.

At first glance, it looked like a zombie. Pale, long hair unkempt, with ugly-looking bite wounds and pitted flesh on both of its arms. But as Izuku's gaze drifted up and fell on the thing's face, his heart dropped. There was no mistaking him, even under the scars and bite marks. Those cold, red eyes couldn't belong to anyone else.

"Hello Midoriya Izuku."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for being patient, folks.

This is it, just one final chapter and epilogue left.

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 48: DEADICATED: Part Two

Chapter Summary

In which there are zombies to kill.

Chapter Notes

Happy six year anniversary to the day the very first chapter of DEADICATION was posted on AO3.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Shigaraki.”

Izuku took an uncertain step back as he looked at the man standing in front of him. He was tall, his figure almost waifish, cutting a sharp silhouette in the low morning light seeping through the windows. Yet Izuku felt almost entirely suffocated by his presence, the air around him thickening with ozone as the man scowled.

“I thought it would take me longer to find you.”

Tomura Shigaraki’s hair hung in ratty threads over his face, his skinny frame clothed in white and grey cotton so crisp and expensive-looking it was at stark odds with the rest of his appearance. One look at his exposed flesh made it clear that Tomura had suffered intensely in the months since Izuku had last seen him; his forearms were pitted with divots and deep ribbon-like scarring, showing where he had been bitten and torn at in equal measure. A large scar below his left eye showed the extent to which his face must have needed to be reconstructed, and despite the fear running through him, Izuku felt another emotion, burning like acid in his chest as he imagined the horrors that Tomura must have lived through.

“You- you were looking for me?” Izuku asked, taking another step back. Tomura watched him coldly, eyes drifting down to look at his feet pointedly.

“And others,” he replied. His voice was raspy, no doubt a result of the bites on his throat. “Ah-*ah*, don’t take another step.”

Izuku froze, aware of quite how vulnerable he was in the deathly silent corridor.

“What do you want with me?”

Tomura's scowl deepened.

“Don’t ask such a stupid question,” he spat. “And after what you and your friends did to me, offer me the damned courtesy as to not waste my time.”

“We didn’t do anything to you,” Izuku replied. “You shot our friend; if you hadn’t done that, we would have just walked away.”

“You expect me to believe you were really going to give Bakugou over?” Tomura’s tongue darted out to lick his dried and cracked lower lip.

“Well, maybe not.” Izuku took a shaky breath. “But don’t pretend like we weren’t just defending ourselves. The things you’ve done, the people you’ve killed… you deserved what you got.”

Still his voice wavered, even if he wanted to be sure of his words. Tomura seemed to notice, head cocking to the side with interest as he continued to stare at him.

“Did Jin deserve to die that way?” Tomura asked, voice quiet yet no less deadly. “I heard his screams, even as the zombies tried to eat me alive. Found what little was left of his body after they were finished with him. And Toga, you want to know how she died? Want to know how I needed to follow a trail of guts to find her body?”

“I-” Izuku gripped his hands into fists. “Shouto told me how you left *my* friends. How they ate each other. Don’t act like you’re the only victim in all this! Don’t say all this to me like you’re the only one who’s lost something!”

He hadn’t meant to shout, but his voice echoed clear down the corridor. Tomura’s face darkened.

“Maybe you’re right,” he said, after a moment. “We’ve both suffered. But, between you and me, it’s clear that one of us suffered a hell of a lot more than the other.”

Tomura gestured to his face and pulled his knotted hair back. He lifted his chin so Izuku could see the patchwork of scar tissue running down his throat as a grim smile twisted his lips. “Show me yours?”

Distractedly, Izuku raised a hand to his bad eye, but he could tell from the satisfied look on Tomura’s face that he had only further proved his point.

“Although-” Tomura’s arms dropped back to his sides. “I will admit, it seems like Bakugou might have almost got all he deserved. Seeing that bar through his stomach, his insides all over the place like that, I think it was perhaps the closest to happy I have felt in so long.”

“Stop it,” Izuku hissed.

“He’s alive, of course.” Tomura shrugged. “Well. *Almost*. He’s only as alive as I am; ain’t that right?”

“You want to know who’s responsible for *that?*” Izuku countered. “It was your uncle. He’s the one who started all of this, he’s the one who released the virus and turned you into this.”

“I know,” Tomura replied. “That’s why I killed him.”

“Why you- *what?*”

“I killed him. Damn fool, thought that keeping me sedated all this time would be enough, but I was listening. I’ve been present that whole time. Every word he said and every experiment he ran on me… I felt it *all*. Every fucking needle! He didn’t know that even unconscious I was able to communicate with someone else and plan for his fucking execution.”

“You *planned* this?”

Tomura smiled grimly. “Even down to Bakugou’s poorly timed outburst the other night. My uncle and that idiot Toshinori had no *idea* just how interconnected the infected are, and I can feel it. I can feel all of them… The pain, the *hunger*. It’s torture.”

“So, you can control them?” Izuku breathed. “The nomu?” Tomura’s face twitched.

“Not quite.”

Izuku shook his head, raising his hands up beside him. “Come on, for one second can’t you see this outside of what happened between us? This could be *huge*! I know that we’ve hurt each other, and I know that there’s probably no room for forgiveness from either of us, but we’re still on the same side here. Your uncle experimented on you, just as he did on Kacchan! He created the zombies, and they went on to kill almost every single person in the country. There are others here just like you. Isn’t it worth considering what we could do together?”

Tomura’s expression was hard to read, softening in a way he hadn’t expected, and for a moment he allowed himself to hope. Then, Tomura took a deep breath and shook his head.

“It’s not like I don’t understand what you’re saying,” he replied. “I just don’t care.” He pressed his hands against his chest and gripped his cotton shirt. “You can’t feel it. You’ll *never* feel what it’s like inside me, the rage and the agony. My uncle used me, infected me, and instead of protecting me, he sent me out there, knowing that I would at some point get bitten and come back to him in this tormented fucking state. It’s *done*, you moron. It’s over! There is no fixing this hell!”

“So you’ll destroy everything that’s left?” Izuku yelled back.

Tomura raised his head, staring up at the ceiling with what could only be described as bliss. “With absolute pleasure.”

Izuku watched with growing horror as Tomura’s skin seemed to stretch and undulate, hands stretching and twisting as if he had been shocked, a high-pitched whine coming from clenched teeth before everything went still. It was a moment, suspended in time, where the hairs on the back of Izuku’s neck stood up and the pressure grew close to unbearable. Then, just like that, it burst. Izuku sagged; the decision to run was made for him as his legs started moving before he was even aware that he had lurched backwards three feet. Still, it didn’t matter. Tomura was on him before the sweat fell, hands around his throat and dropping him to the hard floor. Izuku choked, all of the air expelling from his lungs as Tomura’s weight compressed his chest, and he found himself staring up at a pitted face and the coldest red imaginable.

“Where do you think you’re going?” Tomura hissed, voice dripping with delight and anticipation. The veins and muscles on his neck were corded with tension, eyes alight and electric and chilling

Izuku to his very core. He tried to speak, to scream even, but Tomura only gripped his throat tighter.

“You can’t stop what’s about to happen. The zombies are going to rip through this whole campus and kill everyone you know and everyone you care about, and you know how I know? Because that’s exactly what happened when Bakugou ripped a hole into Tokyo and every. Single. Person. *Died*.”

He yelled the final word in Izuku's face, teeth snapping shut a hair's width away from his nose, and Izuku squirmed, mouth wide as he fought for breath.

“But don’t think you’re going to get off so lightly, *Izuku Midoriya*.”

Izuku had only a brief moment to wonder how Tomura knew his name when the grip around his throat loosened and he was able to take a deep, painful gulp of air. A sharp pain bloomed from the top of his head, and he cried out as Tomura yanked him upwards. Izuku scrabbled to grab at the thin wrists that now held him suspended from the ground.

“Originally I was just going to kill you in front of Bakugou,” Tomura said, leering up at him. “Tear your throat out and drink what’s left of you whilst he lies paralysed and unable to do a damn thing except watch.”

Izuku kicked his feet wildly, glaring at the man holding him.

“But plans change. I think it would be much better to kill you out in the open. Let Bakugou come to us, hmm?”

“Fuck you,” Izuku spat, trying to break the unnervingly strong grip Tomura had on him. Tomura ignored him and began dragging Izuku down the corridor by his hair, indifferent to Izuku’s struggles.

The pain across his scalp and burning down his neck and shoulders made it difficult for Izuku to think straight as he fought to keep his feet beneath him. Tomura had killed Shigaraki, which meant that the truth of the virus and how exactly it had been created likely died along with him. Even if the nomu survived, how much would that matter if UA fell today? Tomura hadn’t mentioned killing Aizawa, or even seeing him down in the basement, but Izuku knew better than to see that as proof of life; Aizawa couldn’t defend himself against hundreds of zombies even if Tomura had left him alive. Kacchan and the other nomu were still locked in the lab, something that Izuku had to assume Tomura didn’t know about if he was expecting Kacchan to come to them, which meant it was all on him now. He had to find a way out of this, stop Tomura, and get to the nomu so Overhaul and the rest could herd the zombies back in the basement before UA was lost.

“Hurry up.”

Tomura tugged him closer, mercifully letting go of his hair for a heartbeat before cinching his hand in a painful grip around Izuku’s wrist. Whatever nomu abilities Tomura had, strength was certainly among them. Super strength, the ability to control zombies and, from what Tomura himself had said, telekinesis of some sort? And just who in the hell had Tomura been communicating with all of this time?

A loud bang jolted Izuku from his thoughts when Tomura kicked the laboratory doors open and dragged him into the courtyard. The ground beneath them had been churned up by the hundreds of zombies that had marched over the turf, the frozen earth a filthy slush that Izuku slipped on as Tomura continued to drag him. He tried to pull himself free, fingers scratching fruitlessly over the back of Tomura's hand, before they came to a stop.

"Izuku?"

Izuku's head snapped up, fear clouding his senses when he saw Shouto standing ahead of them. He'd followed him, and it looked like he had needed to fight his way here already, going on the blood spatter on his clothes and the piece of wood he'd used as a weapon.

"Oh, you're Dabi's brother, right?"

"Let him go," Shouto replied firmly, gripping his makeshift weapon.

"Shouto, get out of here!" Izuku cried.

"Are you *crazy*?" Shouto yelled back, looking at him in disbelief. "I'm not leaving you with this freak."

"He's too strong! Just… just let me handle this-"

"Quit shouting," Tomura snapped. "He ain't so far away that you have to be yelling in my ear."

"I said, *let him go*."

"And I ignored you the first time. Shouto, right? I can't remember what Dabi said your name was before we left you for dead way back when. Do you even remember my name?"

"I don't care who you are," Shouto replied. "Or why the hell you look like that. I just care that you let my friend go."

"What, and you're going to make me?"

Tomura grinned before pulling Izuku close and grabbing him by his hair and tugging hard. Izuku bit back a cry, staring at Shouto through watery eyes.

"Shouto, he's *infected*! I need you to go!"

But Izuku already knew there was no way that Shouto was going to leave him behind, and he watched as he shook his head and ran towards them, weapon held high and eyes fixed on his target. If Tomura had been a regular zombie, Izuku wouldn't have fancied his chances against a seasoned survivor such as Shouto, but Tomura had the kind of strength that Izuku hadn't experienced since he had been in Mr. Zombig's clutches, and he screamed for Shouto to stop. He heard Tomura laugh before he was tossed onto the cold, rough dirt, his head hitting the ground hard enough to make his ears ring. Izuku gasped, squinting through stars in his vision, looking up in time to see Tomura knock Shouto's arm aside, his weapon clattering to the floor, before a pitted hand grabbed Shouto by the throat and squeezed.

“No!”

Shouto’s eyes bugged on his face, wide and terrified. He was taller than Tomura, but that didn’t stop him from being lifted from the ground, his feet kicking wildly as he hung in the air, hands uselessly trying to break Tomura’s grip on his throat.

“Let him go!”

Izuku clambered to his feet, reaching for Shouto’s fallen weapon, swinging it with all his strength at Tomura’s face. The wood cracked, Tomura flinching and snarling as fresh blood bloomed from his cheek, but still he didn’t let go, only tightening his grip around Shouto’s throat so that only a weak wheeze could be heard from him.

“I said let him go!”

Izuku jumped, wrapping his arm around Tomura’s neck and pulling tight, but he shook him free like it was nothing, throwing Izuku aside with ease. His mind raced, watching as Shouto’s face grew redder, his expression hazy, before he grabbed hold of Tomura’s wrist and bit down with all the force he had.

Tomura yelled as Izuku shook his head and tore into the flesh and tendons in his mouth, feeling hot, acrid blood dribble down his chin. Shouto watched in horror, tears spilling before Tomura finally let go, dropping him to the ground in a heap. With an outraged snarl, Tomura threw Izuku aside, snatching his bleeding wrist back and staring at him in shock.

“Are you stupid or something?”

Izuku ignored him, dropping down beside Shouto as he choked and coughed, struggling to catch his breath, his neck red and painful looking, his voice hoarse as he tried to speak.

“It’s fine,” Izuku assured him, as Shouto stared at the blood around his face. “It’ll be ok, it’s not-”

But Tomura wasn’t about to let him finish, grabbing Izuku’s hair and pulling him away. He glared down at Shouto, and Izuku didn’t even have time to yell before he kicked out, his heel hitting Shouto’s head with a sickening thud.

“I think I’ll leave that one here to be eaten,” Tomura said, before spitting onto the dirt beside Shouto’s ear.

“You didn’t have to hurt him!” Izuku yelled, hitting Tomura against his chest.

“He attacked me. Didn’t you see that?” Tomura replied. “Funny how often that seems to be the case with your lot.”

“I swear if you don’t let me go-”

“You’ll what, bite me again?” Tomura looked at his injured wrist, his expression foul. “You can’t help but ruin everything, can you?”

“I’ll kill you,” Izuku hissed.

“Oh, you’re already dead,” Tomura snapped, waving his hand in irritation. “You bite me you might as well have bitten a zombie; you’re infected all the damn same.”

“I don’t give a shit.”

“I know *you* don’t. But this isn’t about you, is it? Moron, killing you just won’t feel the same knowing you’re already infected.”

Izuku couldn’t stop the cruel, twisted smile from curling his lips.

“You know, Dabi said the exact same thing to Kacchan when he realised he was infected. Right before Kacchan bit half his face off and I beat his skull in.”

Tomura froze, shock passing over his features before it was carefully schooled into rage, pulling Izuku close to him, their faces barely an inch apart.

“I think I’ve changed my mind again. I’m going to do so much more than make an example of you. I’ll torture you, flay you, kill you oh so very fucking slowly whilst everyone you care about watches.”

Izuku glared, refusing to break eye contact, before Tomura was once again holding him by the wrist and tugging. Izuku looked back, Shouto lying prone on the floor, his throat already blooming a bruise as a thin-sounding groan came from his lips. He prayed that nothing would find him before he could find his way back to him.

“Yeh, change of plans,” Tomura muttered, hauling Izuku away. “Change of plans. Overhaul, you listening?”

Izuku’s eyes widened, and his head snapped back to look at Tomura.

“*Overhaul?*”

“Far as I can figure, there’s just about one way out of this right now.”

Katsuki grunted, acknowledging that he had heard Hawks as they ran side-by-side through the laboratory. It was still early in the morning, but they had climbed enough stairs now that they could finally see a dull red dawn through the high, narrow windows of the ground floor. The fire alarm had stopped at some point; Katsuki figured perhaps Aizawa was responsible for that blessed scrap of relief, but the red emergency lights still flashed. They had already taken too long. Even a minute of zombies loose on a campus was a nightmare to consider, let alone the forty or so minutes it must have been since this all started. His friends were strong, and they were capable, but faced with hundreds of the undead, there was only so long anyone could hold out.

“You think Overhaul can actually control all of them?” Katsuki asked. “They’re probably spread out all over the fucking campus by now.”

“You saw him hold back all the zombies at the gate,” Hawks replied.

“I saw him control a bunch of zombies that he could *see*, and that could probably see him. This ain’t the same situation, and you know it.”

“Well, what other option do we have?” Hawks huffed. “You’re freakishly good at killing the damn things, so we let Overhaul get the ones he can into the basement, and we pick off the rest.”

Katsuki didn’t answer, just focusing now on the ground beneath his bare feet, the amount of blood and zombie residue making the floor treacherous at the speed he was running.

“There!” Hawks cried, pointing ahead of them.

Large double doors guarded the exit to the lab ahead of them, with what appeared to be a courtyard of sorts just visible through the smeared glass. Katsuki barely had a moment to appreciate that it was his first taste of freedom in upwards of four months before he slammed the doors open and skidded to a halt.

“Right, where now?” he barked, looking back at Hawks.

“We’re right in the middle of the main building here,” Hawks explained, looking around. “The dormitories are all situated to the west, so we probably need to cut through this way.”

Hawks pointed to their right, a wide pathway that cut between two of the large buildings of the main campus, and Katsuki nodded.

“Zombies have definitely gone that way,” Hawks remarked, gesturing to the slush underfoot and to a body that lay around twelve feet away. Katsuki scowled.

“Ain’t no way zombies did that and didn’t eat the guy,” he said, hurrying forward. His breath caught in his throat when he got closer. “Oh, fuck.”

Kacchan dropped to Shouto’s side, hand hovering uncertainly. Shouto wasn’t in a good way; there was blood on his temple from where he had been knocked out, and a dark bruise was forming around his throat, but the steady wheeze coming from him assured Katsuki that he was alive.

“Oi. Princess.”

Hawks gave him a confused look, but Shouto didn’t stir. Katsuki shook him a little harder.

“Hey! Todoroki!”

Shouto groaned, his brow furrowing. Katsuki, growing impatient, slapped him on the cheek and with a gasp Shouto’s eyes shot open. There was a moment where he just stared blankly up at him, before his eyes widened in recognition.

“*Bakugou?*”

“One and only,” Katsuki replied grimly, gripping Shouto’s shoulders as he tried to sit up. “Careful, you probably got a concussion or something.”

“But you slapped me,” Shouto mumbled, raising a hand to his head, hissing a breath as he touched

the still-bleeding wound.

“You’ll survive,” Katsuki replied with a shrug. “What the hell happened?”

Shouto blinked, looking over at Katsuki again. His eyes were still somewhat out of focus and hazy, and he swayed in Katsuki’s grip.

“It really is you,” Shouto said. His voice was hoarse, a product of the nasty-looking bruise on his throat. “Kaminari isn’t completely crazy.”

“Idiot can be real fucking perceptive when he wants to be,” Katsuki said, somewhat proudly. “You should be more embarrassed that he was the one that figured it out.”

“Right,” Shouto replied, still seeming unfocused. He looked around and noticed Hawks for the first time, who offered him a cheerful wave.

“Who-”

“Later,” Katsuki interrupted. “Tell us what the hell happened.”

“I- uh,” Shouto swallowed and winced. “I was… I followed Izuku-”

Shouto gasped, his hand reaching out to grab hold of Katsuki’s wrist.

“It was him! The leader, the one my brother was travelling with!”

“Shigaraki,” Katsuki said coldly.

“Right, him. Only he looks different now. And he has Izuku.”

“Crap,” Hawks breathed. Katsuki pressed his hands to his face, rubbing hard. Of course, *they had taken too long*, and now Shigaraki had Izuku.

“Where did they go?” he asked. Shouto looked over his shoulder.

“To the dorms, I think. But wait- *wait*!” He grabbed hold of Katsuki again, tugging him down just as he made to get to his feet. “There’s something else…”

Shouto trailed off, and Katsuki felt fear growing as he took in the expression on his face and the way his lips trembled.

“Shigaraki, he’s infected. Like you, I mean.”

“We’re well ahead of you on that one, Princess,” Katsuki said, trying to shake Shouto’s grip lose so he could stop wasting more of their time.

“There was a struggle, and Shigaraki got me. Only reason he let go is because Izuku *bit* his arm.”

Shouto’s voice shook, eyes wide as if pleading for Katsuki to understand the implications because it was far too painful to say the words out loud. Katsuki felt something in him soften unexpectedly,

when he saw the pain in Shouto's eyes.

"He's infected," Katsuki said, before he sighed. "It's ok. Izuku is like me. In a way."

Shouto gaped. "*What?*"

"Look, I'm sure Izuku'll be happy to give you a long-winded and unnecessarily complex explanation himself when we *find him*," Katsuki said firmly. "But we need to get going, you hear?"

Shouto nodded. "Right, right."

"So, is your ass coming, or am I leaving you here?"

"I know this place better than you do," Shouto replied, letting Katsuki pull him to his feet, where he wobbled for a moment before steadying. "I'm coming."

"Great!" Hawks announced. "Another one for the road!"

"Who is he again?" Shouto asked, and Katsuki grunted.

"Hawks. Another nomu."

"A what?"

"Holy fuck, can we *go*?" Katsuki yelled, grabbing Shouto's arm and dragging him forward. "We need to find Izuku and kill the fucking freak who has him."

"Maybe it's best that we split up," Hawks offered, as the three of them began to jog down the pathway. "You and, uh… *Princess*-"

"Todoroki," Shouto sighed.

"Right, you and Todoroki look for Midoriya and Shigaraki, and I'll peel off and see if I can track down where Mirko, Fat and Overhaul ended up."

"Did you say Overhaul?" Shouto asked, looking back at him. Hawks brightened up.

"Yeh! Why, you see him?"

"Look, I'm fuzzy on account of being kicked in the head," Shouto replied. "But I'm pretty sure Shigaraki mentioned him. Something like… if he was listening?"

Katsuki threw him a confused look. "Hah?"

"*Overhaul, are you listening?* I think that's what he said."

There was a curse, and Hawks slowed to a halt. Katsuki, irritated at yet another distraction, yanked on Shouto's arm again to stop him, almost pulling him over.

"What the hell-"

“Are you sure that’s what he said?” Hawks asked.

“No, I’m not sure,” Shouto sighed, rubbing his aching head. “I told you, I was kicked in the head right before he said it. But it’s what I *heard.* Why, what does that mean?”

Katsuki couldn’t help it, he laughed. A loud, graceless-sounding bark that would have grabbed the attention of any zombie if it were nearby.

“I knew there was something fucking off about that guy,” he said. “He’s been in Shigaraki’s pocket this whole fucking time.”

“No,” Hawks interupted. “Trust me, he despised the man. Hell, if there was any of the nomu that I would have trusted with the truth of what was going on here it would have been Overhaul!”

“Well, it’s a damn good job you didn’t then because that asshole just betrayed you and this entire campus.”

“How?” Hawks hissed. “Nomu Shigaraki has been locked in that basement, how the hell was Overhaul supposed to co-ordinate with him?”

“I don’t fucking know *how*,” Katsuki replied, voice rising. “Some of the nomu can control zombies, right? Maybe there are nomu that can control other nomu or some shit. Hell, there’s gotta be some kinda psychic bullshit going on for the zombies to listen to the nomu anyway. Who’s to say that ain’t exactly what’s going on between Shigaraki and Overhaul.”

“You think Shigaraki is forcing Overhaul to do this?”

“Maybe. Or maybe Overhaul just got fed up of being treated like a guinea pig like the rest of us and did something about it. The *why* don’t matter. Right now, the only shit I wanna concern myself with is saving Izuku, killing Shigaraki, and *forcing* Overhaul to send the zombies back into the basement if that’s what it comes to.”

“Hold up,” Shouto said. “Your plan is for one guy to control all the zombies? You haven’t seen how many of them there are! I was hiding for what must have been five minutes just waiting for the herd of them to pass me; there are hundreds!”

“It’s that, or we kill them all,” Katsuki replied.

It was then that the unmistakable sound of gunfire filled the air, all three of them freezing and looking towards the source.

“Or we let the soldiers do it for us,” Hawks said.

“The zombies must have reached the dorms,” Shouto breathed. “There are armed guards all over the place here, not just at the gates.”

“C’mon,” Katsuki grunted, starting to hurry in the direction of the gunshots. “If the zombies are at the dorms then we gotta assume Shigaraki and Izuku aren’t far away.”

It wasn't hard to follow the trail of destruction that the mega herd had left in their wake; everything in their way had been crushed and destroyed. The trees lining the gently winding path were caked in blood and viscera and whatever else had been torn from them as the zombies forced their way past. It hadn't been long since he had last been around a bunch of the feral undead, but Katsuki was still stunned by the smell all over again, covering his face as he ran. For the first time since he was bitten, he found himself glad for the fact that he was already infected; his bare feet were already so scratched up and caked with blood that he would have no doubt died from that alone if he had been a normal person. By now, they could hear more than just gunshots ahead of them; people were screaming, their sounds of terror making the hair on the back of Katsuki's neck stand up. He tried not to think about whether Kirishima, Mina, or Kaminari were among those screaming.

"Slow down!"

Hawks grabbed hold of his arm, pulling him to a stop.

"The hell are we stopping for now?"

"Look!"

Tugging on him again, Hawks pulled Katsuki and Shouto back to hide behind a tree and pointed. They were close enough now that they could finally see the herd ahead of them, a large mass of bodies pushing against one another, some trampling others beneath them as they went.

"If we keep running without a plan, we'll either end up in the herd or get ourselves shot," Hawks explained. "We need to be smart about this."

"I don't see Izuku," Shouto said, scanning the treeline. "Or Shigaraki."

A fresh wave of screams and gunshots came, voices yelling inaudible instructions followed by the unmistakable howl of someone in a lot of pain. Katsuki cursed.

"Fuck. *Fuck*, ok. We need to cut around, get behind the soldiers, try and get inside of the dorms and find Shigaraki."

"But won't that make us just as trapped as everyone else in there?" Shouto reasoned. "Look, I'm all for stopping him!" he added, when Katsuki threw him a filthy look. "I'm not saying we abandon everyone. But what if that's not where Shigaraki is taking Izuku? What if we get stuck in there and he's somewhere else entirely?"

"Fuck," Katsuki swore again. "Ok, well where the hell else could he be going? What else is over here?"

"You've got the main gates to the right of the dorms," Hawks offered. "What if he's trying to escape UA?"

"He can't, not without Overhaul," Katsuki replied, frowning. "There's no way anyone, even Shigaraki, is getting out of that gate without being killed by the zombies outside. Besides, I know Shigaraki. He's killed the big guy, and this place is secure. He'll want to take UA for himself."

"By killing everyone?" Shouto said.

“He doesn’t need to kill everyone, just enough of everyone. He’ll want the weapon and to seal the place off so only he has access. All he has to do is kill off the soldiers, and between he and Overhaul and the zombies everyone else will just do exactly what he wants.”

“So, what’s the plan?”

Katsuki glanced to his left, seeing both Shouto and Hawks looking at him, and he felt a painful tug in his chest when he realised how insufferable Izuku might have been about that if he were here.

“Get to the dorms,” Katsuki said, raising a hand and gesturing to his left. “We go the long way and try to get behind the line of fire. Assess the situation. Hawks, when Dog Eyes took us out that one time, he took us to some sort of barracks. Where is that?”

“Near the front gates,” Hawks replied.

“I know where it is,” Shouto confirmed.

“Good. Hawks, we’ll split up at the dorms. You look for Overhaul and the other nomu, and if Shigaraki isn’t there, Princess and I will head for the barracks.”

“Well, that meets the basic requirements for a plan,” Hawks said. “I’ll take it.”

“C’mon, keep your heads down and try not to draw any attention. Last thing we need right now is for a zombie to spot us and a hundred of his wanker playmates to come at us.”

“Colourful as ever,” Shouto muttered.

The three of them headed left, away from the tail end of the herd and gunshots, eyes peeled for any strays. They were just about to break out of the tree line when Shouto cursed, a thud heard as he hit the ground. Katsuki swung round to see Shouto on his ass, struggling with a zombie as it bore its weight down onto him.

“Don’t kill it!” Katsuki hissed.

Shouto looked up at him in disbelief, grunting with the effort of holding the zombie back.

“Should I just let it eat me?”

Katsuki ran forward, grabbing the zombie around the shoulders and heaving. It had been so long since Katsuki had needed to do this, and his experiments in the past had made it clear that his control over the zombies was incredibly limited compared to the likes of Overhaul. But the zombies that he sent at Shigaraki and the others had ignored him and his friends to go after the bastards, so he likely had more control than he realised. He took a deep breath, staring into the sunken sockets on the zombie's pitted face, and spoke.

“*Stop.*”

For a moment, he was sure it hadn’t worked. The zombie kept coming. Then, after a couple steps it hesitated, body stiff and head swaying as if, all of a sudden, it had no idea where they were.

Katsuki huffed in relief.

“If we kill one, others’ll sense it and come after us,” he explained. The three of them watched as the zombie seemed to forget all about them. It turned back around to where the rest of the herd was swarming. “Good, it’s leaving. Keep going.”

Beyond the treeline, it was all the more obvious the kind of devastation and horror the release of the basement zombies had created. The tall wire perimeter around the dormitories was, at present, doing its job against the onslaught. Though the way it was beginning to bow and buckle in places likely meant it was a matter of when, not if, the fence came down. A large group of soldiers lined the fence and the only opening to the dorms, firing in bursts at the herd as it ran, leaving a growing pile of corpses between them and it. From their vantage point, Katsuki couldn’t make out much of the herd, though there were pockets where zombies seemed to be swarming, and felt sick. Those pockets were almost certainly where someone had been caught before being eaten alive.

“The guards might be able to hold them off,” Shouto said.

“The fence won’t hold up long enough for that,” Katsuki replied. “There’s too many of the fucking things.”

“This way!”

Katsuki followed Hawks as he began sprinting towards the back of the dorms, the three of them keeping their bodies as low to the ground as they could whilst the zombies were distracted with the soldiers and fallen bodies.

The dormatories were made up of three separate buildings, all tall and identical, linked by a sheltered bridge around three stories up. Faces could be seen pressed against the windows, the people who were fortunate enough to be inside looking down in horror at the zombies beginning to swarm all around them. The zombies, for now, were localised around the front, and the three of them were easily able to run to the fence without being detected.

“Climb over!” Katsuki instructed, as he jumped at the fence and began to scale it, the sound of the metal creaking so much louder than he would have liked for it to be. He dropped gracefully onto the grass on the other side, looking back to see Shouto and Hawks not far behind him.

“We ain’t gonna be able to get in round the back,” Shouto said, looking around. “The only entrances are right at the front where the guards and zombies are.”

“So, find an open window or something,” Katsuki replied, walking up the nearest one and attempting to push it open. “Hawks, you need to get inside one of these damn buildings so you can find the other nomu, then we can head to the barracks-”

Katsuki was interrupted by the sound of three firm knocks, and he swung on the spot, eyes darting around in confusion.

“Todoroki!”

A voice, barely audible over the gunfire and shouting, grabbed Katsuki’s attention and he looked up. A window was thrown open, and through it a man with a scar on his face and electric blond hair

peered out, arm waving urgently.

“Over here!”

“Kaminari,” Shouto sighed in relief. Kaminari looked over at Katsuki and Hawks, before his eyes widened and his mouth dropped.

“Oh my god… *Bakugou*? I knew it! I knew you were still alive!”

“Hey Dunceface,” Katsuki replied, his face twisting into a smile.

“*Did you say Bakugou?*”

Another voice cried out from beyond the window, and with a muffled yell Kaminari was swiftly pushed aside and Katsuki smile grew into a grin as he saw Kirishima and Mina staring down at him.

“W-wait there!” Kirishima ordered, his voice shaky. “We’ll throw down something to get you up.”

Katsuki hesitated. As desperately as he wanted to see them, as relieved as he was that his friends were currently safe, finding Izuku and stopping Shigaraki was the main thing on his mind. Fabric fell down out of the window, sheets and blankets tied together as a makeshift rope, and just as Katsuki began shaking his head, he felt someone slap him hard on the shoulder.

“We got company.”

Zombies, possibly drawn by the noise, had now made their way around the side of the building, and as soon as they spotted Katsuki and the others standing there, they began to run, throwing themselves against the fence. The sound only drew more, and within moments Katsuki watched as the handful of zombies grew to a dozen, the fence screeching angrily against their weight.

“Shit.”

“C’mon!”

There’d be no outrunning them now. It would take too long for Katsuki to scale the fence, and he’d likely have his fingers and toes torn off by the zombies on the other side if he tried. Frustrated, he turned to the sheets, nodding at Shouto who began to climb, with Hawks and Katsuki following after him.

When Katsuki reached the top, Kirishima reached out and grabbed his hand, helping him over the windowsill and into the room beyond. Katsuki barely had time to stand upright before a weight collided with him, arms wrapping tightly around his neck and a wet kiss pressed against his cheek.

“*Katsuki*,” Mina sobbed, burying her face in his chest. “You’re here; you’re alive.”

“Hey, Mina,” Katsuki said softly, gathering her up in the hug and resting his face against the top of her head.

Kaminari and Kirishima stood nearby, the latter with suspiciously wet-looking eyes, and the

moment that Mina stepped back, Kirishima grabbed Katsuki's forearm and pulled him into his own hug, thumping his back with perhaps more force than was necessary.

"Man, you have gotta stop making us think you're dead," Kirishima said thickly, and Katsuki choked out a laugh.

"In my defence, it wasn't my fault this time."

"What happened?" Kaminari asked, and it was then that Katsuki realised that, not only was he barefoot and treading blood into the carpet, but he had only tied the jumpsuit around his waist, leaving the wide expanse of burn scars visible to all of them.

"It's a long story," Katsuki replied, untying the sleeves around his waist and pulling the jumpsuit up to cover him better. "Got blown up, got better, been stuck here like some fucking lab rat ever since."

"I like the new look," Mina said, still sniffling and offering him a shaky smile. "Makes you look like a badass."

"Fuck you, what do you mean makes me *look* like one?" Katsuki teased before his eyes darted down. Mina was wearing a thick jumper; to him she looked no different, but he looked to Kirishima, eyes darting warmly between the two of them.

"Izuku told me. Which one of you two is pregnant again?"

"Very fucking funny," Kirishima said, his grin blooming and his face flush with pride.

"Where is Izuku?" Mina asked, sounding worried. "We went to look for him, but he wasn't in his room. Todoroki, we just assumed you were with him."

"I followed him when he left the dorms," Shouto explained. "I lost sight of him, then I had to hide from the herd as it came out of the campus."

"He went in there?" Kaminari yelped. "God, what if he's still in there!"

"He ain't," Katsuki said. "Fuck, there's so much I gotta explain here for any of this to make sense, but Shigaraki has him."

"*The* Shigaraki?" Mina asked. "The guy that runs this place?"

"No, his nephew," Hawks said, speaking for the first time. "Shigaraki is dead; it's the young Shigaraki that we have to watch out for now."

"Young, like…" Kaminari tilted his head, and looked at Katsuki with dawning realisation. "Shit, you don't mean-"

"Yeh. Tomura Shigaraki," Katsuki replied grimly. "He fucking survived back in the city; more than that, he got bit. Turns out, he's just like me and Hawks."

"Hawks?" Kirishima asked, looking confused. Hawks waved.

“That’s me. Me and Dynamite, uh, *Bakugou*, are what this place calls *nomu*. Bitten, infected, but we don’t turn like most people. And there are a few of us.”

“How many?” Mina asked, voice hushed.

“At UA? Seven, if you include me, Bakugou, and now Shigaraki. Maybe eight, but we don’t know what Midoriya is yet.”

“Whoa, whoa, hold up *what?*” Kaminari yelped.

“Izuku,” Katsuki started, hesitating for just a moment, realising the weight of what he was about to reveal. “He’s immune. Or near enough, I guess? Point is, he’s been infected a bunch of fucking times, by me, by the nomu we came across in that village, and probably by Shigaraki now, too. He tested it; the fucking lunatic purposefully infected himself, and by the next day there was no trace of the virus in his body at all.”

Shouto stared at him, barely breathing. “So… if he wasn’t immune then you-” But he hesitated, shaking his head and tearing his gaze away from Katsuki like he thought better of finishing his question.

“Look, we still don’t know exactly how this shit works,” Katsuki continued. “And we probably won’t for a while. But Shigaraki survived; he killed his uncle, set the zombies loose, and now he has Izuku, and I gotta find him before something worse happens.”

“Why does Shigaraki have Midoriya?” Kirishima asked. “Does he know he’s immune or something?”

“I don’t think so,” Shouto replied. “Izuku got infected saving me when I tried to help him.” He sighed, rubbing the back of his head. “Guess I just made everything worse again. Point is, when Izuku got infected, Shigaraki was really angry about it. I don’t think he has any idea how important Izuku could be right now.”

“Damn right,” Kaminari breathed. “Midoriya being immune… think what that could mean.”

“No, don’t fucking think about it,” Katsuki snapped, feeling his blood boil. “That kinda fucked up thinking is how they justified keeping me locked up and sedated for fucking months, and I ain’t about to let Izuku become a lab rat, too. Shigaraki is dead, and so are a bunch of the scientists in that lab. Right now I don’t give a shit about the virus; I give a shit about saving Izuku and the people living here.”

An uncomfortable silence followed, no one really knowing what to say. Katsuki got Kaminari’s point; hell, it had been just about all he could think about the second that Izuku told him that he was immune. But Katsuki couldn’t bring himself to think about the long term, couldn’t even let that kind of hope in when it depended entirely on Izuku. He was a self-sacrificial idiot and arguably the worst person to be immune because he would give his life if it came to it, and Katsuki was just selfish enough to spend the rest of his days stopping him.

“It’s only a matter of time before the zombies break through the fence or the guards run out of ammo,” Katsuki continued, ignoring the looks on their faces. “If Shigaraki and Izuku ain’t here,

then I need to get out there and find them. Meanwhile, the rest of you should get somewhere safe, y'hear? Somewhere you can hide and defend if the zombies make it up here."

"There's the roof," Shouto offered. "We can probably chain the door shut."

"But that's probably where everyone will go if the zombies get in," Mina said. "I can't chain people out, I can't do that."

"No, you're right; it's a bad idea." Shouto pursed his lips, thinking. "What about the old teachers' dorms? They're their own self-contained unit. We can barricade the main door and then hole up in one of the rooms. Puts two doors between us and the zombies."

"Isn't that also where Midoriya's mum lives?" Mina asked. "Maybe she's still there."

"What will you do?" Shouto asked, looking at Katsuki. He chewed his lip, looking back out of the window. The fence was almost completely covered in zombies by now, and he couldn't see a way that he could sneak out without them catching him.

"Where're the teacher dorms?" He asked.

"First floor," Kirishima replied. "Low enough that we could technically jump the windows if we really needed to."

"That'll do. I'll come with you, make sure it's safe, then get out as soon as there's an opening. Sound good?"

"We still need to find Overhaul," Hawks reminded him. "Mirko and Fat too."

"Who?"

"There ain't no way that they beat the zombies here," Katsuki replied. "Not with how surrounded this place is. My bet is they're still outside, and Overhaul is wherever Shigaraki is."

"Right. So I'll come with you when you leave."

"Me too," Shouto offered. "I know UA's layout better than either of you."

"Sure, sure," Katsuki muttered, waving a hand. "C'mon, we probably don't have long before the zombies force their way in. Show us the way, Princess."

The five of them made their way out of the cramped bedroom, Shouto peering down the hall to check the coast was clear before signalling for them to follow. They only had to go down one flight of stairs to reach the first floor, and aside from the small gatherings of people in the hallways trying to figure out what was going on, they made it to the staircase without coming across any obstacles.

"Right, can't see any zombies or guards on the stairway," Kirishima said. "We're almost there now."

"Hey," Kaminari said. "Doesn't it seem a little… quiet all of a sudden?"

Katsuki frowned, pausing. It took him a second to realise what Kaminari meant, but sure enough it dawned on him that he could no longer hear the sound of gunfire, and his blood ran cold.

“They stopped shooting,” Mina hissed. “Did they get them all?”

But then, there came a single loud yell, strangled and wet sounding, followed by a series of terrified screams.

“Run!” Katsuki ordered.

The group charged down the stairs as the screams grew more frantic and panicked. There was still gunfire, the odd pop among the screams, some of the guards had survived at least, but as people began to run past them on the first floor, heading for the higher levels, Katsuki knew it was likely only a matter of minutes before the zombies flooded the ground floor and followed the people up.

“How far is it?” he yelled to Shouto, as they dodged through the panicked people.

“Nearly there…. Here!”

Shouto pointed to a doorway at the end of the hall. Katsuki looked back, Kirishima and Mina were holding hands so that they wouldn’t get separated, Hawks reaching out to them and guiding them through the crowd. For a heart stopping moment he couldn’t see Kaminari, but then the man pushed his way past a tight throng of people, stopping in front of him and panting hard.

“Everyone’s here, c’mon lets get in!” Katsuki called. Shouto nodded, and grabbed the handle, but it wouldn’t turn. He threw a panicked glance over his shoulder before trying again.

“What’s going on?” Mina asked.

“It’s locked!”

“Well there’s no point breaking it down!” Hawks said. “Let’s just find another room!”

“No, wait, just hold up a second.”

Mina pushed her way past them, and knocked on the door, pressing her ear to it so she could hear better.

“Mrs. Midoriya? Please, if you’re in there, it’s Mina. Can you let us in?”

“She’s our nurse,” Kirishima explained to Katsuki. But Katsuki was running out of patience, and if they waited there any longer they were going to find themselves pinned by hundreds of zombies, and just as he was about to say as much, there was a click and the door opened.

For a moment, Katsuki felt the ground tilt beneath him, because by all accounts it could have been Izuku who opened the door. Only the person at the door was shorter and rounder in the cheeks, hair considerably more tamed.

“Mina!” Mrs Midoriya cried. “Quickly, please get inside; we’re just about to barricade the doors!”

Gratefully, the group filed in before Mrs. Midoriya closed and locked the door, and the rest of the inhabitants started to shift and drag furniture in front of it. Katsuki, watching Izuku's mum struggle with one of the tables, went to help before one of the people in the room caught his eye, and he froze.

"Mother*fucker*."

The man seemed only then to truly register who had just come into the room, and his eyes widened and jaw dropped in surprise.

"Dynamite?"

Katsuki felt a rage bubble up inside of him so quickly that he was moving before he had a change to register it. Professor Toshinori was considerably taller than him, but he had him pinned all the same, grabbing hold of the front of his jacket with both hands and pushing him roughly against the wall.

"Whoa!"

He felt Kirishima at his side in an instant but ignored him, glaring up at the man's face.

"You cowardly piece of shit," Katsuki spat, grabbing the Professor and shoving him. "Those are your fucking zombies out there! What, captain too good to go down with his fucking ship?"

"Hey, take it easy, man!" Kirishima said, putting a hand on his shoulder.

"I am taking it easy," Katsuki growled. "This ain't nothing on what this asshole actually deserves."

"Dynamite," Toshinori said, his voice soft yet urgent. "I understand what you're saying. You're right, I should be over there trying to fix this, but I was blind-sided on this. I couldn't get past the zombies any more than anyone else could."

"Bullshit," Katsuki snapped. "Todoroki made it out. *Izuku* made it out."

"Izuku?"

Mrs. Midoriya spoke then, hurrying forward, her eyes wide and hands wringing together.

"His room was empty; I thought he was with his friends I- oh my god, he's *out there*?"

Katsuki looked over at her, his grip on Toshinori relaxing until the man was able to slide down against the wall. But, instead of escaping, Toshinori grabbed Katsuki shoulder.

"Young Midoriya made it *where*?" he asked, looking just as worried as Mrs. Midoriya did.

Katsuki glared him, before pushing him away and stepping back.

"Look, maybe it's time for a proper explanation of what happened back at the lab," Hawks offered. "Uh…" he looked around, noticing that there were three other women in the room with them, all looking shocked and confused. "I guess it's fine if everyone knows about this, huh?"

“Please,” Mrs. Midoriya said. “What’s going on, where is Izuku?”

“Shigaraki created the virus,” Katsuki ground out, suddenly finding himself unable to look Izuku’s mother in the eye. “Izuku figured most of it out. Turns out, Shigaraki’s been injecting kids with some experimental drug over the last thirty-odd years, infecting us with some sort of virus that gradually spread across the entire of Japan, probably a lot further than that.”

“We’re all infected with the zombie virus?” Kaminari breathed.

“No, not then,” Katsuki continued. “Izuku reckons it was just something that kinda helped the zombie virus along, weakened our immune system or some shit so that when he released the big one, he could guarantee that we’d be infected.”

“That’s not quite right,” Toshinori said, with a heavy sigh, and he looked over at Mrs. Midoriya. “Inko, I’m so sorry, I should have done something sooner.”

“What are you talking about?” Inko said, taking a step away from him. “What did you do? What does this have to do with Izuku?”

“Time for a proper explanation, old man,” Hawks said coldly.

“Originally, I thought the drug really was a unique cure for the Epstein-Barr virus,” Toshinori said. “The link between contracting the virus in your youth and suffering from chronic health issues and autimmune diseases in the future was something that I, and Shigaraki, were particularly interested in. The first time he got permission to use it to treat a handful of children who ended up in critical condition, it seemed to be a complete success. But then, he lost interest.”

Toshinori sat himself down on one of the chairs by the door.

“Five years later, he decided to trial the drug again. It worked, and then once more he lost interest, I couldn’t make sense of it. It wasn’t until the third round that I realised something strange was going on. That was the final round.” Toshinori looked up at Inko again. “And the trial Izuku was part of.”

Inko gasped, her hands coming to her mouth. “This is why he asked me if he had gotten sick as a child.”

“I spoke up,” Toshinori assured her. “I went to Shigaraki and I asked him what he was doing, and when he refused to answer I went to the board but… Shigaraki’s always been able to get away with the sort of things that others couldn’t. The financial backing he had, not to mention his personal wealth, no one would take my concerns seriously.

“Then, Shigaraki started working at UA. He stopped with the trials, and instead started on a different thesis, looking at whether viral pathogens could be deconstructed and their DNA changed into something entirely different. Essentially, he was home brewing a virus that would work only in very specific conditions.”

“And they let him get away with it?” Shouto asked.

“Oh no, trust me, CIRO were onto him,” Hawks interrupted. “We’ve been watching him. I was sent

to UA to gather information on Shigaraki's research."

Toshinori looked up at him in surprise.

"You're an agent?"

"Sure am. See, as one of the kids treated with Shigaraki's *miracle drug*, I had a pretty invested interest in it. My feelings were that me and the other kids at the time were deliberately infected by Epstein-Barr, which understandly got my back up a bit."

"So, why wasn't anything done?" Inko demanded.

"Because we needed proof. Shigaraki's public research into deconstructing a virus was well-known, but we were more interested in the research he was doing into a secret project. Something, I'm guessing, you now know all about."

Hawks nodded pointedly at Toshinori, who sighed again.

"I found out all of this recently, please understand me. I knew there was something not right about him and his research, but it wasn't until the zombie virus was released that I realised quite the extent to which he was responsible. At that point, it was too late to do anything. The drug that you, young Midoriya and Dynamite here were administered wasn't about immunosuppression, or a way to discreetly spread a symptomless virus around the entire of Japan."

"So what the hell was it?" Katsuki snapped, growing impatient.

"A type of IFN, a drug that was indeed designed to treat the hepatitis infections you got as a result of Epstein-Barr, and successfully so. But it also had a hidden side effect, one that would have never been picked up by the PMDA or FDA because it didn't show itself until the patient came into contact with another virus later in life."

"The zombie virus," Katsuki said.

"Yes. Shigaraki's goal was never to help people, it was only ever to help himself," Toshinori replied. "And what he wanted, more than anything, was to find the key to immortality. He believed the answer to that lay in changing the hormonal make-up of the body. He created a virus that would attack the endocrine system, one that would make the essential hormone construction of the body entirely unrecognisable. The virus allowed for the test subject to continue functioning, albeit in a very basic way, after death. Provided that the brain was still intact."

"So, why did he treat a load of kids with that other drug?" Kaminari asked, confused.

"Because despite everything he couldn't deconstruct the zombie virus and alter it so that the test subject retained awareness and could be in any way comparable to their pre-infected state. Instead of changing the virus, he needed to change the test subject. And after those fifteen years of studies he fine-tuned the IFN until he ended up with what he believed to be the solution."

"The final round of drugs," Hawks breathed.

"The one Izuku was given," Inko said, her eyes sparkling with unspilled tears, and her face

reddening in a way that was so familiar to Katsuki that it tugged at his heart again. “Why didn’t you tell me? Yagi, it’s been a *year*.”

“I know,” Toshinori replied softly, before he got to his feet and walked up to her. “At the start, when I came to find you to bring you to UA I hoped that young Midoriya would be with you. When he wasn’t I-” he sighed, his deep-set eyes also starting to look a little wet. “I didn’t see the sense in hurting you.”

Inko shook her head. “And when Izuku came back? When my son, who was part of some *experiment*, came home and put himself into the arms of the maniac that did that to him, you didn’t think to warn me?”

“At the time, it was my belief that Izuku was safe,” Toshinori replied. “He was the only one of the children that hadn’t been bitten or infected; he was far too precious to Shigaraki in that regard. In my eyes, Izuku was just about the safest person at UA, and telling you anything might have put you in danger.”

“And what about now?” Inko spat, still shaking her head in disbelief. “What happens to my son *now*?”

“I’ll find him,” Katsuki said, and Inko looked around at him, as if seeing him for the first time. Her eyes passed over his face, looking up to his hair, before her mouth dropped in a soft *‘o’* of recognition.

“Katsuki?”

Katsuki blinked, taken aback. He knew that Izuku had found out from his mother that the two of them played together as children, but he was not expecting Inko, particularly in the physical state he was in, to recognise him.

“Yeh,” he replied. “Sorry, I, uh… I don’t remember you, though. I don’t remember anything about that time, honestly.”

“The amnesia was a common side-effect,” Toshinori explained. “It affected some more than others, but I believe that it was especially prominent in the version of the drug that you and Izuku were given, as Hawks seems to remember his sickness.”

“I remembered enough,” Hawks confirmed.

“I’m sorry that I kept all of you in the dark,” Toshinori said. “It was for Izuku’s safety as much as anything. I don’t know how the zombies got lose from the basement, and I haven’t been able to contact Aizawa since this all happened. But I do believe that Izuku is in danger now. Shigaraki will have been able to figure out what I have, I’m certain of it.”

“Figure out what?” Katsuki demanded, and Toshinori glanced around the room, before tilting his head at Katsuki apologetically.

“*That*, I cannot say here. But I hope that, given the nature of your relationship with young Midoriya, you may be able to figure out my presumption.”

Katsuki's jaw tensed, and he glanced at Inko who looked just about as frustrated as he felt.

"Well, as for Shigaraki," Hawks piped up, "you don't need to worry about him anymore. He's dead."

"What?" Toshinori gaped.

"His nephew? The nomu he kept down in the basement with him? Well, he woke up, and killed him, and released hundreds of zombies into UA. And not only did little Shigaraki manage to capture Midoriya, if what Todoroki said was right-" Hawks jabbed his thumb at Shouto, "-then he had Overhaul helping him."

"Overhaul?" Toshinori asked. "He's working *with* Tomura?"

"And that's shitty for us for two reasons," Katsuki interupted, raising his hand to count down the points. "First, Overhaul is the only one of the nomu capable of controlling so many zombies, and we have no idea where the hell he is. Secondly, Aizawa was bit and is currently bleeding out in the damn basement ready to lock the zombies down there with him, but the only one who can get them down there is the guy who helped release them in the first place."

"Ok, sorry to interrupt," Kaminari said, holding up his hand. "But do we know why this Overhaul guy would be helping Shigaraki?"

"Coz he was locked up just like the rest of the nomu," Katsuki replied. "Change of leadership, kill off all the people responsible for what happened to him and those loyal to them? Shigaraki gave him the option, and he took it."

"The armoury," Toshinori said suddenly. "Overhaul is incredibly powerful. Last estimations he was able to control close to two thousand zombies and there are only around nine hundred in the basement of the labs, kept there for research. He could easily split those numbers between keeping the civilians inside of the dorms and taking ownership of the weapons in the campus."

"That sure sounds like Shigaraki's m.o," Katsuki said grimly. "He'll want this place, why the hell would he give it up? I'd bet any money that taking Izuku isn't part of some grand scheme, he's just furious that we outsmarted him and probably using him to draw us out."

"Cold as it sounds, he won't kill him either," Kirishima said darkly. "He'd want us to watch."

"Oh my god," Inko whimpered, swaying on the spot. Toshinori reached out and steadied here.

"As damn insightful as this has all been, I can't hang around here any longer," Katsuki announced. "Dog Eyes only has so much time left, and without Overhaul we're pretty much out of options. I'm gonna go to the barracks. Hawks, Todoroki, you're with me if you're still up for it. The rest of you, stay here and protect one another."

"How are you going to get there?" Kirishima asked.

Katsuki approached the only window in the common area of the teachers' dormitory, pulling up the blinds and looking down. He could make the jump, but with Shouto possibly still having a concussion, it wasn't worth the risk of further injury and twisted ankles. They'd need a rope or

sheets to ease their way down, but getting outside wasn't Katsuki's biggest concern. No, the most pressing issue was the zombies filing around the outside of the building, some still outside the fences and others prowling the grounds. All it took was one zombie spotting them, and the entire herd could come running.

"We need a distraction," Katsuki said. "Something to draw the zombies away long enough for us to get out and over the fence."

"What if we drew them here?" Mina asked, peering out beside him. "Have the zombies group together under the window so you can get out through the main door?"

"That's a hell of a risk," Hawks said. "The dorm could be crawling with zombies by now, certainly the lower level."

"So, why don't we go up?" Shouto offered. "Two floors up we can cross between all three buildings. We head to the one closest to the barracks and furthest from here, whilst you guys keep drawing them this side. Then, we drop down and climb the fence."

"That still sounds really risky-" Kirishima started, but Katsuki spoke over him as he grabbed a throw blanket from the couch.

"It'll do. Mrs. Midorya, we need sheets, blankets, anything thin but strong enough we can tie together to make a rope."

"I'll grab some from my room," Inko replied, still looking a little dazed.

"Don't you think I should come with you?" Toshinori said, taking a step forward. "This is in part my doing, for letting it all go on so long."

"No," Katsuki snapped. "Look, Izuku's already lost one of his teachers today; he doesn't need to lose another. Besides, don't you gotta protect his mum?"

Toshinori's throat bobbed, looking up at Inko as she returned to the room, sheets in hand.

"Right, but-" Toshinori hesitated, glancing at the rest of the room before taking Katsuki's shoulder and pulling him aside. "I don't need to explain to you how important it is to find young Midoriya," he whispered. "If he's truly immune, then he could be the key to saving everyone."

Katsuki pulled away, fixing Toshinori with a cold glare.

"You really can't quit, can you?"

He didn't wait for Toshinori's answer before heading back to the rest of the room, where they were busy tying the sheets together. Mina and Kirishima were already at the window and hollering, trying to get the zombies attention.

"Best way to get as many of them over here as possible is to kill a bunch," Katsuki said. Kaminari shot him a wry look.

"You got any hand grenades on you? Might make this a bit easier."

“No grenades but…” Katsuki looked around the room. “Hey, you got any alcohol round here? Lighters, matches, shit like that?”

“I have alcohol rub in my room,” one of the women piped up.

“We’re all nurses,” Inko said. “I’m sure we can find something.”

“Great, grab as much as you’ve got.”

Trying not to think too much over how much time they had wasted, and were about to waste, Katsuki set to work tearing shreds from the sheets, taking the bottles offered to him and stuffing the material inside of the nozzles. Inko handed him a box of matches from one of the kitchen drawers, and Katsuki went back to the window.

Kirishima and Mina had managed to get the attention of a small group, with more and more zombies peeling off and making their way around to see what was going on.

“Wanna aim for the fence, not too close; last thing we want is to start a fire in the dorms.” Katsuki lit a match, holding it against the fabric until the threads caught. He took a moment to aim before throwing the bottle as far as he could, hitting a zombie on the other side of the fence. The first didn’t catch, only a weak bloom of fire coming from the zombie’s chest. But Katsuki was already aiming and throwing his next, and this time the zombie burst into flames.

It was enough to grab the attention of other zombies, turning from where they were pressed against the wall and beginning to make their way towards the flames. Katsuki threw another bottle, catching some of the zombies closest to the fire, and just like that it began to spread among them, the smell already so putrid and intense.

“Well, that should do it,” Kirishima laughed.

“Let’s hope. Keep at it; draw as many of them over here as you can.”

“Here.” Katsuki looked up as Hawks handed him one of the long kitchen knives. “I know we want to avoid killing them if we can, but it’s better to have something on hand, right?”

Katsuki nodded, dropping the weapon into the deep side pocket of his jumpsuit, looking up as Shouto picked out a knife and slid it into his belt.

Toshinori and Kaminari were busy pulling the furniture away from the doorway, and together Katsuki, Shouto and Hawks headed to the door.

“You sure you’re good for this?” Katsuki asked Shouto just as he reached for the lock. “You were unconscious twenty minutes ago.”

“I’m fine,” Shouto assured him. “You ready?”

“Please be careful,” Mina called.

“Yeh, you can’t keep cheating death, man,” Kaminari laughed, voice cracking nervously.

Katsuki nodded, his jaw clenching. Shouto held up three fingers, counting down slowly, before unlocking the door and carefully pulling it open, as the three of them peered out into the hall.

The coast seemed clear. There were no zombies outside, and no bodies or blood either, making it clear that the zombies likely hadn't gone up this far yet. It was strange, especially knowing that people definitely fled from the lower floors, and not quietly.

"Well, I say we take advantage of this," Hawks muttered. Katsuki nodded in agreement, and with one last glance back at his friends, he stepped through the door. It was shut behind them, the sound of the lock turning hitting him with some degree of finality, before Shouto took the lead.

Katsuki could hear people inside the rooms, wails and sobs, as well as the occasional scream from the lower levels, but thankfully there wasn't anyone in the hallways of the dorms as people elected to keep themselves hidden. Katsuki checked the windows as they went, reassuring himself that the zombies outside were still moving in the direction that the fire had drawn them. It didn't take them long to reach the first walkway between the buildings, and outside the smell and sounds coming from the herd came into sharp focus. Katsuki looked down towards the front of the dorm; many of the guards were clearly dead, some crushed beneath the weight of the fence when it finally came down, areas where the zombies swarmed still around the bodies, tearing them apart. It had been a massacre, no doubt about that, and Katsuki wondered just how many people died already.

"Keep going," Shouto said, voice low and deliberately keeping his eyes forward.

Not too long after, they found themselves in the third building, and began testing for doors that would open. Eventually, they found an abandoned room, it's walls decorated with photographs and sketches, kept studiously neat. Katsuki wasted no time opening the blinds and looking out of the window down to the ground below them.

There was two zombies down there, one dragging itself along the wall, a dark foul smear in the grass behind it, and another crawling along the ground with its hands, it's body missing from the waist down. With both zombies weakened Katsuki wasn't worried about them catching them, but that didn't mean that they wouldn't draw more zombies to them.

"We're going to have to risk it," he said, unwrapping the sheets from his shoulder and tying an end to one of the legs of the wooden bed frame.

Hawks opened the window as quietly as he could, taking another look around before nodding back at Katsuki. Taking a moment to double check that the sheets were tightly secured, Katsuki threw the remainder out of the window, relieved that it was just long enough, leaving them maybe only three or four feet for them to freefall.

"I'll go first," Katsuki said. "At the very least I can maybe stop a few of them if they come for us and give you both a chance to get over the fence."

"What do we do about them?" Shouto asked, pointing at the two zombies below.

"Hope they don't catch up," Katsuki replied, before climbing over the windowsill and beginning to ease himself down onto the ground.

From his position suspended against the wall, he could get a much better look at the grounds around him. There were still a lot of zombies on this side of the building, but they were far enough away that Katsuki hoped, if they didn't make a sound, none of them would notice him. The zombies below hadn't spotted him yet either, and when he dropped the last few feet to the ground, the standing zombie didn't look around at him, too focused on getting to the rest of the herd.

He looked up, nodding and gesturing for Shouto and Hawks to join him. When they both touched down, miraculously it was only the zombie dragging its torso across the grass that had noticed them. It was fresh; face still very human despite the chunks bitten out of it, and its eyes rolled wildly.

"Wait," Shouto hissed. "Thats got to be one of the guards."

"I didn't know they could turn that fast," Hawks muttered.

"It doesn't matter," Katsuki said. "Leave it, before any of the others catch on."

"Hold up."

Shouto darted towards the zombie, keeping his body low, and Katsuki threw his hands into the air in frustration.

"*What are you doing?"* he whispered furiously, glancing behind him. The zombie that had been propping itself up on the wall was beginning to turn back to them, and angrily he slapped his palm against Hawks' arm and gestured for him to follow him to the fence.

"Just climb," he said.

"But what about Todoroki?"

Shouto, to Katsuki complete indignation, seemed to be wrestling with the zombie. After a short struggle he fell backwards onto his ass with something held against his chest. Katsuki was about to run towards him, when Shouto climbed to his feet and held his prize out triumphantly.

"We might need it," Shouto mouthed, before hooking the strap of the rifle over his shoulders. Katsuki made a wild, furious gesture like he wanted to stangle him, before starting to climb the fence, and the three of them made it over.

They kept close to the trees of lining the outside of the campus, before running back to the small park area they had cut through to get to the dormitories to begin with. The zombies were now tightly located around the dorms, either drawn by the fire or swarming the main entrances, but for the most part they seemed still, meandering as if without any real sense of purpose.

"Something seems off with them," he muttered to Hawks, who nodded in agreement.

"Toshinori said Overhaul was good at controlling them now," he replied. "Hell, with the guards taken out maybe all he wants now is to keep everyone inside."

Katsuki hummed in acknowledgement, when suddenly Shouto was tapping him on the arm to grab his attention.

“What?”

“Uh, do we know this person?”

Katsuki and Hawks turned in the direction that Shouto was pointing, and sure enough a figure was waving furiously at them, stepping out from behind a tree.

“Mirko!” Hawks cried in relief. “You didn’t make it to the dorms, after all. What the hell happened? Where’s Fat?”

Mirko jogged up to meet them, breathing hard and wiping her hand across her face. There was blood spattered over her jumpsuit and face, a cut through her cheek and into her ear, dirt and leaves stuck to her hair.

“We were ambushed,” she explained. “All three of us. It’s like the zombies were just fucking waiting for us in the woods, a group of ‘em came right for us.”

“All of you?” Hawks asked, eyes darting around to inspect the trees behind her. “Where’s Fat? Where’s *Overhaul*?”

Mirko inhaled a stuttering breath, her throat bobbing.

“Fat… he didn’t make it. I tried pulling the zombies off him but it was like-” she shook her head furiously, her hands shaking. “Fuck, it was like some kinda frenzy, they were all over him, he was buried beneath them. When they came for me I just… I ran.”

“Shit,” Hawks breathed. “Damnit. Fat.”

“And Overhaul?” Katsuki asked. Mirko shook her head.

“I have no idea. We were separated, and I haven’t been able to find him since, but I mean they must have gotten him, right? Or he’d have just stopped them from killing Fat.”

“Actually, we think maybe Overhaul has something to do with all this,” Hawks said grimly. Mirko’s eyes widened.

“What?”

“There’s another nomu,” Hawks explained. “Kept secret from the rest of us. He broke out and has probably been communicating with Overhaul-”

“We don’t have time to go through all this again!” Katsuki snapped, agitated. “Explanations can fucking wait, what matters is we find Izuku before it’s too damn late!”

“Midoriya?” Mirko asked. “Well, shit, I saw him with some guy like fifteen minutes ago, headed that way-” she pointed in the direction of the main gate.

“And you didn’t go after him?” Katsuki cried incredulosusly.

“There were zombies all over the place!” Mirko shot back. “I couldn’t have followed him if I wanted to! Why the hell do you think I’m out here looking for your ass?”

“C’mon,” Katsuki growled. “If Shigaraki has gone this way, let’s fucking hope that Overhaul ain’t far behind.”

Izuku stumbled on the torn up turf below him, his ears ringing and his stomach churning as the sounds of the gunfire stopped and the screaming began. Tomura had a focused look on his face and he continued to drag Izuku through the trees, ceaselessly marching towards his goal, indifferent to the suffering all around him that he was the cause of.

“The people that live here are innocent,” Izuku said, thinking of his mother and his friends, all of them likely trapped inside of the dorms as the zombies fought their way in. “They’re not part of this, or what happened to you.”

Tomura ignored him. He’d barely spoken since they had left Todoroki behind, a look of concentration on his face the entire time. Izuku wondered if maybe he was communicating with Overhaul, using whatever kind of telepathic link there was between the two of them, but when he asked Tomura had just sneered at him and tightened his grip on Izuku’s wrist enough for it to burn. For someone who had been so chatty not long ago, Tomura was doing a remarkable job now of keeping Izuku entirely in the dark.

But Izuku knew UA, and had been able to piece together early on that they were headed to the main gate to the campus. Anxiety ran high and he considered all of the reasons Tomura would want to go there, of all places, and his thoughts kept circling back to the same possibility; Tomura was planning on opening the gates. It wasn’t enough that the zombies from the basement were slowly killing their way through everyone that lived here, Tomura wanted to bring the entire university to the ground.

More sounds grabbed Izuku’s attention as they drew close to the main gates. It was a sickening sound, and Izuku couldn’t think of the words to do it justice beyond *wet* and *ominous*. Things compressing, and bodies sliding, and when he saw the herd of zombies directy in front of them, he realised that it was the sound of so many corpses huddled together, barely moving yet shifting all the same.

“You made it, at last.”

Izuku looked round, and there, leaning against a tree, was Overhaul. His face was drawn tight, with sweat dripping down from his temple, and for a moment Izuku wondered if he was injured before it dawned on him that the mental exertion of controlling so many zombies for so long must be starting to catch up with him.

“So, you’re Overhaul,” Tomura said, looking him up and down, his eyes lingering on his shoulders and his sleeves hanging lose and empty. “My uncle take your arms?”

Overhaul frowned.

“There are still guards in the barracks,” he said, ignoring the question. “I got these zombies surrounding them, and for now they’ve been smart enough not to start shooting.”

“The ones by the dorms?” Tomura asked.

“Less smart.”

“Sounded like,” Tomura remarked. “Any idea which guards are left?” Overhaul shook his head.

“Only one I know by name is Mic. High ranking. I think I heard him yelling in there when this all went down, but other than that I couldn’t tell you. He’s not worth keeping, he’s too loyal to Aizawa.”

“None of them are worth keeping,” Tomura said coldly, and Overhaul frowned again. Izuku struggled against Tomura’s grip again, and for the first time Overhaul looked at him.

“Why is he here?”

“Overhaul, he’s not what you think,” Izuku said. “Whatever he’s told you-”

“He’s mostly here for my entertainment at his point,” Tomura interrupted, before reaching and slapping Izuku hard around the face, sending him sprawling to the ground. “He runs, you send a zombie after him.”

Overhaul nodded, still looking at Izuku where he lay on the ground, head ringing from the force of the slap.

“Send the zombies in,” Tomura said. “Wipe out whoever is left in the barracks.”

“Are you sure?” Overhaul asked. “There’s people in there that might be useful. Once we tell them that it was your uncle who started the virus and set the zombies lose on them, we’ll still want people who know how to use a gun.”

“I don’t trust them,” Tomura snapped, glaring back at him. “And neither should you.”

“Overhaul, don’t do it,” Izuku gasped, climbing to his feet. “I know your angry about how Shigaraki treated you, but he’s the one that started all of this, not them-” he pointed to the barracks. “And not the people back in the dorms. They’re all innocent in this!”

“You have no idea what that words means,” Overhaul replied quietly, his expression morose and pained.

“I know that those people don’t deserve to die!” Izuku cried.

Tomura remained silent, looking between the two of them with his head tilted to the side and raising his brow as if to ask ‘*what’s it gonna be?’*

“Most of the people in the dorms will survive,” Overhaul finally said. Before he turned his head in the direction of the zombies surrounding the barracks. “*Eat*.”

Izuku shut his eyes tight, shaking his head furiously as the zombies charged in unison, never feeling more powerless in his life as he heard the gunfire and the screams began. Tomura, however, seemed

satisfied with Overhaul's decision, before grabbing Izuku and dragging him forward. Izuku yelled, punching and kicking at all of Tomura that was in reach, but Tomura barely flinched, wrestling him into submission and grabbing him by the scalp.

"Let's go."

"Where are we going?" Overhaul asked. "If Shigaraki and Aizawa are dead, shouldn't we be taking this place already?"

"I've got something personal to take care of first. Bakugou, you can sense him, right?"

Izuku's heart jolted in his chest.

"I told you, I'm controlling too many right now," Overhaul said. "I can't just pick out individuals-"

"So try harder," Tomura snapped.

Tomura boldly marched behind the herd of a hundred or so zombies that were bullying their way into the barracks, the gunfire growing more sporadic and the screams louder with every passing moment. Izuku watched in horror as one of the guards tried to escape, shooting wildly before three zombies threw themselves onto him, ripping into him even as they were shot up by the body beneath them.

"Help them," he croaked, looking back at Overhaul, but he kept his head down, not looking at the carnage as he followed Shigaraki towards the main gate.

The noise and the bloodshed inside of the UA had riled up the zombies outside, the thundering sound of their bodies stomping and thumping against the walls enough to make the ground shake. The gates were well reinforced, hopefully more than capable of holding against the weight of the zombies that pressed against it, but Izuku could see the mashed up bodies oozing through the slots in the outermost gate.

When they reached it, Izuku felt himself thrown forward. Tomura pushed him roughly onto the ground. He coughed, looking up with bleary eyes as his wrist was lifted, and something cold and metal snapped around it.

"What-"

"Just a souvenir from my uncle," Tomura hissed coldly, before he attached the other side of the handcuffs to the innermost bars of the gate. Izuku's blood ran cold, looking back over his shoulder, realising that even if Tomura decided to only open the outermost gates of the UA, the zombies would pile in and there'd be no way for Izuku to escape as the zombies pawed at him through the bars.

"I don't see the point in this," Overhaul said, beginning to look increasingly more on edge as the time progressed. "We want the people here to think we *saved* them, right?"

"And we will," Tomura growled. "But Bakugou and the rest need to be taken care of, first. They'll be a problem. Have you found him, yet?"

“No, but-” Overhaul’s face tensed up. “Something happened over by the dorms. I don’t know what, but they’re moving strangely.”

“So, then he’s on his way,” Tomura said confidently, a cruel smile twisting his lips, he looked across at the barracks, which had now fallen entirely silent. “Keep a handful here, in case we need them, but it’s probably time to send the zombies back to the campus to clean up whatever researchers are left.”

“You really think anyone here is going to believe that you *saved* them?” Izuku spat, tugging fruitlessly against the handcuffs around his wrist. “The other nomu, you know none of them are going to buy this.”

Overhaul shook his head, turning his back to Izuku as if to shut him out. His head hung limp, exhaustion obvious in the way that he held himself, but as Tomura asked the majority of the zombies by the barracks began to shuffle away, back in the direction of the university building.

“He’s done this before!” Izuku yelled. “He and his gang left people starving in Tokyo! He used a herd of zombie against me and my friends! Tomura isn’t on your side, Overhaul, and if he’s happy to get rid of everyone else who’s to say you’re not next?”

“And what was the other option?” Overhaul spat back, turning on him. “Let Shigaraki keep us locked up forever? Let them keep experimenting on me and loading me up with drugs that left parts of my body *rotting*?”

“We’re on the same page, there,” Izuku insisted. “You think I liked what they were doing to you? How they kept Kacchan imprisoned? But we had a plan, Aizawa and I, to kill Shigaraki and stop all of it from happening!”

“And what good was your plan?” Overhaul said, nodding his head at Tomura. “*He* killed Shigaraki, not you.”

“So, why isn’t it over?” Izuku countered, desperately. “Shigaraki’s dead, there’s no one left to imprison you! But people are going to keep dying because Tomura wants revenge.”

Overhaul slowly lifted his head, looking up at Tomura. His gaze was unfocused, Izuku could see that it was probably only a matter of time before exhaustion got the better of him, and that only scared Izuku more.

“Maybe the kid’s right,” Overhaul said, with a heavy sigh. “I can’t control the zombies forever.”

“What are you doing?” Tomura demanded.

“I’m sending them back to the basement. Whatever it is you got planned for the kid, it wasn’t part of our agreement.”

“Our agreement was I kill my uncle and you help me take this place, and that can’t happen whilst Bakugou and rest are still alive.”

“Not my problem,” Overhaul said darkly, turning his back and beginning to walk away. “You do what you gotta do.”

Izuku felt himself sag in relief. It was enough. Probably not enough to save himself, but with the zombies in retreat and Overhaul no longer doing everything Tomura asked of him, his mother and his friends would be ok. He sat himself up straight again, shifting on his spot on the floor and glared up at Tomura.

“So, what now?”

Tomura’s expression was cold and bitter as he watched Overhaul leave, the zombies that had remained at the barracks now starting to wander after him. Even Tomura knew that the man was nigh on untouchable at this point, not whilst he was the only one who could stop the zombies lose at UA, and his lip curled furiously.

“Nothing changes. UA still belongs to me, and when people see the zombies retreat and I tell them that the man responsible for creating them is dead it’ll be easy to convince them to follow me. Even if your friends do run their mouths about me, who’s going to believe them? Why would they, when they find out that they were traitors, helping to smuggle in one of Shigaraki’s top researchers and most valued test subject.”

“What?”

Tomura grinned, dropping to his haunches in front of him.

“You, of course. I’ll tell them how you personally performed on me, how you and Bakugou deliberately fed me and my group to zombies before bringing me here. How you and Aizawa tried to have me killed when you found out that I was going to bring an end to my uncle’s great zombie experiment.”

“No one will believe you,” Izuku hissed, and Tomura shrugged.

“I think I fancy my chances on this one. Anyone with any authority who could argue otherwise is dead. I’ve heard so much more than you realise whilst imprisoned, my uncle likes to talk. The great Professor Toshinori? Well, he’s having an affair with the mother of Shigaraki’s key researcher. He’s been working side-by-side with my uncle for years. No one is going to trust anything that he says now. And your friends? UA took them in, after all, despite having its gates shut for months. Payment for bringing you to them. As for the nomu? Without treatment they’ll turn. They’ll say whatever I tell them to.”

“You’ll never get the chance,” Izuku growled, leaning forward as far as he could so that he could be eye-to-eye with Tomura. “Because you’re not taking into account that Kacchan is going to kill you. All these grand plans are pointless, because I’m infected-” he gestured to his mouth, where Tomura’s blood still stained his jaw. “So now he’s got nothing to lose.”

Tomura tilted his head, still smiling.

“I didn’t come into this thinking that I wouldn’t have to fight. He wants to kill me? *Good.* In fact, I relish the opportunity to finally kill him with my own two hands.”

“Fuck you.”

Tomura got back to his feet, and looked over his shoulder. His expression froze for a heartbeat, before he grinned all the more broadly.

“Looks like I don’t have to wait.”

Izuku’s heart lurched in his chest, his throat tightening when he saw the small group of people clearing the treeline, the bright orange of their jumpsuits in contrast with the churned up ground.

“*Kacchan.*”

Overhaul had stopped dead in his tracks, the zombies that had been with him following his lead as he and Kacchan’s small group found themselves in a stand off. Shouto was with them, and Izuku could have cried in relief at that, after fearing that the zombies would find him before anyone else could, and he held a gun up to his chest, aiming it directly at Overhaul. Kacchan looked up, and their eyes met.

“Don’t hurt Overhaul!” Izuku yelled. “He’s sending the zombies back!”

“Is that true?”

Izuku could just hear what Hawks said from this distance, which meant that Tomura could follow the conversation, too. Overhaul glanced back over his shoulder, before nodding.

“It’s true. I wanted Shigaraki and Aizawa dead, and they’re dead. You do whatever you want with him.”

Tomura growled low in his throat.

“You haven’t got any allies,” Izuku said. “So just give it up. You can’t fight all of them.”

“No,” Tomura said, before leaving Izuku’s side and marching towards the small hut that held the controls for the main gates. “But these can.”

Izuku heard yelling, followed by the scream of metal on metal, twisting around in horror as the outer gates began to open. The zombies stacked against the gate immediately began to fall through, cascading in a pile of flesh. He looked back at Tomura, watching as he reached for the controls to the second gate; the gate that Izuku was currently handcuffed to.

A series of shots rung out, Tomura yelling and throwing himself back inside of the hut, as smoke started to rise from the console. The outer gate stopped, only opened by a distance of three or so feet, wide enough that the zombies could pour through, but keeping them bottlenecked in place. It was enough to stop the zombies from getting into UA, but now Izuku was trapped here, and the zombies were approaching fast.

“Todoroki!”

Izuku heard Kacchan yelling, and two more shots fired in Tomura’s direction before Shouto swore loudly.

“I’m out!”

Breathing heavy, Izuku turned his attention back to the cuffs. A zombie had already managed to crawl towards him, its hand reaching through the bars to snatch at his clothes.

“Damnit, *damnit*,” Izuku swore, gripping hold of his hoody and pulling it out of the zombies grasp. If he scooted back far enough, the zombies couldn’t reach his body or his face, but his hand was still dangerously close to the gnashing teeth of the zombies beginning to crowd in front of him.

“Izuku!”

He looked around just as Kacchan fell to the ground beside him, grabbing at the cuffs.

“Kacchan,” Izuku sighed in relief. “You’re awake.”

“Yeh, yeh, don’t ask me how,” Kacchan replied, pulling a knife from his pocket and slotting the tip between one of the links to the cuffs. “Fucking hell, Deku, if anyone could get their ass cuffed to a fucking fence-”

Izuku laughed, watching as Kacchan twisted the knife, trying to break the link. The blade bent at the base, giving way long before the metal did, and Kacchan swore.

“Overhaul!” he yelled. “Can you stop these things?”

But Overhaul was close to his limit, collapsed on the ground, the zombies closest to him hovering and shifting in a way that made Izuku uncomfortable. Hawks was supporting him, and he shook his head as Overhaul only panted in response.

“If Overhaul loses control, it’ll be over for everyone,” Izuku said.

“I can control them. *Some*,” Kacchan snapped, now grabbing hold of the chain with his hands and wrenching. “God fucking *damnit!*”

A zombie had manged to grab hold of Izuku’s hand, Izuku twisting until it only had hold of his little finger. Izuku grabbed the fallen knife from the ground, and hacked at the zombies wrist, but not quickly enough to prevent it from tugging, his finger cracking loudly. Izuku cried out in pain as it broke.

“*Shit shit shit*,” Kacchan panted, looking perhaps more frantic than Izuku had ever seen him.

“Tomura,” Izuku grunted, trying to ignore the throbbing in his hand. “He probably has a key! Did Shouto get him?”

Kacchan looked up, eyes darting to where Tomura had last been, but the hut was empty.

“Where the hell-”

“Todoroki!”

Izuku swung around at the sound of Hawks yelling, and watched as a zombie launched itself at Shouto. Overhaul was beginning to lose control, and with a frustrated yell Shouto was forced to fall

back, pulling a knife from his waistband and stabbing the zombie. One by one the zombies hovering began to move, leaving Hawks, Mirko and Shouto to surround Overhaul and fight each zombie that approached.

“You gotta help them,” Izuku said, teeth grit together as another zombie began to work its arm through the bars. “I’ll be fine, we can’t lose Overhaul!”

“Like hell am I leaving you!” Kacchan growled, redoubling his efforts with the chains.

“Kacchan!”

Kacchan looked up, eyes wide with fear and desperation.

“We are *not* losing our friends!” Izuku yelled. “Not after all this!”

Kacchan reached out, his hand grabbing Izuku’s jaw and pulling their faces close together.

“I’d let the whole fucking world burn for you,” Kacchan breathed.

“I know. But it isn’t burning just yet.”

Kacchan whined deep in his chest, before he pressed the knife back into Izuku’s hand and got to his feet, sprinting back towards Overhaul and the others. Izuku had faith in Kacchan’s abilities to defend them, there wasn’t anyone else in the world better at fighting zombies than him, and he turned his attention back to the zombies at the gate.

Tomura, it seemed, had decided to make a run for it, likely taking the key with him. Izuku looked around, searching the ground and anything near him for something that he could use to unpick the lock, but there was nothing. He felt another of his fingers get hooked in the claw of a zombie, and stabbed at the things wrist. By now, the zombies were in a complete frenzy; they were pressing up against each other, parts of their bodies being squeezed through the bars, faces pressed against those closest to Izuku’s hand, teeth snapping at the metal. It was a horrific sight, dead eyes oozing from sockets, teeth cracking against the force, and if Izuku didn’t do something the sheer strength of the number of zombies there could probably pull him right back against the bars.

He looked down at the knife, bent as it was, then up at his hand, briefly wondering whether he would be able to stay conscious long enough to cut his entire hand off. But if he blacked out for even a moment and fell onto the bars it would be over for him. He grit his teeth and tugged again, as hard as he could, even daring to press his feet against the bar for a moment to get better leverage. The zombies, however, were quick to grab at him, and he shuffled away as quickly as he could, panting hard. If he couldn’t cut off his hand… there was another way.

He pulled the cuff as far down his arm as it could go, and without giving himself a moment to think, grabbed hold of the base of his thumb and yanked. The pain was immediate and be bit his lip to hold back the scream, but the distinct lack of a *pop* made Izuku realised he hadn’t quite succeeded in dislocating his thumb.

“Gah!”

He huffed in three quick breaths, before grabbing his thumb and yanking again, with as much force

as he could put behind it. The sound shot out like a gunshot, and he all but sagged with relief when he looked down to see his thumb hanging lose and useless.

“Ok, ok,” he breathed, grabbing the cuff and compressing his hand at the same time, the sweat and the zombie blood on his hand working as lubrication.

“That was a waste of time.”

Izuku twisted around, but he wasn’t quick enough to defend himself from the kick that came, hitting him in the jaw and knocking him to the ground. Gasping he looked up to see Tomura looming over him, his expression murderous. Shouto had managed to hit him; there was a fresh gunshot wound on his chest and two in his gut, covering his previously crisp shirt with blood. But he seemed hardly to notice, and reached out to grab Izuku by the throat and threw him against the metal bars.

Izuku’s eyes widened, filled with a cold horror as he felt the fingernails scratch down his back and the teeth scrape against his scalp.

“Now you get to find out how this feels,” Tomura hissed, face close to Izuku’s. Izuku could only see deep, cold red as he felt the fingers wrap around his cheek. A jaw embedding itself deep into his arm, the screams so very far away now.

When the heat hit his face, he was sure at first that it was his own blood; the zombies breaking his skull in two and tearing the flesh away, but then he was left blinking up at a blue sky as the ground beneath him gave way. He fell, face first onto the dirt, and a sharp pain in his wrist followed. For a moment he lay there, dizzy and unfocused, before pulling both his arms beneath him and pushing himself up, noticing with detached interest how his thumb hung at an angle that shouldn’t really be possible.

“Izuku!”

He blinked, eyes drifting to his right where Tomura now lay, eyes wide and unblinking, a large hole in the side of his face.

“Wha-”

He looked around once more, before spotting a man who, at first, he didn’t recognise. Long blond hair, and an arguably ridiculous looking moustache looking up over a vibrant yellow rifle.

“*DJ Punch?*” Izuku muttered, confused, before someone was grabbing his shoulders, and dragging his attention away.

“Izuku,” Kacchan said, eyes wide, hands roving across Izuku’s face, his arms, cupping the back of his neck. “*Fuck*, baby, you’re ok, you’re gonna be ok.”

Izuku swallowed, looking over at Tomura again, before back at Kacchan.

“Overhaul!” he gasped, everything coming back to him at once. “Is he dead? Did the zombies get him?”

“He’s fine,” Kacchan replied. He was busy unzipping the front of his jumpsuit, using his teeth to tear at one of the sleeves. “Forget about that for now, need you to hold this against your neck-”

“I’m fine!” Izuku interupted but taking the fabric anyway. “We need to get the zombies back in the basement!”

“Ok, well can we fucking do that after I stop you from bleeding out?” Kacchan yelled in frustration.

Izuku slowly became aware of just how hot and wet his back felt, tentatively reaching up behind his right ear, before a terrifying scream filled the air, and he was knocked over again as a weight colliding with he and Kacchan both. There was a tussle, more screaming, something kicking him hard in the chest, and after another moment of blindness he saw Kacchan thrown on his back, long fingers wrapped tightly around his throat.

Tomura’s jaw hung from his face, eyes filled with only hatred as he squeezed, Kacchan kicking his feet and trying to break his grip.

“Mic!” Izuku yelled, but before the man could shoot, Tomura contorted his body and pushed Kacchan between himself and the gun.

Izuku kicked off from the ground. He knew how strong Tomura was, saw how he was even overpowering Kacchan, but there wasn’t a single part of him that was about to accept it. He threw himself on Tomura’s back, wrapping one arm around the front of his throat, and with his busted hand he grabbed Tomura’s broken jaw and tugged. Tomura howled, the pain enough for his grip to slip, and with a pained gasp Kacchan broke free.

Before Kacchan could do anything however, Tomura grabbed Izuku and threw him, sending him several feet through the air, crying out as his shoulder collided hard with the ground.

“Fucker!”

Kacchan punched Tomura hard, dazing him for long enough to grab his face, thumbs pressing against his sockets, but Tomura only reared back, raising his leg and kicking Kacchan in the stomach, throwing him back. Kacchan didn’t have time to pull himself back up before Tomura was once again on him, hand back around his throat, and the other against his chest, thumb pressed above his heart as he twisted and pressed. Kacchan cried out, Izuku sprinting as hard as he could, watching the blood pool on Kacchan’s chest and dribble from his mouth.

“*Stop!*”

Izuku’s voice rang out across the clearing, echoing off the walls, before everything fell still with a dizzying, unsettling silence. Tomura and Kacchan had frozen in place, the latter looking over at Izuku with a stunned expression on his face, and Izuku took advantage of this moment, whatever it was, to kick Tomura as hard as he could in the jaw, knocking him away from Kacchan.

There was a snarl, Tomura, with half his face now a mangled mess, pulling deep welts out of the earth with his finger tips as he tried to get back to Kacchan.

“I said *stop!*” Izuku shouted again, firmly this time, confident in what was going on. His hand

reached for his neck again, feeling the raw flesh, fingers registering that half of his ear was missing.

“I’m infected.”

He remembered then, with a sudden clarity, the night that Kacchan had attacked him and the way he had recoiled when Izuku had begged him to stop.

“I can control nomu whilst I’m infected,” he breathed, looking down at Kacchan who still lay on the ground beside him, just as affected as Tomura was.

“Izuku, Bakugou.”

Izuku looked up, seeing Shouto standing in front of them, blood and guts splattered over his shirt, and a long knife in his hand.

“Do it,” Izuku breathed.

Tomura shut his eyes, and hacked out a low, wet sound that might well have been a laugh, as Shouto twisted a hand into his scalp and, without hesitation, placed the point of the knife against his temple and pressed until the laughter stopped.

Chapter End Notes

It's been a long journey. I had planned to end the story in this chapter, buuuuut as you can see it ended up being a very long chapter at around 17.5k words. So, I'm going to be writing a bit of a longer epilogue that will be posted on Valentine's Day.

Thank you to everyone who has read to this point!

twt / insta / tumblr
#deadicationtwt

Chapter 49: Epilogue

Izuku heaved a heavy sigh, shifting on the uncomfortable wooden chair that he had dragged over to the window, chin propped on the ball of his palm. It was snowing again; only lightly, which was a relief after the sudden snowstorm that hit the day after *Everything Happened*. From his vantage point he could just see the group of people working outdoors, cutting down trees and stripping the lumber into firewood – fuel to cremate the large pile of bodies that had taken days to recover.

Izuku absently picked at the peeling paint on the windowsill with his thumb, eyes following one particular person as they brought an axe down, adding to their growing collection of firewood. Even from a distance and with a hat pulled over his hair, Kacchan was obvious in the crowd, standing with his usual confidence and barking out orders to those around him. He watched as he marched up to Shouto, his two-toned hair a dead giveaway in any crowd, and Kacchan's voice still managed to carry, albeit muffled, as he yelled. A smile tugged at Izuku's lips as he watched them, Kacchan clearly growing more and more frustrated with Shouto about something.

"Izuku, are you hungry?"

He started, peeling his eyes away from his friends outside and looking over to see his mother coming into the room. Just as he had expected, by the morning following his infection, there were no more signs of the virus in his blood, and gone with it was his ability to control the zombies and nomu. He'd had it long enough to be able to help Kacchan and Overhaul corral the zombies back into the basement, but it had come as somewhat of a relief to find that the ability wasn't something that stuck around. Still, whilst he was certainly immune to the zombie virus, he wasn't immune to the effects of blood loss or infection, and he'd been under his mother's strict care and treatment ever since.

"I'm ok," Izuku replied, smiling at her.

"Still feeling nauseous?" Inko asked, brow scrunched with concern. She walked over to him, placing a hand across his forehead.

"A bit," Izuku confessed. "It's just the antibiotics."

Inko hummed before walking over to the sink in the hospital room and washing her hands.

"Let me take a look at it anyway."

Izuku nodded, looking out of the window again. He'd missed the climax of Kacchan and Shouto's argument but noted with some amusement that the two of them were now working as far away from each other as possible.

"I know it's frustrating," Inko said from his side, her voice gentle. "Not being able to help."

Izuku shrugged and turned away from the window. He angled his head so that his mother could remove the bandages from the right side of his neck and cheek, wincing ever so slightly at the sting.

Between the blurred vision in his left eye, the chunk missing from his right ear, and the large bite scars forming on his neck and forearm, he supposed he made for quite the sight these days. He'd been lucky; if the bite on his neck had been any deeper, then, immunity or not, he would have almost certainly bled out in minutes. As it was, despite the minor infection he'd earned from the bite wounds themselves, he'd come away remarkably unscathed.

"It's healing well," Inko said, as she rolled some ointment onto a cotton pad and gently applied it to Izuku's wounds. "And, look at that," she added, taking a step to the side so that she could stand in front of him, "still handsome."

"Mum," Izuku mumbled, feeling his cheeks heat up.

"I'm sure *Kacchan* thinks so," Inko teased, and Izuku felt his smile falter, glancing back towards the window again. "Oh. He's still not been round, huh?"

"I'm sure he's just busy," Izuku replied. "With the storm and everything, plus the people who were bitten, it can't have been easy."

Inko nodded, preparing and applying a fresh bandage to Izuku's wounds. The days immediately following the zombie attacks had been nothing short of nightmarish for the survivors; the number of people who had been killed by the zombies was high, and higher still were those that had been infected during the chaos. It was fortunate that so many people at UA were experienced in the medical field to some capacity, whether as students, practitioners or researchers, and they did all that they could to keep the infected comfortable until their final moments. But not everyone had been so forthcoming with their injuries, and it became essential to have armed guards dotted around the campus to take out the stray zombies that began to stalk the dormitories and grounds, risking yet another outbreak

The atmosphere on the campus had become incredibly tense as a result. Shigaraki was dead, and so was almost everyone else that the people had come to view as seniority. Mic and his surviving soldiers were doing their best to keep the peace, and Professor Toshinori was still notable enough a figure among the faculty to provide some manner of authority. But, as Kirishima noted when he came to update Izuku that very morning, there was an obvious power vacuum at the campus, and if something wasn't done about that soon, it was inevitable that people would stand up to fill it.

Izuku looked back out of the window again, eyes falling on Kacchan. He took charge in almost any situation he was in; that was just his nature. And, as much as Izuku hated to admit it, Kacchan's startling appearance and intimidating attitude *scared* people. After two more people were found out to be nomu when they didn't die from their bites, the existence of the nomu could no longer be kept a secret on the campus, and that Kacchan was also a nomu had become common knowledge. If it came to it, Izuku was sure that Kacchan could become the de facto man-in-charge at the campus. Whether he wanted to be was a whole other matter.

"Tell you what, how about you go and talk to him?" Inko said, and Izuku looked back at her in surprise. "Todoroki, too. Now, I'm not signing you off to cut firewood or do any heavy lifting, but I think you're well enough to not need to be cooped up in here all day."

"Really?" Izuku asked.

"Just make sure you come find me first thing in the morning so I can check your neck again."

“I will,” Izuku said, getting to his feet and hurrying towards the door.

“And make sure you wear a hat!” Inko called after him.

After a brief detour to his room to grab some fresh clothes and a hat, Izuku made his way out of the dorms and started to walk towards the group still working on the mass cremation site. He could see Kacchan and Shouto, each on one end of a large trunk as they carried it down from the thicket, before dropping it with the rest of the wood being prepped for fuel. Shouto looked up as he dusted his hands together, eyes widening in surprise.

“Izuku, you’re all cleared?”

Kacchan looked over, his expression haughty and closed off as he crossed his arms over his chest.

“Finally gonna do some work like the rest of us?” he grunted, though Izuku was relieved to hear the gentle teasing in his tone.

After the immediate aftermath of the zombie attack, Kacchan had barely left his side, hovering and fussing as Izuku’s wounds were treated. But, after the blood test had confirmed that Izuku no longer had the virus the following morning, Kacchan had disappeared. Izuku had seen him, watching him from the hospital window, but he hadn’t once checked in with Izuku in the days that followed, and truthfully, Izuku couldn’t understand what had changed. He looked at Kacchan, but his face betrayed nothing as he stood there, gruff and seemingly disinterested.

“Sort of,” Izuku replied. “I’m allowed to leave the hospital at least.”

“That’s good,” Shouto said. “We’re going to need all the help we can get.”

“How’re you getting on with this?” Izuku asked, eyes drifting over to the bodies laid out as respectfully as they could be along the track.

“As well as we can,” Shouto replied grimly. “We’ve probably got enough wood now, at least. The hardest part is going to be gathering everyone here who wants to be when it’s time for the burning.”

“Yeh,” Izuku breathed, stomach twisting. “Has, uh, there been any word of finding Mr Aizawa?”

“Hawks volunteered to go in there,” Kacchan said. “I told him it was a bad idea, and Iggy Pop agreed.”

“Mic,” Shouto supplied, when Izuku’s face scrunched up in confusion.

“Whatever,” Kacchan snapped. “Point is, we can’t safely get Aizawa’s body without Overhaul, and right now he’s shut down and refusing to speak with anyone.”

“Is Hawks with him?”

“He’s been watching him, yeh.” Kacchan nodded his head, pointing his thumb over his back. “We got Mirko helping us with this; don’t think she wants to be anywhere near Overhaul right now.”

“Can’t say I blame her,” Izuku sighed. “So, is there anything I can do to help here?”

“Sure-” Shouto started, but Kacchan talked over him, stepping forward.

“Abso-fucking-lutely not.”

“Huh?”

“Not having you dragging wood and bodies about,” Kacchan snapped. “Look, we dropped off Shigaraki with the old man yesterday. You’re a nerd; go do nerd shit.”

“But-”

“I ain’t arguing!” Kacchan yelled, already turning his back and beginning to walk away. “Go do something that doesn’t involve opening your damn wounds up!”

Izuku chewed on the inside of his cheek, watching Kacchan as he stalked off, and feeling all the more nauseous for it.

“You ok?” Shouto asked, and Izuku forced a smile onto his face.

“Yeh! I’ll go see Professor Toshinori and see what I can do there.”

“If you’re sure,” Shouto replied, like he didn’t quite believe him.

“‘Course. I’ll catch up with you later, yeh?”

“Alright.”

Kacchan caught his eye one final time, as if he had been looking over his shoulder to check whether Izuku was there or not, before quickly looking away, and feeling disheartened, Izuku made his way over towards the laboratory.

The labs needed work, though there were researchers and civilians busy cleaning the walls and floors, all dressed head-to-toe in PPE as they dealt with the zombie blood still smeared about in places. Izuku nodded his head and smiled at those that acknowledged him, relieved to see Shinsou among them, his tired purple eyes peeking out over a face mask.

“I wondered where you had gotten to,” Shinsou said. “Come to help?”

“Looks like,” Izuku replied. “I’m just going to see Professor Toshinori; do you know where he is?”

“Uh, lower levels, I think. Harvesting room, last I heard.”

“That’s great, thanks, Shinsou.”

“Oi,” Shinsou called, as Izuku started to walk past, “so, is it true? You got bit and nothing happened?”

A few of the other people in the room looked around at that, and Izuku shifted uncomfortably under

the attention.

“Yeh,” he replied. “I guess I’m hoping the Professor has an idea of where we go with that.”

“It’ll feel good to have some direction,” Shinsou said. “Instead of looking at zombie blood all day without anything to show for it.”

“Shigaraki never had us looking for a cure,” Izuku replied. “He’s gone; things will be different now.”

“I hope so, Midoriya.”

“It will,” Izuku promised. Shinsou nodded, and Izuku shot him and the others gathered around them a smile before heading in the direction of the labs. Part of him felt strangely vulnerable now that people knew that there was something different about him. Going on what Kirishima had told him, most people believed that he was a regular nomu like the rest, rather than having an immunity to the virus, and Izuku supposed that was probably safer for him. Being immune painted a target on his chest like he hadn’t considered before; valuable in a way he didn’t appreciate very much. Perhaps, without Shigaraki hindering research like before, there was still a chance that a cure could come from researching the nomu, but it was far more likely that the key to fighting the virus was inside of him. That made him, at least from a researcher's standpoint, just about the most precious person on the campus, and who knows what people might choose to do with that information.

He found the Professor not long later. There was the sound of music coming from the labs, gentle classical tunes that reminded Izuku so strongly of the days when he had been a regular student, visiting the Professor in his off hours to talk his ear off about the latest things he’d learnt in class. Professor Toshinori was humming along, gloves up to his elbows as he sterilised equipment, his back to Izuku as he entered the room.

“Professor?”

Toshinori half jumped, looking over his shoulder before his face broke into a wide grin.

“Young Midoriya! I wasn’t expecting you so soon.”

“Been getting a lot of that,” Izuku replied wryly, rubbing his cheek. “Uh, Kacchan said he dropped Tomura off with you?”

Toshinori sighed heavily.

“Yes, well. No one quite knew what to do with him. It didn’t feel right cremating him with everyone else given he was responsible for their deaths.”

“We could burn him separately,” Izuku suggested.

“Quite right, and we will,” Toshinori assured. “But, this may also be one of the only opportunities we have to see the inner workings of a nomu up close. Certainly, no one feels comfortable using Toyomitsu for the purpose.”

“Who?”

“Oh, the nomu you knew as Fat. His real name was Taishiro Toyomitsu; I believe Takami and Usagiyama, that’s Hawks and Mirko respectively, wished to handle his burial separately. They were, all three, very close.”

“Right,” Izuku said softly. “Of course.”

“Before cremating Tomura Shigaraki I feel like there is a chance that we can learn something from his body, and with no living family to consent, I propose we deal with it as respectfully as possible.”

“But we have me,” Izuku said bluntly. Toshinori’s eyes widened in surprise. “My blood.”

“We do,” the Professor agreed, looking decidedly uncomfortable. “I- look.” He removed his gloves before pulling two chairs out from under the desks and offering one to Izuku. “May we talk?”

Izuku nodded, feeling unsure as he took a seat. Toshinori dragged his chair forward so that he could sit down facing Izuku, his hands steepled together on his lap.

“I don’t want to make the same mistakes that my predecessor did,” Toshinori said softly, peering at Izuku with his shadowy blue eyes. “I truly believe that we may be able to find a vaccine for the virus using the research contained in the basement once we can get down there, and yes, whatever else we may learn from the subjects treated with the IFN all those years ago.”

“But?”

“I don’t want you, or any of the nomu for that matter, feeling pressured into being part of that process. Fighting the virus is important; of course it is, but so is your autonomy.”

“I want to be part of it,” Izuku said firmly. “I want to do everything I can to help, Professor. I wish…” He swallowed. “I wish I could say with any confidence that what happened here will never happen again, but we don’t know that. And I’ve seen enough of this apocalypse to know that bad things don’t just happen because bad people want them to. People make mistakes, even when they’re trying to do the right thing. And there are good people out there; I’ve met them, and I’m only alive now because of them. If there’s even a chance that my blood could change things, I owe it to them to try.”

Toshinori grasped his hands, eyes sparkling with unshed tears, and smiled.

“You are a good man, Izuku Midoriya,” he said. Izuku shrugged, feeling his cheeks warm up. “Regardless,” Toshinori continued wetly, clearing his throat and getting to his feet. “I believe that we should take advantage of having Tomura’s body available to us, as well as your blood.”

Izuku chewed on his lip, watching the Professor as he picked up his old pair of gloves and dropped them in the bin. *‘I can feel it. I can feel all of them… The pain, the hunger. It’s torture.’* Izuku hadn’t been able to get the words that Tomura had said to him out of his head since. He hated the man, for all that he had done him, but Tomura had been a victim all the same. His uncle had used him, had taken his autonomy from him, had treated him as experiment just like all the rest of them.

“No.”

Toshinori looked back at him in surprise.

“No?”

“I don’t think we should use Tomura like that.”

Toshinori didn’t speak for a moment, just looking back at Izuku in contemplative silence, before he took his seat again.

“Are you sure?”

Izuku swallowed, meeting the Professor’s gaze, and nodded firmly.

“I understand that we might learn something from him,” Izuku said quietly. “Believe me, I know that from a researcher's point of view it's stupid not to. But… Shigaraki used him, too. He… he told me that he was connected to the infected, that he could feel what they felt, that it was torture to him. He did bad things; so many people I loved are gone because of him. But his uncle treated him as a specimen in life and I- *we* shouldn’t treat him that way in death.”

Toshinori met his gaze for a moment before nodding, offering Izuku another gentle smile.

“Ok.”

“Wait- really?” Izuku said, taken aback by how easily the Professor had agreed with him.

“You’re right,” Toshinori replied. “He’s suffered enough in this lifetime.”

Toshinori was on his feet once more, reaching for a fresh set of gloves that he pulled up over the sleeves of his scrubs and picking up a face mask.

“What now?” Izuku asked.

The Professor held the box of gloves out to him, and Izuku took a pair, tilting his head in confusion.

“I think now we put Tomura to rest,” Toshinori said, gesturing for Izuku to follow him into the adjoining room and flicking on the lights. “There were two items of personal effect on him; I’ll let you decide if you would like to keep them in memoriam or cremate them with him.”

Izuku followed Toshinori into the room, his stomach dropping and his heart racing when he saw the figure lying on the metal table in the middle of the room.

Tomura’s face was destroyed, his jaw still hanging in pieces, and Izuku could not tell himself that he at least looked peaceful in death. It was another brutal, honest reminder of the world they found themselves part of, the reality of what Shigaraki had created when he sought immortality, and the hell that they’d been left to deal with.

“We’ll take him to the cremation furnace in harvesting,” Toshinori said, reaching for the blanket that covered most of Tomura’s body and tugging it up to cover his face, much to Izuku’s relief.

“What, uh, what were the personal items?” Izuku asked hoarsely.

“Two rings,” Toshinori replied, gesturing to a closed cardboard box beside Tomura’s feet. “They were tied around his neck.”

“Rings?”

Izuku picked up the small box and opened the lid, instantly recognising the gold bands inside. He gasped.

“These are Kacchan’s,” he said, reaching in and picking up the cord the rings were attached to. “Tomura must have taken them off him when he found him at the stadium.”

“Oh, I remember Aizawa asking me if we had seen two rings,” Toshinori said. “I’m sure young Bakugou will be delighted to be reunited with them.”

“Yeh,” Izuku agreed, closing his fist around them with a small smile before putting them into his pocket.

“Shall we?”

Wheeling Tomura to the cremation furnace was a sobering affair, but as the heavy metal door was closed after him, and the flames began to flicker and roar inside, Izuku knew that it had been the right thing to do. And, for the first time when Izuku thought of his friends, of Ochako and Tenya, Tsu and Sero, the smallest part of the pain fell away, and warmth started to bloom in its place.

Several hours later, Izuku sat on his bed, back in his own dorm room. It had grown dark now, the only light coming from the little lamp at his bedside. In his palm lay the two rings, the only things that Kacchan had left of his parents, glowing in the gentle, warm light. He needed to speak with him, not just to give the rings back to him, but because something had changed with Kacchan, and by now Izuku had a pretty good idea of what it was.

It was the same cycle, the same story, repeating itself over and over throughout the course of their relationship; they would grow close, something would happen that would convince Kacchan that he was a danger to Izuku, and he would try and push him away again. Izuku knew that the last time he and Kacchan had seen each other before he was chained up and left as bait for the zombies was the night that Kacchan had begun to turn, and until now he hadn’t put a lot of thought into that. There’d been so much else going on that Izuku had almost forgotten. Of course Kacchan was distancing himself from Izuku again; it was how he always handled these situations in the past, after all.

He needed to go and find him and reassure him that everything was ok. They’d found that drug, after all, the one that Shigaraki had been using to prevent Tomura from going entirely feral, and as far as he knew, Kacchan had been entirely himself ever since. Tomura himself had said that Kacchan’s turning had been planned, though with Tomura gone he supposed he may never really have an answer as to *how* he managed that. Perhaps it was entirely possible that Kacchan may never have another outburst like that again.

He got to his feet, putting the rings back in his pocket again. He had no idea where Kacchan was spending his nights, but he was sure that Shouto would be able to tell him. He pulled on his slippers before reaching for his door and opening it wide, letting out a shocked little squeak when he saw

that there was already someone standing on the other side, arm up like they had just been about to knock.

“Kacchan!”

Kacchan blinked, lowering his arm.

“Uh. Sorry. You, uh, you on your way out?”

“To go find you, actually,” Izuku replied, laughing. “Guess my Kacchan senses were tingling.”

“Lame,” Kacchan grunted, before the two fell silent, awkwardly shifting and looking back at each other. “Uh-” Izuku hated hearing Kacchan sound so unsure of himself. “Can I come in, or this not a good time?”

“Come in, Kacchan,” Izuku said, stepping back so that Kacchan could enter the room.

Kacchan wandered into the little room, looking around with a passive curiosity, and Izuku realised that this was the first time that Kacchan had been here. He shut the door and watched quietly as Kacchan investigated the contents of his small bookcase and ran his fingers along the spines of the notebooks that Izuku had started writing in since coming to UA. Kacchan then turned his attention to Izuku’s bed before reaching for the book on his bedside table and looking back at him.

“Perry’s Chemical Engineers’ Handbook?” he said, raising an eyebrow.

“What, I can’t take an interest in your interests?”

Izuku, expecting a sarcastic response, was surprised when Kacchan just smiled and gently placed the book back onto the table, fingers nudging it to roughly the same position it had been in before he’d picked it up. He then continued to stand there, somewhat aimlessly, throat bobbing as he visibly fought for the words.

“I know what you came here to say,” Izuku said softly, taking pity on him. Kacchan peered over at him, face impassive again.

“Yeh? So, what did I come here to say?”

Izuku took a deep breath, walking across to his desk so that he could lean against it.

“You’ve come to remind me that you nearly turned just a few days ago,” he said. “That it might happen again, and that it isn’t safe for you to be around me.”

“And I suppose you’re going to tell me that’s all bullshit?”

“No,” Izuku replied honestly. “I know it’s not, Kacchan. But nothing’s changed for me; I still want to be with you.”

“I tried to kill you not even a week ago, Izuku,” Kacchan said quietly.

“That’s sort of an exaggeration; you just got a bit… growly. Besides, you stopped as soon as I

asked you and you realised what was going on."

"I *choked* you," Kacchan said, his voice barely a whisper. "Again."

Izuku blinked, taken aback.

"Huh?"

"*Hah?*"

"What do you mean you choked- wait, is *that* what you're worried about?" Izuku asked.

"*Is that what-* how in the hell can I *not* be worried about it?" Kacchan yelled, rapidly returning to his usual volume.

"Kacchan, I *asked* you to do that," Izuku replied, feeling his cheeks burn under Kacchan's indignant scrutiny. Kacchan's jaw dropped.

"*Hah?!*"

"Hold up," Izuku said, raising his hands. "Do you even remember what happened that night?"

"I remember we had sex," Kacchan replied, looking at Izuku like he had lost it. "And then I remember waking up and choking you and trying to eat you or some shit."

"Oh, oh no." Izuku laughed with some relief. "Kacchan, you got it all mixed up. The choking was part of the, uh… you know, it was part of, uh-"

Kacchan threw his hands in the air in exasperation. "What are you even trying to say?"

"The sex!" Izuku all but yelped. "The choking was in the sex part, not the trying to eat me part!"

Kacchan stood there, mouth agape, seemingly frozen as he tried to process what Izuku had just said.

"Kacchan?"

Kacchan's face scrunched up like he was trying to solve a complicated math problem before he took a step back and fell heavily onto Izuku's bed.

"Are you serious?" he asked, squinting up at Izuku with an expression so perplexed Izuku couldn't stop himself from laughing.

"You really don't remember?" Izuku asked as he sat down beside him.

"I dunno. Kinda. It's all… mixed up," Kacchan replied.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, placing a hand on his knee. "I'm serious when I say that I want you. All of you, and whatever that comes with. I just… I need you to stop freaking out on me every time we hit a hurdle."

“I wouldn’t call my turning into a zombie a hurdle,” Kacchan scoffed. “That drug I found in the basement is doing its thing. The researcher with the ponytail, the one that hung around with Dog Eyes? She seems to think I won’t need to go back on that shitty amiodarone again. But if I stop taking this new thing, I’ll turn, Izuku. There’s no running away from that.”

“We knew that back when it was just the alcohol controlling it,” Izuku reasoned. “This isn’t new information, Kacchan; I’ve already had time to sit with it.”

“And this is really what you want?” Kacchan said, gesturing to himself. “You really wanna introduce *me* to your damn mother?”

“Are you kidding? I can’t wait for you to meet her properly.”

Kacchan’s jaw tensed, but there was a certain shocked wonder in his eyes as he looked back at Izuku.

“Besides, what about you?” Izuku said. “You know, our whole relationship has been about whether or not this is best for me and not whether this is something that you actually *want*.”

Kacchan scowled, and he placed his palms onto the bed, shifting so that he could face Izuku directly.

“You fucking listen to me, Deku,” he said firmly. “I want you. Ain’t a fucking doubt in my mind.”

“Good,” Izuku replied smartly. “So, you’re going to stop crashing out?”

Kacchan continued to pout, running his tongue over his teeth as he considered Izuku’s request.

“M’not promising shit,” he said finally. “I’m probably gonna freak out on you again at some point.”

Izuku raised his eyebrows.

“I’m just being honest,” Kacchan said. “Something tells me this isn’t the end of all this, that me being infected is gonna become the kind of thing some people take issue with.”

“Well, then they’ll be last in the queue for the vaccine when I make it.”

Kacchan’s face split into a lopsided, handsome grin. His eyes dropped down to Izuku’s cheek, reaching a hand out to brush his hair away from his ear.

“Does it hurt?” he asked.

“A little. But honestly, resetting my thumb hurt way worse; this is nothing.”

“Hmm.”

They sat in silence for a moment after that, Kacchan continuing to brush Izuku’s hair back from his face before his hands dropped down to brush against Izuku’s arms, taking his hands in his.

“Oh, I have something for you,” Izuku said, remembering the rings in his pocket.

“For me?”

Izuku hummed in response. “It turns out, Tomura had them. Toshinori found them on him and gave them to me when I helped him cremate him earlier.”

“You cremated him?” Kacchan asked, leaning back to fix Izuku with a surprised look. “I thought the old man wanted to dissect him or some creepy shit.”

“He wanted to,” Izuku confirmed, putting his hand into his pocket. “But it just… it didn’t feel right. Shigaraki dehumanised him enough.”

“So, this mean you’re not going to try and find a cure from the nomu?”

“No,” Izuku said firmly. “My blood’s enough, especially with Shigaraki’s research once we can convince Overhaul to help us get down into that basement.”

Kacchan’s expression softened even more before he looked down at Izuku’s clenched hand as he extended it out.

“What is it?”

“Your rings.”

Izuku opened his hand, and Kacchan reached for them in disbelief, taking the cord and holding the rings up in front of his face.

“*Tomura* had them?”

“Yeh, I guess he took them from you at the stadium.”

“Bastard,” Kacchan growled, as he let the rings settle in his palm, picking up each one in turn. He paused then, as he held the smaller of the two, his mother's ring, his breath hitching audibly.

“Are you ok?” Izuku asked.

Kacchan sat in silence, no longer looking at the rings, searching Izuku’s face.

“I’m gonna say something,” he said. “You might think I’ve gone crazy.”

“I often do,” Izuku laughed, smiling at him gently.

“I haven’t. I’m serious about this, Izuku.”

Kacchan lifted the leather cord to his mouth, gnawing on it until it snapped, before letting both rings slide from the cord into his hand again. Izuku watched with a dawning realisation as Kacchan selected his mother's ring, his heart already hammering hard in his chest as Kacchan held it back out to him.

“‘Til death?”

Izuku laughed, his face split into the biggest grin he’d worn since the dead started to walk.

“As if death could stop us,” he choked, not caring about the tears welling up in his eyes as he held up his hand.

“You’re probably right,” Kacchan grunted, frowning as he tried to push the ring onto Izuku’s ring finger, realising that it was too small, and instead settling for his pinkie finger. “I’ll get you a really fucking fancy cord.”

Izuku laughed again as he reached out to place his hands on Kacchan’s cheeks, the two of them falling eagerly into a kiss.

There was a moment where I truly stopped believing that we’d be able to heal from all the terrible things that we’d been through. It didn’t last long, not in the grand scheme of it all, but I think that was probably the most terrified I’d ever felt. It was like I’d fallen into a pit that I’d spent days trying to climb out of, but at a point you realise that there is no way out, nothing is coming to save you and this cold and lonely place is where it all ends.

It’s hard to think back to that time, even now when I have more hope than I think I’ve ever had. I told Kacchan about it, and he told me that his pit was the stadium and how ironic it was that realising he couldn’t die was the furthest he’d ever felt from alive. But it isn’t like that now. Things have changed so much in the eighteen months since Tomura released the zombies and kick-started it all.

Not all of it has been good. The first six months after Shigaraki was murdered were hard; without anyone in charge and no one feeling like they could trust each other, everything sort of fell apart. Just when we should have been fighting for a vaccine, we were instead trying to keep Kacchan and the rest of the nomu from being killed. Eventually, the people responsible were exiled, but I still think about them, still wish there’d been another way, still wonder if they managed to find somewhere safe.

But after that, Professor Toshinori and I were able to focus on a vaccine. It took almost an entire year, and clearing the basement of zombies so that we could get to Shigaraki’s research hadn’t been easy, but… we found it. I really think we’ve found it. Recreating the IFN that me and Kacchan were treated with turned out to be the simple part; what was difficult was figuring out what made me different from Kacchan and why he wasn’t also immune. We did a lot of comparisons between my blood and the other nomu before I noticed that there was a particular compound in my blood that I had in higher levels. It turns out that much of my immunity was down to sheer luck, a completely benign condition that meant my liver didn’t produce enough of some random enzyme. Harmless, apparently, until that minor genetic anomaly managed to completely interfere with how Shigaraki’s designer drug was supposed to work. We eventually found out that we could replicate that same genetic disorder, put the liver into shock, treat with the same IFN, and when the test subject recovered and was exposed to the zombie virus, they had a seventy-two percent chance of fighting it off.

It isn't perfect, but Professor Toshinori is pretty confident that it's only a matter of time before he's able to produce a complete vaccine. In the meantime, the treatment we have is safe enough to have started offering it to people on the campus, and frankly, a seventy-two percent chance of fighting the virus if you're ever exposed to it is far better odds than anything we've had before.

Unfortunately, none of our treatments had any effect on people who were already infected. If you get bitten before the vaccine, then it's lights out like it's always been, and that goes for the nomu, too. We've been able to synthesise more of the drug that Kacchan found in the basement, and a monthly injection of that is enough to keep the virus at bay for as long as they keep up with the treatment. I still worry every day about what happens if, for some reason, we aren't able to create more of the drug, and it's been scaring me more since Kacchan and I decided it was time to get back out there again. But it offered Kacchan a life, one where he isn't sick all the time or just waiting to turn. We can hope again.

That's sort of what made our minds up about leaving UA. It's one thing to be able to help the people already here, but we know there are others out there, and maybe we can help them. Starting with –

"Oi, Deku. You just about done here?"

Izuku looked up, raising a hand to shield his eyes from the bright, early morning sun. It was glorious out here at this time of day; the breeze hit the trees just right, bringing with it the sweet scent of blossom and spring, the plush grass beneath him still cool to the touch.

Kacchan stood beside him, dressed in combats and a t-shirt, enjoying the new warm weather just as much as Izuku was.

"Nm, almost," Izuku replied. "Just give me one minute."

"Nerd," Kacchan snorted, before chucking the backpack he was carrying to the side and taking a seat on the ground opposite Izuku. Izuku bent back over his journal, tongue between his teeth as he reread his last few sentences so he could remember where he had gotten to. After a few moments of writing, he nodded his head in satisfaction and made to shut the journal before Kacchan swooped forward and grabbed it from him.

"You writing about my '*plush lips'* again, nerd?"

Izuku blushed.

"That was one time!"

"Sure, sure. What about my, uh, what was it again? *Rippling abs*?"

"You just made that up!"

"Only because I haven't found the right notebook yet," Kacchan teased, smoothing out the paper of the journal. "I know you got some real filthy shit hidden away somewhere."

"Too bad you'll never see it," Izuku snipped, snatching the journal back and dropping it onto the

grass beside him. “Not until you start being nice to me.”

“I’m always nice to you,” Kacchan huffed, pouting at him.

“No one believes you.”

Kacchan snorted, leaning back onto the palm of his hands as he stretched his legs out, framing Izuku.

“You sure you’re ready for this?” he asked.

“I am,” Izuku replied, smiling over at him. “I left enough blood samples with the Professor, just in case. You got plenty of the antidote?”

“Enough to keep a zombie elephant alive,” Kacchan said, nodding his head towards the pack on the ground. “I told Hawks we would probably only be gone maybe six months, if that, but he’s almost as much of a worrier as you when you get him going.”

“He just cares,” Izuku said. “You’re his friend.”

“And what a fucking mistake that was.”

Izuku sniggered, reaching his hand forward to flick Kacchan on the nose. Instead, Kacchan snatched his wrist, throwing him a shit-eating grin.

“I think you’ll miss everyone whilst we’re gone,” Izuku said, surrendering his arm to Kacchan when he began fiddling with each of his fingers, before he snorted loudly. “Oh, that’s really going to piss you off.”

“Far from fucking likely, Deku. I’m looking forward to some time away from all these people. Just you and me, comparing zombie kills, all fucking romantic-like.”

“Until we find Shindou,” Izuku reminded him. “Then it’ll be you, me, your ex and about thirty odd other people.”

Kacchan sighed loudly and dramatically, shooting him a sour look.

“Are you trying to ruin my good mood?”

“We might get attacked a lot on the way; slow us down a bit?”

“Improving,” Kacchan replied, pulling Izuku’s hand up towards his face and pressing a kiss against his palm. “But I think you can do better.”

“Well, I do remember something about a waterfall…”

Kacchan grinned wolfishly before dragging the tip of Izuku’s middle finger into his mouth and gently biting down. Izuku flushed, glancing around to make sure that no one was watching them and making Kacchan laugh again.

“C’mon,” he said, climbing to his feet and yanking Izuku up with him and dragging him close. “We best get going before the zombies figure out what’s going on.”

Still feeling decidedly flustered, Izuku reached down to pick up his journal before reaching for his own sizeable backpack and sliding it inside, Kacchan waiting patiently for him to catch up so that they could walk together to the gates.

There was already a small crowd of their friends and family forming as they made their way over, and Izuku should have known that there was no hope of he and Kacchan slipping away quietly, despite having already said their farewells that very morning. He heard Kacchan huff beside him, but he knew it meant just as much to him as it did to Izuku, and he lifted his arm to wave at everyone.

“They always gotta make a scene,” Kacchan grumbled.

“Katsuki, Izuku!” Kaminari called, waving back. “Really thought we’d let you go without a royal send-off?”

“Nah, I should’a known better,” Kacchan conceded, rolling his eyes as Kirishima yanked him into a bear hug.

“Yeh, yeh, enough of that. Where’s the Monster?”

Kirishima pouted. “I remember when I was your best friend.”

“Whatever, gimme the kid.”

Mina stepped forward, lifting up the chubby-looking one-year-old from where she had been diligently digging in the dirt. “Up you get, Kyouko!”

Kyouko already had her arms outstretched as Mina handed her over to Kacchan, and he took her eagerly, cradling her against his hip and pointedly tapping her clenched, muddy hand.

“What you got there?”

“Ba,” Kyouko said confidently, holding the handful of mud out to him. Kacchan nodded.

“Seems serious. You should definitely show this to your Uncle Deku.”

Kacchan angled himself to face Izuku.

“Ba,” Kyouko said again, now presenting the mud to Izuku, who had little choice but to accept it.

“Oh, thank you, Kyouko,” Izuku said. “I’ll make sure to put this safely with the other mud!”

“Nah you gotta keep it,” Kacchan said, with a sly grin. “I think Uncle Deku should put it in his pocket, don’t you, Monster? Keep it safe.”

Kyouko babbled along in full agreement, and Izuku glared at Kacchan as he placed the handful of mud into the pocket of his jeans.

“You can’t keep using my daughter as a way to bully people,” Mina sighed. “It’s going to end up rubbing off on her, you know that?”

“I’m pretty sure that’s the plan,” Izuku sighed, and Kacchan just grinned all the more broadly, turning his attention back to Kyouko as she started tugging on the cord around his neck and playing with the gold ring that hung from it.

“Izuku, please tell me you’re going to be careful out there,” Inko said, her hands wringing nervously. “Don’t get into any fights that you can avoid, and don’t travel at night. Do you have the radio?”

“I’ve got it,” Izuku said, patting the side pocket of his backpack which held their portable handheld ham radio.

“Promise you’ll call us every three days!”

“I’ll bring him back to you in one piece, Aunty,” Kacchan said, as he handed a wriggling Kyouko to Kirishima.

“Well, just make sure you come back in one piece, too, Katsuki,” Inko said.

“Speaking of the radio,” Shouto piped up, reaching into his pocket and pulling out a piece of paper that he held out for Izuku. “This is the updated frequency to connect to. Remember, we have no idea who else might be listening in, so keep locations vague unless it’s an emergency.”

“Got it, thanks, Shouto,” Izuku said, glancing at the number before putting the paper into the jean pocket not currently full of mud.

“You still got those antidotes?” Hawks asked, prodding Kacchan on the shoulder, who swiped irritably out at him.

“Yeh, for the hundredth time I got the damn stuff!”

“If you lose it, or it gets damaged, you come back to UA. Don’t take any chances.”

“I heard ya!”

“Hey, do you both really think that Shindou’s group is still alive out there?” Kaminari asked, scratching his chin. “I still don’t think you have good odds on finding them after all this time.”

“We owe it to them to try,” Izuku replied. “They survived in those sewers for a long time before we came along.”

“This group will be just the start,” Hawks added. “Vaccine’s only so effective with just a small population to share it with.”

“Plus, we know there are other nomu out there,” Kacchan said. “Maybe there are still some we can save before it’s too late for ‘em.”

“It’s worth the risk,” Izuku assured Kaminari. “Besides,” he added, with a confident grin, “whatever we come across out there, Kacchan and I can handle it.”

“Hey! Zombies are gonna start getting restless if you hang around much longer!” A voice called from over by the gates, Izuku looking around to see Overhaul jerking his head pointedly.

“Alright,” Izuku breathed, looking over at Kacchan. “You ready?”

Kacchan reached around to his pack, unhooking the nail-encrusted bat fastened onto the side of it, and casually propping it onto his shoulder. “Let’s go.”

Izuku and Kacchan walked towards the gates. The ever-dwindling crowd of zombies that usually surrounded the campus had been ordered aside, leaving the way clear for them. And, after a quick confirmation from Overhaul that it was safe for them to exit, Hawks pulled down on the levers that opened the outer and inner sets of gates.

Izuku took a deep breath, a familiar spike of adrenaline rushing through him as the world outside of the walls opened itself up for them. A glance at Kacchan’s face confirmed that he felt the same amount of anticipation for the journey ahead of them.

“Stay safe!” Mina called.

“Every three days!” Inko added.

Izuku nodded, looking back at his friends one last time. Shouto stood, with one of Kaminari’s arms hooked over his shoulders and his eyes decidedly watery. Izuku nodded, sending him a soft smile. He felt Kacchan’s hand nudging his, and he gratefully interlocked their fingers, the two of them taking their first steps beyond UA’s walls together.

“I hope they don’t worry about us too much,” Izuku said, looking over at Kacchan.

“Hmm, what was that old saying of yours? *No Unnecessary Risks?*”

“You know, I’m starting to think those might be the ones worth taking.”


the
End

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